She-Ra: The Lost

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M, Multi

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Castaspella/Juliet (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Kyle/Lonnie/Rogelio (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
Unofficial Sequel, Epic Battles, Drama & Romance, Bad Jokes, Original Character(s), Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Fluff, Angst

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Series:
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She-Ra: The Lost

by Largemovingtorb

Summary

THIS TAKES PLACE AFTER MY OTHER FANFIC, SHE-RA: MASTERS OF THE UNIVERSE.

With the Dark He-Man defeated and the god of Death destroyed, Catra and Adora make good on the promise they made to each other at Scorpia's first ball, taking the Vow in the place they first declared their love for one another-The Heart of Etheria. Deciding to visit Catra's long lost homeworld of Elysia as their honeymoon, Catra and Adora soon find themselves in the middle of a tense reunion between two ancient civilizations: Catra's people, the Madgēcots and the people of Empyrea, who send a mysterious warrior as their emissary—Veth, bearer of Zhe-La.
Meanwhile, back on Etheria, Glimmer stumbles upon an ancient evil on nearby Eternia, buried under a place called Grayskull…

Notes

This takes place after She-Ra: Masters of the Universe and 'around' the same time as Double Double and the Orb of Entropy.

This work is 100% complete.

Prologue (BOOK I: SHE-RA)


SHE-RA
THE LOST
BY LARGEMOVINGTORB

BOOK 1

SHE-RA



Faint rays of morning light illuminated the city of Nox as the first calls of Imbolg began to ring out. Deep resonating rumbles of the mournful dirge could be heard from each of the cardinal points of the city, ancient bearing markers whose meaning was past unknown, much like the holiday being celebrated.

Veth squinted their kohl-smeared silver eyes at the sound as they exited the House of the Penumbra, their long, lilac-colored ears twitching in abhorrence of the sound.

We should just do away with these foolish festivals, they thought darkly to themselves. *No one knows their meanings anymore and these morning horns are atrocious.*

Veth sighed as they thought of what their Archon would say to such thoughts. The Archon was the leading proponent of the holidays, touting their continued importance. They would not appreciate that their champion was at cross paths with them on this.

Veth felt an icy jolt through their core at such a realization; that they could be against the Archon Lethe. Such a thing was unthinkable, and they found themselves desperate to find an excuse for their earlier thoughts.

It's not that I dislike the Imbolg celebration, they yielded to themselves. *It's just that I feel so...off after every Penumbra ritual. That's all. This early morning session was especially taxing.*

The Penumbra Ritual; their cyclic sacred ablutions to their people's all-encompassing cause, done under the gaze of the great Archon Lethe, deep under the House of the Penumbra. It was supposed to be a cleansing ritual to help them feel *pure* again. In recent days, however, they just felt agitated after each session.

And it was getting worse.

Veth shook these thoughts from their head and forced themselves to concentrate on the task at hand. As they announced the

completion of this morning's ritual, the Archon had stated they wanted to see Veth in their grand audience chambers. There was a task they had for Veth, one of utmost importance.

Veth looked outward from the House of the Penumbra, gazing down the long Avenue of Triumph to the large domed building that was the seat of power for the Nephraeh. The place of wisdom and direction was where the Archon Lethe had guided Veth's people for eons.

The Hall of Light.

Suddenly feeling a sense of urgency, Veth strode down the long stairs leading from the House of the Penumbra to the beginnings of the great avenue. As was the case every morning of Veth's cleansing ritual, the people of Nox had gathered to praise their champion. They called out with Veth's various titles and nicknames.

"The Light!"

"Zhe-La!"

"Child of Lethe!"

Veth smiled at them, a warm and authentic expression. Besides enacting the Archon's will, they had few pleasures in their life—they had no mate and few—if any—friends, and their role as champion gave them no time for anything as trivial as a hobby. Besides the satisfaction being champion of the Nephraeh gave them, there was the never-ending goodwill directed at them from their people. Goodwill, but not love—Nephraeh were rare to come to such an emotion. Though it was said that this was not always so…

"Zhe-La! What news from beyond Empyrea?" Someone cried to them. "Does our empire spread now that the Great Enemy is gone?"

Veth smiled at the question, exposing a hint of their upper fangs as they unconsciously ran their fingers through their long black hair, tossing it behind their head.

“Horde Prime is gone, but new challenges have arisen! Invaders from other dimensions have come to our galaxy to try and rule us!” Veth cried loud and bright, hearing worried gasps and whispers in response. “But fear not! Our great and wise Archon leads us! Even now, I go to meet them to learn of their new vision!”

Veth’s words were met with cheers and praise. The people held out their hands to brush their claw tips along Veth’s arms and shoulders as they walked out of the crowd and down the long road to the Hall of Light.

The Avenue of Triumph was a long and wide road, and Veth was pleased by its straight and direct path through the city to the Temple of Light. It was orderly and neat, much like the city it bisected. A neat, straight line in a city of straight lines and ninety-degree angles—utilitarian and uniform. It was a representation of the law and order that the Empyrean Hegemony would bring to the rest of the universe—and Veth was going to help make that happen.

The only building allowed to deviate from the city plan was the Hall of Light, a colossal building composed of a massive white dome. Veth gazed up at the dome as they climbed the wide stone stairs to the entrance. The normally white surface glowed a warm orange hue in the morning light.

True to its namesake, Veth thought as they strode past the two figures guarding the entry portal to the Temple of Light.

Both of the Centurions saluted as they passed, which Veth reciprocated. As the ultimate champion of the Empyrean Hegemony, Veth's station elevated them above having to pay tribute to a lowly Centurion...but Veth did it anyway. It pleased

Veth to see the appreciation in their fellow Nephraeh's silver eyes to be honored in such a fashion.

Beyond the entrance was a vast hall that ran entirely around the grand assembly chamber. It was quiet this morning, echoing with the susurrus of distant voices, which unsettled Veth.

Why do I feel this way in the Hall of Light of all places? Am I...unsure about this meeting with my Archon? I feel like a part of me is trying to tell me something. Is it Zhe-La? Veth thought as they strode across the hall and into the grand assembly hall.

This would not be the first time the spirit of their magical power tried to speak to them, but these feelings became more assertive as time passed. As if something within them was fighting to break to the surface.

Veth squinted as they took in the massive chamber of the grand assembly hall. It was an immense, circular space—an amphitheater. Tiered pews ran along the circumference of the hall, and in the middle, a raised lectern brought the speaker above the highest level of anyone seated in attendance.

Skylights high above and in the center of the domed ceiling were usually wide open, lighting the entire space. Now, they were open just enough to allow a bright shaft of light to illuminate the lectern in the center, leaving the rest of the space in shadows.

Veth glanced around, trying to peer into the dark spaces. They felt as if many watchers were hiding in the folds of inky black, but they could discern nothing but the faint whispers they heard in the hall outside. They instantly felt fear.

"Veth! My child!" A loud voice cried from the illuminated lectern. "Come to me! Come before me!"

The Archon Lethe.

As Veth obeyed and strode down the ramp between the seats to stand before the raised lectern, they did not take their eyes off of

the Archon. The Archon Lethe was unlike any Nephraeh Veth had seen before, which made sense, for they were not a Nephraeh.

They were a god.

The Archon Lethe appeared Nephraeh in shape, but not in scale, for they were much larger than a typical Nephraeh. Instead of the light purple skin typical of the species, Archon Lethe's was pure white—as was their hair. Indigo eyes glowed with power as they watched Veth approach the bottom of the towering lectern. Veth kneeled as they reached the bottom of the ramp, eyes averted towards the ground.

"Arise, my Child," The Archon commanded. "Gaze upon me."

Veth did as they were beckoned, standing and laying eyes once again upon their Lord. As usual, Veth felt their heart quicken at the sight of the Archon. They were so powerful and beautiful, wise beyond reckoning. Veth felt like they were basking in Archon Lethe's radiance—they indeed were the light source for the Nephraeh. Veth felt their earlier trepidation vanish as the Archon's gaze radiated down upon them.

"What do you wish of me, Lord Archon?" Veth whispered fervently.

Archon Lethe smiled warmly at Veth's words, exposing their upper and lower fangs.

"Why so formal, my Child? I sensed a resistance in you during our morning ritual, Veth. Tell me, what is wrong?" The Archon asked kindly.

Veth felt embarrassed by their earlier feelings, unsure whether or not to bother the Archon with their emotions. They did not want their Lord to think that they were anything but dedicated to the Empyrean Hegemony and the cause of light.

"I...it's nothing, my Lord, I just—" Veth began but was halted by the Archon holding up a finger.

“Do not try to hide the truth from me, Veth. I think I deserve more than that.” The Archon said quietly down to them. It was barely a whisper, but Veth felt chills run down their back from the power behind it.

Veth cleared their throat. “It’s just that I’ve been having this...feeling after the Penumbra Ritual. A feeling of uneasiness, my Lord, and it’s getting worse. I do not know where it comes from...it’s like—”

“Like Zhe-La is speaking to you? Trying to tell you something?” The Archon interrupted.

Veth felt their heart leap at their Lord’s understanding and empathy, smiling warmly at the Archon.

“Yes, Archon Lethe! You are so wise!” Veth said, then looked forlorn. “Although I know not what they try to tell me. The spirit of Zhe-La is not always clear.”

The Archon chuckled at this. “Yes! Don’t I know it? Almost two thousand years I have been guiding the Nephraeh. Two thousand years of acting as a friend to Zhe-La. Their wisdom is so very hard to decipher sometimes—but I have much experience! I think I know what alarms the magical force within you, Veth.”

Veth’s silver eyes widened, and their mouth gaped as they gazed questioningly up at Archon Lethe.

“Please tell me, Archon Lethe! Please!” They pleaded.

The smile faded from the Archon’s white lips as they took on a stern demeanor.

“You know of these invaders from outside our dimension? Invaders that take advantage of the opportunity Horde Prime’s disappearance affords them?” Archon Lethe asked coldly.

Veth nodded. “Yes, Archon, two planets suddenly appearing within our galaxy, both at different times. The first coincided with Horde

Prime's disappearance and the other a year later."

"Excellent, Veth. I see you are keeping in touch with our Gnosis operatives. But what they don't know is that these planets were originally from this universe. Only I remember them, and only I know what came to our galaxy along with these planets. That is what Zhe-La senses." The Archon said knowingly.

"A weapon?" Veth queried.

The Archon pursed their lips and rocked their head. "Of a sort. They are powerful magical weapons to match the one within you. They are kindred spirits to Zhe-La called She-Ra and He-Man. They are The Lost. Lost to The Light"

This revelation struck Veth dumb, for this was something known only as ancient myth. As far as Veth was concerned, Zhe-La was the only magical champion of the universe. Zhe-La was the only magical champion the universe needed.

"She-Ra. He-Man." Veth said out loud, trying out the words in their mouth. "*He-Man?*" They spoke with a hint of scorn in their voice.

The Archon waved a hand dismissively. "I know not where these names come from; they are older than even myself. Know this though, my champion—you may mock them but do not dismiss their powers."

Veth was properly chastened and nodded to their Archon. "Yes, Archon Lethe, I will not underestimate them. Do you wish me to destroy them?"

The Archon smiled. "No, my Child. Do not be so hasty! You must be subtler than that; you must not immediately seek violence! You must not face them both at once. You must strike when they are vulnerable."

Veth groaned at this, and the Archon held out their hands in placation.

“I know, I know, my champion. This goes against your warrior’s honor. But I will not lose you to foolish honor like I lost many of your predecessors! This is my wish and my command, Veth!” The Archon said sternly.

“Yes, my Archon,” Veth said with head bowed. “Must I wait long then?”

“No!” The Archon Lethe said excitedly. “No, you will not have to wait long. This is why I wanted to speak with you. News comes from our Gnosis operatives that the bearer of She-Ra is on the planet Elysia as we speak! She has recently been bonded to a female Madgēcot, forming an alliance with our enemies!”

“Madgēcots,” Veth whispered, remembering Empyrea’s bitter history with these foes.

With the disappearance of Horde Prime and his false Light, the Empyrean Hegemony thought that it would finally have its time to expand, to finally bring the True Light to the rest of the universe.

However, it was not to be, for as soon as they set foot outside the boundaries of their territory, the Empyrean Hegemony stumbled into the planet, Elysia. It was a magical planet, much like Empyrea used to be—a planet of diverse races, with the majority of the population composed of a feline species called Madgēcots. The Madgēcots were a strong and fierce people, dominating the rest of the planet with a clawed fist—unlike the Nephraeh, who transplanted Empyrea’s other races to their own worlds.

The Empyreans held out their hand in friendship to the Elysians, offering to share their Light with them. But it was not to be—the Elysians utterly rejected the ideals of the Empyrean Hegemony, swearing to keep them from spreading to the rest of the galaxy.

Empyrea’s place at the very tip of one of the galactic arms had been advantageous for so long, allowing easy defense from Horde Prime’s many attacks. Not so now, as the warrior caste of the Madgēcots, The Star Hunters, were always there to block

Empyrean ships from passing by Elysia and to the rest of the galaxy, ordering them to turn back. The wily Madgēcots always seemed to know when the Empyreans were about to try to leave the boundaries of their empire…

When the Empyrean ships refused to turn around, the Madgēcots would board their ships, engaging in hand-to-hand combat and using their strange magic. The Nephraeh were capable fighters, equal to the strength and skill of the Madgēcots, but there just weren't as many of them; their numbers had dwindled over the centuries. They were always outnumbered and overwhelmed, even with the power of Zhe-La added to their forces. The only thing left to them was to wait for the perfect opportunity to defeat their foe. It seemed one had arisen.

"You want me to disrupt this alliance? To strike at this She-Ra, my Archon?" Veth asked with eagerness. If what the Archon said was true, She-Ra would be a daunting foe, one who could truly test Veth's strength and skill.

The Archon closed their eyes, the inner illumination ceasing as they took a deep breath through their nose and exhaled out their mouth. After a moment, they opened their eyes; to Veth, it seemed like the glow emanating within became even more intense.

"To directly attack her on Elysia would be madness. No, with our experience fighting the Madgēcots to date, we must be subtler. We have been at such a disadvantage in our interactions with the Elysians thus far that it is to be expected that we, as the *inferior power,* would be looking to make a truce. I want you to go to Elysia, under a banner of parlay, with the understanding we are looking to negotiate. There you will meet with this She-Ra and *illuminate* her. She will be brought into our Light." The Archon Lethe said softly.

"You wish to make her an ally?" Veth gasped.

The Archon nodded. “Yes, my dear child. Many, many centuries ago, She-Ra and Zhe-La fought as one before She-Ra before she strayed from the Light and became one of The Lost. It is only fitting that she once fights on the side of righteousness!”

To Veth, this sounded even more appealing than defeating She-Ra in combat. To have an ally, a fellow warrior of equal power to Zhe-La would be a truly wondrous thing. To no longer fight against the darkness alone! The Madgēcots and their Star Hunters would not stand a chance against their combined power.

“I know this is not as exciting as your usual missions, Veth, but will you do this for me, my Child? Will you bring She-Ra to me?” The Archon asked.

“Yes! Yes, my Archon! By the Light of Grayskull, it will be done!” Veth exclaimed.

Let’s Try Not to Mess This Up

Four robed and hooded figures crept through the murky corridors of the ancient crypt, deep below the planet’s surface. One of the figures guided the way with a top-lit staff, the illumination like starlight, casting shadows of the group against the moldy stone surfaces of the passage. There was no sound in this dark place except for the traveler’s footsteps.

And munching.

“Uh, do you think you could, like, chew louder, Entrapta?” One of the figures complained.

A figure turned to the speaker as two long, purple prehensile ponytails extended from the inner recesses of the hood. The hair tendrils drew the hood back, revealing a violet-eyed woman in the act of chewing.

“You know, Mermista, I am aware of what sarcasm is—*the use of words that mean the opposite of what you really want to say.* This is usually done for the purpose of three things: in order to insult, show irritation, or be funny. I assume you wanted me to know you are irritated since I don’t feel insulted, and what you said wasn’t at all funny. Am I correct?” Entrapta said in one breath.

The largest figure out of the group laughed at this, reaching up with red claws for hands to draw back their hood, revealing a white-haired woman.

“Ohhh!!! Good burn, Entrapta!” Scorpia said.

The figure who initially spoke pulled her hood down, revealing a dark-skinned face framed by dark blue hair.

“Yeah, okay, I guess I will give Entrapta credit for that one. Score one for the Geek Princess.” Mermista said in her usual monotone voice.

Entrapta looked confused by her comrade's words. "I don't understand. I have no fire. How did I burn Mermista?"

Scorpia groaned, and Mermista grinned at this statement.

"Annnd...point retracted," Mermista exclaimed.

The final hooded figure, the one holding the light source, turned to the others, pulling down their hood to reveal a regal and beautiful face, her mouth currently pulled in a frown.

"Guys, can we be serious? We have no idea what we will find down here. Judging by the magical residue and how creepy it is, I feel I don't think whatever it is will be good." Glimmer said worriedly.

The light source at the end of Glimmer's staff was the Star Stone, one of the ancient Staves of Power given to her by Madame Razz before she sacrificed herself to destroy the Set'Heth-un'dar and save the universe.

"Oh, relax, my fearless Queen," Mermista said, placing her hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "If it were really that bad, our *guide* would have never come down here with us."

As if on cue, padded feet could be heard approaching, coming from the direction the four princesses were headed. From the dark recesses of the passage, two large blue eyes appeared; they burned in the dark like fire, and a mewling sound could be heard as it neared. It was an alien, feline noise, echoing strangely up and down the decrepit halls.

"Oh, my gosh! What's that!?" Scorpia cried, holding her clawed hands over her face.

Glimmer looked at Scorpia incredulously. "Really, Scorpia? You're the biggest and strongest person here, and you're just a big baby. You just watched them scout ahead not ten minutes ago—it's Melog!"

Catra's friend, the purple and blue alien Melog, trotted smoothly out of the shadows. They sat down in front of the group, and Scorpia could have sworn they looked at her with irritation.

"Oh, hey! Sorry, Melog." Scorpia said with a weak smile.

Melog turned from Scorpia to look at Glimmer, and after shaking the dust from their ethereal blue mane, started to speak to her in their strange language.

Glimmer squinted as Melog spoke, the light of the Star Stone at the end of her staff increasing just a fraction as she used her magical powers to understand the alien language.

Glimmer had learned her lesson on the planet Twilight; Melog had tried to warn them against going into an ancient First One's temple, sensing bad magic. No one listened to Melog, and they turned out to be correct—Adora was psychically attacked and rendered unconscious, Glimmer was overcome by corrupted magic, and everyone had to run from the place before being overcome by evil shadows. Last but not least, their disturbance of the temple allowed an ancient enemy from another dimension to enter theirs, almost destroying the universe.

Glimmer was going to listen to Melog this time.

Melog stopped speaking and cocked their head, still staring at Glimmer as she silently processed their words.

"Sooo...you going to tell us what they said?" Mermista asked.

"Give me a moment, Mermista. Be patient! You were not there on the planet Twilight. I was!" Glimmer said, annoyed. "We rushed into things, and it ended up a disaster, right Entrapta?"

Entrapta looked confused by this.

"Disaster? Our first mission to the planet Twilight was a resounding success!" Entrapta said, emphasizing her statement by sweeping one of her ponytails into the air like a pumping fist.

Glimmer groaned, “Oh no, not again,” she said with a slight whine.

“Do you remember how much data we gathered?! WHAT WE LEARNED? By stepping into that temple, we started a series of cascading events that led to the return of Eternia to this universe, learning of the ancient Staves of Power,” Entrapta said, forming hands with her ponytails and counting the fingers as she named their achievements.

“PLUS, WE NOW HAVE HE-MAN!!!” She said finally, pure mania gleaming in her eyes.

Glimmer walked over to her fellow princess and laid both hands on her shoulders, looking into Entrapta’s violet eyes with her pink, sparkly ones.

“Yes, that’s right, Entrapta. All those good things ended up happening. But do you remember what happened to me? To Adora?” Glimmer said with a small, sad smile.

The look of madness left Entrapta’s eyes, replaced by a sudden realization, then sadness.

“Yeah...I do. That part was not so good. It made me really sad when you two were hurt,” Entrapta said while nodding slowly. “I understand what you're trying to tell me, Glimmer.”

Glimmer laughed and squeezed Entrapta’s shoulders.

“Let’s try not to mess this up,” Glimmer said to her friend. “I don’t want anyone getting hurt. The Staff of Power we came to this planet for is not worth that. Nothing is.”

“Sooo...about that,” Scorpia said while nervously chuckling. “Any word on which Staff of Power is here? The one for Mermista or me?”

Glimmer looked at the two princesses, Scorpia and Mermista; both were excited—although you would have to know Mermista to see

it. She was always so neutral that it was on the point of moroseness—but there were signs. A subtle gleam in her eye here and a higher tone in her voice there; Glimmer knew Mermista was so excited that she was on the point of hysteria.

"What did I say, Scorpia?" Glimmer scolded.

"*Let's try not to mess this up*—got it!" Scorpia said, still overly excited. Glimmer sighed audibly.

"Melog did not say which staff is here; it could be the Void Gem, or it could be the Kinetic Krystal—" Glimmer started to say before being interrupted

"If they are even here, that is," Mermista said. "Didn't whatever old text Entrapta found also say there was something called the Orb of Entropy here? I mean, what even is that?"

"You're basically arguing my point for me, Mermista." Glimmer said coolly. "We don't know *what* we will find down her—hence the need to be careful. I would have brought all the princesses—plus the boys—if I could, but someone needed to stay back home to keep things under control."

"Too bad Catra and Adora aren't here. We sure could use She-Ra and Wild-Cat," Scorpia said sadly.

"You want to interrupt their honeymoon?" Mermista said dubiously. "*Rude*…"

Scorpia looked downcast at this, and Glimmer knew how she felt—she missed all her friends, especially Bow. But Shen had asked him to go to Eternia with him, to help out with a problem there. A problem called Grayskull.

"Melog didn't find the staff we are looking for, but they did say there is a divergence in the corridor ahead—one of the paths leads up while the other leads down." Glimmer said, finishing Melog's report.

"Well, going by logic, we have been traveling down so far. It makes sense that the way we need to go would still be down." Entrapta said reasonably.

Glimmer nodded. "Makes sense, Entrapta. Let's go,"

The group continued their journey in silence, Glimmer leading the way with her Star Stone. It didn't take long for them to find the split in the path.

Two choices greeted them. The way on the right led upwards—a light motion of air drifting across their faces from its recesses. The other was so dark they could not tell whether it led up or down—the inky blackness of its depths seemed to consume the light of the Star Stone, and a foul smell emanated from within.

"Eww...of *course*, that is the way we are going," Mermista said, holding her nose. "Reminds me of when I had to go through the sewer to rescue Glimmer and Bow."

Swallowing her disgust, Glimmer raised her staff higher, willing the light of her magical staff to increase its illumination, and walked into the passage on the left. The others followed and discovered that the floor did indeed slope downwards, very gradually. As they descended, moisture appeared on the walls—light at first, then more pronounced. Glimmer ran her hand along the wall, groaning in disgust when she inspected her fingers; they were covered in a dark slime, almost like oil.

"Oh! Let me get a sample!" Entrapta said, pulling out a small sampling syringe.

"All yours," Glimmer said, holding out her fingers as Entrapta slurped up the strange goo.

Taking out an electronic device from one of her many pockets, Entrapta inserted the sampling instrument neatly into one of the slots. The machine beeped, and a display lit up; a plethora of data scrolled down the screen—earning a curious noise from the scientist princess.

“What is it, Entrapta?” Scorpia asked.

“I’m not sure. I’ve never seen readings like this before.” Entrapta said while scratching her head with one of her ponytails. “The substance appears organic while displaying characteristics of unknown energy. It’s like nothing I have come across before. *Fascinating…*”

“Great, because *unknown* has worked out for us in the past. Just saying,” Mermista said dryly.

Glimmer shrugged and held her staff back up, indicating the group should continue.

As they descended further, the slope of the floor increased, becoming steeper. Glimmer stopped when the slime beneath her made her foot slip, her heart jumping up into her throat at the thought of sliding down into the black unknown.

“Guys, I don’t think we should go any further—” She said as Entrapta wandered past her, still looking at her device.

“Huh—?” Entrapta said, looking up just in time to slip next to Glimmer and fall onto her back. As she slid forward, both of her purple ponytails extended to either side of her, which ceased her descent.

“Entrapta!” Scorpia said as she lunged forward to help her friend—only to slip and fall in the same spot as the other two princesses. She slid forward and immediately collided with Entrapta, causing her to lose her grip on the walls. Both princesses clung to each other as they wailed in unison, disappearing into the unknown.

Glimmer and Mermista stared open-mouthed at the fate of their friends, Mermista the first one to break the silence.

“Uh, so should we just go back and get a rope or something?” She said in absolute seriousness.

Glimmer scowled at her, then turned with an audible sigh and sat down, scooting forward until she was sliding. Mermista watched the light of the Star Stone slowly disappear until she was standing in inky nothingness.

"Uh, like, there is no way I am going—AHH!" She screamed as Melog pushed her forward and knocked her down.

"MELOG! I'M GONNA KILL YOU!" Mermista screamed as she slid down the slick surface. The only response was an apologetic sounding mew, not far behind her.

Mermista made a disgusted growl as she slid, the corridor continuing to steepen until finally, it was completely vertical, and she was in complete free-fall.

"AAAAHHHHH—oof!" Mermista exclaimed as she made contact with the ground.

As she hit bottom, Mermista had felt strange objects break her fall —they felt like soft inflated bags—also covered in the black slime which came up to her ankles. The peculiar things slid out from under her weight, making small squeaking noises.

Knowing what was coming, Mermista rolled out of the way as Melog plopped down next to her with a feline whine.

"Just *wait* until we are back on Etheria and I get my magical powers back. I hope you know how to *swim*." She growled at them.

There was a light source behind Mermista. Looking around, she saw she was in a large room, long and rectangular shaped. There were carved murals along the walls, indiscernible from where she sat. A gaping door with intricate designs carved around the frame was at one end of the rectangle. At the opposite end was a raised dais. A series of five stone statues stood there—humanoid and lithe.

“I see you decided to join us, *princess*,” Glimmer said, holding up her lit Star Stone.

“Oh! Glimmer was using sarcasm to show how annoyed she is with Mermista! Am I right?” Entrapta said excitedly.

“Youuuu got it!” Scorpia answered for her.

“Ugh… *whatever.*” Mermista replied.

“What is this place?” Scorpia asked, a little fear in her voice.

“Mmm...not sure. Based on the room's layout, the nature, and grouping of the statues, it appears to be a form of a temple. That is just a rough hypothesis, though.” Entrapta said, holding out a device to record some of the murals on the walls.

“Like a First One’s temple?” Glimmer asked.

“Ehh...I don’t think so,” Entrapta continued, inspecting the murals with what looked like a magnifying glass. “I think this is much older, but you will have to wait until Hordak and I have time to go through the data I collect for an exact date.”

Glimmer did not know why, but she did not like that reply—it sounded too familiar. It seemed like every time they sought what was hidden in the past, they regretted it.

Entrapta was right; they did gain much the last time they sought to bring magic to the universe. But things had come so close to ending in ruin—for all of them. She hated to think of what would have happened if the Set’Heth-un’dar—The Dark Goddess of Death—had come to their universe.

Looking around her immediate vicinity, Glimmer saw more of the funny objects that broke her fall strewn about the chamber. One of them made that strange squeaking sound when Scorpia kicked it across the room; it skidded to a halt in the slime with a sick slurping sound.

“Entrapta, what do you think these are?” Glimmer said, indicating one nearby with the end of her lit staff.

“Oh! Let me take a sample!” She replied, removing her sampling syringe.

“Wait!” Glimmer cried, lunging and grabbing Entrapta’s wrist. “Hold on a second,”

Glimmer looked closely at the strange, squishy object. It was round and oblong, like a fruit or egg—and for some reason, the word *egg* stuck in her head. It appeared black and oily, like the wretched slime covering everything. Shining her light closer on it, Glimmer could see that it had a translucence, and as she squinted, Glimmer could have sworn she could see something move inside…

Glimmer backed away from it, a look of disgust on her face.

“I think we should leave, guys. Let’s try and see if that other door leads out.” Glimmer said to her friends. “Melog, could you scout ahead of us?”

The purple and blue alien feline nodded their head, bounding off and through the door, the sound of their paws slapping in the muck receding into the gloom.

“Well, while we wait, I’m gonna just take a peek at those statues,” Entrapta said innocently.

“Just don’t touch anything!” Glimmer said snappishly.

Entrapta held up her hands and grinned with little reassurance, turning to walk over to the strange statues on the dais with the other princesses in tow.

As they came closer, the Star Stone illuminated the figures on the dais; they were beautiful and elegantly shaped, with long pointed ears sticking out between strands of flowing hair. Highly detailed

faces smiled, looking at the one between them with hands held out.

The middle figure was the most interesting.

They appeared twice the height as the others, though obviously the same species. There was armor on their upper shoulders, thighs, forearms, and shins—the rest of their body concealed in skintight clothing. A helmet sat upon their head, partially covering their face. Their mouth was open, and they were looking up at a sword they held above their head.

With disgust, Glimmer noticed that the black viscous slime was slowly oozing out of the middle figure's eyes, ears, and mouth and pouring down their body onto the floor. It was like she was looking at something once beautiful, but was now horribly corrupted, and she couldn't help seeing the parallels with the corrupted First One's temple on Twilight.

But we destroyed the temple, defeated the Shen'Aan-war, and the Set'Heth-un'dar was undone. This can't be the power of Death. Glimmer thought to herself.

No, this was something different—in the same vein of evil—but different.

"You know," Scorpia said, looking at the middle statue. "That one kind of reminds me of She-Ra..."

Instantly, a loud hissing noise reverberated throughout the room. It seemed to come from everywhere, but with no visible source. The sound reached a crescendo, then died off to a low murmur—like whispers—but this too eventually ceased.

"That was weird," Scorpia said to no one in particular.

As if in response, there was a loud squeak and pop off in the distance, followed by more, the sounds increasing to just a series of rapid popping. The princesses saw with horror that the strange oblong objects were exploding—like disgusting little balloons—

depositing tiny things into the slime. After a moment, this too finished as all the balloon objects finished their self-destruction until there was silence again.

"*Fascinating…*" Entrapta exclaimed as she approached a spot where once an oblong object existed. "I think I saw something drop out of that exploding egg-thing,"

Entrapta reached down towards the spot in question but suddenly stood up straight.

"ACCKKK!" She screamed, looking down as a black-clawed hand grabbed her leg. She tried to kick it off, but it clung on, its grip strong.

"Entrapta!" Scorpia screamed, attempting to go to her friend's aid but held fast by grasping hands.

"Hey! Didn't anyone tell you not to invade someone's personal space!" She yelled, reaching down with her red claws and cutting the hands from limbs.

But more hands replaced the one Scorpia cut as fully formed creatures rose from the muck and flung themselves upon her. They shared similarities with the statues—humanoid with long pointed ears and fangs—but their bodies were void-black and slimy.

Glimmer turned just in time to see one wrap its arms around Mermista from behind, holding her tight.

"Oh my—Ew! Ew! Ew! Get it off me!" She screamed, struggling in its grasp.

Horribly, it opened its fanged mouth and clamped down on Mermista's neck—she screamed in terror.

Her piercing shriek was cut off, and her eyes opened wide—they were now illuminated from within by a dread light. It was deep, a

deep indigo as to be barely perceptible, and it hurt Glimmer's eyes to look at it.

"No!" Glimmer shrieked, holding out her staff towards her friend in need, as she felt clawed hands upon her. She fought against them, but they clung to her with their slimy grip, opening their mouths to sink black fangs into her body.

Glimmer concentrated, summoning a surge of magic and white Star Fire shot from the Star Stone, burning her attackers to dust.

Turning back to her friends, she saw that Entrapta and Scorpia had been subdued by the creatures and they were dragged to the ground, the same dark light in their eyes as Mermista. Mermista was already lying prone, one of the creatures clutching her body as they seemed to sink into the oily slime, reminding Glimmer of a predator returning to its lair with its prey.

Glimmer closed her eyes and summoned all of her fury. The rage was always inside her, but suppressed—she did not want others to see that side of her. But right now, her friends needed her. This was the most desperate of situations, and she let it all run free. She poured it all into the Star Stone, Star Fire issuing out of the top like an eruption. It spread down, over her body—but not burning her.

As she opened her eyes, there was nothing there but the flames.

"GET YOUR FILTHY HANDS OFF OF MY FRIENDS!!!" She shrieked, throwing off her robe to reveal another—the star-studded cloak given to her by Madame Razz.

As she did so, Glimmer spun her body around, staff held out, and the Star Fire swirled around her like a tornado. She stopped twirling her body and stood, holding her staff over her head and moving it circular. The Star Fire continued to rage about her and spread out, engulfing the room in an inferno.

Their attackers shrieked as they were consumed, their bodies disintegrating in the magical flames. The fire danced across the

oily slime, burning it as if it was flammable oil. When all of the fuel for the Star Fire was finally consumed, the flames subsided and died, leaving Glimmer standing, holding her staff out, panting with exertion.

The three previously captured princesses rose to their feet, feeling their bodies for signs of injury. There was a look of genuine fear as Mermista felt at her neck where the creature had latched to her with its fangs, but she sighed with relief when she felt no wounds. All three looked at Glimmer with appreciation.

"I guess we know why you get to be the Queen, Glimmer," Mermista said, not a hint of sarcasm this time. Glimmer winked back at her.

A sudden look of sorrow appeared on Entrapta's face as she looked around the room.

"Aww...there is nothing left for me to get a sample," She whined.

"I see something over there, little buddy," Scorpia said, pointing to an obscure bundle off to the left of the dais. "Maybe it's more creepy stuff you can sample."

Glimmer looked to where Scorpia indicated, raising her staff higher to illuminate it. As she did so, a crimson shimmer could be seen peeking through the folds of the object.

"Where did that come from?" Glimmer wondered aloud as she went to explore this discovery.

"I must have been under the substance covering the floor before Glimmer destroyed it all," Entrapta stated as she followed Glimmer, Scorpia, and Mermista not far behind.

The four princesses approached the strange bundle, and saw it was a pile of ancient and worn rags. Scorpia leaned down to inspect the heap with a tentative claw, drawing a fold of cloth away to reveal what lay beneath—and gasped.

Illuminated by the Star Stone was a skeleton, fanged teeth locked in a grimace as it clutched a long object in its claws. It was a long onyx pole, like a staff, and at the top of the staff was the source of the crimson shimmer—a crystal.

It was a crystal of dark, majestic beauty. Deep blood-red light poured from within its core as motes of blackness danced within. An aura of pulsing un-light surrounded the crystal, but there was nothing sinister or evil about it; just a power, a force of nature and magic.

"That's definitely the Void Gem!" Glimmer said excitedly. "We found it!"

Glimmer reached down and gently pried the newfound Staff of Power from the clutches of the desiccated skeleton. The ancient corpse seemed to release it willingly to her—as if whomever it once had been knew who she was.

She held it up, beaming at Scorpia, then gave Mermista a consoling look.

"Sorry, Mermista, we will find the Kinetic Krystal. I promise." She said to her friend.

Mermista just shrugged. "Whatever…" She said in her distinctive monotone voice. "I'm happy for you, Scorpia," Mermista said, giving Scorpia one of her rare, warm grins.

Something caught Entrapta's eye, and she reached into the folds of the old rags, drawing out a worn satchel. Prising it open with her prehensile ponytails, she drew out a small, cylindrical object.

"Ugh, looks like even Entrapta found something she was looking for," Mermista said, losing her earlier good-natured humor.

"What is it, Entrapta?" Glimmer asked.

"Hmm...looks like some kind of information storage device. I will have to get it back to my lab in Dryl to interface with it." Entrapta

stated, tucking her discovery away into one of her many pockets.

All four princesses turned as they heard a noise behind them, fearing another attack from the slimy creature—but it was only Melog. They padded out of the darkness to sit in front of Glimmer, mewling their report to her in their alien language.

“Well, more good news, guys!” Glimmer said after Melog finished. “Turns out Melog found a way out!”

“Uggghhh...what a relief! I just want to get out of here and off this planet,” Mermista exclaimed dramatically.

Glimmer smiled and turned to Scorpia, holding out the newly found Staff of Power to her.

“Princess Scorpia, may I present to you—The Void Gem!” She said with mock ceremony.

“Wow! Gee, gosh! My very own Staff of Power! Wait until Perfuma sees this!” Scorpia said, holding the staff in her claws awkwardly. “Ohhh! I’m so excited!”

Scorpia gripped the staff tightly in her exuberance, the onyx staff making a brittle sound before breaking into three completely separate pieces.

All four princesses gasped with absolute horror at this outcome.

“Whoops…” was all Scorpia said.

Brother

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora enjoy their honeymoon on Elysia.

Catra meets someone special to her.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora awakened slowly, so slowly, taking her time for once, allowing her awareness to take its time greeting a new day.

She listened to her surroundings, not hearing the usual sounds of Bright Moon; the waters of the bay lapping at the shore, the sounds of the Guard drilling in the courtyard below, the ever-present singing hum of the Moon Stone.

Instead, she heard the soft sounds of wind through leaves, the buzzing of insects, and the cries of animals, as if she were in a forest. Behind it all was faint singing—beautiful, joyous singing—the likes of which she had never heard before.

Until recently.

Adora breathed in, not smelling the early morning smell of Bright Moon's kitchens, the flowers from the garden, or the salt of the sea. She smelled scents of many new and alien things, all indiscernible from each other. Earthy and musky smells competed with strange spicy aromas—there were layers upon layers, and she felt as if she did not have the natural capacity to sort and appreciate them all.

Reaching to her side, she felt around the bed she was currently residing in, feeling the soft bedding and silky smoothness of the fabrics—but that was not what she sought. She wanted to feel the

warm, reassuring body of her friend, soulmate, and now wife, normally soundly asleep next to her.

And usually snoring.

Feeling only an empty space, Adora opened her eyes, peering around the room.

Where is she? She thought as she took in the space.

It was a different bedroom from the one she shared with Catra back in Bright Moon; the smooth, gold-accented pastels she was used to were replaced by wood—beautiful and wonderfully varied wood.

Sitting up, she placed her feet on the mosaic floor—it was made up of purple, red, orange, and green wood, cut into various shapes that fit neatly together. The surrounding walls were composed of interlocking wood planks of a uniform warm honey color; intricate grain patterns stood out in deep brown shades. There were no corners, the walls forming the room into an oblong, organic shape. The walls transitioned smoothly into a domed ceiling made of the same wood as the walls, and placed there haphazardly were recessed alcoves. Adora knew from experience that these were magic light sources which vocal commands could activate.

Along the walls were large round windows;they were all open to allow the night breeze to drift through the room while they slept. Perched in one of the windows was what Adora sought.

Catra.

She was sitting in profile, one arm resting on one bent leg while the other leg dangled over the side, out of view. She had not bothered to dress and was still in the nude, her lengthy hair unbound and free—Adora realized she had never seen it so long before. Catra was staring off into the distance, but not dreamily; she was completely alert—her long black ears perked to catch distant sounds, nose twitching to nearby scents. Her long, stone

gray tail was completely motionless—except for the tip—which rocked back and forth.

To Adora, Catra had never before seemed more wild, beautiful, and *alive*, and she lifted herself from the bed and walked over to be with her wife.

Catra's head jerked towards the movement, startling Adora and making her hesitate. Both of the pupils in Catra's heterochromatic eyes were dilated, and she looked at Adora as if she didn't see her. But the moment quickly passed, and a warm smile appeared on Catra's face.

"Hey, Adora. I thought you would never get out of bed." Catra teased, holding out a hand and turning her body to Adora.

Adora grinned and took Catra's hand, allowing herself to be drawn into a warm morning hug. She felt Catra's arms and legs wrap around her possessively, and she returned the embrace, holding Catra tight with both arms. There was a deep vibrating purr as they kissed, slow and deep, only breaking from the kiss to gaze into each other's eyes.

Adora tried to pull from the embrace, but Catra held her firmly in place, nuzzling her face roughly into Adora's cheek.

"Ow!" Adora complained with a laugh. "Catra, easy! I felt one of your fangs!"

Catra chuckled deeply. "What's the matter, Princess? Can't handle the affection of a Madgēcot?"

Madgēcot. A new word for someone she knew all her life. She never really wondered what exactly Catra was, who her people were. She always took Catra as she was—her friend, then enemy, and ultimately, her lover—now wife. It wasn't until a recent run-in with another of Catra's species on the planet Thenlor that she realized there might be others like Catra.

This Madgēcot—Panga was her name—had helped them in their fight against the Shen'Aan-war by giving them the location of a secret route that would take them directly to their enemy's secret base of operations. It had been instrumental in driving the Shen'Aan-war from their universe, well, at least for a short time…

Panga had also invited Catra to visit their home world, Elysia, to reconnect with her heritage. Interacting with Panga had an unexpected effect on Catra, awakening a hidden desire to know her people. To even possibly find her family and discover why she had been *lost* to them so long ago.

Catra and Adora had realized that such a visit was perfect for them both—a honeymoon after their recent Vow Ceremony back on Etheria. After their Vow ceremony in the now-silent Heart of Etheria was complete and the After-Vow evening celebrations had burned out, both newly-bonded women had said their temporary goodbyes to their friends. They boarded Darla, shooting off for the stars and across the galaxy to find Elysia, a shining emerald in all the dark void. They were enjoying their second day on Elysia, a second day into a beautiful dream.

"How long have you been sitting here on this window sill, Catra?" Adora said as Catra lightly caressed an upper fang along the top of her ear.

"Oh, I don't know, a while. I watched the sunrise. It was so beautiful, Adora!" Catra exclaimed happily.

Adora laughed. She had never seen Catra act this way; it was like she was energized. She had definitely never talked about watching a sunrise before, always exclaiming that such things were idiotic.

Adora caught Catra eyeing her suspiciously. "What?" Catra said, a little annoyed. "You have that dumb look in your eye, like whenever you think I'm being *adorable*."

Adora laughed out loud. “Did you just admit that you are adorable? That’s *sooo* cute!”

“I didn’t—” Catra started angrily, then a slight grin appeared on her face. “I love you, you stupid princess.”

Adora ran her fingers through Catra’s long stone gray hair to its end at her mid-back.

“Catra, this mane of yours...how much longer will you let it grow?” She said, giving Catra’s hair a teasing tug.

Catra gave a playful growl. “I don’t know. I’m definitely not going to cut it as short as Horde Prime cut it—like *your* hair is now.”

Adora smiled and ran her fingers through her short blonde hair; it was a short pixie style with an undercut along the sides.

Catra tilted her head and squinted at Adora, looking at her hair.

“Although, seeing how good it looks on you…” Catra said with a sly grin.

“I’m confused. Are you saying I look good, Catra?” Adora teased.

Catra caressed Adora’s cheek with the tips of her black claws, her eyes hooded and soft as she leaned in.

“I’m saying you are the most beautiful thing I’ve ever seen,” she whispered, pulling Adora in for a kiss.

Adora accepted Catra’s lips and the gentle caress of her tongue, hearing the tone of Catra’s purr change. It took on a faint, trilling edge, very pleasant and musical. It was a purr Adora had never heard Catra make when they were growing up, only after their mutual love had become known to them both—it signified something special.

It meant they wouldn’t be going anywhere for a while.

* * *

Later, as Catra and Adora lay entwined on the bed, a knock was heard from the door.

"GO AWAY!" Catra yelled, then whispered to Adora, "*Can't we put up a sign on the door?*"

"Catra! Be nice!" Adora scolded. "They are our hosts, and so far, they have been pretty good to us. I mean, we did just show up out of nowhere and say, 'Here we are! Can we stay with you for a week or two?'"

Catra smirked at this, then suddenly looked at the door—sniffing. A small smile appeared on her face.

"You're right; we should let him in," she said softly.

Looking strangely at Catra, Adora got out of bed and dressed quickly in a robe.

"Hold on, be there in a sec!" She called as she strode over to the door.

Adora hesitated as she reached the door, unsure how to open it again. It was wood, the same color as the walls, except seven symbols were carved into it, connected by grooved channels. Adora poked at one of the symbols with a tentative finger.

A muffled laugh could be heard through the door, and then a male voice was heard.

"Say, *door open*," the voice said.

This confused Adora even more, and she held her chin in thought.

"If that's how you open it, why didn't it just open when *you* said *door open*?" She said to a loud groan behind her.

Adora turned to see Catra walking from the bed, already dressed in a robe of her own.

"Because it's magic, dummy!" Catra said, exasperated. "*Door open!*" She commanded.

Each symbol flashed with its own light—red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, violet—their illumination spreading out through the channels. When the rainbow lights connected, the door disappeared, revealing their visitor.

Adora was momentarily startled.

Two heterochromatic, slitted eyes peered at her—the left yellow and the right blue. The cinnamon-colored face surrounding the eyes was smiling, exposing upper and lower fangs. Adora saw that the face was framed by a bushy mane of stone gray hair, brown tufts sticking down from long black ears. To top it all off, there were dark freckles on the checks under each eye. It was a face so familiar to Adora, a face she had grown up with—but this was not Catra.

This was Viraj, Catra's twin brother.


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Before landing on the planet, Adora and Catra had explained who they were—the new bearer of She-Ra and a long lost Madgēcot—and the people of Elysia had welcomed them with open arms. It seemed that Panga had relayed a message from Thenlor back to Elysia saying they should expect these visitors, detailing Catra's appearance and using means known only to Madgēcots to explain her scent.

A single Madgēcot recognized these descriptions out of many; Catra's only remaining family—her brother. He was there to greet them upon landing.

"Good morning to you both!" Viraj said in that beautiful lifting accent shared by all Madgēcots.

"Good morning," Adora said, glancing back at her wife.

There was a strange look on Catra's face—like she was shy—and she tilted her head as she looked at Viraj.

"Good morning...Viraj," Catra said as if unsure.

Viraj walked over to Catra and placed both black-clawed hands gently on her shoulders. He leaned in and put his forehead against Catra's.

"Good morning, my sister," he said happily with a purr.

Catra closed her eyes and sniffed, a contented smile appearing on her face as she returned the purr. As Catra opened her eyes back up, Adora was struck by the similarities of the two—Viraj was slightly taller and more masculine—but it was almost like one person was looking in a mirror. The effect of their opposite heterochromia completed this illusion.

Viraj broke the embrace, still smiling, looking at both women.

"I apologize if I am interrupting your time together, it's just that I am so excited to have finally found Sai—" he said, breaking off

and looking unsure at Catra. “To have finally found *my sister*. I could not wait to see her again—I’m sorry.”

Catra shrugged. “It’s okay; we weren’t doing anything,”

Adora almost laughed out loud but stifled it.

“Excellent!” Viraj exclaimed. “I was thinking of taking...Cat-tra to where our family lived. I would love it if you joined us, Adora.”

The thought of seeing this long-lost aspect of Catra’s life filled Adora with excitement, but this changed upon seeing Catra’s face. There was sadness there, and Adora felt her heart break at the thought of what this all must mean for Catra.

“Yeah, I don’t know Viraj, perhaps there is something—” Adora started before being interrupted by Catra.

“That sounds great, Viraj. Let’s go.” She said with a weak smile.

* * *

VIraj led Adora and Catra along a sizable wooden suspension walkway, high up in the great trees of the Jacarandra forest—the place on Elysia where the Madgēcots lived. Catra and Adora held hands as they walked, gazing in wonder at the Madgēcot city around them, the city of Raajadhaanee.

Amongst the gigantic branches of the Jacarandra trees, large wooden structures were nestled or hung, like gigantic seed pods. No two buildings were the same, be it the shape, wood color, or decorations. In fact, nothing the Madgēcots built were alike, as if in abhorrence to conformity. These structures were connected by a web of suspension bridges—like the ones Adora, Catra, and Viraj currently traveled on—and everywhere were the city's residents.

Madgēcots.

They walked, climbed, swung on great ropes, or flew on the backs of great bird-like creatures. They talked, laughed—or in the case

of large merry groups striding about—sung. No two Madgēcots were the same; their fur color and markings were unique to each individual, but they all wore the variations of the same form-fitting outfits Viraj currently wore.

Jaadoo suits, I think they were called, Adora thought to herself, and she took in Viraj.

Like all Jaadoo suits, it covered his entire body below the chin, leaving the hands and feet exposed, and appeared to be composed of interlocking strips of materials. His suit was a dark burgundy, matching the cinnamon color of his fur nicely. Along his upper arms, legs, and entire back were red markings, like stripes, and Adora noticed that these markings were in the same places Catra's stripes were. On his chest, in the same red color, was a symbol, like a star.

Adora and Catra were dressed in their new outfits—a variation of their old clothes but now matching as was the custom of those Vow-Bonded on Etheria.

Catra had on the same deep purple leggings as before, but the burgundy top was now cut off at the midriff, exposing her tummy. The black garment on her shoulders was now replaced by a gold one—with additional gold accents around her lower top and upper leggings.

On Adora was her usual white long sleeve top and gray leggings, but now with a gold collar—similar to Catra's—with gold accents on her shoulders, forearms, and waist. Over her top, she wore Catra's white Star Force jacket—but it was not hers now—the women taking turns sharing the garment.


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A large group of singing Madgēcots passed the newcomers, not alarmed by their strange outfits. They smiled and waved at Adora and Catra as they sang; it was a unique song, in a language neither woman understood.

"What's with all this singing, Viraj?" Catra squinting at the passing group and pursing her lips.

Viraj smiled and waved at the group. "Our people love to sing, my sister, especially on a day like today. You do not like it?"

Catra shrugged and looked away, a little embarrassed. Adora knew her wife enough to know that Catra *did* like the signing, but open expressions of joy were still uncomfortable for her. Growing up in the Horde, such things were always a sign of weakness.

Then why don't I have a problem with it? Adora thought as she smiled and waved at the singing group.

"Viraj, what did you mean, *especially on a day like today?* What is going on?" Adora asked.

"Today is The Roshanee. A very special day." Viraj said almost reverently.

"Annnd you're going to explain what that is, right?" Catra said with a bit of annoyance.

Viraj laughed. "It is like a holiday—a very old one. In fact, it was once celebrated throughout the galaxy. When everyone remembered…" He said, breaking off at the end with a sad look on his face. "It celebrates, or more corrected *celebrated*, the magical harmony of the universe—The Cycle."

Catra gave Adora a look. "Wow, good job answering my question while creating even more questions." She said drolly.

Viraj only laughed, turning to place a black-clawed hand on his sister's shoulder.

"You know, Cat-tra, you really shouldn't be *so sarcastic* all the time. I know you have a tender heart buried in your chest. What happened on this Etheria to make you this way?" Viraj asked kindly.

Catra pushed his hand from her shoulder, but not roughly. "Perhaps I will tell you another time, Viraj. It's a long story. A long sad story."

Viraj looked at Adora, concern plainly written on his face. She gave Catra's hand a gentle squeeze.

"It was a story with a not-so-great beginning, but I believe it had a great ending." She said while looking into Catra's eyes, pouring all her intentions through that gaze. It had its desired effect, and Catra grinned back at her, returning the gentle squeeze.

Viraj, seeing the love between the two women, nodded and smiled.

"Yes, I believe it." He said softly. "Well, my sister, I apologize if my answer only added further confusion. Not to purposely repeat your words, but the details of what happened to our once great galactic society is a long sad story as well. I will tell you everything, but not today. Not on the day of The Roshanee. Not on the day I finally take you to our home."

The three continued their journey through the city of Raajadhaanee, going through a series of additional suspension bridges, only stopping when a particular shop or sight caught their eye. Finally, as they reached the city edge, they began ascending a series of stairs and ladders until finally, they came to the treetops. Adora gasped as she took in the view above the trees.

The Jacarandra forest seemed to go on forever; the green tops of the great Jacarandra trees were more like great rolling hills than trees. The way the morning breeze drifted over the giant green plums created the illusion of dance—it was so beautiful and peaceful that Adora felt her eyes moisten with tears.

In the distance, she saw a prominent parting in the forest, but it did not appear as a dark hole. There was light emanating from the break—beautiful multicolored light.

“Hey Viraj, what’s in that kind of dip in the trees over there, where the light is coming from?” Adora said while pointing her finger.

Viraj didn’t bother looking at where Adora indicated, only smiled at her. “That, my dear Adora, is where the Great Chaliendra Tree resides.” He said happily.

“Great Chaliendra tree?” Catra said dubiously. “How is it great when it looks like it must be smaller than all the other trees?”

Viraj gave a bark of laughter. “Oh, my sister...The Chaliendra tree’s greatness comes not from its size. Tonight, you will see when we gather around the Chaliendra to sing the song of The Roshanee. You will see its greatness then.”

“Great, more singing,” Catra said, rolling her eyes at Adora.

Viraj sighed audibly and led them in the direction of a small wooden structure, perched on the end of one of the tips of the uppermost branches. To Adora, it appeared to be a small, round house, sitting in a field of green grass. It looked like a beautiful place to live.

Viraj strode up the short flight of stairs and placed his hand on the door.

“I am home.” He whispered.

Like the other door, this one disappeared in a flash of rainbow light. Viraj turned to the two women and indicated they should enter with him.

“This was our parents’ home, Cat-tra. It became my home after they...disappeared.” He said with a sad smile. “This is your home too, my sister. Please come in.”

Adora followed Catra up the stairs and into the home, letting her eyes adjust to the light of the space. It was a comfortable, cozy home, definitely suited for Catra's people. There was an ample open circular space, well lit by a series of windows. In one corner was a small kitchen. Along the upper circumference of the main room were a series of large holes, presumably leading to other smaller spaces. Below these holes were long, vertical wooden planks with the same symbols as the door inscribed in them.

Adora looked at Catra; she was taking in the entire space with wide eyes and ears lowered. As her head turned, Adora saw her nose twitch as she took in the scents of her old home—there was recognition in her eyes.

"Well, my sister, I know you were very small when you left us, but do you recognize it?" Viraj asked hopefully.

Catra nodded very slowly. "Yes...Viraj, I think I do. Not the way it looks, though, but the smell. I think I recognize that."

Catra walked slowly toward one of the planks leading to the upper passage and placed a tentative hand against it, feeling the surface. Then, leaning forward, she sniffed it.

"That was our parent's room, wasn't it, Viraj?" She asked, looking up as her tail began to twitch rapidly.

Viraj walked to stand next to her, placing a comforting hand on her shoulder.

"Yes, it was. Would you like to go up?" He said with raised eyebrows.

Catra nodded, and Viraj started to climb the plank with his hand and foot claws. Without hesitation, Catra followed behind. Adora noticed that the symbols glowed with magic power as they rose, and a shimmering rainbow haze appeared over the plank. Upon closer inspection, she saw no claw marks—either the holes were magically repaired, or the two Madgēcots had climbed the magic field created by the symbols.

“Wowww…” Adora exclaimed, then realized her predicament. “Uh, guys, I don’t have claws.” She called.

Viraj laughed, poking his head over the edge to peer down at Adora.

“You don’t need them; just pretend like you do and climb!” He called down.

Adora curled the fingers on both hands and placed them against the board—the magic field immediately appeared—holding her hands firmly. Adora laughed aloud as she held her weight with her hands; she felt weightless.

“Hey, guys! Look at me; I’m a Madgēcot!” Adora yelled to the true Madgēcots as she climbed up.

Near the top, she found Catra watching her with an amused look, holding out her hand. Adora took it and was pulled neatly up to stand next to her wife.

“Can you please not embarrass me in front of my long-lost brother, Adora?” She teased.

“Embarrassed?!” Adora said, pretending to be offended. “Just be glad I didn’t turn into She-Ra and jump up here, sword in hand.”

Viraj instantly looked interested, and his long black ears perked up.

“I would very much like to see that!” He exclaimed.

“Oh man, please don’t encourage her,” Catra said, giving her brother a gentle nudge.

“Adora is a HUGE show-off, and once she pulls her sword out, you can kiss this house goodbye!” Catra emphasized this by pretending to hold a sword, swinging it wildly around her, and making a goofy face.

“Catra!!!” Adora said, now genuinely incensed.

She tamped down on her hurt feelings as she saw the raw emotion hiding behind Catra’s façade—she was in pain and trying to manage it with humor.

Adora just shook her head and chuckled.

Viraj seemed not to notice the interplay between the two women, still looking with interest at Adora.

“I am serious, though, Adora. I hope I am not being disrespectful, but I would like to see you as She-Ra. If you get the chance, that is.” He said with some embarrassment.

Adora shrugged. “Sure, but when we are outside again. I kinda get big when I turn into She-Ra, don’t want to go knockin’ any holes in tha’ ceiling.” She said with a laugh.

Viraj didn’t laugh, only stared at Adora with awe.

“Anyway, shall we move on?” Catra asked dryly, indicating the direction they were headed with a pointed clawed finger.

“Ah, yes!” Viraj said, continuing down the passage.

The hall was like a round, wooden tube; the bottom was flat to walk on, and at the end, there was a round room—the bedroom. It was a simple space; a large bed faced a wall with expansive windows looking out over the treetop landscape. On a small table near the bed were photographs framed in an unknown woven material. Catra sat on the bed near the table and picked up one of the framed images. She stared at it with an obscure expression on her face.

Adora sat next to Catra on the bed, Viraj seated on the opposite side and looked at the picture her wife held.

It was of two happy Madgēcots, each holding a small, blanket-wrapped bundle. Looking closely at the bundles, Adora saw two

cinnamon-colored faces poking out, blue and yellow heterochromatic eyes looking with wonder at the world.

Viraj reached over and gently caressed the image. "Mama and Dama, they loved us very much, Cat-tra."

Adora saw a drop of moisture splash against the clear surface of the framed picture; looking up, she saw tears in Catra's eyes. Adora wrapped a comforting arm around her wife, laying her head against stone-gray hair.

Adora looked at Catra's parents, seeing the similarities between them and their children. The one on the left, their Mama, had cinnamon-colored fur and blue eyes; the other, their Dama, had light brown fur, black ears, and yellow eyes. The stone-gray hair appeared to be a combination of the Mother's white-blond hair and the Dama's black hair.

"What were they like, Viraj?" Catra, her voice once again in a whisper.

"Hmm...I never got to know them as an adult. I was still so small when they disappeared. All I remember is their love—it was strong." Viraj said, tears beginning to fall.

Adora couldn't help herself; she had to ask the question that was burning in her mind the whole time since she and Catra had arrived on Elysia.

"I remember the day when I was very little—when Catra showed up. Shadow Weaver—she was like our mother figure, I guess—" Adora said before being interrupted by Catra.

"A *toxic* mother figure," Catra said sourly.

"Yeah, anyway, Shadow Weaver showed up with a large cardboard box and plopped it down in front of the other children and me, saying, 'Here is your new playmate.' But we never knew where she came from. What happened to separate Catra from your family, Viraj?"

Viraj shook his head. “No one knows; she just disappeared from the bedroom she and I shared. Whoever took her left me alone. According to our Jaadoogar—our strongest magic users—there was a powerful burst of magic the night she disappeared. They had never seen anything like it before.”

Both Catra and Adora were silent, thinking of the implications of what Viraj said.

“What happened to them?” Catra asked, still in a whisper.

“According to our parent's friends, they heard of a rumor of your location and left the planet, not telling anyone of their destination. They never returned.” He said sadly.

“So, who took care of you, Viraj?” Adora asked.

“The same friends of our parents. They raised me as their own. But I still...it was not the same. Even surrounded by our people, I have felt alone—like I was missing something else. It is the main reason I became a Star Hunter; to hopefully find our parents and you, Cat-tra,” Viraj said, touching the symbol on his chest.

Catra reached over and took Viraj’s hand, surprising Adora, and earnestly looked into her brother’s heterochromatic eyes.

“You not alone anymore, my… *brother*. You have *me.*” Catra, smiling at her twin.

Viraj beamed back at his sister, tears in his eyes.

Once again, Adora was reminded of why she loved Catra so much. Even though she had the worst deal of the two—being abducted and raised in a toxic environment which initially put her on the path of evil—Catra was reaching past her pain to someone in need.

Catra had come a long way.

Chapter End Notes

Viraj illustration done by Henar Torinos

Catra and Adora illustration done by @Ansdrela_Art

Catra's Song

Chapter Summary

An unexpected visitor arrives at Elysia.

Catra and Adora visit the Great Chaliendra Tree.

Adora learns that Catra has a hidden talent.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Veth stared out of the forward viewport of the unarmed shuttle, taking in the view of the lush green orb that greeted them as they came out of hyperspace. They stood behind the two pilots controlling the spaceship, one of them announcing their intentions as they approached the planet, Elysia.

"This is a delegation from the Empyrean Hegemony, here on a mission of peace. We have an ambassador sanctioned by the Archon Lethe to discuss a truce with the Madgēcot Empire." One of the pilots stated officially into the intercom.

"Uh...well, there is no Madgēcot Empire here," a voice replied. By the lyrical tone, it sounded like a Madgēcot was speaking. "Only the planet Elysia and its free people. The Madgēcots do not rule here,"

Veth snorted in derision. *Madgēcot liars, so bold as to openly deny their rule.*

Their mind went to the 'gift' they brought—wrapped in a gold cloth and slung at their back. They remembered Archon Lethe's words before their departure.

The Madgēcots will not trust your motives—and rightfully so. But when they see what you bring to them, they will not be able to

resist letting you land. Their need for their ancient heritage will be too great.

"You have a lot of nerve coming here on the day of The Roshanee, Fallen Ones. Hear this: we are not in the mood for your tricks or deceptions," The Madgēcot said over the speaker.

Veth suppressed their sudden spike in anger—but the Madgēcot was right. Both pilots plus the other eight members of their diplomatic entourage were part of the Krypteia—elite warriors trained to fight either alone or as a band. They hated that they had to demean themselves with subterfuge; they were trying to trick the Madgēcots into trusting them.

But the Madgēcots would see through this, recognizing fellow warriors under the clothing of diplomats. They would be on alert and suspicious of a direct attack—too bad they would not see their true motives until it was too late.

They were going to Elysia to complete two goals. The first was to bring the power of She-Ra to the side of the Empyrean Hegemony. Trickery was also involved with this plan, but it was for a good cause. According to the Archon, this woman who bore the She-Ra was under the influence of the Madgēcots and needed to be guided to The Light.

They thought sourly to themselves about the other part of the plan*. I do not like what we must do; it does not sit right with me. I feel that Zhe-La will fight against me on this.*

"Champion Veth," one of the pilots said, breaking Veth from their thoughts. "The Elysians are refusing to let us land."

Veth laid a hand on the pilot's shoulder and nodded at them.

"Let me speak to them," Veth said.

The pilot nodded back and pressed the button to re-open the channel.

“Greetings from Empyrea and the Archon Lethe. This is Veth speaking, bearer of Zhe-La and champion of The Light. As we have stated, we are on a mission of peace, but we understand that you may not trust us. Relations have been strained between our people,” Veth said, forcing a smile in their voice.

“That’s an understatement,” The voice replied over the intercom.

Veth laughed. “Yes, but we are here to try and put that behind us. Besides parley for peace, I am here to bring a gift to the Madgēcots, something they have lost long ago.”

“And that is?” The Madgēcot said suspiciously.

The smile disappeared, and a faint pained expression appeared on Veth’s lilac-colored face.

“We bear tidings of Sher-Va,”

* * *

Adora and Catra followed Viraj along the stone path zigzagging along the forest floor of the Jacarandra Forest. The trail appeared ancient and worn, presumably from thousands of years of clawed Madgēcot feet walking upon it.

The forest floor was covered in rolling, lush moss, and here and there, white flowers bloomed in the shafts of light created by breaks in the forest canopy. The effect of having the mighty tree branches interlocking so snugly high above them gave Adora the impression of being in a cave—a magical and beautiful cave.

“As you can imagine, Madgēcots don’t spend too much time on the ground,” Viraj said with a laugh. “But when we visit The Chaliendra, we travel this way.”

Catra stopped to squat down by the path’s edge, reaching out to pick one of the white flowers. With a smile, she stood up and held it out to Adora, who took it with a sweet laugh and placed it in her hair behind an ear.

“Cat-tra, you should know that the Saphed flowers are irritants and can cause severe itching, not a good gift for your wife,” Viraj said with alarm.

“What!? Now you tell me!?” Catra shrieked, but Adora saw the hint of a grin on Viraj’s cinnamon face—she recognized that look.

Adora pulled the flower quickly from her hair and pretended to start itching.

“Oh, man! It's starting already! It’s itching like crazy!” She yelled.

Catra’s eyes widened, and her tail bushed up with fear, but once she saw Adora’s face, her eyes became hooded with suspicion. She then chuckled to herself, crossing her arms.

“Ugh, you got me,” she said with a grin. “Adora gave it away, Viraj; you should know she is a terrible actor, by the way.”

“I’m getting better!” Adora protested halfheartedly, lunging for Catra and placing her in a headlock while Catra struggled to fight her off. They both fell over into the moss, wrestling and giggling.

Viraj laughed at the antics between the two women, but then a look of momentary sadness passed over his handsome features, disappearing just as quickly.

Adora stood up from the moss, holding out her hand to Catra and plucking her up onto the walkway.

“Hey Viraj, do you have anyone? Like someone special?” Adora asked, still smiling.

Viraj shook his head gently. “No, the work of the Star Hunters keeps me busy. I don’t have much time for a relationship, sadly. I have two friends, fellow Star Hunters, who became married and had a little girl—”

“Well, brother, sounds like it worked out for them. Hey, I know this guy back home, a good friend of mine. I should introduce

you.” Catra said.

Viraj looked sadly at his sister. “You didn’t let me finish. My friend’s little girl died while they were both on a mission; their bond broke not too long after that. Panga threw herself into a dangerous mission on Thenlor—I heard you both ran into her. Maira is still a Star Hunter as well, but she is an angry woman. Not a good thing for a Madgēcot. You may see her at The Chaliendra Tree.”

Catra and Adora looked downcast at hearing of their friend Panga’s tragic history, her single-minded drive to fight on Thenlor suddenly making sense.

“But that does not mean I wouldn’t be interested in meeting your friend, Cat-tra,” Viraj said with a sly grin, exposing a single fang. “He should just be made to understand I’m not looking to settle.”

Catra laughed. “Well, in that case, I should keep him away from you. Shen kinda gets attached. He’s like me in that way.”

Viraj shrugged, and with a twitch of his stone-gray tail, turned and continued to lead Catra and Adora to The Great Chaliendra Tree. He turned his head to look back at Catra as she and Adora followed him, giving her a measuring stare.

“Did you give any thought to what we spoke of? Of accepting your true Madgēcot name… *Saira*?” Viraj said with a single raised eyebrow.

Catra shook her head vigorously. “No. That’s not my name, Viraj. Sorry, but my name is Catra.”

Viraj held up his hands in placation. “Sorry, but I had to try. Cat-tra just seems like such a derogatory name, my sister. A very unfortunate Madgēcot name.”

“Well, I’m a very unfortunate Madgēcot,” Catra grumbled in reply.

Viraj's ears lowered, and he spun around, grasping Catra by the shoulders, startling her with bared fangs.

"*You are not unfortunate, Cat-tra!* There is nothing unfortunate about being a Madgēcot or being alive!" He said, now buffering his initial intensity with a kind smile. "Again, I do not know what happened to you on this planet, Etheria, but I swear, before you leave, I will show you what it means to be a Madgēcot. I swear this on The Great Chaliendra Tree!"

"Okay! Okay!" Catra said sheepishly, trying to brush her brother off. "I get it. Can we lay off this touchy-feely stuff now?"

"Ha!" Viraj exclaimed, releasing Catra and whirling back around. "You have not seen touchy-feely yet, Cat-tra. Just wait until you hear The Song," Viraj said mysteriously.

Catra looked at Adora dubiously, only receiving a shrug in return.

Adora and Catra continued to follow Viraj through the beauty of the Jacarandra forest in silence, taking in the sights while clasping hands. Behind the aesthetic beauty of the forest, there was magical beauty; there was so much magic! Adora could feel it resonating within her, the metaphysical nature of She-Ra responding to it like a soft heartbeat. This feeling grew stronger as Viraj took them deeper into the forest, moving steadily towards The Great Chaliendra Tree.

As they got closer to their destination, the spacing between trees began to decrease, as did the diameter of the trees. It was as if the forest was slowly forming into a protective barrier. As they neared the end of their journey, the trees began to crowd so close to each other, bending and twisting together like vines so that they formed a wall to either side of the stone path.

"We are almost there," Viraj whispered to them reverently.

In a bend in the path ahead, Adora saw the same beautiful rainbow-colored light she glimpsed from Catra's old home, reflecting off the tree barrier enclosing them. Faint murmuring

could be heard as if a million voices were speaking at once—lyrical, joyous voices.

Finally, Adora and Catra saw a kaleidoscope of prismatic rainbows at the end of their path. The shimmering colors took a solid form as Catra, Adora and Viraj cleared the tree barrier.

The Great Chaliendra Tree.

It was shaped like any of the Jacarandra trees of the forest, though smaller in stature. But what it lacked in size, The Great Chaliendra Tree made up for with pure magical beauty.

Instead of the gray bark and dark green leaves of the Jacarandra trees, The Chaliendra was composed of pure magical light; shimmering up and down the length of the trunk, up along the branches, and to the tips of every leaf. It was a soft, pure light—not hurting the eyes to look upon but gently holding the gaze in a comforting caress.

Looking around The Great Chaliendra Tree and to the leafy barrier surrounding it —which formed a large amphitheater, Adora saw the source of the voices.

Madgēcots were sitting in the vine branches on the interlocking trees, thousands upon thousands of Madgēcots. They perched on the branches alone or in small groups—chatting or singing their own individual songs. As the sun set and the sky darkened overhead, their many-colored eyes gleamed, reflecting the rainbow light of the Chaliendra.

Just below the sounds of the Madgēcot voices, Adora just barely heard another sound, like a faint chiming song. The sound of it made her heart ache with its beauty, and looking down, Adora saw the heart rune on her chest was fully lit, burning brighter than she had ever seen it.

Not too far away were the only Madgēcots with feet on the ground; each of them shared the same star symbol on their Jaadoo suits as Viraj—Star Hunters. They stood in a large group,

discussing an issue of great importance. Three Madgēcots gestured animatedly, as if in an argument, while an elder Madgēcot of obvious importance stood silently listening. A slightly worried scowl was on her face as she nodded to something said to her, her gray tipped tail twitching in agitation.

"Uh, hold on a second, Adora and Cat-Tra," Viraj said, indicating with open hands that they should wait. "It appears something is agitating my fellow Star Hunters. I will be back."

Adora and Catra nodded to him, still holding hands while they waited, taking in the glory of the Great Chaliendra Tree. Adora watched Catra out of the corner of her eye, seeing how her wife gazed with wonder at her people's most sacred object.

She had noticed subtle changes in Catra during their brief visit to Elysia—every single one of them good. Sure, Catra may have been the same woman who said to her brother, 'Can we lay off the touchy-feely stuff?' but there were signs that she was opening herself up more, opening her heart.

Adora had noticed that while being on her actual home planet, being in her native forests and around her people, Catra seemed more vibrant—like there was something finally feeding her hurt soul, nourishing it back to life. Being on Elysia seemed natural for Catra, which could mean only one thing…

For the time being, Adora rejected that train of thought as Viraj strode away from the group of Star Hunters with a strange look on his face—a mixture of hope and worry.

"What was that all about Viraj?" Catra asked her brother as he rejoined them.

Viraj pursed his lips, looking at Adora and Catra as if unsure if he should tell them.

"Well, it seems we have visitors," Viraj began tentatively. "Visitors from another world called Empyrea, the Empyrean Hegemony."

“The Empyrean Hegemony?” Adora said dubiously. “Sounds kind of ominous.”

Viraj nodded at her and sighed. “Yeah. They were once just called the Nephraeh—we, the Madgēcots, were very close with them, and we shared much. That was before...something happened to them,” he said with a pained expression.

“Like what?” Catra said, prodding Viraj to tell the whole tale.

“I don’t know my sister; no one does. The Nephraeh were once called the *Light of the Universe* by every race who knew them. Their empathy and goodness matched that of the Madgēcots, but slowly, they seemed to lose that goodness over time, and they became...colder.”

“I mentioned that once there was a wondrous galactic society, well, the Nephraeh were like the glue that held us together. Around the time they started to lose themselves, they were the first to suggest uniting everyone under an Empire—which we did. For a time, things were good under the Empire, but then the fighting started when Horde Prime rebelled and started his civil war. When the Empire started losing to Horde Prime’s vast fleet, the Nephraeh retreated and secluded themselves on their planet of Empyrea, answering no calls for aid.”

“Those were the dark times, the years of Horde Prime’s dominance over the universe and our constant struggle to keep him at bay. We were isolated on our planet through this time, knowing very little about the rest of the galaxy, but we never forgot. We never forgot our friends, the Nephraeh.”

“Then *you* came,” Viraj said, grasping Adora on the shoulder. “Bringing my sister with you from wherever Etheria had been lost. With the love between you, you managed to release the magic of Etheria and defeat Horde Prime, freeing us all. Yes, the Madgēcots know all about this.”

“It was a wonderful time, so much hope after almost a millennium of just trying to survive—then they came to us. The Nephraeh returned to us out of the darkness, from their secluded part of the galaxy, looking to re-establish a connection with us. We welcomed them at first, overjoyed that they returned to us, but then we saw what they had become over those long dark years.”

“They are now the opposite of what they once were, devoid of all their empathy. They spoke to us of their *Light*—a twisted outlook on the universe based on a lack of compassion and total order—much like the *Light* Horde Prime spoke of. They were looking to spread their vision to the rest of the galaxy, starting with Elysia.”

“The Madgēcots and the rest of the people of Elysia rejected them, promising to block them from passing our territory and spreading their poison to a galaxy just recovering from thousands of years of terror. We have been fighting with them ever since…”

Viraj finished his story with a downcast look in his eyes; his ears lowered in sadness.

“I’m sorry, the tale of the Nephraeh’s fall is so sad for the Madgēcots.” He said.

Adora placed a hand on his shoulder, giving it a gentle squeeze. “Well, if they are here to start trouble, She-Ra will be here to kick them to the same place she sent Horde Prime.” She said with a cocky smile. Viraj chuckled at this, placing his black-clawed hand over hers.

“I don’t think that will be necessary, Adora. Well, I hope it isn’t,” he said with a shrug. “You see, they have just entered our orbit saying they would like to meet with us, to talk about peace.”

“Oh...” Adora said, unsure. “Well, do you trust them?”

Viraj shook his head firmly. “No, not one bit.”

“Don’t let them land then! You should shoot them out of the sky!” Catra said with a hint of anger.

Viraj raised an eyebrow at his sister. "I guess that is one way to handle them, Cat-tra. There's just one problem. They may have something we want, something we thought we lost long ago—the sword of Sher-Va."

Catra and Adora looked confused by this proclamation, and Viraj continued his tale when he saw their questioning faces.

"Back in ancient times, during the good times when the universe was united, there were magical champions, one for each of the Prime Magical planets—Eternia had He-Man, Etheria had She-Ra. Well, Elysia had their champion called Sher-Va. Sher-Va was a magical champion specific not only to Elysia, but to the Madgēcots as well." Viraj said wistfully.

"Wowww!" Adora exclaimed. "Really? What did they look like?"

Viraj laughed. "Well, you have asked the right person; I'm kind of an expert on Sher-Va. I've been obsessed ever since I was a little boy, and I will show you some old images I have when we revisit my home."

"So, what happened to your champion, this Sher-Va? And why do these Nephraeh creeps have their sword?" Catra asked.

Viraj shrugged. "No one knows what happened to Sher-Va. The bearer at the time was a Madgēcot named Jihan. It was during the time of the Empire when the magical champion's powers were bound to rune swords, so when he disappeared, so did Sher-Va."

Adora and Catra looked thoughtful at Viraj's words; it was a lot to take in.

"So, what happens now with the Nephraeh? Are you going to make a deal with them or something?" Catra asked her brother.

"I am not sure yet, sister. Their delegation was told to wait in orbit until tomorrow after The Roshanee is over. We will deal with them then," Viraj answered.

Adora noticed Viraj looked unsettled by this, and she didn't blame him. She couldn't imagine if someone like Horde Prime held She-Ra hostage and used it as a bargaining chip.

"Hey, listen," she said, placing her hands on his shoulders and staring into his heterochromatic eyes. "Whatever happens, just know you have She-Ra on your side."

Viraj smiled thankfully to her and nodded. An unfocused look appeared in his eyes as he cocked his head and looked up.

"It is starting soon; we must be quiet," he whispered to them.

Looking up to see what caught Viraj's attention, Adora saw that it was now fully night, the three moons of Elysia gleaming in the sky above The Great Chaliendra Tree. They were moving slowly towards each other— a triple lunar eclipse—and as they neared, the faint whispering song intensified to a low hum. It was easier to hear now, for all the Madgēcots had gone silent.

Peering around, Adora saw glittering eyes all around her, intently focused on the Chaliendra, long ears twitching this way and that—as if they were antennas, trying to find the right frequency. Looking at her wife, Adora saw that Catra was staring at the luminous tree, her head cocked, her ears strained as she tried to hear the song.

Then, a single Madgēcot voice, way up and out of sight, perched in the trees, started singing. It was the most beautiful song Adora had ever heard, in an entirely incomprehensible language. It was a language not meant to be spoken or understood logically but one of pure emotion and beauty.

It was pure magic.

Slowly at first, a few Madgēcots joined the lone voice, singing in complete harmony, strengthening the song with their voices. Then others joined the chorus more rapidly, their white fangs bared joyously as they began their song, all the while holding out clawed fingertips toward the great tree of light.

The entire space surrounding The Great Chaliendra Tree was now filled with the song; it was overwhelming. Adora could feel its power like a force driving into her flesh down to her bones, into her very soul. The light of The Chaliendra was now pulsing in harmony with the song, and Adora felt tears pouring from her eyes.

Then, a single voice joined the mighty symphony. It startled Adora, for she recognized that voice. She turned to the person next to her.

It was Catra.

Her hands were held out as she gazed at the tree, mouth open in song as Catra sang with her people and the sacred tree. Tears welled in her eyes as she sang—it was so beautiful to Adora. It was a sight that she never before imagined that she would ever see in her lifetime.



The words of Catra's song were the same as the others, but where theirs were joyous, hers was sad. It was a song of early childhood pain, loneliness, and abandonment. Then slowly, her song changed. It became one of comfort and acceptance; Adora didn't understand the song's words, but she knew the content; it was a song about Catra's friendship with her.

The emotion changed again, slowly taking on another form, the feeling of Catra's friendship for Adora changed. It took on a sweeter sound, tentative and fragile, which over time strengthened, solidifying into an ultimate emotion.

It was love. It was Catra falling in love with Adora when they were still so young, during that sensitive time when their bodies started to bloom. This realization struck Adora, making her realize that Catra had been secretly in love with her for so much longer than she initially thought.

This secret love, the song of this beautiful emotion, took on hints of another—fear. Its sound covered the love like static until it congealed into a recognizable form.

It was fear of rejection, of Adora finding out Catra's secret love and pushing her away.

Oh, Catra, Adora thought fervently. *I wish I knew. I understand why you didn't tell me, but I wish I knew.*

Catra's song continued in this vein until it came crashing down into base and dark emotions all at once—confusion, sadness, fear, betrayal, and anger. Fury and pain were on Catra's face as she bared her fangs as if to bite the very air as she sang.

Adora did not regret leaving the Horde—she would do it again in an instant—but to hear the pain in Catra's voice made her feel as if she was experiencing her departure from Catra's point of view. It hurt her heart, giving her great empathy for what Catra went through. Adora wanted to reach out and hold her wife, but she

didn’t want to disturb Catra’s song. She felt that it was important that Catra finish it.

Her song continued along the course of the rest of Catra’s time in the Horde—without Adora. The anger turned into a great and terrible shame and then into absolute hopelessness. Catra momentarily ceased singing and gritted her teeth as she relived the old pain, tears flowing down her eyes, and hugged herself. Adora could not help herself, and she went to console her wife when Catra pulled herself up straight, continuing the song with a look of firm resolve.

The hopelessness was replaced by numbness, Catra’s voice taking on a monotone as she expressed this. The numbness turned to anger once more—but the anger was different this time. It was hazy and ethereal, its direction not focused, and it swirled around another, one that she had sung in the beginning.

It was the comfort and acceptance again, and this dampened down the anger, almost smothering it—but not entirely.

This must be after we rescued her from Horde Prime; when we shared that meal on Darla, Adora thought to herself.

These positive feelings continued—these feelings of friendship—becoming more focused on a single point. Or person.

Me, Adora thought. *She’s coming back to her feelings of friendship for me. Like she’s coming full circle.*

It was then that Adora realized that another tone was still present in the song, very faint but still there—perhaps it was there the whole time Catra sang of her pain. It was the sweeter sound, always just under the surface, the love that never left Catra’s heart, even when they were enemies.

As if sensing Adora’s attention, Catra turned from The Chaliendra and focused on her wife. With a smile on her lips and in her eyes, Catra continued to sing, holding out her hands to Adora.

As she locked hands with her wife, Adora realized what was happening. Through song, Catra was telling her life's story to The Great Chaliendra Tree—cementing it into the very magical fabric of Elysia. She was weaving herself into the rich tapestry of her people's heritage, now forever bound to them and the planet.

Adora could see that the act of doing this was somehow a catharsis for Catra. It was as if The Great Chaliendra Tree was holding Catra's pain for her, like a friend sharing a burden with you.

Adora returned to her earlier train of thought—how alive and more vibrant Catra had been since arriving on Elysia—and she let her mind reach the conclusion that she tried to ignore earlier.

Catra belonged on Elysia, not Etheria.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Catra done by @Ansdrela_Art

Grayskull

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer visits nearby Eternia to rescue the boys from a place called Castle Grayskull.

Glimmer sat crossed-legged, eyes closed, the staff that held the Star Stone lying across her lap with her hands resting gently on the shaft. Her mind relaxed and let go of the day-to-day issues of being Queen of an entire planet, letting those stresses seep back and out of her consciousness. She unfocused on the string of minutiae that took up so much of her physical reality, refocusing on her metaphysical existence.

She let her spirit rise out of her body and out of the tower her body resided in, into the sky and beyond, the power of the Star Stone allowing her to reach beyond the planet of her birth. She sped past moons and planets, her spirit form gaining speed the farther she traveled from her body, stars and other celestial bodies appearing as streaks to her spiritual vision.

Finally, sensing her destination as a vibration through her essence, Glimmer stopped her journey, turning with spirit eyes to gaze upon a hazy swirl of velvet blues and purples.

Her galaxy appeared so beautiful and peaceful from this point of view, encompassing so many planets with so many lives that it was impossible to comprehend it all. In her current form, she could see the spirit of life in this galaxy, connecting through lines of faint magic to one another. Here and there were bright nodes where the presence of magic and life was strongest.

Some were recognizable, the brightest being the dual planets of Eternia and Etheria, burning like a beacon in the dark. On the opposite side of the galaxy, she could see Elysia, where her best friends Catra and Adora were. There were other bright flames, unrecognizable, for they had not been discovered...yet. It made

Glimmer realize the magnitude of her task; to bring magic to the galaxy.

One point caught Glimmer's eye, not too far from Elysia and at the tip of the galactic arm opposite from the one Etheria was in. It gained her attention, not for its brilliance but for its deadness. It was odd, for it appeared to her spirit eye not only as a point of darkness, but as an intense source of un-light, entirely at odds with the rest of the galaxy. She noticed that it was not connected by the web of magic and light she saw in the rest of the galaxy—tendrils of its un-light sprung from its source like tentative vines, questing to take root elsewhere.

We should focus our attention there before we try to continue our task to discover more magic, Glimmer thought to herself. *If that point is allowed to spread, it will create significant problems for us in the future.*

"HEL-LLOOO??!!" A tremendous cosmic voice boomed. It was so intense that Glimmer's astral form snapped back into her body so suddenly that she screamed aloud.

Coming back into herself, Glimmer found herself on her back, staring at a high, vaulted ceiling. She was back in the observatory she had made for herself at the top of one of the many Bright Moon towers. It was her personal space, intended as a place of seclusion in which she could explore her new powers granted by the Star Stone.

Her observatory was filled with books, crystals, potion racks, star charts, a telescope, and even a model of an unknown solar system—an orrery—magically floating silently above her. Some of the items came from Glimmer's recent travels amongst the stars, but most had been taken from Madame Razz's shack. Sitting on a nearby scrying table was the three-eyed skull that Glimmer had come across when she first visited Madame Razz's shack. Glimmer took comfort from having the older woman's things nearby. It; it also seemed fitting that she would have them. After all, she was Madame Razz's successor.

Picking herself up, Glimmer looked around her observatory to see who had disturbed her meditations. She hoped it was Bow, finally returning from his mission to nearby Eternia. He, Swiftwind, and Seahawk had accompanied Shen to check out an old castle on the outskirts of Eternos, some mysterious place called Castle Grayskull. They still had not come back, and she was starting to get worried.

Instead of Bow's happy, handsome face to greet her, Glimmer found Entrapta poking her head through the half-open door. She gazed at Glimmer with curious violet eyes.

"Sorry, am I interrupting something?" Entrapta asked innocently.

"No, nothing galaxy-shattering." Glimmer said with a sigh, picking up her staff and coming to her feet.

"Great!" Entrapta cried as she opened the door fully and came into the room. True to her nature, Entrapta was immediately distracted by the items in Glimmer's observatory.

Glimmer watched her friend zip around, trying to take in as much as possible and as quickly as possible. She gave a very audible *ahem* when Entrapta raised herself on her ponytails, about to touch the massive orrery floating above them. Entrapta stopped herself and looked at Glimmer questioningly.

"Please don't touch that. It was found in some ancient ruins on the planet Antar. It took me, Castaspella, and my father a whole month to correctly align it." Glimmer said.

"Oh! Well, I noticed it was misaligned," She said, pulling out a small delicate instrument from her coveralls. "It just needs a small...little...tweak!"

Before Glimmer could protest, Entrapta jabbed the instrument at a brass sphere, sending it on a slightly different orbit. Glimmer cringed and gritted her teeth as the floating model of a planet swung in a wide arc—barely missing the representation of the dual suns in the middle—and finally came to rest at its new orbit.

Much to her chagrin, Glimmer had to admit that there was something more appealing about the orb's new path—it appealed to her inner sense of balance and harmony.

"Huh, it does look better, Entrapta." Glimmer conceded.

Entrapta crossed her arms and gave her a smug look, wiggling her eyebrows knowingly.

"Well, Entrapta, I assume you didn't come all the way over here just to realign my orrery. What did you need?" Glimmer asked.

A look of momentary confusion passed over Entrapta face before being replaced by a sudden realization.

"Ah-ha! Yes, that's right. Yesterday, when we came back from our expedition to find the Void Gem, you gave me two tasks. The first one was to find some way to repair the staff the Void Gem is affixed to, or to transfer the gem to another receptacle."

Glimmer's mind suddenly went to Scorpia—the poor woman had cried the whole way back to Etheria, convinced that she was the only person to have destroyed a Staff of Power. Upon landing on Etheria, Scorpia had descended the ship's ramp holding the two broken halves of the staff as she burbled and sobbed a greeting to Perfuma. The only way Glimmer could remotely console her friend was to promise that she would do everything in her power to fix the damage and make everything right.

"So, any luck with that?" Glimmer asked hopefully.

"Mmmm...no, not yet. The staff which holds the magic source is completely ruined and unusable. Hordak and I still need to do some tests before we attempt to remove the Void Gem from the staff and install it in another receptacle. If we get the *slightest* calculation wrong, it could…" Entrapta said as she wandered off into contemplation.

"Let me guess, it could spell disaster?" Glimmer said drolly.

"I guess you could call the mutual destruction of Etheria and Eternia a disaster," Entrapta said thoughtfully.

Glimmer gaped at her open-mouthed. The way Entrapta so casually talked about the destruction of two planets seemed so detached, even for the usually science-focused Princess. Glimmer realized that there was something off about her friend, although she could not place a finger on exactly what that was. It was as if there was a cold edge to Entrapta now, ever since—

"Anyway, we are working on it," Entrapta continued, interrupting Glimmer's train of thought. "On to the second item you wanted me to look into: the information storage device we found. I am pleased to report that it has been translated and transferred to a datapad,"

Entrapta drew out the datapad in question from her coveralls and held it out with both ponytails with a look of triumph.

"Good work, Entrapta," Glimmer said with a smile as she went to take the datapad, but before she could grab it, Entrapta drew it back, just out of her reach.

"It wasn't just *me* that did the work," Entrapta said with surprising coolness.

"Really?" Glimmer said, crossing her arms. "I'm not saying thanks to *him*! He already owes us *a lot*,"

Entrapta's only response was to raise an eyebrow while tapping her foot.

"Ugh, fine!" Glimmer snarled. "Tell Hordak to keep up the great work! Now, hand it over!"

Glimmer snatched the datapad out of Entrapta's ponytails just as she held it back out.

"Hey! Wait a second!" Entrapta cried suspiciously. "You weren't using sarcasm, were you?"

“Yeah, that was definitely sarcasm,” Glimmer said offhandedly as Entrapta puffed herself up in outrage.

Glimmer powered the datapad up, eager to read the secrets found within the old information storage device. The whole trip to retrieve the Void Gem had unsettled Glimmer. The ancient crypt they explored had been corrupted by evil, and they had been blind to its presence at the time, for it was unfamiliar. This was something new, and Glimmer had to learn more about it in order to fight it properly. She started to read the first passage.

My name is Kishar, child of Ni and Tauthe. I am the nine hundred and thirty-first bearer of Zhe-La. I was bound to Zhe-La on my home planet of Empyrea, in the city of Lumos within the Temple of Light. It is my sacred duty to act as Champion not only for the united people of Empyrea but for the entire galaxy at large. To be the embodiment of The Light of Grayskull, to be exemplification pure empathy—

“From what I read of the information stored, it appears to be someone’s journal. Not sure what help that could be.” Entrapta said with a shrug.

“Well, it’s better than nothing,” Glimmer said softly. “It will just take some reading on my part, but I’m sure I can sift through this and find something of importance.”

Entrapta perked up. “Well, if you need me to, I can create a program to search through the entire text! It can zero in on keywords and save you some time!”

Glimmer shook her head. “No, I don’t think that what will work here. This must be read with an emotional eye, not by a cold machine. No offense.”

Entrapta shrugged again. “None taken! If you don’t need anything else, I’m headed back to Dryl.”

“Wait, Entrapta. Have you heard anything from Eternia recently? I know you are constantly scanning all transmissions to and from

there. Have you heard anything from the boys yet?" Glimmer asked, worry evident in her voice.

Entrapta shook her head. "No, not a thing. Maybe we should gather the princesses and check on them,"

Glimmer shook her head. "No, I will take care of this. I need you to continue your work with the Void Gem. It's probably nothing—just boys being boys. They are probably fooling around, having burping contests and watching He-Man smash things with his sword."

* * *

Bow crept silently down the dark corridor, flame-lit torch in hand lighting the green stone of the walls. He was going as silently as he possibly could in case *he* heard him. Bow was utterly unarmed, losing his bow and friends in their initial attempt to escape their attacker. He was desperate to find the others.

"*Seahawk? Swiftwind? Guys? Where are you?"* He whispered, voice squeaking with fear. He gave a small shriek as a firm hand grabbed his shoulder from behind, pulling him into an alcove in the wall. His cry silenced as a hand clamped over his mouth.

"*Shhhh!* He's going to hear us!" Seahawk rasped in Bow's ear. Bow nodded, and Seahawk released his mouth.

"Where's Swiftwind? Did he get away?" Bow whispered over his shoulder to his friend.

"I don't know," Seahawk responded sorrowfully. "I hope so. He's a brave steed. Alas! This has gone terribly wrong! How long have we been lost in this terrible place?"

Bow shook his head. "I don't know, a couple of days, maybe? I hope the princesses come and save us soon! Before *he* cuts us to pieces or has his friend tear us to shreds with their claws!"

"*Shhh! Wait! What is that noise?*" Seahawk whispered.

The two stood perfectly still as they heard a slow *tap, tap* noise coming closer to their hiding place. Bow was about to put out his torch when he caught sight of rainbow wings on a large white body. It was Swiftwind, walking as slowly as he possibly could in the pitch dark on the very tips of his hooves.

"HEY, GUYS I'M SO HAPPY TO FINALLY FIND YOU—!" Swiftwind yelled before Bow and Seahawk clamped his muzzle closed.

"SHHH!!! You idiot, he is going to hear you!" Bow whispered fiercely.

"*Okay, okay! Sorry! Sheesh*," Swiftwind whispered back. *"Do we know what happened? Why is he trying to kill us?"*

"I don't know," Bow responded*. "All I know is that he picked up that weird stone and went completely nuts!"*

"Oh! I'm too handsome to die, especially in such a dreary place like this! My Mermista! I should have taken the Vow with you, my love! But I was too selfish!" Seahawk bemoaned in a hushed voice.

"Quiet! What's that noise?" Swiftwind said, straining his long ears.

Bow and Seahawk slowly heard what Swiftwind's keen ears picked up; it was a harsh sound, like a piece of metal scraping against stone. There was another sound accompanying it, a soft, collective tapping. As if many sharp objects were striking the ground in synchrony.

Like claws.

"I hear youuu…" A harsh voice called from the dark. "Just come out so we can finish this. I am sooo tired of this game,"

Suddenly, the soft tapping became more rapid, recognizable now as the sound of large paws slapping against the stone floor, accompanied by a low growl.

“HE’S FOUND US! HE-MAN IS GOING TO KILL US!” Seahawk screamed. “FLY, YOU FOOLS!”

* * *

On an expansive and dusty plain, a robed and hooded figure appeared in a haze of sparkles. The robe the person wore was a starlit night sky—as if it was not a material the person wore, but the actual fabric of the universe. In their hand was a star topped staff—the Star Stone.

Glimmer pushed back the hood of her robe, looking up at the bright sky and to her origin point, a beautiful, lush, and magical planet—Etheria.

I’m not sure if I will ever get used to teleporting to another planet, Glimmer thought to herself.

When Eternia and Etheria had begun their mutual orbit after the destruction of the Set’Heth-un’dar, Glimmer had toyed with the idea of interplanetary magical teleportation. If it were just the power of the Moon Stone she was using, it would have been impossible. But now she had the Star Stone, and the power of the Star Stone was not limited to the planet of Etheria. As far as Glimmer knew, it had no boundaries.

Glimmer would teleport to one of the many Star Force ships in orbit as an initial first step. Using them like stepping stones across a stream, she would travel from ship to ship until she was close enough to Eternia, finally teleporting to the planet's surface. She slowly increased the distance traveled between ships until finally, she was able to take the final leap—from Etheria to Eternia.

This was the fifth time she had teleported between the neighboring planets. Perhaps one day, she would be able to travel even further…

Glimmer looked around, taking in her surroundings. She was in a rocky desert; it was a waste, much like the Crimson Waste back

home—but it was not empty. Nearby was what appeared to be a spaceship—if it could be called that.

There was not a speck of symmetry to the craft—it appeared as a jumble of junk parts connected to the side of a large cylindrical thruster. The only indication of a 'front' to the ship was a viewport nestled amongst the chaos of exposed cabling and heat exchangers. The entire craft sat upon three landing struts, which allowed enough space for a ramp to be deployed from the underside.

"What a hunk of junk," Glimmer said aloud as she recognized this particular spaceship.

It was called *The Millennial Seagull,* and its captain was none other than Seahawk. Supposedly, he had received the spaceship during an intense round of cards in a Seaworthy bar. Whether or not he had to win or lose the match in order to gain *The Millennial Seagull* was anyone's guess.

Beyond the ship was a large fissure in the rocky landscape, like an enormous crack in the ground. Perched on the other side of this fissure was a castle; based on its appearance, this could only be Castle Grayskull. For all the times Glimmer had heard Adora use its name to activate her She-Ra power, she was expecting something huge and magnificent, yet looking upon it, she was kind of disappointed.

It was a small castle of simple design—four-sided and rectangular-shaped. Four turrets of different shapes and heights stood at each corner of the fortress, and the entire castle was constructed of moss-green stone. But these were not the most noticeable features.

Carved in the face of the castle was an enormous green skull. I was an ominous sight; the mouth and jaw of the skull forming a drawbridge—currently lowered—while gaping eye sockets made those who dared to enter the castle re-think their decision.

Glimmer gulped, feeling bad that she told Entrapta that the boys were just off having fun.

I don't think anyone ever had fun in this place, Glimmer thought glumly. *I really hope they are still alive.*

Glimmer cocked her head as something occurred to her. *Why is this place called 'Grayskull'? Shouldn't it be called 'Greenskull'?*

She shook the thought from her head; it was obviously not relevant. Summoning her resolve, Glimmer approached Castle Grayskull.

* * *

Swiftwind scrambled down the narrow corridor, Bow and Seahawk mounted on his back as he narrowly dodged a white-hot blazing bolt aimed in his direction. The searing energy slammed into the green rock walls, exploding in a cascade of electric power.

"Yikes! That was too close!" Bow cried as he held onto his friend Seahawk. Seahawk said something in reply, but it was muffled from having his face buried in Swiftwind's neck.

Swiftwind neighed in terror as he came to a screeching halt—it was a dead-end in the corridor.

"Oh, man! We're doomed!" Bow whined.

Turning slowly, Swiftwind looked to see their pursuer finally catch up with them.

It was He-Man/Shen, mounted atop a hulking, feline creature—Battlecat was their name. Battlecat was of the same species as Melog, recently born on Etheria and introduced to Shen by Catra and Melog to be his friend and companion.

When Battlecat first transitioned to their feline form, their coloring was of a green body with jagged orange striping running from their head back to the end of their tail. An ethereal orange mane

extended back from their head to their neck—just like Melog's—which became an armored helmet when Shen saturated Battlecat with his He-Man power. But this was not how Battlecat appeared now—they were bright and blood red, eyes burning like hot coals.

He-Man/Shen was similarly changed; he still wore his familiar black sleeveless tunic, gray leggings, and black boots. The silver armor on his shoulders and forearms was the same, as was the silver crown. No, what was different was the presence of a sinister red substance covering his entire body like a snaking vine. The red malignance glowed with an inner light, pulsing in time with He-Man/Shen's eyes—they were blood red, like Battlecat's.

Bow and Seahawk had seen this taint before when Catra corrupted She-Ra with the First One's tech. She-Ra/Adora had been turned into an unstoppable killing machine, and the only thing they could do was run away. Unfortunately, that option seemed to have been taken from them.

Battlecat stalked forward on red paws, baring enormous red fangs as He-Man/Shen leered at them.

"Ah...see that, Battlecat? Our prey has decided to face us," He-Man/Shen cooed while making broad chopping motions with his sword.

"Come on, Shen! Snap out of it! It's us, your friends!" Bow pleaded.

For a moment, recognition seemed to twinkle in He-Man/Shen's burning eyes, but it passed, like a hint of sunlight behind darkened clouds. He shook his head fiercely as if to shake out a thought.

"There is no Shen here, only HATE," He-Man/Shen said through clenched teeth.

At the word *hate*, Battlecat lunged, screaming with pure loathing for Bow, Seahawk, and Swiftwind. Just as the murderous duo was

about to land on their friends, Swiftwind spun around, kicking out with his hind legs and striking Battlecat in their snout. Battlecat screamed with fury as their head was lifted, sending their entire body spinning backward and sending He-Man/Shen careening into the walls.

Not hanging around to inspect the damage, Swiftwind leaped past the prone forms of his once-friends and bolted away, Seahawk and Bow still on his back. A horrifying scream of pure fury could be heard behind him—the sound of both Battlecat and He-Man/Shen screaming in unison. It was the sound of pure rage; Battlecat and He-Man/Shen were still coming for them.

It was at that moment, when they were in an absolute desperate panic, that Bow saw the shaft of light up ahead. It was the stone spiral stairs they initially took to come down into the depths of Castle Grayskull, before He-Man/Shen had become corrupted and they had become terribly lost.

"Swifty! Up ahead, do you see it?" Bow cried.

"I'm on it, Bow!" Swiftwind responded, putting additional speed into his gallop. Soon they were clomping up the stairs and out of the darkness, free of the nightmare they had lived in the past few days.

"WE ARE FREE! THANK ETHER—ack!" Seahawk cried before sailing over Swiftwind's head as an invisible force seized the winged unicorn. Bow was not far behind, and they landed in a pile before a staff-wielding figure.

"What do you idiots think you're doing?!" A stern female voice cried.

Bow looked up, recognizing the voice, a huge goofy grin appearing on his face.

"Glimmer!" He shouted, jumping up and seizing his wife in a loving embrace. "Oh, Glimmer, I love you so much! Oh! I thought

I'd never see your beautiful face again! I'm never leaving your side ever, ever again!"

Glimmer looked at her wreck of a husband with pure confusion and worry as she patted him on the back halfheartedly.

"It's okay, Bow. It's okay," she said, slightly unsure. "What happened to you guys? I was worried sick! Are you crying, Bow?"

"Eh...Glimmer? Can you please release me?" Swiftwind asked.

Glimmer saw that Swiftwind was still under the control of the immobility spell she used; he floated in midair, completely rigid. The only part of his body he could move was his mouth and eyes.

"Oh! Sorry, Swifty! Here you go," Glimmer said, waving her hand and releasing him from his prison.

"You might want to have that spell handy again," Seahawk said, fear in his voice.

"Why? What's going on? Where are Shen and Battlecat?" Glimmer asked, annoyance appearing in her voice again.

"Yeah, about that—" Bow started to say, but he was interrupted by a low growl. All four turned to see He-Man/Shen rise from the bowels of Castle Grayskull atop a nightmarish beast. Glimmer instantly recognized the red pulsating veins covering her friend's body, but she could not believe her eyes.

"How?" She gasped. "First One's technology does not bind your sword. Entrapta said the rage virus was tech-based. This isn't possible!"

He-Man/Shen gave a low chuckle; there was a murderous red twinkle in his eyes as he gazed at Glimmer.

"Oh, my dear, it's *hate*! *Hate* always finds a way!" He said as Battlecat leaped at them.

Glimmer screamed, letting loose a blast of Star Fire reflexively, not bothering to aim. The magic bolt found its mark, hitting Battlecat and sending them careening into a sizable statue nearby. They smashed through the ancient stone and the entire figure crumbled down upon them.

Glimmer let out a sigh of relief, but it was too soon; the rubble began to shift, then part as He-Man/Shen rose from the statue's ruins. He looked down to his feet at Battlecat, still bright red, but now unconscious. He gritted his teeth, absolutely incandescent in his rage as he focused on Glimmer.

"I can do that too!" He-Man/Shen said as he pointed his sword at her.

Spiraling electric power issued from the hilt and traveled down to the sword's point, coalescing into a searing power bolt. It shot forth at Glimmer as a screaming point of white light that exploded onto a solid wall of magical energy. Glimmer panted with exertion, holding up her staff to maintain the protective barrier.

"I really wish Adora hadn't taught you how to do that," she said, gasping as another bolt struck her barrier. The pure magical power being wielded by He-Man/Shen was incredible. Glimmer did not think she could maintain her barrier for much longer. She had to change tactics, and seeing the corruption infecting her friend, she knew exactly what she had to do.

Glimmer looked at He-Man/Shen, looking past the rage-filled exterior to the person she knew inside. The Shen she knew was kind and compassionate—he would never attack or even try to hurt his friends in any way, ever. Glimmer summoned empathy for her friend. It was not hard to find—especially for Shen.

Using her spirit eye, Glimmer could see Shen's bright soul. She knew that he was constantly pushing against the darkness of his tortured past. Shen did not deserve this hate-filled persona that currently dominated him; Glimmer seized upon the compassion

pouring from her heart and pushed it all into the Star Stone to power the spell she needed.

Glimmer raised the staff above her as beams of rainbow-colored light streaked down, appearing from the very air and alighting on the end of the staff. The Star Stone blazed as she lowered the staff, pointing it at He-Man/Shen as ribbons of pure starlight issued forth from the end.

It was as if the corruption within him knew what was about to happen, for He-Man/Shen held his sword up in a guard position to block the ribbons of magic from entangling him. But it did not help—the ribbons simply floated around the blade and wrapped themselves around him, pinning his arms down to his body. He-Man/Shen screamed with impotent rage as the ribbons swirled around him, finally covering his face and smothering his screams.

Glimmer jerked the staff back towards herself, tightening the ribbons of light around the captive form of He-Man/Shen. With an almost inaudible sigh, the wound bundle of starlight shrunk as a red haze rose from it like steam, evaporating into the air.

As Glimmer lowered the staff, the ribbons slackened, revealing the de-powered form of Shen as he fell limply to the floor. She ran over to him, followed by Bow, Seahawk, and Swiftwind. They kneeled around him, worry on their faces as Shen slowly opened his eyes.

"Heeeeyyyy guys…" He said dreamily. "Why are you all looking at me?"

Shen's eyes were unfocused, and he slurred his words, acting much like Adora did after being influenced by the Rage Virus. Glimmer and Bow exchanged glances, knowing precisely what they were in for.

"Do you remember anything, buddy?" Bow asked.

"Yeah, like trying to murder us for the past couple of days?" Swiftwind mumbled under his breath.

“M—murder you? Wha’?” Shen said with slurred confusion.

“Don’t worry about it,” Glimmer said kindly as she swatted Swiftwind. “All that matters now is that you are okay. How do you feel?”

Shen thought about that question, an intense look of concentration on his face.

“I feel...good! Really...good!” He said with a goofy grin.

“*Silly Adora* went back to normal once the rage virus was removed from her sword...who knows how Shen will be like this?” Bow said with worry.

Everyone turned when they heard confused mewling; they saw Battlecat freeing themselves from the rubble. They were in their de-powered form, back to their usual green and orange coloring. They walked in a stumbling, swaying motion and seemed disoriented like their friend Shen.

“Heeeeyyy, Battlecat!” Shen called. “Hey, buddy! I missed you so much!”

Glimmer stood and watched the reunion between Shen and Battlecat, the orange and green feline alien purring loudly as they rubbed up against Shen, licking his face.

“This makes no sense,” Glimmer said, thoughtfully. “A First One’s sword no longer binds He-Man. How did the rage virus corrupt him? What exactly did you guys find down there? Was it another one of those red First One’s crystals?”

Bow shook his head. “No, it did not look like any kind of First One’s tech. It just looked like a red rock. As soon as Shen picked it up, he and Battlecat started trying to kill us.”

This answer just seemed to annoy Glimmer.

“What were you guys even doing here? Just messing around with stuff until you got into trouble?” Glimmer said, exasperated.

“Oh! I can answer that!” Seahawk said while raising his hand.

“Yes?” Glimmer said coolly, raising one eyebrow.

“You see, Shen had a quest, one he could not complete alone.” Seahawk began pompously. “So, he sought intrepid companions to accompany him on this quest—US! We boarded my mighty *star-ship* and blasted off into space, off on our jour—“

“You can just stop right there,” Glimmer interrupted. “I’ve seen your starship, and it’s not mighty. NEXT!” She said, indicating that Swiftwind should speak.

“Okay, so Seahawk mentioned the part where Shen asked us to go with him. According to Shen, he was being asked to drive an evil force from Castle Grayskull—something about how it is haunted. Well, when we got here, we didn’t find anything...*haunty*.” Swiftwind said.

“So, you decided to go sightseeing?” Glimmer asked, raising her voice. “You guys could have been killed!”

“Easy, Glimmer!” Bow said, raising his hands, trying to placate his wife. “Shen wanted to check every corner of the place to ensure it was secure. There was absolutely no problem until we went into the basement and found what was stored down there. I mean, it was pretty standard stuff for us.”

Glimmer realized he was right; they had faced more significant challenges before; it seemed like something unexpected was encountered here, and it wasn’t right for her to be angry with them. She closed her eyes and rubbed the bridge of her nose, letting out a long sigh.

Opening her eyes, Glimmer looked around them, finally taking in the space they were. She had just entered through the gate of

Castle Grayskull when she saw Swiftwind appearing from the ground. Everything had happened so fast after that.

It was a large chamber or hall, and in the middle were six statues standing in a circle—seven, if the one destroyed in the fight with He-Man/Shen was to be counted. They stared forward with stern gazes, sconces for torches next to each one—and with a start, Glimmer realized she recognized them.

*They're from my vision, when I was out of my body, after being attacked by that Death Binder on Omiros. I saw this before encountering the fragment of good still inside Shen's father, Adam...*Glimmer realized.

Glimmer remembered another aspect from that vision, a feeling of immense power beneath her. She reached out with her magical sense and felt that same pulse of pure energy coming up from beneath the floor. It beckoned to her.

"Seahawk and Swiftwind, please take care of Shen," She said quietly, the assured command of a Queen in her tone.

Seahawk nodded, helping Shen to his feet and onto Swiftwind's back.

"What about me, Glimmer?" Bow asked.

Glimmer looked past him to the spiraling staircase in the middle of the seven stone statues. She realized that these must be representations of the old bearers of the Staves of Power, standing guard over the power below them.

"I want you to show me where you found this stone, the one that corrupted Shen. I want to see what's below us," Glimmer whispered.

I Beseech You

Chapter Summary

> Adora, Catra and the Madgēcots meet Veth - bearer of Zhe-La and champion of the Empyrean Empire.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra could not help the grin on her face as she watched the Madgēcot children play. They screamed and laughed as they leaped or hung from the soft wooden poles of the gymnasium-park, one of many dotted about the city of Raajadhaanee. One little girl in particular caught her attention—taunting her friend to catch up with her as she swung away on overhand supports.

"You must be the slowest Madgēcot in existence!" She teased with a laugh.

"Am not! I'll show you!" The other child cried, jumping and missing the wooden rung her friend used to escape, falling on her rear with a yelp. Her playmate dropped to the floor, running over on all fours to console her.

"I'm sorry, I shouldn't have teased you. Are you okay?" The child asked as she hugged her friend.

Catra felt a swell of emotions in her chest at the display of empathy between two children, remembering all the times she and Adora consoled each other throughout their years in the Horde. There was another feeling welling inside of her; it was newer and was happening more frequently. It was instinctual and emotional, and as she watched the children play, she knew exactly what it was.

"What do you think? Want to make one of those?" Adora said next to her.

Turning to her wife, Catra saw a slight, knowing grin on Adora's face. *This dummy always seems to know what I'm thinking!*

"That's a real *smooth* way to propose having children, princess," Catra said as she began to make a face in imitation of Adora. "*Hey Catra, let's have one of those there children!*"

Adora laughed, giving Catra that warm feeling again.

I love making her laugh, Catra thought to herself.

"No, really, Catra, what do you think of us having a child?" Adora said, more seriously this time.

"I dunno," Catra said with a shrug, her ears lowering as she turned to watch the children at play again. "I hadn't really thought about it."

"Liar," Adora said as she gave Catra a gentle nudge with her hip. Catra couldn't stop herself from exposing her upper fangs in a silly grin, her tail twitching rapidly.

"Okay, okay. Yeah, sure, I've been thinking about it. Especially more so since we came to Elysia," Catra said as she gazed up at the Jacarandra trees around them.

Catra knew her birth planet was affecting her—any dummy could see it. As soon as she landed on Elysia, the planet had saturated her with its essence; the smells, the sights, and sounds. On some instinctive level—beyond the physical and into a spiritual one—Catra responded immediately to it.

It scared her in the beginning, its pull at her very soul made her feel as if she had no control, and she fought against it. She tried not to smell the smells or hear the wild calls. She tried to look at the trees with an unfocused eye, but she felt herself giving in by small increments.

It was when she heard The Song, that wondrous and beautiful song from last night, that she fully gave in. She had been hearing

it faintly the whole time she was on Elysia, but it was not intrusive and easy to ignore. Catra knew it was not a song she heard with her sensitive ears, but by some other means, one that could not be described. It wasn't until she heard it sung openly from the mouths of her people that she realized its significance.

It was an invitation, an open invitation to her to join with it, to join her people and the planet. It was an invitation to life itself, and she could not help herself from opening up her heart fully to it. Catra had broken open fully, like a dam holding back an ocean —except what came forth from Catra's mouth was not water, but her life's story.

Catra was still unsure how she had sung that strange song, and its memory made her feel giddy. It was like being caught up in a river, but unlike that awful experience with Bow and Glimmer when they had captured her, this river was pure joy. After she had completed her song and told her life's story to the Chaliendra Tree, Catra had been filled with a sense of peace and contentment she rarely felt in her life. It made her feel love—love for Adora, for this new planet, for her people, and most especially for herself.

Catra realized that Adora had gone quiet and caught her wife giving her a strange look.

"What's the matter?" Catra said with a hint of concern.

"Nothing is the matter; I've just been thinking," Adora smiled.

"Well, there's your problem right there," Catra said, teasingly.

Adora chuckled and shook her head. "I've noticed this planet affecting you, Catra. You seem like you're really happy here,"

Catra laughed. "Of course, dummy, I'm on my *honeymoon with you!* Why wouldn't I be happy?" Catra held out her hand and grasped Adora's as she looked into her wife's eyes.

"Yes, and I'm happy too. But this is more than that; I see it Catra, I'm your soulmate, I see that you…" Adora said, not finishing her

sentence.

“What? Go ahead and say it.” Catra said gently.

“I think we should move here, move to Elysia,” Adora said quietly. Before Catra could protest, Adora placed a single finger on her lips to quiet her.

“Just think about it. Really think about it.” Adora said gently. She was going to say more when a voice interrupted her.

“Hey, you two, I’ve been looking for you!” Viraj said, striding over to them. “Are you ready for the meeting?”

Adora slapped her forehead. “Oh, my gosh! We almost forgot. I’m sorry, we get easily distracted.” Adora said as a slightly confused look started to appear. “How did you find us anyway? This city isn’t exactly small,”

Viraj smiled back at Adora, tapping the side of his nose with a clawed finger.

“Madgēcot nose,” was all he said.

“Okay, Viraj, we're ready to go,” Catra said, chuckling at the look on Adora’s face.

Adora and Catra followed Viraj as he led them away to their meeting, the one they had promised they would attend.

Viraj had relayed a request from the ultimate superior in the Star Hunters, the Pratham, asking if Adora and Catra could be there when the delegation from the Empyrean Hegemony presented themselves. Viraj apologized for asking this of them on their honeymoon, but it seemed the Madgēcots were worried about this visit from their ancient allies—now turned enemies. They wanted the bearer of She-Ra to be there, to counter the one who led the delegation, Veth, bearer of Zhe-La.

Viraj did not have much to say about what exactly Zhe-La was, only that they were a magical champion, much like She-Ra, He-Man, and Sher-Va. He said that in ancient times, Zhe-La was the *Light of Grayskull* but was doubtful that was the case today. The *Light* the Empyrean Hegemony spoke of was no longer about love and empathy, but absolutes and rigid conformity. It could only be assumed Zhe-La was in the same vein.

They traveled down the many ramps and ladders leading down from the city, towards the forest floor, where the Star Hunters kept their stronghold—The Imaarat. It was one of the few buildings on the ground, an ancient building that stood for millennia, back when the Star Hunters were known by another name, the Sanrakshak—the Protectors. This was where the Madgēcots would greet their visitors.

Much like the pathway to the Great Chaliendra Tree, the path to the Imaarat was of ancient worn stone. But where the path to the Chaliendra was completely intact, there were deep gouges and rents in the path to the Imaarat, as if damaged in a mighty battle from the elder days. The surrounding area was similarly marked—craters or deep pits could be seen, and old scars dotted the nearby Jacarandra Trees, now covered by soft moss.

"You would think a group that called itself the Star Hunters would have their headquarters in space. Or at the very least, up at the highest point in the trees." Adora whispered to Catra.

Why is she whispering? Does she think those long ears my brother and I have are just for show? Catra thought to herself. She saw Viraj's ears twitch, knowing he heard everything Adora said but was just too polite to say so.

"Well, according to my brother, it's in honor of when they were called the Sanrakshak. That was before Madgēcots had spaceships or technology, when the Sanrakshak would guard the other Madgēcots against attacks from the ground." Catra not bothering to whisper.

Adora turned to Catra with a grin. "Wow, look at you 'Miss histori-*ann*,'"

Catra placed a hand over her face and groaned. "Geez, Adora, when will you stop pronouncing it like that? I mean, are you joking when you do that? Sometimes I can't figure out if you're a comedic genius or just a dummy," Catra said.

Adora wiggled her eyebrows at her wife. "Wouldn't you like to know?" she said mysteriously.

Catra was shaking her head, smiling at Adora's antics when she saw it—The Imaarat.

It sat in a wide-open space on the forest floor, appearing as a cluster of gray domed buildings of various sizes with four towers rising like spikes in the middle. There were openings dotted along the circumferences of the domed buildings—presumably for offensive reasons. As they got closer, they saw that the entire fortress was made of large, flat stones—expertly placed together—with enough space in between for hand and footholds.

Like the space the Chaliendra Tree resided in, there was a great parting of the tree canopy above The Imaarat, bathing the building in bright light. An expansive landing pad was nearby, with starships of apparent Madgēcot design residing there—a starport. It was a more recent addition to The Imaarat and appeared to be made of four cross-sections of a Jacarandra tree—appearing as a flower to anyone landing there.

"Ah, there it is. It appears that many of my fellow Star Hunters have arrived already. We must hurry before the Empyreans land," Viraj said as he quickened his pace.

Adora and Catra followed Viraj toward the largest of the domed buildings. There, they saw two mighty wooden doors with four Star Hunters standing guard nearby. The Madgēcots stood loose and limber, watching the three arrivals with cool slitted eyes. This

was the first time Adora and Catra had seen the Madgēcots being anything but friendly and welcoming.

"Hey, Viraj, I don't mean to offend, but don't your people carry any weapons?" Adora said, whispering again.

Viraj turned to her without any hint of humor on his cinnamon face.

"A Madgēcot wearing a Jaadoo suit is all the weapon we need," he said simply.

The four Madgēcot guards placed themselves in front of the door as the three arrivals neared, and Viraj indicated for Catra and Adora to stop. Viraj then held his arms out to either side of his torso, palms facing outward as the guards watched him, their noses sniffing.

One of the guards stepped forward; she was a beautiful onyx-furred Madgēcot with striking green eyes. Her Jaadoo suit was a midnight blue, her chest symbol and suit markings were a light purple.


HENARTORINOS'22

“You are known to us, Viraj. Who are these strangers with you? The blonde is definitely an offworlder, and the Madgēcot with her smells funny,”

She bared her teeth as she said this; it was as if she was biting her words. Catra knew this was the Madgēcot way of sampling the scents in the air, for she had seen Panga do the same thing.

“Hey!” Catra cried in offense. “There is nothing wrong with my smell, you jerk! We were invited here by a Star Hunter called Panga, who, I might add, had only good things about my scent!”

It was as if Catra had slapped the Madgēcot woman when she spoke Panga’s name; her green eyes widened, black ears lowered, and her mouth gaped slightly.

“Easy, Maira, easy,” Viraj said pleadingly. “The Council and the Pratham requested that Adora and Cat-Tra be there when the Empyreans land; please let us pass.”

“Maira, huh? You and Panga were together, right?” Adora asked in a poor attempt to break the tension. Catra gritted her teeth, guessing how this would affect the already irritated Maira—she was not disappointed.

Maira’s eyes became hooded green slits, and she bared her teeth slightly as she growled.

“That is none of your business, *offworlder,*” Maira hissed as her eyes flashed to Viraj. “You may pass. You should keep these two away from me in the future.”

Maira whirled around, placing a hand on the spot where the double doors met, and whispered a command. Great symbols appeared in the wood of both doors, glowing with the now-familiar rainbow colors, but these doors did not vanish. The vast doors parted slightly with a rumbling groan—just enough to allow Adora, Catra, and Viraj to enter.

"That was *real* smooth, princess. *Real smooth*," Catra whispered to Adora as they passed the smoldering Maira. Adora just gave a sheepish shrug in reply.

They entered a vast chamber. It took Catra a moment to take it all in.

Above them was a vast concave ceiling—the underside of the massive dome seen from the outside. The flat stones which the dome was composed of were fitted together so well that not a speck of light peaked through, but wide shafts of light poured down from the many openings that they had seen from the outside. Beneath each of these openings were wooden platforms supporting unknown mechanisms. They looked old and unused, presumably ancient offensive weapons.

About midway down from the vaulted ceiling and below the portals was where a massive wooden structure began. It ran the entire circumference of the chamber, reducing itself in tiers as it neared the center. Walkways led to nooks and cubbies throughout the extensive construction, presumably leading to individual rooms.

In the middle of the chamber where the wooden structure ended was a large, circular area, like an arena. The floor was wood with the symbol of the Star Hunters emblazoned boldly in silver metals. It was empty with no chairs to sit in, and Madgēcots stood about whispering amongst themselves. Catra recognized an older woman with a gray-tipped tail from the other night when she had heard The Song.

That must be the Star Hunter's leader, the Pratham, Catra thought to herself.

Black spots dotted the light blue fur of the exposed portions of the Pratham's body. Her gray-tinged black hair was drawn back into a braided ponytail with two gray tufts protruding from behind black ears. She wore an all-white Jaadoo suit; the star symbol in black with gold highlights the only thing distinguishing her from the

other Star
Hunters.

She did not recognize the others standing by the Pratham, but the fact that they wore sleeveless robes over their Jaadoo suits made her think that these must be the Council that ruled over the affairs of the Madgēcot people. There were other Madgēcots, too, all with Star Hunter symbols on their chests, pacing around wearily.

Viraj led Adora and Catra over to the Madgēcot leaders, coming to a halt before the Pratham. Bringing his hands together, Viraj interlocked his fingers, forming a star, and gave a short bow to his superior. The Pratham returned the hand gesture and the bow, gazing at Adora and Catra with fierce yellow eyes. She pursed her lips as she took in Catra.

"You are definitely Viraj's long-lost sister," she said as her glacial features melted into a small smile. "I'm so happy you finally found her, my boy,"

Viraj beamed at this, seeming a little embarrassed. "Yes, Aadhya, I am too. Her name is Cat-Tra."

The Pratham—Aadhya, her name was—looked slightly amused by this, inspecting Catra once again with a raised eyebrow.

"It's good to meet you finally, Catra," Aadhya said without Viraj and Panga's discomfort to pronounce her name.

Catra shared in her brother's embarrassment and pawed the ground with a clawed foot.

"Uh, yeah, glad to meet you too," she said lamely.

Aadhya turned her gaze to Adora, who had to stop herself from snapping to attention.

"I am glad to meet you, Pratham, ma'am," Adora said, equally as lame as her wife.

Aadhya laughed at this, a merry laugh that was at odds with her initial stern demeanor.

“Everyone knows I am the leader of the Star Hunters, but Pratham is not my name, and I am more than a title. I would like you just to call me Aadhya, Adora. Please.” Aadhya said kindly.

Adora smiled, and Catra could tell her wife was put at ease by the humility of the Madgēcot leader.

“This building is amazing, Aadhya,” Adora said, looking around at the grand space, then pointing up at one of the mechanisms positioned behind one of the many portals. “Are those some kind of weapon?”

Aadhya glanced where Adora pointed, then nodded. “Yes, those are the Gulel. They are ancient war engines capable of hurling large projectiles at great velocities. If allowed to wind to their maximum tension, they could send a bolt through the trunk of a full-grown Jacarandra tree, but we do not need such things anymore. They were used only in the Dark Times.”

“Wowww!” Adora exclaimed. “What were the Madgēcots fighting that they needed weapons like that?”

Aadhya frowned at Adora, then looked at Viraj with confusion.

“How does the bearer of the She-Ra not know of the Dark Times before the coming of the Champions of Good? Before we received the Light,” She asked.

Viraj shrugged. “Much was lost, Aadhya. Etheria had been lost in another dimension, just as She-Ra was. We should just be glad she has returned to us, and someone like Adora is her keeper.”

Catra grinned at Viraj’s words, putting her hand in Adora’s when she saw the blush appear on her wife’s face.

Aadhya nodded in agreement at Viraj’s words, then turned to Adora.

"I do not have time to recount the tales fully to you now, Adora, for we have a new evil to face. But know this: many, many thousands of years ago, this entire universe was bathed in night, and in that darkness, there were terrible things. Those were the times the Madgēcots never even dreamed of leaving our planet, only concerned with defending our homes and living to see the light another day. Today we must constantly be on guard so as to keep our existence from slipping into that nightmare again."

Catra's ears lowered as she reached back to smooth her tail; it had become bushy at the Elder Madgēcot's words of evil.

Just then, a younger Star Hunter approached the Madgēcot elders and bowed, making the sign of the star.

"The Empyrean's ship is landing soon; we are ready," was all the Star Hunter said.

"Good," one of the Council members said. "Let's see what the Empyrean Hegemony has to say for itself, and it better not be more of this *Light* nonsense."

The other Madgēcots chuckled at these words as they all faced the grand doors, hearing the sounds of ships thrusters powering down as the visitors landed. There was a weighted silence as they waited, then with a massive groan, the wooden double doors opened, and the Empyreans entered, escorted by Maira and the other three Star Hunter guards. With everything that Madgēcots said of these visitors, Catra expected them to be hideous and dark people. What strode into The Imaarat was anything but.

The Empyreans, or more accurately the Nephraeh, were humanoid, lithe, and tall. There were eleven of them, and they strode into the grand chamber with a reserved grace employed by only the most seasoned dancers—or killers. There was something about their appearances that Catra could not place a finger on; their features were neither male nor female, fully handsome or beautiful—they were both simultaneously. Her mind suddenly

went to her friend, Double Trouble, and how they were just *attractive*.

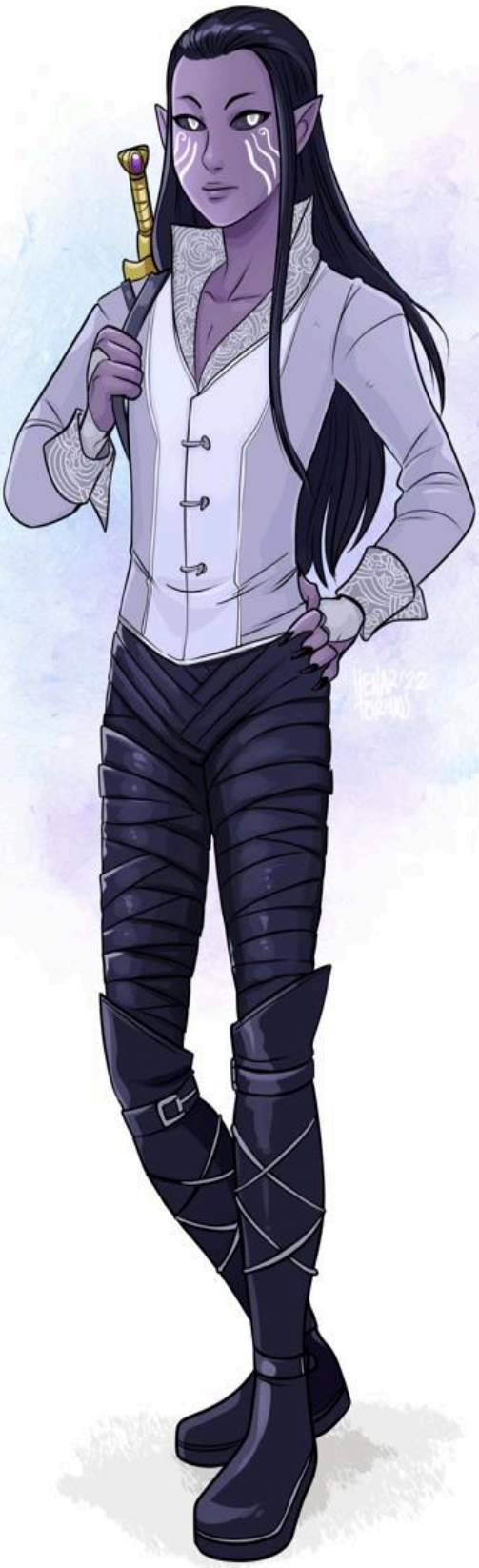
All the Nephraeh had long, sleek black hair, braided in loose plaits behind their heads, with long ears poking out between loose strands of their hair. Their skin was a light purple, and each had different variations of faint, white markings around their eyes, mouth, and nose. Their eyes were their most striking feature—pure silver irises floated in dark sclera. They flashed like mirrors as the Nephraeh glanced about the inside of The Imaarat.

The delegation came to a halt a distance before the Madgēcot leaders, the Star Hunters forming a loose perimeter around them and watching the newcomers with weary slitted eyes. All of the Madgēcots in the room seemed agitated by the presence of the Nephraeh; they practically bristled, and a few growled low in their throats.

One of the Nephraeh separated themselves from the others, giving a slight bow as they came to a halt before the leaders.

"Greetings, oh great and noble Madgēcots. I am Veth," they said in an androgynous voice. It was a pleasing voice, and once again, Catra thought of Double Trouble.

Veth stood out from their companions; where the others were dressed in the flowing robes of dignitaries, Veth wore a tight waistcoat with a high collar; it was a soft white color and opened slightly at the breast. A mysterious bundle wrapped in gold cloth hung on their back from a sash across their chest. It was long—one end extending above their head and the other almost to their knees. Close-fitting black pants of a banded material clung to their legs, and on their feet were high silver boots.



Catra noticed that there was a dark smudging around Veth's eyes —it was black, like smeared mascara. It was not an unappealing look, and seemed to make Veth's striking silver eyes stand out even more.

There was something about Nephraeh she could not place a finger on; they were appealing to the eye, but the longer she stared, the more Catra thought there was something not right about them. It was the most evident in their leader, this Veth.

It's like looking at something beautiful but also somehow ugly at the same time, Catra thought, then realized where she saw it before.

The feeling of seeing something, or more specifically someone, who was outwardly beautiful but horribly flawed and broken on the inside was something Catra was very familiar with. Catra was familiar with it, for it was the face she saw in the mirror throughout her time in the Horde—more so after Adora left.

Why am I thinking this? Catra thought to herself. *I don't even know Veth. How would I know what they are like on the inside?*

Catra forced these thoughts aside as she tried to focus on the interplay before her, unable to shake the feeling of unease.

The Madgēcots were studying the Nephraeh leader intently, and Aadhya was the first one to speak.

"Greetings, Veth, I am Aadhya, the Pratham of the Star Hunters. I would welcome you fully if not for the fact you have already begun these proceedings with subterfuge." Aadhya said coldly.

Veth titled their head, looking confused. "Excuse me? We stand before you free of tricks or deceptions," they said, waving their hands at themselves and their companions.

Catra noticed that there were points at the tips of Veth's fingers—claws—and they looked deadly sharp.

"Free of deceptions, eh?" Aadhya said dangerously. "You come before us dressed as diplomats, but move like warriors. Do you think our senses are so dull that we would not recognize warriors dressed under those robes? Who are they?"

Aadhya padded forward, circling the robed Nephraeh as she inspected them.

"Let me guess, hmm," she said, placing a hand on her chin as she pretended to contemplate. "I don't think they are Peltasts, no, not for a mission like this. Not one of the Sarissa either,"

Suddenly, Aadhya spun around without warning, sending a roundhouse kick aimed at one of the robed Nephraeh's face. The intended target's arm shot up and around, deflecting the clawed foot smoothly away from their face. The rest of their body did not move throughout this whole exchange, and their silver eyes did not even glance at their attacker.

Aadhya gave a bark of laughter. "You send Krypteia with you on a mission of peace? Do you think you can send us assassins dressed in robes and they would not be noticed? Incredible!"

The rest of the Madgēcots in the room tensed at this, and loud mutterings were heard throughout the assembly as the robed Nephraeh looked around nervously. Veth simply raised their hands in placation.

"Easy, now, it was no deception, just good sense on our part. After all, I am the bearer of Zhe-La and an important part of the Empyrean Hegemony. My Archon would not send me into enemy territory without some support. Besides, when did we ever say any of us were just diplomats? Or for that matter, who said that diplomats could not also be warriors?" Veth said reasonably.

Aadhya gave Veth a measured look, then chuckled. "I can see why they sent you, Veth. Besides being Zhe-La, you're a smooth talker.

I’m not convinced, but we won’t kill you outright— not yet, anyway.”

Aadhya smiled at Veth. It was a dangerous smile, exposing her sharp fangs. Veth returned the smile with equal parts danger, and Catra was surprised to see that they also had sharp fangs.

“I appreciate that,” Veth said smoothly. “We didn’t come here for trouble after all,”

“So, what did you come here for, then?” One of the council members demanded.

Veth nodded. “Yes, on to it then, eh?” They said, looking at all of the assembled Madgēcots.

Catra noticed that Veth’s eyes lingered on Adora for a moment, seeming to glitter before moving on.

“I have come to return something to you, long lost and recently found by us,” Veth said, pulling the sash up over their head as they retrieved the gold bundle at their back.

The room erupted in hissing as the Madgēcots reacted to Veth’s sudden movement, baring claws and teeth. Veth instantly stopped mid-motion, holding the bundle over their head, and they glanced at the sudden danger around them.

“Easy! Easy, Star Hunters!” Aadhya cried, holding up her hands to calm her warriors. “Let’s not be hasty! Let’s see what Veth has before we react. We have nothing to fear from these Empyreans in our own home!”

Aadhya nodded to Veth, indicating that they should continue. Veth placed the bundle on the ground before them, unwrapping the gold cloth to reveal what lay inside. The entire assembly gasped as they finally saw it was an ancient sword of power bearing First One’s markings. Catra saw the similarities between it

and the one Adora used to wield before she shattered it and freed the power of She-Ra.

“The sword of Sher-Va!” Viraj gasped next to Catra. “I would recognize it anywhere! It matches all the known images I have studied of Sher-Va!”

“It could be a trick, a forgery made to look like the sword of Sher-Va,” one of the council members muttered.

“I assure you it is not a trick; Archon Lethe themselves verified its authenticity. They are wise and old enough to remember seeing the sword when born by your champion, Jihan. It is the true sword of Sher-Va; I swear it by my honor,” Veth said, pacing a hand to their chest and bowing slightly.

Aadhya snorted in derision. “I think we will need to go on more than that, Veth. You will have to allow us to authenticate this sword by our scholars and scientists.”

Veth waved this away. “Of course, I expect nothing less from the Madgēcots,” they said airily.

Aadhya scowled at this statement. “And what is that supposed to mean?” She snapped, gaining only a shrug from Veth.

“It doesn’t matter, Aadhya,” a councilor interrupted. “So, what does the Empyrean Hegemony want in return for our heritage? Territory? To be allowed to access the rest of the galaxy and spread your corruption?”

Veth shook their head sadly. “No, we do not want that,” they said quietly. “We only request that Empyrea become a protectorate of Elysia. We humbly ask that the Madgēcot Empire accept us, the Nephraeh, to be their humble vassals.”

“WHAT?!” Aadhya shrieked while trying to stifle a laugh. “Have you lost your minds?!”

The Council members looked at each other, a mix of surprise and disbelief on their faces.

"First of all, Veth, there is no Madgēcot Empire," a female council member said. "The rest of the people on this planet rule themselves. They only contact us when they need aid or join us in friendship. We are not sure what you have in mind as far as Empyrea becoming a protectorate of Elysia."

"This is some kind of game," Aadhya said suspiciously, squinting her eyes at Veth. "You think to cajole us with some kind of trick!"

"It's no trick, I swear it!" Veth cried. "You think us your enemies, but I tell you, we are not even worthy of the title! You call us fallen ones—and you are right to say so! We are not what we once were, not since…"

The Madgēcot Council members all looked at each other as Veth's words died off, curiosity replacing suspicion in their eyes. Aadhya was the one who finally spoke up.

"What *did* happen to you, Veth? What happened to the Nephraeh? You used to be the most cherished of friends to the Madgēcots."

Veth's face fell at her words, their glittering silver eyes looking at the floor shamefully.

"Yes, we used to be before we all had to hide in our separate corners of the galaxy. Before HE dominated our existence for so long." Veth said, their voice dead.

"You mean Horde Prime?" Aadhya coaxed.

Fury appeared on Veth's face, and they hissed, baring their fangs in anger.

"Do not say his name!" Veth screamed, then just as suddenly, they calmed themselves.

“I apologize. The Nephraeh do not speak his name for the crimes he committed against us! He is why we are so wretched now and have fallen so low.” Veth said, pain evident in their voice.

“Throughout the many years following the defeat of The Empire, Horde Prime continued to dominate Empyrea, trying to make us one of his many subjects. But we resisted, just as you did! Horde Prime hated us, primarily because of our past status as The Light of the universe, and he turned his focus on us.”

“We all know Horde Prime’s genius when it comes to genetics, and he turned all his power towards devising a way to ruin us using his science. He came up with a special virus, made just for the Nephraeh, and poisoned us with it from space. It is a cruel disease, not killing us outright, but interfering with our ability to…”

Once again, Veth’s words died off, and a look of pure confusion appeared on their lilac face.

“To feel? To feel compassion and empathy?” Aadhya prompted.

Veth tilted their head, looking at her strangely.

“Are those the things we lost? I do not know; we do not use those words anymore, not for thousands of years. I guess that is what we lost, and it must also be the reason why our numbers have dwindled over the years.” Veth said sadly.

“I’m sorry, I’m not asking this because I don’t believe you, but how is that possible? Your people are not purely biological like much of the rest of the universe. Are you not also made of magic? How would Horde Prime make a virus to infect magic?” Aadhya said, kindness in her voice.

Veth nodded. “That is a good question, Pratham. We do not know how he did it. We only know the terrible evidence of it. How would someone be able to create a virus to take away a specific feeling? Why did he not do the same to the rest of the universe? It must have been our half-magical nature that made us susceptible,”

The Madgēcot leaders looked at each other, heads tilted in curiosity and consideration.

"If you cannot take my word at face value, noble Madgēcots, then just think of the evidence! You sensed something wrong with us when we were first reunited and forsook us! You banished us to our own part of the galaxy and held us prisoner, much like Horde Prime did! We did not understand why our friends, the Madgēcots, did this to us, and we reacted with anger—we are so sorry for that!" Veth cried, now going to their knees in supplication. The rest of the robed Nephraeh warriors did the same, mirroring their leader's every move.

"I know you could just take this sword from us and kill us all, but I beg you! I beseech you, please help us! Take us into your fold and guide us back to the correct path!" Veth said, placing their face to the ground, practically groveling.

Catra felt pity swirl in her chest at this display, and her heart went out to Veth and the Nephraeh. She knew what it was like to feel like you had fallen so far that there was no way back. Catra knew this all too well. She looked at the rest of the Madgēcots in the room and saw they felt the same—suspicion and mistrust had been wholly replaced by empathy.

Aadhya strode smoothly over to Veth, bending and lifting them gently to their feet. She placed both of her hands on their shoulders and gave a gentle squeeze.

"No one needs to beg the Madgēcots for help, Veth, and we are ashamed we did not give it freely to begin with. Of course, we will help you. There is no need for gifts or for us to rule you," she said kindly.

Veth smiled gratefully back to her, holding out the sword of Sher-Va, but Aadhya gently pushed it back.

"Hold on to it, for now; we will have it looked at in time. For now, you will be proper guests of the Madgēcots, and we will show you

true hospitality," she said, turning to the Council Members. "What does the Council say to a little short-notice reunion party?"

Beaming toothy smiles appeared on all Council members' faces as they unanimously nodded in agreement.

"That settles it then!" Aadhya cried. "We will welcome our old friends, the Nephraeh, back properly—tonight!"

The room that had begun the meeting in hostile agitation now erupted in joyous cheers as Madgēcots smiled and clapped. Catra found herself caught up in the happy emotions of her people and clapped along with them, halting when she turned to look at her wife's face.

Adora was clapping along with the rest of the Madgēcots, but she was not smiling or showing happy emotion on her face.

There was only suspicion written on her features.

Chapter End Notes

> Both illustrations done on commission by Henar Torinos. You can find more of her work on Instagram @henartorinos OR @ilikeyoucatradora

Abominable Power

Chapter Summary

Glimmer discovers the nature of what lies beneath Castle Grayskull.

Something is wrong with Mermista.

It was on the planet of Phantos that we finally tracked down the last remnant of the terror that once consumed the galaxy, now known as The Dark Times by scholars. I, Kishar, bearer of Zhe-La, along with my mentor Jihan, bearer of Sher-Va, did this deed.

I had just been released from my training at Castle Grayskull when the League of Kalosyni decided it would be best if I were paired with a more experienced Champion for the time being. This was uncommon for a novice but not unheard of, and I tried not to take offense or feel slighted by their decision, accepting their decision with good grace.

When they announced that the champion I was to be paired with was the Elysian champion Sher-Va, I was overjoyed. Everyone knew of the great love between the Nephraeh and the Madgēcots, and any unease I had felt vanished.

I first met the bearer of Sher-Va in my home city of Lumos when he landed his starship in the crystal garden outside of the Temple of Light. The garden tenders were furious when it was discovered that the ship's landing struts had destroyed a bed of Fire Tails; it had taken more than a century to grow them to their current height, and I thought they would pull the ship apart using their bare hands.

A wild-looking Madgēcot disembarked from the craft wearing one of those fantastic outfits they call Jaadoo suits; he was very charming and able to calm the irascible garden tenders. He introduced himself as just Jihan, forgoing the 'Sar' title that many

Champions chose to use. He told me how excited he was to be my mentor and promised that I would learn much from him. Not long after that, Jihan and I boarded his ship, Star Claw, and took off for the stars.

Our first missions were mostly uneventful. We attended ceremonies and resolved minor disputes between different worlds. There was one fairly humorous incident where the Prince of Vitrian proposed a bonding between himself and Jihan. It caused quite a stir when Jihan refused to accept, and we had to leave rather abruptly when the Prince accused Jihan of leading him on.

It was about this time that I began to suspect that the League's decision to pair me with Jihan was not for my benefit but his. Jihan was prone to going on whims, and I must admit he was a bit of a rogue, but even after realizing this, I was still glad of the League's decision. I thought that Jihan and I made the perfect team.

Even though he may be a bit of an unconventional Champion, Jihan is very kind and generous. No matter how far we have to travel, there has not been a call for aid that he refused to answer. Jihan is also very funny, telling jokes and playing the occasional prank on me. They are usually lighthearted pranks, meant to make me relax when I get too serious about what it means to be a Champion.

Jihan may have a flamboyant and wild exterior, but once you get past his walls, you will find a very sensitive and tender soul. As a Nephraeh, I have an advantage in that no amount of bluff can hide your quintessence from my gaze. There was no need for me to get behind Jihan's boundaries. I could already see who he was, deep inside, and I liked what I saw.

The fact that he was a very handsome Madgēcot is a bonus, and I often find myself looking in his direction when it was not warranted. It probably isn't appropriate for a novice to have these thoughts, and I plan only to admit them here in my personal log.

Time passed quickly while I was in Jihan's company, and we soon began to take on more challenging tasks. We stopped the blood games on the planet Rintor by breaking up the illegal trafficking of Morgrags. We stopped the suppression of the Glitter Miners by the royal family on the planet Zal-Cron. On the beautiful and lush world of Thenlor, we helped defend the workers from the vicious predators as they attempted to raise the first building on that planet.

It was when we were hunting for the criminal Drauc in the Illeos system that Jihan and I heard rumors of a Dark Mage. Since anyone using corrupted magic was of more importance than a counterfeiter, we decided to focus on hunting down the Dark Mage. Ten thousand years have passed since the Dark Times, yet Dark Magic was still a curse on our galaxy; it is the prime duty of every Champion to stamp it out.

Following the coordinates given to us, we took Jihan's ship, Star Claw, and came upon the planet Phantos. We knew very little of this planet since it is in Wild Space, outside the borders of our intergalactic society. Even from space, we could tell that something terrible was happening with the planet; massive fires could be seen blazing in places, and the murky gray of ash clouds was between them. It looked like the whole planet of Phantos was at war.

We landed near the ruins of a city, not ancient ruins, for the city showed recent signs of struggle and still burned in places. Upon entering the city, Jihan and I were attacked by bands of marauders who fought so savagely that we both had to transcend into our magical states. As Sher-Va and Zhe-La, we were able to subdue the marauders with little harm on their part.

We were surprised to discover that the marauders who had attacked us were the city's citizens; they were confused and incoherent after defeating them, seemingly under the influence of intoxicants. They rambled about a terrible wizard with a staff of burning blood which made them destroy their city, saying that he

wandered the planet, sowing ruin and destruction wherever he went.

Jihan and I spent a month moving from city to city searching for any rumor of this Dark Mage. In every city we reached, the horror was different, but the tale was the same; rage and hatred forced the people to turn on each other and there was no sign of the perpetrator. It seemed like he was always one step ahead of us, and we knew he was aware of us by now; it was hard for two Champions of the Light to hide their presence from a worshipper of evil.

It was in the Northern Wastes that we tracked down this wizard, facing him in a dark fortress he made for himself on the top of a secluded mountain. It was a wretched thing to behold; constructed of the bones and skulls of his victims—the people of Phantos he forced into a murderous rage using his dark power. By this time, the planet was practically depopulated, and both Jihan and I had our suspicions of who this Dark Mage actually was.

Our suspicions were verified when we entered the fortress and found none other than the last bearer of one of the Abominable Powers. The bearer's name is unknown, for he attacked without mercy while wielding the Eye of Hate—trying to fill us with so much rage that we attacked each other.

It is a horrible feeling, especially for one of my kind, to be filled with an emotion we don't know. Nephraeh may dislike another living being, but never hate them, and the feeling had almost overcome me with not only its power but the pure alienness of it. It was as if I was looking at Jihan through a red haze that burned me, and the only thing that would make the pain go away was to smash my mentor to pieces. The fact that I could see the same thing in Jihan's eyes, the urge to harm me, acted like a spur to goad me on.

But then I felt the pure Light of Grayskull dampening down the red hate—it was fueled by the love and empathy that comes so naturally to the Nephraeh. There was love directed toward Jihan;

it was not the love I usually felt, but a different kind—sweeter and more urgent. That was the ultimate key that broke the spell of the Eye of Hate, freeing me from its power.

Unfortunately, Jihan was still under the influence of the dread power, and he attacked me. He is a mighty warrior, and with the might of Sher-Va plus the Eye of Hate driving him, it took every ounce of my skill just to hold him off. Even if I wanted to, I could not hurt Jihan; he was my mentor and was dear to me. I was able to subdue him momentarily when I destroyed two pillars supporting a section of the ceiling, causing the structure to fall upon Jihan and pin him.

As Jihan fought to disentangle himself, I turned my attention to the sorcerer. I could see the panic in his sunken eyes as he realized his powers would not work on me, and in desperation, he summoned burning fire made from pure hate, and hurled it at me. The flames engulfed me, but instead of burning me, they dissipated into harmless smoke.

I must admit that I felt a thrill at this moment; I had heard tales all my life about the Abominable Powers and imagined that they would be terrible to face. But when I found myself in the presence of one, it was almost powerless against me, and it made me cocky. I laughed in the sorcerer's face, demanding that he give himself up, and when he refused, I tried to take him by force.

It was then that Jihan finally freed himself from his prison and hurled himself at us. He was an avatar of rage at this point, where the Eye of Hate's powers could not find purchase in my heart; it found a home in Jihan. Madgēcots are a gift to the galaxy; every Nephraeh feels this way. Their empathy matches that of the Nephraeh, sometimes exceeding ours, but where we can't feel hate, the Madgēcots are less fortunate. We all know the saying, 'a Madgēcot's purr comes as quickly as their claws; beware the fury of the Madgēcot.'

Jihan bounded on all fours towards us, not bothering with his sword, and tossed me aside as if I weighed nothing. He pounced

on the sorcerer, and using only his bare claws, tore the man to pieces. I felt great pity for the man as he screamed, for as evil as he was, he did not deserve to die like that.

With the sorcerer dead, Jihan reverted into his natural form, in the same delirious state as the city dwellers we encountered upon first landing on this planet. I think that was fortunate for him, I did not want Jihan to see what he had done to the bearer of the Eye of Hate, and I planned on never telling him what he had done.

It was then that aid arrived at this beleaguered planet, summoned by us a month previously. With our help, they tracked down the remaining survivors and transported them off-world; the planet of Phantos was deemed no longer habitable. The survivors were poor and staved, haunted by the horrors they had seen. I suggested that they should be taken to my planet of Empyrea and placed under the care of my people. We Nephraeh are good at reminding others of the joy of being alive.

Jihan and I transported the Abominable Power to Eternia and presented it to the sorcerer of Castle Grayskull to be interred with the other captured Prime Evils. I was pleased to rid myself of the Eye of Hate; it is such an ugly thing, appearing as a lump of red rock. Upon closer (and careful) inspection, the stone is actually translucent, and if you look closely enough, you can see—

Glimmer stopped reading the datapad and looked at the red stone retrieved from the depths of Castle Grayskull sitting next to her on her reading desk. It was lit from above by an open skylight, revealing that it was indeed translucent. It looked like a hunk of red glass that was viciously hacked from another source, and it was indeed very ugly.

"The Eye of Hate," she whispered aloud, feeling chills run down her back.

At the sound of its actual name, a red light pulsed in the core of the stone, and Glimmer felt pure rage course through her body

like hot flames. She gritted her teeth and forced herself to look away from the horrible stone.

Abominable Power, she thought to herself, too afraid to speak aloud. *And I have it here, in Bright Moon, sitting on my desk like it's a paperweight!*

With the permission of the new High Council of Eternia, Glimmer, Castaspella, Micha, and a group of Mystacor scholars had investigated Castle Grayskull. Besides the chamber the statues were located in, they had not found anything of importance in the upper Castle, just a bunch of rooms containing rotted furniture and old junk. Glimmer had seen no sign of the great chamber with the throne she had seen in her vision, the one with Adam as a sad, ancient man.

It was below Castle Grayskull that they found something of interest. The whole underside of the castle was filled with corridors and chambers—it seemed like an endless maze. They did not have to look far for the room with the Eye of Hate; there, they found the ugly, red stone sitting on a black pedestal in the middle of the room. Neither Glimmer, her Father, nor Aunt had sensed anything the matter with the rock, and it was decided that they take it back to Bright Moon for further study—unwisely, it seemed now. It appeared the malignant object could sense the right time to expose its true nature—as if it had an actual intelligence and not just a source of evil power.

Glimmer thought of the other chambers they had discovered, with other strange objects sitting on their own pedestals. They were still back at Grayskull being examined by a Mystacor Explorer team; Glimmer noted that she should warm them as soon as possible as to the nature of the things kept in the basement of Castle Grayskull.

She thought it very strange that no matter how far they descended into the depths below the castle, Glimmer always felt the pull of some greater power below them. They had explored deep into the tunnels, turning around when they feared losing the

way back. There always seemed like there was another flight of stairs or ramp leading down; perhaps it really did extend into forever…

Glimmer suddenly jumped as she heard a tentative knock at the Observatory door.

"Hello? Just come in," she said, trying not to sound annoyed.

She was expecting Entrapta and was surprised to see Seahawk open the door and meekly enter.

"Seahawk! Wow, I wasn't expecting you. Did you come for a tour of my Observatory?"

Glimmer said this happily. She was pleased to see him for some reason. Perhaps it was the fact that Seahawk was always so upbeat all the time—something she felt like she needed at the moment. But these thoughts fled as she saw the look on his face; there was fear and worry plastered all over Seahawk's handsome features.

"Hey, what's the matter?" Glimmer said, concern in her voice now.

"I'm so sorry to bother you, Queen Glimmer, but it is my Mermista. There is something terribly wrong with her." Seahawk said, trepidation in his voice.

Glimmer's mind went back to their return trip from retrieving the Void Gem, how Mermista seemed more morose than usual. Glimmer had assumed it was just the fact that the crypt just wasn't as glamorous as Mermista was used to, but she kept seeing her fellow princess rubbing her neck, where the creature had bitten her. The fear she had seen in Seahawk found its way into her.

"Take me to her," was all Glimmer said.

* * *

A short time later, Glimmer and Seahawk appeared outside the palace in Salineas in a haze of sparkles. Glimmer instantly realized something strange about the palace; its usual opalescent surfaces now seemed dead and drab, as if they no longer cared to shine. She followed Seahawk into the palace and approached a group of guards who appeared to be baring their way.

"Where is Mermista?" Seahawk asked one of the guards.

The woman looked nervously at her fellows and visibly gulped.

"The Princess is in her throne room, she said she did not want to be disturbed. If I were you, I would listen," she said, voice shaking. The guards looked at each other as if unsure whether or not they should bar the visitors from seeing their Princess.

Glimmer stepped forward, placed her hand on the guard's shoulder, and smiled at her.

"Is it okay if the Queen of Etheria visits her friend, the Princess of Salineas?" Glimmer asked kindly.

The tone of Glimmer's voice put the guard at ease, and she visibly relaxed, smiling now.

"I think that might be best," the female guard whispered, indicating to the other guards to let the visitors through.

Seahawk led Glimmer in the direction of the throne room, the usually boisterous man now wholly intent on reaching Mermista. Upon entering the large throne room chamber, Glimmer was surprised to see that it was unchanged—the waterfalls along the walls still flowed, and the beautiful throne shaped like an oyster still sat at the other end of the chamber—now empty. She had been expecting the room to display the same drab appearance as the rest of the palace.

They spotted Mermista standing with her hands behind her back while staring at the wall between two of the waterfalls. There was First One's writing there, and Mermista appeared to be studying it.

That's weird. When did Mermista have an interest in First One's runes? Or anything scholarly, for that matter? Glimmer thought to herself.

Mermista's head turned as Glimmer and Seahawk approached her, a look of mild bemusement on her usually neutral features.

"Ah, *my Queen*," she said, putting a hint of scorn in her voice. "I'm glad Seahawk brought you here; I have something to share with you."

Glimmer pushed down at her anger at hearing Mermista's tone and tried to maintain a civil manner.

"*Princess* Mermista," Glimmer said, emphasizing Mermista's title. "Seahawk wanted me to check up on you. Is everything okay?"

Mermista laughed at this. "Like, everything is fine, never better! Come, take a look at these First One's runes; they are so fascinating! I've never taken an interest in them before, but now I see the pure genius of what the First Ones did!"

As she said this, Mermista traced the geometric lines of the First One's ancient writing with her finger, seeming to find their shapes pleasing. Glimmer had no clue what they said; as far as she knew, Adora was the only one who could read them. She had a strange sensation that this was no longer the fact.

Glimmer's face scrunched up at this. "You mean how they tried to harness the magic of Etheria and make a weapon out of it?"

"Okay, whatever," Mermista said, waving this away with her hand. "What's the big deal? If we had harnessed it ourselves, we could have, like, destroyed the Horde years ago."

"Yeah, but at what cost?" Glimmer said, horrified. "From what Adora told us, using the Heart of Etheria as a weapon cost millions of people their lives. How is that even close to being beneficial?"

Mermista thought about this, weighing the benefits of First One's knowledge versus the lives of other people, then shrugged, making a dismissive sound.

"Eh, I don't know why it seemed so important before…" Mermista said, her voice drifting off.

"You mean wanting to know the secrets of the First Ones? I agree, what they did is no longer important to us today; we are better off with the magic no longer chained." Glimmer said, nodding and smiling.

Mermista snorted in derision. "No. I mean, like, why other people are so important. Especially ones we don't know—who cares what happens to them? I don't even know why I cared in the first place."

Glimmer gaped at the Princess, shocked by her sudden callousness. Turning to Seahawk, she saw that he had his face in his hands and appeared to be weeping.

"Oh, Mermista, my sweet Mermista. *What happened to you?*" He moaned.

Mermista groaned loudly. "Stop your whining! I don't know what I ever saw in you, Seahawk. You're just a whiny boy in a man's body. *You make me sick."*

"Mermista!" Glimmer exclaimed. "What is the matter with you?"

"Nothing is the matter, *Miss Queen of Etheria*. Like, I've never felt better. In fact, I think I will start turning Salineas' attention towards researching First One's technology to benefit us. Perhaps I will enlist the aid of Entrapta and Hordak; they have never balked at new technology." Mermista said airily.

Glimmer slammed her staff on the ground; the sound of judgment was evident.

"I forbid you to do so! As Queen of Etheria, I forbid Salineas from using First One's technology!" Glimmer said, authority in her voice.

Mermista laughed at her. "Well, in that case, Salineas declares itself independent from you and the rest of Etheria. I no longer recognize you as my Queen, and I will do whatever I want. I think you forget how I was the one who led the rebellion against Horde Prime while you were off doing *whatever* in space. It could have just as easily been me crowned Queen of Etheria and not you."

"I was crowned Queen by the people of Etheria, and from what I remember, you agreed with it!" Glimmer cried, incensed now.

Mermista placed a finger to her lips as if a thought had come to her.

"I bet if I showed the people what I could do with First One's Technology, like, they would totally make me Queen instead of you. What do you think of that, Glimmer? Perhaps I could actually protect them from some random interdimensional Death God with actual weapons instead of some silly sparkly magic." Mermista said with a cruel grin on her face.

"Uh, you seem to be forgetting that we beat the Dark He-Man and that weird glowing moon-thing, Mermista. *And* my magic is no longer silly sparkles; it's the power of the universe!" Glimmer said, holding up the Star Stone.

Mermista looked at the magical stone at the end of Glimmer's staff with a look of hunger; Glimmer had never seen that look in her friend's eyes before.

"Yeah, *it's so interesting* how I have not found my staff yet, isn't Glimmer? Are you afraid I will be powerful enough to challenge your rule once I have the Kinetic Krystal? Oh, of course, you let silly Perfuma and loyal Scorpia find theirs. They are too weak to challenge you!" Mermista said, fury beginning to rise in her voice.

"I can't believe you are saying this about your friends, Mermista. What is wrong with you?" Glimmer said in a hushed whisper. "You

were there with me; we had no idea which staff we would find. It could have just as easily been you. We were basically going on the fragments of information Entrapta found."

Mermista snorted, unconvinced. "Entrapta. Yeah, right. Your lapdog minion Princess. I'm sure neither one of you had any clue what we would find—yeah, sure." She said sarcastically. "Maybe I won't be enlisting her help—how could I trust her? I bet Hordak would help me. He knows how to get things done,"

"Help you do what, Mermista?" Glimmer said, already knowing the answer. The only response she received from Mermista was a knowing eyebrow raise.

Glimmer could not believe what was happening; what had initially been a trip to check up on an old friend had turned into an open rebellion against her. She could not believe this was Mermista before her; she was like a totally different person—as if she were being controlled again.

Like when Horde Prime chipped her.

Glimmer raised her hands, trying to soothe her friend.

"Okay, Mermista, let's not be hasty. Can we start over, please? How about we talk about what happened on our trip to find the Void Gem? I feel like you have not been yourself since we got back. I feel like maybe something awful happened to you when those *things* attacked us," Glimmer said as she started to move slowly towards Mermista.

A sudden look of fear crossed Mermista's face, and she reached for the spot where the creature had sunk its fangs into her. Then she saw Glimmer making her way over to her, and anger appeared on her face.

"Nothing is the matter with me!" Mermista snarled. "I'm better than ever, and you can just stay away from me!"

Mermista raised her trident topped staff and pointed it in Glimmer's direction, the three arrow-shaped points glowing with power.

"Mermista, please!" Glimmer begged. "There is something wrong —"

Glimmer's words were cut short as all six of the waterfalls in the throne room burst outward in a solid torrent of water aimed directly at her. If it wasn't for the fact that she created a magical barrier at the last second, she and Seahawk would have most assuredly been killed.

Mermista stared at them, cold hate now in her eyes.

"I want you to leave, now. You no longer have a right to be here, Queen Glimmer. I banish you from Salineas. LEAVE! NOW!" She said through clenched teeth.

"Mermista, darling, please!" Seahawk cried. "If you won't listen to Glimmer, then listen to me! I know you like no other because I love you! I can say without a doubt that you have not been yourself since you came back, it's like...it's like you lost your *compassio*n, my darling. It's not you. It's not you because you are the most compassionate person I know! There is something terrible going on, Mermista; please let us help you!"

"And take that *idiot* with you. I should have banished him a long time ago; he has been nothing but an annoying nuisance ever since I met him," Mermista said, turning her back on them as she crossed her arms.

Glimmer saw the heartbreak in Seahawk's eyes as he gaped in numb horror at the woman he had the misfortune of loving. Not wanting to make things worse with Mermista, she took Seahawk's hand and led him out of the throne room. Before the doors slammed behind them, Seahawk turned to look one last time at his Princess, firm resolve on his face.

“I’m not giving up on you, my Mermista; I will be back. I will find a way to save you,” Seahawk whispered as the doors slammed closed with a resounding bang of finality.

A Curious Attraction

Chapter Summary

> At the Madgēcot celebration, Catra discovers that up close Veth is not what they seem.

Smiling, happy faces packed the main chamber of the Raajadhaanee Celebration Hall; it was the Reunion Celebration, hastily thrown together at the last minute after the tense meeting between the Nephraeh and the Madgēcots. The majority of the celebrants were Madgēcots, but here and there were other citizens of Elysia who were invited to attend the celebration. They all mingled, talked, and enjoyed the various delicious food spreads laid out on large wooden tables while Veth watched with glittering silver eyes.

Veth focused on a group of short-statured beings with a curl of their lips; Umgah, they called themselves. From the Gnosis operative's reports, the Umgah lived in the ground, trading the precious metals they mined from deep within Elysia with the Madgēcots. The Umgah had extremely short limbs, and Veth could not understand how they could function as they shuffled about the room. The short beings were talking to a Madgēcot, a Star Hunter by his look, and he laughed at what was being said. He placed a hand on one of the Umgah's shoulders, smiling affectionately at the smaller being as Veth felt disgust rise in their chest.

Why do the Madgēcots allow these other lesser beings to live on their planet? Veth thought incredulously.

As much as the Nephraeh currently hated the Madgēcots, they still respected them; they still thought of them as equals. The Madgēcots were a strong race of the same stature as the Nephraeh, a race who had the right to rule other lesser ones. It boggled Veth's mind as to why these short, foolish creatures were allowed to attend this so-called reunion party—it was an insult to

the Nephraeh. It was only because they had to play the part of the supplicant that Veth kept from voicing their ire. They did not want to foil the plans they had so carefully laid.

Soon the Phylactery they secretly released from orbit and directed towards a non-Madgēcot settlement will have summoned the Vetala. Veth did not like this plan; it was too messy and unfocused, but it was the Archon's idea, so it must be obeyed. It was a plan that could easily be undone by chance, but there was a backup plan—also a distasteful one, but more reliable.

So many distasteful plans, Veth thought as they ground their teeth.

An unknown sensation overcame Veth as they continued to watch the Umgah, now following their Madgēcot friend as he led them over to a table full of food. They walked in an interesting fashion, pivoting from side to side so as to move their short legs easier. Veth could not place the feeling; it was like a strange gentleness in their chest, and suddenly they hoped the Vetala were not near the place where these diminutive beings lived. The Vetala were instructed to only Enervate She-Ra—that was the whole point of them being there. But even without the power of Enervation, they were still deadly, could still hurt whomever lived in the village.

The Umgah would not stand a chance, Veth thought as they imagined these short beings trying to waddle away from the Vetala's claws and fangs. They shook their head, and the emotion was gone as quickly as it came, like moonlight seen briefly through dark night clouds.

What was that? Why would I suddenly care what happens to those silly creatures? Veth thought angrily. *Am I slipping? When was the last time I performed the Penumbra ritual before Archon Lethe?*

Veth decided that soon they would ask one of the Krypteia to help perform a smaller version of the Penumbra ritual, just to hold them over until Veth could get back to Empyrea and their Archon.

They needed to cleanse themselves; they could feel The Light slipping from them like sand through their clawed fingers.

Feeling the need to get away, Veth scanned the room, making sure they were not watched. They moved out of the main reception chamber and towards one of the smaller adjoining ones. Passing through a small hallway, they saw that it did not end in a room but opened up into a large terrace overlooking the Jacarandra trees. It was empty, and Veth moved out onto the balcony to lean on the rail, thinking back on the day's events since landing.

It had happened so fast, the meeting with the Madgēcots, and Veth realized the stress they had been under. Ever since leaving Empyrea, they were hoping everything would proceed according to plan, hoping not the slightest thing would go wrong and give them away. So many were counting on them, their people. The Archon had put so much faith into Veth, a faith that so far seemed warranted.

So far.

Am I worthy of anyone's faith? Or am I a fraud? Veth thought to themselves.

No, they were worthy—the events of the first meeting with the Madgēcots were a testament to that. Veth had played their part, and it had gone *perfectly;* the Madgēcots were blinded to Veth's true purpose by their weak empathy.

A sick feeling crept into Veth's stomach at the memory of kneeling before the Madgēcots, begging them to accept Empyrea as a vassal world. They hated having to resort to deception, it was not worthy of the Nephraeh, but it was the looks in the Madgēcot's eyes that had truly pained Veth.

It was all Veth could do to be able to stand before them and smile, accepting the invitation to this reunion gathering without doubling over in absolute pain.

It was the pity, the empathy pouring off of the Madgēcots in waves directed towards Veth that they remembered now with horror. It was like a searing red hot knife in their chest as they felt something within them react to this emotion with absolute hatred, a hatred that was not of them but something else. It had rejected the feeling of empathy directed at Veth and, in turn, took it out on Veth in the form of physical pain.

Veth felt a twinge of that same pain and clutched at their chest, allowing themselves a small gasp—believing themselves alone. They were not.

"Are you okay?" a female voice said behind them.

Veth whirled in surprise, baring their fangs at this intrusion, but composed themselves upon seeing that it was a Madgēcot woman. Shock was written on her face at Veth's reaction, but not fear, for she did not retreat. Not that Veth expected any Madgēcot to retreat.

"I am fine, thank you. Just this rich Madgēcot food is not agreeing with me." Veth lied with a smile.

The Madgēcot woman laughed. "Yeah, I know the feeling; I'm still getting used to it myself."

Veth realized that this Madgēcot was different from the others; for one thing, she was not dressed in one of those accursed magic outfits they all wear. Instead, she wore tight-fitting purple pants and a red and gold top that revealed her stomach. She also did not have the accent all Madgēcots shared; it did not even have a hint of that lyrical tone.

She was beautiful, this Madgēcot, and Veth took in her cinnamon-colored face, her heterochromatic eyes—yellow and blue. They were such lovely and alluring eyes, drawing Veth in. It was rare for them as it was rare for any Nephraeh, but Veth liked what they saw.

She held out a hand tentatively to Veth. "Hi, I'm Catra."

* * *

Catra strode through the Celebration Hall, mingling with her people and their guests. The Madgēcots had wasted no time in gathering to celebrate their reunion with the Nephraeh—a little too hastily in Catra's opinion. Just this morning, the Nephraeh were the deadliest of enemies, but after some placating words by Veth, the Madgēcots were ready to forgive and forget.

Well, maybe they're ready to forgive but not forget, Catra thought as she spotted Star Hunters placed about the room, watching the Nephraeh guests intently with slitted eyes.

The majority of the celebration attendants seemed happy to be there, and the mood was relaxed—except for anyplace the Nephraeh were.

The robed Nephraeh were politely talking to a group of Madgēcots; Catra could see how uncomfortable her people were, their tails were practically wagging with agitation. But the Madgēcots were trying to make it work, especially with the tragic nature of the Nephraeh known to all. The Madgēcots were trying to push past the chill nature of the Nephraeh, using their compassion to enable them to tolerate their old allies and hopefully help them heal themselves in the future.

Catra remembered what Horde Prime did to her all too well, forcing her into that horrible green fluid to 'take the pain away,' then installing the mind control chip in her neck. It was the most atrocious violation Catra had ever experienced, and she could not imagine what that monster had done to the Nephraeh to make them the way they are now. It must have been vile and terrible to take a whole species' ability to feel empathy away.

Catra spotted Veth standing separately away from everyone else, watching the party take place like the outsider they were. They were watching a group of the Umgah talking to her brother, Viraj, and Veth seemed uncomfortable with what they were seeing.

Catra had left Adora while she was speaking with Aadhya, the two women bonding over their shared love of military structure. Catra had always hated the regimented part of the Horde and found herself drifting away in the conversation, walking away when she felt the need to wander, seeking something more interesting.

She now realized what she sought was Veth, wanting to lay eyes on the alluring bearer of Zhe-La; she was so intensely curious about them. She saw so much of her old self in Veth, especially now as they appeared so lonely, so tragic, and appearing so in need of making a connection.

Suddenly, Veth peered about the room as if to make sure they were not being watched, and Catra hid behind a table. She peeked between platters of food just in time to see Veth exit the main celebration space, and as she stood abruptly from behind the table to follow them, she almost knocked over a Madgēcot bearing a platter of more food.

"Whoops! My bad!" Catra said with an apologetic smile as she went to steady the server, then stopped herself when she recognized the angry black-furred face and green eyes.

"Ugh, you again, you seem to be becoming a problem for me, Cat-Tra," Maira said with a growl as she deftly rebalanced the tray on her shoulder.

"Yeah, sorry about that, Maira. Hey, I would love to stay and talk about my funny smell with you, but I think I heard Adora call for me. Bye!" Catra said with a feigned smile as she gave Maira a meek wave goodbye.

What did Panga ever see in her? Catra thought as she quickly strode away.

Maira watched Catra go, suspicion now replacing anger in her hooded eyes.

Maira made a disgusted face and turned her attention towards laying out the food platter, giving Catra the chance to slip out of

the main room in the same direction Veth left.

Catra spotted Veth at the end of a long corridor, leaning over a balcony to gaze out on the Elysian night. Veth's back was turned to Catra, and she felt her eyes being drawn down towards the stylish pants they wore; woven black bands of seemingly metallic material accentuated Veth's pleasing form.

Huh, I wonder if all Nephraeh have such nice butts, Catra thought appreciatively, and she tried to approach as quietly as possible. She wondered if she was having any luck with her stealth as she looked at Veth's long ears sticking out between strands of black glossy hair.

She almost leaped when Veth bent over and clutched their chest, giving a small, fragile cry of pain.

"Are you okay?" Catra said, unable to hide her concern.

Veth whirled on her with a snarl, baring their sharp fangs at her just like a Madgēcot would do. The suddenness of the reaction shocked her, and she felt a giddy thrill at the danger she saw in Veth. Just as suddenly as it appeared, the fury was gone, and Veth calmed down, inspecting her with those cold silver eyes of theirs.

"I am fine, thank you. Just this rich Madgēcot food is not agreeing with me." Veth said with a smile; Catra knew this was a lie but did not feel the need to call Veth out on it.

"Yeah, I know the feeling; I'm still getting used to it myself," Catra said, thinking of how the rich food gave her stomach issues, not helping a laugh as she remembered how badly Adora was affected.

Veth gave her a curious tilt of the head as they considered her words, the look on their face continued to be unreadable, making Catra feel uncomfortable.

“Hi, I’m Catra,” she said, trying to alleviate some of the tension by holding out her hand.

Veth looked down at her outstretched hand; they looked like they did not know what to make of the gesture.

“Sorry, don’t you shake hands where you come from?” Catra asked, feeling a little foolish.

She was about to retract her hand when Veth smoothly reached out and clasped her hand in theirs, giving her hand a gentle shake. The feel of Veth’s hand was not unpleasant, and Catra could have sworn there was a mild tingle as she made contact with them.

“I think the Nephraeh used to do something like this, but it was more of a hug than a handshake. We used to allow people to get closer to us before...you know...” Veth said with a shrug as they released Catra’s hand.

Catra dismissed the thought of hugging Veth as she felt a blush rise in her cheeks; she realized that maybe seeking Veth out by herself may not have been such a good idea.

“Yeah, I’m really sorry about what happened to you and you people, Veth. I had a run-in with Horde Prime as well, so I know how horrible he can be,” Catra said as she felt her eyes drift to the place where Veth’s waistcoat opened at their chest, revealing soft-looking lilac skin. There were white markings there, in the form of short lines and curves, and it made Catra wonder if Veth’s entire body was covered in them.

“Yes, I believe I heard the story, Catra. Horde Prime attempted to wipe your memory, and they controlled your mind with his evil technology, making you fight against She-Ra.” Veth said smoothly. “But She-Ra rescued you and cleansed your mind of his taint. Is that why you had chosen to mate with her?”

Catra had to stop herself from spluttering. “Mate with her? You make it sound so dispassionate, Veth. No, I am not with Adora

just because she rescued me; it's more than that. We have a bond that can never be broken, we are soul mates, and we love each other.” Catra said, then became suspicious. “How do you know about that anyway?”

“From our Gnosis operatives. They gather intelligence about the galaxy at large and bring it back to Empyrea. It seems like every world they visit, they tell the same story of the fall of Horde Prime.” Veth said as they seemed to realize something. “I’m sorry about the prying questions, I know we must seem so cold and distasteful to you, and I apologize. The Nephraeh have much to thank you and Adora for destroying Horde Prime. We owe you a great debt.”

Catra waved their gratitude away sheepishly. “Oh, it was nothing. You don’t have to thank us; we were just trying to survive, basically. It was just dumb luck that Adora and I survived the Heart of Etheria and stopped Horde Prime.” Catra said as she once again thought of how lucky she was to have Adora.

She felt very guilty about how she seemed to be attracted to Veth, drawn to the feminine facet of their androgynous nature. Veth was indeed very beautiful, but that was on the outside; Catra knew they were a different story on the inside. Veth was a broken soul, lost without the gift of empathy, and she realized that it was her empathy that was drawing her to them. She wanted to help Veth, help them like so many others tried to help her during her dark times. She just wasn’t sure how yet.

“Don’t you have anyone, Veth?”

Veth’s face fell, and Catra regretted asking, but then they looked back at her more with confusion than sadness.

“No, I don’t have a mate. I have no time to find one as Zhe-La, and I don’t think it is that important, really. I’m sure that when it is necessary, my Archon will pick one for me,” Veth said without emotion.

"*Pick one for you?*" Catra said incredulously, then realized her error. "Sorry, Veth. I don't mean to sound so—"

"Horrified?" Veth finished for her.

"No!" Catra said, feeling ashamed that that was precisely how she felt. "No, it's just that when a person loves you, and you love them, it is such a special thing. It's not something someone can pick for you. When you say that someone is going to pick this person for you, Veth, it just makes me feel—"

"Sorry for me?" Veth said, once again filling in the blanks of Catra's sentences.

Catra ground her teeth as she practically itched with uncomfortable embarrassment.

"No! And stop finishing my sentences!" Catra said with some annoyance. "I hate that!"

Veth allowed her a small smile and shrugged.

Are they messing with me? Catra thought suspiciously.

"I just want to understand, Veth, that's all. I am at a place in my life where I have someone I love. I guess it makes me—ugh, I can't believe I am going to admit this to a stranger—makes me feel like I want to share it—" Catra said as her eyes widened, realizing how her words could be misinterpreted. "—not that I'm looking to share my love with you in that way, Veth!" Catra cried, holding her hands up.

"Well, I guess what I'm saying is that I want you to know how I feel, to feel love, and I want to help show you—uhh...well, not *show you,* show you. Like, I don't want to, *you know*…" Catra said with a nervous giggle. "Not because I don't think you are attractive! Uh, wow! I can't believe I just went and said that." Catra said, putting her hand over her face as she felt her ears droop.

Veth tilted their head, curiosity bright in their silver eyes. “Is this some kind of Madgēcot mating ritual?”

Catra chuckled at this. “No, Veth, I am already taken. Sorry if I sound like an idiot. I’m just bad with this stuff; being good and nice is still very new to me. I guess what I’m trying to say is: you look like you need a friend.”

“You want to be my friend?” Veth said. Catra heard a strange tone in their voice that she could not place, even with her long sensitive ears.

“Yeah, sure. I think I would be a good friend; I have a friend named Scorpia who showed me what a good friend looks like. I think I could be that for you, if you want,” Catra said, trying not to sound so shy.

Veth turned from her, looking out towards the encircling forest as they considered her words. Catra was afraid they would say no and make things terribly awkward when they turned to her with a bright smile.

“I think I would like that, Catra. Yes, we should be friends.” Veth said.

“Great!” Catra beamed.

Veth tilted their head as they considered their new relationship. “So, what do we do *now*, as *friends*?”

Catra could have sworn that there was a suggestive nature to Veth’s question but ignored it as she answered.

“Well, for one thing, friends tell each other stuff. I remember Scorpia telling me just about everything there was to know about her—even if I didn’t exactly want to know it at the time.” Catra said, smiling at the memory of her friend.

Veth looked suspicious. “Is this some trick to fool me into giving up my people’s secrets? I will tell you this, Catra—I hold honor in

high regard and would not appreciate you using friendship as a way to manipulate me." Veth said, cold wrath in their voice.

Catra held her hand up in placation as her tail twitched in agitation. "No! Absolutely not, I would never do that, Veth! When I ask someone to be my friend, there are no strings attached. We don't have to talk about any secrets or anything about your feud with Elysia."

Veth pursed their lips, seeming to accept Catra's response. "So, what do you want to know about me, Catra?"

Catra suddenly felt a loss for words as she regarded Veth, not knowing where to start. There was so much she wanted to know about them, and she was overcome by their invitation. She looked into their attractive face, framed by that long black hair and into their mirror-like eyes, surrounded by dark smudging.

"Well, for one thing, what with the make-up?" Catra said, indicating with swirling motions around her own eyes. "You're the only Nephraeh who wears that make-up."

"Make-up?" Veth asked, confused. "Oh, you mean the kohl-smearing around my eyes? It is symbolic; by darkening the area around my eyes, it allows me to see The Light better."

"The Light?" Catra said with a curious tilt of her head. "What is this Light I keep hearing about whenever anyone mentions your race? Horde Prime always talked about a Light, always telling me to 'step into the light, Little Sister.' I really hope the Light the Nephraeh speak of is not the same thing, Veth."

Veth looked unfocused as they pursed their lips, appearing deep in thought and Catra had a sneaking suspicion they were coming up with a lie. Then, with a shake of Veth's head, the look was gone, and they released a sigh of resignation.

"There is not much difference, I guess, Catra," they said with a shrug. "It's based on seeing the Universe with cold logic, without the hindrance of emotion—especially empathy or compassion. It is

based on peace, absolute peace, and order; it is the basis for which we rule our planet. It's about following the supreme direction and rule of one being who has the logic, reason, and wisdom to rule—The Archon Lethe."

Catra tried to hide the horror on her face as Veth described almost word for word what Horde Prime was all about. The Nephraeh's Light was precisely what Horde Prime spoke of and believed in.

I guess it makes sense; Horde Prime was the one who did this to them. He infected the Nephraeh with his horrible ideals somehow. He infected them with his Light. Catra thought as she felt a sudden surge of empathy for Veth and all the Nephraeh.

"So, now that I told you how messed up we are, do you still want to be my friend, Catra?" Veth asked with a weak smile.

Catra immediately reached out, clasping Veth's clawed hands in her clawed hands, giving them a gentle squeeze.

"Yes, of course, I do!" Catra said, giving Veth a warm smile

* * *

"Yeah, so, when I was ten, I had an idea to organize the Horde battle units from twelve-person squads down to five-person fire teams. I wrote up this whole thesis on it, and Shadow Weaver loved it so much, she incorporated it into the Horde standard operating procedure. It was no big deal," Adora said, trying and failing to sound modest.

"Fascinating, Adora. It sounds like you were quite the child prodigy when it came to tactics; no wonder you were selected to become She-Ra," Aadhya said appreciatively.

Adora laughed. "No, the Horde had nothing to do with She-Ra; I happened upon the sword by accident, actually. And it's a good thing the Horde didn't have the power of She-Ra either—yikes!"

Aadhya nodded at this, and then a thought came to her. "Do you think you would still be in the Horde today if you hadn't found the sword?" She asked tentatively.

Adora immediately shook her head. "No. I would have figured it out at some point that the Horde was not the force for justice they claimed to be. I might not have had the power of She-Ra to fight them, but I would have ended up in the rebellion all the same.

This seemed to satisfy Aadhya, and she nodded to herself. "We are truly fortunate to have you act as the bearer of She-Ra, Adora. You are an intrinsically good person with a unique perspective on evil, having grown up in the Horde. Tell me, what do you think of this Veth? Do you think their offer is true?"

The suddenness of the question made Adora draw up short, remembering watching Veth practically beg the Madgēcots to accept the Nephraeh's offer of fealty. She remembered feeling pity for Veth and the people of Empyrea; it sounded like they suffered at the hand of Horde Prime. But at the moment she felt her heart go out to the Nephraeh, it suddenly became shielded, as if by another force. She had felt mistrust being thrust into her breast—as if someone was dictating it to her and realized it was not actually her that was feeling it.

It was She-Ra.

The spirit of her magical avatar was trying to tell her not to trust what she saw, more specifically, not to trust Veth.

But looking into Aadhya's eyes and seeing the trust in them, she knew she could not voice this distrust. There was too much riding on this reunion between the Nephraeh and the Madgēcots; Adora could not be the deciding force driving a wedge back between them. She had to see how this played out; who knows, perhaps she was misinterpreting what She-Ra was trying to tell her. Adora was more of a 'punch your feeling out' kind of person.

“Yeah, I don’t know, Aadhya. Veth was just too unreadable for me to know whether or not they were being truthful. There is one thing that I do know, and that is that Horde Prime was pure evil. I believe that he was capable of doing what the Nephraeh claim he did.” Adora said.

Aadhya cocked her head in consideration. “If Horde Prime truly did take away the Nephraeh’s capability to feel empathy, then I believe that would make them even less worthy of trust.”

“Just because they are less worthy of trust does not mean they are not worthy of our help, Aadhya,” Adora said with a slight tone of reproach in her voice.

Aadhya caught the tone, and her eyes widened, as her tail twitched in agitation. But as suddenly as it came, the annoyance was gone and replaced by a rueful smile.

“I can see why you are the bearer of the She-Ra, Adora. Someone as young as you has more wisdom than an old gray-tail like me,” Aadhya said with a chuckle. “You're; we should help the Nephraeh no matter what.”

Just then, a black-furred Star Hunter approached their conversation, and Adora recognized Maira from before. The Madgēcot was staring at a datapad in her hands with an urgent look on her face.

“Excuse me, Pratham. But we are receiving calls for aid from a small village to the east of the Jacarandra Forest. They are under attack from an unknown force.” Maira said.

Aadhya gave Adora a meaningful look, raising one gray eyebrow.

“Whose village is it?” Aadhya asked.

“It’s the Fareek, Pratham,” Maira answered.

Aadhya’s face lit up with surprise. “The Fareek, you say? Under attack by an unknown force? The Fareek never ask us for

aid...they never ask us for anything! They are always too proud!”

Aadhya shook her head as her tail twitched rapidly in agitation, and Adora placed a comforting hand on the elder Madgēcot’s shoulder.

“What can I do to help, Aadhya?” Adora said gently.

Aadhya nodded in appreciation. “This whole thing is suspicious, Adora. I don’t like the smell of it. But it would be good to have She-Ra with us when we investigate this disturbance. I will have a flyer pick us up from our location. Can you be ready soon?”

Adora nodded firmly. “You bet. Let me just find my wife first,” Adora said, looking around. “Where did she get off to?”

“I saw her sneaking off towards the balcony,” Maira said smugly, indicating the direction with a clawed thumb.

Adora ignored the other woman’s disrespect towards Catra and nodded her thanks, quickly heading off in the direction of the balcony. She finally spotted Catra as she made her way along the curved hallway and was surprised to see her wife was not alone. More importantly, she was shocked by what Catra was doing.

Catra was holding hands with Veth and smiling at them; she was giving them a very genuine smile.

Adora stopped in her tracks, surprised by the sudden spike of jealousy she felt. At that moment, Veth spotted her, withdrawing their hands from Catra’s, and Adora felt a sense of vertigo at the surrealness of the situation. Catra’s head spun around, and a wide grin appeared on her face, melting away the feeling of unease Adora had just felt.

“Hey Adora,” she said, turning fully to Adora and walking towards her. The grin vanished from Catra’s face as she saw the look on Adora’s face.

“Hey, what’s wrong?” Catra asked with concern.

“Uh, what? Huh?” Adora said, trying to shake the feeling that she had stumbled upon something intimate.

Catra laughed. “You have that stupid look on your face. Like when we were kids, and Rogelio took the last gray ration bar.”

“Oh! Yeah, right!” Adora said with a nervous chuckle. “It's just that there is trouble here on Elysia. Someone is attacking a village not far from the Jacarandra Forest, and Aadhya asked if I could come as She-Ra.”

Catra nodded to Adora and smiled. “And of course, you said yes. That means I’m coming with you, you know.”

Adora smiled, feeling a strange relief, but that changed when Catra turned to Veth.

“Hey, you coming with us? We could probably use your help, Veth. It will give us a chance to see whatever this Zhe-La is in action.” Catra said as she laid a hand on Veth’s shoulder.

Adora did not like that.

Veth shrugged. “Sure, of course. If that is okay with you, Adora?” They asked tentatively.

Before Adora could answer, Catra spoke up. “Of course, it is, Veth! Come on; a friend doesn’t go asking another friend's wife permission to do anything! Let’s go!” She said while giving Veth a gentle prod and winking at Adora. Veth nodded and smiled, allowing Catra to coax them into movement; Adora watched them pass her, feeling unsure as to what she should do.

“You coming, Princess?” Catra asked, turning to look back at Adora.

Adora gave her wife a tight smile. “Yeah, of course.” She said as she watched her wife place a friendly arm around the shoulder of someone whom She-Ra herself did not trust.

Suddenly, Adora felt like that mistrust was justified.

A New Rebellion

Chapter Summary

Glimmer discovers the true horror of what has befallen her friends.

A fallen Princesses true motivations are revealed by the unlikeliest of sources.

The Bright Moon council chamber buzzed with conversation as Glimmer stood with her hands behind her back, peering at the section of mural directly behind her seat at the council table. It depicted her parents; her father, King Micah, standing straight and holding a crescent moon scepter vertically before him. Behind him stood Queen Angella, hands held out to either side and holding two golden orbs aloft. Queen Angella was much taller than her husband, and to Glimmer, she looked like a representation of the pillar which held the Moonstone aloft—that was a strength Glimmer wished she had with her now. More than anything, Glimmer wished her mother was there with her.

Feeling a hand on her shoulder, Glimmer turned to see her father, care and worry on his handsome features, and she felt a stab of guilt.

I should be thankful I have my father back instead of wishing for something impossible, She thought with a smile as she placed a hand over her father's.

"I wish she were here too, baby girl, I really do. But right now, we need our Queen; we need Queen Glimmer," he said with a kind smile.

Glimmer said nothing in reply, only nodding and taking her seat at the large round Council Table.

The Princesses were in attendance there—minus Scorpia and Mermista—plus other people of authority in Etheria. Star Force

Admiral Octavia was there, sitting in her own large seat, the star symbol of the fleet emblazoned on the top of her chair. Glimmer's Aunt Castaspella was there as well in her own chair. Since these council chambers represented all of Etheria, it was thought prudent to have a permanent chair for the Head Sorcerer of Mystacor.

The other non-princesses were Glimmer's husband, King Bow, seated to her left; he took her hand in his as she sat, giving her a reassuring smile. Next to Bow was her father—no longer King, but now Advisor to the Queen. To Glimmer's right was General Juliet, once captain of the Bright Moon guards, and now head of all of Etheria's planetary forces. With annoyance, Glimmer noticed that her Aunt Castaspella had moved her chair directly next to Juliet's, breaking all Council Chamber protocol.

Ugh, whatever, we let Netossa and Spinnerella sit next to each other; I will let my Aunt off the hook. After all, I have bigger problems than seating arrangements, Glimmer thought to herself with a loud sigh. Castaspella caught Glimmer looking at her and gave her niece a wink when she heard her exhalation.

Seahawk was sitting in Scorpia's empty seat, and Glimmer was surprised to see him; after Mermista's cold rejection of their relationship, she half expected Seahawk to be drinking his sorrows away in Seaworthy. But the man sitting at the council table appeared stone-cold sober; Glimmer had never seen Seahawk look so serious in all the time that she knew him. It was a testament to Seahawk's love for Mermista and how much he wanted to see her return to her usual self.

Swiftwind was not invited to the Council Meeting but was there anyway, sitting just behind Bow.

"Uh, where's my seat?" He said, looking around. Everyone just ignored him.

The last member of the Council Meeting was Shen, the new He-Man, sitting in Mermista's empty chair with his friend Battlecat

seated on their haunches next to him. It was deemed wise to invite Shen in Adora's absence; they would need a Magical Champion, especially with the nature of the recent events on Etheria.

Everyone quieted down as Glimmer finally took her seat. She looked at each member of the Council in turn, starting with Bow and ending with General Juliet.

"By now, you have all heard the news: Princess Mermista and her entire kingdom of Salineas has chosen to secede from the Princess Alliance and also from the Kingdom of Etheria. Not only has she declared it openly to my face, but she has also sent a formal declaration of independence to every kingdom on Etheria." Glimmer said loudly and evenly.

Shen held up a finger, and Glimmer nodded for him to speak. "I have also received word from the High Council of Eternia that they have received their own copy of the declaration as well. I suggested they hold off on responding and let the kingdoms of Etheria handle this situation, but since I abdicated as King of Eternia, who knows if they will listen." Shen said with an apologetic shrug.

"Great," Bow whined. "Not only do we have to deal with a rebellion in Salineas, but we might also have to deal with our neighbors on Eternia sticking their noses into the situation. The High Council of Eternia is relatively new, right? Who knows what they could decide. They have just been freed from thousands of years of oppression; they could see us as oppressors and side with Salineas."

Admiral Octavia spoke up before anyone could respond. "Oh, please. Our Star Force ships would keep them from leaving their planet; we could shoot their ships down if need be." She said with brashness.

Perfuma let out a small squeak of outrage. "Shoot down their ships? *Really?* I'm sure there could be a more *peaceful* solution,

Admiral." She said with her typical soothing tone. "I could put together a delegation to our friends on Eternia composed of Plumeria's best performers. Through song and dance, we could convey our situation to the High Council peacefully, before any violence was needed."

Admiral Octavia sneered at this idea, but before she could respond, Glimmer spoke up.

"*Whoa now!* We are getting ahead of ourselves, ladies. *Wayyy* ahead of ourselves." She said, holding her hands above her lowered head. "We need to figure out how we are going to handle the situation with Salineas before talking about how Eternia would take it. Besides, a good friend of mine is from there, and I don't think he would like it if we went to war with his home planet."

Shen chuckled at that. "Naw, I like Etheria better now anyway; you guys can do whatever you want. Blow the place up."

This drew smiles and chuckles from the assembled group; Glimmer appreciated her friend's levity.

"So, what should we do about Salineas? I mean, we can't allow Mermista to separate herself from the rest of Etheria, can we?" Netossa said, unsure.

Everyone looked at each other at this question, hesitant of the correct answer, and Glimmer cleared her throat to speak.

"The Princess Alliance was always a voluntary group. No one forced anyone else to join, and when it disbanded, it did so without repercussions. The same goes for the Kingdom of Etheria; you all voted me as your Queen; my authority comes from each of you. If one of you chooses to withdraw your vote and rule yourself, I will not stop you. If Mermista no longer wishes to be part of our kingdom, there is nothing we can do to stop her."

Glimmer's pronouncement was met with murmurs, but she was not finished.

"*But* this situation is not as cut and dry as all that. Something is going on with Mermista, something not right. We cannot stop her by force from separating herself from the Kingdom of Etheria, but I believe something has influenced Mermista to make this choice. It is not our friend doing this, but something else." Glimmer said, then turned to Seahawk. "Seahawk, what can you tell us? You are the closest to Mermista; please describe what you saw that made you come to me for help,"

Seahawk nodded sadly. "Yes, well, when I returned from our adventures on Eternia, all I wanted was to see my Mermista. We had a terrible time in Castle Grayskull, what with He-Man trying to kill us and all,"

Everyone looked at Shen with alarm. He only returned their stares with a nervous chuckle and a shrug of the shoulders. Seahawk then stood, becoming more animated as he continued his story.

"I bounded into the Palace of Salineas, '*My Mermista! Your Seahawk is here!'*—I cried. I did not receive a response, but this is not unusual for my Mermista; her love comes in different forms. I searched frantically, from room to room—but to no avail; I could not find my Mermista."

Seahawk stood now with hands clasped to his chest, and head bowed in dramatic sorrow.

"This isn't going to take long, is it?" Juliet asked dryly. A stern glance from Glimmer silenced her.

"I became the most frantic when I found Mermista in the unlikeliest of places—the Palace workshop; everyone knows how much my darling Princess hates doing work! She appeared to be working on some form of old First One's technology; I could not believe my eyes! *'Mermista! My love! Your Seahawk is back from his grand adventure!'*—I cried, but she only looked up with the strangest expression and nodded to me."

“Well! This was odd behavior, even for my Mermista, who to this day always seems to forget my birthday. I tried to shrug it off and step up the ol’ Seahawk charm—but alas! Even my stunning good looks and wit did not seem to catch my Mermista’s attention, and when it did, it was only to tell me how irrelevant I was. She had never said such things to me before! If my Mermista did scorn me with words, it was to say I was ‘annoying’ or ‘a pain.’ Nothing as cutting as saying I was irrelevant.”

“I decided to give my love some space—for don’t they say ‘*absence makes the heart grow fonder*’? But the next day, I started receiving reports from castle servants and guards, noting Mermista’s strange new behavior. They all told me she was slightly different—colder than usual—ever since she returned from her trip to another planet. They all thought it was because she did not find what she sought—the Kinetic Krystal—but instead of getting better, her behavior became more irregular.”

“It was then I decided that it would be wise to seek help, and I came to you, Glimmer,” Seahawk said, holding his hand out to Glimmer, who smiled in appreciation of his trust.

“Little did I know you would end up making things *worse!*” Seahawk finished, sitting down and crossing his arms.

“Hey!” Glimmer shouted. “That’s not fair! Maybe if I had a little more *information,* my visit wouldn’t have ended up starting a rebellion! Did you think of that, Seahawk?”

“Now, now,” Spinnerella said, standing and raising her hands in placation. “Glimmer, Seahawk didn’t mean that; he is just going through a hard time with his girlfriend rejecting him. Seahawk, do you really think it’s really wise to throw blame around at this point? Glimmer is just trying to help.”

Seahawk uncrossed his arms and sagged into his seat with a dramatic sigh, appearing to everyone like a deflating balloon.

“I guess I was being unfair, sorry Queen Glimmer, I was out of line,” he said sorrowfully. “It’s just that I miss my Mermista so,”

Glimmer accepted his apology with a nod, and Spinnerella sat back down and continued to address the council.

“So, from what Seahawk said, it appears as if Mermista is indeed under some kind of influence. Do we think it's mind control, like with Horde Prime?” Spinnerella said as she felt around the back of her neck, at the place her mind control chip used to be. Everyone present at the assembly who was likewise once chipped did the same.

Glimmer shook her head. “I don’t think so; I feel like it has something to do with our trip to find the Void Gem. When we were all in that underground crypt, we were attacked by these...*monsters.* One of them bit Mermista in the neck, and an unusual light appeared in her eyes. I used my magic to destroy the creatures before they could take her...away.” Glimmer said, then instantly realized something. “Wait a minute. They also attacked Scorpia and Entrapta; where is Scorpia, by the way?” Glimmer said, looking directly at Perfuma.

Perfuma looked startled by all the attention on her, laughed nervously, and then cleared her throat.

“Scorpia is a little indisposed right now,” Perfuma said, waving her hands airily. “She has not been herself lately, and hearing about what happened to Mermista; it is all starting to make sense to me now.”

“What do you mean by indisposed, Perfuma?” Bow asked skeptically, earning another nervous chuckle from Perfuma.

“Well...She has been acting downright horrible lately! Just horrible! First, I thought it was because she broke the staff holding the Void Gem, but it's more than that. I fell in love with Scorpia for her big heart,” Perfuma said with a glowing smile as she held her hands to her breast. “But it’s like that big heart

disappeared, and what is left is…" Perfuma's voice died off as she gazed off into the distance.

"What is left is...?" Micah prompted.

"A BIG JERK!" Perfuma exploded, making everyone jump. "I wouldn't stand for it, and I confronted her—which only made things worse! She tried to bully me, and we fought!"

Perfuma stood now, rolling up imaginary sleeves. "Let me tell you; it wasn't pretty! *'I'm not going to listen to a whiny wimpy flower princess,"*—she said to me. I couldn't believe it! *'If you don't like the way I am now, just leave!'*—she also said, and that's when I had enough." Perfuma said, sitting back down and crossing her arms.

"What did you do, Perfuma?" Frosta said, looking at everyone nervously. Everyone knew that Perfuma was wound a little tight and seemed like something would finally set her off one day. Perhaps today was the day—to Scorpia's misfortune.

"Oh, nothing major, I used my Princess power to bind and gag her with Jasmine vines—I didn't even have to use the Life Gem to do it. Scorpia is safe and sound back in Plumeria." Perfuma said simply.

"So, you did this without even knowing about what was happening with Mermista, and that something may be wrong with Scorpia? Uh...what were you planning on doing with Scorpia all tied up?" Netossa said with concern.

"Does it matter?" Perfuma said with annoyance. "I mean, if I hadn't done it, we would have had another rogue Princess running around, right? You all should all be glad that I have such innate good sense and made the right decision."

Everyone looked at each other with dubious expressions as Swiftwind leaned forward and whispered while Bow stifled laughter.

“I AM NOT A CRAZY GIRLFRIEND!!!” Perfuma shrieked as she stood and raised her Life Gem-topped staff, pointing it at the alicorn.

“Easy, Perfuma, easy!” Bow said, raising his hands with fear in his eyes. Swiftwind was right behind him, and he was in direct line of fire if the angry Princess decided violence was the right course of action.

“Put your staff down, Perfuma. Swiftwind didn’t say you’re crazy,” Glimmer said, exasperated.

“Yeah, I did,” Swiftwind mumbled under his breath.

Perfuma stood, staring at Swiftwind, clenching her staff as one of her eyes started to twitch. Glimmer started to wonder what exactly Perfuma could do to Swiftwind with the Life Gem if she chose to do harm.

Perfuma stopped clenching her staff, and with an audible sigh sat back down into her seat, laying the staff across her lap. She placed both hands upturned on her lap with her index finger and thumb forming a circle.

“Ohmmm...ohm...ohmmmmm…” She chanted.

“Hey! You’re doing the same magic Catra knows!” Shen said brightly as he pointed to Perfuma.

Perfuma sighed again and opened one of her brown eyes to peer at Shen. “Yes, Shen, that is because I taught it to Catra to help her deal with her anger. *I know it* because I have anger issues as well,” Perfuma said, releasing an even bigger sigh as she looked up at the ceiling.

“I have even *more* anger now because of what is going on with the love of my life! I’m so sorry, everyone! I just didn’t know what else to do!” Perfuma cried as she sputtered into complete tears, laying her arms and head on the table as she began to sob.

Seahawk, who was sitting in Scorpia's empty chair next to Perfuma, reached over to gently rub Perfuma's back.

"There, there, my dear. I know your pain all too well. You did the best that you could, given the circumstances," he said gently as tears came to his eyes as well. Perfuma raised herself and wrapped her arms around Seahawk, and the two broken hearts wept openly into each other's shoulders.

"I didn't know this was going to turn into a therapy session, my Queen." General Juliet said, leaning into Glimmer's ear to whisper.

Glimmer ignored her General's words as a sudden realization came to her, and she turned her attention to Entrapta. The usually boisterous and curious Princess was usually the first to voice a question, but now with so many questions to be asked, she was utterly silent.

"Entrapta," Glimmer said, worry plain in her voice. "I remember you were attacked by these creatures as well; why are you not acting like Scorpia and Mermista?"

Everyone looked at the purple-haired Princess with suspicion now —minus Seahawk and Perfuma who continued their cry session, oblivious to what was transpiring.

Entrapta responded to the open suspicion with confusion, scratching her head with one of her ponytails.

"You know...I have been feeling different lately. I don't have the words to describe it...but I have a hard time describing any emotion, really. That's why I try to approach emotions logically— that's what I've always done. So when I started feeling...differently, I just tried to make up for it by acting as I should, you know? That's what I've always done, you know? To fit in with my friends," Entrapta said simply. "Are you guys mad at me?"

Glimmer felt her heart go out to Entrapta and her eyes mist up with potential tears. She brushed them away and laughed.

“No, Entrapta. Far from it—*I think you're perfect*. You are protected from whatever evil inflicted our friends because of who you are and how special you are. I also think you are in a position to help us understand what is happening with Scorpia and Mermista. Can you try, the best you can, to describe the way you feel differently?”

Entrapta frowned deeply and looked down as she thought of this. After a moment, she spoke up.

“Well, it’s like how happiness feels—all bright sunshine and warmth in your chest,” she said, looking around as she rubbed at her chest with her gloved hand. “But it’s a different happiness...hmmm...wait, I’m describing this wrong,” Entrapta said as the deep, thoughtful frown returned to her face.

“So, take that happiness and flip it upside down—it's the opposite. Sadness feels like a heavy weight on your chest, and sometimes I can tell when someone feels sad. Not all the time, though—as I said, I’m not great with emotion. But when I can tell someone is sad or hurt, it makes me kind of hurt too; it makes me want to help them. When I do, that is when I feel the warmness. I feel the bright sunshine and warmness because the other person feels better.” Entrapta said with a blank look on her face. “Well, I’ve noticed that I don’t feel that anymore, or I just don’t care. I’ve been trying to make up for it, but it’s getting hard,”

Perfuma had ceased her crying and was now focused on Entrapta. “That is empathy you are describing, Entrapta. You’re saying you no longer feel empathy.” She said with the emotion of which she spoke plainly on her face.

“I don’t feel empathy anymore? Why?” Entrapta said in the same neutral voice but with tears streaming down her face. “I think that I don’t like that I no longer have the capacity for empathy. Can someone help me?”

Glimmer heard a sob and turned to see the ordinarily stoic General Juliet wiping at her eyes. Looking around, she saw that

the rest of the assembled council was similarly affected by Entrapta's plight.

"So that is what happened to Mermista and Scorpia? They are no longer able to feel empathy?" Bow said, not seeming to believe it. "How is this even possible? Better yet, how do we fix it?"

Glimmer shook her head. "I don't know, Bow, but it has to do with whatever those creatures that attacked us were. As crazy as it sounds, I think they somehow *sucked* the empathy out of them."

"Should I prepare ships to return to this planet, my Queen," Admiral Octavia spoke up.

Glimmer shook her head again. "I don't think so, Admiral. I don't think there is anything we need there, and if there was, Entrapta took enough pictures and samples to fill in the blanks. I can't afford to leave the planet when one of the Princesses is in the middle of establishing her own kingdom. A Princess who no longer feels empathy for anyone else on this planet. I think things are going to get worse before they get better."

Glimmer stood up and walked around the table to where Entrapta sat and wrapped her arms around the Princess in a tight hug. The same blank expression was on Entrapta's face as she accepted the hug, but Glimmer knew some part of her appreciated it. Even if you did not have the capacity to care for others, you still had the capacity to care for yourself and feel other emotions. It was a testament to Entrapta's character that she noticed the absence of empathy and that it made her sad.

Glimmer released Entrapta and held her by the shoulders, looking into her rose-colored eyes with her pink and sparkly ones.

"Entrapta, we are going to figure out how to fix you, but I need to know something: do you think that you would be a danger to the rest of us the way you are now?" Glimmer asked kindly.

Entrapta frowned again as she thought this through, now looking confused.

“Glimmer, wasn’t I always kind of a danger? I mean, I almost destroyed Etheria when I messed with the Elemental Princess powers and then almost fractured reality with the portal technology,” Entrapta said reasonably.

Glimmer let out a laugh and squeezed Entrapta’s shoulders. “I guess you have a point! But we will need your help to fix yourself, and you will probably have to work back in your lab in Dryl. If the goal is self-fulfilling, we won’t have to worry about you deviating away from that course. Just promise me that if you think you’re going to do anything dangerous, you will let us know, okay? Also, I think it's best if you don’t work on the Void Gem project right now, not until you’re better.”

“Right!” Entrapta said, becoming more animated now and more like the old Entrapta. She suddenly thought of something, placing a finger against her lips and sticking her tongue out.

“You know, maybe it’s better if you communicate through Hordak. That way, he will let you know if anything is wrong or if I am steering off course. Also, he can make sure I don’t do anything too crazy or selfish!”

Glimmer’s eyes widened in shock at this, and she now looked unsure.

“Uh, you want me to rely on *Hordak* to keep you out of trouble? Uhhh…” She said, looking to Bow for assistance.

“That sounds like a good idea, Entrapta. We can talk to both you and Hordak daily. We can also give Wrong Hordak a datapad and even speak to Emily through her onboard comms system. But most of all, Entrapta, we trust you,” he said with a reassuring smile.

Entrapta blushed and looked down. “Right, I will get started on this right away. I think I will get started on those samples I took of the substance we found; It was organic-based with an unusual energy signature. That may be the key.”

Glimmer nodded, turned, and walked back to her seat, directing her attention to Perfuma.

"Perfuma, now that we know what is wrong with our friends is there anything you can do with the Life Gem to heal them?" Glimmer asked.

Perfuma sat up and sniffled, wiping away at her nose and eyes.

"Not as of yet; I'm sorry to say I have been lax in my studies. I've been too busy planning the drum circle for the Solstice of the Twelfth Moon. But now, I will be turning all my attention to it." Perfuma said, excitement and happiness in her voice. "If there is any power that can help us, it has to do with the Life Gem. I just wish I had some way to know what the old bearers of the Life Gem were able to do with it."

"Well, from what Madame Razz told me of her sister Zzar, it seemed like her sister was the bearer of the Life Gem for a *really* long time. Anything Zzar may have written about the Power of Life is not to be trusted. She did twist the power of the Life Gem with the power of Death to become a god after all," Glimmer said darkly. "*However*, there is an old text I have come across recently, written by someone named Kishar. They say they were the 'bearer of Zhe-La' and that they were a Champion—I can only assume Zhe-La is something like She-Ra or He-Man. The text seems old, from at least a couple thousand years ago. I will keep reading through it; maybe Kishar mentions the bearer of the Life Gem from that time."

Castaspella was the next to speak up. "Micha and I will check in with the Mystacor Exploratory Expedition still in Castle Grayskull. They are investigating the depths of the castle; perhaps they have come across an old artifact or text that may help us."

"Just make sure they are careful, Aunty. From what I have read in Kishar's journal, there are terrible sources of magic down there." Glimmer said.

"Yes, yes. *Abominable Power,* I remember what you told us." Castaspella said with annoyance. "I'm the head sorcerer of Mystacor, remember? Not some first-year plebe."

Glimmer pursed her lips and rolled her eyes, not bothering to respond to her Aunt.

"What about the rest of us? We may not have any scientific ability or access to ancient knowledge, but we want to help." Frosta said.

"I will need the rest of you to help with reining in Mermista. We cannot use any outward aggressive means, but we need to...I don't know...capture her or something," Glimmer said, waving her hand in the air.

"That sounds kind of aggressive, Glimmer," Netossa said with a smirk.

Glimmer gave Netossa a scathing look. "I need you guys to think outside the box and figure it out. Maybe talk to her? Trick her? At the very least, I need someone keeping an eye on her."

"How about I fly over Salineas and drop He-Man off over the palace?" Swiftwind said with all seriousness. "He can smash his way in and grab her!"

Glimmer plugged her ears and closed her eyes. "*Whatever*! Just don't tell me about it!" She shouted.

Swiftwind looked over at the bearer of He-Man and winked; Shen gave She-Ra's faithful steed a thumbs up.

"But before anyone does anything drastic, make sure someone talks to her first!" Glimmer yelled to a disappointed-looking Swiftwind. "Try to reason with her. I would do it, but she seems to resent my authority as Queen. Spinnerella, Netossa, any chance you two could try?"

"What? You think because we don't actually have a kingdom, she won't see us as a threat?" Netossa said a little angrily. "*Yeah,*

sure. Send in Spinnerella and Netossa; they don't have a kingdom to rule; they have got nothing better to do,"

Spinnerella placed a calming hand on her wife's shoulder with a weak smile.

"Don't worry about it, Glimmer, we've got this," Spinnerella said reassuringly.

"Thank you," Glimmer said with some mild exasperation. "Okay, I believe that wraps it up. If anyone needs me, I will be in my Observatory.

* * *

After the incident with the Eye of Hate, Jihan and I continued to be paired as Novice and Mentor. We did not get involved with anything as serious as an Abominable Power again, but something big did happen to us, something perhaps a little more frightening than Dread Magic—we fell in love with each other.

Anyone who knew Jihan would have thought it would be him that initiated courtship. Not so—it was all me. As I mentioned before, I found Jihan's outward appearance to be very attractive—if that were the extent of his appeal to me, I would have never made the first move. It was what I saw inside him that drew me to him.

Jihan's quintessence matched his outward nature, and it burned bright to my Nephraeh's eye. It is lovely to look upon, always steady and true, and I can't help but notice how his soul pattern is in harmony with mine—almost flawlessly. Initially, the implications were frightening when I thought too hard about them, and I concluded that it was The Light's way of telling me I was on the correct path.

It took me a while to realize the truth, for I had never encountered someone who is my soul-match. When I did discover the truth, it took me a while to figure out how I would make this fact known to Jihan; Madgēcots may be able to see much with their lovely eyes, but they can never see such as Nephraeh sees.

Initially, Jihan politely rebuffed my advances; as I said before, he may seem like a rogue, but Jihan has a very solid form of honor. He saw it as inappropriate for him to be with me in that way since he was supposed to be my Mentor.

I thought this was touching but silly; Jihan may be my Mentor, but he was not much older than me. I backed off anyway, I did not want to drive him away, but I could see I was having an effect on him. A Madgēcot may be able to put up an air of indifference, but their tail tells a different story.

Every time he was near me, I would find his tail brushing up against me, sometimes even wrapping around me in a gentle caress. He tried to ignore what a part of his own body was doing, but after a particular incident in the maintenance shaft of his ship, he could no longer ignore how he felt.

Jihan had asked for my assistance with some repairs and we were in a very tight space together. As Jihan focused on repairing a Xeloite Capacitor, his tail had decided to wrap around a particular part of my body—I could not help my gasp. When he turned, he saw the smile on my face and what his tail was doing—that was when he finally gave in to me, right there in that maintenance shaft. He was mine, and I was his.

We decided it would be prudent to keep this a secret at first, primarily out of fear of what the League of Kalosyni would say if they knew a Novice was romantically involved with their Mentor. We did not want to be split up, for we were more than just lovers —we were soul mates, and we even spoke of becoming bonded on Elysia in front of the Great Chaliendra Tree. But we decided it was time to tell League of Kalosyni of our relationship after my induction ceremony from Novice to Full Champion.

As it turns out, our fears were completely unfounded; not only did they accept this news, but they were actually overjoyed by it!

The League of Kalosyni told us that love between two Champions is a sacred thing and rarely seen. It is a powerful union, a force

for good and the Light, and it was the love between two Champions that had been instrumental in ending the Dark Times millennia ago. The League of Kalosyni gave us their blessing and promised that we would be Champions paired for life if that is what we wished.

I started to have a sneaking suspicion that they may have known this was going to happen, especially since they paired a Nephraeh and Madgēcot together—our two races had always had an attraction towards one another. If that were true, then I owe a great debt to their wisdom.

I could not believe I could ever be this happy!

Glimmer stopped reading the datapad as she heard the door to her Observatory open; looking up, she saw it was Bow with two mugs of hot tea. She greeted him with a thankful smile.

"Hey, you," Bow said as he closed the door with his hip. "You're not going to keep hiding away from me in your new office, are you?"

Glimmer chuckled as she accepted one of the mugs from him, took a sip, and sighed with pleasure. It was the exact ratio of bitter and sweet that she preferred. Bow was the only other person besides herself who knew exactly how she liked her tea.

"Sorry, Bow. I know I have been a little distant since we both went on our separate trips. I will make it up to you, I promise," she said, wrapping her arms around his waist and placing her head against his warm bare stomach. When she finally released him, Bow grabbed a nearby chair, pulling it over so he could sit next to his wife and enjoy a moment, even if it was only to be talking and sipping tea.

"It's okay. I know how busy you must be, what with the discovery of the Abominable Powers under Castle Grayskull and Mermista rebelling." He said as he peered around her reading table. "I see you finally got rid of the Eye of Hate."

Glimmer nodded. “Yeah, I teleported it back to where we found it. I didn’t like the way it made me feel when it was around.” She said wearily. “I’ve read enough about it to know we don’t want that kind of evil released on Etheria.”

Bow smiled as he thought of something. “How is your reading going, anyway? Did Kishar and Jihan hook up yet?” He said with a sly grin.

Glimmer giggled. “Yeah, I just got to that part. I know I’m supposed to be finding important information, but I feel like a little girl skimming through my mother’s romance stories—trying to find the juicy bits before being caught.” She said with a sly grin of her own. “I really like these old Champions, Jihan and Kishar, I really wish they were alive today and with us,” Glimmer said sadly.

Before Bow could respond, a nearby datapad beeped—it was the datapad that was designated for communication with Dryl. Glimmer looked concerned and picked it up, surprise lighting up her features as a face appeared on the screen; a hard, white face that looked almost skull-like. Two red glowing eyes seemed to bore into her from the display.

“Hordak!” Both Bow and Glimmer said in unison.

“My King, my Queen. I am sorry if I am disturbing you. Should I contact you some other time?” Hordak said politely in that cold, stern voice of his.

“No, no...Hordak, it's fine,” Glimmer stammered before regaining her composure. “It must be important if you're contacting us. Is Entrapta okay?”

At the mention of Entrapta, a warm expression passed Hordak’s cold features, then was gone as suddenly as if it never existed.

“Yes, Entrapta is well; she is working hard in the lab as we speak. It is another matter in which I wanted to talk to you about. You see, Mermista recently contacted me.” Hordak said.

A jolt of shock and dread passed through Glimmer's chest. "Go on," she said, trying to control her voice.

"The Princess Mermista proposed an alliance with Dryl. She was interested in my military experience but was mainly interested in Entrapta's experience with robotics—specifically with combining First One's tech with old Horde technology. Princess Mermista said she could not rely on the people of Salineas for what she wanted to do and wanted to make something more reliable. Queen Glimmer, I suspect she wants to build some kind of robot army." Hordak said as suspicion now mixed with the fear in Glimmer's chest.

"What did you say in response, Hordak?" Glimmer said as neutrally as she could manage.

Confusion clouded his features. "Why I said no, of course. Why would I say yes? Did I not take an oath to never act against the best interests of Etheria again?" He said, a little affronted now.

Glimmer felt abashed. "Uh, yes...you did, Hordak. I'm sorry that I asked. It's just with what is going on and all…"

Hordak gave a curt nod. "I understand. I guess it was foolish of me to think that I have automatically earned trust with a few good deeds. I will continue to keep an eye on my lo—I mean Entrapta."

"Thank you, Hordak, this means a lot to us," Glimmer said with a kind smile. He nodded again and cut the connection.

Glimmer instantly flopped back into her chair and groaned as Bow rubbed worriedly at the back of his neck.

"UGH! This just keeps getting worse!" Glimmer cried to the ceiling.

Liar

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra help the Madgēcots investigate a mysterious attack on a nearby village.

Chapter Notes

Illustration by @Ansdrela_Art on Twitter.

The Star Hunter flyer glided over the trees of the Jacarandra Forest; the transport was so silent Adora could hear the wind whispering over its broad wings. Her, Catra, Veth, and several Madgēcot Star Hunters were packed in the transport's hold, hanging onto overhead rails as they gazed out of the open deployment hatches on either side of the craft. It was late at night, and three of Elysia's moons illuminated the rolling terrain of treetops; it was still a beautiful view, although slightly more ominous.

Amongst the Madgēcots was the prickly Maira and the rest were strangers to Adora; with an unknown danger assaulting the Fareek, Viraj had volunteered to make sure the non-Madgēcot guests made it home safely from the evening celebration. He seemed to be particularly worried about his Umgah friends, and stated that he would stay the night in their village and watch over them.

Adora really liked Viraj; he was openly kind and protective of others, traits that she knew Catra also had, but had suppressed after years in the toxic environment of the Horde. She hoped that the exposure to her twin brother would positively affect Catra, allowing her to become the person she could have been if not for the Horde. Adora did not want this for her sake, but for her wife's.

Thinking of the recent influences on Catra, Adora turned to the newest one, an influence that she did not particularly appreciate

nor trust.

Veth was standing right next to the edge of the open hatch, their face in profile as they gazed out on the passing landscape. The moon's light glittered in their silver eyes, and with the backdrop of the night sky, they could have been one of the many stars seen there. Adora watched them run clawed fingers through their long black hair whenever the wind blew it in front of their face. Their straight and glossy hair seemed to flow down from the top of their head like water.

If their normal form already has great hair, I wonder what their Zhe-La hair will be like, Adora thought with admiration and a touch of jealousy.

Despite her suspicion of their motivations—or more accurately, She-Ra's suspicion—Adora had to admit that Veth was quite beautiful. She knew she was focusing on the feminine aspect of their features and forced herself to look at the masculine; she did not want her judgment clouded by physical attraction. But this did not help her at all; their masculine accentuated their feminine in such a way that made them even more attractive.

Adora could not put her finger on what it was about Veth that was so alluring; was it their masculine energy in female form? Or was it female energy in a masculine form? Adora did not know what kind of sexuality a Nephraeh had; maybe it was entirely outside what was considered male or female. Perhaps this was the attraction—Veth was utterly unknown. There was a hint of exciting fear in not knowing what they could be capable of.

Before Adora could pull her eyes away, Veth turned and caught her staring at them. Not wanting to seem afraid or ashamed, she held their neutral gaze with one of her own. After what seemed like an uncomfortable eternity, Veth finally smiled and nodded, breaking eye contact to continue looking out upon the night.

Adora almost jumped when she felt a warm hand grasp hers; looking down, she saw a cinnamon-colored hand in hers. When

she looked back up, she found Catra gazing at her with a wry smile.

“Not nervous, are you, Princess?” Catra teased.

“Uh, no,” Adora said with forced bravado. “What’s there to be nervous about? I’m sure whatever’s going on, She-Ra can handle it.”

Catra pursed her lips and shook her head in mirth.

“Besides,” Adora continued. “I have you with me, my wife who attacked a demon assassin and a fallen He-Man to protect me,”

“Yeah, well, after spending all that time on bed rest after the Demon Heart almost killed me, I’m not sure how quickly I will be doing that again,” Catra said with a laugh.

“Hey! I took good care of you when you were injured!” Adora said, feigning being hurt. “Besides, you loved having all of us taking care of you. You know you’re a little Princess at heart!”

Catra smiled warmly at this and was about to press herself into Adora for a hug when something caught her attention and she halted with a sour look upon her face. Turning, Adora saw Maira watching them with a curl of her lips. The onyx-furred Madgēcot suddenly turned her attention away from them and onto Veth, the nasty expression replaced by only suspicion now.

“What is her problem?” Catra growled low. “She’d better watch it, or I’ll scratch her eyes out. Why did Aadhya have to send her with us?

“Remember what Viraj said, Catra. She lost her child and her mate; she is probably angry and jealous. You remember what that was like, don’t you, Catra?” Adora said teasingly.

Catra finally pressed herself into Adora for that hug, wrapping both arms around her.

“Yeah, I guess. It gets hard to remember when I’m so happy all the time now,” she said softly into Adora’s ear.

Adora felt a strange sensation, not from Catra, but nearby, as if there was an interested gaze upon them. Instantly, she knew who was watching them—Veth—but she refused to turn her attention to them. She felt foolish thinking it, but some part of her was afraid to engage them while in contact with Catra—as if they could somehow reach Catra through her.

“Okay, lovers,” Maira said acidly. “Time to stop hugging and get ready. We are close to the Fareek Village.”

Catra parted from Adora with a low hiss, turning to display an upper fang to Maira. The Madgēcot Star Hunter only snorted in derision, turning her attention on the horizon.

Adora now saw a reddish glow in the direction they were heading, and even in the low light of the moons, she could see the black shapes of rising smoke columns.

“Anything you could tell us about these Fareek, Maira?” Adora said, switching to her all-business Force Captain voice.

Maira turned to her and nodded, putting her dislike of the offworlder aside for the moment for the sake of the mission at hand.

“They are a fierce race and keep to themselves. They warred with us in ancient days, but we made peace with them long ago and only make contact when necessary. In all our history with them, they have never asked us—or anyone else on Elysia—for help.” Maira said evenly.

“That is interesting timing,” Adora said meaningfully as she glanced at Veth. The Nephraeh didn’t seem to notice her words and continued to stare out of the open hatch, but Maira caught her meaning.

“Yes, I thought of that as well,” Maira said, giving Adora a measuring look. “There seem to be many *offworlders* on Elysia these days.”

Adora frowned at the Madgēcot’s implication that she and Catra were responsible for what was happening but chose to ignore it.

“When we land, you are to follow my lead,” Maira said sternly. “Aadhya made me Neta of this mission, so that means I am in charge. You are to—“

A sudden jolt was felt throughout the flyer, making everyone stumble; Maira looked around, her long ears lowered and green eyes wide with shock.

“What was that? Did something just hit us?” She cried.

“I don’t know what that was!” One of the pilots yelled back. “It seems like someone is throwing objects at us from the ground!”

“Just take us down now!” Maira shouted back. “We can get there on foot. I don’t want to get shot out—”

There was a loud crack as something tore through one of the wings and the flyer suddenly veered to one side. Adora jolted in the direction in which the flyer dipped and slammed into Maira, sending them both cartwheeling out of one of the open hatches. Adora found herself in a freefall over the unknown, Maira howling in fury next to her.

“You clumsy oaf!” The Madgēcot screamed at Adora.

“Oh, don’t worry, I can handle this,” Adora said confidently as she raised her hand.

“FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!” She shouted, transforming into She-Ra.

She-Ra/Adora reached for Maira, but the Madgēcot pushed her hand away with a hiss, causing the Star Hunter to tumble in her

descent. Maira spread her arms and legs outward, regaining control and slowing her fall.

"If you had not been so hasty, I could have gotten us both safely to the ground," Maira said admonishingly. "But now you're too big, you will have to save yourself."

Before She-Ra/Adora could retort, Maira placed her arms against her sides, her legs together, and whispered. When she spread her arms and legs back out, thin membranes made of the same material as her Jaadoo suit appeared between her legs and under her arms, attaching to her sides. It caught the wind and slowed her downward fall, allowing her to descend in a glide.

"I hope to see you on the ground," Maira said as She-Ra/Adora fell away from her, open-mouthed.

"How did she do that?" She-Ra/Adora gaped just before crashing through the roof of a building.

The shock of that initial impact caused her to lose her sword, and it dematerialized as soon as it left her hand. She broke through two floors before finally coming to a painful halt on a soft surface, fine debris forming a dusty cloud around her.

"Ugghhh…" She-Ra/Adora groaned as she sat up, holding her head.

Looking up through the hole she created, She-Ra/Adora saw a black-winged shape spiral down from the sky. It landed softly on the roof, and a dark head with two bright green eyes peered over the edge of the hole down at her.

"Are you still alive?" Maira called as she started to climb down.

"Yes, although I think I'm going to have a bruise on my backside that will last a month," She-Ra/Adora said as she stood up. "Try not to be too relieved."

Maira landed in a crouch next to her and stood up, looking up at She-Ra/Adora with a scowl.

"I *am* glad you are alright," she said tersely. "Just because I don't like you doesn't mean I want you to get hurt. Besides, the Pratham would flay the fur from my hide if I ended up getting She-Ra killed."



She-Ra/Adora was surprised to see a slight grin appear on the other woman's face momentarily, but then it was gone.

"Come, we need to get outside and find the others. From what I saw as I came down, it appears this entire village is in the middle of a war." Maira said, looking around for the exit to the building.

She-Ra/Adora followed Maira's gaze, seeing that the building she currently occupied was a fighting hall of some kind. Various hand-held weapons lined the walls, and it appeared she sat on a large mat, probably used for sparring.

"This must be the Fareek's Akhara, or dojo. Knowing them, this will be located in the center of their community; the Fareek hold fighting in the utmost regard." Maira said.

"Another reason to get out of here, I'm sure they will not be happy to see I wrecked the place," She-Ra/Adora said with a weak smile.

Maira nodded, indicating the exit to the building, and She-Ra/Adora followed her out. Once outside, She-Ra/Adora was instantly struck by chaos—many of the surrounding buildings were on fire while what only could be the Fareek ran about screaming and shouting.

The Fareek were tall, bipedal beings with dark green skin; four muscular arms sprouted from long torsos, and their faces ended in snouts. They looked like they could have been related to Rogelio's people—minus the tail.

In the distance, it appeared as if some of the larger Fareek were fighting, but with what, She-Ra/Adora could not tell. It was hard to see through the flames and smoke, but it appeared that the assailants were smaller than the Fareek and all-black, like shadows. Whatever they were, they gave the larger warriors a hard fight, one the Fareek seemed to be losing.

"Look out!" Maira shouted.

She-Ra/Adora turned just in time to see a large male Fareek charge her. Immediately she grasped him by the shoulders and leaned in, stopping him from barreling her over, but his momentum was so great that he caused She-Ra/Adora to slide back an inch before coming to a halt.

The Fareek snarled, pushing She-Ra/Adora back with his two lower arms as he reached back for a large maul slung on his back with its upper. Before the Fareek could unsling his weapon, Maira leaped between the two combatants, both her hands raised in a placating gesture.

“Peace! Peace!” She cried. “This warrior is called She-Ra; she is with the Star Hunters. You called us for aid, remember?”

Sudden recognition lit up the Fareek’s reptilian eyes.

“Madgēcot, you came,” he said in a voice that sounded like sand blowing over rocks.

Maira nodded. “Yes, of course we came. What is happening here? How can we help?”

The Fareek looked around at the ruins of his burning village with a forlorn expression.

“I do not know what they are; they came out of the night and attacked us with no warning! They are not of Elysia, I know this. They are demons!” The Fareek said, making a warding motion with all four of their hands.

“Did they set these fires?” She-Ra/Adora said, waving her hands at the burning village.

The Fareek shook his scaled head. “No, that was us. Our homes are tainted now; we must burn it out!” He rasped with raised upper arms. “We can also rebuild after the taint is purged.”

A sudden cry rang out; it had the same raspy quality She-Ra/Adora now associated with a Fareek voice. Other voices

answered the call throughout the village, and the Fareek before them perked up.

"I must go!" He said, pulling out the massive maul on his back and running towards the source of the original call.

"Wait!" Maira shouted, but he was already gone.

"He was a big help," She-Ra/Adora said sarcastically.

Maira gave her a wry look, then lifted her head and sniffed the air. With perked ears, she pointed in the direction they should proceed.

"There is a lot of smoke in the air, but I think I smell Catra. She has a very distinct smell to me," Maira said absently. "This way!"

Before Maira could do anything else, a black shape leaped out of the shadows and upon her, knocking the Star Hunter to the ground. Maira shrieked with rage, instantly struggling with the assailant with her slashing black claws.

She-Ra/Adora rushed to her aid but was immediately blocked by two more attackers; they glided out of the night slowly on two feet, their arms held out to either side of their bodies to display long claws. Their lithe bodies were all black and appeared shiny, like oil, reflecting the firelight like dark mirrors. Their features were barely discernible, but She-Ra/Adora could make out two black eyes, a nose, and a fanged mouth. Two long ears sat on either side of a bald head, and to Adora, they seemed very familiar.

They seem almost like a shadow of a Nephraeh, she thought suspiciously. *Veth is behind these creatures being here, I'm sure of it.*

The two creatures halted and stood up straight as if recognizing her. They turned to regard each other and, after a shared nod of unknown agreement, started to circle her on opposite sides.

She-Ra/Adora summoned her sword and held it up in a guard position as she regarded her enemies. She began to slowly back away and out of their potential trap, not sure of the capabilities of these mysterious creatures.

The one on the left tensed and leaped at her, and she swung her sword to bisect the creature midair. To She-Ra/Adora's horror, her sword passed harmlessly through the top of the creature's head and exited out its groin, and the creature landed on her with clinging claws. Its face was now level with her shoulder, and it opened its mouth, appearing as if it was going to sink its fangs into her neck.

"Gah!" She-Ra/Adora gasped with disgust.

She grasped her attacker by the back of the neck and pulled, letting out a cry of pain as it dug its claws deeper into her flesh. With a wince and a tug, she pried the creature off of her body and flung it away with all of her might; it smashed through the side of a burning building and out of sight.

Before she could celebrate, the other attacker made its move; it leaped, landing on her back and wrapping its black arms around her neck. Already knowing what it would do next, She-Ra/Adora reached back to hold its head back and keep its teeth from her neck.

"Get. Off. Me!" She gasped as she felt the creature choking her.

It was immensely strong, and as she tried to pry its arms from her throat with her free arm, she felt it wrap its legs around her torso and squeeze the air from her lungs. The creature's vice grip was having its intended effect—She-Ra/Adora felt herself weaken and the head pushed closer; hot breath tickled her neck. It would not be long before she felt the pain of its fangs sink into her flesh.

She-Ra/Adora dug deep, instinctively summoning the magic of She-Ra and pulling it into her core. She-Ra/Adora released the power with a mental flex—it burst from her heart as three

concentric gold discs, shearing the creature in half. It released its grip and screamed, falling to the ground in two pieces which thrashed wildly, then slowly melted into two separate puddles of black ooze.

The sound of struggle made She-Ra/Adora turn, and she spotted Maira; she was on her back as one of the creatures held both of her wrists. It was slowly leaning down towards her with its mouth open and fangs bared.

With two large bounds, She-Ra/Adora was next to the creature, landing a mighty kick to the side of its head. The head came free with a strange hollow pop and sailed away into the darkness.

Maira flung the headless body off her with a furious hiss and leaped to her feet. Leaning over on knees, she panted, trying to catch her breath as her onyx tail twitched wildly in agitation. With a disgusted curl of her lips, Maira watched the body of her assailant melt into the strange black ooze. Standing straight, she looked at She-Ra/Adora with pure gratefulness and let out a laugh.

"Thank you, Adora. I think that thing wanted to do something horrible to me; I am in your debt. I mean it," she said with a genuine smile. "A Madgēcot's debt is a bond for as long as either of us lives. Whatever you need, I will provide, as long as it's in my power to give."

She-Ra/Adora smiled sheepishly. "Think nothing of—" she said, stopping herself as she thought of something. "Actually, Maira, I will just ask one thing,"

"Yes?" Maira said, perking up.

"Can you just try to be nice to Catra? Even if she smells bad?" She-Ra/Adora said hopefully.

Maira laughed again and nodded, but before she could say anything, the two women turned as they heard a low hissing sound from one of the burning buildings. One of the creatures

was exiting the doorway—the one She-Ra/Adora had thrown through the building wall. It appeared no worse for wear and upset now.

Before She-Ra/Adora could do anything, Maira raised her hand to halt her.

"No, please, let me. The last one ambushed me and made me feel like a short-tail; let me regain my honor," Maira said as she strode purposefully in the direction of her quarry.

The creature instantly leaped at her; clawed hands held out to grasp her. But before it could lay a finger on her, Maira delivered a spinning kick directly to its face, flipping it away where it landed on its back, screaming in fury. As it was getting to its feet, Maira spun at it, arms held out, hands flat, claws in neat rows. She tore into her foe like a razorblade tornado, almost decapitating the creature with her slashes, and it shrieked in pain as it tried to get away.

"I am not such easy prey, am I, wretch?" Maira taunted, seeing her enemy clutch its neck, trying to staunch the flow of its black oily blood.

But Maira's green eyes widened as she saw the creature withdraw its hands from its neck—the blood flow had ceased, and the wounds sealed themselves back up. It regarded Maira wearily now and paced around her at a distance, not wanting to get within her striking range again.

The creature held one of its arms up; the hand opened as if to grasp something. She-Ra/Adora watched as a ripple traveled from its shoulder and towards its open hand, like a slight wave in a black sea. A long spike appeared in its hand, black and shiny like the creature's body. The creature whipped its body around, sending the spike whistling in the direction of Maira—too fast for her to see.

The Madgēcot was faster—she leaped into the air in a sideways spin, just as the missile passed under her midsection. It smashed through a building wall with a loud crack, creating a large hole with the power of its momentum. Obviously, this was the cause of the flyer going down; these creatures must have shot it out of the sky with this strange and deadly weapon.

"Need any help yet?" She-Ra/Adora asked mildly. She had expected her question to upset the typically angry Madgēcot, but Maira only shook her head, a thoughtful expression on her face.

"I have an idea," was all Maira said as she reached down to her outfit. Without even looking, she selected a section of her Jaadoo suit between two fingers and pulled it away, the rest of the outfit sealing up the hole she made. Maira balled the material in her hand and, with a quick motion, flung it at her enemy.

The creature ducked, thinking that it was a projectile weapon, but the material exploded over its head, raining down rainbow-colored sparks all over its oily body. It immediately slammed down on its back, flailing its arms and legs in apparent agony, its mouth open in a silent scream. It started to melt, and this time it was more gruesome as bones appeared under the melting black flesh of its body. With its destruction complete, only a black skeleton rested in a puddle of viscous oil, the skull's eye sockets pointed in Maira's direction, fanged jaws open in a parody of shock.

Maira strode over to the remains, crouching down to stick a claw tip into the black oil. Raising the oil-covered finger to her nose, she sniffed tentatively at it, her expression unreadable as her tail twitched rapidly—it was now twice its standard size.

"What was that you did to it?" She-Ra/Adora said in amazement.

Maira glanced back at her, still sniffing her finger. "The Chakra Block? Oh, it is a standard Star Hunter cantrip, used to block a magic user from their power source. I suspected those creatures were using magic when I saw it heal itself so rapidly and create

that throwing weapon. I didn't realize magic was keeping it alive, though. Very strange…"

Maira stood up, wiping her finger on her leg absentmindedly as she suddenly caught sight of her tail. She grasped it with one hand and ran her hand along its length to its end, smoothing the agitated fur.

"It seems that we are in the presence of a type of evil," Maira said as she released her tail.

She-Ra/Adora gaped at her, and Maira favored her with another smile.

"A Madgēcot's tail always senses evil, Adora. Always," she said in explanation.

She-Ra/Adora snapped her mouth closed. "Catra's tail just bushes up whenever she is near water," she said wonderingly. "Come to think of it; there were other times when we were up against something you could call evil that her tail frizzed up. You Madgēcots should come with an instruction manual."

Maira laughed brightly at this. It was a very pretty laugh, at odds with her originally bristly manner.

"You know, Adora, you're pretty funny," Maira said with a sly grin. "Catra should watch out; I might actually start to like you,"

Even in her She-Ra form, Adora blushed furiously. "Uh, yeah. So, can all Madgēcots do that with those outfits? Do that magicky cat-trip thing?" she stammered, trying to change the subject.

Maira cocked her head, a curious look on her face. "For a second, I thought you were making fun of me, but now I realize you are just naturally charming." She said, still smiling. "It's called a *cantrip*, and no, not all Madgēcots can use it—only the Star Hunters. Other Madgēcots can do useful things with their Jaadoo suits, but only Star Hunters have offensive cantrips. I would be

willing to discuss in more detail, but right now, I think we should find the others,"

She-Ra/Adora nodded, relieved to be back on the mission on hand and not discussing how attractive she was to the beautiful female Madgēcot.

They made their way down the streets; they were empty now but still smoky, backlit with a reddish glow from the embers of dying fires. Here and there, She-Ra/Adora sensed movement in the shadows, but none of the creatures came forth to attack them, perhaps knowing the fate that waited for them in Maira's Chakra Block. Abruptly, a loud and clear voice rang out, making both She-Ra/Adora and Maira jump.

"BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!"

Maira's long ears perked up. "That was Veth! Hurry!" She said, leaping on all fours in the direction of the cry and disappearing into a wall of smoke.

"Wait, Maira!" She-Ra/Adora said lamely as she stumbled after the quicker Madgēcot and into the choking air.

The thick ash did not hamper Adora's enhanced magical form, but it did restrict her vision, and she crept warily towards the sounds of fighting. Finally making her way out of the smoke, She-Ra/Adora was shocked by the image before her; it was Veth, or more accurately, Zhe-La, fighting multiple creatures at once.

Like She-Ra, Veth in their Zhe-La form was much larger and taller —but that was where the similarities ended.

They were encased in a body glove composed of the same material as the pants they wore—interlocking black metallic bands in a woven pattern—and it covered their entire body from the neck down. Dark armored plates covered the critical parts of Zhe-La/Veth's body, and on their chest armor was an obscure symbol, much like She-Ra had. A helmet covered their head, leaving only

their face and long ears exposed; their long black hair was drawn up into a high topknot which flowed behind them as they fought.

In their hands was a giant black sword; a faint indigo light shimmered around the blade. It was not a power sword but was now in a pure magical form, no longer bound by First One's technology.

The same light which emanated from the sword replaced the silver in Zhe-La/Veth's eyes—a deep indigo that made the eyes hurt to look at it.

What surprised She-Ra/Adora even more was that Catra was fighting back to back with Zhe-La/Veth, almost in complete synchrony, and she felt the same stab of jealousy that she had felt before.

Maira and the rest of the lost Star Hunters were there, fighting what seemed like the main force of the creatures that assaulted the Fareek village. Like Maira, the Star Hunters fought with a hand-to-hand combat style that was enhanced by their Jaadoo suits; she watched as one Madgēcot pulled something from his outfit and flung it at an attacker. The creature was instantly engulfed in green flames and writhed on the ground, trying to put them out. Another Madgēcot used what She-Ra/Adora recognized as a Chakra Block, having the same deadly effect on the creatures as when Maira had used it.

She-Ra/Adora turned her attention back on Zhe-La/Veth, her suspicion rising as she continued to watch them fight. Every strike with their sword was precise, slashing foes to pieces before they could lay a single claw on them. It was perfect—too perfect—as if she was not watching an actual fight but a choreographed one, like in one of Double Trouble's musical performances.

Zhe-La/Veth noticed She-Ra watching them, momentarily ceasing their battle to study her. Even though their helmet partially obscured their face, She-Ra/Adora could have sworn she saw disappointment there. With a jolt, she realized that was the whole

reason these creatures were attacking this village; to lure her here to be killed...or worse. She felt anger pour into her heart, directed towards this Zhe-La/Veth, this magical champion she now knew was her enemy.

Zhe-La/Veth turned their attention from her and raised their sword over their head with both hands. The blade burst into purple flames, lighting the entire area before Zhe-La/Veth as they spun the blade down, slamming it into the ground before them.

A ring of purple fire spread out from Zhe-La/Veth in a wave, passing harmlessly over the Madgēcots and She-Ra but disintegrating every single one of the attacking creatures. Everyone stared at Zhe-La/Veth in open-mouthed surprise when the fire finally died out.

"Wow! You think, maybe, you could have done that at the beginning of the fight?" Catra said to them with her hands on cocked hips. It was not declared in spite, but in a friendly manner, and there was a grin on Catra's cinnamon-colored face.

Zhe-La/Veth grinned back at her and shrugged sheepishly. "Sorry, that is something I can't do that often, and I wasn't sure it would work. Besides, I think you were handling yourself pretty well. I would have you watching my back anytime, Catra." They said with a sly, toothy grin.

She-Ra/Adora saw the blush on her wife's face at Zhe-La/Veth's compliment, spiking her anger into greater heights of rage. They were toying with Catra, messing with her wife's head to get at her —for what purpose, She-Ra/Adora could only guess at. Having Veth try and set her up was one thing, but messing with Catra was going too far.

She-Ra/Adora had had enough.

"LIAR!" She-Ra/Adora screamed as she charged Zhe-La/Veth, sword raised to pierce their heart.

Black Tears

Chapter Summary

She-Ra pits herself against Zhe-La and gets the chance to she what another Champion of Grayskull is made of.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The point of the magical golden blade whistled like an arrow, aimed to pierce the chest of Zhe-La/Veth. The sword's wielder had no idea if that would be a killing blow or not; she was not thinking about that. All She-Ra/Adora knew was that Zhe-La/Veth was her enemy, an enemy who had set her up for some unknown purpose and was currently manipulating her wife. For She-Ra/Adora, that was more than enough.

Just as the tip of her sword was a hairbreadth away from making contact, Zhe-La/Veth brought their indigo blade up and around for a parry, deflecting She-Ra/Adora's sword smoothly away. They followed this up with a kick to her stomach, sending She-Ra/Adora reeling from them.

"Why do you attack me, She-Ra?" Zhe-La/Veth asked, a hurt look on their face. "I fight on your side against these creatures."

"Adora! What the heck are you doing? Stop it!" Catra yelled behind her. Maira said something along the same line as Catra, but She-Ra/Adora chose to ignore all of them. She kept her eyes on Zhe-La/Veth as she held her sword up in an aggressive stance, tip pointed at the other Magical Champion.

"This is not up for discussion—surrender now to me, and we can avoid violence, Veth," She-Ra/Adora said in a cold voice.

Zhe-La/Veth narrowed their eyes at this, angered by her suggestion.

“I came to this planet to ask the Madgēcots for help; I abased myself before them and showed absolute humility. Now you want to add insult on top of humiliation by asking me to surrender to you?” They said, shaking their head. “NO. I will not.”

Zhe-La/Veth lifted their sword in a defensive position, and the two began to circle each other warily.

“This is a mistake, She-Ra,” Zhe-La/Veth said reasonably. “I have trained since a young age to master my enhanced form. You began your training much later than me and only just recently freed She-Ra from the shackles of the Empire. You are at a disadvantage.”

How do they know about breaking the First One’s sword? She-Ra/Adora thought with a scowl. *For people that are supposedly trapped on the opposite side of the galaxy, the Nephraeh seem to know a lot about Etheria.*

She-Ra/Adora lunged at Zhe-La/Veth, testing their capabilities with horizontal cuts and upward slashes. They deftly blocked and deflected her attacks; all of their movements were defensive actions. They had yet to strike back at her.

I know they are the enemy, but I must look like the aggressor right now. I need to draw them out so they no longer look like the victim, She-Ra/Adora thought as she changed tactics.

Pointing her sword at Zhe-La/Veth, She-Ra/Adora drew power from her magical reservoir and focused it into her weapon. A searing beam lanced out from the tip, but before it could blast Zhe-La/Veth, the energy splashed harmlessly over a purple transparent dome erected over the Nephraeh Champion. Zhe-La/Veth had dismissed their sword and had both of their hands raised over their head, holding the barrier in place with their magic.

Interesting, that’s not something She-Ra can do. Let's see what other tricks Veth has up their sleeve, She-Ra/Adora thought.

Just then, there was a popping sound, and She-Ra/Adora looked up to see rainbow-colored sparks dance around her head. The multicolored lights rained down, and She-Ra/Adora sensed a momentary halting of her power as they absorbed into her body. She felt herself start to transition to her normal form, but she fought against the draining sensation and maintained her She-Ra state.

She-Ra/Adora whirled, wide-eyed, and looked at the Madgēcots surrounding her with surprise.

"Who just used a Chakra Block on me!?" She yelled.

None of the Madgēcots answered her, but she knew it was Maira from the sorrowful expression on her face.

"Adora, have you gone mad? Stop this at once!" Maira pleaded, ears lowered.

"Maira, why is She-Ra doing this? What should we do?" One of the other Star Hunters asked.

Maira shook her head at her comrade. "I do not know, Ajala. Perhaps one of those creatures has done something to her; we must stop her. We must combine our Chakra Blocks and focus them on Adora."

She-Ra/Adora looked incredulously at the Star Hunters. "*Hellooo?* I'm standing right here! I can hear you. Don't you *dare* use your cat-trips on me! You should be attacking Veth, not me!"

She-Ra/Adora was about to ask Catra for assistance when she felt a tingle—it was She-Ra, telling her that she was about to be attacked, and she turned just in time to block a mighty downward strike from Zhe-La/Veth. Their magical sword was somehow bigger now, bloated with some form of power, and the faint indigo glow from earlier now blazed along the blade's length.

She-Ra/Adora blocked more strikes as Zhe-La/Veth went on the offensive. Her plan to draw them out had worked, and the

Empyrean was no longer content with being on the receiving end of her wrath.

She was amazed by their strength, on par or more significant than hers, and fought to keep up with the speed and skill of their strikes. Their earlier boast of training since birth was no lie.

As She-Ra/Adora continued to block their attacks, she noticed Zhe-La/Veth's eyes matched their sword; they blazed with indigo fire. It was such a deep, searing light—pitiless in its harshness. Her eyes were then drawn back to Zhe-La/Veth's blade and the light it emitted—it felt so cold. It was not a physical sensation, but an emotional one. It was such a frigid feeling that she felt her soul shiver with its intensity—it was taxing her strength.

She-Ra/Adora blocked one last strike when her will faltered and her magical sword shattered in her hands. She fell on her back with a startled cry, laying there panting as Zhe-La/Veth stood over her, their sword pointing down at her chest, gazing at her with cold indigo eyes.

"Now you surrender to me," they stated flatly.

She-Ra/Adora's eyes widened in a fury. "NEVER!" She screamed, launching herself to her feet and summoning her sword.

She-Ra/Adora burst forward with such blinding speed that to the onlooking Madgēcots, she seemed a gold and white blur that struck Zhe-La/Veth with a flash of light.

The Empyrean cried out in pain as they reverted to their normal form, stumbling backward to kneel on one knee. Veth looked with shock at their torso; a glowing indigo slash bisected the previously immaculate white waistcoat. She-Ra/Adora realized with a start that it was their blood; she had cut them with her sword, and she suddenly felt unsure of herself.

What have I done? She thought with horror.

This thought left her as she felt a body land on her back and two arms wrap around her neck. Instantly thinking of the hideous black creatures and their sharp fangs, She-Ra/Adora heaved her upper torso down, sending her assailant flying off her back.

Catra slammed down on the ground before She-Ra/Adora with such force she let out a sharp cry of pain—which was immediately silenced as her head hit the ground. She-Ra/Adora looked at her wife with horror, seeing that Catra did not get up; she lay still and motionless next to Veth.

"CATRA!" She-Ra/Adora shrieked.

A cascade of rainbow sparks surrounded She-Ra/Adora, raining down on her body and absorbing into her enhanced form. This time, the disconnect to her power was so significant that She-Ra/Adora reverted to her normal form and stayed that way—but she did not care. Adora rushed to Catra's side and lifted her head, feeling for a pulse—it was still there, and Adora sighed with relief.

A calico-furred Madgēcot kneeled on the other side of Catra and started to remove strips of material from his off-white Jaadoo suit. Adora watched as he licked each one, in turn, and placed them on critical points of Catra's body. Once he was done, the calico-furred Madgēcot whispered a command and the strips suddenly glowed with golden light, sinking into Catra's body. Catra let out a contented sigh in her unconscious state, and Adora smiled thankfully at the Madgēcot healer.

"She will be okay, I promise." He said with a small smile.

"Adora, please stand up and turn around," Maira said behind her in a stern voice.

Adora did as she was asked, standing and turning with her hands held up in placation.

"Maira, I'm sorry—" Adora said, then stopped mid-sentence as something wrapped tightly around her arms and pinned them to her side.

“What the—” Adora said in surprise. She looked down to see three bands wrapped around her upper arms, elbows, and wrists; they were the same midnight blue as Maira’s Jaadoo suit. They held her firmly, but not too tight—as if they were tailor-made specifically to bind Adora.

“Please do not try to transform or fight us, Adora,” Maira said. “I’m sorry, but under the authority of the Pratham of the Star Hunters, I am placing you under arrest. Please come peacefully and await judgment.”

For a split second, Adora felt like fighting against the Star Hunters—why should she give herself up for arrest when it was Veth who was in the wrong?

But instead of struggling, she turned around; when she saw Catra and Veth behind her, all fight left her.

The Madgēcot healer was now tending to the wound on Veth’s chest. It was a grievous one, and Adora could not believe she had done that to them.

What has gotten into me? Was I trying to kill Veth? She thought, ashamed of her actions. *Catra wanted to stop me from making a horrible mistake, and I almost killed her too; I deserve to be arrested.*

Adora turned back around and faced Maira with her head bowed.

“You don’t have to worry, Maira; I will come peacefully,” Adora said in a defeated voice.

* * *

Catra awoke in her guest bed feeling dizzy and anxious; she instantly felt next to her for Adora but found nothing. She groaned as she tried to sit up, but two hands gently pushed her back down into the soft bed. It was Viraj. Her brother was sitting on the bedside, his blue and yellow heterochromatic eyes gazing down at her with concern.

“Easy, sister, easy. Just take it one step at a time; you suffered a massive blow. Sanket almost had to get a new Jaadoo suit with all the healing cantrips he used on you.”

“Where is Adora?” Catra whispered.

Viraj’s face fell. “She is being held in The Imaarat; she is in captivity, but she is safe.”

Catra growled at this and forced herself up into a sitting position. She bared her fangs at her brother when he attempted to push her back down.

“I need to see her, Viraj. NOW.” She tried to sound menacing, but it only ended as a plea. “This was some kind of mistake; she would never hurt me on purpose. We fought on opposite sides of a war for years; Adora could have snapped me like a twig as She-Ra...but she didn’t! This was a mistake!”

Viraj shook his head sorrowfully. “Unfortunately, she also attacked Veth, Cat-tra. She hurt them badly. Veth represents another race we hoped to mend relations with, and her actions might have ruined that. Aadhya wants her in isolation for now, and the Jaadoogar were summoned to inspect her. They are the only ones with magic powerful enough to determine whether or not Adora has been...corrupted. We still don’t know what those creatures who attacked the Fareek were; they have never been seen anywhere on Elysia.”

Catra looked unfocused as she remembered the time she had purposely corrupted Adora with the First Ones’ virus. Adora had almost killed her as She-Ra, and it was only the intervention of her friend Scorpia that kept that from happening. From the way Entrapta talked about it, the virus sounded technology-based, but who really knew with First One’s technology? It was so far beyond any tech the Horde or anyone else on Etheria had, it might as well have been magic.

There was so much happening right now; she and Adora had come to Elysia for a honeymoon, and now, Catra was surrounded by mysteries and separated from her greatest comfort in life.. It was a little overwhelming, but Catra forced herself to skim through the jumble of the past couple of days, looking for the point at which everything started to go downhill. She didn't have to think too hard about it—it was with the appearance of the Nephraeh, and more importantly, Veth. Veth, whom Adora had attacked and tried to kill the night before—Catra was confident that they would have the answers she sought.

"Then I need to see them; I want to see Veth. They must know what happened. I need to talk to Veth. Where are they, Viraj?" Catra said, placing her cinnamon-colored hand on his.

A small smile appeared on Viraj's face, and he nodded. "Okay, I can help you. They are in this same guest house recuperating in their own quarters. The other Empyreans are nearby in separate rooms; Aadhya felt it necessary they stay there so no further harm can come to the Nephraeh. I don't see any issue with you visiting Veth as long as I am with you. I am one of the Star Hunters, after all."

Now that she had something to focus on, it didn't take long for Catra to get out of bed and get dressed—the aches and pains from the injuries she sustained the night before melted away the more she moved. Whatever the Madgēcot healer had used on her was effective.

Viraj led Catra out of the room and up a couple of flights of stairs, ending up on the top floor where the suites for the Nephraeh were situated. They were regular stairs, not the magic planks typically used by Madgēcots; their hosts wanted their guests to be as comfortable as possible.

"How come the sworn enemies of the Madgēcots get the sweet top rooms, Viraj?" Catra said in a joking tone.

He turned to his sister with a confused expression. “Why do you think the top rooms are better? They are above the tree canopy, and all they see is the sky. The lower rooms are the ones that get a view of the city and the forest floor.”

Catra pursed her lips and nodded at this. “I guess it’s all about perspective,” she said absentmindedly.

Catra and Viraj came to a long hall—five rows of doors on either side with the corridor ending in an eleventh door. Before they could proceed, the ten doors on either side opened in unison, and a Nephraeh stepped out of each one. They were the Nephraeh who accompanied Veth to Elysia, initially dressed as dignitaries in robes and identified as Krypteia by Aadhya. She had stated they were assassins. The Krypteia no longer wore their robes, and if anyone looked like an assassin to Catra, it would be these Krypteia.

Each Krypteia was covered in a skin-tight outfit made of the same woven metallic bands as Veth’s pants. Their outfits were dull black—the effect making the Krypteia appear as voids sucking in all light. Helmets covered their heads entirely—silver eyes peered out of a faceplate which swept back from either side of their heads, covering their long ears and appearing like long horns pointing back from their head.

Each Krypteia adopted a fighting stance; clawed gauntlets held out threateningly towards Catra and Viraj, who immediately froze in place.

“State your business here,” one of the masked Krypteia barked, presumably the leader.

Catra sensed her brother’s agitation; it was more than evident to her in his stance, scent, and tail movement. She had to admit she liked being around other Madgēcots; they were so open to each other with their feelings, not like being around the mixed species of the Horde. It was no wonder she had such a hard time making friends there.

“My business?” Viraj said, anger in his voice. “I am a Madgēcot on Elysia, *offworlder*. This is my home, and you are our guests; *how dare you threaten me?*”

The Krypteia were not moved by his words and did not cease their threatening formation.

“Yes, we are guests, that is true. But our Champion was attacked last night by one of *your* other guests and almost killed! We were sent here by the Archon Lethe to guard the bearer of Zhe-La, and we will not let you pass.” The Krypteia leader said firmly.

Catra placed a reassuring hand on her brother’s shoulder when a low growl rumbled from his chest.

“Easy, everyone, easy. I just want to talk to Veth, that’s all. I spoke with them last night, and I think we got along pretty well together. I’m not totally sure what happened with Adora, and I just want to ask them a few questions, that’s all.” Catra said in her calmest voice.

The Krypteia leader shook their head. “No, I am not letting you anywhere near Champion Veth. I know just how deadly a Madgēcot can be, even one without a Jaadoo suit such as yourself.”

“I can’t believe this!” Viraj cried, incensed. “I am a Star Hunter on my home planet! I will not be told what to do by some Gadhe!”

All the Krypteia hissed at this and started to move towards Catra and Viraj, claws held out to tear them to pieces.

Catra sank into a fighting stance and looked out of the corner of her eyes at her brother.

“Viraj, what’s a Gadhe?” She said out of the side of her mouth.

“I will tell you later—if we survive.” He said with a groan. “*Me and my Madgēcot temper!*”

Before the Krypteia reached Viraj and Catra, the door at the end of the hall opened, and a voice rang out.

"ENOUGH! Nefeli, recall your Krypteia. I wish to speak to these visitors." Veth said sternly.

The Krypteia halted in their advance and the leader, Nefeli, turned to Veth. "Are you sure, Child of Lethe? At least let me be by your side, please,"

Veth smiled at Nefeli and shook their head. "No, I do not wish it. I want to speak to them alone. Please leave us."

After a curt nod to Veth, Nefeli made a brief whistling sound; all of the Krypteia instantly stood up straight, turned, and entered their rooms, closing the doors behind them. Veth beckoned Viraj and Catra to follow and then turned to enter their room, leaving the door open. Viraj looked at Catra with a curious tilt to his head, and she shrugged, then proceeded down the hall to Veth's room, her brother in tow.

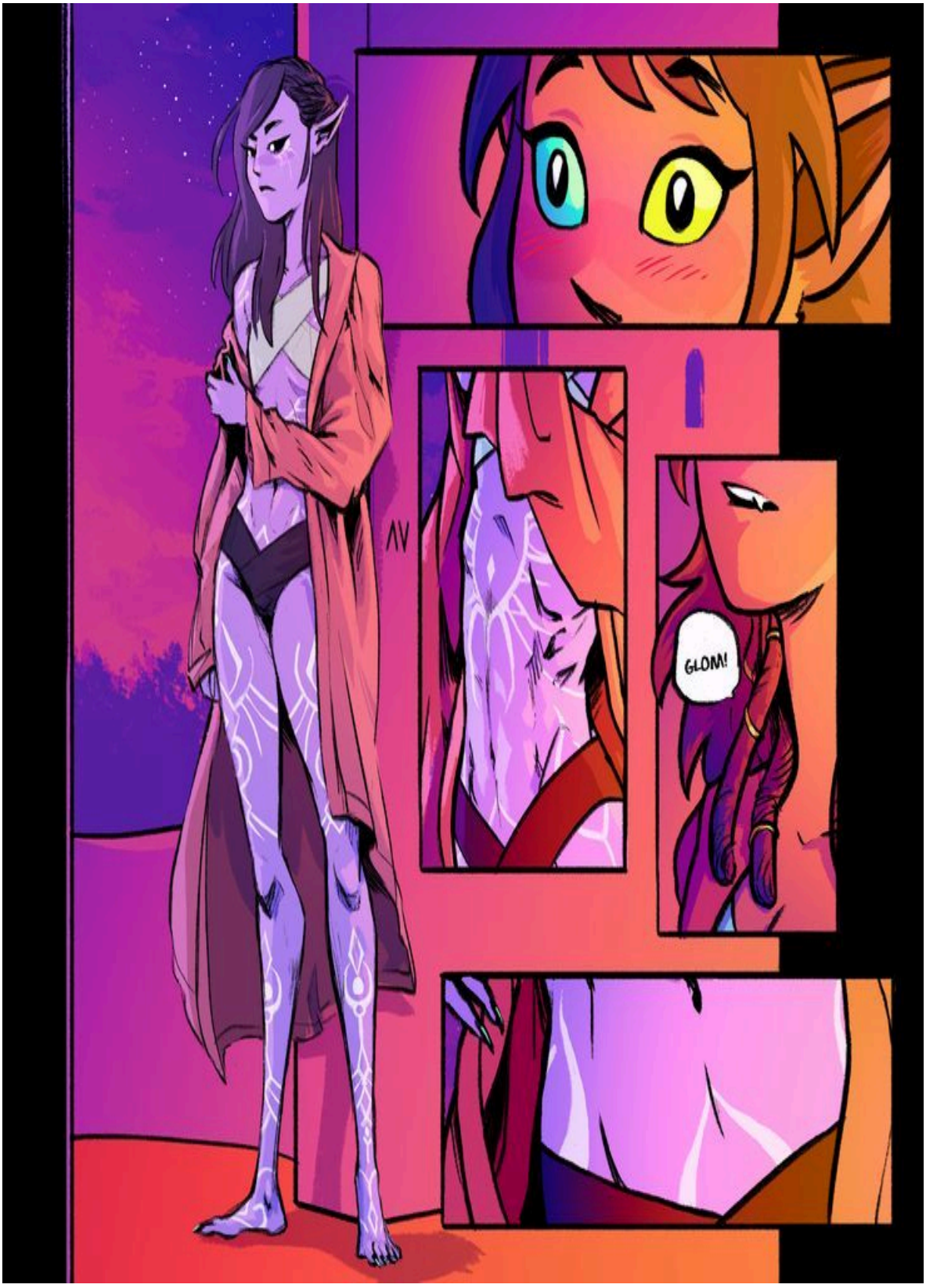
When she entered the room, she realized it was similar to her and Adora's room but not identical—following the Madgēcot aesthetic of non-conformity. Veth stood nearby an open window, gazing absently into the distance. They were wearing the same kind of loose robe she and Adora were given, and as Veth turned to greet them, Catra felt a jolt of surprise as she saw what they wore under the robe.

They wore except for a tight pair of black briefs, much like she would wear, and white bandages that crisscrossed their chest.

Catra tried not to be distracted by Veth's partial nudity, but she could not help allowing her eyes to take in what was so openly displayed. There was a slight soft curve to their body lines, not openly feminine but not wholly masculine, like her friend Double Trouble, and she could not help how this appealed to her.

Her earlier question about how far down their body the white markings on their chest went was partially answered; she followed

them down from under the bandages, over the faint lines of their stomach to disappear into the top of their underwear. Not allowing her eyes to linger there, she moved down Veth's long legs and to their feet, seeing points at the end of each toe indicating claws—much like her feet.



Realizing she was staring, Catra forced her eyes to Veth's face and felt her face burn as she recognized the twinkle in their glittering eyes.

Viraj nervously cleared his throat, and Catra could tell her brother was similarly affected by the sight of Veth.

"Greetings, uh, Champion Veth...uh, is that how I should address you?" Viraj stammered as his stone-gray tail twitched furiously.

Veth laughed. "No, you don't have to be so formal, Star Hunter, just call me Veth." They said in that alluring androgynous voice.

Viraj laughed again, and Catra winced at how obviously uncomfortable it sounded. She found herself sweating and forced herself to look at a point just above Veth's head.

"Okay…Veth. How are your injuries? I hope the healing cantrips Sanket used are helping you." Viraj said.

Veth absentmindedly touched their bandages and shrugged slightly. "I have suffered worse, Star Hunter," they said casually.

Viraj perked up. "Oh, you can call me Viraj, I insist," he said, placing the fingers of one hand on his chest. Catra winced again.

Veth smiled at this. "*Viraj*." They said, rolling the word around in their mouth as if enjoying the sound of it. They then turned their attention to Catra. "It's good to see you again, Catra. It was good to have you by my side last night, despite what happened to me."

Catra hoped they missed the blush rising on her cheeks. "Yeah, it was no problem, Veth." She said, embarrassed.

Veth started as if realizing something. "I do not leave Empyrea much, so I am not the best with binary races, but I can tell you are…*brother* and *sister*, right? Actually, you are twins, correct?"

Viraj and Catra glanced at each other and nodded. Veth smiled at this, seemingly pleased.

"Amazing! Such an attractive pair as well, hmm…" Veth said, gazing at Catra and Viraj with a clawed finger held to their lips. They then waved their hand away absentmindedly. "Sorry, the

idea of male and female has always fascinated me, but you did not come to talk about that. How can I help you?”

Catra was very thankful for the subject change. “I wanted to talk to you about what happened last night when Adora attacked you.”

Veth nodded at this, indicating their guests sit in nearby chairs as they wrapped their robe around their body, seating themselves in a chair of their own. Catra could have sworn her brother whined when their host covered their exposed skin but realized it could have just as easily been her.

“Yes, I have been waiting for someone to come and talk to me about that,” Veth said in a reserved tone. “How is She-Ra—uh—I mean Adora doing? She has not been harmed for attacking me, has she?”

“No, she is fine, Veth. She is just being held captive at The Pratham; it is where we all first met. We wanted to make sure nothing was affecting her judgment.” Viraj said reassuringly.

At the mention of her wife, Catra suddenly became angry—not at Adora, but the situation and herself. Here she was practically drooling over this stranger when her wife, Adora, was locked away in some dungeon. She cleared her mind of all distractions and focused on why they visited Veth—getting Adora released and back in her arms.

“Adora is my wife, by the way, and this trip to Elysia was meant to be our honeymoon,” Catra said, then saw a look of confusion on Veth’s face. “That’s like a vacation after we swear a lifelong Vow to each other—anyway, that’s not important—what’s important is that we were never meant to be here for whatever this meeting is between you and the Madgēcots. We never heard of Nephraehs or Zhe-Las before coming here, so Adora attacking you makes no sense.”

Catra felt herself becoming angrier as she outlined the situation, the act of speaking the words focusing her will to a fine point.

"So, Veth, what I want to know is this; why did the person I have known and loved *my entire life* go berserk and attack you? She would never do it without reason; what did you do to cause my wife to attack you? Also, what were those creatures that attacked the village? I have a feeling you know what they were, for how could you have known to use that fancy trick to stop them? Tell me that!"

Catra realized with a start that she was standing now, fists clenched at her sides and teeth bared. She felt her brother's hand on her wrist, gently guiding her back down and into her seat. When she met his heterochromatic eyes, she saw surprise and admonishment there, and he shook his head slowly at her. He turned from her to smile reassuringly to Veth, who seemed utterly unmoved by Catra's
words.

"Sorry about my sister; as she said, she is distraught by what happened last night—we all are. We—"

Veth abruptly held up a hand, indicating Viraj should stop talking, and they stood back up. There was a pained expression on their face as they wrapped the robe around themselves and hugged themselves protectively. Veth walked over to the window and gazed out, not saying anything as Viraj looked at Catra with a *now look what you did* expression. There was an uncomfortable moment of silence before Veth sighed heavily as if coming to a decision, and they seemed to deflate as if shedding a massive burden.

"Catra is right, but more than you know. I am trying to deceive you all," they said in a whisper.

The long ears on both Madgēcots perked up, and Catra and Viraj looked at each other with surprise on their faces.

"Uh...*what?*" Viraj said with a tilt to his head.

Veth leaned over the open window sill, gripping the edge with clawed hands.

"I am so very tired of all of this, so tired," Veth said wearily. "When I sent away the Krypteia, I thought it was so they would not agitate you, but now I realize that I wanted to confess myself to you. They would try and kill us all if they were about to hear what I am going to tell you."

Both Catra and Viraj's tails twitched out of the back of the chairs as they silently waited for Veth to continue.

"When I said the Nephraeh were infected by some unknown disease created by Horde Prime, that was true, but to a greater extent than I explained. We are cursed now, not just devoid of empathy, but driven by the desire to consume that emotion in others. I cannot explain how—again, the Nephraeh are half-magical. Perhaps Horde Prime devised a way to combine magic and technology; the Empire he was once part of was proficient with such things. They did manage to once bind the power of Zhe-La, She-Ra, and other Champions to Power Swords, after all."

"The main reason I was sent here by my Archon was not so Empyrea could become a vassal world of Elysia, but to lull the Madgēcots into trusting us through their empathy. We wanted our old allies close to us again, for we do miss the Madgēcots—not for fellowship—but the desire to feed on their empathy. The Nephraeh want to draw the people of Elysia to their bosom and suck them dry, making you a mirror of us."

Catra felt horror at this admission, and looking at her brother, saw pure fury on his face.

"This does not explain why Adora attacked you; did she find out? Also, are you behind those monsters that attacked the Fareek?" Viraj said, a low growl humming behind his words.

"The Vetala," Veth said with a nod. "Yes, they are ours, unfortunately."

“What are they?” Catra said with disgust.

Veth turned from the window, still hugging themselves, and seated themselves smoothly in their seat. Catra now saw black lines under their kohl smeared eyes—they were crying. The black tears ran down lilac cheeks, falling off their jaw and on their bandages, creating stains there.

“They are Nephraeh, Catra,” Veth said simply. “Nephraeh whose hunger has become too great, turning them into monsters with only desire left to them—the desire to feed. It is the fate that awaits all Nephraeh—including me.”

“So, what were these fallen Nephraeh doing on my planet, Veth?” Viraj asked, still angry.

Catra and Viraj were surprised when Veth suddenly laughed.

“*Fallen Nephraeh*, you say? The Nephraeh are already fallen; how can we fall any further? But I guess we do anyway, don’t we?” Veth said sourly. “To answer your question, we brought them here. We can—I don’t know how to describe this properly—contain the Vetala in a Phylactery—a vessel if you will. We deposited the Phylactery in orbit and allowed it to fall to the planet in the direction of one of the settlements before we landed.”

Viraj snarled and leaped to his feet, but this time it was Catra who reached up and restrained her brother, guiding him back into his seat. She stared at Veth, trying to maintain calm, wanting to get the entire story from them before jumping into action.

“Why would you do this, Veth? What was the purpose of exposing innocents to such dangerous creatures?” Catra said, trying to sound compassionate.

“The Archon planned to lure the She-Ra into a fight with the Vetala; they hoped that during the battle, the Vetala would be able to Enervate She-Ra—corrupting her and making her susceptible to our ways. I will tell you that I am glad it did not

work; I want She-Ra on my side, but not like that. I don't want to see such a beautiful Champion brought so low." Veth said with a weak smile.

Catra felt dizzy as the trip to Elysia took on a whole new dimension. The Nephraeh—a race they never knew existed—planned on her and Adora being on Elysia and brought horrible creatures with them to hurt her wife. They also planned on corrupting her entire race—including the brother she just reunited with—all because Horde Prime corrupted them.

It all came back to Horde Prime, that evil dictator who brainwashed her into attacking Adora and trying to kill herself. Horde Prime, who violated her spirit with his technology and, to this day, was the reason she sometimes woke up in a dripping sweat after dreaming of drowning in green fluid. Horde Prime, who was somehow still in her life more than two years after defeating him.

Veth's admission had made her angry; she had wanted to jump up and hurt them for what they tried to do to Adora. But now she realized that Veth and the Nephraeh were not the problem; they were victims left over from a madman's attempt to dominate an entire galaxy.

Catra felt pity for them, and her earlier anger was redirected towards the one who deserved it—Horde Prime. She did not want Horde Prime to win, and the best way to make this happen was to help the Nephraeh—not by allowing them to feed on other's emotions—but by healing them of their corruption—forever. She had no idea how to achieve this, though.

Catra studied Veth. She wasn't sure if she could trust them yet, but their story put them in such a vulnerable position it was hard not to believe. She watched as they wiped the tears from their eyes, clearing away the kohl smudging to reveal white markings around their eyes. They were such pretty markings; they surrounded each eye and extended down from the outer corners

to end in points. Combined with the silver eyes, the effect was quite striking.

"Veth, why are you telling us this all of a sudden? Why should we trust you, especially after what you tried to do to my wife?" Catra said in a stern voice.

Veth nodded to her, knowing this question would be asked of them.

"That's a long story, Catra, but simply put—I'm just so tired of all of this. From birth, every Nephraeh knows of the emptiness and the hunger—it is all-encompassing and inescapable. As Zhe-La, it is my duty to help the Archon guide our people, not for some vague ideal called The Light, but for survival. I came here to help my people the only way I know how; by following the directions given to me by the Archon Lethe."

Veth sighed and looked back out of the window as they continued their story.

"I have been having a hard time with all of this lately, especially since I know that this was not the way the Nephraeh were supposed to be. I may not have the capacity to care for others, but I care for myself; I know I do not want this for myself any longer. When I came to this planet, I dreaded this mission—I hate all this messy subterfuge. But when I saw Adora, I saw something in her that I had never felt before—hope. She is endowed with a magical power like me, able to become a Champion, and I felt an overwhelming desire to have her fight by my side."

"But when she attacked me last night, I—" Veth said sadly as their face fell. "I knew she must have seen through my deception, and I felt shame. I felt unworthy."

Veth turned to Catra, and she saw the raw pleading in their silver eyes.

"I want to make amends finally; that is why I am telling you. I won't say it's because I feel guilty. After all, you know that to be a

lie—I am not capable of that. I want to make amends for myself, and I will do anything to achieve that. I want to be worthy of Zhe-La and the trust the Nephraeh placed in me to lead them on the right course. I no longer feel like Archon Lethe's wisdom is the best for us."

Catra turned to her brother; his earlier anger had bled away into uncertainty. She knew exactly what he was thinking—he didn't know whether or not to trust Veth either.

"So, first things first," Viraj said slowly. "Are you willing to tell our Pratham everything? Are you willing to confess the entire plan of the Empyrean Empire to the leader of the Star Hunters so we can clear Adora's name?"

Veth closed their eyes and nodded slowly. "Yes, I will. It is the least I can do for her,"

Viraj nodded, seemingly satisfied. "What about the rest of your people you brought with you? The Krypteia. I doubt they will take your defection very well." He said meaningfully.

"No, they will not. They will try to kill or capture me with the goal of returning me to Empyrea. Letting the power of Zhe-La fall into enemy hands would be a disaster for the Empyrean Empire." Veth said, looking crestfallen. "I would not be able to defeat them by myself; they are deadly. I would need help."

Catra brightened. "Well, lucky for you, I happen to know someone who could help." She said with a grin.

Chapter End Notes

Mini-comic done by the wonderful fan_fun_off (Instagram) a.k.a. AV Stravaganza (Tumblr)

The Battle of Salineas

Chapter Summary

The Princesses band together to face down one of their own.

Kishar's journal takes a turn for the worst.

Not long after revealing our relationship to the council, Jihan and I were bonded before The Great Chaliendra Tree—just as we planned! It was a fantastic ceremony, and all the Champions of Grayskull were in attendance there. It had been centuries since all of us occupied the same planet, let alone be so near to each other. The grand space around The Great Chaliendra Tree seemed small with all seven Champions gathered there.

Our collected presence so enhanced the power of The Great Chaliendra Tree that the sorcerers of Trolla could see the refraction of its magical essence through the interdimensional veil —something never before beheld! The sight of it made the usually steadfast Trollans panic; they thought a Universal Multidimensional Collapse was upon them and almost convened a Council of Eschaton! Thank all the stars that we had Trollan guests, and they were able to communicate with their brethren in the Timeless Dimension and forestall such a disaster.

It was good to see all the Champions in one place. Astra, bearer of She-Ra, gifted us with a song she had written herself. She sang to us in her enhanced form, managing to be entirely in harmony with The Great Chaliendra Tree. It was one of the most beautiful things I have ever heard, and both Jihan and I wept to hear it.

Zeika, bearer of Thon-Ra, brought gems from Geolon—it was a fine gift, but Jihan and I do not need such things. We decided that they would be better suited as a donation to one of the many poorer planets on the outskirts of the galaxy, the ones who have not joined our society yet.

Herheif, the bearer of He-Man, was also at our reception. I would not go as far as to say he is my least favorite Champion—for I do not rank my friends in this way—but his presence is not as easy to bear as some of the others. The fact that he never stops trying to court me is another gripe I have with the man; I am continually having to turn him down. Herheif is so far beyond what I would seek in a partner; he is crude and too overbearing in his extreme masculinity. But he behaved himself at our ceremony, which was a small blessing.

The ceremony was held at dusk to be in keeping with the Celestial Harmonies that The Great Chaliendra Tree is in tune with—

Glimmer stopped reading the datapad, placing it down on the table before her to rub at her weary eyes. The recent troubles on Etheria were weighing heavily on her and were the cause of quite a few sleepless nights. She had to force herself to read through Kishar's journal in what spare time she had, searching for any clues as to the nature of the evil they now faced.

The earlier report from Hordak stating that Mermista was creating an army of robot soldiers was verified to be true. Not long after his report, refugees from Salineas had arrived in Bright Moon seeking sanctuary—it seemed that none of Mermista's people wanted anything to do with what she had planned.

According to her own Royal Guard, Mermista was not content with simply separating from the rest of Etheria, she also wanted to expand her kingdom. This meant only one thing; she was going to take it by force from her former allies—The Kingdom of Etheria. This was why she had tried to reach Entrapta through Hordak, to create a mechanical force that would obey her every command. Since Hordak turned her down, Mermista turned to another source for help—none other than Beast Island.

After the defeat of Horde Prime, small teams of scholars were granted access to the First One's dumping ground for research purposes. But after a series of vicious Pooka attacks and the mysterious nature of the will-sapping 'signal,' the scholars

abandoned Beast Island, deeming it off-limits to the rest of the planet.

According to the Salineas refugees, Mermista had enticed the scholars to return to the island, promising to protect them in exchange for their knowledge. Eager to return to their work, they had accepted, only finding out what Mermista had planned to do with this knowledge when they were on the Island. By then, it was too late, and under the threat of force, Mermista used them to create her army from the discarded technology on Beast Island. Based on what Bow told her of the place, Glimmer was fearful of what kind of robots she could make using the technology even the First Ones thought was too dangerous to keep around.

The nature of Mermista's Elemental Magic and the location of her kingdom was a source of great worry for the rest of the planet. Mermista had the power of the sea, connecting her to every one of the Prime Kingdoms on the planet. Even Bright Moon had access to the larger sea via its bay—Mermista could bring her forces directly to its shore and take the castle. She could even destroy the Moonstone if she wished. Who knew what she was capable of without empathy as a guide?

After hearing this news, Glimmer had convened another council, and after heated debate, it was decided that the best course of action was to strike first at Salineas. Hopefully, they could capture Mermista and destroy her army before she could mobilize it against them. The rest of the Princesses, plus He-Man, were even now gathering for the attack while Glimmer tried to find some way out of this mess without resorting to violence. It had been centuries since one Etherian kingdom had warred with another and she did not want to be responsible for the disruption of that peace.

It seemed so much easier when she was just a freedom fighter and part of a greater rebellion; even when she became Queen of Bright Moon, she at least had the other Princesses to lean on. Problems seemed to come with a heavier weight now that she

was responsible for what happened on an entire planet, especially when it was one of her own friends rebelling against her.

Glimmer forced herself to return to Kishar's journal. She did not know why, but she was absolutely sure that the solution was in this text. There was something about the Abominable Powers mentioned there that resonated with her. If there was an Eye of Hate that drove someone to a murderous rage, wouldn't it make sense for there to be something that made someone lose all their empathy? Wouldn't that specific Abominable Power also be the most powerful one of them all?

Glimmer suddenly remembered something her mother, Queen Angella, once said to her. It was one of those snippets of wisdom her mother tried to impart upon her daughter—her heir and successor.

My daughter, the greatest evil you will ever face will not be greed, hatred, or jealousy but the absence of empathy—called apathy. Be constantly on your guard, for when people start to no longer care for one another, that is when you have failed as their Queen. It is your job not only to appear as if you care and love your people, but also to truly feel that emotion in your heart.

She always hated those little heart-to-heart sessions with her mother and gritted her teeth through them, but now Glimmer saw their truth. She silently thanked her mother and wished her peace, wherever she was now.

Glimmer continued to read through Kishar's journal, finishing the details of the bonding ceremony and on to their lives together. She enjoyed reading about how happy they were, but she was running out of time, and she was desperate for any other hints of Abominable Power. She started to breeze through the passages, looking for any keywords or clues; it did not take her long to find it. She stopped skimming and started reading more thoroughly.

She noticed that here, Kishar had started marking each entry with dates, something they had not bothered to do earlier.

Unfortunately, she was not familiar with the dating system and therefore did not have a frame of reference of how long ago it was.

01.2376.99

Something horrible has happened. Something completely unexpected and unforeseen has befallen the love of my existence, Jihan.

Because of our popularity as the 'Galactic Power Couple,' Jihan and I were asked to attend the coronation of the new Psychopomp of Zal-Cron IV. We were both in the reception hall, doing our part to mingle with the guests and regal them with tales of our adventures while in our enhanced forms. Jihan was just telling the Prime Minister of Omiros about the time he saved me from the half-living Xex on Denebria when he suddenly reverted out of his enhanced form and collapsed to the floor.

At first, I thought this was one of his tricks; Jihan still loves to play his pranks even to this day, but making me afraid for him was not his style. I rushed to his side as Zhe-La and lifted him into my arms; he was still conscious but disoriented and dizzy. He had no idea what had happened to him, and after an examination by the local healer, nothing was determined to be wrong with him.

We passed this off as a fluke; after all, both Jihan and I have been constantly on call throughout the universe, and we were both taxed. We continued our responsibilities as Champions, but the collapsing spells continued with increasing frequency.

It was during a mission to the asteroid belt of Dactis that we decided it was time to get help. At a crucial moment, Jihan lost his powers and collapsed again, almost killing me plus a group of scientists, causing us to fail the mission. We decided it was time to get to the bottom of this, and we returned to Elysia; perhaps Jihan's own people, the Madgēcots, would know what was happening to him.

As it turns out, they did.

Jihan was diagnosed with a rare Madgēcot degenerative disease called Kamajor. It was something Madgēcots feared during The Dark Times but was thought to be eradicated millennia ago. It was terrible luck for Jihan and me, for Kamajor is untreatable, and a death sentence—at the most, Jihan was given one Elysian year to live.

My whole world has come crashing down.

01.2395.99

My whole existence has become consumed with finding a way to save Jihan.

We compiled a list of the galaxy's greatest healers with the plan to visit each one in turn. But after only visiting the first one, we realized this was too much for Jihan; he was becoming too weak for space travel and could no longer leave Elysia.

It was up to me to find the solution.

I have spent the last month traveling from healer to healer, visiting various spiritual fanes of healing, and even visited the technologically advanced planet of Xe-Xi but came up with nothing.

It was such a dreadfully horrible feeling being away from Jihan for that long—what if there was nothing I could do for him and I was wasting what time I had left with him? I feel like I am being pulled in many places at once and that my soul will shear in half. I don't know what to do! I am in absolute despair!

01.2398.99

Astra recently paid a visit to Elysia. After hearing of what had befallen Jihan, she had rushed here as quickly as she could, hoping to use her She-Ra healing power on him.

Unfortunately, it did not work; She-Ra may be able to bring someone back from the brink of death, but there was nothing she could do for Jihan. The Kamajor was too insidious, and Astra suspected it was some form of malefic magic left over from the Dark Times—perhaps The Gastrolith of Decay was the original source.

But that Abominable Power is locked up safely in Castle Grayskull —how would it affect Jihan?

There is only one course of action left to me; I must visit Castle Grayskull and speak to the Sorcerer there, Zzar.

I don't know why I did not think of visiting her initially, for not only is she the Keeper of Secrets at Castle Grayskull, but she is also the bearer of The Life Gem!

I feel like I finally have hope again! I am leaving for Eternia as—

Glimmer stopped reading here for a moment; the implications of where this story was leading were too apparent to her.

Zzar, the fallen keeper of the Life Gem who convinced Adam, the last bearer of He-Man, to sacrifice countless Eternians to fuel her ascendancy to Godhood. Zzar, who became the Set'Heth-un'dar and tried to re-enter the galaxy from a dimension of terror to dominate all of existence, only to be stopped by the ultimate sacrifice made by her sister, Madame Razz. This was the person whom Kishar was turning to for help.

But a seed of hope for Kishar blossomed in Glimmer's mind; after all, didn't Madame Razz say that her sister Zzar was once good, and only after a very long time, did she begin to fall to evil? Perhaps the version of Zzar that Kishar was going to visit was still the good one, and she was able to help Kishar.

Glimmer doubted it.

Before she could return to her reading, the door to her Observatory opened, and Bow strode in, worry creasing his

handsome features. She turned to him with a sad smile.

"I'm out of time, aren't I?" She said weakly.

Bow nodded. "Everyone is gathered at the shore and waiting for you. We should probably do this soon since Mermista will have seen us by now and know what we plan; we don't want to give her much time to plan a defense."

Glimmer sighed and placed the datapad back on her reading table. Standing up, she picked up the Star Stone staff and walked wearily over to Bow, laying a hand on his shoulder. They disappeared in a haze of sparkles.

* * *

The first sight that met Glimmer's eyes was a jagged shoreline pointing like a knife in the direction of Salineas. She remembered the last time she teleported to this location; it was right after Double Trouble revealed Hordak's plot to distract all the Princesses while he staged a surprise attack on Salineas. Glimmer, Adora, Bow, and Mermista had arrived on this very spot she stood on now to find the banner of the Horde flying high over the ruins of Salineas.

The Salineas that met their eyes was now wholly intact, but the situation seemed much worse. Now Glimmer would be the one laying siege to Salineas.

All the Princesses were gathered there—minus Scorpia and Mermista, of course—and He-Man/Shen paced the shoreline atop his steed, Battlecat. With the nature of the foe they faced, it was deemed prudent to limit the force to anyone with some form of elemental power. No one else was equipped to meet Mermista in her home territory—they would just end up as casualties.

Everyone turned as she and Bow appeared, looking at them with expectation. Entrapta approached her with a datapad in hand.

“As per your instructions, a final plea has been sent to the rebel Princess Mermista, stating our intentions and asking her to come forth from her palace and answer for her recent actions,” Entrapta said formally.

“And?” Glimmer said with a raised eyebrow.

“So far, there has been no answer from Mermista. We can only assume she has declined our offer of peace,” Entrapta said neutrally.

Glimmer sighed again then turned to Frosta, nodding to her. Wearily, the teenage Princess turned towards the section of water that separated the shoreline from Salineas and raised her hands to use her Elemental Princess Power. A faint, icy haze appeared over the water as tiny points of ice formed; white tendril-like vines spread out from these isolated points and reached for each other, growing larger as they joined. When it was finished, a solid floor of ice connected the shore directly to Salineas, giving Glimmer’s forces a direct avenue of attack.

He-Man/Shen immediately galloped forward on Battlecat; the green and orange alien bounding ahead on the slippery ice on clinging claws. But they had not made it twenty paces before the ice exploded before them, sending the pair sailing back through the air to crash back on the shore.

Glimmer and the rest of the Princesses watched with horror as two metal-clawed hands reached up to clutch at each edge of the ice hole. A monstrous face soon appeared over the edge; five glowing electronic eyes burned over rows of razor-sharp wire teeth in a mouth that seemed to leer at them. The robot horror pulled itself entirely from the ice to stand on two clawed feet. It towered over the Princesses—it was even half again taller than He-Man/Shen. It opened its mouth and bellowed at the force arrayed before it—but it was not a challenge. It was a war cry.

There were numerous other explosions in the ice as more robot abominations appeared. No two were alike; some stood on two

feet while others moved on treads. Some had arms attached to torsos, while others had guns connected directly to their heads. There was even what seemed like a giant worm-beast wriggling out of the ice to smash down onto its surface. The robots appearing from beneath the ice may not have shared the same design, but they were all united in their cause—the eradication of the Princesses and He-Man/Shen.

This was obviously the robot army Mermista was so keen on creating from the technology found on Beast Island. It seemed like she was not only successful in making them, but her efforts were highly prolific—where once there was a flat icy surface, there were now more than fifty of the robot creations.

Chaos immediately ensued.

Using the power of the Life Gem, Perfuma created not one but three of the giant plant golem monsters she used on the Horde-occupied tower during the Princess Rebellion. They surged forth with strange howls to grapple with their robot enemies—one of the Golems lifted a snarling spider-shaped robot to smash it down into another as another Golem wrapped its arms around the worm-shaped mechanical, beginning to crush it.

Frosta had summoned her ice armor, also used in the attack on the Horde tower, and charged forth to bash her way into a crowd of enemies. Just as they were starting to surround and trap the ice Princess, Frosta delivered an uppercut to their leader, sending its head soaring through the air.

Entrapta, now piloting the replacement for her last mech-suit dubbed 'Linda II,' rolled down the slight decline to the shore to bowl into a swarm of charging killer robots, knocking them back onto the ice. She directed her suit to lift the nearest enemy in one hand to smash it repeatedly in the torso with her other. It soon lay in pieces at her feet, and Linda II went in search of other foes.

Much like they did in the battle against the Dark He-Man, Spinnerella and Netossa fought back to back, using their powers

in combination to deadly effect. Three mechanical abominations were swept up in Netossa's net and pinned in place, making them an easy target to be destroyed by a whirlwind blast from Spinnerella.

In the center of them all was He-Man/Shen—currently grappling with the original robot who surprise attacked him. Compared to its fellows, this mechanical monstrosity appeared larger and meaner—an Alpha. With lightning slashes, the Alpha deflected He-Man/Shen's titanic sword blows, all the while attempting to kick the biting and slashing Battlecat who was trying to take out its legs.

Glimmer watched this battle take place, all the while feeling like a helpless failure. If someone had told her a month ago that this would be happening, she would have laughed in the face...but here she was.

Her distraction almost cost her, and she turned just in time to see a quadruped robot charge for her, it's muzzled mouth opened like a steel trap to snap down on her.

Raising the Star Stone above her head, Glimmer drew down power from above in a blink of an eye, the rainbow beams that typically appeared as she charged her ability appearing as just a flash of light. She had come a long way in her training with the Star Stone, and the power came much faster now.

She pointed the staff in the direction of her assailant and blasted it with white-hot Starfire, completely disintegrating the robot until nothing was left but a black smear on the ground. Her heart sank as she directed her attention back to the battle before her. It appeared that the tide had turned, and it was not in their favor.

Two of Perfuma's plant golems were being torn to shreds by a mob of howling robots, while the third golem was being crushed by the very same worm-beast that it had tried to crush.

Frosta's armor had been completely smashed to bits leaving her with only her ice fists. She appeared utterly drained of power as she fought back to back with Linda II, who was now missing an arm. The two of them were surrounded by an encircling horde of monsters that were eagerly closing in on the two Princesses.

There was no sign of Spinnerella and Netossa; they were completely overrun by a new surge of mechanical monsters that were leaping out of the ice to reinforce their fellows.

He-Man/Shen and Battlecat seemed to be the only ones having any luck; Battlecat had just succeeded in ripping out the Alpha's ankle struts as He-Man/Shen bisected it with his silver sword. Glimmer saw him peer around at the battle taking place; resolve solidified on his broad handsome features.

Mounting Battlecat, He-Man/Shen rode into the greater mass of the enemies, raising his sword high over his head.

"FOR ETHERIA!!!" He screamed at the top of his lungs.

A crackling point of light appeared at the tip of his sword, its intensity slowly increasing the farther He-Man/Shen galloped. It made Glimmer think of the energy blast she saw Adora use, but instead of aiming the power at any particular enemy, He-Man/Shen kept the sword raised.

A white-hot sun sat on the tip of He-Man/Shen's sword as searing lightning lanced out in all directions, striking numerous enemies at once. The bolts that did not immediately land on targets buzzed and popped on the ground as if in search of victims, finally leaping onto nearby robots once it was within an acceptable range.

Every victim of the power He-Man/Shen wielded met its demise in its own unique way; some exploded into fiery sparks, while others simply melted. Some seemed to evaporate into mist, while others seemed just to disappear.

The storm of energy slowly traveled out from the epicenter that was He-Man/Shen's sword, dancing from robot to robot while completely missing any of He-Man/Shen's allies. When the power was finally spent, there was not a single one of Mermista's robot abominations left standing.

He-Man/Shen sagged in his saddle, also drained, and reverted to his normal form, as did his friend Battlecat. He slid down the green and orange alien's back to sit in a slump on the ground, Battlecat following suit as they flopped to the ground, lying on their side. They were both utterly spent.

Glimmer walked over to him, eyebrow raised, holding out a hand to help Shen to his feet.

"Wow, Shen, I've never seen She-Ra do anything like that. Where did you learn that?" She said in amazement.

Shen shrugged after he stood back up. "I dunno, I guess it was *The Power of Grayskull*, whatever that is. This is all still very new to me." He said as he leaned over to brush slushy ice off his pants.

This statement seemed to resonate with Glimmer; it appeared to be the basis for all their recent difficulties.

The Staves of Power, the Champions of Grayskull—we really don't know anything about all this magic power we all have. She thought as she watched Shen kneel to pat Battlecat*. I have a feeling the answer lies with Castle Grayskull.*

Linda II tromped up to Glimmer and Shen, the mech-suit now emitting sparks from its empty arm port and several deep gashes in its torso.

"What is the next plan, Queen Glimmer? Whatever it is, I don't think I can be a part of it; Linda II is operating at below fifty percent and no longer battle-ready. I'm sorry." Entrapta said, static accompanying her voice through the suit's external speakers.

“It’s okay, Entrapta. Stay here with Shen. The rest of the Princesses and I will face Mermista. We can handle her.” Glimmer said as she turned, beginning to stride towards Salineas.

Perfuma, Frosta, Spinnerella, and Netossa formed up behind her, and the Princesses approached the enemy kingdom to face a friend. All of them were hoping that now she was defeated, Mermista would come quietly, and judging by the fact that the Seagate was now down, this seemed likely.

Passing under the Seagate, the Princesses were met by silence and emptiness; not a single living person or robot was seen on the palace grounds, and the doors to the Mermista’s castle were left slightly ajar.

As the Princesses crept inside, they moved slowly, wary of any traps or ambushes, but in the end, they found none. They finally made it to the throne chamber doors. Using their powers to throw the doors open dramatically, the Princesses burst into Mermista’s throne room.

“PRINCESS MERMISTA! AS QUEEN OF ETHERIA, I ORDER YOU TO —” Glimmer began to shout but was cut off short as she saw what lay inside.

It was empty; there was no sign of Mermista on the throne or anywhere inside, just the sounds of flowing water from the waterfalls and her voice echoing off the walls.

“That is kinda anti-climactic, don’t-cha think?” Netossa said drolly.

“Where is she?! Where is Mermista?!” Perfuma said, a hint of hysteria in her voice. Glimmer realized that her friend Perfuma had a lot riding on the capture of Mermista, perhaps even convincing herself that the capture of the other Princess would somehow be the solution to Scorpia’s loss of empathy.

Glimmer laid a calming hand on Perfuma’s shoulder. “It’s okay, she must be here somewhere, we have to search the entire—”

The sound of running feet interrupted her, and Glimmer whirled around, her staff raised in defense as she saw Entrapta stumble into the chamber. She was completely out of breath and sagged over her knees, trying to speak.

"*Gasp...gasp...*Plumeria...*huh*...Mermista...*gasp*...*huh*...Scorpia!" Entrapta wheezed.

Glimmer's eyes widened in sudden realization. Summoning the power of the Star Stone, she teleported herself and all five of the other princesses—they disappeared in a sparkly haze.

* * *

01.2407.99

I had not been to Castle Grayskull since my training days, but it was the same dreary-looking place that I had remembered; only one thing had changed—there was a new Sorcerer, Zzar.

As the Keeper of Secrets, Zzar was not what I expected.

Her predecessor, Oeilla, was a stern older woman in heavy robes, and I had heard she passed away not long after I left. I was sad to hear this, for she was very kind to me, and I learned much from her.

Zzar was the complete opposite of Oeilla; she appeared as a young and beautiful human woman with sleek blond hair. She was dressed in a very sensual outfit; tight black pants with a matching black jacket that partially revealed her breasts. She also made some overt overtures to me in a romantic nature, seeming to know many details of the Nephraeh physiology, which made me blush. I politely declined her, of course.

There is something extraordinary about the jacket she wore; to the casual observer, it appeared as a simple waistcoat—very stylish looking—as if made of black feathers. But to my enhanced Nephraeh sight, it seemed to have magical energy—but it was a

reserved presence, as if the jacket itself had a consciousness and was hiding its true nature.

I have not experienced such a thing since being in the presence of the Eye of Hate, but I doubt it was any form of Abominable Power. The Keeper of Secrets would never use such terrible power.

Zzar welcomed me back to Castle Grayskull and after hearing my woes, seemed interested in helping me. She stated that she could not help me heal Jihan using the Life Gem; such things were beyond its power, but something at Castle Grayskull may help me. I was very interested in learning more.

I followed Zzar into the bowels of the Castle, down to the oubliettes where the Abominable Powers plus other mysteries lie. I vividly remember passing the oubliette where the Gastrolith of Decay was kept; the thick wooden door appeared heavily diseased and corrupted. It oozed with what appeared to be puss which collected in a puddle on the stone floor, and it smelled absolutely wretched.

We descended further into the catacombs, passing the oubliettes where the Black Knights of Karahed'Jihn were imprisoned and coming close to the boundaries of Subternia. Zzar finally stopped before one wooden door in what appeared to be an endless line of wooden doors. She opened it to reveal yet another oubliette containing a simple pedestal with a small box upon it.

Lifting the box from its stand, she offered it to me, stating it was called the Shlihm-bess'a-rune.

The Shlihm-bess'a-rune was a beautiful object constructed of several unknown metals and appeared to be manufactured, almost mechanical—like a puzzle box. In all my travels amongst the stars, I had never seen anything like it; I felt like I was holding something of great age and significance, there was a substantiveness to the Shlihm-bess'a-rune that I could not describe.

Zzar confirmed that the Shlihm-bess'a-rune was very old—from before the Dark Times. She said it was a form of ancient technology that could directly enhance the magic within the user to heights beyond reckoning. It was powered by the user and fueled by their greatest strength, their most positive attribute.

I could not believe what I was hearing. How could such a marvelous device be locked up in Castle Grayskull alongside horrors such as the Eye of Hate? Zzar did not have the answer to that. I only had her word as Sorcerer of Castle Grayskull that it was safe for what I intended to use it for. She then proceeded to give me careful instruction on properly channeling your power through the Shlihm-bess'a-rune.

Zzar said you had to hold the Shlihm-bess'a-rune in one hand, and with the other, trace the lines—

A knock sounded on the door to Glimmer's Observatory, interrupting her reading of Kishar's journal.

"Door is open," Glimmer called, turning to see Bow enter, a forlorn look on his face.

"Let me guess, the news on Scorpia and Mermista's location is not good." Glimmer said with a sigh.

Bow shook his head no.

Upon arriving in Plumeria after the Battle of Salineas, the Princesses found that Mermista had snuck into the undefended kingdom and freed Scorpia from her bonds. The two then escaped before anyone was the wiser; everyone had been frantically searching Etheria ever since, trying to find any sign of the rogue Princesses. It appeared that Bow had news of their whereabouts.

"Some traders out of the Spaceport in the Old Fright Zone verified that they saw both Scorpia and Mermista board a starship bound for Thenlor. From what we know of that planet, it is just one big city for them to get lost in. We could be searching for them forever!" Bow said hopelessly.

Glimmer stood and walked over to her husband, grasping both of his biceps in her hands gently while she gazed up into his brown eyes.

“Well, we should get started then.” She said meaningfully.

Sword and Tree

Chapter Summary

Adora warms up to Maira.

Plans are made as to what do about the Krypteia.

Catra finds herself alone with Veth.

"—Seventy-Nine! Eighty! Eighty-One! Eighty-Two! Eighty-Three! Eighty-Four!" Adora grunted as she proceeded to do one-arm push-ups on the floor of her cell. She had been at it for an hour now in a vain attempt to stem off the anxiety of being away from Catra.

It was the evening of the day after the attack on the Fareek Village. Almost twenty-four hours had passed since she had attacked Zhe-La/Veth and almost accidentally killed her wife. Maira had solemnly brought her bound before Aadhya to account for her actions, and as she recounted the events that led up to her attack on Zhe-La/Veth, she could see the increasing doubt grow in the older Madgēcot's eyes. That doubt turned to worry as Aadhya pronounced her judgment on Adora.

"I'm sorry, Adora. I can see the reason for you to have your suspicions, but the fact that the creatures that attacked the Fareek *may* have shared similar characteristics with the Nephraeh isn't justification for attacking Veth. Also, a gut feeling from She-Ra and a perceived look shared between you and Veth is not justification either." Aadhya said sternly.

This outright rejection of her reasons only strengthened Adora's resolve, causing the earlier doubt of her actions to fade away.

"I know we have just only recently met, Aadhya, but you have to trust me! Veth is up to something! Ask Maira, she was there! She

can tell you that the creatures looked exactly like a Nephraeh!" Adora said forcefully.

Aadhya turned to Maira, who gave Adora a hesitant look.

"Pratham, I can attest there may have been *some* similarities between the creatures and the Nephraeh...uh...they both had long pointy ears...and sharp teeth?" She said, ending her statement in a question. "But...I guess Madgēcots do as well, so…"

Adora made an exasperated sound, shaking her head with irritation at Maira.

"What do you want from me, Adora?!" Maira said incredulously. "I mean, those creatures were all black, slimy, and creepy. The Nephraeh are purple and attractive—a little cold—but definitely attractive. I'm having a hard time seeing the connection. I'm sorry." Maira finished with her ears lowered.

Adora let out a loud sigh and stared at the ground, defeated.

"So, what now?" She asked the two Madgēcots.

"I think it's best you stay here, at The Imaarat and under guard—for now," Aadhya said, not unkindly. "I am worried about you, Adora. You are bound to a Magical Avatar, which makes you powerful, but it also may make you more susceptible to supernatural influences. I want the Jaadoogar to have a chance to inspect you. Only they will know if you have been corrupted.

At the word *corrupted*, Adora instantly remembered being under the influence of the First One's rage virus, and the certainly of her cause evaporated.

What if she is right? What if there's something wrong with me? Maybe it's for the best to be locked up so I don't hurt someone, Adora thought as she nodded to Aadhya.

"I will abide by your commands, Pratham," Adora said tonelessly.

The Jaadoogar came not long after Adora had been placed in her cell, their arrival preceded by a chorus of small ringing sounds that echoed down the hall. The five Madgēcots that arrived outside her cell were unlike any other she had seen so far.

Unlike the Jaadoo suits Adora had seen so far, the strips that composed the Jaadoogar's suits were not just two colors but numerous ones. They did not follow any natural striping pattern either, looking almost like patchwork quilts or a jester's motley. Small bells were sewn into the places where strips of two different colors joined, making the ringing sound. Over their Jaadoo suits were hooded robes, much like the one Panga wore when they first met.

The hair of the Jaadoogar was braided into thick bundles, like dreadlocks, and piercings dotted their long ears, noses, and mouths. Jewelry was abundant on these Madgēcots in the form of amulets, charms, and rings—one even had three wooden bands on his tail, each one etched with runes.

Clutched in hands with elongated claws, the Jaadoogar carried wooden staves topped with various totems and skulls. They tapped the ends of their staves in concert as they halted before Adora's cell, peering through the bars at her with slitted white eyes that glowed with magical power.

"Uh, hey!" She said lamely. "You must be the Jaadoogar, huh?"

The Jaadoogar did not respond, only staring at her with twitching ears and tails. After a moment of this, they simply turned and left, the sounds of ringing bells and clinking staves accompanying them as they departed.

Maira showed up later with food and drink, informing Adora of the Jaadoogar's pronouncement.

"They said there is nothing wrong with you—well, nothing wrong magically, anyway. I mean, I've only known you for a day, and I can tell there is *something* wrong with you," Maira teased—but

then her ears drooped, and a sorrowful expression appeared on her face. “Sorry, too soon, huh? Panga always said I could be awkward sometimes.”

Adora shook her head at the female Madgēcot. “No, Maira, thank you. I appreciate you trying to lighten things up.” She said with a grin. “Anyway, it takes one to know one—*the awkward thing,* that is*!* Not the, you know, *something wrong with you thing*…”

Maira laughed brightly. “There you go, being charming again.” She said with a sly smile.

Adora blushed, eager to change the subject. “So, now that the Jaadoogar have cleared me, does that mean I can be released?” She said hopefully.

Maira shook her head. “No, I’m sorry. Aadhya wants you to stay here for the time being, at least until things can be smoothed over with the Nephraeh.”

So Adora had stayed in the cell, distracting herself with exercises and thinking over the events of the night before, letting them play over and over in her head. The more she thought it over, the more Adora felt that she was right—the attack on Veth might have been hasty—but she knew that was only because they were trying to influence her wife in some way.

When she was finally released from this cell, Adora promised herself she would play it cool and not make rash decisions. If Veth and the Nephraeh were still on Elysia, she would watch them closely; the only action she would take would be to present her findings to Aadhya once she gathered enough evidence.

In the meantime, Catra was on her mind; she had been informed that her wife would recover fully and was currently safe with her brother—but this did not ease her worry. Veth was also on the path to recovery, and once they were able, they would try to re-establish their influence on Catra.

Adora was now uncertain. Was this just her jealousy speaking? Was this something all Vow-bonded go through initially—constantly worrying about someone coming to sweep their wife off their feet and take her away? Veth was incredibly attractive and was also the bearer of Zhe-La; she never had to contend with a rival like them before. The only other Magical Champion she knew was Shen, and even though he was also in love with Catra, Adora never felt threatened by him.

Shen was a different story altogether; he was Adora's friend and would never do anything to hurt her. Besides, being a man made the possibility of Catra being attracted to him impossible—Veth on the other hand, was a different story. Shen was also one of the most empathetic people she knew—Veth was far from that, as they had the capacity for empathy taken from them.

Adora conceded that she might be jealous, but it was only for a good reason—someone was after her wife, using Catra's empathy and past trauma as a way to inveigle themselves with her. Adora had to get out of this cell—and soon.

As she began her sit-up routine, Adora could hear the tap-tapping of clawed feet approaching down the hall to her cell. Since she was the only one imprisoned here, she assumed Maira was coming to check up on her. She continued her sit-ups, her back towards the bars as she heard the door open.

"Hey, Maira…Fifty-One! You bring me...Fifty-Two! …something to eat?" She panted through crunches.

"I heard there was a Princess in here that needed rescuing," A familiar voice purred behind her.

"CATRA!!!" Adora cried, leaping to her feet and running to her wife.

"Hey, Ador—*aah*!" Catra yelped as Adora swept her up into a hug, kissing her cinnamon-colored face.

“Come on, Adora, we were only apart one night. Geez…” Catra said with a chuckle.

For a moment, uncertainty swelled in Adora’s chest, but then it was gone as she felt and heard the deep purr coming from Catra. Catra was just teasing her—as usual.

This was further verified as Catra gently held Adora’s face in her clawed hands and kissed her passionately, their tongues meeting in a caress. Adora went to put Catra back down, but her wife gently clung to her, not wanting to be parted so soon after reuniting. It seemed that Catra also had a rough time being away from her.

“Hey...what’s wrong?” Adora soothed as Catra wiped away at her eyes.

“Nothing, dummy. I just missed you, that's all.” Catra said as she tried and failed to sound annoyed. She ended up just giving Adora a wry smile, the love plain in her eyes.

“So, you thought I was Maira, eh? Has she been torturing you, Princess? Want me to kick her butt?” Catra said, exposing a single upper fang.

Adora laughed as she shook her head. “*Nooo,* Catra...Maira is actually not bad once you get to know her. She has been making sure I was alright in my cell, bringing me food, and keeping me company. You should thank her for taking such good care of your wife.”

A sudden hooded gaze appeared on Catra's face as her tail thrashed behind her—Adora could feel the bare hints of Catra’s claws through the clothes she wore.

“Taking care of you, eh? She’d better stay away from you, or I *will* thank her, and not in a way she would like.” Catra growled.

Huh, she’s jealous. Good. Adora thought to herself as she smirked at Catra.

"Oh, don't worry about it, Catra. I didn't flirt back with her when she flirted with me. Honest." Adora said offhandedly.

"WHAT!?" Catra screeched, her eyes wide and teeth bared. "*I'm gonna kill her!* Here I was, worried sick about you, and you've been here, getting flirted on by another woman! I can't believe it!"

Adora couldn't help laughing. "Wow! You are such a jealous thing, aren't you? Who would've thunk." She said, running her hands through Catra's long, stone-gray hair.

Catra gave her a measured look; there was a hunger in her eyes. "Yeah, so what? I am jealous. I don't like to think of another woman near you, especially a jerk like Maira. I guess I'm going to have to remind you of why you took the Vow with me, and soon," she said wickedly.

Adora laid a finger on Catra's soft lips; it was a promise—for later. Catra closed her eyes as she enjoyed Adora's touch, purring softly.

"I agree, Catra. But right now, why don't you tell me what's going on? Are you breaking me out? I don't think that's a good idea if you are." Adora said softly.

The smile on Catra's face turned into a confused look as she opened her eyes back up, her heterochromatic eyes unfocused.

"Huh? Wah? No!" She said, almost sleepily. "It's a long story, but Veth confessed to deceiving us; they told Viraj and me everything! We had them confess directly to Aadhya, and she said you were to be released immediately!" Catra said, suddenly excited.

Adora felt confused. "Wait, what were you doing with Veth?"

Catra looked at her again, head tilted in confusion. "I went to see them; I wanted to get to the bottom of what happened at the Fareek Village. It turns out it was one of my better ideas. Why?"

Adora pursed her lips and shook her head. "Oh, nothing. So, what did Veth say, exactly?"

Catra went into the details of Veth's story, from the true nature of the Nephraeh's affliction to the real reason the Nephraeh came to Elysia, and finally, what really happened at the Fareek Village. How it was a trap to ensnare Adora and corrupt her, turning her into a creature devoid of empathy and susceptible to the ways of the Empyreans.

"I *knew* I was right! I *knew* Veth was behind this whole thing!" Adora said through clenched teeth. She had released Catra and held her hands down at her sides; they were clenched into fists.

Catra shook her head. "No, Adora, it wasn't Veth or this Archon Lethe—it's Horde Prime! He is behind everything! Veth is just a victim. So are all the Nephraeh. We can't think of Veth as the enemy, but someone who needs our help," Catra said imploringly.

Adora studied her wife; Catra seemed utterly convinced of herself, and if what she said was true, then Veth and the Nephraeh were not the enemies. They were just lost people and needed someone's help to find their way back.

I'm not entirely convinced, but I don't want to upset Catra and make a mess of things again. I have to play this cool, Adora thought as she laid a hand on Catra's shoulder.

"Can I see them? Can I see Veth?" Adora asked neutrally.

Catra nodded emphatically. "Yeah, they are here at The Imaarat, along with Aadhya, Viraj, and some other big-shot Madgēcots. We will discuss what to do about the Krypteia since they won't take Veth's defection very well. Veth asked made us promise not to kill them but to capture them,"

Now it was Adora's turn to look confused. "If Veth has no empathy, why would they care about us hurting their people?"

Catra shrugged. "I don't know, Veth has this sense of honor and an extreme overachiever complex—like someone *else* I know," Catra said with a smirk. "I think letting their people die would make them feel like a failure."

“Huh, okay,” Adora said, unconvinced.

Catra caught the tone in Adora’s voice. “What? You don’t believe me?” She said with a bit of annoyance.

“I believe you, Catra. It’s just that I don’t trust Veth,” she said, giving up on the ‘playing it cool’ approach.

Catra looked at her incredulously. “And you think I do?”

Adora sighed. “I mean, I don’t trust *anything* they say. This new story of theirs is just too convenient. It explains away all the current discrepancies while still maintaining them as victims. I don’t like it, Catra.”

“Well, *I* believe that part of their story, Adora. I know first-hand how horrible Horde Prime was, and I know what it’s like to be on the wrong path—I want to be the person to help someone else find their way. I *need* to do it for my own sake. Can’t you just trust me, Adora?” She said, almost pleadingly.

Adora sighed again, more heavily their time. “Of course, I trust you, Catra, it’s just—” She said, stopping herself before she could finish her sentence.

It's just that I think you are being manipulated by your past trauma and empathy, Adora finished mentally as she looked into Catra’s eyes.

“It’s just me being me, Catra. You know—‘Miss Hard-headed,’” Adora said with a chuckle while giving her head a few knocks with her knuckles.

Catra looked at her suspiciously, then nodded with a smile. “That’s why I love you, Princess. You ready to go?”

“Surrree arrre…” Adora said with forced enthusiasm as she followed Catra out of the cell.

Climbing the stairs out of the dungeon, Adora found herself back in the vast main chamber of the Imaarat; it was empty now except for two Star Hunters standing guard at the entrance of the fortress. Catra led Adora to a flight of stairs leading up to the first tier of the massive wooden structure that resided with the stone building that was the Imaarat.

They passed over a walkway and up a ladder, finally reaching one of the openings and entering. At the end of a long wooden hall was a room, and inside were Veth, Viraj, Maira, and Aadhya, along with a few other Madgēcots Adora recognized as the Council Elders. It appeared as if they were in someone's office or study—various trophies, books, and other esoteric items filling the space.

"Adora! Glad to see you out of your cell!" Aadhya called, arms held wide. "Welcome to my personal chambers."

"Thank you, Aadhya," Adora said, accepting the hug awkwardly. "It wasn't *your* fault I was sent there anyway." She said, giving Veth a nasty look. The Nephraeh had the good grace not to meet her gaze, and they stared down at the floor.

"Yes, about that. It seems we are in the uncomfortable position of asking for your help after we imprisoned you," one of the Council Elders said with a sheepish smile.

Adora waved this away. "All is forgiven. I will admit I reacted hastily in attacking Veth. You were in your right to lock me up—it gave me a chance to cool down."

"And?" Catra said to her, eyebrows raised in expectation.

Adora looked at her wife incredulously, then turned to Veth.

"I'm sorry, Veth. I'm sorry I attacked you. I should have found another way other than violence," Adora said with genuine sorrow.

Veth shrugged. "I deserved it. I'm just glad that you were not punished too harshly and that we are on the same side now. I am sorry as well."

Adora shook her head. “Just because I am sorry for hurting you and that I’m going to help the Madgēcots capture your comrades does not mean we are on the same side, Veth. I still don’t trust you,” she said coldly.

“Adora!!!” Catra shouted.

“No, it’s okay, Catra,” Veth said, holding up their hands to forestall more of Catra’s protests. “I deserved the mistrust; I really do. How can Adora trust me after what I tried to do?”

Veth suddenly gasped, holding their chest with one hand as they bent over in pain.

“Are you okay, Veth? Is it your wound? I can call Sanket, and he can apply more healing cantrips if you need.” Aadhya said as she placed a black-spotted hand on their shoulder, concern evident on her features.

Veth stood back up, waving her concern away with one hand. “No, no, it’s fine, really. It just pains me now and again. We need to discuss what to do about the Krypteia. We must capture them before they can escape and cause us grief.”

Adora crossed her arms, gazing at Veth evenly. “So, fill me in. What are we up against with these Krypteia? What are their capabilities? All I know is that they are assassins.”

“I would like to know that too,” Aadhya said, looking expectantly at Veth. “I have crossed paths with the Krypteia many times, and I still don’t feel like I know what they are capable of.”

Veth looked unfocused for a moment, then they nodded, running their hand through their long black hair.

“Yes, they can be called assassins, for that is one of their many functions. But they are more than that, second only to myself; they are Archon Lethe’s finest warriors. They are an exemplification of the Archon’s will, and they are directly imbued with some of Archon Lethe’s power.”

“And what power is that, exactly?” One of the Elders asked.

Veth looked at the speaker, giving them a strange look. “I am not completely certain, and Archon Lethe has never confided with us the true nature of their power, only calling it Oblivion. I would assume that is just a name they have for magic, much like the Madgēcots with the word ‘Jaadoo.’”

“*Oblivion,*” Adora said aloud. “Sounds kind of ominous, Veth. Does this also have something to do with Horde Prime? I can’t imagine it does, Horde Prime hated magic, and it was his greatest weakness.”

Veth shook their head, seeming confused. “I’m sorry, I’m missing your meaning, and I think you misunderstood. I never said Archon Lethe’s power had anything to do with the ailment that affects the Nephraeh; it’s their own power that they have always had for millennia.”

“Yes, let’s stay on topic, Adora,” Aadhya said, a little sternly.

Adora looked to Catra for support, but her wife only shook her head in annoyance at her. Adora gave a resigned sigh and waved for Veth to continue.

“Sorry, I get sidetracked easily,” Adora said with a weak smile. “So, what does the power of *Oblivion* allow the Krypteia to do?”

Veth nodded, continuing their explanation. “Well, there are many abilities, but I will focus on the ones that will give us the greatest difficulty. The Krypteia can render themselves *unseen,* and if they do manage to escape us, this will become a great problem.”

“Like invisibility?” Catra said with her head tilted. “Someone once tried to use invisibility to sneak into our bedroom and kill Adora. I saw right through it and kicked his butt.”

Aadhya smiled at this. “Yes, Madgēcot senses are second to none; no invisibility will work on us. What happened to this poor fool who tried to kill She-Ra with a Madgēcot to look over her?”

Catra pursed her lips. “Oh...he became He-Man, then one of my best friends.” She said offhandedly while the rest of the Madgēcots looked at her with curious tilted heads.

“I think you misunderstand my words,” Veth said, interjecting. “I did not say they can become invisible, but they are *unseen*. They have the power to make you not see them, to forget you have seen them. This has been used to sneak by many a Madgēcot in the past.”

The Madgēcots shared worried glances as their tails twitched in unison.

“So now you can understand my fears in letting them escape.” Veth said meaningfully.

“That is good to know, Veth. What else can the Krypteia do with the power of *Oblivion*?” Adora said, purposely emphasizing the last word.

Veth did not miss her intent; there was a twinkle in their silver eyes as they met Adora’s gaze—she could have sworn she saw amusement on their lilac face and a faint smile on their lips.

“Yes, Adora, I was just getting to that. They can also use the power given to them by Archon Lethe to make the affliction that all Nephraeh are cursed with into a weapon. They can direct it towards an opponent to drain them of their will, thus allowing them the advantage in a fight.”

“Like a life drain?” One of the Elders asked.

Veth tilted their head and pursed their lips. “No, it has nothing to do with the taking of life energy, more of a removing of someone’s empathy. For someone who has lots of it in the first place, the sudden removal of that emotion can be demoralizing.”

Adora abruptly interrupted. “That was what you used on me! During our fight! You did the same thing to me. that was how you were able to disarm me!” She said, now angry.

Veth let out a loud sigh. “Yes, that is right. I used that power on you during our fight, and I am sorry for it.” They said with genuine regret expressed on their attractive face.

This did not appease Adora. “So that means *you* have this *Oblivion* power too, am I right? You have whatever this dark power is—on top of being Zhe-La! Again, you’re not being honest with us!” She said, getting even more animated.

“Adora, I never said I did or didn’t have any additional powers; no one has asked me, and it's never come up!” Veth responded, visibly upset by Adora’s accusation. “Also, why is the power of Lethe being called *dark*? It is magic and neither good nor evil—it just is.”

Adora knew this to be utter nonsense. Magic could be evil; the power of the Set’Heth-un’dar and the Dark He-Man was evil—it was based on Death and misery. Whatever this Oblivion power Veth was neck-deep in sounded like it was in the same vein as that.

Something else bothered Adora; if Veth had the power of Zhe-La and this Oblivion, how had she defeated them in battle? She had sparred with He-Man/Shen as She-Ra and knew neither was stronger, nor weaker than the other. So, any advantage would tip the scales, making Veth as Zhe-La the stronger. It didn’t add up.

Before she could voice any other objections, Aadhya stepped between them, holding her hands up.

“Please, let’s keep this discussion civil. Adora, I would please ask you to keep any accusations to yourself for now. Whether or not Veth is telling the truth, they are helping us capture a small force of Nephraeh who could be dangerous to us. I think we should concentrate on that.” Aadhya said civilly.

Maira stepped forward. “Pratham, with all due respect, we should listen to Adora,” She said assertively. “Adora had seen through

Veth's previous deception and tried to warn us, but we locked her up for it. I think we owe her."

Adora beamed thankfully at Maira—the one person there who seemed to want to take her side. She could practically feel the annoyance and jealousy pouring off of Catra next to her but chose to ignore it.

"Okay, Maira, I agree." Aadhya conceded. "So, Adora, what do you think we should do now?"

Adora was instantly wrong-footed, not expecting everyone to want to listen to her all of the sudden. She ended up gazing at Veth—into their silver eyes—and in them, she saw no animosity towards her, only resignation.

"I want to hear what Veth thinks we should do." she said simply.

There was genuine surprise on Veth's face at Adora's pronouncement, and they nodded to her.

"The Krypteia are due to perform the Penumbra ritual—it's a symbolic rite everyone within Archon Lethe's inner circle must do to declare themselves worthy of The Light. They will gather in the early morning to do this, and once finished, they will be sequestered in their own rooms and be vulnerable. During the Penumbra Ritual, each Krypteia will have no weapons and will not wear their Aegis Lace suits."

"Excuse me, their what?" Viraj said, tilting his head in confusion.

Veth patted their hip in explanation, and Viraj saw the weave of their pants tightening at their touch—once Veth stopped patting themselves, the weave became more loose and supple. They gave Viraj a meaningful wink once he looked back at their face, and he gave a small gulp as he blushed.

"So basically, we have to catch the Krypteia with their pants down—literally," Catra said slyly. "I think I might like this mission."

Adora did not miss the grin Veth gave Catra at her words, but she suppressed her anger and jealousy.

"I don't know, isn't that kind of...I don't know...a cheap shot and dishonorable?" Maira said uncertainly. "I mean, I'm all for capturing them without killing them, but they deserve to retain some modesty."

Veth laughed at this, loud and bright. "I think you misunderstood me!" They said, still chuckling. "They will not be nude, just out of their armor. They will be wearing undergarments, you know, like I was wearing when you showed up to my quarters the other day, Catra."

Adora's eyes widened at this, and she immediately looked at Catra; her wife's eyes were also wide with a rictus smile plastered on her face—she was also sweating.

"*Huh, you didn't mention that part, Catra,*" Adora growled at her wife.

Catra laughed nervously. "Uh, well, Viraj was there too! Weren't you, bro?"

Viraj nodded vigorously. "Yep. I definitely was."

Aadhya shook her head in annoyance. "This is all irrelevant!" She said as she made a curt gesture, indicating Adora, Catra, and Viraj be silent. "So, from what Veth is saying, we should wait until they are in the middle of this ritual when they will all be gathered together. During this time, we insert an ambush team in each room to take each Krypteia by force. Is that correct, Veth?"

Veth nodded. "Yes, they will gather in Nefeli's room—they are the leader of the Krypteia. Since no one will be able to enter Nefeli's room and surprise them, I suggest myself and She-Ra take them ourselves. I'm sure the two of us can take someone as fierce as Nefeli without harm coming to anyone."

Adora was not sure if she liked the idea of being alone with someone powerful as Veth and as deadly as this Nefeli sounded, but she did like having Veth separated away from Catra. She also relished the idea of them trying to betray her; she could finally expose them for the liar they truly were.

Veth winced and bent over, holding their wounded chest. When they lifted their torso straight, they gently hugged themselves with their eyes closed, looking very weak.

“I’m sorry, but I think that is enough for me; I need to go and rest.” They said to everyone with a sorrowful smile. “I think it's best if I go back to my quarters so we don’t raise any suspicion.”

Aadhya nodded in understanding. “Okay, Veth, will you be okay to get back by yourself?

Veth nodded and then winced again, letting out a slight pained sound.

“Actually, my wound seems to be really acting up.” They said with a grimace. “Catra, is there any chance you could see me back?”

Catra instantly perked up. “Yeah, of course, Veth,” she said, concern plastered on her features.

“Yeah, I think I will help you too,” Adora stated with much less concern for Veth.

Aadhya shook her head. “No, Adora, we need you here to help plan this whole thing. According to all those stories you told me the other night, we will need your tactical ability. One Madgēcot is strong enough to make sure Veth gets home safe.”

Adora silently kicked herself and nodded.

“Okay.” She said, defeated, watching Catra and Veth leave together.

Before they exited the door, Veth glanced at Adora, giving her an unreadable look—there was no hint of triumph or sly intentions.

But Adora took no comfort in that.

* * *

The journey back to Veth's quarters was uneventful; Catra and Veth took a standard Madgēcot flyer from The Imaarat back to the guest housing they both shared. The trip was spent in silence, but Catra was happy to see that Veth seemed to be recovering from the flare-up of pain from their injury. She watched them intently as they had gazed out of the viewport, and whenever they appeared as if they would look in her direction, she would quickly divert her eyes.

It wasn't long until they were striding down the long hallway past the ten doors of the Krypteia. Just as before, all ten doors opened in unison. Catra's heartbeat picked up as all of the Krypteia that had accompanied Veth to this planet stepped out, fully garbed in their suits of Aegis Lace.

"Champion Veth," The one Catra recognized as Nefeli said. "Where have you been? We were concerned that something had befallen you."

"At ease, Nefeli, it is alright," Veth said as they held their hands up in placation. "With all that had transpired recently, I figured we would be leaving soon. I saw an opportunity to enjoy what Elysia has to offer before we are again at odds with our old allies. Catra was so kind as to accompany me to dinner, and now we are going to...*retire* to my quarters for the evening."

Heat blazed across Catra's face at Veth's insinuation, and she felt anger blossom in her chest when she heard the Krypteia chuckle. All of them turned back into their rooms except Nefeli, who nodded to Veth.

"Have a good evening, *Champion Veth,*" they said before turning into their room and closing the door.

The fury continued to boil inside Catra as she followed Veth into their room, finally coming out in a snarl as Veth closed the door behind them.

"Was that *really* necessary?" Catra said, hands in the air.

Confusion clouded Veth's face at her apparent anger, and they froze, unsure as to whether it was a good idea to be alone with an angry Madgēcot.

"I'm sorry, what did I do?" They said in honest bewilderment.

"That whole thing you said—*we are going to retire to my quarters.*" She said in a mockery of their androgynous voice. "I mean, I know we are trying to maintain this deception, but did it have to be at my expense?"

Veth sighed and nodded in resignation. "Yes, I am sorry. I forget how conservative binary sexes can be when it comes to anything sexual in nature. Forgive me."

Catra's face scrunched up. "Did you just call me *conservative*?"

Veth only shrugged, further annoying her.

The anger turned to suspicion as Catra watched Veth walk over to their bed, removing their waistcoat to reveal a tight-fitting silver tank top. Their arms were exposed now, and Catra could see more white markings on their shoulders, as well as supple muscles in their arms and back. At any other time, this might have aroused her, but now the suspicion had overcome her desire.

"I'm not a dummy, Veth," Catra said, crossing her arms. "Why did you ask me to accompany you to your room? I watched you all the way here. You didn't need any help. Do you really think you could lure me here and seduce me by revealing a little skin?"

Veth glanced at her as they folded their coat to place it on the bed, their eyes glittering with mirth.

“Are we still talking about that?” They said with a laugh as they reached back for the coat. “Catra, this jacket is very tight, and it was aggravating my injuries; I couldn’t *wait* to get it off. But if seeing my bare arms makes you uncomfortable, I can put it back on.”

Catra now felt very foolish. “No, sorry...I’m sorry, I’m being stupid. Leave it off. I’m fine.” She said, smiling sheepishly.

Veth shrugged, tossing the coat onto the bed, and turned fully towards her.

“You were right about me luring you here, though,” they said meaningfully.

Catra suddenly froze and willed her tail not to bush up—cursing it silently when it did.

Veth strode over to her, their face intent as a predator’s as their eyes caught the distress evident in her body language. They stopped, standing so close to her now that she could smell the faint musk of their body—it was indescribable. She had never smelled anything like it, but the feelings of sensuality it summoned were unmistakable.

Catra gazed up at them, utterly unsure of herself and torn between the desire to stay or to flee—as fast as she could run. Her heart hammered in her chest as her body struggled to process the intentions of her brain, and it took all her strength to speak.

“Wha—what did you say?” She stammered.

Veth reached for her hand, grasping it in theirs. Catra did not pull her hand back.

“I’m sorry, but yes, I didn’t need your help. It was another lie. But you will have to forgive me, for I needed to speak to you alone.” Veth said with a sad smile.

“Uh, okay,” Catra said dumbly.

“You see, Catra, by helping you, I’m betraying my people. I am a traitor to them and will forever be forsaken.” They said, looking down at their clasped hands with a look of despair. “I am now with your people—who at best don’t trust me, or at worst completely despise me—like your wife, Adora.”

Catra shook her head vehemently. “Adora doesn’t—” Catra started to say, but Veth placed a lilac finger on her soft cinnamon lips to silence her.

“It’s okay, don’t deny it. I don’t blame her either.” They soothed. “I deserve it, but it places me in a very lonely position. I may not feel empathy, but loneliness is still known to me—*isn’t that the real curse?* The nature of the Nephraeh’s sickness pushes people away, driving us further into our despair.”

Catra saw a great weariness in Veth now; they seemed so beautiful and brittle at that moment—it made her want to touch them, to break through their prison of misery. She stopped herself from doing this, though, too afraid to break the fragile state between them; it was as if Veth was genuinely opening up to her, and she didn’t want to break the spell of that truth.

“So, what do you want from me, Veth?” She asked tentatively.

Veth reached out, clasping her other hand in theirs, gazing into her heterochromatic eyes with their pure shining silver ones.

“Catra, if we fail and the Krypteia escape, they will never leave until they have recaptured me—or killed me. Even though the latter sounds like it may be better for the Elysians, it isn’t. By killing me, they will release Zhe-La from their bond to me, allowing the power to return to Empyrea to be placed within another bearer. We cannot allow either to happen! Archon Lethe must not get the power of Zhe-La back under their control!”

“Come back with us to Etheria, Veth!” Catra exclaimed excitedly. “She-Ra, He-Man and—I can’t believe I’m saying this—the

Princesses are there; they will protect you!”

Veth shook their head. “No, Catra. Believe me, I wouldn’t make it off this planet. There would only be one option.”

Catra felt dread in anticipation of what Veth would say next.

“And what is that Veth?” She whispered.

Veth turned from her, walking over to a gold cloth-wrapped bundle lying next to the bed. They withdrew the sword of Sher-Va from within it, holding it up to the light to inspect it.

“The only way to destroy a Champion’s Avatar is by using two magical sources—like a hammer and an anvil. We would need to go to The Great Chaliendra Tree—there in my Zhe-La form, I will need you to take this sword,” they said, holding the sword of Sher-Va to Catra, “and pierce my heart, here,” they said, indicating the center of their chest. “while I stand against the tree. That will destroy Zhe-La.”

Catra’s eyes widened, and her ears lowered as she gaped in horror.

“NO!!!” She shrieked, pushing the sword away from herself.

“Catra, you *must* do this! I do not think I can do this myself. It must be you. You’re the only one I trust!” Veth pleaded.

Catra shook her head violently and then grabbed Veth firmly by their upper arms, her claws digging into their flesh, making them wince.

“You *will not* do that, Veth! I won’t allow it! *You idiot!*” She practically screamed in their face.

“Catra, listen—” Veth began to say but stopped when Catra shook them violently.

"NO. *You* listen." She said, baring her teeth at them. "I had a friend who tried to sacrifice himself based on some stupid idea, and you know what I did to him? I tracked him down in the woods, kicked his butt, and dragged him back to lock him up for his own good. I will do the same thing to you!"

Now it was Veth's turn to stare at her wide-eyed and dumbfounded.

"I think I believe it." they whispered to her.

Catra gave them a curt nod. "So, this is what is going to happen: we are going to go through with this plan to capture the Krypteia. With Adora and the Madgēcots helping, it's likely to succeed, but if it doesn't, we will develop a new plan. You will *absolutely not* sacrifice yourself, do you understand?"

Veth nodded slowly, then let out a relieved sigh as they seemed to put down a great burden they had been carrying.

"Is this what having a friend is like?" Veth asked with a grateful smile.

Catra shook her head and pointed a clawed thumb at her chest.

"No, this is what having a friend like *me* is like," she said with a cocky grin.

Siphon

Chapter Summary

Adora confronts Catra regarding Veth.

Adora finds out what it truely means to lose love.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The halls of the Guest House echoed with the sound of Adora's crisp footsteps as she walked briskly down the corridor. She was headed in the direction of the guest room she shared with Catra, on her way back from the strategy meeting with Aadhya and Maira—which had taken longer than Adora would have wished. The two Madgēcot women wanted to go over every part of their plan to ambush the Krypteia in minute detail over and over again, while Adora only wanted to get back to the guest house to be with Catra.

Stopping near a stairway leading to different floors, Adora hesitated. She gazed up the flight of stairs which led to the upper floors—where the Nephraeh stayed—and had to stop herself from proceeding up them.

Catra is not up there; she is waiting for you in your room, stupid, Adora thought with an angry shake of her head. *It's been an hour since she left with Veth, plenty of time for her to get them safely back to their room and...*

Her mind finished that train of thought in several different directions, most of them ending in scenarios that made her inwardly cringe. She turned from the stairs and continued towards her room, walking faster now, almost a jog.

"Door, open!" Adora shouted as she practically stumbled into the guest room. After looking frantically about, she let out an audible

sigh of relief when she spotted Catra lying on their bed. Her wife was on her stomach reading a Madgēcot book; Catra looked up with surprise to see Adora in such an agitated state.

"Adora!" She said, sitting up with a concerned look on her face. "What's wrong?"

Adora smiled sheepishly, suddenly feeling foolish and guilty that she would ever doubt Catra's faithfulness to her. She tried to laugh off the question, but it sounded forced, and she knew Catra's keen hearing would pick up on that fact.

"I was just…umm...caught up in thinking about the strategy for tomorrow morning, that's all," she said as Catra padded towards her, worry still plainly written on her features. Catra placed a comforting hand gently on the side of Adora's cheek and gazed into her eyes.

"That's not true, you love talking about strategy—it makes you all dorky and happy. No…" She said, shaking her head. "Were you worried about me?" She said incredulously.

"Puh! No!" Adora blurted out, but after seeing Catra wasn't convinced, sighed and looked down. "Yeah...I was…" She said in resignation.

Catra laughed. "About what dummy? You did such a number on Veth with your big magical sword that I don't think they were in any shape to do anything to me," she said, studying her wife's face. "What were you worried about them doing?"

There was something about how Catra said, `*you did such a number on Veth with your big magical sword'* that Adora didn't like. It almost sounded accusatory, but she pushed it out of her mind, chalking it up to misinterpretation on her part.

Adora waved Catra's question away. "I don't know, Catra, I'm just on edge, is all. I mean those things that attacked us last night really creeped me out."

This seemed to satisfy Catra, and she wrapped her arms around Adora, starting to purr. Adora enjoyed the feeling of being with her wife once again and returned the hug, kissing Catra's forehead.

"So, how did it go with Veth? Any new revelations or hidden secrets they suddenly wanted to share?" Adora said with a hint of scorn.

Catra caught her tone and pulled back slightly, looking at Adora's face with a measured expression.

"You really don't like them, do you?" Catra asked neutrally.

Adora shrugged. "Can you blame me? Just the other day they were setting me up for who knows what. I feel like since whatever they tried to do to me failed, they are changing things up just enough so they can try again. You know?"

Catra gently held the sides of Adora's head and gazed into her eyes. Adora loved it when Catra did that; her heterochromatic eyes were so large and beautiful, and Adora always felt as if she could sink right into them.

"You know I would never let that happen, right?" Catra said meaningfully.

Adora let out another sigh and nodded. "I know you would never knowingly let anything happen to me, Catra. It's just—ugh, I don't know."

Catra placed her hands on Adora's shoulders and started to give them gentle messages, alternating the pressure applied there. Catra had always done this for Adora, ever since they were little. It began when they first started sharing a bed; Adora would wake up, and Catra would be kneading her stomach and purring. It was such a comforting thing that Catra did, and Adora had missed it intensely during the long years they fought against each other.

Catra worked her way up Adora’s neck, rubbing the stiff muscles there, and finally made her way up behind Adora’s ears, pressing the pressure points gently. Adora could feel the tips of Catra’s claws gently tickling the soft skin behind her earlobe, and she enjoyed the sensation immensely. She closed her eyes and sighed heavily in Catra’s hands, opening them back up when she felt her wife return her hands to her shoulders and give them a gentle squeeze. Catra smiled kindly at her, her blue and yellow eyes hooded and warm.

"Feel better, dummy?” Catra said with a chuckle. “Why don't you just fill me in on what the big strategy is?”

Adora looked at Catra sleepily. “Huh? Strategy?” She said dumbly.

Catra gave her an exasperated look. “*You know*, where you’ve been the last hour or so? With Viraj, Aadhya, and jerk-face Maira? I really didn't like having to leave you back there with dumb Maira and her dumb flirting. I could totally tell that she digs you now!" Catra said a little huffily.

"How could you tell? Is it some scent thing?" Adora said with a frown.

Catra placed a finger on her lips and looked up absently in contemplation.

"I dunno, it's hard to explain; I can just read it on her—the way her tail moves, her ears tilt, the expressions on her stupid face. It's a Madgēcot thing," Catra said with a shrug. "Anyway, enough about Maira, TELL ME THE PLAN!"

Adora chuckled at her wife's antics before going into the plan; she really enjoyed that Catra was jealous of Maira.

"Veth said they do this ritual thing of theirs in the morning. That’s when we will do it. The Krypteia will all be gathered in their leader's room—this Nefeli—and while they are there, nine teams of five Star Hunters will sneak into their rooms and wait for them."

"While they are doing that, Veth and I will climb up the outside of the building as She-Ra and Zhe-La. In our magical forms, we can easily create handholds in the wood of the Guest House and reach the window outside Nefeli's room. The Madgēcots have this gizmo that will let us see the Krypteia inside by viewing their energy signature."

"Once they leave the room, we will be able to see when they enter their rooms, and the Star Hunters will seize them. That's when we bust through the window and grab Nefeli." Adora finished with a reluctant look on her face. "I really wish Veth didn't leave so early and was able to fill us in a little more on the Krypteia's capabilities. Veth had an interesting way of leaving before they could tell us any more about them. I found that kind of odd."

Adora caught a strange look pass over Catra's face at the mention of Veth's departure from the meeting—it was almost as if Catra knew that Adora's suspicions were justified. It made her feel strangely ill.

"Maybe I should go see Veth now," Adora said thoughtfully. "I mean, I should let them know the details of the plan, especially if they have an injury that could start aggravating them in the middle of a fight."

Catra shook her head, now adamant. "No, I think you should just leave them for the night, Adora. They seemed to be okay on the way back to the room, and when I left them they just seemed a little stressed out about what they were doing. You know, betraying their people and all…" Catra said with a lame chuckle. "Anyway, they were the ones who suggested that you two take this Nefeli character by yourselves. They wouldn't have said it if they weren't ready."

Adora looked at Catra suspiciously; her wife was hiding something, she could tell. Hiding something about Veth.

"Why are you so defensive of them? Why are you defending this complete stranger who tried to set me up just the other night? What's going on, Catra?" Adora said, trying and failing to hide her accusatory tone.

With mouth agape, Catra looked as if Adora had just struck her.

"What the heck are you talking about, Adora?" Catra said incredulously. "Where is this coming from all of a sudden, and what are you accusing me of?"

Adora shook her head, now mad. "I don't know, Catra, I just can't shake this feeling like something is going on—like Veth is up to something. I see the way they look at you, and they are a little too friendly with you—I don't like it."

Catra let out a bark of laughter at this. "*Really? That's* what this is about? You're jealous that Veth is going to steal me away from you? Come on, Princess!" She teased.

Catra's laughter did not put Adora at ease—it came off as mocking and drove her to even greater heights of anger.

"Don't play dumb with me, Catra. You know what I'm talking about," Adora said with a hint of scorn. "I openly admitted that Maira flirted with me because it meant nothing to me. I *know* Veth has been doing the same with you—I see it. How come you won't admit it openly to me?"

Catra only stared back at Adora dumbfounded, silently shaking her head.

"Is it because you enjoy it, Catra?" Adora said, almost whispering.

Catra exploded.

"HOW DARE YOU!!!" She screeched, baring her teeth at Adora. "How can you accuse me of that? *Yes,* Veth is very attractive. WOW, I admitted it. So, what? Does that mean I would automatically run off with them? NO, YOU IDIOT!"

"So why don't you admit that if it's not a big deal?!? Adora shouted back, hands raised.

Catra made a disgusted face. "What? Do I have to come running to you every time someone attractive takes an interest in me? *Get real!"*

Catra abruptly turned from Adora and hugged herself, her tail twitching rapidly in agitation. Letting out a hiss, Catra turned back towards her wife; there was hurt written on her face and tears in her eyes.

"You know, Adora, I thought you would understand," Catra said, crying. "I mean, you grew up with me; you were my friend, my enemy, and then my lover. How can you not see?"

Catra's tears did not move Adora, and she shook her head in irritation.

"See what, Catra?" She said, exasperated. Catra just gaped at her as if it was the most obvious answer in the world, and Adora was an obsolete idiot for not seeing it.

"Veth is so much like I was for so much of my life—LOST. *So lost."* She said, hugging herself again. "I can see it in the way they act and what they say, and I empathize with them, Adora. Because of what I went through, I feel like it puts me in a position to help them somehow—help them find the right...*way.* Do you know? I feel like I did that with Shen somehow. By helping him, I was also helping myself find the right way."

Adora softened and walked over to Catra, placing her hand gently on Catra's arm.



"That is one of the many things I love about you, Catra—your big heart. You keep so much love buried within you that I'm surprised you haven't burst yet. I love that you want to help people because I want to do the same—like I did when I helped you and Shen. You both deserved a chance at redemption, and I fought hard to see you both get it." She said kindly, stroking a hand against one of Catra's long ears.

Catra closed her eyes in pleasure, enjoying Adora's touch, and slowly moved towards her, eager to press her body into her wife's.

"I was thrilled when I saw you open up to Shen and then become friends with him, Catra. You both shared such a tragic past that it was easy to bond with him and your empathy led you on the right path. When I saw you reach out to help him, I was overjoyed! Shen was someone who absolutely deserved another shot, and you were right to help him. Your empathy led you on the right path." Adora continued as she reached out to hold Catra.

"But this time Catra, you're wrong."

Catra, who was about to embrace her wife, hissed in anger and pushed Adora away.

"Who do you think you are, Adora? What, because you have She-Ra, you think that gives you the right to pick and choose who gets redemption? What great life experience did *you* get that I didn't, which gives you such insight?" Catra said, her words dripping with disdain.

"The experience of being your wife, Catra!" Adora shouted. "You think I don't understand you when I absolutely do! Yes, I grew up with you, Catra. I saw what Shadow Weaver put you through. It was terrible, especially since you are so sweet and sensitive. It's a big part of who you are today."

"Then why don't you trust my instincts in helping Veth?" Catra cried.

Adora slowly walked over to Catra, hands held out, reaching for her wife—she was within reach.

"Because, Catra, I think you are being manipulated through your empathy. It is making you blind." She said simply.

Adora's head suddenly rocked back, and stars clouded her vision; she was completely confused as to what had just happened to her. She tentatively reached up to her stinging cheek to feel that it burned like red-hot fire. It took a while, but the realization that Catra had just struck her finally dawned on Adora. Despair instantly rose in her throat.

"*I can't believe you just did that, Catra!"* Adora cried. There were tears of hurt in her eyes now—not from a physical pain, but an emotional one.

Catra bared her teeth again, and her ears were lowered in anger.

"*I can't believe YOU, Adora!* You have a lot of nerve to play Miss high and mighty Princess with me! You DO NOT know any better than me! Just because you are my wife does not give you the right to tell me when and where I get to show my empathy!" Catra raged. “I can’t believe in one breath you would tell me that my empathy is my greatest strength and then go on to tell me it is making me an idiot! I CAN’T BELIEVE YOU SAID THAT TO ME!”

Adora did not respond, only continuing to hold her cheek as the tears came more freely now. Never, in all the years they fought, did a blow from Catra hurt more than it did now. It felt so much deeper than the slashes on her back that Catra gave her—it felt like a betrayal.

She could not believe that Catra could not see Veth’s manipulation. All she wanted to do was protect Catra—because she loved her. She felt like she was back at the First One’s temple with Catra, trying to bring her back to the side of the Light. Just like in that situation, instead of letting Adora lead her back, Catra

had once again lashed out at her—but this time, it was worse than letting her fall into a great chasm.

Every time Adora tried to stop Catra from making a mistake, it only worsened things. Adora felt like she was losing Catra, that somehow Catra was slipping through her fingers again. She didn't know what to do, and the despair inside her opened wider—so vast that it became a pit bigger than the one Catra had once watched her fall into.

Adora couldn't hold it in and openly wept as she walked over to the bed to sit, still holding her cheek. She did not look up when Catra walked over to her to stand nearby, only gazed numbly at the hand that struck her now at Catra's side.

Catra let out a big sigh. "Look, I'm really sorry I hit you, Adora. Can I take a look at it?" Catra said, tentatively reaching out to Adora.

"Don't you dare touch me, Catra," Adora hissed as she slapped her wife's hand away.

She turned on the bed away from Catra to lay on the other side, curling up into a protective ball. She had not done anything like it since she was very little—before she met Catra—and it seemed like the only way to comfort herself.

It had been a long time since Adora felt this hurt and lost. She realized that she had come to depend on Catra's comfort over the past couple of years. Suddenly, Adora felt like comfort from Catra was impossible.

Catra seated herself on the opposite side of the bed, and Adora could feel her wife's eyes on her.

"Look, Adora, I'm really sorry." Catra began. "I know you are just trying to look out for me in your own stupid way, and I appreciate it. I promise that whatever I do with Veth, I will involve you. Tomorrow, when you go to capture Nefeli with Veth, I'm going to

be there too. I will watch your back and make sure they don't pull anything."

Adora turned her body slowly to look at her wife—Catra's ears lowered in shock when she saw how red her wife's eyes were from crying. The shock instantly turned to concern when she saw how puffy Adora's cheek was from her blow—she had struck Adora hard.

Adora looked at Catra through bleary eyes.

"Catra, do whatever you want. *I don't care."* she said coldly before turning back around.

Catra sat there dumbly for a moment, not sure what to do, before she, too, turned her back to Adora, curling up into a ball of her own.

The two spent the rest of the night like this, so close, yet so far apart. Neither of them got any sleep.

* * *

It was very early in the morning—around the time Veth had said the Penumbra ritual was to be conducted—and the first rays of sunlight were poking through the dense branches and leaves of the Jacarandra Forest. The various creatures of the forest were already wide awake and making themselves known; their hoots, screams, and whistles made a cacophonous din, creating an excellent sound cover for the surprise attack that was currently underway.

She-Ra/Adora grunted as she clung to the outside of the Guest House, forcing her enhanced fingers into the soft wood of the structure. By creating her own handholds, She-Ra/Adora was able to climb from the lower level entrance up towards the top of the building, where the Nephraeh were housed. It was slow and challenging work for her; slamming her whole fist into the wall would be quicker but would create too much noise and give away

their position. Looking back down, she saw that Catra and Zhe-La/Veth were not that far below her.

The Nephraeh Champion was having an easier time scaling the outside of the Guest House; their clawed gauntlets found a much easier purchase in the soft wood. A morning sunbeam shone upon Zhe-La/Veth, revealing that the armor plating covering their body was actually deep purple and almost translucent. Faint lines—like veins within a crystal—could be seen, adding more mystery to an already mysterious individual.

Catra also had no problem climbing; her black claws easily grasped the natural wood of her homeworld. Feeling her wife's gaze upon her, Catra looked up at She-Ra/Adora and smiled, raising one arm to wave up at her. She-Ra/Adora did not return the gesture, only turned back around to continue her climb.

She was still angry with Catra, not saying a single word to her when they got up from their sleepless night together. When her wife said good morning to her in an 'un-Catra-like' sugary manner, Adora had only responded with a scathing look.

The feelings of the night before were still there in her chest—the hurt and feelings of betrayal. They were the exact feelings she struggled with after Catra had let her fall to her death at the First One's temple. The sense of hopelessness was there, too. It felt so pointless to try and convince Catra that Adora was right; she was too much of a stubborn brat.

For a moment, Adora had wondered if last night's events had irrevocably ruined their relationship—that by striking Adora at such a moment of truth, Catra had shattered the love between them.

But Adora had not allowed herself to go there, too afraid of what paths she would be led down. There was too much riding on what they had to do today, and she did not need her focus clouded.

Besides being angry, Adora was afraid to engage with Catra, too scared to talk to her. She felt like her mind would be forced to face uncomfortable truths if she did. So, she and Catra had just prepared themselves in silence, meeting up with Veth soon after. Adora did not bother to watch for any subtle interactions between the two anymore; she didn't want to look at either of them. She just wanted this whole mission over with as soon as possible.

She-Ra/Adora finally reached the spot shown to her on a schematic by Maira—it was right outside Nefeli's room. She was now between two exterior windows, and there was enough room for Catra and Zhe-La/Veth to climb to either side of her. Ignoring the feeling of Catra's eyes upon her, She-Ra/Adora turned to Zhe-La/Veth and pulled out the device Maira had given her. Maira had called it a Dekhana scanner and showed Adora how to use it—holding it up against a wall to see Viraj on the other side. Catra's twin brother had shown up a fuzzy blob with a tail and had waved to her—it had made Adora smile.

"It should be happening soon, She-Ra," Zhe-La/Veth said urgently. "We need to be ready."

She-Ra/Adora gave the other champion a measured look. "How do you know what's happening? I have not even used the Dekhana scanner yet." She-Ra/Adora said as she placed the device against the wall. The Dekhana scanner instantly lit up, showing the Nephraeh within as fuzzy white blobs against an electric blue background.

"The Penumbra ritual has been a part of my entire life, She-Ra. I have learned to sense when the ritual is near its completion." Zhe-La/Veth said cryptically.

She-Ra/Adora looked at the Nephraeh Champion suspiciously before turning back to the viewscreen; their answer did not satisfy her one bit.

On the screen, She-Ra/Adora could see the room represented as a three-dimensional image—walls, floors, furniture, and other

objects were outlined in faint blue lines. The white blobs of the Nephraeh were grouped near her, and she could distinctly make out the outlines of their forms.

She noticed something strange about the energy signature the Nephraeh gave off in comparison to the one Viraj gave off—they seemed brighter somehow, with faint motes of prismatic light dancing within. It was quite beautiful to look at.

Must have something to do with them being half magical and all, She-Ra/Adora thought to herself as she glanced at Zhe-La/Veth. The Nephraeh Champion was traversing closer to her to peer at the screen she was holding, the nearness of them making her skin tingle.

Zhe-La/Veth studied the screen intently, and She-Ra/Adora turned her attention back to the Dekhana scanner as well. She could tell that the majority of the Krypteia were gathered in kneeling positions before a single figure—obviously, this was Nefeli.

She watched as the kneeling Nephraeh took turns standing and presenting themselves before Nefeli, who would then reach out to them with an object in their hands—what it was, She-Ra/Adora could not tell. Whatever it was, it had an immediate effect on the energy signature of the Nephraeh that Nefeli directed it towards; the light of their image would dim, and the motes of prismatic light would cease their movement.

She-Ra/Adora turned towards Zhe-La/Veth, hoping for an answer to what she just witnessed, but the Nephraeh Champion only met her gaze with an ambiguous expression.

Turning back to the screen, She-Ra/Adora watched as nine Nephraeh Krypteia bowed to Nefeli, turned, and exited their leader's quarters.

"*Is anyone going to fill me in on what's going on?*" Catra whispered behind She-Ra/Adora.

When She-Ra/Adora didn't answer, Zhe-La/Veth decided to answer. "Patience, Catra, it will be very soon. Be ready!"

She-Ra/Adora continued to watch the Dekhana scanner screen, feeling hollowed out by the familiar way Zhe-La/Veth spoke to her wife. She now wanted to move, to take action, and she tensed herself in preparation for violence.

She-Ra/Adora stopped when she felt Zhe-La/Veth's restraining hand on her shoulder and shrugged it off.

"Easy, She-Ra! We must wait until Nefeli puts the Antithetical Philter away! We don't want it in their hands when we make our move!" Zhe-La/Veth implored as She-Ra/Adora shook their hand off violently.

The Nephraeh Champion's word's enraged She-Ra/Adora—she gripped the wall with her enhanced strength, causing the wood to crack. She felt like she wanted to explode inside, to lash out—whom she wanted to lash out at, She-Ra/Adora was not sure.

I wish they would just stop calling me She-Ra! Just call me Adora! She thought angrily. *And what the heck is an Antithetical Philter? More mysterious Nephraeh nonsense!*

Once again, She-Ra/Adora had enough, and she started to shimmy towards the window opposite Zhe-La/Veth. The look on her approaching wife's face made Catra yelp, and she quickly scrambled up the wall and out of She-Ra/Adora's way.

"*NO! You mustn't yet!"* Zhe-La/Veth hissed.

"Adora! I know you're angry with me, but you should listen to Veth, please!" Catra said in a loud whisper.

She-Ra/Adora turned to look at the Nephraeh Champion and her wife, giving them both a disgusted look as she shook her head. She then turned back towards the window, completely set on her course of action.

With a flex and a massive heave, She-Ra/Adora burst through the window and into the room, landing in a crouch. The glass cascaded down around her in a tinkling shower and her massive bulk crushed broken pieces of it into powder—making audible crunching sounds.

She looked just in time to see Nefeli turn, surprise written on their lilac features. Just as Veth said they would be, Nefeli was out of their Aegis Lace, wearing only a pair of tight black briefs. In their hands, they held what appeared to be a stone-hewed vessel or jug. Indigo light emanated from its top, like liquid.

She-Ra/Adora held up her hand and summoned her sword, a cocky grin plastered on her face.

"I'm having an awful day," She-Ra/Adora growled to the almost-naked Krypteia. "So how about you put that down and come with me, peacefully? Otherwise, I'm going to have to use my sword. Believe me, I think I might enjoy the latter option."

Nefeli looked at the golden sword held in her hands; She-Ra/Adora saw no fear in their glittering silver eyes. They grinned at her.

"If you're having such a bad day, She-Ra," they said, hefting the jug in their hands. "How about you have a drink? Courtesy of Archon Lethe!"

Nefeli flung the jug at She-Ra/Adora; it sailed at her head like a missile. Raising her sword in an upwards slash, She-Ra/Adora completely halved the stone vessel, freeing the contents within, which continued in her direction. A glowing indigo glob struck She-Ra/Adora full in the chest and splashed over her body—but instead of pouring off her and onto the ground, it clung to her. She-Ra/Adora looked down at her body in horror as the strange substance absorbed into her body wherever it touched.

The reaction was immediate and intense.

Emotional coldness, much like She-Ra/Adora had felt during her fight with Zhe-La/Veth, suffused her entire body, making her emit a low groan. The sensation was horrible, and the magnitude of its effect was more significant than what Zhe-La/Veth used upon her—it was as if the liquid that covered her was the refined essence of that dark power.

She-Ra/Adora could feel a black hole within her soul—she could feel its gravity beginning to tug at various parts within her being. A strange tearing sensation was felt as pieces of who she was started to slide away, towards this point, like water down a drain.

A specific part of her was leaving—it was not her curiosity, anger, or fear. It was not her desire, her sadness, or pride. It was none of those things, but as she began to lose it, she realized it was perhaps her most important emotion. The emotion acted as the guide for the rest of her swirling feelings, the balance point of what made her who she was.

She-Ra/Adora could feel her empathy being taken from her.

She-Ra/Adora clutched her head and screamed as she felt all her love and care swirl out of her like a siphon. The shock of that loss caused her to transition out of her She-Ra form, collapsing onto the floor.

Adora lay there, dumb and insensate, feeling herself drift away. As she sank into unconsciousness, she slowly realized something: Adora may have been angry with Catra before, but she still had loved her—with all her heart. But now, with her empathy taken from her, she was not sure if she would ever love again.

Adora closed her eyes and was gone.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Catra and Adora by @Ansdrela_Art on Twitter

Supplicants Before the Mighty Janus

Chapter Summary

Glimmer travels to the city-wide planet of Thenlor to find her friends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

01.2406.99

I have returned to Elysia with the Shlihm-bess'a-rune and gave Jihan the good news—I was now able to heal him!

My dear Jihan was excited at first, but then he started to worry. He wanted to know more about this magical device I had brought back from Castle Grayskull, saying that there was something about its name he did not like.

When I told him that the user's most powerful attribute somehow powered it, he became agitated, saying that his life was not worth me taking such a risk. I told him he had no option in the matter; I could not stand by and let him waste away. Jihan is so sickly and thin now, and there are places on his body where his beautiful fur has fallen out. If I knew the Shlihm-bess'a-rune would kill me by using it, I would use it in an instant to save Jihan. In the end, Jihan gave in to me, like he always did.

Tomorrow is the day! Some of the Jaadoogar want to be there when I use the Shlihm-bess'a-rune. They are very interested in its operation and will watch over me while I use it. We all agree that Jihan's restoration will take place at dawn—the symbolism is perfect; it is when the light returns to banish the darkness.

Soon Jihan will be restored to me.

01.2407.99

Thank all the stars—it worked! The Shlihm-bess'a-rune did exactly what Zzar said it would. It returned Jihan to me whole and complete!

I will admit that the experience of using the Shlihm-bess'a-rune was very odd and indescribable—I could feel it taking something from me. I think I am okay now, just completely exhausted; I don't think I have ever felt this tired before.

But it doesn't matter! I have Jihan back! I'm not wasting any more time with this silly journal—all my time is going to be spent with him!

Glimmer put the datapad down and smiled to herself; she was so happy that Kishar could heal Jihan and they could be together again. It seemed that whatever this Shlihm-bess'a-rune was, it did precisely as Zzar said it would—it performed miracles. Perhaps she should explore the catacombs below Castle Grayskull and seek it out; it was exactly what they needed to heal Scorpia and Mermista.

There was one problem, though—the Shlihm-bess'a-rune sounded like it was in Castle Grayskull. Glimmer was no longer near Eternia or Etheria; she was currently onboard Seahawk's starship—The Millennial Seagull—on her way to Thenlor.

Once it was known that Mermista and Scorpia had left Etheria for Thenlor, Glimmer wasted no time in making preparations for departure. There was no question that she would be leading the expedition to recapture her friends, but the number of people that wanted to join her was astounding.

Star Force Admiral Octavia begged Glimmer to let her collect the entire fleet and blockade the whole planet of Thenlor. Even though it sounded like a surefire method to trap the rebel Princesses, Glimmer didn't like the sound of bearing that much force against another planet; such actions might be seen as warlike and aggressive. Besides, it would take too long to assemble the entire fleet, make their way to Thenlor and form an

effective blockade around the planet. No, Glimmer needed a faster and more agile mode of transport.

So, she approached Seahawk and asked if she could borrow the Millennial Seagull—it seemed like the best choice, given the circumstances.

Mermista leaving Etheria had driven Seahawk into greater depth of misery—he had agreed to her request with the caveat that he accompany Glimmer on 'this grand adventure to reclaim love.' Glimmer had no problem with bringing him and agreed, but she was a little worried about Seahawk's state of mind; he was like a drowning man desperately seeking anything to hold on to.

It was no surprise that Perfuma also demanded to come—Glimmer was expecting this—and she tried to convince Perfuma that it was in Etheria's best interest that one of the only two bearers of the Staves of Power remain. But Perfuma was not moved, and Glimmer had to accept her into their ranks.

Bow also asked that he go, saying that he would not be separated from her again. Glimmer was more than happy to accept, grateful to have her husband by her side.

Glimmer was uncertain about the next member of her mission, not wanting to strip Etheria and Eternia of his protection, but she felt like they would need the extra muscle that He-Man would provide. Shen accepted Glimmer's invitation with no hesitation, and with him came Battlecat.

The last member of their party was unexpected but not unwelcome—Melog had approached Glimmer and asked her to come. Their reasons were mysterious, only saying they wanted to see Catra and that she would need them soon. Glimmer reminded Melog that this mission was to find Mermista and Scorpia, but the alien being only responded—*I know.* Despite their mysterious reasons, Glimmer accepted them into their party, grateful to have someone with their knowledge of the universe with them.

With their merry band assembled, they had blasted off for the stars the very next day. They were now into their fourth day into their trip, nearing the planet Thenlor. Glimmer had established communications with the only person she knew of on that planet, the same person who helped them in their fight against the Shen'Aan-war—the mysterious contact known as White Claw.

Glimmer was not part of the mission to speak with White Claw, but from Adora and Catra's report, White Claw was a woman named Panga. She was of the same species as Catra, a Madgēcot —Glimmer now knew they were called. Panga was more than happy to help Glimmer find her lost friends, promising to bring Glimmer and the others to speak with someone who could help.

Someone Glimmer may already know.

Glimmer didn't like the mysterious nature of that statement but decided to trust that Panga's intentions were pure. After all, without her, who knows where they would all be now? Probably living in a nightmare version of their galaxy ruled by the Set'Heth-un'dar—a new Dark Times.

Glimmer was about to resume her study of Kishar's journal when the room's intercom beeped. After pushing the button, Seahawk's voice came over the speaker.

"This is your Captain speaking. I wish to inform you of our imminent arrival to the planet Thenlor." He said in a deep and solemn tone. "I would like to take this moment to thank you for traveling with Starhawk spacelines, and I hope your journey was a pleasant one."

Glimmer rolled her eyes at Seahawk's corny behavior but ended up smiling despite herself. She was glad that this mission allowed Seahawk to focus on something other than his falling out with Mermista. He even seemed to have some of his old flamboyance back, telling everyone that he was to be referred to as Starhawk while they were in space. Everyone refused to do this, of course.

“Yes, thank you, Seahawk,” Glimmer replied. “I will be up there in a moment.”

“Fantastic!” He responded enthusiastically. “Oh, and by the way, please call me Starhaw—”

Glimmer cut the connection before he could finish, standing up to stretch; she groaned with pleasure as she pushed into her lower back, releasing some of the tight muscles there. When she was not spending time with Bow, Glimmer had been holed up in her room, reading Kishar’s journal or meditating as she would do back in her Observatory.

Glimmer was very interested in observing the interconnecting web of magic she had seen in the galaxy and its relationship with the dark corner, over on the opposite spiral from Etheria. While in her transcendent out-of-body state, she observed a dark planet, a place of evil, and she could see a tendril of its corruption reaching out to grasp other words near its position.

If she studied this tendril long enough, she thought she could see it moving. This had caused her to constantly go into a meditative state to watch this tendril for any further movement, silently hoping it had not made any progress. Glimmer could not help but observe the parallels in this obsessive behavior with when she was a teenager—always looking in the mirror to track the progress of any facial blemishes. Except where the blemishes on her face would only cause her to apply a concealer, these galactic blemishes had yet to be known consequences. She was sure that whatever these consequences were, they would be disastrous for countless innocents.

Putting on the star-studded black robe Madame Razz had given her, Glimmer exited her quarters and went about searching for her husband Bow. She tentatively knocked on the door adjacent to her room, the room Seahawk and Shen shared, but only heard a strange mewling sound coming from within. Fearing that someone may be in distress, Glimmer opened the door to find both Melog and Battlecat staring at her. Both ethereal aliens had stern

expressions on their faces, as if in admonition of Glimmer, and she suddenly felt very uncomfortable.

"Uh, sorry if I was interrupting something," she said with a nervous chuckle. "But have either of you seen Bow around?"

Both Melog and Battlecat shook their heads for *No*, and Glimmer quickly shut the door, eager to be away from such an uncomfortable situation.

Glimmer made her way through the tight confines of Seahawk's unique starship, ducking under pipes and over humming mechanisms, finally finding her way to the central space. It was the largest area in the starship, and its primary function was unknown. It seemed to serve as a lounge, meeting area, and kitchen. Glimmer spotted Bow sitting at a small round table with Shen on the opposite side; the two intently playing a board game based on holographic characters.

After nudging Bow with her behind, he moved over just enough so she could sit next to him on the sofa—which formed an arc around the game table. Neither player said a word to Glimmer, too focused on their match, and Glimmer sighed audibly, seeking attention.

"Haven't you too had enough of this stupid game yet?" Glimmer whined. "I mean, you have been playing it *nonstop* this whole trip. How many rounds have you played so far?"

"Huh?" Bow said distractedly as he kissed the top of her head. "Oh, we are still playing the first round. It took us a day just to figure out all the rules."

Glimmer looked at the both of them with exasperation and started to get annoyed, not liking that their attention was fixated on an inanimate object. Just as Glimmer was going to resort to drastic action, Seahawk appeared from behind an automatic sliding door, coming from the direction of the ship's cockpit. Glimmer was instantly alarmed.

“Uh, Seahawk, shouldn’t you be flying this thing?” She asked with concern.

He shook his head nonchalantly. “My dear Perfuma is at the controls; it's nothing to worry about.”

Glimmer gaped at him, and Seahawk laughed.

“It’s okay, Glimmer, I’ve been teaching her. She is actually an excellent student and a natural star pilot. The ol’ Millennial Seagull sings at her touch.” He said with a broad sweep of his arm.

Glimmer looked around at the ship she was traveling in, taking in the worn-looking interior. The Millennial Seagull seemed so old, yet she could now see the care put into its construction. Whoever had previously owned the ship had put a lot of love and attention into it.

“Seahawk, did you really win this ship in a card game?” She asked. By the sudden downcast look on Seahawk’s face, Glimmer instantly regretted her question.

“No, I made that up.” He said with a sigh. “Actually, it was a gift from my sweet Mermista. She said she bought it from two spacers over at the Old Fright Zone Starport. She said they were an odd pair—one was a scruffy-looking older gentleman, and his partner was completely covered in long fur. Anyway, I think it is fitting that we go and rescue my Mermista in the same gift she gave me out of love.”

Glimmer absorbed this in silence, not wanting to dig deeper into Seahawk’s apparent wound, but Shen broke the silence.

“So, Seahawk—I mean *Starhawk,*” he said distractedly while maintaining his attention on the game. “Does the fact that Mermista gave you this ship increase or decrease the likelihood of you setting it on fire? I think it’s important that we get that little detail out of the way,”

Seahawk barked laughter and instantly broke out of his moroseness, slapping Shen on the back.

"Shen, my boy, it makes no difference to Starhawk. Whether a ship sails the sea or the stars, I will find a way to set it aflame!" He said with his usual drama.

"Greeeaaat…" Glimmer said sarcastically.

The levity was broken as a slight tremor was felt through the ship. Everyone looked at each other nervously, as if joking about disaster had caused it to happen. Perfuma's voice called out from a nearby intercom, sounding very nervous.

"Uhhh, Seahawk? Can you get up here? We are getting close to the planet, and you never showed me how to handle the ship in a planet's atmosphere or land it. I'm going to need some help."

Seahawk nodded and smiled at everyone. "If you will excuse me, I have a ship to land." He said as he pressed the button to open the automatic door. Glimmer stood to follow him, leaving Shen and Bow to their game. She was very interested to see what an entire planet covered by a city looked like from space.

As she entered the tube-shaped cockpit, the view that greeted her from the forward viewport was disappointing, to say the least. The planet Thenlor appeared as a murky gray-green blob; on the night side, she could see hazy orange and yellow lights shining up through dense rainclouds. It was a very unappealing sight.

"I guess if you no longer had any empathy and wanted a place to belong, Thenlor is the perfect place to go," Glimmer said to no one in particular.

"Oh, I don't think so," Perfuma said as she exited the pilot's seat, allowing Seahawk to take the controls. "I can sense an abundance of life down there and can feel many good people who have not given up on hope."

Glimmer gave Perfuma a surprised look. "I thought out of all of us, you would hate this place the most. I don't think there is a single tree left on that entire ball of steel and rock."

Perfuma picked up her staff and held up the glowing yellow Life Gem; there was a look of pure benevolence on her beautiful, freckled face.

"I am no longer just concerned with growing plants, Glimmer, but *all life* now. I can't describe how beautiful the planet Thenlor appears to me." She said with hushed wonder.

Glimmer smiled at her friend, placing a hand on her shoulder. "I'm really glad you came, Perfuma." She said.

Perfuma blushed and nodded, turning back to look at the forward viewport. They were now entering the planet's atmosphere, and as they plunged through the depth of the clouds, rain droplets began to streak across the outside of the transparent surface of the viewport. They soon broke through the cloud layer, revealing the vast cityscape below.

Tall rectangular buildings, as far as the eye could see, were densely packed together like a vast crowd of people. Nestled amongst these smaller buildings were larger ones—much larger—scattered here and there like dark, grim giants amongst ants.

As the ship drew closer, they could see other vessels and speeders zipping in multiple directions over and amongst the buildings. There were also giant floating blimps with viewscreens on the side displaying various images and advertisements in bright strobing lights that seemed to glow brightly in the endless sheets of pouring rain.

The whole scene was unlike anything any of them had seen before; it was a vast and dreary world—nothing like their home of Etheria. Glimmer turned to see a different expression on Perfuma's face now and could tell her friend doubted her earlier words.

“Seahawk, are you sure we are going in the right direction? I mean, how can you make anything out down there?” Glimmer said with wonder.

Seahawk didn’t bother responding; he only tapped on a nearby screen. The display showed a three-dimensional representation of the city below with a red blinking light indicating their destination, one of the many mega-structures dotting the cityscape.

As the Millennial Seagull neared its destination, Glimmer could tell something was very different about this building. Where the other giant structures were composed of uniform, straight lines, this one was more fluid and ornamental, shaped like an immense octagonal column. Looking closely, she could see it was comprised of millions of stone spires and buttresses, all heaped upon one another in a complicated, confusing jumble. In addition, there were large expanses of multicolored glass of varying shapes and sizes, placed haphazardly amongst all that complexity, without any thought to reason or practicality.

At the very top of the gigantic building was what seemed like another structure. It was all black and shaped like a pyramid, with a vertical rectangular window on one of its four triangular sides.

Seahawk piloted the ship around the building, revealing a large landing platform near the apex of the Gothic building. With a smoothness that belied his lackadaisical manner, Seahawk expertly landed the Millennial Seagull; a small bump felt through the deck was the only indication that they landed. Through the viewport, Glimmer watched as a pair of large double doors swung open, and a robed figure glided out into the rain.

“Time to greet our gracious hosts,” Glimmer said dubiously as she exited the cockpit.

She was glad to see that Bow and Shen had finished their silly game; likewise, Melog and Battlecat were finished with whatever they were doing as well. Everyone was patiently waiting for her to give the go-ahead to disembark.

“Okay, guys, just follow my lead. Let me do the talking,” Glimmer said to them. “Until we have established that this is indeed the same White Claw that Catra and Adora met, we *absolutely* do not let anyone know what we are here for. If anyone is interested in what we are doing here, tell them we are looking to set up trade between Etheria and Thenlor. Got it?”

“So, what are we trading?” Shen asked.

“*What?*” Glimmer said with a hint of annoyance.

“If we are traders, then what have we got to trade? Also, what are we looking to trade for?” He asked simply.

Glimmer shook her head in vexation. “Just keep your mouth zipped, and you won't have to worry about it, Shen.” She said huffily as she proceeded towards the ship’s airlock. Shen looked at Bow in indignation and only received a shrug in reply.

Glimmer pulled up the hood of her star-studded robe in anticipation of the rain and walked down the deployment ramp beneath the ship, using the Star Stone staff as a walking stick.

Who am I kidding? There is no way we could hide who we are. Anyone we would want to avoid would see us coming, she thought as she looked up at the glowing Star Stone.

The robed figure that had exited the door strode over to her quickly, and as they got closer, Glimmer could see a wet tail behind them. It was a cream color with brown stripes running its entire length, and it twitched back and forth in obvious irritation of the rain. This was definitely Panga; the tail fit the description given to her by Catra and Adora.

Reaching up with orange hands to grasp the sides of her hood, Panga peered at the newcomers with yellow slitted eyes; Glimmer was instantly struck by how similar Panga was to Catra—she was definitely one of the Madgēcots.

But before Glimmer could say anything, Seahawk brushed past her and towards Panga, hand held out in greeting.

"Hello! My name is Starhawk, I am the intrepid Captain of the Millennial Seagull, and I was wondering if you could help me find my friends?" He said in greeting. "Their names are Mermista and Scorpia, and we are desperately trying to find them. Mermista is a beautiful brunette with stunning brown eyes—"

"SEAHAWK!!!" Glimmer shrieked in outrage. "I told you to keep your mouth shut!"

Seahawk, thoroughly admonished, immediately clamped his mouth shut, and stared at Panga with a nervous grin, who only returned his stare with a curious expression.

"Sorry about him. He is not very good with meeting new people," Glimmer said with a lame chuckle.

Panga waved this away. "How about we do the introductions inside, out of this dreadful rain?" She said in an accented voice. It was a beautiful, lilting accent that Glimmer had never heard before, and she immediately found herself wanting to like this Panga. Glimmer nodded to the Madgēcot woman who turned and led the Etherians towards the open double doors.

Once inside, the double doors closed behind them and Panga drew down her hood to reveal wet brown hair. She shook her head back and forth violently, shedding water in all directions. Glimmer was immediately reminded of the time she and Bow captured Catra. They had just pulled themselves from a raging river after a disastrous teleportation attempt and Catra had shook the water from herself in the same fashion.

Once she was done drying herself, Panga reached up with hands tipped with white claws and combed the hair back, tucking strands of it behind her long, cream-colored ears. She smiled kindly to them; Glimmer saw that there was a cream-colored oval, like a patch, around her left eye.

“Greetings, I am Panga—also known as White Claw.” She said to them simply.

“Good to meet you, Panga!” Glimmer said, injecting some of her royal charm into her voice. She then introduced the rest of the group, beginning with herself and ending with Shen. Panga cocked her head at the mention of his name.

“So, you are the bearer of the mighty power of He-Man?” Panga asked, sounding amazed. She walked around him, inspecting him closely.

Shen grinned nervously. “Yeah, that’s me.” He said with a shrug. “I can’t believe you have even heard of
me.”

“Hmmm…” Panga said, one white-clawed finger held to her lips. “Yes, we Madgēcots know what goes on in the universe. We heard of the downfall of the Dark He-Man and the passing of the mantle to his son. Although I thought you would be bigger, taller, perhaps. The stories of He-Man always depicted him as a massive warrior, even when he was not in his Champion form.”

Glimmer looked nervously at Shen, but he only laughed good-naturedly. He gave another shrug and smiled at Panga as if in apology.

“The stories also said the bearer of He-Man was usually a vain and arrogant man. I’m glad to see that has changed, and the He-Man avatar finally selected someone worthy.” Panga said simply as she turned to inspect the rest of the group. Glimmer caught a faint blush on Shen’s cheeks and smirked at him.

“So, I assume you all have come to Thenlor to capture the rogue Etherian Princesses?” Panga said finally, to Glimmer’s surprise.

“Eh, yeah—yes! That’s right,” Glimmer stammered. “Do the Madgēcots know all about that too?”

Panga chuckled and shook her head. “No, they don’t—but Janus does.”

Glimmer looked at Panga questioningly with eyebrows raised. “Who is Janus? Is that another code name?”

Panga favored Glimmer with another smile on her beautiful, orange face.

“Janus is my partner, and this is their building, actually,” she said with arms raised, indicating the expansive hall they occupied.

The inside of the building was much different than its dark exterior. The walls and floor were composed of opalescent marble that gleamed in the light provided by nearby sconces. Looking up, Glimmer could see gold geometric frescoes on the ceiling, forming beautiful, yet complex patterns. She looked back at Panga with awe on her face—whomever this Janus was, they must be very important.

“Come, I will take you to Janus. They will answer all your questions.”

Glimmer and the rest followed the Madgēcot woman down the vast corridor, coming to a halt near an alcove enclosing a pair of smooth metallic doors. Panga pressed a button on a control panel next to the doors, and they opened to reveal a luxurious elevator paneled in rich woods. Panga turned to the group with an apologetic smile on her face.

“As you can see, the elevator is very small. I think it would be best if Glimmer and Shen accompanied me to see Janus. The rest of you can wait down here. Someone will be along soon with refreshments.

“Now, hold on a minute!” Perfuma cried as Seahawk, Bow, Melog, and Battlecat voiced their own outrage.

Glimmer held up her hands to silence her friends. “It’s okay, guys, it’s fine. I mean, if this was a trap, they picked the wrong two

people to try it on," she said with a hint of bravado.

Panga gave Glimmer a reproachful look. "You seem very sure of yourself, Queen of Etheria. You should know that there are many frightening and powerful forces in this universe that make the power of the Star Stone pale in comparison. I can assure you this is no trap, but your hubris may get you into trouble one day."

Glimmer had no answer to this, and for once, was utterly chastened. She knew Panga was absolutely right.

"I can assure you, Panga, that Glimmer is much more than her magical powers," Shen said forcefully, now abandoning all humility. "She is one of the strongest people I know, and if she had ever come face to face with any of these forces you speak of, I can assure you she would defeat every single one of them."

Panga stared at Shen. There was admiration in her eyes—plus something else. Glimmer was reminded of when she was young and had a crush on a young Princess from a distant kingdom. This Princess had a suitor who knew of Glimmer's romantic feelings for the Princess. This suitor had looked at her the same way Panga was now looking at Shen.

"No wonder they liked you so much," Glimmer heard Panga whisper.

"Huh?" Shen said, utterly oblivious to what was transpiring.

Panga only shook her head as if irritated with herself. "Nothing. Are we going to see Janus or not?" She said, then indicated the open elevator door.

Shen and Glimmer shared a glance, then proceeded into the elevator with Panga not far behind.

They rode the elevator up in silence. Glimmer watched Panga stare at Shen—who only looked up at the ceiling and tapped his toe. Finally, with a loud *ding*, the elevator stopped, and the doors opened, revealing a vast space.

Looking around, Glimmer realized that they must be inside the black pyramid at the top of the mega-structure—three of the four walls slanted inwards until they met at a point at the top, high above. The walls looked like they were made of onyx or obsidian, much like the outside of the pyramid, and the floor was made of the same opalescent marble as the halls in the lower building.

At the opposite end of the cavernous room was the large, rectangular window revealing the dark cityscape beyond. In front of this window was a massive black throne, and on this throne was a giant hooded figure. The figure raised its head to gaze at the newcomers, allowing Glimmer to see a cruel face with black eyes and a leering mouth.

"Janus!" Panga called. "I bring these supplicants before you! They would be honored if you would provide counsel for them!"

"Supplicants? Really?" Glimmer hissed at Panga. The Madgēcot woman only waved for her to be silent with a look of horror on her face.

A clawed, bony hand appeared from the fold of Janus' robes and beckoned them forward.

"**Proceed,**" Janus said in such a deep, male voice, it seemed to make the room vibrate with its might.

Glimmer gulped, instantly thinking of what Panga had said to her about meeting powerful and dark forces. Perhaps this was one of them.

With Panga behind them, Glimmer and Shen stopped before Janus—all three gazed up at his horrible visage. Glimmer did not recognize his species, but he was ancient; his face appeared as if it had been torn in half then cruelly stitched back together, giving it a lopsided look. Janus' eyes bored into Glimmer and seemed to know everything about her.

"So, the high and mighty Queen of Etheria has deemed to honor me with her visit. Tell me, why should I bother with

such an insignificant being wearing such a tacky black robe? Are those…*sparkles* embedded in the fabric?" Janus boomed.

Glimmer gaped up at Janus, completely taken aback by his words. There was a strange sound behind her—as if someone was stifling a sneeze—and she turned to see Panga with her hand over her mouth. Turning back to face Janus, Glimmer inspected the robe she wore; the stars in the fabric were so lifelike that she didn't see how they could be confused for sparkles. But looking up at Janus, she could see faint cataracts in his dark eyes and realized he must be almost blind.

"Uh, yes, they are sparkles. How kind of you to notice, anyway—"

"Don't condescend me, insignificant girl!" Janus interrupted her as he turned towards Shen. **"I see you brought the handsome new He-Man with you."**

Glimmer heard Panga clear her throat loudly behind her. Janus quickly glanced at the Madgēcot woman before continuing.

"Tell me, Shen, are you still trying to throw your life away in stupid attempts to save everyone? I hope you haven't locked anyone in a dry storage locker lately," he said, almost sounding a little hurt.

Shen gazed up at Janus, dumbstruck. "How do you know all this?" He asked, now suspicious.

Janus waved his question away. **"It doesn't matter! I wouldn't expect someone as good-looking as yourself to understand—just stick to He-Man things, like the proper way to hold your big sword."**

Glimmer heard another sound from behind her, coming from Panga; it sounded almost like a giggle. She turned to face the Madgēcot woman, and Panga only gave her a look of pure innocence. Glimmer turned back around, annoyed now.

“Janus, I didn’t come all the way from Etheria for you to play games and insult us.” Glimmer said defiantly, slamming her staff down on the floor.

“Oh? And why did you come to visit me…darling? Are you going to threaten me with your magic staff? Oh, good heavens, no!” Janus said in an entirely mocking tone.

Glimmer turned back around to see Panga bent over and clutching her sides—she was completely seized up in a laughing fit. Glimmer looked at her in exasperation.

“What the heck is so funny?!” She shouted at Panga.

“Ignore her, darling. These Madgēcots are so unreliable—always lying about and grooming themselves. I keep Panga around because she finds the dullest joke funny, and it boosts my confidence. She is such a precious lamb,” Janus said while trying to maintain a straight face.

“I have had enough of this! What is going on? Tell me now!” Glimmer shouted as she held the Star Stone aloft. The source of Ultimate Power suddenly shone brightly, illuminating the entire room, making everyone wince.

Panga regained her composure as she stood and wiped the tears from her eyes. She held her hands out in placation.

“Easy, Glimmer, easy. It’s okay.” She said, then turned towards Janus. “I think you’ve had enough fun, Atreyen. Let’s be nice to our guests now.”

“Areyen?!” Glimmer heard Shen gasp.

Janus gave Panga a pouting look, then sighed audibly. He abruptly stood with arms raised and started to spin. As he rotated, his entire form became black, like a great void, and within this blackness, dancing green lights could be seen—like fireflies. His outline shrank, the robe disappeared, and a long thick tail appeared. Janus stopped spinning and took solid form.

Where once there was an ancient man, a familiar green-skinned and lithe figure now stood in a jaunty pose. They were dressed in tight-fitting, glossy black pants, and over their slender torso they wore a matching jacket, the front open to reveal a bare green torso. They grinned at their guests, exposing rows of sharp teeth, and twitched their long, pointed ears in greeting.

"Double Trouble!?" Glimmer shrieked. "What are you doing here?!"

"*Hiii,* my darling Glimmer, it's so good to see you!" Double Trouble cooed. "What a fabulous reunion this is!"

Chapter End Notes

> Curious as to how the nefarious imp ended up on Thenlor doing their 'Wizard of Oz' act? Well, look no further! All your questions are answered in my other fanfic, 'Double Trouble and the Orb of Entropy'!

Virtue

Chapter Summary

> Adora lies in an unconscious state after the attempt to capture the Krypteia and Catra blames herself for her wife's current state.
>
> A secret is revealed.

Catra held her head in her hands in abject misery as a feeling of surrealness hit her once again—*how did we end up here?* She lifted her head to gaze at Adora as she lay motionless on their shared bed, searching for signs that her wife was about to regain consciousness.

Adora's chest would slowly rise, then fall, gently—the sound of her breathing was barely audible, even to a Madgēcot. Adora's eyes moved steadily behind closed lids, indicating that she was dreaming—but they were not pleasant dreams. Occasionally, she would give a slight groan, and her hand would twitch, as if reaching for something—or someone.

Catra would stand up and move to Adora when she saw this, wanting to touch her. But as she held out her hand, she would freeze, knowing that the hand she held out was the one that struck her wife's face the night before. She would then drop her arm in defeat, turn and walk back to her chair to sit with her head in her hands, returning to her original position.

Anyone who saw this behavior would have thought that Catra was slightly mad—for it appeared senseless. But there was a reason for this solemn ceremony, even if Catra herself did not know it. It was her guilt that was driving her now, and Catra was too far in the throes of despair to stop and think about her actions; she had been like this the last ten hours since the disastrous attempt to capture the Krypteia.

Catra had scrambled along the wall behind Zhe-La/Veth as they both watched She-Ra/Adora burst through the window to single-handedly capture Nefeli. But by the time they both had entered the room, Nefeli had escaped into the Guest House, and Adora was lying on the floor, unconscious and out of her She-Ra form. Catra had screamed in horror and instantly ran to her wife's side, no longer caring about the mission.

While this was happening, Nefeli had rallied their comrades, alerting them to the ambush waiting for them in their rooms. The Krypteia were able to fight their way out of the trap, injuring five Star Hunters in the process, and escape into the Jacarandra Forest by destroying an exterior wall; how they had managed that while completely unarmed was anyone's guess.

Catra had carried Adora in her arms back to their room, where the Star Hunter healer Sanket inspected her for injury—but he was utterly beside himself as to what was wrong with her. According to him, all her vital signs were low, indicating that she was in a coma-like state. Even though he was helpless to bring Adora out of her condition, Sanket stayed by her side, applying healing cantrips every now and then to help make her comfortable.

The Jaadoogar had also come to inspect Adora. They had surrounded her bed, staring at her with glowing white eyes and examining her supine form with tentative claws. After they were done, they stated that an aspect of Adora's quintessence had been driven away—like a small group of animals being separated from the greater group by a predator. Like those animals, Adora's quintessence would return to her over time—as long as it had not been lost. Or destroyed. Either way, they said, Adora would regain consciousness—she may be the same person when she wakes up, or a completely different one.

Catra was utterly horrified by this proclamation and had almost fallen apart if it wasn't for Veth, stating with complete assurance that Adora would be restored. They said the only part of Adora that had been driven away was her empathy, and it would soon return to her without being destroyed—such things were

impossible. Catra had noticed that Veth had said nothing about the possibility of Adora's empathy being lost, but she chose not to comment on this.

With Adora's immediate health seemingly addressed, everyone's attention had then turned to the matter of the Krypteia; there were now ten dangerous individuals roaming the Jacarandra Forest. By now, they must have known that Veth had betrayed them and sided with the Madgēcots, and they would seek vengeance. Just as they had said to Catra, Veth told everyone that the sole mission of the Krypteia was now to kill or capture the bearer of Zhe-La—nothing else mattered to the elite Nephraeh assassins.

According to Veth, once out of direct line of sight, the Krypteia could employ magical means to render themselves 'unseen' to the naked eye, making them practically invisible. Every Star Hunter on the planet, including Viraj and Maira, were put into hunting groups equipped with Dekhana scanners to help locate these stealthy and dangerous Nephraeh. Because Adora's condition was considered stable, even the healer Sanket was involved in the search, leaving Veth alone with Catra and Adora. They now reached to stop Catra as she stood once more to conduct her rite of repentance.

"Catra, enough," Veth said as Catra pushed their hand away. "I know you are beating yourself up for this, Catra, but it is not worth it."

"It is worth it! It's worth everything to me!" Catra snapped. "This is my fault. I should have listened to her!"

Catra stiffened up, clenching her teeth as she attempted to close her eyes and stop her tears from falling. Her hands were balled up so tight at her side that she could feel her claws digging into her palms, beginning to draw blood, but she did not care.

She wrenched her hand away as she felt Veth trying to pry her fists open, trying to stop her from self-harm.

“Don’t touch me!” She snapped.

Veth held their hands up, trying to soothe Catra in her anger.

“I am only trying to help Catra. There is no point in drawing your own blood. Why are you so angry with me?” They said with a hint of hurt in their voice. Catra looked at them with hooded eyes as the tears started to flow freely.

“Adora thought that something was going on between us, Veth. It made her angry and jealous. She also thought you were manipulating me and playing on my sympathy, and when she confronted me about it last night, we ended up in a fight. She wouldn’t talk to me the rest of the night, and I’m sure it was the reason she was so reckless today.” Catra said as she hugged herself.

Veth slowly nodded as if something finally dawned on them. “So, you blame me for this?” They asked simply.

“Yes!” Catra blurted out. “I do blame you! But mostly, I blame myself. I should have listened to her instead of brushing off her worries—she is my wife! But no, when she said she was worried about me, I laughed at her! I got angry with her! And finally, I—"

Catra stopped herself as she held her hand up, the one that had stuck the love of her life in the face, slowly clenching it into a fist.

“You know Veth, she was right,” Catra said, slowly looking back up at them as she opened her hand. “Something was going on between us.”

Veth did not respond, only looked at her curiously with a tilt of their head as Catra continued.

“From the moment I saw you, I found you extremely irresistible—I have never met anyone like you before. Well...except for one other…but they were *trouble,*” Catra said with a chuckle. “And I know you feel the same about me. I mean, I have a lot of

experience with people being attracted to me, so I know the signs to look for."

Veth laughed at this, but it was not mocking.

"That is a very cocky statement bordering on arrogance," they said without accusation.

Catra just shrugged.

"It's the truth—although I cannot understand *why,"* she wondered. "I mean, what is so special about me? Sure, I'm attractive and all, but I'm also hard to handle sometimes—even I can see that. I get angry easily, I'm cocky, stubborn, and on top of that, I snore every night—I don't know how Adora puts up with me!"

"It's because she loves you," Veth said in fascination. Catra gave them a measured look when she heard the tone in their voice.

The idea of love is so strange to them, she thought to herself with pity.

"Yes, she does. Adora loves me, and I love her. More than anything. Do you have any idea what we went through to finally be together? For years, we fought each other on opposite sides of a war, and it was only when I had hit rock bottom that I saw I was on the wrong side. It was not long after I had joined the rebellion with Adora that we both realized that we were in love with each other—it was that love that destroyed Horde Prime and saved the universe.*"*

As Catra said those final words, the impact of the current situation slammed against her in waves of regret and anguish, making her gasp with grief. No matter what Veth said, there was now a very real chance that Adora would return to her a person devoid of compassion. How would she be able to still have love for Catra without it? What would Catra do, especially since she felt responsible for their current predicament? Adora had picked up on Catra's attraction to Veth. If Catra had only 'fessed up last night,

they could have worked through it, and Adora wouldn't have acted so rashly today.

She looked at Veth. They did not move, only stared at her strangely as if she was some unknown spectacle. She knew the reason they did not console her wasn't out of any respect for her and Adora's relationship, but because they did not care. *How can you care about someone when you have no empathy?*

Veth's outward beauty seemed to dim in Catra's eyes; their mysterious androgynous nature was no longer compelling. For Catra, it was almost as if the final puzzle piece clicked into place—that her attraction for someone was a derivative of their virtue, and without it, there was nothing. Suddenly, all previous attraction she felt for Veth vanished, leaving only a sense of compassion for them.

"Catra, I never intended to steal you away from Adora, you know that, right?" Veth said evenly.

Catra cocked her head as she thought about that, skimming through their interactions the past few days. Not once was there an interaction in which Veth openly stated their attraction for her. All she remembered were innuendos that her lust for them could have misinterpreted. Catra let out a long sigh.

"No, I guess not, Veth," she said with a weak smile. "I'm sorry that you were caught up in this—Adora and I have a pretty wild past. Some could argue that many of the battles fought during the Rebellion on Etheria could be chalked up to lovers' quarrels between Adora and me."

Catra almost burst out laughing when she saw the look of incredulity on Veth's lilac face, but then the mirth passed, and the sadness reasserted itself as she thought of those times she fought Adora. She sampled those emotions she had felt for Adora during those times; on the surface, they felt like spite and ridicule, but beneath, Catra knew their true meaning.

Where virtue was absent in Veth, it was found in abundance in Adora; it radiated out of her like beams of bright sunlight. There was no dampening that power within Adora, and Catra had always loved her for that. Compared to what she endured now, those times seemed like a faint memory of something no longer attainable.

Catra put her face into both of her hands and started to weep. Her body heaved with the power of her anguish as tears dripped down from between fingers. It was like she was alone again when Adora had abandoned her, and no one was there to console her in her suffering.

"Ca—*Catra?"* A voice called from the bed.

Catra's head and ears perked up as she looked to see that Adora's eyes were open. She immediately rushed to Adora's side, clasping one of her limp hands gently as she kneeled down to gaze at her wife with joy.

"Adora!!!" Catra cried, the tears immediately changing from ones of sadness to joy.

Adora gave Catra's hands a weak squeeze as she smiled weakly. "Catra, why are you crying?"

Catra absently wiped her eyes and laughed brightly. "For you, dummy, I was worried sick! You've been unconscious for the past ten hours—since this morning!"

Adora closed her eyes and nodded. "Yes, I vaguely remember what happened. I went ahead and tried to capture Nefeli by myself, but they threw some kind of glowing goo on me. It was horrible…"

"Yes, the Antithetical Philter," Veth said, stepping forward. "It is used in the Penumbra ritual and is a small part of Archon Lethe's power. No one is meant to take as much as you did at once; you are fortunate it did not kill you."

Adora nodded slowly. “I am so sorry, Veth. I should have listened to you when you tried to warm me. This is all my fault.”

“No, Adora! Stop!” Catra said, caressing her wife’s face with both hands. “It’s not your fault; it’s all mine! I should have listened to you last night, but I’m such a stubborn dummy!”

Catra gently stroked her claws against the bruised flesh of Adora’s cheek and looked into her eyes apprehensively, searching for signs that Adora was no longer the person she fell in love with.

Adora picked up on her wife’s behavior and looked at her with concern.

“Catra, are you looking for signs of brain damage again?” She said with a smile. The grin faded as she saw her words had made Catra’s face scrunch up in sadness, and the look of concern had returned.

“No, Adora,” Catra said, shaking her head while trying not to cry. “What I’m looking for is worse than that. I’m going to tell you something, and I want you to tell me immediately how it makes you feel, okay?”

“Uh, okay…” Adora said, completely unsure as to where this was going.

Catra took a deep breath before she spoke. “Glimmer contacted us from Etheria while you were unconscious. She had some bad news…”

Adora immediately sat up, the concern on her face turning to open fear. Catra continued.

“There was an accident, Swiftwind was trying to impress someone and he started doing loop-de-loops. Well, he did too many, and it made him dizzy—he crashed into the ground and died. He’s gone, Adora.” Catra said simply.

"NOOOOO!!!" Adora screamed, tears pouring from her eyes matching those shed by her wife earlier.

The apprehension on Catra's face turned to absolute joy as she leaped onto the bed and wrapped her arms around Adora's neck, all the while showering her with kisses. Adora grabbed Catra's arms while looking at her wife with complete incomprehension.

"Catra! What is wrong with you! I know you were not a big fan of Swiftwind, but—"

Catra clasped Adora by the face and laughed. "No, it's okay, Adora, your stupid magical horse is fine. I made that up. It was a test to see if you were still you, and you passed!"

Catra went into detail regarding the past ten hours, explaining everything from the escape of the Krypteia to them finding her unconscious. Finally, to the proclamation of the Jaadoogar and the fears Catra had for her soul. Adora took this all in with mute bewilderment.

"So Swiftwind isn't dead?" Adora said finally when Catra was done.

Catra chuckled and shook her head, and she wrapped her arms around Adora and pressed down on top of her in an all-encompassing hug. Adora returned the hug as Catra snuggled her face into her neck and started to purr.

"No, you dummy," Catra said as she lifted her face to whisper into Adora's ear. "I have you back now, and I'm never letting you go, I promise."

Adora closed her eyes and let out a sigh. "This is a really great way to wake up," she said as she stroked Catra's hair. "To wake up and have *Soft Catra* here to greet me."

"You're going to get a lot more than just Soft Catra later, you can bet your lucky stars on that Princess," Catra said with a wicked

smile. “I don’t know how long it takes me, but I’m going to make up for everything, you’ll see,”

The two lovers parted as they heard a soft noise behind them, and both turned to see Veth appearing as if they wanted to be anywhere but there at that moment. Catra smiled at them.

“You were right, Veth; you were totally right. Adora is fine,” she said happily.

Veth returned her smile with a weak one. “Yes, perhaps now I have earned a scrap of your trust,” they said, hopefully. “Although I would never assume I deserved it.”

“I think we will have to start trusting you if we are going to capture these Krypteia, Veth,” Adora said meaningfully.

Veth gave a slight bow to her. “You have no idea what that means to me, Adora—truly, you don’t.” They said graciously as they stood straight. “Now, I will take my leave of you; it seems like you two need some time alone,”

Adora and Catra laughed at this, thankful for Veth’s tact.

“Be careful, Veth,” Catra said. “Don’t leave the guest house—I mean it. Those Krypteia could be anywhere.”

Veth didn’t reply as they walked towards the door. Before they departed, they turned to look back at the pair.

“Catra. Adora. I will make this right. I promise.” They said, then walked out the door.

There was something about Veth’s statement that Catra found odd, but that thought left her as Adora turned her face and pulled her down for a passionate kiss. Catra accepted Adora’s lips as she lay down on top of her, enjoying the feel of her wife’s body under hers. Catra started to purr—it took on the distinctive trill of her excitement and sounded like sweet music to Adora’s ears.

"Adora, are you sure you're up for this? I don't want you to push yourself too hard," Catra whispered.

Adora nodded. She had a shy blush on her face that Catra loved so much as she started to pull Cara's top off. But a sudden warning feeling Catra felt caused her to gently push Adora's hands back down, keeping her from removing her clothes. Confusion clouded Adora's features.

"What's wrong, Catra?" she asked.

Catra shook her head, frowning. "I don't know, I just have this weird feeling—like I should be doing something," she said vaguely.

Adora stroked Catra's face in reassurance. "If you're feeling guilty about not helping in the search for the Nephraeh, we can go after we are done. We deserve a moment alone, don't you think?" Adora pleaded.

Catra nodded absently, but she could not shake the feeling that something terrible would happen. Out of the corner of her eye, she could see her tail twitching back and forth in irritation, and words instantly flashed in her memory.

…I will need you to take this sword…

…and pierce my heart, here…

…while I stand against the tree...

…That will destroy Zhe-La…

…I do not think I can do this myself…

…Catra, Adora. I will make this right. I promise…

Cold dread seared through Catra's chest as she finally realized the meaning of Veth's last words to them.

"Oh, nooooo…" Catra groaned. *"Not again…*THAT IDIOT!!!"

“Catra, what is it? What’s happening again?” Adora asked, concern written on her face.

Catra turned to Adora and told her everything that had transpired the night before in Veth’s room—how Veth had asked her to help them destroy the power of Zhe-La if the Krypteia escaped, and the only way to do it was to be impaled on the Great Chaliendra tree with the Sword of Sher-Va. How they basically asked her to help kill them.

“I need to check their room. If Veth and the sword are gone, I need to stop them, Adora!” Catra cried.

Adora nodded. “I’m coming with you,” she said as she began to stand—but then almost fell over as waves of dizziness overcame her. Catra caught her in her arms and steadied her.

“I don’t think you’re up for this, Princess,” she said, pushing Adora back down on the bed. “If I’m going to do this, I need to move fast.”

“But I can keep up with you in my She-Ra form,” Adora said, holding her hand out to summon her sword.

“FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!” She said, initiating her transformation.

Catra watched as the magical golden sword of She-Ra appeared in Adora’s hand, then shimmered as it faded in and out of reality. Finally, it disappeared, and Adora lowered her hand in shock.

“It’s like I can’t get a good grip to summon her...she just slipped through my fingers,” Adora said, trailing off.

“It’s okay, Adora,” Catra said, cupping Adora’s cheek in reassurance. “You’re probably not one hundred percent whole yet. It takes time. Besides, I have a lot of experience chasing down dummies in the forest. I got this.”

Adora nodded her head in defeat. “Okay, just promise me you will be careful, Catra. Who knows if you will run into the Krypteia or not. Even someone as cocky as you can’t take all ten of them by yourself.”

Catra feigned being hurt. “Ye of little faith! Come on, Princess, this is me you’re talking to!” She said, pointing a clawed thumb at her chest.

Adora gave Catra a dirty look. “Yes, I know,” she said dryly.

Catra grasped Adora by the face and kissed her once more, gazing into her eyes for a heartbeat.

“I will be back soon, I promise,” she said before turning for the door. Before she stepped over the threshold, Adora called to her.

“Catra! I love you!”

Catra turned in the open doorway and grinned at her wife. “I know, Princess. I love you too,”

With a flick of her tail, Catra bounded away on all fours down the hallway towards the stairs, then up to the top floor. She did not spare a glance for the ten doors of the now presumably empty rooms and went straight for Veth’s room. Yelling the command to open the door, Catra scrambled in and stood on two feet, searching frantically for Veth. There was no sign of them, and as she looked around the mostly empty room, she saw that there was no sign of the sword either.

With a hiss of irritation, Catra turned and bounded out of the room and towards the building’s exit. From there, she would make her way to the Great Chaliendra Tree—hopefully just in time to stop Veth from making a huge mistake.

* * *

Dusk neared as Catra made her way along the stone path, meandering between the dense foliage that led to her destination.

She now walked at a brisk pace on two feet; the trek down from Raajadhaanee City and through the forest on all fours was taxing, and she needed to conserve her strength. Hopefully, she wouldn't have to subdue Veth as she had with Shen; she felt like she would have a more challenging time with the Nephraeh than with her friend.

Catra was close to The Great Chaliendra Tree now. She could feel its pull on her Madgēcot soul and hear its faint song. Even though she did not have Melog with her this time, Catra could not help the intense feeling of deja vu that overcame her.

This is my job now? She thought to herself. *Stopping idiots from sacrificing themselves for the greater good?*

Catra gave a small chuckle at this thought as she realized she should be grateful to have people in her life worth fighting for. She always had people like this in her life, even in the Horde. Besides Adora, of course, there was Scorpia, Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle—all good people who, at the time, she did not appreciate.

Even though the situation was serious, Catra noticed how calm and quiet the forest was tonight—much like the Whispering Woods the night she confronted Shen. She realized that this peaceful state matched the one growing inside her now. The seed had been planted the day she sacrificed herself for Glimmer, and the tree of virtue had been growing inside her ever since. Catra would never admit it, but she really loved the person she was becoming.

I'm such a dummy, she thought as she once again started running on all fours. *I'm a dummy who would never stop fighting for her special dummies.*

Bounding around a bend, Catra finally spotted the radiant glow of The Great Chaliendra Tree between two rows of dense foliage. As she cleared the forest and entered the large open area around The Great Chaliendra, she spotted a figure holding a sword

against their shoulder next to the tree's trunk. Their back was to her as they gazed up at the giant magical tree in front of them.

“VETH! WAIT! DON’T DO IT!” She screamed as she raced towards them.

Veth turned slowly towards her; she saw no surprise on their face, just complete calm.

“Catra, you came,” they said simply.

Catra came to a stop a distance away from Veth, close enough to leap at them if she needed, but far away enough to not spook them into doing anything drastic.

“Of course, I came, Veth! I’m not letting you do this; you don’t have to sacrifice yourself!” She said imploringly. Catra stood up straight, holding her hands to either side with palms open in a non-threatening pose. “Just give me the sword, Veth and come back with me. We can work this out!”

Veth lowered the sword of Sher-Va from their shoulder, holding it out to inspect it in the light of The Great Chaliendra Tree. Their eyes glittered as they looked back up at Catra; there was a look of bemusement on their face.

“Why do you think I’m going to sacrifice myself, Catra?” They asked simply.

Catra was suddenly wrong-footed and felt utterly out of place—there was no way she misunderstood the situation, but she could not escape the creeping sense of wrongness she felt as her tail began to increase in size.

“Did anyone ever tell you where The Great Chaliendra came from, Catra?” Veth asked, indicating the tree behind them with a broad sweep of the Sword of Sher-Va. “No? Huh, that’s funny the Madgēcots forgot to tell you all about it. Not surprising, though.” They said with a grin.

“You see, thousands of years ago, not long after the Dark Times, the Nephraeh came to this planet, seeking to help those who suffered the most during those nightmare years. We found your people, the Madgēcots, living in a state of constant fear; they were too afraid to leave the safety of the trees, let alone the safety of their planet. We took pity on the Madgēcots and pulled them up from the mud and the grime—up into the light.”

“The Nephraeh saw great potential in the Madgēcots. They could be so much more if someone would just help them, so we decided to stay on Elysia for a time—five hundred years, in fact. During that time, we watched your people grow from fearful tree-dwellers to noble warriors—the Madgēcots thrived under the care of the Nephraeh, and a powerful love grew between our two people.”

“Besides linking the Madgēcots and the Nephraeh forever, this love had an unforeseen outcome. There was powerful magic hidden deep inside the planet Elysia, and it was starting to wake up after the long winter of the Dark Times. There were signs of its return everywhere, but it mostly manifested near the places the Madgēcots and Nephraeh resided. The magic seemed to be drawn to us, to our love, and it finally focused itself into a single point. At this point, a tree grew, the most beautiful tree ever seen. It grew into the majesty you see before you.”

The confusion that Catra felt started to transform into annoyance, and her tail twitched rapidly behind her.

“So, is that what we are here for? Some history lesson? I have to tell you, Veth, I know you don’t have empathy, but this is pretty messed up. I thought you were going to destroy yourself.” Catra growled.

Veth laughed, but there was no merriment in their tone.

“No, I’m not going to end myself, Catra. But I am going to destroy *something,*” they said as their silver eyes flashed in the direction of the tree. Catra caught their meaning instantly.

“WHAT?! Are you mad? Why would you even suggest such a thing!” Catra cried, instantly going into a crouch to leap at Veth.

“Because Catra, the Nephraeh have changed, we are no longer what we once were. This has created a division between the Nephraeh and the Madgēcots that cannot be rectified, not the way things are now. We must change the dynamic between us if we are going to bring the Madgēcots to the Light once more.”

“The Light?” Catra sneered. “The same light Horde Prime talked about? No way, Veth. Not going to happen.”

Catra leaped at Veth, hands outstretched to grasp them, but before she was even halfway to them, a sudden force struck Catra in the center of her chest, knocking the wind out of her and sending her back to land on her rear. She looked around, dazed and disorientated, trying to find the assailant who had hit her. She saw nothing, only Veth looking at her sadly.

“My friends, you can come out now,” Veth said aloud.

Dread coursed through Catra as ten shimmering shapes appeared around her—coalescing into deadly warriors garbed in skintight outfits of flexible black bands. Each was crouched and ready for action, lethal gauntleted hands held out as they gazed at her with cold silver eyes.

The Krypteia.

Catra looked around her, eyes wide and ears lowered as she scrambled back trying to escape the deadly Nephraeh. One went to grab her, and Catra lashed out, kicking them in their masked face and eliciting a gasp of pain.

Standing to her feet, Catra jolted as she felt two arms wrap around her, pinning her arms in place. She flung her head back, smashing the Krypteia in the face before she jerked her torso forward, sending them flying over her shoulder.

More Krypteia came for her, and Catra fought to escape their clutches, much like she did against the clones aboard Horde Prime's ship. But this time, Catra faced more than just dull-minded copies of Horde Prime. The Krypteia were elite fighters, and they quickly overcame her.

Catra doubled over, wheezing, as a fist impacted into her stomach. She lashed out with her claws only to have her hands numbed by expert hand chops. She felt her feet swept out from under her and her face collided with the ground, almost knocking her out. Firm hands grasped her ankles and wrists together as someone kneeled into her back. Catra was trapped and ultimately defeated—she yowled with fury when someone stepped on her tail.

"Careful!" Veth yelled. "I don't want Catra hurt more than necessary!"

"My apologies, Champion Veth," Nefeli said. "This Madgēcot is one of the fiercest fighters I ever met."

Catra spat blood on the ground and hissed.

"I'M GOING TO RIP YOU TO SHREDS FOR THIS!!!" She screamed.

Veth walked over to Catra and kneeled to look into her eyes.

"There is that famous Madgēcot temper," they said with a grin. "Fury and empathy are just around the corner from each other when it comes to you people,"

Catra let out one last hiss then sagged in the restraining hands of the Krypteia. She looked up at Veth with complete sadness now.

"So, this whole thing was a trick? You played on my compassion with that whole story of sacrificing yourself to get me out here by myself? Why, Veth? How could you do this to me?" Catra cried.

Veth shook their head down at her.

“Haven’t you been *listening,* Catra?” They said, words dripping with scorn. “*I have no empathy!* That’s how!”

Catra shook her head vehemently.

“No! No, that’s not completely true, Veth! I know that deep inside you, there is a sliver of compassion; I felt it! There was no way I would have ever been drawn to you in the first place if there wasn’t at least a spark of empathy somewhere inside you!”

Veth’s face fell momentarily, but then they looked at her with a rueful smile.

“You may be right, Catra. When I return to Empyrea, I will humble myself before Archon Lethe and ask to be cleansed. After the success of this mission, I have no doubt I will be forgiven.”

Veth stood and turned from her, striding towards The Great Chaliendra Tree as they rested the Sher-Va against their shoulder.

“NOOO!!!” Catra shrieked. She renewed her struggle against the Krypteia, but only gained an extra pair of hands to restrain her. A clawed gauntlet held her by the back of the neck, forcing her to watch what was unfolding.

“Don’t worry, this will be over quick, Madgēcot.” A Krypteia whispered down at her. By their tone, Catra could not tell whether they were trying to be reassuring or cruel.

Catra gritted her teeth in dread as she watched Veth stop before the tree and raise an empty hand to the sky.

“BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!!!” They shouted, beginning their transformation.

Searing indigo light appeared within the center of Veth’s torso, like a dark star. The strength of its light intensified, causing Catra to squint and close her eyes.

When she opened them back up, Zhe-La/Veth was there, holding the sword of Sher-Va in one hand and their magical black sword in the other. They dismissed their own sword to hold the Madgēcot Power Sword in a two-handed grip. They brought the blade up over their head, tip pointed in the direction of their target.

"FOR ARCHON LETHE AND EMPYREA!!!"

With all their enhanced might, Zhe-La/Veth thrust the sword of Sher-Va into the tree's trunk. An instant explosion of green fire burst outward from The Great Chaliendra Tree, pitching Zhe-La/Veth backward in a cartwheel. They crashed down in front of Catra while still maintaining their Champion form. When Zhe-La/Veth shook off the shock of what had happened to them, they stood and gazed in wonder at the result of their actions.

The Great Chaliendra Tree still stood, but instead of glowing with beautiful prismatic light, it now burned with emerald fire. From its trunk to its very crown, the entire tree was engulfed in green flames. They surged upwards in roiling waves that did not show any signs of abating, maintaining their intensity as if fed by an endless source of fuel. Nor did the flames appear to be harming the tree but protecting it. It was as if the tree had summoned this shield through magic. The sword of Sher-Va was halfway embedded in its side where Zhe-La/Veth had cruelly struck it.

"Wh-what, is this Champion Veth? Is the tree dead now?" One of the Krypteia stammered.

Zhe-La/Veth turned to the Krypteia with utter bewilderment on their face.

"I don't know...I felt something...at the last moment before I struck the tree. I was as if something...*pulled back*...at the last moment, keeping me from delivering the killing blow. I think it might have been—"

A cackle of laughter interrupted Zhe-La/Veth's words, and they turned towards its source—Catra.

“Oh, man! You totally messed that up!” Catra said mockingly between chuckles. *“I guess wittle Vethy won’t be getting their forgiveness from big bad Lethey, huh?* Not after you totally failed this mission!”

The look that Zhe-La/Veth gave her made the laughter dry up in her throat, and she gazed up at them fearfully with wide eyes and ears lowered.

“Who said destroying The Great Chaliendra Tree was my mission?” They asked simply.

Sacrifice

Chapter Summary

Adora is vindicated when she finally meets the real Veth.

Facing a tough choice, Adora ends up doing what she is best at.

…She-Ra…

Adora woke with a start—her hand jerking out to the usual spot Catra slept, but only found a cold empty space. She felt immediate confusion as the fug of the short span of sleep clung to her brain, making her thoughts sluggish, but one thing found the way to the surface of her consciousness.

Catra. Where is Catra?

There was a commotion outside of her room; it seemed not only to be coming from the Guest House around her, but also outside, from the city of Raajadhaanee—it sounded as if thousands of voices were screaming in outrage and fear. The noise added to her sudden anxiety, making her feel like she was still asleep and having a nightmare.

Adora sat up and rubbed at her head, looking around at the room illuminated by the city lights, the shapes of furniture taking on sinister form in the half-light.

"Lights on!" She commanded.

The soft magic lights came on but didn't maintain their brilliance—they flickered on and off as if their power source was damaged. The effect of the strobing lights did not help to relieve the sudden fear rising in Adora's throat, only serving to enforce it.

"Lights off." She said, not as forcefully this time, and she was again cast into twilight.

She sat perfectly still for a moment, too disoriented to act, as the memories of the night's recent events solidified in her mind. Catra—she had gone to stop Veth from destroying Zhe-La and themselves at The Great Chaliendra Tree. *Why had Adora allowed herself to fall asleep? How long ago was that? Where the heck was Catra?* It felt like her wife should be back with her by now.

Something was terribly wrong.

Adora lifted herself from the bed, feeling much stronger than she did upon regaining consciousness hours earlier. The short time she spent with Catra and the extra sleep seemed to have sped up the reunion with the missing aspect of her essence. She felt almost like her old self.

After dressing quickly, Adora noticed the door to the room's exit was now fluctuating in and out of existence. It seemed that something was affecting the magic the Madgēcots used on a daily basis; perhaps this was the reason for the uproar.

"Door open," she commanded.

The door did not respond, just continued its strange fluctuation. Adora sighed, then watched the instability for a pattern; after a moment, she spotted it.

After three brief fluctuations, there was a long pause in which the door was solid—then two rapid fluctuations followed by the door vanishing completely for two heartbeats. That was her chance.

Backing up enough to get a running start, Adora mentally timed the right moment using her experience from years of intense Horde training. Feeling that the time was right, she bolted forward, using her powerful leg muscles to quickly propel her forward into a full sprint. She passed through the exit at the exact moment the door was absent, feeling a soft motion of air against her back as the door started to fluctuate again.

Adora glanced up and down the empty hall. The same instability afflicted all the lights and guest doors. Through the noise of the

tumult outside, Adora could hear a cry for help.

She followed the noise, leading her to a guest room not far away. Through the fluctuating door, she could see a person trapped inside their own room—obviously too afraid to take the chance she did. She could barely make them out through the fluttering door, only recognizing a humanoid-shaped being in obvious distress.

"Hold on, I'll get you out!" Adora called as she held up her open hand.

"FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!"

This time, the golden sword stayed in her hand as it appeared, and the trapped being watched with mute awe as Adora transformed into her Champion Avatar—She-Ra.

"Stand back!" She-Ra/Adora shouted before she bisected the door—the two halves fell to either side of the stunned being, continuing their fluctuations as they lay uselessly on the floor.

Upon closer inspection, She-Ra/Adora saw that the being was male and of an unknown species. His skin was light pink and hairless, with two long fleshy appendages protruding from the top of his skull—like tails. Yellow eyes gazed at her fearfully as the man started to back away from She-Ra/Adora in fear. She dismissed her sword and held up her hand soothingly.

"It's okay. I'm here to help you," she said reassuringly. "Do you have any idea what's going on around here? What is happening with the magic?"

The man shook his head slowly. "I have no idea, I visit the Madgēcots on a regular basis, and I have never seen anything disrupt their magic—not once! Something awful must be going on!"

She-Ra/Adora nodded to him. "Okay, I'm going downstairs to see what the House Attendant has to say. Do you want to come with

me?”

The man shook his head, his head tails swaying with the movement.

“I think I will just stay here. I’m sure the Madgēcots are upset—I don’t want to get in their way,” he said fearfully.

She-Ra/Adora shrugged and turned, heading in the direction of the stairs which led to the Guest House’s exit in the middle of the building. When she got to the reception floor she found that no one was there; it was empty.

That’s odd, She-Ra/Adora thought to herself. *Viraj said there was always a Madgēcot in the building. He said they didn’t want their guests to feel alone.*

…She-Ra…

She-Ra/Adora froze, tilting her head and straining her ears.

Did I just hear a voice calling my name? She thought.

She-Ra/Adora listened for a beat longer, looking around the empty reception floor for signs that someone was there, but she saw no one. She shook her head.

I must be hearing things. I’ve been under a lot of stress lately, what with the massive fight with my wife followed by having my empathy ripped out of me and all. She thought blithely.

Returning her attention to the tumult outside, She-Ra/Adora kicked the flickering entrance door, shattering it into pieces, and strode out of the Guest House. The scene that greeted her outside was beyond baffling.

Thousands of Madgēcots were pouring down from multiple locations like a torrent—all heading in the same direction—down towards the forest floor. They ran on all fours down walkways, or crawled down the sides of the massive Jacarandra trees. They slid

down on great ropes, flipping like acrobats at the ends to grab another length of rope to continue their journey downwards. Some even rode what appeared to be massive gliders; they soared downwards like giant birds swooping in for the kill.

On the faces of all the Madgēcots, She-Ra/Adora saw the same anxiety and wrath that she heard in their chorus of voices. She felt a pang of sudden fear in her chest, for she knew that something terrible had happened and that Catra must be involved in it. Catra *and* Veth went to The Great Chaliendra Tree, who knew how long ago. Then it hit her—something must have happened to the Madgēcot's sacred magical tree—that was why the magic was erratic.

She-Ra/Adora let out a massive groan as she realized that the Madgēcots—ALL the Madgēcots—had sensed this somehow, and were rushing to check on The Great Chaliendra Tree. She felt very sorry for whomever they found there messing with it.

She-Ra/Adora started to run in the same direction as the Madgēcots, now very determined to get to The Great Chaliendra Tree before her wife was torn to shreds. Running down the walkway from the Guest House, she came to a broad thoroughfare and found herself in a river of Madgēcots, all going much faster than her. They were unhappy about her getting in the way and yelled at her.

"Get out of the way!"

"Move, offworlder!"

"Who is this massive lunk?"

"Hey!" She-Ra/Adora yelled, thoroughly offended. "That was hurtful! Why are you guys so mean all of a sudden?"

One of the Madgēcots leaped out of the crowd at her, and she was about to raise her hands to defend herself when she recognized Viraj. He clasped her hands in his claws and looked up at her with a frantic look in his heterochromatic eyes.

“Something horrible happened to The Great Chaliendra Tree!” He cried. “I tried to get here as fast as I could! Where is my sister?”

His long black ears lowered when he saw the look on She-Ra/Adora’s face.

“She went to The Great Chaliendra Tree. Catra thought that Veth was going to use the Sword of Sher-Va to destroy themselves. They told her it was the only way to keep Archon Lethe from having the power of Zhe-La. But that was hours ago, Viraj!”

Viraj appeared as if he would weep for a moment, but firm resolve came over his handsome features.

“Come. I think I know a faster route to the Chaliendra—this way!” He beckoned She-Ra/Adora to follow him down a side ramp. She-Ra/Adora followed Viraj as he ran on all fours away from her; the way he led was completely clear of other Madgēcots and appeared to travel into complete darkness.

“Wait up!” She called after him. “Man, you and your sister are fast!”

…She-Ra…

She-Ra/Adora instantly froze as fear flickered through her body. Viraj, seeing that she had stopped, came running back to her.

“What are you doing?” He yelled desperately to her. “We need to move fast!!”

She-Ra/Adora held a hand up for silence as she strained to listen for the strange voice. She had an odd feeling that if she tapped into her She-Ra power, she might be able to hear it clearly. She-Ra/Adora drew on that well-spring of elemental power, drawing a small portion of it for that purpose. She channeled this power not to her ears but her mind, to an unused corner of her brain. She then strained to listen once more.

…She-Ra…can you hear me…?

The shock of a voice forming a complete sentence in her mind almost made her lose concentration, but then she maintained her focus and responded.

…Yes…I can hear you…

Through some unknown means, she felt the speaker smile at her reply.

…Good…I have been trying for a while to reach you…I didn't think you were going to respond to me…

There was something about the speaker's voice that She-Ra/Adora recognized.

…Who is this…? She sent.

…It's me…Veth…I have never had the chance to use this way of speaking before…isn't it fantastic…?

She-Ra/Adora felt confusion mixed with annoyance at Veth's casual voice in her mind.

…This is how Champions of Grayskull communicated with each other over long distances…back when there were more of us…I always wanted to try it…

She-Ra/Adora felt a clawed hand on her wrist and looked down. Viraj was peering up at her with concern plastered on his face.

"Adora, what is the matter?" He asked.

"It's Veth," She said, still sounding confused. "Somehow, they are speaking to me in my mind."

A sudden look of wonder appeared on Viraj's face. "Yes! I remember reading about that! The Ancient Champions were able to communicate with each other telepathically! What is Veth saying? Is my sister okay?"

…Tell Viraj that his sister is just fine…for now…

She-Ra/Adora felt a jolt of panic at Veth's insinuation that harm may come to Catra. She also did not like their evident ability to hear others speak to her—it instantly made her feel vulnerable.

…Veth…what is going on…where is Catra…?

She-Ra/Adora felt a sense of resignation from Veth, it was subtle, but it was there. Whatever they would say to her, they were not happy about it.

…Catra is with me…if you want to see her again, you must do as I say…you see…you were right this whole time, She-Ra…I was planning on betraying you this entire time…you have very good instincts…that is one of the many reasons we must have you…

She-Ra/Adora sighed loudly and turned to Viraj, the anger plain on her face.

"Veth has betrayed us." She said simply. "They are holding Catra hostage, Viraj. I'm trying to find out where they are."

Viraj hissed in outrage and bared his teeth. "Treacherous, Nephraeh! Just wait until I get my claws on them!"

She-Ra/Adora turned from Viraj to resume her concentration.

…What happens if I don't do what you say…?

She felt a mental sigh from Veth through their connection.

…Then I will kill her, She-Ra…please don't make me do it…

…What do you want then…?

…I want you to meet me…I'm at a place near the Imaarat…an abandoned outpost of some kind…bring the

Madgēcot with you…he will know where it is…

She-Ra/Adora closed her eyes and gritted her teeth in a fury.

…Fine, I will do it…just don't you dare hurt Catra…

…That all depends on you…see you soon, She-Ra…

She-Ra/Adora felt a disconnect as Veth severed their mental link. They were gone.

"What do they want, Adora?" Viraj asked, his eyes wide and fearful. "We must get Catra back. I can't lose her again!"

She-Ra/Adora laid a comforting hand on his shoulder and smiled down at him.

"I can't lose her again either, Viraj." She said softly. "We need to meet them somewhere near the Imaarat. They said they were at some abandoned outpost. Do you know where that is?"

A thoughtful look passed briefly over Viraj's cinnamon-colored face, but then he perked up, both of his long ears standing straight.

"Yes! It's a place nearby that I used to play as a child when I was first inducted into the Star Hunters. I will take you there!" He said, indicating they continue in the same direction before. She-Ra/Adora bounded after Viraj as he ran on all fours, down the many ramps and walkways, towards the forest floor.

* * *

The Krypteia carrying her deposited Catra on the ground, having carried her over their shoulder all the way from the burning Chaliendra Tree. As she lay on her stomach, they fastened her bound wrists and ankles together behind her to make her helpless. Her mouth was also gagged; the Krypteia had silenced her when her ceaseless taunting had become too much for them.

Catra enjoyed ruffling the feathers of the proud Nephraeh, even if she did it to her detriment.

Looking around, she saw the ruins of an ancient-looking Madgēcot building nearby. It appeared as if it once was domed, like a smaller version of the Imaarat, but had its roof smashed in long ago. Looking at how thick the stone was that comprised the building, Catra imagined that it must have been a mighty blow to accomplish such a feat. Whatever battles her people fought during the Dark Times, they must have been grim indeed.

It was late night now, and the forest around them buzzed with the sounds of nocturnal creatures. The light of Elysia's moons managed to penetrate the forest canopy, and the soft glow had an enchanting effect on the forest floor. It appeared now as if they were in a dreamscape; the rolling mossy mounds of the ground paired with the mighty pillars of the Jacarandra trees somehow beckoned to Catra—it was a siren call to her inner primal nature. Her pupils dilated as she instantly felt invigorated—she wanted to run, leap, hunt, and give in to the night.

Catra growled as she fought against her bonds, thrashing sideways back and forth like a landed fish. As she was scissoring her upper and lower fangs over the gag, one of the Krypteia spotted her struggling and came to check on her. Catra glared up at them as they leaned down and tested her restraints, ensuring they were still intact. Catra jerked her face away when she saw them reaching for the gag, thinking they would tighten it.

"Easy now, Madgēcot. I only want to remove it." They said calmly. "I see you were trying to bite it in half, and I know there is nothing I can do to stop you from doing so."

Catra recognized Nefeli's voice and stood still as they gently held a single clawed finger out, slicing the gag neatly in half. She spat it on the ground and ran her tongue around in her mouth, trying to get rid of the taste of the fabric.

"Yuck! Where did you get that from? Was it someone's underwear?" She said, leering up at them.

Nefeli chuckled as their eyes glittered down at her through their mask.

"Funny. You know, I'm not sure where Amah got that from," Nefeli said thoughtfully. "I think you may be right, and it was their underclothes. I think those things you were saying about them annoyed them just enough to do something like that."

Catra frowned up at them, not happy with the idea her jest was, in fact, truth.

"Really? Gross!" She said, making a retching face.

Nefeli laughed brightly and gently poked Catra on the nose with a claw tip.

"Got you," they said, still laughing. "No, we would not do something like that to you. I'm sure Amah just summoned it to silence you."

Catra looked up at Nefeli with confusion now, not for the obscure summoning reference but for the subtle changes she noticed in her captors. She felt a strange vibe from them, reminding her of the time Bow and Glimmer had captured her. Those two had managed just barely to subdue her, and they had argued incessantly about whether or not they should hold her for ransom. At the time, Catra made herself believe that their compassion was a weakness to be exploited, but looking back on the person she was, Catra knew she had admired them for it.

The Krypteia had hurt her in the process of subduing her, but they were not cruel. The one she now knew as Amah had constantly shifted her placement on their shoulder whenever she became too uncomfortable, as if they had sensed her discomfort.

But how could they do that without…

“Nefeli, why are you doing this? Deep down, I know the Nephraeh have empathy, but you are suppressing it somehow. Aren’t you?” She said, then realized something. “You don’t have any more of that glowing garbage, do you? The stuff you use in your dumb ritual—you wasted it all on Adora!”

The uncertainty in Nefeli’s eyes confirmed her words, and Catra saw an opening she could exploit.

“Aren’t you starting to feel much better as your empathy comes back? Doesn’t it make you feel like what you are doing is wrong? The other Krypteia must be feeling the same, as well as Veth—”

Catra stopped speaking when a stern-faced Zhe-La/Veth walked up to Nefeli and placed a hand on the Krypteia leader’s shoulder in solidarity.

“Catra seeks to manipulate us, Nefeli. We are so far from The Light now, and we are slipping into darkness.” Zhe-La/Veth said as they gently lifted Nefeli to their feet, then turned them, so the two Nephraeh were facing each other. “But we must be strong. We must complete our mission so we can then return to Empyrea as heroes and bask in the Light of Archon Lethe once more.”

Nefeli, now awed by the splendor of their Champion, nodded up at Zhe-La/Veth.

“Yes, Child of Lethe. Thank your words,” they said, looking back at Catra. “I needed that reminder.”

“I know you did. We all do at this moment,” Zhe-La/Veth said to them reassuringly. “Now, prepare yourself and make sure the Krypteia are ready. I sense that She-Ra is nearing.”

Catra glared up at Zhe-La/Veth as Nefeli walked away to join their comrades. She felt no anger for them at that moment, just intense regret and hopelessness. She knew she was right about the Nephraeh, but just could not get through to them; she felt as if she was running out of time. As she recognized the luminous

light of She-Ra seen from around a large Jacarandra tree, she knew that time was up.

She-Ra/Adora and Viraj were running towards them, pure fury on both their faces, and the Krypteia were there to meet them. Both sides collided into a furious melee of physical and magical attacks that lit the surrounding forest for miles in all directions.

The majority of the Nephraeh assaulted She-Ra/Adora by summoning and launching spiked projectiles from their hands—much like the Vetala did in the Fareek Village. These were all blocked by the magical golden sword of She-Ra, which spun so rapidly it appeared as a golden disc. After she had enough of the Krypteia's ranged attacks, She-Ra/Adora slammed her sword into the ground, creating a massive shockwave that sent her attackers sliding away from her on their backs.

The Krypteia regained their footing, holding out their arms as ethereal indigo light appeared in their eyes and gauntleted hands. They lunged at She-Ra/Adora, slashing at her with claws tainted by the power of Archon Lethe, seeking to drain her of her will once more. But they all failed to land a blow—She-Ra/Adora expertly blocked strikes while delivering kicks and punches, incapacitating at least two Nephraeh as the rest backed away warily.

Viraj was having similar luck in his battle. Upon entering the fray, the Madgēcot had leaped on the nearest Krypteia, pinning them on their back while he slashed at them furiously. Sparks flew as the Krypteia's Aegis Lace armor deflected his claws, and the Nephraeh managed to get their legs under the enraged Viraj to kick him off them, up into the air.

As he somersaulted away from them, Viraj pulled offensive cantrips off his Jaadoo suit and flung them at the Krypteia before landing on his feet. Small explosions appeared on the black armored body of the Nephraeh, and they reeled from the pain of it. As the Krypteia wrapped protective arms around their body, Viraj sent another cantrip missile their way, and bands of

burgundy material wrapped around their arms to pin them. As they struggled against the fabric of his Jaadoo suit, Viraj swept his enemy's feet out from under them and pinned them in place, pulling his fist back to deliver a knockout blow.

"This is for all the Star Hunters you hurt," he hissed, but a mighty blow sent him reeling back to crash at She-Ra/Adora's feet before he could strike.

Dazed, Viraj looked up to see Zhe-La/Veth leaning over the fallen Krypteia, using their black sword to cut their comrade's bonds. Zhe-La/Veth helped the wounded Krypteia to their feet, and the Empyrean champion turned their indigo gaze on Viraj.

"Many on both sides have been hurt, Madgēcot. Make no mistake." They said coldly.

She-Ra/Adora stepped forward with her sword held high.

"Then how about we keep this between us then, Veth?" She challenged. "No more hiding behind lies and deceptions—just you and me, Champion vs. Champion. Unless you are afraid things will turn out like last time?"

She-Ra/Adora's taunts had their intended effect—Zhe-La/Veth strode forward with their sword held low and cold anger smoldering on their lilac face.

"You will regret those words, She-Ra," Zhe-La /Veth said as they lunged at her, the point of their black blade whistling towards her face.

She-Ra/Adora deflected the strike with a one-handed parry, directing the sword to stab harmlessly over her shoulder while punching at Zhe-La/Veth's face with her free hand. Her opponent jerked their head to the side, dodging her blow, and brought their sword hilt in towards their body to deliver another thrust. They feinted, causing She-Ra/Adora to bring her sword into a downward parry and opening her to a headbutt from the Nephraeh champion. She-Ra/Adora stumbled backward as she

held her bruised face; she had not expected such a savage maneuver from her opponent. She spat blood on the ground and glared back at them.

“Are tricks all you’ve got?” She taunted.

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head. “No, I have the power of Oblivion at my disposal.” They said simply as they held their black blade up.

As before, the faint indigo glow emanating from the blade's core intensified, becoming a torch of purple flames. But unlike before, the fire didn’t stop at the sword but traveled down the pommel and onto Zhe-La/Veth’s hands. She-Ra/Adora watched as the flames traveled up Zhe-La/Veth’s arms and then down their torso to the very bottoms of their feet. Their head was the last to be enveloped, and when it did, both of Zhe-La/Veth’s eyes burned like two indigo furnaces.

Their attack was sudden and brutal. Holding their burning blade in a one-handed reverse grip, they hammered against She-Ra/Adora’s raised sword, putting her entirely on the defensive and driving her back. Their strength was immense, and She-Ra/Adora was reminded of her fight with the Shen’Aan-war—another fallen Champion whose power was augmented by evil.

As Zhe-La/Veth continued their assault, She-Ra/Adora felt the emotional coldness again, but more intense, leeching her greatest strength out of her through her core. Like the true cold, this power of Oblivion dominated her with its absolute despair, making her ache down to the very center of her soul. She gritted her teeth, trying to summon her power, the power of healing to counteract it.

For a while, it worked, and She-Ra/Adora was able to counteract the dark power, but Zhe-La/Veth only intensified their will to subdue her, and the power of Oblivion wrapped her in its dread embrace. She quailed under its influence, feeling as if her entire

world was closing in around her and her whole life was a singular point of misery.

She-Ra/Adora thought of her friend, Shen, and his affliction; the way she felt now was what he had described to her. His life of pain had left such an impression on his soul that from time to time, he suffered under anxiety and despair—much like she did now. She-Ra/Adora suddenly had great compassion and respect for her friend; he must be strong indeed to endure this kind of torment.

She-Ra/Adora seized on the kernel of empathy she had kindled for Shen. In her mental view, she held it in her hands and blew on it, stoking the weak embers into flames. Closing her eyes, she placed this flame of compassion into her heart, letting it fuel her battered body, and when she opened her eyes back up, they burned bright blue.

She-Ra/Adora went on the offensive, rushing Zhe-La/Veth with mighty thrusts and overhand strikes of her own. The Nephraeh Champion was momentarily wrong-footed by her rally; they did not understand how she was thwarting their power and backed away from her a step. Just as She-Ra/Adora was performing a two-handed overhand chop, Zhe-La/Veth dismissed their sword and grabbed her descending hands in theirs.

She-Ra/Adora gasped as she made direct contact with Zhe-La/Veth, the power of Oblivion having a greater connection to her and completely smothering the flame she had just manifested. Her golden sword appeared to die before it shattered to pieces, raining down on her surprised face like broken glass that immediately fizzled into sparks. She-Ra/Adora completely lost her connection to her avatar, transitioning out of her She-Ra state. For a moment, Zhe-La/Veth held Adora up off the ground like a rag doll before they slowly lowered her to the ground, where she slumped over, defeated.

“ADORA!!!” Catra screamed as she thrashed wildly at her bonds.

“I see you let me win the last time we fought,” Adora slurred to Zhe-La/Veth as they kneeled before her. They smiled sorrowfully at her as they dismissed their dark power, and Oblivion ceased to engulf their body in flames of apathy. They reached for Adora and gently brushed a loose strand of hair away from her face, almost tenderly.

“Do not feel ashamed,” they said kindly. “When you are with us, you will have this power too. Nothing will be able to stop you then, I promise you.”

Adora looked up at them defiantly.

“I will never join you, Veth. You’re going to have to kill me,” she whispered.

Adora’s words seemed to have a more significant effect on the Nephraeh than she thought they would, and Zhe-La/Veth shook their head in anger—they stood abruptly and strode over to where Catra lay. She looked up at them with wide heterochromatic eyes as Zhe-La/Veth seized her by the back of the neck, lifting her bodily off the ground. Catra kicked and hissed in their gauntleted grasp as Zhe-La/Veth brought the tip of the black sword to just under her chin. Catra stopped struggling as she felt the emotional coldness of the blade and winced from the pain of it being so close.

“CATRA! NO!” Viraj screamed. He started to run on all fours towards the Nephreah Champion, but a look and raised hand from Adora stopped him. He turned towards her looking wholly helpless, and Adora smiled weakly back at him.

“This whole time, you thought it was Catra I was after, when in fact, my entire mission revolved around bringing *you* back to Empyrea.” Zhe-La/Veth shouted. “I swore to Archon Lethe I would succeed, and nothing will make me break my vow! Don’t make me kill Catra, please!”

“Adora! Don’t do it! Please!” Catra shouted through tears. “Veth isn’t going to do it, Adora. They’re bluffing! Trust me!”

Adora walked over to stand before Zhe-La/Veth, gazing up at them coldly. They shook their head at her, one black eyebrow raised.

“Do you really want to take that chance, Adora?” They said frostily. “Don’t forget, I have no compassion. That’s not a smart bet to make with your wife’s life on the line.”

Adora sighed heavily and nodded.

“Yes. I will go with you,” she whispered.

“NOOOO!!!” Catra screeched as she was placed on the ground. She immediately resumed her fighting, desperately seeking release from her bonds to get to Adora. But it was unnecessary. Adora went to her, kneeling in front of her to lift Catra into her arms.

“Shhh...hush, Catra. It will be okay.” She soothed her wife. Viraj had rushed to their side as well, and he placed a hand on Adora’s shoulder, concern plain on his face.

“Adora, please, don't do this!” Catra cried, tears pouring down her face. “I won’t let you do this! Viraj, get these bindings off me!”

Adora turned to Viraj and placed a hand over the one he had put on her shoulder.

“Viraj, can you take care of Catra for me? She is going to need you.” Adora said earnestly.

Viraj nodded. “Are you sure you want to do this, Adora?”

The look on Viraj’s face told Adora that the Madgēcot would fight to the death if she asked it of him, but she nodded to him.

“NO! ADORA, NO!” Catra continued to plead, her voice becoming hoarse from all shouting.

Viraj’s ears lowered, and he began to growl as two Krypteia came up behind Adora. Gently, they lifted her to her feet, placing black fabric bindings around Adora’s arms and legs which immediately shrunk to the appropriate size once fastened around her. She began to sway, almost losing her balance.

“Catra, I love you! I love you more than life itself!” Adora shouted as Zhe-La/Veth picked her up in their arms. Adora leaned out around Zhe-La/Veth’s shoulders as they began to walk away to peer back at Catra and her brother.

“Adora! I love you! I promise I will find you! I love you!” Catra shouted back.

Catra wept as she watched the Nephraeh procession get smaller, making their way over the rolling landscape in the direction of the spaceport. They were moving fast, eager to escape with their prize, and it was not long before they disappeared entirely behind a large Jacarandra tree.

“ADORAAA!!!” Catra screamed.

“Hold still, sister!” Viraj cried as he reached for her.

Viraj seized Catra’s bonds in his claws, severing them entirely in one slicing motion. Now free, Catra leaped to her feet and shoved her brother away from her.

“How could you!” She screamed angrily at him. “How could you just stand there and let them take her?!”

Viraj seized his sister by the shoulders and gazed into her eyes.

“Cat-Tra, it's not too late! They are heading to the starport. If we are quick, we can get there before them!” He said urgently.

“Then what? We try and fight them? That didn’t turn out so well the last time.” Catra retorted.

Viraj shook his head. “No. I have already alerted the other Star Hunters. They will be waiting for the Nephraeh at their ships. There is no way they will leave Elysia.” He said confidently.

Hope surged in Catra’s heart. “How? How did you contact them?”

Viraj shook his head angrily. “I have no time to explain. We must hurry!”

Brother and sister bounded on all fours over the rolling terrain of the Jacarandra forest, much like any Madgēcot would do over the many centuries. Clouds had completely covered Elysia’s moons, and the forest was bathed in complete darkness now, but Catra found she could still make her way through instinct.

The sounds she and her brother made as they ran reflected off of ground and tree back at them to be received by their long ears, giving them a three-dimensional mental view of their surroundings.

The distinct smells of their quarry could easily be detected, allowing the pair to bypass the escaping Nephraeh through stealth. It was not long until they saw the immense shape of the Imaarat through the trees and the jagged outline of the Empyrean shuttle still situated on the landing platform nearby. Catra could detect the smells of Madgēcots nearby—many Madgēcots—verifying that her brother had indeed contacted the Star Hunters.

“Where are they, Viraj? The Star Hunters?” She said, straining her eyes to see them in the weak light.

“They are hiding, waiting for the right moment to spring their ambush. Come.” He said, indicating they move toward the mossy mound nearby the landing pad. Once over the crest of the small hill, fifteen sets of shining eyes turned in their direction—it was the Star Hunters. Catra immediately recognized the distinctive

green eyes of Maira and the bright white Jaadoo suit of Aadhya and made her way over to them.

“Catra!” Aadhya said in greeting. “Viraj told us everything! I promise you that those treacherous snakes won’t make it off Elysia with Adora!”

Catra saw Maira nod in agreement, and she smiled in thanks at the two female Madgēcots.

“I hope you have a good plan. Those Krypteia are mean, and Zhe-La was powerful enough to beat She-Ra by themselves,” Catra said, ears down in trepidation.

“Don’t worry, Catra. We have a little surprise for the Nephraeh.” Maira said reassuringly.

“Hush now! Here they come!” Aadhya said, pointing.

Looking in the direction the elder Madgēcot indicated, Catra saw the Krypteia trot out from behind a Jacarandra tree with Zhe-La/Veth carrying Adora at the rear. The Nephraeh looked wearily around the clearing that encompassed the area around the Imaarat, breaking into an open run once they deemed the way was clear.

Aadhya lifted her forearm to her mouth, and a section of her Jaadoo suit turned yellow at her wrists.

“Now! Activate the cantrips!” She commanded.

A series of small explosions dotted the Nephraeh shuttle, and the entire ship went up in a massive fireball that bathed the Nephraeh in orange light. They immediately halted in their tracks, looking around themselves to locate an avenue of escape.

“Now! Reveal yourselves!” Aadhya said into her wrist as she rose from her hiding place.

Catra and the Madgēcots ran down the slope of their hiding place just as three other Star Hunter teams appeared. The Krypteia formed a tight circle around Zhe-La/Veth and Adora as the Madgēcots closed in on them—they were surrounded.

The Star Hunters stopped a distance away from their enemies, not wanting to spook them into doing anything rash as Aadhya stepped forward.

“Nephraeh! You are cut off with no means of escape!” She yelled. “Hand over Adora and surrender! You must answer for the crimes you committed on this day!”

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head, amusement written on their lilac features.

“Crimes? What crimes? We are only evening the playing field so you no longer have an advantage over us!” They said with scorn. “We Nephraeh lifted the Madgēcots from their life of misery, making you what you are today! And what do you do in thanks? You forsake us and trap us on our planet! NO MORE!”

Aadhya sighed and shook her head. “You will have plenty of time to plead the Empyreans case, Veth. The Madgēcots are a fair people, and with your smooth tongue, I’m sure something can be worked out. But right now, there is only surrender. That is your only option.”

“No, Pratham, you're wrong,” Zhe-La/Veth said as indigo light blazed in their eyes. “There is another option.”

From the forest outside the clearing, strange whispers could be heard, coming from all directions. With ears lowered, the Madgēcots looked fearfully as they tried to spot the source of the ethereal voices in the inky blackness between the Jacarandra trees. Catra felt a jolt of fear as she saw a piece of that darkness separate itself and move forward towards them. More followed suit, and as they got closer, Catra saw the shapes solidify into humanoid forms—lithe bodies of the utmost black, long ears on

the sides of bald heads, fanged mouths open to bite, hands outstretched to reveal clawed fingers. She instantly recognized them.

The Vetala.

The Elysians hissed in outrage as their tails bushed up and claws extended; they turned to face this dread foe as the Vetala bounded towards them on all fours—much like a Madgēcot would do.

But the Vetala did not seek to engage with the Star Hunters—they leaped over their heads and continued towards the Nephraeh. The onyx creatures piled on top of their kindred—clutching at them as if they were devotees—and formed a shield of black bodies. The Madgēcots watched in incomprehensible wonder at this strange behavior, unsure what to do next.

The answer came soon as the mass of Vetala began to melt—like candles exposed to intense heat—slowly forming a giant puddle of black oil. As the Vetala started to sink towards the ground, so, too, did the Nephraeh along with their prize—Adora. Catra watched in horror as her wife was slowly consumed into the substance—as if she was disappearing into a giant black hole.

Or a portal.

"NOOO!!!" Catra shrieked. She ran as hard as she could, tearing the ground with her claws in desperation to reach the escaping Nephraeh. But she was not fast enough; Catra had only enough time to watch her wife mouth the words *I love you* before her head sank under the surface of the black oil along with Zhe-La/Veth's.

The large puddle—or portal—began to shrink in on itself, and in one last desperate act, Catra leaped towards it with hand outstretched to reach into the darkness for Adora. Mossy ground slammed into her face as she landed, and Catra howled with fury at her failure.

“NOOO!!! NOOO!!! NOOO!!!” She screamed, tearing at the ground with her claws as if she could dig her way to Adora.

But it was too late. Adora was already long gone and far away—whisked away from Catra by the treacherous Veth. Catra had lost Adora, perhaps for good this time.

“ADORAAA!!!” Catra screamed towards the sky—but there was no answer, only the cold silence of darkness. A darkness that was now filling her heart.

Despair

Chapter Summary

For the second time in her life, Catra has lost the person she treasures the most.

Will Catra turn back into the person she once was?

Adora is brought before the leader of the Nephraeh to face her new destiny.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Great Chaliendra Tree burned in the night as ethereal jade fire coruscated up and down the length of the ancient tree, bathing it in its magical protection. The flames raged in life-like fury, seeking the source of the attack on The Great Chaliendra Tree and focusing their heat on the Sword of Sher-Va impaled in the trunk. But the sword remained where it was, embedded in the tree's body, so close to piecing its heart and destroying it.

The flames and the sword had formed an endless loop of cause and effect that could not be stopped. The sword summoned the fire, and they, in turn, kept the blade in place, for try as they might, the Madgēcots could not figure out how to remove the sword of Sher-Va. The self-defensive magic of the tree had never been encountered before, and it was entirely outside their realm of understanding.

Even the magically endowed Jaadoogar were helpless to penetrate the barrier; at best, they were only effective in soothing the tree enough to calm and stabilize the magic it provided. The chaotic state that Adora had encountered upon waking hours earlier had now passed, and the power of the Madgēcot's was stabilized.

But The Great Chaliendra Tree still burned; its wondrous song could no longer be heard—there was too much hurt and anger in its primeval soul. There was too much rage. Where once there was beautiful music, now there was only a low howl of agony. The Great Chaliendra Tree broadcasted a mournful dirge as if in desperation to be heard—and this message was indeed received.

Thousands upon thousands of glittering eyes surrounded the tree and reflected the green flames in confirmation that they shared this pain. That they shared this rage. The Madgēcots filled the air with screams and cries of outrage and fury. It was as if they were no longer sentient beings, but dread ghosts summoned for only one purpose—revenge.

Empathy was no longer found in this place; the Madgēcots were now the embodiment of wrath. Even now, preparations were being made for war. The Empyreans would soon find out what it meant to wrong their once allies. Soon, the wrath of the Madgēcots would be upon them.

But there was one here who did not share the emotions of her people. Down below on the ground near the base of The Great Chaliendra Tree, a Madgēcot wept. Catra lay on her side with arms and legs tucked up into her body—the picture of despair and misery. Having just lost the one thing that meant everything to her in this lifetime, she was now cast adrift in an endless sea of darkness.

This is all my fault. This is all my fault. This is all my fault. This is all my fault. This is all my fault. This is all my fault. This is all my fault. This is all my fault. This is all my fault.

The words echoed ceaselessly in her mind like a mantra, her penitence for showing empathy to someone who did not deserve it. For not listening to the one she loved.

Adora told you! She loved you and was trying to protect you! YOU DIDN'T LISTEN! She thought with so much anger directed upon herself. She slammed a fist into her forehead repeatedly.

You deserve this. You deserve this. You deserve this. You deserve this. You deserve this. You deserve this. You deserve this. You deserve this. You deserve this. You deserve this.

Catra now hugged herself and began rocking side to side as tears streamed down her face. She was alone again. This was her life—to have no one and nothing, to constantly bear the brunt of life's sorrow in a never-ending state of desolation.

Catra felt the structure of the person that she had worked so hard to build over the past two years begin to collapse upon itself. She was now digressing, inch by inch, into the person she worked so hard to leave behind.

"NOOOOO!!!!" She screamed, desperately trying to hold onto herself, to maintain the virtue she so cherished in herself.

Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go. Don't let go.

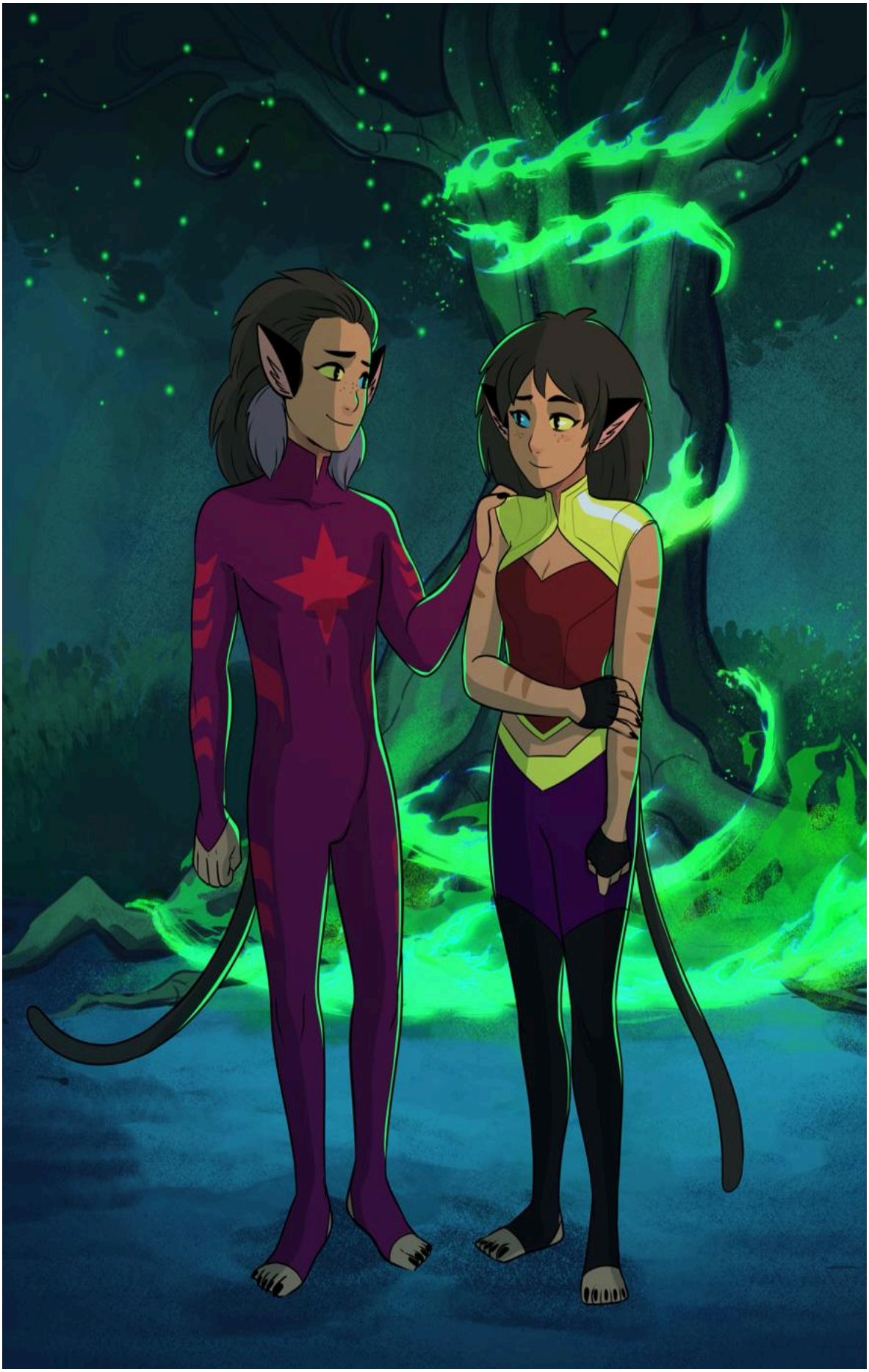
But Catra couldn't maintain the balance; the night's tragic events had fractured her psyche, leaving her vulnerable to despair. Clutching at her face, Catra squeezed her eyes shut as she felt herself slip with no way of stopping herself.

"Somebody...heeelllp meeeeee!!! I'M SO ALONE!" She screamed through clenched teeth.

A clawed hand grasped her shoulder, instantly jarring Catra out of her downward spiral. It was a firm but gentle touch, and it acted as an anchor in the whirlpool of her self-destruction.

"Sister! It's okay, you're not alone! You will never be alone again!"

Catra opened her eyes, finding herself gazing into a heterochromatic pair so much like her own. Viraj gazed down at her with love as he gently coaxed her to her feet; Catra suddenly felt ashamed and embarrassed by her outburst, but her emotions left her as Viraj wrapped her in his arms.



“It’s okay, Cat-tra. We will face this together.” He said as he started to purr.

Catra was initially put off by his affection but then slowly sank against him, the sound and feel of his purr reawakening old memories of comfort she never knew she had. Catra returned the embrace, laying her head on Viraj’s shoulder as she began to purr as well.

“Thank you, brother,” Catra said, tears of happiness replacing the ones of sorrow. “I felt myself slipping away for a moment. I couldn’t help it.”

Catra felt Viraj nod as he rubbed her back. “It’s okay, Cat-tra. You are my sister, and you are strong—but everyone needs a little help once in a while.”

Both siblings parted to look up at the Madgēcots all around them. Their people had started to sing—not a song from The Great Chaliendra Tree—but one that came from within them. It sounded old and fierce, and the area around the Catra and Viraj seemed to vibrate with its power.

“What are they singing, Viraj?” Catra said, looking up at the Madgēcots with wonder.

“It is an old song—an ancient song. One not sung for thousands of years. Since the Dark Times.” He responded with awe.

Catra was swept up in its call as Viraj began to sing along with their people. The Madgēcots were proud and strong—nothing seemed to be able to stop them. An intense pride started to blossom in Catra’s chest; pride in the Madgēcots and herself. The earlier self-pity melted away in the presence of thousands upon thousands of voices raised in an anthem of martial strength.

Why had she been so filled with doubt earlier? Hadn’t she been in a worse situation when Adora had left the Horde? She had been alone then, and neither she nor Adora knew their love for each

other. Not only did they know now, but they were married, and looking at her people, Catra instantly felt far from alone.

Catra began to sing along with her people as a fire lit in her heart. She smiled fiercely at her twin brother, who nodded, returning her smile with a feral one of his own.

I'm going to get Adora back, Catra thought to herself. *Even if I have to tear Empyrean down piece by piece.*

And Veth is going to pay for what they did to me.

* * *

Darkness greeted Adora's eyes, a darkness so deep that it seemed to weigh upon her like a heavy blanket. It was thick and vicious, like a fluid, but instead of floating in it, she felt like she was sinking in it. Adora sensed a vastness to the blackness, an infinite expansion of incomprehensible night, but instead of feeling open, it only smothered in her a feeling of desperate claustrophobia.

Adora began to scream, but no sound came out as she began to feel the darkness rushing down her throat, like a fist seeking to squeeze her heart. Wild desperation coursed through her as she tried to flail her arms and legs—but they were still bound. Suddenly hands were upon her, drawing her close to their owner, who pulled her through the murk. Adora felt herself cradled in someone's arms like a baby, and she was lifted out of the darkness towards light.

Looking around, it appeared as if she was in a vast chamber and she was being carried up a small flight of stairs out of a pool. Peering below her, she saw that the pool did not contain water but the horrible essence that transported her from Elysia to wherever she was now. Other figures were climbing out of the pool. As the liquid night slid off them completely, Adora recognized the armored forms of the Krypteia. They pulled their black helmets off and smiled at each other, visibly happy to be done with their mission and away from the Madgēcots.

“We did it, Champion Veth!” Nefeli cried. “For a moment, I thought we were done for! Thank the Light for the Vetala! I thought you destroyed them all at the Fareek Village?”

Adora looked up into the face of the person carrying her—Zhe-La/Veth. They grinned at Nefeli.

“No, I did not destroy them. I merely scattered their essence for a short duration. They re-formed in the forest not long after. I merely had to call them.” Zhe-La/Veth said with a smirk.

Zhe-La/Veth looked down at Adora and smiled. A sudden rage filled her at the Nephraeh’s jubilation at her expense.

“It disgusts me how you use your people as nothing more than tools to be discarded when you no longer need them,” she said, voice dripping with scorn.

Nefeli walked over to them, confusion plain on their face.

“What in the name of Empyrea is she talking about, Veth?” They asked.

Zhe-La/Veth was still smiling as they placed Adora on the ground to stand on her own two feet.

“Adora is referring to one of the many...*fictions* I told Catra,” they said unhappily. “I told Adora’s wife that the Vetala were Nephraeh whose hunger for empathy overcame them, turning them into monsters.”

Nefeli burst out into laughter and came over to lay a hand on Adora’s shoulder.

“That is completely not true!” Nefeli said, still chuckling. “The Vetala are simply phantoms of Archon’s Lethe’s power—pure magic! We would never use our people like that!”

Adora looked back at Veth, cold fury blazing in her eyes.

“Were you honest about anything?” She hissed.

Adora was surprised that her words affected the Nephraeh Champion; they looked away from her in shame.

“I did not enjoy lying to you all,” they said tonelessly. “But it was necessary to complete my mission.”

“That’s a great comfort, Veth; I feel all warm and fuzzy now,” Adora said, her words dripping with sarcasm.

“But there were many truths sown within the lies,” Zhe-La/Veth said as they returned their gaze to her. “The Nephraeh are at the unfair mercy of the Madgēcots, and we do need your help.”

Now it was Adora’s turn to laugh. “You really think that after everything you put me through, I’m going to help you?” She said incredulously. “Fat chance!”

Zhe-La/Veth nodded, letting out a resigned sigh as they reverted out of their Champion form, becoming just Veth once again. They reached out and placed their hands on Adora’s leg bindings—she felt them disappear and now could move her legs.

“Your attitude will change once you meet Archon Lethe,” they said to her quietly.

Veth gently led Adora away from the pool and farther into the large chamber; the air was cool and dense here, giving Adora the impression of being underground. The vast area was lit by soft lights high above, bathing everything below in perpetual twilight. Immense pillars, as wide around as one of the Jacaranda trees on Elysia, dotted the space, supposedly holding the expansive roof up over their heads. As Veth and the Krypteia led Adora around one of these pillars, she spotted what lay in the center of this strange cavern, and Adora gaped with awe.

It was the most beautiful building she had ever seen—nothing on Etheria or any of the planets she had visited since could match its splendor. It seemed organic—as if it was spun from pure white

sugar—and the entire structure was composed of a series of interlocking arches that swept up from the ground to meet at a single point above. At this focus, a light shone—it was a strange light, simultaneously beautiful and unpleasant. A radiant brilliance surrounded a single point of deep indigo—like a maleficent star of despair.

Adora had to look away from this light, not liking how it made her feel, and concentrated on the area surrounding the beautiful building. She noticed that she appeared to be walking on bare dirt now—it seemed desiccated and ancient—as if the rich soil it was once composed of withered away long ago. Here and there, Adora spotted groupings of crystals—they looked ugly and dead as if they had stopped growing and started to fester. She walked over to a collection of these crystals and prodded them with her toe—it immediately crumbled into a fine white powder, and she shook the remains off her shoe.

"This was once my most favorite place in the whole universe," a powerful Nephraeh voice said behind her.

Surprised, Adora turned to see who had spoken, looking to see that the Krypteia and Veth were all on the ground, kneeling in supplication. Looking in the direction they kneeled, Adora was again struck by an incredible sight.

A Nephraeh, unlike any of the ones that accompanied her, strode out of the structure. They were immense—much taller than her in her She-Ra form—and they exuded dark majesty. Their skin and hair were pure white while their eyes burned with searing indigo light that made Adora look away—it was like looking into the sun. They were dressed in a variation of the same clothes Veth wore but more archaic and extravagant—Adora had a sense she was looking at a fashion from eons past.

Striding over to where Adora was standing, the immense Nephraeh gazed down upon her; Adora had to force herself not to flinch from the sheer magnitude and presence of this colossal being. Slowly and hesitantly, she made herself look up at their

face while steering away from the eyes—a difficult task. Adora immediately looked down at her feet when they smiled at her, exposing black serrated teeth and pronounced fangs—reminding her of the dread Vetala.



“Welcome to Empyrea, Adora. I am Archon Lethe.” The Nephraeh before her said.

Adora could feel their gaze upon her as two stabbing points of intense cold upon the top of her head. She had to force herself not to tremble as her gaze crept back up to their face, finally stopping at their chin. She summoned all her courage to speak.

“What was it you just said? About this being your favorite place?” Adora said, trying not to sound meek.

Adora felt the cold leave her as Archon Lethe looked at the strange crystals at her feet.

“This was once a garden, a very long time ago.” They said thoughtfully. “These crystals are called Fire Tails, and their beauty once enhanced the splendor of this place. As for why this was my favorite place…”

Archon Lethe seemed to ponder the question; their sudden uncertainty was unnerving.

“You know, I’m not sure why it was my favorite,” they laughed. “Perhaps it was just that—their once magnificent beauty! As you can see, it has long since faded.”

Adora looked behind her, towards Veth and the Krypteia kneeling, and she now felt annoyed. These people had kidnapped her and dragged her to this bizarre place for what? To talk about nonsense?

Adora let that annoyance turn to anger which in turn increased her boldness. She forced her gaze back to Archon Lethe—up their face—and back to the two burning points. Tears ran down from squinting eyes as Adora looked the ruler of the Nephraeh straight in the eyes.

“So, Archon Lethe, did you drag me from my honeymoon for a chit-chat, or was there a point to all this?” Adora said fiercely.

"*Adora!!!*" Veth hissed behind her. "You mustn't speak to the Archon that way!"

Archon Lethe laughed—cold, hard and devoid of any genuine merriment. Their deep indigo eyes seemed to pulse as they blazed into her, making Adora want to fold into herself and disappear—but she held her ground.

Archon Lethe waved Veth's protestations away. "It's okay, my Child. Adora is new here; she will soon learn our ways." They said with a sinister tone. "I think it's time we show Adora what we brought her here for."

Veth immediately stepped forward. "Shall I retrieve the Antithetical Philter, my Archon?"

Archon Lethe shook their head, still maintaining their cold stare at Adora. She instantly felt dread seep into her body.

"No, Veth. I think Adora here needs something more potent," they said meaningfully. "I think this calls for a full Enervation; I must use all my powers of Oblivion on her."

Adora looked at Veth, seeing uncertainty in their glittering silver eyes.

"But, Archon Lethe, is that really necessary?" Veth said, concern plain in their voice. "I mean, what will be left if you take away who she is?"

Archon Lethe's gaze left Adora and speared into Veth as the Nephraeh Champion started to back away from that baleful gaze.

"My Child, is it prudence that summons your words, or is it compassion?" Archon Lethe asked dangerously.

Adora could not see Veth, for they had backed out of her view; she did not dare turn her back on the dangerous person before her.

“My...my Archon...I…I have been far from your Light for so long. I’m afraid I have begun to slip,” Veth said with trepidation.

Archon Lethe’s facial expression softened as they regarded Veth and their demeanor became benevolent.

“My Child, there is nothing wrong with admitting weakness, and I appreciate your honesty.” They said kindly. “Perhaps it is time for you to absorb a larger measure from the Antithetical Philter during the Penumbra Ritual?”

“Yes, my Archon, you are right,” Veth conceded. “I apologize for questioning your wisdom; it was ungrateful of me,”

Archon Lethe nodded in appreciation, turning their attention back to Adora.

“Now, my dear. It’s time for you to join our ranks.” They said quietly.

The unease returned to Adora as she gazed into the white visage of Archon Lethe.

“What do you plan on doing to me?” She asked, no longer able to mask the fear in her voice.

Archon Lethe smiled at her, revealing all their sharp black teeth; the upper and lower fangs seemed to absorb all light in their utter darkness. Her mind flashed to a memory of teeth trying to sink into her neck. Black, sharp teeth so much like the ones she looked at now. The fear became absolute terror as Adora realized what Archon Lethe intended.

“No…” Adora whispered as she backed away from the terrible Nephraeh.

She backed into a body, and two strong arms pinned her and held her in place as Archon Lethe began to walk towards her, lips parted in dread intention.

"Just calm down, Adora. It will be over quickly." Veth whispered in her ear.

"NOOO!!!" She screamed as she fought against Veth, but more hands seized her as the Krypteia joined Veth holding her in place. Archon Lethe was upon her now—they kneeled to reach her; mouth open to bite. A cool hand covered her eyes as Veth attempted to spare her the sight of the approaching horror.

"Try to relax," Veth soothed.

Adora felt cold lips press against her—but there was only intense vertigo instead of the pain of teeth. She felt something creep into her from her neck. It was the blackness from before, the vast, unknowable darkness smothering her in its ultimate weight. Adora began to panic, to fight against the tide of nothing that was sweeping through her—she reached out for She-Ra.

No…Adora…you don't need She-Raaaaaaa…just give innnnnn…

A feeling of softness accompanied the strange words in her mind like an anesthetic, and memories were brought forth. They were happy memories of good times, and in her mind's eye, they appeared as separate images floating above an ocean of disregard.

Something new is in her bunk room—a strange cardboard box sitting near the door.

"Hey, Lonnie, what's that?" she asks.

Her friend looks to where she is pointing with a frown on her child's face as she scratches her head.

"I dunno Dora; I think Shadow Weeber left it. I wouldn't touch it though, sumth'in inn-it is growl'in," her friend said in warning.

She doesn't listen to her friend; Lonnie is always unwilling to look beneath the outer surface of anything. She goes to the box and

knocks on the top, where the cardboard flaps are folded into each other.

"Hello?" she asks.

She hears scrabbling noises from within, like claw sliding—then—a high-pitched growl.

"Go away!" a voice says from within.

She hears nothing but fear and loneliness in that voice—it makes her do the opposite of what she was told. She opens the flaps to look within.

She sees two long, furry, black ears sticking out of a fuzzy dark gray ball which slowly unfolds to reveal the most beautiful eyes she has ever seen. One is blue, and the other yellow and they are slitted like a kitty cat. They both gaze at her uncertainly.

"Hi! My name is Adora!" She exclaims happily. "What's your name?"

The uncertainty leaves those pretty eyes, and hope replaces them. The ball of fur speaks.

"My name is—"

Adora watched the memory sink into the black ocean in her mind-eye, and another memory took its place.

Catra giggles under the covers of her bed as she holds the flashlight between them.

"Shhh!!! Someone is going to hear you!" She scolds.

"Oh, don't be a baby; no one will tell on us!" Catra says as she reaches over to her. Catra's hands find the right spots on her sides and begins to tickle her, making her immediately squirm.

"S—Stop that!" She protests between laughing fits.

"You have to give me something in return!" Catra says while increasing the intensity of the tickling. It is unbearable now, and she tries to grab Catra's hands, but her friend is too quick.

"O—Okay! Okay!" She says between gasps. "Anything!"

"Hmmm…" Catra says thoughtfully. "You have to...mmm...give me a kiss!"

She stops struggling as Catra's tickles cease, and a warm flush rises in her cheeks.

"Okay—"

That memory too, sunk into the depths, and another took its place.

It was late at night in the bunk room, and as usual, Catra had crept down from her bunk to lie next to her.

"So, is there anyone in the Horde you—you know—like?" Catra asks her.

She laughs at this. "I like you, dummy!"

Catra sighs loudly in exasperation. "No...I mean liiiike. That you think is attractive and…"

"And what?" She asks, confused. Catra was vague sometimes; it was like she was fishing for something.

A rare look comes over Catra's face—a shy look.

"You know, you want to kiss them or something…" Her friend finishes, sounding annoyed.

"Oh!" She says as she finally catches Catra's meaning. "Well, I don't know...the only person I ever kissed was you...but that was years ago. I don't know, Catra, I haven't thought about it."

Catra is quiet for a moment, and then she speaks.

"Yeah, me too. I don't really think about it either." Catra whispers.

Suddenly, she thinks about that kiss with Catra. They were so young when they did that—it was just a quick peck on the lips. She didn't remember much about it other than she thought it was nice—perhaps now it would be different since they were older.

"Hey, Catra?" She asks.

"Hmm?"

"Let's try it again. For fun." She says.

"Try what, dummy?"

"You know...like when we were little. Just see what it's like." She says in a tentative hush.

She sees Catra's heterochromatic shining eyes widen in the dark, and her ears perk up.

"Oh! Uhhh...yeah, okay. Let's try it again." Catra says with a small smile. "For fun."

She closes her eyes and leans in to—

Another memory disappeared to be replaced by another, which in turn, also disappeared. It started happening faster now—so many memories dropped like rain to be consumed in the infinite void.

There was one of her and Catra sparring against each other as cadets. Catra had knocked her down and helped her to her feet, unable to hide the sorrow on her face.

I

A memory of when Catra had her distinctive maroon headpiece made. She had caught her wearing it while looking in the mirror and making serious faces while pretending to give commands to non-existent Horde soldiers.

Will

This one was after she left the Horde and joined the rebellion. It was the Princess Prom, and Catra had crashed it while wearing a purple tuxedo. She cornered her on the dance floor, and they danced—at the time, she had felt angry with Catra but exhilarated. When Catra dipped her, she was surprised how much she enjoyed the way she felt against her—it was all she could do not to kiss her enemy.

Make

She had just rescued Catra from Horde Prime and brought her back from death's doorstep. Catra opened her beautiful eyes to gaze up at her, smiling weakly.

"*Hey, Adora,*"

You

"Don't you get it? I love you; I always have!"

The admission of love had brought her from the brink of death, and she awoke in Catra's arms below the Heart of Etheria.

"You love me?" She had asked.

Catra chuckles. "You're such a dummy—"

Catra's heterochromatic eyes widen, and her ears perk up when she sees the expression on her face.

"I love you too."

MINE

The memories continued to fall, and with the increasing love they now contained, they appeared more beautiful now—like gems refracting starlight. The last one disappeared, sinking below the surface, and to Adora, this fact had absolutely no significance. She

had been completely hollowed out and felt weightless from the absence of so much life lived.

But Adora was not empty. There was still so much to her—she was still the strong-willed woman with the drive for excellence.

I like that…

She was still a fierce fighter, a natural with any form of combat with a firm grasp of tactics.

Yes, that will serve me well…

She still had She-Ra, the Magical Avatar that was bound to her for life and could be called forth at any moment.

The best and most valuable thing about you…

She was still the caring and compassionate person who would fight for her friends, for those in need, and those who are so lost to themselves that all they need is for someone to believe in them.

You won't need that anymore…

She still had a strong moral compass which firmly grounded her in the difference between right and wrong.

I will be your compass now…

She still had the capacity for love; even if she had forgotten who this love was for, it could still blossom if she ever encountered the right person. The seed was still in her heart, waiting to be nurtured and grow.

This is very dangerous to me…

Like the memories before, parts of her were consumed in the ocean. She watched them fall away, feeling utterly unconcerned

that she had become the absolute antipathy of what she worked so hard to stand for all her life.

She now felt more potent, ferocious, and powerful the way she was now. She was ready to dominate and use the powerful magic given to her for her own needs—instead of others. She no longer remembered that once she strove to be the embodiment of virtue—such things were meaningless and for weaker, lesser beings than her. This was her time now; for her and not anyone else, she would make the power of She-Ra burn across the universe.

Let everyone despair.

Ahhhh…very good…now awaken, my Child…

* * *

She awoke.

Confusion immediately clouded her mind; she did not know where she was or, more importantly, who she was. Sitting up, she saw that she was lying on a raised surface amidst a grand luminous space. Everything around her, including the plinth she was on, was constructed of a pearl-white material that seemed alive. It looked brittle and weak—she immediately disliked it.

In fact, there was nothing about her surroundings that she liked; it spoke of shortcomings and limitations. It was too gaudy and bright to her eyes, and she had to squint against the glare of its light.

Wanting to leave this place, she slid off the plinth to stand on two feet, and as she did so, she caught sight of what she was wearing.

Her entire body was encased in form-fitting armor—it was fantastic, like intersecting bands of black metal woven together seamlessly together to form a perfect defense. She tested this armor, striking against the surface of her stomach with her fist

and feeling the bands tighten to deflect the blow. She barely felt a thing.

"Marvelous," she said out loud.

"I'm glad to see you are awake," a powerful voice called.

That voice instantly resonated with her, and she looked for its source; it was like a clarion call. She did not have to look far as an immense being strode into the room, smiling at her. Long white hair framed an androgynous white face, and powerful indigo eyes held her gaze in rapt fascination. The smile was perhaps the most attractive part of this being; white lips parted to reveal dangerously sharp and deadly teeth of the utmost black.

They were like a terrible god, and it was all she could do to stop herself from kneeling before them to submit to their power. They stopped not far from her to regard her, studying her with those wonderful indigo eyes that burned her with their intensity. She could not look away from that gaze, for as much as it pained her, she yearned for the power in it.

"Who are you?" She asked boldly.

The being looked sad at her words. "I was afraid of this," they said with a slow shake of their head. "Our enemy's plan had worked—the magic they used upon you has taken your memory from you. I am Archon Lethe, my Child. I am your Lord."

This made sense to her; memory loss accounted for her confusion, and the fact that this mighty being was her superior was also right—for now.

"Is our friend awake, Archon Lethe?" Another voice said. It came from the same direction as the other being and sounded nowhere near as powerful as the other.

Another being appeared from behind the one now known as Archon Lethe; they were smaller in stature, perhaps as large as she was, and had light purple skin instead of white. There were

other differences, too; black hair instead of white, and their eyes did not glow with that supreme power but shone like mirrors. They smiled at her; not as dangerous as Archon Lethe's smile, but after feeling her teeth with her tongue, she realized hers was even less so than theirs. She didn't like how it made her feel inferior not to have such deadly fangs.

The newcomer came to stand next to Archon Lethe, and they gazed up at the greater being in admiration. Archon Lethe turned to them and smiled fondly, like an owner regarding a dear pet.

"Do you remember your dear comrade in arms?" Archon Lethe asked as they turned to her. "This is my other child, Veth,"

She studied this Veth, not recognizing them in the least bit. There was a feminine attractiveness to them, which she now realized was her preference, but this was marred by something about them she could not place a finger on. But then she realized what it was; it was the difference in how the two beings looked at her.

Where Archon Lethe's gaze seemed to assert its dominance over her, letting her firmly know where she stood with them, Veth's gaze was different. They were not looking at her as a potential rival or threat, but as someone they genuinely wanted as an ally. Veth wanted a partner, a comrade to stand by their side—perhaps even a friend.

Weak, she thought with disgust, turning her attention back to Archon Lethe. There was one other thing she needed to know.

"Who am I, my Lord?" She asked, now allowing some deference to creep into her voice.

Archon Lethe placed both of their massive, white hands on her shoulders. She saw claws on the tips of the fingers as they passed her head; it sent a giddy thrill through her to know how close they were to her neck and could quickly kill her.

"Your name is Despara," Archon Lethe said in almost a whisper.

"Despara," she said, liking how the word sounded in her mouth. She noticed that Veth visibly winced at the sound of her name—as if they did not like the sound of it.

They fear my name, Despara thought with satisfaction.

"Now, Despara, there is one other thing we must know," Archon Lethe said with visible concern. "We must know if you can still access your power—your She-Ra power."

Confusion once again raced through Despara's mind as she tried to remember. She did not want to come up short and disappoint Archon Lethe—she did not want to be weak. A faint hint of something touched her mind, but then it was gone, like a curious animal retreating as it sensed a predator.

"I'm not sure, Archon Lethe. Perhaps if I have a reminder?" Despara asked tentatively.

Archon Lethe nodded magnanimously. "Veth, perhaps if you demonstrate the power of Zhe-La, Despara will also remember her abilities?"

Zeth nodded and backed a step away from them, and Despara watched them intently as they raised a hand into the air—as if they were holding a sword.

"BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!!!" They shouted.

Dark light, the same intensity found in Archon Lethe's eyes, seared Despara's eyes as it shone forth from the center of Veth's chest. It became brighter, causing her to look away and growl with annoyance as she rubbed at her eyes. When Despara looked back, Veth was much changed.

Veth was now much larger and taller—almost as big as Archon Lethe. Their body was encased in the same suit of interlocking black metallic bands she was; dark armor plates covered the critical parts of their body. Deep indigo light blazed from eyes that peered from an open face helmet, and in their hands, a giant

black sword was shimmering with the same light that shone from their eyes.

Despara gaped at Zhe-La/Veth as she yearned for the power on display. She desperately searched within herself for that strength, knowing that it somehow had something to do with that earlier feeling that evaded her touch. Despara surged forth within herself like a hunter seeking her prey, scrabbling for that elusive essence that she knew was the key to her advancement. Finally, Despara found it, the thread she needed, cowering in the deepest recesses of her mind—she seized it in her grasp and subdued it with her indomitable will.

Raising her hand to the air as Veth had done, Despara spoke the words that surged forth into her mind.

"FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

Despara felt the power within her cry out in anguish as it exploded outward and into her body. Elation flowed within her as Despara felt the power of She-Ra course into every part of her body, enhancing her weak form and making it worthier of her. With eyes closed in rapture, Despara felt the magic flow through her making her body grow in size and might.

When Despara opened her eyes, she was at the same eye level as Zhe-La/Veth, which pleased her. Looking down at her enhanced form, she saw that the flexible armor was now augmented by black armor plates, covering critical points while accentuating her feminine form. A black sword was in her hands, and just like Zhe-La/Veth's, it burned with dark power.


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“Magnificent!” Archon Lethe breathed. “You are a vision of beauty!”

She-Ra/Despara thought Archon Lethe’s words odd; it was as if they were seeing her enhanced form for the first time. From the way Archon Lethe had initially spoken to her, it seemed she had fought on their side before her memory loss. But she shook these thoughts from her head—they were irrelevant.

Zhe-La/Veth approached her with their hand held out and a welcoming smile.

“It’s good to have you back...Despara,” they said, sounding almost unsure.

She-Ra/Despara took in Zhe-La/Veth, now seeing them in a different light. Their enhanced form appeared robust, magnifying the earlier appeal she saw in them. She liked this version of them better.

Perhaps they will be a good ally, Despara thought as she clasped Zhe-La/Veth’s wrist in the warrior’s fashion. *For now.*

Both warriors smiled grimly at the other. They were now collaborators united in the cause of Archon Lethe—tentative allies joined in the cause of darkness.

They were two fallen heroes, united in evil.

END OF BOOK I: SHE-RA

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! Stay tuned for Book II: He-Man!

All illustrations in this chapter were done by Henar Torinos. You can check out her stuff on Instagram at @henartorinos or @ilikeyoucatradora

A Fabulous Reunion (BOOK II: HE-MAN)

Chapter Summary

Shen and Glimmer find themselves reunited with Double Trouble.

The two paths begin to converge.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

BOOK II

HE-MAN



Shen stared dumbstruck at the sight before him. The last time he had seen Double Trouble, Shen had slammed a door in their face in an attempt to trap them and keep them from stopping him from completing his suicide mission. Now here they were, standing before him on an entirely different planet, wearing his jacket and pretending to be someone named Janus.

Double Trouble was looking at him pointedly, a bold grin on their elfin face, as if in challenge of him.

"What's wrong, Shen darling? You didn't miss me?" They said with a pout.

"Uh…" Shen stammered. He had to stop himself from running to them and wrapping his arms around them. Shen wanted to beg them to forgive him but held his ground—there were people watching. He could feel Glimmer and Panga's eyes on him as his mind reeled.

Before Shen had locked Double Trouble in that dry storage locker, he had shared his plans with them to travel by portal to the realm of Night. He told them that the only way to stop his father from hurting everyone he cared about was to use the Heart Rune Adora gave him to cut off the interdimensional tether connecting that place to Etheria. But such a thing would mean that he would be trapped in the Nightmare Dimension and face death—or worse.

Shen had told Double Trouble of his plan, not thinking that they actually cared, but after reflecting on their relationship, he realized how callus this was of him. He would have seen that they did care if he had bothered to look beyond their aloof outer surface—Double Trouble cared a lot. Shen realized that he must have hurt them very badly by telling them so openly of his plans and then trapping them inside a space they could not escape from. In intimate moments past, Double Trouble had shared how much they feared being in a place they could not immediately leave.

After the dust had settled from the battle with his father's forces, Shen had sought out Double Trouble, wanting to apologize to them. But as hard as he looked, Shen could not find them; they had sold the Enchanted Grotto, and their living space was empty. Shen had assumed Double Trouble was sulking, that they had assumed another shape and were hiding somewhere on Etheria. He knew it was pointless to try and find them; if Double Trouble did not want to be seen, you were not going to find them.

After the pointless search for his friend, Shen had discovered that his black jacket was missing, the one Madame Razz had given him. He quickly realized the green imp had stolen it in spite of him; they had always teased him in the past that he lacked the refined taste for such a stylish jacket.

"I guess I know where my jacket went," Shen said finally. "Unless that is an illusion."

Double Trouble's tail twitched, and Shen recognized the sign—his comment annoyed them.

"No, darling," they said with a grin. "I can assure you; the jacket is real. Do you want to come and feel it?"

Double Trouble caressed the sleek black material of the jacket with long fingers, which then veered to the bare green skin of their chest in open invitation.

Before Shen could do give in to the temptation, a loud *ahem* was heard from two throats, and he turned to see both Glimmer and Panga in obvious discomfort.

"Sorry to interrupt whatever is going on here," Glimmer said with slight annoyance. "But can we get back to the task at hand?"

Shen got a hold of himself and chuckled, feeling slightly embarrassed as he waved a hand to Glimmer to proceed. Double Trouble put both hands on cocked hips—obviously, they felt no shame at their behavior.

“So, Queen Glimmer, I guess you want to know about Scorpia and Mermista, hmm? Or do you want to bring up the bill I sent you for your wedding? You still owe me for all that catering,” Double Trouble teased.

“Yes, Mermista and Scorpia would be a good start,” Glimmer replied, ignoring their baiting. “After that, perhaps you can tell us about this!”

Glimmer swept her arms out, indicating the entirely of the gigantic building they all occupied.

“Yes, yes,” they said as they directed a limp wrist at her. “Good things come to those who wait, precious lamb. Hmm… let’s see…”

Shen watched as Double Trouble sauntered back to their throne, draping their lithe body across the armrests while Glimmer ground her teeth in annoyance. He had to stop himself from laughing out loud—not everyone appreciated Double Trouble’s ‘performances.’

“Just the other day, Panga presented me with two robed strangers who refused to give their names. I did not think this odd for many supplicants come before the might of Janus with no names,” Double Trouble said in a bored tone. “Imagine my surprise when they pulled down their hoods to reveal none other than two Etherian Princesses!”

“I was still in my Janus form and decided to stay that way—I wanted to have a little fun with those two before revealing myself. It turns out that was perfect sense on my part, for Scorpia and Mermista were acting very strange; there was an edge to them I’d never noticed before. After all, I am very good at reading people,” they said with a wide sharp grin.

“Anywho… I did my whole dark, angry Janus thing and asked them what they were doing on Thenlor. This was the strange part—they did not seem to know. They wanted to talk to me since they had heard on the street that Janus was involved—and I

quote here— ‘dark magic.’” Double Trouble said while making the quotation sign.

“Yeah, right, knowing you, that’s the truth,” Glimmer said drolly.

“Good heavens, how dare you!” Double Trouble exclaimed while holding their hands to their chest.

Panga chuckled. “Well… it’s not that far from the truth, Atreyen. I mean, you were having children sell pieces of evil life-stealing rock on the streets of Thenlor before I stopped you. Plus, who knows what the *other* Janus was up to before you assumed the mantle,”

Glimmer shook her head at Double Trouble. “Wow, I really don’t want to know more, do I? Can we just get back to Scorpia and Mermista, please?”

“I have nothing to hide, honey. But yes, back to the original tale.” Double Trouble said with a shrug. “I told Scorpia and Mermista that I was no longer involved in that sort of thing but offered to put them in touch with someone who was—for a price, of course. I do have a business to run, after all.”

Glimmer looked as if she would be sick. “So, great job steering my friends in the direction of evil, Double Trouble. Thanks for that.”

“Easy now, Glimmer,” Panga said defensively. “From what it sounds like, Scorpia and Mermista are adults, and Atreyen was only giving them what they wanted. For all Atreyen knew, this could have been part of some mission.”

“It’s okay, Kitten,” Double Trouble cooed to Panga. “Glimmer here just does not appreciate my charms as you do. She is still very prickly with me—you know—like you used to be,”

Shen noticed a blush on the Madgēcot woman’s face and could not help but feel a slight stab of jealously at the way Double Trouble was so familiar with her. The fact that she used their actual name so openly was also an indication the two had become close—much closer than he had ever gotten with Double Trouble.

They always told him never to speak their true name, Atreyen, in public.

Glimmer let out a loud sigh of exasperation. "Okay, I guess I apologize, Double Trouble—you did not have the full facts."

"Which are?" Double Trouble said with silver eyebrows raised.

"I won't go into all the details, but for reasons I cannot explain yet, both Mermista and Scorpia have been stripped of their empathy." Glimmer said evenly. "They are now completely different people who only do what is in their best interest without care or regard for others. Mermista tried to start an insurrection back on Etheria, but when that failed, she broke Scorpia out of Perfuma Prison, and they boarded a ship for Thenlor. We are trying to track them down to capture and heal them—once we figure out how that is."

"Lost their empathy, you say?" Panga said with head tilted. "That is strange… my people have recently reconnected with estranged allies of ours who also have lost their empathy. They are called the Nephraeh, and according to my last communication with Elysia, they claimed Horde Prime had taken it from them, using his technology."

Glimmer frowned at this statement as she absently stared at the Star Stone at the end of her staff.

"I don't know, Panga," she said distractedly. "I feel like taking someone's emotions is outside the realm of technology. I have recently come across evidence of magic powers that directly oppose the Staves of Power. Evil Powers. I think taking away empathy would be something they are capable of."

Panga nodded. "Yes, the Abominable Powers. With the return of Grayskull to this Universe, so too have the Great Evils returned. The Madgēcots were going to reach out to Eternia and Etheria to help teach you about such things, but the Nephraeh have now taken all their attention."

Glimmer nodded at this. “Yes, when we get Scorpia and Mermista safely back, I think there needs to be more communication between our people. There is so much magic power in our hands now, but I feel like we are missing the knowledge to use it properly. But first things first, we need to find our friends; can you tell us where Scorpia and Mermista are meeting these contacts?”

Double Trouble stood from their throne in one fluid motion and glided over to Glimmer, taking her hands in theirs.

“I will do everything in my power to help you, dear,” they said with surprising benevolence as Glimmer gaped up at them.

Shen was shocked by this behavior; it was as if Double Trouble was a completely different person. A person who cared not for mischief but for helping others—Shen had a strange sensation that he was finally seeing Double Trouble for the first time. He liked what he saw.

“Uh… thank you, Double Trouble,” Glimmer stammered. “Or should I call you Atreyen? Is that your real name? Panga keeps calling you that.”

Double Trouble smiled down at her. “Yes, dear. If you want, you can call me that. Or you can call me Double Trouble, makes no difference to me,” they said nonchalantly.

“What happened to you Double Tr— uh, Atreyen,” Shen asked, feeling strange using their real name so openly but not wanting to be left out.

Double Trouble favored him with a sharp-toothed smile. “Lots happened to me, my boy. It’s also a long story, but in short, Queen Glimmer and I both have something in common now,”

Glimmer had since regained her composure and regarded Double Trouble suspiciously.

“Oh yeah, and what’s that? The casual disregard for authority figures? Great taste in outfits?” she said with a smirk.

Double Trouble returned the grin as they held out a hand, and a long gold staff appeared out of thin air. They caught the staff, giving it a twirl before thrusting it upwards where a black sphere appeared at its top. Double Trouble then allowed the staff to slide back down between their fingers, the end clattering noisily against the hard floor as the black sphere lit up with green dancing lights —like fireflies on a dark summer's night.

"You're not the only one with a Staff of Power, my dear," Double Trouble said knowingly. "May I introduce, the one and only, the truly spectacular—Orb of Entropy! Hold your applause, please,"

"WHAT!?" Glimmer shrieked. "You have the Orb of Entropy!? But we were looking for it! It belongs with a Princess, and I was going to give it to Spinnerella!"

"What, I can't be a part of your Princess Club? What am I, chopped liver?" Double Trouble said, feigning hurt feelings.

"You can be my Princess, Atreyen," Panga said with a toothy grin. Double Trouble bowed to the female Madgēcot as Glimmer continued to shake her head.

"Is there any chance you would sell the Orb of Entropy to me? I know how much money means to you and all," Glimmer asked tentatively.

"Glimmer!" Panga shouted in genuine outrage. "The Staves of Power cannot be bought and sold as if they were common trinkets!"

"Okay, okay, sorry!" Glimmer responded with hands held out. "Just thought I would ask, sheesh,"

"Even if I were to stoop so low as to sell this power, Glimmer my pet, I cannot. For the staff you see in my hand is an illusion—it's part of me. The true staff was destroyed, and the font of power which is the Orb, now resides within my body," Double Trouble said as they laid a hand against their chest.

“Again, it’s a long story,” Panga added with a shrug.

Glimmer slowly snapped her gaped mouth closed and now looked very resigned.

“Well, I guess you and I will have to start seeing more of each other in the future,” Glimmer said with a forced smile. “I had planned on forming a kind of council after we found at least three of the Staves of Power,”

“Yes, in days past, they were called the League of Kalosyni,” Panga added.

“Yes, I read about them. I didn’t know that was what they were, though,” Glimmer said thoughtfully. “We really need to all get-together and talk—soon.”

“As long as Atreyen is involved, I will be there,” Panga responded, crossing her arms over her chest.

“Yes, yes, I will join your little ‘club,’ but first, let’s get back to what you originally came here for,” Double Trouble said before Glimmer could respond. “Mermista and Scorpia will be meeting with members of the Tartarean Coterie later tonight. I can give you precious lambs the exact coordinates.”

“What can you tell us about this Tartarean Coterie?” Shen asked.

Double Trouble smiled fondly at him. “Good question, my lovely He-Man. Panga, my dear? Can you fill him in?”

Panga turned to Shen with a very cool expression on her face. Despite her earlier compliments of him, Shen was starting to have a feeling she did not like him.

“I was on the planet when your father’s forces occupied Thenlor—I was sent here to fight against them and protect innocents. The Tartarean Coterie were a group of people who were acolytes of the Death Binders, helping them with their dark works and learning their dread magic. When the Death Binders were

defeated, their followers remained, becoming the Tartarean Coterie. Before disappearing into the underworld, they seized the Death Binder's artifacts, scrolls, and other esoteric items. They only appear now and again to trade their items through an intermediary."

"It sounds like you work with these people," Glimmer said, hands on hips. "You act all high and mightily with us, but here you are working with the scum of the universe!"

Panga bared her teeth. "The Universe is not like Etheria, *Princess*," she hissed. "Sometimes, you have to deal with a little evil to stamp out the greater. I have suspected for a while now that a Death Binder has somehow survived the fall of the Dark He-Man and is operating somewhere in this quadrant. The Tartarean Coterie may have ties to this individual, and until I unravel the mystery, they may continue their operation unmolested by me. But believe me, *I will crush them*when they are no longer useful*!*"

Shen was abruptly taken aback by the ferocity in the female Madgēcot, remembering the time Catra had pulled him up a cliff face after summoning similar fury. Double Trouble went to Panga, laying a calming hand on her shoulder.

"Easy now," they soothed. "We are all friends here, my darlings. We all are on the side of *good* now,"

If there was a more surreal moment for Shen, he couldn't imagine it—Double Trouble had never spoken this way before. The ways in which they had changed were staggering.

Panga sighed, looking at Glimmer without anger now. "When you go to capture your lost friends, make sure you do it after the meeting is over. If the Tartarean Coterie finds out you knew about the meeting, all my plans will be ruined."

Glimmer held up her hands in placation. "Okay, okay. How about we discuss the plan together then?" She said with a small smile.

“How about downstairs with the others? I feel like I should tell them all we are okay; they are probably worried about us.”

Panga nodded to the other woman, meeting her smile with one of her own.

“Sure, perhaps some food is in order. The children had become excellent little cooks.”

“*Children?*” Glimmer exclaimed incredulously.

Panga laughed, taking the other woman by the shoulder to guide her towards the elevator.

“It’s a long story,” Panga said not for the first time this day, making Glimmer laugh.

Shen grasped Double Trouble by the hand before they could follow—they looked at him curiously.

“Atreyen, is there any way we could talk? Alone?” He asked.

Double Trouble gave a slight nod before calling out to the two women entering the elevator.

“You two dears head on down, Shen and I have some old business to discuss.”

Panga’s tail began to twitch rapidly as she pursed her lips. “Are you sure, Atreyen?” She said with a touch of annoyance.

Double Trouble only favored her with a nod and a wink before the elevator door closed, and they turned to Shen with hands on their hips.

“So, Shen, my boy. Did you want to get me alone so you could show me your He-Man—OH!”

Double Trouble did not get a chance to finish their sentence as Shen slid his arms around them, under their black jacket. He

pulled them close in a warm embrace as he pressed his head against the side of theirs.

"Atreyen, I'm so sorry about what I did; I mean it." He whispered into one of their long green ears. The feel of their bare skin felt so good against his hands—so soft and smooth—bringing back fond memories of more intimate moments.

Shen began to feel Double Trouble respond, but they stopped themselves, placing their hands on his shoulders to softly push him away. Double Trouble looked down at him with a small smile.

"No, my dear Shen, it was not your fault. It was mine. I had lived my life full of secrets and regrets for so long that I never really showed you my true feelings. I don't blame you for thinking I didn't care." They said as they cupped his jaw with long cool fingers.

"I should have known, though, Atreyen, if I only bothered to look closer—"

Double Trouble placed a green finger against his lips to silence him. "*Hush now*—don't be foolish, that's all in the past. Everything is different now; I'm different now."

Shen grinned. "Yes, I've noticed. You seem much more open, and now I know how you feel about me; perhaps things can be different between us."

A strange expression came over Double Trouble's face as their lips parted, revealing rows of teeth—such dangerous sharp teeth that looked as if they could rend and tear. But Shen had never felt their bite against his tongue when kissing Double Trouble—*their* tongue had always been there, cushioning his from the peril, making him forget that the possibility of pain could ever exist.

It was this memory that caused Shen to reach out and gently brush Double Trouble's now silver hair behind one of their long ears. Their eyes, already hooded with passion, closed expectantly as Shen cupped their chin and pulled them—but before both lips

could meet, Double Trouble placed a hand on his chest and pushed him away. It was a slow, gentle push, but they had put all their indomitable strength was behind it.

Shen looked up to Double Trouble's face and was shocked to see tears in their eyes.

"Oh, Shen…" They said with infinite sadness. "Yes, the feelings are there, but as I said, things are different now. There is someone now who has become special to me,"

Shen's heart sank as devastation set in. "It's the Madgēcot, Panga. Isn't it? I could see you two are close now."

Double Trouble nodded. "Yes, we have become very close; she was there for me when I had become *lost*. Panga helped me find my way back."

Shen nodded slowly as the hope for resuming what he had with Double Trouble was dashed to pieces.

"She was there when I wasn't," he said sorrowfully. "I'm sorry for that, Atreyen—but I am happy for you. You deserve to be loved. Truly."

Double Trouble gave him a warm grin. "I know you are," they responded softly. "That is what makes you so special,"

They raised one hand as if to touch his face—then, with a gentle shake of the head—withdrew it. Double Trouble then removed the jacket they had stolen from him and held it up; the strange black material of its making glistened in the light, making it appear as if it was made of numerous bird's feathers. An exact copy of the jacket they now held in their hands appeared over their body—as if they never took it off.

"Come, come," Double Trouble said as they held the jacket up.

Tentatively, Shen reached out and placed an arm in the jacket's sleeve. He then turned and allowed Double Trouble to guide his

arm into the other sleeve as they pulled the coat up over his shoulders. It felt good to have it on, and it was still warm from its previous owner, but it was a little bigger than Shen remembered. This changed as Double Trouble placed their hands on his shoulders, giving them a gentle squeeze before running their long fingers down his arms. Instantly, the jacket became snugger, like before—like it was made for him.

Double Trouble still held his forearms as they leaned in—Shen could feel their breath on his neck as they spoke to him.

"You are *wrong*though, my dear," they whispered. "You *were* there for me—you and this jacket protected me when I needed it the most. Even though we cannot be together, you will always be in my *heart*, Shen,"

Double Trouble gave his wrists a gentle squeeze before they backed away from him. Shen shut his eyes against the tears that threatened to spill out.

"Now, I think I should head down with the others," Double Trouble said as they glided past him towards the elevator. "I feel like someone needs to keep an eye on Panga and Glimmer. Putting those two together is like putting oil next to a fire and expecting them not to explode into flames. Such hot tempers on those ladies!"

Shen nodded to them as he turned away, looking out the large window and onto the dark city. He was starting to feel it again, the urge to accept *its*embrace and escape from the sadness.

"Yeah, okay, Atreyen, I think I need a moment." He said, gritting his teeth.

"I know, honey, take all the time you need." Double Trouble said softly, pushing the button to close the elevator and take them away from him.

Shen peered through the window and into the jumbling maze of the dreary city under the curtain of constant rain. This place was

in a perpetual twilight, so much like where he grew up—the planet of Shen'Dar-oom—and Shen felt a strange comfort in that.

But Shen'Dar-oom had returned to this universe to become Eternia once again, and he felt no connection to the place anymore. Now the one person who had become home for him—be it only for a brief span of two weeks—could never be that again.

Shen realized how much he had hoped to reconnect with Double Trouble, to reignite what they once had. Even though friends surrounded him, there was a deep loneliness inside him that only true love could fill. As much as he hated himself for admitting it, the loneliness had become worse after Catra and Adora's wedding. There was no reason to analyze the reason why; it was obvious. Everyone had someone else, even the once aloof Double Trouble had Panga now, and he felt cast adrift into that half-light in front of him, lost into the sea of melancholia once more.

But there were bright points in that darkness; the city lights seemed like dim, hollow smears amongst the shadows. There was one that drew his eye; a distant light that appeared to be an advertisement on one of the gigantic mega-structures. It was a brilliant red that pulsed steadily, almost in time with Shen's heartbeat, and it instantly pulled his mind to the recent past. In this memory, another bright red point appeared—an *eye*—and it called to him, beckoning him into its embrace of rage.



Shen clenched his fists, then relaxed them with a sigh. He reached up to his chest and tentatively activated the heart-rune that Adora

had given him—it soothed him and acted as a ward against that dark desire.

Shen turned from the window and made his way towards the elevator, not daring to look back.

* * *

Nine sets of eyes peered down from the balcony of the abandoned performance hall, watching the black hooded figures on the old stage intently. The watcher's perch was high above and far away from their quarry, for the grand hall was so big it could encompass the entirety of Bright Moon Castle. Everything on Thenlor seemed too vast to the Etherians, and the old performance hall was no exception.

The entire space was dark, for scavengers had long ago stripped the building of anything salvageable, but there was light, provided by a large hole in the ceiling. Rain cascaded down from the opening, and the city lights outside created a beam of light that lit the stage—much like a spotlight in better days.

"How are we supposed to see anything?" Bow complained.

"Don't you have some kind of arrow with binoculars on the tip or something?" Glimmer replied, not bothering to look at her husband.

"Oh yeah!" he said, sounding happy as he rummaged in his quiver case.

"Bow, what in Etheira's name made you think you needed binoculars on an arrow?" Perfuma asked.

"I could think of a few uses for that, honey," Double Trouble cooed.

"Well… you see…" Bow said distractedly as he continued to rummage. "It's just in case—"

"Shhhh!!!" Panga hissed in a whisper. *"I know this hall is huge, but sound travels easily. Also, the members of The Tartarean Coterie are known to utilize surveillance by supernatural means. That includes hearing!"*

All three speakers made the sign for zipping lips to placate the Madgēcot as Shen regarded her. Panga seemed more relaxed around him since his private talk with Double Trouble, almost a little smug even. It didn't take a genius to realize that in some female—or Madgēcot—way, Panga knew that Double Trouble had chosen her over Shen. He did not fault the female Madgēcot her feelings of triumph—why would he? He felt true love for Double Trouble and wanted the absolute best for them.

As he continued to watch her, Shen realized what a perfect fit Panga was for Double Trouble—she was open with her feelings, where theirs were closed. Panga had a solid sense of right and wrong and would help steer the Double Trouble's lose sense of morals in the right direction. She was strong, fierce, and loyal—and under it all—Shen sensed a great well-spring of kindness. All Shen felt like he had to offer was pain and problems—Double Trouble was better off not having to deal with him anymore.

Shen turned back to look at the dark figures as chin rested on his shoulder; the owner's voice spoke in his ear in a mewling whisper.

"You are doing it again, Shen; we talked about this," Battle Cat said.

Shen did not answer and sighed. There was no reason to speak when the other person could read your mind openly.

Give me a break, Battle Cat; I'm having a hard time here. He thought.

"Yes, but internal self-abuse is not helpful, especially with what you have been struggling with lately."

Shen ground his teeth, for he knew exactly what his friend was speaking of.

"Anger may feel good in the short term, but it is self-destructive. Why do you think it was harnessed into an Abominable Power?"

The image returned to Shen's mind—the pulsing red light, so much like an eye. Like an Eye of Hate.

Shen did not like how much he enjoyed being under the influence of that dark power—but the anger, the rage felt *so good.*While under its embrace, there was no pain, there was no sadness or terrible anxiety. There were only waves of red fury bathing him in an endless tide of*blood*—utterlyfree of all other emotions.

Great shame well up in Shen at that moment, for he also remembered the looks on his friends' faces when Glimmer had freed him from madness. It was a pure and absolute terror of him—for he had spent days hunting for the in the underground tunnels of Castle Grayskull in his He-Man form, trying to kill them. He and Battlecat.

"Yes, remember what we almost did to our friends, Shen," Battlecat continued. *"Seahawk and Bow have since forgiven us, but I have not seen Swiftwind since Castle Grayskull. I fear he no longer trust us,"*

Yes! I remember! Shen thought back to them. *I don't need you lecturing me about it! Also, weren't you just born a couple of months ago? I don't need wisdom from a newborn!*

"*I have the wisdom of the undivided aggregate, of countless millenniums,"*Battlecat said with a scolding tone. "*Also, don't forget, I too was under the influence of the Eye of Hate."*

Yeah, I remember. But the thing is, The Eye of Hate is locked away back in Castle Grayskull and far away from me. Unless you still feel it's taint on me, there is nothing to worry about. Do you sense the Eye of Hate's influence on me, Battlecat?

His friend was silent for a moment as Shen felt a spike of fear at the thought of carrying a taint amongst his friends. Finally, they responded.

"I'm not sure, I don't sense anything, but it does not need to be."

Care to explain that?

Battlecat was silent a moment longer—as if dreading a subject that they long wanted to broach but was too afraid of his reaction.

"Shen, you are a good person, and I have grown a great love for you in a short amount of time, but there is a wellspring of anger in you. The encounter with the Eye of Hate has… tapped that anger… making it flow free. You must be careful, Shen, for this potential for anger has been passed down to you, from someone who let that anger fuel them and drive them into darkness…"

Shen felt sudden rage coarse through him at Battlecat's insulation.

"I am nothing like my father!" He hissed, and his friend backed away from him to sit meekly on their haunches.

When he turned to look at Battlecat, there was a forlorn expression on their green feline face, and Shen instantly hated himself for lashing out at them. He turned to see all his friends staring at him worriedly while Panga glared at him with wide yellow eyes and teeth bared. Shen noticed that her twitching tailhad become twice its normal size—as if she sensed danger.

Closing his eyes, Shen once again touched the heart rune, seeking solace, but this time it eluded him. He was about to resort to the meditation Catra had taught him when a hand grasped his. When he opened his eyes back up, Seahawk was beaming at him with reassurance.

"Hang tight, lad, stay strong," he whispered.

Goodwill suffused Shen, almost as if some of Seahawk's boisterous spirit had been shared with him, and it drove away the dark emotions. Shen smiled back at the older man, thankful for his kind words.

Everyone turned their attention back from Shen and towards the figures on the decrepit stage. Shen could barely make them out, they were so far away, but they all appeared to be turning in one direction, as if in expectation of visitors. Sure enough, two newcomers arrived from offstage; they were also dressed in robes, but Scorpia's clawed hands and tail were unmistakable.

The two hooded groups exchanged words, indiscernible from where Shen sat, but by the way Panga's ears were perked, he could tell she could hear what was being said.

"They are talking terms," Panga whispered. *"It sounds like your friends are just buying information. A specific location they wish to go to,"*

"That's perfect; if we can find out where they are going, we can just follow them," Glimmer whispered excitedly.

Panga continued to listen, cocking her head in her attempts to hear the words clearly.

"*Your friends just handed over currency,"* Panga continued. *"Now they are being given the information. It sounds like coord—* AHHHH!!!!"

Panga screamed in agony as she slammed down on her back, holding her hands against her long ears. Double Trouble was immediately at her side, lifting her up in their arms and holding her very tenderly.

"Panga! What is it, darling?" They cried, fear plain in their voice.

Panga slowly regained her composure and looked up at them with wide, yellow eyes—there was an absolute terror in them.

"Atreyen! Something is terribly wrong—I heard a scream! In my head! I've never heard anything like it before! I think… I think it was the Chaliendra Tree! I must contact Elysia immediately!" She cried.

Panga lifted herself from Double Trouble's arms to peer over the balcony's edge and groaned.

"I'm so sorry, everyone; I ruined everything," she said apologetically.

Shen and everyone else peered down at the stage, where their quarry was. It was now empty; Scorpaia, Mermista, and the members of the Tartarean Coterie had all escaped.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration done by Henar Torinos. You can find more of her work on Instagram at @ilikeyoucatradora

Already Gone

Chapter Summary

Glimmer and the rest are on the hunt for the rebel Princesses.

Kishar's story takes a turn for the worst.

01.2410.99

Something is terribly wrong with me.

At first, I thought I was just tired from using the Shlihm-bess'a-rune three days ago, but instead of feeling refreshed as the days passed, the fatigue has only worsened.

I guess tired is not the right word for it; I still have boundless energy just like before—Jihan can attest to that. It's just that… I don't know… I feel like I don't care about things like I used to, and it's just getting worse.

I have not shared the full extent of how I feel with Jihan; I don't want him to fret about me. I only stated that some things don't interest me lately—of course, he became worried and said I might be depressed. But why would I be depressed now? Especially now that I healed Jihan.

Jihan said depression does not have to make sense; it can affect you with seemingly no cause. He said that I had been through a lot lately and that maybe the stress of trying to find a cure for him was finally catching up with me. Who knows, perhaps he is right. I think I will talk to a Madgēcot who specializes in this sort of thing.

01.2413.99

I can no longer see.

Let me rephrase that—I can no longer see as a normal Nephraeh can see. I cannot see another person's quintessence. All I can see is the person.

I'm not sure how I feel about this; I should be alarmed, for no Nephraeh in the history of our people has lost their ability to see another person's soul. It's a big part of who we are; it is one of the reasons we are called the Light—no matter what a person appears on the outside, we can always see their true nature. We can see their inner beauty. We can see the scars and the hurts they have endured during their life, and it is a big part of where our empathy comes from. It enables us to understand others.

But the truth is, I'm not sure if I care about any of that—not anymore. I'm okay with not seeing as a Nephraeh sees anymore; I feel like I don't need it.

Isn't that odd?

01.2420.99

I think I have finally figured out what is wrong with me.

The other day, Jihan had come to me in tears; he was an absolute mess. He told me an old friend of his, a Star Hunter named Harihar, was killed while on a mission. He was a childhood friend of Jihan's, and Harihar's loss had hit him hard.

The strange thing was, while Jihan was telling me all this with tears in his eyes, all I wanted to do was change the subject and talk about when we would start going on missions again. Thankfully, I stopped myself from doing this and forced myself to act sad. I also had to force myself to console Jihan in my arms—this was a strange sensation—almost as if I was outside myself looking in.

Much later, I realized that this feeling of not caring was not just for Jihan's friend or his pain—it was everyone's feelings. It was everyone's pain. I just did not care about it anymore.

I have lost the ability to feel empathy, and I know the cause—it was the Shlihm-bess'a-rune. That device that Zzar gave me had removed my compassion to power itself. That is what Jihan's rejuvenation had cost me.

I need to speak to Zzar. I need to find a way to reverse this. I think I should also keep my distance from Jihan for the time being. It will not take him long to figure out that I have lost my most positive attribute—I think that would drive him away.

But, I don't think I would not care about that, and I realize I am no longer in love with him—but I know why. I know that once I have my capacity to care for others back, those feelings for Jihan will return.

I need to come up with some excuse for leaving for Castle Grayskull without Jihan. I must be able to speak to Zzar alone. She must have the—

"Gwimma?" a child's voice interrupted Glimmer from her reading. Looking up from her datapad, she saw a little girl standing next to her, looking very shy.

"Yes, Cora?" Glimmer asked sweetly.

Cora looked down at her feet as she fidgeted nervously, then finally summoned the courage to speak again.

"How did you get your hair to sparkle like that? It's so pretty," Cora said meekly.

Glimmer laughed brightly and reached for the little girl, running her hand through Cora's long brown hair while summoning the power of the Star Stone. When she pulled her hand back, hints of sparkles highlighted the little girl's hair, much like her own. Cora lifted a lock of her long hair so she could see the transformation and shrieked with pleasure.

"By magic, little one," Glimmer said, smiling at the little girl's happiness.

Cora instantly turned and ran over to her friends. "Guys, guys! Look!" She shouted as she pointed at her hair.

Glimmer sat back in her cushioned chair as she enjoyed the sights and sounds of happy children. She was still in the mega-structure where they had met Double Trouble and Panga when they had first arrived on Thenlor. Glimmer now knew the building was called *Eleutheria*; Double Trouble had mentioned offhand that they had renamed the strange mega-structure after taking ownership. The last name had been too offensive to them.

Double Trouble had given Glimmer and the rest an abbreviated version of what they had been up to since arriving on Thenlor. Skipping over the reasons why they left Etheira in the first place, they said that when they first came to this planet, a person named 'Janus' approached them with a business proposition. This venture turned out to be selling a product called Sable on the streets of Thenlor, which Double Trouble accomplished by employing some of the local homeless children and creating a network of 'little salespersons.' Double Trouble had been very successful in this endeavor and made quite a lot of money for themselves.

Unbeknownst to Double Trouble, Sable had an evil side-effect; it drained the life essence of the user in exchange for reliving their most pleasant memories. Double Trouble only found this out when Panga confronted them, trying to put them out of business using her brand of street justice. After a fight that ended in a draw, Panga convinced Double Trouble that what they were doing was wrong, and the two joined forces to confront Janus—which they did the very next day.

During this face-off, Janus revealed to Double Trouble and Panga the true nature of their power—the Orb of Entropy—which according to them, was taken by force from the previous owner. Janus also revealed that they wanted the dread Sable sold not for money but to power a spell that would allow them to ascend to Godhood.

The rest of the details were skewed for Double Trouble and Panga told slightly different versions of the story's end—but the outcome was the same; Janus was defeated, Double Trouble now had the Orb of Entropy, and the two allies took mutual ownership of all of Janus's holdings. Glimmer had some suspicions that there was more to the story and wasn't ready to believe anything Double Trouble said, but there was something very familiar about Janus' plans to become a god.

What Janus had attempted sounded a lot like what Zzar had done by sacrificing everyone on one of Eternia's moons to become the god of Death. There was the nature of the spell, the sacrifice, and the involvement of one of the Staves of Power—a power for good that is used to fuel her elevation. Zzar had combined the Life Gem with her own body to become the opposite of the power she was responsible for—Death. Glimmer had a suspicion that this Janus must have had access to the same spell Zzar used, perhaps even some of her writings. Someone as egotistical as Zzar was bound to have written down all her knowledge so future generations would know of her genius.

It filled Glimmer with trepidation to think of the rest of the staves of power unaccounted for—who else had dreams of becoming a god? Or even worse, who had already done it besides Zzar? Glimmer forced herself not to think of this—she had better things to worry about than 'what ifs.' She still had to track down her friends, Scorpia and Mermista.

After the failed attempt to capture the rogue princesses, Glimmer and the rest had spent the entire night scouring the city streets in an ultimately fruitless effort to find them. Scorpia, Mermista, and the members of the Tartarean Coterie had vanished without a trace. According to Double Trouble, finding the latter was impossible without an open invitation.

Panga had been beside herself with sorrow for having been the cause of their failure, and she had scoured the streets personally for many days before duty drove her to return to Elysia. It was now four weeks since Panga had boarded a transport off-planet

for her home-planet, and they had failed to make any progress in their search.

Just as they were ready to give up, Double Trouble had surprised everyone with an offer; they would use their 'special expertise' to go undercover and track down answers from the Tartarean Coterie—but only in return for a small favor. What that favor had turned out to be was perhaps the biggest surprise Glimmer had encountered during this trip; it was to babysit Panga and Double Trouble's many children.

The children Double Trouble had employed during their time with Janus were now under their care—the orphans now lived with Panga and Double Trouble inside the massive Eleutheria building. Panga had even gone as far as to adopt a little girl name Flit, whom she had taken with her back to Elysia.

When asked how they would support so many children, Double Trouble only grinned at Glimmer, showing all their sharp teeth. She could imagine that whatever it was, it wasn't legal, but she was willing to overlook such a thing, especially given that it was for a good cause.

Watching the children had turned out to be a breeze for the Etheirans, and Glimmer found that she had a knack for it. When it was her and Bow's turn to watch them while the rest continued their search, she figured it was good to brush up on Kishar's journal.

Glimmer was saddened by the price Kishar had paid to heal Jihan; the sudden loss of empathy sounded like an all too familiar turn of events. It was no coincidence that they found the journal in the exact same spot where Mermista, Scorpia, and Entrapta had their empathy drained from them. Glimmer felt like she was on the right track reading Kishar's journal—perhaps what she was reading was when all these problems began.

"You know, now that you put sparkles in Cora's hair, they are all going want it," Bow said to Glimmer, drawing her out of her

thoughts. He was in a seat nearby, enjoying one of Double Trouble's books.

"Hm? Oh, yeah, maybe," she responded offhand, watching the children around Cora look thoughtfully in her direction.

"Well, if they want sparkles, Aunty Glimmer has lots," Glimmer said, holding up the Star Stone. Bow laughed at this.

"What's so funny?' Glimmer asked with a coy tilt of her head. "Perhaps Uncle Bow wants sparkles of his own?"

"Sure!" Bow responded enthusiastically. "But that's not why I laughed. I just love seeing you around these children; you're so good with them; like it comes naturally to you."

Glimmer smiled warmly at this and took Bow by the hand.

"Yeah, I've noticed that too. Perhaps… you know…." Glimmer said, almost shyly.

Bow instantly caught her meaning, and his eyes softened. "Yeah, I've been thinking a lot about that lately. Maybe it's time? Once we have our friends back to normal, of course."

Glimmer was about to respond when the entire group of children came running over, begging for sparkles in their hair.

"Please! Please!"

"Aunty Glimmer! My turn!"

"No fair! No fair!"

Glimmer laughed, holding her hands up. "Okay! Okay! But you all need to get in line! This is going to be done in an orderly fashion!"

The fun was suddenly interrupted as black hooded figure glided into the room, making Glimmer rise to her feet, Star Stone staff in hand. But before she could say or do anything, the figure became

a black shape of dancing green motes, which then morphed into the familiar form of Double Trouble.

"Dama's back, everyone!" They shouted jubilantly.

The children all squealed with delight and ran to them, and Glimmer felt a stab of jealousy at being upstaged by the green imp.

"Don't you mean *drama?* You're missing an *r*," Glimmer said a little more caustically than intended.

"Oh! That too, darling," Double Trouble said with a broad smile. "Such wit on you!"

"Uh! Oh! Dama! What did you bring us!" One of the little boys squealed.

Double Trouble looked indulgently at the youngster and patted him on the head.

"Sorry, Rory, my little mouse, Dama was on an important business trip; I had no time for frivolities," they said apologetically.

"Aww…!" The children said sorrowfully in perfect unison.

"Well, we are just glad your back Dama," Cora said up to them, beaming.

Glimmer was surprised to see Double Trouble's entire body take on a slight shade of purple at the little girl's touching comment—but as quickly as it came, it was gone. Double Trouble fondly patted Cora on the head and strode over to Glimmer and Bow, their long tail swaying behind them.

"Didn't you tell me that seeing children fall brought tears of joy to your eyes?" Glimmer accused. She was still not over the fact Double Trouble stole the children's attention away from her.

“Oh, darling, different time, different me,” they responded nonchalantly. “I love the little squirts now,”

“So, how did your mission go, Double Trouble? Have any luck with the infiltrating Tartarean Coterie?” Bow interrupted, wanting to stop the bickering before it started.

Double Trouble rewarded Bow with an incredulous look as their tail curled up into a spiral.

“Honey, do you know who you are talking to? The Etherian Gazette once printed that I was ‘Actor of the Century!’ Sure, I was disguised as Prince Peekablue at the time—but that’s beside the point.” Double Trouble replied airily.

Glimmer and Bow shared an eye roll at Double Trouble’s huffy behavior as they waited for them to continue.

“After assuming the appropriate disguise as an old associate of mine named Borpt, I reached out to my contact within the Tartarean Coterie with an offer to sell a certain amount of… product to them,” Double Trouble said carefully.

“You mean that Sable stuff you sold before?” Bow asked.

“Ugh, yes, but it was for a good cause, mind you. Please don’t tell Panga! You would only make the poor darling upset!” Double Trouble said as they rubbed at a spot on their tail, close to their behind.

“Anyway, these Tartarean Coterie people are absolutely mad for Sable—they can’t get enough of the stuff. They were very eager to talk to me. After that, it was some smooth finagling on my part, and I was a part of their group—easy as that! Well… I had to demonstrate my knowledge of certain dark magic, buuuut I managed to muddle my way through that.” Double Trouble finished with a casual wave of the hand.

“How were you able to do magic, Double Trouble?” Glimmer asked uncertainly.

“Honey, you forget, I have the Orb of Entropy now. There is a lot I can do now that I couldn’t before.” They said as they wiggled their eyebrows at Glimmer.

“Better question—how do you know dark magic?” Bow asked suspiciously.

“Oh, it’s everywhere on Thenlor. You can’t walk down the city streets without dark magic jumping out at you!” Double Trouble said while holding their clawed hands out as if they were going to grab Bow.

“Yeah… that hasn’t been my experience,” Glimmer said with a frown. “But whatever, I don’t care about you knowing Dark Magic. It makes more sense to me than you being ‘Dama’ to a bunch of children. Just continue,”

Double Trouble smiled broadly at Glimmer and gave a lavish bow.

“Yes, well, after no small amount of time, I gained their trust. After that, it was just a matter of asking the right questions the right way.” They said, crossing their arms proudly. “I was able to find out exactly what Mermista and Scorpia were trying to acquire from them; a set of celestial coordinates.”

“What?! Where?” Bow exclaimed as he pulled out a datapad.

Double Trouble placed a long green finger to their lips as they tried to remember.

“Hmmm… let’s see. Right ascension of fifty-eight point seven and declination of ninety-six point one. Or was it the other way around? I keep getting the ascension and declination thingys mixed up,” they said, sticking their lounge out between closed lips.

Bow quickly typed in the coordinates and the datapad beeped as it brought up a visual representation of the galaxy in three dimensions. The coordinates that Bow had entered were represented as a blinking red dot near the tip of one of the galactic arms opposite of the one Etheria was found in. Glimmer’s

heart was in her throat as she realized this was the same exact point she saw the planet of darkness during her transcendent meditations, the one reaching out with tendrils of evil to corrupt neighboring planets.

"This might not be the right one, Double Trouble," Bow said, frowning. "It seems like it's almost outside the galaxy. Perhaps if I rearrange the numbers,"

Glimmer reached out and placed a hand on her husband's wrist before he could do anything as she shook her head.

"No, Bow, that's the right one," she said quietly. "When did the Tartarean Coterie give our friends these coordinates?"

Double Trouble suddenly looked apologetic. "About four weeks ago, my dear. Not long after we failed to capture them at the abandoned theatre, they must be long gone by now."

Glimmer turned to Bow, absolute resolve in her eyes.

"Contact the others, tell them to get back here immediately. We need to leave Thenlor as soon as possible,"

* * *

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THAT CURSED WOMAN!!!

I just come from my discussion with Zzar—that treacherous fiend! I approached her in absolute misery, telling her of my woes and presenting her with the Shlihm-bess'a-rune. I asked her—no, I PLEADED with her to help me restore my empathy. Do you know what she said to me?

Why?

She asked me why I wanted my empathy back, and the question enraged me. At the moment, I did not know why I was so angry,

but I have since realized it was because I did not have an answer. The only reason I wanted it back was for the IDEA that I SHOULD have it back, not for any need. I just knew I wanted it back for Jihan's sake, so I could return the love I knew he still had for me —for now, that is.

I told her my reasons were my own and that as one of the Seven Champions of Grayskull, she was commanded to help me. She only shrugged at me and retrieved some dusty old book from one of the dusty bookcases that made up the Sorcerer's chamber. She told me it was the only one of its kind and the only book left from before the Dark Times.

Zzar began to read aloud the passage regarding the Shlihm-bess'a-rune like a schoolteacher instructing her student. But the name she read was not Shlihm-bess'a-rune, but something different. The Shlihm-bess'a-rune was actually called the Flux Perennial—a strange name.

The rest of what she read was exactly what she told me before; the Flux Perennial was created as a way to perform miracles with seemingly no consequences.

*She turned a page, and a small handwritten note fell from the book, and before she could stop me, I picked it up and read it aloud—"**No matter what, DO NOT USE THE FLUX PERENNIAL! It is not what we suspected it to be; it is a curse on the universe! It is the Shlihm-bess'a-rune—something that was intended to do good but makes things much worse. It has started a state of CHAOS and HORROR in the universe; our great society is slipping into DARKNESS!!!"***

Rage filled me after reading that note, rage like I had never felt before. Zzar must have read this note—for how else did she know to call this cursed device the Shlihm-bess'a-rune? She had done this to me on purpose; for what reason, I did not know.

I immediately demanded Zzar undo what the Shlihm-bess'a-rune had done to me, saying that I would expose her treachery to the League of Kalosyni. Zzar only laughed at me—threatening to do the same to me. She said that the League of Kalosyni would strip me of Zhe-La if they found out that the magical avatar's champion was bereft of empathy.

This angered me even more, for I knew she was right; more than anything, I knew I could not lose my connection to Zhe-La. In my new state, having the power that Zhe-La meant more to me than Jihan's love, and nothing could threaten it.

I then transitioned into Zhe-La and attacked Zzar—I was going to kill her.

I will admit, attacking the Sorcerer of Castle Grayskull while they were INSIDE Castle Grayskull was not a wise decision, but I felt like it was my only recourse. I could not let her live with what she knew of me, especially someone as treacherous as Zzar. She would use this knowledge as leverage over me to do her bidding.

I will not go into the details of the battle between myself and Zzar, but it ended with me defeated and driven from Castle Grayskull. Zzar could have destroyed me if she wished, but she didn't. I suspect she had reasons for letting me live and that this whole situation was part of some grand scheme of hers. She wanted me alive and out amongst the Universe, for what purpose I have not determined yet. All I know is that I feel as if I have been un-tethered; it is as if I am floating away, like a kite that has been let go by its owner.

I'm not sure… but I think I'm starting to like it…

Glimmer let out a heavy sigh as she placed the datapad on her lap. She gazed out of the small viewport of her quarters aboard the Millennial Seagull, contemplating what she just read in Kishar's journal. Seahawk's ship was currently in hyperspace, and all she saw were a confusing array of colors as they were now traveling beyond the usual restrictions of space and time.

So Zzar had already turned to evil when she gave Kishar the Shlihm-bess'a-rune, she thought with a shake of her head. *She must be somehow responsible for what has happened to my friends. Even though she is gone, Madame Razz's evil sister is still finding ways to hurt me.*

Glimmer and her friends were on the second day of their journey towards the coordinates given to them by Double Trouble, who, because of their responsibility to the many children under their care, could not accompany them. Double Trouble did wish them all luck and told Glimmer that she would be seeing more of them in the future now that they were both bearers of Staves of Power. Glimmer was surprised that she seemed to take comfort in knowing Double Trouble now had a common cause with her. There was something very reassuring about the Green Imp now, although she would never admit it aloud.

Glimmer was about to resume her reading of the journal when the deck below her jolted, sending her careening into the wall, almost knocking her out. Glimmer rose to her feet unsteadily as she tried to see past the stars in her vision and pressed the button on the intercom located on the nearby wall.

"Seahawk! What the heck was that?!" She yelled.

"We have just been yanked out of hyperspace by some kind of gravity well!" Seahawk replied, sounding close to hysterics. "There is a fleet of ships bearing down on us! You might want to get up here!"

Glimmer grabbed her Staff of Power and rushed out into the hall, almost colliding with Shen and Battlecat as they too exited their room.

"Don't bother asking!" Glimmer said when she saw her friend's confused face. "I'm as in the dark as you!"

Bow, Perfuma, and Melog were already packed in the cockpit when Glimmer rushed in; she stopped dead in her tracks when

she saw ten enormous spacecraft of an outlandish design bearing down on them. Glimmer was still new to galactic travel but had never seen their like before. They had beautiful, organic shapes which almost seemed to mimic animals. Some had sweeping wings like birds while others had prows shaped like muzzled faces. Not one of the space-faring ships shared the same size or shape; it was as if each one was individually crafted and unique. In the cosmic half-light of billions of distant stars, the hulls of the approaching ships had a warm color, like rich honey, and gleamed as if covered in lacquer.

Seahawk pressed a button on the console and a screen lit up, showing the unknown ships up close. Under the higher magnification, Glimmer could see dark swirl patterns in the skin of the vessels; they were very pleasing to the eye, and Glimmer instantly knew she had seen something similar before.

"Are those ships made out of *wood?*" Bow asked incredulously.

"I believe they are, Bow," Perfuma said with her eyes closed. "I can sense the entirety of each of those ships is made of wood—*living wood!"*

"How is that even possible?" Bow responded.

"Magic," Both Glimmer and Perfuma responded in unison. The two women shared a laugh at their identical response despite the situation.

"Okay, everyone, we are being hailed," Seahawk said, pressing a button on the ship's communication panel.

"Attention, unidentified craft! This is Captain Nyra of the Star Hunter warship *Pakadna*. You have entered territory belonging to the forces of Elysia and have been interdicted by us out of hyperspace. I hereby order you to power down your ship and prepare to be boarded! If you do not comply, you will be taken by force!" A female voice yelled from the speaker. The voice had the

same lyrical accent as Panga's, making Glimmer realize that this was a Madgēcot speaking.

"Greetings, Captain Nyra of the Madgēcot ship Pakadna; this is Queen Glimmer of Etheria speaking. I advise you not to threaten us; such actions would be seen as an act of war. Believe me, you don't want war with Etheria," Glimmer said, putting all the force of royal authority in her voice. "In case you have not heard of us, we are the ones who defeated Horde Prime,"

"How dare you!" Captain Nyra seethed. "I have half a mind to—"

Nyra's voice was cut off as another person could be heard yelling at the Captain in the background. After a moment, Captain Nyra came back on the line, suddenly sounding very sheepish.

"It appears that someone here wants to talk to you," She said.

"Thank you, captain," a familiar female voice said. "Wow, Sparkles, only you would threaten an entire fleet of warships from inside that floating piece of space garbage,"

"Catra!?" Everyone on the bridge exclaimed in unison.

"Yep, that's me," Catra responded with a chuckle. "Why don't you guys come aboard? "We have lots to talk about."

What Have They Done to You?

Chapter Summary

Despara is revealed to the Universe.

Catra's happy reunion is dampened by the news of Adora's fate.

Captain Dhiraj gazed out of the starship bridge's forward viewport at the planet Enos, admiring the rare sight before him—a tri-solar sunrise. There was a blue flash as one of the three stars blazed up through the ocean layer before appearing over the world's edge, making Captain Dhiraj squint. The other two suns immediately preceded it, and their combined light bathed the ship's bridge in unbearable brightness, making everyone watching this sight turn their heads away. His second in command, Zeshan, dimmed the viewport with a press of a button, saving their sensitive Madgēcot eyes from the harsh light.

"Another beautiful sunrise, Captain," Zeshan said, grinning back at him from the ship's helm.

"Indeed, my friend," Dhiraj agreed. "Although I wish we were at the front lines of this war and not stationed so close to Elysia. I want to hunt!"

The tri-solar system that included Enos was very close to Elysia and far from the established warzone, making the threat of attack minimal. The Madgēcots had shielded the planet Enos from Horde Prime throughout the dark years of his reign, and they had come to depend on the Elysians for protection. Because of this history of friendship, the Madgēcots decided a watch was to be maintained for Enos' safety. So, Captain Dhiraj and his ship, *Hawa*, had been stationed here since the hostilities with the Nephraeh had begun almost a month ago. But there were other reasons to keep an eye on the planet, strategic reasons that could not be ignored.

Enos was a technologically advanced planet; they had created many wonders that eased the lives of people not only on their world but throughout the universe. One of these wonders was the Motive Mass Array; a device that harnessed the immense gravitational forces of their unique tri-solar system and was the center point of a vast structure—The Relativity Forge. In this place, powerful gravity was drawn in from the three suns by the Motive Mass Array and converted into energy which was then stored within immense capacitors. By doing this, the people of Enos were able to generate an almost limitless supply of energy—energy which they shared with all neighboring systems, including Elysia.

But there was a dangerous side-effect of storing that much energy in one place; if suddenly released, it would have disastrous consequences on the delicate mutual orbits of the system's three stars. A wave of powerful gravity would cause one star to crash into another, causing not one but three supernovas. Such an incredible explosion would destroy not only the Tri-Solar system but also the neighboring ones—including Elysia. It would be foolish of the Madgēcots not to keep a close eye on this system, no matter how far-fetched a potential attack could be.

Captain Dhiraj had not heard much of the fighting, for it was moving too swiftly to keep track of, but from the scattered reports that had made it back to him, it sounded like it was going in favor of the Elysians. The Nephraeh were formidable fighters, and their starships were superb, but they're just not as many as them compared to the Madgēcots.

The outcome of this fight was never really in question, but the Madgēcots wanted it over as quickly as possible to minimize the damage necessary on both sides. As much as the Madgēcots wanted to punish the Nephraeh for their betrayal, they did not want to exterminate their old allies.

"I heard from a friend of mine on the *Shikari* that they are close to taking Darrikon," Jaya, his third in command at the navigation panel, said. Captain Dhiraj's grey-blue tail twitched in irritation.

“Jaya, you know better than to spread classified information,” he scolded.

Jaya’s long tan ears lowered in shame as Zeshan chuckled.

“Captain, no disrespect, but if she is right, that means we are close to taking Empyrea! This war is going to be over soon! So, what if we spread a little gossip? It’s good for morale!” Zeshan said good-naturedly.

Captain Dhiraj shook his head firmly. “This war is moving fast, and I’m hearing too many wild things. Some of them are not good and sound outrageous. For instance, this talk about a Champion fighting at the side of the fallen Zhe-La. It’s bad enough that the Nephraeh have one Champion, but two? Stuff like that is too impossible to be true and only hurts morale.”

Zeshan and Jaya shared a look; they too had heard the rumor of a Warrior Champion fighting on the side of the Empyreans. So far, no concrete information had surfaced, only vague references to a word—or name.

Despara.

“Those treacherous snakes almost destroyed our sacred tree and also managed to kidnap the bearer of She-Ra right from under our noses!” Captain Dhiraj said, bearing his fangs in anger. “To suggest that the enemy now has another Champion…”

He did not have to finish his sentence; the connection between the capture of Adora and a potential new enemy hero was too unthinkable even to suggest.

A small alarm went off before the Captain could respond, and Jaya’s ears perked back up.

“What is it, Jaya?” Captain Dhiraj asked.

Jaya’s blue eyes widened as she read the display before her. “A reading a large inbound energy signature, coming out of

hyperspace!” She shouted.

“Impossible! There are no Madgēcot ships scheduled to—” Captain Dhiraj started to say but was cut off as numerous dark and jagged-edged ships blinked into existence next to the planet Enos. They were not Madgēcot warships.

“Nephraeh!” Zeshan breathed. “Those are Nephraeh ship’s Captain!”

“I see that,” Captain Dhiraj growled. “It looks like the entire Nephraeh fleet! What in the name of The Great Chaliendra are they doing here?”

Almost fifty Nephraeh warships had finished their translation into real space and immediately began to bombard the planet below them, targeting automated gun satellites and atmospheric shielding. The surprise attack had caught the people of Enos off-guard; no one expected an attack this deep into Elysian territory. The Nephraeh made short work of the defenses.

“Captain, what should we do? Should we… attack?” Zeshan asked, unsure.

“No,” Captain Dhiraj said with resignation. “No, take us behind the nearby moon and alert Star Hunter command. We need to let everyone know that the Nephraeh are within striking distance of Elysia. Until reinforcements arrive, we wait here and hope those Nephraeh *gāda* don’t see us. Blast it! What are they doing here?”

“Captain,” Jaya said, squinting at her display panel. “It appears the Nephraeh have launched landers; they are heading towards the planet’s polar regions.”

“What the heck do they want there?” Zeshan asked.

Captain Dhiraj’s long grey ears lowered as he realized what the Nephraeh were after.

"That's where the Relativity Forge is located," he said in a whisper. "They are going to capture the power source for the entire quadrant!"

* * *

Veth strode down the lander's gangplank and onto the snowy waste of Enos' polar region, enjoying the way the cold, crisp air stung their nose. There was something appealing about this place; it was utterly devoid of any extraneous details, much how they have felt now that they had decided to drink deeper from the draught of Archon Lethe's power.

I wish I had done it sooner, they thought as the cold wind raked through their hair. *It would have made my mission to Elysia so much easier.*

Archon Lethe had praised them for the mission's success; Empyrea now had an ally with the power of She-Ra who would fight side by side with Zhe-La. Archon Lethe even seemed pleased that Great Chailendra Tree was merely wounded and not destroyed—which confused Veth. When they questioned their leader about this, Archon Lethe only made an obscure reference to a 'greater plan.'

But Veth's memories of the mission were not good ones; they had done things for the sake of Archon Lethe's plan that made them feel uncomfortable with themselves. They had found that they had grown to like Catra, making the knowledge of their ultimate betrayal hard to bare. When they had admitted these feelings to Archon Lethe, they told Veth the same thing they had told them since they were a youth; it was just Veth's warrior's honor speaking. That sometimes integrity must be sacrificed for the greater good—for The Light.

Veth knew better than that; it was their natural empathy creeping back into their soul. Compassion for Catra and every single one of the people of Elysia they were about to betray. But they were

feeling better now—much better. They were now ready to enact the next phase of their overlord's will.

Veth looked to their left and right, seeing numerous landers dispersing Nephraeh troops. The majority of these were Hoplites led by the heavily armored Centurions, but here and there, the warrior Peltasts or the agile Sarissa were seen. Even the dread Krypteia were arrayed on the field to act as an honor guard for the two Empyrean Champions. In fact, the host that arrived in the Tri-Solar system of Enos comprised almost the entirety of the Nephraeh's fighting force, leaving the world of Empyrea defenseless. The Elysians could swiftly take the enemy planet if they so wished, but Veth knew they would not dare once they saw what the Nephraeh had taken.

The massive complex of the Relativity Forge was before them, sitting upon an icy plateau. The structure appeared as an array of numerous cylinders of varying sizes, all pointing upwards towards the bright sky. From the center of the complex a blue haze pulsed towards the sky; evidence of the strange technology being utilized to harness the power of gravity.

Archon Lethe had told Veth that they knew the secret of the Motive Mass Array located deep within the Relativity Forge, but they had not shared with their champion what that secret was. Archon Lethe said that when the time was right, they would harness the true power of this device, but only after the Nephraeh had used it as a bargaining chip in this one-sided war with the Elysians.

"It's good to be fighting a real war and not having to rely on subterfuge anymore," a voice said at Veth's side.

They turned to see Nefeli helmetless and grinning at them, their long black hair whipping in the wind. One side of their head was now shaved down to stubble to reveal a slash a Madgēcot had given them at the beginning of the war. The wound ran part-way down Nefeli's face, missing the eye, giving them an appealing and

wild look. A pleasant feeling stirred in Veth's breast as they laid eyes on the leader of the Krypteia.

Veth suddenly realized they had always desired Nefeli but had suppressed those feelings due to their station as Champion of the Nephraeh. From the way Nefeli was looking at them, it appeared they felt the same way.

Perhaps I will ask Archon Lethe if I can mate with Nefeli, Veth thought as they smiled back at Nefeli.

Suddenly, a memory came unbidden to their mind as they remembered someone speaking.

When a person loves you, and you them, it is such a special thing, it's not something someone can pick for you. When you say that someone is going to pick this person for you, Veth, it just makes me feel—

Veth shook their head, trying to dislodge Catra's voice and not relive the obvious disgust she had for the Nephraeh's idea of intimacy.

"You okay, Champion Veth?" Nefeli asked.

They quickly nodded, not wanting to seem weak or unsure before such a critical mission.

"Yes, my friend. It's just the effects of a more intense Penumbra Ritual, that's all." They said, trying to sound reassuring.

Nefeli nodded in agreement. "Yes, I know what you mean. I have tripled the amount of Antithetical Philter I was taking before. It takes some getting used to."

Veth was shocked by this. "Really, Nefeli? Is that wise? You only needed to double the amount you were absorbing before."

Nefeli shrugged; there was a distant look in their glittering silver eyes.

"Veth, I don't want to feel like I did during the mission to Elysia again. It was getting very… hard for me towards the end. I could feel my connection to The Light slipping."

Veth sighed heavily. "Yes, you are right, my friend. I feel like we need to be stronger now, especially around our new ally,"

As if on cue, the second Empyrean Champion appeared from within another lander flanked by her own contingent of Krypteia—Despara.

As was her preference, Despara was in her She-Ra form, which she had not reverted out of since her 'awakening.' She towered above the Krypteia as she surveyed the landing area with burning indigo eyes. Spotting Veth standing nearby, she strode over to where they stood, her cold face regarding them with a cruel smirk.

"*Champion, Veth*," she said without an ounce of respect. "Why are you out of your enhanced state? Didn't you notice we are in a warzone?"

Veth felt Nefeli bristle next to them and willed their friend not to defend their honor. A mere Krypteia would not last seconds against Despara.

"Champion Despara, it is good to have you with us," Veth said cordially. "I chose not to summon Zhe-La unless they are needed,"

Despara openly leered down at them as she placed her massive black sword against her shoulder. She then turned her head in the direction of the Relativity Forge, pointing a black gauntleted finger in its direction.

"Does that merit a *need,* Veth?" She asked with scorn.

Looking in the direction Despara indicated, Veth saw a billowing cloud of ice crystals as the defenders of the Relativity Forge raced towards their position. This opposition was composed of numerous tank robots on whirring tracks with a few humanoid

versions running alongside them. Looking closer at the bipedal robots, Veth discerned forward viewports revealing Enosians piloting the mechanicals within the torso.

"Yesss!!!" Despara growled. "I love smashing robots!"

Looking at their fellow champion sideways, Veth saw Despara clutching her sword in the two-handed grip, manic glee plastered on her face.

"Despara, the tanks are indeed robots, but the others are mecha-suits. There are living beings inside," Veth said slowly.

Despara looked at them incredulously. "*So?* So what? I will *smash* them too!" She said, absolutely brimming with violence.

Before Veth could say anything else, Despara raised her dark sword in the air and let loose a fearsome war cry.

"AT THEMMMM!!!" She screamed.

"Wait!" Veth screamed, watching in disbelief as Despara raced forward in her desperation to get at the enemy. In a few brief moments, she was halfway to them and completely alone. The rest of the Nephraeh forces looked at Veth expectantly.

"We still only follow you, Veth," Nefeli said, looking at them with admiration.

"All Nephraeh forces! Follow Despara! ATTACK!" Veth shouted, "BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

Upon their transformation into their Champion form, Zhe-La/Veth charged forward to fight at Despara's side. By the time they reached her, Despara was lifting one of the tank robots and throwing it into its fellows. They collided in a fiery plume as she raced away to cleave the legs from a nearby mecha-suit, sending the rest of the body tumbling to the ground.

Since fighting at Despara's side a month ago, Zhe-La/Veth had noticed how she preferred close combat over any of her other magical attacks. From experience, they knew there were numerous ranged attacks at She-Ra's disposal, but Despara used none of these in battle. It was as if she craved the visceral feel of absolute violence.

"Glad you felt the need to finally summon Zhe-La," Despara said as she picked up the downed mecha-suit and ripped out its power core. She dropped the now defenseless enemy to the ground and gave it a dismissive kick, sending it spinning away.

Zhe-La/Veth did not have a chance to respond as another mecha-suit swung a buzzing power sword at them, barely missing their face. Drawing on the power of Oblivion, Zhe-La/Veth created a null-empathy void around themselves, bathing their foe in enervation. The mecha-suit pilot's eyes widened as the dark power overwhelmed them, making them stand rigid in shock. Using their sword, Zhe-La/Veth expertly removed the suit's arms and legs, rendering the enemy no longer a threat.

Zhe-La/Veth turned just in time to see Despara kick another robot tank, sending it cart-wheeling through the icy snow to collide with two other tanks, destroying all three with one blow. She turned to favor Zhe-La/Veth with a savage grin and gave them a mocking salute with her sword. They only shook their head at her, amazed by her absolute effective brutality. Zhe-La/Veth may have grown to dislike their new ally, but they were quick to admit how effective she was against the enemies of Archon Lethe.

A searing white beam streaked past Zhe-La/Veth to collide with Despara, pitching her back and slamming her into the ice to disappear within a massive steaming crater. Looking for the attack source, Zhe-La/Veth spotted a mecha-suit wielding an enormous energy cannon—which was now directed at them.

Zhe-La/Veth dismissed the power of Oblivion and the null-empathy void transitioned into its natural state; a hazy transparent shield that deflected the energy blast just in time.

After the deadly energy dissipated, Zhe-La/Veth saw their enemy desperately operate the controls on their weapon, attempting to recharge it for another blast.

They did not give their opponent the chance; Zhe-La/Veth lunged forward to slash their sword into the end of the energy cannon, crippling it. The mecha-suit raised their inoperable weapon above their head, intending to club the Nephreah Champion, but Zhe-La/Veth neatly sliced the raised arms in half at the elbow and kicked the mecha-suit onto its back.

As the mecha-suit driver flailed their legs and useless arms against the ground, Zhe-La/Veth placed a booted foot on their torso, pinning the mechanical in place. They ripped the transparent window away to reveal a female pilot struggling to free herself from the restraints. She stopped moving to gaze up at Zhe-La/Veth with fearful wide eyes.

"I suggest you surrender," Zhe-La/Veth said.

Anger suddenly replaced fear on the woman's face.

"Never, you treacherous scum!" She screamed.

Wetness struck Zhe-La/Veth as a red mist suddenly appeared in the air. In confusion, they wiped at their cheek and looked at their gauntleted hand, but the armor covering their fingers was too dark to see what the substance was. Rubbing their fingers together, Zhe-La/Veth felt that it was sticky, like drying glue, and smelled strange. Rich, and metallic—but familiar.

Looking down at the mecha-suit, Zhe-La/Veth felt a jolt as they saw the woman—now obviously dead. Despara stood over her, black sword held tightly in a two-handed grip as she panted with exertion and fury. Her Oblivion imbued sword glowed with indigo light as it dripped, creating red stains in the pure white snow.

Zhe-La/Veth felt something then, a strange sensation, like the insides of their body being stretched as a part of them tried to get out. A part of them that had been subdued and buried, but now

with what had been witnessed, could no longer be denied. Zhe-La/Veth bit back a sudden feeling of nausea as they looked away from Despara.

Zhe-La/Veth could not help remembering who she once was, a person who would have been horrified by what she was doing now. A person who had fought Zhe-La/Veth in righteous anger, and when she had stuck down and wounded them, felt sorrow for her violent actions. Zhe-La/Veth felt a longing to have that other person at their side instead of the one Archon Lethe provided—but it was not to be. There was no point in wishing for the impossible.

The rest of the Nephareah force had since caught up with their heroes and we were busy mopping up the rest of the Relativity Forge's defenders. Zhe-La/Veth could see their fellow Empyreans leading mecha-suit pilots away in black bindings; the Enosians looking dejected in their defeat. But at least they were alive.

Unlike this poor wretch, Zhe-La/Veth thought, looking back at the dead Enosian.

Zhe-La/Veth sensed someone near and turned to see Nefeli looking at the ruin of the mecha-suit pilot before them. A strange expression passed over the Kyrpteia leader's face as they glanced from the body to Despara.

"So much for their defenses," Despara said as she casually wiped her sword in the snow. "Let's go claim our prize, eh?"

Both Nephraeh nodded to the warrior woman as she turned and strode away, walking with a strut in the direction of the Relativity Forge.

"She's an animal," Nefeli whispered.

Zhe-La/Veth sighed as they nodded. "Yes, but she is our animal," they said sadly.

"We made her."

* * *

Catra raced through the corridors of the Star Hunter warship *Pakadna* on all fours, eager to get to the landing bay and greet her friends. It had been months since she had seen any of them, and after everything that had happened to her, Catra just wanted to see a familiar face again.

"Cat-Tra! Wait up!" Viraj called, running on all fours to catch up.

"Hurry up, you slowpoke!" She called back. "I'm starting to wonder if you are really my twin!"

"Hey!" her brother yelled back in indignation.

Catra grinned as she turned up the speed, scrabbling along the outer wall as the corridor abruptly turned ninety degrees. Catra performed a leap and a somersault over a group of Madgēcots blocking her way, earning an annoyed hiss.

"Hey! No running on all fours in the corridors unless in combat!" One of them yelled.

"Sorry! Sorry!" Viraj said as he passed the angry Madgēcots walking on two legs. "My sister is new here; this won't happen again,"

"Yes, it will!" Catra yelled gleefully back at them.

The past month had been hard on Catra; sitting aboard the *Pakadna* waiting for news about Adora as the warship had raced from warzone to warzone. The Nephraeh always seemed to be one step ahead of the Madgēcots, melting away as the threat of engagement became imminent. Whenever the Star Hunter fleet made a move for their home planet, there was always a direct attack at their flank, drawing them away. Catra had only heard about the battles secondhand; they sounded quick and intense, lasting only long enough to keep her people distracted before the Nephraeh retreated.

To Catra, this whole war seemed like one long attempt for the Empyreans to buy time—for what, she could only guess. Catra could not help the dread that had built up inside her with all the waiting. When she found out her friends from Etheria were here, she could not wait to see them.

Finally arriving at her destination, Catra barked a command to open the magical wooden door and stood on two feet to survey the large open area of the landing bay. Suppressing a squeal of delight when she spotted The Millennial Seagull, Catra got ahold of herself just enough to saunter over to her friends as they disembarked from their ship.

"Hey, guys, I know you are practically on the other side of the galaxy, but what took you so long?" She said, crossing her arms and giving them all a cocky grin.

The bravado instantly vanished as Melog came bounding down the deployment ramp and over to Catra, knocking her flat on her back.

"Heyyy… easy! I missed you too!" Catra said as her friend licked her face.

Glimmer was next to approach Catra, and as usual, her friend was not in the mood for levity.

"Catra, what in the name of Etheria is going on?" She said, hands on hips. "Why are you on a warship, and where is Adora?"

Catra felt her façade of coolness vanish as Glimmer's last question hit her like a hammer. Rising to her feet, Catra wrapped Glimmer in a hug as she attempted to keep the tears from spilling out.

"Adora is gone, Glimmer. The Nephraeh kidnapped her—they took her from me," Catra said as the tears finally escaped from her eyes.

"The *who,* Catra?" Glimmer said in bewilderment as she returned the hug.

Feeling Glimmer's embrace was too much for Catra, the dam finally broke inside her. The sadness that had built up since Adora's kidnapping was finally released, and Catra could not help herself from burying her face in Glimmer's neck as she wept. It was *so good* to have her friends here.

"There, there, Catra," Glimmer soothed, rubbing her back.

"Hey Cat-Tra, why didn't you—" Viraj said, stopping short when he saw his sister crying on Glimmer's shoulder.

"Hi there, I'm Glimmer," Glimmer said with a lame wave. "You are definitely related to Catra,"

"Yep, I'm Viraj, Cat-Tra's twin brother," he said with an equally lame wave.

By now, the rest of Catra's friends had disembarked the *Millennial Falcon* and had surrounded the crying Catra. She pulled herself away from Glimmer while trying to wipe the tears from her now red eyes.

"Hi guys," Catra said as she gave them all a weak smile. "Wasn't planning on falling apart in front of you all,"

"Oh, Catra, honey," Perfuma said as she pulled her into an embrace. "Tell us what happened,"

Catra felt herself moving towards tears again as Perfuma hugged her tightly. She began to purr as she cried; she felt safe to open up with these people, and the catharsis was pure bliss. Catra felt reassuring hands on her arms and back as Seahawk, Bow, and Shen joined in—even a tongue on her ankle on Battlecat licked her.

Catra felt tremendous gratitude for them all, even giving Bow, Seahawk, and Battlecat a firm hug. But she stopped herself from embracing Shen, instead of clasping him by the wrists.

“Shen, I am so glad you’re here. I need your help, badly,” she said.

Shen smiled back to Catra and nodded. “Of course. Anything you need, Catra, I’m there,” he said simply.

Catra felt overwhelming appreciation for her friend’s words but couldn’t help but notice something was different with Shen. His eyes always had a subtle sadness to them, but there was a greater degree now, plus something else; a darkness smoldering in the background that unsettled her.

“Hey, are you okay?” Catra asked with a tilt of her head—Shen frowned back at her.

“Yeah, of course. Why?” He asked. Catra could tell he was lying to cover up his feelings but chose just to drop it.

“Just checking,” She said casually. “That’s just what friends do—talk to each other when they need to.”

Shen shrugged. “I will let you know. But right now, why don’t you tell us what is happening?”

Catra nodded as she wiped the residual tears from her eyes.

“Right. Why don’t I fill you in as we head back up to the bridge? Captain Nyra wants to talk to you. She is interested in how you knew to come to our aid.” Catra said.

“We didn’t have a clue about what is going on out here, Catra, honest. We are on a completely separate mission,” Glimmer said as she shook her head.

“And that is?” Catra said, raising her eyebrows.

Glimmer took Catra by the shoulder as she led her to the exit of the landing bay.

“It’s a long story. I will tell you on the way,” she said with a small smile.

As they walked down the long corridors of the *Pakadna,* Catra told her friends how she and Adora had been enjoying their honeymoon on Elysia when they suddenly became embroiled in the drama between the Madgēcots and the Nephraeh. She went into detail about the lost sword of Sher-Va and the mysterious bearer of Zhe-La, Veth, but she chose to leave out the part of her attraction to them. Catra explained that the Nephraeh had used the false claim of wanting to heal the rift between Empyrea and Elysia in order to get close enough to enact their secret plan.

“The whole time, they had been lying to us,” Catra said with a hint of anger. “They wanted to trick us into letting our guard down so they could destroy The Great Chaliendra Tree and kidnap Adora. They partially succeeded with the former and then used me as leverage to get Adora to surrender to them. Elysia and Empyrea have been at war ever since,”

“Have the Empyreans said if they are holding Adora for ransom?” Glimmer asked.

Catra shook her head. “Our side isn’t talking to them; we have no idea what they have done with Adora.” She said sadly. “Anyway, your turn now. Why did you come all the way from Etheria if not to join in the fight against the Nephraeh?”

From the look on Glimmer’s face, Catra knew it would be a doozy of a story—and she was right.

“What?!” Catra exclaimed after Glimmer was finished with her story. “Scorpia and Mermista are gone? Like when they were chipped?”

Bow chimed in. “Sadly no. They are still in control of themselves, just missing their empathy,”

“And that’s it?” Catra said dubiously. “That’s all it took, and they are running amok? I can’t believe that they would do that,

especially Scorpia! It just doesn't make sense."

"Why wouldn't you believe it, Catra?" Bow said. "I mean, think about who Scorpia was, how big her heart is. Take that all away; what do you have left?"

Catra sighed; what Bow said made sense. After all, she knew all about people that were missing their empathy; she had been dealing with them for a while now.

"Could what happened to Scorpia, Entrapta, and Mermista be related to the Nephraeh?" Catra asked suddenly. "I mean, I would have a hard time believing it doesn't."

"I believe they are directly connected," Glimmer said, nodding her head. "I discovered a journal from a Nephraeh named Kishar in the place Mermista, Entrapta, and Scorpia were attacked. I believe the taking of Empathy is directly tied to Kishar somehow; I just—"

Glimmer was interrupted by a loud siren sound and the flashing of magical red lights recessed in the wooden walls of the corridors. There was a slight tremor in the deck as Madgēcots began running up and down the halls frantically.

"Come!" Viraj said, taking the lead. "The ship is translating to hyperspace; we need to get to the bridge!"

The large bridge of the *Pakadna* was bustling with activity as Viraj led everyone inside. The entire space was ovoid with a slightly raised circular plinth in the center for the ship's master and her senior bridge officers. In contrast, the rest of the bridge personnel sat on tiered platforms adjacent to and at the same level as their commanders. The entire bridge sat under a dome which projected a view of the immediate area around the massive warship by magical or technological means. The effect was dizzying and it had made Catra want to vomit the first time she visited.

Currently, Captain Nyra and her two junior officers were huddled around a table at the back of the bridge. Catra immediately

headed over to her, followed by her brother and friends.

“Cat-Tra, we will have to dispense with the introductions; something has come up,” Captain Nyra said with a guarded tone.

“What’s going on, Captain?” Catra asked pensively. Usually, the Captain was more direct with her speech, and she did not like this sudden change.

“Nephraeh forces have attacked a planet in a system close to Elysia. They managed to surprise the planet’s defenses and take a critical resource—the Relativity Forge,” Captain Nyra said matter-of-factly.

“How, Captain? The Nephraeh are stretched thin and just trying to keep us from taking Empyrea.” Viraj asked.

Captain Nyra nodded. “They combined their entire fleet into one single unit and circumvented our fleet. We believe that the entire Empyrean fighting force is now on the planet Enos,”

“Well, that’s great news!” Catra said. “We can just leave them to and take Empyrea! I’m sure that’s where they are holding Adora!”

Fear gripped Catra as she saw the Madgēcot woman’s face fall, and she waited for the bad news to come.

“We cannot make a move towards Empyrea. If we did, the enemy could destroy the Gravity Forge, releasing enough energy to destabilize the orbits of the system’s suns and creating a triple supernova. That would destroy this system, the Elysian system, and about ten others. They Nephraeh have us by the throats,” Captain Nya said grimly.

Everyone looked forlornly at each other as they took in the dire circumstances.

“And Cat-Tra, you’re going to want to see this,” Captain Nyra said as she pressed a button on the round table.

A holographic image appeared displaying hazy static before resolving into a stable image. It projected a snowy plain where a battle was taking place; lithe black armored troops fighting a horde of what appeared to be various robots.

The image zoomed in on a more prominent armored figure swinging a black sword at what looked like a bipedal robot. After closer inspection, Catra saw a person inside the robot through a transparent window—it was a mecha-suit like the one her friend Entrapta used. Catra instantly recognized the top knotted helmet and shape of the sword wielder as they cleaved the arms and legs from the mecha-suit. She immediately started growling.

"Veth," she said through clenched teeth. "Wait until I get my hands on you,"

The camera viewpoint switched to another black armored figure running at a full sprint; it was a woman, a huge and powerful one wielding a sizeable black sword of her own. She brought the massive sword over her head to hack down at the downed mecha-suit—spraying blood on herself and Zhe-La/Veth. Catra felt sick at the brutal violence on display.

"Her name is Despara," Captain Nyra said as she pressed a button to zoom in on the woman's face. "But I think you will recognize her, Cat-Tra,"

The warrior woman turned, giving Catra a clear and close-up view of Despara's face. At first, she almost did not recognize her; the face was brutal and cruel, framed by a wicked headpiece. But Catra reeled as the indigo glowing eyes blazed out through the holograph and into her heart. Catra screamed as she recognized her soul mate.

"NO!!!" she cried. "It can't be!"

But it was. The face was one Catra recognized, for she had spent countless hours caressing the cheeks and kissing those lips. It was a face that had lit up her soul whenever it turned in her direction,

even when they had fought. It was the face Catra had yearned to see once more the past month since her wife's abduction, but now she saw it, wished she hadn't.

"Adora," Catra whispered as tears poured from her eyes. *"What have they done to you?"*

Apathy Wanes

Chapter Summary

Veth struggles with "The Light."

Catra, Glimmer and the Madgēcots make a daring plan to attack the Relativity Forge.

Catra dreads the idea of facing Despara.

Veth opened their silver eyes, answering the call of the impending Penumbra Ritual to awaken. It was a daily experience, their internal biological clock precisely tuned to the moment in time they sacrificed their compassion to The Light. Except this morning was different, there was an odd sensation there to greet them as the new day began. Veth looked around their quarters in Relativity Forge for the source but then realized the cause was lying on top of them.

Nefeli was pressed against them with their arm draped over Veth’s chest, face soft and impassive in sleep. Veth smiled as they remembered what had occurred the night before; how they approached Nefeli, asking them to go over some fine details of the defense of the Nephraeh’s new territory back in Veth’s quarters. This had gone on for hours, and Veth had steered the conversation into lighter territory, finally maneuvering into open flirting. Nefeli had seized upon these overtures; their eyes glittering as if they had been waiting for it.

Veth had felt excitement when they knew that Nefeli had passionate feelings for them. Also, the fact that they did not have permission from Archon Lethe to be with the Krypteia Leader gave Veth an additional thrill of danger. They remembered thinking that Catra would be proud of Veth for taking the initiative, for following their desires instead of the dictates of another.

Except Catra will want to kill you whenever she sees you again, Veth thought sadly. *And you deserve it.*

Nefeli's stirring shook Veth from these morose thoughts, and they smiled to themselves as they admired their sleeping lover. Veth ran their fingers lightly over the raised lines of the scars on the side of Nefeli's head, enjoying the way they felt in combination with the short, bristly hair. They followed the claw marks down to where they ended, just below Nefeli's eye, then continued to their lips—Veth suddenly wanted to kiss them.

A smile appeared on those lips as Veth ran a clawed finger over them and a metallic glint appeared as Nefeli's eyes opened

"Good morning, *Champion* Veth," they said with a sleepy grin. Nefeli wrapped their arms around Veth, squeezing them tight; the feel of the lithe body pressed so firmly against them felt so good.

"I wondered if you were ever going to wake; you're going to make us late for the ritual," Veth teased, kissing them on the forehead.

Nefeli chuckled. "I have a feeling that after last night, we are going to need it badly today,"

Veth didn't have to guess at Nefeli's meaning; lovemaking weakened the effects of the Antithetical Philter, pushing every Nephraeh further from the Light. It was only to be done sparingly and out of need, to perpetuate the species—never for pleasure.

Veth felt Nefeli's claws slide gently across their stomach as a reflective look appeared on their beautiful face.

"Veth? Do you ever think of just skipping it? Like, just for a day?" Nefeli asked tentatively.

"Skipping what?" Veth replied.

"Don't be obtuse, Veth. We've known each other for a long time, you know what I mean," Nefeli said with a bit of annoyance.

“Why would we go against the Archon’s wishes and not go through with the Penumbra Ritual?” Veth asked tonelessly.

Nefeli was quiet for a moment, then nuzzled their face into the side of Veth’s neck. Veth could feel their lips there and enjoyed how Nefeli’s breath tickled their flesh.

“For *this* Veth,” they said. “Back on Elysia, when we had not taken the Antithetical Philter for a day, I started feeling… this *feeling*. It felt *so good*—I had never felt it before. It’s like last night and *this*, here and now; I don’t want it to stop.”

“I thought you told me you never want to feel that way again. Isn’t that why you wanted to take triple the dose during the Penumbra Ritual?” Veth asked, confused.

Nefeli sighed. “I said that because the feeling was so intense and pleasurable. At first, I thought that something that felt so good could only be wrong—so I felt guilty. But after last night, in your bed, I’m starting to feel differently.”

Veth knew what Nefeli was speaking of, for they felt the same way, but years of indoctrination in the ways of The Light steered them away from such a thought.

“No, Nefeli, I don’t. Please don’t ever speak like this again, I would never turn you in, but others might. I don’t want anything to happen to you,” they responded.

Nefeli raised their head to look down at Veth incredulously.

“Do you have any idea how the statement, ‘I don’t want anything to happen to you,’ sounds, Veth?”

Fear jolted through Veth as they realized that Nefeli was correct; they did care what happened to the person lying beside them. Which could only mean one thing.

Before they could respond, a loud buzzing rang out in the room indicating that someone was at the door. Veth attempted to

disentangle themselves from Nefeli's embrace to answer it.

"No, Veth, just ignore it and stay here with me," the leader of the Krypteia pleaded as they clutched Veth tighter.

Veth chuckled as they finally freed themselves from Nefeli's grasp and stumbled over to their clothes strewn on the floor.

"We will have plenty of time for that, Nefeli. Right now, we have a war to fight—or did you forget?" Veth admonished as they yanked their Aegis Lace pants on.

"Oh, I don't think I could ever forget," they responded, feeling the slash marks on the side of their head.

Hastily shrugging into their white jacket, Veth strode over to the door to open it. As the shiny surface of the door slid over to open, Veth found themselves staring into a woman's black armored chest which was emblazoned with the red corrupted symbol of She-Ra. Looking up, they found themselves locked with Despara's cold, pitiless gaze.

"Took you long enough to answer the door," she growled.

"Uh, greetings, Despara; I was distracted. I apologize." Veth said, suddenly realizing they forgot to put a shirt on under the jacket. They felt very vulnerable in the presence of the massive warrior.

"Ah, I think I see the distraction now," Despara said with a leer as she peered around Veth. "Here, I thought you Nephraeh were cold-blooded, but now I see you are quite the opposite. Eh, Veth?"

Despara ran a black gauntleted fingertip from Veth's chest down to their belly, stopping at the top of their pants. They cringed inwardly at her touch, remembering the violence doled out by those very same hands the day before. They had to stop themselves from summoning Zhe-La. Veth pushed Despara's hand away and tugged their jacket closed, trying to hide their bare skin from her hungry gaze.

“What do you need, Despara? Have you decided to join us in the Penumbra Ritual, finally?” Veth said, trying to hide the annoyance in their voice.

“Pah! No, of course not; why would I do that?” She answered with a smirk.

“Because that is what those closest to Archon Lethe must do. To prove they are worthy of the light,” Veth answered by rote.

The leer returned to Despara’s face. “For you, Nephraeh—but not for me. According to Archon Lethe, I never have to prove my worth,”

Veth frowned at this response and became even more uncomfortable than before. By the very definition, they were utterly unworthy of Archon Lethe’s Light, given their admitted feelings for Nefeli. But here was someone whom the leader of the Nephraeh decreed never to have to prove their devotion to apathy—and Veth believed it.

“Speaking of our beloved leader, they asked to speak with you. They are waiting for you to contact them in the holo-chamber,” Despara said.

Veth decided to ignore the disrespect they heard in Despara’s voice and turned to go back into their chamber. They stopped when they felt a heavy hand grasp them by the shoulder, stopping them in their tracks.

“Now, Veth,” Despara said with menace.

Veth whirled on her, lashing out with claws that sparked on the reactive armor covering the fallen She-Ra.

“*Touch me again, and I will kill you!*” Veth hissed, baring thier fangs at the other warrior.

Despara lowered herself until she was face to face with the other Empyrean champion but did not reach for them.

“I would like to see you try, Zhe-La,” she whispered. “I know about you. You are weak; I can see it. You are just pretending to serve The Light, and when I get the chance, I will expose you *for the liar* we both know you to be,”

Anxiety surged through Veth as they realized that this was the second time the person before them accused them of being false. No matter who she was, this bearer of She-Ra could always see right through Veth’s facade.

“I look forward to the day. But until then, how about you just go away,” Veth said coldly.

Despara shrugged and then looked behind Veth. “Nefeli, why don’t you get out of bed and put some clothes on? We have to prepare for the Elysian counterattack which could come any day now. I expect the Krypteia down in the courtyard for review before noon.”

“Yes, Champion Despara,” Nefeli called back. “Right after the sacred ritual is complete, you can count on the Krypteia.”

Despara snorted as she turned and strode away, her arrogant strut in full effect.

Veth gazed back into the room at Nefeli in their bed, yearning to go to them. By the look they returned in Veth’s direction, it was apparent Nefeli felt the same way.

“We will wait for you, Veth. When you are done speaking with our leader, we can all conduct the ritual together,” Nefeli said with a smile.

Their agitation from the encounter with Despara melted away at Nefeli’s words, and Veth nodded in appreciation.

“See you soon,” Veth said, closing the door and following Despara’s footsteps. They suddenly shook their head and chuckled to themselves.

People say I am good with words, and all I come up with is 'see you soon?' They thought with a bit of embarrassment. *Ah, well, I will have time to consider something better. I have the feeling this is only the beginning between Nefeli and me.*

The corridors of the Relatively Forge were expansive and stark, the Enosians choosing function over esthetics in designing the complex. It was much like the city of Nox, back on Empyrea. But instead of being pleased by this similarity, Veth found it austere and dispassionate. They were surprised that this feeling also encompassed their memories of their home city as well.

I hope this does not take too long; I really need to conduct the Penumbra Ritual, Veth thought as the walls and ceiling disappeared as the corridor suddenly transitioned into a catwalk.

They were now in the colossal space which housed the Mass Motive Array and main capacitors. Veth leaned against one of the rails to take in the magnitude of the place. Millions of pipes lined the cylindrical walls of the chamber, running down to the floor to meet in a heap at the center. Pulsing capacitors poked out of this tangle, and from a large hole at the peak, a blue beam of light streaked up towards the heavens. Veth knew that deep inside, at the center of this agglomeration, was the Mass Motive Array; they had only seen it once, an inconspicuous rectangular box floating in a haze of dazzling energy.

The workings of this device mystified the Empyreans, and so many of the Enosian scientists were allowed to remain in the facility. Veth turned to see a group of them trying to sneak past behind them; there were four of the natives, and they shrank from Veth's silver gaze as the Nephraeh turned to regard them.

The Enosians were a variety of humans that once made up most of the great Empire that once ruled the galaxy millennia ago. Not many of the galaxy's residents knew about humans and their history, but Veth's people did, and so did the Madgēcots—they remembered everything.

Veth walked over to the group of scientists and favored them with a warm smile. All four of them immediately went to one knee, bowing their heads in a way that went beyond respect.

Veth was immediately taken aback. "Come now, that's not necessary. You don't have to bow to me; I just wanted to talk to you," they said.

The scientists shared a look amongst themselves before one spoke up—a slight woman of middle age.

"We were told to show absolute abasement before any Nephraeh —especially before a Champion, Lord Veth," the woman said while still not meeting Veth's gaze.

"That's utter nonsense! Who said that?" Veth scoffed.

"Lord Despara," she said, absolute fear in her voice.

Veth nodded to themselves. *I should have known Despara was behind this; she does enjoy her petty games.*

Veth laid a hand on the woman's shoulder, giving it a reassuring squeeze.

"What is your name?" They asked her.

"Elora, my Lord," she said hesitantly.

"Elora, can you please look at me?" Veth asked gently.

The woman slowly raised her eyes to meet Veth's, they widened as she took in their features, a slight blush rising on her cheeks. Veth's smile broadened as Elora could not help grinning at them, suddenly seeming embarrassed.

"Elora, please do not address any Nephraeh as Lord; we may be occupying your planet, but we are not your rulers. Once we are finished here, and if victory allows it, you will be placed under the

protection of Empyrea and allowed to govern yourselves." Veth said firmly.

"What about the other, the one who is not a Nephraeh?" Elora asked uncertainly.

Veth nodded. "Perhaps you should continue calling her Lord for now. She does not deserve it, but I fear what she may do if you do not obey her. I would protect you from her, but I cannot be everywhere at once," Veth said.

The woman nodded, smiling gratefully up at the Nephraeh. Veth brushed the backs of their claw tips against the side of her cheek as her eyes closed in the enjoyment of their touch.

"You have such a pretty smile, Elora," Veth said before dropping their hand and walking away.

Veth grinned to themselves as they felt the eyes of all four scientists watch them depart—but it vanished as they realized that they felt great pleasure in the fact they had alleviated the fear in the humans.

I'm so unworthy, Veth thought as they gritted their teeth in anger. *It was not right that Despara was abusing her authority over these people, but I went too far! Curse it! Last night with Nefeli has weakened my resolve!*

Veth was clenching their fists in anger as they strode into the holographic chamber and onto the raised disc of the transmitter. They kneeled, activating the device to open a channel with Archon Lethe. It was not lost on Veth that they were humbling themselves just as the scientists did to them but knew that their Lord expected it.

Veth felt a static prickle on their skin as a holographic representation of Archon Veth's disembodied head appeared before them in the air, magnified fivefold in size. The Nephraeh Champion raised their eyes to find themselves gazing into the

Leader of the Nephraeh's bone-white visage, their indigo eyes seeming to blaze into Veth across lightyears.

"You summoned me, my Archon?"

The imaged smiled, exposing teeth blacker than the void between galaxies.

"Yes, my Child, I wanted to congratulate you on your latest achievement! Taking the Relativity Forge in the name of the Empyrean Empire." Archon Lethe said proudly.

Veth knew better—Archon Lethe did not dole out compliments so quickly, especially when the taking of Enos was an expectation.

Do they know about Nefeli and me? Veth thought with a spike of fear.

"Is there something the matter, my Child?" Archon Lethe asked suddenly.

Veth clamped down on the fears as their mind raced for an answer.

"No—I mean yes, my Archon. I had a disturbing interaction with some of the locals on my way to speak with you. It seems that Despara has been misrepresenting the Empyrean Empire and abusing her authority over some of the people here. I'm also concerned with some of her more violent tendencies. She used an excessive amount of force in taking this facility." Veth said finally.

Archon Lethe pursed their pure white lips as they contemplated their Champion's words. They finally spoke for what seemed like an uncomfortable eternality.

"My Child, did I keep you from participating in the ritual this morning?"

Veth was taken aback. "Uh, yes… my Lord… but—"

“Well, there you have it, my Child!” Archon Lethe said, beaming. “Once you partake in the ritual, you will only see that this is your jealousy speaking. You fear for your place as my number one. Don’t you, my Child?”

Veth suddenly bowed their head, utterly uncertain of themselves.

“Uh… yes, my Archon. I’m sorry, it is so unworthy of me,” they whispered.

“Do not fret about it, my Child. You may not be my only Champion anymore, but you will always be my first.” Archon Lethe said kindly.

“Yes, my Archon. Thank you, my Archon,” Veth said meekly.

Suddenly, a thought occurred to Veth, something that did not make sense in the grand tapestry that was Archon Lethe’s vision of The Light. This disparity gave them the sudden courage to speak boldly to the dread specter before them.

“My Archon, Despara said something interesting to me earlier. She said she does not need the Penumbra Ritual. How can this be? Does Despara not have to prove herself worthy of The Light?” They asked.

A nebulous expression passed over Archon Lethe’s face but then passed, replaced quickly by the guise of a smile.

“Do not concern yourself with Despara, Veth. She is beyond the need for the Penumbra; I have seen to that myself,” they said.

Veth was not content with this answer; it only raised more questions.

“If you have the power to do this for someone who is not Nephraeh, why do you not do this for your own people? Why must we go through this ritual every day?” Veth asked, confused.

“Are you questioning me, Veth?” Archon Lethe said, the warning plain in their voice.

“No, my Archon, but—”

“*Besides,*” Archon Lethe said, abruptly cutting off Veth. “You have other things to worry about, my Champion. I have word from our operatives that two bearers of the Staves of Power, plus He-Man, have been spotted on Thenlor. They were followed until our Madgēcot friends interdicted their ship and picked them up. Soon they will be headed here; I have doubt about it,”

“He-Man…” Veth said pensively. “The Power of Grayskull,”

“Yes, He-Man, your fellow *Champion*,” Veth said with a sneer. “I remember his father Adam and the He-Mans before him. They were all brawn and no brains—this one is no different. Plus, I have it on good account that this one has a weakness you can exploit.”

Veth lowered their face at the mention of exploitation, not wanting their Archon to see their dismay at having to use underhanded tactics again.

“This He-Man, Shen, has a form of emotional imbalance which makes him prone to anxiety and despair. Such a person is vulnerable to our particular powers—he will be easy pickings for you and Despara.” Archon Lethe said with relish. “I cannot fathom why the Avatar of He-Man chose this current bearer, but no matter,”

Veth raised their silver eyes to the hologram, using every bit of their willpower to hide the disgust they felt at their new task.

“It will be done, my Archon,”

* * *

Catra forced herself to concentrate on the mission briefing taking place as the knowledge of her wife’s fate weighed on her mind.

Adora is now someone named Despara. Will she even recognize me when we finally meet?

That, plus many other questions, raced through Catra's head as the nature of the current situation slowly solidified in her numb mind.

So now Adora is fighting on the side of evil while I am on the side of good. The universe really has a sick sense of humor. Is this my punishment for all my time in the Horde? For all the people I hurt? Now I get to see what it's like for—

Catra was roused from her thoughts by a gentle elbow in her ribs —it was Glimmer. Her friend was sitting next to her in the briefing hall; a circular-shaped room with tiered benches in the back and a viewscreen in the front. Captain Neyra was currently giving them all a summary of the intelligence they had on the Relativity Forge, hoping to find a way to neutralize its threat. All of Catra's friends from Etheria were gathered there, plus her brother and a few Madgēcot fleet commanders.

"Catra, you need to pay attention to this," Glimmer whispered through tight lips.

"Ya, I know, Sparkles. Why don't you give me a break? I just found out my wife is a brainwashed maniac who likes to dice people up with her giant sword," Catra whispered back through gritted teeth.

Captain Neyra stopped her presentation to stare daggers at the two women: their whispering back and forth had distracted everyone around them.

"Anything you would like to add, ladies?" The Captain asked with deadly sweetness.

Catra cocked her head as she studied the current image display on the screen; it was one of the many giant energy storage capacitors that were the leading cause of distress for the Elysians. If just one of them were destroyed, it would set off a chain

reaction releasing the system-annihilating energy stored inside the Relativity Forge. Catra realized they just needed a means to safely release all that energy and direct it away from the three stars.

“Yeah, I do, actually,” Catra piped up. “I see those are non-polarized capacitors. That means we can send the energy stored within them right back to where it came from, right?”

Captain Neyla shook her head. “Yes, Catra. That is right, but the whole point of this operation is to avoid hitting one of the suns with a massive energy burst. That’s exactly what you would do if we did that.”

“Can we direct where the Mass Motive Array is pointed?” Catra responded with a hint of exasperation. “I mean, the planet Enos is constantly changing position in relation to the three suns as it orbits them. There must be a way to adjust it. After that, it’s just a simple means of aiming it away from the suns and releasing all that power back out into the cosmos.”

“Like a big gun,” Bow added. “Hopefully, we aren’t pointing all that energy at someone,”

Catra waved this concern away. “That’s a problem for future us,”

Captain Neyra grinned. “That’s a good idea, Catra; I’m glad being away from Elysia hasn’t dulled your Madgēcot wits. You won’t have to worry about hurting anyone, though. Our stellar cartographers will map out a trajectory for the energy beam, which will send it safely outside our galaxy. It will dissipate harmlessly in the intergalactic void.”

“So how do we keep them from building energy back up once we get rid of it?” Perfuma asked the group.

“I know! I know!” Seahawk said excitedly.

“No, we are not setting it on fire, Seahawk,” Glimmer said.

Seahawk was instantly crestfallen.

“If not, set it on fire; how about blow it up?” Catra interjected.

Seahawk immediately brightened.

“No, Catra, we are not going to just blow the Relativity Forge up.” Captain Neyra said with a scowl. “When this is all over, the Enosians will want it back intact. The Elysians will not be responsible for multiple systems losing their power source.

“I thought it was a great idea,” Shen whispered in one of Catra’s long black ears. She turned and favored her friend with a toothy grin.

Captain Neyra pressed a button in a nearby console; the image before them changed. It now showed a section view of the Relativity Forge’s core. There, an innocuous rectangular box floated above an enormous well at the center of a massive jumble of pipes, cables, and capacitors.

“This is the Mass Motive Array, the gadget the Enosions use to draw the gravity from the three local suns and transduce it into power. If this is removed from the facility, then we won’t have to worry about them recharging the capacitors.” Captain Neyra said.

“What do we know about this technology?” Bow asked, very curious. “I would be fascinated to know how it works.”

Captain Neyra shook her head. “We know nothing about it. The Enosians always kept its workings a carefully guarded secret and the Madgēcots respected their wishes. We do think that it can be removed based on the fact it is not connected directly to anything and is suspended in a null gravity field. I’m sure once it is released from the field, it will be a simple matter for the Queen of Etheria to teleport it to one of our ships.”

Catra stood a walked over to Captain Neyra with her chin held in contemplation.

“So, it all comes down to getting inside this Relativity Forge without the Nephraeh knowing—which means a small team. We

already know we need Sparkles for the teleport, and there is no way you are doing this without me." Catra said, pointing a black-clawed thumb at her chest. "So that is two people so far."

"Now wait a second, Catra," Perfuma said, standing and holding up her hands. "I know you want to face Adora, but you cannot let your feeling get in the way of the mission. I sense your chakra is imbalanced, Catra. Perhaps you are not the right choice for this mission."

"Try to keep me from going, and I'll imbalance *your* chakra, *Princess,*" Catra hissed.

"See? She proves my point!" Perfuma complained to the room.

"Okay, okay," Glimmer said, placing herself between her friends. "I trust Catra, and I don't think she will ruin the mission for the sake of herself. Right Catra?"

Catra crossed her arms over her chest and shrugged, giving Glimmer a cool expression.

"I can't promise that if Adora crosses our path, I won't react. But I do promise I won't go off on my own and look for her. Not yet anyway." She said with a twitching tail.

"That's good enough for me; anyone else objects?" Glimmer said to the rest of the room.

No one responded.

"Catra has great technical know-how but considering how much we don't know about this Mass Motive Array, we should have another gadget person. I volunteer myself," Bow said.

"And if things go wrong, you'll need backup," Perfuma added, lifting her Life Gem staff.

"Hey! If you all are going, I'm going too! I'm good in a fight," Seahawk added with arms crossed.

“To give you guys a better chance of getting inside without being stopped, I think you will need a distraction. I volunteer Battle Cat and myself,” Shen said as Battle Cat lowered their head in distress.

“Huh, sacrificing yourself for others. Where have I heard that before?” Catra said sarcastically. “Just don’t get yourself killed, Shen. We can’t afford to lose He-Man,”

Catra noticed her words seemed to irritate her friend and decided to add something to her statement.

“And we can’t afford to lose you too,”

Shen suddenly looked away in embarrassment, but not before Catra caught the same look in his eye as before. A dark, brooding look that made Catra’s tail start to bristle.

“Well, if my sister is going, I am too. We should have a Star Hunter on this mission,” Viraj added.

Captain Neyra shook her head. “No, Viraj, I need you here. Our fleet will station ourselves nearby and wait for the signal that the ground team is ready for pick up. If they run into trouble, I will need you to lead a reinforcement team to get them out,”

Viraj’s ears lowered as he nodded in acquiescence to his superior, and Bow leaned over to pat Catra’s brother on the back.

“It’s okay, buddy. Knowing Seahawk, we will get caught and need your help,” he said with a grin.

“Hey! Your implications that Seahawk’s stealth skills are subpar is unfair!” Seahawk said, affronted.

Everyone, including the Madgēcots, rolled their eyes at him.

“I have a question and I’m surprised no one has asked this yet,” Catra began with a tilt of her head. “Why doesn’t Sparkles just

teleport straight to the thingy-ma-what-sit, grab it and teleport out."

"Really, Catra? Do you think I'm stupid?" Glimmer said while giving Catra a nasty look. "Of course, I thought of that! But there is some form of… *power* blocking me. I can't while it's still active,"

"Power? Could it be the strong gravity being drawn from the three suns?" Bow asked.

Glimmer shrugged. "No idea. I've never come across it before."

Captain Neyra nodded as she stood a little straighter while holding her hands behind her back.

"That settles it," she said. "I want everyone to make the appropriate preparations; we do this tomorrow morning. This stalemate with the Nephraeh needs to end soon. Dismissed."

The room immediately became noisy as everyone got up to chat amongst themselves. Catra noticed Shen in the back, leaving with Battle Cat in tow. She immediately followed them out of the room, quickening her pace to catch up with the bearer of He-Man.

"Hey, wait up, buddy; I want to talk to you," Catra said, gently placing a hand on Shen's shoulder. As he turned towards her, Catra saw a shadow pass from behind the windows of his dark eyes.

"Yeah, what's up?" he said with a grin. "Want to talk about how we are secretly going to find Adora and kidnap her when no one is looking?"

Catra shook her head but smiled broadly at her friend's support.

"I wish, but no. I meant what I said about not jeopardizing the mission. There are too many lives on the line—Adora's included. I wanted to just check up on you, that's all," she said, cocking her head.

"Why do you keep asking me that?" Shen asked, the irritation plain in his voice. "Do I seem like I'm unhinged or something? I mean, if anything, I should be the one asking if *you* are okay."

Catra chuckled at this. "Yeah, well, some issues are obvious to everyone. I've had my brother plus every Madgēcot around me offering their support—that part has been great. But I won't forget that other people around me may be suffering, and I know how you always withdraw into yourself when something is bothering you. I can feel it and see it, Shen; why don't you want to tell me what it is?"

Shen's eyes widened, and for a moment, Catra thought he was going to open up to her. But then the darkness reemerged, and she instantly recognized it for what it was; rage, seething anger that seemed to boil within him to smother the sadness. Catra knew this cycle all too well, she used it often during her time in the Horde after Adora left. She knew it was pointless to press him, it would only make things worse. Catra remembered how she had lashed out at Scorpia whenever her friend had tried to cheer her up.

"Hey, tell me whenever, if you want." She said, suddenly holding her hands up. "Just know I'm here."

The intensity she saw in Shen's eyes vanished, replaced by gratitude.

"Anyway, enough about me," he said, forcing a smile. "This mission tomorrow can't be easy for you, especially if we run into Adora—I mean Despara. Just know we all have your back, Catra, whatever happens."

Catra's face fell at the mention of her wife. She and Adora had just been on their *honeymoon*, now everything was upside down, and Adora was running amok across the star as Despara. Catra forced this pain into the compartment where she had been keeping it lately, in a dark corner of her mind.

"Yeah, you don't have to worry about me, Shen. Remember, way before you and I even met, Adora and I fought against each other on opposite sides of a war. I can handle her," Catra said confidently.

"I don't know, Catra, from the way it sounds, Adora isn't herself; she is a totally different person," Shen said, suddenly becoming distracted. "I had an… experience not too long ago. I was in Castle Grayskull on Eternia, and I came across something… evil."

Catra noticed a sheen of sweat break out on Shen's forehead as she sensed his heartbeat quicken. Whatever he was reliving from this memory, it was intense.

"Anyway, I touched this thing called 'The Eye of Hate,' and it did something to me, made me into a different person. I—"

Shen suddenly broke off as he looked down at his hands; they were curled into claws and held out before his body. He suddenly shook his head and rubbed his hands against his shirt as if they were covered in something he wanted to wipe clean.

"Anyway, I think Adora might be the same way, Catra. You should be careful. You say you two fought for years, but I think you both held back all those times—subconsciously. Because deep down, you still cared for each other. Now Adora no longer has empathy, and it means she doesn't care anymore—about anything. With the power of She-Ra behind her, she can do some real damage. I don't want to see you get hurt." Shen said, the concern plain on his face.

"Stoooop…" Catra said, rolling her eyes. "Come on; you think I'm dumb? I'm not the one being used as bait tomorrow—worry about yourself!"

Catra playfully punched Shen in the shoulder, and he grinned back at her, seeming to be put at ease. But as the two friends continued down the hall, Shen's words continued to echo in Catra's head. She knew exactly what he was talking about, for she

had faced a rage-virus infected She-Ra in the snowy waste of Etheria and barely escaped with her life.

As much as Catra wanted to see Adora once more, the thought of facing Despara filled her with dread as a single thought raced through her head.

Adora wouldn't hurt me, would she?

Confrontation

Chapter Summary

The Etherians attempt to take out the Relativity Forge.

Catra and Despara finally meet.

Shen squinted his eyes against the glare, the snowy plain magnifying the intense light of the planet's three suns to blinding effect. In the distance, he could see it; a cluster of cylinder shapes topped by a faint haze—The Relativity Forge.

"Shen, I would like to mention once more that I don't like this plan," Battle Cat mewled below him.

Shen looked down at the discernible outline of his friend; both were currently invisible, courtesy of the alien's magical nature. Shen patted his friend on the neck in reassurance, thinking about what Battle Cat's people originally named them—Cringer.

"You don't think we can handle playing distraction, buddy?" Shen asked good-naturedly.

Battle Cat shook their ethereal maned head. *"It's not that. I just don't think this plan will work. From what Catra told us about Veth, I don't think this simple trick will fool them."*

Shen shrugged. "Well, it's all we have right now. Anyway, it's too late, we cannot contact the others, and right now, they are making their way to their positions and waiting for us to draw out the bad guys. We have to make this work, and I'm counting on your speed to keep us out of danger."

Battle Cat did not answer as they continued to move towards the Relativity Forge and away from Darla's hiding spot. Both Battle Cat and Melog had used their ability to surround themselves in an invisibility field to cloak Darla during their approach to the planet Enos. Once they landed, Melog had gone with the others while

Battle Cat went with Shen—both teams would have the advantage of the alien's shroud on this mission.

Shen stared off into the distance, becoming lost in thought as he listened to the soft crunching sounds Battle Cat's paws made in the snow. Through their bond, Shen could sense his friend's worry and waited for Battle Cat to speak. He didn't have to wait long.

"You should have told her, Shen," Battle Cat said finally.

"Should have told *who, what*, Battle Cat," he answered, exasperated.

"*Catra. You should have told her what is going on with you. With your anger. I think she would understand and be able to help you if you would only open up,*" they responded.

Shen sighed. "I don't want to put that on her, Battle Cat. She has bigger problems to worry about than my little mood swings. Catra lost her wife, her soulmate, and it's killing her not to have Adora by her side. I'm not going to add to that.

After a moment of silence, Battle Cat spoke again.

"You're still in love with her, aren't you? With Catra, I mean," Battle Cat mewled.

Shen gritted his teeth; sometimes, he really did not like having someone so intimately connected to his emotions and thoughts. Some things he just wanted to keep buried.

"You know the answer to that," Shen answered.

"Catra and you would be a good match; you are both similar in ways that make you relatable while still being different enough that the relationship stays engaging. I don't understand the problem?" Battle Cat said.

Shen found himself laughing at his friend's naiveté.

"What's so funny? Did I make a joke?" The ethereal alien mewled.

"No, I'm sorry for laughing, buddy. It's just that you make it sound so simple when it's actually very complicated. For one thing, Catra is with Adora. They are married, and I have a feeling they are not looking for anyone to join their relationship," Shen said with another laugh. "Another reason is that I may be attracted to Catra —but it is not mutual,"

Battle Cat shook their mane as if a pest were nagging them.

"Why? I am not familiar with physical attraction, but I see how others look at you, Shen. I have gathered enough information to deduce that you are handsome."
Battle Cat said matter-of-factly.

Shen smiled and patted his friend again. "Thanks, pal. But again, it's more complicated than that. You see, Catra is only attracted to women, and I am a man. Therefore, it wouldn't work,"

Battle Cat nodded their head. *"I can see the problem for you then, and I am sorry."*

"Eh, you have nothing to be sorry for; it's not your fault. It's just the way life works out sometimes. You got to be able to move on," Shen said with a hint of sorrow.

"The relationships between different sexes sound very complicated. Perhaps one day I will get the hang of it." Battle Cat said good-naturedly.

"How do those things work with your people, Battle Cat? I know you have no male or female, so does that mean that everyone is compatible with each other?" Shen asked.

"Compatible? What do you mean?"

"You know…" Shen started vaguely. "I'm not sure if I can do it justice if I describe it— can't you just read it from my mind?"

Battle Cat nodded. *"Yes, hold on while I… got it. Hmm… no, we do not do that. Have sex, I mean."*

Shen groaned. "Jeez… that's rough, buddy. Now I feel bad for you and Melog. You don't know what you are missing out on," Shen said while shaking his head.

Battle Cat let out a high-pitched bark which Shen knew was a laugh.

"I was thinking the same about you since you cannot experience the Metaphysical Amalgamation as my people do. This sex I see in your mind pales in comparison," Battle Cat replied a little haughtily.

Shen shrugged. "Hey, we are all entitled to our opinions, buddy. You can keep your Metaphysical Amalgamation—whatever that is,"

Another moment of silence before Battle Cat started in with yet another question.

"*When you say that sometimes you have to move on, is that what you were trying to do with Atreyen?"*

Shen was beginning to get uncomfortable with his friend's questions and shifted in his saddle.

"I guess not consciously, Battle Cat. I wanted to be with Atreyen because I wanted to be with them. Not for any other reason. Although, if we had become closer and allowed what was possible to grow, I think I would be able to move on and be happy," Shen said quietly.

"That's too bad it didn't work. Atreyen is also a great match for you. Their carefree and frivolous nature is a good counterbalance for the more morose aspects of your personality," Battle Cat mewled happily.

"Thanks, Battle Cat," Shen said through gritted teeth. "How about we be quiet now and focus on the mission, huh?"

Battle Cat nodded their head and picked up their pace; they were now very close to the Relativity Forge and could see a massive entryway. It looked like an open mechanical bay used to bring equipment to and from the facility—Shen could see Enosian workers within, busy handling various crates and canisters. Battle Cat stopped outside the opening, and Shen dismounted, mentally preparing himself for what needed to happen next. He walked until he was in the middle of the mechanical bay, stopping there to watch all the workers who were oblivious to his presence.

"Okay, Battle Cat, now!" Shen called to his friend.

Hearing his disembodied voice, the Enosians lifted their heads in confusion, looking around the space for the speaker. The uncertainty turned to shock as Shen suddenly materialized amidst them, smiling and waving to them.

"Hey, guys!" He said merrily. The Enosians all looked at each other, confused about what to make of this. No one moved.

"Does someone mind sounding the alarm?" Shen said, trying to sound helpful.

"They will kill you!" One of them said, a young man in his late teens.

Shen gave the youth a cocky smile, one he had seen Catra give many times.

"You let me worry about that," he said as he raised a hand into the air.

"BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

Electric power surrounded Shen's form, filling the mechanical bay with bright white light. The Enosians cried out in fear as they shielded their eyes; many turned and ran to the nearest exit. The alarm rang out soon after.

He-Man/Shen laid his massive sword against one shoulder as he waited in the now-empty mechanical bay. Battle Cat materialized next to him in their enhanced armored form as the alarm suddenly cut out, and the sound of footsteps was heard coming from a nearby corridor.

"Are they only sending one person?" Battle Cat hissed next to him.

"Hmm… sounds like it. I was hoping to make a little more of an impact than that," He-Man/Shen whispered.

The clipped sounds of booted feet slowly increased as He-Man/Shen's heart began to beat faster. The thought that this may be Adora coming to fight him filled him with sudden dread—he was not sure he would strike his friend, even if she tried to kill him.

He-Man/Shen's fears were allayed as a tall figure strode out from the hallway and into the space. They were encased in black armor which clung to their lithe body and moved with supple deadliness. A massive black sword glowed with an unknown dark light in one gauntleted hand—this same illumination shone from eyes that peered at He-Man/Shen through an open face guard of a black helmet.

"Ah, you must be Veth," He-Man/Shen said in greeting as Battle Cat let loose a ferocious snarl beside him.

Zhe-La/Veth nodded in greeting before glaring at Battle Cat.

"I thought He-Man was the mighty Prince of Power—so why does he need an Ethyriel bodyguard?" Zhe-La/Veth asked neutrally.

He-Man/Shen was suddenly wrong-footed. "Prince of Power? Ethyriel? What the heck are you talking about?"

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head in disgust. "The people of this universe are *so ignorant*, so quickly they forget *everything*,"

"He-Man was once called the Prince of Power, Shen," Battle Cat whispered up to him. *"And the Ethyriel is me,"*

"Really? Why didn't you ever tell me that is what you and Melog are called?" He said down to his friend. "Huh, wow! You learn something new every day!"

"Yes, I'm sure that every day is a brand new experience, especially for someone as intellectually stunted as He-Man," Zhe-La /Veth said as they sneered at him. "Although I do have to admit your outfit is an upgrade from a single strip of animal fur,"

He-Man/Shen looked down at himself and nodded, "Yeah, I took a lot of inspiration from Adora's She-Ra—although with black and silver colors. I'm glad you like it!"

"Yes, although the black now matches the outfit the new and improved She-Ra wears," Zhe-La /Veth said wickedly. "I'm sure you will meet Despara soon,"

At the mention of his friend, He-Man/Shen felt a sudden spike of anger, but he suppressed it. He did not like that Veth used Adora's corruption as a taunt.

"So, are we going to fight or chat, Veth? I'm getting bored." He-Man/Shen said as he swung his sword in lazy arcs around his body.

Zhe-La/Veth suddenly smiled, exposing their upper and lower fangs.

"Well, I could say something about how only boring people get bored, but that would be too easy."

With a growl, He-Man/Shen started to move toward his opponent but stopped when Battle Cat leaped in front of him.

"Remember what Catra said! Don't let them get too close! That's how they defeated Adora!" Battle Cat cried.

He-Man/Shen nodded as he raised his sword to summon the Power of Grayskull—sizzling static appeared at the tip just before a lancing bolt lanced towards Zhe-La/Veth. They brought their sword up just in time to deflect the deadly energy up towards the ceiling—it clung there for a moment, sizzling and popping before a section of the overhead exploded into a shower of molten sparks. Zhe-La/Veth stared at He-Man/Shen with wide indigo eyes, their mouth agape.

"Impressive," they said finally, brushing ash from their shoulder plates. "I think you will make a great ally, like Despara, once you've been shown The Light,"

Zhe-La/Veth held their sword up; it erupted into a torch of purple flames with a blazing indigo core. This inferno spread from blade to bearer as it enveloped Zhe-La/Veth in its fell power, and they rushed He-Man/Shen, seeking to engage him in close combat.

He-Man/Shen brought his sword down, pointing the tip at the charging Nephraeh Champion as multiple jagged lines of spearing fire sprayed over them. Zhe-La/Veth dismissed their sword to cross their arms over their face, summoning a transparent purple dome to shelter them as they hunkered down on their knees. Feeling this use of power-draining his reserves, He-Man/Shen stopped the torrent of lighting, hoping that his nemesis didn't realize it taxed him.

I need to get to Battle Cat and leave, He-Man/Shen thought. *I don't want what happened to Adora to happen to me.*

As He-Man/Shen crept sideways towards his steed, Zhe-La/Veth rose smoothly to their feet, dismissing their shield to re-summon the sword. They looked at He-Man/Shen wryly, as if they knew exactly what he planned, and it was of no concern.

"Do you think this silly plan will work, He-Man?" they asked slyly.

"Uh, what plan?" He said, knowing they could see through him.

Zhe-La/Veth laughed. “I’m not talking about your attempt to get to the Ethyreal and escape me—which won’t work, by the way. I am talking about this whole plan to distract us while your friends try and dismantle the Relativity Forge. They are walking into a trap.”

“I told you it was a bad plan!” Battle Cat hissed to him.

Fear jolted through He-Man/Shen, and he halted his retreat. He turned fully towards Zhe-La/Veth and brought his sword up, gripping the hilt tightly as the anxiety was replaced by rage.

“Shen? What are you doing? Get on my back, and let’s get out of here!” Battle Cat whined.

“Yeah, Shen. You should listen to the Ethyreal and run away. Leave your friends behind to suffer the consequences of your cowardice!” Zhe-La/Veth called.

“How do they understand me?” Battle Cat cried.

He-Man/Shen ignored this question; it was utterly irrelevant when faced with the boiling fury building inside him. He felt it then, an unknown tugging sensation at his hindbrain—as if he were a fish on a hook and had come to the end of the line’s slack. With a clawed gauntlet, Zhe-La/Veth beckoned to He-Man/Shen, urging him to them.

“Don’t do it!” Battle Cat pleaded, but it was too late; He-Man/Shen was already charging the Nephraeh.

The two swords collided with a dull peal; like reality itself was crying out at the wrongness of two Champions fighting. He-Man/Shen sliced and hacked at the Nephraeh, his hand now guided by feral emotions instead of logic. But all his blows were blocked effortlessly by Zhe-La/Veth, who seemed completely unfazed by his attack on them. To He-Man/Shen, they seemed to mock him; his attempts to strike them, his fear for the lives of his friends, his silly temper, and his absolutely pointless existence.

He-Man/Shen's hate suddenly turned inwards, at himself; it was like the ignition of a chain reaction with the result of a supernova. The tugging at his mind became a yank, but instead of pulling He-Man/Shen, it acted as an anchor for something to draw itself to him across lightyears from the other side of the galaxy. He-Man/Shen felt himself sliding sideways towards a crescendo of red insanity, and he braced himself against it with all his willpower.

I can't… I can't… not again… he thought as he held back the tide. *My friends… will… get… hurt…*

Zhe-La/Veth saw an opportunity to strike a critical blow but backed away from their opponent, unsure whether it was a wise choice. Shaking their head as they made a decision, Zhe-La/Veth summoned the magic given to them by Archon Lethe, surrounding themselves and He-Man/Shen in a null void of apathy. No longer impaired by the restriction of compassion, He-Man/Shen cried out with joy as the Eye of Hate claimed his soul.

"YESSS…" He said with relish as a crimson light appeared from behind his eyes. The once noble He-Man form that Shen had manifested began to warp as the muscles bulged with obscene power. Spittle dripped from between clenched teeth as he leered at Battle Cat, who backed away from him in an attempt to flee.

"Oh no, you don't!" He-Man/Shen said with glee as he raised his sword in this friend's direction.

Arcs of scarlet lightning blazed out, bathing the Ethyreal in the same power that took their friend. They too, began to change—becoming deadlier, crueler, and lit from within by light the color of rich blood. Once their transition was complete, Battle Cat roared; it was the sound of an apex predator who would soon hunt and feast upon their prey.

Peering through a red haze, a faint scrap of who He-Man/Shen once was could see the form of Zhe-La/Veth backing away, just before everything went black.

* * *

The Enosian scientists murmured amongst themselves as they walked through the spacious hall of the Relativity Forge, completely unaware six sets of unseen eyes watched them. If they had bothered to stop and look closely at the corner where the passage turned, they might have seen a faintly shimmering outline of a humanoid form with a tail. But the scientists did not do this; they were too concerned with the constant presence of the Empyreans to look for any possible intruders.

"You know Catra; this invisibility works better when you stay still. Is there any way you could keep your tail from twitching?" Bow asked.

"No, Punchy, I cannot keep my tail from twitching. It has a mind of its own," Catra responded tartly.

"If you want, I could hold your tail still for you, Catra," Seahwak said as he reached for the twitching tail. A low growl immediately made him hesitate.

"Seahawk, if you place one finger on my tail, I will—" Catra started before being interrupted by Perfuma clearing her throat.

"Catra, remember what I said about resorting to anger? All you have to say is 'Seahawk; please respect my personal space. That includes my tail,'" Perfuma said calmly.

Since they were both under the same charm, Catra could see the faint outline of Seahawk when she turned to him.

"Seahawk," she began sweetly. "Please respect my personal space. If you don't, I will invade *your* personal space and slice your face off!"

Seahawk gulped audibly as he backed away from Catra as the unmistakable outline of sharp claws appeared. Catra chuckled to herself as she went back to scanning the way ahead with her penetrating eyes and listening for threats with her long ears. She

could have sworn that she heard a large explosion in the distance, but it could have been anything with the amount of machinery around them.

“How close are we to the main reactor, Punchy?” She whispered.

The sound of shuffling could be heard as Bow removed the datapad from his back pocket.

“Let’s see. We are currently in the passage which services the repair facility and fabrication bay. This way will lead us to the main hall, which runs directly to the center of the building, where we need to go.” He said helpfully.

“It would be nice if we could get there without any more threats to harm each other,” Glimmer said sourly.

“Me too,” Seahawk added in a sulk.

Catra ignored them as a sudden uneasiness overcame her, making her fur itch. She felt a nudge at her side and knew it was her friend Melog trying to get her attention.

“There is something wrong, Catra,” they mewled at her. “*I can feel it,”*

Melog’s words made Catra’s anxiety immediately increase. She had hated the fact that Shen was going to act as a distraction for their mission, and it caused her to worry endlessly all the night before. Now here they were at the exact moment he would be playing his part, and all she felt was dread.

“Is there any way you can contact Battle Cat?” She asked Melog.

They were silent a moment before they replied.

“I cannot reach them, Catra. They are gone,” Melog answered cryptically.

Catra almost jumped when she felt a hand on her shoulder. Turning, she found herself gazing into Glimmer's sparkly eyes.

"Catra, what wrong?" Her friend asked.

"How do you know something is wrong?" Catra asked, perplexed. "Do you feel it too?"

Glimmer shook her head and pointed behind Catra to her tail; it was currently three times its normal size and beating Bow across the face. Catra seized her tail to still it, running her hand down its length to smooth the agitated fur.

"Both Melog and I sense something wrong, Glimmer. It's Shen; I just know it!" Catra hissed.

"Okay! Okay! I believe you!" Glimmer responded with soothing hands. "But we have to trust that Shen can handle himself; too many lives are at stake. Once we neutralize the threat this place poses, we can go and find him,"

"Okay," Catra said, nodding. "Let's just get this over—"

She was interrupted by a series of loud bangs in the distance; they echoed sharply up and down the metal halls, making everyone wince. Not long after that, the alarms sounded; piercing wails assaulted everyone's ears, accompanied by the strobing of red lights.

"Hurry!" Glimmer shouted as she ran ahead. "I don't think we have much time!"

Everyone followed Glimmer as the yelling and fighting steadily increased in volume. Whatever was happening, it wasn't too far away.

An ear-piercing howl of absolute rage pierced the air, making Catra's ears lay flat, and fur stand on end.

“That was Shen! He needs help!” She cried, diverting from the group and running down an adjacent hallway with Melog close behind.

“Catra! Wait!” Gimmer screamed behind her.

Catra ignored her friend as she raced away on all fours. As she veered around a corner, she suddenly leaped to one side just as a giant sword slammed down where she had just been. Catra did a split to duck the follow-up slice and rolled out of the way as a booted foot attempted to stomp her into paste. Melog lunged at her attacker but was slapped with an open hand, sending them careening into a wall with a yelp of pain. Catra crab-walked away from her attacker, staring at them with wide eyes and an open mouth.

“I knew there was a pest problem here!” Despara said with a leer. She strutted over to Catra, who was now getting to her feet, and stood in a crouch.

“You’re a strange-looking Madgēcot,” Despara exclaimed as she held her chin with a black gauntlet. “Where is your silly Jaadoo suit or whatever it’s called? A Madgēcot without her magic won’t stand a chance against me,”

Catra stared at Despara dumbfounded, at a complete loss to process the image before her.



“A—Adora?” She asked meekly. “It’s me; it’s Catra,”

Despara frowned at Catra; it was an ugly look of utmost disgust and disregard.

“So, you are the one my Archon warned me about,” Despara growled as she held her black sword in two hands, ready to end the enemy before her.

“Your Archon?” Catra said with horror. “Adora, I’m your *wife,*”

Despara shook her head as she advanced on Catra, her gauntlets clicking as she tightened the grip on the deadly sword.

“I have no wife,” Despara said as she raised her weapon above her head. “All I have is The Light!”

Catra could not reconcile what was happening; the person before her sounded like Adora, her face looked like Adora’s, and she even smelled like Adora—but this was not Adora. Tears poured from heterochromatic eyes as Catra froze in place, unable or unwilling to run as her soulmate came to kill her. Catra closed her eyes, waiting for the end; she did not want to exist in a universe where Despara lived in her wife’s body. It was better this way.

But before the black blade could slice Catra in two, a searing bolt of Starfire collided with Despara’s face, knocking the woman back and off-balance. Despara screamed as she dropped her sword to clutch at her wound. When she removed her hand, Catra felt a jolt of anguish to see one-half of the face she treasured was scorched black. She started towards Despara, one hand held out to console her but a firm grip on Catra’s shoulder stopped her from this bad decision. Turning, she found herself looking into Glimmer’s stern face.

“Catra! What are you doing? Do you want to get yourself killed?!” Her friend screamed in her face.

Catra shook herself from her stupor, turning to see the blackened skin of Despara’s face slowly disappear to reveal unblemished pink

flesh. But the Fallen Champion's healing powers did nothing for Adora's once radiant beauty; her face was twisted as it seethed with rage. Despara's indigo eyes blazed as she sought the one bold enough to strike and hurt her.

"You will die for that," Despara said to Glimmer. "I will make sure it's painful, too,"

Catra saw that Despara's words affected Glimmer deeply as tears appeared in sparkly pink and purple eyes. The Queen of Etheria did not respond as she raised her Star Stone staff to ward against her once friend. The rest of the party had since arrived to stand by Catra and Glimmer's side, each individually affected by the Dark She-Ra.

"Glimmer, that's Adora! What do we do?" Bow cried as he notched an arrow to his bow.

Despara walked slowly towards them, her intentions evident in the set of her grim expression.

"Why do you fools continue to call me by another's name?" Despara asked. "Do you really think this silly trick will work?"

"It's not a trick, Adora!" Catra pleaded as she attempted to go to her wife once more.

Despara lashed out at Catra but stopped mid-strike, frozen in place as a lambent yellow glow suffused her body. Despara's eyes bulged as she fought against this unseen force; to her, it was as if the very cells of her body were refusing to move.

"Somebody grab Catra! I'm not sure how long I can hold her!" Perfuma said as she held up her staff, the Life Gem burning bright at its top.

Despara made a gurgling sound as she fought against her very body, forcing her arms to move the sword towards Catra's heart. Seahawk rushed up behind Catra, seizing her in a bear-hug to

drag her back, away from danger. Catra did not fight him, going limp in his arms as if the will had been sapped from her.

Perfuma cried out as Despara finally overcame her power—the yellow light fracturing into glass-like shards which fell away from her black armor in a tinkling shower. Despara immediately continued her advance on the group, not at all daunted by the threat they posed. She flinched as three arrows struck in rapid succession; they each exploded on contact and covered her lower body in a green sticky substance. After a moment of hesitation, Despara continued forward, the adhesive not affecting her movement.

"Pathetic," she said to Bow as he lowered his weapon and visibly gulped.

Seahawk had since released Catra, and she sagged against a nearby wall, watching with lowered ears as Despara came for them. She could not help noticing sounds nearby, the same sound of violence as before, only closer. Catra's ears perked up as she subconsciously sought to hear what was going on.

Despara was halfway to them now, her sunken eyes blazing with the power of her new master. They appeared as two indigo flames above her nose, burning with such an intensity that it spread to her body, engulfing her in the power of Oblivion which reached out to her victims.

Catra felt it then, like cold but worse. It was a chill beyond the icy regions of Etheria's Northern Waste, and it sent her reeling into a realm of callous indifference. Catra was a creature of intense emotions, and the sudden removal of the strongest one unbalanced the rest, leaving her in a stupor. As she faded, she could see her friends similarly affected; each sank to the ground in a daze as the murderous Despara came for them.

Catra was jarred from her downward spiral as the wall behind Despara exploded, sending pieces of shredded metal whizzing past her. A riotous cacophony of violence entered the passageway,

making it crowded as black-armored figures struggled against a tornado of wrath.

She recognized the forms of the Kyrpteia and Zhe-La/Veth in the chaos, but the figures at the center of the battle were unknown to her. One was a creature—a gigantic, red, vicious thing made of fangs and claws. The other was a man, a massive and hulking figure whose upper torso was bare and blazed with crimson light.

His face was a rictus mask of madness and hate; it was a face that Catra would never want to know. She felt of jolt of horror as she looked at the man's chest and saw what blazed there; it was a heart rune; one of only two in existence given to the bearer by her wife, Adora. It had been given to Shen through a bond of friendship to help release him from his demon—but it appeared he found a new devil to replace the old one.

Catra would have wept, but all her tears had gone to Despara, who now turned to face this new enemy with a howl of rage.

"What do we do?" She asked Glimmer. Her friend shook her head in bewilderment as the nightmare unfolded; two Champions of Grayskull were fighting to the death, with a third soon to join them. It seemed as if the massive structure of the Relativity Forge was woefully unequipped to house such a titanic struggle, and it shook as if above a tremendous earthquake.

The Kyrpteia had surrounded what could only be Battle Cat, attempting to subdue them with summoned lengths of black material while dodging razor talons. He-Man/Shen was hacking wildly at Zhe-La/Veth as they tried to defend themselves with their black sword. Multiple injuries on every part of their body openly bled, and their face was haggard as if they had been fighting for centuries. Zhe-La/Veth appeared completely drained as they stumbled backward in an attempt to gain space from the endless onslaught before them. They turned as they heard Despara approach, sudden fear on their face at the sight of their ally.

“Despara! Do not use the power of Oblivion! It only feeds his power!” They shrieked.

She ignored their warning, still blazing indigo bright with the magic of enervation as she tackled He-Man/Shen. He instantly lost his sword, and it vanished as both Champions fell to the ground to brawl like berserk animals. Just as Zhe-La/Veth warned, the power she had used to subdue the Etherians backfired, and He-Man/Shen roared as added strength coursed through his body. He broke Despara’s lock on him and seized her, wrapping his arms around her in a crushing embrace against his massive chest. A flash of white light seared out from between the two combatants as their matching heart runes met, and Despara was flung away from He-Man/Shen to crash through an opposite wall.

Sadness passed through Catra as she realized that neither one knew what had just happened to them, that the heart runes had sensed their fight and separated them. Catra had seen it happen once before on Etheria, during better times when Shen and Adora sparred. Adora had been the one to lock Shen in a hold then, the two were blasted apart when Shen had maneuvered around in Adora’s grip, and their heart runes met.

He-Man/Shen had since risen to his feet; the extra might supplied to him by Despara’s magic sent him into even greater heights of mania. He instantly summoned his sword; somehow, it looked larger and deadlier than before and charged back at Zhe-La/Veth, once again seeking to destroy them.

Zhe-La/Veth held their sword up weakly as He-Man/Shen hammered down upon it in a rapid-fire frenzy. Their blade broke as He-Man/Shen’s cleaved through it and into the armor of Zhe-La/Veth’s shoulder, making them scream in pain.

Catra saw one of the Krypteia fighting Battle Cat turn their head at the sound.

“Veth!!!” They cried.

Catra instantly recognized the voice of Nefeli as they rushed to Zhe-La/Veth, placing themselves between the Nephraeh Champion and the brutal killer coming for them. He-Man/Shen did not hesitate as he impaled the leader of the Krypteia on his sword on his way to kill Zhe-La/Veth.

"NOOO!!!" Zhe-La/Veth screamed, instantly on their feet and holding out their hands.

What happened next was beyond reasonable comprehension for Catra as an illumination appeared, emanating from the center of Zhe-La/Veth's chest. It was beyond mere light and virtuous in its beauty; it bathed the entire hall, seemingly overwhelming everything around its epicenter. But its intensity did not hurt, for Catra stared straight into its core as if wishing she could be swallowed up by it and live within an eternity of paradise. When the radiance finally ceased, Catra found that she and everyone else nearby were now standing in front of Zhe-La/Veth, as if they all sought the same bliss in a trance-like state. She looked up to find Despara looking down at her, utter confusion on her face.

"C—Catra?" She asked, unsure of herself.

Catra suddenly felt joy as she reached for her wife—but Despara suddenly returned and pushed Catra's hand away, the moment vanishing as if it never existed.

"Don't you dare touch me, filthy creature!" She hissed.

Catra looked away from Despara as she fought against tears and swallowed the bile of despair rising in her chest.

But sudden hope appeared as she spotted Shen, no longer in his corrupted He-Man form and lying unconscious on the ground. Catra ran to him, seeking to protect her friend in his vulnerable state with so many enemies nearby. Battle Cat was in the same condition as their friend; they were nearby on the ground as Melog licked their green muzzle. Catra kneeled by Shen, shaking him gently by the shoulder.

“Wake up, dummy!” She implored, looking up to see if Zhe-La/Veth was coming for him, looking to finish their enemy off. But this was not the case.

Zhe-La/Veth was also kneeling, and in their arms was the dying Nefeli. The Krypteia leader’s helmet was off, and indigo glowing blood dripped down from their lips. They gazed up as the Nephraeh Champion gently stroked fingers down Nefeli’s face in grief. There was such tenderness there, and Catra could not believe one such as Zhe-La/Veth could feel such emotion. She was also surprised to see tears in the Nephraeh Champion’s eyes, real tears for the absolute anguish on their lilac face could not be feigned.

Catra felt great anger towards Zhe-La/Veth for what they had done to her and Adora, but now, she only felt pity. Catra knew how they felt, for she had felt it many times. She looked at Despara, hoping to see similar sadness in her wife’s eyes, but it wasn’t there. There was only confusion about what was happening before her. A thought suddenly occurred to Catra.

“Adora! You can save Nefeli; use your She-Ra power!” She cried.

Despara did not respond, only looking at the display of emotion between her allies with a disgusted curl of her lips. But Zhe-La/Veth had heard her.

“Yes! Despara, please!” They cried. “Your power of healing is greater than any other Champion of Grayskull! Heal Nefeli, please!”

Despara looked at Zhe-La/Veth and shook her head in irritation but walked forward while holding out her hands. She laid her massive black gauntleted hand on the rent in Nefeli’s chest and closed her eyes, summoning the power of She-Ra. Catra held her breath as she waited, surprised at how much she wanted Nefeli to live. But why wouldn’t she? They had not been cruel to her, and they only kidnapped Adora with a misguided notion that Archon

Lethe's Light was the answer to everything. If there was anyone who would understand misguided, it was Catra.

After a moment of nothing happening, Despara growled in annoyance and withdrew her hands.

"I don't know how to do this, Veth," she said simply.

"Your lying! I just saw you heal yourself!" Catra cried, balling her fists in anger.

Catra felt a hand grasp her shoulder, and she turned to see Glimmer shaking her head sadly.

"She is right, Catra. Adora knew how to heal, but Despara does not. She can heal herself because it's in her own self-interest, but you need empathy to heal others."

Catra looked around in desperation, looking for the one other person with the power of life in her hands. She finally spotted Perfuma in Seahawk's arms, eyes closed and utterly despondent with a large bloody gash on her forehead.

"Some flying debris must have struck Perfuma when the wall exploded." Glimmer explained. "She is alive but out cold."

Catra closed her eyes as she felt tears appear; when she opened them back up, Zhe-La/Veth was staring at her. There was genuine sorrow in their indigo eyes, sorrow for what they had done to her and for what was currently happening to them. Zhe-La/Veth looked down as Nefeli's hand touched their cheek.

"W-wish we h-had more time. Eh, my c-champion?" Nefeli wheezed.

Zhe-La/Veth laid a clawed gauntlet over Nefeli's hand and nodded, tears falling down their face and onto the other's cheeks like soft kisses.

“Yes, perhaps in the next life?” Zhe-La/Veth said softly. But Nefeli did not respond; their silver eyes were already gazing up lifelessly in death as Zhe-La/Veth let out an anguished gasp, clutching them to their chest. Faint indigo luminance appeared over the body, which then turned to black, and Catra watched in amazement as the whole of Nefeli dispersed in a misty haze. Zhe-La/Veth was left holding an empty Aegis Lace bodysuit; the bands of material were now slacked and unbound, looking like black ribbons as they fell into Zhe-La/Veth’s lap. There was absolute quiet as the Krypteia looked at the intruders with clawed hands held out, waiting for the command to attack. Despara summoned her black sword and held it up, eyeing Catra with a dangerous look in her pitiless eyes.

“Let’s finish this,” Despara said with relish.

Catra crouched with claws out, ready to fight to the death to defend her friends. Glimmer growled as she held her staff up, and Seahawk gently put Perfuma down as Bow notched an arrow, a hard look on both of their faces.

“NO!” Zhe-La/Veth shouted, rising to their feet. “Let them leave,”

“WHAT!?!?” Despara cried. “You can’t! I’m not letting this happen!”

Zhe-La/Veth turned towards their ally with a hardness on their attractive lilac face.

“You will find out that it is I who is in charge here, Despara, and I say let them go.” They said, waving at the remaining Krypteia. The black-armored Nephraeh instantly formed around the Nephraeh Champion, claws now held at the ready in Despara’s direction.

“I will not forget this Veth,” she growled. “Archon Lethe will hear about this!”

Catra turned to Glimmer. “Can you teleport us to Darla? I can carry Shen, but I don’t know about Battle Cat!”

Glimmer nodded. “Everyone get around Shen and Battle Cat, quick!”

Seahawk quickly picked up the downed Perfuma as the Etherians hurried over to their unconscious friends; they were eager to get out of the Relativity Forge before the Empyreans changed their minds. As they gathered into a group, Catra looked once more at Zhe-La/Veth, who was again looking at her. There was anger on their face as they pointed at Shen in Catra’s arms.

“Tell He-Man if I ever see him again, I will kill him,” Zhe-La/Veth said simply.

Catra didn’t have a chance to reply, her vision blurred as Glimmer summoned the power of the Star Stone and the Relativity Forge disappeared in a haze of sparkles.

Comfort

Chapter Summary

> To Glimmer, Kishar's journal is starting to sound like a horror story.
>
> With some help from others, Catra and Shen try and deal with what happened to them on Enos.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

01.2505.99

The purpose of this journal is no longer to document my childish flights of fancy. Now that I no longer feel empathy, I have grown out of such things and matured. It's incredible how straightforward everything is to me now that I have been separated from my sympathy; there are so many aspects of my life I can cut away and leave behind forever. I feel like an Omnilisk which has shed its old skin; new, fresh and clean, and ready to face the universe. I am now taking my first steps towards a bold new purpose, which I have not fully discovered. I will document the process here in my old diary.

Every day it seems like I discover something new about myself. It's like walking down a path you walked countless times and approaching the same dead end. In the past, I would have to turn around and or find a new way, but now it seems there is a door that I can now open to pass through the barrier, allowing me to continue my journey.

But I have to be careful who is watching; it seems there is a universal rule never to use this door—for those who do are ostracized. There are many eyes on me, so I have to be extra careful when and where I use this door.

Especially when Jihan is around, it's not that I care what he thinks; it's just that I don't want him to find out my secret and expose me. I am surprised by how he has gone from feeling like my dearest loved one to someone who feels dangerous to me.

Almost like… an enemy?

01.2531.99

Something odd started happening to me lately; it seems my freedom comes with a cost. I started feeling an unpleasantness, an undefinable desire for something that, at first, I could not grasp. It was a demand that went beyond hunger, lust, or the need for sleep. As time went by without this urge being satiated, the more dreadful my life became. Thankfully when it had become the most intolerable, my body took over and showed me the way.

I was on the planet Kang-dar on a solo mission to investigate some old ruins when I made this discovery. The overwhelming need had become too much, and it had become hard to hide what was happening to me, so I found an excuse to go off on my own without Jihan. I don't think Jihan has begun to suspect my new nature, but he has noticed subtle changes in me, making him worry. He nags me incessantly about whether something is bothering me or my health, not knowing that what had happened to me runs much deeper.

I tried to think of excuses to be away from him, but each one was as flimsy as the last and easily dismissed by Jihan, who would find a way to not let me out of his sight. It had become unbearable for me, for I felt like I could not escape—I started to have darker plans to rectify my predicament but decided wisely not to follow through with them.

My chance came during the Madgēcot celebration of Roshanee. Jihan always attended this celebration as Sher-Va, and it was seen as his ancestral duty to be there when peaceful times allowed. The day before the ceremony, I told him I received a communiqué from the League of Kalosyni stating that a Champion was needed

on the planet of Kang-dar, which so happened to be in a system nearby Elysia. Jihan was saddened by this news but did not ask any unnecessary questions, for he believed me and did not have a reason to mistrust me.

I was overjoyed to be away from him, feeling as if a heavy weight had finally been lifted from my body and allowing me to be free. I realized then that I had to be absolutely free of him; I just didn't know how to accomplish this yet.

Kang-dar is a bit of a backward place; they abhor technology and rely on the small amount of magic the planet has. There are no large cities to be found, only small communities governed by the resident Mystic. I gravitated towards the closest village; at this point, the hunger had become so intense that I was barely thinking straight. I was being driven by instinct like an animal.

The community welcomed me, of course, for it is seen as a universal blessing to be visited by a Nephraeh. I did not give my true identity to the people; there was no need for them to learn that I was the bearer of Zhe-La. For some reason, I did not want them to know that.

I wandered around for a while, watching the locals go about their mundane and boring lives. I was unsure what I was looking for; I just had a vague feeling that what I needed was close. It was not long before I found it.

Time and time again, my attention was drawn to a single individual, someone who spent their day amongst the citizens of the village healing ills and resolving conflicts. It was the village Mystic, the person with the strongest connection to the planet's magic and in charge of the community. He was a young male, early into his powers and full of positive ideals.

I could not keep my eyes off him, I felt obsessed, and my hunger drove me to follow the Mystic, which I spent a torturous day doing. Finally, as the local sun set, he retired to his home.

Waiting until the Mystic was asleep may have been more prudent, but at this point, I was utterly helpless to the need. I entered the Mystic's home basically on his heels, and he turned with absolute surprise to find that there was a Nephraeh in his home. He was initially very pleased with the circumstances—and why not? The Nephraeh are the Light and wherever they go, only love, and goodwill follow. He was a very humble individual; he asked whether or not I had come to teach him new healing techniques, for he was always open to learning new spells. I did not answer him; I was too overwhelmed with confusion and desire, which I am sure unnerved him.

Sudden realization appeared on his handsome face as he appeared to see something in me. He told me he could see my wounds, my brokenness and that he could help me if I wished. The Mystic opened his arms wide, asking me to come to him if I wanted to be healed. My confusion intensified as I pondered whether or not this was the reason I was drawn to him, and I walked hesitantly towards the Mystic. As I passed his open arms, another part of me took over; the hunger. I embraced the Mystic in my arms, and as I felt his wrap me in unconditional love, I found out what I was there for.

By some unknown knowledge, I bit his neck.

It was a bizarre thing for me to do, and some hidden part of who I was screamed at me to stop. But I couldn't, I was too hungry, and I had finally found my sustenance. I couldn't stop myself if I tried. The Mystic attempted to fight me, but I was too strong and held him fast as I consumed him.

I felt something pure and good pour into my mouth and then my soul; it was beyond the most delicious meal or pleasurable carnal experience. I drank deep of the Mystic's essence, and when he was emptied, went limp in my arms. I let him fall to the ground, and out of curiosity, felt his neck for a pulse—he was still alive. I was astonished to see the place on his neck where I felt teeth sink in was free of any wound. I was even more amazed when I looked in a nearby mirror to see that I now had upper and lower

fangs. They were black as night and looked out of place next to my normal flat white teeth. As I went to feel at my new lower fang with a finger, they suddenly disappeared as if they never existed.

I felt so good at that moment; it was as if I was whole once more, but I could perceive whatever I had taken from the Mystic slowly dissipate. I would have to do this again.

Against my better judgment, I stayed in the Village a while; I wanted to see what my actions had wrought on this community. The Mystic appeared seemingly unaffected the next day, but this was not the case. The person who was the Mystic the day before was no longer there; there was a new person in his place. The Mystic still performed as healer and resolver of conflicts but now demanded compensation for these services. When the village people refused to provide this, he simply packed his belongings and left.

It was then that I realized what I had taken from him to assuage my desire; it was his empathy, of course. I had somehow wholly removed his compassion to fuel my new state of being. I accepted this fact rather quickly; I was not concerned with how or why it worked, only that when I fed, I no longer felt the dreadful emptiness.

The only thing I was concerned about was when I would feed again.

Glimmer put down Kishar's journal, trying to absorb what she had just read; what Kishar had turned into sounded like something out of the books she would read as a child. One of the scary ones was that she was not allowed to read, but she would anyway late at night and under the covers of her bed.

"Hey, Bow, remember that book you let me borrow when we were twelve? I think it was called *The Glenmar Ghoul?*" Glimmer asked.

Bow, who was seated next to her on the bed in one of Darla's cabins, looked up from his datapad with a quizzical expression.

"Yeah, what about it?" he asked.

"What was the name of the monster in it? They one with the fangs that drank people's blood," Glimmer said with two fingers pointing down from her lips.

Bow cocked his head as she pondered this question, then lit up as he realized the answer.

"Do you mean a vampire?"

Glimmer nodded slowly as she absorbed the word.

"Babe, why are you asking me about some children's story?" Bow said with a hint of concern.

Glimmer recounted the events from the journal, how Kishar was now in many ways a vampire—but instead of drinking blood, they now consumed the empathy of others.

"It sounds like Kishar's tale is turning into a horror story," Bow said, shaking his head.

"Yeah, it is, and I don't think I have gotten to the worst part yet." Glimmer said sadly.

"It fits with what you told me about what happened to Scorpia, Mermista, and Entrapta. Whatever happened between now and then, Kishar's disease or whatever it is has spread," Bow said.

"Yeah…" Glimmer said with a shiver. "But it doesn't add up yet. Some things don't fit, especially with Kishar's people, the Nephraeh. If the entire race needed to consume people's empathy continually, they would not be isolated on their planet. They would have gone out into the galaxy, and there would be stories of whole planetary populations drained of empathy."

"From what Catra said, her people stopped the Nephraeh from spreading past Elysia and quarantined them to their end of the galactic arm. Was it because the Madgēcots knew the Nephraeh would feed on other people?" Bow responded.

Glimmer shook her head. "That's was because of the Nephraeh's beliefs—this Light nonsense which sounds a lot like what Horde Prime talked about when I was held prisoner."

"I remember you telling me about that. Horde Prime's Light sounded like the opposite of what Light should be. It sounded cold, logical, and without any…"

"…compassion?" Glimmer finished for him.

"Yeah," Bow said as he nodded. "Do you think there is some connection between the Nephraeh and Horde Prime? Catra said that Veth used this reason as a way to manipulate the Madgēcots. Could there be some truth in it?"

"Horde Prime didn't take the Nephraeh's empathy, I'm sure of it. But there may be some connection." Glimmer said with a sigh as she placed the datapad on the bed and stood up. "Right now, I think I should check on Catra. She said she is all right, but we know better."

* * *

The dazzling lights of hyperspace were quite beautiful, appearing as a kaleidoscope of billions of different colors that continuously exploded into an endless geometric sunset. But the person viewing this display felt no joy at this site—the pain in her heart was too great.

Catra hugged herself as she sat on the corner of Darla's forward viewport, trying to stop her body from shivering. But no matter how hard she tried, she just could not warm herself. Catra turned toward Darla's control seat, the place where Adora would sit.

"Seahawk, can you *please* turn the heat up in here. I'm freezing!" She said through chattering teeth.

"My dear Catra, I have already turned up the temperature in here to the point where it's causing me to sweat. I think it's high enough!" Seahawk complained. "Perhaps you should retire to your room and under the blankets of your bed?"

The thought of being alone in her room made Catra shake her head vigorously and turn back to the window. She tried to wrap her arms and tail around herself tightly as the memory returned to her mind, the same one tormenting her ever since they left Enos to return to Elysia. An image of a beloved face twisted in disgust and hatred of her.

So, you are the one my Archon warned me about…

I have no wife…

Don't you dare touch me, filthy creature!

Catra fought against the tears as the memory once again threatened to overwhelm her. She knew she was being cruel to herself but refused to stop the torment, feeling that in the end, she deserved it.

You know you were attracted to Veth. You wanted them, and you let that blind you to their manipulations. You were attracted to another person—and right after you married Adora! How could you? You deserve this! Catra thought as she dug her claws into her bare arms. *Adora was right about your stupid empathy; she was right about everything!*

Catra felt the cold return to her body, the all-encompassing chill, and she once again tried to rub her arms in an attempt to stifle it. She felt something wet and sticky on her hands as she did so, and when she looked at her palms, saw blood there. She had dug very deep with her claws.

You deserve it. You deserve the pain; maybe it will make you stop being so emotional and weak-hearted.

The chill intensified at this thought, and her teeth chattered so hard she knew Seahawk could hear it.

"Would you like me to get you a blanket, my dear?" He called from the pilot's seat.

"NO!" She snapped at him—instantly regretting it. She may find Seahawk annoying at times, but she liked him for his adventurous and free spirit. He didn't deserve to get yelled at, and Catra knew it; but instead of apologizing, she stared back at the view of hyperspace, hoping the colors would mask the image of two hateful eyes.

The closest Adora had ever come to displaying such emotion to Catra had been after the incident with the portal, when Adora had stopped Catra from destroying Etheria in her self-destructiveness. Right before she had escaped with Hordak, Catra had locked eyes with her ex-best friend. There was anger in Adora's eyes, mixed with disappointment and resolve. But there was no hatred.

Catra had wept alone in her room after that incident, feeling like there was absolutely no going back for her. Soon after that, she had cut off both of her brown hair tufts in what she now knew was a lame attempt to show the world she was compassionless and would not be manipulated again. In the end, burying her true self deeper had increased the distance between Catra and other people, making things worse for her. Being who she was then had driven her most loyal friend Scorpia away, causing her to ultimately break down.

Even though Veth manipulated me using my empathy, I can't go down that path again. Adora and Scorpia worked too hard to make me see it a different way. But I feel so lost…

Adora and Scorpia, the two people who were instrumental in Catra's re-birth, were gone—they were the ones who needed her

help now. But how was she going to achieve this? The smartest people in magic and science Catra knew had no luck fixing this problem. For all she knew, they were stuck with Despara and a broken Scorpia forever. On top of it all, there was something off with Catra's newest friend, Shen. She knew he was not telling her what was wrong out of some bone-headed concern of burdening her with his feelings.

But isn't that what you sometimes do? Shen is so much like me. Well, except for the mean part…

Catra had protested when the Madgēcots had taken the unconscious Shen aboard the *Pakadna*; she did not want him to wake up surrounded by strangers. But she relented when Viraj said their people were better equipped to handle a rage corrupted He-Man than the Etherians were. Catra agreed to let Shen be taken as long as Viraj was there when he woke up. Her brother's face was similar enough to hers to provide some comfort in familiarity. For now, that was all Catra could do for her friend.

As had been the case since leaving Enos, Catra's thoughts steered away from Shen and anything other than her main torment—Despara. In Catra's mind, Adora's dark counterpart was so intense that she created her own gravity, dominating Catra's consciousness and keeping her in Despara's dark clutches. Time and time again, she heard the force of the boot trying to stomp her or the whispering caress of the black sword as it attempted to end her life in one slice. Despara was so horrible and violent. So hard and cruel. Catra realized with a start that she was terrified of Despara as she continued to shiver.

Catra felt someone place a blanket over her shoulders and instantly tried to shake it off. Arms gently wrapped themselves over hers as a soft body pressed against her back, and Catra felt herself giving in to the embrace.

"Easy, Catra." Glimmer whispered. "How long have you been sitting here?"

Catra tried to fight off the irritation she felt at the question and failed.

"I don't know… since we left," Catra snapped back.

"Well, no wonder you are shivering. Space is cold, and you're practically sitting right next to it, dummy!" Glimmer said with a chuckle.

"I don't need you're lecturing right now, Sparkles!" Catra said as she tried to buck her friend off her. It was a half-hearted attempt, and Glimmer only held onto her tighter.

"What you need is to go back to your room and rest. Come on," Glimmer said as she pulled Catra off her perch.

The idea of being alone instantly made Catra tear up. She shut her eyes and gritted her teeth against the thought, not allowing herself to be moved by Glimmer.

"You know, Catra, I can just teleport you to your bed. I will if I have to," Glimmer said.

"Please don't, Glimmer," Catra said, the pain in her voice plain to hear.

"Catra! What's wrong?" Glimmer asked as she wrapped her arms tighter around her friend.

"I just… *can't* be alone right now. *Please* don't make me…" Catra pleaded.

"Hush, I wasn't planning on leaving you alone. I will stay with you if you promise to come with me," Glimmer said as she attempted to coax Catra away from the window.

Catra allowed herself to be displaced, and the two women made their way towards the exit in the back. Seahawk perked up as he saw that Catra was finally leaving.

“Does this mean I can turn the heat back down?” He asked hopefully.

“Yes, Seahawk,” Glimmer replied with exasperation.

Glimmer led Catra by the shoulder down Darla’s central corridor and to the room they had placed her after the rescue from Horde Prime’s ship. Catra could not help feeling as if she had come full circle to the broken state she had been in then. But it was worse; at least then, she had Adora.

Catra immediately burrowed deep under the bed's covers and curled into a fetal position, fighting the chill that had suffused her body. She could feel Glimmer lifting the covers, getting into place behind her, once again pressing her body against Catra to wrap her arms around her midsection. Glimmer felt so good to Catra; being snuggled in bed with one of her best friends felt so right. The cold that had haunted Catra since leaving Enos had vanished, replaced by a warmth that went beyond the physical. Catra started to purr deep and loud, making Glimmer giggle.

“The vibration from your purring is tickling my chest,” Glimmer said.

Catra could not help the laugh. “Yeah, Adora says the same. There is no way to turn it off, unfortunately.”

“I didn’t say I wanted you to; I like it. It’s comforting,” Glimmer said, giving Catra a gentle squeeze.

Catra couldn’t help grinning as she imagined what the ‘old Catra’ would say if she could see what was happening now.

“You want to hear a secret, Catra?” Glimmer asked quietly, her breath tickling one of Catra’s long ears.

“Are we going to start sharing secrets like best girlfriends now, Sparkles?” Catra asked sarcastically.

“Yep! Sure are!” Glimmer said, giving Catra a playful poke in the side. “Do you want to hear it or not? It’s a good one, and I’m not sure I want to tell it to you now,”

“Sure,” Catra responded as she rubbed at the spot Glimmer prodded. “Just don’t start tickling me or anything. I can’t stand that.”

“Remember that time we fought in your secret hideout? When it was just you and me? I kind of had a crush on you after that,” Glimmer said shyly.

Catra couldn’t help the wide grin spreading across her lips.

“No way, Sparkles!”

“Yes, way,” Glimmer said with a laugh. “That outfit you were wearing was *so hot*! How did you escape, anyway? I went back for you, but you weren’t there. I was pretty bummed you got away,”

“Oh, that? Double Trouble came by and rescued me. I ended up having to pay them a bonus for it, too,” Catra responded with a sigh.

“That is my fellow bearer of a staff of power for you,” Glimmer said drolly.

“I think they will be a good addition, Sparkles. I’m serious. Double Trouble may seem like they don’t care, but it’s all a front. I have never admitted this to anyone else, but I think the main reason they betrayed me wasn’t for money or to be on the winning side, but to make me see the error of my ways. They did it to save me,” Catra said quietly as if afraid others might hear.

Glimmer did not respond, and the two women were quiet for a moment as they enjoyed each other’s company. Finally, Glimmer spoke.

“We are going to save her, Catra. We are going to get her back. I promise.” Glimmer said in an earnest whisper. Catra closed her eyes as she felt the tears come back, but she didn’t fight them this time. It felt so good to be held by another person; it was too much, the pain rose in her throat, and she let a soft gasp of grief. Catra let the pain flow out of her.

“Oh, Catra… just let it out. It’s okay, I’ve got you,” Glimmer said kindly.

Catra could not imagine how she made it through all those years alone in the Horde without someone to hold her this way. Sure, Scorpia would have, but Catra was too angry and full of angst ever to let that happen. In the end, Catra needed comfort, she needed compassion, and she could not imagine a world without empathy. She would rather not exist in that place.

As the tears finally ran out and Catra was silent, there were still her friend's arms, surrounding the fragile form of her body, like walls against the pain. Catra found herself drifting away, the fatigue of the past couple of days finally catching up with her. Right before she finally succumbed to sleep, Catra made a decision.

No matter what happened with Adora, even if the worst happened, Catra would never let her empathy go. It was who she was, and Catra would rather die without it.

* * *

The infirmary of the *Pakadna* was a wide, spacious room, designed that way to give medical personnel the proper space to help multiple patients in times of great need. It was also a warmly decorated room; the wood comprising the walls was a warm honey color and engraved with soft designs. A mural was also carved into the ceiling of the room depicting the Great Chaliendra tree in all its glory. This depiction of the sacred tree was imbued with magic that radiated the same beautiful glow as the actual tree before the Nephraeh wounded it. But the singular resident of

the infirmary found no comfort in this image; not only had he never seen the sacred tree of the Madgēcots, but he was too far into the depths of misery to be comforted by mere pictures.

Shen felt as if he wanted to be anywhere other than his own skin as waves of terrible anxiety racked his psyche. These feelings were not new for the current bearer of He-Man; from time to time, he was plagued by amorphous dread, even refereeing to it as times he *slipped*. But the times before had nothing on the current state of torment; Shen had never felt anguish such as this before. He was not sure he would make it.

"Just deal with it, you weakling," Shen muttered to himself, unknowingly repeating the words his cruel father would say to him time and time again.

"Did you say something? Are you okay?" One of the two Madgēcots standing guard at the door asked.

Shen shook his head quickly. "No, sorry. Everything is fine,"

The two Madgēcots glanced at each other briefly, and Shen caught the concern in their eyes.

They must think I'm some kind of monster. Why else did they post a guard here? He thought to himself. *I don't blame them. Whatever happened to me down there, I think I hurt someone. Badly.*

Shen shut his eyes and gritted his teeth against the sudden wave of self-hatred and despair. No one would tell him what happened down on Enos. All they said was that something had taken him over and used the power of He-Man for evil. That he should stay inside the infirmary until they could get back to Elysia. Once there, someone called a Jaadoogar would examine him and help him. Until then, he was utterly alone with his darkness; his friend Battle Cat was separated from him and on an entirely different ship. There was fear that they too were corrupted—but Shen knew better. Hopefully, he would see Battle Cat again on Elysia.

The last thing Shen remembered was the fight with Zhe-La, how they had taunted and goaded him into anger. But such things never bothered Shen in the past; insults and jibes were a way of life growing up. He had long ago learned to let them slide off him and appear unaffected. Why had he allowed this Veth to anger him so?

Shen knew the answer; it was plain before his eyes. Even Battle Cat knew what had happened; they had told him so. It had been the Eye of Hate; it had taken hold and possessed him. It was somehow tethered to him across the span of light-years, anchored to his anger and influencing him towards that dark desire. Shen knew he was the perfect victim for this Abominable Power; he was the rich soil for its red roots to take hold and grow.

Once again, Shen was helpless against an intruder in his body, an evil that was inside him. He was a ticking time bomb that would hurt those he cared about. Except when before it was 'the Other' possessing him to become the Demon Heart, now he only had himself to blame.

Dark thoughts crossed Shen's mind, and he watched the two Madgēcot guards, wondering if they would ever leave him alone. He knew from experience that his state of suffering would pass, making these desires seem foolish in the light of day. But at this moment, all he knew was the distress.

The door to the infirmary suddenly opened, and another Madgēcot entered. Shen suddenly recognized this Madgēcot; his heterochromatic eyes and distinctive fur coloring were so similar to Catra's that it was hard not to. He turned to the guards on either side of the door, saying a few words before dismissing them.

"Hey, Shen!" Viraj said as he strode over to the bed. "I really wanted to be here when you woke up. I'm sorry!"

Shen was not expecting Catra's brother to be so friendly and was slightly taken aback.

“Uh, no worries, Viraj,” Shen said with a lame shrug. “You didn’t have to bother with me,”

Viraj’s cinnamon-colored face frowned at this statement as he pulled a chair up to the bed and sat down. Shen knew that look; he had seen it all too many times before.

“How do you feel?” Viraj asked with a slight tilt of his head.

Shen now recognized the genuine concern in Viraj’s voice and bit back the pity he felt for himself, a grimace appearing on his lips as he bit back the tears. He gave another shrug—as if that was the ultimate defense against the flood of pain he was currently holding back.

“I’m fine, I guess,”

“I guess that was a stupid question, huh?” Viraj said with a chuckle. “I wouldn’t feel great if I woke up on some strange ship surrounded by people I didn’t know. You should know Catra gave me a hard time giving you up; it took a lot of convincing for her to see this was the best place for you to be. At least for right now, that is,”

Shen suddenly felt suspicious of Viraj’s intentions, as if he was being nice to dig answers out, like an interrogation technique. There was no way he was just being friendly to him.

“I’m not totally sure what happened down there, Viraj, if that is what you want to know. I do know that it is wise of you to keep me locked up. Perhaps you should have more guards, though. I wouldn’t hold it against you if you did.” Shen said, putting some bite into his words.

Viraj’s heterochromatic eyes widened as his long stone-gray tail twitched rapidly from the back of his chair.

“I see why my sister likes you. You are very altruistic, even to your detriment. Maybe a little too hard on yourself as well,” Viraj said as a knowing smile appeared on his lips.

Shen could not help noticing how similar Viraj was to his sister—from the dark freckles below each eye to how his ears perked and drooped to emphasize certain emotions. Shen could not help noticing the fascinating outfit Catra's brother was wearing—a Jaadoo suit he heard it referred to. The maroon material clung to Viraj's slender body, and looking closely, Shen could see the individual sections of material that made up the outfit.

With a start, Shen realized his eyes had been openly roving over his guest, who, at the moment, was still studying him. Shen looked into Viraj's slitted eyes—the right yellow, the left blue—the heterochromia the opposite of Catra's. Finally, Viraj spoke.

"I know you were lying to me," Viraj said simply.

Here it comes, Shen thought with annoyance. He hated when he was right about these things.

"You said before that you are fine, but you are anything but, Shen. I can feel the anxiety pouring off you in waves—it's making my fur itch!" Viraj said, baring his upper fangs in a funny expression.

"So, what? You think by confronting me with my lie, you will drag the truth out of me?" Shen said, putting some annoyance in his voice.

Viraj shook his head vehemently. "No! That's not what I meant! I wanted you to know that I can sense that you are in pain and that you don't have to hide it, that's all."

Shen suddenly wanted Viraj to go away as he felt his façade begin to slip; the need to weep overwhelmed him. Just as he did with Catra, he clenched his fists and teeth, looking away from Viraj as he tried and failed to hold it back. With a sigh, he gave up, sinking back into the soft mattress, and stared up at the beautiful ceiling as tears ran slowly down his face.

"I've always dealt with stuff like this—like this pain. It's just never been this bad before. The dread and—" Shen circled his chest

with his hand; fingers bent in a clawing motion. "…anxiety. I call it *slipping* when it happens,"

Shen glanced at Viraj's, the fear of admitting his weakness to another coming back to him. Growing up on Shen'Dar-oom had taught him to keep his mouth shut concerning his affliction. But he only saw compassion in Viraj's eyes, not disgust.

"*Slipping…*" Viraj said with a frown. "Do you always minimize your pain with euphemisms? What I feel from you is intense and no small thing."

"Sorry, I'm sure it's unpleasant to be around. It's not something I could turn off; I wish I could. All I can do is suffer through it until it passes." Shen said.

Viraj was quiet for a moment as he pondered this. Suddenly, his ears perked up, and a broad smile appeared on his handsome face.

"When I was little, I had a friend with a problem like yours. I was able to help him. Do you want to try it?" Viraj asked enthusiastically.

"Sure, why not?" Shen said doubtfully.

Viraj immediately stood over Shen, making his apprehension increase momentarily.

"Rollover and lay flat on your stomach. Make sure you are comfortable," Viraj said as he waved black-clawed hands over Shen's torso.

Shen was suddenly very uncertain. "Are you going to use magic on me or something?"

Viraj laughed. "*No!* Just do it! Stop asking questions!"

Shen did as he was asked, rolling over on the mattress and turning his head away from the Madgēcot.

“Now, just relax,” Viraj said.

Suddenly, Shen felt the bed shake as Viraj hopped onto it. He was about to turn and look when a weight pressed down on his back, pushing him back down.

“Wha—?” Shen exclaimed as he realized Viraj was settling on his back.

“I said *relax*,” Viraj said as he rested his chin on Shen’s shoulder. “You are as tense as stalked Hiran. If this is going to work, you need to just let go,”

Confusion whirled around Shen’s head as the surrealness of someone he just met snuggling him passed. It was replaced by the realization that it felt good to have Viraj on top of him; the weight of his body was not oppressive but comforting, acting as a damper to the flames of his anxiety. Shen found himself doing as he was asked; he allowed the tension to leave his muscles and felt Viraj nod in approval.

“Very good. Having you like that is not comfortable for me either,” Viraj said as he tucked his arms under Shen’s.

A gentle vibration was felt against Shen’s back, coming from the center of Viraj’s chest. Soon after, the sound of a contented purr was heard. It permeated down into his body, suffusing him with the calm white noise of peace.

“Is the purring too much?” Viraj asked softly.

Shen didn’t even try to put up a front; they were well past that now.

“No, it’s wonderful,” he murmured.

“Good! Because it’s not something I can turn off!” Viraj said with glee.

Shen chuckled at Viraj repeating the words he used before and resumed his focus on the sensations he felt. Having another person on top of him was not just simply a weight; there was the softness of his body, the way Viraj's chest rose and fell from breathing, the way his tail rested on Shen's legs—twitching gently. And, of course, there was the purring.

Shen realized how exhausted he was from being awake ever since the mission to Enos and before that. He felt as if he had been running a great distance for a long time, felt stretched thin and worn out. Viraj was exactly what Shen needed at this very moment in time; someone to brush past all his barriers and comfort him in the most basic way possible.

Viraj shifted slightly, getting more comfortable as the purring changed its tune—becoming softer, lazier. He was allowing his natural method of reassurance to carry him to sleep, and Shen was caught in its pull—but he gladly allowed himself to drift gently away. Shen's eyelids became heavier, and his breathing slowed, matching its rhythm to Viraj's to become completely in sync. It was not long before both were fast asleep, and for a while, Shen knew peace in another's kind embrace.



Chapter End Notes

Shen and Viraj illustrated by Henar Torinos, ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram

New Beginnings

Chapter Summary

Viraj and Shen become close.

To prepare herself for her next confrontation with Despara, Catra learns the ways of the Madgēcot.

01.2540.99

I have developed a method to meet the demands of my new state of being since leaving Kand-dar. Now, instead of waiting for the hunger to return and weaken me, I go out to hunt and feed. During the day, I observe others around me, looking for the most compassionate, then choose and mark those I desire.

The night is when I visit them; the darkness hides my movements well and enables me to approach prey when they are most vulnerable. One issue vexes me, though; I wish my hair and skin were not white, for this is hard to hide in the dark. If only Nephraeh were darker colors, it would make my nightly forays much easier. For now, I cover myself in a concealing robe.

Sustenance is bountiful.

01.2592.99

For the past month, Jihan and I have been stationed on the planet Ceter 8, living in the city Ecilia. Yesterday, Jihan commented that he was worried about the changes he had seen in the people around us. He said they seemed more 'callous' and 'cruel' since we arrived. Since then, I have started to travel father to feed, but this has become hard to account for, especially when Jihan asks me where I am going or where I have been.

I've come across the first hurdle in my new lifestyle. I now need to feed regularly, so being in one place for too long is a problem. Jihan will not be the only one to notice the pattern of apathy springing up wherever we are, although he will probably be the first to figure out it is me doing this. I need a better solution; I need to speak to someone who will understand me.

I need to speak with Zzar.

01.2619.99

My third trip to Castle Grayskull turned out to be the most fortuitous one yet. I have learned much from that Devious Witch Zzar.

The guardian of Castle Grayskull was very happy to see me, stating that she had been expecting my return. I had nothing to say to this, not caring that my presence pleased her; I only wanted answers. But I was polite and reserved; after all, I was on her territory seeking knowledge; it would be unwise to be uncouth and displease her.

After the pleasantries we dispensed, I told Zzar of my new desires and the problems I have been having meeting the demands of my flesh. She was most intrigued by what I had to say to her; it seemed that she had no specific designs for leading me towards using the Shlihm-bess'a-rune . I knew then that I was nothing but an interesting experiment for her, something to do to pass the time.

I would make her pay for that.

Zzar made me wait outside her sanctum as she delved into the secrets of Castle Grayskull, looking for the answers I needed. She was very jealous of the wealth of knowledge she hoarded; I knew then I must find a way to gain access to what she guarded. But that would be later when the opportunity revealed itself.

I waited a day and a night for Zzar. Finally, she came to me with the enlightenment I sought.

Zzar said I could use the prime ability of Zhe-La—The Light—to harvest empathy from others. She said I could do this by using a dark spell she had been studying for the past century. This dark magic would enable me to reverse The Light to create a kind of Null-Light. It was pure genius; I had to admit. She said that with time, I could learn to drain others around me without fully emptying them. I could feed on those around me—multiple sources of sustenance at once— and they would return to normal over time when I left.

Then I had my grandest idea to date; who in the universe had the most significant quantity of empathy to feed on? It is my people, the Nephraeh.

The Nephraeh are half-magical, as everyone knows, but what people don't know is the powerful connection between Zhe-La and the Nephraeh. Every champion has some form of relationship with their planet and its people, but Zhe-La's bond with the Nephraeh is special. Once I have gained mastery over this spell, I could use this connection like a siphon upon the collective souls of the Nephraeh. I would then have limitless sustenance for as long as I needed it.

Zzar gave me an abbreviation of this spell, for she was loathed to provide me with it in its entirety. This was very curious to me and piqued my interest, but Zzar became very agitated after I asked about the true nature of this spell. I realized my question had terrified her, but she appeared eager to share some aspect of what I asked; it was as if Zzar was desperate to seek someone to help her bear the terrible knowledge she held. Zzar was intractable in the end—the stubborn woman. It was then I turned to a persuasion of the more physical kind.

I would not say I seduced Zzar, more like I allowed her to think she seduced me. Zzar may seem cruel and cold to those who know her, but she was still a living being. She still had some form of desire that needed to be fulfilled and the need to feel the comfort of another living being. I must admit that even though I

care not for others, I still care for myself. I too, still desire this, although I do not care how I get it. Or who I hurt in doing so.

After our mutual lust was satisfied, Zzar finally relented and shared a tiny morsel of information with me. She said that she referred to the spell as The Apogean Ritual and that it was her ultimate desire. Zzar noted that just as I had ascended to another level, she too sought advancement in the most profound way. She said this spell could achieve this for her, but many aspects of it were occluded. Zzar would not go into further details on the matter, but I believe I had the answer I sought.

Zzar was right about one thing; I had ascended to another level. But I would not stop there. I wanted more, and it was just a matter of time before I got it.

Glimmer let out a long sigh as she placed the datapad down to pick up the mug of Madgēcot Chaay she had been sipping. She loved the drink's combination of sweet and spicey and was pleased to find that it was just as warm as when she received it. Looking closely at the glowing symbols engraved in the porcelain, Glimmer realized that the cause of the heat's longevity was, of course, magic.

Looking out from the guest house balcony and out over the treetops of the Great Jacarandra forest, Glimmer took a deep breath of the Elysian air, enjoying the floral and earthy scents. She had been here only a few days, but Glimmer was starting to fall in love with this world. There was magic here—lots of magic—and she was very eager to learn the Madgēcot mystical arts from the Madgēcot Jaadoogar once she had the chance.

But the pleasant taste of the beverage and beautiful view did not detract from the unease she felt. The Apogean Ritual mentioned in the journal could only be the sacrificial spell Zzar had used to attain godhood. Obviously, Zzar had since learned everything she needed to know about the spell and had gotten over her fear of using it.

But was Kishar's role in all this? It appeared that they had succeeded in feeding on their own people; the descriptions of the Nephraeh sounded like a people whose compassion had been periodically *eaten* from them over centuries. From Catra's account of her interactions with Veth and the other Nephraeh, it seemed their empathy would return over time if they stopped doing whatever this Penumbra Ritual was.

But who was feeding on it? She didn't think it was still Kishar, for Veth was the current bearer of Zhe-La. Was Veth the one who was now using the ritual to consume the empathy from the Nephraeh? Or was it this Archon Lethe person? It couldn't be them, for they needed the power of Zhe-La to achieve this.

It seemed like the more Glimmer read of Kishar's journal, the more questions were raised. But she could not stop now; not only did she feel like she was close to the answer to helping her friends, but also to ending the conflict between the Madgēcots and the Nephraeh.

The door to the balcony opened, and Glimmer turned to see Bow with Perfuma in tow. Both had looks of concern plastered on their faces.

"Can't I just enjoy a moment of peace without some new issue rearing its head?" Glimmer complained.

"Sorry, babe, but you will want to hear this," Bow said, pulling out his datapad.

He pressed a button, and the display lit up; on it was what appeared to be a recording from none other than Entrapta.

"Hello! Is this on? Greetings from Etheria! As you know, it is impossible for us to communicate with you directly since you are so far away, so forgive this recording. I'm having Emily help me with this, but her analog to digital processor is on the fritz. The image quality may be subpar, so please forgive that as well."

Glimmer groaned. “Get to the point, Entrapta,” she said through clenched teeth.

“Anyway, I’m sure you’re saying ‘get to the point, Entrapta,’ so here it goes! We had a coordinated assault on Etheria and Eternia yesterday—well, not so much assault as a sneak attack. Or robbery? Do you think that is the right word, Emily?”

The sound of Entrapta’s robot friend beeping could be heard as Glimmer rolled her eyes at Bow and Perfuma.

“Hordak and I were in our lab in Dryl, working on our research into emotions, when the Crypto Castle’s defense system activated. After an extensive search of the entire castle, we found no sign of any intruder nor of any disturbance. But after returning to our lab and running a quick inventory, Hordak and I discovered that something was missing,”

The dread from before returned to Glimmer as she realized she instantly knew what Entrapta would say.

“The Void Gem has been taken from its suspension field and removed from the Crypto Castle, possibly even from Etheria. We can no longer pick up its unique magical energy signature anywhere on our planet or Eternia. We think an unknown group had snuck in and taken the Void Gem. They must have kept themselves hidden from us by using some technological or magical concealment.”

“As this was happening, another incident was taking place on Eternia. As you know, your Aunt Castaspella, Father, and a group of scholars have been conducting research into the many artifacts kept under Castle Grayskull in what they call The Dungeon. The interlopers had also used a concealment spell when they infiltrated the Castle but were discovered by your aunt and father, who had placed warding glyphs all over the Castle grounds. Mmmm… very interesting. I should get a sample of those…”

"Anyway! There was a fight that resulted in a few of the Mysticor scholars injured and the attackers escaping. Micha and Castaspella believe nothing was taken but are unsure due to the quantity of… items kept in The Dungeon of Castle Grayskull. Micha has requested one of the two bearers of The Staves of Power return to Castle Grayskull to act as its guardian. He said the intruders used strange offensive magic and that he and your aunt were hard-pressed to drive them back."

Glimmer shared a glance with Perfuma; there was shame and sorrow on the other princess's face.

"Besides all that, I just wanted to tell you that since my research has been halted, I have decided I should be out in the field! I am coming out to you, Queen Glimmer. By the time this message reaches you, I should be close to Elysia! I can't wait, it's going to be so much fun! See you soon!"

"Gee, I can't wait either." Glimmer said sarcastically as Bow switched off the datapad and placed it in his back pocket. "How does she even know where we are? For all she knows, we are still on Thenlor."

"Knowing Entrapta, she placed a tracker on the Millennial Seagull," Bow said with a shrug. "I did get word from the *Angella* that they are a day away from translating into the Elysian system,"

Glimmer closed her eyes as she held the bridge of her nose.

"Of course, it's the ship named after my mother that's coming to check up on me,"

"So, I guess we need to decide who goes on the ship back home," Perfuma asked Glimmer. "We can't leave Castle Grayskull undefended; there is too much evil locked away there that cannot see the light of day,"

Glimmer reached out and took her friend by the hand, a small smile on her face.

“I guess I will go back. You need to stay here and continue searching for Scorpia,” Glimmer said sorrowfully.

Perfuma shook her head adamantly. “No, it should be me, I insist. We both know this has become much bigger than two missing princesses. You’re the best one out of all of us to fix this, Glimmer; I believe in you,”

“Are you sure, Perfuma? I mean, I can continue my research from Eternia,” Glimmer persuaded.

Perfuma nodded. “Just promise me, Glimmer, you will get her back?”

Glimmer went to her friend, grasping her by hand to gaze into her eyes.

“I promise, Perfuma. No matter what, I will get Scorpia back.”

* * *

A euphonious mixture of animal noises welcomed Shen to another beautiful morning on Elysia. Like his friend Glimmer, he too looked out upon the rolling green treetops of the Great Jacarandra forest. But unlike the Queen of Etheria, he was not currently residing in the Guest House.

Just as he was breathing in the morning air, two cinnamon-colored arms wrapped around him, and a warm body pressed up against his back.

“Good morning, He-Man,” a voice purred in his ear.

Shen immediately grinned as he laid his hands on the arms, tracing the brown stripes in the fur.

“It is, isn’t it, Viraj?” he answered with a chuckle.

Since awakening on the Pakadna, Viraj had continued to help Shen with his anxiety in his open-hearted way. He even invited

Shen and Battle Cat to stay at his home on Elysia, overwhelming Shen with how generous he was. Shen didn't think twice about accepting the offer; he felt an irresistible pull towards the friendly Madgēcot that could not be ignored.

Since it was her home as well, Catra and Melog were also there, and the five of them would spend the evenings telling stories and laughing. Once, Viraj brought out a strange stringed instrument and played what almost sounded like a lullaby. As he had played this song, Shen noticed Catra rub her eyes as she started to tear up. When he asked if she was okay, Catra smiled sadly, saying she thought she recognized the song.

Not an evening passed where Viraj did not snuggle up to Shen, and not once did Catra comment on this. Shen was slightly surprised that she seemed just to take this occurrence in stride—as if it was normal. He realized it must be natural for Madgēcots to be like this, to hold each other in comfort or just to relax. Shen wondered what his life would be like if he had been raised on Elysia and not Shen'Dar-oom. Perhaps he would not feel as broken as he was.

As the days passed, Shen started to feel better as the burning anxiety melted back into the dark recesses of his soul. Viraj also noticed this, commenting that being around Shen no longer made his fur itch.

Shen smiled to himself as he remembered the previous night when his and Viraj's friendship took on a whole dynamic. Catra and Melog had decided to visit the Etherians at the Guest House, and for some reason, Battle Cat chose to join them. At the time, Shen didn't know why his friend left him alone with Viraj. Only later, in retrospect, did he see the Ethyriel's sly wisdom.

Viraj was laying on Shen's back, as was their routine, but this time, as Shen was starting to drift away, he was pulled from sleep's embrace by Viraj's squirming. Shen noticed that his new friend kept lifting his midsection to tug at his Jaadoo suit, finally sitting up with a chuckle.

"Shen, I think we should find another way to relieve your anxiety. Maybe a massage? I promise not to scratch you with my claws," he said sheepishly.

Shen turned in place to look up at Viraj kneeling over him and was very quick to see the issue. Before Viraj could move away, Shen gently placed his hands on the Madgecot's hips, stopping him in place.

"Well, that's a good idea, Viraj, but it looks like you already know another way to relax," Shen said slyly.

A broad, toothy smile appeared on Viraj's face as he sat down on Shen's lap, settling there.

"Yes, I do. I've been wanting to try it recently," Viraj said quietly.

Reaching up to the neckline of his Jaadoo suit, Viraj ran a black claw-tipped finger down to his belly button as he whispered a command. Suddenly, the individual sections that comprised his outfit lost cohesion and fell from his body like leaves. Viraj then reached out with fingers spread, brushing the pieces of the Jaadoo suit together until they magically collected into a ball. Viraj picked this up and tossed it over his shoulder as he looked down at Shen with a coy smile.

"You know, this was not my intention when I first sought to comfort you," Viraj said as his long stone-gray tail wrapped around Shen's leg. "But now that we are here..."

Viraj's ears suddenly lowered, and with a playful growl, raked his claws over Shen's shirt, slashing it to ribbons. Shen gasped as he looked down at his bare torso, looking for signs of blood—but there was not even a scratch. He looked back up wide-eyed at the naked Madgēcot sitting on his lap, baring a single gleaming fang down at him.

"So! Do you want to take your pants off? Or do I have to use my claws on them too?"

That was the extent of the roughness Shen experienced from Viraj, for he was much gentler the rest of the evening and into the night. To say Shen felt even better now would be an understatement; Viraj had helped him banish not only his anxiety for the time being but also some of his loneliness.

But the nagging doubt was still in the back of his mind, like an insidious black thorn. Even in this wonderful place, surrounded by his friends and the fantastic Madgēcots, Shen still felt it—a steady beat, like a drum, acting like a goad to keep the flames of anger alive. Shen knew it was not just him anymore; it was an outside force acting upon him through its foothold on his soul.

He was corrupted.

Fear at this realization made him want to keep this a secret from his friends; Shen did not want to be ostracized and cast away. But he did in the end, knowing that if his corruption had caused any one of them to be hurt, he would never forgive himself. Shen already had too much of that burden to bear from his time as the Outcast, under the control of the Demon Heart.

Upon arriving on Elysia, Shen insisted he stay in confinement, fully revealing his fears of being controlled by the Eye of Hate. The Madgēcots took his suggestion seriously, but instead of imprisoning him, brought him before their Jaadoogar.

Shen had to admit he had been intimidated by these strange, mystical Madgēcots; their glowing white eyes, outlandish outfits, and taciturn manner were a stark contrast to the rest of their people. They had quietly inspected him, sweeping long claws over his body, and were very interested in the heart rune on his chest. But in the end, they did not deem him dangerous, only that he should work on maintaining the balance of his chakra. Even after a lengthy explanation from Viraj, Shen had no clue what a ‘chakra’ was and was doubtful it was the key to his salvation. He doubted anything was.

The best thing to keep my friends safe is for me to—

“Hey, what’s going on in that head of yours?” Viraj said as he gave Shen a firm squeeze.

Shen shook his head, too deep in his thoughts to develop a coherent response. Viraj took him by the arms and turned Shen around to get a better look at him. Shen gazed into Viraj’s heterochromatic eyes; both pupils were thin vertical slits in the bright morning sun. They seemed to bore into him, making Shen want to look away, but Viraj stopped him with a gentle hand on his chin.

“It’s nothing, Viraj, don’t worry about it,” Shen said, slightly peevish.

Viraj shook his head. “Your very moody, you know that?”

Shen sighed, feeling ashamed of himself. Seeking to change the subject, he looked down, taking in Viraj’s fully nude body.

“Aren’t you worried someone will see you out here like this?” Shen said as he reached for one of the long brown tufts behind Viraj’s ears.

“Nudity is not a big concern for Madgēcots,” Viraj said as he gently swatted Shen's hand away. “And you won’t change the subject!”

Shen swallowed as he realized he could not escape Viraj’s concern. He was a lot like Catra in that way.

“I don’t know, Viraj, I just feel like your Jaadoogar missed something, like I’m a ticking time bomb, just waiting to go off. I still feel this… presence. It has a hold of me. I don’t know…”

“Easy, easy,” Viraj said, caressing his claws down Shen’s face. “The Jaadoogar did not miss that Shen; they saw it. They *immediately* saw the influence of the Abominable Power,”

“Then why am I not locked away? Shen said, shocked. “Or why don’t you all just—”

“Hush… no,” Viraj whispered. “Again, you are too hard on yourself. The Jaadoogar sensed the taint, but they trust the person who is tainted; they trust you, Shen. They see you are a good person, a strong person who can handle this darkness.”

Shen felt intense gratitude for the kindness and pulled the other close, pressing his cheek against Viraj’s. The soft fur felt so good against Shen’s face, and he took comfort in the now-familiar scents of Viraj’s body. He felt Viraj turn his face, brushing his lips against Shen’s gently—his hot breath an invitation to taste him. Shen felt fangs as they kissed, their dangerous sharp points tickling the soft skin of his lips, eliciting a thrill. He slid his hands down Viraj’s back, brushing past the tail and cupping the supple behind. Viraj pressed his mouth against Shen’s neck, growling softly.

“Feeling better, eh?” He chuckled. “Maybe we should go back inside. Madgēcots don’t care about nudity, but what we are about to do is something to be done in private.”

Viraj took Shen by the hand, leading him back into the home and into the bedroom. Shen suddenly thought of something when he saw the open door.

“Was that open all night? I hope Catra didn’t hear us,” Shen said, a little embarrassed.

Viraj suddenly tensed and slapped a hand against his forehead.

“I am such a *paagal!* I totally forgot about Cat-Tra!” He cried.

Shen laughed. “Hey, it’s okay. I’m sure she understood. I mean, she was probably expecting this to happen,”

Viraj shook his head. “No, I don’t mean about that! I was supposed to meet her this morning. Cat-Tra wants to learn the Madgēcot ways, and I was going to teach her Angophora,”

“Anga-what?” Shen said, confused.

“It’s an ancient Madgēcot fighting form developed to be used in conjunction with our Jaadoo suits. Speaking of which…” Viraj said distractedly as he searched the floor.

Shen could not help the admiring Viraj as he searched under the bed on his hands and knees.

“There you are, rascal!” Viraj exclaimed as he pulled out his balled-up Jaadoo suit.

Tossing it into the air, Viraj said another command, and the bundle dispersed into individual sections which then covered his body, forming into the skintight maroon outfit he typically wore.

“You want to come with me? I think Angophora would be good to redirect some of your aggression,” Viraj offered.

Shen shook his head. “No. I think you should have quality time with your sister. Besides, I’d rather have a private lesson,”

Viraj laughed and kissed Shen’s cheek.

“Deal! Perhaps I will show you the Madgēcot Mallayuddha!” Viraj said as he wiggled his dark eyebrows.

“And that is?” Shen replied.

Viraj favored Shen small with a fierce smile combined with a knowing look in his blue and yellow eyes.

“Wrestling,” he said, and with a twitch of his tail, was gone.

* * *

Catra lounged on one of the ancient stone walls of the Imaarat courtyard, staring up at the tree canopy high above as she listened to the Star Hunter cadets train. She had been watching them run through their exercises for the past hour while she waited for her brother to show up, trying to find similarities

between their training style and that of Horde cadets. There were few, if any.

For starters, the Madgēcot trainees, or Shikshu as she heard them called, were not made to stand in rigid formations while getting yelled at by a sergeant. They were allowed to move about freely and learn from the different training areas set up in the stone-hewed courtyard. There appeared to be seven stations, all having to do with the art of being a Star Hunter. Catra had been particularly interested in the one focused on using the magical capabilities of the Jaadoo suits. Catra had never been interested in magic before, but a voice in her head made her now think otherwise.

A Madgēcot without her magic won't stand a chance against me,

Catra had tried to dispel the sudden fear at hearing Despara's voice in her head, turning her attention away from the Madgēcot trainees in apparent disinterest.

I need to get over my fear of my own wife if I'm going to get Adora back. Where is my blasted brother? Catra thought as her tail twitched in irritation. A mewling from below drew her attention downwards to where her friend Melog sat on the ground.

"If you're going to read my thoughts, buddy, you need to learn to recognize when I'm asking myself rhetorical questions. I know perfectly well what my brother is up to—more like *who* he is up to," Catra said with a chuckle. Melog mewled a response.

"No, I didn't say they shouldn't be together. It's just…"

Catra was unsure how she felt about her brother getting involved with Shen, especially after he told her he was looking to avoid commitment. To her, this could only end badly for Shen.

One problem at a time, eh Catra? She thought as she heard the sound of a Madgēcot running down the stone path that led from the city above. Looking up, she spotted Viraj scampering towards

her on all fours, a fretful look on his face. He stopped below where she lay to hunch over, hands on knees while he panted in exhaustion.

“You would have never made it in the Horde with tardiness like that, brother,” she teased down at him.

Viraj only looked up at her, shrugged, and then patted Melog’s snout as they licked him. She jumped down to stand next to him.

“You up for this, Viraj? I mean, after staying up all night and running all this way from home, I’m not sure you have the energy,” Catra said.

Viraj gave her a skeptical look. “You should know that I was not up all night. Besides, what I had been doing only gives me more energy!”

Catra could not help the bark of laughter that escaped her lips.

“You truly are my twin!” She said, giving him a playful punch on his shoulder.

Viraj finally stood and looked confused as he rubbed his shoulder.

“Why did you hit me?” he said.

“It’s how I show affection,” Catra said with a grin. “I do that with Shen all the time. Speaking of which, I thought you said you weren’t looking to get involved with anyone?”

Now it with Viraj’s turn to laugh. “Cat-Tra! It was one night! Surely Shen and I are not going to run off and be bonded before the Chaliendra Tree any time
soon,”

Viraj stopped laughing when he saw the hesitant look on Catra’s face.

“Just promise me you won’t let it go too far if you’re not committed. Don’t hurt him, Viraj; he has been hurt enough,” Catra said softly as she placed a hand on her brother’s shoulder.

He smiled back at Catra as he placed a hand over hers.

“You’re very protective of him, aren’t you? Don’t worry; I will be careful with him. I like your friend very much, sister, but I sense a… darkness in him. It takes some getting used to,” Viraj said with a vague expression.

Catra nodded. “It’s called trauma, Viraj. Something I know a lot about. Anyway, enough about Shen. Are you ready to teach me something? Perhaps I will end up showing *you* a thing or two!”

“Ha! We will see!” Viraj exclaimed.

Melog cocked their head as they watched the siblings; Catra and Viraj’s cocky faces were a mirror of each other as their tails wagged furiously.

Viraj led Catra over to an unoccupied courtyard area near a line of five vertical poles. On the top of each was a large, round fruit that was native to Elysia.

“Is this where the most advanced learn? Is that why it’s empty?” Catra asked as she picked up some fruit from a nearby pile and sniffed it.

“Uh… no, not exactly,” Viraj said with ears lowered. “More like where the earliest beginners start their journey,”

Catra growled in response, tossing the fruit in the air to slash it with her claws. A spray of pulp and juice landed at Viraj’s feet as he gave his sister a sorrowful look.

“You just proved this is the right place for you. Angophora is not about giving in to primal fighting instincts but a better, smarter way. Show me your claws. How do you hold your hand when

prepared to use them?" Viraj said as he stood straight, placing his hands behind his back.

Catra felt annoyance at her brother's lecturing tone but did as she was asked, holding her hand up with fingers curled and claws extended.

"You want to get a close-up view?" Catra asked with a leer.

Viraj gave his sister a suffering look as he took her hand in his.

"Are others impressed by your bravado? Remember, I have claws too," he said as he directed Catra to one of the poles. He guided her hand in a downwards motion over the wood, her claws creating four parallel grooves. Viraj did this several times as his sister looked on perplexed. Finally, Catra withdrew her hand from his, massaging the stiffness from her fingers.

"What did you notice about holding your hand like that?" Viraj asked with raised eyebrows.

"My fingers are tired. Duh! What? Yours wouldn't be?" Catra snapped.

Viraj shook his head. "They don't have to be,"

Viraj suddenly leaped, arms held out, hands flat as blades, and spun at a nearby fruit. A fine mist of aromatic juice filled the air as the top half slid off to be caught by the grinning Viraj. He took a bite of the fruit's meat, offering the rest to his sister, who took it with a laugh. Catra inspected the neatly sliced edges before taking a bite herself—it was sweet and creamy, unlike any fruit she had ever tasted.

Viraj held his hand up before him, fingers curled, and claws extended just as Catra demonstrated.

"This is the primal way, the old way, Cat-Tra. It is effective but inefficient. Your body burns unnecessary energy in holding your

finger this way. Plus, as you have found out, it creates other issues such as tightness in the joints."

Viraj then flattened his fingers, placing the black claws in neat, deadly rows. They gleamed in the morning light.

"Placing the hand in the Talavaar position is better—using your claws to slice instead of tear. It also decreases the change of breakage, which I am sure you know, hurts a lot," Viraj said.

"Yeah, when we were little, Adora would have to put band-aids on all my broken nails before my claws became tougher," Catra said, suddenly becoming crestfallen at the mention of her wife.

"Why don't you try?" Viraj said, gesturing to one of the target fruits.

Catra nodded before mimicking her brother's spinning leap, attacking the fruit with her hands in the Talavar position. She was pleased to see that she succeeded in hitting the fruit on the first try even though she did not cut it completely in half. Where there should be one deep cut, there were two smaller ones, one on top of the other.

"Very good, Cat-Tra! You are a fast learner!" Viraj exclaimed happily.

Catra held her fingers up, still all in a row, and licked the juice from the tips.

"Yeah, it wasn't bad. It needs some practice, though," she said nonchalantly.

Catra spent the rest of the morning under her brother's tutelage; she was less resistant to Viraj's teachings after seeing the sense of the Talavar. Just as her brother commented, Catra picked up the moves and forms quickly and was able to demonstrate them perfectly. The Angophora was very similar to the fighting form she was already using, just with the rougher edges smoothed over. By midday, Viraj called a halt to the session.

“Excellent, Cat-Tra!” He said with a wide grin. “I will say it again; you are a fast learner! You are now fighting at a Varishth level!”

“Is that good?” Catra asked with head cocked. Viraj nodded vigorously.

“Yes! I don’t think I have anything more to teach you as far as the physical arts are concerned. It is time for you to learn the magical,” Viraj said.

“Well? Let’s get started then. Unless you’re eager to return home to your *new friend*,” Catra said with a crafty grin. Viraj crossed his arms and shook his head, chuckling at his sister’s mischief.

“No, it’s not that, Catra. You aren’t equipped for deploying cantrips today,” he said.

“So, what do I need to do, Viraj?” Catra asked.

Viraj gave his sister a meaningful look as another smile crossed his lips.

“We must get you your own Jaadoo suit, Catra. It’s time for you to learn the ways of the Madgēcot fully!”

Revelation

Chapter Summary

> With some help from a fallen She-Ra, Veth's eyes are finally opened.

Violence was heard throughout the Relativity Forge as loud, resonant metallic clangs echoed up and down the long stark corridors. But this was no attack nor cause for any alarm; the Enosion Scientists and occupying Empyreans went about their business as if nothing was happening. Occasionally someone would flinch when an especially vicious blow was landed, but for the most part, everyone strove to put what was happening out of their minds. They tried not to think about how either one of the two combatants could wipe them all out if they so desired.

Despara and Zhe-La/Veth sparred in a vast storage room; the previous contents emptied so they could have the space for this contest of skill and strength. Both had agreed not to use any powers or tricks, only to use their mighty blades and martial skill. They had been battling this way for the past four hours, neither gaining any ground on the other as they sought to find their opponent’s weakness.

Zhe-La/Veth ducked a sideways slice as they lashed out with their leg, seeking to sweep their adversary’s legs as she overextended. But Despara saw this, leaping into the air to perform a somersault over Zhe-La/Veth. As she was above them, Despara stabbed downwards at Zhe-La/Veth’s face—this was deflected with such force that it sent Despara careening away, and she barely made her landing. Despara blocked a downward chop from bisecting her as she stood from her crouch, deflecting the blade while lashing out with her fist—only hitting air.

Dodge, evade, reassess…

Zhe-La/Veth somersaulted backward, barely escaping an S-shaped slash through the air and gaining some space from the Fallen She-Ra. Despara growled and charged, seeking to get closer, desperate to have to quarry near.

Bend, redirect, strike…

Despara's eagerness to re-engage with her adversary had driven her to overreach once again; her momentum was too great. Despara's eyes widened as Zhe-La/Veth dismissed their sword and stepped closer to her advance. Seizing her by the wrists, Zhe-La/Veth smoothly moved backward with her and down onto their back. As Despara began to fall, Zhe-La/Veth brought their legs under her and kicked her out and into the wall as they pivoted backward together. The force of the kick sent Despara through the metallic wall and into the next corridor.

Reassess, prepare, reassess…

Despara came howling out of the rent in the wall, her face pure fury; Zhe-La/Veth could imagine that she did not like being made to appear a fool.

Surprise, thrust, strike…

Zhe-La/Veth re-summoned their sword, thrusting the point directly at the maddened Despara, who batted it away just in time.

Spin, redirect, chop…

In an elegant pirouette, Zhe-La/Veth brought the edge of their black sword sideways in the direction of Despara's back. She cried out and dove onto her belly, rolling sideways to miss another downward sword strike.

Attack, attack, attack…

Despara stood and roared, furious that her attacks were being turned against her. But she did not advance, only eyeing the other Champion as she began to circle them. Zhe-La/Veth came at her

on the balls of their feet, sword in an offensive position, and delivered expert cross diagonal slashes, which Despara blocked.

Reassess, retreat, reassess…

…Good morning, Champion Veth…

Zhe-La/Veth shook the unbidden memory from their head as they backed away from their attack. Seeing an opportunity, Despara went on the offensive and started to probe Zhe-La/Veth's defenses with small jabs of her sword.

Fortify, fortify, fortify…

…Veth? Do you ever think of just skipping it? Like, just for a day?

Zhe-La/Veth gritted their teeth against the sudden pain—not physical pain, but hurt much closer to the heart. In their distraction, Despara scored a small cut in the Aegis Lace of their upper arm, and a few drops of indigo blood spilled out from the rent onto the floor. Zhe-La/Veth did not bother to notice.

Redirect, redirect, redirect…

…w-wish we h-had more time. Eh, my C-champion?

…please, redirect…

A mighty blow broke Zhe-La/Veth's guard, and their sword shattered. Despara kicked them backward, and they stumbled, falling onto their back. Looking up, Zhe-La/Veth found themselves looking at the extreme point of Despara's long black blade, just inches from their face.

"Do you yield, Champion?" Despara panted.

Zhe-La/Veth stared at her mutely as they struggled with bittersweet memories.

"You are too distracted, Veth. There is still too much compassion in you—like Nefeli. Do you want to end up like them?"

Rage filled Zhe-La/Veth, making them bare their fangs in a savage hiss as they rose to their feet. They launched themselves at Despara, whose eyes were wide with shock at the other Champion's rally.

…Adora knew how to heal, but Despara does not. She can heal herself because it's in her own self-interest, but you need empathy to heal others…

Summoning their sword, Zhe-La/Veth slammed their blade down at Despara in a rapid series of strikes, their black sword ringing off hers as she brought it up in a defensive position. The sound was like an alarm bell, drawing Zhe-La/Veth's attention to the apparent truth.

Despara could have saved Nefelu if only she had—

The power behind Zhe-La/Veth's blows was immense, as was their passion, and with a sound like the explosion of glass, both magical swords disintegrated into nothing. The Champions were left weaponless but not defenseless, and they stared at each other as they breathed heavily. The empty storage room was a ruin around them; large holes had been torn through the walls, and the floor was pitted. It would take the Enosions a couple of months to repair the damage done by two Champions of Grayskull practicing their fighting techniques.

"I knew you had it in you, Nephraeh," Despara said with a smirk. "I just had to find the right trigger,"

"And that is?" Zhe-La/Veth asked, suddenly worried.

She must think I'm entirely fallen from the Light. Should I try and kill her?

"Your prickly pride. All you Nephraeh are so poised and haughty—but there is a monster lurking in each of your black hearts. You're

a lot like me in that way, Veth. You're a killer," Despara said as she crossed her muscular arms over her chest.

She has no idea what is going on with me. Good.

"I'm glad you finally see it, Despara. Perhaps we can stop this silly rivalry," Zhe-La/Veth said hopefully.

Despara laughed. "What would be the point of that?" She answered, slapping Zhe-La/Veth's shoulder plates and striding out of the storage room. Before she left, Despara turned her head and favored the other Champion with a warrior's salute.

"Thanks for the exercise, Veth. There may be hope for you yet,"

Zhe-La/Veth did not answer, only pursed their lips and nodded, then listened to her departing footsteps echoing down the corridor. They let out a long sigh when they no longer heard her, reverting to their ordinary form to exit the chamber. Veth wanted solitude at that moment; they wanted a moment of relief to drop the façade of indifference they had been presenting ever since Nefeli's death.

On the outside, Veth appeared as before, uncaring and apathetic, but on the inside, grief and despair ate away at their soul. There seemed to be no relief from it, not even with Penumbra Ritual; Nefeli's death had cut a hole through Veth's apathy which no amount of Antithetical Philter repair. They were becoming desperate, and they had hoped the contest with Despara would help them divert their mind.

At least I seemed to assuage her doubt of me, at least for the time being, Veth thought as they entered their personal chambers.

The room was not very spacious but seemed vast now to Veth—like a void they could tumble into if they were not careful. It had been this way now that a single person was no longer there to fill it with their life.

Veth removed their white jacket, tossing it on the floor to sit on the bed, and felt at their arm, where Despara's sword had cut. The wound had since been healed when they were in their enhanced state—but that was not what they sought. Veth's fingers brushed the silky section of Aegis Lace now tied there; the armor section completely limp now that its owner was deceased.

Removing the ribbon from their arm, Veth held it up to their nose, breathing in the scents of Nefeli's body. Tears poured from Veth's eyes as the smell awakened memories, not only of their brief romance but of a lifetime of fighting at Nefeli's side.

They had both been raised under the direct guidance of Archon Lethe and groomed for different roles—Veth to take on the mantle of Zhe-La, Nefeli to become Krypteia. There were other Nephraeh children amongst them, but Nefeli and Veth had become close, going through many rites of passage together.

When Veth had become old enough to start partaking in the Penumbra Ritual, Nefeli had been there, by their side, to begin down the path of The Light with them.

When the old bearer of Zhe-La had fallen, Nefeli was there under the Temple of Light to watch Veth's acceptance of the Champion Spirit.

And Veth was there, watching proudly as their friend had taken the mantle of leader of the Krypteia two years ago.

Veth realized that sometime during the course of their lives together, they had fallen in love with Nefeli, and they were sure that this love was reciprocated. The knowledge saddened them. Perhaps they could have had more time together if they had only realized this sooner. Why had they not known?

Because the Penumbra Ritual dampened the love just enough to make it imperceptible. But it was never strong enough to keep it from happening, Veth thought as they wiped tears from their eyes, smearing the kohl into black streaks.

The Penumbra Ritual was supposed to be the ultimate representation of The Light's goodness, but Veth was beginning to feel like they hated it. What did it mean to despise the definition of what was right?

It means I am unworthy of The Light, perhaps even Zhe-La, Veth thought as they stroked their thumb over the piece of Nefeli's armor.

The internal conflict that had begun during their mission to Elysia resumed as Veth struggled with the nature of The Light. The embodiment of Archon Lethe's will had enabled them to betray a person they had not only liked but had somehow grown to care about. It had also made them do things that, at the time, made them feel disgusted with themselves. They remembered all those moments vividly.

The horror they felt when they thrust the sword of Sher-Va into that beautiful, magical tree and the feeling that to destroy such a marvel was a crime.

The look on Catra's face when she realized they had betrayed her and the anguished cry as they stole her soulmate.

Adora's fear as they held in her place to be enervated by Archon Lethe, then transformed into Despara.

Finally, Nefeli's sorrow as they died, not only for a life lost but for a love—cut short.

Veth shut their eyes and gritted their teeth against this final memory as a traitorous thought came to the fore.

If only Despara had empathy, Nefeli could have been saved. Apathy is wrong; The Light is evil!

"NOOOOO!" Veth screamed as they stood, throwing the piece of Aegis Lace away from them.

The lightweight material did not go far and seemed to resist the force of their throw, gently falling to the ground not two feet away from them. Veth stared at it in fury as they clenched their fists, the tips of their claws beginning to dig into the flesh of their hands.

Another thought crept into their mind, a recollection of that chaotic fight with He-Man. They had him, they could have bested him, but when they used their power to drain his empathy, he turned into a monster.

Had I done that? Or did he summon that power to best me? Better question, what did I do to defeat him finally? I have never done anything like that before in my entire life.

The memory of the power that blazed out from their body was like an echo of a dream half-remembered. It didn't seem real that they had summoned that wondrous… light…

The room intercom suddenly buzzed, making Veth jump in surprise. Walking over to the communication panel, they depressed the button to open the line.

"Veth? Are you there?" Despara's voice buzzed over the speaker.

"Yes! What do you want?!" Veth replied tersely.

"Don't get snappy with me, Nephraeh. What's the matter? Did I interrupt something? Are you indoctrinating the new leader of the Krypteia in your quarters?" Despara said with a cruel laugh. Veth hissed with outrage at this insinuation but did not answer, too afraid they would let their true feelings slip.

"I have a mission for us, Veth. Something local to this planet that needs to be taken care of. Meet me down in the landing bay in fifteen minutes." Despara said.

Veth sighed, letting out some of the frustration and rage in order to respond.

"Fine, see you there," Veth said as they cut the connection.

* * *

Zhe-La/Veth gazed about the shuttle bay, taking in the activity as Nephraeh scurried about in preparation for departure. There were five of the bladed and dagger-shaped shuttles being readied, each one capable of carrying a complement of ten armed Nephraeh. Whatever this mission was, it must be essential to field such a force.

Zhe-La/Veth felt a jolt of surprise as they saw a group of Krypteia carrying the unmistakable form of a Vetala Phylactery. The large glass container ate the room's light as four Krypteia hefted it, the ultimate night of its contents sloshing about from the movement. A sizeable wooden stopper and wax seal kept the essence of the Vetala from spilling out; only when the glass was broken or the proper command spoken would that happen. Zhe-La/Veth spotted the new leader of the Kyrpteia and quickly strode over to them.

"Amah! Who authorized the use of Vetala on this mission?" They asked.

Amah turned and saluted their Champion before responding.

"It was Despara, Champion Veth; she ordered it. She said we would need the added help to complete this mission."

Zhe-La/Veth waved them to proceed as incredulity washed over them.

She better have a good reason for this; the Vetala are not toys to be played with. Where is that woman? Zhe-La/Veth thought as they scanned the landing bay.

Finally, they spotted a large, black armored female shape directing a group of Peltasts to different shuttles.

"Despara! What is going on? Why are we deploying Vetala?" Zhe-La/Veth barked as they approached the other Champion.

Annoyance flashed over her face as she turned to address them.

“Veth, there you are. Yes, Archon Lethe sanctioned the use of the Vetala. You have a problem with that?” Despara snapped.

“Yes, I do. I wish to speak to them and confirm this before we depart,” Zhe-La/Veth responded as they crossed their arms over their chest.

Despara shook her head. “No time, Veth; the rebels are close to their preparations and will strike soon. We must act now!” She said, emphasizing her words by slamming a black-gloved hand in an open palm.

“Rebels? What is going on?!” Zhe-La/Veth suddenly felt like events had slipped beyond their control.

“I will explain on the way! Come, you will ride with me!” Despara said, taking the other Champion by the shoulder and leading them to a nearby craft.

Once aboard, the five attack shuttles lifted off and headed in a southerly direction, increasing their acceleration and altitude until the ground far below appeared as a slowly spinning sphere. It would not be long until they reached their destination, wherever that was. Despara turned to Veth, her usually stern countenance even more frigid than usual.

“I have received word from our Knosis operatives that a rebel cell is operating nearby. They are gearing up for an assault on the Relativity Forge to free it of our presence. We also have word that they are receiving aid from the Madgēcots and that a Star Hunter is working with them. Possibly even leading the operation.” Despara said.

“Why did I not get this news? The Knosis are supposed to bring any fresh information straight to me.” Zhe-La/Veth said incredulously.

Despara shrugged. “I have no idea, probably because they just found me first. I immediately contacted Archon Lethe, and they suggested bringing the Vetala. I agreed. I think we should stamp this threat out with extreme prejudice just in case these Enosians get ideas to attack us again.”

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head; they did not like this, but nothing was to be done about it. They would enforce their Archon’s will wherever it was needed.

Looking out a glass portal, Zhe-La/Veth saw that they were crossing an expansive ocean, and in the direction they were headed, a vast continent emerged. The watery expanse soon disappeared, and land streaked by under them; it was arid and rocky, appearing as a broad waste. Soon this too started to vanish as small buildings and roads dotted the ground, the signs of civilization increasing as they traveled.

The attack shuttle started to decelerate as it descended towards a large metropolis, and Zhe-La/Veth could see people on the streets and speeders buzzing about the glass and steel high rises.

These people have no idea what is coming, Zhe-La/Veth thought as they glanced sideways at Despara.

Retro thrusters activated, and the attack shuttle landed with a jolt. The forward gangplank deployed to reveal the paved asphalt of an avenue broad enough for all five Empyrean craft to land side by side. Enosians ran in all directions, some crying out in fear as Zhe-La/Veth, Despara, and the rest of the Nephraeh deployed.

“Ahhhh!!” Despara said with relish. “I love the sound of screaming; it makes me know I’m appreciated,”

Zhe-La/Veth did not answer as they watched four Krypteia descend from a nearby shuttle carrying the Phylactery. They set it down in the middle of the large street, backing away as they saw Despara approach with her sword on her shoulder.

“Wait, Despara, we should first see—” Zhe-La/Veth started but was cut short as the other champion sliced through the top half of the container, sending the stoppered end crashing to the ground. A chill was felt as black clawed hands reached up to grasp the edge of the Phylactery, and eleven Vetala heaved themselves out and onto the solid ground of Enos. Their oily bodies glistened in the light of the day as they cast bout themselves, sniffing with black noses and peering with even blacker eyes.

They regarded the Empyreans around them, seeming to identify them as allies— but not all of them. With a start, Zhe-La/Veth saw that all eleven of the Vetala were taking an interest in them. The creatures stared at the Nephraeh champion as if they were a tasty morsel. One Vetala in particular caught Zhe-La/Veth’s attention; there seemed to be something very familiar about it.

Suddenly, the Vetala shifted their focus on the fleeing Enosians and immediately gave chase—like a pack of hunting dogs. Zhe-La/Veth watched with mute horror as they seized one unlucky man, pinning him to the ground and draining him with their black fangs.

A hand on their shoulder drew them from this horror, and they turned to see Despara staring at them.

“You awake?” She asked coldly. “Come on; we don’t have much time. They are inside this building,”

Despara pointed at an immense building nearby, the outside of which was emblazed with symbols Zhe-La/Veth could not understand. The structure's shape and construction differed from those surrounding it; instead of being mostly glass, the outside was composed of a composite, like concrete—but more robust. Small windows peered out from within the building, giving Zhe-La/Veth the feeling that they were looking at a fortress.

“I guess this would be the right place,” Zhe-La/Veth said vaguely.

As if on cue, hover vehicles arose from ramps depressed into the roots of the building, appearing as if they were rising from the very avenue itself. Each attack craft carried two people: one in the front to pilot and one at the rear to man a turret weapon. Beams of red energy blazed out at the Empyreans as the hover vehicles sped toward them. Zhe-La/Veth summoned their protective energy shield and expanded it, protecting them and the entirety of the Empyrean attack force.

The Sarissa were also quick to respond, flinging long javelins at the attackers, which expertly pierced the hover vehicles to disable them. The Enosians inside leaped from within their now useless craft only to be subdued by summoned black bands before they could draw their weapons.

“Hey! Save some for me!” Despara shouted.

She flung her sword in the direction of the last two hover vehicles; it spun in the air, appearing as a black disc that sliced through the entirety of one of the crafts, causing it to veer into the other. Zhe-La/Veth winced as both vehicles exploded in a ball of fire.

“Despara. Perhaps you should let our warriors do most of the fighting? How are you going to question anyone if you kill them all?” Zhe-La/Veth said as calmly and slowly as possible.

Despara ignored them as she suddenly bolted towards the building with the Vetala trailing behind her. The creatures became distracted by the abundance of prey and fell on any Enosians unlucky enough to be in their path. Mentally, Zhe-La/Veth attempted to reign in the creature’s hunger through their Oblivion power, but the Vetala did not respond. They listened to a different master now.

Despara had made it to the building’s entrance and shattered the thick double doors completely with one mighty strike from her sword. Sounds of violence echoed out of the open doorway as soon as Despara disappeared within, followed by shrieks of dismay as the Vetala joined her.

“Let’s go!” Zhe-La/Veth commanded the Nephraeh. “Let’s try and keep her from any more unnecessary destruction!”

The Nephraeh raced into the building, following in the wake of the fallen She-Ra’s charge, but when they entered, she was nowhere to be found, only the proof of her passing. Zhe-La/Veth looked around the entryway, seeing nothing but destruction and enervated bodies. Here and there was the red evidence of Despara’s sword work.

“There!” Amah said, pointing a clawed gauntlet in the direction of a stairwell.

The Nephraeh raced up the many flights of stairs tirelessly, following Despara’s trail until they reached the top of the structure. There, they found what looked like a command center where Despara and the Vetala battled against the last of the defenders. The Enosians fought in a circle, appearing to be protecting a figure in the middle.

Is that the Madgēcot? Zhe-La/Veth thought as they sprung forward.

Seeking to end this struggle as quickly as possible, Zhe-La/Veth summoned the power of Oblivion, bathing the tower defenders in its draining power. The Enosians cried out as they fell to the ground, and the Nephraeh rushed forward to subdue them. Sensing easy prey, the Vetala lunged for the prone Enosians, but Zhe-La/Veth placed their body in the way.

“ENOUGH!” They screamed, putting the full force of Oblivion behind their words.

Suddenly unsure, the Vetala halted, looking between the Nephraeh Champion and the Fallen She-Ra.

“YOU WILL LISTEN TO ME!” Zhe-La/Veth commanded again.

As the Vetala lowered their heads and acquiesced to their alpha, one of them drew Zhe-La/Veth’s attention. It was the same

creature as before, and now Zhe-La/Veth saw what had made this one seem so familiar. There were markings on its bald head; they appeared as four lines that ran from the side of the scalp and over one of the black eyes.

A sudden voice drew Zhe-La/Veth's attention away from their inspection.

"Why? Why did you attack us?" a man's voice asked.

Turning, Zhe-La/Veth saw that the speaker was the person the defenders had been trying to protect. It was not a Madgēcot but an older human man dressed in a heavily decorated uniform. He was sitting up and looking at the Nephraeh around him, incredulity plain on his weathered face.

"We were told you were gathering a rebel force to attack the Relativity Forge. That you were being led by one of our enemies, the Madgēcots, and were going to drive us away." Zhe-La/Veth said, trying to put steel in their voice. The leader of the Enosian defenders only laughed at them.

"What!? We agreed to your demands and vowed not to attack you!" The man shouted at Veth.

"Then what is this, then? Why all the armed soldiers?" They replied, waving a hand around them.

"This is the military facility for the District, you idiot! Of course, there are armed soldiers here!" He shouted back at them.

Zhe-La/Veth turned to look questioningly at Despara; she only shrugged, giving them a slight knowing grin.

She tricked me. This was all for her fun, for sport. Despara hurt all these people because she was bored. Zhe-La/Veth thought as they stared daggers at the other Champion.

They wanted to destroy her at that moment, wanted to kill her for manipulating them and their people into hurting innocents. But

they didn't as a single thought stayed their hand.

You did this to her, Veth. Adora is not responsible for this; you are, they thought as they shut their eyes against the sudden need to weep.

"You're a fool for thinking there was a Madgēcot here. They would never have us fight for them. They would come here in force and crush you if you were not holding the Relativity Forge over their heads!" The man continued, encouraged by Zhe-La/Veth's silence.

Zhe-La/Veth let the man's words wash over them as they gazed at the Nephraeh all around them. Their people looked back at them questioningly, ready to follow the true Empyrean Champion's orders, whatever they were. A strange feeling of dissociation struck Zhe-La/Veth as they stared at their fellow Nephraeh. They had a sense that there was something wrong with all of them, that they were meant for something else, something more than what they currently were. Zhe-La/Veth shook these thoughts from their head as they turned back to the man who dared speak so boldly to them.

"What is your name, sir?" Zhe-La/Veth asked as they turned their glowing indigo eyes upon him.

"My name is Rikan, *General* Rikan of the Northern District of Kendowa." General Rikan said proudly.

Zhe-La/Veth nodded to him. "On behalf of the Empire of Empyrea, you have my apologies, General Rikan. You will be compensated for the physical damage, of course. Unfortunately, there is no compensation I can give for the lives lost today, for no monetary value can be placed on living beings. I only have deep sorrow for their unnecessary deaths,"

The General had no response to this, only looked down and sighed as Zhe-La/Veth waved to a nearby Krypteia.

"Release the General and his people," they said.

"Hold on a second! We need to bring them back for interrogation!" Despara shouted.

"What interrogation, Despara? I'm not letting you bring back these people so that they can be tortured for your amusement!" Zhe-La/Veth shouted back.

Despara clenched her fists and appeared as if she would confront the other Champion but stopped when she saw the entirety of the Nephraeh were behind Zhe-La/Veth.

"I thought you were coming around, Veth. I see I was wrong," she said coldly before turning for the stairway and leaving abruptly.

"*I'm so happy to disappoint you,*" Zhe-La/Veth said to her back.

They watched their people remove the black bindings from the Enosians, who rose unsteadily to their feet to stare past Zhe-La/Veth. Curious as to what drew their attention, Zhe-La/Veth turned to see the Vetala milling about in a group. The creatures seemed listless and unfocused, and doing a quick count, Zhe-La/Veth realized they were only ten.

"Where is the other—" they started to mumble but then spotted the missing Vetala.

It was standing in a nearby doorway, and when it caught sight of Zhe-La/Veth looking in its direction, it retreated into an adjacent room. Deciding that there was no longer any threat, Zhe-La/Veth transitioned into just Veth and crossed the expansive command center and into the room the Vetala disappeared into.

Looking around, Veth saw that it appeared to be a conference room; one large table sat in the middle with chairs placed about its periphery. The Vetala was standing in the opposite corner; its black body turned away from Veth in a hunch that was typical of its kind. But as Veth approached the Vetala, it suddenly straightened and turned to regard them with black eyes.

Veth noticed subtle nuances in how this Vetala held itself that seemed familiar— as if they were looking at someone they have known all their life. As Veth got closer and saw this Vetala's face more clearly, they realized this was indeed the case.

The Vetala had no hair, its skin was glistening and void black, but the face was unmistakable— the full lips, high cheekbones, and sharp jawline. Veth even recognized the slash marks that a Madgēcot had created a little more than a month passed.

"Nefeli?" Veth whispered as tears fell from their silver eyes.

The Vetala nodded, opening its mouth to emit a strange mewling noise. Veth went to it, grasping the Vetala that was once Nefeli by the shoulders. As it continued in its attempts to communicate, Veth saw that there was no tongue behind its black jaws.

"How is this possible? Wha— why? Archon Lethe said the Vetala were simple manifestations of their power," Veth stammered.

"Hhhheeeth… hiiiiiiddde…" The Vetala rasped.

Dread jolted through Veth as they ascertained the meaning behind the Vetala's barely formed words.

"*Lethe lied,*" they said quietly.

The Vetala nodded, raising a black hand to brush deadly claws against Veth's lilac face. It was a gentle touch, a lover's touch, and Veth found themselves pulling the Vetala close in an embrace.

"Nefeli! I miss you so much!" They cried, holding the back of the Vetala's bald head, pressing its face against their neck.

Veth felt the Vetala tentatively place its hands on their sides, then slowly around them in an awkward embrace. Fear jolted through Veth as they felt cold teeth against their neck, but before they penetrated flesh, the Vetala pushed Veth away with a hiss, and they fell back on their rear.

Veth looked up as the Vetala faced the ceiling and howled in heart-wrenching agony. Slowly, Veth raised themselves to their knees and tentatively reached out to touch the Vetala once more, but it backed away, out of reach.

“I will find a way to fix this, Nefeli. I promise!” They said.

The Vetala shook its head slowly, a look of sadness plain on its face.

“Nuuuhh… fhhheeeexxxx… Heeetthhh…” it said to them.

“Then what can I do for you? There must be something I can do?!”

The Vetala nodded, and Veth’s heart fell, for they already knew the answer.

“Heeellllppp… mmmuueehh… hhhhiiiiiieee…”

Veth shut their eyes against the tears as they hugged themselves; they wanted to do anything but that. They just could not believe what was happening; not only did they have to watch Nefeli die, but now they were being asked to destroy them again. It was too painful to bear.

Veth felt clawed fingers gently grasp them by the chin, raising their face to look up at the Vetala. It was so glossy and sleek in its nudity, and for a moment, Veth remembered a more intimate moment with Nefeli this way.

“Pleeeezzzz… Heeeetthhhh… ahhhh…. hhhuuuuuvvvv… eeewww…”

Veth placed their hand over the Vetala’s and smiled.

“I love you too, Nefeli,” they said.

Rising to their feet, Veth placed both their hands on the sides of the Vetala’s smooth head and summoned the power given to them

by Archon Lethe. It was the same power of Oblivion that saturated the Vetala, holding its essence together like glue; it was only a simple matter for Veth to remove that bond.

“Nefeli, I promise. I am going to get answers for this, I swear!” They said.

The Vetala nodded as it caressed its claws down Veth’s face one more, emphasizing its desire to be with them physically. Veth closed their eyes as they absorbed the energy keeping the Vetala corporeal; lambent indigo vapor poured from the black body and into Veth’s as the Vetala slowly vanished. When Veth opened their eyes, they saw beautiful light in the vague outline of a Nephraeh, but that too disappeared into nothing.

Veth stood there, their shining eyes wide with shock. They still could not believe what had happened and tentatively touched the place the Vetala had caressed them. A single thought played out repeatedly in their numb mind as the room spun about them. It was the same thought they had earlier in the day, a thought they had immediately tried to reject. But after seeing what had become of the person they had loved, they were now more readily able to accept.

Archon Lethe is deceiving us; The Light is a lie.

Way of the Jaadoo

Chapter Summary

Kishar and Zzar join forces to turn their society into an Empire

Catra learns how to use magic while her brother, Viraj, learns something about his new boyfriend, Shen.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

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Much has transpired since my last entry, and I believe I now know my purpose—or at least a path forward in this seemingly meaningless existence. Zzar and I have formulated a plan that will transform this entire galaxy. But first, I should mention how I have made harvesting empathy easier and less fraught with danger for myself.

Using the knowledge gleaned from Zzar's mysterious spell, I can fully harness my unique nature and the power of Zhe-La to draw small bits of empathy from Nephraeh everywhere at once. The amount of emotion I borrow from my people is barely perceptible, but I believe that will change over time as my thirst increases. I'm sure that the Nephraeh losing their empathy would be cause for alarm and draw unnecessary attention. For now, though, this situation works, and I will face that problem when it arises.

Being fed slowly and continuously is a strange sensation and not as thrilling as feeding directly from a victim. Perhaps, from time to time, I will give into this desire—just for fun. But most of my nourishment will be received in this sterile way; it is much safer for me. I am very fortunate to have my connection to Zhe-La, and

by proxy, my connection to the Nephraeh. I don't know what I would do without it, but I'm sure I would figure something out.

Since stabilizing the situation with my need for sustenance, I could turn my attention to my other problem—Jihan. Killing him outright would be a mistake and too messy; instead, I have been slowly sabotaging our relationship. When he needs me, I am distant and withdrawn. When something positive happens, I find a way to paint it in a negative light. I have also started withholding affection and only giving it in a transactional way—which is to say, when Jihan does what I want, he gets to make love to me. This is now easy for me to do since I am currently seeking others to satisfy my physical desires, including that witch Zzar. Believe it or not, she and I have become quite the pair… but I'm getting ahead of myself.

Even after striving to push him away, Jihan will not relent and give up on me. I do not understand it, and it is a cause for much frustration. No matter, I will only need to increase my attempts. Perhaps I will even allow him a peek behind my mask; let him see the new me. That will change his mind, I'm sure.

In the meantime, I have been making a few trips to Castle Grayskull when time allows. This has become much easier with the recent invention of portal technology; instead of having to travel great distances via spacecraft, one simply finds the local interdimensional portal, instantly transporting to another planet. Granted, this would make my feedings easier, but I believe that would be a backward step for me. I am on the best path forward.

I digress…

The time spent with Zzar has become so intoxicating, not because of her wit, charm, beauty, or sexual talents, but what she represents to me.

Power.

Zzar is the key to unlocking the limitless potential found beneath Castle Grayskull; I'm not just talking about the Abominable Powers but other lesser-known secrets. The rare moments Zzar speaks of this Apogean Ritual, the more enticing it sounds to me. She is obsessed with mastering this spell, and I think I know why. Once completed, I believe the Apogean Ritual grants the caster of this spell limitless power and immortality—in effect, becoming a god.

But I am still playing the long game on this, still biding my time and waiting for the right moment to learn this spell. Zzar is very cagy, and I don't believe she believes my facade of not appearing interested in the Apogean Ritual. Why would she be? Anyone would want to become a god if the opportunity presented itself.

Besides her fear of using this spell, I know one aspect of the Apogean Ritual keeps Zzar from casting it; it's transcribed onto an ancient crystal data cube via an advanced cryptograph. The other day I had the chance to peak over Zzar's shoulder as she went through her laborious process of translating the spell. From the glance I got, it appeared the cryptograph is based on a variation of Nephraeh language that was spoken when we first arrived on this dimensional plane—Sera'Phael-im. I have not mentioned this to Zzar and decided to bide my time once again. While I wait for this opportunity, I decided to learn this archaic language and use it when the time was right.

I should now speak of the grand plan Zzar and I have been developing to help transform our Great Intergalactic Society into something more pliable, something that could be more easily influenced by a person with more vision. The way it is now is too chaotic and directionless, too fixated on trivial ideas such as fairness and love. People are allowed to govern their own lives and waste them in their stunted view of what happiness means to them. When they die, only memories are left, nothing of any substance—no great works.

The billions and billions of lives that encompass this Society should be used for more than that. They need to be harnessed

and made to do what those with an actual purpose in this reality want—these superior beings of vision I speak of are, of course, Zzzar and I.

Well… for the time being, it's the two of us. I can't imagine either of us sharing power for very long.

Zzar and I have a better plan for our universe, but it will take time. We must work slowly and carefully, each of us slowly accumulating influence so that we can manipulate events to mold society to our perfect vision. This grand new society can have only one form, one structure, and one common purpose.

It will be an Empire.

This is a daunting task and may take many years, hundreds, even —

A green flaming magical bolt buzzed bast Glimmer's head, bursting into green flames on Jacarandra Tree behind her. She shrieked in surprise, leaping to her feet and dropping the datapad she was just reading. Looking around frantically, Glimmer only saw the rolling floor of the forest and the widely spaced trunks of the Jacaranda trees, but her assailant finally made herself known.

"Heads up, Sparkles!" Catra called from the crest of a nearby mossy knoll with an insufferable smirk plastered on her face.

She was wearing the new Jaadoo suit her brother made for her, and like Viraj's, it was a maroon color. But instead of red striping, Catra's Jaadoo was black; it loosely followed her natural stripes with a spiral running down her right leg. As was her nature, Catra made a completely unorthodox Jaadoo suit that did not cover her body completely. Instead, both arms were left bare, with a single glove of material on her right arm. Glimmer had to admit that her friend Catra looked good in it.

"Catra! I know magic is new to you, but could you please be careful!" Glimmer said peevishly.

Catra put both hands on her hips, giving Glimmer a slightly feral look as her tail twitched.

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“Hey Sparkles, want to see how your sparkly magic holds up to *Catra magic*? How about we have a little sparring match?” She said cockily.

“What?!” Glimmer shrieked.

“No, no, no, Cat-Tra! Absolutely not!” Viraj called as he came up behind his sister. “You can barely control your cantrips as it is. You are not ready for sparring,”

Catra visibly bristled as her brother crossed his arms, regarding her with a stern expression.

“Yeah, I think I will pass, Catra. I came here to watch you practice using your new suit, not become one of your practice dummies,” Glimmer said.

“You know, Viraj, I’m not the type who likes being told what to do,” Catra said as her tail twitched rapidly.

“Yes! I’m starting to see that problem, sister,” Viraj said as his tail began to match his sister’s. A low growl could be heard from each of the Madgecot’s throats.

“Uh, guys, how about we just relax. You two have been at this for a while,” Glimmer said tentatively.

“No,” Viraj answered with a shake of his head. “My sister has become too big for her tail; I must bring her down a notch or two,”

Catra hissed at this. “Many have tried, *bro!”*

Glimmer was thinking about using magic on the two angry siblings when Viraj pulled a section of his Jaadoo suit off and flung it at Catra. She yowled as she flipped over the cantrip, which had ignited into a buzzing ball of static electricity that arced harmlessly away. As Catra was still in the air, she yanked a section of material off her glove and sent two cantrips back in her brother’s direction.

They made a hideous sound that made Glimmer plug fingers in her ears.

“More is not better, Cat-Tra!” He yelled, ducking under two screaming projectiles. “And using Howlers against me is not the best cantrip for this situation!”

Glimmer watched as Viraj sent more cantrips in his sister’s direction; Catra ducked and dodged them, even reaching out to bat one out of the air. She shrieked as it exploded into blue dancing sparks which crackled around her.

“Did you just try to deflect a cantrip with your hands?!” Viraj said, laughing. “What do you think they are, Cat-Tra? Arrows?”

Hissing in rage, Catra reached behind and pulled a section of Jaadoo material from her lower back and began to ball it up with both hands.

“Careful now, Cat-Tra,” Viraj said as he held up a hand. “Do not use the Jvaala if you do not mean—”

Catra flung the cantrip at her brother; it exploded into a white-hot flaming ball as it streaked towards him. Viraj yelped as he barely dodged a fiery explosion; he rolled in the moss as he patted cinders still burning on his Jaadoo suit.

“How’s that for a lesson, Viraj?” Catra called to him.

As Viraj leaped to his feet, Glimmer was surprised to see pure fury on his usually friendly face. He raced on all fours towards his sister, who watched him come with wide eyes and lowered ears.

What happened next was almost too quick for Glimmer to see; the two Madgēcot siblings fought each other with kicks, chops, and slashes. She was suddenly reminded of when she saw two cats fighting, the vicious interchange happening so fast it seemed to be over in moments.

Catra pushed away from her brother and ran up a nearby Jacarandra tree on all fours. He immediately followed, swatting her legs out from under her and causing Catra to fall back into him. They rolled down the side of the tree, still fighting, and bounced on the soft moss of the forest floor.

Viraj kicked his sister off and Catra somersaulted away, landing in a crouch nearby. She reached down at her chest, quickly removing another cantrip and tossing it sideways at Viraj with a flick of her wrist. It hit him square in the face, immediately covering Viraj from head to toe in liquid. He stopped from a forward lunge to look incredulously down at his body.

"Do you mean to use a hydration cantrip on me, Catra?" He said as he spat water.

Catra shrugged. "I meant to use the green flamey one, but I guess I missed it,"

Viraj looked suspiciously at his sister. "The Hara Taara is located at the waist, Cat-Tra, nowhere near the hydration cantrip. You did that on purpose,"

Catra gave her brother another shrug along with a sly grin.

"I was hoping it would cool you off. Did it work?"

Irritation passed briefly over Viraj's heterochromatic eyes before he snorted with derision.

"I guess, sister. Although you were the one to start this, not me,"

Catra gave a loud sigh. "Sorry, brother. I guess I was just getting frustrated. I hate learning something new and feeling like a… what do you call it?"

"A short-tail," Viraj answered with a grin.

Viraj went to his sister, embracing her in a warm hug which Catra returned. Glimmer could hear purring from them both as she

shook her head, incredulous at how quickly they went from fighting to hugging.

"I'm sorry I lost my temper, Cat-Tra. Have you ever heard the saying, '*a Madgēcot's purr comes as quickly as their claws?*'" Viraj asked as he parted from his sister.

Catra shook her head as she looked up at her brother's cinnamon face.

"It's an ancient saying, Cat-Tra, given to us by other races who encountered us. We Madgēcots are very passionate, very emotional. The two emotions we have in the biggest supply are empathy and anger. We used to let the latter rule us, especially during the Dark Times, but now strive to suppress the anger, letting the compassion flourish. We have many tools to help us with this constant struggle. One of these is the Dhyaan—or meditation. In my haste to teach you Angophora and the ways of Jaadoo, I forgot the most important thing: control."

Catra let out an exasperated sigh. "Yeah, yeah. Perfuma has been teaching me 'self-healing' and 'balance,'"

"And how is that working for you?" Viraj asked with a single raised eyebrow.

"Eh," Catra said, raising both hands open-palmed and shrugged. "Perfuma tries, but a lot of the time, it's a struggle for me,"

"Well, Dhylaan was developed by Madgēcots for Madgēcots. I'm sure it will do the trick, Cat-Tra. Why don't you join Shen and I as I instruct him?" Viraj said with a tilt of his head.

Catra let out a bark of laughter. "I'm not sure I want to be around when you're *instructing* your boyfriend, Viraj,"

Glimmer found herself giggling at the expression on Viraj's handsome face. He crossed his arms and gazed coolly at his sister —tail wagging furiously.

“Ha, ha. Very funny. Do you want to come or what?” He said.

“I do!” Glimmer exclaimed, raising her hand. “I think some calming techniques would work wonders for me!”

“Of course! See Cat-Tra? Even your friend recognizes the wisdom of the Dhylaan,” Viraj said.

“Ugh! Fine! Why not sign up for more touchy-feely stuff?!” Catra exclaimed.

Glimmer could not help going over to her friend and wrapping an arm around her shoulder.

“Don’t worry, Catra,” Glimmer whispered. “*I won’t tell your brother that the big bad Catra has a soft wittle underbelly,”*

Catra scowled as she slapped Glimmer’s hand away from touching her stomach.

“Well, Sparkles, you just did. My brother can hear just as well as I can,”

“I already knew this,” Viraj said to them both. “Cat-Tra is my twin sister, after all. What is wrong with having a soft side? Shen also seems to think showing a sensitive side is a form of weakness. Are all people from Etheria like this?”

“Nope,” Glimmer said smugly. “Just Catra and Shen. They are a not good representation for the rest of us Etherians,”

“Yeah, we are too awesome for the rest of you *dorks*,” Catra said, crossing her arms.

“So, Viraj, how are things going with you and Shen, by the way?” Glimmer asked.

The question caught Viraj off guard, and Glimmer could not help but notice that his ears lowered and tail twitched before answering.

"It's good—I mean, it's great, Shen is great. He is very kind and compassionate," Viraj answered offhand, looking up at the trees. Glimmer and Catra shared a look.

"*But?*" Catra prompted.

"Oh, I don't know," Viraj said, pawing at the ground with a clawed foot. "Shen is a man of contradictions; on the one hand, he is so caring of others; on the other, he is horrible to himself. It's tough to watch."

"Yeah, I know how that is, Viraj; Adora is the same way—although she has come a long way from how she was in the Horde. Adora, Shen, and I all grew up in toxic environments, and it takes a while to shake that. You just have to have patience, bro," Catra said kindly.

"I guess I've lived a sheltered life here on Elysia. Even when our parents disappeared, I was loved and taken care of. It's… jarring to be around someone who has had the opposite experience." Viraj said uncertainly.

"Well, Viraj, if you don't think it's working out, you should break things off sooner than later. Remember what I told you." Catra said.

"It will be okay," Viraj said, holding his hand up in placation. "I don't want to push him away, Catra, especially if this is just me needing time to adjust. But yes, if I feel like it won't work, I will gently break things off."

"It would be great if you and Shen were a couple, Viraj," Glimmer piped up. "I mean, you're perfect for him. You already look so much like Catra!"

The moment she finished the sentence, Glimmer knew she had said too much. Her massive faux pas was verified by the looks in both siblings' heterochromatic eyes; Catra's were wide with horror, while Viraj's were squinted in confusion.

“What do you mean by that? Viraj asked slowly.

“Uhhh…” Glimmer said while looking at Catra for support. “I guess he didn’t know?”

Catra slapped a hand to her face and groaned as Viraj looked back and forth between the two women, his agitation mounting.

“Can someone explain? I’m very confused,” Viraj said in almost a plea.

“Look,” Catra started, placing her hands on her brother’s shoulders. “Back when Shen and I first met, we really didn’t like each other. Well, mostly I didn’t like him,”

“Yeah, no one blames you for that, Catra; he did almost kill you and put you on mandatory bed rest for like, forever!” Glimmer exclaimed before blushing and closing her mouth.

“WHAT!?” Viraj exclaimed, his long tail bushing up.

“It’s nothing. It wasn’t Shen’s fault, plus it’s all in the past,” Catra said calmly. “Anyway, after Adora made me start hanging out with him, I found out Shen wasn’t that bad. We had a lot in common; a sick sense of humor, hatred of bullies and authority figures, and last but not least, a pretty good sob story about growing up. I started to take a shine to him and started to see Shen as a good friend—a best friend.”

“Well, as it turns out, Shen started to like me too. In fact, he started to like me *a lot*,” Catra said, beginning to wring her hands in front of her.

“*Oh,*” Viraj said simply. “So, what you are telling me is that my boyfriend is in love with my sister?”

“It’s not like that, Viraj!” Catra exclaimed. “Shen knew it was ever going happen between us, and I think he beat himself pretty badly over it. I’m sure he is long over me,”

Viraj did not respond, only pursing his lips as he thought about this revelation. Catra stared daggers at Glimmer, who only responded with a sheepish smile.

"Okay! That's something I wasn't expecting today!" Viraj said finally, favoring each woman with a smile. "How about we go meet Shen for our daily Dhylaan session? I believe he is waiting for me,"

"Uh, you know, actually, I think I was supposed to meet Bow for lunch," Glimmer said with a weak laugh. Catra's dirty look instantly changed to pleading; Glimmer knew her friend dreaded the thought of being alone with Viraj and Shen. The upcoming situation was bound to be awkward.

Glimmer only shrugged, mouthing the words *sorry* to Catra as she lifted her Star Stone staff and teleported away.

* * *

Shen chuckled as he watched Melog and Battle Cat frolic through the flowers that dotted the small glen tucked away between two massive Jacarandra trees. This was where Viraj would take him for their Dhylaan sessions; it was beautiful and quiet, a perfect place to be alone or spend time with someone special. For whatever reason, the two Ethyriels had been sticking close to him lately and had followed him here. Shen was very suspicious that they were keeping an eye on him.

"You know guys, I appreciate you keeping me company, but at some point, you will have to give me some alone time with Viraj," Shen called to them. Melog immediately mewled something back to him.

"Can you please translate, Battle Cat?" He asked with arms crossed.

"Melog said we can leave when Viraj gets here, but you will not be alone with him. Catra is coming," Battle Cat mewled back.

Shen thought on this, not really sure how he felt about that. It was so beautiful in this spot; the sides of the slight depression they were in seemed to enfold around him with the broad canopy spread out high above. The light through the dense branches of the Jacaranda's created luminous beams in which colorful insects gathered. The forest sounds were soft, with bird cries and hoots echoing in the distance.

Shen breathed in the air; it was intoxicating with its many scents and thick with the pheromones of the vast amount of life that surrounded him. As much as Shen liked being around Catra, the thought of being alone with her brother seemed much more enticing at that moment.

Am I… am I falling for Viraj? He thought tentatively but then shook his head. *No. You've just been so alone for so long. Viraj is filling a void, and you are just grasping for anything that feels good. Like you always do, idiot.*

This thought left his head as Viraj suddenly appeared over the crest of the glen, and a smile appeared on Shen's face. Catra appeared behind him, and Shen could not help noticing his friend seemed tense. Her ears drooped more than usual, and her usually lively tail seemed to drag on the ground behind her.

Huh, maybe training isn't going well, he thought as he went to embrace Viraj.

Catra's brother accepted his hug, and once again, Shen enjoyed the different sensations of Viraj's body; the soft and sleek fur of his face, the way the tuft behind his long ear tickled his nose and the feel of his body pressed so close to his. But there was something off about the way Viraj held him; it was a little wooden and awkward. Shen dismissed this as yet another result of Catra's lessons.

It must be hard to teach someone as strong-willed as Catra. I just need to be understanding of that, Shen thought as he kissed Viraj's cheek.

“I take it the Jaadoo suit training was rough today?” Shen asked jovially. “What’s the matter, Catra? Finally find something you’re not good at?”

Catra gave him a slight grin but did not respond with the usual retort, only glancing at her brother furtively.

“Cat-Tra did quite well today. My sister is picking up the way of the Jaadoo quickly; she just gets… frustrated with it. That is why I suggested she meditate with us,” Viraj said.

“That’s my Catra,” Shen said with a laugh. “Always quick to anger. But I’m sure she will get it. Catra always overcomes odds and ends up on top.”

Viraj glanced at his sister and then looked back at Shen quizzically.

“Yes, *your* Cat-Tra is quite amazing,” Viraj said simply.

“Okayyyy!” Catra said suddenly, clapping her hands. “How about some meditation? I *really* love me some meditation. How about it, boys?”

Shen looked at the two Madgēcot siblings, now noticing that both their tails were twitching rapidly with agitation.

What’s going on with these two?

“Yes, let’s begin. Shen, I’m sure you know how to assume the correct position. Why don’t you show *your* Cat-Tra how it’s done?” Viraj said as he kneeled on the ground.

Shen found himself frowning at Viraj, not sure he liked the tone in his voice.

“Sure, but aren’t you pretty much doing it?” Shen said as he assumed the same position facing Viraj.

“It’s okay! I got it!” Catra said, placing herself next to Shen and facing her brother.

Viraj nodded curtly to them both and closed his eyes.

“Now, close your eyes and focus on your breathing. Then, concentrate on your body, starting with the very tips of your tails. Try to still the movement there and cease its movement.”

“This is new,” Shen said quietly. “You usually tell me to focus on my toes.”

“Yes, well, this is first and foremost a Madgēcot calming technique. The Dhylaan did not have outsiders in mind when it was developed,” Viraj said.

Shen felt a cold jolt in his chest at Viraj’s use of the word *outsider*; he did not like how it made him feel. Like he was suddenly not welcome.

“Okay, calming my tail—got it,” Catra mumbled next to Shen.

“Now, focus on your ears, release the strain there, take the weight of emotion off them. Allow them to rise towards the sky.” Viraj continued.

Shen peeked at Catra next two him, seeing her long black ears slowly extend up until they were two points sticking up in the air. Once again, Shen had the feeling he was being excluded from the Dhylaan. He remembered that Viraj had tailored it to fit Shen whenever he had done this with him before. But for some reason, Viraj was no longer even trying to make an attempt now.

Did I do something to make him mad? Shen thought as he peered at Viraj, as if the answer was going to be written on his handsome face. But it was written on his body; Viraj spoke of calming the tail and releasing the ears, but it did not look like he was listening to his own instructions. He had composed most of his tail, except for the tip, which fluttered back and forth. Viraj’s ears were upright

and perked, but they twitched endlessly as if a pest were aggravating them.

"Now, take a deep breath in. As you release it, let go of negative emotions." Viraj said as he took a deep breath.

Shen did as he was told, eager to be a part of the Dhylaan now that it was no longer focused on Madgēcot body parts. Viraj continued the instruction, taking a deep breath and naming a negative emotion as he expelled air.

"Breath in—release fear. Breath in—release jealousy. Breath in—release hatred. Breath in—release secrets. Some of us here have quite a few of those, so it may take a few breaths."

"*Okay!*" Catra shouted as she jumped up. "I can't take it anymore; I'm leaving!"

"Catra! Wait!" Viraj said as he got up to stop her.

"Nope! You two need to talk. Alone." Catra said, shaking her head fervently. "Melog! I need a ride back to Raajadhaanee. Battle Cat? I suggest you come with us; you *don't* want to be here for *this.* Trust me."

Viraj and Shen watched Catra as she hopped on her friend's back and rode away. Battle Cat looked at Shen with a forlorn expression, not wanting to leave him alone.

"I think Catra is right, buddy," Shen said with a small smile. "You should go with them."

Battle Cat gave a slight nod before bounding after Melog and Catra, leaving Shen alone with Viraj. Catra's brother was turned away from him, looking up into the leafy canopy with his arms crossed and tail making long sweeps behind him. Shen had a creeping sensation that he knew what this was about as he tentatively moved closer to the obviously angry Madgēcot. He was surprised by how nervous he felt approaching Viraj, imaging that if he touched him, Viraj would spin around and slash him with his

black claws. Shen pushed this foolish thought from his mind as he laid a hand on Viraj's shoulder.

"Viraj? What's going on?" Shen asked gently.

"Really, Shen? I know we have only been together a short time, but I'm sure you figured out what this could be by now." Viraj said, finally turning and pinning Shen with his eyes.

"Are you in love with my sister?"

Shen let out a sigh, a long deep sigh.

"Yes… maybe. I don't know anymore, really," Shen answered.

"How can you not know something like that, Shen?" Viraj replied, irritation in his voice once again.

"Viraj, I have a lot of… turmoil inside me," Shen said, making a circling motion in front of his chest. "It gets hard to see things clearly sometimes. I know at one point, yes, I was in love with Catra, but it's not like poof, that love is suddenly gone. I mean, even before Catra, I loved another person,"

"Yes, you told me about him. Shen'Dara was his name," Viraj said.

"Yes, Shen'Dara," Shen said, nodding. "He was my first love, but he is gone now. I know I still love him, even as I fell in love with Catra. I have a lot of capacity for love, Viraj. Why does it matter if I am in love with Catra?"

"Because of this, Shen!" Viraj exclaimed, waving his hand over his face. "Because Catra is my twin sister, she looks like me! It makes me wonder—are you just with me because it is the closest you will ever get to having Catra?"

Shen shook his head immediately and vehemently.

"No, Viraj! Yes, when I first met you, I saw Catra in you. But now I only see Viraj! I mean, you two have some similarities but are

very different,”

“How are we different?” Viraj said, crossing his arms again.

Shen smiled. “For one thing, Catra is closed off emotionally: you’re not. You are very open-hearted and kind—two qualities that I treasure. Where I grew up, they were in short supply, so I appreciate them when I find them in someone.”

Doubt crossed Viraj’s heterochromatic eyes as he looked away.

“That’s all well and good, but I don’t know, Shen; I will be honest with you, I see much empathy and kindness in you, but there is also….” Viraj said, trailing off as he searched for the right words.

“Darkness in me?” Shen offered.

Viraj shook his head. “No, not that. It’s not evil, I sense. There is so much pain in you, Shen; I am not used to it. I’m sorry. I feel for what you went through in life, Shen, and I want to help, but I’m not sure us being intimate is a good idea.”

“Why?” Shen said, hating himself for how desperate he sounded. But he could not help it; the sudden spike of anxiety he felt at the notion of Viraj pushing him away was so soul-crushingly painful. Shen realized then that he had come to depend on Viraj’s affections and desperately sought them out.

“Shen, you’ve developed very unhealthy ways of managing your sadness. This anger I feel inside you… it’s not good for you. It’s also not good for me. Madgēcots already struggle with anger, and we each learn to balance ourselves so we do not affect others.”

Shen’s heart raced as he fought against the panic. He felt it then —the call. The bright red light in the approaching storm of misery acted as a beacon to safety. But it was a lie, and Shen knew it to be false.

“Please, Viraj. I mean, you are helping me, aren’t you? I am trying as hard as I can to… be better,” Shen said, the words coming out

slowly as if he were straining against an obstacle.

Viraj smiled as he nodded. “Yes, you are trying, Shen. You have come quite—wait, are you okay?”

Concern appeared on Viraj’s face as he placed one hand on Shen’s shoulder and the other on his chest, activating the heart rune.

“Your heart is racing,” Viraj said, eyes wide.

Shen ignored Viraj’s words as he caressed a hand up one of his long black ears, running his fingers along the fuzzy edge and then into his stone-gray mane. Viraj’s leaned his head into Shen’s hand, a crackling thrum beginning in his chest.

“Is it all bad being with me, Viraj? Is there anything you like?”

Viraj’s eyes suddenly softened, and he took Shen’s hand from his hair and gently rubbed it against his soft cheek.

“Yes,” Viraj purred with eyes closed. “There is so much to like about you, Shen,”

Viraj pulled Shen down as he lay back in a bed of flowers that were nestled amongst soft, downy moss. He was purring so very hard now as he gazed with heterochromatic eyes at Shen, who could not help but lean in for a kiss. As their lips met, Viraj stroked black claws down the sides of Shen’s face; they tickled him gently and felt wonderful. Shen suddenly laughed.

“What’s so funny?” Viraj said suspiciously.

“I was just thinking about how I thought you would turn around and slash me with your claws before,” Shen said sheepishly.

“And this is funny to you? I would never hurt you, Shen, never.” Viraj said with a frown.

“Yeah, I don’t know why I thought that… it must be anxiety or something,” Shen said, looking past Viraj with an unfocused look.

“I will help push those thoughts from your mind,” Viraj said. He waved a hand down his front and gave Shen a wide grin, exposing his upper fangs.

“You remember how to get this off me?” Viraj asked with a coy tilt of his head.

Shen’s grin was equally wide as he ran a finger down from Vriaj’s neckline.

“Huntana,” Shen said.

Nothing happened, and Viraj immediately cackled with laughter.

“Close!” He said with glee. “I guess you don’t want it that bad, huh, *He-Man?”*

Shen felt the blush as he fought to control the goofy look spreading across his face. He tried again, this time running his finger all the way down Viraj’s front and well past his belly button.

“*Hataana*,” Shen said in a whisper, and Viraj shut his eyes, letting out a small gasp.

“*Ahhhh, you got it that time,”* he said in a hush, the Jaadoo suit falling away from his body in pieces.

Chapter End Notes

Artwork of Catra done by Miledibuja on Instagram, Twitter, and Tumblr.

Genesis of Evil

Chapter Summary

Veth confronts Archon Lethe with the truth.

Glimmer learns how an old enemy came to be.

An opportunity to strike back arises.

"What can I do for you, My Child?"

Veth looked up from their kneeling position to the holographic representation of Archon Lethe's disembodied head. The leader of the Nephraeh looked calm and impassive, completely self-assured of their authority and unaware that things were quite different. But things were different; Veth had just returned from Despara's false mission to crush non-existent rebels and had come straight to the holographic transmission chamber. They were very eager to get answers for what they had just witnessed.

Veth wanted to scream at their supreme ruler, to condemn them for their lie. The Vetala were not simply manifestations of Lethe's power but were somehow Nephraeh who had been cursed to a mindless existence of feeding on other's empathy. Archon Lethe not only knew about this atrocity but had taken advantage of it by using the Vetala as shock troops against their enemies.

Even worse, they had used Nefeli this way.

Veth swallowed as they maintained eye contact with the one who, from their earliest memories, had been the ultimate representation of what was good and true. The basis for the ideal of perfection; The Light.

The Light is a lie!

With one eyebrow raised, Archon Lethe watched Veth slowly rise from kneeling to stand fully erect before them. Defiant.

“Ah, what is this, My Child?” Archon Lethe asked, the danger evident in their tone.

“Why didn’t you tell us the Vetala were actually Nephraeh?” Veth asked, their voice impassive.

Surprise flashed in Archon Lethe’s glowing eyes, but a look of utter contrition quickly suppressed this.

“How did you find out?”

“I saw Nefeli as one of the Vetala! It was undeniably them!” Veth said a little more passionately this time.

Archon Lethe ignored the tone in their Champion’s voice, turning to look away for a moment as they pursed their lips. Finally, they nodded.

“You and Nefeli were close, weren’t you? Perhaps you had become more than just friends before they died. Am I correct?” Archon Lethe asked smoothly.

Veth looked away, the accusation clear in their Archon’s words. *You did not ask for permission to be with Nefeli, and you have the nerve to question me.*

“I apologize for not asking permission to ma— to be with Nefeli, My Archon,” Veth said through clenched teeth. “But it just happened one night. It was a culmination of a life spent living and fighting by each other’s side, nothing more,”

Archon Lethe seemed to accept this as Veth inwardly cringed at the diminishment of what Nefeli meant to them. But now was not the time to expose their slip from The Light. They had to maintain the higher ground in this confrontation.

“M—my Archon, why did you not tell us the true nature of the Vetala? Why the fiction? This whole time I… *used* them in battle, I never knew I was using my own people,” Veth said, looking down at their hands forlornly.

“Would knowing the truth have made your role as Champion of the Nephraeh any easier?” Archon Lethe asked.

“No, it would—” Veth began to respond, but Archon Lethe interrupted with a wave of their hand.

“Well, there you have it, My Child! There is your answer! I did not tell you to protect you. To protect our people. Don’t forget; we are fighting to survive here. We need every asset at our disposal,”

“Asset?” Veth said incredulously.

Fury blazed in Archon Lethe’s eyes, and Veth was suddenly very happy to be millions of lightyears away from the ruler of the Nephraeh. But they still felt their displeasure, for Archon Lethe’s power was in their blood, and a heaviness suffused Veth’s body. A weighty domination pulled them to the ground, making their eyes lids droop, and their thoughts become sluggish. It was not an unpleasant feeling—as if they were falling asleep. But Veth knew this was not the case; they were dying.

“I see you have been lax in taking you Antithetical Philter, Veth. I cannot feel you as well as I should,” Archon Lethe said in a whisper.

Veth did not answer, for they could not move their mouth. They could feel that they were being held at the very threshold of death and were being shown the folly of standing up to Archon Lethe. But at that moment, Veth did not care. They would rather die than return to the lie that was their entire life.

“Did I ever tell you that I knew Horde Prime before he betrayed us all?” Archon Lethe asked, jolting Veth from their thoughts of death.

“Horde Prime was once a famed scientist named Mazdak Zeno. He was a genius in many fields, including genetics, as you might have guessed,” Archon Lethe said with a chuckle.

"When he rebelled against our Empire, it was the Nephraeh who stood foremost against his tyranny when all others wanted to bend a knee to him. It was *us* who held back his tide of darkness with nothing but our vaunted *empathy*. Do you know what it got us? *Damnation!*" Archon Lethe said with vehement rage.

"Only when our people had been ruined did the other members of The Empire deem it necessary to fight back against Horde Prime—but it was already too late for us! It was then that I realized what would befall us if the people of the galaxy knew what had happened to the Nephraeh. I decided to hide us away in our corner of the galaxy before we were labeled as monsters to be hunted—and I was right to do so!"

Veth continued to listen to Archon Lethe's tirade even though they already knew this story; it had been hammered into them at a young age.

"I created The Light to help guide our people, to keep us from ever becoming the martyrs again. But it was hard to be the only one to steer the course of *millions*; I needed help. I then learned how to imbue others with a fraction of my power so they could help me—that is how the Penumbra Ritual was born."

Through the fog of their suppression, Veth's mind focused on Archon Lethe's words; they had never heard of the creation of the ritual.

"This plan worked; my acolytes could fill in the gaps of my leadership, and everything appeared to be perfect. I learned this was not true when the first of my acolytes perished. I was horrified when they returned to me as a Vetala—neither living nor dead and cursed with a heightened desire to feed on compassion. Do you know how hard that was for me, Veth? *Do you?"*

Veth felt a sudden stabbing right in the center of their chest, and they cried out in anguish.

“That is a mere fraction of my grief for our people! To have us be brought so low by the treachery of Horde Prime only to then have no peace in death? It was too much! But I adjusted and persevered, limiting the number of individuals who partook in the Penumbral Ritual. Instead of many, there are now only the Gnosis, the Krypteia, and of course, the bearer of Zhe-La. I continued leading our people with the help of a chosen few, and when they fell, they served the Empyrean Empire as Vetala. It may not be appealing, but it is an honorable service.”

Veth suddenly felt their subjugation fade, but they stayed where they were, on their knees in front of Archon Lethe. They felt utterly helpless against the leader of the Nephraeh and completely hollowed out by the knowledge of what awaited them upon death —eternal servitude to a master with no pity. Veth was not eager to anger Archon Lethe more than they already had; they did not want to speed up the process of becoming a Vetala by being killed out of hand.

I need to bide my time and play the humble servant while I figure out what to do, Veth thought as they gazed up at the holographic image.

“I apologize if I angered you, My Archon. It was unworthy of me to question you,” they said finally.

Archon Lethe studied Veth’s face a moment longer before nodding, accepting their apology.

“Now, I want you to forget this business with the Vetala; I have a new task for you,”

Veth lowered their eyes and bowed their head. “Yes, My Archon. Whatever you desire.”

“Gnosis agents are in possession of artifacts that they recently acquired from Eternia, from Castle Grayskull actually. They cannot pass the Elysian blockade without being intercepted, so I need you and Despara to meet them on the planet Iohiri. You will not

be able to bring these artifacts to me directly; you will have the Vetala under your command open a Skotos Portal directly to me on Empyrea. I will have the rendezvous coordinates transmitted directly to you."

"May I ask what these artifacts are, My Archon?" Veth ventured.

Archon Lethe was silent for a moment before they finally spoke.

"They are powerful artifacts from the Dark Times. Treat them with the utmost care. That is all you need to know, Veth,"

"Yes, my Archon. Your will shall be done," they replied, realizing that Archon Lethe was no longer calling them 'My Child.'

Archon Lethe gave a curt nod before breaking the connection, leaving Veth reeling. They knew they could not bear serving Archon Lethe anymore. The conversation Veth just had with them convinced them of that. But they were unsure how they could betray someone who could control their body from lightyears away and kill them on a whim.

Who can I turn to if everything I know is a lie and the only person I trust is gone? Who has empathy enough to help one such as me?

Veth let a loud sigh as they realized who that person was, knowing they had no right to ask her for help. Especially after what they did to her.

Maybe Catra will help me—especially if there is some way to get Adora back. I just have to figure out what that is. Perhaps if I learn more about this strange Light I can summon… I think that may be the key…

* * *

01.2755.99

I believe I have made a huge discovery and just found the key to creating the Empire that Zzar and I envision for the galaxy. That key is non-other than Mazdak Zeno—genius scientist, inventor, and last living member of his race.

I was tasked with visiting Mazdak Zeno on his mausoleum planet of Hourdwold-1 by the League of Kalosyni. It was mostly a formal gesture by the people of the galaxy to check up on the poorest of poor souls, a man who had lost everything and worked tirelessly by himself to better the lives of others. Why they chose me for this task—I could only guess. Perhaps they felt that by seeing the beauty and radiance of the Nephraeh Champion, Mazdak Zeno could be convinced to leave his planet and join the living instead of residing with ghosts. But upon seeing the planet and what Mazdak Zeno had built there, I developed different plans for him.

As I approached Hourdwold-1 from space, I could see the massive, automated shipyard surrounding the word like a silver ring. There, Millions of ships were constructed simultaneously for the different societies of the galaxy. What they would end up using them for, I did not know. Perhaps foolish frivolities such as leisure or something as mundane as mass transport. I think those ideas are redundant and pointless with the mass use of portals, but such is the waste of our glorious intergalactic society.

I saw a different use for those shipyards, to manufacture a different kind of ship; warships that our future Empire could use to dominate those who would not fall into line. Mazdak Zeno could quickly fabricate a fleet for me in secret if only I could convince him.

As I entered the atmosphere of Hourdwold-1 and descended towards the place Mazdak Zeno resided, I saw evidence of a once-great society now repurposed for a new task. Vast roads and avenues had been turned into conveyor systems for fabrication material. Villages had been turned into storage yards, towns into sorting areas, and the cities for where the assembly took place. The whole of the planet had been turned into one big factory. Everything was constantly in motion, but there was no life, only

Mazdak Zeno's white robots standing in for his dead people. What I saw was the perfect representation of what I wanted for the galaxy—forward progression out of the bones of a once useless society. It was beautiful and wonderous.

I no longer deemed this trip a nuisance task and now was eager to meet the mastermind behind this planet of possibilities. I landed my ship outside his residence; it was a massive building built into the side of a mountain far from what had once been civilization. It was new construction, made after the fall of his people, and did not appear to be built with an eye for homey aesthetics or manufacture. It seemed to me like a hospital—or laboratory.

A figure wearing a white smock and pants approached my ship from the building, and I got my first close-up view of Mazdak Zeno.

I was not impressed.

Mazdak Zeno was a diminutive and shy man. He greeted me without having the nerve to look me in the eyes or the boldness to try and touch me in whatever form of greeting he was accustomed to. I played the part of the friendly and compassionate Nephraeh, taking the meek Mazdak Zeno into my arms for a warm hug. After releasing the sputtering man from my embrace, I took a closer look at him, trying to see the greatness I had seen in his work.

His species had not been known for their attractiveness; like the Nephraeh, they had white skin, white hair, and pointed ears. But where the Nephraeh's white skin and hair were lustrous, Mazdak Zeno's was dull and pasty. Our ears are long and elegant, whereas his people's were ragged-edged and appeared like the wings of some fleshy flying creature. I finally got a look at his eyes when he glanced furtively up at me; they were an emerald green color and slitted like a lizard's. I hid my disgust well and did not allow him to see how much I loathed to look upon him.

Mazdak Zeno brought me into the facility where he resided, and I saw at once my earlier assertion that this was a place of scientific research was correct. But this was not just any laboratory; it was a fane to the practice of genetics. I was taken past rows upon rows of glass cylinders, each housing a member of Mazdak Zeno's species in varying stages of growth. As he accompanied me, Mazdak Zeno explained that everything I had seen, from the automated shipyard to the planet-wide manufacturing plant, was simply a means to an end. I was now looking at his real endeavor —to revive his dead race through science.

I decided then I was completely wrong about this man; he was not looking boldly towards the future but stagnating in the past. Mazdak Zeno had great potential and could do amazing things; he just needed the right muse.

I think I will be staying here for a while.

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Things are not proceeding with my little project as smoothly as I would have liked.

Mazdak Zeno was delighted when I told him I would be staying with him—the ugly little man is quite smitten with me. I used this opportunity to insert myself into his day-to-day life and take an interest in his research. I will say here that this interest was not feigned; I was fascinated to learn what he knew about genetics. He was a true master in the field, and this was an opportunity for me to absorb something not many in the universe knew anything about.

I learned that Mazdak Zeno's work had been stymied for a long time. He had no problem creating clones of himself, but to create a brand-new person was beyond his capabilities. He just could not breach that barrier, and it was vexing him to no end. I saw his problem then; he was so focused on the science of his task that he overlooked what was plain. He needed to harness another resource in order to achieve what he wanted—he needed magic.

Mazdak Zeno rejected this out of hand, saying that he would never involve magic in his great work. I got the feeling he had a phobia or hatred of magic that must be connected to what happened to his people. I found this odd; he seemed to have no problem having me around, and I am half magical.

Mazdak Zeno's hypocrisy aside, I suggested a different course. Why not proceed with making clones of himself and just populate his world with those? From what we know of telepathy, he could create many clones with the telepathic gene woven into their genetics. Then, he could make a master clone body for himself and transfer his consciousness to it, thus being able to control the many clones.

I was rather pleased with my suggestion, but Mazdak Zeno was absolutely horrified. It was then I realized that I had let my 'mask' slip a little too far and simply retracted my statement as a joke in bad taste. Mazdak Zeno seemed to accept this and was put at ease.

The little fool simply had no idea who he was keeping company with.

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I have given up on Mazdak Zeno and have just left Hourdwold-1, but what I have left behind may bear wondrous fruit in the future.

After my ill-thought-out suggestion regarding his genetics research, I decided to switch my focus to the other potentials. I often broached the subject of turning his facilities towards more martial means, but I hit the same wall every time. Mazdak Zeno was a pacifist who refused to create anything resembling a weapon. He said he wanted to be responsible for creating life and not death.

What rubbish!

He held his ground on this subject even after I attempted to persuade him by saying he was protecting lives by building

weapons. He didn't want to hear it and said I was twisting the facts. I was surprised to realize that Mazdak Zeno was starting to become annoyed by my presence, and he seemed to want me elsewhere.

I couldn't believe it!

I decided then and there to play my last card, even though I was absolutely loathed to do so, and I attempted to seduce Mazdak Zeno. But what I failed to conceive of ended up happening, and my entire reality almost came crashing down when Mazdak Zeno rebuffed my advances.

I was utterly dumbfounded.

This little creature, who should be honored to be even in the presence of a Nephraeh, let alone the Nephraeh Champion, turned me down!

His ridiculous reasons for being faithful to his long-dead wife were ludicrous! I was completely offended and enraged by his idiot excuses that my disguise of beneficent Nephraeh fell, and Mazdak Zeno got to see the real Kishar. I'm not sure what happened next, but I think I tried to kill him. This might have been the case if not for the many robots he summoned to his defense.

After smashing what seemed like an endless supply of robots in my Zhe-La form, I finally got close enough to Mazdak Zeno to seize him. He cursed and spat at me, calling me names such as 'betrayer' and 'bearer of False Light." I ignored these foolish insults and was now calm enough to see a reason not to kill Mazdak Zeno. I had a better idea—which I should have done right from the start. I summoned my fangs and drained Mazdak Zeno of his empathy completely.

Oh my! He tasted so good! His compassion was a rare delicacy that had been allowed to soak in the sweet juices of despair and false hope. I savored it immensely, and I fled when I was done feasting upon him.

As I write these words aboard my ship, I wonder; what have I wrought? Will Mazdak Zeno awaken and simply go back to his pointless works? Or will he have a new goal in mind? Only time will tell, but I think I will look forward to seeing what Mazdak Zeno becomes.

Glimmer felt a hand on her shoulder, drawing her eyes away from Kishar's journal and into Bow's brown eyes. After a brief moment of confusion, Glimmer remembered they were both sitting in lounge chairs outside their room at the Guest House. They had decided to come out here and enjoy the warm morning light in peace and quiet together.

"Hey, is your beautiful face going to be stuck in that datapad all day, or are we going to do some more sightseeing? I have this feeling that things will start heating up again, and we will miss our chance," he said with a grin.

"Wha…?" Glimmer replied, not listening. Bow was immediately concerned.

"What's the matter? You look like you've seen a ghost?" He said, drawing closer to his wife in comfort.

"Bow… I'm not totally sure, but I think I just read how Horde Prime came to be. I mean, not how he was born or anything, but how he became such a horrible monster," Glimmer said faintly.

"Really? Did Kishar have something to do with it?" Bow asked.

Glimmer nodded.

"It makes me wonder; where did this all start? Kishar created Horde Prime, and Kishar was made the way they were by the device Razz gave them. Razz did that on purpose because she was evil, but at one point, she was good. Something happened to Zzar to make her evil—it keeps going on and on back in time. Where did it all begin?" Glimmer said, the despair plain in her voice.

“Easy now, easy. It’s okay, Glimmer, you’re getting too worked up over this,” Bow said, wrapping his wife up in a hug. “You are taking on too much responsibility with this. Don’t think about all that; it’s too much. Let’s just focus on the here and now. We can look past our current predicament when and if we are able. Small steps, babe. Small steps.”

Glimmer nodded and returned Bow’s embrace.

“Thanks, I needed that. Sometimes I just need to be reminded I’m not responsible for the entirety of Space and Time,” Glimmer said with a chuckle.

“DID SOMEONE SAY SPACE AND TIME!?” A familiar voice called from below their balcony.

Both Glimmer and Bow groaned as two prehensile ponytails grabbed the railing, and Entrapta hoisted herself up onto their balcony.

“Is your room under us, Entrapta?” Bow asked with a raised eyebrow.

“Nope. I was looking for you two. I forgot which room you were in and had been scaling the walls of this *fantastic* building and looking in all the windows. I saw some great stuff and collected lots of DATA!” Entrapta said, beaming with excitement.

“I can’t imagine how many complaints have been lodged with the Madgēcot attendant today.” Glimmer said with her hand on her forehead.

“Well, I’m sure the entire planet knew when Entrapta showed up a couple of days ago,” Bow added with a grin.

Entrapta continued to stare at her friends, confusion plain on her face.

“It’s okay, Entrapta, we’re just joking.” Glimmer said with a laugh. “So, what’s going on? Why were you looking for us?”

“Oh! Right!” Entrapta said, shaking herself. “Well, since the attack on Etheria and Eternia, I put together a device to track the energy signature of the Void Gem. Its range was limited at first, but I finally figured out a way to increase it dramatically!”

“And how did you do that?” Bow asked suspiciously.

“Don’t get bogged down by details!” Entrapta said, waving away at Bow with her ponytails. “Anyway… I am now tracking where the Void Gem is going.”

Glimmer immediately sat up. She had been waiting for any excuse to take action, and this sounded like her chance.

“It looked like it was headed straight for the Elysian system but then veered off towards a new set of coordinates. By my calculations, it is headed to a planet called Iohiri.”

“When is it getting there!?” Glimmer asked, jumping up and surprising Bow.

Entrapta pulled out a datapad and inspected it, her tongue sticking out as she studied the data.

“Hmm… by my calculations, it should be there tomorrow,” Entrapta said.

Glimmer immediately turned to Bow and grasped him by the arm.

“Get a hold of Catra and the others. Tell them to meet us at the Star Hunter headquarters. We need to act fast!”

* * *

Catra crept on tiptoes down the hall adjoining her room to her brother’s. She knew she shouldn’t be doing this, but Catra was a creature of curiosity, and she just had to know. After all, it involved two people she cared very deeply for, and not knowing was going to drive her crazy.

Well, dummy, who's to say they are even in there. Maybe Viraj and Shen fought and ended up sleeping alone in the forest somewhere, she thought as she whispered the command to open the door. Catra immediately smiled as she spotted the two of them on their sides on the bed; Shen was snuggled up against Viraj's back, his face pressed into the other's bushy mane of hair.

Looks like the lover boys made up, she thought as she began to tiptoe back the way she came. Catra felt warm in her chest at the thought that maybe Shen and Viraj would work out. Perhaps even one day, Shen would be her actual brother—which felt perfect to her.

"*CATRA!*" Bow's voice barked from the datapad at her hip, making Catra shriek in fright.

"Ca—Catra?" Shen's voice called as Catra retreated down the hall. She did not know why, but her face was on fire with embarrassment.

"*I'm here, Punchy!*" She whispered into the datapad. "*You know, when you contact someone on one of these things, it's probably not a good idea to just start yelling.*"

"Noted, Catra," Bow said, his voice serious. "We need you to grab Shen and Viraj and meet us at the Imaarat. Something important has come up,"

"What? What has come—" Catra started to say, but Bow cut the connection.

"What is it, Cat-Tra?" Viraj said with a yawn as he padded out of his room.

Catra glanced at her brother, not hearing his question over the worry that started to creep into her chest.

Is this about Despara? Am I going to have to face her already?

"Cat-Tra?" Viraj asked, placing a hand on her shoulder in concern.

Catra finally looked at her brother, shaking her head wryly when she saw he hadn't bothered putting his Jaadoo suit on.

"You know, I grew up in the Horde, and modesty wasn't a big concern. But the Horde has nothing on Madgēcots!" She said.

"What?" Viraj said with a shrug. "We can't always wear our Jaadoo suits. It's good to air out the fur every once in a while,"

Catra tilted her head and squinted at her brother; she just couldn't tell when he was joking.

"Go and get your boyfriend and put some clothes on. Something is going on, and we need to meet everyone at the Imaarat," she said.

At the mention of his order's headquarters, Viraj's long ears perked up, and he nodded. Catra listened as he went to retrieve Shen, her Madgēcot ears picking up her brother's words spoken softly.

"*Come, we need to go— OH! Ha, ha! No time for that!*"

Catra couldn't help smiling as she walked away down the hall, deciding to wait for them in the main living area. That good feeling changed as she, Viraj, and Shen made the journey down from the city of Raajadhaanee to the forest floor. Catra could not help remembering the last time she had made this trip with her brother; Adora had been with her then, and she remembered being so happy. It was the first and last time they had spoken of having children together, and the memory drove a spike of sadness through Catra's heart. As she thought that day, Catra realized how badly she wanted a family of her own. How would she have that now if Despara ruled her wife's body?

But looking at Viraj and Shen, plus thinking of her other friends, Catra realized she was building a family. She was pulling special people into her orbit and holding on to them tightly. A weave of love connected them all, and the bonds were strong—almost

unbreakable. Catra felt tears in her eyes and attempted to brush them away before her brother, and Shen saw them.

“Catra,” Shen said softly next to her. “It will be okay. I promise you that, as He-Man, I will do everything I can to get Adora back. You’re not alone,”

Catra sniffled and laughed brightly at this; there was no way she could hide her feelings from someone who knew her so well. She turned to Shen, surprising him with a beautiful smile.

“I know,” she said simply.

The three continued their journey down, finally making it to the forest floor and the stone path that led to the Imaarat. As before, there were Star Hunter guards at the front entrance, but Maira was not there among them. Instead, a male Madgēcot with orange fur with white stripes was in her place; he gave Shen a once-over and Catra a respectful nod. When he spotted Viraj, a wide toothy smile appeared on his face as his tail twitched rapidly.

“Hey, Viraj,” he called. “Have not seen you in a while. Whatever happened to our Dhylaan sessions together?”

“Kiaan! I have not forgotten them! I have just been… busy!” Viraj responded nervously.

As Shen passed Kiaan, the Madgēcot sniffed him, and his yellow eyes immediately widened.

“Ah, I see.” He said coolly. “Take care of yourself, Viraj,”

Catra sided up to her brother and nudged him with her shoulder.

“Why didn’t you just tell that dummy you’re with Shen now?” She said, surprised by how irritated she sounded.

Viraj shrugged, annoying Catra further. “I just don’t want to hurt his feelings, is all,” he said lamely.

Catra dismissed her brother's behavior and focused on the gathering in the main chamber. There were Star Hunters there, many of whom Catra recognized from her prolonged time on Elysia. Aadhya, the Pratham of the Star Hunters, was currently speaking with a representative of the Jaadoogar. Catra was not surprised to see Glimmer in the middle of the gathering; she knew her friend could not help inserting herself into Madgēcot business. Bow and Seahawk were also there, plus the newly arrived Entrapta, who was currently climbing up the stone walls of the Imaarat to inspect the archaic weapons perched in the portals above.

"Hsst!!! Hey! No! Get down from there!" One of the Madgēcots called to the inquisitive princess.

Catra chuckled as she made her way over to Aadhya, but before reaching the older woman, she felt Viraj grasp her bicep lightly.

"Now, Cat-Tra, remember. By wearing that Jaadoo suit, you are an honorary member of the Star Hunters. You must pay the Pratham the proper respect." He whispered in her ear.

"Yeah, yeah," she replied, brushing her brother's hand away.

Catra stopped before the Pratham and saluted in the Star Hunter fashion. Aadhya turned to her and smiled, returning the salute.

"Good to see you in a Jaadoo suit, Catra. It suits you," Aadhya said by way of greeting. "Although it seems incomplete. Your missing parts of the arms,"

"Nope. That's just the way I made it," Catra responded. "So, what's this meeting about, Pratham? Are we going to attack those dirty Nephraeh?"

Aadhya shook her head and pointed at Glimmer.

"I didn't call for this meeting; your friend did."

Catra snickered as she turned to Glimmer.

“Only you would have the nerve to come across the galaxy and boss the Madgēcots around, Sparkles,”

“Good, Catra is here. I think that is everyone,” Glimmer said as she turned to the room and raised her Star Stone staff.

“Everyone, can I have your attention, please?” Glimmer said, projecting her voice with magic.

The gathered Madgēcots turned curious eyes and perked ears towards the Queen of Etheria as the room quieted down.

“Entrapta!” Glimmer shouted up at her fellow princess. “*Get down here!*”

Entrapta dropped down from her inspection of the ancient Madgēcot weapons and landed on her extended ponytails, making nearby Madgēcots jump and hiss in surprise.

“Sorry! Sorry! Did I miss the presentation?” Entrapta asked.

Glimmer gave her a cool expression as she crossed her arms over her chest.

“No, Entrapta, you’re the one giving it, remember?”

“Ohh… that’s right…” Entrapta said.

She looked wide-eyed at all the individuals watching her before finally puffing herself up.

“Alright! So! As many of you know, an object of significance was recently taken from Etheria. Most likely by agents of your enemy, the Nephraeh,”

“*Object of significance?* I think you may be understating the importance of one of the Staves of Power, Etherian,” a nearby Madgēcot said.

“Don’t interrupt!!!” Entrapta shouted back. “Anyway, I have tracked the power signature of *The Void Gem.* It is currently on its way to the nearby planet of Iohiri and will be there tomorrow.”

“Why is it going there?” Someone asked.

“We believe that Archon Lethe does not want the Void Gem brought into Elysian territory,” Glimmer spoke up. “Whoever stole the Void Gem is heading to Iohiri to rendezvous with persons who can get it safely to Empyrea. Most likely Zhe-La or Despara. Or both.”

Murmurs broke out amongst the assembly at the mention of the two deadly warriors.

“So? We go there and stop them from getting what they want,” Catra said simply.

Murmurs of agreement were heard throughout the hall at Catra’s bold words.

“It should be a small team that intercepts the Void Gem; we don’t want to scare away the Empyrean Agents with a fleet of ships. Whoever goes should also be strong enough to face two Champions of Grayskull.” Aadhya added.

“We have one Champion, plus we can bring as many Star Hunters as Darla can fit; they won’t stand a chance!” Catra said enthusiastically.

Aadhya was suddenly interested at the mention of He-Man and spoke up.

“Shen, how are you doing with controlling the influence of the Abominable Power? Are you ready for this mission?

Catra saw her brother take Shen’s hand, giving it a reassuring squeeze. Shen responded as he gazed at her brother.

“Yes, Pratham. You can count on me.”

Some good-natured chuckles were heard throughout the hall as the Madgēcots discerned the nature of Shen's cure. Aadhya nodded, giving her blessing to the mission and her permission to the Etherians to lead her people into battle.

Glimmer walked over to Catra, placing both hands on her shoulders to gaze into her heterochromatic eyes.

"You sure you're ready for this, Catra? Are you ready to face Despara again?"

Catra did not answer right away. She searched inside herself, looking for the answer. Catra had been preparing herself as best she could, learning the ways of her people to become stronger and mentally fit to face Despara again. It made her feel more confident to feel the Jaadoo suit on her body and to know she had over a hundred magical cantrips at her disposal. Catra could also now fight without being overwhelmed by emotions, which, when facing Despara, could get her killed.

Is this it? Am I ready? She asked herself. But she already knew the answer.

Catra put her hands over Glimmer's and gave her friend a confident smile.

"Let's do this, Sparkles," she said.

Basilica of the Obscene

Chapter Summary

> Traveling to the planet Iohiri, Catra, Shen, and Glimmer attempt to stop the enemy from acquiring a powerful artifact.
>
> Catra must face Despara again.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The eerie drone of the night wind unnerved Catra; it sounded like a low moan of pain as it moved over the fractured waste, and she flattened her long black ears to dampen the noise. Catra had only been on the planet Iohiri for an hour, and already she wanted to be far away from it. There was something about the rocky terrain that bothered her; it was warped and ruined, as if this was not its natural state, but one inflicted upon it. Catra was reminded of her visit to the planet Krytis and the feeling that she was in a place where a great tragedy occurred.

Glancing at the rest of the Madgēcots in the group, she was relieved to see that she was not the only one who felt this way. Every single one of her people appeared agitated; some even had nervously twitching bushy tails. Catra's friends from Etheria were also affected; Seahawk attempted to cover his nervousness by whistling a sea chanty while Bow and Glimmer held each other's hand in comfort. Shen was sticking close to Viraj's side while Entrapta hummed as she peered over the edge of a nearby chasm. These large cracks in the ground dotted the entire landscape of Iohiri; it was as if the whole planet was slowly breaking apart. Catra veered over to Entrapta's side, careful not to startle her friend and cause her to fall in.

"Did anyone ever tell you about curiosity and the cat?" Catra said with a grin.

Entrapta did not turn her head to look at Catra as she responded.

"Yes—*curiosity killed the cat*. It's an old proverb about the dangers of unnecessary experimentation or exploration. I heard it MANY times, in fact." She said as she stood up, looking at Catra with raised eyebrows. "Have YOU heard the rejoinder: *but satisfaction brought it back*?

Catra laughed at this. "No! I haven't, but I like it."

Catra peeked over the ledge and down into the wide crevasse in the ground. What she saw down there did nothing to assuage her earlier fear; silver mist swirled between the stone walls, appearing as a watery pool. Deep within its depths, flashing motes of light could be seen—like lightning within distant clouds.

"They say these pits lead to other places, although no one has dared venture in to verify this," Viraj said suddenly at Catra's shoulder, making her jump.

"Don't sneak up on me like that!" She said, swatting at her brother.

"What do you mean by other places, Viraj?" Shen asked as he joined them.

Viraj shrugged noncommittally.

"I don't know. There is a lot of rumor and myth surrounding this planet. It was once a bastion for the powers of evil and a great battle was fought here at the end of the Dark Times. That is why it appears as it does—like the shell of a world. The forces released here during that struggle have left these marks; they are not just holes in the planet, but in reality itself. If you fall in, who knows where you could end up?"

Catra shivered at the thought, and Entrapta leaned further over the edge.

“FAAAAACINNAAAATINGGGG…” she whispered as Catra tugged her back.

The four rejoined the rest of the group and continued their journey through the haunted landscape. Soon mountains were seen over the horizon; they jutted up sharply, reminding Catra of sharp teeth. As the group got closer, a bizarre fortification nestled at the base of the range of peaks appeared; it was black and glistened like obsidian under the billions of glittering stars shining above. The bastion was vaguely rectangular in shape, with four dagger-like towers marking each of the four corners. Its surface was strange, appearing pitted, as if it were not entirely solid but porous, like coral. So far, no door could be seen anywhere outside the structure.

“Okay,” Glimmer said, indicating that the group should stop. “Just as we planned: Catra and Melog patrol the outside for stragglers while the rest of us head in under Battle Cat’s cloaking ability. Once inside, if we don’t find anything right away, we split into two groups; I will lead one, while Shen leads the other.”

Catra hated splitting up the group; this was when everything went wrong in every bad story she read. But since they only knew the relative position of the Void Gem, they had to do it this way. She took some comfort in knowing that everyone else was in a larger group, while only she had to be the one that went by herself.

A nudge at her hip drew her attention down, and she saw Melog peering up at her with glowing blue eyes.

“*You’re not alone, Catra,*” they mewled at her.

Catra smiled thankfully at her friend and stroked them gently on the head.

“I’m not liking the looks of where everyone is going, Melog. If there was anywhere that looked pure evil, it’s that place,” she said.

"*My people call it the Basilica of the Obscene, but it had another name used by the ones who built it, which I won't repeat,*" Melog said.

Catra felt her tail slowly bush up at Melog's words, and she hugged herself.

"*Basilica of the Obscene?* Great, just great," Catra said sarcastically.

Her earlier comfort in knowing her friends were together immediately vanished.

* * *

Zhe-La/Veth ran their fingertips over the surface of the strange wall, the ends of their claws making sharp sounds as they scraped over the chaotic honeycomb of openings. The entire structure was constructed of this material, making it permeable to the endless wind outside. The sum of the enormous draft through the building created a disconcerting tone that almost sounded like music, and Zhe-La/Veth's long ears strained as they tried to catch the tune. But as they were about to ascertain the harmony—horror filled them—and they blocked it out of their mind.

Zhe-La/Veth studied the expansive space they occupied; it was empty of any furnishings, just bare black walls. They knew there were openings to other areas but could not spot them at the moment; only when they were at the correct angle could they see an outline of a door which then could be pushed open on unseen hinges.

"This place is magnificent. Isn't it, Veth?" Despara said nearby.

Zhe-La/Veth bit back their initial reply and nodded at their fellow Champion. They hated this place with every part of their being, and they knew why; they had stopped taking the Antithetical Philter the day they had confronted Archon Lethe. They were changing inside and starting to feel much different. New feelings and sensations were emerging, both thrilling and scaring Zhe-

La/Veth as they intensified over time. They felt like they were becoming a whole new person.

“What do you think the people who created this place did here?” Despara asked, wonder in her voice.

“Not even you would want to know that, Despara. Trust me,” Zhe-La/Veth answered, the disgust plain in their voice.

Zhe-La/Veth remembered the history lessons Archon Lethe had given them; the leader of the Nephraeh was steeped in the history of the galaxy and had taught them much. Not many were left who remembered the whole story—the fall into the Dark Times and the rise back into the light. The coming of the seven Champions and the seven Staves of Power to fight the Abominable Powers.

But given their extensive education, Zhe-La/Veth found it odd that they had never heard of the bearer of Zhe-La being able to summon purifying Light—for that was what it was, they realized. Then again, perhaps it made sense Archon Lethe never told them; it is probably a weapon that could be used against them.

“Do you sense your people, Veth? I do not have your connection to them,” Despara asked, drawing Zhe-La/Veth out of their thoughts.

“They are close, very close. I’m sure they sense me and with reveal themselves soon.” Zhe-La/Veth answered.

“Shouldn’t you summon the Vetala then?” Despara continued, a little annoyed.

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head. “The Vetala won’t be joining us, Despara. They won’t be joining us ever again,”

Despara grabbed Zhe-La/Veth roughly by the shoulder as she confronted them.

“What do you mean, Nephraeh? What did you do?”

Zhe-La/Veth mildly brushed her hand away as they smiled back at her, remembering how they had released the Vetala from their horrible bondage the night before. They had summoned the Vetala in their private room in the Relativity Forge; the creatures had appeared to Veth, hungry and confused, but when they saw the look on Veth's face, the Vetala kneeled before them, clutching and mewling at their legs. Veth had known they were not begging for mercy but pleading for sweet release from their cursed existence, and they had given it to them. One at a time, Veth had released the souls of the Nephraeh to the great beyond.

"I righted a terrible wrong, Despara. It is the first of many wrongs I plan to fix." They said to Despara, giving her a knowing look.

"What's that supposed to mean?" She said with disgust, backing away from the other Champion.

Zhe-La/Veth strode to her and clutched her hands in their clawed gauntlets.

"You're not supposed to be like this, Despara!" They cried.

Despara stared at Zhe-La/Veth, disbelief and anger mixed on her face as she shook her head.

"No—" she started to say, but Zhe-La/Veth interrupted her.

"Your real name is Adora! You're married to a beautiful Madgēcot named Catra! It's all true!" Zhe-La/Veth implored.

"NOOO!!!" Despara shrieked, pushing the other Champion away as she summoned her sword. She swung at them sideways, and Zhe-La/Veth quickly jumped back. Despara held her ground as she panted, not from exertion but from the wealth of emotions roiling through her body.

"I want you out of my sight, Veth—before I kill you," she growled. "Go outside and patrol the grounds. I will find the Gnosis without needing your connection to them."

Zhe-La/Veth held their hands up as they backed away from Despara, not wanting to anger her further. They still were unsure how they would give her memories and empathy back and did not want to get into a fight in which either could be needlessly hurt.

Finding the hidden door, Zhe-La/Veth exited the chamber and continued down the long hall back outside. They did not plan on leaving the building for long, wanting Despara to have just enough time to cool down.

Relief filled Zhe-La/Veth as they pushed the oval-shaped double doors open and left the horrible interior of the dread fortress. Briefly looking about, they spotted one of the large chasms that dotted the landscape and walked over to it, curious to see what was inside. They had heard all the rumors regarding them—that they were gateways to other realities, other dimensions. Looking down into swirling mists and strange lights, they believed it.

A tingling up Zhe-La/Veth's spine made them suddenly look around. They instantly knew someone was watching them and summoned their black sword.

"Come out! I know you're there!" They shouted.

A figure riding atop a feline creature suddenly materialized and leaped at Zhe-La/Veth—they brought their sword up, barely blocking a slashing claw strike. The beast landed nearby, and Zhe-La/Veth instantly recognized it as an Ethyreal—like the one that accompanied He-Man. As the rider dismounted to face them, there was no mistaking her cinnamon-colored fur and heterochromatic eyes.

"Catra!" Zhe-La/Veth exclaimed.

"Hey, Veth. You and I have a score to settle," Catra growled.

* * *

He-Man/Shen crept through the long dark corridor; he was surprisingly stealthy for someone of his enhanced bulk. The

twelve Madgēcots in his wake were quieter still, and together, they searched for signs of the enemy in the ominous fortress. They had since ascertained the method of finding the strange doors; the keen Madgēcot eyes quickly spot the openings' faint outlines.

Viraj gently grasped He-Man/Shen's wrist, pointing when they had found another door, and He-Man/Shen nodded. He was about to push the door open when a different Star Hunter stopped him; she shook her head, pointing to one of her long ears to indicate that she heard something. He-Man/Shen turned to Battle Cat, directing them telepathically to cloak the entire group with their magic. Once concealed, they entered the adjacent chamber; He-Man/Shen immediately noticed that it was much larger than any other they had encountered. He saw wide concave basins cut into the black floor, which, unlike the walls and ceiling, was smooth and solid. Channels connected the basins which eventually led to a small hole in the middle of the room. The sight gave He-Man/Shen chills, making him think of a similar sight deep beneath his father's palace on Shen'Dar-oom. He jumped when he felt an arm around his waist; looking down, He-Man/Shen saw the outline of Viraj gazing up at him, concern in his eyes. Not wanting to speak needlessly, He-Man/Shen smiled in gratitude as he placed his larger hand over the Viraj's. He felt safe with Viraj around, not physically safe, but safe from the dread and anxiety of his mind.

There is someone here, Shen. Beware! Battle Cat said in his mind.

He-Man/Shen saw every Madgēcot Star Hunter tense as a barely perceptible haze was seen on the opposite side of the room. Squinting as he summoned the power of He-Man, He-Man/Shen was able to pierce through the glamour of the hidden figures and see seven lithe bodies huddled around two box-like shapes. They appeared to be waiting for someone, for they were absolutely still.

He-Man/Shen turned to the Madgēcots, indicating through hand signals that they should wait; he wanted to make sure they were not ambushed by Zhe-La or Despara when they attempted to seize the Void Gem.

His caution was rewarded when a bulky black-armored figure appeared through an opening on the other side of the room.

“Hello?” Despara called. “Are you sneaky Nephraeh in here?”

He-Man/Shen felt immense sadness when he heard Adora in Despara’s cruel voice, but he maintained his cool. This almost failed him as he watched Despara start to walk in his direction, but before she was halfway to them, the Gnosis operatives revealed themselves.

“Despara!” One of their number called in a strange whispery voice.

Despara immediately veered her course and hurried over to the group as He-Man/Shen heard twelve Madgēcots sighing in relief.

“About time! I’ve been looking all over this place for you!” Despara complained as she approached the Gnosis.

“Where are the Vetala?” A different Gnosis Operative asked. “We must get these to Archon Lethe immediately!”

Despara shook her head at them. “Your glorious Champion destroyed the Vetala. We must get these back to Empyrea the hard way.”

The Nephraeh looked at each other, appearing unsure of Despara’s response.

“Where is Zhe-La? Why are they not here? We want to see them,” one of them said as the rest formed up protectively around the two packages.

“Are you serious? How about I kill you all and take the Archon’s prize back to them myself?” Despara said threateningly. Every member of the Gnosis hissed, raising their hands in the direction of the fallen She-Ra as the indigo light of Oblivion appeared in their palms.

"Everything we have heard of you is correct, Despara. You're a vicious brute who has no place in the Empyrean Empire! Just try and take these from us, and I promise you will regret it!"

Despara growled in annoyance as she dismissed her sword.

"Fine! I will find Veth and bring them here, but I swear you all will pay for this insolence!" She snapped as she turned and headed in the direction she originally came from. Once she was gone, He-Man/Shen nodded to his Madgēcot companions, and they crept across the room under the cover of Battle Cat's invisibility magic.

"I really don't like that woman. I don't understand why Archon Lethe puts up with her," one of the Nephraeh complained.

"I agree with you, Philotas. I plan on lodging a formal—"

"Now, Battle Cat!" He-Man/Shen cried.

Every member of the Gnosis spun in the direction of the appearing enemies, raising their hands once more to defend their prize to the death if necessary. They hurled bolts of indigo fire out from their palms—which were easily dodged by the Madgēcots and deflected by He-Man/Shen's sword.

In unison, the Star Hunters flung their Chakra Block cantrips at the Nephraeh; rainbow sparks exploded amongst the Nephraeh, disconnecting them from their offensive magic, and the two sides collided into a melee.

He-Man/Shen dismissed his sword, not needing it in this confrontation, and instead relied on the fighting skills taught to him by Catra. He blocked a downward claw slice on his silver gauntlet, kicking the Nephraeh in the chest and sending them cartwheeling back. Another Gnosis Operative tried to strike him with a leaping kick to the face—he caught the slender Nephraeh in mid-air and delivered a hand chop to the back of their head, knocking them out cold. He-Man/Shen placed the unconscious enemy on the ground and turned to engage another one.

He-Man/Shen felt good—fantastic in fact—he felt totally in control of himself and his emotions. He still felt the Eye of Hate trying to influence him, but it was a slight tickle instead of a pull at the back of his mind. He-Man/Shen felt free and wanted to laugh at the Abominable Power's attempts to seize him from so far away; it seemed so insignificant at that moment.

The Nephraeh finally retreated before the onslaught; picking up their wounded, they fled through the nearest exit.

"Let them go!" Viraj said, holding up his hands towards his fellow Madgēcots. "Let's collect what we came here for and get out of here before Despara gets back!"

He-Man/Shen approached the two objects the Gnosis Operatives had left; both appeared as lidded boxes with clasps holding them closed. But that was where their similarities ended, for their construction was completely different; one was metallic, shiny, and new. The other was wooden and worn, appearing as if it was ancient.

"Let's make sure this isn't some trick," Viraj said as he opened the metallic box. Inside was a shorn black rod with a sizable crystal attached at the end; it was a deep crimson and dark motes of un-light danced within its structure.

"That's definitely the Void Gem," Viraj said with wonder.

"I thought Entrapta said that was all they had stolen?" He-Man/Shen said as he lifted the wooden box in one hand.

"These Nephraeh are sneaky, He-Man. Be careful with that," one of the other Star Hunters said.

He-Man/Shen shrugged and unfastened the clasps holding the lid closed, opening the ancient box. He immediately regretted it.

Inside was a fist-sized stone sitting upon a luxurious cushion. Like the Void gem, it was red in color, but unlike the crimson of the Ultimate Power, this object was the color of rich blood and flared

from within with a fell light. He-Man/Shen immediately noticed that this light pulsed steadily, entirely in time with his heartbeat.

The Eye of Hate.

At that moment, He-Man/Shen realized what a fool he was for thinking that he had escaped this fate; the Abominable Power had only let him think he was safe in order to spring this trap. Turning to Viraj, He-Man/Shen saw the horror on his cinnamon face as he also realized their mistake.

"Shen! Fight it!!!" Viraj cried.

But it was already too late for He-Man/Shen—he was already being drawn into the Eye of Hate's embrace. He-Man/Shen stood stiff as a board with eyes wide and mouth agape; he was no longer aware of anything around him, only seeing what was in his mind's eye. In that abstract reality, He-Man/Shen was drawn down a long, relentless tunnel, with only a singular conclusion; a red pulsing mass of wrath, burning with an epiphany of murder.

He-Man/Shen saw everything became red—then everything went black.

* * *

A low, threatening growl escaped Catra's throat as she glared at the person responsible for turning her wife into Despara. Zhe-La/Veth has since overcome their shock of Catra's surprise attack and studied her; she was surprised to see a warm smile spread over their lips.

"I see you are wearing a Jaadoo suit now, Catra," they said admiringly. "It looks good on you,"

Catra screamed with rage and lunged at Zhe-La/Veth. She tugged the cantrip for Jade Fire from her hip and threw it at Zhe-La/Veth with all her might. They brought their black sword up in time to deflect the magic but were not quick enough to block the downward slash Catra delivered as she leaped over their head.

Zhe-La/Veth cried out in pain, bringing a hand up to their wounded cheek as glowing indigo blood dripped down their chin. Melog followed their friend's attack by leaping into the Empyrean Champion's chest, knocking them back into the dirt. Before Zhe-La/Veth could rise, Catra was upon them, slashing wildly down at them with furious claws. They sparked off of Zhe-La/Veth's black gauntlets, giving the Nephraeh Champion enough time to rise to their feet and back away from their attacker.

"Enough, Catra! Enough! I surrender!" Zhe-La/Veth said as they held their hands up.

"What!?" Catra yelled. "No way, Veth. No more tricks."

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head vehemently.

"No tricks, Catra! I swear!" Zhe-La/Veth said as they suddenly transitioned out of their Champion state.

Catra and Melog approached Veth threateningly as they backed away slowly, only stopping when they saw they were at the edge of the nearby chasm. Catra seized Veth by their white jacket, bringing them close as she bared her sharp fangs directly in their face. Their expression remained neutral as she glanced down, her eyes briefly drawn to where their jacket parted before dragging her gaze back to their glittering silver eyes. Catra had never been this close to Veth before, and she could not help but feel stimulated by their proximity. She noticed changes in Veth since the last time she had seen them; subtle differences, but they were there. The haughty arrogance and cold demeanor were gone, replaced by an openness to their face and body language she could not place a finger on. There was also a faint luster to their lilac skin; it was lovely, and Catra's pupils dilated as she desired to touch it. Catra shook these thoughts from her head and refocused on her anger; she gently nudged Veth towards the edge of the cliff.

"Why shouldn't I just throw you over this edge and be done with you, liar?" Catra snarled.

“You could do that, Catra, and I would deserve it. But then I would not be able to help you get Adora back,” they said simply.

Catra shook them angrily.

“What did I say about lies? Also, how dare you say her name to me! You don’t deserve even to utter my wife’s name!” Catra cried.

Veth nodded. “I know, Catra. I don’t. I have no right to ask for your trust but believe me, things are different now! I’m different now! I no longer what to serve the Archon’s Light!”

Catra squinted her eyes at Veth, suspicious. “Why Veth? What’s made you change your mind?”

Veth glanced downward as their face fell, and Catra immediately recognized the look from when Nefeli died.

“Nefeli changed me,” Veth said quietly.

Catra released Veth’s jacket and backed away from them slightly, giving them room but not enough to escape her.

“Nefeli and I were in love, Catra,” Veth said.

Catra immediately let out a bark of laughter and crossed her arms as her tail twitched rapidly behind her.

“You expect me to believe this nonsense?” She said with a smirk.

“Nefeli and I grew up in the Empyrean Empire; it was a hard childhood, and it pushed us closer together. That bond only strengthened when we fought by each other’s side as Zhe-La and Krypteia—it was only very recently when we discovered we both had romantic feelings for one another.”

Catra was silent as she listened; Veth’s story was a mirror of what she and Adora had gone through.

"That love was cut short when you and the Madgēcots attacked the Relativity Forge, and that… *monster* He-Man killed Nefeli!"

Catra's eyes widened slightly at the vehemence in Veth's voice.

"That wasn't Shen's fault, Veth. That was—" Catra began before she was cut off.

"It's not relevant, not anymore. It's in the past." Veth said, holding up their hands. "What matters is that after Nefeli's death, I started having my doubts. Doubts about Archon Lethe and their Light. It wasn't until I had Archon Lethe's lies exposed did I finally make my decision,"

Catra's ears lowered in horror as she listened to Veth recount their story of assaulting the false rebel stronghold on Enos and how the entire attack was based on the lies of Despara. Finally, the discovery of Nefeli's fate as a Vetala and the confrontation with Archon Lethe. Cara's heart raced as she tried to process it all.

At first, she was ready to dismiss it all as a lie; Veth had used lies before to inveigle themselves with the Madgēcots. They had used pity and compassion as a tool to use against their enemies and with great success. Now here they were again with another tale of woe—why should she trust them?

Because you were there when Nefeli died, you saw how it affected Veth. You could see that Veth was in love with them and that they are telling the truth now. She thought as she gazed into Veth's shining eyes.

"Okay," she said suddenly. "Let's pretend that I believe you. What are you going to do to get Adora back?"

Veth smiled and nodded. "I'm not completely sure about this, Catra, but something happened when we were all fighting in the Relativity Forge. When He-Man stabbed Nefeli, it upset me so much that I… did something. I summoned some kind of… Light…"

Catra found herself nodding as she remembered exactly what Veth spoke of; the wonderous luminance that issued from Veth's chest. How Despara had momentary remembered who Catra was before returning to her evil state. Catra suddenly felt hope.

"I'm not sure how to summon this Light again, Catra, but I think it is tied to the Penumbra Ritual. I have stopped taking the Antithetical Philter because I feel like this will make my connection to this Light stronger. It's only a matter of time before I master it."

Catra let out a long deep sigh as she approached Veth.

"Okay, Veth, I will trust you," she said as she pointed a black clawed finger in their face. "But I swear, if this is some trick, I swear I'm gonna—"

"Well, well, well," a female voice boomed. "What have we here? Looks like treason to me,"

Terror coursed through Catra as she turned to find Despara walking towards them from the fortress. The hulking warrior was resting her massive sword on one shoulder as she leered at them.

"BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYS—"

Veth had started to shout their words of transformation when Despara stomped a heavy boot into the ground, sending a shockwave lancing in Veth's direction. Catra watched as they were pitched backward over the cliff edge, and she lunged forward on her belly, seizing Veth's hand before they disappeared.

"Hang on!" She screamed down at Veth as they dangled over the ephemeral mist.

Catra's ears twitched at the crunching of booted footsteps. Despara must be standing over her.

"Hmmmm… this seems too easy. Kill this Madgēcot, and I will get rid of the traitor too," Despara said before a snarling interrupted her musings.

Despara turned in time to deflect a lunging Melog, and the two engaged ferocious row as Catra attempted to heave Veth back up. Melog yelped when Despara kicked the Ethereal in the midsection, sending them spinning away in the air.

"Where was I… Oh yes! Killing!" Despara said as she returned her attention to Catra and Veth.

Despara raised her blade over Catra's prone form as Veth stared into her eyes; Catra could see the pure remorse and sorrow there. She immediately knew what they would do.

"*Don't do it! I can get us out of this! I need you!*" Catra hissed down at them.

"I'm sorry, Catra," Veth said as they yanked their hand out of her grasp. Veth did not make a sound as they fell, their silver eyes gleaming up at Catra as the swirling mist swallowed them whole. Veth was gone, taking the brief hope of getting Adora back with them.

"NOOOOO!!!!" Catra shrieked as she rolled, barely missing being cut entirely in half.

Despara raised her black sword for another downwards chop—but this time, Catra was ready. Doing a backward somersault over the whistling point of the weapon, Catra sent two cantrips in Despara's direction; they both impacted, and Despara shrieked in rage as she stifled the magical flames spreading over her body.


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“How do you like that, Despara?” Catra taunted.

“What? No more of that Adora nonsense? You finally given up and decided to call me by my *real* name?” Despara called.

Catra grinned. “Yes and no. Despara is *your* real name, but I haven’t given up on getting Adora back. I never will!”

Despara roared as she brought her blade up; the entire length of the sword suddenly engulfed in purple flames as she summoned the power of Oblivion. As before, the magic spread down the hilt to the bearer’s arms, continuing to travel until Despara was engulfed in the power of Apathy.

“I’ve told you before, Madgēcot. There is no Adora; there is only The Light. There is only Despara!” Despara said as she pointed the burning weapon in Catra’s direction.

Cold waves of frigid emotion bathed Catra as she started to shiver, but she gritted her teeth against the fell magic and paced wearily around Despara, out of striking distance. She felt down her torso, searching by muscle memory for the section of Jaadoo she needed. Finding what she desired on her hip, Catra pinched the material away and balled it up, activating the cantrip before she tossed it sideways. Despara flinched as she saw it coming and the cantrip burst into a fan of crackling rainbow sparks just before it hit her. They danced around Despara before absorbing into her body, and instantly the purple flames were doused. Despara peered down at her body, confused.

“Sorry, Despara. It looks like you have to fight fair,” Catra said. She immediately regretted her words as a cruel grin spread across the other woman’s face.

Despara roared as she charged, grabbing Catra’s ankle when she tried to leap and slamming her to the ground. Dazed, Catra looked up as Despara lifted her sword, intent on killing her enemy with one stabbing strike.

“No! Please, Adora! Don’t!” Catra pleaded, tears forming in her eyes as she tried to crawl away.

Catra felt the fear again—the fear she felt whenever she thought of facing Despara after that disastrous attack on Enos. It seared through her body, making her break out in a cold sweat under her Jaadoo suit. But it was not death she feared…

“I guess this is the last time I must tell you, Madgēcot. There is no Ador—”

A blazing ball of Star Fire blasted into Despara, sending the Fallen She-Ra pitching in cartwheels away from Catra. Catra raised herself to see Glimmer, Bow, Seahawk, Entrapta, and almost twenty Madgēcot Star Hunters running in her direction, making her heart soar.

“Get away from her!” Glimmer shrieked, raising her staff over her head to deliver more magical blasts at the Empyrean Champion. Despara had since drawn herself to one knee and blocked Glimmer’s attacks as she summoned her power to hastily heal the damage inflicted upon her. Glimmer sent Star Fire in a rapid spitfire, breaking through Despara’s guard and scoring hits on her arms, leg, and stomach. Despara screamed in pain and rage as she fell to her knees, the sound digging straight into Catra’s heart.

“NOOO!!! Glimmer stop! You’ll kill her!” Catra screamed as she jumped to stand between her friend and enemy.

Glimmer grimaced as she lowered her staff, and Despara took the opportunity to rise to her feet unsteadily.

“Stay away from me!” Despara hissed, once again summoning the power of Oblivion to surround herself with a protective barrier. She backed away from her attackers as she held her sword up in warning, but before she turned to flee, Despara spoke to Catra.

“Until we meet again…. *Catra,*” she spat.

Catra watched helplessly as her corrupted wife escaped, a strange kind of hope brimming in her mind.

She called me Catra—not Madgēcot, she thought as Glimmer came up to her.

"You okay?" her friend asked, placing a hand on her shoulder.

"Not really," Catra said, looking in the direction Despara escaped. She suddenly turned and walked to the cliff's edge, where Veth fell. Catra gazed into the strange swirling mists as her tail twitched back and forth in agitation.

What is it?" Glimmer asked as she joined Catra in gazing down into the chasm.

"Veth. They had confronted me with a plan… a plan to get Adora back. Despara came out of nowhere and attacked us. Veth sacrificed themselves to save me," Catra said weakly.

"What? Why?" Glimmer said incredulously.

Catra shook her head. "I will tell you later. How did the rest of the mission go? Did we get the Void Gem?"

Catra's heart sank when she saw the look on Glimmer's face, instantly knowing something was wrong.

"No, the Nephraeh got away with the Void gem. Your brother and Shen had succeeded in capturing what the Gnosis carried, but when they verified what it was, they discovered the Void Gem AND The Eye of Hate. Shen transformed and…" Glimmer said.

"*What!?* What happened??" Catra cried.

"We got there just in time to subdue Shen. Viraj is okay, but you should see him; he's really shaken up."

Catra looked over Glimmer's shoulder to see a group of beat-up-looking Star Hunters carrying Shen. Her brother was in the front

of the procession, and to Catra, he seemed as far from Shen as possible. Catra ran to her twin brother, stopping herself from embracing him when he flinched away—she immediately saw that he was holding his arm stiffly.

"Sorry, Cat-Tra, my arm is broken. I need time for my Jaadoo suit to heal it," he said with a weak grin.

"Don't be stupid, Viraj; it's okay," she said, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder. "How is Shen?"

At the mention of Shen, a dark look passed over Viraj's face, and he looked away.

"Catra, it was horrible. We found the Eye of Hate… and Shen turned into a monster. I could have never imagined that *that* was what he was fighting. He tried to kill me…" Viraj said weakly.

Catra immediately felt defensive of her friend and was about to argue when she saw tears in Viraj's eyes. She only gave his shoulder a gentle squeeze before turning to the Madgēcots carrying the unconscious Shen. He was wrapped in so many restraining cantrips that he looked like a bug in a cocoon.

"Be careful, Cat-Tra. He's dangerous." One of them warned.

Catra let out a snort of derision as she shook her head.

"Not to me; he isn't," she said, placing a hand gently on her friend's forehead.

"*Oh, Shen*," she whispered to him. "What am I going to do with you?"

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by miledibuja on Tumblr, Instagram, and Twitter.

Catra’s Promise

Chapter Summary

Despara faces the consequences.

Shen awakens to find he is abandoned.

In Kishar's journal, the final pieces are falling into place and Horde Prime is revealed.

For the first time ever, Despara felt fear. It was an alien feeling for her; at first, she thought it was a kind of excitement, for her heart was racing. But as she knelt before the holographic projector, waiting for Archon Lethe to make contact, she realized it for what it was.

It had been a day since the rendezvous with the Gnosis on Iohiri, a day since she had failed to transport Archon Lethe’s prizes directly to them—as they had commanded. It was also a day since she had killed the traitor Veth, and Despara was not fool enough to believe her Lord would greet this news favorably.

Despara was already going to report Veth to Archon Lethe for destroying the Vetala and repeating the lie that she was someone named Adora, not Despara. But then she had heard Veth plotting with that Madgēcot Catra in secret, revealing them to be false. It had been her duty to act at that moment, but that did not mean she had the right to destroy her fellow Champion outright. She should have captured them or, at the very least, brought this news back to Archon Lethe and let them dole out the appropriate punishment. Now she was back on Enos, in the Relativity Forge, about to face judgment in Veth’s place; Despara felt sudden rage at this but bit it back, not wanting to appear disrespectful to Archon Lethe.

Another thought was in Despara’s head, one seemingly pleasant mote in the torrential storm of fear and anger that had been her

life as of late. A face, a beautiful face with two heterochromatic eyes that gazed at her longingly.

Catra.

Who was this Madgēcot? Warning Despara of Catra was one of the first things Archon Lethe had said to her upon regaining consciousness after her memory loss. Why was that? Plus, why did her enemies insist on calling her Adora? As a tactic to undermine her, it was a poor one. It did not matter what name she was called; she was Despara to her core; she was a killer with no remorse.

But Veth had told you your name was Adora, that you are married to Catra. They could have been lying, but they were so adamant when they said it… What was the point of that? Just to mess with her mind?

A transmission received indication chime drew Despara's thoughts away from her doubt, and she lowered he gaze as a holographic representation of Archon Lethe's head appeared in the air before her.

"Greetings, My Child. I did not receive the Void Gem nor the Eye of Hate; I hope you have an explanation for me," Archon Lethe said by way of greeting.

"They are here with me, on Enos, My Archon," Despara said as she raised her gaze to the image. This news was met with a single raised white eyebrow.

"Explain," Archon Lethe said.

"For reasons I do not know, Veth had destroyed the Vetala under our command. I only found this out right before we met with the Gnosis Operatives. Then, right before I received the artifacts, I discovered Veth plotting behind my— YOUR back. They were talking to that Madgēcot, Catra, and making some kind of deal." Despara said.

“So where is Veth? Are they in your custody now?” Archon Lethe asked.

Despara swallowed as she looked away briefly, then returned her gaze to Archon Lethe.

“I tried to, my Lord. There was a fight after I confronted them, and they… fell. They are gone, my Lord. Veth is dead.” Despara said quietly.

“Fell? Fell where? Be clearer, woman!” Archon Lethe snapped.

Despara felt rage at being spoken to like this but held her tongue and lowered her gaze, not wanting them to see the anger in her eyes.

“There are these canyons— or holes all over Iohiri. They were very weird with strange glowing fog; Veth fell into one of these,” Despara responded.

Archon Lethe did not speak for a moment, their glowing indigo eyes boring into the top of Despara’s bowed head. If she had raised her head then, Despara might have seen the fear in her Lord’s eyes at this news.

“I see,” they said finally. “That is unfortunate but of no concern. The death of the bearer of Zhe-La has happened many times. The power of Zhe-La will return to Empyrea to be bound into a new host. Perhaps I will be more careful and make sure this one is worthier than the last.”

Despara did not bother to respond, only continued to bow her head in false abeyance.

“I should congratulate you, my Champion. You managed to turn what could have been a complete debacle into something salvageable. Well done,” Archon Lethe said with a forced smile.

“Yes, my Lord, for Empyrea and The Light,” Despara said, trying to hide the resentment in her voice.

Archon Lethe nodded. “The fact that the Eye of Hate is on Enos maybe be fortuitous. It is not what I originally planned, but I know of a way to make this work.”

Despara looked up to see her Lord place a black-clawed finger to their lips as they pondered this turn of events.

“Hmmm… yes, this may work splendidly!” They said with a sudden laugh.

Archon Lethe’s demeanor changed before Despara’s very eyes; they now gazed at her with affection instead of anger. Whatever they had thought up had pleased them immensely.

“What is the operational status of the Relativity Forge, Despara? Is it still fully functional after the attempt to destroy it?” Archon Lethe asked.

Despara nodded. “Yes, my Lord. The structure of the building itself received some damage in the fight, but the mechanisms at the facility's core are still intact. Gravity can still be drawn from the solar systems’ three suns and stored as energy within the capacitors.”

“Excellent! So that means the reverse is also true; you can send that collected energy in a specified direction back out into space?” Archon Lethe continued.

“Yes, I suppose. Although if you plan on trying to blast Elysia with the power, I do not think it will work, my Lord. From what I understand, the energy will dissipate by the time it reaches them and just be absorbed harmlessly by the atmosphere.” Despara said with a shrug, completely confused now.

“Yes, that is true, Despara. You are smarter than most give you credit for,” Archon Lethe said, greatly angering Despara.

“The *energy* will completely ionize in the atmosphere, but not what it carries with it. You see, there is no defense against *pure*

hate, my Child. *Hate* will get though," Archon Lethe said with a wicked grin, exposing all their black teeth.

* * *

There was darkness, but this was not an empty void; it was filled with a terrible fire of fear and despair. It was endless yet incredibly finite, a fixed position of suffering with seemingly no escape.

But there was a release—a sweet, sweet escape from the doom. It was there, in the dark, the only beacon of hope appearing as a red light. He knows there will also be burning there and much, much hotter. But this kind of immolation was better than the one currently tormenting his soul; it was a righteous fire, and he remembers the lick of its flames along the edges of his heart. It felt so good when compared to anything he has felt recently. *Doesn't he deserve to feel good? Why can't he be allowed to feel a moment of peace which so many others around him took for granted?*

Faces flashed in his mind's eye; old faces and new. He immediately recognized one as Shen'Dara's; his beautifully handsome face was flushed red in suffocation as his life faded—it was the moment of his death at the hands of the Demon Heart. Other faces appeared, his friend's faces; they look at him with terror and fear as he came to destroy them. Suddenly, the red fury no longer seemed appealing, and it was snuffed out as cold emotion flooded his psyche and blackness returned.

Suddenly he heard voices—accented voices he recognized. They draw him out of the dark and into the light. Shen opened his eyes to find that he was lying on his back, once again looking up at the mural in the Medical Bay aboard the *Pakadna*. He had managed to escape the sightlessness of the nightmare, but the anxiety remained; it had followed him from his dreamscape.

The voices distracted his attention from his emotions, and Shen turned toward them. Cold, hard bindings at his chest, legs, and

arms immediately jolt him to a halt with a rattling sound. He looked down at his body to find heavy chains held him in place; they were thick and black, with glowing magical runes etched in every link.

"What the?" Shen said, confused.

"He's awake!" A female Madgēcot voice exclaimed. Shen felt a jolt of shame to hear the unease in that voice.

Madgēcot Star Hunters immediately crowd around his bed. There are hard looks on their feline faces, entirely at odds with the friendliness he was used to, and they hold their distance from him while forming a protective wall around him. Shen knew that this shield was not for his benefit but for others.

"Guys, I'm okay now. Just let me go. I promise I won't let the Eye of Hate retake control," Shen pleaded.

Hissing and growling was the only response after Shen mentioned the Abominable Power, and every single tail bushed up to twice its normal size. Not a single Star Hunter moved towards him to do as he asked.

Suddenly, Viraj pushed through the wall of Madgēcots, and Shen's heart soared to see his friendly face. Viraj came to the bed and kneeled next to him, concern plastered on his handsome face, and he took one of Shen's hands in his.

"How are you feeling, Shen?" Viraj asked with a faint smile.

Shen felt overjoyed to feel Viraj's warm body, even if it was only his hand. It comforted him immensely, alleviating the anxiety by a small degree, making him greedy for more.

"I'm not doing good, Viraj; I feel like I'm drowning here. I could really use your help," he said as he caressed the top of Viraj's hand with the top of his thumb. Viraj's eyes widened, and he withdrew his hand, sending an icy jolt through Shen's heart.

“I mean, how are you feeling anger-wise?” Viraj said in a neutral tone.

“Viraj, what is this? Why are you acting like this? Did I hurt someone? Did I hurt you?” Shen asked.

Viraj looked away, then stood, looking down at Shen as his tail twitched.

“If there were any fewer of us when you… changed, we would have been in trouble. As it was, Glimmer showed up just in time to help subdue you. There were a few injuries, but they were minor. Nothing our magic couldn’t mend,” Viraj said.

To Shen, Viraj could have been talking about the weather for all the emotion his voice displayed.

“You didn’t answer me, Viraj. Did I hurt you?” Shen asked as he tried to reach for Viraj. A sharp metallic click was heard as he reached the end of the chain’s slack, his hand inches from touching Viraj’s thigh.

Viraj turned to his fellow Madgēcots before responding.

“Can we please have a moment alone? I need to speak to Shen privately.”

The assembled Star Hunters nodded, and without saying a word, moved to the other side of the medical facility, giving the two the space they needed.

“Shen, you turned, right before my eyes, into a… monster and attacked us. It was like you didn’t know who I was. You broke my arm without batting an eye…” Viraj said, the sadness plain in his voice.

Shen once again tried to reach for Viraj, now wanting to give comfort instead of receiving it.

"I'm so sorry, Viraj! You know that wasn't me, right? I would never hurt you!" He said as tears formed in his eyes. Viraj looked down at the hand reaching for him, uncertainty written on his features.

"Just release me, Viraj; I will make it up to you, I promise!" Shen pleaded.

"You tried to warn us, didn't you? But we— *I* didn't understand what you were capable of," Viraj continued as he looked past Shen. "I've never had someone close to me turn on me like that and hurt me, Shen. My arm has since been mended, but something else is broken now… I just don't think us being together is going to work for me,"

"Why? Because you don't trust me? Do you feel like I've broken your trust? Viraj, we can work it out!" Shen said.

Viraj shook his head. "No, Shen, please don't make this harder. I don't really think we were right even before this happened."

Shen felt the panic from before return as his mind reeled.

"So, what? You're going to break up with me now when I need you the most?" Shen said, incredulously.

Viraj shook his head again and held his hand up placatingly.

"I'm stopping off our intimate relationship Shen, but that does not mean I'm casting you away. No, I am here for you; I will help you through this. I'm just not going to help you in *that* way," Viraj said.

"Gee, thanks, Viraj," Shen said.

Viraj missed the sarcasm in Shen's voice or ignored it as he continued.

"We are getting you back to Elysia, and we will help you, but we must ensure everyone is safe, too. Maybe when you are more

stable, you can come and stay with me and Catra again. It can be like—”

Viraj cut off what he was going to say, his long ears drooping as he looked down at the floor shamefully.

“Like before? Yeah, right, only you already said it plainly it won’t be like before!” Shen snarled.

“Shen, I’m sorry, I didn’t mean it—” Viraj started to say but was cut off by Shen.

“Oh, yes, you’re *sorry*. You know what, Viraj? I don’t need your help! I’ve been suffering just fine on my own without you, thank you very much!”

Shen felt the bitter anger rise in his throat as he spoke the words and hated how he enjoyed the sadness in Viraj at the vehemence in his words.

“Shen, don’t be this way. You’re getting angry…” Viraj said as he placed his hand on Shen’s leg.

“*Don’t touch me!!!*” Shen hissed as he tried to kick the hand away. Again, the chains made that irritating noise as they halted his movement, adding fuel to his burgeoning wrath. The restrictions on his body were all-encompassing, reminding Shen of the stifling darkness filled with smothering dread. He wanted to be free of them; he wanted an escape.

As if called, the Eye of Hate came to Shen. He felt a tugging sensation at his hindbrain, letting him know his desire for freedom could be granted if only he would let go. As this happened, the Medical Ward's magical lights flickered in recognition of its evil presence.

“I could use your assistance over here!” Viraj called as he turned and motioned to the other Madgēcots.

For a split second, Shen almost willingly gave into the Eye of Hate; he was so angry at Viraj for pushing him away and the Madgēcots for locking him up. But in the end, he just could not do that to them; he was no killer. Shen heaved a sigh, sinking back into the bed and letting the heavy chains weigh him down.

Well, these chains aren't a warm Madgēcot boyfriend, but their heaviness could help with my anxiety in a pinch. Shen thought ruefully to himself.

Shen saw an attractive female Madgēcot in a white Jaadoo suit coming at him; she was all business with a cantrip in one black clawed hand.

"It's okay; I got it under contro—"

Before Shen could finish, she slapped the cantrip on his forehead, and he instantly lost consciousness. Shen gladly sank into the inky depths of his subconscious, the magic of the Madgēcot healer somehow disconnecting him from the misery of his tormenting emotions.

After a period of indeterminable nothingness, the dreams came, swirling out of the mists of his temporal lobe. They were images of what could be, given to him by force that wished to enslave him. A force that wanted not only Shen's soul but the power of Grayskull that came with it.

There is smoke in his nostrils; it is the smoke of many fires burning in the night. He can see them from his perspective, for he is high above it all. He is far from those he rules, far from the trivial concerns of all those tiny people. Even better, he is separated from his pain, from his terrible trauma, that is all behind him now. There is only righteous wrath in his new state, for he has become what his father could only have dreamed of; he is a god now.

His body is huge and no longer flesh and blood; where once there was skin, now there is magma. Where once there was a heart,

there is now a furnace. He once had two eyes, but they had burned away to be replaced by the one; it is a red eye, an Eye of Hate.

He strides over the ruined hellscape of the planet, and the people who still remain alive flee before his coming. Those who are not as fortunate are smitten beneath his mighty feet, becoming nothing more than cinders in his wake. He pays them no heed; they are beneath any consideration.

Something catches his eye far in the distance, and he diverts his course to investigate it. It is a ruin of a once beautiful castle, and his mighty footsteps echo off the jagged peaks which once encompassed it. As he nears, he can make out a broken white column; the top half smashed on the shore of a bay below. Pieces of a crystalline shape are nearby; they appear as if they were once ovoid, like an egg. For a moment, he thinks he recognizes this object…

*"How **dare** you return!" a voice cries out.*

The disrespect in this voice makes him roar, and he looks down to see who had dared address him. He spies a figure below; they are dressed in white and gold, long blonde hair held in a ponytail flowing behind their head. It is a woman—a mighty woman by the looks of her. Somewhere in his black mind, he feels like he knows this warrior.

"I should have never saved you all those years ago! I should have left you to your damnation! You took everything from me! You killed my wife!" She screams. He can tell she is weeping as she speaks. It sickens him.

The woman summons a sword as he reaches down for her; it shines bright with Honor. She stabs it into his palm before he grasps her, but he feels no pain. She screams as his inferno fingers wrap her form, and she drops the sword. She is still screaming as he lifts her to his open mouth. She tastes so goo—

“ADORA!!!” Shen screamed as he woke from the nightmare.

Jolting upright in the bed, he is surprised to find chains no longer held him down. Shen then jumped as two muzzles pressed down on his leg, and two sets of glowing eyes peered at him in the dark —one blue and the other yellow.

“Battle Cat? Melog?” Shen asked.

“*Yes, we are here. You are safe now, Shen,”* Battle Cat mewled.

Shen looked around, barely seeing the outline of an oblong room that was obviously Madgēcot in design. Open windows peer out onto a forest night as insects and animals make a chorus of soft sounds.

“I’m back on Elysia?” Shen asked.

“Good guess, dummy,” a voice said nearby.

Shen turned to see a figure lying on a bed near the door. Two heterochromatic eyes gleam at him in the dark; the right blue and the left yellow.

“Catra?” Shen asked, astonished.

“Wow, you’re on a roll,” Catra said with a chuckle. Melog mewled something to her that Shen could not understand, and Catra groaned with annoyance.

“Yeah, yeah, Melog,” she said, waving them off. “Sorry, Shen, just goofing with you a bit,”

Catra stood up and walked over to his bed, sitting on the edge to look at him.

“Gonna tell me what’s going on? Or are you going to keep messing with me?” Shen asked, surprised at himself that he felt irritated with Catra.

"Well, my brother and all the Madgēcots wanted to bring you back here on Elysia and lock you up in some kind of magical prison. They were going to have you do all this weird therapy with those weirdo magical Madgēcots—the Jaadoogar. When I heard that, I told them all they could do that over my dead body, and I threatened to fight them," Catra said simply.

Shen felt a lance of fear when he heard Catra say *over my dead body.* He remembered Adora's voice from his dream, cursing him for killing Catra.

"Well, they were pretty mad at me for threatening them all, but they agreed. They said you could walk free if I took responsibility for you. Since you and my brother are having trouble, I figured it best if we move into the Guest House with everyone else. Glimmer and the rest can help me keep an eye on you—*you nut job*," Catra said, slapping his arm playfully.

Shen shook his head. "Catra, I don't think you are taking this seriously. I'm a threat; you should have let your people lock me up!"

Shen could hear Catra groan and knew she was rolling her eyes.

"Oh, here we go. Mr. '*I have to be a Martyr for everyone and please sacrifice me'* routine. Give me a break, Shen." Catra said.

"I'm dangerous, Catra! You should not be anywhere near me! I want you to leave! Go back and stay with your brother, where it is safer!" Shen yelled.

Both of Catra's gleaming eyes became hooded, and in the room's half-light, Shen could see her ears flatten and tail twitch rapidly.

"Make me," she said coolly.

Shen growled with frustration as he flopped back on the bed, pressing his fists into his eye sockets.

“Catra, I had a dream, and I think it was a premonition of a possible future. In it, I had become a monster and killed you, and I think I killed everyone else. I’m not going to let that happen!”

Catra was silent for a moment before reaching over and placing a hand on Shen’s knee.

“Remember that night in the cave? After defeating your father? Do you remember what I said to you?”

Shen removed his hands from his face and nodded.

“I said I would always be there for you, and when I make a promise like that, I mean it. I may not help you through this as my brother did, but we will figure this out together.” Catra said, giving his knee a firm squeeze.

“Okay,” Shen said, letting out a final sigh.

Catra nodded as she stood up. She walked back to her bed to lay on her side, her eyes still on Shen.

“By the way, Viraj and I aren’t having troubles, Catra; we are over. He made it pretty clear to me he doesn’t want to have that kind of relationship anymore,” Shen said.

“That’s too bad; I liked the idea of you two being together. I hope you can stay friends. I mean, it would really stink for me to have my best friend and twin brother hate each other.” Catra said ruefully.

“I could never hate Viraj, but I know what you mean. It’s just that I was so angry; he cut me off right when I needed him most.” Shen said as he hugged himself.

Catra rolled over on her stomach and propped her head on her hands.

“Oh, believe me, I totally get it. Viraj just doesn’t. We both lost our parents, but he grew up in a great environment here on

Elysia. He doesn't know the kind of trauma both you and I have faced. Sorry, Shen, but the wrong sibling understands you," Catra said with a small laugh.

Shen shook his head adamantly. "No, you're wrong. I think the right sibling does,"

Catra cocked her head as her heterochromatic eyes narrowed.

"*Ohhhh*… I see! Look at you! Just broke up with my brother, and you're putting the moves on me—shame on you!" Catra exclaimed.

Shen immediately sat upright. "What!? NO! That's not what I meant, Catra! I meant you—"

Shen stopped when he heard a high-pitched cackle from Catra as she rolled on her bed.

"You're too easy! You should have seen your face!" She exclaimed with glee.

"Ha, Ha," Shen said drolly as he crossed his arms and sat back.

Catra snorted before laying her head down. Shen could tell she was still pleased with herself; a shadow of a wide grin was plastered on her face. Once again, he noticed the positioning of her bed right in front of the magical door.

"So, what's with the bed right there, Catra? You playing 'guard cat' with me?" He asked.

"Oh, funny! Cat jokes! Never heard those before…" Catra replied. "As a matter of fact, yes, I am. I am taking my responsibility of watching you seriously. Can't have you sneaking out in the middle of the night and all,"

"What? Don't trust me?" Shen said as he feigned a hurt tone.

“Trust you never to hurt me or anyone I care about— yes. Trust you to do what’s right—yes. Trust you not to do something stupid in some hair-brained attempt to protect everyone else.... ABSOLUTELY NOT!!!” Catra exclaimed.

Shen had to laugh at this; Catra knew him all too well.

“Now—go to bed. We have a long day ahead of us tomorrow. I have no idea how we will tame this anger beast inside you, and I want to start early. Good night!” Catra said, flopping her face down into her pillow.

Shen said goodnight to his friend, but after a moment, he had one more thing to add.

“Catra?”

“…hmmm…?”

“You’re a really good friend,”

A moment of silence before Catra responded.

“Go to bed, dummy,” Catra said, and by the tone of her voice, Shen could tell she was smiling when she said it.

A deep purr emanated from her bed not long after, filling the room with a Madgēcot’s comforting sound. Two others accompanied this purr as Battle Cat and Melog joined in, creating a symphony of beautiful white noise, drawing everyone in the bedroom into a deep sleep.

* * *

01.2881.99

I do not have much time to spend on this journal, for much is happening now. I feel like we are entering a momentous period in history, and I must be ready to take advantage of opportunities as

they arise. My journal entries will only document events of great importance, and I will come back later and fill in the details.

Something occurred recently which makes me feel like we are living at the end of our so-called 'Golden Age' and entering an age of more relevance.

It seems my time with Mazdak Zeno has borne fruit and has not been a complete waste. I just received news that he has revealed himself to the universe at the head of a mighty fleet. He has stated that he is the rightful Emperor of the Galaxy, and it is his duty to spread his 'Light.' He has also completely reinvented himself with a new cloned body and name; from the images I have, his new body is huge, about as tall as my Zhe-La form, and quite attractive. I wish he were in this new body when I had attempted to seduce him; perhaps I wouldn't have given up so easily.

As for his new name, he calls himself Horde Prime, and the reason for this is obvious. Mazdak Zeno—or Horde Prime—has abandoned his disdain for making mindless clones of himself and created an entire army of them. He has also stolen my idea for telepathically controlling them—but I will let him have that free of charge—for he has created an opportunity for Zzar and I.

In the meantime, diplomats have been sent to Horde Prime with the hope of finding a peaceful resolution to this dispute. So far, he has not made any moves to threaten star systems neighboring Hourdwold-1, but I doubt that will last.

01.2893.99

Several systems have left our Intergalactic Society and have united under Horde Prime. It seems they have done this not out of fear of his mighty fleet and army of clones but to join with his 'Light.' From what I understand, Horde Prime's 'Light' represents total order with no regard for the individual. It is absolute submission to the will of the one who, in this case, is Horde Prime.

It seems that after many centuries of living under no direction, the hardline order of Horde Prime's rule appeals to some people.

It is a simplistic ideal, and I admire its directness, but I see no future in it. You will need more than laws and direct force to keep a population in line.

The systems that did not find immediate appeal in Horde Prime's Light have been driven to absolute fear of having their freedom taken away. Not since The Dark Times has this much terror coursed through the galaxy, and my lovely Zzar has wasted no time in using it to her advantage. She has been using her influence as Keeper of Secrets to rally everyone—stating that only together can we fight Horde Prime's tyranny. She has presented plans for forming our disparate societies into one—an Empire.

So far, not one person objects to this idea. Everyone is too afraid of Horde Prime.

01.2930.99

We are now formally an Empire, centered around Eternia as the Capital with the other magical Prime Planets as fiefdoms. Each Champion has also taken on titles of importance on their respective planet; Adam was already royalty, so being called Prince is no change for him. Jihan is now called 'Mahat,' and She-Ra is called 'Princess.' My people are calling me 'Archon' now, and I have become quite taken with the title.

Archon Kishar.

01.2949.99

It has recently been discovered that Horde Prime has been sending agents amongst our Empire to sow discord and undermine the fabric of our society. He has been abducting people of influence and using unknown technology to control their minds and do his bidding.

I'm astounded by the pure genius of the man. Even if his agents had failed in their tasks, he has sown distrust amongst the people of the Empire. No one knows whether their neighbor is an agent of Horde Prime.

Zzar seized on this and managed to point this suspicion to the Champions that protect the Empire. Zzar has argued that shackles must be placed on each Champion, binding their Avatar power to the Empire forever. There have been arguments against doing this, mainly from Astra, the Bearer of She-Ra, but most people are listening to Zzar blindly.

This is all according to our plan—of course—for Zzar has shown me how she would join each Champion Avatar to a Power Sword using a mix of magic and archaic technology from before the Dark Times. The Power Sword binding Zhe-La will, of course, be a fake; I have no intention of ever being bound.

01.3050.99

The time has come; Horde Prime declared war against the entire galaxy. He has unleashed his fleet upon the systems closest to his —the ones that have not already joined him—and completely smashed any defense they have attempted. Everyone is utterly numb with terror; there has never been any need for a grand fleet or standing army since the Dark Times, and no one is prepared for this onslaught.

Before he rebelled, Mazdak Zeno had shared designs for a large-scale starship that he has since modified into a warship. The Empire is using these designs to create a warship similar to his and has just begun mass-producing them. But many fear it is too late; Horde Prime's ships vastly outnumber the Empire's, and his designs are far superior.

01.3090.99

The war goes very poorly for the Empire. Horde Prime has proven himself to not only be a genius in science but military tactics as

well. Systems have been falling one by one, and the forces of the Empire are dwindling. Many Champions of Grayskull have perished, and their Power Swords passed to new, untested bearers.

Zzar has come to me recently. She fears Horde Prime will destroy the Empire we worked and schemed so hard for and blames me for creating him.

I enjoyed seeing the fear in Zzar's eyes, and I decided to use that to my advantage. I asked her about the Apogean Ritual and whether it could help us. I told her that I suspected her secret spell could grant us the power to destroy Horde Prime out of hand and rule the galaxy as we saw fit.

Instead of denying this, Zzar asked me to help her decipher the last portion of the spell, the part in the ancient language of my people. She said that we could both ascend to godhood together and escape the inevitable doom of the Empire.

I now have a copy of the Apogean Ritual on a data cube and am heading to The Temple of Light on Empyrea to decipher it.

01.3095.99

I gained access to The Temple of Light's library and found the codex to translate the archaic language of Sera'Phael-im. After that, it did not take long to learn the last portion of the Apogean Ritual.

Although the spells and incantations are complex, it is a straightforward ritual when you think about it. It is basically like starting a fire; you need a source of fuel and an ignition source. The fuel is a sacrifice; one person or many, it does not matter. What does matter is how the sacrifice is achieved—that determines the quality of the fuel. If the sacrifice is someone you don't know, then the quality is low. If it is someone who trusts you or even loves you, well, that is fine fuel indeed.

The ignition is a source of immense power. What that is could be anything, as long as it is great. The only caveat is this source of power cannot be tied to your person, for it would be disastrous to the caster of the Apogean Ritual.

I am laughing to myself as I write this, for I believe I have found a way to get Zzar back for using me as her plaything. I think I will give her this entire spell with that bit of detail left out, and she will use the Life Gem she is bound to as the ignition source for the spell. Just as she gave me the Shlihm-bess'a-rune to see what it would do to me, I will provide her with this broken version of the Apogean Ritual.

I wonder what will happen to my dear Zzar?

Glimmer wanted to vomit as she stopped reading Kishar's journal. There was only so much evil she could read about, and her mind buzzed with the history lesson she had just absorbed.

So many questions were answered in one sitting, but so many were left unanswered. There was one detail Glimmer could not get out of her mind; Kishar was calling themselves Archon Kishar. Does that just mean that they were the first in a long line of Archons? Or is Archon Lethe actually Kishar? The journal was from a millennia ago, but it was possible Kishar was still alive. After all, Horde Prime had lived that long using his cloning technology. Didn't Kishar say they had learned much from him during their stay on his planet?

Evil was abundant in Kishar's time, but many of those participants were gone now. She-Ra defeated Horde Prime, and Madame Razz destroyed her sister Zzar. There was only Kishar to be accounted for, and there was one place they could be now.

Glimmer moved off her chair to sit on the floor of her guest room. She crossed her legs and rested her arms on her knees as she let go of her physical form to transcend into the spiritual. Her essence rose into the sky, then into space, traveling faster than thought until she could see the entirety of the galaxy. She focused

on the dark planet she knew was Empyrea and felt her ghost quail at what she witnessed.

The corrupted tendril which had been tentatively reaching out to grasp other planets was now extended all the way to the planet Enos, encapsulating it. Another tendril was rising out of its mass, like an offspring of the original, and was making its own way in the universe to spread its evil.

And it was reaching for Elysia.

Searching for Balance

Chapter Summary

Glimmer finally comes to the end of Kishar's journal.

Catra helps Shen find balance using her own brand of therapy.

A new threat rears its head.

Glimmer felt like running out of her room in the guest house to warn everyone of the encroaching danger. By some unknown means, the Nephraeh—or, more accurately, Archon Lethe—was going to attack them here on Elysia. But one thing stopped her from doing this.

How are they going to attack us? By what means? They cannot do it directly by force, or they would have already done so. It must be by some magical way. She thought to herself as she picked up the datapad holding Kishar's journal.

Glimmer checked the indicator showing the journal entry memory; there wasn't much remaining, meaning that Kishar's story was nearing the end.

Before I run off and warn everyone, I should just finish this thing. I'm mean, I really should have completed it a while ago, Glimmer thought as she sat back down. She pressed the on button, and the screen lit back up.

01.3100.99

What I have been dreading has finally happened; Jihan has learned the truth about me. It was my fault, really; I had become complacent and careless by leaving this journal out. Jihan would typically never violate my privacy in this way, but he has been so worried that he could not help but peek behind the curtain of my outer façade. I can imagine that Jihan got way more than he

bargained for as he read of my secret desires and plans for galactic domination with Zzar.

Instead of going straight to the League of Kalosyni with my journal, Jihan foolishly decided to confront me. I just don't understand his thinking. Didn't he just read about how I no longer have compassion?

Jihan said he wanted to help me, that he could use the power of Sher-Va to reconnect me with my lost empathy. As he spoke these words, I realized that he might be right; the prime ability of Sher-Va could help me regain my empathy. I don't know what I did not think of that before.

At that moment, I decided that perhaps now was the time to kill Jihan; not only did he know of my secret, but he could also strip me of my freedom. I ascended to my Zhe-La form and attacked Jihan, but before I could strike him down, he took on his Champion form. For the first time ever, Zhe-La and Sher-Va fought as enemies.

Jihan and I were not evenly matched; I found that I now had three advantages over him that he did not have. One, I no longer had any empathy and truly wanted to kill him. I don't believe he felt the same, having only just learned of what I had become. Second, my Zhe-La power was not shackled to a Power Sword; it was still raw and potent. Third, my new ability to feed by twisting The Light of Zhe-La. He was not prepared for the sudden draining of his empathy and was overcome; it was a simple task to kill him.

I felt the power of Zhe-La betray me then; it attempted to break its bond to me as I tried to sink my sword in my ex-lover's heart. But I seized the power of Zhe-La with my will alone, making it remain connected to me.

Jihan had seen my struggle, probably mistaking it for inner turmoil, and had used that opportunity to escape. I am sure he has fled directly to the League of Kalosyni and will try to capture me with backup from a member bearing a Staff of Power. There

are not many to choose from since two have fallen in this war with Horde Prime. Zzar will, of course, not side with him, and her sister, Razz, has disappeared. There is Mnum'Hra, Bearer of the Kinetic Krystal, Janus, Bearer of the Orb of Entropy, and Dinala Katan, Bearer of the Void Gem. Any one of these members, combined with Sher-Za, could defeat me.

I must flee.

01.3112.99

The Empire is crumbling; everything is in chaos now as Horde Prime closes in on Eternia. I have not heard from Zzar since I transmitted the complete Apogean Ritual to her. I am sure she is busy with her own struggles as Eternia readies itself for a final stand. From my understanding of her situation, she has that fool Adam wrapped around her finger. I'm sure she will connive him to help her perform the ritual; I'm just sorry I won't be there to see it when it blows up in her face.

01.3117.99

Jihan has made his first attempt to capture me on Omiros, and he indeed has help. Dinala Katan, Bearer of the Void Gem, was with him, and I barely managed to escape. The Void Gem is quite ferocious in combat, and I believe Dinala was trying to kill instead of capture. The only reason I got away was that Jihan turned on her, trying to stop her from destroying me, and I slipped away as they fought.

I think it's time for me to turn to the Apogean Ritual, and I believe I know the place to perform it. There is a Nephraeh temple nearby, one of many set up as a shrine to The Light—the Light of love and compassion, not 'The Light' Horde Prime speaks of. It is a place of weakness and sanctuary for those who are in need.

I believe that I am very much in need.

01.3122.99

Just as I expected, the Nephraeh here at this temple welcomed me with open arms. There are many here, perhaps around twenty, and they have promised to help me defend this place from anyone who attempts to do harm here. I have even told them I am pursued by a Champion and member of the League of Kalosyni who have betrayed the Empire. In this time of turmoil, it was easy for them to accept this lie as truth.

There are others here, refugees from the war, looking to the Nephraeh for sanctuary. They are gathered down below in the chamber dedicated to Zhe-La, and they are overjoyed that Zhe-La themself is there to protect them.

I believe I have found my fuel.

My people, plus the refugees, will make the perfect sacrifice. Hopefully, the betrayal I inflict is enough to grant me ascension. I just have to wait for the spark to arrive; I could not have asked for a more ideal situation. Jihan and Dinala will give me the perfect gift.

They will make me a god.

End of Entries

Numbly, Glimmer turned the data pad off for the final time and placed it on the table. She had indeed found the answer she initially sought; the key to helping her friends regain their empathy lay in the power of the Madgēcot Champion, Sher-Va. Somehow, they needed to remove the Power Sword from the tree and bind it to a new bearer, but that did not solve their most pressing concern.

Glimmer was now firmly convinced Kishar was still alive and using a new name—Archon Lethe. There was no absolute concrete evidence, but it made perfect sense it was them. How they were no longer the bearer of Zhe-La was an unanswered question but unimportant, especially now that Zhe-La was possibly lost with the

apparent death of Veth. What was important was whether Kishar had succeeded in performing the Apogean Ritual.

Was Archon Lethe a god?

All evidence pointed to this theory being the truth. Jihan had been lost, and Archon Lethe had the sword of Sher-Va. The crypt—or temple—where her friends had been tainted must have been where Kishar had gone to find sanctuary with the Nephraeh and those poor refugees. It was where they had found the Void Gem and the remains of its bearer, Dinala Katan. Those creatures they encountered, the Vetala they were called, must have been manifestations of Kishar's new power—Oblivion.

But if Archon Lethe was a god, why have they just been sitting back on Empyrea for the past millennia? Why have they not destroyed Horde Prime years ago and taken over the universe for themselves? They could have molded it to their whim, but instead, they were kidnapping champions and playing war with the Elysians. What was the point of all this?

Glimmer shook these thoughts from her head; they were not crucial to the immediate concern. The attack on Elysia was. She had to tell everyone what she knew; Glimmer could not let whatever evil was coming hurt the Madgēcots. Catra's people were the best suited in the galaxy to help defend against the tide of evil pouring out from Empyrea.

Putting on her star-studded cloak and seizing her Staff of Power, Glimmer teleported away and down to the Imaarat.

* * *

Shen panted as he ran through the Great Jacarandra forest, desperate to escape his pursuer. He had been running for a while now and was absolutely exhausted. Looking around furtively to make sure he wasn't being watched, Shen stopped and leaned up against one of the giant trees to catch his breath.

I really miss Viraj's way of helping me relax, he thought.

A scrabbling noise alerted Shen, making him look up and around the broad side of the Jacarandra tree he rested on; it sounded like claws on the bark. Spotting nothing, Shen resumed his flight; he was eager to escape the tree that could possibly spell his downfall.

She can easily sneak around the side and leap down on me, he thought as he looked around the forest floor for a potential hiding place. The sound of flowing water greeted Shen as he made it to the top of a mossy knoll, making him grin.

That must be the river she mentioned! Once I get there, I win this silly game!

The sound of something heavy landing nearby made Shen pause, and after a moment of silence, he heard a low chuckle.

She is toying with me, he thought with annoyance.

Turning, Shen spotted his pursuer rising from a crouch next to the Jacarandra Tree he had just come from. She stood slowly to regard him with heterochromatic feline eyes and a smug grin on her face.

"Going somewhere, *buddy boy?*" Catra said with glee.

Shen didn't bother responding and immediately bolted for the safety the river promised. Catra let out a shriek of laughter before she gave chase, running after him on all fours.

"*I'm gonna geeeeet yoooouuuu…!*" Catra called.

The creepy way his friend taunted him gave Shen a slight thrill, making him push harder to reach the river. As he ran down the slight hill slope, a root caught his foot, causing Shen to stumble and fall. He rolled down the rest of the way, the pain of the rocks that struck his body turning earlier exciting into pure rage.

"*Ooohhhh*… man, that had to hurt," Catra said from behind him. Shen turned to see her crouching at the top of the crest, her tail

making languid sweeps behind her.

Biting back a furious and possibly hurtful response, Shen suppressed the pain of his many bruises and forced himself to run up the next rolling hill. As he made it to the top, he finally spotted his destination.

The Saanp River was a glorious sight, not just because it was his goal and the end to this abuse, but because it was just plain beautiful. It sparkled in the light of the many breaks in the tree canopy above and flowed down several steps, making small waterfalls.

"What are you waiting for! Run!" Catra called. Shen turned to see her running up behind him on two feet, not even bothering with the advantage of using all four limbs.

You are getting cocky, Catra. I'm going to win this! Shen thought as he raced towards the river. He was five paces away from the cool rushing waters when a hand swiped his foot into the other, making him stumble and fall once again. Before he could rise, a weight pressed down on his back, and two clawed hands seized his wrists, pinning them.

"Wow, I was hoping you would give me more sport than that. *Buuut* I guess that is what I should expect with your stubby legs." Catra teased.

Shen growled as he fought against her grip, furious at being so thoroughly defeated.

"Oh! There he goes! There is a little fight in him! I may have to put a little effort into this!" Catra said.

She squeezed her knees into his sides and pressed her claws into his flesh. The pain had its intended effect and Shen's blood boiled at this added humiliation. Even though it hurt him more, Shen writhed in Catra's grasp, trying everything to get free. Catra only doubled down, rewarding Shen with only more agony.

Calm down, calm down; this is only a game. Shen thought as he attempted to quench the rising wrath.

"You want to summon He-Man? Go ahead; you need him. You are nothing without He-Man to go running to," Catra hissed in his ear.

Catra knew him too well; her words were the key that unlocked the red door to self-hatred, and Shen roared as he felt the Eye of Hated grasp at his soul. Instantly, Catra was off him and kneeling next to Shen—her whole demeanor changing from oppressor to soother. Looking up at Catra through a red haze, Shen saw her sit, crossing her legs and laying her hands on her knees in her meditation position.

"Shen, listen to my voice; let it help you guide you back," Catra said soothingly.

He did as she asked as he forced himself to mimic her position, awkwardly sitting with legs half crossed. He could not form the same circle with his index and thumb as Catra did, only making fists which he pressed into his knees.

"Repeat after me," Catra continued with her eyes closed. "Ommmmmmm… ommmmm... Ommmmmmmmmm…"

Shen tried to do as she asked, making a sound more akin to a low growl than a mantra for peace.

"That's close, Shen; you almost have it," Catra said with a laugh. It was a sweet laugh without a hint of scorn or malice.

"Listen to the tone of the chant, feel the vibrations of my voice and try to match it. Like a harmony," Catra said before beginning the chant anew.

"Ommmmmmmmmmmmmmmmmmmmmm…"

Shen did as Catra instructed and attempted to focus on the simplicity of the chant as he once again tried to form the sound in his throat. Knowing immediately this would not work, Shen looked

past the structure of the sound to the one making it. He focused on the vocalization; Catra's voice was so distinctive and pleasing to Shen's ears. Once he latched on to that, it was only a simple matter to follow this thread to the feeling he associated with the voice's owner, and calmness suffused Shen's body.

"Ommmm…" Shen said tentatively.

Catra opened her eyes, and a wide smile appeared on her face.

"Good! You got it! It worked!" She exclaimed as she patted his shoulder.

Shen let out a long breath and felt himself deflate as the crimson fog drifted away back to where it originated from. He gave Catra a weak smile as he suddenly felt embarrassed.

"What's the matter? You should feel good about yourself. You let go of your anger all by yourself without my brother having to take his Jaadoo Suit off," Catra said with a chuckle.

Shen found himself sharing his friend's laugh but not her confidence. He knew it wasn't him that had been instrumental in banishing the Eye of Hate's influence.

"Yeah, I don't know, Catra. This is well and good now, but what about in the middle of battle? I don't see myself sitting and chanting then,"

"Patience, we will get there. Don't get frustrated," Catra assured.

Shen nodded to her, wanting to assure Catra and not have to discuss it any further.

"Anyway, I'm hungry," Catra said, suddenly placing her fingers on her lips and whistling loudly.

Battle Cat and Melog answered as they came trotting out from behind a Jacarandra tree; small knapsacks attacked their sides.

They stopped and sat on their haunches next to Catra and Shen, mewling their greetings.

"*You lasted a lot longer than I expected, Shen. Good jog trying to evade Catra!"* Battle Cat said happily.

"So, was everyone just following me and watching me run through the forest like an idiot?" Shen said, not bothering to try to hide the annoyance from his voice.

"Hey, it's not our fault you can only run on two legs. We were really trying to make it look like a chase; I could have caught you a while ago," Catra said.

"I'm sure you didn't want to ruin the fun," Shen said, crossing his arms.

Shen knew he had hurt her feelings by the look on her face.

"Do you think I liked hurting you, Shen?" Catra said as she furrowed her brow.

"No, I don't, sorry. I don't know why I said that." Shen conceded.

"We only did it like that because that was the only way I could think of making you mad without having to fight you. Also, that whole thing I said about you being nothing—"

Shen held up his hands, interrupting Catra.

"I know, you didn't mean it. Let's drop it, okay?" He said.

Catra studied Shen for a moment before nodding. Reaching into the bag attached to Melog's side, Catra withdrew food wrapped in paper bundles. She tossed one to Shen, who caught it deftly. She then went to Battle Cat, opening their knapsack to remove fruit brought for the Ethyriels. Catra and Shen then sat on the mossy ground to enjoy their lunch as Battle Cat and Melog lay nearby, gobbling down their meal.

Shen opened his package to find a kind of wrap; he sniffed at it tentatively before taking a bite. Whatever was inside the soft bread was good, although slightly on the spicy side for his liking.

“What is the filling in these wraps?” Shen asked as he coughed slightly.

Catra frowned as she inspected her food.

“Not sure, some Madgēcot secret recipe. It took me a while to get used to, but I feel like I have more energy when I eat it,” she said as she took neat bites of her wrap.

As he pondered this, Shen noticed Catra inspecting him. Trying to see what caught her attention, he looked down at his forearms to see small streaks of blood.

“Sorry, I didn’t mean to cut you that bad,” Catra said with ears lowered.

Shen laughed. “I didn’t even feel a thing.” He said, rubbing the blood away on his pant leg.

Catra scooted closer to Shen and reached to her stomach, removing a section of material from her Jaadoo suit. Shen watched in amazement as the hole magically sealed itself back up, and the exposed portion of her cinnamon fur disappeared.

“Lemme see,” she said, taking his wrist gently.

Catra raised the material to her mouth to lick it, and before Shen could protest, she slapped it over his wound. He had lied earlier when he said it didn’t hurt, but the itching pain subsided as Catra rubbed her thumbs over the patch to help seal it to his skin.

“Now the other,” she said, repeating the process on his other writs.

When Catra was done, Shen rubbed at the strange bandages on his arms. There was something so personal about them; they had

just been touching his friend but now were attached to him via Catra's saliva mixed with a bit of magic.

You're a sentimental idiot, Shen thought as he tried to dismiss what he was feeling.

"See? All better!" Catra exclaimed. "Although I would like to find a way for you to practice calming your anger that doesn't involve drawing blood,"

"Ah, don't beat yourself up over it, Catra. I can take a little pain. Anyway, I think I have the hang of this anger management thing." Shen said nonchalantly.

Catra gave her friend another look as she threw a piece of lunch at him.

"I hope you are serious about this, Shen. I mean it. Besides wanting you to be okay, I'm going to need your help. I can't take on Ado— Despara without He-Man." Catra said with ears lowered.

This surprised Shen; the normally cocky Catra wouldn't usually admit she couldn't do something.

"Really? What about all that talk about how you used to fight Adora as She-Ra during the war on Etheria? How you could handle her? Plus, you have magic on your side now." Shen asked.

Catra let out a long sigh before responding.

"Well, you were right, Shen. Back on the *Pakadna,* before we attacked the Relativity Forge, you mentioned that you thought Adora was holding her She-Ra power back when she fought me during the war on Etheria. Well, now she isn't, and even with my fancy new Jaadoo suit, she almost killed me,"

Shen could see how much this admission cost his friend and laid a comforting hand on Catra's shoulder.

“One of the things I appreciate about you is how strong you are—but it’s okay to admit you need help, Catra. You have many friends who will gladly help you, including me.” Shen said.

Catra gave him a sheepish look as she wiped at one of her eyes.

“You’re such a dummy—but thanks,” she said with a chuckle.

Catra suddenly looked pensive as she stared down at her food, her tail making long sweeps behind her.

“I haven’t admitted this to anyone, so if you repeat it, I’m going to kill you,” she said finally.

Shen made the hand motion for zipping lips and throwing away the key.

“I’m afraid to face her—Despara, I mean. Even now, when I think about it here with you, I’m terrified.” Catra said with a slight shiver.

“I don’t remember anything from either fight I had with Despara, but from the pictures I’ve seen, she is pretty scary looking,” Shen said.

Catra shook her head. “No, I’m not scared of her like that, Shen, and I’m not afraid of dying. What I am afraid of is her killing me. I’m afraid of Despara killing me and then one day Adora getting all her memories back and knowing what she had done to me. Adora is strong, but killing her wife will eat away at her for the rest of her life.”

Catra suddenly burst into tears, surprising Shen, and he pulled his friend into an embrace as she wept.

“I can’t let that happen, Shen! But I also must stop her! I’m constantly torn between wanting to go to her and running away! I don’t know what to do!” Catra said between sobs.

Shen pressed his cheek against the top of Catra's head as she shook with grief. After a moment, Catra lifted herself back up to wipe furtively at her nose and eyes.

"There I go, big bad Catra weeping away," she said with a chuckle.

"Catra, I'm not stupid enough to promise no one will get hurt in a fight. But I promise you, here and now, I will be there for you. I will control my silly issues and use He-Man's power to defeat Despara. I will return Adora to you, I swear it," Shen said as he placed his hand over his heart.

Catra looked down at his chest and smiled. The heart rune was activated, the one Adora had given Shen out of friendship and love. She placed her hand over his, giving it a grateful squeeze.

"Thanks, my friend," she said.

Catra and Shen went back to their lunch, both silent in their individual contemplation. Shen's mind was continuously drawn back to those times he was under the influence of the Eye of Hate and the fact he had no memory of the events. Shen knew he was even worse than Despara during those times, wholly unhinged and willing to use the Power of Grayskull to cause as much damage as possible. Dread filled him, knowing that he could have done anything.

"Catra, can you tell me something?" He asked.

"…Hmmm…?" Catra said between mouthfuls.

"Did I… hurt anyone during those times I was lost? Not hurt like breaking Viraj's arm— which I hate myself for—but I mean… kill?" Shen asked, looking down.

Catra's eyes widened, and she swallowed hard. She looked down at her food as she contemplated her response, then finally spoke.

"Yes, you did," she said.

“Who was it?” Shen said, dreading the answer.

“One of the enemy, a Nephraeh named Nefeli. They were trying to defend Veth, and you killed them,” Catra whispered.

The shame of this knowledge almost drove Shen to tears; he never liked hurting anyone. For every life he had taken, whether intentional or not, was another piece of his soul eaten away.

“Did you know them somehow?” Shen asked, not sure why he wanted the details.

Catra nodded. “Yes, before and after we knew what Veth and their people were up to. Nefeli was the leader of the Krypteia; they weren’t that bad and had a bit of a sense of humor. I think they were close to Veth—very close. Veth took their death very badly, actually. They said the next time they saw you; they would kill you,”

Catra took a bit of her food and then shrugged.

“But Veth is gone now—dead as well. So, I guess that doesn’t matter,” Catra said sadly.

“It matters to me, Catra,” Shen said softly.

Catra smiled at Shen and cocked her head.

“I know. I just don’t want you to beat yourself up over it, that’s all,”

Shen gave a small laugh, already knowing it was too late for that. He then glanced at Catra, unsure if he wanted to say anything further, but decided to anyway. After all, Catra had opened up to him about her fears.

“Catra, do you ever wonder what you would have been like? I mean, if you didn’t have your history? The trauma, I mean.”

Both of Catra's dark eyebrows were raised as she looked at him with mild surprise.

"Sometimes I wonder about that," Shen continued. "Sometimes I wonder how much of a better person I would be if I didn't have this… damage. I've been thinking about it a lot recently,"

Catra pursed her lips as she thought for a moment, absentmindedly running her claws through her mane of stone-gray hair.

"I used to, Shen. Especially after Adora saved me and we defeated Horde Prime. I struggled a lot during those times, especially when I found myself around people who actually cared for me. I learned about words like *toxic environment*, *emotional abuse*, *trauma*, and I understood the amount of damage done to me by Shadow Weaver and the Horde. I would look around at people like Bow, Glimmer, and Perfuma and see how they were not affected by stuff to the same degree as me. I would wish to be like them and I kind of hated myself for it."

Catra suddenly turned to regard Shen intently—her heterochromatic eyes pinning him in place.

"But then I met someone, a person who was hurt even more than me. Someone who grew up in a place way worse than the Horde and had so much pain inflicted upon him that it would have driven anyone else to evil. Despite it all, he still strove to be a good person. I learned so much from him; he taught me that my compassion was my greatest strength and that true love was selfless."

Shen felt his face burning as Catra spoke; she was obviously talking about him.

"So, whenever you wonder if you could have been a better person, Shen, just remember *that.* Remember that you are such a wonderful person that you made me want to be better—scratch

that—you DID make me a better person, and I love who I am now."

Shen had to look away for a moment, his face turning red in embarrassment.

"Wow, Catra… I was just asking it rhetorically; you didn't have to go all touchy-feely on me," he said.

Catra laughed and gave him a light punch on his shoulder.

"Anyway, I know how I would have turned out if I didn't grow up in the Horde. Just look at my brother, he thinks he is all-wise in his Madgēcot ways, but he is naïve in so many others. Can you imagine me like that?" Catra asked dubiously.

Shen laughed as he tried and failed to imagine a proper Madgēcot version of Catra.

"I didn't think so," Catra said, taking a bite of her wrap.

The two friends finished the rest of their lunch in silence as they enjoyed each other's company. When they were finished, they both lay on their backs, looking up at the broad expanse of the tree canopy far above them. Flocks of white birds were streaming between the branches, and the cacophony of their cries echoed down from above.

"Okay, let's get out of here before one of those birds poops on us," Catra said as she stood and brushed herself off.

"So, back to more anger management training?" Shen asked as he joined her.

Catra shook her head. "Naw. Let's just have some fun." She said with a mischievous grin before hopping onto Melog's back.

"Want to race again? No He-Man cheating this time!" Catra said, waving her finger at Shen.

“Definitely!” he responded, hopping onto Battle Cat’s back.

“So! Remember that funny boulder, back where we started? The one that looked like a butt?” Catra asked.

Shen laughed and nodded.

“Well, that’s the finish. You ready? On three! One, two—GO!!!!” Catra shrieked as Melog sped away.

“Cheater!!!” Shen called as Battle Cat leaped after them.

Shen watched terrain that only an hour ago he labored across, speeding past him in the opposite direction. Battle Cat and Melog traveled up and down the rolling terrain so quickly that they seemed to bound from knoll crest to knoll crest. It wasn’t long before they approached the rock, indicating the finish line.

“Faster Melog! There’s *Butt Rock*! We’re gonna win!” Catra cried.

Suddenly, Melog turned their head and mewled at Battle Cat, who nodded in response.

“I was thinking the same thing, Melog,” Battel Cat mewled back.

“What are you doing, Battle Cat?” Shen asked when he felt the Ethyriel speed up.

“Hey! Melog! You can stop now! We won!” Catra yelled. Her long hair whipped back over her head as she turned to regard Shen with a perplexed expression.

A sudden acceleration of speed made both Catra and Shen lay flat on their respective mounts as they clung for dear life. It seemed that their Ethyriel friends had been holding back every time they were ridden and had a secret reserve of speed. Great Jacarandra trees sped past as if they were mere saplings making Shen wonder how much faster they would go. He suddenly thought of moments in his past when he rode on other mounts—once on the back of a Sekth with Shen’Dara and the other on the back of a

speeder with Catra. In both instances, the speeds he had attained were exhilarating, but he was going much faster this time.

A shriek of fear from Catra made Shen turn his head just enough to see her holding onto Melog with teeth gritted and eyes closed. She was barely clinging to them, and looking closer through tear blurred eyes, Shen saw she was using her claws.

How am I holding on then?

Shen felt it then; he was not trying to grip Battle Cat but was lying flat and pressing with every part of his body against his friend. He was moving with Battle Cat, truly riding the Ethyriel instead of trying to control them. He suspected that Melog and Battle Cat were trying to teach them a lesson; they were not simple creatures to be directed this way and that. That any control over them was a complete lie and that Shen and Catra were only allowed to ride on their backs.

Soon both Battle Cat and Melog started to decelerate, and when they were slow enough, stopped short, sending both their riders over their heads to flop on the soft moss.

"Ohhh… we shouldn't have done that right after lunch… I'm gonna barf…" Catra moaned.

Shen let out a chuckle as he watched Catra writhe miserably on the ground as Melog nudged her behind with their muzzle. Battle Cat stuck their face next to his, their feline expression seeming expectant.

"Yeah, lesson learned, buddy," Shen said amicably, patting their green head. Suddenly he thought of something, and his smile became wider.

"You know, I think you two taught me two lessons instead of one," he said thoughtfully.

"What lesson is that? That Ethyriels are jerks? OW! Melog!" Catra yelled.

"No, that they are genius. During that joyride, I was not in control of Battle Cat. They were like a force of nature that I just had to find a way to endure—which I'm good at." Shen said as he stood, placing his hands on his hips.

"Where are you going with this?" Catra asked.

"Don't you see? With the anger, the rage—it's also like a force of nature. I should stop fighting it and… *ride it*… maybe I can direct it to do good instead of evil."

Battle Cat and Melog shared worried looks before glancing at Catra.

"Sounds kind of risky and dangerous, Shen," Catra said thoughtfully before her face broke into a sly smile. "I like it!"

"Well, I think it's a terrible idea," a disapproving Madgēcot voice rang out.

Shen was surprised to see Viraj standing nearby with his arms crossed and tail twitching in irritation. Catra's brother had seemingly appeared out of nowhere to deliver his proclamation, and Shen suddenly felt uncomfortable. He had not spoken with Viraj since their breakup in the medical bay, and to say they parted ways in contention was putting it mildly.

"I thought I smelled something stuffy nearby," Catra said in greeting.

Viraj gave Catra a confused look after quickly smelling himself.

"Viraj, I'm doing the best I can here," Shen said with slight exasperation.

Viraj shook his head firmly. "No, the best you could do is to surrender yourself to our care. You are a danger to yourself and others, Shen,"

Viraj quickly held up his hands to stop Catra's protest.

“But I didn’t come to argue. You are both needed in the Imaarat. It seems something of great importance has come up.”

* * *

The vast space of the Star Hunter headquarters was buzzing with conversation as Shen, Catra and Viraj entered. Catra was not surprised to find that once again, her friends from Etheria were in the center of the hubbub as she spotted Glimmer and Entrapta speaking animatedly with Aadhya. The leader of the Star Hunters noticed the newcomers entering and held her hands up; every Madgēcot in attendance was immediately silent and pinned Shen with slitted eyes. Catra found herself moving closer to her friend protectively.

“We are ready to begin,” Aadhya said with a nod. “As many of you already know, the enemy has just gained two potent sources of magic—the Void Gem and the Eye of Hate. One of the Ultimate Magics falling into anyone’s hands is cause for great concern—let alone an Abominable Power—and we believe we know what the enemy plans to do.”

“Queen Glimmer of Etheria has alerted me to a vision she had recently, a vision granted by the power of the Star Stone. She believes that the enemy is planning an attack on Elysia from Enos; not a physical attack, but a magical one. We suspect that the enemy has not transported the Eye of Hate back to Empyrea but is keeping it on Enos to use in this attack. I will leave it up to Entrapta of Etheria to explain the rest,”

Using her prehensile ponytails, Entrapta lifted herself up above the crowd and addressed them with hands on hips.

“Right! So, much of this is based on my hypothesis—but my theory is sound! As you know, the Empyreans control the Relativity Forge, which has the capability of drawing in or projecting out force. How it does this is beyond my ability to rationale… hmmm…”

A smile crept across Catra's face as the sound of over one hundred Madgēcot tails swished in impatience.

"Anyway! This ability alone cannot harm Elysia, for the force projected outward from Enos would dissipate to insubstantial degrees by the time it reaches the atmosphere. But! This outward force would be able to act as a carrier for something else which could piggyback across lightyears. This something else could be anything; another form of energy, a small-scale projectile, or even magic,"

Loud whispers could be heard throughout the room as the implications were discussed.

"Either one of these powerful sources of magic could be used to destroy us," Aadhya said, quieting everyone. "But we have a plan. We can no longer ignore the threat the Relativity Force poses; we must take it out once and for all!"

"How?! We already tried sneaking in; it didn't work!" Bow asked.

Aadhya shook her head, a feral grin on her face.

"Who said anything about sneaking? We are going to attack them, full-on." She said.

"What about the threat of them using the Mass Motive Array on the nearby stars and wiping us all about?" Bow continued.

"About that!" Entrapta piped up. "I've been studying what information we have on the Relativity Forge. It seems that whatever this Mass Motive Array is, there is no way to turn it off. It's always working, always drawing in or pushing away. Since there is only so much energy the capacitors can store, there must be a point when they must release the energy, or else the capacitors will melt down. Usually, this is done by dispersing the power out through transmission lines, which travel throughout the planet. But since Enos is on lockdown, the usual power demand is much lower, so they need to do something with that extra power."

"I have been watching Enos for some time now, and it appears that they send that energy back out into space, in a direction in which it will scatter harmlessly. Our plan is to wait for this cycle; when we see the discharge, we attack! It will take them a while to recharge the Relativity Forge to a level capable of displacing one of the local stars; it will be plenty of time to do what is needed to be done!"

"There will be two attacking forces," Aadhya said. "One to attack and draw out the majority of the defenders, the other to enter the Forge and finally disable the Mass Motive array. Our friend Entrapta has a device that will do this safely and without the risk of any capacitors with remaining charge exploding."

"What kind of device is this Entrapta?" Glimmer asked suspiciously.

"Oh… just something Horak and I have been tinkering with. We have been trying to improve our portal technology recently and—"

"What!?" Bow suddenly cried. "Oh, no, not again!"

Entrapta immediately held up her ponytails in a placating fashion.

"It's okay! It's okay! While searching Horde Prime's old database, we came across schematics for the portal technology they used throughout the Empire. It's completely safe!" Entrapta said with an all-knowing look on her face.

Glimmer nodded at this. "Yes, I read about that. They were able to travel instantaneously anywhere there was another portal. Go on, Entrapta,"

"So! After hearing about the potential danger of the Relativity Forge, I developed a portal that is *slightly*… What's the word? Hmmm… *volatile*?" Entrapta said with a wince. Everyone instantly shared worried glances.

"But don't worry! It will only be open for a short duration! Just long enough to pull the reactor safely away and thereby remove

the enemy's weapon!"

Aadhya shook her head at Entapta, entirely dubious.

"So, you took an ancient transportation method and turned it into a dangerous weapon?" She asked.

Entrapta nodded excitedly, and Aadhya let out a loud sigh of resignation. She then

turned in Catra's direction; she could tell the Madgēcot leader was staring straight at Shen.

"We need your help with this He-Man. Are your demons under control enough to help us achieve this task?" Aadhya asked.

Before Shen could respond, Catra spoke.

"Yes! Yes, he is!" She yelled.

"And what makes you think that?" Viraj asked dubiously.

Catra didn't bother looking at her brother, only stared into Shen's brown eyes.

"Because I trust him," she said, taking Shen's hand in hers. "He's my best friend,"

Hero

Chapter Summary

> The time had come to remove the knife held at Elysia's throat.
>
> The full fury of He-Man is unleashed.

The crisp sound of boots in snow accompanied Despara as she made her circuit around the Relativity Forge. She enjoyed being out in the cold, away from the stifling heat of the reactor. It also helped her clear her head to think, something she had been doing much of since Veth died.

There was a lot on Despara’s mind today; this was the day they would enact Archon Lethe’s plan to use the power of the Relativity Forge and the Eye of Hate against the Madgēcots. Her leader had explained that this would be a massive blow against the enemies of the Empyrean Empire, to strike directly at the Madgēcots where they live. But try as she might, Despara just could not see sense in it.

She understood the mechanics of the plan, for they were pretty simple; the power of the mysterious Mass Motive Array would transport the essence of the Eye of Hate directly to the people of Elysia and corrupt them with the power of rage.

The next part is what Despara had a problem with; she remembered fighting someone who had been tainted by that very same power. He-Man was an unstoppable force of death when he was under the influence of the Abominable Power. Now they want to do the exact same thing to an entire race of elite warriors? Sure, the Madgēcots would be seen as monsters, for they would go from world to world, decimating everything and everyone they encountered. But who is to say they would not come for the Empyreans first?

When she questioned Archon Lethe about this, they scolded her and once again insulted her intelligence. But Despara was not stupid; she knew Archon Lethe was withholding information and keeping their true motivations secret. If her leader felt they could not share what this was, that only meant that they thought Despara would not go along with it if she knew what it was.

Archon Lethe had said something else that puzzled her. After they had ordered her to transport the Void Gem to them immediately, they told her that in the event of catastrophic failure or attack, she was to transport not only the Eye of Hate back to Empyrea but also the Mass Motive array. Despara was not sure what the leader of the Nephraeh wanted to do with it; from what she understood of its workings, the Mass Motive Array needed the facility built around it in order to operate properly. By itself, it was just a useless rectangular box.

Hearing a familiar sound behind her, Despara turned just in time to see the Relativity Forge conduct its dispersion cycle; the blue beam of light changed to red as the power stored within the great capacitors was discharged into space. It was the last time they would conduct this cycle, for Elysia would be in perfect alignment to be fired upon after the next charge up.

The sound of multiple sharp cracks made Despara whirl around; looking up, she saw starships translating from hyperspace and directly into high atmosphere. Despara instantly recognized the make and design of the strange wooden ships of her enemy—they were unmistakable. With a growl, she spun on her heel and ran towards the Relativity Forge, intent on sounding the alarm.

The Madgēcots were attacking.

* * *

The forward hatch of the lander magically vanished to reveal the snowy waste of the Northern regions of Enos. Glimmer stepped down from the lander and into the snow; it was noon-time, and it was soft and wet from being in the bright sun. Looking left and

right, she saw other landers taking position next to hers, forming a long line as Madgēcots bounded out. They immediately ran in the direction of the Relativity Forge and the group of black figures streaming out of the complex.

"Here we go again," Bow said next to her. He was on Battle Cat's back and notched an arrow as the Ethereal eyed the enemies wearily. Since Melog was going with the other group, He-Man/Shen had asked his friend to accompany the others in case they needed their shrouding abilities.

"I wish they would just wait up for us! Don't they know we can't run that fast!" Seahawk complained.

"Seahawk, you should know better," Glimmer said as she raised her Star Stone staff. "When you're with me, you don't need to run!"

Glimmer instantly transported them right behind the colliding forces of Madgēcots and Nephraeh. Glimmer heard Seahawk give an audible gulp at being so close to an intimidating struggle; Madgēcots leaped and whirled, sending magical cantrips whistling at their foes. These spells were absorbed by black shields, but a few got through, bursting into lengths of material to entrap Nephraeh victims. The Empyreans answered this with projectiles of their own; black spears were sent hurtling towards the Elysians, who easily dodged or batted them out of the air with deft hands. The two sides finally abandoned ranged attacks and closed in on each other in a melee of chops, punches, slashes, and kicks.

"Let's get in there!" Glimmer yelled, and she pointed her staff to send a blast of Star Fire at a group of enemies. The ground exploded under the Nephraeh, projecting them into the air in multiple directions. But they twisted in flight to land elegantly on the ground, completely unharmed.

"Concentrate on the Staff Bearer! Stop her!" One of them cried.

Battle Cat leaped in front of Glimmer as Bow let loose three adhesive arrows in rapid succession. The projectiles burst amongst the Nephraeh like overripe fruit, immediately covering their sleek black armor and holding them fast.

A few made it past the trap, and Seahawk leaped before them, swinging his laser sword wildly.

“Avast!” He cried as he slashed at an enemy. The Nephraeh blocked the sword strike on their gauntlet easily, following up with a leg sweep which landed Seahawk on his back. The Nephraeh looked down at their opponent, shaking their head.

“You shouldn’t be here, human! You will get hurt!” They said.

A black and purple blur collided with the Nephraeh, knocking them down to the ground and pinning them. After a brief struggle, Maira stood triumphant over them as Nephraeh writhed in a binding cantrip.

“You should worry about yourself, Nephraeh,” she said contemptuously.

“Madame, you saved me! Might I know the name of my rescuer, who, I must add, has the most stunning green eyes?” Seahawk swooned.

The black-furred Madgēcot gave him a long-suffering look before turning and leaping back into the battle. Glimmer watched in awe as Maira spun and whirled, assaulting multiple opponents at once. But the skill of the Nephraeh was equally impressive, making Glimmer realize it was a waste that the two great societies fought each other when they could turn their abilities elsewhere.

“Seahawk, maybe you should just get behind Bow and I. Eh? Watch our backs?” Glimmer said to her friend. Seahawk nodded sheepishly as he took up the rear, and Glimmer turned to take stock of the ongoing battle. It seemed to be going well for the Elysians, mostly because Despara was not on the field. But that could mean only one thing.

“Catra, Shen, I hope you guys are alright,” she murmured.

* * *

“Cat-Tra! Look out!!!” Viraj shouted.

He-Man/Shen gripped the back of the pilot throne as Catra—currently in the seat—dodged and weaved Darla around airborne explosions. Since the last time they visited, the Empyreans had installed turret defenses—of which were presently trying to blast Darla out of the sky. To top it off, these defenses were somehow enhanced by sensing capabilities that pierced through the magical shroud the Ethyriels were capable of summoning.

“Thanks, Viraj! You screaming behind my head is really helpful!” Catra shouted back.

Besides He-Man/Shen, Viraj, Battle Cat, and Melog, Darla’s bridge was packed with almost twenty Star Hunters. They slid the floor on tense claws as Catra piloted the ship as chaotically as she could, trying not to make an easy target for the gunners.

“You know, Meera is actually an excellent pilot; perhaps she can take over, sister?” Viraj asked tentatively.

He-Man/Shen saw a female Madgēcot with brown fur and tan stripes look over hopefully as she clung to a forward terminal.

“No way!” Catra growled. “No one is going to pilot my wife’s ship other than me!”

Everyone became momentarily weightless as Catra plunged Darla into a steep dive, heading straight for the Relativity Forge. The vast building grew larger on the view screen the closer they got, again appearing as a cluster of cylinders of varying lengths—the longest being at the center of the building. The bright beam in the middle was again blue as the Empyreans attempted to charge the weapon to be fired; He-Man/Shen that was precisely where they were going.

“Uh, Catra. There is no place to land there,” he whispered in one of her long ears.

“Who said anything about landing?” Catra said with a smile.

Everyone cried out as a massive shock jarred the bridge, followed by an abrupt halt that sent everyone colliding together in a jumble. Darla was currently stopped with her nose pointing directly down as He-Man/Shen found himself in a pile of disoriented Madgēcots on top of the main viewscreen.

“Owww…” Catra moaned. “Can someone get their foot out of my face?”

“Nice landing, Catra,” He-Man/Shen said as he helped a Star Hunter to his feet. “How are we going to reach the exit ramp now?”

He-Man/Shen instantly realized his mistake as over twenty pairs of slitted eyes looked incredulously in his direction.

“Sorry, I forgot who I was talking to,” he said.

Catra leaped up to the pilot’s throne and pressed the button to deploy the landing ramp. All the Madgēcots, plus Melog, leaped to the exit leaving He-Man/Shen to bound out in a single mighty leap. As he landed on his feet, He-Man/Shen saw that they were now in a massive corridor that appeared to veer off gradually, as if it was part of an enormous circle. Behind them was Darla, the ancient spaceship blocking the other direction entirely.

“Good work, Cat-Tra. We appear to be in the corridor surrounding the main reactor; we just have to find the way in.” Viraj said.

“Thanks, bro, at least someone here appreciates what I do,” Catra said pointedly at He-Man/Shen.

“Come on, let’s do this,” He-Man/Shen said as he went to take the lead. A hand on his wrist stopped him, and He-Man/Shen turned to see Viraj looking up at him sternly.

“I’m sorry, Shen, but I believe we would be better off with someone else leading us,” he said.

He-Man/Shen was about to give Viraj an angry reply but saw most of the Star Hunters looking at him wearily. Many he recognized from the trip to Iohiri who probably would never forget having to fight for their life against a rage-fueled He-Man. He ended up only nodding in acquiescence and indicating someone else leads.

“Ease up on him, Viraj,” Catra warned as she took the lead. Viraj only shrugged sorrowfully in reply as Melog stared daggers in his direction.

As Catra led the group down the expansive hallway, He-Man/Shen could not help but notice how eerily quiet it was. The only sound was the collective rustle of multiple Madgēcot feet as they attempted and failed at absolute stealth.

“I know Sparkles is creating a distraction outside, but I expected some kind of resistance,” Catra whispered.

It was then that He-Man/Shen started to hear something else; what he initially took to be his own heartbeat was becoming progressively louder. He realized that he was not hearing anything; it was the Eye of Hate calling to him within his mind. It had to be close—very close—and He-Man/Shen knew his resistance to its call was about to be sorely tested.

“You feel it, don’t you, Shen?” Viraj said to him, the worry plain in his voice.

“Viraj! What did I say?!” Catra shouted as she whirled on him.

He-Man/Shen held up his hands in an attempt to calm his friend.

“No, he is right, Catra. I do feel the Eye of Hate; it is very close to us.” He said.

“This was a mistake; you shouldn’t have come, Shen!” Viraj said with ears lowered.

He-Man/Shen kneeled before his ex-lover, taking Viraj's hands in his larger ones as he gazed into his eyes.

"Viraj, I will never forgive myself for what I did to you; I am so sorry. You were right to push me away, and I see that now. But please believe me, even though you don't like me anymore, please trust I will make this right. I will not let the Eye of Hate control me this time,"

Viraj shook his head fervently. "Shen, I could never not like you. It's just… I don't know…"

"I'm not going to hurt anyone. Not your sister, not you, anyone on our team or on the enemy's side. I swear it, Viraj," He-Man/Shen said, holding his hand over his chest and activating the heart rune.

Viraj only stared up at He-Man/Shen as his tail twitched rapidly behind him, but after a moment, he smiled.

"That is a bold promise Shen—but I will trust you," he said.

"Guys!" Catra interrupted. "Now that you can be friends, can we return to the mission?"

Viraj and He-Man/Shen shared a look before nodding to Catra, and the group continued their journey down the passageway. Soon they spotted a large opening, and from the large amount of heat pouring from its direction, knew this must be the way into the main reactor chamber. As He-Man/Shen entered the enormous space, he instantly saw why they had not run into any resistance; it was there waiting for them.

Despara was standing before them between two large glass cylinders, which were almost as tall as her. Each one contained a horrible black substance; it oozed and writhed against the sizeable wooden stopper sealed at the top with a thick wax. Around Despara and the strange containers were all eleven of the Krypteia; they stood there staring at the intruders with glittering silver eyes behind black face masks.

“Ah! Welcome!” Despara called jovially as she lifted her sword.

He-Man/Shen’s attention was immediately drawn to the massive pile of cables and glowing capacitors at the center of the room. At the top of this heap was the blue beam projecting up through the top of the Relativity Forge and out towards the local suns. Floating suspended within this coruscating energy was the object of his nightmares—The Eye of Hate.

Viraj gasped next to him.

“No! You can’t!” He cried. “Don’t you see what you are going to do, you lunatic?!”

Despara casually turned to look up at the Eye of Hate; it glittered above them like a red star.

“Yeah, I think I do,” she said, holding her chin as if pondering the idea. “We will infect your entire planet with rage, turning you filthy Madgēcots into mindless beasts. It was Archon Lethe’s idea, but I don’t see what difference it will make. The lot of you are no better than animals already,”

Despara spat on the ground as she said it, and He-Man/Shen glanced at Catra. He could tell she was trying to control the hurt from appearing on her face and was baring her teeth as a cover.

“I don’t care what you think of us!” Viraj continued. “Don’t you know what that will do to us? What we will do to everyone around us? Do you think we won’t come to Empyrea and completely eradicate all of you in mindless rage?”

He-Man/Shen saw doubt cross Despara’s face as she hesitated and was about to take action when a gentle hand on his wrist stopped him.

“Shen, careful. Those are Vetala Phylacteries she is standing between. You have not had to face the Vetala yet. They are horrible!” Viraj whispered up to him.

An itching pull at the back of his mind drew He-Man/Shen's attention back to the Eye of Hate. Its light was starting to pulse—rapidly at first—but then decelerating slowly, as if it was trying to sync with another source. He could feel his heartbeat quicken to meet this dark rendezvous, his body betraying his secret desire.

"Noooo…" He-Man/Shen said through gritted teeth.

He suddenly dismissed his sword and held up both hands—index and thumb together in a circle with the others held out.

"Ommmmmm…" he chanted.

"What is this nonsense?" Despara scoffed. "If this is some attempt at a trick, it's a pretty poor one!"

The scorn in Despara's words drove into He-Man/Shen's mind and broke the chant of calm he had learned from Catra. He started to growl as he began to slip towards catastrophe.

But two sets of clawed hands grasping his wrists pulled him back; He-Man/Shen looked down to see Catra and Viraj gazing up at him with their mismatched heterochromatic eyes. There was peace on their faces as they both purred, the gentle vibration traveling through the point of contact to calm him. He-Man/Shen's heartbeat slowed as his body withdrew from the communion with the Abominable Power, and he let out of sigh of relief.

Catra and Viraj released his hands as the three returned to the confrontation with Despara. The Fallen She-Ra watched this entire display with a dawning understanding appearing on her rigid features.

"You are so *weak*. You should have let him use the power the Eye of Hate granted. Maybe then you would have survived THIS!"

Despara spun on her heels as she lashed out with her sword, and both of the Phylacteries shattered into glittering plumes. The contents sloshed onto the floor to form into twenty-two glistening Vetala; they shrieked in hunger as they spotted the intruders and

instantly lunged for them. Despara and the Krypteia joined them, and the two sides clashed in a fury of slashing claws and sword strikes.

Despara slammed her sword down on He-Man/Shen's, surprising him with her massive strength.

"Where is that famed Power of Grayskull I have heard so much about?" Despara sneered.

"It's here; I just don't need it right now." He-Man/Shen grunted.

Despara only laughed at this as she pulled back to deliver two lightning-fast blows with her sword.

"I don't think so, *He-Man,*" she jeered. "I think you're *afraid,*"

He-Man/Shen felt Despara's words dig the old insecurity instilled in him by his father; fear was a weakness.

"I think you are scared of using your full strength because of what you might unleash," Despara said as she suddenly backed away from him. She lifted her sword and jabbed it upward towards the Eye of Hate above them.

"Just give in, *Shen*," Despara said, no longer calling him He-Man.

If she had thought this would provoke him to further anger, she was wrong. Even though her voice was cruel now, hearing his name spoken aloud by her only reminded him of who she once was. A person who did not believe he was too damaged and beyond redemption, someone who believed in him. Adora was inside Despara, somewhere.

"Rishi, NO!!!" Viraj screamed.

He-Man/Shen turned to see three Vetala pull down a Star Hunter and sink their fangs into him. He screamed for help as they drained him, his voice finally ceasing as he lost consciousness.

Despara used the moment's distraction to attack and almost impaled He-Man/Shen on her black sword. He grunted with exertion as he deflected the blow, following it up with a kick to her midsection. Despara quickly leaped away from his strike, and he only met air.

"I see we will be having a Madgēcot joining our ranks; I guess we will take what we can get," Despara taunted.

He-Man/Shen was distracted now as he tried to keep an eye on his allies. He spotted Catra and Viraj fighting back-to-back against a group of Krypteia as the rest of the Madgēcots were just barely holding off the dread Vetala. It didn't look good for any of them.

A lance of pain in his side told He-Man/Shen he needed to keep his attention on Despara. After feeling a hot stickiness at his side, he knew the other Champion had just dealt him a vicious blow.

This is not good. We will all end up drained of our empathy while the entire race of Madgēcots are corrupted by the Eye of Hate. He-Man/Shen thought as he once again looked up at the Abominable Power.

The haze of energy surrounding it was becoming a lighter shade of blue, indicating that the capacitors would be fully charged and ready to fire. Soon it would be all over.

He-Man/Shen charged Despara, slicing at her with alternating sideways and upper sword slashes; she blocked these effortlessly, for they were not done with the intent to deal mortal wounds.

Do I have to kill Adora to save everyone? Is that my choice? He-Man/Shen thought desperately.

"Viraj!!!" Catra screamed.

He-Man/Shen turned to see Catra struggle as three Krypteia attempted to subdue her. Viraj was on his back with a Vetala straddling him, his hands on its throat as he desperately tried to keep it from biting him. Viraj was slowly losing this battle as the

Vetala gradually overcame his strength and lowered its black fangs toward his neck.

"NOOOOOOO!!!!!!"

Everyone present in the chamber, from Madgēcot to Vetala, stopped what they were doing to look for the source of the harsh and powerful voice. With astonishment, He-Man/Shen realized it was him they were looking at—he didn't even remember speaking. All he remembered was…

Too late, He-Man/Shen realized he was already sliding away into the embrace of the Abominable Power. There was no time for chanting or soothing from his friends; He-Man/Shen hurtled down a long dark tunnel towards the red core of fury. He tried to stop, but he was going so incredibly fast it seemed, faster than he had ever gone, much like…

A ride along a twilight road as he clung to someone who would become the love of his life…

…holding on to another as she piloted a roaring speeder across a desert waste. She was howling with glee as her hair tickled his face. This was when he started to fall in love with her…

…gripping a saddle as he rode his new-found friend, they race against other friends in a moment of bliss…

The memories summoned are a thin membrane of virtue, enabling the plummeting He-Man/Shen to harness the winds of rage around him. He found he could not slow his descent but direct his course.

Don't you see? With the anger, the rage—it's also like a force of nature. I should stop fighting it and… ride it… maybe I can direct it to do good instead of evil.

He-Man/Shen stopped trying to slow his descent and let go. Just before the Eye of Hate swallowed him, he altered his course slightly, moving up and around the red inferno. Every time it

began to draw him in, he veered again, moving away just far enough to keep from being engulfed. He-Man/Shen was like a small object that had attained orbit around a red star—not allowing himself to be swallowed but close enough to bask in its power.

He-Man/Shen saw red, but there was no black. Just red.

Red. Red. Red.

* * *

Dread filled Catra as she watched her best friend transform. Crimson light flared out from the center of his body, much like the Demon Heart did once before. But instead of transforming into the hulking beast she encountered the last time she was in the Relativity Forge, He-Man/Shen kept his current shape. The red light spread throughout his body, and when it receded to his center, Catra saw that he was now translucent, like a red gem in the shape of He-Man/Shen. With his transformation complete, he turned to regard Catra with bright red eyes; they stabbed at her like two laser beams.

"No!" Viraj gasped next to her.

He-Man/Shen's face was a picture of rage barely in check; with brows furrowed, his face jerked with ticks as his mouth formed a grimace. But then his lips parted, exposing teeth, and Catra realized he was attempting a smile.

"It's okay, Viraj. Shen is in control; he's got this," she said softly but firmly.

At that moment, Despara came up behind her enemy, looking to put down He-Man/Shen with a sword thrust through his back.

"Adora, NO!" Catra shouted.

Before she could succeed, He-Man/Shen kicked backward, hitting Despara in the midsection. She flopped down on her stomach to

spin away as her jagged headpiece clattered on the ground. As Despara came to a rest, she gazed back at He-Man/Shen incredulously, and Catra felt a pang in her heart to finally see her wife's face in its entirety once again.

Shrieking with rage, the Vetala rushed at He-Man/Shen; they sensed a significant threat in his presence and sought to tear him to shreds with tooth and claw. A quarter of their number was bisected by a mighty sweep of He-Man/Shen's red sword; they dissipated into a black haze as the rest of the monsters leaped upon him. They raked at him with black talons and bit with black teeth, but try as they might, the Vetala could not penetrate his newly formed crystalline body.

"Catra! We need to activate Entrapta's device! We are running out of time!" Viraj said, drawing Catra's attention away from the battle. She instantly saw that the blue haze was gone and the many capacitors pulsed with energy, ready to be released. The enemy would be firing the device soon, and they had to act now.

Catra motioned to a nearby Star Hunter. He immediately ran to her, carrying the dimensional portal in a satchel at his back, and handed it to her.

"Melog! I'm gonna need some help with this!" She called to her friend.

Catra leaped on the Ethyriel's back, and together they bounded towards the reactor in the center of the chamber. Catra held tightly to her friend's back as they scrabbled and leaped up the massive tangle of cables and pipes, steering clear of the blazing hot capacitors. Finally reaching the top, Catra saw the gaping hole in which the Mass Motive Array's strange ability drew and repelled energy. High above her, the Eye of Hate spun in midair—an ugly red rock with a hideous pulsing light. She placed the oblong device near the aperture's edge and inspected its workings.

"Okay, Entrapta said all I have to do is press this button, and I will have—what did she say? Five seconds to get away?" Catra

mumbled to herself.

With a shrug, Catra activated the dimensional portal; it lit up with beeps and flashing lights. Not wanting to wait around, she hopped back on Melog, and together they tore down the side of the reactor as fast as Ethyriel's legs could muster.

Catra's ears flattened as she perceived a sound like a fire igniting while a slight tugging sensation drew her backward. But Melog's powerful momentum overcame the attraction of the dimensional portal's opening, and they escaped to a distance safe from its influence. Catra looked up to see the results of her efforts, seeing a disc of chaotic light at the apex of the reactor. It was opening slowly, like a dilating pupil, and parts of the reactor started tearing away.

"It's working!" Viraj exclaimed.

Catra returned her attention to He-Man/Shen and was once again amazed by the immense strength of his new form. He had freed himself of the Vetala and slowly eliminated the creatures with brutal sweeps of his sword. One of the Vetala had managed to wrap its body around the mighty blade, and He-Man/Shen simply dismissed, using only his bare hands on his foes. He grabbed Vetala one by one, tearing limbs from their bodies as the onyx monsters shrieked with incomprehension. A few had by now retreated instead of facing such an implacable foe.

When the Krypteia joined the fight, Catra could not help inwardly wincing. She imagined the corrupted He-Man using his red sword on the living Nephraeh as he just did with the Vetala, but her fears were unfounded. He-Man/Shen lashed out with fists or delivered hand chops to each Krypteia that approached him, incapacitating each one into an unconscious stupor.

"I guess he is keeping his promise," Viraj whispered next to Catra, who let out a brief laugh.

"*Well*, his exact words were that he wouldn't *hurt* anyone," she said as He-Man/Shen struck a Krypteia in the face so hard their mask shattered.

The Madgēcots stepped in, helping He-Man/Shen subdue the rest of the enemies, and Catra was not surprised that he paid them no heed. Returning her attention back to the slowly opening portal, Catra saw that it had not made much progress; it was now two arm lengths in diameter and starting to move downwards to consume the reactor. But the capacitors still glowed, indicating it was fully operational, and a deep thrum was heard and felt throughout the facility. The weapon was prepared to fire; they had run out of time.

"Shen! Please, do something!" Catra screamed.

She was unsure why she had yelled to him, but as soon as Catra spoke his name, He-Man/Shen's head whipped around. He saw Catra pointing a black claw-tipped finger up at the encroaching doom of the Madgēcots and immediately sprang into action. He-Man/Shen ran towards the pulsing reactor, appearing to everyone as a furious red comet, and leaped upwards toward the top.

"What is he doing? He is going to get himself ki—" Viraj started to say.

But He-Man/Shen's trajectory took him nowhere near the dimensional portal—he was going for the Eye of Hate. With a tremendous roar, he lifted his red sword and slammed it into the Abdominal Power—what happened next was utterly unprecedented since the coming of The Dread Powers to this universe. The Eye of Hate was destroyed as it exploded into a deep red fireball, the bottom of which was sucked into the dimensional portal, protecting those on the ground from its final fury. The ceiling and roof of the Relativity Forge were not so fortunate as they disintegrated in the Abdominal Power's death throes. The Madgēcots below took cover from falling debris, casting shielding cantrips for themselves and their captive Nephraeh.

Looking around, Catra spotted He-Man Shen lying on the ground, appearing unconscious, and ran to him. She was happy to see that he had reverted to his normal He-Man form and no longer appeared corrupted as she almost slid into him in her excitement.

"Shen! Are you okay, buddy?" She asked as she shook him.

He-Man/Shen groaned as he sat up, peering at Catra through one open eye.

"I think so," was all he said.

Viraj was standing nearby, absolute awe on his cinnamon face as he gazed at He-Man/Shen.

"Do you have any idea what you just accomplished?" Viraj asked in a hush.

He-Man/Shen moaned as he rose to his feet and dusted himself off.

"Yeah, the therapy worked. I was finally able to get rid of some baggage," he said simply.

Viraj and Catra laughed as they hugged He-Man/Shen tightly; he smiled down at the Madgēcots before something caught his attention.

"Despara," he said.

Catra turned to the Dimensional Portal; it seemed that it had gained momentum and was now five times its previous size. It was halfway down the reactor, which had been lifted off the chamber floor as it was consumed. Catra could see what could only be the mysterious Mass Motive Array floating beneath it as a prominent black armored figure raced towards it.

"Adora!" Catra shrieked. "Don't do it! It's too late!"

Despara glanced furtively over her shoulder as she continued to run towards the Mass Motive Array. As she yanked it bodily from its suspension field, Despara turned and struggled against the power of the dimensional portal to escape.

“No…” Catra whispered as dread filled her stomach.

Despara fell to her stomach as she slammed her feet and hand into the hard floor, attempting to climb her way away from the gravitational pull of the portal. But she was not going fast enough as Despara refused to let go of her prize; Catra knew her wife was about to die.

“Shen!” She said, desperately clutching at his massive bicep. “Please! Do something!”

He-Man/Shen looked down at Catra, his face softening. He smiled and nodded before bounding away to rescue Despara. Catra instantly felt a jolt of anxiety as she realized what she had just done and attempted to go after her friend.

“No, Shen, wait!” She cried before Viraj grabbed her.

“Cat-Tra! Do you want to die too?”

Catra sagged in her brother's arms as she watched He-Man/Shen suddenly be seized by the force of the Dimensional Portal. He was yanked into the air and flew towards Despara, but before He-Man/Shen was drawn in, he slammed his sword into the ground next to her. Despara looked up incredulously as she was plucked up by He-Man/Shen, who lifted her bodily over his head.

“RRRRRRAAAAAAGGGGGHHHH!!!” He-Man/Shen bellowed as he threw Despara with all his reserves of power. She sailed towards Catra, but before she made it completely out of the area of effect, she slammed down on the ground. Once again, Despara used her feet and hand to pull herself away, but now that she was farther from the epicenter of the portal, she was finally successful in escaping its pull.

Despara stood, still clutching the Mass Motive Array, and walked over to stand next to Catra. Catra looked up at her estranged wife furtively before returning her attention to He-Man/Shen as he struggled to escape his doom. The dimensional portal was now expanded to its maximum radius, and a whistling shriek was heard as it consumed the last portion of the reactor. All that was left below it was He-Man/Shen, who attempted to escape its pull in the same fashion Despara had. He slammed his powerful hands into the hard floor as he kicked in footholds with his boots. He-Man/Shen was making much slower progress than the other Champion, for the portal was directly above him, howling like a great mouth. Soon, he could go no further, and momentarily resting his head against the ground, lifted back up to gaze at Catra and Viraj.

"Noooo! It can't end like this!" Catra pleaded.

Smiling slightly, He-Man/Shen nodded to them before he was ripped away and swallowed by the portal. He was gone as if he had never existed at all.

"Why did he do that?" A voice asked.

Catra looked to see Despara looking at the portal with complete confusion on her face.

"Because he was your friend, Adora," Catra said between tears.

Despara looked down at Catra, and for a moment, she could have sworn there was recognition in her wife's eyes. But then it was gone, replaced only by cruel regard.

"What an idiot," she said dismissively.

Catra fell to her knees as a great gasp of anguish escaped her lips, and she hugged herself as tears fell from her eyes. She felt Viraj come up beside her to wrap her in his arms; his face was wet as he pressed his cheek against her forehead. The siblings looked up just in time to see the dimensional portal collapse in on

itself with a loud pop; all that was left of the reactor were torn pipes and cables which crackled with electricity.

In the sudden stillness, Catra heard Despara stamping away. She turned to see the fallen She-Ra stride menacingly towards where the Madgēcots held the Krypteia prisoner.

"*Move*, fleabags," she snarled.

The Star Hunters looked questioningly at Catra, who waved them away.

"Just let her go, let them all go," she said, the words coming out drained of all emotion.

As Despara kneeled amongst the bound Nephraeh as the surviving Vetala crept out of nearby shadows to press their back bodies against the Empyreans. Just as they did on Elysia, the Vetala began to melt, forming a black portal into which Despara and her fellows sank. Before her blond head disappeared below the surface, Despara gazed back at Catra, her expression unreadable. Then Despara was gone, just as before, whisked away by dark means straight to Empyrea, and another person Catra cared for was taken from her.

The forces of Elysia had scored a great victory today; not only had they freed the planet of Enos from the invaders and removed a threat to several systems, but an Abdominal Power had been wiped from existence. Catra knew it was a cause for a grand celebration, but at that moment, she only felt loss. She could only push herself into her brother's loving embrace as she wept. Soon, the silence of the great chamber was replaced by a low keen of mourning as the Madgēcots marked the loss of a great hero.

Guilt

Chapter Summary

Despara returns to Empyrea to face Archon Lethe.

The Madgēcots and Etheirans return to Elysia to celebrate a victory and mourn the lost.

Sick of losing the people close to her, Catra ponders a new destiny.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It was late evening as Despara exited the House of the Penumbra on Empyrea; she had just translated via Skotos portal and was fresh from her defeat on Enos. The setting sun bathed the entire city of Nox in red light, reminding Despara of her failure; the Eye of Hate was destroyed, and the Madgēcots were left uncorrupted. Squinting, she gazed down the long Avenue of Triumph and to her destination, the Hall of Light, where Archon Lethe surely waited for her.

"Let's get this over with," Despara growled.

Tucking the Mass Motive Array under her arm, Despara descended the House of the Penumbra stairs and onto the processional avenue, her booted feet clicking loudly against the hard pavement as she marched. On any other given day, the street would have been full of Nephraeh going about their business, but that was not the case now. What city residents Despara did see steered clear of her as their silver eyes regarded her with hostility.

I hate these people, Despara thought as she purposefully changed direction to confront two Nephraeh.

"Do you have a problem with me?" She asked, looming over them.

The two stopped and gazed up at their only Champion, and Despara realized with a start that they were holding hands. She found this very odd, for not only was open affection never seen among Nephraeh but it was also frowned upon.

"No, Champion Despara, we do not," one of them said coolly.

The more Despara regarded these Nephraeh, the more unusual they seemed. There was an unreserved quality to them; it was they were more alive and vibrant, and Despara straight away felt very aggravated being so close to these two.

"Um, okay… that's good," Despara stuttered as she backed away.

The look of distaste the two initially had for her vanished, and the Nephraeh glanced at each other. When they finally turned back in her direction, there was no mistaking the emotion which was plain on their lilac faces.

"Are you okay, Champion Despara? Do you require assistance?" One of them asked.

Despara felt revulsion at the concern in their voice and almost tripped over her own feet as she tried to get away. She turned from the Nephraeh and hurried off, desperate to be away from how the Nephraeh made her feel. As she continued down the Avenue of Triumph, she noticed more Nephraeh looking in her direction—as if they sensed her discomfort. Wisely none of them approached Despara; in her heightened agitation, she would have killed them.

The changes Despara noticed were not reserved only for the Nephraeh; here and there, she spotted color applied to the usually drab surfaces that comprised the city of Nox. It was not only on the buildings but also on the columns spaced along the processional. It was even on the road itself; with a curl of her lip, Despara could see she was currently walking along an unmistakable rainbow.

"What is going on around here?" She hissed as she quickened her pace.

Despara felt relief as she reached the end of the processional avenue and the beginning of the broad stone staircase that led up to the Hall of Light. She glanced furtively behind as she stomped up the stairs—as if making sure she was not pursued. Finally, she arrived at the doors of the Hall of Light, guarded by two Centurions; these heavily armored warriors only nodded curtly in her direction as Despara advanced. She was surprised at how relieved she felt.

At least these Nephraeh don't appear to be losing their minds, she thought as she entered the Hall of Light.

Crossing the vast hall which encircled the Grand Assembly Chamber, movement caught Despara's eye, and she stopped to peer into the shadows behind the mighty columns which held the domed roof up. Despara spotted a figure there, squatting in the dark, and she drew closer, wanting to see who or what it was.

"Who is back there? Show yourself!" she cried, summoning her sword.

The figure stumbled out, and Despara was surprised to see that it was a Vetala. It blinked up at her with black eyes and licked its fangs with a black tongue, but there was something off about this one; the usually glossy black body was dull and its movements sluggish.

"I wonder who you might be?" Despara mused.

After Veth's demise, Archon Lethe had told Despara about the true nature of the Vetala—that they were the souls of Nephraeh trapped in hideous vessels. She did not think much of it at the time, not really caring where the creatures came from, only that they fought for her.

As Despara inspected this Vetala, a thought occurred to her, and she smiled.

“Veth?” She asked tentatively.

The Vetala made no indication it recognized that name, and Despara shrugged, turning away with a snort to continue into the Grand Assembly Chamber.

The immense circular space was lit by the setting sun's red glow pouring through the domed ceiling's open skylights. If the crimson light hadn’t reminded Despara of her shame, then the indigo gaze of Archon Lethe did; they were seated at their high lectern like a bird of prey in their nest.

“Greetings, Despara,” they said simply.

“Archon Lethe,” Despara said, doing a slight bow.

“Come before me,” they said, emphasizing the command by pointing a black clawed finger down at the ground.

Swallowing her fury at being spoken to so disrespectfully, Despara walked down the ramp between the many pews that filled the assembly hall and halted at the base of Archon Lethe’s lectern. She kneeled there, not saying a word.

“Are you going to give me news of Enos, or are you going to sulk down there?” Archon Lethe finally said after an uncomfortable silence.

Despara bit back her initial response, instead deciding to bring to light her strange encounters.

“I apologize, My Archon; I am just unsettled by some of the things I saw since arriving on Empyrea. The city seems to be… changing…”

Archon Lethe let out a long sigh that ended in a chuckle.

“Yes, that. This happens whenever the bearer of Zhe-La falls. There is a slight… *waning* in my powers which returns when Zhe-

La is established in a new bearer. Until then, my people have a brief time of *privilege* which I allow," they said.

A giddy feeling overcame Despara. *The fool admits to me they are weak. Perhaps this is my chance to kill them?*

Despara's thoughts of domination escaped her as she thought of trying to control the Nephraeh. It wouldn't work; they hated her.

"Will this waning of your power also affect me, My Archon?" Despara asked, thinking of the Vetala she had seen outside the Grand Assembly Chamber.

Archon Lethe shook their head. "No, I just can't expend my resources as I could before. Transporting you from Elysia has taxed me. I need time to replenish,"

Again, they admit weakness. Is this some kind of trap? Despara thought to herself.

She gazed up at the ruler of the Nephraeh, using her powers to enhance her vision and get a closer look at them. Archon Lethe did not look weaker—their pure white skin projected vigor, and their eyes radiated power. But she had seen the evidence of their vulnerability all around as she approached the Hall of Light. Perhaps this was her chance to strike.

Archon Lethe's pointed stare drew Despara out of her reveries, and she cleared her throat.

"Yes, Enos, I was just getting to that. Umm… so you see, everything was going according to plan. We were powering up the weapon to fire upon Elysia when the Madgēcots launched a surprise attack. I was guarding the reactor along with the entire force of Krypteia and Vetala when He-Man struck. At first, I thought I could defeat him, but he somehow augmented his power again…" Despara said.

"Using the Eye of Hate. Interesting…" Archon Lethe mused, holding a clawed fingertip to their lips.

"I'm not sure if that was what it was. He-Man did return to his normal form after he destroyed the Abdominal Power,"

"WHAT?!" Archon Lethe hissed incredulously. "Impossible!"

"I do not lie; I saw it for myself," Despara growled before remembering herself and adding, "My Archon,"

This statement only drew Archon Lethe into further musings.

"I suppose I underestimated this bearer of He-Man; he will need to be neutralized… *or turned*…"

Despara shook her head, happy to be able to deliver good news.

"He-Man is no more; he is dead, my Archon. The same weapon the Elysians used to eliminate the reactor also killed He-Man. He is gone,"

Archon Lethe shrugged. "That's too bad. I could have used him,"

Despara was instantly annoyed; she expected a better response at the demise of He-Man. It was as if she were telling Archon Lethe it was raining outside for all they seemed to care.

"Did you at least get the Mass Motive Array as I commanded? Surely you didn't mess that up, Despara," Archon Lethe said caustically. Fury bloomed inside Despara, but she successfully suppressed it. There was an opportunity here, and she would not miss it because of foolish emotion.

"It's right here, My Archon," Despara said, holding up the smooth rectangular device. "Perhaps you should take a closer look at it? I may have damaged it in my stupidity."

Archon Lethe smiled down at her, and Despara felt her first spasm of doubt. The way they were looking at her was predatory, like a cat regarding a mouse.

“Yes! Of course, you’re right, Despara!” They said, stepping off the lectern and into the air.

Archon Lethe floated in the air momentarily before they started to drift down slowly with arms held out to either side. As they neared her, Despara was struck again by just how immense Archon Lethe was. Seen from a distance, their slender and lithe form was beautiful but appeared weak. Now, with them landing to stand right next to her, Despara was struck by the raw majesty of their presence. She felt dizzy being so near to them and had to stop herself from falling to her knees.

It's some kind of trick; they are using a spell on me. I just have to maintain my focus, Despara thought as she gritted her teeth.

Archon Lethe kneeled to inspect the Mass Motive Array, spreading their fingers over its smooth surface. Despara tensed; this was her chance. The Nephraeh leader wasn’t even looking at her; she had to act now. Summoning and swinging her sword in one sweeping motion, Despara struck at Archon Lethe with all of her enhanced might.

“RRRRRAAAAAGGGHHHH!!!”

Despara pitched forward, almost falling onto her face with the momentum of her death strike, and at once realized there was nothing there to hit. A low chuckle made Despara pivot on her heel to swing wildly behind her—but again, she only met air. Despara panted with fury as she looked about the vast chamber, looking for her quarry.

“*Tsk, tsk*, so predictable,” Archon Lethe taunted. Their disembodied seemed to come from everywhere at once, making Despara feel even more frantic than before.

“Show yourself and face me!” She screamed.

Archon Lethe abruptly appeared before Despara, and she shrieked, drawing her sword back to thrust it directly through their stomach. What would have usually been a fatal wound did not

seem to bother the Nephraeh Lord as they gazed down at Despara, indigo eyes bright with mirth.

“You never really appreciated me, did you, Despara?” Archon Lethe said as they clutched her black sword.

Despara yanked back at her blade, but it did not budge, nor could she remove her hands from it. With mouth agape, she stared at the point of penetration; there was no blood, only Archon Lethe’s parted perfect white skin. They reached for her then, gently but firmly placing their large hands on her shoulders. Despara looked at the hands that held her, seeing them closely now; the blackness of their claws extended down their fingers like stains. Archon Lethe drew her closer to them, her sword moving deeper into them as they embraced her.

“You want to kill me, Despara?” Archon Lethe asked as they cupped her chin. Their words were sad, like a lover who could not believe they were no longer wanted.

She felt their power immediately, their transcendent might; it disseminated from their body, through the sword, and into her. Despara thought she knew power when she first grasped the magic of She-Ra upon her awaking, but her Champion Avatar paled in comparison to this. What was entering her body was pure and unadulterated; it could not be seized. Instead, it dominated her, and Despara gasped as it gripped her very soul.

“What are you?” Despara asked, barely forming the words.

Archon Lethe only smiled beneficently to her as they rubbed a finger gently over her mouth.

“I am your Archon,” they said, pushing a black clawed thumb between her lips to seize her jaw. “I own you,”

Despara knew then what a fool for even considering defeating Archon Lethe; they were beyond her. She tried to go limp in their arms, but even this was not allowed her, for Archon Lethe had absolute control over her body and remained rigid. Despara felt

Archon Lethe release her then, both physically and magically, and she slumped to her knees before them, defeated.

"I am ready, Archon Lethe. Kill me," she said.

Archon Lethe only laughed at this; it was high-pitched and piercing.

"Why would I do that, Despara? Because you tried to attack me? Kill me? No!" They said, laying a hand on her blond head. "That was just a little disagreement, and it was all my fault, really. I should have made you understand the full extent of our *relationship* when you first came back to us,"

Despara looked up at Archon Lethe, surprised at her disappointment at being granted her life.

What life is this? In servitude to a god to be used? She thought miserably.

"*But,*" Archon Lethe continued, holding a finger as if she were a naughty child. "There will be consequences for this little rebellion. You will start taking the Antithetical Philter and join the Penumbra Ritual like the rest of my closest servants. Do you understand?"

Humiliation heaped upon humiliation, Despara thought as she nodded.

"Now, with that unpleasantness behind us, let's focus on what we want to accomplish. Your screw-up on Enos is not a complete failure, for I believe I can still salvage something from it. If I know my Madgēcot friends, the death of He-Man can work to our advantage. He will be a Martyr, driving the Elysians to rage even without the Eye of Hate. But first…"

Archon Lethe picked up the Mass Motive Array in one hand as they inspected it. Then, with a smirk, they drove their other hand directly through its surface to grasp its innards.

"Whaaaa…" Despara cried, completely dumbfounded.

Archon Lethe ripped the Mass Motive Array away, like a wrapper over a piece of candy, and threw the empty shell over their shoulder. Despara could not believe her eyes when she saw what they had withdrawn.

It was a wooden staff, smooth and worn from eons of use, inlaid with fine silver pictographs. At its top was a faceted crystal sphere —but this was no ordinary jewel—it pulsed with soft light which radiated both outward and inward, perpetually in motion.

"Is that a Staff of Power, My Archon?" Despara asked.

Archon Lethe nodded sagely. "This is the Kinetic Krystal, My Child. The Enosians had somehow taken it from its bearer and used it for the past millennia to power their planet. Now it's ours,"

As Despara took this in, she realized how pleased she felt that Archon Lethe had called her *My Child.* She hated herself for it.

"I have been working on reattaching the Void Gem to its own staff, and when I am done, we shall have two Staves of Power!" Archon Lethe said.

"Who will bear these staves? Members of the Krypteia? Or the Gnosis? I am not sure if wielding a staff and sword is right for me, My Archon," Despara said mournfully.

Archon Lethe regarded Despara with an almost kind smile as they shook their head.

"No, My Child. I have someone else in mind," they said, turning towards the entryway of the Grand Assembly Chamber.

"You can come down now!" they called.

Two figures entered and strode purposefully down the walkway to Archon Lethe and Despara. As they neared, Despara saw they were not Nephraeh but two women dressed in Aegis Lace body suits. One was a huge white-haired woman with red endoskeleton armor plates on her shoulders, matching red clawed hands, and a

segmented tail. The other had dark brown hair and was shorter; she moved with an insouciance that matched her gaze.

"These are Princesses from Etheria; they have come across the Galaxy to join my cause. The large one is named Scorpia, and the other is Mermista. They will be my Staff Bearers,"

Despara was amazed to see recognition in both woman's eyes as they regarded her; the larger one, Scorpia was her name, even smiled.

"Hey, Adora, I see you have decided to join us," Scorpia said.

Shock coursed through Despara at hearing that name directed at her from someone on her side, and she cast an almost pleading look at Archon Lethe. Almost sorrowfully, they smiled back at Despara and placed their hands again on her shoulders.

"My Child, there is a lot we have to talk about."

* * *

All lights in the City of Roshanee were extinguished as its residents gathered on walkways, platforms, and balconies—their feline eyes shining in the dark night as they waited. Three long blasts of a mighty horn suddenly pierced the silence, echoing off the mighty Jacarandra Trees that held up the city and making the many Madgēcots flatten their ears. It was the ancient Turahī, created by the Madgēcots to warm of approaching horrors during the Dark Times. But now, it was being used for a different purpose, and its deep and mournful dirge was the only sound allowed during the Ceremony of Remembrance.

After its toll had ceased, a single figure strode out into the dark expanse at the city's center, holding a single fire aloft. They approached a wide platform via a walkway, and when they reached their destination, lit the signal fire found there. From her viewpoint, Catra watched as hundreds of torches, candles, and bonfires were lit in response, filling the vast city amongst the trees with warm light. It symbolized the coming of the Light to the

universe so long ago, a light that spread and cast away the evil of that era. It was a perfect way to memorialize the passing of a Champion of Grayskull.

The Madgēcots were marking the passing of someone who was not only great but had selflessly sacrificed himself for the Madgēcots. If not for Shen destroying the Eye of Hate, the entire planet of Elysia would be a world of burning fury, and the race of Madgēcots would be the scourge of the galaxy. Catra's people had elevated her best friend to the position of a saint—forever remembered and loved. She had even heard talk of a statue commissioned in his likeness. It was to be placed somewhere down on the forest floor; Catra knew the perfect place for it, somewhere beautiful that would have had meaning to Shen.

Catra wiped her eyes for what seemed the hundredth time and turned to the others on the viewing platform. Bow and Glimmer held each other as Seahawk openly wept into Entrapta's comforting shoulder. The diminutive princess did not seem to be affected by the proceedings, and Catra was not sure if she would even if she had her empathy returned to her. Viraj was in the back of the platform—arms crossed as he watched the torchlight. The death of Shen had affected her brother in ways that Catra had not expected; besides the sadness, there was an anger that had been awakened inside him. Catra was unsure if it was towards the Nephraeh or himself; she knew the blame game all too well and could only imagine her twin brother was the same way.

As Catra approached her brother, she saw the pique vanish from Viraj to be replaced by receptiveness as he opened his arms to her. Catra noted tear tracks in the fur of Viraj's face and knew her own face must be a mirror of his as she embraced him. The Madgēcot siblings purred as they held each other, and Catra placed her mouth next to Viraj's long ear to whisper to him, breaking the protocol of remembrance.

"It's not your fault Viraj; even if you had forced yourself to stay with him, Shen would have still done what he would have done," she said.

Viraj gave his sister a gentle squeeze in thanks as he brought his face near her ear in return.

"Neither is it your fault, sister. You did not tell Shen to sacrifice himself; he would have done it anyway. He loved Adora; she is his friend,"


Ansdrela

Catra felt fresh tears burn her eyes at his words and nodded thankfully. She disagreed but wanted Viraj to think his words had affected her. She broke from his embrace, suddenly wanting to be somewhere else, away from all these people and their ceremony. There would be a joyous celebration later, but she was not in the frame of mind for levity; her mood was too heavy and disconsolate.

Catra walked down the stairs from the viewing platform and onto a long walkway, not really having a destination in mind and letting her feet take her away. She crossed several more platforms before reaching the many stairs she recognized as leading to the forest floor. Not stopping, she continued down, the lights from the many fires of the ceremony receding as she moved closer to the forest floor. Soon she was at the bottom of the stairs and on the stone walkway, the light of Elysia's moons and phosphorescent insects providing the only light source now. It was more than enough for Catra to see; her sensitive Madgēcot eyes were made for this environment.

As Catra continued along the path, her mind conjured memories of Shen; the time she first met him as an assassin sent to kill Adora and the time they bonded during Perfuma's therapy sessions. That day she had taken him to the Crimson Waste to the moment he had saved everyone by taking up his father's sword. All just memories now of a friend she had for what seemed only a short time but whose life impacted her significantly. Catra wept more tears for Shen, for, in the end, he did not want power or fame—although he had both. Shen only ever wanted to be loved in life, much like she did, and the sorrow for him not having a true love before his death was heartbreaking for her.

Now Shen was something he never wanted to be—a Martyr—for the Madgēcots were now holding him up as an example of righteousness. Someone to be emulated. Catra laughed at this thought, giving her a moment's relief from the pain. Shen would have found the fact that he was being held up as a paragon of nobility ridiculous—although she would disagree with him. Nor did

she agree with her people's reasons for celebrating Shen—that he had sacrificed himself for them. Catra knew better.

Shen has saved the Madgēcots by destroying the Eye of Hate, but that was not what killed him. Shen had died saving his enemy, Despara; when she was about to be consumed by the dimensional portal, he had taken her place. He had done it because he was asked to by his best friend, someone he loved and trusted. Shen had saved Despara—no, Adora—for Catra. Because he loved her.

Why did I ask him to do it? Why? Did I know he would sacrifice himself? Catra thought as she gritted her teeth. *Better question yet; would I do it again knowing what I know now?*

The moment Catra thought this, new tears formed in her eyes. She knew the answer and hugged herself in despair. It was the most unfair of questions to be asked whom do you love more, and Catra was slowly beating herself to death with the answer.

"Oh, Shen… I'm so sorry, I'm so, so sorry, my friend." She cried softly into the dark night.

Catra wished there was someone to hold her at this moment, but there was no one. She had left hastily to be by herself and had not told anyone where she was going. This desire for solace left her as a light caught her attention; it was a soft green glow, up ahead and around the bend. The Giant Jacarandra Trees were much smaller here and packed densely together, like a wall. Catra realized where she was, where her feet had taken her, and what was just around the corner.

The Great Chaliendra Tree blazed before her, still burning with bright green fire. Catra had not been in the presence of the sacred tree of the Madgēcots since right after Adora was taken. Nothing had changed about it; the magical flames still coursed up and down the tree protectively, and the sword of Sher-Va lay embedded in its trunk. But this time, there were no angry Madgēcots surrounding her, no loving brother to comfort her; it was just Catra, the tree, and the sword.

Catra had no idea why she had come down to the Great Chaliendra Tree. She had done it almost as if she were in a trance, not questioning her feet as they transported her from the city of Roshanee and down to the forest floor. But here Catra was, and she immediately felt glad to be by herself. She knew the reason why, too. It was obvious.

Catra was sick and tired of losing the people she cared for; she had spent too much of her life feeling alone and uncared for to let any more people sacrifice themselves for her. Adora had done it when Veth captured Catra; her wife had given herself up to be taken back to Empyrea and brainwashed to save Catra. Then it was Veth's turn; even though they were far from close, Veth had chosen to fall to their doom than let Despara kill Catra. Finally, it was Shen's turn. Everyone chose to give themselves up for Catra and she had enough of it; Catra would rather be the one to give herself up before anyone else was taken from her.

There was a goal her subconscious had in mind, taking Catra before the Great Chaliendra tree and her mind conjured a memory of something Glimmer told her on their way back from Enos. It had to do with that journal she had been reading, the one about a Nephraeh named Kishar. Glimmer had paraphrased much of the tragic story, but the main thing she wanted to convey to Catra was how Kishar had feared Jihan towards the end. Kishar was worried that Jihan would enable them to regain their empathy by using the power of Sher-Va.

If there was any time in her life that Catra was absolutely sure of anything, it was this moment. The Sword of Sher-Va had to come out of The Great Chaliendra Tree to balance the harmony of the sacred tree and the harmony of the universe—to heal Catra's heart. Sher-Va had to return to make things right, and Catra was convinced there was only one person who could do it.

Suddenly, Catra felt dizzy and confused, as if she were in a soft dream, and a figure appeared before the burning tree. It was a young, handsome Madgēcot, smiling with his hands placed on slender hips. On his marble-furred body, he wore a tan Jaadoo

suit, and his green eyes sparkled with mischief; there was a roguishness to this Madgēcot, and Catra suddenly felt a kinship to him. He spoke to her then, but she could not hear the words.

What? I cannot hear you. What do you want?

Catra felt like her mouth was full of cotton and was not exactly sure if she spoke. The Madgēcot only smiled kindly, beckoning her towards him. Catra did as prompted, feeling the soft mossy ground under her bare feet as she walked towards the apparition. The Madgēcot smiled at her one last time before disappearing, and Catra saw what he was beckoning her towards.

The sword of Sher-Va.

Catra walked close to the burning Chaliendra Tree, noticing that the flames did not seem to give off any heat. They raged and fumed before her, but they did not actually burn; she decided to get closer, wanting to see how far she could get before the green fire turned her back. Soon she was directly before the tree, within a whisker's distance of the licking fire. But she overlooked that; her heterochromatic eyes focused on one thing and one thing only.

Tentatively, Catra lifted one hand and slowly reached for the Sword of Sher-Va.



END OF BOOK II: HE-MAN

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for your continued reading! Stay tuned for Book III: Sher-Va!

Illustrations in this chapter were done by Ansdrela on Twitter, Instagram and Tumblr!

Subternia (BOOK III: SHER-VA)

Chapter Summary

Micah, Castaspella and Perfuma make a discovery beneath Castle Grayskull.

BOOK III

SHER-VA



An ancient city sat atop a rocky outcrop in the middle of a vast grassy plain—it was Eternos, the capital of Eternia. This was a storied city, full of myth and legend, much of which had been lost to time. Few records remained of when it went by another name or of its role in the downfall of the galaxy into the Dark Times. What people do remember—and only barely—is that it was once the capital of a mighty empire and the seat of a Champion of Grayskull, He-Man, before it fell into its own darkness. That part of history the people of Eternia knew all too well, for most of them were born in the dark dimension of Night when Eternia went by a different name; Shen'Dar-oom.

The city of Eternos was still shrugging off the memory of those millennia spent under the rule of the Dark He-Man—The Shen'Aan-war—and bathing under the sightless gaze of the god of Death in the forever night sky. The site of the domineering fortress of the dark ruler has since been razed to the ground to make way for a grand park—but no plants will grow there, for the taint of evil still permeates the very soil. The many temples of the Death Binders that once dotted the city have also been destroyed; many had even taken out parts of the city when their evil magic was released. There were other grim reminders of their old life, cruel customs, and toxic behaviors which clung to them like bad smells, not letting the people of Eternia forget their time in the dark. A kind of communal trauma tormented Eternia's people, one which was almost impossible to break out of without assistance.

But the Eternians were not forsaken; they had help. When their planet returned to its original universe, it came not to its prior location but one much more fortuitous. Eternia now shared a mutual orbit with one of its sibling Prime Magical planets—Etheria—and the people there were only glad to help their brethren back into the light. A mixing took place between the two worlds; many Etherians traveled to Eternia with dreams of adventure while Eterians visited Etheria to behold its beauty. The people of Etheria brought joy and fun back to Eternia, while the Eternians made the Etherians realize just how lucky they had been despite their past.

The exchange was woefully one-sided regarding who had the greater need, but the Etherians did not mind; they were more than happy to help their cousins. It was in their nature to spread joy.

Not all Etherians were on Eternia for the sake of frivolity, and few were drawn there by a much more serious task. There were ancient powers buried on Eternia that called for a more astute mind, and some of Etheria's preeminent scholars and mystics were on Eternia even now to delve deep into these mysteries. Three of these intellectuals were even now seated outside at a local café as they debated the greatest enigmas found on Eternia —none other than Castle Grayskull. It was a newer establishment, constructed on the side of the butte on which Eternos was built. Its open terrace jutted out from the side of that giant rock, giving the patrons a view of the Crystal Mountain Range facing the city's northern side.

"So why is it called Castle Grayskull? I mean, the whole outside of the place is green; shouldn't it be called Castle Greenskull?" Castaspella asked before taking a dainty sip from her tea.

"Yeah, I'm not sure, Cassy. Maybe it's covered in a kind of mold, and underneath it's gray? We could get some of the first years from Mystacor to come and scrub it clean. It would be a better use of their time than tuning the crystals in the Lunarium." Micah said as he inspected a pastry with a doubtful expression. It was a dense biscuit with green berries baked within its crust, many of which gave off a pungent scent. After taking a bite, Micah shook his head and tossed the offending pastry over his shoulder as the other patrons looked at him scornfully.

"Remind me never to get anything with Venom Berries in it," he mumbled.

"I don't think it's a mold covering the outside of the Castle, the place Castle Grayskull is too arid for any plant life—especially a fungus," Perfuma said, cheerful as ever.

“Well, you would be the expert, my dear,” Castaspella said airily.

“Anyway, I like the green color, and it would be a shame to remove it.” Perfuma continued, oblivious to Castaspella’s condescension. “Since I have been spending so much time there, I was thinking of planting a garden somewhere on the castle grounds. What the place needs is some more color! Perhaps some pretty flowers; I know of a blooming vine with the most gorgeous pink roses that would be perfect!”

Castaspella and Micah shared a dubious glance as they both imagined the skull on the face of the castle covered in pink flowers.

“Perhaps, dear, but didn’t you just say it was too dry for plants?” Castaspella asked.

Perfuma only answered this question by raising her staff—the Life Gem at the top glimmering in the noon sun.

Castaspella shrugged, suddenly unconcerned with the topic she initially broached.

“It’s so good to get out of that dreary place once in a while. Castle Grayskull may be the most fantastic magical wonder of the known universe, but it sure does begin to wear on a person. All that gothic architecture and bare stonework – yeck!” Castaspella said with a shudder. “I would bring Juliet up to Eternia, but I’m afraid that place would kill any ideas of romance!”

Perfuma was crestfallen as Castaspella spoke of her relationship with Juliet, and Micah gave his sister a slight kick under the table.

“Right!” Castaspella said as she sat upright. “I’m so sorry; that was so insensitive of me. Here is silly me yapping away about Juliet while your Scorpia is still lost to us. My poor Perfuma, we will find the secret to getting her back somewhere in Castle Grayskull, I promise you. There are so many wonderful treasures locked away in its dungeons; we are bound to find something that

gives a person back their empathy!" Castaspella said as she gave Perfuma a reassuring pat on the shoulder.

Micah frowned at his sister's words but did not respond; he was thinking of all those 'wonderful treasures,' many of which would destroy Eternia and Etheria if they were ever allowed to leave the dungeon and end up in the wrong hands.

"How is it going with your research, by the way? I have not been on Eternia long, and I would like to know more about what you guys have been up to. Have you learned more about the castle and what its purpose is?" Perfuma asked.

Micah's frown deepened, and he was about to answer when Castaspella spoke up; she was always happy to appear as the primary font of knowledge.

"Well, I think that is quite obvious! It was built as a kind of prison for the Abominable Powers—which I think is a silly name, actually. How can magic be 'abominable'?" Castaspella said with a nervous chuckle. "Anyway, since then, it's become a dumping ground for other random artifacts which have accumulated over the years,"

"So, it's like a big storehouse?" Perfuma said with a curious tilt of her head.

"Not necessary," Micah said, holding up one finger to forestall his sister from answering. "We still don't know what's below the dungeon; there are still many things about Castle Gray skull we know nothing about."

Castaspella rolled her eyes dramatically at her brother. "Oh, all that nonsense about 'Subternia' is hogwash—nothing more. It's just some rumor you read about in some dusty scroll—which I might add—mysteriously vanished after you *supposedly* read it!"

Micah ignored his sister's scorn; his eyes suddenly bright with enthusiasm.

“Supposedly, there is an entirely different realm under Castle Grayskull, a kind of waypoint or nexus, if you will. There it is said you can access the many realities that run parallel to our own. It is the reason why Grayskull was built, for it covers the only known entrance into Subternia. If someone with power ever got inside, not only would they be the master of this universe, but the infinity of all of the others. They would be able to mold or destroy any reality at a whim, becoming more than just a god; they would become the supreme deity to whom all others would answer.”

Everyone was silent at Micah’s proclamation as a gust of wind whistled through the café. It was a cool breeze blowing down from the mountains, giving everyone outside the café a slight chill, and they shivered. Finally, after an awkward silence, Perfuma spoke.

“If that were true, Shen’s father would have gained access to Subternia long ago, and we wouldn’t be having this conversation,” she said.

‘Not true!” Micah said excitedly. “According to this same scroll—”

Suddenly Castaspella scoffed, interrupting her brother. “Oh, here we go…”

“According to the same scroll,” Micah continued, louder now. “Only the seven Champions working in unison can activate the portal to open the gateway to Subternia. The Shen’Aan-war was trapped in another dimension and could not access the other six champions to make this happen.”

“*Oh! How convenient!*” Castaspella said.

“Don’t mock me, Cassy; I saw it with my own eyes! Why don’t you believe me?” Micah said, a little hurt.

“It’s just too fantastical to believe; a place where you can access all realities at once? How could anyone resist that kind of power?” Castaspella said, a slightly greedy look in her eyes.

“I could,” Micah said sternly. “I did it when Shadow Weaver tried to tempt me with dark magic, and I think it would be in your best interest to resist it as well, sister.”

“So, have you found this… door or whatever to access Subternia?” Perfuma asked, interrupting the sibling’s bickering.

“Ah, no… we are still excavating the lower tunnels of the dungeon. Many of them collapsed when Eternia transitioned to and from the dimension of Night. But we are getting close now; I can feel it!” Micah said, crossing his arms and leaning back in his seat. “There is so much to all this we don’t understand, but I believe we could soon have the keys necessary to access Subternia. I would be fascinated to see what is inside—not for the power—but the opportunity to perhaps…”

Micah broke off his sentence to look off in the direction of the mountains, his intentions suddenly very plain to his sister.

“Oh, my dear sweet brother,” Castaspella said as she laid her hand on his. “I’m such a fool. I didn’t realize what this meant to you. How could I not see? If Subternia exists, we could maybe get your dear Angella back!”

Perfuma suddenly gasped, laying her hands over her mouth at the implication as Micah turned to regard his sister, his eyes tearful.

“That’s right; I still have not given up hope. Why do you think I’ve been so obsessed with this?” He said, wiping at his eyes and then letting out a loud sigh. “We just have to find the other five Champions, and on top of it all, get Adora back.”

“And I will help you do it, brother,” Castaspella said with a kind smile.

“Well, I know of two more Champions,” Perfuma said abruptly.

“What?!” Castaspella and Micah said simultaneously.

“One is Sher-Va, a Madgēcot Champion, and the other is Zhe-La, one of the Nephraeh. There is a slight problem, though, Sher-Va’s sword is stuck in the Madgēcot’s sacred tree, and Zhe-La was the one who put it there. The Madgēcots are at war with the Nephraeh last time I checked.” Perfuma finished sadly.

“It’s too bad we are stuck on Eternia; perhaps Cassy and I could help them get Sher-Va’s sword out of this tree,” Micah said as he brought a fist down into his open palm.

“Well, Glimmer, Bow, Seahawk, Catra, and Shen are still there. I’m sure they are working on getting the sword out,” Perfuma said confidently. “It’s important we remain here to ensure Castle Grayskull remains safe.”

Micah regarded Perfuma, impressed now.

“Such a wise young woman you are, Perfuma. We are lucky to have you as the bearer of the Life Gem,”

The older sorcerers chuckled as the younger woman blushed with embarrassment, and Micah’s face brightened as he thought of something.

“Could you imagine they get the sword of Sher-Va out of the tree and Catra becomes the new Champion?”

“Oh! That would be amazing!” Perfuma gushed before Castaspella’s sour expression dampened her excitement.

“Do not joke about that; I don’t find such an idea funny. Perfuma told me that horrible villain Double Trouble has the Orb of Entropy —that’s bad enough!” She huffed. “The idea of *Catra* becoming a Champion of Grayskull—ugh!”

“Oh, Cassy, when will you lighten up on her? Catra has more than redeemed herself. Horde Prime would most likely have brainwashed us all if it weren't for her, and he would still be ruling the universe!” Micah said.

Castaspella turned her head away with her nose up, almost comical in her disapproval.

“One good deed doesn’t make up for many. You would still have your wife, and I would still have my best friend if it weren’t for her,”

Micah turned to Perfuma and rolled his eyes at her before standing up slowly.

“Anyway, ladies, I think it’s about time we head back to Grayskull. We’ve had enough rest and relaxation; ancient tombs and forbidden secrets aren’t going to unlock themselves!”

Castaspella rose to her feet with a pouty whine as Perfuma rose good-naturedly while lifting her staff. Micah tossed a few coins that passed for the new currency on Eternia, and the three exited the Café, ascending the stone staircase leading back to the main city. Once at the top, they found themselves on the main avenue which ran the periphery of Eternos, it buzzed with activity as merchants and street vendors plied their many wares. Castaspella immediately veered towards one displaying the latest fashions, obviously intent on delaying their departure a little longer.

“Ahhh? What do you think?” She said, lifting an all-black gown with black lace at the neckline.

“Mmmm… do you have anything in pink?” Perfuma asked the merchant as she inspected the wares.

“No, sorry, Madame, we do have something in a light shade of gray or deep purple,” he offered in the accented voice all Eternians shared.

“Yeah, hmmm… you really need to add some variety to your wardrobe,” Micah stated as he browsed. “Even I like to add some color every once in a while,”

The merchant displayed his open palms in a display of sorrow. “I apologize. We have spent too long in darkness; all these colors

are just so overwhelming."

"Oh! My good man!" Castaspella said good-naturedly. "I know a few interior decorators and stylists that can fix that problem for you. Everyone needs a little help getting out of their 'goth' phase!"

The merchant only smiled and nodded at this, obviously uncomfortable with the conversation and eager for his visitors to leave.

"I've never had a goth phase," Perfuma said absentmindedly as she lifted a pair of pants made entirely of lace. "Hmmm… wonder what event you wear these for?"

Castaspella sided up to Perfuma with a wicked grin plastered on her face.

"Never too late to try out a 'phase,' my dear. Those would look marvelous on you! I will get them, and when we get Scorpia back, I'm sure you can figure when you wear them,"

Perfuma hastily placed the pants bank down and whirled away, her face a deep shade of crimson as Castaspella chuckled. Micah shook his head at his sister as they followed the retreating Perfuma away from the vendor.

"You're a wicked woman, Cassy," Micah scolded while trying not to smile.

The Etherians continued along the long road, enjoying the sights and sounds of civilization before they had to return to the desolation of the wastes. After taking a mechanical lift down to the plains surrounding Eternos, the three caught a Sekth carriage heading in the direction of Castle Grayskull. The journey was long and took much of the rest of the day, the carriage journeying through Ghoul's Woods and over the mighty Simbar river. Finally, as dusk began to settle upon the land, they made it to the outskirts of the waste; Castle Grayskull was not much farther away. The carriage driver dropped them off at a crossroads with the Castle in sight, saying she refused to approach such a

haunted place. Micah, Castaspella, and Perfuma continued on foot, taking in the grim setting of their temporary abode.

Castle Grayskull sat upon a stone pedestal facing a wide, dark pit, its skull visage making it appear as if it were alive and watching the trio who dared approach it. The barren waste in the vicinity of the castle was warped and changed, forming into protrusions that appeared like teeth jutting up from the ground. If any visitors were not already unsettled by the sight which greeted them, then the undeniable weighty feeling that permeated the area would. It was a heaviness that pulled at the body and seemed to drag at your very soul, as if the power of the place was manifesting a gravity of its own.

"Here we are! Home sweet home!" Micah said jovially.

As if it heard him, the draw bridge suddenly came alive, lowing itself from below the upper jaws of the skull to create a path across the dark chasm. A robed figure came scurrying across as soon as it was lowered, and as they came closer, the newcomers could see it was a young Mystacor Acolyte, his face flush with excitement.

"Thank Etheria; you've come back!" He shouted before coming to a halt before Micah.

"What is it, Deras? Don't tell me we were attacked while we were gone!" Micah exclaimed.

The Acolyte Deras waved this away as he panted, trying to catch his breath enough to speak.

"No, no, nothing like that!" He gasped. "Come and see for yourself!"

Deras beckoned them back into the Castle, and they followed him through the gate and into what had become known as the Hall of the Staff Wielders. The name was obvious because six representations of ancient bearers of the Staffs of Power stood in a circle, all facing the entrance to the dungeon in the center.

There was a seventh statue, but it had been ruined during the struggle to subdue Shen after his corruption by the Eye of Hate. Scaffolding stood in its place as Mysticor Acolytes attempted to reconstruct the statue. There had even been talk of creating a new sculpture based on either Glimmer or Perfuma, but both women dismissed the plan; Perfuma was too humble, and Glimmer was too embarrassed by the idea.

All four magic users summon illumination by their own individual means before descending the spiral staircase into the dark bowels of Castle Grayskull. Immediately upon sinking below the first floor, the now familiar feeling of oppressiveness permeated their being; it was the collected weight of stored power trapped within the depths of the dungeon. Coming to the bottom of the staircase, they entered the central passageway, which branched off to the various other chambers and oubliettes. At the opposite end of this corridor, another set of spiral stairs awaited them, taking them further down. They passed many strange and unknown doors, many of which had yet to be explored and were still locked.

But some were known to the Etheirans; the rotted and decrepit door to the crypt of the Gastrolith of Decay was evident by its wretched stench as was the entrance to the Glove of Domination. The door holding the Rod of Ignorance was not as apparent, for that was the insidious nature of its evil and was now marked with a large white X in warning. All of these Abominable Powers were cataloged as ‘most offensive’ and deemed never to leave to premises of Castle Grayskull nor be allowed to be studied.

Taking the staircase at the end of the corridor, they traveled to the next level down, which was a mirror of the one above. They descended another twenty levels before reaching the excavation site; the walls and ceiling were now propped up with supports as the dig team uncovered the ruined lower parts of the dungeon. The group traveled carefully through this part, careful not to disturb the newly revealed tunnels and create further cave-ins.

They soon came to the end of their journey—an even narrower section of tunnel that ended at a smooth wall. As Micah got closer,

he could see writing etched in the material of the wall; he instantly recognized the language.

"Those are First One's runes—what we now know as the writing of the great Empire which ruled the universe before Horde Prime destroyed it. But I thought Castle Grayskull predated the Empire? What's it doing all the way down here?"

Deras shook his head. "We aren't sure. Perhaps it's an annex built during the time of the Empire? Maybe the evil one, Zzar, built something down here?"

Micah grimaced. "I surely hope now. Have you translated it? What does it say?"

"We have not, Master Adept Micah. We have been waiting for you to proceed. We were afraid some spell or rite would be performed upon reading the runes and did not want to proceed without Senior Sorcerer's present."

Micah smiled appreciatively. "Good work Deras. Now go ahead, translate it."

The younger sorcerer was suddenly nervous as he looked down at the floor.

"Umm… well… I don't know First One's runes. That's Peri's area of expertise, and he's back up at the Castle."

Micah groaned as Castaspella glared at the Acolyte; she was about to deliver a tongue lashing when Perfuma spoke.

"I can read it. I've been studying First One's language since I took up the Life Gem. I'm surprised that two senior Sorcerers of Mysticor haven't done so already," Perfuma said in her typically non-offensive manner.

Both Micah and Castaspella appeared contrite as Deras looked on smugly, and Perfuma walked up to the writing, holding up her staff to illuminate it.

“I can only partially read it. It says, ‘Defenders of Grayskull, speak.’ The rest is obscured.” Perfuma said as she squinted.

“Here. Allow me,” Micah said as he stepped up, lifting his own magical staff as he muttered an incantation. A large section of dirt and rock suddenly vaporized, leaving just trace amounts behind. Micah wiped the rest away, revealing the text in its entirety as he leaned against the wall to get a closer view. The surface felt strange to his bare hand, not cool as he would expect stone to be but warm with a faint sensation—like a vibration.

“Defenders of Grayskull, speak virtue and enter,” Perfuma said, now able to read the entire text.

“What does that mean? ‘Speak virtue?’” Deras asked.

“Oh, I get it!” Castaspella said as she clapped her hands happily. “It’s like a game! Say something virtuous, and you can go in!”

She walked up to the wall while holding her hands over her mouth as if she were going to call over a great distance.

“Being on time to a mutually agreed-upon appointment!” She yelled at the wall.

Nothing happened, and Perfuma suddenly giggled.

“That’s not a virtue, silly.” She teased.

Castaspella turned on her, looking very irritated to be made to appear the fool.

“Then what is Miss Know-It-All?”

Perfuma smiled back at her, not appearing to be affected by her scorn.

“Love. Love is a virtue,” she said, beaming.

Instantly, Micah vanished into the wall he was using as a support, making everyone gasp in surprise. After a brief and tense moment, his head reappeared, sticking out from within the wall, his face an expression of wonder.

"It must be some kind of magical barrier which remains solid until the command word is spoken. You should come through and see this—it's amazing!" He exclaimed before his head disappeared again.

Without a second thought, Perfuma passed through the barrier while Castaspella hesitated.

"You coming?" She asked the junior sorcerer.

Deras shook his head. "No, I'll stay here and make sure the door doesn't seal up,"

Castaspella shrugged as she followed her brother and Perfuma through the magical gateway and to the other side. The sight which greeted her immediately made Castaspella stop in her tracks and gape open-mouthed as she tried to process what she was looking at.

Luminous light filled a cavernous space, the source of which seemed to be coming from every surface at once. It was not bright nor dim light, but it was pleasant and warm, like a perfect summer's day. Looking closely, Castaspella saw that the walls and ceiling of the space were crystalline—as if she were inside a giant geode. Here and there, larger crystals jutted down from the roof, walls, or floors; every one of their faceted surfaces reflected the visitor's amazed faces. In the center of the beautiful cavern, a series of raised platforms rose from the floor—they appeared to be cut from the same gems and were clear as glass. Upon this pedestal, seven pylons stood in a circle—they were cloudy and opaque, appearing to have the consistency of soft clouds. Upon closer inspection of these pillars, Castaspella saw they were almost twice as tall as she was and covered in more runes.

“This must be the gateway to Subternia!” Micah exclaimed as he ran his hands over the surface of the closest pylon. Prismatic light appeared at his touch, radiating out like ripples in water and slowly fading away.

“From what I recall from that scroll, each one of these pillars is for a Champion of Grayskull!” Micah continued excitedly. “Now, all we need is seven Champions, and we are on our way to Subternia,”

“What is that over there?” Castaspella asked as she pointed off to the side of the pylons.

Micah’s eyes widened as he spotted a smooth oblong crystal in the shape of an egg sitting on a solid pedestal. It was as tall as one of the pylons, and inside was a shining amorphous object which floated about the interior like a butterfly. It seemed to be aware of the visitors and pushed against the surface of the crystal as if it were a fish in a tank.

“Is that what I think it is?” Micah whispered.

“What? What do you think it is? Spit it out!” Castaspella said.

Micah did not answer right away. Instead, he placed his hand on the surface of the clear crystal as the strange inhabitant bounced on the opposite side.

“I think this is the Well of Champion Spirits. The place where the powers like She-Ra and He-Man go when they are no longer bound.” He said in awe.

“Wow! So that is one of the Champion Spirits? And that means we could bind it to someone, right?” His sister answered in a hush.

Micah nodded. “Although I have no idea how to do it, nor do I have any idea which Champion this is,”

“They are called Thon-Ra,” Perfuma said suddenly.

Both Castaspella and Micah turned to see Perfuma gazing at the transparent container with a vague expression on her face. She held her staff with both hands as the Life Gem at the top pulsed with yellow light.

“How do you know that?” Micah asked.

Perfuma suddenly turned to them, appearing as if she were snapping out of a trance.

“They told me.” She said simply, pointing at the spirit of Thon-Ra.

Micah and Castaspella were silent as they contemplated the implications of Perfuma communicating with the magical spirit. However, they jumped when one of the pylons abruptly emitted a deep, low tone. They looked just in time to see its entire surface turn black before returning to its original soft white coloring.

“That was one of the pylons for a Champion,” Perfuma said, trepidation in her voice. “Something must have just happened to one of them,”

Micah turned to regard the Well of Champion Spirits, half expecting a new Champion Spirit to appear. None did, and the Spirit of Thon-Ra remained the only occupant.

“Is this bad or good?” Castaspella asked in her brother’s direction.

Micah pursed his lips and shook his head.

“I have no idea. I’m sure we will find out soon enough,”

Unwanted Responsibility

Chapter Summary

Catra wakes to find that destiny has finally chosen her.

The Madgēcots are mad, and you know what they say about an angry Madgēcot.

She dreams. At first, they are old dreams—old for her, that is—half-forgotten memories of a childhood cut short. A mother's kind face stares down at her; she has beautiful blue eyes set in a cinnamon-colored face. The other face has yellow eyes; they call her 'their Rajkumari,' which makes her giggle and laugh. There is another, and she is unsure how she knows this, but he is her other half—her twin. He snuggles her at night, keeping her warm and in comfort with his purr. She loves them all so much and could not even conceive of a life without them.

Then a dark night, one like no other she had experienced in her short little life, one in which she awakes to a strange feeling, one that her older mind recognizes as dread, and it makes her cry. She feels for her brother, but his warm body is not there, and she screams—but no one answers. She crawls to the side of her crib, her tiny claws strong enough to help lift her to the top. A hand catches her as she is about to topple over the side; it is a strange hand, not at all like the other ones that have held her so far. Instead of being covered with soft fine fur, it is bare and cool. The hand lifts her up to an androgynous face as green and yellow-slitted eyes peer down at her in curiosity. The person smiles, revealing rows of very sharp teeth, and she feels fear.

"Don't worry, little dear." They say in a voice her older mind recognizes. "I am not here to harm you but to set you on your path. I will take you to a place you will not like at first, but it is necessary. It is necessary in order for you to meet your destiny."

They smile down at her, showing her those dangerous teeth once more, but this time, she isn't afraid. She is ready. They change then, their face and body turning entirely black with green dancing sparks—like fireflies. She sees this spread from them to her, and she giggles to see the lights in her tummy. Darkness enfolds them both, and she feels dizziness combined with an inexplicable sense of traveling without moving.

As her sight returns, she finds she is alone in a very unfamiliar place surrounded by cold hard surfaces and bad smells—like smoke from a fire but worse. It is a hall filled with sickly green light, and as she hears approaching footsteps, attempts to hide in the first thing she can find. It is a strange object; it smells of wood, but it is not like any wood she has encountered. It is thin and flimsy, formed in a cube with flaps at the top, which she attempts to pull down as she hides inside. The footsteps stop outside her hiding place, and she feels it lifted as she is carried away. She trembles and attempts to tuck her little body in a tight ball in comfort. Soon she is lowered onto a surface; she braces herself as the top opens, and a light shines down upon her.

"What is this!?" A stern female voice exclaims. "Some kind of pest has gotten into my delivery!"

She squints as she looks up into the woman's face, not totally sure what she is looking at. Two white eyes stare down at her in a red face framed by long, greasy black hair. There is no nose or mouth; she does not like the face and immediately hisses at it.

"What a nasty little beast you are! Don't you know who I am?!" The cruel woman exclaims.

She shakes her head sorrowfully, suddenly wishing the strange person had not taken her from her home.

"You understand me? Huh. Well, I know just the place for you. With the other orphans," The woman says, closing the flaps and sealing her back into darkness.

The dream transitions from her memory and into another's as new images appear. They are brief and fleeting scenes—a green castle with a skull-like visage. An attractive but sinister woman, smiling as she lifts a sword she recognizes; the last time she had seen it, it was embedded in a tree as magical green flames coursed over it. But in this version, it appears dull and lifeless, but that changes as the woman performs a magical rite. There is a wicked knife that gleams with fell light, then blood that is hers but not hers. There is incredible pain as she feels something yanked from her and bound to the blade, this occurrence feels unnatural to her, and she senses the other whose memories she experiences resent the woman. This other body feels familiar to her; she has a tail and long sensitive ears, but some things are off. She realizes that the body is a Madgēcot but a male; she instantly feels a kinship with him. Abruptly his voice is in her head.

"Madgēcot, sister. You must take up the sword. You must undo the wrong." He says with the distinctive accent all her kind shares.

She withdraws from his desire to give her this responsibility but feels his spirit is unwavering and now connected to her. She is outside his body now and looking at him; he is in his Champion form and magnificent. His enhanced body is covered by a tan Jaadoo suit accented by gold armor on his shoulders, wrists, and shins. The exposed fur of his body is a marbling of brown and black, his eyes a light green. A proud feline face gazes at her from behind a gold headpiece, the top of which protrudes upwards like antlers.

"Cat-Tra! You must take up the sword and become what you were destined to be! Become Sher-Va!"

"NOOO!!!" Catra screamed, sitting upright in bed to find herself in a cold sweat.

She looked around furtively, searching to see if the Madgēcot from her dream was still there, demanding she take up the sacred duty. But he was not there, only an empty room; no wife next to her nor friend in a nearby bed. Melog was off in the Jacarandra forest,

looking for Battle Cat, who had taken Shen's death badly. Catra suddenly felt very lonely.

It took her an additional few moments to remember where she was; Catra was no longer staying at the guest house, her friend Shen was gone, and there was no longer any need to keep him company. She was back in what was her room, in the house she shared with her brother Viraj. It was once Catra's parent's room, and the photograph showing them holding her and Viraj still sat on the bedstand. The realization that she had just recollected an old memory during her dream was not lost on her, and the love she had once felt for her parents returned as she looked at their happy faces.

A knock at the door pulled Catra away from thoughts of her parents, and she looked around the floor for her Jaadoo suit before answering.

"Cat-Tra? I heard you yell. Are you okay?" Viraj called through the door.

"Yeah, I'm okay, Viraj, just a bad dream," Catra replied. She finally spotted her outfit in its ball form sticking out from under her bed. Getting on her hands and knees, she reached for it but then hesitated when she saw a glinting shape behind it. Reaching for it, she gripped something cold and hard and pulled it out into the light. When Catra saw it fully, she gasped, letting go of the thing she had drawn out from under the bed to stand up straight.

It was a sword—a very, very old sword, ornate in its style and very unmistakable.

The sword of Sher-Va.

"I'm coming in, Catra," Viraj exclaimed.

"NO!" Catra shrieked. Suddenly panicked, she kicked the sword under the bed, the edge biting into the bottom of her toughened foot and making her yelp in pain.

Viraj entered her room after commanding the door to open and spotted his sister hopping on one foot to sit on her bed.

"Cat-Tra! What's going on? What happened to your foot?" He said, hurrying over to sit next to her.

"It's nothing, Viraj, just something that happened last night when I was in the forest," Catra said, trying to hide her foot from his gaze. Viraj would not relent.

"Let me see it," he said.

Catra shook her head, feeling annoyed at his concern. "No, just leave it—"

Viraj reached down and seized her leg, gently bringing it up as Catra flopped back on the bed with an irritated hiss.

"This is a new injury, Catra. You're lying to me. Where did this come from?" Viraj said. Catra did not hear accusation in his voice, only concern.

"You know, Viraj, I don't need you to take care of me. I've been doing just fine by myself so far," Catra said, trying to put some bite into her words.

Viraj shook his head sadly. "That's the problem," he said, reaching down to his stomach to pull a section of his Jaadoo suit away. Just as Catra had done with her friend Shen the other day, Viraj licked the material to apply it to her bleeding foot. He rubbed his thumbs over it, helping it seal properly, and the tender way he did it almost made Catra want to cry. This is what she had been missing out on all those years in the Horde; a family looking out for her. Sure, she had Adora, but that was different. Even though Catra never knew what a sibling was, she never saw Adora as a sister, and now that she had a brother, Catra realized he would always be her brother. He could never stop being that for her, and for Catra, that meant everything. Especially now with so much loss that she had been experiencing.

Viraj released her bandaged foot, and Catra set it on the floor to tentatively stand on it; there was no pain, the magic of the Jaadoo already in the process of healing it. Catra felt her brother's hand in hers, and she turned to see raw pain in his heterochromatic eyes and his ears flattened.

"Catra, I know things are bad, but you're not hurting yourself, are you?" He asked.

Catra had to stop herself from laughing, not wanting to hurt her brother's feelings, and instead let out a long sigh.

"No, Viraj. The old me might have done something like that, but I'm different now. I know people care about me, and I would never do that." She said, noticing that Viraj did not look convinced.

"Don't you trust me?" Catra asked, placing her hand on Viraj's shoulder.

Viraj's eyes softened, and he nodded, placing his hand over her.

"Yes, sister, I do."

"Good! Now get out of my room so I can get dressed!" Catra said, punching him lightly on the shoulder.

"Ow! I still don't know why you do that. Is that something you learned in this Horde place you grew up in?" Viraj said, rubbing his upper arm.

"Nope! That's all me!" Catra said happily.

Viraj shook his head as he walked out of the room; right before he exited through the door, he turned.

"Oh! I almost forgot! There is a meeting later, down in the Imaarat. We are discussing the next course of action in the war with the Nephraeh. I think you should be there, especially since you are an honorary Star Hunter,"

This confused Catra, and she tilted her head to regard her brother.

"What's to discuss? We keep fighting them until we beat them and get Adora back," she said simply.

"Yeah, well, there is talk that with the recent death of He-Man, the Nephraeh deserve worse than just being defeated. We are talking about destroying them, utterly." Viraj said before turning and leaving.

Catra sat down heavily on the bed, bouncing slightly, the gravity of what her brother just said hitting her hard. Her people were talking about wiping out another race—*what is happening?* It made her feel wrong and out of place. She knew the old her, the Horde Catra, would have said she was ready to do such a thing—hating herself, even more, the whole time. But the new version of her—the real version—absolutely loathed the idea. Catra knew that she had to divert her people from making such a huge mistake and would absolutely attend the meeting.

A realization that she was forgetting something drew Catra's attention back to the sword, and for a giddy moment, she hoped it was just her imagination and not the actual blade of Sher-Va under her bed. The slight throb in her foot stifled this hope, and she kneeled—not to retrieve the sword—but to pick up her Jaadoo suit. Catra tossed her outfit into the air and whispered the command for it to unfurl from its ball form and magically clothe her. Her tail twitched rapidly as she considered how the Power Sword of Sher-Va ended up in her possession.

T*he last thing I remember was standing in front of the Jacarandra Tree last night, and then…*

Catra's eyes widened, and her ears stood straight as she also remembered reaching for the sword as if in a trance. The fire had parted for her hand, the green tongues of flame undulating in a manner in which it appeared they were beckoning her to take the sword. Her hand on the hilt—it felt so cool to the touch, even

after being bathed in fire for months. She pulled; there was a feeling of resistance at first, then the sword came loose. Then...

Catra stared unfocused for a moment as she tried to make sense of a series of seemingly unconnected images and emotions. A forest, obviously the Jacarandra forest. A beautiful tree—the Great Chaliendra Tree—and receiving a power; Sher-Va. Traveling to another planet—then—a grim green castle with a skull-like visage. The images blurred to a face, a beautiful androgynous face with long, pointed ears. This part confused Catra; for some reason, she recognized this face as a Nephraeh. But this Nephraeh's face and skin were white, their eyes gold instead of silver, and when they smiled, their teeth were flat, with no fangs.

That must be what they used to look like before whatever happened to them. Catra thought.

Catra suddenly shrieked as the male Madgēcot voice from her dreams suddenly spoke, seeming to come from everywhere at once.

Yes, that was my Kishar, before they were tainted and before they corrupted their own people in their hunger.

Catra flattened her ears as she placed her hands over them, eyes wide with terror.

I'm going crazy! She thought as she started to pace in circles.

No, your mind is sound. When you pulled the Power Sword from the Great Chaliendra Tree, you forged a bond with Sher-Va. Now hear an echo of its last bearer.

"Jihan?" Catra whispered.

Yes, that is right. I was Jihan, the last bearer of Sher-Va. You are Cat-Tra, the next bearer.

"NO!" Catra yelled but slammed her hands over her mouth. She did not want her brother to hear her and come to see her in the

process of going nuts.

Again, you are not losing your mind. You should tell your brother the good news. You should tell EVERYONE the news! Sher-Va is back!

"*Oh, no!* Not me! Your mistaken; there is *no way* I'm Sher-Va! I am absolutely NOT a princess!" Catra hissed.

The voice in her head laughed; it was deep and rich. Whomever Jihan had been in life, Catra thought he must have had a good sense of humor.

She-Ra is the Princess, my Madgēcot sister. You are Sher-Va and are called 'Mahat' by our people.

Catra scratched her head, thinking of the Madgēcot words she had learned.

"Mahat means 'great,' right?" She asked.

That's right. You are great amongst our people. Not for your power, but for your virtue. Your truth.

Catra grinned momentarily to herself; she could get used to being called great—but not if it meant she had to take on this responsibility.

"Listen, 'Mr. Jihan in my head,' I'm not the right person to be in any kind of leadership position. Believe me, the last time I was, it didn't work out so well."

I don't believe—

"*Uh, nope!* You will NOT be interrupting me inside my own head!" Catra said as she held up one finger. "I will tell you what, Jihan. You keep quiet and stop trying to make me crazy, and I will find someone better than me to be Sher-Va for you. How does that sound?"

The voice was silent for a moment before it finally responded.

Very well. But you will find out that there is no one more suited than you, Cat-Tra.

Catra laughed in response, shaking her head ruefully.

"Oh, man! YOU must be the crazy one if you think that. You have no idea who you are speaking to,"

I do know you; I can see all your memories—

"Uh! Nope! Remember the promise!" Catra said, once again placing her hands over her ears and shutting her eyes. "La, la, la, la, la! I can't heaaaaaarrrr youuuuu!"

After a moment of this, Catra tentatively stopped to open one eye and lower her hands. Jihan was no longer speaking to her.

"This is the last thing I need right now—some long-dead Madgēcot speaking to me in my head. I have enough problems as it is," she griped to herself as she left her room to find her brother. Once through the door, Catra turned and commanded the door to close while also giving it the command to not open unless by her.

I don't need Viraj going through my stuff and finding the sword. Catra thought to herself before she stopped dead and snapped her fingers.

Not until I show it to him myself! He is a big Champion Fan-Boy! Viraj would make the perfect Sher-Va!

Catra hesitated for a moment, expecting her new 'inner voice' to argue, but he didn't. Catra took this as a sign of acceptance, not bothering to remember that she made a deal with the ghost of Jihan not to speak again.

Catra collected her brother, and together the two siblings began the trip down to the Imaarat. It was a long trip, and as they passed over the many catwalks and suspended walkways of

Raajadhaanee, Catra kept looking at her brother sideways, trying to imagine him in the armor of Sher-Va.

He is a goodie-two-shoes, a stickler for rules, the perfect Star Hunter, Catra thought as she counted off Viraj's virtues.

"What are you doing, Cat-Tra?" Viraj asked, stopping in place and palcing both hands on his slender hips. Catra suddenly felt foolish as a blush threatened to creep across her face.

"Nothing! What are you talking about?" She said, trying to look innocent.

"You keep looking at me," Viraj said, regarding his sister with hooded eyes.

"What? Can't a sister look at the brother without there being suspicion?" Catra replied.

Viraj made an incredulous face—it was one he learned from Catra.

"Catra. I know what's going on with you," he responded.

Catra felt a jolt as she turned away, not wanting Viraj to see the surprise on her face. He gently turned her back around to look into her eyes, a small smile on his lips.

"Nothing is going to happen to me, Catra. I'm not going anywhere, I promise you," he said, giving her arm a gentle squeeze.

"Oh!" Catra responded lamely. "Yeah… I know that… dummy…"

Viraj chuckled and released her, walking ahead as she watched him for a moment.

Yeah. He would make a perfect Sher-Va.

The siblings continued their journey in silence—Viraj thinking he had quelled his sister's fears and Catra believing her decision had

been made. Soon they were on the forest floor and on the stone path, the round stone shapes of the Imaarat slowly coming into view through the trees. Viraj and Catra's long black ears perked up as they got closer; there was a low susurration that got steadily louder as they neared. When they finally got a clear view of the Madgēcot headquarters, they saw where the noise was coming from.

A crowd of Madgēcots—thousands of them—were standing outside the ancient building. The massive group was spread out from the front of the Imaarat and covered the entire landing pad nearby. It looked like the whole city of Raajadhaanee and many neighboring towns had gathered here to help determine the fate of the Nephraeh.

"I guess we won't be having the meeting inside," Viraj said in awe.

"Why?" Catra asked. "They look like civilians. This is a Star Hunter matter and doesn't concern them."

Viraj shook his head, giving his sister a sad expression.

"Oh, sister, you still have much to learn about your people. Star Hunter matters are everyone's concern. If other Madgēcots want to be involved in a military decision, they are allowed. They typically do not get involved, preferring to let us take care of it."

Catra nodded, feeling chagrined. "I guess wiping out another race is something that shouldn't be discussed lightly."

As Catra and Viraj neared the crowd, they spotted Star Hunters here and there keeping an eye on things. Maira was among them, and Catra headed straight for the onyx furred Madgēcot.

"How's it hanging, Maira?" Catra said in greeting. Maira turned when she heard Catra's voice, a sly smile on her face.

"Hey, Cat-Tra. I thought I smelled a stinky Madgēcot nearby," she said.

Both women chuckled as they hugged each other; they had come a long way from their antagonistic first meeting to learn they had a lot in common. They held each other's forearms as they parted, smiling wide, toothy grins at each other.

"To answer your question, things are not good, as you can see. Madgēcots everywhere are angry—very angry. I wanted to hurt the Nephraeh after the Great Chaliendra was hurt, but this—" She said, emphasizing the crowd with a wave of her hand. "—is not good."

Catra inspected the crowd of Madgēcots, not just looking with her eyes but with her other natural senses. Her people were an open book to her, and Catra could see the rage boiling just under the surface of the entire group. She suddenly felt a spike of fear at the decision that just might be made at the conclusion of this gathering.

This is bad, Cat-Tra. There is a saying from my time— ' A Madgēcot's purr comes as quickly as their claws; beware the fury of the Madgēcot.'

Catra had to stop herself from rolling her eyes—instead just shaking her head to silence the voice of Jihan.

Just be quiet! Yes, I've heard that stupid saying AND lived it! She thought angrily at Jihan.

"You okay, Cat-Tra? You look like you have a bhoot on your tail," Maira said.

Catra's dark eyebrows were raised at the unfamiliar word. "Eh? A boot?"

Maira laughed. "No! A *bhoot*. It means *ghost,*"

Now it was Catra's turn to laugh. "Yeah, I guess you can say that." She said with a smile before looking furtively around. "Say, have you seen my dummy friends from Etheria?"

Maira nodded and pointed a black-clawed finger at a spot in the crowd near the front door of the Imaarat. There Catra could see a Glimmer, Bow, and Seahawk standing in a huddle with Entrapta perched above them on a platform made from her purple ponytails. Catra finally did roll her eyes as she nodded her thanks to Maira; taking her brother by the hand, she led him over to the Etherians.

Bow elbowed Glimmer as Catra approached, and the three members of the Best Friends Squad shared a hug as Seahawk looked on forlornly.

"Oh, come on, goofball," Catra said, pulling him into the group embrace as Entrapta watched curiously.

"How are you two holding up?" Bow asked as he reached for Viraj's shoulder, planning on giving it a friendly squeeze. Catra was surprised to see her usually amicable brother pull back from Bow's touch as his ears lowered.

"About as well as can be expected," Viraj said with a shrug.

"What are we talking about?" Entrapta asked as she lowered herself down from her self-made perch. Viraj gave her an incredulous expression before crossing his arms and peering off in the opposite direction. Catra lowered herself so she was gazing into Entrapta's violet eyes; her technique for concentrating the usually distracted Princess.

"We are talking about Shen, Entrapta. Remember? He's gone," she said slowly.

Realization spread across Entrapta's face. "Ahhh… that's bad, right? Yeah, that's bad. He-Man brought a twenty-point-seven-eight percent increase in the chance of surviving hazardous encounters. Without him, we lose an important assent." Entrapta said happily as she nodded her head. "I get it now!"

Viraj hissed in outrage as he started towards the diminutive Princess, but Catra placed herself between them, holding her

open palms towards her brother in placation.

“Easy, bro, easy,” she said. “Remember—my friend Entrapta had her empathy taken from her; she is trying her best,”

Viraj let out a sigh as he nodded to her while Entrapta looked at them, confused.

“I guess I don’t get it,” she said sadly before suddenly brightening and holding up one gloved finger. “But I will next time! I promise!”

Catra gave Entrapta an exasperated look as Glimmer dismissed her with a wave.

“Forget Entrapta; what are we going to do about this?” She said with hands on hips. “Viraj! How can your people talk about annihilating the Nephraeh? I thought they were better than that; it’s deplorable!”

Viraj shrugged, crossing his arms as his stone-gray tail started to twitch back and forth.

“My people are angry. To tell you the truth—I’m angry too.” He said almost defiantly.

“That’s a dumb reason to want to exterminate another race, Viraj,” Catra responded.

Growls were heard around the group as other Madgēcots reacted to Catra’s words. They had been listening to Catra and her friends and could no longer hide their disapproval. Catra bared her teeth at them as Viraj stood up to them in protection of his sister.

“These are Star Hunter affairs we are discussing; mind your business,” he said with a low growl.

The Madgēcots turned away with a collective hiss, focusing their attention on the entrance of the Imaarat as the doors opened. Aadhya strode out—senior Star Hunters and Council Elders in tow.

The Star Hunter Pratham had a smile on her face as she held up her light blue hands for silence.

“My people! Good news! After much careful deliberation and in consideration of all the available facts, I, along with the senior leaders of the Madgēcots, have made a decision!”

The crowd was immediately silent in anticipation of the news—the only sound was the whispering swish of thousands of furry tails. Aadhya turned to an older Madgēcot behind her, one of the council elders, and he stood forward to proclaim the fate of the Nephraeh proudly.

“We have decided to forgo the destruction of Empyrea and its people, instead focusing our strength on helping the people of Enos rebuild from their recent occupation. We, the senior members of your leadership, believe that in their weakened position, the people of Empyrea will be more likely to discuss a surrender!”

The entire crowd erupted into murmurs and angry hisses as the council member looked nervously at Aadhya behind him.

“Madgēcots! This is good news!” Aadhya shouted as she stepped forward. “Destruction is not the Elysian way; we must—”

“NOT GOOD ENOUGH!!!” A voice suddenly shouted over her.

A collective gasp was heard as thousands of heads turned in the direction of the person bold enough to interrupt the leader of the Star Hunters. The crowd parted away from the speaker to reveal a young male Madgēcot in a green and black civilian Jaadoo suit; his white ears were flat, and an expression of anger was plastered on his light teal face.

“Rishi?” Viraj said, and Catra instantly recognized him.

It was the Star Hunter who fell to the Vetala during the last attack on the Relativity Forge, the one who had been enervated and his empathy taken.

“Rishi,” Aadhya said coolly. “Why are you not with the healers?”

Rishi waved this away. “They cannot do anything for me! Nor do they need to! I am completely fine; I’m able to see the truth now!”

Aadhya motioned to Star Hunters in the crowd, and they immediately headed in Rishi’s direction, restraining cantrips in their hands.

“Do not let them silence me, Madgēcots! Aadhya and our other blind leaders want to hide the truth from you!” Rishi said, his yellow eyes flashing as he looked around.

Jeers and mutters rose from the crowd, and Aadhya signaled her people to cease their advance on the rogue Madgēcot. She knew the only way around this peacefully was through reason.

“And what truth is that, Rishi? What grand vision does having no compassion for others give you?” Aadhya asked.

Rishi was not mollified by her scorn, instead seeming emboldened by it.

“Yes! That is right! I’ve had my empathy taken from me! It has caused me to be discharged from the Star Hunters—which I do not disagree with—but it also revealed the simplicity of our course of action! Why do we skate around what must be done? Do we not cut down the Jacarandra that is too sick or old to stand up on its own? What would happen if we didn’t? That’s right; over time, it would collapse, possibly killing or harming innocents! It’s the same with the Nephraeh; they are tainted beyond saving and have already hurt us many times! What else needs to happen before our *wise leaders* finally see reason?

“ENOUGH!!!” Aadhya shouted.

Catra saw that the older Madgēcot woman was so upset that her tail was not twice its normal size as it made broad sweeps behind her. Rishi was now silent, but his words had already affected the

crowd as they started to voice the opinions they had up until now kept to themselves.

“Let him speak!”

“He is right! They took He-Man and She-Ra from us!”

“Destroy the Nephraeh!”

“That is not our decision!” One of the other senior Star Hunters cried to more boos.

Catra found herself becoming slightly panicked as the crowd seemed to take on a life of its own. The noise, smells, and sights of angry Madgēcots overwhelmed her as she sensed a presence inside her start to stir.

This is very bad, Cat-Tra. You MUST take your responsibility seriously and stop this!

Catra gritted her teeth as she shook her head; she was going to respond to the echo of Jihan when a new disturbance drew her attention to the back of the crowd. A Star Hunter was barging through the Madgēcots, receiving angry words and shoves as he made his way to the front.

“Let me through! It’s the Tree! The Great Chaliendra Tree!” He shouted before coming to a halt before Aadhya.

“What is it, Veer?” Aadhya said. “What happened to our sacred tree?!”

Veer stood up as a broad smile spread across his face.

“It’s healed, Pratham! The flames are gone, and so is the sword of Sher-Va! It’s a miracle!”

The Cenotaph

Chapter Summary

With the help of two fallen Princesses, Despara assaults an alien world in search of a powerful relic.

Catra finds herself thrust into a new position for her-the voice of reason and temperance.

Bhus'ik raced down the Cenotaph hallway, clutching the diffusion separator's long cylindrical shape in all four of his limbs as the sirens of the sacred building blared. The sound was so loud that Bhus'ik thought all four of his cochlear nodes would burst, and he clamped his beak closed against the pain.

"What's happening? Are we actually under attack, or is this another drill?" He shouted to Chis'ik as he finally caught up to her.

She turned her head to regard him with two of her eye stalks as the third faced the opposite direction.

"I have no idea, Bhus'ik. This doesn't feel like a drill to me." She said, nervousness evident in the way her beak clicked as she spoke. He wanted to hold her then, to wrap his tentacles around her body in comfort, but there were too many other Custodians nearby, likewise summoned by the alarm. There would be time later for affection after this emergency was behind them.

"Invaders have come to the city of Chiu'ka; they have fought through the defense force and are now set upon us! They want the sacred relic!" A nearby Custodian said.

Raged instantly coursed through Bhus'ik body at this thought, and he tightened his grip on his diffusion separator, making it creak. Protecting the Sacred relic has not only been the duty of every Custodian over the past thousand years but a point of pride

for his people—the Qer'kek. There had only been a few attempts to take the relic by force over the long years and even an extravagant offer from the Archon of the Nephraeh—but all had been rebuffed. Now it seemed a new attempt was being made.

"Not on our watch!" Chis'ik said proudly.

Bhus'ik arranged his eye stalks in a pleasing manner; he loved Chis'ik so much at that moment. She was the strongest of all the Custodians, and he was honored to be her primary mate.

"Come! Let's meet these invaders head-on! We held off Horde Prime for that past thousand years; whomever these interlopers are, they are in for a surprise!" She continued.

Her words were met with hoots and clacks as Bhus'ik, and the other Custodians followed Chis'ik to the main entrance of the Cenotaph. The sharp sting of smoke greeted his nostrils upon exiting, as well as confusion. Bhus'ik looked around the expansive plaza where the Cenotaph was located, expecting to see an army of attackers. But all he saw were three figures under the large colonnades that ran the circumference of the plaza. They were far away, but he could tell they were walking in his direction, the flames of destruction in their wake.

"What in the name of— Is that all of them?" Chis'ik asked.

Bhus'ik raised the magnifier to his eyestalks, getting a closer view of the attackers. They were bipedal and limbed with two arms instead of tentacles. They appeared to be three different heights, but all three were clothed in distinctive black Aegis Lace. The largest of the three even had black armor augmenting the bodysuit, a red corrupted symbol of a Champion on their chest.

"They are Empyreans," Bhus'ik muttered.

"But Elysia is between Empyrea and us. How did Nephraeh get here?" Chis'ik asked sharply.

Bhus'ik twitched his eyestalks in the negative. "Not Nephraeh. They look human—at least two of them do. One of them appears to have a red exoskeleton and pincers—I have no idea what species that is,"

Bhus'ik handed the magnifiers to Chis'ik. She whistled through her beak when she saw the red symbol.

"That's a Champion of Grayskull!" She said in awe. "That's… that's She-Ra!"

"No," Another Guardian said. "Haven't you been paying attention to recent events? She-Ra is now on Archon Lethe's side. She calls herself Despara now!"

The Guardians were silent as they watched the trio approach casually—as if they were not assaulting a heavily defended bastion but were out on an afternoon stroll. As they got closer, Bhus'ik could start to see details in the individual figures; going by what he knew of humanoid body shapes, all three were female. The shortest one was darker in complexion than the other two; she carried a staff, at the top of which a beautiful crystal glowed. The one with the red chitin on her shoulders and claws for hands had white hair—around which sat in a black crown or diadem. Sitting in the crest of this adornment was a red gem; it glowed with dark light which pulsed in time with the spreading fires in the distance.

The final figure—Despara as she was known—carried her massive black sword over one shoulder as she strutted towards them. Bhus'ik was not an expert on human facial features, but the expression of disgust on Despara's face was unmistakable as she regarded the defenders of the sacred Cenotaph.

The trio stopped twenty paces from the line of thirty Qer'kek; the defenders all held their diffusion separators with the emitter plates pointed in the direction of the Empyreans.

“Take one more step closer, and you can say goodbye to your molecular cohesion!” Chis’ik yelled.

The shorter of the trio curled her lip as she regarded them.

“Did you just, like, threaten us? You disgusting creature!” She spat.

The entirety of the defenders hissed through their beaks at the insult, but a raised tentacle from Chis’ik stopped them from rash action.

“Stand aside, and no more of your kind will be crushed today. All we want is the relic,” Despara commanded as she pointed her deadly blade in Chis’ik’s direction.

Chis’ik stepped forward, holding herself erect on all six of her multi-jointed legs.

“Over my dead body!” She proclaimed.

All three women smiled at Chis’ik’s words, seeming to be pleased by her defiance. Despara turned to the white-haired woman and waved her sword in Chis’ik’s direction.

“Want to do the honors, Scorpia?” She asked.

Scorpia smiled, broad and malicious. “With pleasure,”

Bhus’ik watched in mute horror as a black beam lanced out of the woman’s headpiece to sear through the center of Chis’ik’s body. She did not make a sound as her body was pulled into the beam—as if it were a black hole—and when it ceased, nothing remained of Bhus’ik mate.

“Does anyone else want to resist?” Despara asked with a cruel smile.

* * *

Despara was not surprised when the entire line of Qer'kek Guardians suddenly activated their weapons, bathing her, Scorpia and Mermista in a deadly dispersion field. Pain seared through her as the molecules that comprised her body started to lose their bond and disperse.

"Mermista?!" She growled through gritted teeth.

Her fellow Fallen Princess huffed with annoyance as she activated her Staff of Power, sending a wave of kinetic force outward from her body. The magical wave slammed into the defenders, scattering them in all directions as each one was imbued with perpetual motion. They bounced away from the ground and floated through the air like balloons, hooting and whistling as they attempted to grab onto one another with their long tentacles. But each time they made contact, they were repelled from one another, like opposing magnets. A few of the Qer'kek managed to position their strange weapons to point in Despara's direction, but when they tried to activate their weapons, they would not work.

Scorpia stepped forward, pointing her clawed hands at the ground where a black point appeared. The spot spread outwards until a large void appeared under the hapless Qer'kek Guardians; they started to move down towards it as they were drawn in.

"Enough, Scorpia! Remember what Archon Lethe said? We must leave witnesses to our power—lots of them!" Despara shouted.

Scorpia pouted. "Aw! But Mermista gets to use her power!"

"Because I'm keeping them from frying your stupid brain, idiot," Mermista said as she twirled her Staff of Power over her head like a baton.

Scorpia spun on Mermista, opening and closing her clawed hands in a threatening manner as the other Fallen Princess yawned at her. The Void Gem—embedded in its new receptacle by the alchemy of Archon Lethe—began to glow a dull crimson as Scorpia prepared to use it.

“Enough! The both of you!” Despara shouted. “Scorpia! Dismiss your power! Now!”

Scorpia shot Despara a hard look before banishing the yawning nothing under the descending Guardians just in time. They bounced harmlessly off the ground to float aimlessly through the air.

Scorpia stomped up to Despara, her jaw set as she glared at the taller Champion.

“Don’t think you’re the leader of us, Adora,” she said.

Despara bared her teeth. “It’s Despara, now, Not Adora. Try to remember that.”

Scorpia snorted in derision, barging her shoulder into Despara as she passed.

“Even if you’ve forgotten who you are—we haven’t,” Scorpia said, not looking back as she strode towards the Cenotaph. Mermista gave a bored sigh as she followed her, leaving Despara to consider her situation. She was still coming to grips with the understanding that she was once a person named Adora—that every one of the enemies that had called her by that name was not trying to trick her. In fact, the only one not being truthful with her was her Lord, Archon Lethe.

Archon Lethe lied to me; what else are they keeping from me?

As the thought ran through her head—and not for the first time—so too did the memory of trying to defeat the ruler of the Nephraeh. Despara had been utterly powerless against them. They had dominated her, making her fully aware that they owned her no matter where she was in the universe. This truth was made all the more apparent now that Despara had to partake in the Penumbra ritual; she could feel the essence of Archon Lethe coursing through her veins. It gave her added power, for the dark art of Oblivion was more potent—but it came at a cost—acting as a yoke about her neck. Whenever Archon Lethe beckoned,

Despara was now beholden to respond. She knew the price of defying them, the eternal servitude as a mindless wretch—a Vetala. She had no intention of becoming one of them.

Despara sighed loudly as she suddenly thought of Veth; they had tried to tell her, and she had killed them for it. Despara did not feel guilty for doing such a thing, of course, but it would have been good if they were still alive. If not an ally, then at least Veth could have been a fellow prisoner she could commiserate with. Now all she had were the two Fallen Princesses, both of whom had no idea of the trap they led themselves into. Despara would not enlighten them either; doing such a thing would make her appear weak, and she could most definitely not have that. Especially in Archon Lethe's Empyrean Empire.

Hefting her black sword, Despara approached the Cenotaph; it was a strange alien building, much in line with its guardians. It looked like a cluster of silver triangles tossed in a heap—but they all shared a common denominator; every single one of their vertex points pointed up towards the sky. It must have some meaning to the Qer'kek, but Despara did not know what that was, nor did she care as she passed through the triangle-shaped portal and into the main hall, which was entirely in line with the door. The walls and floor were a uniform metallic silver, like the exterior of the building, and Despara was met with her reflection from all three sides of the hall. She followed the sounds of Scorpia's loud voice as she talked loudly to Mermista, leading Despara deeper into the Cenotaph. Finally, she came to the center of the building, finding herself in a wide-open space with Scorpia and Mermista. A rectangular white stone block was sitting in the middle of the area, lit from above by sunlight peering through an obscure opening. Looking closely at the object, Despara could see it had a thick lid, and she knew they had found what they had come for.

"The Tomb of He-Ro," she said out loud.

Like the outside of the Cenotaph, the walls of this room were also covered with triangles; Despara's voice echoed weirdly off them, sounding warped. All three of the trespassers instantly froze as a

group of triangles began to move, joining together to form around a small white triangle, the conglomeration then falling to the floor. The mass of shapes rose then, standing on six spindly legs as four waving limbs spread out from a swelling body. Once the new threat had finished its transformation, it revealed itself to be in the shape of a Qer'kek— although twice their normal size and the color of liquid mercury.

"Uh, like, what did you just do, Despara?" Mermista accused.

"Is that some monster in the shape of one of the Guardians? Is it a ghost of the one Mermista killed?" Scorpia asked nervously.

"Shut up, Scorpia!" Despara hissed as she raised her sword. "It's nothing but a construct, and I'm sure there is some way to destroy it!"

Despara rushed the Tomb Guardian, looking to smite it with one downwards chop of her sword, but the construct was faster, slapping her aside with its tentacles. Despara slammed backward into the tomb, crying out in pain as the lid slid off, smashing to pieces on the ground.

Scorpia crouched as she directed a beam of void energy at the Tomb Guardian, but the black light refracted harmlessly off its surface to transform into crackling red sparks.

"Oh no, you don't!" Scorpia shouted as she changed tactics. A void portal—like the one she used outside—opened under the construct. A metallic screech emanated from its silver body as the power of the void began to pull at it—but it did not budge. The Tomb Guardian simply walked off the void portal as if it was a simple black carpet.

"What the—?" Scorpia cried. "No Fair!"

"Looks like I have to clean up your mess, girls," Mermista said in her typically bored tone. She lowered her Staff of Power as she stepped forward, directing a wall of kinetic force at her enemy. It struck the construct full on, but instead of lifting it harmlessly into

the air, the Tomb Guardian's body began to quiver. This motion began to speed up rapidly into vibration, and a high-pitched sound started to build—like a tuning fork—and all three trespassers placed their hands over their ears as this noise reached intolerable levels. Finally, it reached a harmonic crescendo, and with a keening peal, the construct redirected the power of kinetics back out, throwing Mermista and Scorpia backward as Despara took shelter behind the open tomb. Peeking over the top of the sarcophagus, Despara saw the Tomb Guardian beginning to advance on them, the tips of each of the four tentacles forming into blades.

Something else caught her attention; looking down over the edge of the open tomb, she spotted an ancient and ornate sword lying at the bottom. It was the only occupant of the coffin, for its bearer had fallen long ago in the war with Horde Prime. It was the power sword of one of the seven Champions of Grayskull.

It was the sword of He-Ro.

Despara jumped and reached inside the tomb, seizing the ancient power sword. She now wielded a sword in both hands as she advanced on the relentless enemy who lashed out at her with bladed appendages. Despara blocked a deadly strike with her black sword as she hacked at the construct with the sword of He-Ro, slicing off one of its tentacles. The Tomb Guard made a sound like breaking glass as it backed away from Despara, holding up the wounded appendage for inspection.

"I see Power Swords work on you; I will just keep cutting off pieces until nothing is left!" Despara taunted.



The construct kept backing up until it touched the wall, and Despara watched as one of the triangle shapes peeled off to be absorbed into her enemy. A new tentacle appeared where the old one was cut, and the construct again advanced to resume its attack.

“Nice trick,” Despara said as she clacked her swords together in a challenge. “I’m just going to have to cut bigger pieces,”

With a war cry, she lunged at the Temple Guardian, expertly delivering surgical sword slices while blocking every counterattack. Despara loved physical combat, her dark spirit soaring at being confronted with an actual challenge. Her blood sang with the exertion; she no longer relied on dark magic provided by her master but on She-Ra alone. The usually resistant Avatar Spirit was for once in concert with her will, and she hacked off pieces of the contract. Whenever it tried to retreat to the wall, Despara was there to block its way; the Temple Guardian screeched with rage as it found its body slowly dwindling away until finally, there was only the key piece left—the white triangle.

Despara strutted up to the core intelligence of her enemy, raising the sword of He-Ro with the point down.

“You were a worthy foe, but ultimately it was pointless to stand before me,” she said before stabbing the last piece of the Temple Guardian. It shattered like glass, and Despara kicked and spread the bits with her boot just in case it was able to reform.

Despara held the power sword of He-Ro up in the shaft of sunlight, inspecting the blade's surface. There were intricate runes carved there, appearing like circuity; for some reason, she could read them.

“To the Glory of Grayskull,” Despara read aloud.

For a thrilling moment, she wondered if she could actually activate the sword, thereby binding herself to two Champion Spirits instead of one. But nothing happened, and Despara shrugged, dismissing her magical black sword and commanding her Champion Avatar to form a harness on her back to carry the other.

“How come you get to carry the sword?” Scorpia asked.

Despara turned to the other Fallen Princess while giving her a blank stare.

“Because I’m the leader here,” she said coldly.

Neither Mermista nor Scorpia responded to this declaration, and the three exited the chamber to bring Archon Lethe their new prize.

* * *

“YOU WILL NOT DICTATE TO ME WHAT THE STAR HUNTERS WILL OR WILL NOT DO!”

Aadhya had shouted so loud that some of the adornments on the wall of her study shook and caused almost every one of the room’s Madgēcot occupants to flatten their ears. The exception to this was the focus of the Pratham’s ire—Rishi. He withstood her outrage with a calmness that spoke volumes about his bravery. Catra thought he was completely mad, on top of having no empathy.

After the proclamation of the Great Chaliendra Tree’s revitalization, it was decided that they should retire away from the crowd. Aadhya invited the senior Madgēcot leaders—along with Glimmer as representative of Etheria—to join her in her private study in the Imaarat. But the only way this could be done without inciting a riot was by agreeing to let Rishi accompany them to this exclusive meeting. By his own proclamation to the crowd, he would represent the ‘spirit of their anger’ and see that appropriate justice was done.

Catra had no idea how she got in; she had just followed Glimmer and the guards had barred everyone else while letting her in. Catra thought that perhaps her unique insight as a Madgēcot from another planet was valued, but this didn’t seem to fit. It was almost like there was an aura around her, and the Madgēcots around her were reacting to it on a subconscious level.

“Pratham, with all due respect, it is just not me commanding this to happen. Our people have chosen me to represent them,” Rishi responded calmly.

Aadhya snorted in derision. “Don’t make me laugh. Mob mentality isn’t the wisest of decision makers, as this situation clearly illustrates,”

“Rishi,” Glimmer spoke up, using her most reasonable tone. “Why do you want to destroy the Nephraeh so bad? I know you realize that the loss of your compassion is influencing you; can’t you just see past that to help us find a reasonable solution to all this?”

Rishi turned his head slowly towards Glimmer, his ears lowered and teeth partly bared.

“You have no business here, Outsider,” he said with a low growl. “Do not speak to me about Madgēcot business,”

Glimmer backed away as if struck as Catra bristled with outrage.

“Hey! You can’t talk to her like that! She is a Queen, you jerk!” Catra shouted as she got in Rishi’s face, baring her fangs fully.

Rishi made a scornful face and turned away from Catra, his tail waving lazily, expressing his indifference towards her. Catra noticed it and hissed in anger.

“You may be Madgēcot, but you’re not one of us, Cat-Tra. You are unwanted here, and you insult us with your presence. Everything about you is offensive; your derogatory name, the way you wear your Jaadoo suit—even your smell is offensive!”

Catra was about to raise her hand and slash Rishi when a calming presence suffused her, instantly pushing away her ire. With the cloud of anger now cleared, she could see Rishi for what he really was; broken and in need of pity. Catra turned from his insults with a sniff to stand proudly by Glimmer’s side.

“Rishi, you will not be disrespectful to our Etheria guests, or mob or no mob; I will exclude you from this gathering. You can count on that,” Aadhya said as she pointed a claw-tipped finger at him. “Now answer Glimmer’s question,”

Rishi shrugged. “It just makes perfect sense to me, Pratham. As a Star Hunter, I was raised from a young age with one goal: protecting Elysia and my people. Now I am no longer seen fit to be a Star Hunter, but that does not mean I don’t want what’s best for the Madgēcots! The Nephraeh once were our allies—but that was a thousand years ago. Who even remembers that friendship?”

Aadhya shook her head. “The Madgēcots remember; the Madgēcots remember everything!”

Rishi laughed at this. “Yes, yes, the old adage, it seems our people are full of them. Yes, we do not forget, but the more recent events are perhaps clearer to recollect. The love between Nephraeh and Madgēcots made the Great Chalandra Tree grow—but that was *eons* ago. What have they done recently? Oh, that’s right, they tried to destroy the Great Chalandra Tree!”

“But it’s healed now!” Catra retorted, suddenly feeling nervous when everyone looked at her. Catra felt guilty not telling anyone she was the one who had removed it and that it was currently hidden under her bed.

“Yes, it is! But how? And why?” Rishi exclaimed, suddenly animated. “I will tell you what the people think—the same people who are angry and tired of being hurt by the Nephraeh.”

Aadhya waved her hand dismissively. “It’s utter nonsense and cannot be proven,”

Catra was suddenly very interested. “What are they saying, Rishi?”

He turned to her, fervent belief in his yellow, feline eyes. “That Great Chalandra Tree burned the Power Sword away, releasing the Champion spirit. Sher-Va is now waiting for the proper Madgēcot to be bound to, but first, there must be a reckoning with our enemies, the Nephraeh. Only after they are destroyed will Sher-Va come back,”

Catra jumped and almost shrieked when the voice of Jihan spoke in her head.

Utter nonsense! Sher-Va would never want another race to be destroyed! Cat-Tra! You must tell them you have the Sword! Tell them you are the new Sher-Va!

Catra gulped as she looked about; every Madgēcot in the room had registered her discomfort and was staring at her.

"Is something the matter, Catra?" Aadhya asked.

Catra chuckled anxiously. "Yeah, there is something the matter. That was the *dumbest* thing I had ever heard! How can anyone know such a thing for certain!"

Rishi regarded her with hooded eyes as his tail wagged furiously behind him.

"I wouldn't expect you to believe, Outsider. You have no connection to The Great Chaliendra; you wouldn't understand how we feel," he said scornfully.

For some reason, Rishi's words affected Catra; she did understand how they felt and did not like being labeled as an Outsider.

You are not an Outsider, Cat-Tra. You are one of us! A true Madgēcot!

Pleasure suffused Catra at Jihan's words and allowed herself a small smile.

"What's so funny, Cat-Tra?" Rishi asked suspiciously.

"Oh, nothing." She said in the most insufferable way possible. "It's just that you don't know me; you know nothing about me. You don't know where I've been or what I've experienced, Rishi. I look at you, and I just see myself a couple of years back; angry and alone,"

Rishi snarled with rage, his tail bushing to twice its usual size as he confronted Catra, his face inched from hers.

“And YOU have no idea what I’ve been through! Let me tell you; I’ve had the one thing that meant the most to me my whole life taken from me, my friends look at me with pity, and my mate has left me. I have NOTHING!”

Catra gazed into his eyes, her own softening as she placed a hand on his shoulder.

“There is always a way back—trust me,” she said softly.

Rishi brushed Catra’s hand off as he turned away, back towards Aadhya and the senior leaders.

“We are wasting time, and the Madgēcot people want answers. Will you order the correct course of action?” He demanded.

Aadhya didn’t bother looking at the other leaders. “No, we are not destroying the Nephraeh. They have been beaten and are back on Empyrea, licking their wounds. Until we have further proof that they are a continued threat, I will not countenance—"

The door to the study suddenly slammed open as a junior Start Hunter burst in, datapad in hand. She looked around nervously before heading straight to the Aadhya.

“What is the meaning of this, Saanvi? I said no interruptions!” Aadhya scolded.

“Pratham! You must see this! This came from the Qer’kek; they are under attack!” Saanvi said as she handed the datapad over. Aadhya’s long ears lowered as she looked at the viewscreen with slowly widening eyes.

“No… not now…” She whispered.

“What is it, Pratham?” Rishi asked as he stepped forward, hand outstretched for the datapad.

Aadhya quickly withdrew it from his reach as she looked at Rishi with subdued rage, but he would not relent and continued to hold open his hand expectantly. Aadhya sighed loudly before waving him back.

"I will show everyone what's on this datapad. Everyone needs to see," she said, plugging the datapad into a nearby device on her desk. A holographic screen appeared above it, depicting an expansive courtyard encircled by a series of colonnades. As Aadhya pressed a button, the image suddenly came alive, and three figures in black were seen walking toward whoever was recording these images. Catra felt her heart begin racing as they got closer, and a cold sweat broke out all over her body; she would recognize those faces anywhere. It was Despara along with Mermista and Scorpia—the latter of which had a red stone in a black band wrapped around her head. Mermista was carrying what appeared to be a staff with a powerful gem emanating power held at the top.

"Oh no!" Glimmer cried. "Our friends! They have Ultimate Powers —the Void Gem and Kinetic Krystal!"

Catra reached out to take Glimmer's hand into hers, giving it a gentle squeeze of solidarity.

Despara, Scorpia, and Mermista stopped a distance away, standing arrogantly as they regarded whoever was recording with distaste. There was no audio, but Catra could guess what was being said; *give up, or we will destroy you.* The answer was clear when Scorpia stepped up, the Void Gem now unmistakable as it glowed red before a beam of pure black lanced out. The image suddenly went blank.

"The Qer'kek have requested aid from us," Aadhya said slowly. "They have reported that they have been attacked and that their sacred artifact has been stolen,"

"What is this sacred artifact?" Glimmer asked.

Aadhya pursed her lips as she considered the question. "Not many know this, but they guard a tomb of one of the ancient Champions who was a Qer'kek—He-Ro. The bearer was killed during the war with Horde Prime, and her Power Sword was the only thing left. That was what the Qer'kek have been guarding for the past millennia, and that is what has been stolen."

"By the Nephraeh!" Rishi shouted triumphantly.

"We don't know that! None of the attackers were Nephraeh, Rishi!" Aadhya shouted back.

"Oh, please, Pratham. Despara is known to be Archon Lethe's puppet, and all three wore outfits made of Aegis Lace—only minions of the Empyrean Empire wear that!" Rishi responded as he crossed his arms.

"But, that doesn't—" Aadhya started before one of the Madgēcot council elders interrupted her.

"Pratham, please. You tried, and I respect you for it, but this is too much. The enemy is not licking their wounds back on Empyrea; they are running amok, creating havoc, and getting stronger. Two staves of Power? Now they have just stolen a Champion Power Sword? Enough is enough!" He said reasonably.

Aadhya looked at the rest of the Madgēcot leaders, seeing that none would look her in the eyes; they all agreed with the plan to destroy the Nephraeh before they became more powerful. As she thought about it, she was starting to feel like she agreed with them. It looked like she had no other choice.

"Fine," Aadhya said, seeming to deflate. "But I am the Pratham, and this is my operation. I will see it done right,"

"Fine," Rishi said as he headed for the door. "See that you do, Pratham,"

The rest of the Madgēcot leaders plus Saanvi followed him, leaving Glimmer, Aadhya, and Catra alone in the room.

“So that’s it? You are going to destroy an entire race?” Catra asked.

Aadhya suddenly groaned, holding up her arms as she performed a stretch which she finished by rubbing at her back and scratching her hindquarters.

“Look, Catra, I’m old and tired. I don’t have any answers for you.” She said with a weak smile. “I kind of wish Rishi was right, though,”

“About what?” Glimmer said incredulously.

Aadhya looked at her as she cocked her head, wonder twinkling in her eyes.

“That The Great Chaliendra Tree did destroy the Power Sword, and the spirit of Sher-Va is going to return to us. That is the very thing we need right now, in this dark time. Even without the Eye of Hate, anger has taken hold of my people—it’s even found its way into my old heart. The only thing now that can stop the Nephraeh from being destroyed is a miracle,”

You know what you have to do, Cat-Tra.

Catra shut her eyes as Jihan’s accusing voice rang through her head, but she could deny the unwanted responsibility no longer.

Empathy Waxes

Chapter Summary

Despara, Scorpia, and Mermista return to Empyrea with their prize: The Sword of He-Ro.

A plot is hatched, right under Archon Lethe's nose.

Despara was deep in thought when the Nephraeh shuttle touched down. The landing was so gentle that if it wasn't for her heightened perceptions, Despara would have thought they were still in space—not on Empyrea.

Elegant and weak, like the people who made it, she thought with a scowl.

She had been ruminating over Archon Lethe's inability to summon the Skosis Portal which could have instantly transported them from their mission to the Cenotaph. Instead, Despara and her two companions had to travel by spacecraft back to Empyrea—another testament to Archon Lethe's failing might.

Except they are still strong—vastly stronger than me, Despara thought sourly.

Help would be needed if she ever planned to defeat Archon Lethe and—not for the first time—Despara regarded her two companions as they passed her on their way to the shuttle's exit ramp.

Mermista seemed cool and calculating—a perfect ally with which to defeat an enemy. Scorpia was strong and indomitable, also good traits to have in a collaborator. But would that be enough to defeat their Lord? An even better question: how would she ever be able to trust them? Lack of empathy was freeing for oneself but detrimental to any sort of alliance. Despara would have to find a common cause they all shared; what better goal than freedom did they need?

Except these two don't feel the yoke yet, all they see is the benefits of beings Lethe's pets, Despara considered as she followed them down the ramp and onto the expansive landing pad that served the Hall of Light.

She was immediately jolted from her thoughts by a shocking sight; a large group of Nephraeh had surrounded the entrance to the Hall of Light, shouting and waving their arms. To Despara, they appeared to be performing some kind of protest.

"The Light is wrong!"

"Why are we fighting the Madgēcots? We should open peaceful talks!"

"Archon Lethe, come out and answer us!"

The heavily armored Centurions stood outside and amongst the crowd, appearing befuddled and unsure about what to do.

"Centurion!" Despara called as she approached one of Archon Lethe's guards. "What is the meaning of this? Why do you let this rabble surround the Hall of Light and speak out against the Archon?"

The Centurion regarded her carefully. "And what would you have us do, Champion Despara?"

"Clear them out! With force if necessary!" Despara said as if it were the most obvious answer. The Centurion shook their helmeted head vehemently.

"We absolutely will not do that, Champion. We will not raise our hands against our own people." The Centurion said.

"Like, I can't imagine that Archon Lethe is down with all this," Mermista said as she waved at the crowd with a black-gloved hand.

The Centurion shrugged dismissively, their heavy shoulder plate rattling with the gesture.

"I have no idea what Archon Lethe thinks, nor I would not try. If you want to ask them, they are in the bowls of the House of the Penumbra. That is where they had *retreated* right after you left," The Centurion said, turning away from the trio to turn their attention back to the crowd.

Despara shared a look with Mermista and Scorpia—all three had heard the disrespect in the Centurion's voice when speaking of their leader.

"Let's go," Despara said, indicating the direction of the grand processional leading to the House of the Penumbra. The trio did not say a word as they walked along the Avenue of Triumph and Despara noticed even more changes in the City of Nox from the last time she walked this way.

There was color plastered everywhere in beautifully created mosaics or scenes depicting love and beauty. Amongst this splendor, Nephraeh could be seen in either groups or pairs as they walked or lounged in their enjoyment of the bright Empyrean day. Instead of their usual cold and stand-offish demeanor, these Nephraeh smiled and even laughed, their silver eyes glittering as they regarded each other with obvious affection.

"What happened around here? I mean, these Nephraeh are completely different than we first arrived on this planet." Mermista noted.

"It must have been us," Scorpia said casually. "These Nephraeh just needed some Etherians to show them how to live, that's all,"

"No, you idiot," Despara growled. "It's Archon Lethe's power. It's fading, or haven't you noticed?"

Scorpia's eyebrows shot up as she turned to Despara, while Mermista only snorted in disbelief.

"And why would that be happening, *oh wise leader?*" She said in a monotone.

Despara abruptly halted, holding out her hands for the other two Etherian Princesses to stop.

"You never met Veth, did you? The bearer or Zhe-La?" She asked.

Both Mermista and Scorpia shared a blank look before Despara continued.

"Zhe-La is like me, or more correctly, like my She-Ra power. Archon Lethe had a connection to them, and I think they had used Zhe-La as a conduit to feed on the Nephraeh as a whole,"

"Feed? Like, your saying, Archon Lethe was eating them?" Mermista asked.

"NO! Haven't you been paying attention?" Despara exclaimed, raising her hands over her head and receiving nervous looks from the Nephraeh. "Lethe feeds on empathy; where do you think yours went when it was taken? That's what this whole Oblivion power of theirs comes from—taking compassion from others. Archon Lethe can remove all of someone's empathy or just a little at a time. We don't have to worry because they took all of ours at once. That is not the case for the Nephraeh; their empathy is coming back, and that is why they are acting like this. This means only one thing; Lethe can no longer use Zhe-La to feed on their people. Or at the very least, they can't feed on as much without the Champion Avatar,"

"Well, don't they have you? You're a Champion." Scorpia asked.

Sudden shock seared through Despara; Scorpia was absolutely right.

Why hadn't I thought of that?

"Judging by her expression, I would say you hit a nerve, Scorpia," Mermista said with a rare laugh.

Despara's mind reeled as she considered the possibility that Archon Lethe was feeding through her now; she was partaking in the Penumbra Ritual, just like Veth was. The spirit of Zhe-La was connected to the planet of Empyrea and its people—that's how Archon Lethe fed on them. But that could mean only one thing; She-Ra was connected to Etheria, so perhaps…

Despara shook her head. She did not care about the people of Etheria, but if that was how Archon Lethe was getting their power now, she had to find a way to stop it. If only she could stop taking the Antithetical Philter without Archon Lethe knowing it…

Despara felt a tickling sensation in her hindbrain, a feeling associated with being observed. Looking about, she saw that they were in the part of the city reserved for the living quarters of the Nephraeh. Monolithic apartment complexes sat on either side of the Avenue of Triumph like two immense blocks. Square windows dotted the outside of the flat gray walls, most of which were covered by blinds—but one on the first floor was open.

It appeared to be an apartment for a Nephraeh of rank, for it had its own entrance—complete with a short stack of stairs. As soon as her indigo gaze rested upon that singular window, there was a flicker of silver before the shades were abruptly drawn closed. Someone was up to something in there—something devious—she could just sense it.

Despara shrugged her massively armored shoulders and continued her journey towards the House of the Penumbra.

"Stupid Nephraeh," she muttered to herself.

* * *

Etana looked furtively through their home's window; it had a perfect view of the Avenue of Triumph and that was why their place was selected as the point of meeting. What Etana and their fellow conspirators were planning was very dangerous—it had

never been thought of, let alone attempted in the thousand years of Archon Lethe's rule.

Rebellion.

"Do you see anything, Etana?" Nurma asked nervously behind them.

As soon as the question was posed, they did see something—three figures in the middle of the wide road. They instantly recognized Despara and the two wielders of staves of power that had recently come to Archon Lethe's side. Etana felt a jolt of fear as Despara suddenly looked their way, and they hurriedly shut the blinds—then cursed themselves for acting so rashly.

"What is it?" Nurma asked, very nervous now.

Etana peeked through the curtain's edge just in time to see Despara and her companions continue in a direction other than their front door. Etana sighed in relief.

"Nothing, my love. It's nothing; we are safe," they answered.

Nurma came up behind to wrap Etana in a tight embrace. "Don't lie to me—remember; I can see the truth in you now,"

Etana chuckled. Yes, just like every Nephraeh, Nurma had *the sight* now.

"There was a moment when I thought we were in trouble, but now it's passed. That is all," Etana said as they turned in Nurms's arms to face them. "Nothing will stop our plans, I promise you!"

"And what is that plan, exactly?" Aloros asked behind them. The entwined pair turned to the rest of their collaborators; all eight were standing or seated on the two long couches in Etana's small apartment.

Aloros, Inanna, Urhammu, and Sargon were all Arachi of the Empyrean Empire—magistrates who dealt closely with enacting

the Archon Lethe's will via their interpretations of *The Light*. All four were dressed in tight-fitting black, gray, and purple outfits worn by magistrates with short black capes hanging down from their shoulders. Zu, Kirashi, and Bau were Stategos of the armed branches of the Nephraeh—high generals whose will directed those mighty forces. They wore the Aegis-Lace body-suits typical of Nephraeh warriors, which were accessorized by capes, belts, or marital sashes. Ki was an off-duty Centurion who had recently become the lover of Ningal—the Agos of the Centurions. They were out of their Aegis-Lace and wearing a casual loose robe of a gossamer material, the top of which was parted to reveal the white marking on their chest. Etana and Nurm were Hierophants of the Temple of the Penumbra—perhaps the most important of all the members—for they knew the truth of Archon Lethe. They still wore the white full-body robes of their order, the hoods down to reveal their attractive lilac faces.

"Archon Lethe is desperate right now. The spirit of Zhe-La has not arrived in the Temple of Light beneath the House of the Penumbra. That can mean two things; either it has gone to the Well of Champion Spirits now that Castle Grayskull is back in our reality, or Veth is still alive and out of their reach. Either way, Archon Lethe no longer has control over Zhe-La." Etana said.

"And why is that important?" Aloros asked.

"Because that is how Archon Lethe has been draining our empathy for the past millennia, to fuel their power—through Zhe-La. Through the Penumbra Ritual, Archon Lethe had been making the bearer of Zhe-La absorb parts of their essence to establish a link to the Champion Avatar. Zhe-La is magically connected to our planet, and since we, the Nephraeh, are magical in nature, they had a direct connection to every single one of us." Etana answered.

Everyone looked at each other, shock plain on their lilac faces.

"So, all this time, you Hierophants knew all about this? And you helped Archon Lethe do it?" Ki asked, incredulous.

“Yes, we did. Archon Lethe gave us the knowledge to help suppress the Temple of Light and to assist with the Penumbra Ritual. And why wouldn’t we? We had our empathy taken just as you did. Would you have cared if we told you how your compassion had been taken?” Etana spoke up.

Everyone looked at each other and shrugged; they knew they would not have cared.

“Well, knowing what I know now—no—how I *feel*,” Ki said, closing their silver eyes and gently caressing their claws down their chest. “I would have fought to get it back! I would have fought to get it back for all my people!”

Everyone nodded in agreement at Ki’s words. The return of empathy to the Nephraeh had many wondrous effects, the increase in passion foremost of them all.

“And the things I can see now! Wondrous!” Ki continued as they opened their eyes wide to look at their fellow Nephraeh. “When I first started seeing it in my fellow Nephraeh, the colors that went beyond colors, the indescribable shapes, I thought I was going mad! And then, when you told me that I was seeing souls, Etana, I thought *you* were mad!”

Everyone laughed at this, for they all went through the same thing. In millennia past, before Archon Lethe took their empathy, it was simply called Nephraeh Sight, the ability to see another living being’s ethereal essence, their *quintessence*. This ability accentuated the compassion of the Nephraeh, for it allowed them to see the path which made the person. They could see the joy, the love, and the pain someone had experienced—it was all there for them to see, as plain as the nose on someone’s face.

“Yes, yes,” Aloros said with a small smile. “It is a truly wondrous time, and I agree with you, Ki—I would fight to keep what I have just recently discovered in myself. So, let’s get back to the plan, eh?”

“What’s the matter, Aloros?” Inanna said with a mischievous smile. “Has your Nephraeh Sight not helped you find someone to help you with all these new *sensations* you’ve been having? Don’t worry if you haven’t; you will find them just as I found mine. In the meantime, though, Sargon and I can help you with the need to find *satisfaction*,”

Aloros turned away as their color darkened, making the assembled Nephraeh share a chuckle.

“Enough, Inanna, stop teasing Aloros,” Etana said not unkindly. “They are right; we need to get back to the discussion at hand,”

The grin did not leave Inanna’s face as they seized Aloros’ wrist, pulling them gently down to sit on the couch between themselves and Sargon. Aloros’ blush did not recede but was now accompanied by a very pleased expression.

“As I said, Archon Lethe is below the House of the Penumbra. I suspect they are attempting to use their hold on She-Ra to develop a new connection in which to feed; the people of Etheria,” Etana said.

“But you just said it only worked on us because we Nephraeh are half magical,” Aloros said, screwing up their face in confusion. “I am not very familiar with Etheria—no one is. Are the people there half magical?”

Etana shook their head. “According to my contacts in the Gnosis, the majority are not. But that won’t stop Archon Lethe—believe me. They will get what they want through She-Ra, and everyone on Etheria will be like we were for the past thousand years.”

Everyone muttered at this, worried at the thought of so much evil coming to so many people far away.

“Yes, and that is not the least of our *wonderful leader’s* crimes. I have it on good authority that they recently attempted to corrupt the entire race of Madgēcots with an Abominable Power!” Zu said, barely able to control their anger.

“That’s right! Now that Grayskull is back, that *evil* has returned to our universe,” Aloros said in a hush. “Which one of the dread powers did they use?”

“The Eye of Hate,” Zu answered with disgust. “They must have used the skills of the Gnosis to break into Grayskull and steal the Abominable Power. It must have happened before Zhe-La disappeared, for I know the Gnosis would not do it now.”

“Yes, we worked closely with them. As soon as their order began to develop sympathy, they secretly joined our ranks. Once we get our hands on the Eye of Hate they can help us get it back to Grayskull,” Kirashi stated.

Zu suddenly turned towards Kirashi, placing their hand on the other’s shoulder.

“There is no need, my friend. Before he was drawn into the chaotic portal, the bearer of He-Man destroyed the Eye of Hate. It’s gone, forever.” Zu said with a smile.

“So is He-Man dead now?” Aloros asked no one in particular, looking around at the assembled group.

“The Madgēcots think so,” Etana answered. “But we of the Hierophants believe otherwise. He is simply *lost*—for now,”

“So, where does that leave us?” Aloros proposed to everyone. “What’s the plan to stop this evil from getting worse?”

Etana nodded at Aloros. “We cannot go against Archon Lethe outright. We Hierophants know they are mighty—beyond our combined capabilities as they are now. But we have been working to sabotage them by lifting some of the restraints on the Temple of Light—this will begin to weaken Archon Lethe and make our planet painful to them. We even have been working on trying to figure out a way to nullify the Antithetical Philter and stop them from gaining a connection to Etheria. If we could keep them from their source of nourishment—to starve them if you will—perhaps

we could weaken them enough to strike at them. That's where you come in,"

Etana waved a clawed hand toward the three Stategos, who nodded back.

"I have been working on slowly subverting the ranks of my Hoplites to our cause. This has become easier as time passes, and their empathy grows." Kirashi said.

"Same with my Peltasts, and I believe the entirety of the Sarissa has already been *corrupted*," Zu said as they shared a mischievous grin with Bau.

"Do we even want to know what the smile is for, Zu?" Nurma asked.

Bau shrugged. "It's nothing too terrible; I just had the idea of creating secret warrior lodges in which to gather my Sarissa in small groups to spread ideas and *fraternize*,"

Bau emphasized the last word by gently reaching over and running a single clawed finger down Zu's face. The meaning was not lost on anyone.

"I thought it was such a great idea I incorporated it into my forces," Zu added as they beamed back at Bau.

"When were you going to share this revelation with me?" Kirashi said with a frown.

"Poor Peltalts," Bau said, matching Kirashi's frown with a teasing one of their own. "Don't worry; we were going to get to you,"

"I hope you are all taking this seriously," Aloros said, shaking their head in reproach. "I know we have been experiencing a kind of renewal and freedom lately, but we cannot forget what our goal is,"

Three scathing looks were what Aloros received, their words ruffling the feathers of the three proud leaders of warriors.

"Relax, *magistrate*," Bau said as they brushed their sleek onyx hair back over one shoulder. "We know what we are doing. Out of all our techniques to turn our people, fraternization is the most effective. It builds bonds between warriors, making them think twice about risking each other's lives. It also makes them wonder about the person ultimately leading them."

"Yeah, sometimes doing important things can be fun," Zu said, still grinning as Aloros rolled their eyes at them.

"And you can count on the Centurions," Ki added. "Ningal has them all on the same page as us."

"Excellent! Everything is coming together splendidly!" Etana said, clapping their hands together. "What about you, magistrates? What can we expect on your end?

Aloros looked at their fellow Arachi—they nodded back, and Aloros cleared their throat.

"Well, while the Stategos were having a good time, my fellow Arachi and I have been busily stymieing any new rules and regulations Archon Lethe has passed to restrict our freedoms. We have been starting to see them coming, and we now know the reason; Archon Lethe cannot dominate us through Zhe-La anymore. Now they try to do it through new laws."

Many of the assembled Nephraeh scoffed at this. "It will take more than mere laws to subdue us now. What we are experiencing is a revolution not just physically but spiritually as well! It cannot be stopped!" Bau exclaimed proudly.

Aloros regarded Bau with hooded eyes. "You can be stopped if your dead," they said simply.

Before Bau could retort, a loud banging came from the door leading to the outside of the apartment. Etana peeked around the

edge of the window to see who was at the front door; as soon as they did, they let out a low moan.

"Who is it?" Aloros whispered as they crouched down on the ground. The other three Arachi were attempting to hide with them, but the four Nephraeh warriors were on their feet, pulling out obscure weapons and adopting fighting stances. Etana turned to the conspirators, their face grim as they mouthed the word 'Krypteia.'

"Open up; I know you all are in there," a muffled voice said through the door.

"That's Amah," Bau whispered. "Let them in, and we can subdue them."

Etana nodded and opened the door in one quick motion. The leader of the Krypteia strode in, fully garbed in their raiment of Aegis Lace and black armor. Immediately Zu, Kirashi, Bau, and Ki rushed them; clawed hands reaching out to seize them. Amah immediately adopted a fighting stance, pushing out with gauntleted hands to project a wave of enervation at all four attackers. Immediately they went down with cries of dismay; now that the Nephraeh had empathy to remove, the power of Oblivion was very effective on them.

"Don't try that again, you idiots!" Amah scolded. "Using the power of Oblivion is very hard for me now, and I don't want to use it again!"

Bau helped Zu up as Bau and Ki struggled to stand. All four of the warriors looked ill from the effects of Oblivion.

"I think I'm going to be sick," Ki complained.

Having not been affected by the enervating wave, Aloros stepped forward, putting on a brave face as they confronted the Krypteia.

"What is it that you want?" They cried, fear plain in their voice.

Amah removed their sable helmet to reveal a grim lilac face. Suddenly they smiled at everyone, exposing their upper and lower fangs. It was a genuine expression, for it reached all the way up to their glittering silver eyes.

"What do I want? To join you, of course. The Krypteia have had enough of Archon Lethe's lies."

* * *

Despara's mood had not improved as she led Mermista and Scorpia up the stairs to the entranceway of the House of the Penumbra. During the trip from the Hall of Light, she had been constantly reminded of the increasing freedoms granted to the Nephraeh—freedoms that were not given to her. Stomping loudly through the foyer and into the temple, Despara looked about the open space, taking it in one long sweep.

The House of the Penumbra was one enormous hall for one straightforward task: the taking of the Antithetical Philter. Despara had started coming here recently, as per Archon Lethe's orders, to partake in the Penumbra. Striped of all clothing besides a simple loincloth, Despara would kneel upon the circular plinth in the center of the temple as the Hierophants poured the indigo glowing substance of the Antithetical Philter upon her chest. There it would absorb into her, cleansing her of any unwanted weakness and solidifying her loyalty to Archon Lethe and the Empyrean Empire.

Despara was surprised that she did not see any of the Hierophants; they were usually quick to greet those who visited. Only a single young Nephraeh in the robes of a Neophyte approached the visitors, giving them all a gracious bow.

"I don't recognize you; where are the ones who usually attend to me when I come for the Penumbra Ritual?" Despara asked.

The Neophyte smiled as if they expected this question. "Etana and Nurma are elsewhere, Champion Despara. Are you here for your

sacred ablution to the Penumbra? You are not due for that until tomor—”

Despara cut the Neophyte off with a chopping motion of her armored hand.

“Actually, I don’t care where those Nephraeh are, and I’m not here for the Penumbra. I heard Archon Lethe is here, and I want to see them, that is all.”

The Neophyte bowed more deeply this time as they indicated the passageway to the Vaulted Crypt under the House of the Penumbra. Already knowing the way, Despara rolled her eyes in irritation as she led the other two Princesses to the alcove which housed the small dark opening. Taking a lit torch from a nearby sconce, Despara proceeded down the winding spiral stone steps and into the depths of the temple. As they moved down, the staircase walls narrowed, increasing the sense of claustrophobia.

“How does Archon Lethe get down here?” Scorpia complained as her shoulders scraped against the wall.

As soon as she spoke, the wall ended, and Scorpia and Mermista cried out in fear as they almost tipped over and into the stygian nothingness. They pressed their bodies back against the staircase as Despara chuckled at their panic.

“Careful! Or Archon Lethe will have to find two new Staff Bearers!”

After scowling down at their self-appointed leader, Scorpia and Mermista took in the cavernous space as their eyes slowly adjusted.

They were in a massive cavern, high in the air and above a dirt floor, which they could see far below by way of a glow cast by numerous lights placed in the cavern’s ceiling. But there was another light source, far down below, shining out from behind the many wide pillars which held the roof aloft. This light was wonderous and beautiful, but it appeared obscene and awful to the three whose compassion was absent. To them, the inky black

the illumination held at bay was much more preferred than its luminescence, and they averted their eyes to the comfort of the dark. After carefully navigating the rest of the stairs, they eventually made it to the bottom, much to the joy of Mermista and Scorpia. All three took a moment to take in the realm of dusk they now inhabited.

The air was dense down here—but not from the increased weight of the air. The pressure seemed to come from elsewhere beyond the physical, appearing to the visitors as if a force was being applied everywhere at one—like something was trying to push free. Satisfaction filled them at knowing that whatever this presence was, it would remain trapped, for a terror filled them at the thought of it being set free.

"Come on, our Lord should be over here," Despara said, indicating that they proceed in the direction of the light.

As they moved closer to their destination, Despara noticed that the ground—typically dry and lifeless—was spongier, like it had started to accumulate moisture. Instead of falling freely from her boots as she walked, it stuck to her soles, accumulating like mud. But Despara was not aware of this; she was more disturbed by the increasing unpleasant sensation of drawing closer to the light, as was Scorpia and Mermista. Turning around the last column, the travelers finally saw their destination.

Much like the other times Despara had seen the strange building, she was immediately filled with loathing and disgust. The entire structure was made of pure white material, appearing as bands of fiber so fine it was like spun sugar. The architecture was wretchedly organic, composed of sweeping arcs that raised from the ground to meet at the point at the top. At this peak was the source of the radiance, and Despara felt overlapping waves of nausea as she laid eyes upon it.

"Unnnnggghhh…" she moaned, suddenly falling to her knees before its glare. Mermista and Scorpia were likewise affected, and all three were held in place by the power of the luminescence.

“It is… worse than… I remember,” Despara said through clenched teeth.

Despara had only been here twice before; the first time was upon her awakening from her transformation, and the second was after the disaster at Enos. Both times the light’s glare was offset by another power that Despara knew was associated with Archon Lethe. But that was gone now, and it was like looking directly into the sun without the benefit of eye protection.

“What is it, Despara? Why does it hurt so much?” Mermista said in a rasp behind her.

Despara could not answer, for the blazing light had overcome her. It was like a malefic star, one whose radiance sought to dominate her body and soul, and with a creeping terror, Despara felt it begin to change her. It was not entirely apparent, but it felt like the light was pushing something into her soul or ripping out a piece of her body—perhaps both, simultaneously. She had felt this sensation before, back on Enos, when she fought the corrupted He-Man for the first time. It was when Nefeli had been struck through and Veth had summoned the same horrible light from within their body.

“My Children! Do not fear! I am with you!” A powerful androgynous voice suddenly rang out.

Through hazy vision, a vision of pure magnificence appeared from under the domineering blaze. It was Archon Lethe; they were striding out to the anguishing trio with hands held out, a look of benevolence on their beautiful white face. Reaching down, they plucked Despara from the ground so easily, it was as if she were nothing more than a baby. Archon Lethe held her gently with one arm as they retrieved Scorpia and Mermista in the same manner, then carried all three towards the strange building, ducking under the entrance portal as Despara and her compatriots sighed with relief. They were away from the baleful gaze of the ghastly light and safe in the arms of their dread god.

Despara knew from experience that the interior of the ugly building was much more spacious than its exterior led one to believe. It was as if the entire building was just an outward façade, hiding a much bigger structure that was hidden beyond sight and knowing. They passed through halls made of the same fine material as the outside—the walls made of interlocking strands of a fine, white substance, while larger quantities in thick cords formed the structure of the building. There were no hard edges or corners, just rounded surfaces that projected softness and delicacy. Despara didn't mind, though; she was just glad to be away from the hideous light and allowed herself to be carried to wherever Archon Lethe desired.

Striding by the room she recognized as the place of her awakening, Archon Lethe carried them further, passing more rooms, until gradually, the corridor widened and formed into an area of its own. It abruptly opened into a chamber so vast it was impossible to imagine that it was inside the underground cavern beneath the House of the Penumbra.

"Where are we?" Despara whispered as Archon Lethe placed her gently on the ground.

"At the heart of the Temple of Light, My Child," they said as they placed Scorpia and Mermista down next to her.

Despara stared in awe around her; this room was composed of the same material as the rest of the Temple of light, but instead of white, much of it glowed dull indigo, darkening the chamber. Despara was amazed by the sense of comfort it gave her, seeing the evidence of her Lord's power here in the heart of all the white wretchedness. But here and there was evidence of the power of Oblivion being undone; white patches like blemishes dotted the walls and floor. The worst corruption was at the center of the chamber—there, a great crystal sat on a pedestal of white, spun material. It was a massive stone, standing about five times Despara's height and twice her width; it was utterly translucent and at its apex was the dread light, shooting upwards like a lance

through the roof. Instantly, the sensation from before returned—more subtle and not as intense.

"Don't look at *The Light,* My Child." Archon Lethe said gently, placing their massive white hand over Despara's face.

Despara did as instructed, averting her gaze from the top of the crystal as she stood wearily to her feet. Mermista and Scorpia were likewise regaining their senses, and the three stood before their lord, bowing their heads in obeisance.

"My Children!" Archon Lethe said with a laugh. "It was foolish for you to come here; the wards I have placed on the Temple of Light have recently slipped; it is hazardous for you to be here,"

Despara cleared her throat, still keeping her eyes averted from Archon Lethe's face. At that moment, she felt utterly subjugated by them.

"My Archon, we have returned from your task and have the Sword of He-Ro,"

Despara withdrew the power sword from the scabbard at her back and kneeled, holding it aloft as she bowed her head. Archon Lethe took the sword from her, holding it up with one hand as they ran a black claw down the blade's surface, tracing the runes there.

"To the Glory of Grayskull," they said with a smile and walked over to a high black table set up near the giant crystal. Archon Lethe laid the Power Sword of Her-Ro on the table whose surface was even with Scorpia's shoulders as Despara and her companions crept up behind their master, peeking over the table's edge like children. There they saw incomprehensible objects whose functions were mysterious; a glossy black orb, delicate instruments made of glass and bone, and an intricate metal box composed of different metals were amongst the most noteworthy. But Archon Lethe ignored these treasures as they reached for a hammer; it was cruel in design, appearing forged from dark iron

and etched with incomprehensible runes. They lifted it tentatively as they considered it with glowing indigo eyes.

“Will the power sword be bound to one of the Krypteia, My Archon?” Despara asked.

Archon Lethe turned to her so suddenly it made Despara step back a pace; it was as if they were looking at a ghost. But then they smiled, showing all their sharp black teeth as they shook their head.

“No,” Archon Lethe said evenly.

They suddenly brought the hammer down, striking the Power Sword, which exploded into sparks and metal fragments. Despara and her companions cried out in surprise, shielding their faces and eyes from flying detritus. Still in shock, they brought their hands down just in time to see an ethereal shape rise from the sword. It hung in the air inches before Archon Lethe’s face, undulating and pulsing before it sped away towards the giant crystal and into its glassy surface. It fluttered inside the giant crystal momentarily, bouncing against the sides before moving in a circular motion, orbiting a singular point in diminishing arcs—like a leaf caught in a drain. As it came to the center of the decreasing spiral, it stopped, and the strange shape which came from the destruction of the Power Sword of He-Ro simply vanished.

“Where did it go?” Scorpia said like a sad child.

Archon Lethe placed the hammer down and turned to their followers, steepling their black stained fingers as a pleased expression spread across their face.

“To where I need it to be,” Archon Lethe said.

Truth

Chapter Summary

Catra accepts the truth of who she is.

There is a new resident in the Well of Avatar Spirits.

“Catra! What have you done?”

The sun's light through the bedroom window glinted off the sword as Catra held it out, beckoning her brother to take it. Viraj stared as if he was looking at a ghost, both of his heterochromatic eyes wide with shock and long black ears flat against his head.

“You took the sword of Sher-Va from The Great Chaliendra Tree? How?” He said, gently reaching out to brush the tips of his black claws against its gleaming surface.

Catra shook her head, mouth open as she fought for the right words. She had brought him to her room directly after the disastrous meeting to decide the fate of the Nephraeh, hoping to convince him to take on the mantle of Sher-Va.

Tell your brother the truth, Cat-Tra. Tell him Sher-Va chose you and The Great Chaliendra Tree allowed you to take it. Tell him! The ghost of Jihan pleaded in Catra’s head.

“I don’t know, Viraj! Last night, after the ceremony for Shen, I just… wandered off… like I was in a daze. I was—am—so angry and sad. I found myself in front of The Great Chailendra tree, and then… I don’t know. I woke up back in my bed, and I had the sword,”

Catra shrugged her shoulders before lowering the Power Sword down.

“Why didn’t you tell me, Cat-Tra? This is amazing! Why wouldn’t you tell your own brother something like this?” Viraj asked.

Catra gritted her teeth, she knew this question was coming, but it didn't prepare her for how the sadness in Viraj's voice stabbed her heart.

"I wanted to, Viraj, believe me! When I found it, I thought I was going crazy, especially when—" Catra stopped herself from mentioning Jihan with a shake of her head. "Anyway, when I saw it, I just got scared. Then you busted into my room and…"

Catra's eyes searched the room vainly as she tried to think of what else to say, but she didn't have to. Viraj's face softened as he grasped his sister by the shoulders to peer into her eyes.

"It's okay, Cat-Tra. I understand. What matters is that you are telling me now." Viraj said with a smile.

Catra nodded and returned the smile, but the guilt of not telling her brother the whole story bothered her. She did not want to be the person that didn't listen to her feelings anymore; time and time again, when she was still in the Horde, Catra had ignored her intuition. That was what brought her so much pain.

"No, Viraj, there is something else," Catra said finally. "Last night, before everything went black, I saw someone, a male Madgēcot. He was beckoning me to take the sword."

Viraj cocked his head as he stared at Catra, confusion plain on his face, then suddenly, he nodded.

"Yes, that is not a strange occurrence. Many Madgēcots have visions in the presence of The Great Chailendra Tree,"

This made Catra laugh. "Do other Madgēcots hear the voice of a long-dead Champion? A voice that continues to speak to them even though she tells the voice to be shut up?"

Viraj gaped at Catra. "Jihan? Do you hear Jihan speaking to you? What does he say?"

Catra waved his question away. “It doesn’t matter, Viraj. What matters is what are we going to do about this?” She said, lifting the Power Sword back up, holding it horizontally in both hands. “It needs a new bearer, someone to be Sher-Va,”

“Well, before the Champion Avatars were bound to Power Sword by Zzar, new bearers were chosen by the Avatar itself. They were bound together in ceremonies that took place in sacred locations. For the Madgēcots, it was before The Great Chailendra Tree. I’m not sure how it happens now that it’s bound to a Power Sword,”

Catra already had an answer to this—she was steering the conversation to this point.

“Well, when Adora found the sword of She-Ra in the Whispering Woods, all she did was say, ‘For the Honor of Grayskull,’ and she became She-Ra the first time and bound to the Champion Avatar. I'm sure it’s the same for this sword,”

Cat-Tra, that is an oversimplification of what happened. She-Ra had already chosen Adora before she took up the sword, Jihan chastised her. But Viraj seemed convinced.

“Okay, so say the words,” he said to her. “The sword came out of the tree for you, and you should be the bearer of Sher-Va,”

I like your brother; he is wise.

“NO!” Catra practically shrieked. “Didn’t you hear what I said? It doesn’t matter that I pulled the sword out; I’m not special. It can be anyone! I think it should be you!”

If Viraj’s heterochromatic eyes could get any wider, Catra thought his head would explode. On top of that, his tail had increased in size and beat the air behind him. After the shock had initially worn off, Catra could see that the idea was starting to take root in him; he reached out as his eyes began to sparkle.

“Why… what… me?” He said slowly.

Catra proffered the sword out, handle exposed and ready to be taken.

"You are a perfect choice, Viraj. You know all about the Champions. You were trained to fight, honorable, and are strict rule follower; you're perfect!" Catra exclaimed. "Just take the sword and say the words!"

Viraj took the sword in both hands, testing the weight before holding it above his head. The blade tip almost touched the top of the ceiling as Catra backed away expectantly.

"Oh! We are going to do this now?" She said, surprised at the disappointment she felt.

Why am I having second thoughts? This is the right choice, she thought to herself.

"On the Truth of Grayskull!" Viraj shouted.

After nothing happened, Viraj lowered the sword, confusion on his face as Catra began laughing.

"I thought you were the big Champion Fan-Boy!?" She said, still giggling. "Don't you know the words are 'By the Truth of Grayskull?' It's *by* not *on*! Try it again!"

"I read the words from an old text; it's the only remaining recording we have from a thousand years ago. It must have been corrupted over the long years," Viraj said, lowering the sword. "Wait! How do you know the right words?"

Catra pointed to the blade of Sher-Va, tapping a black-clawed finger against the surface. "It says it right here, on the sword. I'm surprised you missed it, 'Mr. Attention to Details,'"

Viraj frowned and shook his head. "I can't read Runes, Catra. I was never any good at it; not many are. You need a special magical connection which I don't have."

Catra backed away from her brother, uncertain. "No… that's not possible. I can't read First One's Runes; that's something Adora was able to do—not me!"

Now it was Viraj's turn to laugh. "First of all, they are not 'First One's Runes,'— whatever that is! But that is beside the point; you can read them!"

The realization that her brother was correct hit Catra like a hammer—as well as the implication that she had some form of magical connection. Magic always made Catra uncomfortable; it was a big leap for her that she accepted using it in the form of her Jaadoo suit. But to have a magical *bond*—that was too much. But there it was, clear as day, written along the blade; *By the Truth of Grayskull*.

"Uh, so what?" Catra said in a lame response.

"SO, WHAT?" Viraj exclaimed, lowering the sword as suspicion spread across his cinnamon face. "Cat-Tra, what is this ghost of Jihan saying to you?"

Catra tried to back away from her advancing brother, but her bed stopped her. Catra sat down hard and looked up at Viraj with both of her black ears lowered as far as they could go.

"Nu—nothing!" She said, trying to look away. "Just some stupid nonsense about some… history… some history garbage,"

Viraj sat next to Catra, laying the Power Sword between them, and placed a comforting hand on her shoulder.

"Cat-Tra, it's okay. Just tell me, I won't judge you. I'm your twin brother, remember?" He said kindly.

Catra groaned and shook her head. "*Fine.* I will tell you. But you have to promise not to take *his* side,"

Viraj was taken aback by his sister's familial reference to her inner voice but nodded. "*Your side* is the only one I will take, my sister,"

Catra couldn't stop herself from blushing in embarrassment; even if she could, Viraj would have picked it up in the way her tail moved or the position of her ears.

"So, when I woke yesterday and found the sword, he started talking to me. In my head," Catra began, wringing her hands together.

"Jihan, you mean?" Viraj said, placing his hand over hers to stop her from fidgeting.

"Yes—Jihan. Or maybe some echo of who he once was. Adora sometimes speaks to the last bearer of Sher-Ra, somebody named Mara. Anyway, he said that I was chosen, by who or what, he didn't say. But what he did say—and continues to say even though I told him to stop—is that I am the next bearer of Sher-Va,"

"WHAT!!" Jihan almost shouted.

Catra immediately leaped off the bed, holding up her hands to forestall her brother from saying anything more.

"But I'm not, Viraj! It's a mistake! I can't have that kind of power! Not again!" Catra pleaded.

"Again? What are you talking about? You've never had a Champion power before… have you Cat-Tra?" Viraj said, tilting his head.

"No! Not that… but similar." Catra said, letting out a long sigh. "I told you about my time in the Horde, right? About the time after Adora left?"

Viraj nodded. "Yes, you became—what is it called? Force Captain? That you worked your way to becoming Hordak's second in place. I believe you even beat him in hand-to-hand combat—twice. I'm confused about the last part; were you in charge of the Horde at that point? Or were you still Hordak's second? Co-leader?"

Catra waved Viraj's question away. "Not important! What is important is what that authority did to me; I hurt people. I hurt people close to me, all so I could get more power. I can't imagine what I would become as Sher-Va. I don't… I don't trust myself, Viraj,"

Catra looked down forlornly, pawing at the floor with a clawed foot as Viraj stood up, taking her hands in his.

"Cat-Tra, let me ask you a question: why did you do those things in the Horde? What was driving you?" He asked.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra said, pulling her hands away and walking towards the window, hugging herself. "I went over all this with Perfuma. It was all based on my abandonment issues… blah blah…"

"Yes, you let anger and your need for revenge drive you—negative emotions which, of course, only led to pain and suffering," Viraj said, walking up behind his sister tentatively. "But what would drive you to take up the sword of Sher-Va? The same emotions?"

"No," Catra practically groaned, deflating. Viraj placed his hands on Catra's shoulders.

"That's right. You would be doing it to protect others. Because you are a Madgēcot and because you care."

Catra moaned again but did not argue as her brother continued.

"Last but not least, you are doing it so you can face Despara—to defeat her— and get Adora back. You're doing it for love, Cat-Tra," he finished.

Catra turned to face Viraj, staring into his heterochromatic eyes with her opposite ones.

"Catra, don't you see? Your past has made you the perfect choice for Sher-Va; it has tempered you to resist all the negative emotions which could corrupt a Champion. You have seen

firsthand what it does to you and know it is not the right way. No other Madgēcot on Elysia has gone through what you went through. It's why they are all driven by anger now," Viraj said, turning away sorrowfully. "Including me,"

Don't you see now, Cat-Tra? Are you ready to do what is required of you?

Catra could no longer deny the truth; Sher-Va had to come back, and the only person who could bear Sher-Va's sword was her. Catra could not help but notice that a small part of her was happy about this; even Catra demanded that she become Sher-Va.

"Yes," Catra said. "I do. I will become Sher-Va,"

* * *

"Micah! Come look at this!" Castaspella called.

Micah looked up from scroll he had been studying to turn his attention to his sister; she was standing in front of the Well of Avatar Spirits, pointing at it with a look of shock. One of the pylons was obscuring what she was looking at, and Micah placed the scroll on a nearby table. He was glad for the distraction, for the old parchment was another dead end; useless details on the categorization techniques of a prior Keeper of Secrets for Castle Grayskull. One before the evil Zzar took the post, of course.

Micah and his sister had continued their investigation of the secret chamber found beneath the catacombs of Castle Grayskull after its discovery—now called 'The Vestibule of Subternia' by everyone involved. As Head Sorcerer of Mystacor, Castaspella could call on additional aid from her kingdom, and a temporary conservatoire was set up in the Vestibule to conduct field research. Acolytes and Students from Mystacor were busy pouring over old scrolls and books from Castle Grayskull—some were even examining every surface of the chamber, looking for any patterns from which to decipher any hidden meanings. But they hadn't made much progress regarding learning anything new, mainly because there

wasn’t anything new to discover. The purpose of the Vestibule was straightforward enough; all seven Champions of Grayskull must activate all seven pylons to open the way to Subternia. Other than that, it appeared to be also a collection point for the Champions Avatars, perhaps even a place where new bearers were bonded to bearers, becoming Champions themselves. There wasn’t much information regarding that, just the Well of Champion Avatars—a giant crystal where magical spirits would gather when no longer bonded.

“What is it, Cassie?” Micah asked as he moved closer. But the answer was evident once he looked inside.

Where once there was only one Champion Spirit of Thon-Ra, now there were two. Both amorphous shapes glided about the interior of the crystal, their movements like jellyfish deep underwater.

“Well, I’ll be!” Micah exclaimed. “When did that one show up?”

Castaspella shook her head. “I have no clue; I was on my way to ask the acolytes to collect more documents from the library above when I saw there was a new Spirit.”

Micah continued to stare at the Avatar Spirits; now that there were two, he realized he could tell the difference between them. He recognized the Spirit of Thon-Ra, for it had two broad ethereal shapes to either side of it—like wings. Both Spirits were pure white, but Thon-Ra had yellow threads that moved slowly about their form. The new Spirit undulated throughout the Well like a snake, with two blue points on the forward end—like eyes.

“What are you two looking at —” Perfuma started to say before she gasped and dropped the scrolls she had been carrying.

“Another one!” She said finally. “They are beautiful!”

Micah came to stand by Perfuma, suddenly nervous about the question he was about to ask.

“Which one is it, Perfuma? Is it She-Ra? Or—”

Perfuma shook her head fervently. “No, they are not the Avatar Spirt of She-Ra or He-Man,” she said, closing her eyes and summoning the power of the Life Gem. “They are called *He-Ro*,”

“He-Ro,” Castaspella said as she pursed her lips. “Pretty obvious name, huh?”

The Spirit of He-Ro pulsed a light blue in response to Castaspella, and Perfuma suddenly laughed.

“You going to let me in on the joke?” Castaspella said with annoyance.

Perfuma grinned. “He-Ro said you shouldn’t mock them with a name like Castaspella,”

“What’s wrong with my name!?” Castaspella practically shrieked.

“Cassie?” Micah said as he crossed his large arms. “*Casta. Spella.* Cast a spell—like what you do for a living,”

“Humph!” Castaspella pouted. “You know as well as I do, *Micah*, that name has been in our family for centuries! It was our grandmother’s name!”

Micah winked at Perfuma while giving her a knowing grin; he remembered the taunts his sister suffered growing up with a name like ‘Castaspella.’”

“What else can He-Ro tell us?” Micah asked Perfuma. “Like how did they get here, or what happened to their bearer,”

Micah suddenly felt foolish as the Spirit of He-Ro began pulsing. Obviously, there was no need for Perfuma to ask them; they heard him themselves.

Perfuma tilted her head as she listened to the Spirit communicate, the Life Gem at the top of her staff glowing a dull yellow as their words were translated.

“They said their last bearer was killed long ago, during the war against Horde Prime. The sword they were bound to was kept locked in a tomb ever since. He-Ro had slept during the long years until recently when they were taken away from their resting place. They say that they were taken to another planet by the bearer of She-Ra and—”

Perfuma suddenly squinted as the Spirit of He-Ro blinked rapid fire—obviously in intense agitation.

“They say that the bearer of She-Ra was wrong; they did not like how she felt. They say that She-Ra brought her to Empyrea and that the planet they returned to was not the one they remembered.” Perfuma said, still squinting. The Spirit of He-Ro had intensified their light, making them difficult to look at.

“I’m sorry. Can you slow down? I don’t understand. Who is Kishar? What is the Hammer of Zzar?” Perfuma asked.

The Spirit of He-Ro suddenly stopped blinking, and their light dimmed as they floated to the bottom of the Well. They lay still on the floor, not making a move.

“What happened?!” Castaspella gasped. “Are they dead?”

Perfuma laid her fingers gently against the surface of the Well as she peered inside. Abruptly the Spirit of Thon-Ra began pulsing a dull yellow, and Perfuma nodded.

“No. Avatar Spirits cannot die. He-Ro is simply overwhelmed by their ordeal and must rest. We must wait until they have regained their strength before we can learn anything more.”

Micah nodded grimly. “I have a feeling that whatever is happening on the other side of the galaxy, it cannot wait. It seems like whomever this Kishar is; they are after Champion spirits—gathering up Power Swords to release the Avatars, sending them here,”

“Why would someone do that?” Perfuma asked.

Micah grimaced. “Whatever it is, it isn’t good.”

* * *

“So, for the last time, Cat-Tra, are you sure you want to do this?” Viraj asked.

Catra turned to her brother and nodded. They were currently on their way to the Imaarat; Viraj had called a meeting of the Pratham and everyone else involved in deciding the fate of the Nephraeh. The plan was to announce to everyone that Sher-Va had returned and the Catra was the new bearer. But there was a minor issue with that, and it was causing Viraj a bit of stress.

Catra had yet to transform into her Sher-Va form; they had no idea if she could do it.

Why don’t we just spend half a day somewhere in the forest and work on your transformation? Isn’t this a little hasty?” Viraj pleaded.

“What's the matter, Viraj? You don’t think I can do it?” Catra said, giving her brother a sideways glance. Viraj immediately put up his hands in placation.

“That’s not what I said! I just think that maybe your first time shouldn’t be in public, that’s all. Maybe you will get nervous and cannot summon Sher-Va. Imagine how that would look?”

Catra dismissed his worries with a wave of her hand. “Don’t worry; I do best under pressure. Besides, this cannot wait; those idiots plan to leave soon to destroy the Nephraeh. I must make them stop now!”

Viraj sighed and glanced at the Power Sword strapped to her back. Catra had created a harness for it with her Jaadoo suit, causing every Madgēcot they passed many walkways and platforms of Raajadhaanee to look at her strangely. Some recognized the sword for what it was and cheered at Catra.

“Sher-Va! It's Sher-Va!”

“Mahat!”

“The Great Chailendra has chosen!”

Viraj gave a small chuckle, unable to help it in the face of his people’s hope at seeing his sister with the sword of Sher-Va.

“Anyway, I guess it’s too late now; the news will spread everywhere now.” Viraj mused.

Catra glanced at the Madgēcots that were following at a distance; the looks they were giving her were making her nervous. Catra was used to dismissal, suspicion, and even outright disapproval, but to see wonder and joy directed at her was entirely new. It made her uncomfortable.

“I mean, all I have to do is hold the sword up in the air and shout: ‘By the Light of Grayskull,’ and BAM! I’m Sher-Va!” She said, emphasizing her imagined transformation by knocking a fist into her open palm. “Right?”

Viraj shrugged and turned away, waving at some of the onlookers who had now formed into a small crowd.

It’s not as simple as that, Cat-Tra. As happy as I am that you have accepted your new role, I don’t think you are taking this seriously, the voice of Jihan scolded. **You should listen to your brother and take some time to practice your transformation.**

“Oh great, you’re going to nag me too?” Catra hissed.

Viraj suddenly turned his head towards his sister; his ears perked.

“Are you speaking to Jihan? What is he saying?” Viraj said with wonder.

"Just that he agrees with me, that I have everything under control, and that I will be an awesome Sher-Va," Catra said as mildly as possible, making her brother scoff.

No, I didn't. Although I think you will make a good Sher-Va—not as good as I was, mind you.

Catra let a bark of laughter; Jihan was just as cocky as she was. Maybe this would work out after all.

"I have a question, and I will pose this to either my brother or the annoying Madgēcot in my head," Catra said. "Every Champion has their specialty ability; She-Ra can heal, and He-Man has that lightning power. Based on what I saw Veth do once, I think Zhe-La's ability was to banish evil, which would be good for getting Adora back. What can Sher-Va do? What's their specialty?"

"*Your* specialty," Viraj said with raised eyebrows. "You are part of Sher-Va now, so their power is now yours. As for what your prime power, well, that's in your words of activation,"

Catra frowned, not liking that answer. "Truth? That is my specialty? Geez, great. I mean, at least Adora had healing, which could be useful in a fight. What can I do with truth?"

Catra whipped around, adopting a fighting stance as her followers halted in expectation.

"Halt, evildoers! It is I, Sher-Va! Beware my Truth!" Catra said in mock seriousness. Her japery was lost on the adoring Madgēcots; they applauded her antics as Viraj looked on, tail wagging in irritation.

"Listen, Horde Prime," Catra continued, hands on hips. "I want you to meet my friend," she said, holding up a fist. "Their name is Truth, and they are here to—"

ENOUGH! Jihan suddenly shouted in Catra's head, making her yelp. **I've heard enough of your foolishness! You have no idea of the power in which you scorn!**

Having Jihan scold her instantly made Catra furious, and she bunched up her fists as she began shouting back at him.

"Listen, I don't care if you were the last bearer of Sher-Va—you don't get to yell at me!"

Viraj looked around nervously as his sister carried on a conversation with a person only she could hear. He turned to the watching group of Madgēcots, a polite smile plastered on his face.

"Don't worry, my sister is speaking telepathically with another Champion! You know they could do that, back in the day when there were more Champions!" He explained to them.

The crowd oohed and awed at this, but it only worsened the situation.

"Which Champion is it? Is He-Man returned to us? She-Ra?" Someone called.

Viraj's ears flattened, and his tail went limp at the mention of He-Man and She-Ra. He turned to his sister, grasping her by the arms to move her along and away from any more questions. But Catra yanked her arm out of Viraj's grasp, still too angry to allow anyone to handle her, and focused on lashing out at Jihan.

"You are the one who chose me to be Sher-Va, so don't get upset that I don't fit into your perfect mold! Do you hear me? I'm Catra, and I do what I want!"

Catra held still, her eyes unfocused as she waited for a response, and after a few heartbeats, she got one. The ghost of Jihan started laughing uncontrollably inside her head; it was such a hearty and genuine laugh that Catra could not help smiling at it. She had a picture of Jihan in her mind, rolling around and holding his sides as he cackled.

Ahhhh! Cat-Tra! Thank you for that! You just made me realize what a great choice you are. You are just as I was

when I first took on Sher-Va—brash and cocky! But that was before… Mmmmm…

Catra waited for Jihan to continue, but he remained silent in his recollection of ancient memories.

You mean before you got sick and Kishar sold their soul to save you? I am so sorry about that, Jihan, Catra thought to him.

Thank you. But now is not the time to talk about Kishar—although we must, later. Now we must focus on Sher-Va.

Catra sighed. *Yes, I know, and I'm sorry for how I acted. It's just that I want to get Adora back so bad, and I just don't understand how Sher-Va's Truth will make it happen.*

What's so hard to understand? Truth is a powerful weapon. It is the enemy of ignorance and deception, which are abominations. I wish I knew what was wrong with Kishar, for I would have used my powers to stop them before it was too late.

How? How will my power get Adora's memories back? How can I make her love me again? Catra thought, almost making herself cry.

Let me ask you a question; what is love without truth? You must have one before the other. Once you make Despara face the truth, she will remember the love, and Adora will return. You have my word on it.

Catra nodded to herself and smiled; it made perfect sense—although she was still unsure how to make this 'Truth' power happen. But that was for later; first, she must summon Sher-Va.

"Come on, bro," Catra said, taking Viraj by the hand. "Let's go. We have some important Madgēcots to see,"

Catra and Viraj continued their journey, taking the stairs down from the city of Raajadhaanee to the forest floor—all the while

gaining more followers. By the time they proceeded down the stone walkway to the Imaarat, around one hundred Madgēcots were following them. When they arrived, Maira was one of the Star Hunters guarding the gate, and she shook her head at Catra as she approached.

"Do I even want to know what kind of trouble you brought my way, Cat-Tra?" She said before spotting the sword at Catra's back. Both of her green eyes widened when she recognized it for what it was.

"Cat-Tra! Wha— How?!" Maira stammered. Catra patted Maira on the shoulder as she gave the other woman her most cocky grin.

"Isn't it obvious? There is a new Sher-Va in town. You going to let me in or what?" Catra said.

Maira and the other Star Hunter guards did not say a word as they opened the heavy doors, allowing Catra and Viraj entry into the Imaarat. Catra glanced around the wooden structure which sat under the giant dome ceiling of the fortress of the Star Hunters. As before, it was a jumble of walkways, ladders, and doors—the latter leading to various chambers and living quarters. The structure ran the periphery of the inside of the cavernous Imaarat, ending at both sides of the entrance Catra and Viraj had just passed through. Before them was the wide circular floor with the symbol of the Star Hunters emblazoned in the center. There Aadhya waited, along with everyone involved in the decision to exterminate the Nephraeh—including Rishi. As she approached, he gazed at Catra with suspicion in both of his yellow eyes.

"This better not be more of your stalling, Cat-Tra," he growled. "The fate of our sworn enemies has already been decided. No bleeding-heart pleas for mercy will stop that!"

Catra ignored Rishi's taunts as she stopped before Aadhya and bowed. Every single one of the gathered Madgēcots gasped as they saw the sword of Sher-Va harnessed at her back.

"Impossible! How did *you* get that sword?" Rishi hissed.

"The Great Jacarandra and the Spirit of Jihan chose me. I guess they aren't exactly on board with the Madgēcots destroying the Nephraeh," Catra said to him coolly.

"It's a wonder!" One of the council elders exclaimed.

"Sher-Va has returned!" Another said in awe.

"You sure are full of surprises, Catra," Aadhya exclaimed as she crossed her arms and smiled.

Initially taken aback by this turn of events, Rishi approached Catra as he pointed at the sword at her back.

"You have the sword, but that doesn't mean you can summon Sher-Va," he stated.

Catra unsheathed the Power Sword at her back and held it out so quickly Rishi jumped back with a yelp.

Now is the moment of truth, Catra, she thought.

Catra concentrated on a memory of what Shen once told her, of his experience summoning He-Man for the first time through his connection to Adora, how he could feel what Adora felt as she transformed—her focus and drive to succeed. Shen had said this did not work for him; it was Adora's way to transform into She-Ra, not his. Shen had to use a unique method—just for him. He had concentrated on what made him who he was, so Catra focused on the same.

Abandonment—then fear and terror. A cruel woman who would become the adopted mother in a place of darkness and cruelty. Endless loneness amongst a backdrop of dismal industrial hell—but then, a light appears. A smiling face of an angel with blonde hair who becomes her entire world—a reason to live. But then, the love of her life abandons her, leaving her in a worse state than she was initially found. She decides to take her surroundings into

herself, replacing the bits that hurt, but she cannot do it all the way; she cannot replace the core of herself. She cannot remove her empathy, her compassion. It is too intrinsically part of her soul, and she breaks, making her realize she cannot be what she wants. It could mean one thing—

She is a pure and good person—a person who is worthy of Sher-Va.

"BY THE TRUTH OF GRAYSKULL!!!" Catra shouted as she held the sword aloft.

Green flames instantly spread down from the sword's hilt and onto Catra's hand, spreading down her arms to bathe her entire body in a jade inferno—to the onlookers, Catra began to grow in size until she towered over all of them. The fire then dissipated—not back into the sword—but into Catra's body, revealing her new form.

Catra was still in her Jaadoo suit, but it was much larger to cover her enormous body. Gold armor enclosed her shins, forearms, and shoulders—the back of which a massive black cape billowed down. Glowing heterochromatic eyes blazed out from a face framed by a maroon headpiece. The adornment was similar to her old headpiece except at the top; where the previous version ended in two short points—like ears—the top of this mask swept up into two great crests—like wings.

"Does this satisfy you, Rishi?" Sher-Va/Catra boomed.


HENARTORINOS'22

Sher-Va/Catra took momentary satisfaction in the trepidation in the former Star-Hunter body language, but this changed as a new look spread across his teal face. She was familiar with the look from her time on Horde Prime's ship; it was an expression on every clone's face she met there.

Righteous zeal.

"It truly is a miracle!" Rishi suddenly exclaimed. "I was a fool before, blinded by my ignorance, Cat-Tra. But now I see! The Spirit of Sher-Va chose you, in this time, to help us!"

Sher-Va/Catra's massive tail beat against her cape in irritation, making a sound like a sail unfurling in a strong wind.

"And what do you think I'm supposed to help you with?" She asked suspiciously.

Rishi held his hands out toward Sher-Va/Catra, his eyes bright with fervor.

"Why to destroy the Nephraeh, of course! Why else would Sher-Va come back at this time?"

Sher-Va/Catra snarled at Rishi, the sound like a lion's challenge, and he backed away with ears lowered.

"I have come now to stop this madness!" She retorted.

One of the council elders stepped forward to place a hand on Rishi's shoulder as she shook her head.

"No, Rishi's is right. If Sher-Va's intention was to stop us from destroying the Nephraeh, they would have come before we were reunited with them—to stop them from hurting The Great Chailendra Tree. Or they would have come before She-Ra's abduction or He-Man's death. That Sher-Va comes now is too fortuitous."

"Sher-Va's intention?" Sher-Va/Catra shouted. "I am Sher-Va!"

The council elders looked at each other, frowning.

“You are the bearer of Sher-Va, Cat-Tra. Not Sher-Va. You will make that distinction in time.” Rishi said almost kindly. “But now, you must stand by your people’s side in these dire times.”

Sher-Va/Catra looked incredulously at Aadhya, hoping to find an ally in the older woman. But the Pratham only shook her head sadly.

“It’s too late, Catra. It is already set in motion.” She said.

Sher-Va/Catra could not believe what she was hearing and let out a low, threatening growl, making the assembled Madgecot’s fur stand on end. But the fear in her people’s eyes was not what Sher-Va/Catra wanted, and she sighed, letting the tension dispel from the room.

“Fine. But I’m coming with you,” Sher-Va/Catra exclaimed.

Rishi’s face brightened as the looked of ardor returned to his face.

“I know you are, Sher-Va. We are counting on it.” He said.

Some Place Else

Chapter Summary

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Suddenly conscious, he opened his eyes slowly, finding only the darkness to greet him. But this was not the smothering darkness that suffocated him with infinite despair—it was only darkness. Cool, safe darkness. It was the same kind of concealing darkness he sought whenever his father was in a cruel mood, looking for someone to victimize. In the end, his father had always found him, no matter how well-hidden he had been, for his dark father had powers that had gone beyond the natural and into the realm of death. To find his living son was no matter for his sire—but his father was gone now, dead by his son's own hand.

He felt that wherever he was now, he was safe from the torment that had been dogging his steps for the past few months. The cycle that had been dominating his life, from sadness to anger to dread, over and over—caused by the red eye which appeared in his mind like an endless sunset.

But didn't I…? Yes, that was right; I destroyed the cause of my dark anger. Right before I… ended up here. Wherever here is.

The Eye of Hate—that was what it was called. One of the Abominable Powers created in ancient days to drag the universe down into the Dark Times. It had formed a bond with him when he and his friends were exploring Castle Grayskull. The Eye of Hate had seen an opportunity in him and sought to use him as a puppet. But he had used it instead; he had summoned his love for his friends to shield himself against its evil. For admit it or not, he was special; he was the son of the Shen'Aan-war—the dark ruler of Shen'Dar-oom. He was a friend to Adora, bearer of She-Ra, and her wife, Catra. He was the current bearer of the mighty Avatar of

He-Man. He was Prince of Eternia, and his name was Shen'Thran-zansmar-eth—or as he was known by his friends—Shen.

But most of all, he was still alive.

Taking stock of his surroundings, Shen could feel that he was on his back, lying on a cold hard surface. He began to sit up but stopped midway as his face collided with a hard surface.

"Sheyta!!!" Shen cursed in his native language of She-Thar.

Lying back down, he felt around himself as the stars danced and faded in his vision. Shen felt only solid surfaces to each side, behind and above him—wherever he was, it was very tight—like it was a box fit precisely to his dimensions. For a terrifying moment, he thought he was dead and inside his own tomb.

No, that is foolish. I was drawn into that dimensional portal. If I had been killed, that would be it; I would not be waking up. The Demon Heart is no longer bound to me—there is no resurrection, thank all the stars. There is no way Catra would let anyone bury me otherwise. Unless…

"Hello?!" Shen yelled. "Can someone let me out? You buried me alive!"

His voice echoed back and forth inside the rigid enclosure, making his ears ring painfully. But there was a dullness to the sound at his feet; lifting his head as far as the roof would allow, he could see faint light between and to either side of his feet—there was an opening.

Wriggling and writhing towards the opening, Shen slowly made his way out of the 'coffin,' his legs dangling over empty space which he could not see. It could be a bottomless pit for all he knew—but it was preferable to his current confines. Shen still could not feel the floor as he came fully out, finally falling a short way to land hard on his rear end. Standing to his feet slowly, Shen took a moment to appreciate his surroundings.

The room was large and octagonal, perhaps one hundred feet between facing walls and that much in height. Faint light, like moonlight, poured through a twelve-sided window in one of the walls of the eight-sided room. There was no glass in the window's frame, only a metal grill whose mesh formed more geometries—shapes whose sides numbered between twelve and three. Shen recognized that there was meaning to every part of the construction of the room he occupied but was at a loss as to what exactly it was.

Looking back up to where he had come, Shen saw a flat wall upon which a ghostly beam of light rested. The light shared the pattern of the window grill, creating a confusing jumble of light and shadows, making it hard to spot the tight alcove he had been lying in. Squinting at an intersection of two triangles and a dodecagon, Shen thought he saw a reticular dark spot, but when he brought his face closer to the wall and looked up, he saw that it was only an illusion. Only a smooth, unblemished surface ran from floor to ceiling.

With his perspective so much closer to the hard surface, Shen saw that whatever the wall was made of, it was semi-transparent—like crystal. Fine gold and silver veins ran through the stone's interior, and behind that, a faint glow was seen, deep within its core.

Shen backed away from the wall as a strange feeling crept over him; it felt as if he were being watched and directed from afar by someone whose motives could not be comprehended. Feeling a chill, Shen tugged his black jacket closed and hugged himself, imagining the previous person who had worn it in an attempt at comfort. He was sure Double Trouble would have had some witty comment about his current circumstances, probably something about having to constantly save Shen from himself. They would have been right, of course; if it weren’t for Double Trouble, Adora, or Catra, Shen would have been long gone by now, by his own doing.

Suddenly feeling as if he wanted to be away from this room, Shen located a door on the opposite side of the space; it was a typical

door of the rectangular kind, free of obscure meaning. But as he passed through it and into the hall beyond, Shen realized that the fact it had four sides could also be meaningful.

The corridor was short, leading into another geometric chamber containing eight sides; the walls of which were adorned with carvings instead of flat and smooth. Looking closely at the carvings, Shen saw that they were murals depicting images of strange beings performing what appeared to be arcane rites. The way the beings were depicted was odd; they were robed with two arms and a head covered by a hat, the top of which ended in a floppy point. Two long ears protruded from the hat's wide brim, almost Nephraeh-like in their appearance. But that was not what was odd about these people; what was strange was the fact that they were shown without feet—as if they simply floated in mid-air.

Entrapta's portal could have sent me anywhere, quite possibly to another dimension. Somewhere where people have no legs and feet. Shen thought as he shook his head at the murals.

Thoughts of being displaced in space and time left Shen as he noticed writing along the bottom of the murals, immediately recognizing it as a derivation of the language he grew up with—what his friend Adora would refer to as "First One's Runes." Shen squinted as he attempted to read the writing aloud.

"The great exodus from the enemy," he said.

The image above the writing depicted scenes of destruction; arrow-like shapes hung above flaming cities as groups of floating beings fled toward structures shaped like arches. From what Shen knew of the history of his world, what was being shown was the war with Horde-Prime—the distinctive shapes of his ships were unmistakable. That, plus the writing, led him to believe that he was either still in his universe or that whoever had built this place was originally from it. Shen was starting to think it was the latter—that the arch shapes were gateways used to summon portals. He would know; it was a magical portal that brought him to Adora's universe when he was sent to kill her.

If these people used portals to get here, then there must be a way back, Shen thought as he turned, spotting the next passageway.

Shen continued to explore the seemingly empty complex, finding more rooms of unknown purposes. Most of these rooms shared the eight sides of the one he had awoken in, but here and there, he came upon ones with seven or nine sides. There was even one with eleven sides; in this singular room, he came upon the first form of furnishing that this place had to offer.

It was a large black table, irregularly shaped but flat on the top—as if it were cut from a cross-section of a larger object. Nothing was placed upon this table, and no chairs were found.

I guess people that have no legs and that can float don't need chairs, Shen thought as he ran his fingers over the top of the table. He also found it odd that there was no dust—as if the place he was in was beyond such mundane trivialities as grime and dirt.

Turning from the table, Shen made his way to a hall leading to the next chamber and was surprised to see an abundance of the soft light seen through the window before. Upon entering the passageway, he found it was open at the other end and led to the structure's exterior. Once outside, Shen found himself standing in a grand courtyard, surrounded by a series of squat square buildings connected by smaller passageways. Each individual building hosted a conical tower rising from its center—at the peak of which a bulbous shape sat, the top ending in a sharp point, reaching for the heavens.

Shen almost fell onto his back as he looked above the building, to the sky, and needed a few moments to process what he was looking at fully.

Shen had once gone out to the middle of the Growling Sea with his friend Seahawk during a rare occurrence when all twelve of Etheria's moons were eclipsed. There he had seen a sky so clear that billions of stars could be seen twinkling in the night. The dust

belt which ran the circumference of their solar system was fully visible, and beyond that, a distant nebula glittered like a ruby. What he saw now made that pale in comparison, verifying his earlier assertion that he was no longer in his reality.

There were stars—stars beyond counting—glittering so bright that they had created a light source bright enough to bathe whatever planet Shen was on in weak light. He instantly had a sense of deja-vu—as if he had never left Shen'Dar-oom—and was still on that cursed planet in the realm of Night. But where the light provided by the hideous Set'Heth-un'dar was dreadful, this light was beautiful and ethereal, giving everything a soft, dream-like quality. The stars were not fixed in the firmament either; they undulated back and forth across the sky, like glitter caught in an ocean tide as it lapped against the shore. Beneath this spectacle, soft billowing clouds raced across the sky, making Shen think he was seeing a recording at double speed, not real-time. In a mockery of natural weather patterns, there was no wind accompanying these fast clouds, only a gentle breeze.

"Where am I?" Shen breathed in awe.

"Hello?" A voice responded, sending a jolt of surprise through Shen.

Across the courtyard was another opening into the building, and in it, a figure stood in the gloom. Shen squinted as he attempted to see them better in the strange light. They were humanoid, and for a moment, Shen thought they were one of the beings he had seen in the murals, for two long pointed ears stood up on either side of the person's head.

But as the figure strode out of the shadows and into the light, Shen saw that they walked on two legs, just as he did. Two gleaming eyes peered at him from an attractive face, and for a moment, Shen couldn't decide if he was looking at a beautiful man or a woman. As they neared, he realized that it was neither; it was a Nephraeh approaching him. But this was not just any Nephraeh.

It was Veth.

Shen saw that Veth had also recognized him, for their upper and lower fangs were instantly bared in outrage, and he immediately sensed their deadly intentions. What came next was second nature to both Shen and Veth as they raised their hands toward the starry sky.

"BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

"BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

Both Shen and Veth stood expectantly, but nothing happened, and after a beat, both lowered their hands, confused. Shen suddenly laughed as he shrugged at Veth, who looked at him with hostile silver eyes.

"I guess that means we have a truce?" He said hopefully.

Veth's eyes widened as they screamed in rage, suddenly charging at Shen, clawed hands outstretched to tear him to pieces.

* * *

They were instantly conscious and alert, aware of the unpleasant and hard surfaces they were lying on. Opening their silver eyes, they took in their surroundings, immediately seeing that there were in a very tight space. They tentatively reached around themselves, brushing their sharp claws against the cool stone of their enclosure.

Where am I? The last thing I remember was… falling. Then a flash of light, then… nothing, and then I was here.

That was right. They had sacrificed themselves to save another, someone they had horribly betrayed when a dark master thoroughly enthralled them.

But that was before… before I stopped taking the antithetical philter. Before I started feeling so… different.

They were once the Champion of the Empyrean Empire, the Child of Archon Lethe. They had tricked the Madgēcots into trusting them, enabling them to fulfill their dual mission—destroying the Great Chaliendra Tree and kidnapping the bearer of She-Ra.

Well, I had only half completed my mission. The Great Chaliendra Tree was only wounded, and Adora was turned into Despara. It was Despara who had tossed me into that pit, but that was because I was going to betray the Empyrean Empire. All because I had fallen in love.

They had fallen from Archon Lethe's Light by not partaking in the Penumbra Ritual; by doing so, they were changing. Every day they felt more different; new emotions and sensations blossomed inside them. It was the main reason they had chosen to betray Archon Lethe and try to help Catra, for the main feeling they were experiencing was an abundance of empathy. But at their core, they were still who they always were; Veth—elite warrior and bearer of Zhe-La.

But most important of all, they were still alive.

Veth considered their situation, not letting the tight space goad them into claustrophobic fear by knowing that if there was a way in, there was most definitely a way out. Veth closed their eyes, calming themselves and thereby increasing their focus. It was an old technique, one which came easily to them before, but now took an extra bit of effort. Once focused, Veth could sense the exit —it was at their feet. There was an opening.

Wriggling slowly out of the enclosure, Veth immediately felt the absence of any firm ground, taking that into account for later. As they pulled themselves entirely from the alcove, Veth clung to the lower edge as they balanced themself, taking in the distance to the floor in an instant. Seeing that they could land satisfactorily without harm to themselves, Veth let go, landing on the floor in a graceful crouch. They immediately looked back up from where they had just come from, taking a few moments to understand what they were looking at.

It was a high flat wall, illuminated by the window behind them. Veth was confused for a moment; they could not spot the alcove they had just dropped down from, even with their keen sight. They looked back and forth between wall and window, seeing how the window grill created strange shadows on the wall.

That light, it's definitely not from a moon, nor is it from a weak star—it's too potent to be that. But it's also dim—as if it's far away. Distant stars? Veth thought as their eyes widened. *There must be countless stars to be creating this much light!*

Veth immediately noticed the geometry of the window grill, the shape of the window, and the room they occupied, and their long ears twitched with realization.

The numerology combined with the starlight—this is old magic! The three-sided shapes represent travel, and the twelve-sided represent dimension. The eight-sided room could mean anything —protection? Focus?

Veth held a claw tip to their lips as they considered the wall again, spotting the place in which they had just come from.

Yes, there! At the intersection of the twelve and two threes—there is a rectangular shadow! That is where I passed through! Such wondrous and old magic, but only the Trollans harnessed it, and they are all gone now.

Veth continued to appreciate the genius in the room's construction for a moment longer before they noticed a section of wall lit by starlight. They approached it tentatively, seeing that it was a semi-transparent stone, threaded by veins of silver and gold—like an intricate web. Behind that, Veth saw the faint light and immediately felt the presence; it was familiar to them and unwanted.

Veth turned and fled, taking the only exit out of the room and running through the corridor into the next chamber. Not stopping there, Veth continued to sprint through the interconnecting

chambers, not bothering to inspect any of them. They were too frightened by the presence they had felt and did not want to be ensnared by it.

Veth stopped running and hesitated as they saw they were approaching an exit to the building, indicated by the abundance of starlight. Creeping on the balls of their feet, Veth let their eyes adjust to the larger quantity of light as they made their way slowly out of the building and out into the open. Veth did not bother taking in their surroundings, for they were utterly focused on what was directly before them; a humanoid figure standing straight and gaping up at the sky.

"Hello?" Veth ventured, beginning to approach the figure.

They immediately turned to face Veth, who saw that it was a young human male; long black hair was drawn back into a loose ponytail and framed a handsome face. Veth's eyes were immediately drawn to the jacket he was wearing—on the outside, it appeared as a simple black jacket with five silver buttons. But there was something enchanted about it; Veth's innate magical nature could sense like for like. The young man abruptly tensed; looking back up at his face, Veth immediately saw why.

Although he was held unconscious in Catra's arms at the time, Veth would recognize Nefeli's killer anywhere, for his face was burned into their mind. It was the bearer of He-Man—Shen was his name. Rage instantly burned hot in Veth's heart as they saw him begin to lift his arm into the air, and they immediately followed suit.

"BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

"BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

Veth could feel the Avatar of Zhe-La approach them through their bond—but something blocked it—sending it back to its dormant state. Veth was pleased to see that Shen was similarly affected;

confusion plastered his face as he lowered his hands. Shen suddenly grinned, shrugging his shoulders at Veth.

"I guess that means we have a truce?" He said.

Veth was apoplectic; here was Nefeli's killer smiling at them as if they were friends. As if he hadn't taken the love of their life from them with their cruel sword. The rage from before boiled over as Veth screamed in outrage, and they charged; they were going to tear Shen limb from limb for what he had done, and there was no one to stop them.

Veth lunged at Shen, clawed hands outstretched to slice his flesh, but the bearer of He-Man dodged and deflected the attack, sending Veth rolling away and stopping in a crouch. They considered him for a moment, realizing their initial move was far too reckless. Only with skill would they take Shen down.

Veth leaped at Shen, delivering an expert kick at his face, but he ducked while executing a hand chop to their thigh. But Veth was already using their momentum to move away, leaving Shen to strike only at the air. He came at them then, delivering a series of hand blows and kicks which Veth blocked and evaded. The two traded blows and counter-blows this way, neither making any headway until finally, Veth backed away to reassess the situation.

I need to get closer to him. He is skilled in fighting, but he is still only human. I can overcome him with my greater strength.

"Can't we just talk about this?" Shen said reasonably. "Catra told me you want to kill me. Because of what I did. But that wasn't me —"

Veth feinted, causing Shen to tense up for a block, then transitioned into a sweep, taking their opponent's legs out from under him and falling onto his back. Veth was on him instantly, straddling his body to reach for his neck. Shen seized their writs in an attempt to stop them, but their Nephraeh strength was more significant, and Shen watched with gritted teeth as their lilac

hands slowly approached their target. Finally reaching his neck, Veth squeezed, beginning to choke the life from their enemy, avenging their lover's death.

Shen gasped and writhed under them, surprising Veth with his will as he dropped his hands from their wrists to deliver punches to their torso. But it was too late; as the life was slowly drained from Shen, so too did the power of his blows. He was dying as Veth stared into his eyes, seeing the spark of life slowly fade.

Shock coursed through Veth as they abruptly saw something; it was strange—as if they saw an image superimposed over Shen's form. But they weren't seeing two things at once—more like it was only one, true sight. Amorphous shapes beyond shapes coalesced into one another; they were beautiful with colors that went beyond the visual spectrum and into the spiritual. Veth wasn't sure how they knew it, but they were looking at Shen's quintessence—his soul. There they saw immense kindness and goodness, like a bright sun, but at the side of this illumination, there was darkness, like a stain. Something horrible must have occurred to create such blotching, and impulsively, Veth felt a softening.

Suddenly, Veth was aware of Shen's body beneath them—a living, breathing being with a whole life full of memories. Veth was going to end this life—right now—and there was no coming back from that; they released their grip on Shen's neck, and he gasped for breath. Veth stood slowly, gazing down at Shen with glittering silver eyes as he curled up onto his side to cough and wheeze. They were still trying to come to terms with what they had just seen; it seemed so bizarre at the moment, but somehow, also so innately natural to them, as if they were finally able to see after a long life of being blind.

"Get up," Veth commanded after Shen had sufficient time to collect himself.

He looked up at them then, fury in his dark brown eyes.

“No,” he said firmly.

Veth’s dark eyebrows raised at this response; they were not expecting defiance from him.

“I could kill you, you know. I almost did, just now.” Veth said simply.

This brought Shen to his feet, fists clenched and ready to continue their fight.

“Go for it! Try that again! You will not get the better of me this time!”

Veth could see that his warrior's pride was hurt for being brought so close to his demise; they could also see he was not afraid to face it again. Some part of them could see that this human knew death all too well—as if he had experienced it, time and time again.

“I am sorry for killing Nefeli! I truly am!” Shen continued, so angry now his limbs were shaking. “Back when we first fought, I was not only fighting you but the influence of the Eye of Hate. It had taken all my willpower not to let it take over me. But then something happened… I don’t understand why, but I did not care anymore and let it take me over,”

Veth felt shame at his words, for they knew why he had not cared; they had used Archon Lethe’s power upon him during their fight, draining him of his empathy and will to resist the Eye of Hate. They had not faced the true reason Nefeli died, but it was glaringly evident now.

Veth was the reason Nefeli had died; if they hadn’t taken Shen’s compassion at that moment, he would not have allowed the Eye of Hate to control him. Shen would not have killed Nefeli in such a cold-blooded fashion—Veth knew that because they had just seen it. They could not explain how they knew it, but they could see his soul now, and the soul does not lie.

“I’m sorry, Veth, I am sorry for Nefeli, and I promise you nothing like that will happen again. The Eye of Hate was destroyed, and it no longer has a hold over me. But if you don’t believe me, we can go back to fight—”

Veth suddenly held up a hand, interrupting Shen. “Wait, what did you say? The Eye of Hate is destroyed? How do you know this?”

Shen shrugged again, irritating Veth with the vague gesture.

“Because I was there, I destroyed it,” Shen said simply.

Veth instantly burst out laughing; it was loud and piercing in its mockery, making Shen bare his teeth in anger.

“You? A human destroyed one of the Abominable Powers? One of the very sources of evil which cast the entire universe in the Dark Times? You expect me to believe that?”

Shen sighed and looked away from Veth; he seemed so weary and tired, not caring whether or not they believed him or not. But Veth did believe him; they could see how special he was—it was written in his quintessence.

“So, are we going to go back to fighting?” Shen asked with a wave of his hand. Veth stared at him briefly before running their clawed fingers through their long black hair.

“No, not unless you want to, bearer of He-Man,” they said finally. “But if you do not want that, then perhaps we could work out that ‘truce’ you suggested—if only to find a way out of here,”

Veth waved a clawed hand around them, indicating the surrounding building and the entirety of their current location.

“We could just part ways and figure out our own ways out of here,” Shen suggested.

Veth shook their head vigorously; they did not want that at all.

“No. I am not letting you out of my *sight*, Shen.” They said firmly.

Shen chuckled and shrugged again, again annoying Veth. They did not know why the gesture bothered them, but it seemed to speak volumes of this human’s attitude toward life.

“The last thing I remembered is being sucked into a dimensional portal while in my He-Man form,” Shen said.

“Why would you allow something like that to happen? Isn’t He-Man supposed to be strong, or was that before the Avatar was bound to someone like you?” Veth asked scathingly.

Shen ignored the taunt. “I did it to save my friend. Ador—I mean, Despara was caught in the gravitational pull of the portal. I couldn’t let that happen, so I saved her. So instead of sucking her up, it got me instead.”

Shen did it again, once again giving his noncommittal shrug of indifference. Veth would have slapped him if they weren’t already fighting the genuine smile from appearing on their face.

“You’re a moron,” they said instead. Shen grinned.

“Yeah, Catra says the same thing about me.” He said, and Veth could not help seeing this human's affection for the beautiful Madgēcot.

“So, what about you? How did you end up here?” Shen asked.

Just like you, I’m an idiot and traded my life for someone else’s, they thought to themselves.

“Despara tossed me into a gaping hole on some cursed planet. Instead of having a bottom, it had a gateway to someplace else. Here, I’m assuming,”

Shen pursed his lips and nodded. “Any idea where this is?” He asked, pointing upwards.

Veth turned their silver eyes to the heavens, not surprised to see the countless stars. They were startled by the unnatural movement of the stars and sky—as if time had no hold over them. It was so hauntingly lovely to gaze at, and if Veth were in any other situation, they would have stayed a while, enjoying the view.

"I have my suspicions of where we are," they said finally.

"What to share them with me?" Shen asked, a little annoyed.

Veth shook their head. "No, not yet. Unlike you, I do not like making a fool of myself."

Shen scoffed at this. "You're not very nice, are you, Veth?"

Veth turned towards Shen, giving him their coldest look.

"You have a long way to go, Shen, before I come close to ever warming up to you. Until then, I suggest you make yourself useful and help me find a way out of here."

Veth turned back towards the structure surrounding them, seeing the opposite openings from which both they and Shen had appeared. The courtyard they stood upon was rectangular in shape, with the outlets located in the middle of the longest sections. A large double door sat at one of the shorter ends, with two massive forms on either side.

"The room I awakened in only had one exit, which I assume yours had as well," Veth said as Shen nodded.

"So, going back the way we came is not where we want to go," Veth continued, pointing at the double doors. "I would say that way is our best bet."

"I would agree," Shen answered, holding his hands out to their destination. "After you?"

Veth smiled, bearing their upper and lower fangs. They glinted dangerously in the weak light.

“Nope. You first.” They said.

Shen shrugged again, leading the way to their hopeful exit as Veth followed, not taking their eyes off him.

Hammer of Zzar

Chapter Summary

Despara is tasked with her last mission from Archon Lethe.

The most unlikeliest of allies, Shen and Veth, must work together to explore the mysteries of the strange realm they find themselves in.

Deep underground, beneath the House of the Penumbra, Despara was once again answering the call of her dark master. She winced, holding up her hands up to shield her eyes; the glare from the Temple of Light was so intense that it could reach her even as she crept behind the immense pillars that held the roof aloft. Its potency had increased since the last she came this way, returning from the mission to retrieve the sword of He-Ra along with the two fallen Etherian Princesses.

Why aren't Scorpia and Mermista with me? She thought to herself, not for the first time. Despara had been by herself when the summons came—an urgent pulse behind her heart had let her know that Archon Lethe required her presence. Despara had tried to ignore this call once, but the gentle sensation had become a burning, turning into a stabbing. She knew what would come next if she delayed any longer; death and eternal servitude as a Vetala. Perhaps her new 'friends' from Etheria were testing the boundaries of their new existence and learning that there was no defiance of the Lord of the Nephraeh.

Just as the intensity of the horrible Light was at this most unbearable, Despara caught sight of the Curtain—a long tunnel hastily constructed as protection for Archon Lethe and their closest lieutenants. It ran from behind one of the pillars, through the entrance, and all the way to the Heart of the Temple of Light, where Archon Lethe worked tirelessly at their secret task.

Despara let out a sigh of relief as she entered the Curtain; running her hands along the wall, she felt the ridges of the individual sections of black material that the Curtain was made of—Aegis Lace. Up ahead of her, two Acolytes of the House of the Penumbra were summoning more sections of Aegis Lace to repair portions of the Curtain that had begun to fail. It seemed that even the power of Archon Lethe was diminishing before the increasing strength of the Temple of Light. She recognized the two robed Nephraeh as the two most senior members of their order and even remembered their names—Etana and Nurma.

"Greetings, Champion Despara. How goes your day?" Etana said with a smile.

Despara instantly scowled at them, making both Nephraeh take a step backward away from her.

"It would be better if you could make this blasted tunnel longer; it was all I could do just to get to the entrance!" She snarled.

The two Nephraeh looked at her apologetically, but behind their placations, she could see something else—something false.

"We apologize, Champion Despara. But with the increasing strength of the *True Light*, this is all we can do just to maintain the Curtain in its current form. If the Light's potency increases, then even the strides we made with its length now will diminish." Nurma said.

Despara instantly squinted at Nurma, suspicion plain on her rigid features.

"What do you mean by that? The *True Light*?" She asked.

Both Nephraeh gave a jump and looked at each other anxiously, but Despara waved it off.

"Whatever. I don't care." She said dismissively, abruptly walking away from the nervous Nephraeh.

Stupid Nephraeh. Light this, light that. I've had enough of it. Despara thought darkly.

Despara continued through the comforting enfolds of the Curtain, knowing that just behind its protection was the hideous white wall of the Temple of Light, organic and weak in its making. She wanted to shiver at the idea that the power of this repellant place could get any stronger.

A thought occurred to Despara, and she felt foolish at not realizing it before. How did those two Nephraeh withstand the power of this '*True Light*' Nurma spoke of? They must have been able to in order to construct the Curtain, for it didn't just appear on its own. Even though they were high-level acolytes, they were only Nephraeh, nowhere near as powerful as Despara or Archon Lethe. But they could go places and do things neither she nor the Lord of the Nephraeh could—Despara did not like that. She did not want a weakness that could be exploited—but if she had it, so too did Archon Lethe, and this, Despara did like.

Clearing these thoughts from her head, Despara entered the Heart of the Temple of Light and prepared to face her Lord. She looked about the interior of the great space, noticing that the majority of the dull indigo which had once covered the walls was now gone, replaced by the glaring white—more evidence of the failings of the Power of Oblivion.

Despara immediately spotted Archon Lethe; they were standing before the massive crystal which dominated the room and was the source of the terrible Light. With eyes closed and black-stained hands outstretched, they appeared to be directing what could only be described as a storm of darkness within the interior of the great stone. Billowing dark clouds spewed forth purple lighting, which danced on the tips of Archon Lethe's extended claws. Despara could not fathom what their Lord was achieving by this display, nor was she in any hurry to interrupt them. She stopped a short span away, dropping to a kneel to await their attention.

Finally, after what seemed like hours, Archon Lethe lowered their hands, and the tempest within the crystal was quelled. They seemed to sag for a moment, letting out a deep groan before standing back up straight and proud. Archon Lethe then turned to regard Despara with their eerie eyes, glowing with the absolute indigo of their might. A small smile split their lips, revealing teeth of utmost black.

"My Child—Despara. How happy I am you answered my call," they said with such silkiness it was almost a purr.

Like I had any choice, you miserable tyrant. She wanted to say.

"Yes, Archon Lethe. What is your bidding?" Was what Despara said instead.

Archon Lethe gave a satisfied nod, and Despara could not help thinking that it was as if something was finally going right for them. Emboldened by that thought, she risked a most dangerous question.

"If I may ask, what were you doing just now, My Archon? Does it have to do with why you summoned me?"

Surprise crossed Archon Lethe's features before it transformed into amusement, and they waved their hand dismissively toward the transparent stone.

"I was just guiding two lost lambs back home, that is all, My Child. You see, it is all part of my greater plan," they said mysteriously. Archon Lethe did not elaborate further, and Despara wisely chose not to press the issue.

"Come over here," Archon Lethe said, beckoning Despara over to the large table set up nearby. Once again, the proportions of the giant table and Archon Lethe made her feel as if she were a child, although she did not ever remember being one. Archon Lethe picked up the black hammer they used to destroy the sword of He-Ro, hefting it in their hand as they appreciated the weight of it.

“An ally of mine made this hammer a very long time ago,” they began dreamily. “Back when we had such grand plans for the entire universe. Her name was Zzar, and I have much to thank her for. She was the one who helped me find my way to my current path and was responsible for binding the Champion Avatars to Power Swords. But she is gone now—but her hammer remains,”

Archon Lethe handed the hammer to Despara, who took it uncertainly. It felt cumbersome in her hand, as if it were not simply its physical weight she was holding but something more; an implicit expression of arcane craft.

“What do you want me to do with this, My Archon?” Despara asked.

With hands held behind their back, Archon Lethe turned away from Despara to gaze at the beam of bright Light pouring from the top of the mighty gem into the roof of the chamber. Despara could not follow their gaze, instead staring at their midsection—the place she had once plunged her black sword.

“I am going to have to leave this place soon, Despara. I no longer have a connection to my people, and this planet is becoming… unpleasant to be upon.”

Archon Lethe shivered as they wrapped their long white arms around their slender torso. It was a very vulnerable display, which was unlike them.

“Before I depart, I still have one task to complete before I leave—but I am running out of time,” they said as they reached out and brushed their fingers against the large crystal.

“You see, the Madgēcots are coming; they are on their way this very minute to destroy us. They are so filled with hate for the Nephraeh that they have managed to remove the sword of Sher-Va from their silly tree and bind it to a new Madgēcot bearer. Sher-Va is back amongst us, and they are on their way here. That

is where you come in, My Child," Archon Lethe said as they turned to Despara to place their hands gently on her shoulders.

"I need you to take the Hammer of Zzar along with the entire Nephraeh fleet and intercept the Madgēcots. You must delay them long enough for me to complete my work,"

Rage filled Despara as she brushed Archon Lethe's hands off and backed away.

"What? You expect me to run off on some suicide mission just so you can play with your stupid rock? No way! Tell Mermista or Scorpia to do it!" She seethed.

Archon Lethe's beautiful face instantly crumpled into anger, their indigo eyes blazing with displeasure.

"I thought you would be pleased by this. To sacrifice yourself for me is the greatest of honors. Plus, it would earn you your freedom from eternal servitude as one of my Vetala," they said coldly.

For the first time in her life, Despara wanted to weep. She wanted to scream with the absolute hopelessness of her situation. To die or be damned—*which was the better of two horrible outcomes?* That was what she was being told to choose between.

"I see I have made myself understood." Archon Lethe said with a cruel smile. "It is of absolute priority that you defeat this new bearer of Sher-Va. You must kill them and release the Avatar Spirit from the power sword with the Hammer of Zzar—just as you've seen me do. You must do this before you die if you wish to be free of your bondage to me,"

"I hope sacrificing me, and your entire fleet is worth it, *Lethe*," Despara hissed as she tightened her grip on the black hammer.

Archon Lethe's smile widened as they nodded their head vigorously.

“Oh! But it is! It is *so* worth it for me! Now, we must part ways, Despara. I expect you to be on board my flagship by this evening, on your way to your grand fate. Away with you,” they said with a dismissive hand wave.

Despara turned on her heel and marched out of the Heart of the Temple of Light, not bothering to look back at her cruel master. Try as she might, Despara could not think of a way out of this situation; she was set on this path, on her way to her destruction.

I am one of the greatest warriors in the universe, but I am only fodder to be used by Archon Lethe. Why is this happening to me? It is such a waste! Despara thought with self-pity.

She was in such a distracted fury as she raged back through the hall of the Curtain that Despara almost barreled into the two senior Acolytes she had met on the way in.

“Move! Before I kill you!” She shrieked at them.

Nurma and Etana backed away from her wrath, bowing and scraping in fear. As she brushed past the two robed Nephraeh, Despara was startled to feel one of them reach out and grasp her wrist.

“How dare you touch me!” She cried, spittle flying from her lips as she summoned her immense sword. It was Etana who had grabbed her, and they held up their hands as they tried to calm her down.

“Easy, Despara! Easy!” They said soothingly. “I know what Archon Lethe wants you to do; I know they are sacrificing you and our fleet to save their own skin!”

Despara was so shocked by the sudden earnestness in the previously meek Nephraeh that her mouth gaped open.

“How do you know that?” She asked in a horse whisper.

Nurma stepped forward, sharing the same look of persuasion as their fellow Acolyte.

"We have allies in the fleet; they told us of Archon Lethe's orders. They know the nature of Archon Lethe's mission for them," they said.

"Then why do they go if they know it's hopeless? They merely die to provide a distraction, buying time for their Archon." Despara said.

"For the same reason you go, Despara," Etana said. "But they are not buying time for Archon Lethe; they are buying time for *us*,"

Despara shook her head; she was dumbfounded by what she was hearing.

"What are you talking about? Who is us? What is going on?"

Etana and Nurma turned to look at each other, nodding in agreement before answering her.

"We can no longer be complacent with Archon Lethe's evil. We are rebelling against them, Despara, and have been planning on doing so for a while now." Etana said.

Despara let out a bark of laughter; she couldn't believe what she was hearing.

"We are orchestrating a plan to drive Archon Lethe off Empyrea. Once off our planet, they will no longer be able to feed off us; we think it will destroy them." Nurma continued.

Realization shot through Despara as her eyes widened. "The Temple of Light—that's *you* making it stronger, isn't it?"

Etana and Nurma glanced at each other, sharing a secret grin.

"Yes! It is us—we just need a little more time!" Nurma said.

Despara shrugged. “Well, why are you telling me this? Better question; how do you know I won’t just tell Archon Lethe about all this?”

Now it was Etana’s turn to laugh. “And what would that get you, Despara? A pat on the back before Archon Lethe sends you back out into space to die? We know better than that!”

Despara was startled to see Nurma approach her, clasping her large hand in both of their soft lilac ones. What surprised her even more was the fact that she enjoyed their touch.

“Join us, Despara! Our people in the fleet will cover for your absence; you do not need to die needlessly! You can help us free the Nephraeh! You can help free yourself!” They implored.

Despara was immediately torn; after so much time alone, the thought of allies had a certain appeal to it. Having someone who cared about her and wanted what was in her best interest was exactly what she wanted—deep inside. But Despara knew she could never reciprocate the compassion, nor could she stomach faking it. No, it was better to die than admit her weakness. She was Despara to her core.

“No,” Despara said softly yet firmly as she pulled her hand out of Nurma’s grip. Both Nephraeh looked saddened by her reply, but they did not try to argue with her decision.

“You should know something before you go,” Etana called before Despara could turn away. “The bearer of Sher-Va is Catra—your wife. She is the one Archon Lethe wants you to kill,”

Despara felt a shocking jolt through her heart; she was astounded by how this news made her feel… uncertain. She was also very grateful to know this; if Despara had found out when she faced Sher-Va that it was Catra, she was unsure how it could affect her. She gave the Nephraeh a respectful nod.

“You should know something as well,” she said. “Archon Lethe already had plans. I’m not sure what they are, but it involves the

Champions. When I brought back the sword of He-Ro, they destroyed it and released the Avatar spirit. They already know they must leave Empyrea, and I bet this has something to do with it."

Etana and Nurma shared a concerned look before returning their attention to Despara.

"Thank you, Despara. Whatever you choose to do, good luck to you. May the Light guide your path," Etana said.

Despara grunted before turning and stomping away, not helping help the smile creeping across her lips as a single thought ran through her head.

Stupid Nephraeh.

* * *

Shen approached the double doors at the end of the courtyard cautiously—ready to spring back away at the slightest suggestion of threat. He was uncertain now that he could see the two figures on either side a little closer; they were humanoid with large upper bodies, arms, and blocky heads. Both were about three meters tall and covered in segmented plates, making them look like warrior statues. Shen stopped and held up a hand, indicating that Veth should hold up.

"I read enough stories to recognize two sleeping guardians which wake up at exactly the wrong moment for the hero," he said.

"You think you are a hero, human?" Veth said, stopping next to him and crossing their arms. "That's funny; heroes don't usually kill people in cold blood,"

Shen looked away, trying not to let Veth see how much their barb hurt him. If he had bothered to look at Veth at that moment, he would have seen them staring at him, the look of mild regret on their features.

“But I agree with you,” Veth said, laying their silver eyes on the two figures. “They are magical in nature. I assume they will reanimate once we attempt to open the doors.”

“How do you know they are magical?” Shen asked.

Veth tossed their long black hair and held their head up high. “Because human, I am half magical. Like senses like—and all that,”

Shen was starting to get annoyed with Veth’s attitude but tried not to show it; after all, he was stuck with them, and they were with him. At least until they both found a way out of this place and back home—then he could be out of this arrogant Nephraeh’s presence and away from their accusations.

“So, since you have all the answers—*oh mighty and wise Nephraeh*—what do we do next?” Shen asked.

His scorn was answered with a winning smile, further aggravating Shen as Veth glided away to face the two guardians.

“It is always wise to defer to your betters, human. I see you have sense after all,” they said mildly.

“I have a name, you know,” Shen replied angrily.

Veth ignored him as they continued forward, now cautiously at a nimble crouch, hands held at the reach at each side.

“Be careful!” Shen exclaimed.

Veth scoffed in return. “I will have you know that even without the power of Zhe-La, I am still a very skilled warrior—”

Veth was interrupted as both Guardians lunged simultaneously, their movements quicker than their bulk belied. Veth performed a perfect somersault away from a crushing blow from one Guardian, only to be clipped with an open-handed swipe from the other.

They hissed with irritation as they landed hard on their rear end and Veth stood to rub at their hindquarters.

"Watch out!" He cried as the Guardian that had managed to stumble Veth went in to bash them in the back of the head. Veth immediately ducked, pivoting their body around to slash its wrists with their deadly claws. The Guardian shrieked, their hand now limp and appearing useless as it stepped back from the dangerous Nephraeh. Veth seemed pleased with themselves and delivered a taunt.

"Ha! That will teach you to try and strike me in such a dishonorable fash—"

Where the first Guardian failed, the second succeeded, and Veth was pitched forward and onto their face by the tremendous blow delivered to them, unaware. The Guardian followed this up by raising both hands overhead to finish off the defenseless Veth, but as both large fists came down, they were deflected by Shen, who collided with them in a sideways tackle. The Guardian roared, furious at being denied its kill, and kicked out at Shen, its blocky foot connecting with his side. Shen wheezed with the force of the blow and stumbled away; he fully expected to have received several broken ribs for his troubles, for the creature's body was solid like a rock. But as Shen stood straight, expecting to feel stabbing pain, he was surprised to feel nothing of the sort.

So strange, Shen thought, running his hands over the silky black material of the jacket Madame Razz had given him. *Almost as if…*

Shen dodged out of the way as the Guardian Veth had injured tried to head-butt him. As it missed, it stumbled forward, knocking into Shen and sending them both to the ground. Shen found he was now pinned under the Guardian; its weight was immense, slowly squeezing his life out. He turned his head to look at Veth, hoping for some support from their end, but the Nephraeh Champion was still on the ground, unconscious.

Great. I survived an exploding source of ultimate evil and being sucked into an interdimensional portal, only to die by squishing, Shen thought as he tried to push the Guardian off him. But it stayed where it was, holding him in a perfect position for its ally to stomp on his head. As the foot came down, Shen looked past the Guardian and to the sky; there, he saw two glowing eyes like bright indigo stars.

Abruptly, the Guardian crushing him was pulled off and flung away; it crashed to the ground, dashing into pieces which clattered across the open courtyard. It was as if an invisible hand had seized it and thrown it carelessly away, like a child abusing a toy. The remaining Guardian sensed the new threat and looked up into the sky just as two searing purple lightning bolts streaked down to blast it into smoldering pieces. Shen was dumbstruck by what he had just witnessed; it was as if some nameless god had noticed their plight and had chosen to assist them on a whim.

Rising to his feet, Shen went to Veth, rolling them over to hold them gently in his arms. Their black hair was a tangled mess over their face, and Shen brushed it gently away. He had to admit, now that they were unconscious and not looking at him with spite, Veth was quite beautiful. Their high, noble cheekbones and pointed chin gave them an elfin look, even more so with the long ears. Their lilac skin seemed to have a faint luster in the starlight, and the white markings on their face and chest seemed to glow. As Shen raised his eyes from the open portion of their jacket, he was startled to see Veth was now conscious and studying him with their silver eyes; the expression on their face was unreadable. His face burned as Veth lifted themselves and groaned, holding the back of their head.

"Owwww… I guess I got rather careless there," they said, rising to their feet slowly. Veth's eyes instantly widened with shock as they spotted the ruins of the two Guardians and looked at Shen with awe.

"Believe me, I would love to take credit for that, but it wasn't me," Shen said as he stood. "All I did was stop that one from crushing

you while you were unconscious by blocking it with my body,”

Veth looked at him with that same unreadable expression as before, their strange eyes glinting in the half-light.

“That was a dumb thing to do,” they said finally.

Shen was about to roll his eyes and look away when Veth continued.

“But thank you just the same, *human*.”

Veth went to the closest fallen Guardian, kicking the pile of rubble that was their remains with the toe of their black boot.

“So, what did happen? Were they just faulty and fell apart?” They asked.

Shen smiled nervously as he thought of a response. “Well… I’m not sure I should tell you; I don’t want you to—"

“What? Think less of you?” Veth interrupted with raised eyebrows. “Believe me, human; my opinion can’t get any lower.”

“Glad to see you are back to your old self,” Shen responded with a rictus smile. “I was going to say ‘crazy.’”

Shen told Veth what he had seen, from the strange eyes in the sky to the rapid destruction of their enemies just as he was about to face death. Instead of treating Shen with more of their derision, Veth appeared terrified by what he had to say.

“What do you think it was?” Shen asked after he was finished. Veth looked away from him, running their clawed hands through their hair nervously.

“I’m not sure,” they said.

Shen scoffed at this. “Don’t lie, Veth. You may hate me, but we are in this together. I know you have some idea of what that was;

I could see it in your face!”

Veth looked at him as if he had startled them, finally responding after a moment of not saying anything.

“I don’t hate you, human. I mean… Shen.” They said, turning away and walking towards the double doors. Veth seized the handle of one and, with a heave, pulled the door open. Before they disappeared inside, they turned back to Shen with an exasperated look.

“Are you coming?” They asked.

Shen realized he was gaping at them and closed his mouth. Not saying a word, he followed Veth back into the strange building; as the door closed behind them, they were both pitched into absolute darkness. Shen felt around blindly, hoping to touch anything to help guide him in the total absence of any light.

“Veth, any chance those silver eyes of yours can see in this?” Shen asked hopefully.

“No human, they cannot,” Veth replied tersely.

“*Great. Back to human, again*,” Shen mumbled in reply.

Shen started walking in a single direction, hoping he would finally find a wall. After walking for what seemed like way too long, he stopped, suddenly feeling very uncomfortable and exposed.

“Veth?” He called, instantly noticing the absolute absence of any echo. There was no reply from the Nephraeh Champion, which immediately filled Shen with anxiety. He stood rigid as he fought against the creeping dread; the all-encompassing blackness was so horribly familiar to him.

“VETH! This isn’t funny!” He shouted into the void, again receiving no response, not even the empty comfort of his own voice. The emptiness surrounding him had swallowed everything, including Veth, and soon, it would have him too.

A chill permeated his body, not just an physical one but a emotional one as well. Shen could sense something nearby, watching him from the profound nothing. Even worse, it spoke to him.

Shen.

The unease multiplied into terror inside him, but Shen fought against it, trying to hang onto the logic fraying like an old rope to safety.

This isn't real. This must be some kind of trick to trap anyone trying to escape this place—like the guardians. He thought desperately to himself.

It's no trick, Shen. It's me. It's really me. Don't you remember your old friend?

"NO!" Shen shouted. He recognized that voice; he would never forget it for the rest of his life. It was the same voice Shen heard in his darkest nightmares, the ones he still wakes up from screaming in a cold sweat. It was a voice from the worst period of his life when his father had shackled his spirit to another, one who took over his body to kill everyone he ever cared about.

The Other—The Demon Heart.

Yes, it is me. Did you think you could get rid of me so easily? You are in another dimension now, one so close to the place of Night. I can reach you here. We can be together again.

Shen felt desperately at his chest, to the place where Adora had placed the heart rune when she banished the Demon Heart. But no magical symbol appeared—or if it did—its light was smothered by the darkness with no end.

No Adora to save you. No dirty old magic to keep you from me. You are mine again, Shen.

“NOOOO!!!” Shen screamed, crouching down with his head in his hands in a lame attempt to shield himself from the Other’s return. He could not believe this was happening; he would become a slave once more to evil, death, and despair. The fear and terror Shen had felt before became so unbearable that he felt his mind begin to go. A sense of halting took hold of his consciousness, a feeling of his mind becoming stuck in place; it was the most terrible sensation he had experienced in all of his life, all the more terrible for the fact he suddenly could not scream.

“Shen?”

The androgynous voice sounded weak and far away, but Shen instantly seized on it as if it were a lifeline, enabling him to halt his descent into certain madness.

“*Veth! Please… help me…!!!*” He screamed.

“I’m coming!” The voice replied.

Shen looked up just as a set of shining eyes approached him in the dark, eyes that looked so much like a demon hunting for him. The voice had been a trick; it was the Other pretending to be Veth so that Shen would let his guard down.

“No! Stay away!” He shrieked, backing away.

But it was too late; the Other had come for him—Shen screamed as claws took hold of his flesh. Soon it would have his soul.

A Light in the Dark

Chapter Summary

> In order to escape the room of darkness, Veth must first make a connection.
>
> Catra gains perspective on what Truth means to her from an unlikely source.

Veth advanced into the yawning darkness beyond the entrance of the strange building, sensing the human Shen follow not far behind. Events had proceeded so quickly since their arrival, from encountering Nefeli's killer to almost murdering him to immediately facing the Guardians. Their normally calm inner balance was in a state of turbulence, made worse by burgeoning emotions slowly unraveling in them since they ceased partaking in the Penumbra Ritual. Many of these feelings were uncomfortable at first, but over time, they became rather pleasant—even thrilling. Veth felt that being with someone they didn't know was the worst time for this to happen; they didn't know what they would do or how they would react, especially in any new and stressful situations.

The fight with the Guardians was a prime example; why had they been so reckless in that battle, allowing themselves to be taken from behind and rendered unconscious? Sure, the enemies had been formidable, but they were a Champion of Empyrea, victor of over hundreds of confrontations and battles. Veth knew they were skilled enough to have bested those creatures. But they had taunted them, acting like a fool—had they been trying to impress the human?

No, that this foolish. Why would I care what that idiot thought? Veth thought with a shake of their head. *Why would a Nephraeh care what a human thought of them? Well, maybe I did it to show him his place so he does not seek to challenge me—that makes sense.*

Veth nodded to themselves, too pleased with their rationalization to notice that they were wandering in absolute blackness.

“Veth, any chance your silver eyes can see in this?” Shen’s voice called, pulling Veth out of their thoughts. Initially, they thought this question foolish, but with a sense of hope, they looked around, looking for the patterns and colors they had seen in the human earlier. But it was no use, the strange images were gone, and they were left completely blind and fumbling in the dark.

“No, Human, they cannot,” Veth answered. They were surprised that they felt annoyed—not with Shen—but for not being able to summon the sight. They had liked being able to see that way; even more, Veth had liked what they saw. It was the most beautiful thing they had ever seen.

Veth continued in the dark; in the absence of sight, they moved smoothly and carefully, using all senses in concert not to stumble or run into any unforeseen objects. They smiled to themselves as they imagined the clumsy human trying to do the same and strained their long ears to listen for him. Not hearing anything, Veth suddenly became concerned.

“Human?” They called tentatively.

Not hearing a response, they tried a different tact.

“Shen? Are you there?”

Nothing, no response was heard, and Veth’s worry unexpectedly became fear.

“Well, Human, if you’re not going to respond—” Veth said before stopping abruptly. For a second, they thought they heard something, a voice calling their name.

“Shen…? Was that you?” Veth called into the void.

Veth…

Veth was instantly still, not moving a muscle as they fought to control their emotions. They realized they recognized the voice and it was not fear they were feeling but a stirring of hope and joy. Veth would have known that voice anywhere, for they had heard it their entire life. It was the voice of the one person they had lost, the one person they had loved.

"Nefeli? Is that you?" They called.

Yes… it's me… your love…

"Where are you? How—?" Veth said, no longer fighting the smile spreading across their face as they felt about themselves, hoping their hands would find their lover's body again.

I'm here… close… just follow my voice….

Veth hesitated for a moment, suddenly thinking of Shen, who was undoubtedly lost somewhere as well. Indeed, if a Nephraeh was having difficulty making their way through the blackness, he would not fare any better.

If I find Nefeli, we can just come back and locate him together, Veth thought excitedly as they moved toward the position of the voice. *I must be in a place beyond the strictures of my normal universe, close to the boundaries of the realm beyond, where spirits lie. This voice really must be my Nefeli!*

Veth's clawed fingertips suddenly brushed against something; it was wood running vertically before them. Touching it with both hands, they found a handle; it was a door, and Veth pulled it open, light immediately greeting them. Veth squinted in the sudden brightness, and after their sight finally cleared, they let out a shout of glee at the vision before them. Somehow, Veth was now standing in the Heart of The Temple of Light deep below the House of the Penumbra. They had known about this secret place all their life, for Archon Lethe had brought them there to be bound to Zhe-La when they were still an adolescent. Veth had

always hated the place; it seemed so weak and full of that horrible Light that made them feel sick.

But now… it was so different. It felt wonderful to be there, especially at the heart of the Temple of Light. The font of the Light, The Great Crystal of Sera'Pah, filled Veth with so much joy that they felt like they would burst. If that were not enough to push Veth into a state of complete euphoria, then the sight of the person standing nude in front of The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah was.

It was Nefeli, opening their arms wide to beckon Veth to them with a beautiful smile. Veth found their legs already in motion as they sprang forward, running with abandon to their long-lost love. As the two lovers met, both laughed joyously as they embraced, and as they both parted, tears were in both sets of silver eyes. Veth was completely thoughtless in this state, not caring that they were also suddenly without clothes. It was as if they were in a magical dream—or even better.

"Are we… is this the Everlasting Love, Nefeli? Is this Elysium?" Veth asked breathlessly.

Nefeli laughed, bright and sweet. "Maybe! How about you kiss me and find out?"

Their lips met instantly, and Veth kissed Nefeli so passionately that they felt as if they could melt into each other. Veth hadn't considered how much they missed Nefeli, just how much they loved them until they had them in their arms once more. The feel of Nefeli's body was so warm, the rapid pulse of their heart was a gentle tapping against Veth's chest, and they could feel their own quicken in time to the other's. Nefeli's arms were likewise about Veth's body, the feel of their claws against their backside—

Veth's attention was suddenly focused on Nefeli's hands; they didn't recall them being so cold, nor did they remember their claws being so long. Veth felt Nefeli suddenly seize their lip with razor teeth; they bit hard, drawing blood.

“Ow! Nefeli—” Veth yelped as they attempted to draw back. But Nefeli held them tight, and as Veth opened their eyes to peer at the other, they gasped.

Two black eyes—like voids—stared at Veth, set in a face equally as black. The mouth they had just been kissing smiled, revealing rows of jagged teeth that gleamed like obsidian.

A Vetala.

“NO!” Veth shrieked, finally getting the strength to pull themselves out of the grip. They backed away as the Nefeli/Vetala gazed at them, head tilted curiously.

“Was this some trick to trap me? To enervate me and turn me back into one of Archon Lethe’s minions?” Veth shouted.

“And why would I need to do that?” A familiar and powerful voice called.

The fear Veth felt before returned as Archon Lethe strode out from behind The Great Crystal of Ser’Pah. A welcoming smile was spread across their white features, exposing their awful teeth and reminding Veth of a Vetala.

“How?!” Veth gasped, walking backward from their dread god.

“How indeed.” Archon Lethe cooed, bridging the space between them with great strides of their long legs. They seized Veth in their grip, holding them in place to bathe their wayward minion in an indigo gaze.

“Did you think you could hide from me in this pocket dimension?” Archon Lethe said with a laugh. “You cannot escape me, Veth. You cannot escape your ultimate destiny.”

“Wh—what are you talking about? My destiny?” Veth stuttered.

Archon Lethe released them to step back, waving a hand down at Veth’s body, indicating that they should look at themselves. Veth

did and immediately screamed.

Their entire body was glossy and black, long talons protruding from every digit—be it foot or hand. Veth already knew what they would encounter when they reached for their hair—but knowing did not stem the horror when they felt only bare scalp.

"Huhu? Wuhu? Ah chunt eak?" Veth said, attempting to talk through rows of razor teeth and the absence of a tongue. There was no questioning it; there was no point. Somehow, Archon Lethe had found them and punished them. Veth would exist for eternity as a dread Vetala—to suffer and be used for Archon Lethe's purposes. They were damned.

"Naaaaahhhhh!!!" Veth howled as Archon Lethe laughed.

Veth the Vetala lowered themselves to the ground to curl up into a fetal position, trying to curl their body into as tight a ball as possible. It was no use thought; there was no solace as a Vetala, only the hunger, which suddenly came upon Veth in relentless waves. They howled in absolute misery; the suffering was so great that each second in this existence was an eternity. Veth the Vetala felt their being—who they were—start to crumple and compress into a singular point. Soon, who they were would be gone, and only Vetala would remain.

"NO!!!"

Suddenly confusion filled Veth the Vetala's mind helping them achieve a certain clarity.

Who had said that? Veth the Vetala thought to murky hunger. *Was that— was that me?*

Instantly they knew it was; Veth had spoken, and if they could form words, that meant…

"I'M NOT A VETALA! I AM STILL NEPHRAEH! I AM VETH!"

Archon Lethe back hesitantly away from Veth as they began to stand; amazement was plastered on the Nephraeh leader's face. A Light was slowly appearing—like a sun cresting over a horizon—and Archon Lethe was withering away from it.

"Impossible! How can you—NO!" Archon Lethe shouted.

Veth looked behind themselves for the source of the radiance, but it was not there; it was coming from them, from within their body. A luminance like no other light—except the one which came from the Temple under the House of the Penumbra. Veth had summoned it, and by some unknown means, they knew what this Light was for; it was for good, for life, and for love. It was brought forth for many purposes, but first and foremost, its purpose was to banish its opposite; hatred and apathy—evil.

"BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

Veth had shouted the words so many times before, but it was only now they fully understood the meaning. The radiant luminosity seared out from Veth in an explosion, bathing the forms of Archon Lethe and Nefeli the Vetala, immediately breaking them apart in the torrent like filth washed away by clean water. But it did not stop there; the Light consumed the surrounding false Temple in a deluge, disintegrating it to dissipate back into its natural state. When the summoned Light finally subsumed back into Veth's body, they saw they were right back where they came from; the pitch-black room they had entered with Shen. Veth quickly felt at their body; they were still clothed, and everything was exactly where it should be. Veth let out an audible sigh of relief.

Was it *all an illusion?* Veth thought to themselves. *This… darkness… is more than it seems. Yes! I can sense it now; it is made of evil. Probably put here to stop people from getting out of this building.*

Veth was pulled from their thoughts by a sound—like someone crying out in the dark.

“Shen?” They called, hopefully. The reply was instantaneous.

“Veth! *Please… help me…!!!*” Shen screamed in reply. The sound of pain and anguish in his voice was piercing, manifesting in Veth an undeniable desire to help. By some new instinct, they knew exactly what to do.

Veth peered into the dark, focusing their will and intent upon it. Instantly they could pierce the veil of blackness and see the room in it entirely. It was a vast space, appearing in a strange fuzzy manner—like static on a viewscreen. The places where the walls, floor, and ceiling met were visible as straight white lines. They could see the closed double doors of their entry on the broad side of the space as well as an opposite exit; it took Veth a moment to get used to this sight, but amongst all this visual noise, they spotted what they were searching for.

Veth instantly recognized Shen in this sight, for they would never forget the signature of his quintessence. His soul was being dimmed and suppressed, the form of his body crouched on the floor much like Veth had been earlier. All around him was a cloud, a concentration of the blackness which flooded the room. It was attacking him with all its evil intent, and Veth knew this was the same attack they had just undergone. The dark purpose of the room had been to break them and crush their spirit; if it weren’t for the Light they could summon, it would have. Veth’s heart went out to the human, for they knew exactly what he was going through. But somehow, Shen was holding on, and Veth was immediately impressed by his fortitude of spirit.

“I’m coming!” Veth cried.

As they ran to him, Shen looked up, and instead of relief on his handsome features, Veth only saw burgeoning terror. Shen leaped to his feet and backed away, holding out his hands to ward Veth away. As Shen made his escape from salvation, the cloud of evil clung to him like a leech.

“No! Stay away!” He shrieked.

Veth would not be deterred and reached out to him, trying to seize hold of Shen and perhaps break the evil spell afflicting his mind.

“It's okay!” They tried to soothe. “It’s mean, it Ve—aaggghh!!”

Veth took a step back momentarily, shaking out of the blurry vision from being struck directly in the face. Annoyance immediately bloomed inside them, and they hissed, lunging at Shen faster this time and with more force. He tried to struggle out of their grasp, but Veth was stronger. They already knew they could subdue him with a choke hold or a knockout strike—but instead of doing that—Veth wrapped their arms tightly around Shen, pressing their body against his back and squeezing him tight against them.

“*Stop fighting me, you idiot!”* They growled into his ear.

After one final fruitless attempt to escape them, Shen finally sagged in their arms, defeated. Instantly Veth could see the influence of the cloud cease as it dissipated into murky smoke, which reabsorbed back into the surrounding darkness.

“Veth?” Shen asked in a hoarse voice. Veth released him, walking around him as he slumped over on his knees, panting. He looked up at them through strands of black hair; they were wet with sweat, clinging to his face limply.

“Yes, you fool. It’s me.” They said, rubbing at their jaw. “You hit me in the face, by the way. I *hate* being hit in the face.”

“Sorry,” Shen said miserably, slumping back down on his knees.

“How are you seeing me in the dark?” Veth asked suddenly. “You are looking in my direction.”

Shen finally stood up straight, waving at his face.

“Your eyes; they are glowing… or shining. I can see them in the dark. I thought you were….” he said, hugging himself in comfort.

Veth waved their hand dismissively, even though they were the only one who could see the motion.

"It doesn't matter, Human. We need to get out of here, and I can see the exit. You need to follow me," they said, turning away from Shen to proceed to the doors opposite the ones they entered in.

"Wait!" Shen called after them. "I can't see in this, remember? And when you turn away, I can't see your eyes,"

Veth pushed down their irritation as they went to Shen, grasping his hand in theirs. He jumped at the sudden contact, but the initial surprise at being touched had faded, Shen gently gripped their hand in his.

"It's fine. I will lead you out," Veth said simply.

Veth led Shen through the darkness to the double doors of the exit. They both squinted when Veth opened the door to the outside, for even starlight seemed bright compared to absolute night. Once they both had a chance to adjust to their new environment, Veth saw they were in a forest. Unlike the Great Jacarandra forest, the trees that comprised this one were much smaller, about the size you would expect of any tree outside Elysia. Silvery trunks held aloft bows of delicate white leaves which glowed beautifully in the starlight. That, combined with the fantastical sky above, filled Veth with so much joy at the beauty on display that, for a moment, they felt they might cry.

Perhaps this truly is The Empyrean, Veth thought, just as they felt Shen withdraw his hand from theirs. Glancing at him sideways, Veth saw Shen turn away from them, and judging by the pattern of his quintessence—which they still saw—he was feeling great shame and embarrassment.

"I'm sorry about back in there," he said to them. "I get these ways sometimes—it's like a…"

"Heavy weight that feels like it's smoothing you?" Veth finished.

Astonishment crossed Shen's face before he laughed.

"Yeah, exactly. It gets so bad, especially for me, and I get… fragile. Weak. I'm sorry about it—that you had to drag me out of there. Also, for hitting you," he said sheepishly.

Weak? Is he serious? Does he have any idea how strong he is? Veth thought incredulously.

They were about to comment on that fact but thought better of it. Veth was also going to tell him he was an idiot, but they thought better of it as well. In the end, Veth decided not to comment.

"Forget it. Let's just concentrate on finding something or someone who can help us," Veth said, pointing to a trail along the ground. It was a well-worn track, curving through short silvery grass and disappearing behind a grove of trees.

"Help us with what?" Shen replied.

Veth laughed; they had thought it obvious.

"To get back to where we came from. I have unfinished business, and I'm sure you do as well. I must face my Lord, Archon Lethe, and free my people. But first, I have many wrongs to right, starting with Despara,"

* * *

Once again, Catra found herself staring out a starship viewport as it translated through the chaos of hyperspace. The last time she had done this, Catra had been a complete mess; they were on their way back from Enos, and Catra was still reeling from facing her estranged wife. But much had changed since that journey back from the disastrous first attempt to disable the Relativity Forge.

For starters, Catra had come to grips with the fact that Adora was now a completely different person named Despara. She also now knew the path in which to get her wife back—but that was what

was causing her current strife. Catra now had so much power in her hands—magical power. She could feel it even now, connected to her through the Power Sword strapped to her back. It was the kind of might that went beyond commanding the vast army of the Horde, and the potential for destruction staggered her.

How could she control Sher-Va? Was she strong enough to stop herself from going too far when so much power was at her fingertips? Even more, did Catra fully understand the meaning of Sher-Va's core virtue—Truth? Catra had lived so much of her life in the gray between good and evil; Truth seemed like an absolute, an all-or-nothing. Did she have what it took to wield Truth as a weapon?

On top of that, there was the way every Madgēcot looked at her every time one of them passed. Catra was used to looks of disrespect, suspicion and even unwanted lust pointed her way, but not how her people now looked at her. In their eyes, she saw hope, pride, and even admiration—it poured out of every single Madgēcot like an unending well, making her very uncomfortable. She had come to this corridor in the aft outskirts of the Madgēcot starship *Saty* to try and escape the looks.

If all that were not bad enough, then what was happening and where she was currently going was. Looking out of the viewport and into the confusion of non-space, Catra could see the shapes of other starships flying in concert with the *Saty*. It was a mighty Madgēcot fleet—on their way to Empyrea to destroy the Nephraeh. They were three days away from the home world of the Empyrean Empire, and Catra still had no idea how to stop her people from performing mass extermination of another race.

Suddenly, a familiar smell caught her attention—an overabundance of musky cologne that no Madgēcot would be caught dead applying to themselves. Her ears twitched, pinpointing the sound of supple boots padding on the wooden deck of the corridor as the newcomer approached her, and Catra prepared herself for another unwelcome interaction.

“Isn’t it magnificent?” A familiar male voice asked.

Catra rolled her eyes as she turned away from the viewport—one of many that dotted the hallway—to face the speaker. He was taller than her, dressed in a rakish fashion, and currently twirling one of his mustachios—something which always annoyed her.

Seahawk.

“I guess if you like a bunch of lights that make you dizzy,” Catra said, waving at the view of hyperspace behind her. “I didn’t come here for the view, but because this part of the ship is mostly empty,”

Seahawk beamed at Catra, mistaking the hint she wanted to be alone for an invitation for company. He came up next to her to lean on the railing, which separated them from the oval shape of the viewport.

“Yes, it’s true that if you stare long enough at the dazzling kaleidoscope of wondrous beauty, you can start to feel a certain… effect. It’s actually quite pleasant.” Seahawk continued.

“Well, if you are looking for a buzz, the cantina is amidships—that direction.” Catra ventured, pointing down the corridor with a black-clawed finger.

“Naw!” Seahawk said, giving Catra a gentle nudge with his elbow. “I would rather hang with my fellow Etherian right here.”

Lucky me, Catra thought with an inward groan. She had come a long way from the old version of herself, who would lash out at anyone who wanted to spend time with her.

“Besides, you must be lonely without Melog. Why did they decide to stay behind on Elysia?” Seahawk asked.

Catra pursed her lips as she thought of the question. Melog had been missing the whole time she dealt with the appearance of the Power Sword of Sher-Va and the debates on the Nephraeh. Melog

finally turned up around when Catra was preparing to leave for space, telling her that they could not go with her, that they had to stay on Elysia with Battle Cat. It turned out that the Ethyriel was in a worse state than previously thought; that Battle Cat was disconsolate with the death of the one they were bonded to, and they needed Melog more than Catra did.

Catra was initially taken aback by this announcement—Melog was her constant companion, weren't they? How could they not go with her when she needed them the most?

But then it hit her, and Catra realized she was a selfish fool. Melog had a life of their own—needs that only others of their kind could fulfill. If Catra had taken the time to stop and consider what her friend had been up to, she would have noticed that ever since she had met up with them aboard the Madgēcot Ship Pakadna, Melog had been spending most of their time with Battle Cat. It may not be what she would consider a romantic relationship, but Melog and Battle Cat had formed whatever the Ethyriel equivalent was. Melog had other priorities than Catra now, and she was okay with that—although she did miss her friend's company now and again.

"Melog has their reasons for staying back, and it's none of my business. Besides, I do better on my own anyway."

Catra regretted speaking so quickly and realized that she sounded defensive. Based on the annoyingly raised eyebrow, Seahawk noticed it too.

"It must be hard now, being this Sher-Va. All that responsibility, everyone looking to you for answers," Seahawk said musingly.

"Yeah, it is, actually," Catra said, surprised at how perceptive the rogue was.

"I know exactly how you feel," he continued, puffing himself up for an anecdote. "You see, I too, have a great responsibility—*as a sea captain!*"

"Uh, huh," Catra said miserably.

She wanted to start zoning out then; she really did want to be alone, not listening to Seahawk compare being captain of some small dingy to holding the power of one of the seven Champions of Grayskull.

"As *Master* of a mighty sea vessel, everyone aboard the ship is beholden to me. I decide on the ship's course! I dictate chores and rations! I choose who sings falsetto during Thursday night sea chanties!"

"Sound tough, Seahawk," Catra said in a monotone.

"Oh, and it is!" Seahawk agreed, oblivious to her sarcasm. Catra leaned further onto the railing until her face was resting on her hands; she wished she could sink right down into the wood of the beam to escape Seahawk's voice.

"Oh, how responsibilities vex people like us, Catra!" Seahawk exclaimed as he came down to her level, placing an arm around her shoulder in solidarity. Catra's tail began to twitch rapidly at the unwanted touch.

"I had so much trouble juggling all the different pressures upon my gorgeous shoulders that I even started thinking of quitting the captain's chair and demoting myself to a lower station," he continued.

"Geez, that would have been a HUGE loss," Catra quipped.

"Yes, I agree!" Seahawk said, nodding vigorously. "But then, it happened!"

"Let me guess; you discovered the secret of mustache wax and proper grooming?" Catra interjected.

"That happened when I was but of lad of six!" Seahawk said with a chuckle. "No, it was when a great storm hit! The largest ever seen in the history of all four of Etheria's seas!"

Catra knew she was in for it when Seahawk jumped up on the railing, creating a makeshift stage for his theatrical performance.

"The Madgēcots are going to yell at you for doing that," Catra warned as she backed away from him. But Seahawk ignored her warning, too caught up in his memories.

"There I was, at the helm of my ship, The Dragon's Daughter II, when I saw it; a wall of thick black clouds from horizon to horizon!" Seahawk said, waving his arms wide to illustrate the magnitude of the storm.

"'Captain! We should turn back!'—one of my crew cried. 'Never! The sea does not dictate to Seahawk where to go! Set sail for the heart of the storm!'" Seahawk exclaimed in full pomposity.

"*Oh, brother,*" Catra moaned.

"Instantly, we found ourselves locked in a mortal struggle! The sea was tearing at my ship this way and that! There was no sailing into the waves, for they seemed to come from every direction at once. Every time I changed course, we were struck amidships—the last place you want the ocean's fury! For the first time in my life, I believed that I had made an error,"

Seahawk bowed his head in mock sadness as Catra looked up at him, incredulity plastered on her cinnamon face.

"You realized what an idiot you were for making your crew sail into a storm?" Catra ventured.

"Wrong!" Seahawk exclaimed, pointing a finger into the air. "My mistake was that I could not control everything at once! That was not the job of the captain. I was not all-knowing, all-seeing—I was not perfect! Once I realized it was only a matter of letting the sea take us, to ride it out until its fury abated."

Catra stared at Seahawk for a moment, her jaw slack with wonder.

How did this idiot live for this long? She thought before asking, "So… in letting go and not fighting the storm, your ship and crew safely made it out of the storm?"

Seahawk gave Catra a curious look before answering. "Why, no. The storm tore our ship to pieces, and we were shipwrecked on a deserted island for months. My crew was about to eat me when rescue arrived—why would you think that was the result of the story?"

Catra was about to leap up and smack Seahawk in the face when she thought of something; Seahawk's ridiculous story reminded her of what someone else had said. Shen had talked of not trying to control his anger while not wholly allowing it to take over—to find a middle ground and ride it. Perhaps there was something to that in her new responsibility as Sher-Va; most of her earlier fears could be summed up by that one idea.

There was no escaping her destiny now, Catra was Sher-Va, and there was only one path forward—accepting that *Truth*. Catra was also not a bad person—she never was, simply on the wrong path—that was a *Truth* too. It also didn't matter what people thought of her; good, bad, indifferent—Catra knew who she was now, and in that was *Truth*. Her people, the Madgēcots, were honorable and noble; they would see the wisdom of staying their hand and not destroying the Nephraeh. They just had to be shown that *Truth*—by her if need be. And finally, the need for the *Truth* of Sher-Va—Adora. Catra would need this power of truth to get her wife back, for, in the end, she could not imagine a life without Adora by her side. That was the ultimate *Truth*.

"Hey, human! Get down from there! What do you think you're doing?" A Madgēcot voice shouted, surprising Seahawk and making him lose his balance on the railing. Before landing hard on his back, Catra leaned in and caught him deftly in her arms. Seahawk looked at her sheepishly as Catra shook her head at him. Setting him down on his feet, she turned to the speaker; she was dressed in a blue Star Hunter Jaadoo suit with the winged star emblem on her chest, denoting her as a member of the ship.

“Sorry, I dared him to do it—won’t happen again,” Catra said with a smile.

The crewmember’s long ears perked up in recognition of Catra, and she stepped back.

“Oh! *Mahat* Cat-Tra! I’m so sorry! If I knew he was with you—”

“No worries!” Catra said, waving her apology away. “We were just on our way to the cantina,”

The female Madgēcot nodded, walking in the direction opposite the one Catra and Seahawk headed in.

“Thanks for that,” Seahawk said. “Are you really going to the cantina with me?”

Catra nodded. “Sure. Why not. I’ll even buy you a drink,”

Seahawk beamed as he walked beside Catra, pleased that she had seemingly accepted him. Before they could get very far, the entire hallway shifted to one side violently, making both Seahawk and Catra stumble into a nearby railing. This was immediately followed by another jolt, tossing them both onto the floor.

“What in the name of the Salineas Gate was that?!” Seahawk cried, holding the back of his head.

Catra didn’t answer as she hopped to her feet and headed to the nearest viewport. There she saw the answer to Seahawk’s question; they had been yanked out of hyperspace and were back in realspace. Arrayed before them like of collection of black daggers was a fleet of ships—a massive fleet. Judging by the spacecraft's sharp edges and dark looks, Catra didn’t need help recognizing whom they were aligned with.

“It’s the Empyreans! They yanked us out of hyperspace!” Catra said in a shocked whisper. “Somehow, they know what we are going to do and sent their entire fleet to stop us!”

So Close Yet So Far

Chapter Summary

Despara finally faces Catra in her Champion form - Sher-Va.

Now that Catra has the capabilities, can she defeat Despara and get Adora back?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With eyes fixed on the ship's forward view screen, Despara watched as the entire Madgēcot fleet tumbled about space like lost toys. Having been yanked out of hyperspace, the Elysians were confused; their elegantly designed wooden spaceships were too busy stopping themselves from running into each other to notice the Empyrean ships bearing down on them.

"Well done, Zaidu," Despara said to the ship's captain in a rare demonstration of appreciation. "You caught them with their Jaadoo suits down,"

The Nephraeh captain nodded curtly at Despara's compliment but didn't smile at the attempted jest. Neither did the bridge's crew react, not even bothering to turn from their stations.

I'm sure Zaidu is one of the conspirators Nurma spoke of. I wonder how many of the bridge crew are with them. Despara thought to herself.

She knew that there were Nephraeh in the fleet who were against Archon Lethe's plans and were likely to keep their fellow Empyreans from doing the Madgēcots too much harm. This dumbfounded Despara; counting the number of ships the Madgēcots had, the Nephraeh were woefully outnumbered. The Elysian would soon rally, becoming more of a threat, and the Empyreans were doomed to destruction. This was a suicide

mission, and everyone knew it; why not do as much destruction as possible before falling to the Madgēcots' wrath?

Despara dismissed this thought, chalking it up to more Nephraeh weakness. No matter what, she would see this mission through to the end. Not only to fulfill Archon Lethe's wishes and free her from their domination in death but also to strike out at the visions that had been haunting her dreams as of late.

Despara had not rested since given the news of who she had been destined to face. Despara had not batted an eye when Archon Lethe told her she must kill the bearer of Sher-Va and break their Power Sword. But when Etana told her that the current bearer was… *her…* that was when the strange dreams started.

Eyes peer at her from the dark—one yellow, the other blue. They are slitted like a feline and pin her in their hunter's gaze. They come for her in her vulnerable state—they can do anything they want to her—and they have complete control. She tenses as clawed hands lay upon her flesh—but instead of hurting her—they are gentle, caressing her skin with expert skill. She suddenly realizes she is naked as she feels the other's body press against hers; it is soft and warm, seeming to seek every corner of her form. She hears a soft thrumming and knows it comes from the other, for she can feel the vibrations against her chest. Arms wrap around her, pulling her even closer, and she can feel the other place their mouth against her ear, their breath hot as they speak.

"Hey, Adora…"

"Are you okay, Champion Despara?" Zaidu asked.

Despara jolted out of the unwanted memory and glanced at the ship's captain; they were staring at her strangely, with a faint smile on their lips. She knows her face must be flushed from what she had just experienced and suppressed the resultant desire with anger.

"Yes!" She snapped, instantaneously making the smile vanish from Zaidu's face. Despara tried to put the awkward exchange out of her mind as she concentrated on the battle unfolding.

On the viewscreen before them, bright beams lanced out from the Nephraeh fleet to strike at the Madgēcot ships. Despara was surprised to see shields appear, blocking the energy of the strikes. To her trained eye, the enemy's defensive capabilities seemed strange. Unlike the Nephraeh's shipboard shields, which, when activated, appear as fuzzy blue grid patterns, these looked to her like faint green bubbles.

"Are they using magical shields?" Despara asked.

"Uh—yes, Champion. I thought you knew that." Zaidu said uncertainly. "Their ships are powered mainly by magic—how do you think they get away with flying through space with wooden ships?

Despara snapped her head around to stare at the Nephraeh captain, and they diverted their silver eyes away from her glare.

"Watch your tone, Nephraeh," she growled. Despara was sick of the subtle disrespect directed at her by the Nephraeh and was eager for them to meet the same fate as herself.

Turning back to the viewscreen, she saw the entirety of the Madgēcot fleet turn simultaneously in their direction to begin their counterattack; she did not have much time left and needed to act soon. Somehow, she had to learn which ship the bearer of Sher-Va was on and board it before they were all destroyed.

"Bring us in close to engage the Madgēcots in close-quarters combat," she commanded.

Zaidu looked uncertainly in her direction; she knew that for the goals of their mission, this was the only course of action. The Madgēcots would have a more challenging time locking onto ships in their midst, enabling them to do as much damage for as long as possible. But that wasn't *this* captain's goal.

Despara summoned her black sword and brought it up to Zaidu's throat in one smooth motion. The Nephraeh captain did not move or look at the blade, only gazing coolly back at its bearer as the bridge crew watched them nervously.

"I command here, not you, *human,*" Zaidu responded.

Despara grinned at them, appearing corpse-like in her aspect.

"I could threaten to kill you, but I know that is not enough for you, so I will start with the bridge crew and leave you for last," she hissed.

Fury bloomed in Zaidu's silver eyes as they turned away to command the bridge crew to follow Despara's command. It was foolish for Zaidu to care for their people when they would all die anyway, but Despara had given up on trying to make sense of the Nephraeh.

As the ship sped forward into the mass of enemy ships, Despara concentrated, drawing upon She-Ra's potential and combining it with her other, darker magics. She called upon a perception that went beyond her mortal five senses and into the realm of the mystical, searching for one soul among hundreds.

Instantly her new awareness was overwhelmed by the abundance of life around her, and confusion filled Despara. After a moment of getting her bearings, she could differentiate between Nephraeh and Madgēcot—but only barely. Both were hideous for her to look upon, for in their luminescence were the same virtues—just in slightly different shades. Despara marveled that they were about to fight one another to the death and had to give Archon Lethe credit for facilitating such a thing. She would have seen such a thing as an absolute travesty if Despara had even a speck of compassion. But she was not such a person—Despara was a killer with no conscious, and she was on the hunt for one victim. One person who had the gall to follow her beyond consciousness and into her dreams, haunting her there with a temptation of what could never be—for Despara would never allow it.

Never.

Finally, she spotted it, the brightest kernel of them all. A soul whose compassion was tempered by great sorrow and experience —now augmented by ethereal energy. It was on a Madgēcot ship on the outskirts of the fleet; she just had to get there, somehow.

Walking to a nearby display terminal and pushing the Nephraeh crewperson to the side, Despara called up a 3D representation of the two fleets and highlighted the target ship.

"Take me to this ship, the *Saty.* Now." She said to Zaidu.

They walked over to stand next to the bigger warrior, looking up at her incredulously after scanning the screen.

"First, you wanted us in the middle of the battle, now on the outskirts. Which will it be?" Zaidu demanded.

"Just get me there and give me access to a boarding torpedo, Nephraeh; I will do the rest. Plus, I will be out of your hair," Despara answered.

The promise of having the dreadful Champion off their ship was all the enticement Zaidu needed, and they immediately commanded the crew to change course to intercept the *Saty*. As this transpired, Despara left the command bridge and made her way down to the lower decks where the torpedo bays were kept. As she stomped down the halls, the ship began to rock as it entered combat, taking hits from an enemy Despara could not see nor strike back out. Not yet, at least.

Nephraeh's crew looked up suddenly as Despara entered the cavernous torpedo bay; they were startled at having such a deadly threat amongst such dangerous ammunition. Despara ignored them as she scanned the space, finally spotting the rarely used transports tucked away in the corner. The Nephraeh crew looked nervously at each other as she pointed a black gauntlet toward the boarding torpedoes.

"Load one of those for me, now." She commanded.

The Nephraeh jumped to carry out her demands, perhaps out of fear or simply happy to blast her off into space.

Don't worry; you will soon be rid of me. Everyone will be. Despara thought sourly as she watched a gantry crane lift the sleek black tubular shape out of its cradle and onto the loading mechanism. Once in place, the Nephraeh opened a hatch atop the torpedo and waited for Despara to enter.

"You better aim me at the *Saty* and not towards a star lightyears away," Despara growled as she entered the torpedo. The space was cramped—meant for a much smaller being than her—and she tore out one of the seats to make room for her bulk. Sitting down in the tubular shape the best she could, Despara did not bother strapping herself into the seat harness, instead holding onto the sides with her strength alone.

"May *The Light* guide you," the Nephraeh crewperson said before closing the hatch and sealing her in.

Which Light did they mean, I wonder? Archon Lethe's or the other? These stupid Nephraeh are so confusing with all this Light nonsense, Despara thought as she tensed herself in preparation.

She didn't have to wait long; suddenly, Despara felt extreme g-force push her body back into the seat as the torpedo was launched from within the safety of the ship and out into the void. She gritted her teeth as the torpedo flew through the empty gulf between ships, only being able to imagine the large-scale battle taking place outside.

Despara felt the torpedo's propulsion cease and her body tingle as they passed through the enemy's shielding—the magic only in place to deflect energized beams or high-velocity weapons. Once through, the small engine of the one-way transportation let loose one last massive blast, expelling all its fuel to provide enough energy to punch its way through the hull of the target vessel.

Feeling a jolt and an abrupt halt, Despara knew she had arrived at the intended destination, and she kicked the torpedo hatch open to leap out onto the deck, sword in hand.

Hearing a hissing noise behind her, Despara spun on her heel, expecting a Madgēcot attacker—but it was only the torpedo sealing the rent in the ship's hull, maintaining the pressure inside the vessel.

"We have an intruder!" An accented voice said behind her.

Whipping back around, Despara saw two Madgēcots in Star Hunter Jaadoo suits, and she grinned viciously at them.

"Hello, my furry friends," she said in greeting, holding her brutal black sword up. Straight away, both Star Hunters pulled cantrips from their Jaadoo suits and flung them at the Dark She-Ra. Despara simply deflected the offensive magic with her sword—sending them into the walls and ceiling—where they blew large chunks out of the wood. Both Madgēcots were stricken at the destruction they had caused their own ship and looked at each other with lowered ears.

"Zoya, it's no use! Its Despara—she is too much for us!" One said to the other, who nodded.

"It's a good thing Sher-Va is on board," the other responded. "She will beat this menace."

Despara gritted her teeth in sudden rage as the two Madgēcots bounded off on all fours, and she chased after them. The thought of coming face-to-face with her rival had made Despara unhinged with rage; she could not wait to get her hands on Sher-Va.

"Yes! Tell Sher-Va that her doom has come!" She screamed, spittle flying from her lips.

"CATRA!!! I'M GOING TO KILL YOUUU!! CATRRAAA!!!"

* * *

Having left Seahawk far behind in her urgent need to get to the ship's bridge, Catra bounded down the corridors of the *Saty* on all four limbs. The spacecraft shook around her—evidence of the struggle outside—and Catra stumbled, almost running into a crewmember.

"Sorry! It's hard to run with this blasted sword on my back!" She called over her shoulder in apology.

"No worries, *Mahat!"* They called back on their way to their duties.

Catra stood on two feet as she rounded a corner, seeing the entrance to the ship's command center ahead. Once inside, she was assailed by a tumult of activity; Star Hunters were scurrying about as crewmembers hunched over consoles, their tails twitching in agitation. Catra could see the chaotic battle unfolding via the massive glass domed ceiling directly over the wide command dais where the captain and command staff were seated. From this viewpoint, she could see that where surprise had been on the Nephraeh's side, they were vastly outnumbered by the Madgēcot's fleet. Sleek Empyrean ships danced amongst the more primal-looking ships of Elysia; for every one of the black dagger-like ships, there were at least three of the wooden ones.

"Cat-Tra! Thank Elysia, you're here!" Captain Kailash exclaimed.

Catra tilted her head in confusion, pointing a black-clawed finger at the ceiling.

"I'm pretty new to fighting in space, but even I can tell we outnumber them. Why the long face, Captain?" She asked.

Captain Kailash shook his head sorrowfully. "I'm not worried about them, Cat-Tra. I'm worried about the Fallen Champion of Grayskull currently running rampage through my lower decks!"

Catra felt her ears droop at this news—with Veth gone, there was only one Champion that fit the description.

"Where is she now?" Catra asked evenly.

Captain Kailash looked at a view screen embedded in the armrest of his chair and scanned it briefly.

"Despara is currently making her way through the mid decks; I have five separate teams of Star-Hunters trying to divert her from the essential sections, but she is fixed on reaching us here—on the bridge." He said.

Catra's expression became set. "Don't worry; I will meet her halfway and stop her,"

Catra reached back and drew the Power Sword, holding it aloft as she exclaimed the words to summon Sher-Va.

"BY THE TRUTH OF GRAYSKULL!!"

Every single member of the bridge stopped to turn their head as green flames encased Catra, initiating her transformation into a Champion. It was a great honor for every Madgēcot present to witness something that had not been seen in over a thousand years.

Once complete, Sher-Va/Catra stared back at her people with glowing heterochromatic eyes and a look of determination on her cinnamon face. Before she turned to exit the bridge, Captain Kailash called for her once more.

"Mahat! One more thing! I have reports that Despara has been calling for you by name, saying she will kill you. I hope you are ready for this,"

A brief look of sadness crossed Sher-Va/Catra's face before she nodded curtly.

"I would expect nothing less," she said before turning and exiting.

* * *

"WHERE IS SHE? WHY WON'T SHE FACE ME!!!" Despara screamed as she dodged flaming cantrips from multiple

opponents. She had been making slow progress through the enemy ship; separate teams of Star Hunter were conducting hit-and-run strikes on her, trying to distract her from her objective. The accursed Madgēcots were always just out of her reach, using their natural agility to keep out of danger. It made her even more furious than before, pushing her into a berserker state. By this point, Despara could tear someone limb from limb without thinking about it.

A fiery bolt slammed into the back of her head, making Despara stumble. Turning, she saw a group of Madgēcots waving at her, beckoning her to chase them. But she would not be deterred—even by the chance to get her hands on one of the elusive foes, and she ignored the taunts. Despara knew she must be close to the bridge, for the Elysians seemed more desperate in their attempts to redirect her. Turning a corner, she found the most significant threat she had encountered on the enemy ship so far; ten Star Hunters crouched with cantrips in hand.

"Ah, finally, you plan to face me?" Despara called.

The Madgēcots were in an intersection of two wide corridors, which gave them room to fan out. Despara crouched, preparing herself for their attack. These constant delays in her progress were frustrating; all Despara wanted to do was face Sher-Va so she could end it all. End her trapped existence under Archon Lethe's heel and rid herself of the face in her dreams—soon, it would be over, and Despara would know peace.

"WHERE IS CATRA?" She yelled. "WHERE IS YOUR MIGHTY SHER-VA?!"

The Star Hunters answered by hurling their cantrips at Despara simultaneously. She tightened her guard at once, but the cantrips all burst outside her reach, revealing their type in a cascade of rainbow sparkles.

"*Chakra Blocks?* Right off the bat? Really?" Despara said as she backed away from the magic-dampening effects of the cantrips.

Throughout this struggle between Nephraeh and Madgēcot, Despara had been tested by Chakra Blocks time and time again—attempting to sever her connection to She-Ra and render her powerless. Initially, these attacks had almost worked on her, but over time Despara had figured out a way to counter the Chakra Block. When she felt her connection to her Champion Avatar begin to slip, Despara simply had to focus on her hatred. It seemed such a simple thing for her to do, but unbeknownst to Despara, it was because hatred was in plentiful supply in her. Hatred not only for her enemies and Archon Lethe—but for herself—perhaps the most potent hatred of all.

The Star Hunters looked uncertainly at each other as they saw their magic did not affect the dread warrior; as they reached for different cantrips, Despara struck. Summoning the power of Oblivion, she sent out a wave of coruscating purple energy, impacting on the Madgēcots just as they were about to unleash their next attack. They cried out in agony as the effects of enervation took hold of them, each one falling to the ground and lying prone. Despara walked up to her fallen enemy steadily; sword held out to the ready. She was eager to see Madgēcot blood.

"All you fleabags had to do was point me to Catra," she said, her face twitching from the buildup of fury. Despara raised her sword to deliver the killing blow to the closest Star Hunter, who struggled to regain their footing.

"WHERE IS CATRA?!?!" She cried one last time.

"I'm here, Despara," a voice replied.

* * *

Sher-Va/Catra padded down the ship's corridor, her large feet slapping against the wooden deck the only sound.

I'm not used to all this bulk; it's harder for me to move as quietly as I used to. She started thinking but was then distracted by the

sound of fighting ahead. The sound of cantrips was unmistakable, as was the voice which accompanied them.

"*Chakra Blocks?* Right off the bat? Really?"

Sher-Va/Catra turned a corner just in time to see Despara summon her dark abilities and subdue the Star Hunter defenders. She had seen this version of her wife a few times, but now it seemed to hit harder than ever before. Perhaps it was that Sher-Va/Catra had time to adjust to the fact that Adora had been brainwashed, or it was that she saw Despara through the eyes of a Champion Avatar—but now—when she looked at the Fallen She-Ra, she did not see Adora. There was not an ounce of the person Sher-Va/Catra had taken The Vow within the terrible spectacle that was Despara. Perhaps that was what she had needed all along—that was The Truth she needed. It would make what she had to do that much easier.

"WHERE IS CATRA?!?!" Despara screamed as she was going to kill one of the Star Hunters.

"I'm here, Despara," Sher-Va/Catra called.

Despara jumped at the sound of Sher-Va/Catra's voice, and she pulled her sword up mid-strike. The Star Hunters had since rallied from the effects of Despara's enervation and were back on their feet, cantrips in hand. Every one of the Madgēcots seemed energized by the proximity of their Champion and ready to take on Despara.

"We are with you, Mahat!" One cried.

"Sher-Va! We follow your lead!" Said another.

Sher-Va/Catra smiled gratefully at her people but shook her head.

"No, I need you to give us space. This is between her and me," she commanded.

The Star Hunters did not say a word as they backed away slowly from the two combatants, then once a safe distance from Despara, leaped away down the halls on all fours. Despara scowled as she watched them leave, a hint of jealousy on her face.

"Must be nice to have the people you fight for actually respect you," she spat.

Sher-Va/Catra tilted her head. "The Nephraeh would have respected you if you did fight for them, Despara. Problem is, you only fight for yourself." She replied.

Despara snorted at this. "You're calling me Despara. So, you have accepted the truth."

Sher-Va/Catra nodded. "I've accepted the truth that you were once Adora, my wife."

"THAT NAME HAS NO MEANING FOR ME!!!" Despara cried, lunging at Sher-Va/Catra to deliver a downward chop of her sword. The Madgēcot Champion leaped out of the way of the clumsy strike, lashing out with her foot to strike Despara in the thigh as she passed, stumbling her. Despara slammed into the corridor wall, creating a jagged break in glossy wood, which alarmed Sher-Va/Catra.

Curses! I hope there is no empty space on the other side of that! She thought with lowered ears.

Seeing the alarm on her enemy's face, Despara smirked, turning back to the wall to dig her sword into the large tear she had created. The wood cracked as Despara tore into it, and Sher-Va/Catra lunged forward, clawed gauntlets outstretched to stop her.

"You idiot, you are going to kill us—ARRGHH!!!" Sher-Va/Catra cried as she stumbled back from the sword that almost bisected her. Looking down, Sher-Va/Catra saw blood on her midsection—more than she had ever seen come out of her. But before fear

could take hold, warmth dampened the pain, and the bleeding slowed as her Jaadoo suit sealed up over the wound. It happened almost instantaneously; the healing nature of her Madgēcot clothing was somehow enhanced by her Champion magic

“Nice trick,” Despara commended. “I ran into an enemy like you just recently; it kept healing itself whenever I cut a piece off,”

“Very interesting,” Sher-Va/Catra responded, wanting to keep her opponent distracted longer. “In what genius way did you solve that conundrum?”

A rictus smile spread across Despara’s features. “BY CUTTING OFF BIGGER PIECES!!!” She screamed.

Sher-Va/Catra braced herself; seeing the sword coming down in an overhand chop, she reached up and seized it midair with both clawed hands. Despara grunted as she attempted to push the blade down, but it was held fast by the equal strength of another Champion.



“Nice trick, making your sword into armored gloves.” Despara conceded. “But getting close to me is not the greatest idea.”

Sher-Va/Catra suddenly realized what the other had planned—but it was too late. Despara’s eyes flashed with purple fire, and she felt it—the coldness that did not freeze—the dread emotion sapping her will. Despara was summoning her Oblivion magic to turn the tide; it might have worked if it were anyone else. But not with the current bearer and not on Sher-Va.

Sher-Va/Catra had the Truth as her shield. She knew who she was—how mighty her empathy was—and it would not be taken away. Sher-Va/Catra focused on this and, for the first time, brought forth the full capabilities of Sher-Va. Despara’s face became uncertain as green light poured out from her enemy’s eyes, turning to flames to match her own. The jade fire spread outward, down to Sher-Va/Catra’s body, to her arms and Despara’s concern turned to terror.

“NOOO!!!” She shrieked.

Sparks flew as Despara yanked her black sword out of the golden gauntlets and backed away, panting with exertion. Despara suddenly looked frantically around, like a trapped animal desperate for escape. By now, Sher-Va/Catra was covered entirely in her power, blazing like a torch that no shadow magic of Oblivion could withstand.

“Give up, Despara; I know it seems you have been running forever. *Believe me; I* know that feeling. Wouldn’t it be better just to accept peace?” Sher-Va/Catra asked as she approached the Fallen Champion with hands held out. Despara looked uncertain for a moment, then dismissed her sword, one hand held out as the other reached behind her.

“Yes, it would be better to be done with this life. I have been nothing but Archon Lethe’s plaything. I have no allies and am all alone; not even Scorpia and Mermista can be trusted. I have

nothing now; all I can count on is a quick death in service to my Lord," Despara said, almost sadly.

Sher-Va/Catra felt her heart go out to Despara, for in her vulnerability was the spark of Adora, begging for release. Sher-Va/Catra tentatively approached Despara with hope in her heart—perhaps this was it—she would get Adora back after what seemed like ages. But Sher-Va/Catra was blind to what Despara was reaching for.

Before she had time to react, Despara pulled a black hammer from her belt and swung it for Sher-Va/Catra's outstretched hands. The armored gauntlets—which were actually the Power Sword of Sher-Va—exploded into pieces as dazzling sparks danced between the two combatants. Catra abruptly lost her connection to her Champion Avatar and fell onto her back, dazed.

Despara looked down at her fallen nemesis, supreme satisfaction plastered on her cruel face as she re-summoned her sword.

"Wow! That worked better than I thought!" She exclaimed.

Catra's vision was blurry as she got to her haunches and kneeled amongst the ruins of her Power Sword. It no longer appeared as two razor-clawed armored gloves but as a sword with its blade shattered. Catra tentatively picked up one of the pieces to peer at it, still in shock.

Figures… only I can lose my connection to Sher-Va JUST as I was beginning to depend on it. She thought wryly as she tossed the metal fragment away.

Catra jumped back just in time to miss being cut in half, somersaulting away from a follow-up horizontal slash. Despara was fast—too fast even for a Madgēcot—and Catra was sorely missing her connection to Sher-Va. She grasped the Starburst cantrip from her side and tossed it at Despara—it exploded into a glaring light—temporarily blinding Catra's opponent and giving her space to maneuver away from the deadly blade. Despara hissed

with annoyance as she rubbed at her eyes, but when she removed her hands from her face, Catra was surprised to see her laughing.

"You know, Catra, for a moment, I thought you had me—I really did! But here we are, back where we were originally—with you running for your life!"

Catra shook her head vigorously. "No. You're mistaken. If that were true, and we were back to the way things were, we would not be fighting," she said sadly.

Despara stopped laughing as a strange expression came over her stern face.

"Yes, I think I have dreamed of that. You and me… they were very intense…" Despara said softly.

Hope surged in Catra's chest. "Yes! You are remembering!"

Despara lowered her sword as she considered Catra.

"What were they of? We were fighting in some of the dreams—not like now, for we weren't trying to kill each other. Other times in the dreams—and these are the most intense—we aren't fighting." Despara continued.

Catra suddenly smirked. "Did one of those memories occur in the Bright Moon council chamber when no one was around?"

Even though she had the cruel black mask covering her face, Catra could see Despara's eyebrows shoot up in surprise. Emboldened by this, Catra started to move forward.

"Do you also dream about the time, back in the Horde, when we stayed up all night talking about kissing? And that we ended up practicing on each other?" Catra continued.

Despara's face began to screw up in confusion as she stepped back.

"How about when we went swimming naked in Bright Moon Bay under a full moon? Remember? After we were done, we swam to shore and spent the rest of the night making—"

"ENOUGH!!!" Despara shrieked, causing Catra to jump back in alarm. Despara was panting heavily now, not from any physical exertion but the emotions roiling inside of her. Catra could see she was influencing the Fallen She-Ra; all she had to do was keep up the pressure.

"Yes, Catra, I remember all that," Despara said, suddenly calm. "But all those memories mean nothing to me—NOTHING! They are just dreams of a life I never lived,"

"Your lying, Despara! I can see my words are affecting you!" Catra cried, desperate to hang on to this one glimmer of hope.

Despara's face twisted and became almost purple with rage.

"*Yesss… you are having an effect…*" She panted. "THAT'S WHY I HAVE TO KILL YOU!!!"

Catra's eyes were wide as the huge warrior suddenly charged her, black sword held out to impale her. Catra jumped in time to miss the blade—but not in time to avoid the head butt delivered to her sternum. She wheezed as the air was expelled from her lungs and sent bouncing off the nearby bulkhead in a stupor.

Cat-Tra?! What are you doing?!

It took Catra a moment to realize it was the voice of Jihan speaking inside her mind and not the effects of a severe head injury.

Jihan? What are you talking about? I'm getting my butt kicked—that's what I'm doing! She mentally shot back before scrambling away from a stomping boot.

I know you are not as bright as I was, but why haven't you summoned Sher-Va?!

"The sword was broken, Jihan!" Catra said aloud as she ran. She was just trying to get away from Despara at this point, unsure as to what her next move was. The Killer Champion was not far behind, absolutely intent on painting the corridor red with her blood. Catra heard an exasperated sigh in her head before Jihan spoke again.

Sher-Va is not a sword, *you moron*! Sher-Va is YOU!

At that moment, Catra wished Jihan was real so she could pummel his face.

"YES! I KNOW! I am married to Sher-Ra, and I heard the stupid story of how Adora broke the sword and ended up summoning a stronger version of She-Ra! Oohhfff!!"

Catra grunted as she flopped on her face, just as Despara's enormous black sword spun over her head. It impacted with a heavy thud against a pair of closed double doors, sticking into the wood point first. After a moment, the sword vanished, returning by magic to its owner.

Getting to her feet, Catra saw Despara walking casually towards her, sword in hand.

Knowing I can summon Sher-Va without the sword and learning how to are two different things! Catra thought as she crouched, teeth and fists clenched in frustration. She had no idea how Jihan expected her to summon the pure form of Sher-Va when it took Adora months to accomplish it. It was just too much expectation in such a short amount of time.

Catra had two choices: stand and fight, or continue through the doors and into the bridge, putting additional lives at risk. For Catra, that was no choice at all; turning towards the approaching killer, she bared her fangs and claws in a last stand.

Despara seemed to have gotten a hold of her raging emotions at this point, seeming calmer as she approached her quarry—but the look of murder had not left her eyes.

“I can see the attraction to you, Catra.” She said evenly. “You’re a fighter. Your beautiful and brave—too bad I have to kill you,”

Catra’s only response was to hiss at Despara; she had nothing left to say at this point and was ready to meet her fate.

Think Cat-Tra! What is there to learn? Adora thought she had destroyed her connection to She-Ra; she only called upon her Champion Avatar after realizing it was possible! You don’t have to go through that! You already know it's possible! Believe in yourself! Believe in Sher-Va! Believe in the Truth!

Jihan’s words suddenly made sense to Catra; if only she were not fighting for her life, she would have eventually come to the same conclusion. Catra knew the connection was still there; she just had to find it—but she was running out of time. Despara had sensed the shift in Catra and was coming to end the threat before it could rear its head—she charged for one final attack.

Truth. It's about Truth, Catra. Either it is, or it isn’t—true or false. You do, or you don’t have a connection to Sher-Va—and you know you do! SO DO IT! Catra thought as she suddenly leaped towards the impending doom, running on all fours.

“BY THE TRUTH OF GRAYSKULL!!!”

A green blaze—like a fireball—struck Despara full-on to knock the black armored juggernaut onto her back so hard it sent her jagged black facemask spinning away on the floor. Despara looked up dumbfounded as Sher-Va/Catra stood over her, eyes burning with jade fire—with Truth.

“*Hey, Despara,*” Sher-Va/Catra purred.

Despara’s glowing indigo eyes were wide with the realization that this was the end for her, and she screamed with desperation.

“NOOOO!!!!” Despara shrieked, grabbing Sher-Va/Catra’s legs and yanking her down onto the ground.

Despara was on her feet and running—straight for the double doors to the bridge. With a strength born of desperation, the Fallen She-Ra clove the wooden door in two, kicking the remaining pieces to the side and gaining entry to the ship's command center. Every single Madgēcot turned towards the intruder, expressions of shock on their feline faces as the Empyrean Champion was suddenly amongst them.

But Despara's mind was not on death, only escape, and she looked about the large chamber for her salvation. Looking up, she spotted it—the glass dome that still provided a view of the battle outside. The captain and crew sensed the maddened intruder's intent and ran as fast as all four limbs could take them out through the door and past Sher-Va/Catra as she finally caught up.

"Adora! Don't do it!" Sher-Va/Catra pleaded.

Despara turned to look at her enemy, a bizarre mix of sadness and hope on her face.

"You are not changing me back! There is no going back for me!" Despara cried.

Sher-Va/Catra held her clawed gauntlets out—not in threat—but as an invitation. In hope.

"Please! You don't have to do this! I can help you! There is nothing for you outside this place other than pain and damnation!" She pleaded.

Despara snorted. "Oh yeah? What can you offer me?" She asked.

The answer for Sher-Va/Catra was instantaneous.

"My love, Adora. I can offer you my love."

At first, Despara didn't respond to this and looked away, but when she returned her gaze to Sher-Va/Catra, there was only a cruel smile on her lips. She laughed suddenly—a loud cackling chuckle

with the warmth of an old grave. Sher-Va/Catra dropped her hand to her side, already knowing what would happen next.

"Love? *Bah!* Love is a *shackle*—I am no one's slave! I AM DESPARA!!!" She screamed, hurling her black sword two-handed up and into the transparent dome. It punched through, bursting it like one giant bubble, and the atmosphere of the bridge was sucked into the void.

Sher-Va/Catra did not see this, immediately leaping to the deck to dig her foot and hands claws into the wood to hold on tight. It did not take long for the pressure to equalize as the air fully evacuated, and for a moment, Sher-Va/Catra was weightless and exposed to the harsh vacuum of space. It was an unpleasant experience—but not wholly fatal—as the magic of Sher-Va protected her from instant death. This changed when the ship's arcane damage protocols sensed the hole in the hull, summoning a barrier to replace the missing dome. Soon air and pressure returned to the bridge, and Sher-Va/Catra rose to her feet, looking up through the magic shield to where Despara disappeared.

I'm proud of you, Cat-Tra! You did it; you brought forth Sher-Va without the sword! I knew you could do it!

Sher-Va/Catra did not respond; her twitching tail was the only indication that she had heard the voice of Jihan inside of her head. She was too distracted by the fact that she had missed her chance.

Despara was gone.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Ansdrela on Twitter, Instagram and Twitter.

Insurrection

Chapter Summary

The fate of the Nephraeh Fleet is decided.

Archon Lethe gets a surprise.

Glimmer gazed from a heightened perspective, seeing the galaxy she resided in as a beautiful purple swirl dotted with blue streaks and yellow splashes. She was once again in her meditative state, but instead of performing her ritual in her tower back on Etheria, she was in her cabin aboard the Madgēcot starship *Satay*. Glimmer and her friends had been allowed to come with the Madgēcots as they traveled to conduct their grim task—the annihilation of the Nephraeh. But she was not interested in being a passive observer; Glimmer was desperate to find an excuse to stop this madness.

From her transcendent cosmic view, Glimmer could see that the foul tendril reaching for Elysia was utterly gone, and all others reaching out from Empyrea were diminished. Even more surprising, the planet of Empyrea no longer appeared dark; it was now in a middling state as if it were in twilight. As Glimmer focused on the planet, she could see a slow and barely perceptible brightening—like a sunrise.

Something is happening on Empyrea, something amazing, she thought to herself.

But as Empyrea was waxing, Elysia was waning; the previously bright emerald of a planet seemed tarnished. A haze was around the planet—like smog—which traveled out from its location and out into space like a trail. As Glimmer followed this stained path, she realized it coincided with the direction the Madgēcot fleet was taking, leading all the way to Empyrea. But midway along its course, it became darker, eviler; something will happen to the collective Madgēcot fleet to cause it to descend into even more

tragedy. With a start, Glimmer realized that they were just about to cross this threshold; perhaps it was upon them this very instant and—

Glimmer was abruptly pulled from her meditative state as the ship around her jolted. The magical lights in her and Bow's stateroom flickered as she opened her eyes, and she turned to see her husband jolt upright in their bed.

"What in the name of Etheria was that?" Bow shouted.

"Something not good," Glimmer stated as she reached out with her magical senses to feel her surroundings. The *Satay*and the rest of the Madgēcot fleet were no longer translating through hyperspace—they were now in real space. The fleet had an absolute absence of kinetic motion which was only achievable by an outside force, and Glimmer could immediately sense the cause of their frozen state; another fleet was moving in on them.

"It's happening," Glimmer said in horror. "The Nephraeh must have pulled us out of hyperspace to ambush us. Something terrible is about to occur."

Bow was immediately out of bed, by his wife's side, and holding her hands.

"What is it?" He asked.

Glimmer looked into her husband's big brown eyes with her sparkly pink ones, seeing absolute confusion there. She shook her head.

"I don't have time to explain how I know this, but I think the Nephraeh have just pulled us out of hyperspace to ambush us."

"Uh, that sounds bad enough by itself." Bow said with a grimace. "What could be worse? Do you think they are going to destroy us?"

Glimmer shook her head again, more fervently this time.

“I don’t know! But what I do know is that we need to get to the bridge!”

Picking up her Star Stone staff in one hand and taking Bow’s hand with the other, Glimmer teleported in a haze of sparkles. But the destination she had set in her mind’s eye was not the one in which she and Bow ended up. As they coalesced back into reality, Glimmer saw that they were indeed on a spaceship, but not one of Madgēcot design.

They were in a medium-sized room; the walls and ceiling were faceted—like the inside of a gem—and gleamed with a bluish opalescence. Dim recessed lights lit the space from multiple directions, giving both Bow and Glimmer a clear view of the figures surrounding them—Nephraeh. All seven surrounded the newcomers and were arrayed in full Aegis Lace outfits with black face masks. These Glimmer recognized as the Krypteia, and she immediately pointed her Staff of Power at them.

“Hold! We mean you no harm!” One of the Krypteia shouted.

“Why did you capture us? Are we your prisoners?” Glimmer demanded as Bow notched an arrow.

“There is no need for that,” the same Krypteia exclaimed as they made a hand signal to their compatriots. As one, the Krypteia raised themselves from their fighting stances and lowered their clawed gauntlets. Bow and Glimmer looked at each other uncertainly.

“What do you want?” Bow demanded as he notched an arrow.

The Krypteia held out their gauntlets placatingly, but Glimmer found nothing comforting in the razer claws at the tip of each finger.

“Someone will be here soon to explain everything. On my warrior’s honor, you will not be harmed,” The Krypteia said.

Glimmer did not respond as she considered Nephraeh honor. She remembered that Veth had tricked the Madgēcots, wounded their sacred tree, and kidnapped Adora. Seeing the expression on her husband's face, she knew he was thinking the same thing.

Bow and Glimmer waited for what seemed like an eternity; the only sound was that of battle as the ship they were upon engaged the Madgēcot fleet. Bow cleared his throat nervously under the stare of the seven Krypteia—their eyes glittering like diamonds behind their no-nonsense masks.

Everyone turned as a pair of double doors slid open, and a different Nephraeh entered. Glimmer saw that the newcomer was unmasked and dressed in a skintight outfit made of a black velvety material. Over this was a dark purple cape and hood, which appeared big enough to completely conceal the wearer when needed. Like all Nephraeh, they were attractive, which they accentuated with a welcoming smile.

"Welcome aboard the *Lepida,* Queen Glimmer, and Bow of Etheria,"they said in a melodious and androgynous voice.

"Who are you? Why did you capture us? Are we your prisoners?" Glimmer demanded angrily.

The newcomer shook their head vehemently. "No! We just want to speak with you. I am part of a group within the Nephraeh called the Knosis, and we know all about you, Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon. We were hoping you would use your powers so we could… *divert*you here." They said reasonably.

"For what purpose? Hostages?" Bow asked as he raised his weapon slowly.

"No, as I said, we just want to talk, Bow." The Nephraeh said. "Please put your weapon down."

Bow looked uncertainly at Glimmer, who gave him a slight nod, and he lowered his bow as he returned the arrow to the quiver.

“I am Ninurta, and these are my colleagues,” Ninurta said as they waved a hand at the other Nephraeh. “Their names are not important now—what is important is that we all are part of the same group. We all share the idea that the Nephraeh have deviated from our true course, and that must be rectified.”

“That’s real nice; what does that mean for us?” Bow asked.

“I’m getting to that impatient human!” Ninurta said with a laugh. “There is a rebellion brewing on Empyrea, one that has been stewing ever since the death of Champion Veth.”

“A rebellion?! Against Archon Lethe?!” Glimmer exclaimed.

“Yes. We are so close to enacting our plans and tearing down the tyrant Lethe. But they have plans of their own and have sent this fleet—” Ninurta said as they waved a black-gloved hand around them. “—to try and slow the Madgēcots down. We have done as Archon Lethe asked—to do otherwise would tip our hand. But we also know we are going to our deaths for the Elysian ships outnumber ours—that is where you come in, Queen Glimmer. We know the Madgēcots are angry—they are right to be. But we do not want to die needlessly, for our strength is needed back on Empyrea; to help our people free themselves from Archon Lethe’s rule. We need you to speak on our behalf, to inform the Madgēcots we wish to surrender.”

“Then why did you ambush us? Why not just pull us out of hyperspace and surrender? Bow asked suspiciously.

Ninurta looked briefly at their companions and sighed. “Yes—*that*. This might be hard to believe, but Archon Lethe’s eyes are upon us, especially those closest to them—the Knosis and the Krypteia. We had to attack so Archon Lethe would know we were following their orders.”

“But once you surrender to the Madgēcots, won’t Archon Lethe know that too?” Bow asked.

Ninurta nodded with a knowing smile. “I see our intelligence on how smart you are was correct. Yes, they would know, but we have slowly taken measures to weaken Archon Lethe’s connection to us. Once we are ready, we will all simultaneously sever that connection; Archon Lethe will just assume we all died and be none the wiser.”

Bow shook his head. “This is all too far-fetched.”

Glimmer, who had been silently listening to the exchange, pursed her lips.

“I believe them,” she said as Bow looked at her incredulously. She turned to him, clasping his hands in hers.

“I had a vision before we were pulled out of hyperspace. The Madgēcots are about to do something terrible—something that will stain them forever. Destroying the Nephraeh fleet is that horrible deed, and we must stop it from happening!” She exclaimed, persuading Bow.

“Thank you, Queen Glimmer,” Ninurta said. “You can leave us now —and please be quick,”

As if to underline Ninurta’s request, the ship around them shook violently as it took a grievous hit from the surrounding Madgēcot ships. The room's lights dimmed briefly before coming back online, and Glimmer clasped Bow’s hand as she concentrated on her destination. The dark hues of the interior of the Nephraeh disappeared as Glimmer and Bow teleported away, quickly replaced by the warm amber colors inside of a Madgēcot vessel. They were on the *Satay’s* bridge, and Glimmer was immediately shocked by its state; small-scale damage could be seen on the deck, and it was frigidly cold as if it had been recently exposed to a vacuum. The Madgēcots, who were either glued to displays or speaking loudly to one another, instantly pinned the newcomers with slitted feline eyes—only looking away when they recognized Glimmer and Bow as friendlies.

Above her, the gaping hole where the viewing dome once resided was jarring; a shimmering green forcefield was all that stood between them and the cruelties of space. Standing immediately below the opening was Sher-Va/Catra; she gazed mournfully up at the hole, seeming to have lost something dear to her. Glimmer immediately went to her friend, clasping her much larger hand with two of her.

“Catra! What's the matter?” Glimmer asked.

Sher-Va/Catra looked down slowly at Glimmer, taking a moment to focus on the shorter Princess with both of her glowing eyes.

“Glimmer,” Sher-Va/Catra said as if in a daze. “She’s gone—Despara is gone.”

Glimmer immediately understood what had happened; Despara and Sher-Va/Catra had fought, and somehow, the glass dome was broken, sucking Despara out into space.

“Catra, Despara will be fine. I mean, don’t you remember when Adora took out those Horde Clone Ships when we first rescued you? She did it fully exposed to space while shooting lasers out of her sword!” Glimmer said with a chuckle. “She will be fine—but right now—I need your help!”

This realization came over Sher-Va/Catra’s heterochromatic eyes, and she nodded.

“You want me to help you stop this?” She said, waving a golden gauntlet up at the battle taking place. At that very moment, one of the bladed Empyrean ships exploded, scattering debris in multiple directions. Amongst the detritus were small pods—escape craft—floating helplessly into the void.

“Yes, Catra! I want you to help me stop this madness before it's too late!” Glimmer said, now adopting a more scolding tone. Sher-Va/Catra chuckled.

“Okay, Sparkles. Don’t get in a tizzy,” she said.

Sher-Va/Catra turned, and, almost in a saunter, went to the captain seated in his command chair. Glimmer took a second to admire her friend in her Champion form; she thought it suited Catra well.

"Captain Kailash, we need to open communications with the Nephraeh." Sher-Va/Catra said down at the commander of the *Satay*.

At that moment, the captain was focused on a display at his chair's armrest and looked up at the Madgēcot Champion with pure shock.

"Why would we do that? What would be the purpose?" He demanded.

Sher-Va/Catra's massive tail twitched at his tone; she never liked being talked down to.

"To ask for their surrender. They are beaten, and I'm sure they know it. We must stop this now before our fleet goes too far and annihilates all the Empyrean fleet." She said.

The captain looked taken aback; it was as if Sher-Va/Catra had proposed something that he had not even considered. Perhaps in the collective anger of the Madgēcots, he had not. After a moment, he nodded.

"Yes, I agree." The captain said before turning to the crew. "Alert the other ships; the Satay is opening communications with the Nephraeh fleet. We ask the other Madgēcot vessels to prepare to stand dow—"

"NO!" A voice shouted from the other side of the bridge.

Glimmer was not surprised to see Rishi hurrying over to the command chair, resentment and anger plastered on his face.

"How dare you interrupt me on my own bridge!" Captain Kailashshouted. Rishi waved his hand as if the commander of the

Satay's protests were meaningless pests.

"You may be captain of this ship, BUT I represent the anger of the Madgēcot people! We will not settle for anything less than total extermination of the foul Nephraeh!" He shouted back at the captain.

"Aren't you taking your self-proclaimed responsibility a little too far, Rishi?" Glimmer asked with arms crossed.

"Shut your mouth, Outsider! This is none of your concern!" Was Rishi's immediate answer, enraging Glimmer with the disrespect in his words.

Before she could answer, a low and deep growl rumbled throughout the bridge, putting every Madgēcot there on alert.

There was an alpha predator amongst them.

"Rishi," growled Sher-Va/Catra. "I've had just about enough of you,"

When Glimmer turned to her friend, she was shocked to see a green glow pouring from both Sher-Va/Catra's eyes. Something was igniting inside the Madgēcot Champion as emerald flames spread down from her eyes and alighted on her clawed gauntlets. Rishi watched this happening with wide eyes and lowered ears.

"H—how dare you threaten me!" He shouted as he backed away from the angry Champion. "Don't you touch me!"

There was genuine fear in the Ex-Star Hunter's voice; it was as if part of him knew what Sher-Va/Catra was about to do. The part of Rishi that enjoyed being cut off from his compassion, thinking that in doing so, he was free. But that was a lie; Rishi was a broken soul ever since the Vetala had sunk its fangs into him, and before him was his salvation.

"I think I know just what to do with you," Sher-Va/Catra said as she held out hands bathed in an emerald blaze.

“NOOO!!!” Rishi screamed.

In his desperation to escape, Rishi went to all fours and ran towards the bridge's exit as fast as he could. But Sher-Va/Catra was after him, and the much larger Madgēcot swiped his hind legs out from under him, making Rishi tumble in a heap on the deck. Sher-Va/Catra was on him in an instant, pouncing on him and seizing Rishi in her claws to bathe him in the fire. Rishi screamed as the conflagration from Sher-Va/Catra’s gauntlets entered his body to pour back out through his eyes and mouth. A faint dark haze came with the blaze, but it was not smoke; it was something dirtier, and it dissipated to nothingness once free of its hiding place.

Releasing her victim, Sher-Va/Catra stood up as the flames vanished. She appeared exhausted; using the power of Truth had expended her energy, and Sher-Va/Catra reverted to her normal form, becoming just Catra once again. Before she could collapse, Bow and Glimmer came to either side of Catra, placing her arms over their shoulders to support her.

“*Easy, girl*,” Glimmer said to Catra with a smile. “You know, it seems like just yesterday Bow and I were helping Adora adjust to her She-Ra power.”

Catra chuckled at this and looked down at Rishi; he was unconscious but beginning to stir.

“At first, I thought my Sher-Va power was stupid,” Catra said thoughtfully as Rishi opened his eyes to look upon the world as a whole person once again. “But now I can’t imagine having a better one. To be able to bring someone back from evil—it fills me with such hope…”

Catra’s words died out as she stifled the oncoming need to cry, and she wiped at her eyes. Glimmer and Bow stared at this display and looked at each other meaningfully. Catra saw this and immediately gave them a suffering look.

"Yeah, yeah—*get over it!* Haven't you realized yet I'm just a big softie?!" Catra exclaimed. Bow and Glimmer laughed at this before returning their attention to the bridge and the ongoing battle. The Madgēcots were still going to annihilate the Nephraeh, and they had to do something.

"Captain!" Catra called as she freed herself from her friend's grasp to stride over to him.

"Yes, Mahat?" He replied, awe now evident in his voice.

"I believe you were going to give orders to stop this madness before you were interrupted." She said, turning to Rishi. The Ex-Star Hunter got to his feet, seeming disorientated but no worse for wear, and went to stand by Catra.

"Do you have any more objections, Rishi?" Catra asked.

Rishi immediately shook his head. "No, absolutely not. I agree we need to stop this from going any further."

Catra nodded curtly and was about to turn back to the captain when Rishi stopped her.

"I remember everything, Catra, and I'm sorry. I was trapped in a horrible existence and thought myself better for it. Thank you, I am in your debt for life," he said, placing his hand over his heart.

Catra laughed. "No need for all that—just buy me a drink when we get back to Elysia," she said, slapping Rishi on the shoulder. He smiled back at her and nodded, and the two Madgēcots turned to look expectantly at the Captain of the Satay. He immediately pressed a button in his command chair, opening a channel to the Empyrean ship.

"This is Captain Kailashof the Madgēcot Ship, *Satay*, to the Empyrean fleet. You are outnumbered, stand down and surrender to us or you will be destroyed." He said in a commanding voice.

A three-dimensional hologram immediately appeared before them of a violet Nephraeh face. Glimmer immediately recognized it as Ninurta.

“I am Ninurta, and I represent the Empyrean Resistance which now commands Nephraeh Fleet. We accept your terms and will immediately stand down and prepare for surrender.” They said formally before their silver eyes found Glimmer. “Well done, Queen Glimmer,” Ninurta said with a smile before cutting the link.

Glimmer could see the Nephraeh and Madgēcot ships disengaging from battle through the gaping hole in the roof of the command center. The dagger-like Empyrean ships then came about, making themselves prone to boarding by the Elysian craft.

“It’s over,” Glimmer whispered.

“Not yet,” Catra said firmly next to her. “It’s not over until I have Adora back.”

* * *

With eyes that burned deep indigo, Archon Lethe stared into the depths of The Great Crystal of Ser’Pah as they manipulated events far, far away. They had been at this task for weeks now, working day and night to achieve their goals. Sleeping was not necessary, nor was the consumption of food—but that did not mean they did not need sustenance. Archon Lethe did need to feed and were wholly consumed with the desire—even more so as their connection to the Nephraeh slowly slipped through their black-stained hands. They knew they were running out of time and soon would be too diminished to fight against their many enemies, but they were also so close to achieving their ultimate desire; a source of unending nourishment, the scope of which was beyond reason.

Archon Lethe always knew they would reach the limits of the resources this reality had to offer. That is why, millennia ago, after the disappearance of Eternia and the Avatar of He-Man, they had

decided to curb their appetites and bide their time. Once they had discarded mortality to attain godhood, the one who had been called Kishar had looked upon their reality with new eyes. They could see everything from a greater vantage point now; all the little people of the universe going about their business appearing as ants. To the people of the universe, the one who had been called Kishar must look like a giant now, staring down at them from lofty heights. But from their new perspective, the one who had been called Kishar felt awareness upon them, directed down at them from observers greater than they. The one who had been called Kishar immediately sensed that these beings had motivations and interests which were diametrically opposed to their own—mortal enemies who served good, evil, or neither. If the one who had been Kishar ever tried to lift themselves to or even above the heights of these others, it would mean their end; any one of these greater gods would utterly obliterate them.

So, they went about the centuries as quietly and humbly as possible; the one who had been Kishar renamed themselves Lethe and stayed on their home planet of Empyrea, tending to their people as the galaxy burned under Horde Primes' onslaught. They learned how to harness the power of Zhe-La to feed on their entire race—always taking just enough to survive but not to grow. For to increase their power would mean they would have to consume more—and by doing so—overextend beyond what the Nephraeh had to offer.

Over the many years, Archon Lethe had watched their people change as they continuously fed on their empathy. The once luminous Nephraeh became darker; white hair and skin became violet and black, and golden eyes became silver. The Nephraeh grew sharp fangs and claws almost in mimicry of their master's predatory nature, and Archon Lethe took a certain amount of pride to see this, for they had molded their own race to match their new disposition.

They found humor in the fact that they—Archon Lethe—had been responsible for their people's downfall, yet they alone retained the original Nephraeh appearance. But this irony was later marred as

their teeth blackened and gleaming white hands stained—how, Archon Lethe did not know. Further confounding them were the beautiful markings that appeared on the bodies of the Nephraeh—almost like an unreadable script in an unfathomable language. Archon Lethe took these as signs from ones greater than themselves, warning them not to try and surpass them.

Archon Lethe smiled to themselves, for they did plan to increase their stature—but not in the way their enemies thought. Archon Lethe had long ago decided that when they did elevate themselves, it would be to a level far beyond any other. They would become the ultimate power, and they knew exactly how they would achieve it.

Archon Lethe saw the pattern of their arcane design within the structure of The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah begin to fray; somewhere, lightyears away, one of their pawns had become adrift. Archon Lethe growled with annoyance.

*Despara has failed in her task. No matter, I must divert her back to an alternate path,*they thought.

Reaching out with a black-stained hand, Archon Lethe realigned the structure of their magic, which appeared as a black storm within the giant crystal. Purple lightning instantly coruscated within the transparent stone, making the Light pouring from its apex waver momentarily.

During the long years of their possession of the Temple of Light, Archon Lethe had tried to stamp out this Light—for it was an anathema to them. But try as they might, they were only ever able to diminish it, subduing its power just enough to allow them to stay on the planet comfortably.

But that had changed recently; the Light had started to break down the barriers Archon Lethe had placed around it, making Empyrea much less hospitable to them. Archon Lethe was beginning to have suspicions as to why.

Suddenly, Archon Lethe's awareness left the undertaking before them as they heard a sound coming behind them. Turning slowly around, they found the two House of the Penumbra Acolytes, Etana, and Nurma, standing at the entrance of the great chamber. Archon Lethe was instantly confused.

"What are you two doing down here? You have tasks above that require you atten—"

The look of defiance burning in the silver eyes of their once-trusted minions made Archon Lethe stop short as a sudden realization hit them. They were immediately annoyed.

"Ahhh… I see…" Archon Lethe mused. "I assume I have you two to thank for strengthening the Temple of Light?"

Archon Lethe's annoyance turned to rage as more Nephraeh entered the room; they instantly recognized their own Centurions and even Krypteia amongst them.

"We are putting an end to your tyranny, Kishar!" Etana yelled.

Archon Lethe's eyes were wide with shock—not at the apparent rebellion—but because someone had addressed them by a name they had not heard uttered for a thousand years.

"How *dare* you worms threaten me," Archon Lethe hissed. "You may have dimmed a fraction of my might with your treachery, but I am still strong enough to kill you all!"

Indigo light blazed from their hands as they lifted them in the rebels' direction. But before they could strike, both Nurma and Etana raised their own hands, and a flash of pure Light appeared, momentarily stunning Archon Lethe.

"How… ? Are you using *Lumomancy*?" Archon Lethe gasped.

"That's right, Kishar!" Nurma stated. "As you were teaching us your foul and twisted arts, we were delving into knowledge

forbidden by you! We have brought back the art of summoning Light in order to defeat you!”

Archon Lethe lowered their hands momentarily—but in a flash, raised them up to direct beams of searing energy out from their fingertips at their erstwhile minions. Nurma and Etana’s reaction was instantaneous as they once more summoned Light—this time to form a wall that blocked the deadly attack. Seeing their attack fail, Archon Lethe lowered their hands back down.

“So, what now? You wish me to leave my birth planet? Is that why you lifted the restriction on the Temple?” Archon Lethe asked.

Etana shook their head. “Originally, that was our plan, Kishar. But we don’t want to inflict your menace on the Universe—no, we will imprison you.”

Archon Lethe laughed. “What? Where? Here in the Temple of Light?”

Nurma’s face was hard as they answered. “We will destroy the House of the Penumbra and free the Temple of Light. We would not further stain its beauty by trapping you inside. No, we have another place for you—the Realm of Night. The demons there would be good company for one such as you!”

Archon’s Lethe’s eyes were instantly wide.

“NO!!!” They shrieked as they immediately bolted forward to run at the group assembled before them.

Nurma and Etana were taken aback by the sight of the god running at them, and before they could summon a defense, Archon Lethe was amongst them, throwing Nephraeh to the side in their desperate escape. The warriors amongst the group attempted to tackle their escaping quarry, but Archon Lethe was mad in their desperation to get away, giving them more significant boosts of strength. Archon Lethe fought free of the throng to run full bore down the protective Curtain set up within the halls of the Temple of Light.

“Don’t let them get away!” Cried Nurma as they and the rest of the rebels gave chase.

Making their way out of the Temple of Light, Nurma and Etana saw Archon Lethe run not for the spiral stairs that led up and out of the underground cavern but in the opposite direction.

“STOP THEM! They are going for the Skosis Lagoon!” Etana cried.

Archon Lethe was running towards the black pool in which Veth had arrived when they first kidnapped Adora from Elysia. Made of the same foul substance as the Vetala, the Skosis Lagoon was connected to every Vetala in existence, enabling their master to reach them. The assembled group of Nephraeh who bravely decided to stand against their dread god watched helplessly as Archon Lethe leaped into the obsidian waters—instantly transporting them away.

“NOOO!!!” Etana cried, leaping into the pool after Archon Lethe.

They reached under the pool's surface as if they could somehow seize Archon Lethe and haul them back to justice.

Nurma entered the Skosis Lagoon after them, not to join Etana in their fruitless search—but to pull them out. There was no telling what horrors lay under the surface.

“Etana, it’s no use,” Nurma said, reaching out to console the other Nephraeh.

“Wait! I have something!” Etana suddenly cried.

The other Nephraeh crowed around the edge of the Skosis Lagoon as Etana and Nurna heaved a figure up from the pool's depths to carry it to the edge. Confusion was on everyone’s face as they helped pull the body up and onto the shore—whoever it was, they were not Archon Lethe. They were much too small to be the deposed ruler of the Nephraeh.

“It’s a woman!” Nurma cried, seeing a female shape clothed in a skintight body suit comprised of Aegis Lace. Her face was lovely, topped with short blonde hair, and it took a moment for Nurma to recognize her face; every other time they had seen it was fixed in a cruel expression behind a jagged black mask.

“It’s Despara!” Nurma exclaimed. “She is not in her Champion form—but it’s definitely her!”

Sometimes Love Kills

Chapter Summary

> Catra lets off a little steam while Jihan grants her insight on the choices she may have to face in saving Adora from Despara.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The ten Madgēcot Star-Hunters spread out as they approached the abandoned building, sensing their quarry hiding within. Wanting to completely overwhelm their prey before rushing in to subdue them, each selected a different cantrip from their Jaadoo suit. One Star-Hunters hesitated as she activated her cantrip, looking incredulously as a senior member pulled the cantrip for Jvaala from his lower back.

"Seriously, Viraj? Are you going to use *that* on her? Isn't that a little excessive?" She exclaimed. The other Madgēcot only laughed as his heterochromatic blue and yellow eyes sparkled playfully.

"Naw, I owe her one, Aaira. Besides, I don't think anything else will stop her, do you?" Viraj answered.

Aaira looked down at the cantrip she selected; it lay like a limp rag in the palm of her hand. She grimaced, shaking her head as her ears drooped.

"Didn't think so," Viraj admonished. "Better go with the Jvaal instead,"

Aaira pulled a new cantrip from her lower back and began to ball the material with both hands; the potent spell needed more work to activate it—Star Hunters wanted to ensure that such powerful magic was not used lightly. By now, the structure was entirely

surrounded by the team of warrior Madgēcots, and there was no escape for the one inside.

"We have you now! Come out and give up!" Viraj called in the direction of the building. It was a derelict structure, old wooden walls pitted from numerous conflicts holding up a sagging roof.

Glowing eyes briefly peeked through one of the broken windows before disappearing, confirming they had the right place. Immediately, every one of the Star Hunters tensed as they sensed a low vibration coming from the direction of the shack. The feline warriors knew this was no typical tremor, their long ears perceiving a noise accompanying the sensation—a low menacing growl.

Every tail present immediately bushed up with alarm.

"You think you have me, don't you?" A cocky voice said from within the structure. Viraj looked at his fellow Star Hunters and shook his head with exasperation.

"Come on," he chided. "I mean, there are ten of us. Do we *really* need to do this?" He said as he rubbed at bruised ribs. He was still hurting from their last attempt to catch this quarry and, looking at his fellow Star Hunters, knew they also had aches and pains they did not want to add to. A Jaadoo suit could only do so much healing before its power was wholly drained.

"Yeah, Viraj, *we really need to do this,*" came the answer.

Without waiting for further discussion, Viraj threw his cantrip; it streaked through the air like a screaming ball of green fire; when it encountered the target, the dilapidated shack exploded into burning pieces.

The surrounding Madgēcots had covered their sensitive eyes in anticipation of the flash of light, not seeing the maroon blur streak up through the roof and into the air out of harm's way. A massive figure hovered over her pursuers momentarily as a black cape billowed behind gold-armored shoulders. In a split second,

heterochromatic glowing eyes selected a victim before their owner began her descent.

Hunters soon became the hunted.

Viraj looked from the burning remains of the building when he heard one of the Star Hunters cry out in alarm. Burning detritus was scattered everywhere, creating clouds of billowing smoke, which confounded the usually astute Madgēcot senses. Viraj squinted into the haze as he searched for his fellow Star Hunters.

"Krish? Was that you?" He called.

His call was answered by a flash of green light and a yelp of pain. Viraj crouched with claws held out as a figure came running towards him. As they neared, he immediately recognized Aaira as she sped through the smoke; her entire upper torso was wrapped in thick maroon bands, which she attempted to bite as she ran.

"Aaira! Come to me!" Viraj called.

The female Madgēcot tripped and fell into the ground before Viraj; she growled and writhed as she attempted to fight free of the bindings.

"She just used a restraining cantrip on me! She didn't even bother fighting me!" Aaira complained.

Viraj extended his claws fully as he ran them over the bindings holding his fellow Star Hunter, but it was of no use; the Jaadoo suit that spawned this cantrip was not the regular kind. Viraj's black nails slid harmlessly over them, not even leaving a mark.

"Why would you bring a *short tail* to face me?" A voice called out from the smoke.

Aaira's blue feline eyes widened in outrage as she bared her fangs.

“Short tail!! I advanced beyond Shikshu two months ago!” She yelled.

A cackling laugh answered the outraged Aaira as seven Star Hunters came out of the smoke; they had heard the voices of their fellows and wisely sought strength in numbers. The scattered team was now reassembled—minus the missing Krish and the disabled Aaira.

“You’re getting overconfident. Why don’t you come out of that smoke and face us? Or are you afraid of the strength of the Star Hunters?” Viraj called in a challenge.

There was no reply to his words, only the crackling sound of burning timbers. The smoke was beginning to dissipate when the Star Hunters heard the sound of large bare feet padding towards them. A prominent figure could be seen through the haze, standing straight and proud as it strode straight for them. Viraj could not help but feel a bit of trepidation as their quarry finally revealed herself; billowing smoke parted in curtains before her massive body as she flexed gold-taloned fingers. She stopped a few paces from Viraj, her cinnamon face breaking into a smug leer as her glowing heterochromatic eyes pinned her would-be pursuers.

‘Hey guys, how’s it hanging?” Sher-Va/Catra said with menace.


Ansarela

Aaira's face immediately expressed confusion as she looked up at the Madgēcot Champion.

"What the heck does that mean? 'How's it hanging?' I'm not hanging; I'm tied up!" She shouted back.

Viraj scratched his mane of stone-gray hair thoughtfully as a slight toothy grin spread across his lips.

"I think I get it," he said with a laugh, pointing down with a black claw. "It's in reference to—"

"UH, NO!" Sher-Va/Catra yelled. "I don't need my raunchy references explained back to me. *Especially* by my twin brother—thanks."

Viraj shrugged noncommittally as the other Star Hunters looked at each other confused, their furry tails twitching in unison.

"So… are we going to fight now or what?" One of the other Star Hunters asked. "I mean, you managed to wreck our training hall to the point that it will need to be completely rebuilt."

The Star Hunter waved a clawed hand, indicating the training hall around them—deep inside the belly of the starship *Satay*. Besides the smoking ruin of the dummy structures, wide grooves gouged the wood of the walls, ceiling, and floor. Many of the magic lights were also damaged; they flickered on and off, creating a disconcerting strobing effect. Obviously, the training hall was not made for a Champion.

Sher-Va/Catra grinned and nodded vigorously. "Yes, please! I need more practice before we get to Empyrea. I fought Despara, and I'm certain I can take her next time, but you never know. I mean, I'm still new to this Sher-Va thing and all. That is unless you guys are too beat up to fight me. I know Krish is…"

Sher-Va/Catra's words immediately raised nine hackles, and the Champion laughed again as she leaped away from nine different

cantrips sizzling, popping, and whistling in the space she once occupied.

Good to know I still can annoy people, Sher-Va/Catra thought as she selected the cantrip for binding in midair. As she landed, she tossed the prepared cantrip at two Star Hunters as they came for her—it activated with a popping between them, instantly binding their tails together. As they landed, the Star Hunters yowled in outrage; neither of them could make a move without yanking on the other's sensitive hind end, and they both fixated on freeing themselves.

Sher-Va-Catra shrieked with laughter, pleased with her prank. She had to be so serious recently, and it felt good to have a little fun—even at the expense of others.

We will all laugh about this later, Sher-Va/Catra thought as she threw another binding cantrip at the pair, instantly pulling them together. They both fell to the ground, still growling as Sher-Va/Catra waved a hand, releasing the cantrips at their tails.

"Four down—six more to go!" Sher-Va/Catra called with glee.

Viraj approached her with the rest of the Star Hunters in tow; all were weary as they faced the Madgēcot Champion. Her brother looked down at his bound fellows and shook his head at this sister.

"*Really, Cat-Tra?* Did you use binding cantrips on Madgēcot tails? That is a low blow," he said.

"All is fair in love and war!" Sher-Va/Catra replied as she crouched, ready for action.

Viraj's dark eyebrows raised at this sister's response, and he stood straight, tail twitching in contemplation.

"Oh, so normal rules of honor are tossed aside when facing the mighty Sher-Va? Is that what you are saying, Cat-Tra?" He asked, reaching for a cantrip at his chest.

Sher-Va/Catra snorted in derision. “Pah! Whatever! Honor, no honor. I will still—”

Sher-Va/Catra’s glowing eyes suddenly widened as she recognized the cantrip her brother was about to use.

“Oh, no! That’s too far—” She started to say but turned mid-sentence to run away.

“Star Hunters! Hydration cantrips!” Viraj commanded. As one, the remaining six Star Hunters sent their revenge whistling at the escaping Champion, hitting Sher-Va/Catra in multiple locations to thoroughly drench her in water.

“Arrrggghhh!!!” She cried, shaking her body vigorously in an attempt to remove the hated liquid from her fur. The Star Hunters laughed in unison at their handy work, leaping back just in time to miss being hit by flying droplets as Sher-Va/Catra shook her voluminous mane dry. The Madgēcot Champion scowled at the Star Hunters as a low growl emanated from her chest.

“Oh, come now, Cat-Tra!” Viraj chided. “You said it yourself; all’s fair. We were just trying to level the playing field!”

Sher-Va/Catra tilted her head suddenly as an idea came forth. Her brother recognized the look for what it was—more mischief.

“Oh, no. I thought we made our point, Cat-Tra!” Viraj exclaimed as he held up his hands in an attempt to ward away further misfortune.

“No one out ‘dirty-tricks’ me!” His sister exclaimed, pulling off a cantrip and tossing it with a jerk of her wrist in one smooth motion. The six Star Hunters were standing in a group as the missile sped towards them, but none of them bothered to run—they perceived its nature from its origination on Sher-Va/Catra’s Jaadoo suit. Every single one of them winced with lowered ears as it exploded to shower them all in rainbow sparks. It was the Chakra Block—the Star Hunter’s answer to foes powerful in magic. Since none of the Madgēcots there were innately magical by

themselves, it affected the only other thing that was—their Jaadoo suits.

The Star Hunters looked down as the individual strips of their outfits lost cohesion, falling from their bodies like dead leaves to collect into round balls—the dormant state of all Jaadoo suits. Instead of being embarrassed by their sudden nudity, the Star Hunters only looked annoyed.

"Really, *Mahat?*" One of them exclaimed as she crossed her arms. "You think this will stop us from fighting?"

Sher-Va/Catra chuckled. "I didn't do it to stop the fighting—only for laughs!"

A loud and authoritative voice suddenly broke throughout the training hall, interrupting Sher-Va/Catra's fun.

"WHAT IN THE NAME OF THE GREAT CHAILANDRA IS GOING ON IN HERE!!!"

All eyes turned to see Aadhya standing in the open doorway to the training hall, hands on hips as her tail wagged furiously.

"This training hall is completely ruined, and I'm looking at Star Hunters out of uniform! As the senior member of this group, there better be a good explanation for this outrage, Viraj!" She continued to shout.

Viraj's long black ears lowered as he looked down, shamefaced, as the rest of the group quickly kneeled to pick up their outfits. One of the Star Hunters tossed Viraj his outfit, which he accepted gratefully. By now, the limiting effects of the Chakra Block had faded, and with whispered command, the Star Hunters were back in their Jaadoo suits.

"Where are the rest of you? There should be ten; all I see is six!" Aadhya said, peering around with angry yellow eyes.

“Over here, Pratham!” Said a Madgēcot, still bound by cantrips and lying on the ground.

“Here too!” Said Aaira as she wriggled on the ground.

That was enough for the Pratham; she took one look at the helpless Star Hunters and hissed.

“Clean this up by the end of today’s cycle,” she said before turning and walking out of the training hall. Viraj looked worriedly at his fellows and sighed.

“Let’s get to work,” he said.

“What!?” Sher-Va/Catra yelled. “What about my training?”

The other Madgēcots scoffed at this.

“Yeah, right, and risk making even more of a mess of this place?” Viraj said, waving his hand at the state of the training hall. “Come on, Cat-Tra. We are going to need Sher-Va’s help cleaning this up,”

Sher-Va/Catra rolled her eyes as she watched her brother walk away. Waving a golden clawed gauntlet, she released the four Madgēcots she had bound—once freed, they joined the others who had begun to pick up the wreckage. Sher-Va/Catra watched Aaira and three others form a square as they held out construction cantrips. As they backed up slowly, a new structure gradually formed out of thin air; it was a complete copy of the one in which Sher-Va/Catra hid and Viraj destroyed.

“Humph!” Sher-Va/Catra exclaimed to no one. “I’ve got better things to do than clean up messes! I think I will leave that up to you guys!”

That is very arrogant of you, Cat-Tra. It is not befitting the bearer of Sher-Va.

Sher-Va/Catra rolled her eyes at the voice of Jihan scolding her.

Oh great, just what I needed. The naggy ghost in my head just woke up to start lecturing me. She thought to him.

I was not asleep; I saw that whole farce from within your thick head. You wasted an excellent opportunity to train for your upcoming trial to play pranks and make fools of your fellow Madgēcots. Well done, Cat-Tra.

Sher-Va/Catra kicked at the ground angrily, sending a piece of charred wood spinning away. She knew Jihan was right—she just hated having to admit it.

"Oh, come on! I mean, do I really need more training? I faced Despara before and almost had her! What more do I need to know?" Sher-Va/Catra said out loud, gaining strange looks from the Star Hunters.

She instantly regretted asking the question as she heard Jihan give a heavy sigh within her mind.

As you know, there are no guarantees when it comes to battle. You could defeat her and use your Truth upon her, or she could kill you—like what happened to me.

Sher-Va/Catra gritted her teeth at Jihan's words; she could not imagine what it was like to have been killed, knowing that you failed and the love of your life would remain a monster for all time. Once again, she felt great sorrow for the last bearer of Sher-Va and decided she had better listen to him.

Fine. You are right—as usual. I'm just new to this Champion thing and let myself get carried away. I guess I should be more aware of what I am doing, especially if I don't want to make the same mistakes as when I was Force Captain. She thought.

Much better. I am thrilled the bearer of Sher-Va has a free spirit—like I did. I just don't want what happened to me to happen to you, Cat-Tra. That is all.

Sher/Va-Catra allowed herself a small smile—admit it not, she liked having Jihan's spirit looking out for her. Someone who had her back was a quality Catra greatly valued in another person—it was one of the many reasons she loved Adora so much. It was something she lacked in her adopted mother—Shadow Weaver.

I am glad you are listening to me now, for I have to tell you something vital: you must not go to Empyrea. You must not face Archon Lethe.

"WHAT!?" Sher-Va/Catra cried aloud. Now the Star Hunters stopped their repairs to look at each other and their Champion with concern.

"Uh, should we call someone? Perhaps a healer?" Aaira whispered to Jihan.

"It's fine, it's fine. It's just the past bearer of Sher-Va speaking to my sister inside her head. Happens all the time," he replied, gaining a worried look from the other Star Hunter.

"Going to Empyrea is the point of all this! How else am I going to get Adora back? Plus, the entire Madgēcot fleet is on their way there, and I'm on one of the ships—stop talking crazy, Jihan!" Sher-Va/Catra yelled.

Yes, yes. I know there is no stopping my people once they have their minds set on something. You have also made great strides in mending the wound between the Madgēcots and the Nephraeh; together, they are a force to be reckoned with. But, you must not face Archon Lethe by yourself. Even if—WHEN you get your Adora back and have She-Ra by your side, it will not be enough.

Then what is enough, Jihan? What more do I need than Adora? Sher-Va/Catra thought. She was starting to feel frustrated with the ghost of Jihan.

Nothing less than all seven Champions of Grayskull is what is needed to face a god, for a god is what my Kishar

has become.

Sher-Va/Catra felt like slumping to the ground. She had heard Glimmer mention that Archon Lethe could be a potent being—but a god—that was staggering. On top of that, she would need six other Champions fighting by her side to take them down; where to begin? Shen was dead, and so was Veth; there was no telling if their Champion spirits were binding to new bearers at this very minute or were lost for all time. Supposedly Archon Lethe had the power sword of He-Ro—how was she going to fight them for it when it was what she needed to fight them? That left two more Champions she didn't even know about or have a clue how she would find them.

The task was just too big.

I must *concentrate on getting Adora back—the rest will come later.* Sher-Va/Catra thought to herself.

Yes, but what if you must face both Archon Lethe and Despara simultaneously? What then?

Anger bloomed inside her at Jihan's words; she was getting frustrated with his naysaying.

Do you have any good suggestions, then? Because so far, all you seem to have is reasons for me to give up! Why don't you give me something to work with Jihan? Sher-Va/Catra thought angrily.

The ghost inside her head was quiet for a moment, then after giving a sigh of resignation, spoke.

Yes, I think it's time I show you how I died. It is also the moment Kishar became what they are now. It isn't easy for me, but I think it may give you some perspective on what you may face.

Show me? Sher-Va/Catra thought back, confused, but she soon understood what he meant as her vision suddenly changed.

Her glowing eyes widened, for, from her perspective, she was speeding down a long dark tunnel streaked with colorful lights. Looking closely at these lights, she saw they were specific recollections, all jumbled together from a lifetime of memories. There was one in particular that she noticed right away; the darkest and most brooding of all—that was her destination.

A strange sense of vertigo passed over Sher-Va/Catra's consciousness as she passed into this memory and slid into another's body.

This body is not her own, but it is familiar to her, for she had inhabited it during another vision granted to her by the power of Sher-Va. It is Jihan from a millennia ago, and Catra settles into his form as she adjusts to what she is seeing. He is striding down a bright hall; the walls, floor, and ceiling are comprised of perfectly fitted stone blocks. Each one is white and gleaming—as if they were made of pure sugar—giving Sher-Va/Catra the sense she is in a place that exemplifies virtue and empathy. Between each stone is a slight golden glimmer—as if the richest of materials was used as mere mortar—but Catra feels something else is holding this place together. Suddenly someone is speaking.

"You better not try and stop me this time, Jihan," the speaker says.

Turning to look at them, she sees a severe-looking woman of a species she had never seen before. She is covered in a dark robe with only her face and hands exposed. Her skin is covered in teal and green scales; they are jagged and sharp looking, becoming more pronounced at her hairline and forming into large quills that sweep back over her head. Yellow reptile eyes glare at Catra angrily as the woman waves a staff at her, the top of which holds a crimson gem that glows with dark power. The implied threat is obvious.

"Don't threaten me, Dinala. The galaxy may be in a state of chaos, but we are still supposed to be on the same side here," Jihan says.

Dinala laughs; it is a raspy and sibilant sound, not at all friendly or reassuring, and Sher-Va/Catra can feel Jihan's tail begin to bush up.

"I have not heard from my fellows in the League of Kalosyni in weeks—they could be all dead, or worse—on the side of Horde Prime. I think that allows me a certain amount of leeway in my actions," Dinala says with a cruel smile.

Catra can sense Jihan's thoughts; he does not like his companion, nor had he ever. Dinala is a necessary evil, for she is a bearer of a Staff of Power—The Void Gem—and he would need her help if he is going to defeat Kishar.

"Just remember where we are, Dinala. This is a Temple to the Light, and there are Nephraeh here—plus refugees—I'm sure. Kishar has probably lied to them about our intentions, so we must not hurt anyone." Jihan says.

Dinala shrugs at this and pushes on ahead of him as she holds her staff out. Catra feels anger within Jihan, and he shouts his words of activation.

"BY THE TRUTH OF GRAYSKULL!!"

Dinala whirls around as Jihan ascends to his Champion form, holding her staff with the Void Gem pointed in his direction. With his enhanced Madgēcot reflexes, Sher-Va/Jihan is faster than her—he sends a cantrip whizzing in her direction. It transforms into tan-colored bindings, which pin Dinala's arms to her torso, and she drops her staff. With a furious hiss, she charges at Sher-Va/Jihan, mouth opened with rows of serrated teeth to bite him. Sher-Va/Jihan sends another restraining cantrip at his erstwhile ally, this time to wrap her legs, and she falls with a growl.

"You fool! How are you going to take Kishar without me!" She screams, writhing like a snake on the floor.

"I would rather take that chance than side with someone like you," Sher-Va/Jihan says sorrowfully. He turns from her to

continue down the beautiful corridor as she shouts at his back.

"I HOPE THEY KILL YOU! YOU DESERVE IT!" Dinala shouts at his back.

Sher-Va/Jihan glances back at his old comrade and shakes his head.

"For everyone's sake, you better hope I succeed." He whispers back to her.

Sher-Va/Jihan turns from the bound bearer of the Void Gem, continuing his journey through the sacred Temple to the Light. Catra can feel the other's trepidation as he pads down the corridor; slowly, the radiance of the walls starts to dim—as if something is acting opposite to the building's nature. Something terrible is happening further down in the bowels of the Temple, and Sher-Va/Jihan is sure that is where he will find Kishar.

The passage suddenly dips down, plummeting deep into the ground at a sixty-degree angle, becoming too slanted to gain purchase—even with Sher-Va/Jihan's clawed feet. Thankfully, stairs are constructed over the floor, allowing him to descend without falling down the shaft. Being a native of a planet where trees are part of everyday life, Sher-Va/Jihan recognizes wood planks under his bare feet. As he makes his way down, the stairs become wet and spongy, as if they are decomposing the deeper he goes. A rot is taking root in the Temple to the Light, and Sher-Va/Jihan instantly knows its source—evil.

A slow creaking sound of protest emanates from below his feet, letting Sher-Va/Jiahn know the structural stability of the staircase is failing. He tries to go as slowly and carefully as his enhanced bulk will allow, but soon, with a loud crack, the staircase gives out completely, and Sher-Va/Jihan plummets down into uncertainty. He knows he could probably stop his fall by inserting his claws between the small gaps in the wall, but Sher-Va/Jihan does not do this; he is ready to face what is below.

The shaft suddenly veers straight down as Sher-Va/Jihan crashes through the remains of a spiral staircase; he freefalls through the open air before crashing painfully to the ground, hitting his head in the process. Catra feels jarring pain all over her subconscious body in sympathy with her host, and Sher-Va/Jihan's vision is blurry as he tries and takes in his surroundings.

Sher-Va/Jihan is in a large room or hall, and he immediately knows it is the Haiden of the shine— the place where the Light is venerated at the Heart of the Temple. Murals line the walls of this place, depicting deeds of love and virtue. Sher-Va/Jihan immediately recognizes the scene depicting Aurelia and Kiera, the first bearers of She-Ra and Thon-Ra, during their Ceremony of Bonding. It was their love that helped turn the tide against evil during the end of the Dark Times thousands of years ago.

He turns from the murals to see the double doors of the main gate closed and barred; he and Dinala had tried that way before going through the secondary entrance after they could not open the doors. They knew that it must be locked closed against their intrusion, with the majority of Nephraeh and refugees hiding within. Worry came over Sher-Va/Jihan as he thought of the innocents trapped inside, made more intense by the intense smell that hit his sensitive nose. Turning slowly, Sher-Va/Jihan saw that his fear was well-founded.

Bodies littered the floor, perhaps over a hundred; they were a mix of different races which had come to this place from all over the galaxy, looking for succor. Each one appeared to have been dispatched with a sword, indicated by a bloody bisection in the victim's torso. Whoever had done it had absolutely no pity as they coldly culled each person one after the other.

Here and there, Sher-Va/Jihan recognized the clothing of Nephraeh; they were empty, telling him that the keepers of this shine were not saved from the same fate as the refugees. Because of their mystical nature, Nephraeh dissipate into ethereal energy upon death, which then flows into the background magic

of the universe. The clothes on the ground were all that was left of them.

Lifting his eyes slowly from the bodies, Sher-Va/Jihan looked to the altar of the Haiden; a stone dais held five statues of Nephraeh aloft, each intricately and lovingly carved. Sher-Va/Jihan's feline eyes widened as he saw the middle sculpture in the middle was not just any Nephraeh but a representation of Zhe-La. This was not only a Temple to the Light but one that also celebrated the Champion of the Light. Catra felt immense sadness in Sher-Va/Jihan as he realized the irony of this fact, especially now that he spotted the architect of all this ruin.

Kishar was kneeling right next to the representation of Zhe-La in their Champion form. Their hand, once pure white, was now stained dark with the blood of innocents as they held a massive sword in their lap. Zhe-La/Kishar's helmeted head was bowed as if in contemplation as they continued to sit in silence—it was as if they were meditating on what they had done—or preparing themselves for a particular task.

"Kishar! What have you done?!" Sher-Va/Jihan shouts.

Zhe-La/Kishar finally responds, raising their head and opening their golden eyes to look at the one they once loved. A wry smile appears on white lips as they stand, and Sher-Va/Jihan quails at the sight of them.

Zhe-La/Kishar has fallen into darkness and has done terrible deeds, but to look at them, it is as if they are still the same person he had fallen in love with. They are still lovely in their white armor, which clings to their lithe body, almost like a body suit. What parts of their face Sher-Va/Jihan can see through their helmet is still beautiful—their long hair pulled into a top knot at the crown of the helmet, it gleams like a beacon in the room's light.

"Jihan, you've finally tracked me down." Zhe-La/Kishar says as they step down from the dais. "Where is the lovely Dinala Katan

and her Void Gem? You're going to need her if you're going to fight me."

"I—" Sher-Va/Jihan starts to say but then looks around at all the bodies. He realizes that he had foolishly left behind the added protection of Dinala—all to protect those who do not need any protection.

Zhe-La/Kishar laughs at his hesitation; it is almost a kind laugh, the typical laugh of a Nephraeh who does it not to mock but to lift you into joy with them. But the hard edge in Zhe-La/Kishar's golden eyes tells a different story—one of cruelty and malice.

"What's the matter, my love?" They say in mockery. "Cat got your tongue?"

The old, shared joke has its intended effect, biting at Sher-Va/Jihan's heart with the memory of love lost, of a harmonious relationship that will never be whole again. He grits his teeth against the pain and grips his sword tightly, raising it against his former love.

"I'm here to stop you, Kishar." Sher-Va/Jihan says, earning another laugh from the other.

Zhe-La/Kishar glides over to him, making sure to lift their white boots to step gingerly over the bodies while smiling radiantly.

"And how are you going to do that, my love? With that clunky Power Sword?" They say as they point a stained finger at his sword. Sher-Va/Jihan sees that Zhe-La/Kishar's sword is vibrant with magical energy and not bound to any arcane object. He realizes that Zzar must have faked binding the power of Zhe-La to their Power Sword, and Kishar had been carrying a fake this whole time. That is how Zhe-La/Kishar had almost defeated him in their last encounter; their Champion power was unrestricted and pure. Sher-Va/Kishar realizes that his situation is very dire indeed.

"Why have you done this, Kishar? I know you no longer feel compassion, but this is just murder! What is the point?" Sher-

Va/Jihan implores, hoping to delay the upcoming conflict a moment more.

Zhe-La/Kishar purses their lips as if this is a question to contemplate, and they wave their sword at the bodies.

"Their deaths serve a purpose, my dear Jihan. You see, up until now, their lives were meaningless—here they are, hiding under a rock as great events unfold around them. Through them, I will ascend. Perhaps it is fortuitous that you came; I will add your death to the tally, strengthening the power of the Apogean Ritual."

"The WHAT?!" Sher-Va/Jihan exclaims. "I've never heard of such madness! The Shlihm-bess'a-rune has taken your sanity as well as your empathy!"

Zhe-La/Kishar shrugs. "I don't need your belief—just your blood!!!"

Sher-Va/Jihan brings his sword up just in time to block the other Champion's sword as Zhe-La/Kishar leaps at him, looking to kill the Madgēcot Champion with one blow. It seems that Zhe-La/Kishar simply wants an end to this exchange as quickly as possible—perhaps in boredom or impatience to partake in their mad ritual.

Sher-Va/Jihan pushes the other away, following up with a strike of his own which Zhe-La/Kishar easily bats away. Catra can feel the power of the other Champion through the connection; it is marginally greater than Sher-Va/Jihan's own, just enough to tip the scales in any fight. She finds herself wishing that somehow Zhe-La/Kishar breaks the Power Sword during their exchanges, thus freeing the power of Sher-Va and leveling the playing field. But Catra knows this is just a memory, and Sher-Va/Jihan's fate was sealed a millennia ago.

"Poor Jihan," Zhe-La/Kishar says with a pout. "You see now, don't you? My power is unadulterated and unbound. You should just

give up and let me kill you. I mean, can't you just do that for me? For old time's sake?"

This time the giggle that escapes Zhe-La/Kishar's lips is cruel, making Sher-Va/Jihan's Madgēcot blood boil with fury. This anger act as an ignition point, awakening the power of his Champion Avatar, and green fire pours from Sher-Va/Jihan's eyes. The laughter ends as trepidation appears on Zhe-La/Kisha's face; they recognize what this means and back away from the Madgēcot Champion.

"My power may be bound, Kishar, but I have something you do not. It is something you have lost on your path to evil. THE TRUTH!" Sher-Va/Jihan shouts as he rushes the other Champion.

Absolute terror is now on Zhe-La/Kishar's face as they hold up their sword two-handed in a ward against Sher-Va/Jihan's weapon —but that look changes to surprise as he drops his Power Sword to seize their wrists in his claws.

"NOO!!!" Zhe-La/Kishar shrieks as they struggle in his grip. They drop one of their hands from the pommel of the sword in an attempt to push Sher-Va/Jihan away, but his grip is strong, and the fire in his eyes travels down to his arms and toward his intended victim.

Catra realizes this is the same thing that happened when she last faced Despara and knows what Sher-Va/Jihan was about to attempt; freeing Zhe-La/Kishar from their darkness to bring them back to the Light. That is the only way he will defeat them now.

Catra senses the power of Sher-Va's truth entering Zhe-La/Kishar's body from the contact at their wrist—but it is not enough—he needs a different access point. Sher-Va/Jihan also senses this and, letting go of one of Zhe-La/Kishar's wrists, places one of his hands on their face. Zhe-La/Kishar instantly screams as the emerald fire of Truth surges into them now, filling their body and soul so completely that green flames pour out of their mouth and eyes.

But still, it is not enough. He needs to use his other hand, which is still holding Zhe-La/Kishar's sword arm and keeping them from striking him. Catra feels the effects of Sher-Va's Truth on Zhe-La/Kisha begin to slip—soon, they will break free of Sher-Va/Jihan's hold. She can sense that Sher-Va/Jihan also realizes this fact; he knows what he must do and what must be sacrificed to save Kishar.

Sher-Va/Jihan lets go of Zhe-La/Kishar's wrist and places that hand on their face, strengthening the effects of the Truth. Instantly the tide is turned in his favor as the taint of absolute apathy is slowly driven out of Zhe-La/Kishar's soul—it was working.

Both Sher-Va/Jiahn and Catra scream as a searing pain stabs within their belly, the pain of which travels up to their chest as the blade is cruelly drawn up their body in a complete evisceration. Sher-Va/Jihan drops his hands from the other's face as a grateful sigh expels from Zhe-La/Kishar's lips.

"So close, my love, so close. But in the end, you fail." They say as the sword is twisted and yanked from his body.

Sher-Va/Jihan falls to the ground as darkness closes in on Catra's vision, and soon there is nothing.

Catra jolted upright, immediately feeling hands and arms on her body as they tried to restrain her.

"NOO!!" She shrieked as tears of pain and sorrow poured from her eyes.

"Cat-Tra! It's okay! It's me, Viraj!" Her brother implored.

Catra found herself gazing into her brother's opposite heterochromatic eyes as relief poured over her. She was in his arms as the Star Hunters in the training hall crowded around them, worry plastered on their faces. Catra could still feel the phantom pain of a mortal stab wound in her belly and chest, and she clutched at it, moaning in sympathetic agony. Seeing this,

Viraj placed his hands over his sister's, and the other Madgēcots likewise placed their hands on different points of Catra's body as they began to purr.

"It's okay, Cat-Tra. It's okay. Whatever that was—it's over. You are okay." Viraj soothed.

Catra could feel the agony fade as her people's soothing washed over her; likewise, she began to purr in an attempt at self-calming.

"I ha—had a vision, Viraj. Of when Jihan… died." Catra said.

Viraj nodded as he gently brushed her hair away from her face.

"I hope it was worth this, Cat-Tra. I hope it was worth this pain you are feeling." He said.

Catra nodded as she felt for the presence of Jihan within her soul. He was still there, tucked away and quiet—sullen—from reliving the experience of his death. Catra hoped that Jihan could feel the comfort she was receiving and giving, for the last bearer of Sher-Va had gone one-thousand years without it.

"Thank you, Jihan. Thank you." She whispered.

The perspective he had just shared with her was invaluable, for it prepared Catra for what she may face. When they finally did make it to Empyrea, and Catra had her chance to confront Despara, she too may have to make the choice Jihan once did; let Despara continue and live or save Adora and die.

Catra knew which she would choose.

Chapter End Notes

Sher-Va/Catra illustration by Ansdrela on Twitter, Instagram, and Tumblr.

Sacrifice, Part II

Chapter Summary

The Madgecots finally make it to Empyrea.

The time has come for Despara to answer for what she has done.

Can Catra save Adora and live to see her wife again?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The planet slowly came into focus on the holographic display; what was at first a fuzzy dot slowly blossomed into an orb of rich life lightly covered by clouds. Based on all the other instances Glimmer viewed this planet during her meditations, she was expecting a dank and vile place. But the planet Empyrea was not that dark vision; it was a magical planet whose beauty could rival that of Etheria.

The Captain of the *Satay* reached out and spun the hologram of Empyrea around, giving Glimmer a clear view of the rest of the planet. Vast blue oceans surrounded five continents dotting the equator, each one connected via a land bridge, forming a chain or necklace around the homeworld of the Nephraeh. Captain Kailash pointed a clawed finger at a location on one of the continents, and the image zoomed in on a vast mountain range. Nestled amongst these peaks was a city, and Captain Kailash focused everyone's attention there.

"This is the city of Nox—the capital of the Empyrean Empire and the seat of Archon Lethe. It is our main goal; if we take this city, the rest of the planet will fall in line." He said.

"Isn't that a little direct?" Bow interjected. "The capital will be the most heavily defended; perhaps we should work on the outlying

regions first?”

Glimmer smiled at her husband’s suggestion; Bow was always so level-headed. Based on the reactions of the others on the *Satay’s* bridge, many were not in agreement.

Aadhya nodded sagely at the idea while Catra crossed her arms, shaking her head. Glimmer was sure her friend was eager to get to the capital; it was the obvious place to find Despara. Glimmer was not willing to go charging into enemy territory based on her friend’s impatience—but neither was she ready to broach that subject with Catra.

“I could create a bunch of robots that could be dispersed throughout the planet from space. Once in position, they could broadcast morale-dampening messages while playing nonstop loud music. After weeks of that, I’m sure they would give up peacefully!” Entrapta ventured.

Glimmer smiled to herself—not at Entrapta’s suggestion—but at the fact that the tech-mad Princess was back to her old self. After seeing how well her Truth power worked on Rishi, Catra immediately used it on Entrapta and restored her empathy. Entrapta’s non-violent suggestion was proof of that, albeit not the best course of action. They needed to act fast to end this quickly—who knew what Archon Lethe was up to down there?

“I can supply an endless stream of Sea Shanties for your robots to broadcast, Entrapta!” Seahawk said, puffing up his chest. “I will win over the enemy through song!”

“Or they will just all do themselves in to escape your voice,” Catra said with a grin.

Seahawk gave a bark of laughter, slapping Catra playfully on the back. Glimmer was surprised that Catra did not react violently at his touch—although her tail twitched rapidly.

“I would be interested in what our Nephraeh friends have to say. What about it, Ninurta?” Glimmer said, waving a hand at the

Gnosis Operative.

After the surrender of the Empyrean fleet to the Madgēcots, the Nephraeh had become invaluable to the mission, providing much-needed intel on the infrastructure of Archon Lethe's empire. Glimmer was surprised to see how quickly the Madgēcots and Nephraeh started working together, almost as if they had never been enemies and were always dear allies.

Ninurta nodded gracefully to Glimmer before beginning.

"According to the plans of our rebellion, all communication systems were to be severed prior to our insurrection. That way, those unaware of our plans could not coordinate and react in time when we struck. We had to keep our rebellion small to avoid notice from our tyrant of a ruler, and we did not want to fight our own people to depose Archon Lethe. Unfortunately, we cannot locate our fellows on Empyrea, and we do not know what is going on at this time. But the fact that there is no communication is evidence enough that the full-scale rebellion had begun." Ninurta said.

Aadhya pursed her lips as she considered this.

"Even if Archon Lethe retains control of Empyrea, the fact the communications systems are silent is conducive to a swift strike. As commander of the Madgēcot Star-Hunters, I say we go directly for Nox." She said, jabbing a clawed finger into the three-dimensional representation of the city, making it flash red.

"I'm with you, Pratham," Catra said, giving the older woman a toothy smile.

Glimmer gave a long sigh before responding. She looked at Entrapta, Bow, and Seahawk—they all gave her small nods, telling her they would follow whatever she decided.

"We are with you as well, Pratham. Etheria will see this done," she said.

* * *

Sher-Va/Catra's glowing heterochromatic eyes peered through the forward viewport of the Star Hunter flyer as it sped over the frozen, jagged peaks. She was searching for the first sign of the city where so much of her future would be decided, out there amongst the swirling frozen mountain mists. It helped Sher-Va/Catra to do this, for the alternative was to stew on the vision granted to her by Jihan—if she let it, the death of Jihan would play out over and over in her mind. But instead of Kishar holding the sword, it would be Despara plunging the black blade into Sher-Va/Catra's stomach—just as she was about to get Adora back.

Just because that happened to Jihan doesn't mean it will happen to me. Sher-Va/Catra told herself for the hundredth time.

Catching her mind straying back to the niggling doubt, Sher-Va/Catra forced herself to focus on the task ahead. But try as she might, Sher-Va/Catra couldn't shake the image from her mind; it tormented her with the possibility that even if she could get Adora back, Sher-Va/Catra may not be alive to enjoy it.

As long as Adora is okay, nothing else matters, she told herself—but then instantly had to shut her eyes against the tears threatening to spill out. The mere thought of Adora returning only to find her wife dead was too much to bear, and Sher-Va/Catra gritted her teeth as waves of grief washed over her.

Easy, Cat-Tra. Easy. It will be okay. I showed you that vision not to torment you but to prepare you—so you don't end up like me.

Jihan's words bolstered Sher-Va/Catra's resolve momentarily, and she was once again thankful to have his council—even though it was occasionally unwelcome.

I know, Jihan, and I appreciate your sharing such a painful memory. I can't stop dwelling on it—I'm sorry! Sher-Va/Catra

thought back to him. Jihan was silent for a moment before speaking again, and when he did, it was very reluctant—as if he were giving something up in order to say it.

Cat-Tra, even if you fail and Despara kills you while retaining her evil ways, that does not mean you will never see Adora again. You might not see her in this life, but you will see her—I promise.

Sher-Va/Catra felt a slight shiver pass over her, making all her fur stand on end. At that moment, she knew she had become privy to a great secret from the beyond—and just as was intended—it filled her with great comfort.

But that does not mean this life does not matter, Cat-Tra! It does, and you must do everything in your power to stamp out evil wherever you find it—especially since you are a Champion. That means ending Despara's dark reign; not only is Despara standing in the way of getting Adora back, but she is a corruption of the She-Ra Avatar—that must not continue!

Sher-Va/Catra finally let a few tears fall as peace suffused her body, and she smiled, nodding in agreement to the long-dead Champion of Grayskull.

"I will do it, no matter the cost," she whispered aloud to Jihan.

Feeling a hand gently clasp her gauntlet, Sher-Va/Catra looked down to see Glimmer gazing up at her, concern in her sparkly eyes.

"It will be okay, Catra. I promise." Her friend said up to her.

Sher-Va/Catra wiped the tears from her eyes as she laughed brightly.

"I know," she said, still smiling. "Everything will be just fine."

Glimmer looked confused momentarily as Sher-Va/Catra gave her hand a gentle squeeze before turning back to the forward viewport. There she observed a dark blotch slowly appearing through the veil of clouds, and as the flyer neared, the vast city of Nox appeared. It was nestled between four different peaks, situated on a plateau excavated into the very foundation of the mountains. No walls surrounded the city, but a faint haze encompassed it, indicating a forcefield against invaders or an environmental envelope to protect the city from harsh mountain weather.

The capital of Empyrea I remember is completely gone. I don't recognize this place. Instead of warm and inviting, this city is... cold. Jihan said inside Sher-Va/Catra's head.

Sher-Va/Catra immediately noticed the ordered symmetry of the metropolis, and it grated against her Madgēcot sensibilities; straight lines ran parallel or perpendicular to each other, and every angle was ninety degrees. It confused Sher-Va/Catra that the Nephraeh lived here, for it seemed suppressive—but perhaps that was the nature of the home of Archon Lethe—everything they did was to dampen the spirit of the Nephraeh race. She found another feature of the capital odd; it was almost like it was raised on a platform or sitting upon another structure. Like another city was buried under the darker one.

The most prominent features of Nox were two vast structures situated on opposite sides of the city, connected by a large boulevard. One was a large white dome, the only circular building in the city, and the other was a blocky edifice with four tower-like pillars at each corner. It appeared the latter had suffered damage recently; massive holes gouged the exterior, surrounded by scaffolding. Figures could be seen outside this building, presumably performing the work of the building's reconstruction.

"That would be the House of the Penumbra," a voice said next to Sher-Va/Catra.

She looked down to see Ninurta indicating the building she had been studying with a lilac finger.

"Looks like it was damaged during your rebellion. Since your people are repairing it, maybe Archon Lethe is still in control?" Glimmer commented.

Ninurta frowned at this, focusing on the House of the Penumbra for their silver eyes. After a moment, they smiled and shook their head.

"Not everything is as it appears, Queen Glimmer. I don't think my people are rebuilding it," they said, finally.

Before anyone could question their statement, Ninurta glided over to the flyer's pilot, pointing down where the long road met the House of the Penumbra.

"We should land down there. That is where the leaders of our rebellion—Nurma and Etana—will most likely be," they said.

The Madgēcot piloting the flyer nodded and lifted her arm to speak into their wrist's glowing yellow communication cantrip.

"All Star Hunter craft; we have identified a landing site—mark six-oh-seven-niner. Be aware of any hostile threat and keep your ears on a swivel—over." She said in a clipped fashion.

Everyone held tightly to support rails or straps as the flyer suddenly banked around the House of the Penumbra; Sher-Va/Catra could see a large group of figures leave the monolithic building to watch the invaders come in for a landing. They formed into a crowd at the foot of a long flight of stairs proceeding down from the House of the Penumbra, looking up at the Madgēcot flyers with glittering eyes.

"Let's hope they are friendly," Bow muttered as the flyer hovered in mid-air to begin its landing descent.

Sher-Va/Catra noticed Seahawk give a nervous chuckle in agreement as Entrapta attempted to stand on her tippy toes to look out the nearest viewport. The diminutive Princess may have had her empathy restored, but she was still the same overly enthusiastic seeker of knowledge she had always been.

With a gentle bob, the flyer touched down, and the side hatches immediately opened to dispel Star-Hunters; they leaped out, cantrips at the ready. Sher-Va/Catra's friends were right behind the Madgēcots, with Glimmer, Bow, and Seahawk wielding their signature weapons as Entrapta pulled out a recording device. Sher-Va/Catra hesitated momentarily as Ninurta followed the others; when the Nephraeh realized she did not follow, they turned to her with their head tilted coyly.

"Welcome back to Empyrea, Sher-Va. Come," they said, beckoning with their hand.

Sher-Va/Catra sighed heavily and followed Ninurta out of the flyer and into the bright Empyrean day. She immediately noticed that it was not cold but a mild, comfortable temperature, indicating that the earlier assertion that the city was surrounded by an environmental shield was valid. Crisp mountain scent wafting through the air combined with the four shining mountain peaks hovering above the city were the only indications that they were at a high elevation.

"Cat-Tra!" A familiar voice called. Sher-Va/Catra turned to see her brother exit a nearby flyer; by now, over one hundred flyers had landed on the broad avenue which bisected the city. He ran over on all fours to stand beside her, his tail twitching excitedly.

"Can you believe it! We are the first Madgēcots to step on Empyrea in a thousand years!" He said with shining heterochromatic eyes.

Sher-Va/Catra gave her brother a weak smile; she was having difficulty sharing his enthusiasm—not with dread in her belly sitting there like a lead weight.

Turning, she spotted the crowd which had observed their landing making their way to the newcomers, with two robed Nephraeh at the fore. There was no hostility in the approaching figures, only smiles and open faces, but the Star Hunters remained alert on guard, not moving from their positions. The crowd of Nephraeh finally stopped their approach twenty paces away from the Madgēcots, and Empyreans and Elysians regarded each other, neither making the first move in fear of provoking the other. Eventually, Ninurta stepped forward to greet the Nephraeh, heading straight for the robed couple; Sher-Va/Catra followed the Knosis Operative with her friends and brother in tow. Aadhya had also appeared out of the crowd of Madgēcots; the leader of the Star Hunters was keen on being present at this historic meeting.

Ninurta was sharing a warm embrace with the two robed Nephraeh as Sher-Va/Catra approached, clearing her throat loudly.

"I assume you are Etana and Nurma, the leaders and representatives of the City of Nox?" She asked in her most important-sounding voice.

Before answering, the two Nephraeh looked up at Sher-Va/Catra with surprise and wonder on their attractive faces.

"You must be Catra, the new bearer of Sher-Va." One of the robed Nephraeh said. "You are right on one count; I am Etana, and this is Nurma," they said, laying a hand on their fellow's shoulder.

"But we are not the representatives of the City of Nox—no, we are the representatives of the City of *Lumos!*" Etana continued.

Cheers suddenly erupted from the crowd of Nephraeh, confusing Sher-Va/Catra.

"It's what this city used to be called," Viraj said next to her helpfully. "Before Archon Lethe and the Empyrean Empire,"

"The handsome Madgēcot is right," Nurma said with a smile, making Viraj blush. "We have reclaimed much in a short amount

of time—soon, old Empyrea will be restored, and the Light will shine upon the universe once more!”

More cheers sounded before Nurma and Etana turned to Aadhya; they both kneeled humbly before the Pratham as Etana began to speak formally.

“But before we do that, a reckoning must take place. As representatives of not only the City of Lumos but as representatives of all of Empyrea, we surrender ourselves to the mercy of the Elysians. We will not make excuses for our actions, nor do we expect forgiveness—but you should know, the Nephraeh of the past thousand years are no more. Our compassion has returned, and with that, our Light. As soon as we realized Archon Lethe’s false light was wrong, we revolted against them. From now on, the Nephraeh will only stand for good and virtue.”

Sher-Va/Catra could not help remembering seeing this display before when Veth first presented themselves in the Imaarat. Judging by the look on the older Madgēcot’s face, Aadhya was thinking the same thing. She eventually reached down to Etana and Nurma to gently nudge them to their feet; once standing, the Pratham laid her hands on each of their shoulders.

“Just as I told Veth when they first came to us, no one kneels to the Madgēcots. I accept your surrender on behalf of the Madgēcots—but that does not mean you immediately have our trust,” Aadhya said, holding up one clawed finger.

Both Etana and Nurma nodded at this. “We would expect nothing less, Pratham. We plan on earning the Madgēcot's trust over time. We want the bonds between Elysia and Empyrea to be strong—just like they were before Archon Lethe.” Nurma said.

Aadhya gave a curt nod at this statement as Glimmer approached the two Nephraeh leaders.

“Where is Archon Lethe? Did you destroy them? Capture them?” She asked.

The smiles instantly disappeared from Etana and Nurma’s faces for the first time, and they looked down in shame.

“Archon Lethe’s power is beyond our means to destroy them outright. We surprised them in the Temple of Light in an attempt to banish them into the Realm of Night. Unfortunately, they broke free and escaped off-planet. As of now, we have no idea where they could be.” Etana said sorrowfully.

“We would have gone after them, but all of our ships were sent to intercept your fleet. The only other means is interdimensional travel—but our power in the Light is not strong enough for that. We have been working to dismantle the House of the Penumbra and excavate the Temple of Light in hopes of gaining the means to locate our old leader.” Nurma said, indicating the large building behind them. Now that she had a closer look, Sher-Va/Catra could see that instead of repairing the structure, the Nephraeh on the scaffolding were taking it apart—piece by piece.

Sher-Va/Catra shook these thoughts from her head as the focus of her desires came to the fore.

“Where is Despara?” She asked of Etana and Nurma. The two-robed Nephraeh shared a glance before both pointed down the long avenue behind Sher-Va/Catra. Turning to look in the indicated direction, Sher-Va/Catra understood they were pointing at the large domed building at the other end of the broad road.

“She is in the place once called the Hall of Light—now known as the House of Lies. As soon as Despara returned to Empyrea, she took up residence there. We did not disturb her and were waiting for your arrival, Sher-Va. We think Despara is also waiting for you.” Nurma said.

Sher-Va/Catra nodded her thanks to Nurma and Etana before immediately heading in the direction of the House of Lies, her

entourage of friends and family in tow. It was a long road, and it gave Sher-Va./Catra time to balance her humors before the trial ahead, plus giving her a chance to see more of the City of Lumos up close.

Nephraeh were all about the city, engaged in a kind of rejuvenation she could not see from the air. Just like with the House of the Penumbra, buildings were being demolished—it was as if the Empyreans could not stand the sight of the place they lived in and wanted it immediately changed. What the City of Lumos would change into, Sher-Va/Catra could not tell—although she hoped she lived long enough to see it. Judging by its people's newfound exuberance and joy, the City of Lumos could be a wonderous sight to behold once the restoration was complete.

Coming up to the staircase leading to the entrance of the House of Lies, Sher-Va/Catra spotted heavily armored Nephraeh standing guard in front of the main doors. They nodded in respect to her as she ascended the stairs, stepping to the side as she neared.

"Welcome back to Empyrea, *Mahat*," one of the Nephraeh guards said with a bow.

Sher-Va/Catra turned to her followers before entering, looking at each one with glowing eyes.

"Thank you all for coming with me, but I must do this next part alone," she said.

Not surprising her, Viraj and Glimmer immediately stepped up.

"No way, Catra! Adora did the same thing to Bow and me when she went to the Heart of Etheria! I won't let you do it too!" Glimmer protested.

"Sister! Why do you insist on carrying the burden on your shoulders alone? We are here to help!" Viraj almost shouted.

Sher-Va/Catra laid a golden gauntlet on each of their shoulders, and she kneeled, bringing them both in for a hug.

“You both mean so much to me,” She said to them. “Viraj, I never knew what I was missing until I met you and knew I had a brother—I love you so much.”

Viraj grasped the hand on his shoulder as he began to purr, the vibrations of which traveled through their point of connection and into Sher-Va/Catra.

“I love you too, sister,” he said.

Sher-Va/Catra turned to the Queen to Etheria next.

“Glimmer, we have come a long way together, and you are one of my best friends. I love you so much—you know that, right?”

Glimmer looked into Sher-Va/Catra’s eyes; her own eyes were wide and wet with tears as she nodded.

“I love you too… *Horde Scum,*” she said with a grin.

Sher-Va/Catra laughed as she stood, looking at the rest of her companions in turn.

“Take care of each other,” was all she could say without bursting into tears.

Before she could turn away, Sher-Va/Catra felt a weight on her leg—looking down, she saw Seahawk wrapped around her shin, looking up at her with doleful eyes.

“Why does this sound like a goodbye?” He asked.

Bow and Glimmer helped pry the clinging Seahawk from Sher-Va/Catra, allowing the Champion of Grayskull to depart without further entanglements. She found leaving all of them very hard—for admit it or not—Sher-Va/Catra was attached to every single one of them.

Leaving your allies behind is not a good idea, Cat-Tra. Jihan said suddenly.

I'm not putting anyone in danger, Jihan. Adora had been kidnapped and brainwashed because of me. This is mine to fix—no one else. Sher-Va/Catra thought back to her inner ghost.

Passing through the open doors, Sher-Va/Catra found herself in a large hall that curved out of sight to either side to run the periphery of the building. Sher-Va/Catra's ears twitched as she heard a low moan—it was the mountain wind creeping over the stone floor and the only sound to greet her inside the House of Lies.

Sher-Va/Catra strode across the wide passage and through an open door, finding herself in a massive hall filled with shadows. Tiered pews ran the circumference of the chamber—seating for an audience or congregation to gather within this place, which ran down from Sher-Va/Catra's level to a circular floor below. A skylight high in the ceiling provided the only illumination in the chamber— from there—a beam of sunlight pierced the gloom, alighting upon what she sought.

With head bowed and face hidden in darkness, Despara sat upon a throne. The seat upon which she sat had been hacked from a tall pillar, the remains of which lay crumpled upon a section of the pews. She was level with the ground floor, and as Sher-Va/Catra walked down between the benches, Despara looked up to regard her with glowing indigo eyes. As Sher-Va/Catra neared the fallen Champion, Despara summoned her black sword and laid it across her knees with one hand resting on the pommel.

"I see you finally made it, Catra," Despara said. Unlike the other times she had spoken, Despara's voice was soft, sounding almost drained. Sher-Va/Catra could not help her heart going out to the other Champion—after all, she did love her, and they were technically married. Sher-Va/Catra knew Despara must feel hopelessly lost after surviving the suicide mission only to come back to Empyrea to find nothing left of Archon Lethe's Empire. After seeing the Nephraeh with their empathy returned, Sher-Va/Catra knew there was no place for a ruthless warrior amongst them. There was nowhere left to go for Despara.

“Don’t you have anything to say for yourself? No gloating, Catra? You won—*congratulations*,” Despara said, the sarcasm dripping like acid from her voice. Sher-Va/Catra looked Despara right in the eyes and shook her head.

“The Madgēcots won—but I did not get what I wanted. That’s why I came here,” she said simply.

Despara sneered at this, the expression ugly on what was naturally a beautiful face.

“Well, you can’t have me!” She growled. “I’m not yours!”

Sher-Va/Catra looked down at her gauntleted hands as she flexed the fingers, the golden claws on the tips extending as she unsheathed her natural ones.

“I don’t want you, Despara. I want Adora,” she said, tensing.

The fallen She-Ra rose at these words, her entire aspect full of menace as she held her black sword in two hands.

“For that to happen, I must die,” she rasped.

Abruptly, Despara leaped into the air, landing to deliver a mighty overhand chop with her blade. Sher-Va/Catra somersaulted backward out of the way, but not before being caught in the massive shockwave brought forth by the impact of Despara’s weapon hitting the ground. Sher-Va/Catra crashed amongst the pews as the shockwave continued up the side of the bowl-shaped chamber; it ended by crashing through the wall, opening a way into the outer hall. Sher-Va/Catra leaped to her feet just in time to see Despara gazing up at her with a nasty smirk.

“I think you should be the one that dies, Catra,” she threatened.

Sher-Va/Catra let out a lion’s roar as she bounded down through the destroyed pews with fangs bared and claws extended to engage Despara. Sparks flew as sword strike met gauntlet; both warriors exchanged blows before Sher-Va/Catra delivered a

leaping kick to Despara's midsection, sending her crashing back into her self-made throne, breaking it apart.

As Despara lay prone on her back amongst the ruin of her throne, Sher-Va/Catra rushed forward, seeing the chance to use her power upon the other. But as Sher-Va/Catra reached down to grip her head, Despara struck her full in the face, sending spit and blood flying in thin ribbons. Sher-Va/Catra yowled as she reeled backward, holding her injured mouth.

"It's not going to be that easy, *darling*," Despara said as she jumped to her feet.

The pain of the strike, combined with the taunts, enraged Sher-Va/Catra—but instead of rushing headlong into the attack—she reached for her lower back to select a cantrip.

"You're so cold, Despara," Sher-Va/Catra said, balling the material in two hands. "Have this to warm up!"

The cantrip burst into a searing green fireball as it left Sher-Va/Catra's hand; it streaked towards the alarmed Despara and exploded against her crossed forearms, sending her cartwheeling away to crash into more pews. Sher-Va/Catra did not relent and threw more cantrips of differing specialties at the downed Despara; they exploded or imploded about her reeling body, pinning her in place.

Cantrips will not hold a Champion, Cat-Tra! Beware! Jihan warned.

As if on cue, Despara screamed in absolute fury as she summoned the power of She-Ra, and created a shimmering shield around her body. Now under her own magical protection, Despara pointed her sword at her tormenter as a lance of pure white power spat forth from the tip. Sher-Va/Catra yelped as she rolled away from the searing energy, attempting to run away on all fours. But Despara only diverted the aim of her weapon, vaporizing pews as she chased the scampering Sher-Va/Catra with the deadly beam.

Despara screamed in frustration as she did this, the rage in her heart bolstering the strength of her attack—abruptly, the ground below the Madgēcot Champion exploded, sending Sher-Va/Catra soaring through the air.

It seems Despara has gained the advantage, Cat-Tra. Jihan interjected suddenly in Sher-Va/Catra's addled mind.

Thank you, Captain Obvious! I didn't notice! Sher-Va/Catra thought back.

As she was airborne, Sher-Va/Catra pivoted her body, enabling her to toss another cantrip Despara's way. So distracted with the destruction of her enemy, Despara overlooked the material until it was too late, and it burst into bright sparks in her face, blinding her momentarily.

"RAAAAAAARRRRRGGGGHHHH!!!" Despara screamed

Arching her back in apologetic rage, Despara diverted the powerful sword blast toward the ceiling, obliterating a vast section of the roof. She ducked as building materials came crashing down; one large chuck struck Despara directly in the head, knocking her senseless to the ground as more roof sections buried her. But Despara was not to be taken out in this manner—she rose from the rubble, looking out in hazy confusion for her hated enemy. Despara did not have to search for long.

Sher-Va/Catra leaped out of the swirling debris cloud to come to grips with Despara, delivering slashes and kicks so furious she was like a maddened animal. Despara attempted to block the many attacks, but where she had one weapon, her opponent had two. Before long, the fallen She-Ra was backing away from the panting Sher-Va/Catra, holding the many red lacerations on her black armored body. With wide heterochromatic eyes, Sher-Va/Catra realized she had grievously wounded the other Champion—she hesitated as Despara laughed through bloody lips.

"There won't be much of Adora left after this, Catra," she rasped, holding out a red-streaked hand for the other to see.

Sher-Va/Catra shook her head desperately, stifling the urge to weep, having hurt the person she loved more than life itself so severely with her own hands. But before Sher-Va/Catra could criticize her actions too harshly—the many rents in Despara's body began to seal as she summoned the potent healing magic of She-Ra.

"We can go on forever like this, Catra. I will just keep healing as you cut me—doesn't that sound like the perfect relationship? I know it does to me," Despara said seductively.

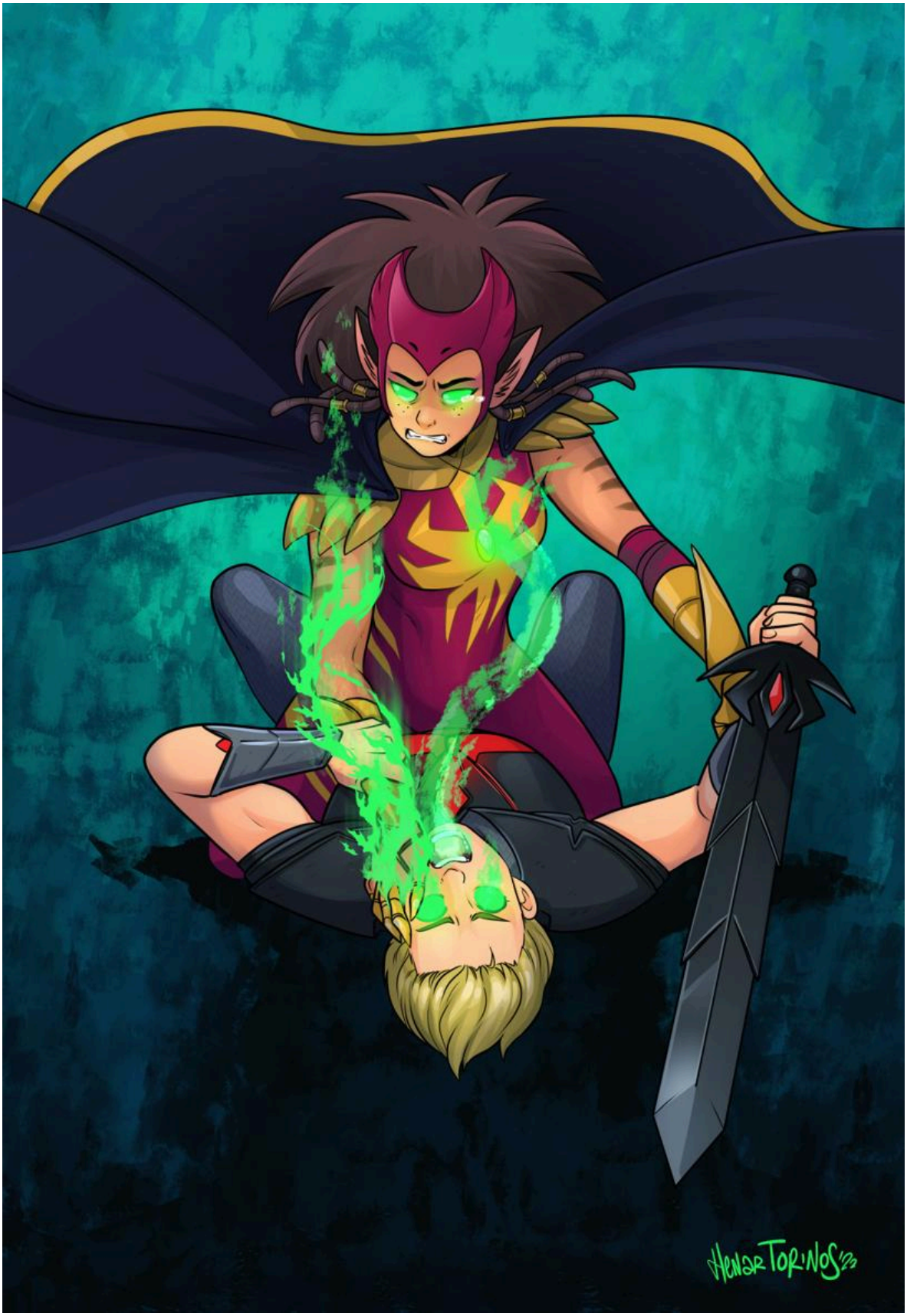
Cat-Tra, because she used so much healing power, her energy reserves are abated momentarily—but you must strike now, or this WILL go on forever! Jihan urged Sher-Va/Catra in her mind.

Silently agreeing with the long-dead Champion, Sher-Va/Catra raced forward. Seeing the other Champion coming, Despara raised her sword—but just as Jihan had predicted, her movements were slightly sluggish, and Sher-Va/Catra had time to seize the wrist holding the weapon in one of her claws. With her free hand, Sher-Va/Catra slugged Despara full in the face, knocking her headpiece free and sending her tumbling backward. Sher-Va/Catra did not let go of Despara's weapon hand as she followed the other down; as Despara landed hard on her back, Sher-Va/Catra straddled her, pinning her to the ground.

"Get off me, filthy Madgēcot!" Despara shrieked.

Sher-Va/Catra dug deep—into her love for Adora—and summoned the power of Truth. Her eyes immediately blazed with green light, and her hands became torches of emerald fire. Despara screamed as a burning hand reached for her bare face, her eyes alighting with the same green glow as they grasped her flesh. Sher-Va/Catra poured not only her positive emotions into the other, but the same love and compassion she knew Adora had into Despara's

black heart. The strength of this Truth was intense; green flames poured from Despara's eyes and mouth as the evil was burned out of her core.



But Sher-Va/Catra sensed it was not enough; the spirit of Despara was resisting her death and subverting the power of

Truth. Streaks of ingo light appeared amongst the green, and Sher-Va/Catra knew she was running out of time.

I must choose—Adora's life or my life, she thought, looking at the hand holding the sword.

Sher-Va/Catra let go of Despara's sword arm to grasp the other side of her head— immediately, the flames of Truth pouring from the other's eyes and mouth intensified, as did the screams of Despara's death cry.

It's working, Jihan! Adora is coming back, and she won't kill me! Sher-Va/Catra thought joyously.

Yes, I am so happy for you, Cat-Tra! It's a miracle— WATCH OUT!!!

As soon as Jihan screamed, Sher-Va/Catra felt the most intense pain—worse than she had ever felt— searing through her stomach. Looking down, she recognized Despara's black sword buried all the way to the hilt in her abdomen.

"You may have killed me, but you won't live to see Adora!" Despara rasped through the fire pouring out of her mouth.

Sher-Va/Catra gritted her teeth against the pain. Despara was right; she could feel herself fading away, and it would not be long until she was gone.

"As long you go first!" Sher-Va/Catra screamed, summoning the last dregs of her slowly draining life to pour more power into Despara. The flames of Truth found the core of the evil Champion, and with a final searing blast, the fire ceased as a hazy blackness rose from her eyes and mouth, which dissipated back to the realm from which it came.

Entirely spent, Sher-Va/Catra reverted into her normal form as Catra tumbled back off of the person she sat upon. Reaching down to her stomach, Catra held up hands covered in rich blood— more than she realized was in her.

"*Well, that's not good*," she moaned as her head dropped to the ground.

Even though her eyes were wide open and staring up through the massive hole in the roof, her sight was slowly fading, but Catra still smiled to see it was a beautiful day.

"Today was a good day," she whispered as the darkness closed in.

"C—Catra?" A voice called.

Hands reached under Catra's dying body as she was lifted by strong arms and cradled against a body with soft breasts. Through hazy eyes, Catra caught sight of a vision—an angel of radiant beauty gazing down at her with love.

"Adora!" Catra exclaimed.

Her wife was in her She-Ra form, but it wasn't the She-Ra Catra remembered. Instead of a gold headpiece, it was silver, and a slight darkness lined the rims of She-Ra/Adora's glowing blue eyes. It seemed that her time as Despara had marked her, but looking into She-Ra/Adora's face, Catra knew she had her back all the way.

"Hang on, Catra! You will be okay; I got you!" She-Ra/Adora urged.

Reaching up, Catra caressed her black claws along She-Ra/Adora/s jawline; she loved everything about her wife's face and was so happy to have Adora back. But as her fingers slid over smooth skin, red streaks were left behind, reminding Catra that she no longer had any time left.

"*I love you, Adora,*" Catra whispered.

Sher-Ra/Adora clutched her wife's body desperately in her arms, raising Catra's face to press her own against it.

"I love you too! Just hang—*hang on, Catra!*" She yelled.

Catra smiled faintly at Adora; she may have suffered the same consequences as Jihan, but Catra had succeeded where her mentor hadn't. Adora was free, and it was over—time for her to let go and know peace. Catra could feel tears falling onto her face as the darkness slowly claimed her; soon, that sensation vanished as she slipped entirely into darkness.

Catra was gone.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Henar Torinos, aka, Ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram.

Drawn to Evil

Chapter Summary

Evil spreads when not stamped out fully.

The day had started quite nicely in the City of Eternos; throughout the night, a mild wind had blown down from the neighboring Crystal Mountain Range, dispersing every cloud in the sky. The city's residents woke that morning to bright sunlight and mild temperatures—not a rare occurrence on Eternia, but a welcome one none the same—and happily went about their daily routines in good spirits. The people of Eternia had since adjusted to the presence of sunlight without taking it for granted—although not uncommon, perfect days like this were held in high regard. But soon, the people would find out this was no typical day.

By afternoon, dark clouds started to form over the many rocky crags of the Crystal Mountain Range, indicating a shift in the weather. That was when the bad news reached the city from the other side of the galaxy; the heir apparent and the potential future king had been killed on a planet far from Eternia. Back when they were all still in the realm of night, he was known by his full name, Shen'Thran-zanmar'eth, but after the return of the day to Eternia, his name was shortened to the sir-name every Eternian had since abandoned—Shen.

The inclement weather and terrible news had an immediate effect on the City of Eternos, dampening the spirits of the people and making them focus inward instead of outward. They still went about their business, but now in a grim fashion of people who just wanted the day over before more bad news could rear its ugly head.

Everyone was too fixated on their own dark thoughts to notice the three figures who suddenly appeared amongst them. Covered head to toe in black robes, two people of average size followed one who stood much taller than anyone in the city. While the

people of Eternos seemed to mill about aimlessly, these three had a more focused path with a set destination in mind. If anyone had bothered to watch them, they would have seen these very peculiar strangers were headed for one of the most important buildings in Eternos—The Grand Conclave—where the High Council of Eternia was meeting at this very moment.

* * *

High Councilor Kerk drummed his fingers impatiently on the glossy surface of the raised bench he and his fellow councilors sat behind. He had been interrupted from his morning spent in his private garden in the southern quarter of Eternos—a secret garden composed primarily of now illegal Demon's Blood flowers—and had been in the process of covering the delicate light-sensitive plants when he received the summons. Having to abandon his plants to the daylight, High Councilor Kerk knew that not even one of the flora native to the Realm of Night would survive until his return—which irritated him greatly. But when he found out WHY this emergency session had been called, he was absolutely furious.

That useless moron gets himself killed, and we are left picking up the pieces. He thought darkly.

High Councilor Kerk looked side to side at the other twelve members of the High Council, also seated on one side of the long, gently curved bench which dominated the chamber. He wondered who else shared his viewpoint; to most of the people of Eternia, the Shen'Aan-war's son was a hero, and any other opinion was most unpopular. He knew that High Councilor Elros had been a member of the Shen'Aan-war's court but had made comments in the past lauding Prince Shen for his part in freeing their planet. All the others were not closely associated with the last administration—or worse—had been part of the rebellion.

Turning from his fellow councilors, High Councilor Kerk gazed out into the Council Chamber to regard the various aides, functionaries, and sentinels in attendance. The former two groups

were seated at their own smaller benches, which faced his much bigger one. In contrast, the latter were positioned at the vast and heavy wooden double doors situated on the opposite side of the room as the High Councilor bench, keeping a close eye on the proceedings. The shape of the large bench, combined with the arrangement of the many smaller ones, created a circular space between them; this spot was the audience area for anyone to come to this great hall to either petition, report, or simply address the High Council.

Scanning the many somber faces staring back at him, High Councilor Kerk knew he would not find any allies amongst them either. He allowed himself a small sigh; in the end, it wasn't even worth trying. High Councilor Kerk did not want to reveal himself to anyone and take the chance of anyone finding out about his more… unsavory hobbies.

"What was Shen'Thran-zanmar'eth—I'm sorry—I mean, Shen, even doing on this planet? What was it called again?" High Councilor Vikor was saying to no one in particular.

"Enos," Answered High Councilor Scrollos. "By all accounts, he died a hero fighting an enemy of the Madgēcots,"

"Excuse me, *the what*? Did you say magic cats?" High Councilor Rotor asked, confused.

Scrollos shook her head. "No, Ma-gee-cot. Madgēcots. They are a race of feline warriors from a magical planet like Eternia called Elysia. I think they would find the term, *magic cats* very derogatory. I wouldn't say such a thing in their presence."

High Councilor Kerk scoffed at this, loudly and audibly. He never liked High Councilor Scrollos and found the respect she was giving these people misplaced; she had been a rebel fighting against the Shen'Aan-war before his downfall and was prone to being overly sympathetic. High Councilor Kerk also had a suspicion she knew about his dark past and was working to uncover him

"A planet of magic cats? Sounds ridiculous. What was Shen'Thran-zanmar'eth doing with these creatures—and more importantly—who was responsible for his death? We should demand answers from these magical cats!" He practically shouted.

High Councilor Scrollos regarded him coolly before answering.

"The *Madgēcots* report it was during a battle to save the planet Enos and that a race called the Nephraeh was involved. It seems the two parties were fighting over a rare power source which was about to go supercritical before our Prince stepped in and saved the day." She said proudly.

The other eleven councilors applauded her words, leaving High Councilor Kerk to follow suit awkwardly.

Yeah right. He was probably partying with these magic cats and these nympho-whatevers and caused some kind of disaster, killing him in the process. High Councilor Kerk thought as he clapped along.

"Is this all we will receive from halfway across the galaxy? Just bad news? What about some form of reparations for the death of our Prince and unnamed king?" High Councilor Zien asked. High Councilor Kerk liked that question, especially since it had to do with getting paid out of the misfortune of others.

"The Madgēcot representative didn't mention anything about that, Councilor Zien. They only apologized for not sending a more formal envoy to our planet and conveyed a wish to open talks between our two people. They expressed a desire to help us learn any forgotten history of Eternia and its place in the Ancient Galactic Society." High Councilor Scrollos said. This was too much for High Councilor Kerk.

"What?! You're telling me all they offer us is what? *Friendship?* And they say they are *going to teach us? What arrogance!* Who do they think they are? I say we send them a message demanding they compensate us for Prince Shen's death with a

very strong ‘or else’ attached!” He said, puffing out his chest. The twelve other High Councilors looked at him disapprovingly.

“So, your answer to the Madgēcots hand in friendship is to declare war on them? Is that what I should gather from your statement Councilor Kerk?” High Councilor Scrollos asked tersely.

“There is no need to openly declare war if you simply deliver the message with wits and tact, my dear Scrollos.” High Councilor Kerk responded with a false smile. He was immediately disappointed when High Councilor Scrollos did not respond to his bait of ignoring her title and insulting her intelligence with an outburst of anger.

“It’s interesting you mention intelligence when you also talk of threatening an unknown race whom we know literally nothing about,” she answered simply.

High Councilor Kerk felt a spike of rage at being spoken to in this way and just barely managed to suppress it. He had spent a great deal of time carefully creating the façade of a respectful and clean-cut member of Eternian society to let his mask slip now.

“I’m sorry, Councilor Kerk; I did not mean to say you are stupid.” High Councilor Scrollos continued, now sweetly. “I mean, you’ve done such a great job of hiding your recent acquisition of Death Binder artifacts that I have not yet found any concrete proof.”

“How dare you!” High Councilor Kerk screamed as he jumped from his seat. He wanted to pull the contraband Heart Thorn he had hidden under his robes and kill High Councilor Scrollos for her temerity. Before he had the chance, High Councilor Zien interrupted them.

“Please! We are not meeting to discuss unfounded accusations but what to do about the succession!” He interjected.

High Councilor Kerk flopped back down on his chair and crossed his arms sullenly.

"No disrespect to our late Prince Shen, but what is there to discuss? Shen plainly stated he had no interest in taking his father's place as king and was the one who suggested reinstating the High Council—us." High Councilor Kerk stated as he indicated the other councilors with a waved hand. "I, for one, believe it was a wise decision. Instead of forcing a ruler upon us, the people elect their peers to sit on this august Council and represent them."

High Councilor Scrollos immediately gave a high-pitched laugh, making High Councilor Kerk grind his teeth.

"And who elected you, Councilor Kerk? What interested party helped you get a seat at this table?" She asked, placing two hands on top of the smooth bench.

Before High Councilor Kerk could answer, a pleasant chime sounded throughout the chamber, indicating someone important was waiting outside and wishing to address the High Council. One of the guards opened a small slot in one of the great doors to interact with whomever it was; after a brief exchange, they turned to address the High Council.

"Suzerain Shen'Shalidar of Morrigor wishes to address the High Council regarding the question of succession," the guard called.

The High Council Members looked at each other with open mouths as High Councilor Kerk had a moment of hope. Shen'Shalidar was of the old guard, as indicated by his continued usage of the sir-name 'Shen.' There were rumors he had connections with Death Binders that had managed to survive the destruction of the Set-Heth-un'dar and had escaped off-planet. He was someone High Councilor Kerk was very interested in seeing in a position of power—that is—if he couldn't attain it himself first.

"Ugh. He is here already?" Moaned High Councilor Scrollos. "Prince Shen's death was just announced; how did he get here already?"

She looked back and forth between the other members of the council, her gaze lingering on High Councilor Kerk. He made sure to give her his most vicious leer in response to her suspicions.

"Let him in. As ill-timed as it is, this council will hear his petition." Announced High Councilor Zien. The guards bowed and began the process of operating the levers and pulleys to work the ancient mechanisms which opened the massive doors. They groaned as they spread apart, revealing a man dressed in extravagant and decadent clothes, attended by two servants.

Having light blue skin, white hair, long ears, and stunning blue eyes, Suzerain Shen'Shalidar was of the Elvar. He sauntered into the room as if he owned all he surveyed, not bothering to acknowledge any of the people passed on the way to present himself before the High Council. Once situated in the exact center of the circular area before the High Council bench, Suzerain Shen'Shalidar cleared his throat pompously as one of his attendants began to make the official introduction.

"It is with obvious pleasure that the High Council of Eternia receives the most honored Shen'Shalidar, Suzerain of Morrigor, keeper of the Seven Salt Scrolls of the Ancients, and hero of the Battle for the Plains of Perpitua!" The man said in a nasally voice.

Once his introductions were complete, Suzerain Shen'Shalidar gave a slight nod to the High Council—as if finally conceding they were allowed to exist. High Councilor Kerk immediately felt any hopes he had accumulated evaporate completely.

This guy is a pompous fool, and this is a waste of time. He thought as High Councilor Scrollos cleared her throat to speak.

"My! That is quite the introduction! I have to admit that I have never heard of the Battle of the Plains of Perpitua—but I am familiar with the *Massacre of Perpitua,* in which the Shen'Aan-war's forces chased down a butchered a group of defenseless refugees. Are we talking about the same thing, *most honored* Suzerain Shen'Shalidar?"

High Councilor Scrollos asked the question with a smile, but everyone felt the chill behind her voice. Suzerain Shen'Shalidar's lips gave a slight twitch before his attendant spoke.

"Ah! No! They are two completely different events, I assure you!" He said nervously.

High Councilor Scrollos snorted with derision before High Councilor Rotor spoke up next.

"Well, introductions out of the way; why don't you lay out your claim for the crown of Eternia before us so that we might judge its validity." He said officiously.

Suzerain Shen'Shalidar placed his hands behind his back and stood at his full height as his other attendant, a young woman of slight build, pulled out a dusty parchment from a satchel at her hip. In a meek voice, she began to read the lineage of Suzerain Shen'Shalidar, starting with the fall of Eternia into the realm of Night a thousand years ago. After an hour of this narration, she came to the conclusion that Suzerain Shen'Shalidar was related to Prince Shen through a marriage between distant cousins. With the official claim complete, she placed the desiccated parchment back into its satchel and looked up nervously at Suzerain Shen'Shalidar as he finally spoke.

"I assume that clearly explains to you that I, Suzerain Shen'Shalidar of Morrigor, am the rightful king of Eternia. I expect now we will talk about my coronation date?" He said in a voice like the night wind.

The councilors looked at each other in absolute incredulity before High Councilor Scrollos spoke for them all—High Councilor Kerk included.

"Shen'Shalidar," she began, not even bothering with his title. "Have you traveled beyond your lands since Eternia left the realm of Night? I assume you have not since you are the only person I know—besides the late Prince—to use the sir nam e 'Shen.'"

Confusion passed briefly over Shen'Shaildar's light blue face, and High Councilor Scrollos waved her hand dismissively before he could respond.

"Don't answer that; it was a rhetorical question, and I have a much better one to ask you. Even if your claim was not tenuous and you had happened to be Prince Shen's younger brother, why in the name of Grayskull would we allow one of the Shen'Aan-war's bootlickers to become one of our kings?" She asked sternly.

Shen'Shaildar's mouth was immediately open in shocked outrage.

"How dare you! You filthy rebel scum!" He screamed.

"You know," High Councilor Scrollos continued, almost in a thoughtful tone. "It was rather kind of you to bring yourself here and save us the time of putting together a force to come and arrest you. There are so many war criminals left over from the Shen'Aan-war's reign that the Tribunal is overtaxed hunting down them all."

As she finished her statement, High Councilor Scrollos's eyes settled meaningfully upon High Councilor Kerk before she returned her attention to the unfortunate Shen'Shaildar.

"Guards, I want this man arrested—now!" She said, pointing an accusatory finger.

The once haughty Suzerain of Morrigor crumpled in the arms of the stern-faced guards as they hauled him away. Obviously, Shen'Shaildar had long experienced the comforts of unquestioned power under the old regime—that he could be arrested and face a lifetime of imprisonment was barely conceivable. His servants looked at each other in absolute incredulity as their lord was taken from them. After a moment of uncertainty, they shouted with joy and embraced before they left the High Council chamber in high spirits.

"Well, now that we have that unpleasant matter out of the way, we should get back to—" High Councilor Scrollos started to say

before the chime rang out again.

“Another one?!” She practically gasped. “Are we to deal with a procession of fops with claims of kinghood all day?”

The doors were still open with the most recent departure, giving the entire High council chamber a view of the newcomers. There were three of them, all dressed in fully concealing black robes, standing just outside the open door. As they were granted access to the High Council Chamber and proceeded forward, High Councilor Kerk saw that the one in the front was very tall but appeared hunched—as if trying to mask their actual height. The two others that followed were of more average stature; one a bit larger than the other and, based on the bulge at their rear, had a tail. As they came to a halt in the space previously occupied by Shen’Shaildar, the apparent leader stood straight, revealing that they were not just tall—but giant.

Gasps resounded throughout the High Council chamber as the three figures lifted their heads to reveal their faces; the two shorter figures were attractive women—one dark-skinned, the other lighter. But the female faces were not what caused the disruption; it was the visage of the giant. A pure white face peered out from the recesses of the hood, pinning the assembled High Council with glowing eyes of deep indigo. Whomever this giant being was, they were beyond simple male or female restrictions, and High Councilor Kerk found their androgynous allure beckon to the hidden recesses of his soul. He instantly found himself moved in such a way that made him feel uncomfortable; the primal emotions that sprang forth were only for private moments—not for the likes of the High Council Chamber. Not being able to quite put a finger on it, High Councilor Kerk felt that this immense being was the salvation he sought—that where Shen’Shaildar could have been a means to an end—this magnificent being was the end-all answer to his darkest desires. High Councilor Kerk's disappointment with Shen’Shaildar instantly vanished, quickly replaced by giddy excitement.

“And who might you be?” High Councilor Scrollos asked.

The being smiled without revealing their teeth, bowing graciously.

"You may simply call me Lethe, High Councilor Scrollos," they said in a powerful and genderless voice as they rose once more to their full height. To High Councilor Kerk, it was the voice of a god.

"Where are you from, Lethe? I had never seen one such as you before," High Councilor Zien asked.

Lethe nodded sagely at this. "Yes, I would imagine you have not. Even if Eternia was not recently returned to this universe, I doubt you would have met anyone like me. I am exceptional—if you don't mind me saying."

"We don't mind at all," a voice answered vaguely. When all the other councilors turned to stare at him, High Councilor Kerk realized with a start that he had spoken. A vibrant blush broke out over his face as he felt Lethe's strange eyes on him as they continued to talk.

"As for where I am from, well, I come from a planet on the other side of the galaxy. My friends here," they said, indicating to the two women with a black-stained, clawed hand. "Are from Etheria."

The councilors took a moment to process all this as High Councilor Kerk practically swooned at being in the same room as Lethe. Here and there, others were similarly affected by Lethe's presence, and they practically abased themselves before the newcomer. But not all were impressed by Lethe.

"So, Lethe, why have you come before this council? I can't imagine it is to submit a claim on the king-ship—I doubt you are related to Prince Shen." Councilor Scrollos said tersely.

Lethe let out a bark of laughter at this, and they quickly placed a hand to their mouth to stifle it. It was a very playful mannerism, but High Councilor Kerk sensed an undercurrent of flint behind it—made more evident as he caught sight of the black teeth in Lethe's mouth.

“Something funny, Lethe?” High Councilor Scrollos asked in an unamused tone.

“So, the Madgēcots say your precious Shen is dead, and you believe them? My good woman, he is not dead—I can help you get him back!” Lethe said.

High Councilor Scrollos looked uncertainly at her fellows before responding.

“You come before us and sow distrust against the Madgēcots, all the while promising a miracle—what would you want in return, Lethe? I have a feeling the price is steep,” she finally said.

High Councilor Kerk felt a spike of anger with the way the other Councilor spoke to Lethe; if he could kill her in that instant, he would.

“You are very direct and to the point, my dear High Councilor Scrollos. I was hoping to get to this part after some more careful courtship between us—but very well, have it your way,” Lethe said, almost in a pout.

“I understand that with the absence of your king, you have a leadership issue, which I could help you rectify. I am not saying that I should be your king, for I would not be that presumptuous—what I offer is my guidance. I have lived in this galaxy for a very long time, and I have much wisdom I could offer you.” Lethe said, steepling their black fingers in front of their face.

“That sounds like a magnificent offer. With Lethe acting as Grand Advisor, the High Council can continue as they are and without the need for a king—we accept!” High Councilor Kerk said immediately. High Councilor Scrollos’s head whipped around to blaze daggers in his direction.

“Hold on, just a minute!” She shouted. “High Councilor Kerk does not speak for all of us! I, for one, am not so easily convinced by empty promises, no matter how attractive the one giving them is!”

High Councilor Kerk gritted his teeth at the thought of Lethe being turned away from them—he absolutely could not let that happen.

"Fair enough," he began airily. "Then how about this High Council take a vote, here and now? Those in favor of what I propose raise their hand. Those not in favor shall just do nothing,"

High Councilor Scrollos looked at her fellows uncertainly as Lethe regarded High Councilor Kerk in a pleasing manner. At that moment, he felt as if he were ruler of all Eternia with those indigo eyes upon him.

"Very well," she said finally. "I accept. All those in favor of Lethe becoming Grand Advisor, raise their hand."

With his heart beating loudly, High Councilor Kerk watched his fellow councilors, expecting every single one of them—except High Councilor Scrollos, of course—to raise their hand. When only High Councillors Zien, Kove, and Pyke raised their hands, the crushing disappointment he felt made him almost weep.

"Well, there you have it," High Councilor Scrollos said happily. "We thank you for your offer, Lethe, but the High Council and Eternia do not require your services at this time."

The bright and happy smile on Lethe's pure white face vanished, replaced by a look of absolute disappointment.

"I really didn't want to do it this way," Lethe said quietly. "Especially not so close to the Concurrence—it will draw a lot of unwanted attention."

People looked nervously at one another as Lethe reached down towards their robe and started to draw it open. High Councilor Kerk felt a thrill at the idea of seeing Lethe's bared flesh, but what he saw under those concealing robes only left him feeling confused.

There was night under Lethe's robes—a night so dark that dawn was an inconceivable proposition under the weight of all that

blackness. But it was not an empty night; things stirred back there, within Lethe's form, and started to move towards the light of the High Council chamber. As sleek and glossy figures began to slither out from between the folds of Lethe's robes, that was when the screaming started.

Lithe creatures the color of ebony raced outward from Lethe, each one with sharp claws and fangs exposed as they fell upon the nearest victims. Aides and functionaries that were not quite fast enough to get away were born down by black bodies which clung to them, clamping down on necks with black lips. The whole time this was happening, Lethe continued to hold their robe wide open, face beaming like a proud parent looking upon exuberant children.

A guard brought up a rifle and fired a beam of pure plasma at one of the monsters; it simply disappeared into its body—absorbing the energy like it was a black hole. The monster then ripped the gun out of the guard's hand as it leaped upon him, bringing him to the ground to meet the same fate as the others.

People fled towards the double door but were blocked from escaping by the two women who accompanied Lethe. They stood side by side bearing strange staves pointed threateningly at anyone who tried to approach. The shorter, darker-skinned woman slammed her staff down as a crystal at the top flashed with a teal brilliance. An unseen force radiated out from the epicenter that was the staff, pushing the unfortunate people back into the waiting arms of the creatures.

It was all happening so quickly, but from what High Councilor Kerk could tell, these strange beings appeared as naked versions of Lethe—only sheer of any hair on top of their heads and jet black. Once the similarity was established, High Councilor Kerk was immediately drawn to these monsters, and he started to climb over the main bench—but a hand gripping his arm stopped him. Turning to see who had halted him, High Councilor Kerk saw High Councilor Scrollos looking at him in shock.

“Now you try to be a hero, Kerk?” She hissed at him in exasperation.

High Councilor Kerk looked at her as if she were the most insane person in existence as he pulled himself from her grip.

“They are so exquisite,” he said in a horse whisper.

High Councilor Scrollos withdrew her hand from him as she backed away, stricken.

“I always knew you had a touch of the darkness in you—but now I see that you are simply drawn to evil.” She said in horror.

High Councilor Kerk ignored her as he scampered over the bench and tumbled to the floor; as he rose to his feet, one of the creatures spotted him. He went to it with arms wide and a beatific smile plastered over his face.

“Take me!” He pleaded.

The creature cocked its head as it inspected this strange person who beckoned to it, then started towards him, hips swaying in mimicry of a sexuality it no longer had. It wrapped strong arms around him as it pressed its body against his, its lips parted slowly to reveal rows of uneven, sharp teeth—they looked like they would hurt when penetrating his flesh.

High Councilor Kerk returned the embrace as he slipped his arms around its slender torso, feeling its smooth body was freezing to the touch. Before he could rethink his decision, the monster leaned its head toward his neck—he tensed in anticipation of searing pain—but none came.

A strange sensation spread through his body—like a sliding within his very cells—and he felt something pulled from him. High Councilor Kerk felt terror at the thought of a part of him being taken—he had come to this beautiful monster to receive, not to give—and he tried to struggle. Instantly it clamped down on his neck tighter as its arms squeezed him into submission.

There was no escape.

“H—help meeeeeee!” He squealed as the monster sucked the last portions of its meal from his very essence.

Suddenly, it released its hold on him, and High Councilor Kerk slid down its body, his cheek coming to a rest against one of its icy thighs. The monster pushed him away indifferently—like a baker tossing away an eggshell—for that was what he was to it.

High Councilor Kerk lay on the ground, almost insensate, as he listened to the last of his fellows being taken by the monsters. He was close to losing consciousness when he realized a white face was peering down at him from a lofty height—it was Lethe, smiling almost kindly as they reached down for him. After helping him to his feet, High Councilor Kerk looked up into Lethe’s perfect face as he searched within, looking for the absence of what was taken. He immediately felt it then, a lightness that went beyond simple mass; High Councilor Kerk felt the most unencumbered he had ever felt in his entire life, and he smiled.

“What did you do to me, wonderful lord?” He asked up at the god-like being.

The smile on Lethe’s face widened, making High Councilor Kerk want to weep at their beauty.

“I freed you,” Lethe said simply.

Damage

Chapter Summary

The conclusion of Book III: Sher-Va

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora dreams.

She dreams of scattered fragmented recollections she had not directly lived but observed through a nebulous lens—a prisoner in her own mind. They are Despara's memories—Adora's darker version—who was in a sense was still her, only bereft of any humanity.

I was not in control of my body; I was conscious of what SHE was doing, but I could not stop it.

Adora witnesses dark deeds—horrible, awful crimes—made all worse by the fact she is seeing them from a first-person perspective. These memories are of things done that she could never imagine herself doing—not in a million years.

It was Despara, not me. I am Adora—not Despara.

A human woman inside a mechanical suit—she is helpless on her back, her protection useless as she lies in soft snow. Zhe-La/Veth tells her to surrender, but the woman curses and spits at them.

"Never, you treacherous scum!" She cries.

Adora feels admiration for the woman's courage—but this changes to horror as the woman dies by her hand. It is a brutal end and a dishonorable killing, the person who had done this deed was an absolute monster.

The person… Despara… no… was it Despara? Or was it me?

Another image, this time of a human male. He is dressed in the functional outfit of a scientist and is yelling at Adora.

"You cannot use the Relativity Forge as a weapon! It was made to be a power source, and I will not allow it to be used so basely by one such as you!" He shouts.

His anger suddenly dampens as Adora reaches for him, taking his entire head within her black gauntlet. He instantly screams.

So much callous cruelty, and for what? Why did she do it?

She is suddenly in a strange alien structure; the entire place is constructed of a porous black substance that howls endlessly with the wind, the stain of an ancient evil everywhere she looks. Adora walks out of this place and into a dead world; she is looking for someone, and soon she finds them. It's Veth, standing next to a gaping chasm. They are talking to…

Catra! It's my wife! Why is she talking to Veth?

Anger mixes with jealousy inside Adora, and the first time she shares the emotions of her darker version and the lines between the two become blurred.

I already talked to Catra about this. I am past this jealousy with Veth—they had used it to drive a wedge between Catra and me, so they could complete their mission to destroy the Great Chailendra Tree and kidnap me. That is how I ended up like…

The anger becomes rage, and Adora attacks Veth and Catra; she wants to kill them for their betrayal.

No, I didn't want to kill Catra! It was Despara! She wanted to kill Veth for THEIR betrayal! Catra was just there at the wrong time!

Adora uses the power of She-Ra to knock Veth into the pit, and Catra lunges to the edge to catch them before they fall. As Catra

lies on the ground holding Veth's hand, Adora walks over to stand next to the two of them—two betrayers who are about to get what is coming to them.

I didn't want to kill Veth either! Why am I doing this? It isn't me!

Before Adora can kill Catra with her sword, Veth lets go of her wife's hand, falling into the strange mists within the chasm. This makes Adora even more enraged—it is proof of their relationship. Why else would Veth give their life up for Catra?

Despara would not have cared about Veth and Catra; she was only mad that Veth had betrayed her and the Empyrean Empire. So that means…

Adora tries to kill Catra, but just as she is about to, Glimmer arrives and stops her, using her Staff of Power. There are others with her— Bow, Entrapta, Seahawk, plus too many Madgēcots to fight alone. Adora had to flee.

My friends! They are fighting me, stopping me from killing… my wife…

Other memories torment Adora—more images of death and ruin done by her hands—all merging together into a torrent of evil. These events become even more confusing after the revelation that Archon Lethe is lying to her—that she had been someone else before the Nephraeh ruler brainwashed her.

I… I don't understand this part… I already knew my name was Adora… right?

Old friends fight by her side—Scorpia and Mermista—but they are not friends anymore, for they are now minions of Archon Lethe. They even call her by the name she hates, the one that she had before…

Why did I hate that they called me Adora? It was my name—wait, no! I was Despara then! That's why! I was Despara… wait…

The images that follow are the most confusing for her; it is of the time after Archon Lethe's revelation and the mission to retrieve the sword of He-Ro. Her darker half is filled with so much doubt and uncertainty as she struggles with slowly unraveling memories —from a time she was called by another's name—Adora.

I was Despara then… NO! I was not Despara, but she was in control of my body… I am Adora!

To make matters worse, Archon Lethe no longer cares what happens to Adora and sends her on a suicide mission. She is told she must kill the bearer of Sher-Va and Adora is beholden to do as they command, for if she does not, she will face eternity as a Vetala.

Sent Despara on a suicide mission, not me. I was not the one in control!

All is not totally grim; some people try to help Adora, and they seem to care about her—two beautiful Nephraeh who are rebelling against Archon Lethe. But Adora does not accept their offer, even though she wants someone to trust more than anything.

Despara was too twisted and evil to accept help—I would have taken their hand in friendship in an instant!

One of the Nephraeh tells Adora that Sher-Va is Catra, and this news fills her with more doubt.

I was filled with doubt because I did not think I could kill Catra… because she was my wife and I love her… but, no… Despara had been in control. She probably felt doubt because… I don't know…

Adora is now boarding the Madgēcot ship, desperate to face Catra and end the torment that is her life. She fights her way to the bridge against the aggravating Star Hunter defenders, all the while screaming Catra's name.

Why did Despara feel doubt about facing Catra? Was it because… no…

Finally, Adora is face to face with Catra as Sher-Va, and the ensuing conflict is violent and brief. She manages to use the hammer given to her by Archon Lethe to break Catra's power word, severing her from the Sher-Va Avatar. Just as Adora is about to kill her enemy, Catra manages to summon the pure form of Sher-Va.

If Despara was filled with doubt about facing Catra, that meant that she had feelings for Catra. If she did, that means…

Adora narrowly escapes capture by ejecting herself into space. After floating in the cold void for an indeterminate period of time, a black nothingness engulfs her, and she feels hands on her body. They are looking for something, and after a brief search, they pull the Hammer of Zzar from her belt. After that, she knows no more.

I am confused; Despara had feelings for Catra. This could only be true if some part of me was still in Despara. If that is true, then…

Adora waits on a self-made throne amongst the ruins of the Empyrean Empire. She is alone; the Nephraeh have shunned her totally in their self-renewal and rejection of Archon Lethe's Light. It does not matter, though; soon, she will face judgment.

Why would Despara care about facing judgment? She would only care about that if she felt guilty for what she had done. I know I would if I was in her place… wait…

Soon Catra arrives in her Sher-Va form; she tells Adora to surrender, that her cause is hopeless. Part of Adora wants to give in to the beautiful Madgēcot warrior, but another part feels she does not deserve it. Not after what she had done.

No… no… no… I am not Despara! I am Adora! We are separate people!

Adora is overwhelmed with an abundance of self-hatred and, not knowing what else to do with it, lashes out at Catra. They fight—pitting the might of Champions of Grayskull against each other in a titanic battle. Blood is shed, and the Hall of Truth is destroyed as Adora and Catra fight to the death. Catra gains the upper hand on Adora and uses her Sher-Va power in an attempt to defeat her. She almost succeeded in doing so, but not before Adora took her sword and…

Why? Why did I do it? Oh, Catra… you deserved better than that…

Suddenly Adora is seeing the world in a new light—a new perspective. It is as if she had been color-blind and now could see that particular hue once again, and Adora is overwhelmed with joy. But then she remembers…

I killed her… I killed her…

Adora holds a dying Catra in her arms—her wife and soulmate whom she loves more than life itself. Catra had given her own life to save Adora from her dark persona—the most selfless act one person could do for another. Adora holds her limp body in her arms, begging Catra to stay and not leave her.

NOOOOOOO!!!

* * *

"NOOOOOOO!!!" Adora screamed as she lunged up from the bed in a seated position, throwing the sheets off her. She was completely naked, covered in sweat and crying, and as Adora looked about herself, she was bewildered.

She was in a bedroom, and based on it being wholly composed of wood having no straight angles, Adora realized it was of Madgēcot design. The round windows opposite the end of the bed were wide open, revealing a beautiful Elysian day; soft forest scents and pleasing sounds of fauna immediately bathed her senses, calming her. On the table next to the bed is a picture in a woven

frame; it is of a happy Madgēcot family, two parents holding two babies with miss-matched eyes.

"Wha—where am…?" Adora began to say before sensing a motion behind her.

Adora immediately tensed as two arms wrapped her in an embrace, pulling her back onto a soft, warm body that purred into her back.

"Is okay! It's over! I got you, Adora!" Catra soothed into her ear.

"Catra!" Adora cried in relief as she clutched the cinnamon arms holding her in a loving embrace.

"Yeah, it's me," Catra said, nuzzling her face into the crook of Adora's neck. "I'm okay; I'm here. You were having the dream again, weren't you?"

Adora shut her eyes against the tears as she gritted her teeth. Yes—it was all coming back to her. She had been having this reoccurring dream every night since the final battle between Despara and Sher-Va. Since she almost killed…

Adora immediately turned herself around as Catra let go of her in anticipation of what would come next. Adora placed her hands on Catra's naked body—not in lust—but in need. The need to make sure her wife was safe and whole.

Adora ran her fingers down Catra's face as the other closed her heterochromatic eyes, enjoying the sensation. From there, Adora inspected Catra's arms, looking for any new nicks or cuts in the fine soft fur.

"Nothing there, babe," Catra purred.

Adora moved down to Catras legs, having to stop herself from tracing the dark brown stripes as she continued her inspection down to the feet. Adora felt the hardened undersides of Catra's soles before moving to the tender upper side.

“Ha, ha! Stop! That tickles!” Catra laughed.

Catra rolled on her tummy, enjoying the attention she was receiving as Adora continued her tour of Catra’s body. Seeing that no harm had come to her wife’s shapely behind, Adora gently stroked t her fingers down the stone-gray tail—all the way to the tip.

“Mmmm… you sure do know how to handle my tail,” Catra sighed.

Next, Adora felt down from the supple muscles of Catra’s upper back down to the curve of the lower, taking extra care to trace the lines of her spine. Catra’s purr intensified as her tail began long sweeps behind her.

“Hmmm… want to massage me while your back there?” Catra inquired.

Adora allowed herself a smile as she prodded Catra’s hip, wanting her to turn face up. In one languid motion, Catra twisted her body around, presenting Adora with her front in its entirety, along with a toothy smile.

Adora placed her hand on Catra’s taut stomach, feeling for the injury she had seen in her nightmare. But all she could see was a faint line, barely discernable on her wife’s belly. Catra let out a sigh—not in irritation or pleasure—but in love as she grasped Adora’s hands, bringing them slowly to her mouth to kiss them.

“It’s okay, Adora. Remember? You healed me; you saved me—just in time!” Catra said, gazing into Adora’s eyes.

She did remember; Adora had been freed from Despara by Sher-Va’s power and, in doing so, gained her empathy and love for Catra back. With her compassion restored, Adora could use She-Ra’s healing magic to save Catra’s life, pouring all the love she had missed out on giving to Catra during her time as Despara into one moment—one act—and healing the grievous wound almost completely.


HENRIQUES'22

Adora smiled as she nodded. “I do now, I remember. It’s just the dreams…” She said in a whisper.

Catra smiled kindly, kissing her hands once again.

“I know. You need to make sure I am okay. I think I can get used to this routine and all this attention,” Catra said, grinning from ear to ear. But the smile faded, and a look of concern came over Catra’s face when Adora continued to stare shamefully at the place Despara had hurt her.

“Are the dreams getting worse?” Catra asked finally.

Adora’s face screwed up in frustration as she thought of the response; for her, there was no simple answer.

“Worse? In a way—yes, but in another… I don’t know, Catra. I am slowly realizing that I can’t just dismiss what happened after Veth kidnaped me. You and everyone else keep telling me nothing was my fault, that it was all Despara’s doing. But I don’t think that is right, Catra; the more I look back on Despara’s actions, I am starting to think we are not different people, that I was always Desp—”

“NO!” Catra said sternly, grabbing Adora by the shoulder. “I refuse to believe that!”

Adora looked up in surprise at the vehemence in her wife’s voice; Catra was absolutely convinced of what she was saying.

“I know that when you had your empathy taken, Despara was born. It seems like a small difference, taking one thing from a person to change them into another, BUT it isn’t! Empathy is not a small thing, Adora; it’s HUGE! Believe me; I am the one who faced Despara, not you. When I looked at her, I did not see you, Adora —I promise you! I mean, who knows you better than me?”

Adora looked up into Catra’s face; her head was tilted with an almost shy smile on her lips. There was love in those yellow and blue eyes—something Adora didn’t see through Despara’s eyes

when she faced Catra. Adora looked down at her chest and touched the place just above and between her breasts; the heart rune instantly lit up, reflecting in Catra's gleaming eyes.

"You know, the whole time I was… *lost*… I don't remember seeing the heart rune on my chest. I don't know much about its magic, but I feel like it was bonded to me and only me. I think you may be right, Catra, although it's hard for me to accept, I—"

Adora found she could no longer form words as a wave of grief passed over her—she put her hands into her face as she began to weep anew. Catra gently pulled Adora's head into her lap as her wife sobbed openly, all the while stroking her black claws in the other's blonde hair.

"It's okay, Adora. I'm here," Catra said gently as tears appeared in her eyes as well.

Catra and Adora stayed this way for a moment, one overcome by sorrow and the other comforting in the best way she knew how. Soon though, Adora's fit of anguish passed, and she was still, staring at the opposite wall almost despondently.

"I'm changed, Catra. I mean, I don't think I will ever be the same again. I think I'm… *broken*… Do you really want to be with a broken Princess?" She asked.

Catra immediately let out a bark of laughter, surprising Adora, who sat up and stared at her wife incredulously.

"Seriously, Adora?" Catra said, still cackling. "Do you think you could get rid of me that easily?"

Catra reached out, placing her fingers on Adora's cheek.

"Of course, dummy. I mean, you just have a little more damage than before," she said with a wry grin. "Remember, you're with me, and I'm pretty damaged!"

Now it was Adora's turn to grin. "No, you're not, Catra! Stop! Look at what you've accomplished while I was gone—you removed the sword of Sher-Va from the Great Chailendra Tree and then became its new bearer. You're a Champion of Grayskull—like me! Then you singlehandedly stopped the Madgēcots from exterminating the Nephraeh and, if that was not enough—saved me! I mean, wow, Catra!"

Adora enjoyed the blush blooming on Catra's face; her wife was always embarrassed by genuine compliments.

"Yes, I did all that, Adora. But I did it while still carrying my baggage; it didn't go away. You will learn how to carry yours as well—with my help, of course! Oh! You can start going to therapy sessions with me! It's perfect!"

Adora laughed at this, pleased with the idea.

"Yeah, wouldn't that be something? Off to therapy, just you, me, and She—"

Adora broke off her sentence as Catra's eyes widened and her ears drooped. She had forgotten what happened to her friend; Shen had sacrificed himself to save Despara—to save Adora.

"Hey, Shen isn't your fault, Adora. You know that, right? I looked right into his eyes before he did it—it was his choice," Catra said.

Adora let out a heavy sigh as she looked forlornly at the ground—it wasn't that easy to label Shen's sacrifice as is or isn't someone's fault. She still felt responsible, and Catra knew it.

"I know, I know," Catra said eventually. "But you are not going to bear the burden alone. I asked him—no, pleaded for Shen to do something when I saw Despara being sucked into that portal. I did not want him to give up his life, but I was desperate. After he was gone, I kept asking myself if I knew what he was going to do, would I have stopped him?"

Catra let out a massive sigh of her own and rubbed her hands down over the tops of her legs as she leaned over.

"I didn't have the answer to that question—at least one I just couldn't admit aloud to myself. It was a big reason why I wandered down to the forest floor and ended up in front of the sword of Sher-Va.

I think that in the end, Shen would have been so happy to know that he gave his life for his friend and caused his other to take on the role of Champion. I miss him dearly—I really do—but so much good has come from what Shen did in the Relatively Forge. Without Sher-Va and the Truth, the Madgēcots probably would have destroyed the Nephraeh and become darker versions of themselves."

When Catra stopped talking, she noticed Adora was staring at her, a strange expression on her face.

"What?" Catra asked.

Adora's face changed into a broad smile—it was like the sun rising.

"You've changed, Catra. You've come a long way from Horde Captain Catra. I'm proud of you—you know that?" Adora said.

Catra rolled her eyes, but Adora saw her tail practically wag behind her; she recognized her wife's Madgēcot body language enough to know Catra was very happy to know this.

"Stoooop, Adora," Catra chided. Her wife's antics were doing wonders to lift Adora's mood, and she immediately felt her love for Catra well up inside her. I made her suddenly playful—something Adora had not felt in a long time—and she reached out to tickle Catra.

"I will not stop! It's true! I'm proud of my wittle Champion!" Adora teased as Catra tried to wriggle out of her grasp.

“No! I didn’t defeat Despara only to have you end up-Ahhh!” Catra squealed.

“You know what this means, don’t you? You’re a *Princess* now! *Princess* Catra! Your invitation to The All-Princess Ball is in the mail!” Adora said, reaching for Catra’s tender midsection.

“*I am NOT a Princess, Adora!*” Catra cried as she went on the offensive. “I am *Mahat,* not Princess!”

Adora found she could not stop laughing as Catra straddled her, pinning her in place to receive a relentless torrent of tickling. She tried to fight her wife off, but the sensation of Catra’s fingers finding all her most sensitive spots drained her will to fight back. In the end, Adora flopped onto her back, defeated. Catra stopped her torment but continued to sit on Adora, now gazing down at her meaningfully as her tail wrapped around Adora’s upper thigh. Catra was biting her lip as she looked into her wife’s eyes, her intention obvious.

“Do you think you’re ready, Adora? I mean, if you need more time…” Catra asked in a hopeful whisper.

Adora found that she had been holding her breath in anticipation. They had not been intimate since before she had been kidnapped; after their fight in the Hall of Lies, Adora had been too traumatized, and Catra was still healing for them to express their feelings for each other in that way. But now Adora felt she was ready and judging by the indicators from Catra, she was too.

“Yes, I am,” Adora said, reaching up to pull Catra down for a kiss. As their mouths and bodies met, Adora could not imagine an existence other than the one she shared with Catra. When Despara was at the fore of her consciousness, she had fought so hard to keep this union from happening, telling herself love was a shackle.

But Adora knew it was the opposite; love was freedom—freedom from the prison of the singular when joined with another soul.

When she was with Catra, anything was possible; the horizon was limitless, as was the boundless joy which sprung from both their hearts.

Adora focused on the sensation of Catra's tongue against hers, the feel of her wife's claws as they tickled up her thigh, seeking her most sensitive place. Just as she was near, Catra veered away, up to her belly button, circling it in scintillating caresses.

"Catra… stop teasing…" Adora gasped as the other nipped her ear.

"Your wish is my command… *Princess…*" Catra husked.

A sudden and loud knock from the door made Catra jump as Adora flopped her head back in exasperation.

"What is it with people interrupting us? Are we cursed?" Adora moaned.

"Whaaaaaat?!" Catra yelled at the door.

"It's me, Viraj. Sorry, am I interrupting something?" Catra's brother said through the door.

Catra groaned so loudly that there was no way Viraj didn't hear it through the door, especially with his Madgēcot ears.

"Okay, sorry, I will just tell them to come back later," he responded.

"No, no, no..." Adora called, earning an incredulous look from Catra. "We will get dressed and come down; tell them to hold on."

"*Adora!*" Catra hissed, her tail bushing up in annoyance.

Adora shrugged in response, her face sorrowful. "What? It could be important; besides, I just can't bring myself to push any of my friends away, especially after what I've been through. When Despara was in control, I had no one, I—"

Catra suddenly put a finger on Adora's lips, stifling her from further responding.

"Okay, okay—all right," Catra huffed. "Let's go—but this better be important!"

Both women begrudgingly got up from the bed to get dressed—Adora putting on a spare set of clothes left over from their honeymoon as Catra fetched her Jaadoo suit. Adora watched as her wife tossed the balled-up outfit in the air; at a command, it separated into individual sections which magically covered Catra's naked body. Fully dressed in her maroon outfit, Catra turned and winked at her, eliciting a thrill within Adora.

"That is sooo *neat* that you have a Jaadoo suit, Catra!" Adora exclaimed.

Catra only cackled in response. "Neat? Did you really say that? *Dork*."

Catra glided out of reach before Adora could swipe her butt in retaliation—opening the door quickly to stop any more shenanigans.

"Hey, guys!" Viraj said, giving a small wave.

"*Hey, bro,*" Catra said, shoving Viraj's shoulder with her own as she brushed past him.

"Ow!" Viraj complained, rubbing his shoulder.

Adora gave Catra's twin brother an apologetic smile as she followed Catra down the cylindrical wooden hall which led to the rest of the house Catra shared with her brother. Viraj, Catra, and Adora halted at the top of the magical ladder which led down to the main living space. There, they saw their friends waiting for them below; Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta, and Seahawk.

"Hey, guys!" Bow called, giving the same greeting and wave as Viraj.

Using their claws, Catra and Viraj scrambled down the magical field of the ladder as Adora followed in a clumsier fashion.

"Not interrupting anything, are we?" Glimmer asked with a sly grin.

"*Oh, no,*" Catra said, crossing her arms. "Just me finally getting some for the *first time in months!"*

"I feel your pain, sister," Seahawk answered in solidarity as Bow gave a nervous laugh.

Viraj suddenly looked at Catra and Seahawk; his handsome cinnamon face screwed up in uncertainty.

"Did Seahawk call Cat-Tra *sister*? I don't understand; she is my sister, and I don't see the relation between them."

Catra groaned as Entrapta suddenly brightened, her purple pigtails perking like two ears.

"Oh! I know this one!" She exclaimed, gloved finger pointing up at the ceiling. "It is not meant literally, but figuratively. To use terms such as brother and sister to an unrelated person, the speaker is indicating shared experiences, membership to a related group, or related senses!"

Viraj held his chin as he nodded. "Wow, that was a very clear and concise response—very helpful, Entrapta!"

Catra nudged her wife while giving her an eye-roll. "*Dummies*," she whispered as Adora chuckled.

"So, Catra's dusty libido aside, I'm sure you guys are wondering why we came." Glimmer said as Catra leered at her. "Well, we figured that with everything that happened recently, you two deserve the honeymoon you missed out on!"

Catra and Adora looked at each other uncertainly before responding.

"I mean, coming to Elysia was our honeymoon, and now we are back here, *soooo…*" Catra stated.

Glimmer shook her head fiercely. "No! You need to leave Elysia—no offense, Viraj! You would have constant reminders of what happened—almost losing each other. We have decided on a new place for you to go!"

Glimmer waved to Entrapta, who immediately pulled out her datapad. After pushing a button, the display lit up, showing an image of a tropical alien setting.

"Let me introduce you to beautiful Trellos-5!" Glimmer said with a beaming smile.

A glimmering beach of rainbows abutted a clear purple sea; both were under a pink sky with not a cloud in sight. Three moons of differing sizes gazed down on scantily clad members of various genders and species frolicking amongst yellow tropical trees. Adora saw Catra frown deeply as she stared at this spectacle, already knowing what her wife would say next.

"Sand? Are you serious?" Catra exclaimed. "Let me ask you: do you think having sand under your fur is fun? Oh wait, you don't have any fur—how would you know!?"

"Okay, okay," Glimmer said with placating hands. "We have a backup! Entrapta, next slide!"

The diminutive Princess brought up a new image; this time, instead of an idyllic nature setting, the data pad portrayed tall buildings as far as the eye could see under a backdrop of endless rain. Adora immediately recognized the planet; if the previous two descriptions didn't give it away, then the dazzling neon advertisements plastered on almost every surface was.

"You will all recognize Thenlor, I'm sure! *Show them the other slides!*" Glimmer said, waving a hand at Entrapta.

The following images included luxurious spas, elegant dining settings, extravagant accommodations, ritzy entertainment, and other delights a cultural metropolis could offer.

"As you now know, Double Trouble has become something of a big name of Thenlor, and they have graciously offered to comp you guys. Anything that they can't cover, the Bright Moon treasury can!" Glimmer said, almost squealing with excitement.

"Well… as long as I don't have to go outside in the rain, I think I can enjoy it," Catra mused. "What do you think, Adora?"

"Hmmm… I don't know. There are a lot of people there, Glimmer. I'm just not sure I'm ready for that," Adora answered.

Before Glimmer could respond, Adora continued.

"I just don't know if now is the right time for this Glimmer. Archon Lethe escaped, and we still have not captured Mermista and Scorpia yet. I don't think I could relax with all of them still out there—plus the Nephraeh need help rebuilding—"

Glimmer raised her hands to stifle Adora from saying anything more.

"Adora, come on. I want to get Scorpia and Mermista back and stop Lethe as much as you, but a galaxy is a big place—*they could be anywhere!* As for the Nephraeh, the Madgēcots are helping them recover—why don't you let us help you recover as well? You don't have to take on all the responsibility; you need a break, Adora. Come on—"

"Okay, okay!" Adora exclaimed with a sigh. "I get it. I will take a breather."

Adora turned to her wife and grasped her hand; Catra favored her with a small smile, nodding in agreement.

"How about somewhere quiet and interesting? Someplace with an old culture and fascinating history? I think that could be

romantic," Adora said, giving Catra's hand a slight squeeze.

"Hmm…" Glimmer said, thinking of a good choice. After a few seconds with no answer, Entrapta piped up.

"I know the perfect place!" She exclaimed. "Ever since we reentered this reality, I have been searching for the planets with the most information on the ancient history of the galaxy. The planet I have in mind fits your description! Its previous inhabitants abandoned it a thousand years ago—they left lots of old ruins and relics to explore. The current inhabitants have set up small settlements outside of the ancient cities; they are mostly explorers and scholars who are there to study the ancient culture." She said excitedly.

Adora turned to Catra. "What do you think of my idea? Sound like someplace you want to go?"

Catra gave a noncommittal shrug. "Sounds a little boring, but as long as you are there, it sounds like a great place."

Adora beamed back at her wife; she expected nothing less from the love of her life.

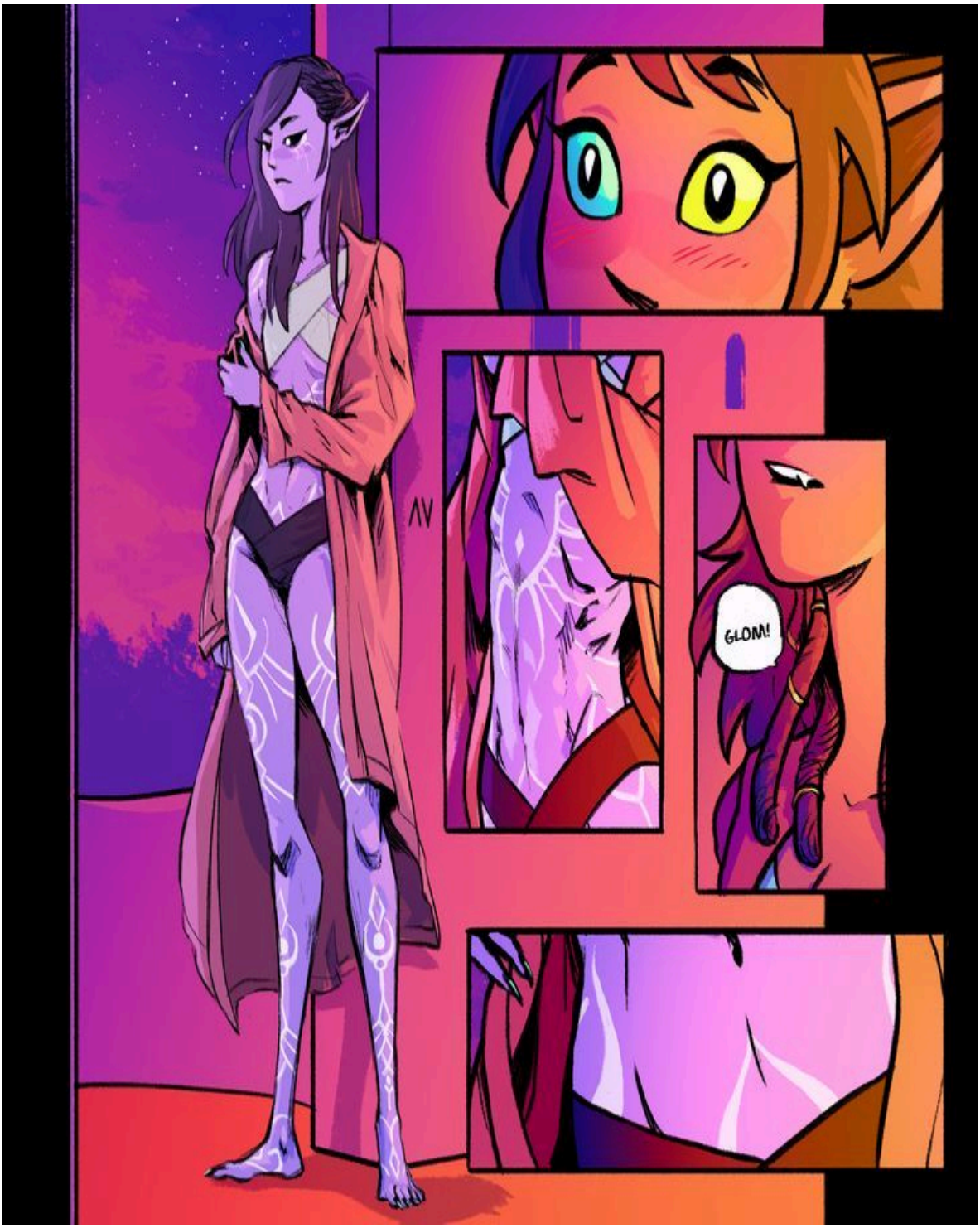
"Oh, Catra, it won't be boring," Entrapta said with a wide smile.

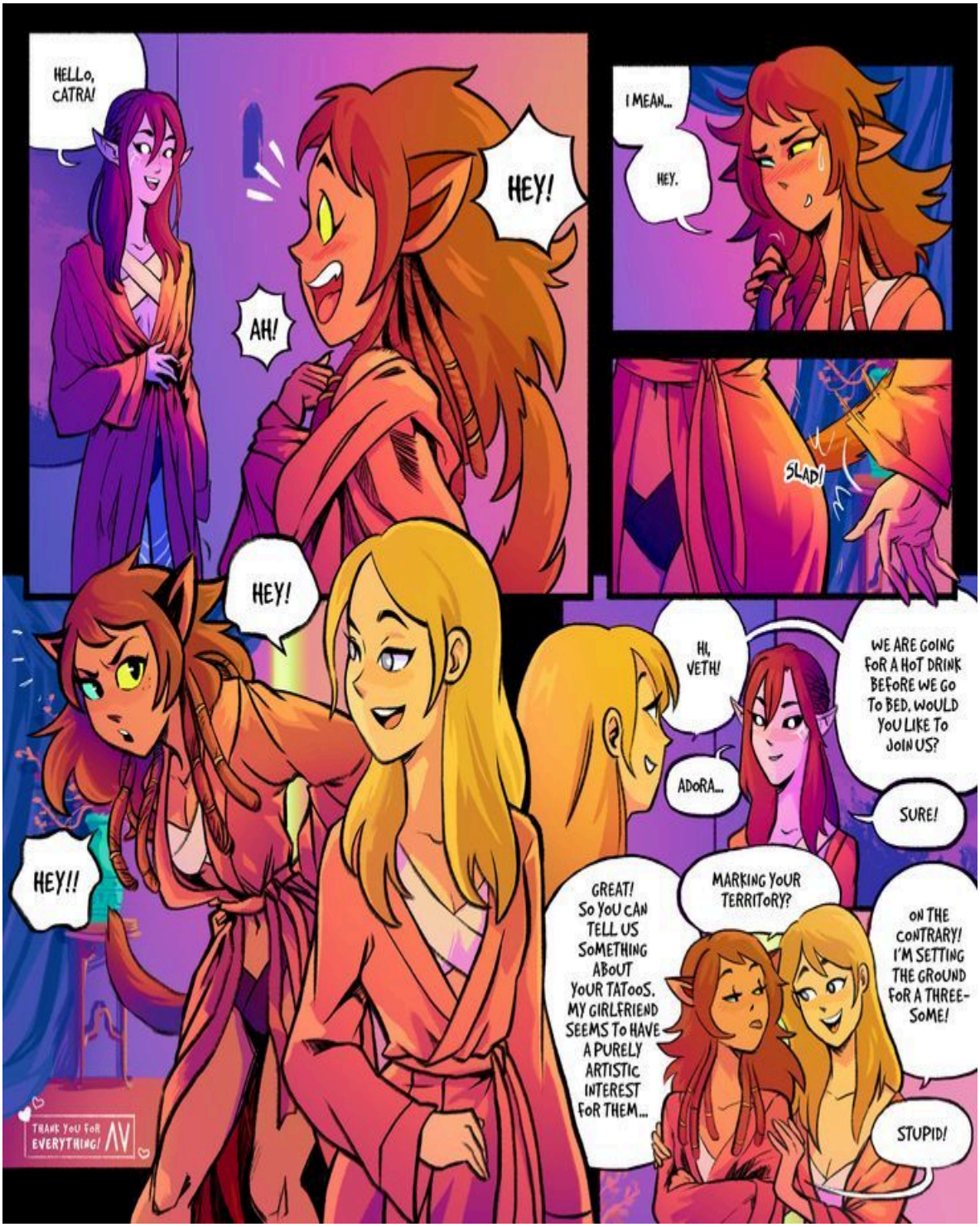
"So, what's this awesome place called, and why haven't you told me about it, Entrapta?" Glimmer complained with hands held up in the air.

Entrapta shrugged. "I don't know; I didn't think you would be interested. Only inquisitive Princesses like myself would care about the planet Trolla,"

Well, that's it for Book III! Stay tuned for Book IV: Zhe-La coming soon! I

In the meantime, enjoy this comic my friend AV made for me! The first panel illustrates a scene from earlier in this story, but the second panel is AV having a little fun with 'potential scenarios ;) ;) ;)





Chapter End Notes

She-Ra/Adora and Catra illustration by Henar Torinos a.k.a. Ilikeyoucatradora

Mini-comic by fan_fun_off a.k.a. AV Stravaganza

Something Wicked This Way Comes... (BOOK IV: ZHE-LA)

Chapter Summary

Evil maneuvers into position, ready to make its final move.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

BOOK IV

ZHE-LA



Deras drove the Sekth hard through the Ghoul's Woods, desperate to escape the horrors he had seen behind him. The beast was covered in lathered sweat from having been ridden at a gallop for half an hour, and Deras felt a momentary pang of guilt for pushing the creature too hard. But after catching sight of a shadow behind one of the forest's many gnarled trees, he dug his heels in, goading the Sekth to even greater heights of speed.

The day had started out so great; Castaspella had sent Deras on an errand to Eternos for more supplies, and he was excited to get out of dreary Castle Grayskull for a while. He had spent much of the morning catching the sights the city had to offer before setting to his task in the afternoon. But by then, the sky had become bruised and overcast, and he forswore any further frivolities, wanting to be back at the castle before any nasty weather hit. First on the list was more Red Cochineal for Castaspella's potions which took him to the more esoteric shops in the interior of Eternos, near the Legislative District.

That was when it happened.

As Deras was walking out of Blackward's Mixtures, the sound of a great many people screaming caught his attention. He turned towards the source of the commotion; The High Council Basilica on the other end of the street shared with the shop he had just exited. Terrified people were pouring out of the massive double doors of the building's entrance, running at full sprint to escape whatever was within. Just as Deras thought his fear was at its peak, he spotted *them*—inky black figures moving like slippery shadows after the fleeing civilians.

At first, Deras thought he was seeing things; their movements were too smooth to be natural. But when one of the creatures caught a victim and hurled them to the ground, conviction filled Deras as it leaped upon them to sink its teeth into the victem's neck. He knew right away what he was witnessing and what kind

of foulness had come to Eternos, for he had read about it in his favorite childhood story—*The Glenmar Ghoul*.

"Vampires!" Deras shrieked.

At hearing his cry, two of the black monsters whipped their sleek heads around to look in his direction—their eyes like black holes and mouths open in hunger. Deras clamped his mouth closed and ran, seeking to escape the Legislative District and find safety in the outlying areas of Eternos. This hope was squashed as he spotted more of the creatures—vampires, he now knew—appearing from dark alleys, open windows leading to unlit rooms, and even storm drains. It was as if they were summoned from every place light was absent, straight from the nether regions which exist between realities.

The city of Eternos was in tumult as Deras came to the mechanical lift which descended from the escarpment and to the plain below—it was packed with frightened people, desperate to flee the city. Cursing to himself, he turned to the more reliable form of escape; stone stairs that zigzagged down the precarious cliff side. Once fully down from the rocky plateau, Deras raced to the stables, hoping that someone had not stolen his only ride back to Grayskull. He was relieved to find his Sekth—whom he had named Solymer—was still there but extremely agitated; it seemed that the beast could sense the disaster spreading throughout the city and was as eager to be away from this place.

A branch slapped Deras in the face as Solymer thundered down the dirt road, making him wince and almost lose the reigns. Seeing brightness ahead, Deras recognized a break in the trees; hopefully, he would soon be free of this dread forest.

Deras ducked just in time to miss a clawed hand reaching for him from above. Looking furtively back, he spotted one of the vampires crouched on a bough, watching him with obsidian eyes.

"Nice try, bloodsucker!" He taunted back at it—but then yelped as more dark shapes rushed out from behind nearby trees, seeking

to thwart him.

"Fly, Solymer, FLY!" He screamed. The Sekth wheezed as it poured its slowly dwindling reserves into escaping the grasping hands, and together, both Deras and his steed burst out of the forest and into the dying light of the cursed day.

"We did it, Solymer! We escaped those foul vampires! Just wait until I tell Mich—AHHHH!!!"

Deras found himself soaring over Sekth's head as it came to a complete halt, and he slammed into the ground hard, close to passing out. Through his disoriented field of vision, he ascertained a fully cloaked figure standing in the middle of the road in front of him. Turning his head, he spotted Solymer trotting away through the open plains, not even bothering to look back at her rider.

"Thanks a lot, Solymer," he muttered as he rose unsteadily to his feet.

Turning to the person responsible for losing his mount, he discovered a dark-skinned face under the hood, peering at him with brown eyes. It was a woman—and a pretty one at that.

"Hey! We need to get out of here—there are vampires after me! They are all over Eternos and…"

Dera's voice died off as the woman began to laugh; it was high-pitched and cruel, and he immediately knew she was no friend.

"Vampires?!" She asked incredulously. "Like, you read too many children's books! *The Glenmar Ghoul*, am I right? Loved that one."

She started walking towards Deras then, and he noticed a long staff in her hand, topped by a glowing crystal orb.

"You are from Etheria?" Deras asked as he began to back away. He was abruptly halted as he came up against another person—whirling—he found himself looking up at a large woman. Short white hair topped a face that would be good-looking if it wasn't

set in a cruel leer; Deras felt like he recognized her from somewhere but couldn't put a name to the face.

"What do you think, Scorpia? Do you think *vampire* is a good name for the Vetala?" The dark-skinned woman asked.

The imposing woman—Scorpia—gave a harsh laugh before pushing Deras away; he landed hard on his rear.

"No, I don't. Vampires don't exist, and if they did, they only take. The Vetala are different; *they give*." She said simply.

"Wh—what do they give?" Deras asked meekly.

Scorpia raised her arm and pointed—not with a normal hand—but with a large, red claw.

"You're about to find out." She said ominously.

Sensing movement all around him, Deras spun, seeing that he was surrounded by the terrible creatures that had hounded him all the way from Eternos. They walked towards him slowly, holding their slender arms out from their bodies, hands open to catch him if he dared to flee.

Now that he could see them close, he noted that their glossy bodies were without clothes; they moved with a grace that was almost seductive in their approach. His addled brain was confused by the duality of whether he was attracted by these beings or utterly repelled, and he froze in place. Scorpia pushed him forward with a cruel laugh, and he found himself caught in the arms of the nearest monster; it was strong and held him fast against its frigid body. As it cupped the back of his head in one hand, the Vetala opened its mouth, revealing rows of serrated black teeth that immediately clamped on his neck in ravenous hunger. As Deras felt his compassion being sucked from his soul, he found Scorpia beaming at him over the Vetala's shoulder.

"Freedom," she said triumphantly. "They give us freedom!"

* * *

Reaching up with the pruners, Perfuma clipped the withered branch from the Spider Tree, making way for new growth. She caught the dead limb in one hand deft hand, closing her fingers around it to disintegrate it with a flash of yellow light. Perfuma then opened her hand and tilted it, depositing the remaining mulch onto the soil before looking for another branch. Anyone watching this process would have wondered how the beautiful Princess could distinguish between what was corrupted and what was pure on such a hideous-looking tree.

Spider Trees were not native to Eternia but had started growling there during the planet's time in the realm of Night, sharing an obvious similarity with their namesake; numerous spindly branches spouted from a bulbous trunk, the entire plant covered in black bark to camouflage it in the eternal night.

Extremely sour fruit called Venom Berries grew from this plant—a staple in the Eternian diet and found in many pastries. Perfuma had planted a grove of them in the rear bailey of Castle Grayskull, using the power of the Life Gem to accelerate the growth process.

Micah had commented that such a malevolent-looking tree would not be affected by the positive magic of her Staff of Power, but Perfuma had just laughed this off. Unattractive as it was, the Spider Tree was neither bad nor good, but it was alive and therefore, bound by the power of the Life Gem.

Perfuma found herself quite taken by the Spider Trees; they reminded her of another plant she had thought she could not connect with—the Cactus. Perfuma had felt she could not control the prickly fauna, not seeing any way to relate to its harsh exterior. Only when she looked deeper inside herself and under the ground did she find understanding—the roots. Thus the basis for everything that lives—everything is connected and intertwined.

Leaning over to pick up the dead branch, Perfuma gasped as a sudden coldness permeated her body, chilling her very soul.

"Wh—what was that?" She said aloud, leaning upon her staff.

Through her connection to the Life Gem, Perfuma could feel every single living being on Eternia and nearby Etheria. What she had just felt was a powerful disturbance—not the sudden absence of life, but the mass distortion of it—as if many beings were losing a crucial part of their nature. Perfuma could tell this was happening to sentient beings based on the disharmony of their essence, and it was close, most likely here on Eternia. What was happening to these people was innately wrong; it was making them evil, and Perfuma knew at once what was happening, for it had happened to the love of her life—Scorpia.

Somehow, a great number of Eternians had just had their empathy removed.

Perfuma looked down at the decayed tree branch, perceiving a connection between her vision and what she was trying to achieve with her gardening. Through the power of the Life Gem, she could cut the threads of this darker life spreading through the planet; it was only a simple matter of concentration.

"No, something bad is happening to them. But that does not mean they are lost—I cannot believe that!" She said, shutting her eyes against the tears. Perfuma did not want to follow that path to its conclusion; only heartache was found there.

Perfuma focused her great power on the spreading darkness, and instead of trying to stop the spreading darkness, she focused on it, searching for the source. Much like her friend Glimmer was able to, Perfuma's spirit left her body as she astral projected upward until her viewpoint hovered high over Castle Grayskull. From this vantage point, she turned east, gazing across the rocky wastes, over the mighty Simbar River nestled amongst the Fertile Plains, to the Randor Flatlands just beyond the Ghouls' Woods. But instead of finding Eternos sitting upon its rocky plateau, Perfuma only saw a terrible storm of black clouds and purple lightning. She knew there was no actual storm surrounding Eternos; it was only

a representation of the dark power there in the ethereal plan she now inhabited.

The storm swirled in upon itself like a cyclone as arcs of coruscating dark energy blasted the surrounding landscape. Amongst the fury of this tempest, Perfuma thought she could see a figure at its epicenter, holding out mighty hands as if conducting a symphony of ruin. Feeling bold, she moved her spirit closer, wanting to get a clearer view of what was obviously the source of the malevolence.

Perfuma instantly regretted it.

Moving languidly at first, the immense figure suddenly whipped around, pining her in place with two bright indigo eyes. Perfuma felt terrified as her astral body was held in place and quailed under the gaze of this terrible god. As the storm parted slightly, Perfuma could see a lithe silhouette, a black cut-out against the reality of this existence. She could sense great malice and obscene intent from this being—they sought ultimate domination through selfish perversion and would not stop until they brought everyone to ruin.

Far below this being, creatures emerged from the bottom of the storm; they were a much smaller version of this dark god, and they came pouring forward like a torrent of destruction. As this happened, the mighty being lifted a slender arm and pointed a clawed finger directly at her trapped spirit as their voice boomed.

I'M COMING FOR YOUUUUUUUU…

Perfuma's spirit screamed as she was hurled back across the landscape of Eternia and all the way back into her physical body. Finding herself lying on the soft ground of her garden, Perfuma rose to her feet, Life Gem Staff in hand.

"I have to tell the others!" She said in a panic, running back into the castle.

* * *

With hands outstretched and fingers splayed, Micah worked his arcane art upon one of the seven pylons inside the Annex, deep under Castle Grayskull. Invocation rings glowed blue around each wrist as Micah performed a simple spell, the intent of which was to identify which Champion this specific pylon was for.

The runes on each pylon were no help in this regard; Perfuma had since translated them, saying they appeared to be warding hexes for a spell so advanced that it was beyond the capabilities of Sorcerers such as Micah and his sister, Castaspella. These same wards thwarted Micha's current efforts, and the Master Sorcerer looked at his writs forlornly as his active magic abruptly dispersed.

"Blasted thing just can't be tampered with," Micah cursed. "Cassey, why don't you come over here and give me a hand reinforcing my spell? Cassie?"

Micah watched as his sister stared at the Well of Champion Spirits, one manicured fingernail to her lips as she contemplated what she beheld.

"What is it, Cassie?" Micah said as he came to stand next to her.

Looking inside the transparent crystal, Micah noted that the Spirits for Thon-Ra and He-Ro appeared very agitated—as if both wanted desperately to get out. Where before the two ethereal beings had gently bobbed and glided inside their resting place, now they zipped about, bouncing off the inside surface of the Well.

"What do you think has them so upset?" Castaspella asked.

Micah shook his head. "I don't know. It's like they are sensing something they don't like. Whatever can upset a Champion Spirit can't be good."

Before he could comment further on the matter, someone burst through the magical opening to the Annex, making everyone inside jump. It was Perfuma; the Princess of growing things looked wild-eyed and frantic as she cast about the wondrous cavern, panting heavily.

“Something is coming!!!” Perfuma shouted, making the already nervous scribes start to mutter and whisper.

Castaspella and Micah rushed to their friend, each sibling taking one of Perfuma’s arms to comfort her.

“What is coming, Perfuma?” Castaspella inquired.

As Perfuma turned in her direction, Castaspella noticed the Princesses eyes did not focus on her but on something else—a vision of horror. Perfuma’s mouth parted as she worked through the process of trying to find the words for what she wanted to say. Finally, she spoke.

“Something… *wicked…*” She breathed. “They saw me; they are coming… HERE!”

Micah looked worriedly from Perfuma to the Well, where the Spirits were still behaving erratically.

“Can you be more specific?” Castaspella asked, not unkindly.

Perfuma suddenly turned and gripped the older woman by the shoulders, startling her.

“I felt a great disturbance through the Life Gem, coming from Eternos! Somehow, everyone there just had their empathy taken from them—like with Scorpia! Whoever is responsible for it is here, on Eternia! They saw me!” Perfuma said breathlessly.

“Who?” Castaspella asked, fear in her voice now.

Perfuma shook her head. “I don’t know. From my experiences on Elysia, what I saw looked like a Nephraeh. It could be the leader they call Archon Lethe—but that is only a guess! All I know is that from the power I sense, nothing here in Castle Grayskull can stop them! We need to leave, NOW!”

“What are you saying? That we should abandon the most powerful place in the universe and let someone horrible just take

it?” Micah asked incredulously.

Perfuma seemed to get a hold of herself at that moment; the scope of the questions being asked allowed her to focus.

“No. We don’t just let them have it. But the scribes and everyone else should flee—plus someone must get help!” She said.

Micah’s face hardened with resolve. “You ladies should go. Find my daughter and her friends; they will stop this madness! I will stay and fight—to die if I have to!”

Perfuma looked at Micah, her face regaining some of its composure as she laid a hand on one of his broad shoulders.

“No, I am the most powerful sorcerer here, plus I feel like I am the guardian of this place,” she said, waving a slender hand around her. “I will stay and fight—you two find Glimmer.”

Micah and Castaspella looked at each other uncertainly.

“It’s not up for debate,” Perfuma said, raising the Life Gem staff and tapping the end on the stone floor. “Go,”

Micah nodded and turned to the many scholars and scribes currently watching the debate taking place.

“You heard her! Everyone out, hurry! I don’t know how we will get off planet with Eternos gone; we will have to try and ride for Drisdos. Hopefully, we can find a ship there!” He yelled.

As everyone bustled out of the Annex through the magical door, Micah turned to Perfuma.

“Good luck, Perfuma. I wish it were me staying,” he said sadly.

Perfuma smiled. “I know you do. If you ever do help get her back, tell Scorpia that I love her,”

* * *

Gusts of wind blew across the empty road leading to Castle Grayskull, creating small dust devils which whirled across the stone surface. Three of these mini tornados merged into one that proceeded in the castle's direction—abruptly, the dust devil dispersed, and a large, cloaked figure materialized; they continued along the road, walking with a grace that belied great power. Reaching up with black-stained hands, they pulled down their hood to gaze upon the place they had sought for more than a thousand years.

“Ah, there you are. It’s been a very, very long time,” Lethe said with a black smile.

Two more figures appeared to either side of Lethe who turned to regard their newly arrived minions with a single raised white eyebrow.

“My Archon, we caught the one who had escaped the city, and he has been enervated. No one in the castle should know of our arrival,” Scorpia said with head bowed.

Lethe sighed heavily. “Scorpia, My Child, how often do I have to tell you? I am no longer Archon of the Nephraeh; I am simply Lethe. Please, please, remember next time,”

Scorpia bobbed her head up and down in subservience as Mermista crossed her arms, giving her a scornful shake of the head.

“Also, I told you not to bother with that one. Someone at the castle already knows we are coming. Someone you are already very familiar with,” Lethe continued in their lecturing tone.

Recognition lit up Scorpia’s face, combined with another more subtle emotion Lethe could not place a finger on.

“You mean Perfuma, my Arch—I mean, Lethe?” She asked.

“That’s the one,” Lethe said while emphasizing by tapping at the air with a clawed finger.

“Is that going to be a problem, Scorpia?” Mermista asked tersely.

Scorpia whirled on the other, clawed hands snapping with fury.

“Of course not! Why would it be a problem?” She snarled. “Maybe we will run into Seahawk, and we will both get a chance to show Lethe how loyal we are! What do you say, Mermista? Do you think you could kill him?”

The other fallen Princess hissed with rage as she lifted the Kinetic Krystal threateningly, but before the altercation could get serious, Lethe laid hands on both of their shoulders, holding them in place.

“My Children, what is with all this strife? You are both loyal to me, and I know it.” Lethe said soothingly.

Scorpia and Mermista shared one last glare before nodding obediently to their lord.

“Now, enough of this foolishness—we have a castle to take!” Lethe said, clapping their hands together in excitement. They felt so good at this moment—not only at being so close to their ultimate goal but also at how powerful they felt. They could not remember feeling this robust; they were bloated from the amount of compassion they had fed upon since arriving on this planet. The Nephraeh may have more empathy individually, but there are just more people on Eternia—plus, once they had seized their souls, Lethe didn’t have to fight as hard to maintain their hold. They hadn’t realized how worn out they were from trying to dominate the Nephraeh for a millennium; now it was mere child’s play—it was almost too easy now that they were away from Empyrea.

Lethe felt like a flame now free from the confines of the candle and allowed to spread; with Castle Grayskull before them, they would soon burn everything, everywhere at once. There would be no hiding from the hunger of Lethe.

* * *

Perfuma had difficulty stopping herself from shaking as she stood before the closed drawbridge inside Castle Grayskull—terrified and alone—she was the only person left to stand before the approaching terror. Perfuma had never been in this position before; there had always been someone at her side, ready to help bear the burden. Treacherously, her mind pulled her in a sad direction, and Perfuma could not help wishing that Scorpia was with her; the indomitable presence of her soulmate was sorely missed at this moment.

With a loud groan, the drawbridge began lower as the ancient and magical mechanism of Castle Grayskull was overcome by an outside force. Perfuma prepared herself for the coming confrontation, the beautiful Princess finding steel in her resolve, making her grit her teeth in anger. There was a significant amount of rage within Perfuma, a well of fury she had spent a lifetime trying to manage.

As the drawbridge was nearing its full extension, Perfuma released that pent-up emotion, using it to fuel her offensive magic. With a resounding boom, the bridge to Castle Grayskull's gaping maw was fully extended, and Perfuma could finally see her enemies. There, standing on the other end of the drawbridge, stood three robed figures—the most obvious one was a giant in a black robe, the hood drawn back to review a beautiful white face with two burning eyes. She recognized this person as the powerful being from her vision, knowing them as the source of all the misfortune that had come to Eternia. The person to their left was known to her, for Perfuma would recognize her fellow Princess anywhere.

If Mermista is here, then that means… She thought, immediately trying to see the face under the hood of the last figure. As they raised their head, the bravery that Perfuma had worked so hard to summon almost completely evaporated. She had got her wish—the one person Perfuma wanted so much to be by her side was there, but not in the way she wanted.

"SCORPIA!!!" Perfuma screamed.

Her soulmate stared back at her, not giving any indication she had heard her—or if she did—did not care.

“Scorpia, please! Come to me! Help me; I need you now!” Cried Perfuma.

Scorpia turned to the giant beside her, looking uncertainly at them. When she turned back to Perfuma, her face was set in stone—immediately, Perfuma knew that no help would come to her from the one she loved, and there was nothing to keep her heart from breaking.

“I know this isn’t you, Scorpia,” Perfuma called. “I love you,”

Scorpia grimaced before glancing nervously at the mighty being. She then spat on the ground before finally responding.

“*I’m going to kill you, Perfuma,*”

The words had their intended effect as Perfuma felt an icy lance directly through her heart. As much as she knew this was not the person she fell in love with, there was no defense against what Scorpia had just said, and a tremor overcame Perfuma’s body as tears began to streak down her face. Despite this, the Guardian of Castle Grayskull stood her ground, lifting her Staff of Power against those who would trespass into her domain.

“You will not pass,” Perfuma said.


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The giant smiled at this; there was no mockery on those attractive pale features, only pity.

“You poor thing,” they said. “You are shaking all over—you are terrified! Why don’t you come over to us? It will be better that way—you can be with your Scorpia once more!”

Perfuma watched them raise their arm and offer out their hand, but when she spotted the stains that ran from claw-tips all the way up past their wrists, she shook her head.

“No. I saw you earlier—I know what you are. You have nothing to offer but tragedy and despair. I reject you—whatever you are.” Perfuma said firmly.

The being looked confused at her words, and they looked down at their outstretched hand forlornly. After a moment, they closed their hand, pulling it back inside the folds of their voluminous robe.

“Very well,” they said solemnly. “We will do this the hard way.”

Before they had finished speaking, Perfuma screamed as she slammed the butt of her staff on the stone floor of Castle Grayskull. The Life Gem flashed with golden brilliance as waves of its power bathed the three attackers; immediately, both Scorpia and Mermista froze in place as the very cells of their bodies refused to respond to their will. But where Perfuma sensed life in the two fallen Princesses, there was none in the third. She felt this one was beyond the strictures of mere existence and governed by a set of rules beyond that of morals.

“What are you?” She breathed.

“I am simply Lethe, My Child. I am your salvation,” they said, walking towards her across the drawbridge.

At that moment, Perfuma reached out, calling on every speck of living matter she could find. Castle Grayskull was deep in the desolate waste, where nothing supposedly lived. But there was life

there, and Perfuma called out to it in absolute desperation. From the colonies of lichen buried deep within the scorched rock to the microorganisms which rode the air currents, Perfuma drew them all in, forming into a single mass. A golem took shape, three times the height of any other one she had summoned previously—it roared as it stomped across the waste in defense of its mistress.

"Impressive," Lethe said, raising their black-stained hands. "Zzar once attacked me in their fashion and drove me from Castle Grayskull. Unfortunately for you, I've learned a few tricks since then."

Bright beams of indigo lanced out from each of Lethe's fingertips and alighted on the charging golem; it shrieked with rage as its body began to immolate, crashing down upon the ground in a smoking ruin. But its life was not extinguished—it surged forward in a torrent of living matter that gushed over Lethe, appearing to sweep them from the bridge.

ENOUGH

The voice seemed to come everywhere at once, outside and inside her head, and Perfuma cringed against its power of it, loosening her hold on Scorpia and Perfuma. Now free, both of the fallen Princesses called upon their individual Ultimate Powers to hurl magical attacks at the defender of Castle Grayskull. Perfuma's staff vibrated out of her hand as it was overcome by high-frequency oscillations, leaving her defenseless against the annihilating void orb howling in her direction.

NO WE NEED HER

A shimmering wall of purple light deflected Scorpia's killing blow just as it was about to hit Perfuma, sending it moaning up into the sky. As the barrier disappeared, Perfuma watched as the pile of living matter she had summoned sizzle and pop as it evaporated into non-existence, revealing the standing form of Lethe. They were still on the extended bridge, and not a single white hair seemed out of place as they scowled down at their minion.

“You fool! We may need her alive! I should kill you for almost ruining my plans!” Lethe raged.

Scorpia was immediately on her knees before Lethe, head lowered in contrition.

“My lord, I was only trying to kill her to prove my worthiness to you!” She pleaded.

Perfuma could not help feeling revulsion at seeing her soulmate ingratiate herself with a monster. Swallowing her bile, Perfuma made towards her staff, intent on continuing the fight.

“You are wise to demonstrate your fealty to me; just try not to be so overeager. Think Scorpia!” Lethe said as they absentmindedly reached towards Perfuma. Just as she was about to grasp the Life Gem staff, it zipped away to land on Lethe’s open palm. Perfuma moaned in absolute defeat, bowing her head momentarily before raising it back up. When she did, she found Lethe directly before her, staring down at her with their eerie indigo eyes. She screamed as she tried to lunge away from Lethe, only to find herself stopped by Scorpio’s familiar body. Perfuma was immediately wrapped by two brawny arms, holding her fast as Lethe gloated over her.

“Now, my dear,” Lethe said as they cupped her chin. “Time to give me a tour of *your castle*. It’s been a while since I was here, and there is much I wish to be reacquainted with.”

* * *

Holding her head in shame, Perfuma allowed herself to be escorted down into the bowels of Castle Grayskull—the one known as Lethe leading them all through the various tunnels and catacombs. Perfuma had a sense that Lethe had been here before, for they knew the dungeon as if by memory, continuously taking the correct turn to lead them deeper into the ground. Occasionally, Perfuma would feel a clawed hand push her from behind, goading her forward whenever she lessened her pace,

and she tried not to think about the person behind her; the pain of that thought made her want to weep even more than she already had.

It's not Scorpia—it's another person who is in her body, she told herself, and not for the first time.

When Lethe insisted they bring her down here, Perfuma thought it was for one of the Abominable Powers. But when she recognized that Lethe was following the magical sconces Micah had placed, she knew where they were headed—The Vestibule.

The blue light emitted by the torches cast eerie shadows along the green stone walls; they danced with the movement of the magical flame. With a creeping sense of dread, Perfuma noticed that the biggest one amongst them did not cast a silhouette; Lethe seemed to absorb all light, like a bottomless pit of darkness.

They are so vile! I cannot lead them to the Vestibule! Perfuma realized.

Suddenly whirling, Perfuma lunged at Mermista who was holding her Life Gem staff. But the other Princess somehow knew this was coming, and before Perfuma could lay a land on her, a shimmering field of kinetic force slammed her backward and onto the ground.

"Careful! We may need her!" Lethe warned.

Both Scorpia and Mermista stood over the downed Perfuma, looking down at her with cruel smiles.

"I can't imagine what we need her for," Scorpia stated.

"Well, that's because you can't imagine anything—*you're dumb, Scorpia,*" Mermista replied.

"STOP!!!" Perfuma shrieked just as Scorpia was about to reply to the insult. Both fallen Princess looked down at her skeptically.

"Stop what? Be specific," Mermista asked, bored.

“St—stop… being… *so horrible!*” Perfuma gasped, grief-stricken. “I just can’t take seeing you both like this!”

Scorpia and Mermista turned away from the weeping Princess, rolling their eyes in disgust as she curled up into a fetal position. Perfuma just wanted to disappear as she felt the pins and needles presence of Lethe, coming to stand over her.

“Get up, Princess. This drama is unseemly.” They said simply.

“No!” She responded, adamant.

“Have it your way,” Lethe said. With their height and long arms, Lethe reached for not Perfuma—but Scorpia, drawing the bearer of the Void Gem close to them. Perfuma looked up to see a black-stained hand cupping the underside of Scorpia’s chin; talons pressed into the skin of her throat.

“Is my intent clear?” Lethe asked as Scorpia looked nervously down at their hand.

“You monster!” Perfuma cried, clenching her fists. Lethe had her, and they knew it. Resentfully, Perfuma rose to her feet, ready and willing to comply with Lethe’s demands. They immediately released Scorpia’s throat and turned with a laugh, flicking their long white hair over one shoulder.

“Are you okay?” Perfuma asked, laying a gentle hand on one of the large red claws.

There was fear in Scorpia’s big dark eyes, and Perfuma found she wanted to hold the bigger woman very dearly. But Scorpia pulled her claw away gently and turned to follow her cruel master.

“I’m fine; it was nothing,” she said tonelessly.

The rest of the journey through the murky corridors was uneventful, Lethe stopping here and there to consider different doors; their reasons known only to them. When they stopped

before the putrid and slimy chamber holding the Gastrolith of Decay, they looked at it as if they were trying to solve a puzzle.

"What is it, my lord?" Mermista asked.

"This door is familiar—like it was important to me long ago. But now I cannot remember why," Lethe had said before waving a dismissive hand. "It's not important, My Child. Come, let's resume our journey,"

It wasn't long before Perfuma was staring dolefully at the flat stone surface that marked the entrance to the Vestibule. Making no indication she knew where they were, Perfuma decided just to see what Lethe would do. She watched as they reached out, brushing black fingers across the smooth rock, their sharp nails clicking as they slid over the inscribed runes.

"I've only been here once, a very, very long time ago, and I have spent almost that long just waiting to get back." Lethe breathed.

They turned to Mermista and Scorpia, their white face bright with glee.

"Would you please do me the honor, My Children?" Lethe asked.

Scorpia hesitated as Mermista stepped up, raising the Kinetic Krystal to light the inscription with its lambent glow.

"I dabbled in First One's runes in Salineas before they drove me out; reading this is a cinch," Mermista said confidently.

Holding her chin in one hand, Mermista squinted as she concentrated on what was written before her.

"*Defenders of Grayskull, speak virtue and enter,*" Mermista said, scrunching her nose. "What the heck does that mean?"

Lethe laughed to themselves, much like a doting parent watching their children learn a new concept.

“It’s a little riddle, My Children! The builders of this place locked the greatest power in all the infinite existences behind a silly little riddle! How foolish is that?” Lethe asked with a sickening giggle.

“So, we name a virtue, and the door opens?” Scorpia replied.

“Oh, look! She smarter than she looks!” Mermista quipped.

Perfuma could not help the anger rising in her chest—she hated how Mermista kept talking down to Scorpia.

“She is smart! And I’m sure she knows the answer too!” Perfuma cried.

Scorpia glowered at a Mermista; her mouth turned down in a slight frown.

“You know what it is, don’t you, Scorpia? You know it because you still feel it for me,” Perfuma whispered hopefully. She slowly approached the larger woman, clutching her hands before her face.

“Do you know what she is talking about, My Child?” Lethe asked.

Scorpia turned to them, her face expressionless.

“Love. She is talking about love, my lord,” Scorpia said.

Both of Lethe’s white eyebrows raised in surprise, and they gave a slight nod.

“You are absolutely correct, My Child,” they said as they reached out and passed their hand through what was just a solid surface a few moments ago. “I got it on my first try as well. Interesting,”

Perfuma felt terror at the way Lethe was gazing at Scorpia with those intense indigo eyes, but after a moment, they turned from her to pass through the wall and into the Vestibule beyond.

“Let’s go, Princess,” Mermista said, shoving Perfuma through the door.

Once inside the Vestibule, she noted Lethe had already made their way in and was standing before the Well of Avatar Spirits. Both He-Ro and Thon-Ra were pointed at the intruder, their radiant forms taking on a very aggressive aspect. Perfuma had never seen them do that before.

“How have you been, my friends? I only just ran into He-Ro—Thon-Ra; how long has it been? I haven’t seen you were bound to that hideous Qer’kek—what was her name?” Lethe asked with a grin.

The spirit of Thon-Ra did not respond, nor did He-Ro, as they both continued to float in place, standing their ground before the dark being in front of them.

“Bah! Your no fun!” Lethe said finally before they turned to regard the pylons.

“What is next, My Lord?” Mermista asked as she brought Perfuma forward to stand next to the massive being. Lethe nodded curtly at this.

“Yes—on to that. Time is not on our side. We must move quickly.” They said, placing their hands behind their back as they started to pace. “First, we must finish our conquest of Eternia by using the Vetala and the Enervated we have managed to turn to our cause. Once that is finished, we must also invade Etheria, solidifying our hold on that planet. With only a few Princesses and no Guardians there, it should be no problem. We need to fortify our position to give us some breathing room in which to work.” they said.

“What about—*what did you call it*—Subternia?” Scorpia piped up. “Don’t we need all the Champions to open the portal to it? I only count two Champions—how will we get the rest if we are bunkered down here?”

Lethe let out a soft chuckle at this, the sound like gas escaping a corpse’s mouth.

“Oh, My Child, we don’t have to go to them. We have Castle Grayskull—the Champions will come to us!”

Chapter End Notes

Book IV cover illustration by Henar Torinos, a.k.a. ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Twitter

Grayskull and Perfuma illustration by Iria Abella, a.k.a ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Twitter

Timeless

Chapter Summary

Veth struggles with their new situation as they come to terms with what it means to be a Nephraeh unbound by Archon Lethe's restrictions.

Shen finds himself with a very testy travel companion.

Both are just trying to find a way back home.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Veth smiles as they watch the other children play in the nursery, a warm sensation stirring in their chest as they regard each of their fellows in turn. There is Ninli and Tamzi playing off in the corner together; Veth knows the two are busy making up stories they love to tell one another. Madala and Ninsun are helping Mmu braid their hair—Mmu has the longest and most beautiful black hair out of all the children; they smile happily at the attention, upper and lower fangs peeking out through parted lips. Then there is Sabitum; they are in the middle of explaining something to Davcina, Erish, and Enlil. As this is taking place, Sargon keeps interrupting Sabitum with jokes, which Veth knows annoys them greatly.

In the midst of all this fun is the one Veth enjoys watching the most—Nefeli. As they are usually wont to do, Nefeli is practicing their dancing; they twirl and leap about the nursery, wholly carefree and unaware of anything else at that moment. All Nephraeh children are inherently graceful, but there is something about Nefeli that tugs at something inside Veth; they cannot explain it to themselves, for their young brain does not have the capacity to identify the emotion.

Veth knows they are grinning like a fool as they watch Nefeli dance, and as soon as the other catches them doing it, Nefeli will tease them mercilessly. But a noise catches Veth's attention, and looking toward the disruption, they see Sabitum and Sargon quarreling. It seems that Sabitum has had enough of Sargon's incessant japes, and based on the many other times this had happened, a horrible fight will soon follow.

"Veth! Why aren't you watching me?" Nefeli says, laughing as they clasp their shoulders. Veth is instantly filled with Nefeli's presence as they turn toward their friend—from the smell of Nefeli's body to the warm breath on their cheek as they pant from exertion. Veth finds themselves in a state of shock as Nefeli stares at them with silver eyes.

"What's the matter, Veth? Was there something wrong with the way I was dancing?" They ask with a slight frown.

This makes Veth grin; Nefeli is always so insecure and unaware of how wonderful their art is. They are quick to shake their head in the negative and point in the direction of the brewing fight.

"Ugh, they're at it again." Nefeli groans but then instantly seizes Veth a little more firmly this time. "Don't do it again, Veth! Please! The Archon will sense it and be displeased!"

"I must, Nefeli," they say, giving their friend a reassuring smile. "I can't just stand by and let them hurt each other.

Nefeli lets go of them, knowing there is no point in arguing when their mind has been set. Rushing over to Sabitum and Sargon, Veth places themself between the two combatants, putting a restraining hand on each of their shoulders, as they dig deep within themselves—to the ***feeling****. The beautiful and magical emotion which constantly wells inside them, somewhere between their head and heart. They associate this feeling with all their friends, but when they focus it on Sabitum and Sargon, it happens.*

*The nursery is already well-lit, but a brilliant luminesce suddenly fills it, making every child turn toward its source. It is coming from Veth, from the core of their body, radiating out from the place they keep that **feeling**. It baths both Sabitum and Sargon in its **Light**, and instantly their angry expressions vanish, replaced by bewilderment.*

"Sabitum, remember that time Sargon made you laugh when you were having an awful time with the teachers? Remember how nice that was?" Veth asks Sabitum before turning to Sargon.

"Sargon, hasn't Sabitum helped you with your lessons? Don't you think you should give them a break and stop messing with them when they are trying to help the others?"

Both Sargon and Sabitum look down shamefully before looking back at each other, sorrow plain on both their lilac features.

"I'm sorry, Sabitum. I really am. I get jealous of the attention you get sometimes, and telling jokes is the only way I can get some of my own." Sargon says, holding out a hand to the other. Sabitum takes their hand in their own and smiles.

"It's okay, Sargon. I tend to go on and on and don't give someone else a chance to speak. I'm sorry too," Sabitum says, pulling Sargon in for a hug. After the two friends make up, they turn to their benefactor, looking very apprehensive.

"Thank you for stopping us from fighting, Veth. But didn't you get into trouble the last time you did that?" Sargon asks, almost in a whisper.

They shrug. "It was worth it,"

VETH!!!

The voice booms through the metaphysical realm that connects every Nephraeh and sears into the physical, appearing as if it comes from everywhere and nowhere at once. Every child in the nursery screams in pain as they cover their long ears and cower

on the floor—but not Veth; they will not cringe. Not when they know they are responsible for their lord's displeasure.

At once, a giant materializes in the nursery—a beautiful and terrible vision of wrath. Veth knows how much using their special power displeases the Archon; somehow, their lord has felt them use it and magically transported themselves here to punish them.

Archon Lethe surveys the nursey with burning indigo eyes; it does not take them long to spot the transgressor.

"Veth! What did I say about using that foul… ability… you have?" Archon Lethe asks as they storm over and tower over them. Veth does not move a muscle as they stand straight, staring up into Archon Lethe's white visage.

"You told me never to use it again. That what I can do is an aberration among the Nephraeh and never show anyone, for I will be ostracized—but I had to!" They answer boldly.

Archon Lethe's lips part to reveal two rows of black serrated edges —they hate the sight of those teeth.

"What could possibly have happened to give you an excuse to perform such an abominable act? Hmm? Answer me, Veth!" Archon Lethe snaps.

Veth glances at Sabitum and Sargon, knowing that if they tell Archon Lethe that they have been about to start fighting, the two will share in their punishment. Letting out a loud sigh of resignation, they look up at Archon Lethe coolly.

"It really none of your business," they say plainly.

All the children gasp at this bold display of disobedience, and Archon Lethe's face darkens. Raising both of their black-stained hands, Archon Lethe pronounces their judgment.

"I see I have a long way to go with you, Veth. There is just too much weakness in you—it will have to be purged for you to come

fully into the Light," Archon Lethe says coldly.

Veth closes their eyes as bright purple energy arcs off Archon Lethe's fingertips. Pain instantly sears through their young body, and they scream. Right before they pass out, a voice sears into their brain; it is so very familiar to them yet wholly different.

REMEMBER WHO YOU ARE, VETH

Veth pulled themselves from the memories as a chill passed over their body; they had suffered that agony many times as a youth, and its pain was one of the few things they had remembered. Everything else from that snapshot in time had been forgotten, from their disobedience to Archon Lethe to the act of summoning the Light. It was such a vivid recollection—almost as if they had experienced a vision—and it seemed to be happening to them a lot lately. Lost memories were coming to the surface of their mind since they had stopped taking part in the Penumbra Ritual—it seemed that their compassion returning to them had unlocked a great door. But much more than mere memories had come pouring out; there was also the blossoming *craving* they were developing—a hunger for something very specific.

Veth ran clawed fingertips through their black hair as they fought against the heat coursing through their body. It was not a painful feeling—well, not a bad pain—and it would be extremely enjoyable in the right setting. But at this moment and in the company of the human—Shen—it was unwanted.

Get a hold of yourself, Veth. They thought for the hundredth time*. You need to think clearly if you're going to get out of this dimension and help Adora.*

Veth had an inkling of what was happening to them, for they had felt a fraction of what they now experienced as an adolescent. Archon Lethe had explained in a very functional and matter-of-fact way that what they felt was the inclination to mate and that when the time was right, they would select someone for them. When

that time came, Veth would perform their duty, and on many occasions, they had.

It was never an enjoyable experience for Veth, and it was only when they stopped taking the Antithetical Philter that it became pleasurable. When that had happened, Veth no longer wanted to be told with whom they could be with; it was what had steered them in Nefeli's direction—the natural course of love years in the making. What Veth and Nefeli had done behind the privacy of closed doors went beyond the mere word mating—*way beyond*. Veth wished Nefeli was with them now, not only because they loved them but because Nefeli would help them satisfy this unbearable need.

Where is that blasted human? They thought as they looked around, trying to distract themselves from thinking of futile hopes.

It had been three days since Shen and Veth had arrived in this strange place and left the building that had tried to imprison them—three days of following an old path through a beautiful forest under an extraordinary sky that time did not command. They had discovered that where the nighttime version of this sky presented an infinite number of dazzling stars, the daytime version was no less fantastical; no sun appeared in the heavens, but come morning, a diffuse golden light permeated everything. It was a beautiful, soft light—like sunlight at sunrise or sunset—and it was consistent throughout the day.

Along the way, Shen and Veth discovered drinkable water sources and various edible fruit-bearing plants. At points along their trek, one of them would wait while the other went in search of food—it was now Shen's turn to forage while Veth lounged under one of the many white-leafed trees. Veth wished it was they who went to gather food instead of sitting around; perhaps it would not have given them the opportunity for their mind to… *wander.*

Veth breathed deep the crisp, clean air of this place, letting it fill their lungs before expelling it in one breath, practicing one of the many calming techniques taught to them. They leaned up against

the silvery trunk of the tree and looked up at the bright sky, concentrating on the fast-moving clouds. But it did not help; the speed of the wispy objects only seemed to agitate them, and after many fruitless attempts at meditation, Veth let out a long growl.

That's it; I'm going to find him! They thought, instantly standing up, and brushing dirt off their pants.

It was at that moment that Shen appeared from behind a tree, walking along a smaller path that deviated from the larger one they had been traveling on. He smiled and waved at Veth, holding up his black jacket he was using as a makeshift basket. When he presented it to them upon his arrival, Veth noticed he had been quite successful; the folded jacket was full of the pink bulbous fruit, each about the size of a clenched fist. It was more than enough food for one day.

"Why did you get so much? We don't need so much fruit," Veth said peevishly. "We will waste energy carrying the extra when we can just find more."

"You're welcome," Shen said, his smile instantly vanishing into annoyance.

Veth gritted their teeth as shame washed over them; they didn't mean to lash out at the human—which had been happening a lot lately. They knew if they kept it up, Shen might take the next opportunity to leave them. For some reason, Veth really did not want that.

"Actually, maybe it would be good to have some extra; I think I might be taking it for granted that we will find food so easily. I will help carry the extra," Veth amended as they took off their own white jacket.

By the way the patterns of his quintessence moved, Veth knew that Shen was surprised by the sudden magnanimity, and he doled half of the food into Veth's jacket.

He thinks he has me figured out, huh? Veth thought smugly. *He has no idea what's going on with me—if he only knew!*

This thought made Veth smile, and they had a hard time stifling a laugh. Suspicion briefly passed over Shen's features, but he did not comment as he slung his bundled jacket over one shoulder. Veth noticed that his article of clothing seemed to change its shape slightly—as if accommodating its new role. They wondered if this human knew how special it was, for there was no doubt in Veth's mind that it was magical.

"So, Veth, should we continue on our way?" Shen said, pointing down the path in the direction untraveled. Veth sighed once again as the impatience overcame them; it seemed like they would go this way forever.

"I guess, Human." They answered, gesturing that he should go first. This was the routine now.

"After you,"

* * *

Shen flopped down on a soft patch of silvery moss, extending his legs with a groan as he let them stretch. The long duration of their travels combined with the fast pace Veth was setting had seriously taxed Shen; he was worried that the strain on his body would catch up to him, leading to an injury that would slow him even more. Reaching down to massage the sore muscles, Shen peered over to the Nephraeh, watching them sit gracefully under a tree opposite him.

Blasted Veth—they don't even appear tired! He thought angrily as he found an especially tender spot on his shin and grimaced.

Shen knew he could ask Veth if they could slow down a bit, but he wouldn't. He was loath to admit his weakness in front of the haughty Nephraeh, especially with how they had been acting recently. He was sure Veth would just have yet another nasty comment for him, and Shen was getting tired of that. The only

reason they had stopped for this break was to eat—something the superior Nephraeh still had to do—and Shen was grateful for it.

Shen glanced over at Veth again, seeing them opening their bundled white jacket to extract a single fruit. With their coat off, Shen noted they were wearing a tight-fitting sleeveless top made of a silvery material that sparkled in the warm light. Soft muscles rippled under strange white markings on their lilac arms; every movement Veth made was fluid and elegant, in a total economy of motion.

No wonder they can walk forever, Shen thought shamefully, looking down at his own human body. I *guess there is something to their Nephraeh superiority.*

As much as Shen hated to admit it, he wished Veth would accept him, not just to make their journey easier, but he wanted the Nephraeh to—if not like him—be able to tolerate his presence better.

Due to Shen's empathetic nature, he knew something was going on with the Nephraeh; just looking at them now, he could see the telltale signs. For one thing, they seemed a little more disheveled than when he first met them, from their long black hair to the glossiness of their skin—almost as if they were constantly sweating.

Maybe something in this place is making them sick. Shen thought, turning his attention back to his food. *I should give Veth a break; who knows what this dimension is doing to someone with magic in their blood?*

Momentarily, Shen thought about asking them about what was going on—perhaps he could help somehow. That made perfect sense to him; wasn't Perfuma always telling him communication is the key to a good relationship?

* * *

Veth held the fleshy pink fruit in one clawed hand, inspecting it briefly before bringing it up to their mouth. They focused on the sensation of piercing its flesh with their upper and lower fangs—slowly—then the taste of the sweet juice as it dripped down to wet their tongue. The fruit made a gentle slushing sound as they bit fully, the meat of its interior spongy yet juicy, a hint of spice behind all that tangy citrus. Veth tried to concentrate on all those sensations at once, but in the end, the focusing technique was woefully inadequate against the ardor coursing through them.

Taking off their jacket had helped; Veth's clothes felt so strict and hot, and they wished to remove the tight wrappings of their Aegis Lace pants. But sensing the human's eyes upon them, deemed that course of action unwise.

Maybe I should encourage him to run off, Veth thought as they tossed the core of the fruit away. *Then I can just run around this place naked. That would feel so wonderful.*

Veth sighed heavily to themselves as they leaned back on their arms, imagining doing exactly that. This dimension was so beautiful; it was just like the stories of the afterlife—the Empyrean—Veth had heard as a child. To run free and wild, not a care in the world—it would be even better if they had a companion. If Nefeli were here with them, it truly would be a paradise.

There you go again, Veth. Thinking of what cannot be when you should concentrate on leaving this place. Focus! They thought angrily.

Veth was starting to have an inkling of what was happening to them; after all, with all the time they had spent walking, there was time to think. There was not much known of the Nephraeh before the coming of Archon Lethe, but from the tales Archon Lethe told, their people were hedonistic and weak, straying far from the true Light.

But from what Veth knew of Archon Lethe, this could mean the opposite of what was actually true. Archon Lethe's version of

relationships was detached and sterile; Veth had a feeling that the Nephraeh as a whole was a lot more passionate when in their natural state. Somehow, by taking their empathy all those hundreds of years, Archon Lethe had also dampened their libido. From the way Veth was feeling now—Archon Lethe had dampened it considerably.

But why does this have to happen now? They thought miserably. *Is this how I'm going to feel all the time? Or will it go away after a while? Either way, I must learn to live with this yearning—I must!*

"Hey, Veth?" Shen said abruptly, almost startling Veth.

Veth ran a hand through their hair, trying to hide their annoyance at being disturbed.

"Yes, Human?" They asked.

"Are you okay? It seems like something is bothering you; I mean, whatever it is, you can tell me about it. We are in this together, like it or not. Even though I'm a stupid human, maybe I can help you?" Shen said hopefully.

Veth could not help the nervous giggle that escaped their lips but then waved at Shen when annoyance appeared on his face.

"I'm sorry, I'm not mocking you; it's just a Nephraeh thing, nothing to worry yourself about," they said quickly and with a false smile. But Shen was not finished discussing the topic.

"You know, I've always had a problem with weakness—with not wanting people to think I have any. It's something instilled in me by my father, and I'm working on it. I have something to tell you, and I was afraid to admit it in case you thought I was a drag."

Veth cocked their head at Shen, suddenly interested in his admission.

"I'm having a tough time keeping up with you; this constant walking is killing me, and I'm not sure how much more I can take.

I have been keeping my mouth closed because—one, I don't want you to think I'm weak, and—two, I know how badly you want to get out of here," Shen finished.

Veth pursed their lips, taking this all in.

"And how would you know how badly I want to get out of here?" They asked.

Shen shrugged, and Veth tried not to let it irritate them.

"Well, you mentioned wanting to help Adora and set things right—I know all about that. When I first met Adora, I had been sent to kill her—I had killed many others before her, too. My life had been one long dark road, but every day since I turned away from the darkness, I've been trying to set it right. To make up for past deeds—I have a feeling you feel the same way,"

Veth could not help liking this human; even if his quintessence weren't so attractive, they would have started warming up to him. Perhaps that made sense; wouldn't what they discerned in his soul shine outward to the person?

Still, given what was happening with Veth, they could not allow Shen to know what was truly happening with them; they just didn't feel that comfortable telling him.

"Yes, you are right, Human. There is much I must set right, and I am eager to escape this dimension. But I'm alarmed that you didn't share your predicament with me; I don't need you falling apart on me at the wrong moment—it was quite foolish, I might add." They said.

Instantly Veth regretted their words, not just based on Shen's facial expression, but the blackening of shame spreading throughout his quintessence. Obviously, their option meant a lot to him; to have spoken so harshly to him had hurt Shen deeply, especially after telling Veth something he would rather not admit. Shen had gone out on a limb in order to help them, and for that, Veth was grateful.

“You don’t have to put up a front with me, Shen.” Veth amended. “I can’t fully explain it, but there is really no point, so don’t bother.”

Shen didn’t answer and turned away from them in evident anger. After bundling up his jacket, Shen stood, turning towards Veth with a blank expression.

“Well? I’ve rested enough. Want to continue? I know I do.” He said tonelessly.

Veth nodded and stood, holding out a hand.

“Lead the way,”

* * *

Another day and more endless walking, Shen thought as he kicked at a stray pebble, sending it skipping ahead down the trail. It had been a day since his ill-thought-out attempt to get Veth to open up to him, and there was still no sign of anything but more forest. The only upside was that instead of nonstop walking before and after lunch, Veth insisted they take multiple breaks, calling them ‘time-outs,’ which Shen found humiliating. He wasn’t sure if Veth was calling them that in mockery of him or if they were overcompensating for his ‘human weakness.’ Shen suspected it was both,

Ah, well. At least it is another glorious day, he thought with a smile, looking up through the canopy of white leaves and into the bright sky.

Having spent most of his life in the dimension of Night, Shen never missed an opportunity to appreciate a stunning day. Be it on Etheria, Elysia, or wherever this strange place was, Shen would take it all in, allowing that moment to imprint on his spirit—an instant that becomes timeless. Shen thought that much of who he was as a person was made of these snapshots of beauty—or at least he would like to believe it.

But for some reason, Shen was having a hard time being present in this moment. He could not get over Veth's loathing of him—it bothered Shen greatly—and seemed to have worsened since yesterday. Shen could feel intense energy coming off the Nephraeh, putting him on edge; it was almost as if Veth were preparing for something. Feeling that presence now, Shen quickly turned to look behind him, seeing Veth's silver eyes quickly flick away.

They had been watching him.

* * *

Veth tried to focus on the vision of splendor that was midday in this dreamlike dimension but kept finding their eyes straying to the greater attraction ahead of them.

Swirling patterns of superlunary shapes coalesced into colors beyond the visual spectrum. Threads of metaphysical ectoplasm rang with a harmony that could not be heard, but, through Veth's new sight, was experienced. Beneath all that extraneous, complicated anima was the core; it was bright with pure Light—not the light in which you see—but the Light Veth could now summon. Somehow, Veth knew it was strong here but was minutely dampened by a dark scarring. Veth found themselves wanting to reach out with their hand and wipe it away as if it were a simple smudge—like they would do for Nefeli when dirt got on their face.

With a jolt, Veth realized that they were reaching out to Shen walking not five paces ahead, and quickly pulled their hand down as if it were burned. With a great burst of embarrassment, Veth felt the passion within them respond to what they had seen in the human and bit their lip in frustration.


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Really, Veth? The human? This is getting ridiculous now; I got to get a hold of myself, they thought angrily. *If you're going to look at Shen, try to concentrate on the physical and not the ethereal; perhaps that will help.*

They did just that, focusing on how the light glistened off of Shen's long hair; it was so dark brown it was almost black—like a Nephraeh's. Veth's eyes strayed down to the bottom of the glossy jacket to the way Shen's dark gray pants fitted his body—then quickly looked away.

Okay, so looking at his butt doesn't help, they thought ruefully.

Shaking their head, Veth gave up on trying to distract themselves from looking at Shen's soul and just let themselves gaze at it shamelessly. There was no point in fighting it; the human was facing away and shouldn't catch them looking. After all, shouldn't they watch Shen closely in case he tries to leave them? What better way to search for indicators of treachery than by looking at his very spirit?

Just as Veth resumed their observations, they glimpsed Shen doing something interesting; through the ethereal lens of their new sight, Veth glimpsed a minuscule amount of Light flowing into Shen, bolstering the radiance at his core and fading the scar temporarily. Amazed, Veth turned their attention to what Shen was doing at that very moment, realizing that he was doing nothing more than peering about himself—at the forest, at the sky—in absolute love with what he was witnessing. Through an appreciation of natural beauty, Shen was summoning Light—true Light—and taking it in to fortify against the dark smear on his soul. They knew Shen was not conscious of what he was doing; it was his way of coping with inner pain.

Wondrous, Veth thought to themselves with a smile. *I must change my ways with this human—Shen, I mean. He does not deserve the way I've been treating him.*

At the moment they made had their inner decision, Shen abruptly turned, and Veth barely had time to divert their eyes away before being caught.

That was too close! Veth thought with relief. *Who knows what Shen would think if he knew I kept staring at him?*

As if in answer, Veth watched as the formation of Light ceased, and Shen's quintessence began to fold up into itself, becoming opaque and difficult to ascertain. Veth had not seen their companion do this with his soul before; it was as if Shen was completely closing himself off to Veth. This was something they did not like.

Uh, oh. That's not good.

* * *

Shen marched along the trail, no longer intent on enjoying the beauty around him. Having just caught Veth watching him, Shen was wrapped up in his head, analyzing his interactions with the Nephraeh since first meeting them. He was beginning to see a pattern in their behavior, and now at this moment, the realization of what was going on them hit Shen like a hammer. The evidence was all there, as clear as day, and he quickly ran down the facts in order to verify his conclusion.

Shen knew that Veth was constantly watching him; he could feel their silver eyes boring into his back every time he walked ahead of them. Whenever they stopped to take breaks, Veth would still do it, and when Shen would look their way, they pretended not to be paying attention to him. Then there were Veth's strange mannerisms; their hands were constantly on the move from twirling their hair to running their fingers over their hips—almost as if they wanted very badly to do something. That, plus the agitated personality, all led him to believe that they were in a heightened state, all in preparation to perform one task with Shen in mind. He knew precisely what Veth was planning to do.

They were going to kill him.

It all made sense; by treating him like dirt, Veth was preparing themselves to perform the act without remorse, seeing Shen not as a person but simply as 'human.' They must have decided when they had to rescue Shen from that dark room; Veth must have been disgusted at touching and restraining him. Plus, with his admission of not being able to keep up, Veth must be itching to get rid of him by now. What Shen wasn't sure about was why they hadn't tried it yet.

They must be waiting for the perfect moment to strike—what will they use when they do? Their claws? They look super sharp, and I saw the damage they did with them to those guardians. But I don't think they will need to; they almost finished me without them when they nearly choked me to death. I don't know why they didn't finish the job then unless they thought they needed me for some diversion—

"Is everything all right up there, human?" Veth asked out of nowhere, interrupting Shen's stream of thoughts. He whirled on them, fists clenched as he tried to keep calm.

"Yes! Everything is fine!" He snapped.

Veth was taken aback by his abrupt answer, their eyes momentarily widening in shock.

"It doesn't seem like everything is fine, human. It seems like anything but," Veth commented, crossing their arms. "Tell me, what is the matter with you,"

Shen felt like Veth was piercing him with their eyes—like they could see directly inside him. By the way they intuitively knew of his inner turmoil, he could believe it. This just made Shen angrier.

"Back there, when I asked you if you needed help, I know why you brushed me off!" He quickly shouted.

"Do you now," Veth said with irritating calmness.

“Yeah, I know what is going on with you! More importantly, I know what you have planned for me!” Shen continued.

Veth suddenly looked unsure of themselves and nervously tucked a strand of black hair behind one of their long ears. Shen instantly knew he had hit a nerve.

“So, tell me, what do you think I want to do to you, human?” Veth asked softly.

“You’re going to try and kill me! Don’t deny it!”

Veth instantly gaped open-mouthed at him, seeming absolutely offended. Shen didn’t believe their act for a moment.

“You are such an *idiot,*” Veth said, shaking their head. “Why would I want to kill you when I already had the opportunity back when we first met? Better yet, if I wanted to, what is stopping me?”

“Because I killed Nefeli! Because I disgust you, and I’m slowing you down! Because you think you're better than me! You know what? Perhaps you are, but that doesn’t mean I’m going to go quietly!” Shen yelled, holding up his hands in a combat potion.

“By what flawless logic did you come to that conclusion, *Human?*” Veth said, starting to sound annoyed.

Shen held his hands out, incredulous that he had to explain.

“By the way you act, by the way you treat me! Calling me ‘Human’ all the time instead of Shen! The endless insults and just plain nastiness! You obviously feel nothing but hatred for me—at the very least!”

Veth crossed their arms and bared their teeth. “You have no idea what’s going on with me, *Human*,” they hissed. Shen could tell he was making them mad but did not care; he was sick of their attitude and wanted to make sure they knew it.

"Well, you glancing my way all the time certainly isn't because you like what you see! Of course not; there is no way the high and mighty Nephraeh would ever see anything other than a filthy piece of garbage human who—"

"*SHUT UP!!!*" Veth shrieked, their face screwing up in fury as they abruptly rushed at him.

Shen was prepared for their attack, bringing his hands up in a guard position, but was completely taken off guard as Veth barreled into him, slamming him into one of the silvery trees. Shen immediately realized there was something off about this alternation—for one thing—Veth was not attacking with an ounce of the fierceness that had before. They grappled with him but seemed unsure whether they were going to push him into the tree or pull him down to the ground.

Why is their body so hot? What is wrong with them? Shen thought, perplexed

He knew that Veth was capable of much more strength than they were currently using, for Shen was holding his own as he struggled against them. Searching for signs on their lilac face, Shen detected no rage there, only anger mixed with a pained look —like something was making them ache.

It's almost as if they are— Shen started to think but immediately blushed bright red.

Wow, Shen. Don't ever tell anyone you're good at reading people because you were way off this time! He thought.

Looking into Veth's impassioned face not too far from his own, Shen recognized the attraction for him summed up in the trembling of their lower lip. All of his rationale for them wanting to kill him flipped to support this opposite intention immediately; it seemed the signs for wanting to murder someone and the desire to be intimate with them were not far off from each other.

Even though they had been horrible to him since the moment he met them, Shen couldn't help but admit how good-looking Veth was; the kohl that was around their eyes had since wiped away revealing white markings that were strikingly beautiful. Their lilac skin looked so smooth, their mouth soft and inviting—Shen immediately knew his attraction equaled theirs.

Suddenly feeling bold, Shen took a chance and leaned in, seizing their soft lower lip with his own, kissing them fully and passionately. Veth's mouth was warm and tasted exotic; Shen could feel the barest hint of their dangerous fangs on his upper lip —but at that moment in time, it felt so right.

Veth instantly froze, not fighting him anymore, and just as Shen thought they would sink into him, they pushed him away firmly.

With heart still racing, Shen watched Veth back away, eyes wide in disbelief; they held tentative claw tips to their mouth as if reeling from a blow.

"You kissed me?" Veth asked, incredulous. "Why did you do that?"

Shen could not believe what he had just done and was in his own state of shock; he had no rational answer as to why he did it. Not knowing what else to say or do, Shen simply shrugged, favoring Veth with a small smile.

"It looked like you needed it." He said.

Veth stared at him for a moment, not making a move, and just as Shen was beginning to get nervous, they started towards him, silver eyes glittering.

"Hello, friends! Am I interrupting something" A high-pitched male voice interrupted.

A vicious hiss escaped Veth as they practically leaped in the air in surprise; turning towards the speaker, Shen spotted the most bizarre being he had ever seen. Floating above the trail was what appeared as a legless torso cloaked in a red robe—a large black

‘O’ written on his chest. Two teal-colored ears poked out from a wide-brimmed hat, under which two yellow eyes gazed above a purple scarf. Besides the ears, the being’s hands were the only other part of his body exposed, and in them was clutched a black wand with a gold tip.

“What the heck are you?” Shen exclaimed.

The floating being seemed taken aback by this question, bobbing up and down in the air like a balloon before answering.

“Oh, you must be new here! I’m Orko! Welcome to the Timeless Dimension!” He squeaked.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Miledibuja on Instagram, Twitter and Tumblr.

Getaway

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra enjoy their 'Honeymoon Do-Over' on Trolla.

Meanwhile...

Everyone back home on Etheria and Eternia is running for their lives.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Feeling her topside getting a little too toasty, Catra languidly flipped onto her tummy, giving her backside a turn to soak up some of the sun's rays. After picking at a wedgie in her bikini bottom, she sighed contentedly before resting her head on the soft blanket.

"Isn't this just great?" She said to her companion.

Reclining in a nearby lounge chair, Adora looked up from her book, her eyes peering at her wife over the pages.

"Hmmm?" Adora responded absentmindedly.

Catra turned to give her a wide grin. "*I said,* Isn't this just great?"

Adora was perplexed as she glanced around the bright red stone terrace they both sunned on. By itself, it was nothing special, appearing like a flat pad with no railings which jutted out of the tall, funnel-shaped building that was their accommodation. Catra and Adora were the only people staying in the ancient and strange-looking building—one of many that composed the abandoned city of Trollos. Besides the outpost on the outskirts of Trollos populated by scientists and scholars, they were basically the only people living in the city, for that matter.

Gazing out from the terrace, Adora took in the remarkable landscape that was the world of Trolla; vast orange formations, like stalagmites, jutted up from a craggy terrain into a sky the color of magenta. No clouds floated in the heavens; in their place, glittering ice formations floated in clusters high in the exosphere. Above it all blazed a sun with a faint purplish hue, the light of which gave everything a rosy tint, making the world appear dreamlike.

"Yeah, it is Catra," Adora said casually before returning to her book. Catra eyed her incredulously.

Before her ordeal as Despara, Catra would have needled and mocked Adora into putting the book aside—but she suppressed these instincts, knowing that her wife needed a softer approach now. Since getting her back, Adora seemed distant and numb; obviously, she had quite a lot of trauma to work through. But Catra was prepared for this and, with patience and attentiveness, was determined to nurse her wife back to health.

I think it's time for me to give Adora a dose of special attention. Catra thought.


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Being close and dexterous enough, Catra extended one leg, using the claw of one toe to gently push the book her wife was reading down into her lap. With an exasperated sigh, Adora regarded her with two raised eyebrows.

"Hey, Adora," Catra said with a mischievous smile. "What-cha doing with that boring book?"

Not able to resist the winning catchphrase, Adora smiled warmly back at Catra.

Works every time, Catra thought to herself.

"Oh, just trying to understand the history of this planet we are on, Catra. According to this book, Trolla was one of the key planets of the universe back in the time of the First Ones—I mean—the time of the Empire. The Trollans were a purely magical people—like Melog—and when they disappeared, much of the magic went with them." Adora explained.

Catra sighed heavily as she rolled her eyes. Moving onto her side, Catra arranged her body in the most alluring position possible, hand on a cinnamon hip as she puffed her chest out.

"Sounds so dry and stale," Catra said with a pout.

"Oh, stop, Catra," Adora said, not unkindly. "It's actually fascinating and was written by Adric Galven,"

"Am I supposed to know who that is?" Catra asked, scrunching up her nose while curling her upper lip. Adora immediately gaped at her wife as if she had just caused a scandal.

"Catra! He was the nice man who showed us through the city when we first arrived! We spent half a day with him, and that was only two days ago!" Adora scolded.

Catra waved this away. "Yeah, okay. Now I remember that crusty old guy. He wouldn't shut up about how the city was built on lay lines that corresponded to constellations."

Adora beamed at this. “So, you were paying attention!” She said happily.

Catra shrugged at this. “Yeah, I know; I’m smarter than I look.” She said as she leaned to one side, scratching at her hindquarters.

“What else does your stupid—I mean—*interesting* book have to say?” Catra asked, wiggling closer to Adora’s lounge chair to gaze up at her wife. She was willing to do anything to make Adora happy, and if that meant listening to her drone on about Trollan history—so be it.

“Besides being highly magic-based, the Trollans had the most extensive library in the Universe! They had records that went back thousands of years, back before these ‘dark times’ the Madgēcots keep talking about. Can you imagine that?” Adora said excitedly.

Catra couldn’t help smiling back at her wife. She was so happy that her friends convinced them to go on their ‘honeymoon do-over’ on this strange planet. Other than the fantastic sights, the mostly unpopulated Trolla was free of distractions, allowing Catra and Adora to focus on each other. This was time well spent in each other’s company—either hiking, sightseeing, or spending long nights in each other’s arms. It was this last part Catra was thinking of as she lifted herself from the ground to settle on the lounge chair with Adora.

“Oh, so you want me to read to you?” Adora asked innocently as Catra sat on her lap.

“Something like that,” Catra said, taking the book and throwing it over her shoulder.

“Catra—!” Adora started to protest but was immediately silenced as Catra placed her mouth over hers in a kiss.

“Hmmm… again so soon?” Adora said dreamily.

Catra nodded. “You bet, Princess. There is a lot of time to make up for, and I expect to get what’s owed to me,”

Adora pulled back to regard their surroundings once more.

“Catra! Not here! someone is going to see us!” She gasped.

Catra glanced over her shoulder at the city of Trollos spread out under them; the balcony they were on was relatively high, and if anyone wanted to, they could see everything that took place there from miles around. She turned back to Adora with a feral grin.

“No one on this planet but us and a bunch of nerds too busy reading dusty scrolls to see what we are about to do!” Catra practically cackled.

Adora was convinced—not that it would take much—and she smiled, settling back into the lounge chair as Catra removed her bikini top. Adora’s eyes softened as she regarded her wife, running fingers down from her neckline down to her belly button.

“I love you so much, Catra,” she whispered.

“I love you too, Princess,” Catra responded, leaning in.

* * *

Hiding under smelly old robes, Micha and Castaspella tried to be as inconspicuous as possible as they entered the town of Cathenay. It had been two days since they escaped Castle Grayskull, and it was now only the two of them; most of the others had been taken by the black monsters as they fled the castle and the rest had decided to find their own way back to Etheria, splitting from the two Master Sorcerers and heading towards other populated areas. Micah had tried to dissuade them from leaving, stating that there was an inexplicable darkening taking place on Eternia, a spreading of evil amongst the populace that was not obvious to any observer, but could be felt by those with more sensitive means. He rationalized that it was better to stick together, but the others would not listen, arguing that if

Micha and Castaspella could not save Castle Grayskull, they couldn't protect them. Micah could not disagree with their reasoning and wished them luck on their journey.

By the time they had reached the City of Drisdos, Castaspella and Micha could sense the taint was already there, waiting for them. It was evident not only through magical means but in the facial and body expressions of the people; they seemed less hospital and closed off. Here and there, black shapes could be seen skulking in dark shadows, moving with an unwholesome and unnatural grace —Micah immediately knew that these were the same creatures that chased them as they fled from Castle Grayskull. Whatever they were, they were directly tied to the evil spreading throughout the planet.

When Castaspella inquired at the local starport about transportation, her queries were met with stony silence. It seemed that besides the collective apathy spreading, there was an unspoken conspiracy taking place against anyone left untouched by the deadening of compassion. They quickly left the Star Port and, by some luck, ran into a trader who supplied them with cloaks and information on a smuggler running out of nearby Cathenay. Whether or not this trader was trustworthy, neither Micha nor Castaspella could tell, but he took their Eternian currency quickly enough with a wink and a grin. Ultimately, they had no choice but to go to Cathenay—they had to get to Etheria and warn them of what was coming. Hopefully, they were not too late.

"Where did he say we could find the smuggler?" Castaspella said nervously next to him.

Micah glanced around the town square, trying not to appear as if he were searching for anything specific. Soon he spotted what he sought; a giant and desiccated lizard head mounted on a hanging sign emblazoned with archaic-style writing.

"Over there, Cassie, *The Serpos Head*—that's where he said the smuggler likes to hang out." He said.

“Ew, Micah. Really? A dive bar?” Castaspella complained.

Micah shot his sister an exasperated look before seizing her hand and leading her across the square. Taking the stairs leading down into the seedy establishment, Micah noticed that the air smelled stale—a mixture of spirits of foul body odor with a faint hint of something else more… vile. Thankfully, the bar was empty during midday, and what patrons present were either too interested in their drinks or huddled together in booths to bother noticing the newcomers.

Micah regarded his sister, who was practically walking on her tiptoes as they made their way to the bar—as if to keep as much of the establishments’ filth off her as possible. He found he could not fault his sister’s behavior; there was something wrong with the place besides the grime and bad smell—something malevolent—but not on the same spectrum as what they were currently running from.

“Swhat cans I’s gess syeu?” The bartender said in a thick Eternian accent.

Micah leaned toward the man before speaking, noticing he was wearing a strange medallion made of pure black stone. It was in the shape of an eye, and to Micah, the bartender’s jewelry was abhorrent.

“I was told I can find someone here who transports things. Things that you are not supposed to have. I heard she is very discreet.” Micah said in a whisper.

When the bartender looked at Micah blankly he sighed, rolling his eyes.

“A smuggler! We need a smuggler!” He hissed in a whisper.

The bartender gave a slight nod before his black eyes darted to a corner of the room; there, Micah spotted a woman sitting alone. Piercing yellow eyes darted about the room under a tricorne hat as red as her skin. Catching Micah regarding her, she reached

down to her leather corset—he instantly caught the metallic gleam as she clutched a knife.

"Thas Captain Cloven—s'I warn yous now—son't engage sith her unless sour serious!" The bartender warned.

Nodding his thanks, Micha led Castaspella over to the smuggler—her blazing eyes watching them as they approached.

"Captain Cloven, I presume? May we sit?" Micah asked, indicating the two empty chairs.

Now that Micah was closer, he could see she was close to his and Castaspella's age; faint wrinkles marked the edges of her eyes, but Micah doubted they were caused by too much laughter. She was a severe-looking woman, yet something about her posture and energy made her very attractive to Micah despite her nefarious connections.

Jutting her red chin towards the two empty chairs, the smuggler indicated that the two should sit, which both Micha and Castaspella did promptly.

"My name is Hubert," Micah said, indicating himself. "And this is my sister, Margaret."

"If you two are interested in contraband—don't bother. I only transport the items; I don't sell them. Talk to Rinko." Captain Cloven said in a husky voice.

"We aren't interested in buying anything from you. We need transport—off-planet," Micah said.

The smuggler cocked her head at this, eyes narrowing.

"That's interesting; right after a furlough in Eternos, the Star Force Fleet started blockading Eternia and Etheria. Are you two on the run from them or something?" She asked.

Micah wanted to growl with anger; from what the smuggler had just said, it sounded like the entire Etherian Space Fleet was subverted. There was no telling how bad it would be on Etheria if this influence had already made it to the planet's surface. Going back home was no longer an option; they had to get help from other sources.

"How long ago was this?" Castaspella asked as she glanced nervously at her brother.

Captain Cloven shrugged. "About two days ago—why?"

Micah pulled a cloth bag out from his robe and plopped it on the table before the smuggler; the sound of coins rattling within plain to hear. It was the entirety of what they had left

"Is this enough for you to get us past the blockage and out of this solar system?" He asked.

The smuggler took the bag, lifting one red eyebrow when she surveyed its contents.

"How far are we talking?" She asked.

"How about Elysia?" Micah inquired.

Captain Cloven's lost some of her icy demeanor as a smile cracked red lips.

"The other side of the galaxy? I don't think so. Name a place on this side of the Maelstrom Gulf, and we have a deal," she said.

After considering their options, Micha sighed. There was one person that Perfuma mentioned was trustworthy that was between here and Elysia—but Micah was dubious. He was not really sure if he wanted to trust them.

"Can you get us to Thenlor?" He asked.

* * *

“I would like to draw your attention here, ladies, to the last known communication written by Trollan hands.” The scholar Yarial was saying as she lifted an ornate cylindrical tube.

Adora noticed that the container holding the ancient scroll was covered with First One’s runes and immediately moved to get a closer inspection.

“Beyond space, beyond time,” she said, reading the runes aloud.

“Yes!” Yarial said brightly. “We had interpreted as much and believe it is a clue as to where the Trollan people went,”

“So, what does the scroll say? Can we see it?” Adora said, holding out her hand.

Yariel immediately blanched as she clutched the scroll to her chest, out of Adora’s reach.

“Absolutely not! This scroll has only recently been discovered! It needs to be opened in a sterile and controlled environment to protect the millennia-old paper on which the message is printed!”

Adora shrugged apologetically before turning to Catra who was scowling at Yariel’s back as the scholar placed the ancient scroll back in the glass display it was housed in. When they were kids, Catra would have laughed at Adora’s enthusiasm for getting herself into trouble, but not now, it seemed her wife was constantly on guard to protect her from anything remotely unpleasant. Adora knew why Catra was acting this way and appreciated it; she only hoped that didn’t mean this poor scholar was about to be torn to shreds.

“Talk to my wife like that again, and I’ll—” Catra started to say before Adora placed a soft hand over her lips. Yariel turned from the scroll to regard Catra with hesitation—as if unsure whether to continue the tour.

“Don’t mind her; she has been out in the sun too long,” Adora said sweetly.

“Well, um, yes.” She said nervously. “Shall we continue the tour?”

Adora nodded quickly as Catra crossed her arms, giving an audible ‘harrumph,’ and the two followed the scholar deeper into the largest and most bizarre building in the City of Trollos—the Athenaeum.

On the outside, the Athenaeum appeared as a giant seashell, spiraling into itself for infinity. On the inside, it housed numerous round chambers connected haphazardly to each other and in no logical fashion. From what Adora could understand, the Athenaeum was a library of sorts; Yariel had said the Trollans called it a ‘well of understanding, insight, and wisdom.’ Adora had asked Yariel to give them a tour, hoping to glean more information on the Trollans along the way. She could not explain it to Catra, but since her time as Despara, Adora felt as if they were woefully unprepared to be out in the Universe—so many terrors lurked out there between the stars; the best tool against them was knowledge. What better place to find this information than the oldest library in the galaxy? The only problem was, besides the single scroll Yariel had just shown them, the entire building was bereft of books; it seemed that every single one was taken when the Trollans abandoned the planet millennia ago, leaving an empty shell of a library.

Expecting Yariel to lead them into yet another barren chamber, Adora was surprised to see a pedestal positioned in the center of the one they had just entered. Comprised of a marble-like stone, the pedestal was emblazoned with more First One’s runes, and at the top was an empty slot.

“And here is one of our bigger mysteries,” Yariel said, indicating the pedestal in the center of the room. “All we know about it is from the inscription on the front.”

“Wun-Dar,” Catra said, surprising Adora. She still could not believe that Catra read First-One’s runes just as well as she could now.

“Yes! But what does that mean?” Yariel said quizzically. “Is it meant figuratively or literally—as a state of being? To *wonder* is to open yourselves up to the cosmos and receive knowledge?”

Catra stared at the scholar as if she had lost her mind.

“What are you talking about? Wun-Dar isn’t a concept! They are one of the seven Champions of Grayskull—duh!” She exclaimed.

Yariel was immediately incensed. “Nonsense! Never heard of them! Seven Champions? Ridiculous, there are only two; She-Ra and He-Man.”

Catra folded her arms, her tail twitching in annoyance as she turned to Adora.

“Should I show her?” Catra asked with a wicked gleam in her eye.

“Uh, nope! Not necessary!” Adora said, holding up her hands.

“Let’s say you are correct, and Wun-Dar is a Champion; what would they have to do with the Trollans? Even better—what is this pedestal for?” Yariel continued.

Catra inspected the pedestal, suddenly perking her ears as she realized the answer.

“It’s obvious! It’s to hold the Power Sword of Wun-Dar! Look here at the top! This slot is where the sword is held.” Catra said, pointing a clawed finger at the top of the pedestal.

Yariel held her chin in contemplation as she peered at where Catra pointed, sticking two fingers into the opening.

“Perhaps this was used for a sword…” she said thoughtfully. “But we need concrete proof for who the sword is for, not conjecture! Academia runs on thorough research, Catra! Perhaps if you feel so strongly on the subject, you can write a paper on it and submit it for peer review?”

Catra rolled her eyes at the scholar and crossed her arms over her chest. By the way the woman spoke, Adora could tell that she thought the likelihood of Catra writing anything was low.

"My wife would write the most stunning paper you've ever seen, Yariel!" Adora said defensively.

Adora didn't see the scholar give a dismissive shrug—she was too busy catching the appreciative grin and wink Catra had for her.

"Anyway, if we move along, we will come to the center of the Athenaeum, where the Gate is located," Yariel said, indicating that they should follow.

After leading Catra and Adora through several rooms filled with more empty bookcases, Yariel presented them with the last and final stop of the tour; a spacious and bright chamber greeted them, varying greatly from the other rooms they had seen thus far. Instead of having a round and organic shape, this one adhered to more rigid geometry and was octagonal; the walls made of the same stone as the pedestal. Sunlight shone down from three dodecagon-shaped skylights in the ceiling; looking closely at them, Adora saw that dust drifted down from them, indicating it was open to the outside. A metal grill sat in place of glass, its mesh forming twelve and three-sided shapes. In the center of this space hung a circular ring that shared the same composition as the walls, suspended from the ceiling by four thick chains.

"Here we are, ladies—the Gate! The place we suspect the Trollans used to leave our reality and enter another dimension magically!" Yariel said breathlessly.

"How do you know all this? Was there a paper written on the subject?" Catra asked innocently.

The scholar ignored Catra's jibe as she glided into the room, taking a deep breath as if breathing in all the history the room had to offer.

"I am sure you have observed all the different shapes and geometries found in this room—that is purely by design! You see, the Trollans based much on their magic on numbers, believing that mathematics was the key to correctly harnessing the arcane arts!" Yariel explained.

"That's it—I'm back to hating magic," Catra responded.

"This room has eight sides, symbolizing protection and harmony—the perfect spot to conduct a powerful spell!" Yariel continued. "The windows in the ceiling provide the access point to vast cosmological forces while the grill harnesses and focuses them!"

Catra chuckled at this as she tapped her claws on the hard surface of the closest wall. Yariel turned to her with eyebrows raised and arms crossed.

"Something amusing about all this?" She asked icily.

"Yeah, sounds like these Trollans were a bunch of brain-heads who thought too hard about magic. As I see it, you can't stuff magic into a box or categorize it with numbers; it's a force of nature! My people don't bother with all this number nonsense—we live in harmony with magic!"

Adora found herself grinning at Catra's use of the word 'we' when referring to the Madgēcots. It was apparent that Catra now identified as one—it made sense since she was the living embodiment of all their virtues as Sher-Va. Once again, Adora felt like much had happened while she was Despara and that Catra had grown so much. She felt immensely proud to be Catra's wife.

"And who might—*your people*—be?" Yariel asked haughtily.

"The Madgēcots!" Catra said brightly, hands on hips. "I'm a Madgēcot!"

Yariel sniffed at this as she nodded. "Yes, I've heard of *them*. Well, everyone approaches magic differently; some by a precise and measured way, others by more *messier* means."

Catra had enough and, with teeth bared, charged at the scholar.

“I will show you messier! I’m gonna messier your face!” She hissed as Yariel shrieked in terror.

Before Catra could get her claws on the unfortunate scholar, Adora was there to intercept her, gathering her wife up into an angry ball of growling fur in her arms. Catra may have come a long way to becoming a better person, but she still could not stand people talking down to her. Yariel leaned against the Gate in the center of the room to collect herself, chains rattling at the disruption of the hanging stone ring.

“I think it would be best if you two leave—now,” she said once she finally composed herself.

“Yep, I was thinking the same thing!” Adora said as she pushed Catra towards the exit.

As Adora passed the marble-like stone wall of the room, she noticed it was slightly translucent as a faint light glowed far behind the veins embedded in the rock. Stopping momentarily, she pointed at it.

“Yariel? What is this light?” She queried.

“LEAVE!” The scholar yelled, obviously done with being polite.

Adora bobbed her head in acquiescence before turning to the exit. As she and Catra left the strange room, Adora could not help the feeling she was being watched, and not by the irritated scholar.

She felt like it was coming from deep within the wall and far, far away.

* * *

Frosta stumbled, almost tripping on an exposed root in the forest floor as she raced through the Whispering Woods. Glancing furtively behind her, she caught sight of her pursuers—lean

shadows gliding through the forest like wraiths. They appeared to absorb whatever midday light managed to break through the canopy above, moving with a fluidity that spoke of skill that went beyond the natural and into the magical. That made sense: Frosta had led a group of refugees to a meeting in the Whispering Woods, hoping to join up with other disparate groups. The monsters had come out of nowhere to leap down on them from the treetops, mostly likely after subverting Frosta's magical wards and ice traps. They had been caught unawares, and Frosta had watched in horror as they pulled down refugees she had saved just two days before. She had tried her ice magic on the monsters—but it had no effect—even seeming make them more energized by the cold instead of slowed down by it.

Everything was happening so fast; one moment, her home planet was peaceful and safe, and the next, the Etherian Star Force had come to her Kingdom of Snows, demanding she and all her people submit to a new authority. Not willing to fight her own people, Frosta was forced to flee her own kingdom, taking whomever she could find and leading them to safety. Now they were all gone and Frosta was defenseless, running from creatures that seemed to come out of her nightmares. Even worse, she was in unfamiliar territory; they had avoided this part of the Whispering Woods during the fight against Horde Prime.

I know I am nowhere near Bright Moon, but I think there is a village nearby; I remember seeing one on a map—Devlan, it's called. She thought, ducking under a branch.

Frosta instantly screamed as cold hands gripped her arm, yanking her toward black teeth. By instinct, she summoned her ice armor and swung an ice-encased fist at the fiend, smashing it back into a tree with such force it spattered into a black muck. The ooze dissipated into smoke, leaving nothing left of the monster that had tried to stop her. But there were plenty more to take its place, creeping under trees and over branches, black eyes intent on the young Princess.

Frosta dismissed her frozen protection to flee unencumbered by its weight; by now, she was running low on stamina, and it would not be long before the monsters overtook her. But she would not give up without a fight; she ran as fast as her legs could take her, bursting through a tangle of brush and into a break in the forest.

Hope coursed through her veins to see a cluster of quaint houses in the center of the clearing; it was the Village of Devlan, and as Frosta scanned it, she could see people milling about on their midday break. Frosta bounded towards the town, waving her arms frantically to warn the people of the approaching danger. They turned to see the disheveled Princess abruptly in their midst, their faces blank and unconcerned.

"Run!" Frosta implored.

The people looked at each other briefly before returning to their business, completely unconcerned. Frosta was incensed, but before she could rebuke them, the sound of rustling from behind made her bolt forward into the settlement. She ran through the town searching for a friendly face—but none were found—only callous stares from people with no compassion for her plight.

What is the matter with these people? She thought.

Looking back, Frosta saw the creatures exit the forest and enter the town, passing the villagers without falling upon them. It was like there was nothing in those people the monsters wanted, and they continued in her direction, making Frosta want to scream in frustration.

"Hey! Over here!" A voice called nearby. It was coming from a basement window in a nearby house.

Desperate to find a place to hide, Frosta scampered over to peer into the cellar, seeing a dirty little human boy standing on a stool gazing at her.

"Quick! Climb inside before they see you!" He urged.

Not needing that much coaxing, Frosta slipped through the open window to land on the dirt floor as the child shut the window, drawing the blinds behind them. He jumped down from his perch to crouch near Frosta, both of them watching as three figures stopped by the window. They kneeled before the glass, tapping at the hard surface with sharp claws, the sound of which made Frosta's skin crawl. After a tense moment, the figures moved on, perhaps not sensing their prey hiding within, and both Frosta and her rescuer let out a sigh of relief.

"I'm Peric!" The boy said, holding out a dirty hand to Frosta.

"Yeah, um, I'm Frosta," Frosta said awkwardly, still recovering from her flight.

The boy—Peric—instantly brightened, seeming hopeful as Frosta shook his hand.

"Your one of the Princesses! Wow!" He exclaimed.

"Yes, I am. But being a Princess didn't help me defend my people against these monsters or help me escape. Thanks for stepping in—no one in your village even batted an eye when I asked for help," Frosta stated.

All of a sudden crestfallen, Peric nodded sadly.

"Yeah, everyone here in Devlan is Darkened. Is the same with all the nearby towns—you can't trust anyone!" He said.

"Darkened?" Frosta asked with a tilt of her head.

Peric nodded. "It's what I call the people like the ones you met in Devlan—they don't care about other people anymore, only themselves. It's like a spreading disease—only it's not a cold! People become Darkened when one of those black monsters gets a hold and bites you!"

Frosta smiled at this, laying a grateful hand on Peric's shoulder.

“Well, I guess I’m glad you rescued me!” She said as Peric blushed.

“Aw, don’t mention it,” he said bashfully. “I was only in this town because the Tinker sent me.”

“The Tinker?” Frosta asked. Peric nodded vigorously.

“Yeah! He is the one organizing things and helping us fight back! He sent me here to try and find people who haven’t been darkened yet. It seems like my mission was a success!” Peric exclaimed.

Frosta glanced around the basement doubtfully. It was extremely cramped, the only furnishing being an old tapestry hanging from a nearby wall.

“Peric, not to dash your hopes, but we aren’t out of this yet. We still have to get out of this town and to safety. I feel those monsters will come back when they don’t find me.”

“Easy!” Peric said happily as he went to the hanging tapestry. Yanking it down, Peric revealed a gaping hole in the foundation; it continued into the ground, forming a tunnel that disappeared into the darkness.

“Let’s go!” Peric said, gesturing to Frosta to follow. “I’m sure the Tinker will be thrilled that I found a Princess!”

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by @Ansdrela_Art

Misunderstandings

Chapter Summary

Orko brings Shen and Veth to New Trolla; both are to be presented before the Crimson Councel.

Not everything is as it seems with the Trollans.

It was with a surreal sense of disassociation that Shen found himself following a being with no legs down a strange path in a dimension beyond normal time and space. He concentrated on just trying to put one foot in front of the other as the being—Orko—jabbered endlessly about things Shen had no understanding of.

"It is so amazing that you passed through the interdimensional stich and bypassed the fractal wards! How in the name of the Five Conflagrations of Yrada did you survive that? Actually, never mind that! How did you find the Timeless Dimension amongst the infinite patterns of the omniverse?" Orko practically squeaked. The Trollan bobbed up and down in the air as he simultaneously tried to glide forwards and turn to speak to his new companions.

"Uh, luck, I guess?" Shen responded lamely with a shrug.

"Luck?" Orko responded. "There is no such thing! Although there is some credibility to the seemingly apparent or unpredictable behavior being determined by—"

Shen tuned out Orko's nonstop talking as he tried to stop his thoughts from tumbling into each other; once again, he was in a position where he felt things were moving too fast.

Upon stumbling on Shen and Veth, Orko introduced himself, informing them that the Crimson Council had sent him to investigate the recent disturbance at a place called the Corporeal Sieve. He then informed them that since they were obviously new to the Timeless Dimension, they must come with him at once to New Trollos—the city where he and the other Trollans lived. Orko

explained to Shen and Veth that they must be brought before the Crimson Council in order to judge the level of threat the newcomers pose.

When he said that, Shen thought that Veth might resist the summons, being already familiar with their irritable mood. But the Nephraeh barely said anything, watching Orko with suspicious eyes while not even casting a glance in Shen's direction. This brought Shen's mind full circle as to why he felt so much turmoil at this very moment; he had kissed Veth—basically out of nowhere—and Orko had interrupted them before Shen could get an honest reaction out of them. Either Veth was about to hit Shen for his temerity or kiss him back—either could have been possible at that moment. Perhaps Veth was about to kill him, and the Trollan had basically saved his life—either way, Shen had no idea what was going through the Nephraeh's head.

Maybe they don't even care about it. For all I know, kissing is not a big deal with Nephraeh, Shen thought, looking askance at Veth walking beside him. But as he looked at their lilac profile, he knew Veth could sense his scrutiny, for they purposefully turned to gaze off in the opposite direction. At that moment, he knew that whether for ill or good, his actions did have meaning to Veth, and he once again tried to figure out why he did it. It certainly wasn't the reason Shen gave Veth—that it looked like they needed it. He had wanted to kiss Veth, perhaps just realizing it when he saw the need reflected in their glimmering eyes.

Risking another look at the Nephraeh, Shen took Veth in—from their sleek, long black hair, and pointed ears, down to their lithe body accentuated by their tight pants formed of black gleaming bands. He knew they were extremely attractive—an almost universal appeal to anyone who understood the sensual—and existed outside the binary spectrum. Shen recognized that he had always been attracted to the same kind of people—those who do not adhere to the extremes of either side of the binary and exist someplace near the middle.

There had been Shen'Dara—the beautiful Elvar of his home planet who had been a fierce warrior and his first true love. Then there was Double Trouble, a being that could be either gender yet preferred a form that tugged at either end of the spectrum. Finally, there was Catra, a beautiful woman with a strong masculine side whose wild spirit was tempered by a core of compassion.

Looking at Veth, Shen recognized facets of all three embodied in one; they were a powerful warrior, the embodiment of androgynous beauty and…

Shen was about to tell himself that Veth had an abundance of empathy but stopped himself there.

Veth has been nothing but horrible to me since we met; why would I think they have some hidden soft side? He thought.

Before he could think any further on the subject, their guide spoke up, pulling Shen from his introspection.

"So, when I first found you too, I felt like I was interrupting something… intimate," Orko said. "Sorry about that! Dree Elle is always saying I'm being awkward and saying inappropriate things!"

"I would say Dree Elle is onto something, Orko," Veth said icily. "I never met Dree Elle, but I would say they are very insightful."

"She! Dree Elle is a girl, and she is my girlfriend!" Orko said happily.

"You are truly a lucky Trollan," Veth responded tonelessly.

Orko's hooded head tilted as he attempted to process what Nephraeh had just said.

"Uh, thank you! I think!" He said happily.

Whoever is going to try and find Veth's nice side will have to bring warm clothes, Shen thought as he grinned to himself. Once again, he tried to catch their eye, but Veth only turned away, nose practically in the air.

"So, Orko, where was it you were saying you were going to? The Corporal Steve?" Shen asked.

"It was *Corporeal Sieve*, moron," Veth interjected. It was the first thing they had said to him since the kiss.

"Yes, the Corporeal Sieve!" Orko said happily. "When travelers find their way to the Timeless Dimension, the Corporeal Sieve diverts them to a place where they can be safely contained until their intentions can be verified. The Crimson Council can't have just anyone showing up in the Timeless Dimension!"

Veth suddenly seized Orko by his sleeve, pulling the floating being around to face them.

"You mean to tell me you built that place we arrived in? That place where two violent guardians tried to kill us? Where there is a room full of evil intent that makes you suffer your worst night nightmares? Is that the Corporeal Sieve?" They hissed.

Orko let out a squeak as they yanked their robe out of Veth's claws.

"The Chamber of Disquietude?" Orko asked.

"Disquietude?" Veth yelled. "That is a pale description of what you put Shen and I through!"

Orko put their blue hands up in a defensive gesture. Shen couldn't blame him; he had been on the receiving end of Veth's anger many times in the past few days. Not wanting to see their guide torn to shreds, Shen reached out and grasped Veth gently by the wrist. They spun on him, eyes flashing and fangs bared.

“Easy, Veth! I have a feeling that Orko here isn’t directly responsible for what we went through. How about we just calm down and allow him to take us to this Crimson Counsel? Perhaps they know of a way for us to get back to our own reality?” Shen implored.

Veth’s silver eyes searched Shen’s own, seeming to find something there, and the ire left their lilac face. Pulling themselves out of Shen’s grasp, they turned away in one fluid motion as they brushed past Orko.

“Lead the way, *trollan*,” they said.

“The name is Orko,” he responded helpfully. Veth didn’t respond.

“It’s okay; you’re not the only one. They call me *Human,*” Shen said, placing a hand on Orko’s shoulder.

Although, when they were upset, they did call me Shen, he amended to himself.

“Okay! New Trolla is not far; just up head!” Orko exclaimed as they continued to lead the way.

* * *

Veth stomped down the path, still fuming from the discovery that Orko’s people had built a place that played on someone’s trauma.

When I get my hands on this Crimson Council, I swear I’ll… Veth thought as they glanced to the side; Orko glided past them with a merry wave as he took the lead.

“The Trollans have come a long way from the virtuous magic users they once were if they are resorting to dark powers,” Veth griped.

“Oh! Are your people familiar with the Trollans?” Orko asked curiously.

Veth balked at the question; it was as if Orko had asked the most ridiculous this possible.

"*Are my people familiar with Trollans*? The Trollans and Nephraeh were the greatest of allies before the coming of Horde Prime!"

Now it was Orko's turn to look confused. "Yes! That is true; Nephraeh and Trollans are dear friends—but you are not a Nephraeh!"

"What?!" Veth said, trying to stop the anger from coming back. "That is ridiculous! I was born on Empyrea; I am the bearer of Zhe-La. How would you know anyway? Trollans can live a long time but not a thousand years. Your records are incomplete!"

Orko pondered this. "No, I've seen pictographs and holograms of prominent Nephraeh. I will admit your ears and body type are similar, but Nephraeh have white skin and hair. Their eyes are gold, not silver. Plus," he said, waving a hand at Veth's hands and face. "They definitely didn't have those pointy ends."

Veth was dumbfounded. Looking at Orko's quintessence, they could tell the Trollan did not have an ounce of deceit in his mystical body.

"Archon Lethe is the only Nephraeh with white hair and skin. They are also so very old, from around the time the Old Empire fell," Veth pondered. "Perhaps… they did something to us when they took our empathy away…"

Veth looked down at themselves, at the lilac skin, white markings, and sharp claws on their fingertips. They tried to imagine skin like Archon Lethe—pure white and untouched by blemishes. It seemed that even if they had their empathy returned to them, the Nephraeh would never be the same.

"Well, I think the Nephraeh look better this way," Shen interjected. "Just white skin and hair? No cool white markings, claws, and fangs? Sounds boring."

Veth reluctantly turned to look at Shen; he was smiling kindly at them. Remembering the kiss, they immediately looked away; Veth did not want to think about that right now.

"I'm sure the Crimson Council will know what to make of you, Nephraeh or no Nephraeh," Orko said confidently.

"I don't need a bunch of Trollans to verify what I already know," Veth growled.

They could not help feeling an immense amount of irritation—Veth was just bursting with it—and they knew it wasn't the ignorance of their Trollan guide making them upset. Veth just could not help feeling like so much time had been wasted—not just their own life but the entirety of the Nephraeh race for the past thousand years.

Instead of being out in the universe, the Nephraeh had been isolated on Empyrea to be little more than sustenance for a selfish god. Their old allies—the ones that still remembered the Nephraeh—had wanted nothing to do with them, and for a good reason too. Archon Lethe had subverted the virtue that now came so easily to Veth's people so absolutely that even the physical appearance of the Nephraeh had changed. Veth's anger suddenly subsided, replaced by sadness, and they stifled the urge to weep.

"Hey, Veth. Are you okay?" Shen said, touching them gently on the arm.

Veth pulled away from Shen's touch and attempted to wipe their eyes before he spotted the tears.

"You really push your luck with me, *Human,*" Veth said, dismissively running a hand through their hair.

Shen didn't seem taken aback by their response; on the contrary, based on his quintessence, he expected it.

"Oh yeah?" He responded casually. "And how am I pushing my luck? By trying to be nice to you?"

Veth snorted. “Be nice to me? Is that what you call it?”

“Ah! So, this is about when we kissed before?” he asked with an insufferable smile.

“When *we* kissed!? There was no *we*—*you* kissed me, remember?” Veth said, thoroughly incensed. They absolutely did not want to discuss this right now.

“Yeah, I did make the first move,” Shen conceded. “But that is only because I could tell you had feelings for me,”

If Nephraeh could blush, Veth would have done so at that moment. Instead, they gritted their teeth and looked away momentarily. By now, Orko had halted ahead, pretending not to listen to the heated exchange between his two guests.

“Orko, Shen, and I need a moment to *discuss* a few things,” Veth said, gripping Shen firmly by his upper arm to drag him behind the nearest tree.

“Oh! That’s completely fine! I will be right here!” The Trollan said happily.

Veth could tell the human was mildly hopeful that he was being pulled into a private meeting, which annoyed them. He seemed so sure of what they were about, just like this Trollan was so confident about them not being a Nephraeh. It was time to disabuse Shen of his notions—no one would tell Veth who they were. They had enough of that their entire lives for it to continue.

“Listen, Shen. I know what you saw in me, and I will be the first to admit it. But it’s not what you think.” Veth started. They found that they were having a hard time telling the human what was going on with them privately—but it needed to happen, so there was no ambiguity between them.

“My entire life, I have to participate in something called the Penumbra Ritual. Archon Lethe had me start doing it at a young age—I thought it was simply a means by which I show my

allegiance to them. But that was not completely true; the Penumbra Ritual was a way to… latch myself to the ruler of the Nephraeh—to connect my soul to theirs. Archon Lethe, in turn, removed all of my empathy and compassion this way; I believe they used it as fuel for themselves—like food."

"It wasn't until I was convinced by someone very close—Nefeli—that maybe the Penumbra Ritual was not the way, that we should stop doing it because it was *lessening* us. When Nefeli died, I stopped taking part in the Ritual completely, and since then, I've been changing."

Veth sighed heavily as they prepared to explain this next part.

"I've been getting my empathy back—a little at first—but then a lot. It's an amazing feeling to get a new emotion, especially one so wonderful as compassion! But there have been… *other changes*… that I have been experiencing. For one, I can somehow view another person's soul simultaneously as I see their physical form—please don't ask me to explain it!" Veth said with a smile, holding up their hand.

"But also—and this is more intense—I've been developing a very strong… *urge.* In the past, this would have been described as a desire to 'mate,' but what I feel has grown beyond that description. It's like a—"

Veth broke off as they noticed that not only was Shen blushing very hard, but his quintessence was folding in on itself and turning a darker, bruised shade. They knew he was feeling a great shame.

"I think I understand," Shen said in a strained way. "Your body is changing; you're just developing this need and don't have any experience controlling it. In my stupidity, I took this as a sign that you were attracted to me and basically took advantage of you. I am so sorry—"

Not it was Shen's turn to be interrupted as Veth practically shrieked with laughter.

"*Oh… Human*—I mean Shen. You? Take advantage of me? *That's kind of cute.* Please don't go beating yourself up over it. After all, it was just a kiss; no harm done." They said.

Shen smiled weakly as he nodded, and Veth noted that his quintessence turned its typical vibrant hues—but remained closed off to them. They frowned.

"Now that's cleared up, how about we catch up to Orko?" Shen asked.

Deep inside, Veth felt they wanted to continue the conversation but wasn't sure what more there was to say. Ultimately, they just shrugged, tucking a strand of hair behind one of their long ears as they gestured forward.

"After you," they said.

Shen and Veth caught up with Orko, who was picking at one of his pointy blue ears as he waited for them.

"Everything settled?" He asked hopefully.

"Yes. Very settled." Shen responded.

Veth nodded at Orko as they glanced at Shen; he was now making a point not to look at them, and they were unsure whether it was out of spite or guilt. Veth felt it was the latter.

The three travelers continued their journey along the worn path in disparate shades of sentiment: one in awkward discomfiture, one in a form of ignorant bliss, and finally, one in unclear regret. Daylight was slowly giving way to twilight in the Timeless Dimension as twinkling dots began to shine through the dimming veil; it wasn't long before the newcomers finally got their first view of the New Trolla.

What appeared at first to be bare branches slowly revealed themselves to be thin spires projecting up from the ends of high towers. As the travelers came entirely out of the enfolds of the beautiful forest, they realized that towers were the extreme points of conical-shaped buildings, pressed together and connected by arched bridges. With their sensitive Nephraeh sight, Veth could sense movement amongst the agglomeration of buildings—almost like they were bobbing up and down—like a Trollan. As they finally reached the point in which they had the entire view, Veth perceived that New Trolla was, in fact, floating.

"Wow! It's like Mystacor!" Shen exclaimed. "Only instead of floating over a hole in Etheria, New Trolla is suspended over another sky!"

Looking down over a cliff edge, Veth observed that Shen was right; under the city protruded a rocky outcropping under which only fading sky appeared, lit by an array of dazzling stars.

"So, this ground we walk upon is not a planet?" Veth asked.

"Nope!" Orko said. "We don't need planets in the Timeless Dimension—only magic!"

Orko hovered over to a shimmering bridge made of rainbow light and pointed to the city on the other side.

"Welcome to New Trolla!" He exclaimed.

As Veth crossed the transparent bridge, they were amazed by both the view below them and the potency of Trollan magic.

This must be an incredibly powerful spell to maintain itself like this continuously, Veth considered to themselves as they tapped at one of the chromatic railings with a claw tip.

Once on the other side, Veth could get a closer view of the city and its inhabitants; Trollans of diverse shapes and sizes levitated over the gleaming roads and walkways as they went about their daily lives. None of the city residents shared Orko's red-colored

robe—each having their own individual color ranging in a wide array of spectrums and hues with various symbols emblazoned on their chests. The Trollans stopped to stare and whisper as Veth and Shen walked past them; they seemed especially interested in Veth, watching them with suspicious eyes under wide-brimmed hats.

Since Trollans are wholly magical, they must either see or sense the magic in me as well. Not recognizing my species, they must be afraid. Veth thought to themselves as they focused their secondary sight on the beings.

Veth was not surprised that they beheld the same nebulous shapes and abstract colors as when they looked at Shen—after all, a soul was beyond the strictures of reality. It did not matter whether or not the being it was connected to was magical or non-magical.

But they were alarmed by the fact that they did not feel the same kind of… *pleasure*… when viewing the Trollan's souls as they did the human. Not that it was because the Trollans were bad—on the contrary—Veth could tell that many were quite good people based on what they detected in their quintessence. They just didn't have quite the same medley as Shen's—like a song sung with no passion.

Dismissing that train of thought, Veth focused on the buildings they passed under; they were crystalline-based, much like the unusual walls in the place they awoke in. Having that reminder of the Trollan's complicity in building that place—Chamber of Disquietude—only upset Veth, and they turned their attention to the minor road Orko was following. It twisted and turned around the buildings, passing over bridges or through tunnels that passed directly through the Trollan structures. This new city was utterly different from the city Veth was used to—Nox. New Trolla was built with no clear plan or semblance of pattern; it seemed very organic and natural, and Veth had to admit it was refreshing.

Soon the road they traveled on raised up off the ground, leading toward the midsection of the largest building at the very center of the city. Two Trollan guards floated on either side of a pair of red double doors; in their hands were wands which they held up as Orko and his two guests approached.

"As a member of the Crimson Council, you may pass Orko. But who are these strangers you bring with you?" Asked one of the guards as they extended their want to poke at Veth.

"Ah! I wouldn't do that, Umpty!" Orko said as he seized the wand, stopping it from making contact with the Nephraeh currently bearing their fangs.

"These are visitors who are lost! I am bringing them before the Crimson Counsel so we can decide what to do with them! Please open the door and stand aside!" Orko squeaked.

At Orko's command, the Trollan guards directed their wands away from the newcomers and toward the entrance as both doors swung out by enchanted means. Stepping within the bizarre structure and crossing a foyer, they entered another chamber via a pair of double doors—once inside, darkness abruptly seized Veth's eyes, making them very suspicious.

"Orko, please don't tell me we trusted you only to have you lead us into another one of your Chambers of Disquietude," Veth said, not in question.

"It's okay! It's here as protection for the Crimson Council, and its magic is not activated right now!" Orko chirped.

Feeling around themselves for Shen, Veth gripped his wrist to pull him closer.

"Stay close to me, Human. Who knows what these idiots might do with dark magic." They hissed.

"Oh, I wouldn't worry about that, Veth," Orko interjected. "There are much more dangerous things in this room than a little magic—

let me tell you!”

Before Veth could question that statement, nine beams of light alighted on nine platforms spaced out in a semi-circle around Veth and Shen. Eight red-robed Trollans glided out of the darkness and over the empty platforms, with Orko taking the last spot. Except for their guide, every single one of the newly arrived Trollans exuded great age, whether by sporting great white beards or by their stooped posture.

“You now stand before the Crimson Council!” Orko proclaimed.

“Yes, yes,” One of the Crimson Council exclaimed, a Trollan with a great bushy beard. “What have you brought before us, Orko? I hope this isn’t a waste of time?”

“Oh no, Blim! This is definitely not a waste of time! You see, I found these two—"

A loud harumph interrupted Orko as another member of the Crimson Council began to rummage in her robe; after a moment of this, she removed what looked like a large monocle.

“Let me get a closer look at these interlopers with my perception magnifier,” she said, peering through it at Shen and Veth. She instantly let out of cry of alarm.

“Orko! You fool! They are bearers of Champion Avatars! How could you let them out of the Corporeal Sieve?! That is what it is there for!” She practically screamed.

“Oh! I didn’t, Foosebella! You see, I was on my way to the Corporeal Sieve when—” Orko started to respond but was interrupted once more.

“Which Champion Spirits are they?” Another Trollan asked.

Foosebella once again inspected Veth and Shen as a sound of disgust emitted from her.

“The known fallen ones! He-Man and Zhe-La—Orko, you idiot!!!” She screeched.

“Now! Now! Our youngest and most inexperienced Crimson Counsel member knows that the Ward of Suppressment is enacted throughout the Timeless Dimension. He-Man and Zhe-La are powerless to harm us here; it was very wise of you to bring them before us!” Another Trollan exclaimed.

The one known as Blim regarded Veth and Shen a moment before addressing them.

“Why have you come to the Timeless Dimension, Dark Ones? How did Horde Prime find us here? Answer me!” He demanded.

In the soft light projected by the spaces occupied by the Crimson Council, Veth could see Shen staring at the hostile Trollans with an open mouth. They shared in his incredulity, but the rising anger gave them enough coherence to respond.

“How dare you accuse us of being sent here by Horde Prime! Dark Ones? What in the name of Empyrea are you talking about?” Veth replied.

Blim turned to his counterparts and began whispering back and forth amongst themselves; after a moment of loud murmuring, he turned his attention back to Veth and Shen.

“Since you will never leave this place alive, we might as well tell you; we, the Trollans, left your universe long ago to escape the tyrant Horde Prime and his army of foul clones. We created the Timeless Dimensions as a haven for the Trollan people, but that did not mean we didn’t keep an eye on the affairs of your universe! We saw how the bearer of He-Man and Zhe-La allowed themselves to be debased and corrupted and prepared for the eventuality when one of them would come here to dominate us. We created the Corporeal Sieve as a means to capture any intruder and enacted the Ward of Suppressment to keep you from harnessing your Champion power.” Blim gloated.

“Blim, that is all true, but when was the last time we checked on their universe?” Orko asked. “I thought you told me you have not used the Speculum Mysticos in over a century—“

“Silence, Orko!” Blim hissed. “Not in front of the outsiders!”

Orko’s floating form dropped towards the floor under the combined withering stares of the other eight members of the Crimson Council.

“So, you see, we were ready for you, Dark Ones! You may have tricked foolish Orko—but not us! You are at our mercy now, so I ask you one more time; why have you come? Are there others on their way? What master do you serve? Is it Horde Prime or some new foul bringer of woe?” Blim finished.

The anger that had been building inside Veth was now an explosive inferno; they could not believe the stupidity of these people and right away realized what they wanted to say to these ignorant Trollans.

“You say you have been watching us from your Timeless Dimension? Watching for the past thousand years as the people of ‘our universe’ fought and struggled against Horde Prime? Were you watching my people—the Nephraeh—slowly become corrupted over the years? My people, who only wanted to spread their Light amongst the universe and who called the Trollans ‘friend’? What did you think when we slowly whittled away until only gray specters were left, bereft of any compassion or warmth? Did you decide to come and help us—your friends? No, you didn’t, and now you have the nerve to accuse us of coming to try and harm you,” Veth seethed, clenching their fists.

“Now, hold on a minute—!” Foosebella started to say but was cut off by Veth.

“NO! I will not hold on a minute,” Veth said in a mimicry of the Trollan’s high-pitched voice. “The Nephraeh have waited a thousand years already! We have been waiting and suffering while

the Trollans hid in their silly little dimension like the selfish little fools that they are! *YOU ARE ALL COWARDS!!!*"

A gasp coursed throughout the chambers at their proclamation, and Veth turned to notice Shen staring at them with admiration. He instantly vanished as the light illuminating the Crimson Council vanished and the darkness set in.

"You will pay for your arrogance!" Blim roared.

The inky blackness around them suddenly clung to Veth's body, seeping in to smother their soul in absolute despair. Shen instantly screamed next to them—the same heart-wrenching cry of anguish they had heard before.

"Shen!" Veth cried.

They did not need to look at the human with their Nephraeh sight to know what was transpiring with his quintessence—the memory of it was seared into their memory. What they did next was a direct consequence of what was happening to Shen—by means which were becoming much easier to achieve, Veth summoned Light. The evil blackness was immediately pushed back as a luminescence spread out from Veth's core—but it didn't go all the way. A bubble formed around Veth and Shen as the darkness fought against the summoned Light, and Veth strained against it with their newly found power.

"Stop them! They are using Lumomancy!" Blim Cried.

"Wun-Dar! Protect us!" Foosebella responded.

The familiarity of that name distracted Veth enough that they lost their grip on the Light, and instantly, both they and Shen were immersed in the blackness. Before Veth could concentrate and bring their protection back, and metallic voice pierced the gloom.

"Lluksyarg fo modsiw eht yb!" It cried.

As Veth struggled to decipher what was just said, a sound like banging steel rattled toward them. Veth slashed outward with their claws defensively, careful not to strike in the direction of Shen, and instantly their wrists were seized in a vice-like grip.

"**You will not harm the Crimson Counsel.**" The jarring voice pronounced.

"Let go of me! I have no intention—" The Nephraeh Champion started to say, but their words were cut off as a very hard and blunt object struck their face with such force that they were driven entirely insensate.

Veth was out cold.

Delusion

Chapter Summary

Perfuma and Lethe discuss matters pertaining to the psyche.

Frosta meets up with some old friends, also on their way to find the Tinker.

On the Creation of an Advanced Desidery Olphactorium:

Preface: It is of the utmost importance that all materials are gathered within the strict guidelines laid out by the Codex Ullemonar Anydae. Any deviation from said guidelines may result in the permeant loss of the epidermis—or, in the case of an exoskeleton—full and permeant sloughing of the exuvia. Please also use caution in the preparation of the mycelium tincture, and that complete separation of the filamentous hyphae must precede full immersion in a solvent. Make sure to consult the writings of Tupius Koharis on the selection of—

A soft noise distracted Perfuma from her reading, drawing her attention to the source—Lethe. They were standing rigid before the Well of Champion Spirits, not having moved since Scorpia and Mermista departed two days past. Now, with the enervated scribes from Mystacor having left for the castle library minutes ago, she was completely alone in the Vestibule with the massive being.

Well, not totally alone—staring right back at Lethe from within the Well were He-Ro and Thon-Ra; it seemed that both sides were locked in a contest of wills, with Perfuma having no inkling which was gaining the advantage. Only when Thon-Ra faded and floated down to the bottom of the Well like a leaf did Perfuma know Lethe was the victor; they smiled to themselves as He-Ro zipped down to inspect their fallen comrade, pulsing with worry.

“Ah, my little friends. If only I could share my gift with you, things would be so much better,” they said.

Perfuma put the scroll down and raised herself up; Lethe’s bullying of the Avatar Spirits had riled her, making her feel brave. She strode from her small desk to stand next to the mighty being—instantly, Perfuma felt dizzy at being in such proximity to them. She hated to admit it, but Lethe was an extremely attractive being—this, combined with their great size—made their presence almost intoxicating in a strained and painful way. It was very hard to describe the sensation she was feeling—almost bittersweet—but she fought against it to gaze up at them. Lethe finally turned to regard her, a quizzical expression on their white face.

“Ah, my dear Perfuma. How are your studies? Anything new to report to me?” They said in a cheery manner.

“If I did learn anything important, I wouldn’t tell you,” she responded defiantly.

Lethe only laughed at this; it was a genuine and rather charming laugh, and Perfuma couldn’t help but remember that they had been someone good. Glimmer had sent a recorded message to Perfuma telling her the results of Kishar’s journal; she now knew that the bearer of Zhe-La from a thousand years ago—Kishar—was still here, standing before her now.

“I know what happened to you,” Perfuma said suddenly. “I know you are not supposed to be like this… *Kishar*,”

The smile abruptly vanished as Lethe’s white lips pulled back to reveal rows of sharp black teeth. Their indigo eyes bored into Perfuma as they turned to her, hands raised to cause harm.

“I did not have you enervated, my dear Princess, because I believe that would have made you useless to me. I stand by my decision, for I do believe you have some purpose—but call me by that name again—and not only will I kill Scorpia, but I will make

you watch before I do the same to you," they said, voice full of cold fury.

Perfuma wanted to wither like a flower under their fiery gaze, but she held on—not by an iron will—but by boundless compassion. She had counseled many people over the years with trauma and baggage who needed help freeing themselves. But never in her life had Perfuma seen a being as damaged as the one that stood before her; she wanted to weep for the one who had once been Kishar.

"I'm sorry; I will respect your desire to be called Lethe." She said calmly, and in a manner she used during therapy. "I'm just trying to understand what happened to you—what made you like this?"

Lethe cocked their head as they regarded her, but finally, they nodded.

"Yes. I would seem monstrous to you—*a great god coming to take away your compassion.* But you see, it's all about perspective—you just don't have the right *perspective* yet. I am sorry I have not gifted you with enervation—I promise I will soon! Once I have, you will see as I do. You will see as your Scorpia does." Lethe said with a kind smile.

Perfuma shook her head. "But I don't want that gift! Compassion and empathy *are* the gifts—not the absence of them!"

A strange expression crossed Lethe's face, and they tilted their head. Perfuma had the feeling they were trying to seize on a faded recollection, one that was entirely lost but had left an impression like a faded ghost.

"Someone else once thought as you do—they said the same kind of thing to me," Lethe said almost dreamily.

Perfuma felt a strange sense of vulnerability coming from the giant being standing near her; it was as if she had discovered a thread—once pulled, the entire tapestry that was Lethe would become undone. Perfuma sensed it was tied to this person Lethe

couldn’t recall—she knew it had to be Jihan. Perfuma opened her mouth to say the name but stopped, remembering Lethe’s warning.

If hearing their true name would drive them to kill Scorpia and me, what would Lethe do if I said the name of the person they once called their soulmate? She thought, clamping her mouth closed.

“Something important to say, my dear Princess?” Lethe asked.

Looking up into those burning indigo eyes, Perfuma realized there was an opportunity for her, but she had to tread carefully. One wrong move could spell misfortune.

“I was just wondering who this wise person was and why you didn’t listen to them. They sound like they were important to you—why else would they have cared enough to say such a thing?” She stated.

Lethe pondered a moment; they seemed like they were giving Perfuma’s words some serious thought. After a few seconds of this, they only shrugged.

“Perhaps someone that mattered to me before I changed. Before I became better,” they said.

“I’ve heard you mention a few times how having no empathy makes you better or that it’s a gift. How are you better now, Lethe?” Perfuma asked.

“Because nothing holds me back anymore. Anything I want—it’s mine. I have achieved great power going down this path—I am a god now!” Lethe said, waving their hands at their lithe body as if in proof of their words.

“But are you happy, Lethe? Do you know love? You may not have the capacity to love others, but you must still desire it.” Perfuma asked.

Lethe peered down at the Princess, amusement dawning on their beautiful face like a sunrise.

"Ah! I know what you are doing. I have lived hundreds of years, and you think I don't know when someone is trying psychotherapy on me?" Lethe asked, suddenly becoming stern. "Tread carefully, Princess; I have a feeling there is much buried within me. I would hate for you to unearth something that gets you killed."

Perfuma gulped as she nodded but did not avert her eyes from Lethe's; their eyes were such deep indigo that it almost hurt to gaze into them. It was like staring into a deep ocean and not being able to view deeper than a foot below the surface, all the while knowing there may be dangerous things within.

"I don't doubt it, Lethe," Perfuma whispered.

"But I will answer your question!" Lethe said suddenly and with a smile. "According to the renowned Psychoanalyst Evagrius Fromm of the planet Phontis, self-love is the key to a healthy mind. Once you can love yourself, there is no need to receive it from any external source. If there is anyone that loves themselves greatly in this galaxy—it's me. You see, my dear Princess, I have no need of any other love—*so I'm all set,*"

Lethe flicked their white hair back with such insouciance that Perfuma had to clench her hands into fists to keep from jumping up and slapping them.

"You're missing a big part of what love is, Lethe! You can't have self-love without the capacity to love others and receive love. Vice versa—you cannot love others without the capacity to love yourself." Perfuma implored.

"No, I think not," Lethe said, holding up one clawed finger. "Jhetha'Zhan, the renowned theologian from Theron states that there are two kinds of self-love: the first is called the drive for self-preservation and is considered the root desire of every sentient being. The second kind—and this relates to what you

claim as being able to give and receive love—is self-esteem. This is generated only by the appreciation of others. According to my friend Shetha'Zhan, you don't need one to have the other."

"I've never heard of this theologian, but whoever they are, they sound like an idiot!" Perfuma said angrily.

Lethe held their chin as they considered her words. "Shetha'Zhan did try to inveigle themselves with the Royal family of Theron and ended up being poisoned, beheaded, burned, and then buried, so maybe you have a point about listening to them absolutely. But I do believe they were on to something; there is nothing wrong with putting your self-interests first. There can be such a thing as *ethical egoism*,"

"I think you are confusing self-love with narcissism and egoism for egotism, Lethe," Perfuma said curtly. "You can keep spouting off other people's sayings; it doesn't matter. I know what I believe is right,"

"Ah! So sure, are you? Between the two of us, who is most likely to be right? The one who has lived a millennium and is a god, or the mortal with twenty-plus years of experience? Perhaps I am not the egotist here, my dear Princess," Lethe said, reprimanding.

Perfuma shook her head at Lethe, amazed at the level of delusion they worked so hard to wrap themselves up in. Why would a powerful and immortal being study different theories of psychologies from all of the galaxy if they were not searching for a way to rationalize their deeds?

Perfuma had seen this kind of behavior before and always found a great deal of shame buried deep behind the façade of contempt. With Lethe and their unique state of absolute apathy, it was most likely more complicated than that—or maybe not. No psychologist had even encountered one like Lethe before, and Perfuma was in unknown territory.

“Before, when you had Scorpia and Mermista open the door to the Vestibule, you said something I thought was interesting,” Perfuma said tentatively.

“Yes?” Lethe asked, interested.

“You said you got the passphrase *love* on the first try when you first came here. Why do you think that was?” Perfuma finished.

The vague expression returned to Lethe’s face as the light in their glowing eyes appeared to dim a fraction.

“I think it was before I became what I am now,” they said, unsure. “When weakness suffused my entire being and such things as love meant something to me,”

“I would say love meant a lot to you, Lethe. Few people would have gone straight for love on their first guess—patience, humility, humility—perhaps. Maybe you felt that at the time and were in love with someone.”

Perfuma knew she was stretching it thin, but it appeared Lethe was too distracted with their thoughts to call her out on it. They were staring off into space while sliding their black claws down their long white hair repeatedly, almost as if they were brushing their hair. The sight made Perfuma think of when she was a child, sitting by herself and dreaming of someone in particular—someone who had a hold of her heart.

Tentatively, she reached out with both hands to grip Lethe’s larger one—the one they were not using on their white mane.

“Does this person have a name? Can you tell me who they are, Lethe?” Perfuma asked.

Lethe looked down at her, their face the absolute blank of total oblivion as they stopped touching their hair.

“I don’t recall,” they said, faintly sad.

Do you want me to help you?" Perfuma asked kindly.

Lethe shook their head slowly. "No, I don't,"

"Why?" Perfuma prodded.

"Because I'm afraid I would have to kill you if you tried. I don't want to do that," Lethe whispered.

Perfuma shivered at their words, for they were icy to the core, spoken with an absolute truth of conviction. She believed Lethe when they said they did not remember Jihan's name, so much of what they said before made sense now. Lethe did not want to remember Jihan's name—why—she did not know.

Perhaps it was unpleasant to remember a love lost—but even more likely—it was the key to unlock the vault that was Lethe's complex psyche, and they would unravel completely.

But Perfuma could not just speak the word; not only did she not know what it would do to Lethe, but it was a guaranteed instant death for her and Scorpia. If it were only her life on the line, Perfuma would gladly take the chance if it meant stopping Lethe.

"Okay, I will respect your privacy," Perfuma said. "But can I ask you something that won't mean death for me and Scorpia?"

Lethe let out a short blurt of laughter. "You can, but I can give no guarantees when I do not know what you will ask,"

"Fair enough," Perfuma conceded. "What do you want with this place? We only just discovered it and have not gotten it to do anything useful. The only thing we discovered is the Champion Spirits,"

Lethe made a rude face at this, waving her words away disdainfully.

"Nice try, Princess, but you gave yourself away. `*We only discovered the Champion Spirits,'* you say? Bah! Do you think that

would not be enough for me? Or do you think I don't know what this place you call the Vestibule actually is?" Lethe sneered.

Perfuma held her hands up in placation as she backed away from the anger rising in Lethe; they appeared to grow even larger and more menacing.

"No! I, uh… I just was wondering—" She tried to say.

"Yes, well, I think I have had enough of your curiosity, Princess. You have probed farther into my private affairs than anyone else has over the past thousand years; you should count yourself not only honored but lucky—lucky I will let you live!" Lethe seethed.

Lethe followed Perfuma as she backed away, their face twisted as they bared their black teeth down at her. With a strangled yelp, Perfuma fell onto her backside when she came against the platform holding the pylons, and she held her hands up in a lame attempt to hold off the angry god.

"My Arch—I mean, my lord?" A voice interrupted.

Perfuma and Lethe turned to find that Scorpia and Mermista had entered; it was Scorpia who had spoken; she was standing just within the entryway, a worried look on her face.

"Ah, my dear Children!" Lethe cried, the wrath replaced by pleasure. "How goes the conquest? I am sure Eternia is completely ours by now—hopefully, you have come to tell me Etheria is as well?"

The two fallen princesses shared a look before Mermista spoke up.

"Yes, Eternia is ours; the enervation has spread throughout the entire planet to cement your hold. We managed to ensnare the Etherian Star Force and spread off the planet—but we are having issues with taking Etheria. It seems our attack was not quick enough, and some resistance had time to form,"

Lethe frowned at this. “Resistance? Yes, that concept is known to me—I don’t like that word! After many long and glorious years, my dear Nephraeh resisted me; they had surprised me with a sneak attack and drove me from my beloved home world—I will not tolerate it again!”

Now it was Scorpia’s turn to speak. “Yes, My Lord. But we were able to gather some intel on this resistance. It is centered around a single person acting as a focal point for the insurgence. They are calling him the Tinker,”

Lethe’s face suddenly became so confused it was comical. If the situation were not so dire, Perfuma would have laughed.

“Tinker? What is that?” They asked.

“I think I know!” Scorpia said, holding up one of her clawed hands. “There was a guy who used to travel around, and he would come by the Fright Zone when I was a kid. My parents would pay him to fix things periodically, and I heard my father call him the Tinker!”

“Could it be the same person?” Lethe asked.

Scorpia shook her head in the negative. “I doubt it; he was already old when I was a kid. Then the Horde came and took over the Fright Zone—I never saw him again.”

“I doubt it’s the same person; it is kind of a common nickname for anyone who mends things,” Perfuma interrupted. “Someone who wants to fix the wrongs you brought to Etheria could be called a Tinker. Or a person who wants to heal a wounded mind could also be a kind of Tinker,”

Perfuma couldn’t help giving Lethe a coy smile as they stared daggers at her in return.

“What is she talking about?” Mermista asked.

“Pure nonsense,” Lethe said dismissively. “Our Princess from Etheria is prone to flights of fancy and foolishness—nothing more.”

Scorpia and Mermista shared another glance, looking unsure; even though they were no longer themselves, they were familiar with Perfuma’s passive-aggressive comments.

“Scorpia and I can handle this Tinker, My Lord. We know Etheria and will bring a swift end to this rebellion,” Mermista said.

Perfuma wanted to weep at hearing such an exclamation from someone who fought against the Horde but instead stifled the urge, focusing on what was being said.

“No, I have another more important task for you two,” Lethe responded immediately. “It is similar to the last one I sent you both on with Despara—back when she was still with us,”

“Another power sword, My Lord?” Scorpia asked.

Lethe chuckled at this. “Sort of—you will know when you find Wun-Dar. But you will have to go much farther than another planet to find them,” Lethe said cryptically.

Bewildered at the strange word, Perfuma couldn’t help but notice He-Ro and Thon-Ra perk up at the mention of the word Wun-Dar.

It must be another Champion Spirit— Lethe wants to add this Wun-Dar to their collection.

“I am curious, My Lord. Who will you send to Etheria, then? Someone must lead the Vetala,” Mermista ventured.

“I agree, and I know the perfect man for the job!” Lethe said, clapping their hands together. “There was this person I acquired when I made my first move against the High Council of Etheria. I believe he was one of Adams’s minions and has some experience crushing rebellions. His name is Shen’Shalidar, and being enervated did nothing to change the man. That, combined with a

gift I found under Castle Grayskull—*The Anguish of Galia*—will make him the perfect person to find and destroy this Tinker,"

* * *

Frosta followed Peric through the crowded streets of Erelandia, nervous at the idea of being recognized as a Princess. The people here did not look as hard as the ones she had seen in Devlin—nor did she spot signs of any black monsters—but Frosta had a feeling she couldn't be too careful, especially when there was no apparent indication who was friendly and who was one of *them.*

Erelandia was not too far from Devlin, but she and Peric had avoided the roads in favor of traveling through the Whispering Woods; thus, the journey took much longer than Frosta liked. She had been just about to suggest they take the more expedient route when she and Peric caught sight of a traveling circus on the nearby road. As Frosta was about to come from behind the tree and wave to her fellow travelers, a roving band of black monsters came out of nowhere, overtaking the traveling circus. After that, Frosta thought much better of their original decision and stayed in the cover of the trees.

But it turned out the forest was not much safer either; not long after seeing the circus performers attacked, Peric and Frosta met a group claiming to be refugees from Thaymor. When they recognized who Frosta was, the group assaulted them, trying to subdue them as they screamed for something or someone called Vetala. Using her ice magic, Frosta was able to fight their attackers off, freezing them in place to make their escape. Now they were in Erelandia—filled with strangers she did not trust.

Frosta had not been among the party to infiltrate Erelandia during the fight against Horde Prime and had not spent much time in this town. She was not too familiar with its people either; the Fungi-Folk they were called—short and diminutive, their heads in the shape of mushrooms.

Not in the shape of mushrooms—I think they ARE mushrooms, Frosta thought to herself as she took them in.

She was just barely taller than the people of Erelandia and stuck out like a sore thumb, earning many a suspicious glance from the Fungi-Folk. Peric had stolen a couple of old dirty robes to hide them, but someone was bound to recognize her face under the hood. After all, she was the Princess of Snows and one of the heroes of the rebellion—well, the rebellion against the Horde. This new rebellion seemed rather short of heroes, besides this mysterious Tinker, of course.

"Peric, I really don't think it's a good idea for us to be in the open for too long. Where did you say we are going to find this Tinker person?" Frosta whispered.

Frosta felt hostile eyes upon her as soon as the words were spoken; glancing around, she noticed other figures in concealing cloaks. There were three of them and definitely not of the Fungi-Folk; two were about the same size as Frosta, and the third was much larger—about Scorpia's proportions.

Peric looked around furtively, searching for some frame of reference amongst the streets of Erelandia before his face perked, and he nudged his chin in the direction of a small shop. Looking at the wooden placard over the door, Frosta noticed that it was a haberdashery; the jaunty silhouette of a finely dressed man embossed in the rich wood was unmistakable.

"I wasn't expecting to find the leader of a rebellion at the forefront of men's fashion," Frosta quipped to herself.

Two strong arms suddenly grabbed her, pinning her arms to her sides in a vice grip as the owner gave a reptilian hiss in her ear.

"Let go—muh!" Frosta cried before her mouth was covered. A small cry nearby told Frosta that Peric was also seized, and both of them were dragged into the nearest ally by their assailants and slammed against the wall.

“What do you know about the Tinker?” A hostile and very familiar female voice asked next to the person holding Frosta.

“Lonnie?” Frosta asked incredulously.

The speaker whipped back her hood to reveal a dark-skinned female with brown hair held in tight cornrows; it was definitely the ex-horde soldier. Frosta had come to know her well from her visits to Bight Moon—she and Rogelio were Royal Guards and were always very polite when the Princess of Snows came to visit.

“Oh! It’s Frosta! Everything is fine, Lonnie; she’s a Princess!” Kyle said nearby. He was the one holding Peric and gave a yelp of pain as the spunky boy stomped on one of his feet. Lonnie lifted Frosta’s hood to peer suspiciously into her face.

“Let me guess, the hissy guy who grabbed me was Rogelio? I should have guessed by his smell,” Frosta asked.

Rogelio let her go and made an indignant growl.

“Hey! I rather like his smell!” Kyle protested. “Rogelio has a musky almondy scent—it’s comforting!”

Frosta saw the large reptilian man gaze lovingly at Kyle as Lonnie rolled her eyes.

“Let’s hold on a second! Yes, I see Frosta—but do we know if it really *is* Frosta?” Lonnie said wearily. “Remember when we came across Osric and the other Bright Moon guards? It turned out we couldn’t trust them, right?”

Kyle and Rogelio looked downcast at Lonnie’s words; Frosta knew the feeling well; not being able to trust those closest to you was a horrible feeling.

“Why are you two not in Bright Moon? Why did you abandon your post?” Frosta accused.

Her words got an immediate reaction from Rogelio and Lonnie as they puffed themselves up with indignation.

"We did not desert! Bright Moon was taken over by… *monsters!* They did something to the people there to make them turn on us, and we barely escaped!" Lonnie snapped. "Besides! I think we'll be the ones asking the questions here!"

Frosta held her hands up in placation. She had no idea that Bright Moon had fallen and was discouraged to hear it—with everything going on, Frosta still had hope that Bright Moon could be used as a safe haven. But now it seemed even sanctuary was unobtainable; everything rested on finding this Tinker character.

"Listen, I know you don't trust me, and I don't blame you. But I just barely escaped my kingdom when the Star Force suddenly attacked us. I'm in the same situation as you; I am looking for any way to fight back. I met Peric here in the town of Devlin when he saved me from those black creatures, and he is taking me to meet someone who is supposedly leading whatever resistance is left on Etheria." Frosta exclaimed.

"That's right! She is telling the truth!" Peric piped up.

Lonnie frowned at the little boy, looking incredulous.

"Why would I care what you have to say? Who are you?" She asked scornfully.

Peric's freckled face suddenly turned bright red; until now, Frosta had not seen him so upset, not even when they were attacked in the Whispering Woods.

"I'll have you know that I'm the Tinker's right-hand man! He trusts me, and you should too!" He shouted.

Now it was Lonnie's turn to be defensive. "Okay, kid—sheesh! We came here looking for this Tinker. We are fighters—well, me a Rogelio at least; Kyle runs a games store."

“But I have Horde training!” Kyle interjected. “And I think it’s time for me to lay aside my pacifist ways and return to the way of the warrior!”

Kyle stuck his thin chest out heroically as Lonnie and Rogelio shared an eye-roll.

“Okay! That sounds grand!” Peric said excitedly. “I’m sure the Tinker would love more recruits! I’ll vouch for you guys too!”

Lonnie gave Frosta one more mistrustful look before she shrugged.

“I guess there is no way for us to tell if you are one of them or not. If this kid is willing to bring you to the Tinker, I guess we have no choice but to trust you.” She said.

Frosta smiled at this. “Glad to have your confidence so quickly.”

Lonnie chuckled at this in such a way as to make the grin vanish from Frosta’s face.

“There is nowhere left to go in Etheria. If this is a trap or you are a spy coming to take out the Tinker, we might as well get it over with. This is our last shot at making a difference,” she said.

“Come on!” Frosta exclaimed dubiously. “I know my kingdom and Bright Moon have been taken, but it can’t be all of Etheria under enemy control! What about Eternia?”

Lonnie shook her head. “Don’t you get it? You said the Star Force attacked you, which means they have access to everywhere on Etheria—probably Eternia too. We are on our own here until some kind of help arrives.”

“Do we have any idea what is going on? What is happening to people to make them so unfriendly? Where did these monsters come from?” Kyle asked Frosta and Peric.

Frosta had been thinking of this since she lost her kingdom; it hadn't taken her very long to spot the similarities between what had happened to Scorpia, Mermista, and Entrapta and what was currently taking place.

"There is an evil spreading; people are having the most important emotion stripped from them—their capacity for empathy. The same thing happened to my friends when they were on another planet, looking for more Staves of Power. Glimmer said they were attacked by monsters that bit Scorpia, Entrapta, and Mermista. When they returned to Etheria, they were different, and I'm sure you know the rest. There was a rebellion against Queen Glimmer—which was stopped—and Scorpia and Mermista escaped off-planet," Frosta said.

"So, is this them coming back to finish the job?" Kyle replied.

Before Frosta could respond, Lonnie interrupted, drawing her hand down in a chopping motion.

"She doesn't know Kyle! We need to stop wasting time guessing and find this Tinker person. I'm sure he knows the full story," she said irritably.

Taking his cue from Lonnie, Peric drew his hood over his head, indicating to the others that they should accompany him out of the alley. Following the boy across a small square, they found themselves in front of the entrance to the haberdashery, which they entered nonchalantly. The interior was just as Frosta would have suspected it would appear; the walls were lined with racks of men's clothes of varying sizes. In the middle of the cozy space were mannequins, some short with mushroom heads, others with heads and bodies more like Frosta's. There was even a mannequin resembling a member of the lizard people—like Rogelio. All were dressed in clothes deemed the height of men's fashion, from custom-tailored suits, tuxedoes, and dinner jackets.

"When this is all over, and we aren't all dead, I have got to come back here!" Lonnie said, admiring a black and gold tuxedo jacket

complete with sequins.

“Oh! You would be so handsome in that!” Kyle said excitedly. “Look at that black velvet suit, Rogelio! Let’s try this stuff on!”

Lonnie and Rogelio started taking their prospective outfits off the racks when Frosta cleared her throat loudly.

“Guys! Can we focus here?” She seethed at them with hands raised. “How about we peruse the latest fashions when empathy vampires and compassionless zombies aren’t hunting us?”

“Excuse me?” A bored voice called from the counter. “But can I help you… *people?*”

Frosta turned to find someone she had not seen in a long time—from her Princess Prom, in fact. The one that the Horde crashed and turned into a complete disaster. The beautiful man behind the counter filing his nails had light teal skin, and his sea-green hair was cut in a quaffed bob. Given where he worked, it was not surprising that he was dressed in a custom-tailored suit of pink silk.

“Prince Peekablue?!” She exclaimed.

He peered at her imperiously, appearing not to recognize the Princess of Snows; after a moment, one of his eyebrows raised as a well-practiced smile appeared, and he nodded to her.

“Ah, Frosta! The Princess of Snows!” He said, coming from behind the counter to bow extravagantly to her. “Welcome to The Cavalier’s Closet!”

“Really? This place is called The Cavalier’s Closet?” Lonnie asked with a dubious expression.

Peekablue waved this away with a white-gloved hand.

“The name came with the establishment, and we just can’t afford a rebranding campaign right now,” he said loftily.

“Are you the Tinker?” Frosta asked, impatient to get to the heart of the matter. Peekablue emitted a high-pitched shriek of laughter, and the new arrivals looked at each other nervously.

“Oh, thank goodness, no, my good woman! Me? Leading the resistance? *Hardly,*” Peekablue said, limp hand raised to his chest.

“Wait, wait, wait,” Frosta said, peering at Peekablue as if trying to look through him. “Are you really Prince Peekable, or is this another trick from Double Trouble?”

The look of utter disdain pouring from Peekablue’s eyes would have made a whole field of flowers erupt into sudden flames.

“Do NOT speak to me of them! Do you hear me? Say that name one more time, and I will have to ask you to leave,” he said, nose high in the air.

“Okay,” Frosta said, drawing out the word. “I guess we won’t go there. If you are the real Peekablue, then what are you doing here? I know you don’t have a kingdom, but you are royalty; why are you running a store?”

“Oh, that’s a long story, honey,” he said before spotting Peric. “There you are! Where have you been? The Tinker sent you out yesterday!”

The boy made a face at Peekablue. “I ran into problems; besides, he won’t care when he finds out that I brought a Princess into the ranks!”

Peekablue rolled his eyes as he shook his head at Peric—obviously, there was some animosity between the two. Frosta doubted that Prince Peekablue had any experience with children—or patience.

“You are an incorrigible child—very well. We will see what the Tinker thinks of what you have brought him. He is down below, in his *shop*.”

Peekablue returned to his original position to reach under the counter, pressing a button. All of a sudden, a clicking emitted from the wall behind him, and a door suddenly became ajar. Peekablue stepped away from the entrance, holding his hands out to indicate they should proceed. He gave an offended gasp as Peric gave him a slight shove as he passed, and Frosta could not help grinning at the antics between the two.

Once past the door, Peric led them down a flight of rickety wooden stairs and into an earthy smelly basement with walls composed of fitted stone. Besides a rotting desk and a tangle of old cobwebs, the wide space was completely empty. Peric led them across the bare dirt floor and to another wooden door set in the basement wall; dull red light shone through cracks in the planks, as a strange buzzing resonated from the other side.

Peric knocked tentatively on the door—three rapid raps followed by another four preceding a long pause. The noise was immediately replaced by loud clattering as something was dropped, followed by loud and profuse cursing. Peric grinned back at Frosta at the more vulgar swear words, and he backed away as footsteps approached the door.

As the door was abruptly opened, the mouths of Frosta, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle dropped as they instantly recognized the mysterious Tinker.

“This better be good—” Hordak started to growl—but stopped himself as he recognized all three newcomers. He was fully outfitted in the armored power suit he wore throughout his time as ruler of the Horde—minus the hand cannon—which appeared to be temporarily replaced by a drill.

“Hordak!? You are the Tinker?” Frosta gaped.

The imposing ex-ruler of the Horde nodded, favoring the Princess of Snows with a grim smile.

“That’s right,” he said, laying his glowing red eyes on each of them in turn. “I am leading this rebellion. With a Princess and three of my best Horde soldiers joining me now, I plan to free Etheria from these new invaders!”

Self-Actualization

Chapter Summary

> After their disastrous meeting with the Crimson Council and Wun-Dar, Shen and Veth find themselves in Trollan jail.

Feeling a sense of intense trepidation, Veth follows the giant down the spiraling steps and into the dark unknown. They look furtively back the way they had come, towards the entrance leading back into the House of the Penumbra; the light from there is weak and dim, appearing so far away. Immediately they feel confused—hadn't they been told they would find the Light down here?

"Come, Veth, do not dally. You must face your destiny head-on and without reservation," the other calls up to them. Veth feels a jolt of fear greater than the one for the darkness when they think that their Lord is displeased with them.

"Coming, Archon Lethe!" They call, hurrying to catch up. When they do, Veth is amazed to find that the leader of the Nephraeh has shrunken themselves slightly—even so, Archon Lethe has to stoop to fit in the passage. Neither has a torch as they travel together; the lambent indigo shine from Archon Lethe's eyes is enough to let them see.

"How much further is it, My Archon?" Veth asks, cringing as their voice cracks slightly. It had been doing that a lot lately, ever since they reached the age of adolescence. Archon Lethe turns to bathe Veth in the light of their eyes; the stare is penetrating, making them feel vulnerable.

"Patience, My Child. Patience. Just enjoy the journey—not many get to see what you are privileged to witness," they say mysteriously.

Shortly, the walls enclosing Veth disappear, leaving them gazing out over an expansive hollow; it is illuminated by lights set in the

cavern roof, the effect similar to the glow of the homeworld's many moons in the night sky.

"By the Empyrean!" They whisper in awe—Archon Lethe tuts at their exclamation.

"What did I tell you about using that kind of language, Veth? There is no such thing as an Empyrean—it's old superstitious Nephraeh nonsense!" They admonish.

Veth bobs their head, absolutely obsequious and internally cursing themselves for the slip. They return their attention to the view before them, noticing massive columns spaced throughout the immense cave. Peaking behind these enormous shafts is a Light of which Veth had never seen the likes of.

Veth clamps their mouth closed, not wanting to comment on the Light until they had a moment to analyze what they should say. They do not want to slip up and speak of something else that would upset the Archon.

Looking at this Light, Veth recognizes that a part of them finds this luminesce to be beautiful—more than that—sublime. But the other part of them, the part that Archon Lethe had been developing through sessions they call the Penumbra Ritual, know it to be ugly and abhorrent. This is the point of view they chose to express.

"My Archon, what is that detestable glare coming from behind the columns?" They say with derision.

Archon Lethe turns their head slightly, enough that Veth can make out the smile on their white lips. Straight away, Veth feels a bloom of gratification that their Lord is pleased.

"That is our destination, My Child—The Temple of Light. It is where you will meet your destiny." Archon Lethe responds.

Veth is again confused; does this Temple have to do with The Light their Archon directed the Nephraeh to follow? Or is it a

different Light? Veth has a feeling they are not only different, but opposite in nature, and decides not to broach the subject.

When they reach the cavern floor, Archon Lethe heads in the direction of The Temple of Light, not bothering to make sure they are being followed. Veth has to jog to keep up with the other; their legs are still short and growing, nowhere near the length of the giant. Veth is out of breath by the time they spot the Temple of Light, and it is a good thing, too, for their panting covers the euphoria involuntarily appearing on their lilac face.

It is the most magnificent building Veth had ever seen—there is nothing even remotely like it in the entire City of Nox. Ethereal white strands of an immaculate substance sweep up from the ground to form a series of interlocking arches. At the very pinnacle of this structure is the source of the radiance—The Light—and Veth has to stop themselves from weeping to viewing it. If not for the indigo stain at the core of this radiance, they might have, revealing their falseness to Archon Lethe.

"Hideous, isn't it?" Archon Lethe asks as they turn to examine Veth.

Veth nods vigorously as they quickly show a disapproving scowl; Archon Lethe smiles in approval and continues.

"You will notice my power at the center of this False Light," They say, pointing with a black stained claw. "If not for that, you would be on your knees—overcome by its terrible power and dead within moments."

Veth feels doubtful that anything so wonderful would kill them and tilts their head as they stare at The Light.

"You do not believe me, My Child?" Archon Lethe asks suspiciously.

Veth tears their gaze away from The Light as waves of terror course through their young body, hoping they have not been caught in a lie. By now, Veth has experienced what happens when

they displease Archon Lethe countless times, and they are terrified of having to undergo another 'lesson.'

"Yes, My Archon! I believe you! I was just admiring your handiwork and basking in its power!" They say quickly.

Archon Lethe pins Veth with their glowing scrutiny momentarily, once again seeming to dissect their protégé with their eyes. After a moment, they nod, motioning Veth to follow them into the Temple.

Once inside, Veth is met with more of the radiant white material that comprises the Temple's outside; it is threaded into flat surfaces, forming the walls and ceilings. Wisely though, they no longer take in the beauty, instead focusing on Archon Lethe, fixing their eyes on a point in the center of their back, not deviating the whole way they are led through the Temple.

After a while, Veth senses they are somewhere important; it draws their attention from their Archon to their surroundings; they are now in a grand hall much bigger than the Temple itself, and a sense of dissociation overcomes Veth. For some obscure reason, they feel like they are no longer on Empyrea—or their original reality, for that matter.

"You are now at the Heart of The Temple of Light, My Child," Archon Lethe breathes.

Veth is pleased to find more of the white material composing the floor and wall of this room, but on the vaulted ceiling, it is darker—like it is stained. Right away, they recognize the work of their Archon in the color of the blemishing and feel ashamed at labeling their Lord's work as anything other than glorious.

Piercing this ill-lit section is a beam of the Light Veth had spotted on the outside—to them—it appears as if the stained part of the ceiling is acting as a filter, reducing the potency of luminescence. The desire to remove Archon Lethe's work becomes more significant at this realization—as does the guilt.

Below all this is the source of the Light; it is a massive crystal, a little more than twice the height of Archon Lethe. It is a magnificent sight, appearing utterly uniform in shape yet maintaining a natural appearance—as if it had been willed into existence having its current form.

"Ah, you found The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah. What do you make of it, My Child?" Archon Lethe asks mildly. Veth is not fooled; they know their answer will be weighed and measured—they must answer carefully. Since The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah is the source of the Light, it must therefore be wrong, or at least Archon Lethe's version of wrong.

Veth! Remember what you are always being told! Archon Lethe's way is your way! *They admonish themself.*

"I don't like it, My Archon. There is something not right about it," they say tentatively.

Archon Lethe nods at their answer, but the expression on their face speaks another story; Veth's words are not believed.

"But why do you allow it to exist, My Archon?" Veth continues, trying to draw their Lord's attention from their perceived infraction.

Their Lord stands up straight at this question, placing their hands behind their back as they turn to regard The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah. Now that they are a bit closer, Veth can discern movement within the large stone—like a moth or butterfly is trapped inside.

"It's a necessary evil, My Child," they say, still staring at The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah. "Come, there is someone I would like you to meet,"

Archon Lethe leads Veth to the base of the crystal and points inside to the source of the motion; a strange ethereal shape is gliding within—like living mist. Veth feels a sense of peace upon viewing this ghostly form; they reach out to brush their claws

gently against the surface as the occupant of the crystal comes to them. But before it could get near, the amorphous shape zips away—Veth turns to see Archon Lethe standing behind them.

It doesn't like Archon Lethe, *Veth muses.*

"This is the Avatar Spirit of Zhe-La, Veth. They have returned to reside within The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah, awaiting to be bonded to their new bearer." Archon Lethe says.

"What?! Why? Has something happened to Ishtar?" Veth gasps.

They turn to observe rage passing briefly over Archon Lethe's face —but then it is gone—replaced by an immense sadness.

"They are dead, Veth. I had to kill them," they say.

Surprised, Veth whirls on Archon Lethe; they know Ishtar well and have great affection for the bearer of Zhe-La.

"Why, My Archon? Why would you do such a thing?" Veth asks, knowing but not caring they are overstepping their boundaries. Archon Lethe does not take them to task for their temerity, instead kneeling before Veth so that their face is only an arm's length above theirs.

"I am going to tell you something, Veth, and you must promise on your honor not to repeat it," Archon Lethe says meaningfully.

Veth nods to their Lord—they will not tell a soul, not even Nefeli. They are too terrified of the consequences.

"Ishtar betrayed me, Veth. I discovered they were working to undo my bindings on the Temple of Light, and when they would not repent, I had to destroy them." Archon Lethe says.

"But why? I knew Ishtar; they were not false. Why would they betray you, My Archon?" Veth asks, confused.

"Because, My Child, they had a great defect which pushed them to turn against me. It is the same weakness within you, and it is how I choose who bears Zhe-La, for the power of the Champion Spirit looks to bond with those like you and Ishtar. It is also why I am so hard on you, Veth; I don't want you to fail like so many other bearers before you," Archon Lethe says.

Anxiety courses through Veth at the thought they would do such a thing to Archon Lethe—but a giddiness replaces it as they replay the words just spoken to them.

"Wait… what do you mean that you don't want me to fail like the bearers before me?" Veth asks.

Archon Lethe smiles broadly, making Veth grateful to be in their presence.

"Because I want you to be the next Zhe-La, Veth. That is what I have been preparing you for," they say.

Veth cannot stop the toothy smile spreading across their face; Zhe-La! Veth is going to be the bearer of Zhe-La! The moments of punishment they have experienced at Archon Lethe's hands made sense now; it is for Veth's own benefit—so they would be prepared for this moment. Their Archon does it because they care about Veth; they want to help Veth overcome their weakness so they can succeed in their new role.

"I see this news pleases you, My Child," Archon Lethe says with rare merriment.

Veth presses themselves fully against The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah as the spirit of Zhe-La zips around in excitement; it seems as if it is eager for the bonding.

"How? How do we do it?" Veth asks breathlessly.

Archon Lethe raises themselves back to their full height as they again take on the role of the tutor.

"First, stop hanging on The Great Crystal of Ser'Pah like a silly little fool," they say scornfully. Veth does as they are told and backs away, sheepishly.

"Then, hold out both your hands towards the Spirit of Zhe-La and repeat after me," Archon Lethe continues. Suddenly, Veth hears music the likes of which they had never heard before, coming from every direction at once. When they glimpse Archon Lethe's lips moving in time with the melody, Veth realizes it is coming from them.

"What were those words, My Archon?" Veth asks in a hush.

A strange expression crosses Archon Lethe's white face, and Veth realizes they are unsure what to say. Finally, though, Archon Lethe does speak, and with a fair amount of wariness.

"It is the ancient language of the Nephraeh, My Child. It is called Sera'Phael-im, and it was barely spoken in my time. I have since made uttering a word of it forbidden—only allowing it to be used during the initiation of the new Zhe-La." Lethe says.

Many questions cross Veth's young mind—most of them ones they know they must not ask. Instead, they choose the most pressing.

"How can I speak this language? I—I don't even know if I am capable…" Veth stammers.

A great anxiety blooms in Veth at the thought that they may fail to become Zhe-La because they cannot speak Sera'Phael-im; it is unbearable. Archon Lethe holds up their hands to forestall Veth from weeping.

"You can speak Sera'Phael-im; I know you can. In days past, Nephraeh who had your affliction could speak the ancient language without any instruction. They simply drew the knowledge from the same place they summoned… the False Light. You can do this as well, although this will be the one and only time you will do so," Archon Lethe says.

Veth is unsure about what their Lord is saying—there seem so many contradictions that it makes their mind spin. But they dismiss these distractions, instead concentrating on their ability to summon The Light which their Lord despises so much. Veth is amazed at how easily the words come to them—as if they have spoken Sera'Phael-im their whole lives. Raising their clawed hands towards the Avatar within the stone, Veth begins to repeat what Archon Lethe said word for word. With each syllable spoken, the Spirit of Zhe-La starts to glow more and more radiantly; Archon Lethe hisses with agitation as The Light becomes stronger. Veth gapes open-mouthed as they peer into this radiance—the more intense it becomes, the more enthralled they are. The Light reaches out for Veth, and in response, they extend their own Light, summoned from within subconsciously. Like meets like in a point of union between the two fonts of goodness, and for a brief moment, Veth feels supreme bliss.

But then it is gone, like a half-remembered memory of something Veth couldn't quite grasp, and they are left staring at the spot the Avatar of Zhe-La had once occupied. Veth looks down at their body, expecting to behold a magnificent transformation taking place—but they only see the same slight form of a Nephraeh youth. They look up when they hear Archon Lethe laughing.

"Expecting to become Zhe-La, automatically?" They ask. Veth looks away sheepishly as they nod.

"It's not that easy, My Child. You must speak the words first—but only after I have tempered your base desires and this affliction of yours is under control," they say sternly.

Veth sighs and nods, looking up at Archon. "I am ready,"

Archon Lethe appears pleased as they again lower themselves towards Veth, reaching out to take them into their clutches. At once, Veth is aware of Archon Lethe's hideous black teeth as they smile at their protégé, the expression doing nothing to assuage the feeling of dread that sneaks into their chest.

"Then let us begin now," Archon Lethe says.

Veth closes their eyes as Archon Lethe opens their mouth wide, leaning in towards their neck. They feel cold lips press against their skin—immediately followed by vertigo as a deadening suffuses their body. At first, Veth rails against what Archon Lethe is doing, for they feel an intrinsic part of themselves being taken. But their Lord is too powerful, and Veth is overcome by waves of enervation so intense they become insensate. A portion of Veth outside of this experience knows that this is the last time they recollect this version of themselves.

NO, THAT IS NOT TRUE, VETH. YOU ARE REMEMBERING NOW

Veth jolted upwards on the bed, almost hyperventilating at the intensity of the dream.

That seemed so real, especially the voice at the end. It sounded almost like… Veth thought to themselves before noticing where they were.

Confused, they peered about the small room they occupied; square stones fitted expertly together to form four solid walls and floor. Illumination poured down through a circular hole cut in a stone ceiling above them; it was crisscrossed metallic rods with a slightly bluish tinge. Then they remembered.

"This must be a Trollan prison," Veth said to no one in particular.

The last thing they recalled was fighting against the Trollan's attempt to use their dark magic on them—right before they were knocked unconscious. A low moan drew their attention to the cell's other occupant; Shen was on the opposite bed, appearing asleep. Veth was pleased that the human was okay and in the cell with them, but that changed to worry when they saw the state he was in. Shen was covered in sweat and appeared agitated—even in a state of sleep. His handsome features were twisted into a

look of pain as he battled with some internal struggle in his unconscious state.

Without even having to think about it, Veth focused on Shen with their second sight, peering within him to discover his affliction. It did not take them long to spot it—a storm of shadows assailing his quintessence. Veth recognized this as not some dark outside force tormenting Shen, but an accumulation of bad memories congealed into a scar of trauma. That was the dark mark they had seen on his bright core when they first viewed his soul.

Being exposed to the Trollan's 'chamber of disquietude' must have disturbed what was usually tolerable, turning it into a horrible nightmare, Veth thought to themself.

Rising off their bed, Veth walked quietly over and kneeled next to Shen's prone form to gaze down at him. Gently, they placed one of their hands on Shen's forehead, immediately becoming alarmed at how clammy he felt; it was as if something were draining him, like a leech upon his will. Reaching out with their other hand, they placed it over his chest—instantly withdrawing it when a flash of light appeared.

"What the—" Veth exclaimed as they examined the shimmering shape that appeared over Shen's chest. Two curved forms bisected by a slight arrow formed an image of a heart—Veth immediately recognized it as a rune written in the ancient language used during the time of the Empire. What it was doing imprinted onto Shen's chest was a different story.

You are certainly full of surprises, human, Veth thought to themselves as they placed their hand back on Shen's chest. The heart rune blazed as soon as Veth made contact, almost as if contact with the Nephraeh was pleasing to it.

Don't be foolish, Veth. It's just a simple magic charm—it has no sentience, Veth admonished themselves.

Now that they recalled how easily it had once come to them, Veth focused on that place between their head and heart, summoning The Light. As if sensing its opposite at work within the human, The Light poured from Veth into Shen through the two points of contact, smothering the tumult until it receded into its dormant state—a dark mark.

The luminescence within Veth's body dissipated as they took in their handiwork; using only the tips of their claws, they gently brushed the matted dark hair away from Shen's face. Although still sweaty, he was now still as his countenance had taken on a more serene aspect; the muscles had relaxed, the brows unfurrowed. Shen was now at rest and peaceful—thanks to what they had just done.

Veth smiled.

* * *

Consciousness came slowly to Shen as he struggled to awaken from a deep sleep. It took him some time to become fully aware of his surroundings—but when he finally did notice the stone walls and barred entrance—he was instantly awake.

Great. I'm in a prison—my favorite place to be, he thought sourly.

"Glad you decided to wake up," Veth said nearby.

Shen turned to regard the Nephraeh Champion sitting cross-legged on a nearby bed, hands resting on their knees and eyes closed in what Shen recognized as a meditation pose.

"You could have woken me if you were so impatient," Shen said, annoyed. He really wasn't in the mood to be nagged right now.

"It's okay; it looked like you needed the rest, Human. It also gave me time to center myself after our confrontation with those foolish Trollans." Veth said, opening both eyes to look at him. "I apologize for my… *rashness*, by the way. I could have handled that better, and I ended up getting us locked in this place," Veth said, waving

a clawed hand around before continuing. “Also, I caused us to be exposed to that horrible magic—I’m sorry for what it put you through,”

Shen was caught off guard by Veth’s words and was still too groggy to handle their sudden compassion. He noticed that they were gazing at him in that strange way of theirs, their silver eyes gliding over his body without actually looking at him. Based on what Veth said before, they were looking at his soul; Shen wasn’t sure how he felt about that. On the one hand, having someone privy to his innermost secrets felt like an unwanted intrusion, and he felt naked before the Nephraeh. On the other, it made him feel like Veth could genuinely know him in the most intimate way—for some reason, Shen liked the thought of that.

“Don’t worry about it, Veth. I’m sure you had your reasons for doing what you did. It sounds like you and your people suffered for a long time, and the Trollans could have helped—you were right to be angry,” Shen said.

Veth stared at him a moment, their head cocked in a curious manner which only heightened their attractiveness. Shen found he had to look away from them as the shame returned—he was still drawn to them, unwanted as it was—much like he was with Catra.

“Why did you kiss me, Shen?” Veth asked abruptly.

The suddenness of the question, combined with the nature of his current thoughts, made Shen want to run—but he was trapped and unable to flee. Veth sensed his agitation and raised their hands in placation.

“If my question causes you that much stress, then forget—” Veth began before Shen interrupted them.

“No, no,” Shen said with a sigh. “Although I’m not sure what to explain. Usually, when one person kisses another like that, the reason is pretty obvious.”

Veth laughed at this; the sound clear and bright. “Yes, that’s true, Human! But not in the middle of a fight! And not out of nowhere like that!”

Shen looked at Veth incredulously. “Really, Veth? I fought you when we first met, I know what a tough opponent you are. I don’t know what that was, but you weren’t trying to fight me.”

Veth rocked their head back and forth as they glanced up at the ceiling.

“Fair point, but I explained what I was going through.” They said with a wave of their hand before standing up in one fluid motion.

“Do you know what you are attracted to, Human?” Veth said with hands on hips. “I am a Nephraeh—not a woman,” they said, waving a hand at their smooth chest. “Nor am I a man,”

Shen took in their lithe frame; not a hard angle was on them, and their hips betrayed a very slight curve.

“Yes, Veth. I know,” Shen responded.

“You know?” Veth said, sounding unconvinced. “You have no idea,”

Shen shrugged. “There have been others like you who I was attracted to. One who I was very close to could be either male or female, and the form they chose to wear normally was neither. I preferred them this way,”

“Ah! A shapeshifter!” Veth said, amazed. “Interesting, Human. But when you were intimate with them, I’m sure they still took on male and female genders. You won’t find that here, with me.”

Curiosity got the better of sense, and Shen found himself speaking before he could stop himself.

“I have a friend like that—completely separated from male and female. They told me how they are… intimate with each other,

and it does not involve any physical contact. It's not what most the people of the universe would call… *sex*. Are Nephraeh like that?"

Shen found himself blushing at his audacity, but Veth seemed taken with the question—as if discussing their sexual nature was not only not a big deal but a favorite subject. Veth placed a finger to their lips as they gazed off into space, contemplating Shen's question.

"You are talking about that Ethyriel I found you with on Enos. Yes, the Ethyriels do not have physical contact during their procreation; they have something called the Metaphysical Amalgamation. The Nephraeh are nothing like that," Veth said with a dismissive wave of their hand.

"Oh? How so?" Shen asked, still speaking without thinking.

Veth turned to pin Shen with their eyes; they were glittering like diamonds.

"Because with Nephraeh, there is definitely *sex*," they said with meaning.

If Shen felt like melting with embarrassment before, he felt like exploding now. Veth caught sight of his dismay and chuckled—not a cruel laugh—but of one who finds the subject of the mirth endearing.

"Anyway, Human. Enough of this foolishness!" Veth said, coming to stand in the center of the cell to look up through the bared hole. "We must come up with a way to escape this prison!"

Although Shen was pleased to have the subject changed, he was not ready for an escape attempt—not until they discussed what had happened in the Crimson Council Chamber.

"Okay, I'm all for escaping, but let's talk about what happened in the Crimson Council Chamber. I mean, I understand the whole

‘black magic of depression’ thingy, but what about that voice?” Shen asked.

Veth seemed startled, and Shen was pleasantly surprised to see the smug Nephraeh caught off guard for once.

“Voice?” They said uncertainly. “You heard it too?”

Shen frowned at Veth. “Uh, yeah. I didn’t understand parts of what it was saying, but I certainly heard it—right before I was hit over the head. *Wonder*, I think I heard it was called.”

Veth’s mouth formed an ‘o’ of comprehension as they seemed to finally catch up with what he was saying.

“Ah, yes! Sorry, I thought you were talking about something else.” Veth said, nodding quickly. “They were called *Wun-Dar*—not *wonder*. I’m stunned you didn’t recognize that name, being one He-Man and all,”

Shen held up his hands in surrender, trying not to become irritated at Veth’s tone.

“Okay, just skip the lecture and tell me who Wun-Dar is.” He said.

Veth gave Shen a ‘there, there’ look before continuing. “I hope someone taught you there are *seven* Champions of Grayskull, my dear Human. There is He-Man, She-Ra, Zhe-La—*that’s me*—Thon-Ra, Sher-Va, He-Ro, and finally, Wun-Dar. That’s who the Trollan’s used to assault us, although how Wun-Dar could summon their Champion Avatar and not us is another matter,”

"Well, that's something good to know if we are going to escape,” Shen said with bite.

Veth gave him an amused look as their long Nephraeh ears picked up the sarcasm behind his words.

“Don’t get fresh with me, *Human*. I thought you already figured this out and didn’t need it explained.” They said, smirking.

“Anyway, we do best to avoid Wun-Dar—at least until we figure out how to summon our Champion Avatars. So, are you ready to escape now, or do you want to go back to sleep?”

Shen fought the annoyance competing with the urge to laugh; he was beginning to realize that what he had first taken for nastiness in Veth was actually a playful wit. Double Trouble had the capacity to banter with him, and it was one of the most endearing things about them. If he wasn’t careful, Shen would begin to enjoy Veth’s tongue lashings.

“Yes, I’m ready to follow the superior Nephraeh—if I’m allowed.” He said, matching Veth’s grin.

Shen came to stand next to the Nephraeh Champion; the only exit to the cell was far above their heads. Even if Veth—who was slightly taller than Shen—stood on their tippy toes, they would still be too far to reach the lip of the opening, let alone deal with the bars.

“How about we stack the beds to reach it?” Shen proposed.

Veth shook their head. “No. I already tried while you were out. They are attached to the floor, and the bond is too strong to break. One of us will have to use the other to reach it,”

Shen looked up at the opening again, trying to gauge the distance.

“Okay, I will stand on your shoulders,” he said.

Veth laughed again, but this time with their old spite.

“And what are you going to do to the bars? Poke at them with your stubby Human fingers? No, I will stand on your shoulders and use *these*,” they said, holding up their extremely sharp-looking claws.

Shen shrugged, not doubting they could do it; he knew Catra’s Madgēcot claws were sharp enough to cut through steel; who

knew what Nephraeh claws were capable of?

Unsure of the best way to lift Veth, Shen went to one knee and held out his hands. The Nephraeh looked at him strangely for a moment before placing one booted foot on his knee, using his hands to leverage themselves onto his shoulders. The sudden weight shift caught Shen off guard, and he stumbled—but before Veth could fall—he grasped them tightly, holding on to a part of their pants that was very supple to the touch.

"Oh! Sorry!" Shen cried as he moved his hands from their rear down to their thighs.

"No! Just hold on to me like before! I'm going to fall!" Veth screeched.

Doing as instructed, Shen pushed Veth up by their bottom until they stood fully on his shoulders. He felt very unsteady but could feel Veth compensating for his clumsiness with their Nephraeh agility, shifting their weight constantly back and forth.

"Steady… steady…" Veth breathed as they reached for the bars. "I almost got them…"

Shen couldn't discern Veth's progress; he was too focused on keeping them balanced and desperately trying not to think of where he had just touched them. Abruptly, a loud buzzing came from above—followed by a gasp from Veth. Shen felt their body tense before going slack; in advance of falling and hurting themselves, he positioned himself so that they slid before him. Wrapping his arms around Veth, he caught them against his front, filling Shen's five senses with their essence. With their body soft and limp, Shen carried Veth to their bed; their cheek pressed against his, an upper fang protruding from between slack lips and poking him in the chin.

As he laid them down, Shen stopped momentarily as he leaned above their unconscious form. He reached out to touch Veth's neck, looking for a pulse but not finding one. Worried, Shen

leaned in to place his head against their chest, smiling when he heard it; a steady thump-thumping indicating Veth was still alive.

“So, you do have a heart,” Shen said with a grin.

He stared at them a moment longer, wanting to touch them again, but feeling ashamed of the thought. Shen left Veth to lie back on his own bed, turning away to face away from the Nephraeh Champion and towards the wall, curling up into a fetal position. But try as he might, Shen could not stop imagining what it would be like to have Veth pressed against next to him—the lingering memory of holding them pressing down on his thoughts. It was not like this with Catra; even in his own mind, he respected who she was. But with Veth, the feeling was different—stronger.

With a loud sigh, Shen closed his eyes as he tried to drift off, trying not to think how he was destined to fall for those who would not return his desire.

Shattered Diamond

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra get a couple of unexpected visitors while relaxing on Trollos.

Suffice it to say, their "honeymoon do-over" is canceled.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

With tongue sticking between lips, Catra extended her arm out; thumb pointed towards the magenta sky as she tried to line up her subject. Only after closing one eye could she gauge the size, proportions, and positioning correctly—just as her annoying instructor taught her.

Now Cat-Tra, remember we are creating a realistic piece—not an abstraction. You are… distorting some of her proportions, I think. Most likely based on your fantasies, I'd wager.

Catra lowered her hand and opened her eyes, looking between the canvas she was drawing on, and her subject—Adora in her new white and silver She-Ra form, standing heroically with sword raised not twenty paces away.

Having decided to take a break from sightseeing, they were both in the courtyard adjoining their accommodations so that Catra could show off her new and improved artistic talent. Not only was Jihan her mentor for her Champion form, but he was also a self-proclaimed artist who had been giving Catra advice on refining her technique.

The senior Madgēcot's guidance seemed to be working; Catra had vastly improved from her days of drawing stick figures and was now able to sketch shapes with accurate detail. However, she was

currently confused about what Jihan was trying to convey with his earlier comment about not creating a realistic piece.

What are you talking about? I am drawing her realistically—be specific! She shot back.

Jihan sighed heavily inside Catra's head, something he did a lot to her vexation.

How do I put this politely? Your wife is a beautiful woman, and I can see why you married her—but some of the attributes you are giving her lean toward conceit. Jihan answered

Catra growled with annoyance; she hated it when he was vague.

Just spit it out! What exactly am I getting wrong? Catra stabbed back at her mentor.

Her breasts, Cat-Tra. You gave She-Ra a chest twice the size of what she actually has. Jihan responded.

Catra inspected both her work and the source of her inspiration, not seeing the discrepancy.

*Jihan, you better choose your next words carefully, especially when describing my wife's 'attributes.' If I am drawing them that size, then that is because they **are** that size,"* Catra thought menacingly.

Jihan didn't respond to this, instead tried to change the subject.

You know, I really like this new look she has—the silver, I mean. The She-Ra Champion Avatar has always been gold and white—it's nice to shake things up every once and a while.

Catra considered Jihan's words; she liked Adora's She-Ra's form in any color, but she did have to admit the metallic sheen of her hair was quite appealing. That, combined with the white of her

uniform and the silver of her armor, made her blue eyes stand out; they were like two gleaming sapphires set in a face of radiant beauty.

But there was a reason Adora was taking this form now, and Catra did not think it was worth the improved aesthetics. It was Adora's way of showing the world what she had been through and the terrible baggage she now carried like a weight around her neck. Although she loathed to admit it, Catra was afraid to discover in what other ways Adora's trauma may surface. Would it be at a critical moment when everything depended on She-Ra taking action? Or would it be more subtle, like Adora's pensive moments when she withdraws inside herself?

Did I say something else to upset you, Cat-Tra? I'm sorry, Jihan asked.

It's *not your fault Jihan. I was just thinking of what She-Ra's new look cost my wife. I made a joke about her being damaged like me, but I think it's different for Adora.* Catra thought back before continuing.

You see, I'm like a piece of iron—I'm tough and able to withstand a lot of punishment. I can be molded into one form but then change into another, smoothing away any blemishes until they are barely perceptible.

Adora, on the other hand, is like a diamond—harder than iron and strong. But when a diamond breaks, it shatters; there is no way to put it back together again. Jihan, I'm terrified for Adora; she is different from before she became Despara. I will never give up on her, but sometimes I feel like I got a different person back—Adora isn't the same person I grew up with.

Jihan was silent as he processed her words. Catra knew she wasn't really speaking to Jihan's ghost, but a mixture of his memories combined with the magic of Sher-Va—perhaps a little of her subconscious mixed in for good measure. She hoped that he was not wholly confounded by the dilemma she faced and

remained silent—Catra wanted his council in this. Finally, Jihan spoke.

The thing about diamonds is that they may break, but the individual pieces are still beautiful. You may not have the diamond in its original shape, but you still have it in its entirety, Cat-Tra. It's up to you to take the new form the diamond takes and move forward—the same can be said of relationships. You and Adora grew up together, but you are both still growing and changing. Even if Adora hadn't suffered as she did, she would have still changed as you both got older. So would you, for that matter.

Catra pursed her lips as she thought about what he had said. Finally, she shook her head.

Those are wise words, but you didn't answer my question about how to help her. I don't want Adora to keep suffering like I know she is. Catra implored.

By some unknown means, Catra could suddenly feel the discomfort coming from Jihan's essence, and she realized she had made a mistake asking him.

Cat-Tra, I'm probably not the best person to ask about helping the one you love. I was blind to the fact that Kishar had lost their empathy; I only found out when it was too late. What kind of advice can I give you? At least Adora has her empathy back, but the healing will take time. Just have patience.

Catra knew Jihan was right; she had only just gotten Adora back and was jumping to conclusions when she should just be enjoying what they both had. After all, there were worse options; Adora could be dead, or worse, still Despara. At least now they can move forward and continue their life together—which is more than Jihan could say for himself. But one thing her mentor had said that was bothering her.

You know, Jihan, I think you're wrong about one thing you said.

Oh yeah? And what is that young one? He inquired.

I don't think it's too late for Kishar; they are still alive, and so are you—sort of. She thought back to him.

Jihan chuckled in her mind; it was a warm laugh, like rich honey.

I would not say either of our current existences is living—but I get your point. I'm not sure how it would be possible to return Kishar back to how they were; they are just too far gone. Even if you could use the power of Sher-Va on them, Kishar is like a god now. By betraying all those innocents and me, Kishar conducted the Apogean Ritual in a way that increased their power exponentially; they are unassailable now. You would have to have all seven champions of Grayskull working in tandem just to have the chance to banish them into a realm from which they cannot escape. As much as I know they are evil now, part of me still remembers who they were and loves them. I know they must be stopped, but the thought of Kishar in an eternity of damnation gives me great pain. Jihan said sadly.

Catra's long ears drooped as her heart went out to her mentor—but then perked back up as she decided something.

I will make a promise to you, Jihan; not only will I find a way to defeat Kishar, but I will also do it in a way that you can be together again. Like you told me before I faced Despara; it may not be in this life, but it will be in the next. This you have my word on, She pulsed back.

That is a mighty vow, Cat-Tra, but based on what I have seen you have overcome, I believe you will try. Though you are wrong about one thing, my apprentice, he said.

Catra frowned. *Oh yeah? About which part?*

You are not like a piece of steel, more like a piece of lead —very heavy and dense. Especially between your Madgēcot ears, he said wickedly.

Catra let out a loud bark of laughter as she shook her head; hearing her wife laughing, She-Ra/Adora dropped her sword slightly and turned her head.

"What's going on? Are you making me hold this pose while you're telling jokes with Jihan? *Catra!* I may be in my She-Ra form, but holding this pose is killing me!" She complained.

"Sorry! Sorry!" Catra called back. "Keep holding it; I'm almost done!"

She-Ra/Adora let out a low moan as she quickly shook herself out, trying to loosen some of her stiff muscles before returning to her pose. Catra took a moment to admire her wife's enhanced form, thinking back to the other night when they tried something new as She-Ra and Sher-Va. The next morning, Yariel had paid them a visit, informing them that the ancient Trollan building they were staying in had developed a large crack in its base, angrily blaming them for its damage. From then on, Catra and Adora decided not to do that again—well—at least not inside any historic and delicate buildings.

With one last artistic flourish, Catra stepped back from her masterpiece, inviting her wife to view it with a proffered hand. With a look of excited expectation, She-Ra/Adora transitioned back into her normal form to stand next to Catra, her head tilting curiously as she gazed at the image.

"So, what do you think?" Catra asked hopefully.

"Hmmm…" Adora considered, holding her chin. "You certainly overemphasized certain parts of my body—for one, my boobs aren't that big,"

I told you.

“What!?” Catra shrieked as her tail bushed up. “No way! Everything is one hundred percent accurate! Shut up, Jihan!”

Adora wrapped her arms around her wife, pulling her in for a hug and a kiss as Catra gazed frumpily at her handiwork.

“I shouldn’t argue with the artist’s interpretation. Besides, maybe your special Madgēcot eyes make certain things look bigger than they are,” Adora said happily.

No, that’s not it.

Before Catra could respond to Jihan, a glimmer caught her eye. Turning her head abruptly, Catra caught sight of an object high in the ether; it was plummeting at an alarming rate toward the city of Trollos.

“What is it, Catra?” Adora asked.

Catra frowned. “Not sure,” she responded, focusing past the object with her enhanced sight to an even larger shape in orbit. By its distinctive profile, it appeared to be one of the many battlecruisers Etheria had acquired after the defeat of Horde Prime.

“I think there is a Star Force ship in orbit,” she said finally. “It looks like they are sending a shuttle down to the planet,”

Adora turned to squint in the direction Catra was looking, her human eyes unable to discern the approaching visitors.

“Star Force? What would they be doing all the way here? Did Glimmer tell them to check up on us?” She said.

Catra let out a groan. “Probably. It would just be like Sparkles to send us on this ‘Honey Moon Do—Over’ and then ask the fleet to send a ship all the way here to check on us. The academics must be freaking out to see a warship in space,” Catra said with a toothy grin.

Adora’s eyes suddenly widened— she pointed toward the advancing spacecraft zipping over the jagged spires of the Trollan landscape. As it neared the city of New Trollos, two atmospheric wings unfurled from its box-shaped body.

“I see it! That’s definitely a landing shuttle, and it is coming in at a combat footing! Why would they be doing that if they were just visiting? And on a planet the Etheria has no relation with?” She said.

“I dunno. Maybe they are practicing. I doubt they get many chances—look out!” Catra cried as the shuttle shrieked over their heads, its tailwind ripping the canvas off the stand to send it spinning across the courtyard. Catra instinctively leaped onto Adora, bearing her to the ground to shield her wife with her body. Both women looked up from their positions to see the shuttle slow, veering in a long arc at the city's center to halt over a very distinctive building.

“Why are they going to the Athenaeum? The starport is outside the city—where we parked Darla,” Adora said.

“Come on, Princess, there is only one way to find out,” Catra said, standing up and holding her hand out to lift Adora to her feet.

* * *

Scorpia looked out of the shuttle’s forward viewport at the unusual seashell-shaped building below them; The Athenaeum, Lethe had called it. When Scorpia had asked them what that was, Lethe had looked at her scornfully before bothering to answer.

“Don’t overthink it,” they said with a sneer. “All you have to do is follow Mermista and do what I ask—nothing more.”

Lethe had instructed her and Mermista to visit this abandoned planet, to seek out this site, all so they could find the entrance to Trollans secret hiding place. There they would find the last Champion of Grayskull—Wun-Dar—so that Lethe could claim them for their own. Lethe had complicated instructions on how to do

this in a way to win Wun-Dar to their side; barring that, Scorpia had the Hammer of Zzar at her hip, and would use it to release the Champion Spirit the hard way.

Scorpia thought about the other items Lethe had given them; vials containing magical substances held within a satchel at Mermista's hip. One of those vials contained Antithetical Philter—the key to opening the gateway to the hidden dimension of the Trollans.

"You ready for this?" Mermista asked.

Scorpia nodded, and together they made their way aft to the deployed landing ramp, the bottom hovering far above the Athenaeum.

"That's as close as I can get the shuttle without getting stuck by one of the pointy Trollan buildings," the pilot said, one of the enervated members of the Star Force.

"It will do," Mermista said in a monotone before leaping out of the shuttle, Scorpia following not far behind. Together they plummeted towards the ground; just before they impacted, Mermista summoned the power of her staff, bringing their momentum to a halt a foot above the dusty ground. She then dismissed the magic holding them, allowing them both to land smoothly on the ground; immediately, Mermista and Scorpia raised their Staves of Power, ready to fend off any defenders.

"Where is everyone? I was hoping for a little excitement than this," Scorpia complained.

"Weren't you listening to Lethe? They said this place is abandoned; just a bunch of historians who mainly keep to their outpost." Mermista shot back.

"Well, looky at what we have here," a familiar voice called.

Scorpia spun on her heel, finding herself facing the last two people she expected to see on this mission.

“Catra! Adora! What are you doing here?” Scorpia exclaimed.

“It looks like you get your wish, Scorpia,” Mermista said irritably.

Their former friends were standing at the short street perpendicular to the entrance of the Athenaeum; Catra with hands on hips and Adora with arms crossed. Both began to stride toward the fallen princesses, their confident swagger a mirror of the other.

“Here on another errand for Archon Lethe, ladies?” Adora asked.

“They are just Lethe now, Despara—oh! I mean Adora now,” Mermista shot back. “Sorry, I get confused as to which side you are on. First, you were Horde—then a Rebel. After that, you became Despara and were our ally before you betrayed us. Who are you now? I’m sure your wife is sick of the constant flim-flam—aren’t you, Catra?”

Scorpia could see Mermista’s words had an effect on Adora as she slowed her advance, insecurity plain on her face. Catra immediately veered to her wife’s side as she took her hand, staring daggers at Mermista.

“Adora never betrayed anyone, Mermista. The Horde wasn’t worth an ounce of loyalty, and becoming Despara was Lethe’s doing, not Adora’s. If you want to talk about betrayal—look in a mirror!” Catra said with teeth bared.

Scorpia glanced at Mermista, who shrugged at Catra’s words; the Fallen Princess of Salineas gripped her staff tightly, raising it as Catra and Adora resumed their advance.

“We aren’t here for you; just let us go about our business, and we will leave you alone,” Scorpia offered.

Catra immediately laughed at this, her tail twitching rapidly in her humor.

“No way, Big Gal! You are lost, and I am here to bring you back to us!” Catra exclaimed, her eyes simmering with green light.

Fear suddenly coursed through Scorpia at the thought of losing her freedom—summoning the power of the Void Gem—she projected a lance of pure anti-energy out from the font at her forehead. Both of the intended targets leaped to one side as the beam annihilated a large section of ground, leaving a gaping hole in its wake. She watched as Catra and Adora brought themselves to their full height, raising their hands simultaneously into the air.

“FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!!!”

“BY THE TRUTH OF GRAYSKULL!!!”

Scorpia was momentarily blinded by the bloom of magical light appearing around both women; bright jade fire for Catra and dazzling opalescence around Adora. When her vision returned, Scorpia found herself gaping at two specimens of female splendor; Adora’s She-Ra form was now silver and white—an interesting departure from her usual gold and white. But Catra’s Sher-Va form was what drew her attention and held it; Scorpia had never fully gotten over her attraction to Catra, only ignored it with respect to their friendship. But now she no longer cared about the feelings of others, and she practically drooled to see her old friend as an eight-foot-tall feline warrior woman. Sher-Va/Catra gazed back at her with glowing heterochromia as she flexed her clawed gauntlets, massive tail swaying behind her.

“Wow!” Scorpia gasped.

“Ugh, get a hold of yourself, Scorpia, *geez.* Like—whatever. Catra is only just a little more attractive than she was—which wasn’t much.” Mermista commented. Scorpia wasn’t fooled, and neither was Catra.

“Oh, please, Mermista. Don’t think I missed you checking me out over Seahawk’s shoulder when we went sunbathing in Salineas.

Or your wandering eyes when you were helping me try out outfits for my wedding!" Sher-Va/Catra said with a smirk.

"You were checking out my wife before our wedding! Mermista, how could you? I thought you were my friend!" She-Ra/Adora said in feigned seriousness.

Scorpia was pleased to see Mermista's face darken in embarrassment; the usually cool Princess was caught off-guard.

"*Whatever!*" She cried, pointing the Kinetic Krystal at Sher-Va/Catra; instantly, the Madgēcot Champion pitched her head over tail toward one of the nearby buildings.

"YEOWWW!!!" Sher-Va/Catra cried as her body punched a hole through the wall. The impact destabilized the ancient structure, sending it tumbling down on top of the Champion and leaving a cloud of dense debris behind.

"Catra!!!" She-Ra/Adora cried.

She-Ra/Adora stopped herself from running to her wife's aid, instead focusing on the two dangerous individuals before her. A timely block deflected a searing blast from Scorpia, followed by an abrupt dodge evading a wave of kinetic force from Mermista. In return, She-Ra/Adora lashed out with magic of her own, sending a lance of power from her sword into Scorpia, launching her off her feet to skid away on her back.

"Nice move, Princess!" Mermista taunted. "But you are going to need more than that for me!"

A hazy teal wall appeared before the bearer of the Kinetic Krystal, blocking her from meeting the same fate as Scorpia. Before Mermista could comment further, She-Ra/Adora was charging, head down and sword raised.

"What are you—Agrrhhh!!" Mermista screamed as her protective wall was shattered by the power of She-Ra, and she was seized by the massive warrior. She-Ra/Adora held Mermista off the

ground and shook her violently, causing her to drop her Staff of Power as her teeth chattered. Mermista's brown eyes widened with terror as she experienced the strength of a Champion of Grayskull, and she clutched at She-Ra/Adora's silver gauntlets in desperation.

"Adora—No! Please… don't!" She stammered.

Anxiety bloomed in She-Ra/Adora's chest as a memory came to the fore, unbidden:

"You cannot use the Relativity Forge as a weapon! It was made to be a power source, and I will not allow it to be used so basely by one such as you!" An older man shouts at her.

She remembers this man—Peder is his name—he is the scientist in charge of the Relativity Forge. She also remembers feeling great rage at the man's words; she wants to hear him speak to her with respect. If she cannot get that, she would settle for terror—she revels in seeing that emotion in another's eyes.

"I—" She-Ra/Adora said before choking on the words and dropping Mermista to the ground.

She backed away from the other Princess while holding out her hands as if trying to warn Mermista of the threat she posed.

No, Adora. That was Despara's memory—not yours! You need to stop them! She-Ra/Adora urged herself, clenching her fists to dismiss the shame welling in her heart.

Just as she was going to resume her attack on Mermista, Scorpia came to the rescue, rising from the ground to throw herself bodily into She-Ra/Adora's midsection. Both women fell to the ground in a melee, but with the greater strength of She-Ra, Scorpia found herself pinned to the ground. Before she could use the power of the Void Gem, She-Ra/Adora yanked it away, tossing it to the side to clatter harmlessly on the ground.

“Surrender!” She-Ra/Adora commanded, summoning her sword and pointing the tip at Scorpia’s throat.

“Never traitor!” Scorpia screamed back.

She-Ra/Adora immediately balked at the response as another image appeared in her mind:

Zhe-La/Veth is standing over a fallen enemy; it is a woman inside a mecha suit—she despises the defenders' reliance on technology to enhance their strength. She does not need such things, for she has the power of She-Ra and Archon Lethe.

Zhe-La/Veth is asking the woman to surrender—which is foolish. Her feelings are justified as the woman spits and curses at her fellow Champion.

How dare she! Doesn’t this fool know she is in the presence of two magnificent warriors?

A two-handed downward sword strike rectifies the woman’s poor attitude.

She-Ra/Adora felt a blow to her head—after a momentary disorientation—found herself on her back looking up at Scorpia and Mermista.

“What is wrong with you?” Mermista asked with a curl of her lip. “I don’t remember you being this weak.”

She-Ra/Adora summoned her sword, and just as she was about to raise it, a booted foot stomped her wrist, pinning it to the ground. She-Ra/Adora opened her hand—immediately, the weapon dissolved back into the magic of her Champion Spirit.

“This seems too easy,” Scorpia said, placing her black crown back where it was, Void Gem shimmering with restrained potential.

She-Ra/Adora felt helpless—how could she fight these two? They were her friends, and they were simply lost; what would happen if

she killed one of them? She had already killed so many…

"Look at her," Mermista continued, cruel amusement plain on her features. "She looks terrified of us. How about we put her out of her misery, Scorpia?"

"I was thinking the same thing," The other woman said, the Void Gem at her temple beginning to glow as she called upon its power.

She-Ra/Adora cringed, closing her eyes to the searing pain she knew she earned—how could she not? She has caused so much pain to others; it was what she deserved.

"NO!!!" A voice screamed.

A crimson and gold tornado of wrath was instantly between She-Ra/Adora and her assailants, sending both women reeling from the fury of the assault. She-Ra/Adora looked up to find Sher-Va/Catra standing over her—golden claws held out and ready to strike.

"Girls," Sher-Va/Catra growled. "I want the both of you back to normal, but if you try that again, I *swear* I will *kill* you!"


Iria Abella 2023

Mermista and Scorpia balked at the vehemence in the Champion's words, both Fallen Princess looking unsure at facing Sher-Va/Catra.

"Come on, we are wasting time here," Mermista said to Scorpia. They both turned, running into the entrance of the Athenaeum as Sher-Va/Catra kneeled next to her wife.

"Adora! Are you okay? Did they hurt you?" She fretted.

Dazed, She-Ra/Adora looked into Sher-Va/Catra's face, feeling a pang of guilt at the worry there.

"I'm fine, Catra, it's just… I'm fine, really," she implored, rising to her feet.

She-Ra/Adora could see that her wife was not convinced, the concern taking on a desperate edge in her glowing heterochromatic eyes.

"It's fine, Catra, it's fine," she implored, trying to shake the other's clutching hands. She-Ra-Adora felt unworthy of the care being shown her while at the same time knowing such thoughts were foolish; it made her angry.

"But Ador—"

"*Just stop it!"* She-Ra/Adora snapped. She immediately regretted the harshness of her words as Sher-Va/Catra's mouth gaped open, and her long ears drooped. She-Ra/Adora had to force a smile on her face.

"Come on! They are getting away!" She implored.

Sher-Va/Catra nodded solemnly as they both turned to give chase to their erstwhile friends; the whole time she ran, She-Ra/Adora felt like another notch had been added to a long tally of shame.

* * *

Mermista followed Scorpia through the circular rooms of the bizarre building, feeling baffled as to where their objective was. Each new space they entered was as empty as the last, with several openings leading to other rooms of the same design. It was like they were in a hive made by insane bees; there was no logical course to follow, nor could they discern which way was the middle.

“We are running out of time—where the heck is the portal!?” She shouted to no one in particular.

Not expecting a response from her companion, Mermista was annoyed and surprised when she answered.

“I think it’s this way,” she said, pointing a claw in what seemed a random direction. Mermista groaned in exasperation.

“There is no door that way, moron!” She yelled.

Scorpia chuckled. “Not yet, there isn’t,” She said before directing a burst of negative particles at the obstruction—instantly, the wall imploded in on itself, the process repeating as the magic of the Void was channeled from room to room. When Scorpia was finished, Mermista spotted a sizeable stone ring suspended by chains at the end of a clear passage.

“Well done, it’s about time you were useful,” she said as Scorpia leered back at her.

The two raced through the opening, running as fast as their legs could take them. Mermista had to stifle the urge to look back as an alarming noise followed them—a rapid clatter that got louder. The sound was like horse hooves—or claws—hitting the floor's hard surface.

“Here! Take this!” Mermista called, tossing the satchel to Scorpia—she caught it deftly between two pincers and quickly removed the vial of Antithetical Philter.

“Why are you giving me this?” Scorpia asked, looking at the glowing indigo fluid in the glass container.

Her question was answered as Sher-Va/Catra burst through the hole in the wall on all fours, her cinnamon face set in a look of determination. Immediately Mermista raised the Kinetic Krystal, seizing the Champion in a field of infinite friction. Sher-Va/Catra snarled and writhed in her prison, causing Mermista to struggle as she held the furious Madgēcot Champion in place.

“Hurry!” She shouted over her shoulder, but Scorpia was already ahead of her, dipping a claw tip into the vial to draw the sigils Lethe had taught them on the surface of the gateway. A hazy distortion appeared at the center of the ring as Scorpia connected the arcane words; when she was finished, a silvery surface appeared, like disturbed water.

The way was open.

“Go!” Mermista shouted—but Scorpia needed no further prodding; not caring what happened to the other Princess, she dove through the shimmering surface to disappear from this reality altogether. Mermista gritted her teeth to see the other escape, knowing she could not follow. In the end, all that mattered was Lethe’s will be done, for to do otherwise would be unwise; she and Scorpia were bound to Lethe through their magic of Oblivion and were extensions of their will. Nothing more.

Feeling the fury of Sher-Va/Catra fully expending her reserves, Mermista let go, falling to her hands and knees as the field holding her prisoner shattered like glass. Looking through strands of hair, Mermista saw two large clawed feet padding towards her; when they stopped, she found Sher-Va/Catra staring down at her with eyes burning with jade fire. Behind her was She-Ra/Adora, late arrived and face drawn in weariness—for what—Mermista did not know, nor did she care.

“It’s over, Mermista. It’s time for you to return to us,” Sher-Va/Catra said.

“NO!!!” Mermisata screamed, knowing what the other intended. She jerked back, trying to scurry away from the golden gauntlets reaching for her—but this was She-Ra/Catra coming for her—and there was no escape.

“No, No, No, No, NOOOOOOO!!!” Mermista wailed.

A sense of vertigo coursed through her body as Mermista was seized and hoisted into the air; looking down at the hands that held her, both were ablaze with the green fire. At once, Mermista felt the conflagration enter her, coursing through her innards with a hunger for the evil which had taken root in her spirit. Feeling the freedom of apathy being scorched away, Mermista screamed as the inferno poured from her eyes and mouth—a diametric shift spread throughout her persona—the intensity of which pulled Mermista into unconsciousness. When she came to, it was to the feel of strong arms cradling her against a soft, warm body—a deep thrumming purr filling the void of her wounded soul.

Mermista opened her eyes wearily, afraid to bear witness to the world in which, only moments before, she had tread so cruelly.

“Hey there, Princess, welcome back,” a kind voice said.

Mermista turned to see two heterochromatic feline eyes staring back at her; it was Catra—she was the one holding her. Instantly, waves of remorse coursed over Mermista—but unlike the tides she could summon—there was no controlling these.

“Ca—Catra!” Mermista sputtered, tears beginning to form in her eyes. “What have I done?”

Compassion lit up Catra’s features as she smiled. Adora was kneeling next to Mermista, her face infinitely sad as she placed a reassuring hand on Mermista’s shoulder.

“It’s going to be okay, Mermista,” Adora whispered. “We have you back now, and that’s all that matters.”

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Iria Abella, a.k.a. ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram and Tumblr.

Rebound and Repose

Chapter Summary

With the most unlikeliest of leaders, Etheria's Resistance strikes back at the invaders.

Micah and Castaspalla run halfway across the galaxy, all the way into a pair of waiting green arms.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Frosta stared down at the mechanisms on the wooden bench, trying to identify which one matched the name given to her.

Hmmm… could it be the tube-shaped one covered with dials? She thought, finger to lips. *Or is it the one that looks like a gun?"*

Frosta picked up the latter, placing her finger on the activation stud and flipping it—an arch of intense blue fire burst forth, ending in a sharp tip inches from the end of the nozzle. Frosta immediately released the button and dropped the torch; she never did like fire—it was in direct opposition to her magical nature.

"Did you find the Omni-Tool, Princess Frosta?" Hordak called.

"Uh…" She said, looking frantically around. Spotting something that looked the most like a screwdriver, Frosta picked it up and brought it to the waiting Hordak.

"Is this it?" She asked.

The ex-ruler of the Horde towered over the smaller Frosta, but when he caught sight of the object in her outstretched hand, he seemed to diminish, wilting like a flower too long in the light.

"I take it that's a no?" Frosta said, starting to draw her hand back.

“No,” Hordak said abruptly, taking the instrument from her hand. “It is not an Omni-Tool but a Six-Sided Hex Driver—it will do,”

Frosta frowned at Hordak, momentarily surprised; she had never interacted with the man, but from every description she had received, Frosta had expected an ill-tempered grouch. Instead of snapping at her for not giving him the tool he asked for, Horak only seemed crestfallen—as if seeing it brought back painful memories.

“Are you okay? Something about a Six-Sided Hex Driver that upsets you?” She ventured.

“*It’s not your concern!*” Hordak snapped.

There is the old grump I was told about, Frosta thought with a grin.

She watched Hordak turn away from her to the old Horde robot sitting on his worktable; it was ball-shaped with its signature four spider legs tucked in its round body. After adjusting something in its innards, Hordak closed the maintenance hatch, and the robot’s single trapezoid-shaped eye lit up with a lambent purple glow. The robot promptly extended its four legs to stand and face Hordak, emitting a series of rapid-fire beeps and bleats that sounded almost chastising. Hordak sighed after the robot was finished with its torrent, turning to Frosta with a sheepish expression on his angular face.

“I apologize for my early terseness,” he said. “I was displacing my feelings again, and it was wrong to snap at you,”

The robot emitted a series of pleased sounds, and Frosta was amazed to observe Hordak give it an affectionate pat. She quickly realized who this robot was.

“Emily?” Frosta asked.

An affirmative beep was the response, followed by a staccato of blurts. Frosta held her hands up and shrugged.

“Sorry, I don’t speak robot,”

“Emily is offended you didn’t recognize her and wants to know if all robots look the same to you,” Hordak translated.

“Uh… I choose not to answer that,” Frosta said, wishing someone else was there to back her up.

But everyone else was gone—sent on their own perspective errands by the new-rebellion leader, Hordak. Frosta was still trying to wrap her head around how that had happened; it seemed like she was now in an alternate reality where up was down and day was night. It was the reason why she had decided to stay behind while all the others jumped at Hordak’s commands; she did not trust him and wanted time alone with the old tyrant to make her own judgments. Frosta still could not believe how quickly Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio had fallen back into their old ways; immediately following his orders as if they were still in the Horde. Well, Frosta wasn’t convinced—not yet anyway.

“So, you never explainedwhy you left Dryl—didn’t you take an oath never leave for the rest of your life?” Frosta asked.

Hordak’s fierce red eyes narrowed as he regarded her. “I was planning on keeping my oath for the rest of my life—that was—until creatures suddenly materialized in the Crypto Castle and started turning my staff against me. When I called for help, the Etherian Star Force responded that they would not assist me and that I should submit to the will of the same things running amok in my home! That the Crypto Castle was now under their authority!”

Hordak paused a moment, clenching his armored fist at the memory.

“Well, oath or no oath, I was not going to let someone take my beloved Entrapta’s castle—not while there was still life in me!”

Frosta pursed her lips and nodded at this; his story was the same as hers—driven from his home by erstwhile allies and on the run

from monsters, unaware of who or what was responsible—all the while not knowing what had happened to the ones you cared about. Hordak continued.

"I have learned much of our enemy since then—their main weapon is the ability to turn those around you to their cause. It reminds me of what my broth—I mean—Horde Prime was able to do. Although his way was technological whereas this new method seems more… magical in nature. I believe it is tied to those very creatures that had attacked Dryl,"

Frosta nodded. "You are right about that; these black monsters can bite people and take their empathy away—I'm sure they are the same ones Glimmer mentioned. The ones that bit Scorpia, Mermista, and Entrapta when they went looking for the Staff of Power,"

At the mention of Entrapta, Hordak was downcast, but then anger blazed across his face. Her raised himself to his full height—the mechanisms of his power armor whirring and buzzing at his command.

"Then these… *monsters* you call them—they will be the first to feel my wrath!" He exclaimed. "I've been wanting to get my hands on the things that hurt Entrapta—now that they have come to me—I will not waste the opportunity to exact vengeance!"

Frosta held up her hands; she was now fully convinced of their shared aims and wanted to forestall the other from taking any rash actions.

"Now, let's not get too hasty!" She warned. "I have yet to see what your plan is! Or, for that matter, any evidence of an actual resistance! Who else do we have fighting on our side? Besides the three ex-horde soldiers I've brought you, all I've seen so far is a little boy and a puffed-up peacock!"

Hordak didn't respond at first, instead moving towards a sizable chest set in the corner of his workshop. He opened it reverently

before removing a large cannon which he slid neatly over his right forearm—it clicked in place as the soft hum of activation filled the room. Hordak extended the arm cannon outward, closing one eye to aim it at a random point. With a slowly building whine, the weapon powered up, and Frosta squinted as a searing red beam pieced the gloom, blasting a heap of scarp into dust. Grunting with satisfaction, Hordak lowered the weapon, turning to regard Frosta.

"I may not have an army of soldiers at my disposal anymore, but I still have my technology. Besides Emily, I have twenty other robots under my command—all heavily modified by Entrapta." He said.

Frosta shook her head. "That's still not enough! There is an entire planet against us—plus the Star Force, and I have not even mentioned Eternia—"

Hordak held up a finger on his free hand, forestalling the Princess of Snows from continuing.

"I am not finished." He said. "I will take these meager forces to the Old Fright Zone—there, I will find the vault in which the entire Horde Robot legion is being kept. Then, I will have the beginnings of the army in which to take back Etheria,"

Frosta considered this; she did remember someone mentioning that the Horde bots were never destroyed—instead, they were deactivated and kept in case they ever needed them. Some people grumbled about this plan, saying it left too much temptation for Hordak to come and claim them, renewing his fight against the people of Etheria. It seems they were right—but not for the reasons they initially thought.

"I suppose that is a good start," Frosta amended. "What about capturing a facility to make more robots? Have you thought of that?"

For the first time, Frosta saw Hordak grin.

"Yes, I have—yet I am surprised to hear you thinking ahead. I am pleased to have you with me, Princess; I see together, we will make an excellent team,"

Frosta was surprised to feel embarrassed by his words and felt heat spread across her face.

Wow, did Hordak just make me blush? Thank goodness no one is here to see it! She thought.

"But we are getting ahead of ourselves!" Hordak continued. "First, we must investigate rumors in the town of Elberon of two Princesses stirring up trouble."

Frosta perked up at this. "Spinnerella and Netossa! It's gotta be them!"

Hordak nodded. "Yes, I thought so as well. I never thought that one day I would be planning on rescuing a couple of Princesses," he said wryly.

Frosta couldn't agree more as she grinned back at him.

* * *

A gray and grimy world appeared on the forward view screen as *The Crooked Star* exited hyperspace and turned to face its destination. Instantly Micah was filled with doubt about his decision to come here—feeling Castaspella grip his hand tightly—he knew that his sister must be feeling the same thing.

"Here we are, ladies and gentlemen—the beautiful and stunning world of Thenlor! Known throughout the galaxy as the premier destination for all lost and hopeless souls—present company excluded, of course!" Captain Cloven exclaimed.

Micah turned to regard the smuggler watching them from her captain's chair; Captain Cloven had proven to be a less prickly woman since they hired her in *The Serpos Head.* When she wasn't

flirting with Micah, she was regaling both siblings with ribald tales of her exploits throughout the galaxy.

Catching Micah regarding her, Captain Cloven winked, making the senior sorcerer blush as he turned quickly to face the forward viewport. To Micah's annoyance, Castaspella elbowed him in the side; he knew she was giving him the look that said *I know what just happened*. Micah had felt that the whole trip to Thenlor had been spent either dodging Captain Cloven's advances or avoiding Castaspella's comments that he should go for it. Just thinking about it made him feel guilty to the memory of Angella.

"I really love this planet," Captain Cloven continued. "I used to make a lot of trips here for a guy named Janus; I would spend days soaking up the sights in the Voluptus Quarter after I would make a drop-off. Did I ever tell you about the Voluptus Quarter, Cassie?"

Micah was surprised to hear his sister give a snort as she tried to stifle a laugh.

"Oh, yes, I do, Corliss. How can I forget?!" Castaspella said, turning to grin at the other woman. Micah could not believe that his sister, of all people, was on a first-name basis with a smuggler captain.

"Ladies, I hope you have not forgotten how serious our situation is?" Micah said a little too sternly. He knew they were rolling their eyes at each other but chose to ignore it.

"Speak for yourself, Mikey," Captain Clovis purred, using the pet name she had for him. "I'm not the one on the run,"

Saying this, she reached a booted toe out and nudged Micah in the rear; he quickly moved out of reach, not daring to turn in case she made out the blush on his face. But there wasn't much room on the cramped bridge on what was a small ship—basically, a large skiff if he was being kind—and Micah found himself pinned between a console and structural beam with nowhere to escape.

This is a good metaphor for my entire trip, he thought ruefully.

"Don't worry, I will get you where you want to go—safe and sound," she continued, a little more serious this time. "I am reaching out to your contact now,"

Captain Cloven pressed a button in the armrest of her chair, and an audible click sounded throughout the cabin as she opened a channel.

"This is Captain Cloven of the completely legal starship *The Crooked Star,"* she announced with a chuckle. "I'm looking for someone named White Claw, and was told I could reach them on this frequency,"

There was static before a connection was made, and someone on the other side began speaking.

"This is White Claw," a lyrical female voice replied. "I am familiar with you, Captain Clovis; your reputation proceeds you,"

Captain Clovis grinned, seeming pleased by the recognition.

"I've never heard your pretty voice before, White Claw; I can't say I know you—But I'm happy to know you're familiar with me!" The smuggler captain said.

A low growl emitted from the speakers in response, making Micah's hair stand on end.

"Don't be—*criminal!* I've waited a long time to get my claws on you!" White Claw hissed. "I know it was you who has been smuggling Death Binder artifacts to Thenlor from Eternia!"

Captain Cloven practically leaped up in her seat to hear the sudden anger in the other woman's voice; Micah found himself holding up his hands in placation even though White Claw couldn't see him.

“Easy now! I am unfamiliar with the history here, but my sister and I are only refugees seeking asylum!” He exclaimed.

There was silence from the other end for a moment as the occupants of *The Crooked Star’s* bridge looked at each other nervously.

“You are refugees?” White Claw said unbelievingly. “And you came to Thenlor?”

Micah nodded. “Yes! We need help, and my daughter said that if I ever needed it, I could come here to find—” Micah said, breaking off at the last part.

“Go on,” White Claw coaxed. “Who did you come here to find?”

Micah looked at his sister with uncertainty, asking with his eyes—*are we really doing this?*

Her response was only to shrug—*a what other choice do we have?*—in reply.

“We are looking for Double Trouble,” Castaspella said, choosing to be the one to answer. “Have we come to the right place?”

* * *

Using a pair of ice-formed binoculars, Frosta peered through the brush at the edge of the forest, watching the people of Elberon go about their business. They had no idea they were being observed—but even if they did—she wasn’t sure if they would care; Frosta had yet to determine whether its people had been ‘darkened’—as Peric would call it.

The citizens of this town were of the Nymph—having plum, pink, or light orange skin and no nose—with every member sporting a pair of feathers protruding from their brows arranged according to their preference. On the outside, they seemed peaceful enough, giving no indication that Frosta was watching people devoid of empathy. They greeted one another on the streets, shared news

of the day's events, and she even spotted a youngster helping an older woman carry her bag home.

"What do you see, Princess Frosta? Is the town under enemy control?" Hordak asked nearby.

Frosta had to quell the sudden sense of surrealness of the situation before answering; after all, it seemed like only yesterday she was defending towns like this from Hordak. Now he was at her side, referring to its people as their potential enemy.

"I can't tell; so far, I would say no. But the last time I was here, I thought the same and barely made it out alive when it turned out Horde Prime chipped the whole town," she answered, not bothering to take her eyes off the binoculars.

Hordak only grunted in response as Frosta glanced back at him; she was surprised that the ex-Horde leader had come on this mission—from all other accounts of his leadership style, Hordak had let his minions do all the fieldwork, preferring to give orders from afar. But here he was, out in harm's way along with Lonnie, Kyle, Rogelio, and Emily—plus the robots he had brought from Dryl.

"So, what do we do?" Kyle asked nervously. "I vote we head back to Erelandia and call it a day!"

Lonnie rolled her eyes as Rogelio growled in his guttural language—Kyle right away looked ashamed, looking down at the ground.

"Okay, okay," he said. "But we need to do something! We have been sitting here watching all morning!"

Frosta had stopped listening to the others—something about how some of the townsfolk were acting had caught her attention. They were trying to appear unconcerned while at the same time vigilant—Frosta could feel the fear coming off them sickly waves.

"I don't think these people are our enemies," Frosta whispered to the others. "I think they are—"

Before she could finish speaking, a cry broke out, breaking the façade of a calm and peaceful community. The people of Elberon instantly took action—racing to hay bales, rain barrels, and other hiding places to extract pitchforks, hoes, and even a few old swords. At first, Frosta was afraid that they had been spotted and the people had mistaken them for invaders, but when she spotted the black shapes pouring out of the forest not too far from their hiding place, she knew that wasn't the case.

Frosta whipped around, looking between the trees and inspecting the branches, expecting to find the same nightmare beings ambushing them. But there was nothing; it seemed their presence had gone unnoticed, or at the very least, the monsters were only interested in the people of Elberon.

"Look!" Shouted Lonnie, making Frosta do an about-face towards the town. There she caught sight of two familiar figures rushing out of a nearby building, ready to participate in the defense of Elberon. The larger of the two defenders raised her hands, summoning a whirlwind that gathered up the first row of attackers in a twisting funnel; the black creatures writhed and hissed in rage at being denied what they craved. The shorter and darker-skinned woman brought forth a net of white light to wrap the spinning monsters; as they were released from the tornado, they fell in a snarling heap on the ground—easy pickings for the armed villagers who fell upon them at once.

"Spinnerella and Netossa!" Frosta cried happily. It was they whom she was hoping to find in that disastrous meeting in the Whispering Woods; to see them well and still fighting filled her heart with joy. She watched as Spinnerella clapped her hands before her, blasting another mass of fiends with a mighty wind gust that sent them tumbling back into the forest. Not to be outdone by her wife, Netossa spread her arms wide, fashioning one of her signature nets into a flat sheet—like a sail. Once fully formed, Netossa sent the net toward the charging enemies—it quickly sliced through their black bodies, leaving only pieces in its wake. The chunks wriggled as the will animating them still compelled them to feed—right before dissipating into ugly smoke.

Frosta observed Netossa cackling at her handiwork as Spinnerella looked horrified that her wife had used her nets as a giant cheese grater.

But before she could chastise her other half, more of the creatures came pouring from the forest—more than three times the original number. Spinnerella yelled something to Netossa that Frosta did not need to hear to understand—*we are in big trouble.* Both women started backing up as the wave of charging monsters came for them with teeth gnashing and hands held out to grasp.

Frosta was horrified.

"What are you waiting for? Come on—let's get in there!" Hordak urged behind her.

Jarred from her stupor, Frosta burst forward to race across the clearing with the others not far behind. Desperation filled her as defenders began to go down under the onslaught—one by one—they were being taken down by the monsters, becoming more 'darkened.' Frosta summoned her magic, creating an ice slide beneath her feet which she rode forward to rescue her friends. By now, two of the creatures had Spinnerella pinned as another was about to bite Netossa—thinking fast—Frosta summoned ice over its black teeth, forming a make-shift muzzle and thus saving the other Princess from a horrible fate. Shoving the beast off her, Netossa rose to her feet, sending two magical nets to bind the creatures holding her wife—which Frosta then dispatched with ice shards in each hand. Noticing Frosta suddenly amongst them, Netossa did a double take before smiling, nodding her appreciation at their sudden rescue.

"Hey, squirt, thanks for the assist," Netossa said.

"You're welcome—although you can stop calling me that; I am sixteen, after all, and no longer a kid," Frosta said peevishly.

"Aww!" Netossa said, reaching out to tussle Frosta's hair.

“Look out!” Spinnerella called, pointing down at their feet; the black creature whom Frosta had muzzled had removed the ice and was creeping towards Netossa—it would have her soon.

A red beam of hot intensity seared past the Princesses, hitting the monster directly in its center and vaporizing it. Blinking away the spots in her eyes, Frosta caught sight of Hordak approaching—Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio in toe—his arm cannon smoking from the recent discharge.

“That was foolish of you to separate yourself from our group, Princess Frosta,” Hordak said. “I would expect better of someone who claimed to have once defeated the Horde,”

Spinnerella and Netossa looked at Hordak incredulously; Frosta got the feeling they were trying to decide if they should attack him and held up her hands to forestall any questions.

“Frosta, Spinnerella, we will explain everything once we get out of this situation,” she said before turning to Hordak. “If we are going to work together, Hordak, you need to know I’m not getting into the habit of explaining myself—especially to you. The situation called for quick action—I took it and saved my friends. I’m not apologizing for it,”

Momentarily taken aback by the intensity in the young woman’s voice, Hordak eventually nodded, respect evident in his glowing red eyes.

“If we are done with the heartwarming reunion, can we get back to the fighting?” Lonnie called, pointing at the tide of advancing black monsters. Amongst this throng, Frosta could see townsfolk—recently darkened and acting on their new instincts. Looking around, she could find none of the citizens of Elberon to aid them—only enemies.

“Well, this is a fine pickle we find ourselves in,” complained Netossa. “I assume this is your leadership at work, eh Hordak?”

The ex-ruler of the Horde did not answer as he pressed a button in his armored gauntlet, emitting a crisp tone. Right away, the sounds of trees cracking could be heard in the distance as Hordak's small platoon of robots came bounding out of the forest, blasting nearby monsters with focused laser fire while knocking darkened villagers senseless to the grounds. The black creatures howled at this new enemy—they were offended by the robot's absence of anything resembling compassion and immunity to the sense of dread. Frosta watched in awe as Hordak and Entrapta's creations single-handedly turned the tide of battle; it seemed the day was saved once again.

"Let's get 'em!!!" Kyle cried, infecting the others with his exuberance for battle.

Seeing her friends enter the fray, Frosta turned to Hordak; the usually grim and stoic man was also watching the winning fight, a strange smile spreading across his craggy features. Almost as if in a trance, he began to speak, and Frosta got a sense that her presence had been forgotten.

"I can win this," Hordak said in a reverent hush. "Perhaps if I do, I can finally be worthy… of you…"

* * *

Hearing an abrupt whirring, Micah whirled to find the *Crooked Star's* deployment ramp retracting back into the underside of the vessel, removing his and Castaspella's option to reenter. Abruptly the smuggler's ship powered up, forcing Micah and his sister to back up; they watched the ship—which had transported them lightyears from Etheria—rise into the rain-streaked sky to blast off towards the underbelly of greasy clouds. Soon, all they could recognize of Captain Cloven's ship was the dull orange glow of the afterburners, which was then swallowed up by the perpetual storm of Thenlor.

Micah was surprised to feel a mild disappointment in his chest, knowing that the smuggler captain had abandoned them, but

turning back to the opening double doors at the opposite end of the landing pad, he soon recognized why.

A cloaked figure came storming out to greet them, yellow eyes blazing from beneath the hood as a striped tail lashed out at the rain behind them. The ferocity emanating from the oncoming person made Micah want to bolt—but looking furtively around himself and Castaspella—saw nothing but a plummeting drop on all three sides.

The figure came to a halt before them, feline eyes gazing up at the sky where her prey had recently departed.

"Looks like your ride left, and with it, any escape," she said, finally pinning Micah with amber eyes.

Micah rose to his full height, meeting the woman's gaze.

"We are through running," he said simply. "I assume you are White Claw?"

The woman gave a dismissive motion with her hand, giving Micah all the confirmation he needed; each of her fingers ended in pearl-white points and looked very sharp.

"I don't use that name anymore—you can call me, Panga," she said, waving them to the open doors. "Come, you can tell me your names inside—out of this wretched rain!"

Following Panga into the entrance, Micah recalled feeling a significant amount of trepidation when he had first laid eyes on their destination. As *The Crooked Star* came in for a landing, the massive structure had appeared through curtains of falling rain, standing like a grim giant amongst glittering light. Micah had thought it strange to find a flamboyant person like Double Trouble in such a place; he had known them for years—way before Catra had hired them for the Horde. The Double Trouble he recalled would have balked at living in such a harsh-looking setting.

Micah's attention was drawn back to Panga as she removed her hood, revealing a pretty orange face, long cream-colored ears, and a mane of long brown hair that she was currently wringing out.

"You're a Madgeycat," Micah said. The word was still unfamiliar to him, relayed by Perfuma on her return from Elysia.

Panga snorted as she eyed him, running her claws through her hair to fluff it out.

"Madgēcot," she corrected. "Yes, that's right, and you two are humans—I know that. What I don't know are your names,"

"Oh, right!" Micah exclaimed. "My name is Micah, and—"

"My name is Castaspella," his sister interrupted. "This is a lovely building you have, Panga,"

Glancing around the building's interior, Micah found it completely at odds with its exterior; it was bright—the walls and floors were comprised of iridescent marble, making him feel homesick for the Moonstone back in Bright Moon. The ceiling was where the true marvel lay; intricate frescoes done in gold depicting images of wonder filled Micah with a sense of calm and peace, making him forget the misfortunes of the past few weeks, if only for a while.

"What is this place?" Micah breathed.

Panga surveyed the interior, seeming to take notice of it for the first time—obviously, the female Madgēcot had since taken its splendor for granted.

"Hmm… I'm not sure; it's been on Thenlor for ages. Before Atreyen took it over, it was called The Numen, but they have since changed its name to Eleutheria—I'm rather taken with the name, actually," Panga said with a toothy grin.

Micah's eyebrows abruptly shot up. "Excuse me—who is Atreyen?"

Panga's eyes flashed in annoyance as her tail gave a quick flick.

"Oh, that's right. I forgot you are still calling them that offensive name—*Double Trouble*. Their name is Atreyen—if any of you bothered to get to know them, you would have found that out!" Panga said defensively, hand on hips.

Micah and Castaspella cast uncertain glances at each other.

"Didn't they introduce themselves to us as Double Trouble all those years ago?" Castaspella whispered to her brother. Micah only shrugged, not wanting to say anything more to upset the prickly Panga.

"Never mind!!!" Panga snapped, whirling away to stomp towards an open lift.

Out of Panga's sight, Castaspella made a twirling motion around one ear, and Micah stifled a laugh; his sister had done stuff like this when they were children. When one of their instructors had taken to screaming at them instead of teaching, Castaspella would prank the teacher this way, making the other children laugh instead of cringe in fear.

Following Panga into the elevator, Micah and Castaspella rode the way up in silence, broken only by an uncomfortable throat clearing when an agitated and damp tail batted someone's leg.

Soon, the elevator came to a halt, and with a chipper chime, the doors parted to reveal a cavernous chamber; black, angled walls met at a point far above a gleaming opalescent floor. At the opposite end of the space was a desk, and behind that, a large vertical window, revealing the cityscape in all its dark majesty.

"Huh," Panga said. "They were just here—Atreyen must be in their sanctum,"

"Double Trouble has a *sanctum*?" Micah asked incredulously. A glare from Panga was his only answer before she led them to a

door nearby— knocking tentatively, she perked one of her long ears to listen within.

"Oh, Kitten, is this a new game? I will play!" Double Trouble's voice cooed within. "*Oh, who is knocking on my door—at this late hour? Don't you dare enter my chambers; I am in the nude and vulnerable!"*

With ears lowered in horror, Panga looked back at her guests with an embarrassed tight smile.

"*Atreyen!*" She said in a strained voice. "*There are people here to see you,"*

"Hmmm…" Double Trouble mused. "If this isn't a game, why have you not used the safe word?"

Panga put her hands around her mouth and whispered something at the door—try as he might—Micah could not hear it, and neither could the recipient of the message.

"I couldn't make that out, Kitten; try again." Double Trouble said.

Clenching her fists and hunching her shoulders, Panga let out a small whine as her tail twitched rapidly. Micah was surprised at how much he was enjoying this; the fierce warrior woman suddenly was not so intimidating.

"Cattywampus!" She shouted.

"Ah! Come in!" Was the response.

As soon as the invitation was spoken, Panga barged into the room, and a wondrous sight greeted Micah—a realm of night populated by an array of dancing green lights—like fireflies. As Micah entered, he took the measure of Double Trouble's sanctum, seeing that it was not an empty space but a room whose every side was comprised of black stone. The green motes were actually in the room's surfaces, radiating out from the object in the center; a sable tree holding aloft a great orb in its twisting bows.

Micah was struck dumb by the sight of the large sphere; where the room was black, this ball was absolutely stygian—the green lights zipping manically within. With hands behind their back and tail twisted up into a spiral was the one they sought; Double Trouble, gazing up at the orb with eyes mirroring that of its design.

“Oh, Panga, you brought these two here?” Double Trouble said, disappointed.

“If you want, I can throw them back out into the rain,” Panga offered nearby, arms crossed. Double Trouble smiled and winked at her.

“No! Wait!” Cried Micah. He was too busy backing away from Panga in alarm to catch the exchange, which made Double Trouble cackle with laughter.

“Oh, silly Micah! I kid!” They said, coming over to pat him jovially on the shoulder. “Right, Kitten? We’re kidding?”

Panga only frowned, giving Double Trouble a dismissive shrug in response.


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“Oh, don’t mind her!” They said, waving a hand at the Madgēcot. “She gets suspicious of new people and very protective of me! Little does she know we are old friends! Right Castaspella?”

Double Trouble gave Micah’s sister a wink combined with a sharp-toothed leer—she quickly blushed, looking away.

“What is that, Double Trouble?” Micah said, pointing at the sight in the middle of the room. Double Trouble turned to regard what he was indicating, their face brightening.

“Oh! You mean the Orb of Entropy?” They said as if it were a trivial question. “Oh, it's nothing, just some tidbit I picked up—pay it no mind!”

Micah wasn’t fooled by Double Trouble’s facetiousness and moved forward to get a closer look—he immediately felt its arcane nature humming throughout his bones.

“It’s chaos magic, isn’t it?” He said in awe. “You do magic now, Double Trouble? It seems rather reckless—even for you,”

Double Trouble’s eyes became lidded as they regarded Micah coolly; it was the first time they expressed anything other than playful mirth to him.

“I *always* did magic, silly man. It’s not something only for graduates of Mystacor, like you and your sister, who had it handed to them on a silver platter,” they said scornfully.

“Look,” Castaspella interjected with a nervous laugh. “We don’t care about what’s happening here; we just need help. We need to get into contact with Glimmer!”

Double Trouble and Panga shared a look at the mention of his daughter’s name, concern plain on both their faces.

“What had happened?” Panga asked with kindness in her voice now.

Micah waved these questions away, not wanting to become mired in explanations.

“We just need access to a transmitter powerful enough to reach Elysia—can you do that for us?” He asked testily.

Double Trouble approached him then, the blackness in their eyes replaced by yellow and green, plus something else Micah was surprised to see.

Compassion.

“Tell me what happened… please?” Double Trouble implored as they gripped his shoulders. He felt their claws poking through the fabric of his tunic, the effect being of comfort—not threat. Micah sagged in their surprisingly strong grip, seeming to deflate as the magnitude of what had taken place on Eternia hit him fully like a hammer.

“We lost it… we lost the Castle,” he moaned.

Right away Panga was at Micah’s side, her hands pawing at his arm in concern; in her wide yellow eyes, Micah recognized the fear of what he was about to admit.

“What? What castle did you lose?” She asked in a ghostly voice.

“*Grayskull*…” Micah finally finished. “We lost Castle Grayskull to… *evil*,”

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Panga and Double Trouble done by Miledibuja. You can find her stuff on Tumblr, Instagram, and Twitter!

The Visage of Wun-Dar

Chapter Summary

> Shen and Veth finally come face to face with the horror that is Wun-Dar.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Veth twitched on the bed, caught not just in a dream but a recitation of memories drawn from deep within their mind by an unknown presence. This benefactor spoke to Veth within their unconscious state, coaxing them along a path of self-realization.

VETH, I HAVE HELPED UNLOCK THE PERSON WHOM YOU WERE MEANT TO BE—NOW IT IS TIME FOR YOU TO RETURN THAT FAVOR; YOU MUST HELP ME

On the bed, Veth whimpered as they curled themselves into a fetal position, their clawed hands gripping the bed sheets, slicing them into ribbons.

WHAT I AM ABOUT TO SHOW YOU IS NOT ONE OF YOUR MEMORIES—IT IS THE KEY TO HEALING ME—TO HEALING THE UNIVERSE

Veth bore their fangs in a grimace; they were resisting the intrusion of this alien will, forcing itself upon their sleeping mind. But on a level beyond that of their subconsciousness, Veth knew this entity was sincere, and it had helped them immensely—now it needed their help in return.

WILL YOU HELP ME, VETH

Veth let out a long sigh as they unclenched themselves, allowing the unknown entity full access to their inner domain. Instantly, Veth's subconsciousness soared down a tunnel of threaded Light;

they veered and banked down a dizzying array of channels and paths, all leading to eons of memories kept within the spirit of their Champion Avatar. Veth was drawn toward the farthest echo, one made a long time ago—but it was not the oldest—only the most painful to the Champion Spirit.

Veth was aware they were being placed within another, and at once, they recognized the feel of a Nephraeh body—only different. As they sunk fully into this form, Veth had access to the other's physical senses—sight, taste, smell, hearing, feeling, and the spiritual. Veth felt their consciousness merge with the other, their awareness coinciding with the memory.

They peer around the chamber, taking in what they have wrought; bodies line the temple floor of Zhe-La. Innocents that had turned to them in a time of need—plus some of their own people; they were the sweetest lives taken that day. To extinguish the lives of Nephraeh for nothing more than their self-aggrandizement… ahhh…

Veth's consciousness flinched from the echo; the vileness of the person they inhabited was just too sudden and intense.

NO, VETH, PLEASE, I KNOW IT'S HARD, BUT YOU MUST SEE

With great weariness, Veth returned to the memory, etheric bile in their spiritual throat.

They turn from their handiwork to look down at their body; the pure white skin of their arms is stained with blood. As it glistens in the torchlight of the temple, they stare at it with rapt fascination, wondering—is it a bit of blood from every single one of their victims? Or is it just one? They cannot remember—but in the end—it does not matter. None of it matters; not the people they killed, not the Empire crumbling around them, not the Nephraeh and their silly Light, not that fool Zzar—all that matters is their ascension to Godhood. They are liberated from all concerns for

others and now free to do whatever they want; they are going to make the most of that freedom, they would—

Veth pulled themselves away from the echo, needing a moment's respite from the experience of that individual. It felt like they had been holding their breath underwater and were poking their head above the surface, gasping for air. After a brief rest, they sank back into the mire, returning to the recollection.

—make the galaxy burn for their ambition. It is not enough that they have been emancipated from compassion; they also need to be unfettered from the need to feed on it. Godhood can give them that—right? What need do they have for such trivial concerns once they attain that level of existence?

Veth let out a low moan on the bed, the feeling of total apathy like poison in their body; if they had felt this before the return of compassion, they could have withstood it. But now, with the song of empathy singing in their veins, they were barely hanging on.

They can feel the power of the Apogeon Ritual rising steadily; it is like a background hum, ready to be fully unleashed yet kept at bay. Why are they waiting? The ritual can be strengthened more, but they had used up all their fuel. They are running out of time and need to act fast—but for some reason—they know they have to wait just a bit longer. For what, they just aren't entirely sure—

"Kishar! What have you done?" a voice shouts, pulling them from their reveries.

A smile spreads across their white lips as they recognize that voice —they realize this is what they have been waiting for. A giant Madgēcot stands amongst the carpet of bodies; he is magnificent in gold armor, his handsome face gazing at them with absolute dread.

"Jihan, you've finally tracked me down. Where is the lovely Dinala Katan and her Void Gem? You're going to need her if you're going to fight me." They say in greeting.

They can barely contain the glee spreading through them; here and now is the one who loves them more than anything—even his own life! Killing him would be glorious! It is what the Apogeon Ritual needs to be fully complete! How can they be so lucky? It is as if some outside force is orchestrating—

Veth couldn't take it anymore; they yanked themselves from the echo so hard they found themselves soaring directionless through the Champion Spirit's vault of remembrance. A great toxic well of angst had infected Veth's soul; it was steering out of the realm of the past and into the future of possibility. This was a much greater space, and the selections were limitless, but based on Veth's current disposition, the choice had been made for them.

They are in another form; this time, it is their own. They can feel that they are in their Zhe-La Champion form, but it is… different.

Looking around themselves, they regard a desolate and cracked landscape; it is a blasted vision of ruin, a haunted planet where the evidence of ancient battles is evident in the gigantic fissures which dot the landscape. They understand that these crevasses are not just holes—but breaks in reality, leading to other places in space and time. They would know—they had once fallen into one…

Turning from these sights, they beheld a range of jagged peaks piercing the night sky like claws. Below these mountains is a fortress made of pain and ruin; it is black—like despair—with four dagger towers at each corner of a rectangular shape. It had a name once, long ago, but they preferred its new one—given to it by people with no understanding.

It is the Basilica of the Obscene, and it is their home.

Finally, they look down at their body, seeing their lithe body sheathed in ebony armor; it is barbed and hooked—the design preferred for the agony it inflicts. In their gauntleted hand is a black sword that glows with fell light—the dull indigo of Oblivion.

Holding it up to catch the starlight, they can glimpse their reflection—

NOOO!!! Veth shrieked out loud.

—the face that stares out from within the helmet is blacker than the armor, the eyes bottomless pits over a smile of obsidian shards.

They are Vetala and Zhe-La, no longer Champion of the Light—be it the true Light or the pretense of Archon Lethe's Light. They are unadulterated malice, and their only purpose is to spread evil, from one victim to another, feeding for countless eons until the very light of the dies—but even then—they will continue, haunting the vast darkness of space, eternally damned—

Veth finds themselves trapped in this vision of torment, unable to escape themselves as a Vetala Champion and fully conscious of their plight. They scream up at the countless stars in the sky—but with no tongue—it comes out as a horse wail. There is no answer from the cold twinkling diamonds in the sky—they are pitiless, much like the black heart that no longer beats in their chest.

With a final surge of desperation, Veth the Vetala opens their mouth to scream, hoping that someone, however far away, can hear their plea.

"Suuu-whonnnn elllppp muuuhhh!!!"

* * *

Shen opened his eyes as he was pulled from sleep's embrace; fighting in the resistance against his father's rule had given him a preternatural sense of his surroundings—right way—he knew something was wrong. Giving the cell a brief survey, his eyes found Veth still laying on their bed nearby. In the weak light provided by the opening above, Shen watched as they shifted slightly before curling up into a ball—drawing into themselves tightly—as if in protection from an outside incursion. Concerned now, Shen left his bed, moving silently to kneel next to the other;

he was momentarily taken aback as Veth bared their dangerous fangs, but this passed as Veth let out a sigh, relaxing their body.

Just as Shen thought they were falling back into a restful sleep—Veth jerked—as if recoiling from something offensive. This behavior intensified as a low whine escaped Veth's lips, slowly building in volume and into a keening howl.

Shen had never heard anything like it; the eerie tone made the hairs on the back of his neck stand on end. If it were anyone else, the sound would have made them back away from Veth—but not Shen—not someone who grew up in the realm of Night. Veth's cry beckoned to him; it was unmistakable in its nature—a cry for help from someone who felt completely lost and alone. Shen knew it, for he had made a very similar plea many times, and he leaped up, grasping Veth by the upper arms to shake them.

"Veth, wake up! It's just a nightmare!" He shouted.

At first, Veth lay limp in his grasp, but after more vigorous shaking, they stiffened as their silver eyes opened—wide with surprise. Hands shot out as Veth seized Shen by the wrists, their claws biting the flesh below his jacket sleeves, making him wince in pain. When they let go of him, Shen backed away as he tied to stem the bleeding; Veth had gotten good, and the flow was profuse—red runnels dripped between clenched fingers.

"Wha—what are you doing, Human?" Veth stammered, still shaking off the effects of the nightmare.

"You were having some horrible dream," Shen said as he tried and failed to squeeze both his bleeding wrists simultaneously. "Apparently, it was a bad idea."

Alarm lit up Veth's face when they spotted the crimson covering Shen's forearms—this changed to dismay when they realized the cause.

"I cut you?" They asked, clearly upset. "Come here quickly,"

Veth indicated the spot on the bed next to them, but Shen shook his head as he backed away.

"It's not anything, Veth. I'll deal with—AH!"

As quick as a thought, Veth gently seized Shen again, pulling him down onto the bed next to them.

"Foolish, Human!" Veth admonished as they pushed his sleeves up. "I'm getting rather tired of your self-deprecation—it borders on self-loathing sometimes!"

Shen stared in wonder at Veth, his mouth partly open in incredulity.

"And don't shrug at me again!" Veth continued. "I swear if you do it again, I'll—"

Veth's words died in their mouth as their eyes glinted—turning down to Shen's writs.

"Bah!" Veth hissed as they reached down to their inner thigh, removing one of the black bands that comprised their pants. Shen spied lilac skin in the missing section—then, just like a Jaadoo suit—the black bands shifted, covering the breach and sealing the pants back up.

Veth promptly wrapped the material over the injury on Shen's left wrist, rubbing it firmly to fasten it in place. Once finished, they repeated the process on the other wrist, leaving Shen with a sense of Deja-vu as the pain was slowly replaced by warmth.

"This is the second time someone has done this for me," Shen said absentmindedly.

Veth frowned at him; head tilted in doubt.

"Not by a Nephraeh, mind you!" He explained with a chuckle. "My friend—Catra. She took pieces of her Jaadoo suit and patched me up just like you did."

Veth nodded at this. “Yes, there is a lot of history between Madgēcots and Nephraeh. Before the coming of Horde Prime, much of our culture was intertwined—they got the idea for their Jaadoo suits from our Aegis Lace,”

Veth indicated their pants before a thoughtful expression passed over their face.

“Although it could have been the other way around, much of what I think is truth has turned out to be a lie,” they said with a dismissive shrug before catching themselves.

“I think I have been spending too much time with you—I’m picking up all of your bad mannerisms,” they said, eyes twinkling. Shen was about to do it again but caught himself.

“You know…” Veth started to say before dying off. Shen noticed their silver eyes dancing in his direction, looking without looking at who he was. Shen began to feel discomfort as he realized what they were doing.

“I’m a little afraid to ask, but are you looking into me again?” He asked with some trepidation.

Veth let out a snort of derision. “*Looking into you?* No, your soul is not *in* you; it’s—never mind,” they said, waving a hand. “I thought I saw something when you mentioned Catra’s name; it was almost like…”

Shen felt his face burn as he right away realized what Veth had seen.

“Ah!!!” Veth exclaimed, eyes going wide. “Now I see it!”

A broad toothy grin spreads across Veth’s lilac features; it was the biggest smile Shen had witnessed on the Nephraeh.

“You are in love with Catra!” They exclaimed. “As you are probably aware, I know her, and I can see why you would be attracted to her. Although I think it might be misplaced…”

“Yes, yes. I don’t want to talk about it,” Shen said with some irritation, but Veth wasn’t finished with their fun.

“*So!* You are going around falling in love with beautiful women who can’t love you back and kissing Nephraeh when they least expect it—you really are something else Human!” Veth said, laughing openly now.

Shen felt his annoyance fade as a grin slowly appeared on his face.

“You’re missing the part where said woman’s brother and I had a brief fling,” he said ruefully.

Veth’s eyes brows shot up as their appraising inspection took on a more appreciative aspect.

“Yes, I met Viraj. He is very handsome,” they said with open admiration. Shen frowned as he cocked his head in confusion.

“I take that back,” Veth amended. “I wouldn’t say you are something else, but…”

Their voice trailed off into a point of obscurity as their face became unreadable; mirror-like eyes searched Shen, making him shift in place. They were doing it again, looking into his soul in that strange way of theirs, giving nothing away as he was bared fully naked before them.

“Are you going to leave me in suspense?” Shen coaxed.

Veth seemed to snap back into themselves at his words, absentmindedly running clawed fingers through sleek black hair.

“Interesting.” They said finally. “You are very interesting.”

After a moment of awkward silence, Veth shook their head before changing the subject.

"Anyway, let's get back to where we were before I lost consciousness."

Shen quickly stood up, eager to be out of the Nephraeh's proximity; their intoxicating presence was starting to take hold of him, as was their alluring scent.

"Yes!" He said, nodding his head a little too enthusiastically. "Let's get back to escaping this place!"

Shen placed himself directly under the opening in the ceiling, smiling and pointing upwards as Veth regarded him quizzically, noticing but not commenting on his sudden nervousness. They lifted smoothly from the bed, striding over to stand next to Shen without taking their eyes off him. Finally, to Shen's relief, they did look away—up to the crisscrossed bars blocking their escape.

"I had just placed the tips of my claws against those bars when I felt something react to the magic within me," Veth said, pointing at the offending gate. "Not sure if you can spot it, but there is an arcane ward placed upon them,"

Shen scanned where they were pointing, again seeing the bluish tint to the metal of the bars. Squinting, he noticed that it was not just an alloying or tinting but an active effect; a subtle fluctuation that was barely discernable.

"I can see it," Shen said.

"*Well… will wonders never cease*," Veth snarked. Shen shook his head, barely able to contain the smile spreading across his face as the other continued. "It's pretty strong magic, too; everything just went black."

"Lucky there was a human around to catch you," Shen commented.

This time the look Veth gave Shen was readable; it was gratitude.

“Yes, I didn’t get a chance to thank you for that, Human,” they said sincerely.

“Well…” Shen stammered. “I guess the mild skin lacerations will have to do,”

Veth eyed him momentarily before looking back up at their only exit.

“Since you are human and not half magical—do you want to give it a shot this time? Since you are cut off from your He-Man power, I doubt that would have any effect either,” Veth said.

Shen mused on this for a moment before beginning to shrug his shoulders—then abruptly stopped the gesture as Veth looked at him wearily. He smiled sheepishly as he nodded his assent.

Veth held their hands out to him, palms up and fingers spread—the gesture momentarily striking Shen as he tentatively reached out, taking their hands into his. Veth gently pulled him towards them, proffering a bent leg for him to step on; as he did, Veth suddenly began to pull Shen up—he hesitated. Veth regarded him questioningly before seeming to realize what the problem was.

“It’s okay—*I’ve got you*,” they said reassuringly.


HENARTORINOS'23

Wanting to hide the rising blush, Shen fell into step with Veth's intention; they guided him up and onto their shoulders. As Shen felt clawed hands around his ankles, Veth steadied him with their natural Nephraeh grace, allowing him to stand straight. Peering up, Shen could study the bars much closer and hear a low hum emanating from the mystical wards.

"Can you reach it?" Veth asked from below.

"I think so," Shen responded, extending his arm upwards.

"Be careful!" Veth warned.

Shen smiled to himself, hearing the genuine concern in the Nephraeh's voice—then, without further hesitation, he grasped them fully, wrapping his fingers around the bars.

There was no response, only cold metal.

Shen let out the breath he had been holding to glance down at Veth; they observed him from the gloom, eyes shining like a predator.

"Looks like it doesn't affect me!" he said.

"Yes, I have eyes and can see that," they responded.

Shen chuckled at their response, not at all surprised by it.

"Come now, Veth. You have to admit you were worried about me," he said.

The gleaming eyes vanished as Veth glanced away, snorting in derision.

"Only worried that a clumsy human would fall on my head," they answered.

Shen returned his attention to the bars, testing the integrity of their joining to the surrounding stone. One would not budge, but

the other wriggled slightly, the casement starting to fracture around it. If he could remove the unsecured bar, it would give him enough room to wriggle through—and if he could get through—then Veth could as well.

"Looks like I can get this bar out, grrrr…" Shen growled as he yanked at it.

Just as it appeared as if he were about to free the bar, a metallic banging was heard in the distance beyond the opening—

—and it was getting closer.

"Shen! I've heard that before—get down!" Veth hissed.

Shen felt the Nephraeh shifting, getting ready to bring him down—he immediately pulled himself out of their reach, hanging from the bars to continue yanking, using his body weight as leverage.

"You idiot! You're going to get hurt!" Veth cursed up at him. Shen ignored them, focusing on his task as resonating clatter—footsteps—got closer. He was so close; one end of the bar was now free, and the other not far behind. All he had to do was—

Shen's eyes went wide as a figure came into view on the other side of the gate; it was huge—about as big as a Champion—and staring down at him with lidless, red-rimmed eyes. It was a sight of true horror—something Shen had only seen come out of the Death Binder laboratories beneath his father's palace.

A crystalline shell encased what appeared to be a skinless corpse; in its right hand was an ancient sword welded to its palm with crystal. In the other was what looked like a hook—it jabbed outward with the appendage as the creature moved with a cumbersome gait, its face twisted in a mask of unknowable pain as a lipless mouth opened to speak.

"**You must not escape!**" It said in a mechanical voice, raising a foot to stomp down on Shen's hands.

“AGGGHHH!!!” Shen cried, letting go of the gate just in time to hear the crunch of a heavy foot where his fingers once had been; he fell a short distance before hitting something soft.

“OOF!!” Veth wheezed.

Shen found himself in Veth’s lap, the Nephraeh having fallen on their rear, stopping his fall. Cradled in their arms, Shen expected to see wrath on Veth’s face—but they were not looking at him—instead gazing up at the creature peering down at them through the bars of their prison.

Reaching down with its hook hand, the creature pulled the loose bar up to bend it around one of its more anchored fellows. Once finished, it tested the integrity of the repair, letting out a wheeze of satisfaction when it did not budge. Its job now complete, the creature turned away, stomping off into the distance. Veth’s eyes met Shen’s as the two shared their mutual shock at what had just happened.

“What the heck was that?” Shen asked.

“I think we just met Wun-Dar,” Veth responded, breathlessly.

* * *

Veth sighed heavily, placing their head against the wall as they rested upon their bed; the stone was cool and felt good but did nothing to alleviate the heat of their body. The intense passion that had started only a few days ago was still there, wearing at their thoughts, but it was more manageable now—like background noise.

Well, maybe not that subtle—more like a hot itch they could not scratch—but it was something they could find a sort of harmony with, at least for the time being.

Since the encounter with the horror that was Wun-Dar, both Shen and Veth had decided to take a break from escape attempts—at least for the time being. Veth wanted to spend their time wisely

and concentrate, trying to solve the puzzle of their current situation and escape this foolish prison. But they could not focus; there was just too much tumbling in their head, too much that was new but also old—sadness mixed with pain.

Their thoughts kept steering them back to the vision-dream Shen had awoken them from—the strange voice had been there, the same one that seemed to be guiding them through recollections of old memories. Veth was in tune with their body and knew this voice was not some manifestation of their inner self—it was completely separate—an outside presence influencing Veth.

But to what end? It had helped them behold their original self—full of compassion with an eye towards beauty—it fit perfectly with the person they were becoming. To know that they were developing into the person they were supposed to be was a true gift—but Veth was shrewd enough to know that such things did not come without a cost.

The unknown voice was very open about that fact, stating that reciprocation was expected. Veth understood this favor had to be tied to the horrible vision—the depraved person with so much blood on their hands. Based on what Veth now knew of their people's ancient history, it had been a Nephraeh—back when their people still had white skin instead of lilac. They sensed this individual was tied to Zhe-La as well; they were in a temple devoted to the Champion of Empyrea.

Were they, in fact, a bearer of the Zhe-La Avatar? Veth could not imagine such a thing was possible; Zhe-La would not bind to a cold-blooded murderer.

Veth felt a chill as they remembered inhabiting that cruel Nephraeh; they thought that they had lived much of their life without compassion, but after sharing sensations with that other, Veth realized that—until then—they did not know what it was to truly live without pity. Empathy had always been there with them, seeping to the surface to be taken by Archon Lethe.

But the other—they did not have that well of empathy; it may have existed once, but it had been… *lost*… or *forgotten*, like a dream you knew you once had but could not recollect, the memory of it escaping as soon as you reached for it. Like trying to hold smoke.

A loud sigh brought Veth's attention from within themselves and back into the cell; glancing over, they spotted Shen on his own bed, laying on his back to stare at the ceiling. Based on the flow of his quintessence, he was also lost in revelries as he attempted to stave off boredom.

Veth looked away from him as the guilt returned—it was happening more and more in the human's presence, tied to their growing regard for him. It was perhaps two months ago that they had been with Nefeli, and now they were dead, and here Veth was with their killer.

But was that true? Hadn't they always been with Nefeli's killer, seeing them every time Veth looked in the mirror? From what they knew of Shen, he was controlling the Eye of Hate's influence during their fight, right up until Veth used the power of Oblivion on him. Shen would have never fought with an ounce of the intensity he had after they had removed his inhibitions, nor would he have killed so casually.

Nefeli would still be alive if not for what Veth did, but could Veth put all the blame on themselves? Perhaps they could, now that they knew they had some empathy the whole time they fought for Archon Lethe. How could they not have seen how evil the power of Oblivion was?

A grief-stricken gasp escaped Veth's throat which they tried to conceal by covering their mouth. But it was too late; the tears fell from their eyes as wracking waves of anguish passed over them. Even if they had so much returned to them, it was as if much more had already been lost—it was overwhelming.

Hearing Shen get up from his bed, Veth gritted their teeth as they heard him come over. They quickly placed one hand over their eyes in a lame attempt to hide the tears.

"Everything is fine, Human—go away!" Veth snapped.

They did not need their sensitive hearing to pick up the soft rustle of Shen sitting at their bedside, nor did they need either of their sights to know he would be expressing concern.

"I can't go away, Veth. I'm locked in a cell with you," Shen answered.

Veth had to laugh at this; he had a point. Lowering their hand from their eyes, Veth found that Shen looked at them just as they suspected—although with a sad smile.

"Do you want to talk about it?" he asked.

Veth was about to reply in the negative, but something about the way his quintessence was arrayed made them decide otherwise.

"Sure—why not," they said. "Do you know what it's like to realize that you are responsible for the death of the one you loved? That by your actions, you might as well have been the one to kill them with your own hands?"

Without even batting an eye, Shen nodded, the smile fading from his lips as the sadness remained.

"Yes, I do," Shen responded. "Although, for me, I *did* kill him with my bare hands,"

Upon having their attempt to shock the human with their admission abruptly reversed, Veth gaped opened-mouthed. They watched as Shen leaned against their bed, his eyes taking on the distant look of one lost in painful memories.

"My father was the absolute ruler of my planet—the Shen'Aan-war he was called—or Dark He-Man as he is known in this galaxy. He

was a cruel leader and an even crueler father—I hated him so much, and I was not alone; there was an active rebellion against him, fighting from the shadows. I joined them when I met someone special—Shen'Dara, was his name. He was my first true love."

"We fought in secret for a while, and it was the first time I could say I was happy. But it did not last—of course—and we were betrayed. My father's minions came to our secret hideout one night while most of us were asleep. I stayed back to hold them off so the others could escape, thinking that out of everyone there, I would receive the least punishment based on my status as Prince. Boy, was I wrong,"

"I was captured and taken before my father—there, I expected censure or banishment. But my father did not hesitate when he told his corpse magicians to take me into the castle dungeons. There they did something worse than death—they cut out my heart and replaced it with another's—a demon I was now bound to."

"That's horrible! They used Death Magic on you!" Veth exclaimed, interrupting Shen's tale.

"Yes—I'm surprised you are familiar with it. The Death Binders were only in this universe a short time before their source of power—the Set'Heth-un'dar— was destroyed." Shen said.

Veth shook their head. "No, there are still Death Binders. Before we became entangled with the Madgēcots, I was working with our Knosis agents on tracking down a cabal of Death Binders somewhere near Thenlor,"

Veth noticed the astonishment on Shen's face at this revelation—which quickly turned to anger. Veth reached out and gently brushed their claws along his arm, bringing his attention back.

"I'm sorry I interrupted you. Please continue." They said. Shen glanced at his arm before resuming his tale.

“What happened next was the absolute worst time of my life. The demon—or the Other as I called it—could take control of my body, turning me into a monster called the Demon Heart. I could keep the Other at bay by wrapping it up with good memories, but emotions like anger and fear could release it almost instantaneously. The Death Binders were good at this, forcing these emotions in me to make me change whenever my father needed an assassin.”

“That was how I was used; I would be pulled from my cell and sent out as the Demon Heart to hunt down rebels—my friends. One by one, the Demon Heart killed them as I watched through my own eyes until only Shen'Dara was left. He fought me the fiercest—not to kill me—but to save me from what I had become. He died with my hands around his throat and the Other’s taunts in my head.”

“When we were in that room full of darkness, it was the Other’s voice I had heard; I thought it was coming for me, to reclaim me as its vessel. That’s why I acted as I did,”

Shen wiped his eyes; they were now full of tears, matching their own. Veth was struck with an overwhelming need to draw Shen in, to wrap their arms around him and hold him, just as they did in the Chamber of Disquietude. But they just couldn’t do that—they mustn’t—instead, they offered solace through words.

“I’m so sorry for what happened to you… Shen, truly I am. I had no idea that you went through all that. But you know you didn’t kill Shen’Dara, right? It was the Other—this Demon Heart.” Veth said.

Shen let out a bitter laugh. “Yeah, I understand that. It’s just hard to differentiate when I saw the whole thing take place through my own eyes—but I appreciate your words, even though I don’t deserve them. After all, not only did I kill my love, I killed yo—“Adora said.

The words seized in Shen's throat as he looked away, too embarrassed or ashamed to finish. Not only had he endured great heartbreak and hopelessness, but Veth knew they had added to the tally of his pain; killing Nefeli weighed heavily on the human, and there was only so much suffering one person could handle. They had to take it from him.

Veth lay down on their side, resting their head on one of their arms to bring their eyes level with Shen's. He turned to them, mild confusion on his tear-streaked face as he found the Nephraeh gazing at him.

"You didn't kill Nefeli, Shen—I did," they began. "When we fought on Enos, I had an advantage over you—a power given to me by Archon Lethe called Oblivion. It has many uses, but the primary is the ability to remove someone's empathy temporarily. I know now that you were trying to control the effects of the Eye of Hate while you battled me, but I mistook it for an opportunity to overwhelm you. When I used that power on you, I took away any vestiges of control you may have had, and you transformed into something else. It wasn't *you,* Shen—that wasn't *your* fault. *It was mine.*"

Veth found the words getting stuck as a well of emotion fought to break free—the sorrow was overwhelming. Just as they thought it would pull them down into despair, a warm hand clasped theirs—with a jolt—Veth realized it was Shen's. He was looking at them with the very same emotion that they had once taken from him; it was plain in both his physical and spiritual expressions. Just as they had seen him do before, Shen was summoning pure Light into his quintessence—a form of self-comfort that he was now using on them. In awe, Veth observed the Light move from him and into them through their point of connection, buoying them in their sea of misery.

"Can you still use that power—this Oblivion power?" Shen asked.

Veth shook their head vehemently. "No, but if I could—I wouldn't. Now that I had my compassion returned, I could not imagine an eviler power."

Shen nodded; it was the answer he had been expecting.

“Well, then I would say that the Veth who did that to me isn’t the same Veth who is with me now—you are not the one who killed Nefeli,” he said.

Veth screwed up their face as they thought of this; Shen was stretching the logic thin, but the gratitude they felt was immeasurable, and they gave his hand a gentle squeeze in thanks.

This human is really growing on me, Veth thought, beaming at Shen.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration was done by Henar Torinis, a.k.a., ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram!

Return of the Light

Chapter Summary

Scorpia infiltrates the Timeless Dimension, seeking Wun-Dar.

Orko gives Shen and Veth an important clue.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The silent room had been locked for many years and mostly forgotten—except by a few—the ones who knew of this secret place they had used to come to their hidden place. Once secure in this sanctuary yet still fearing pursuit, these pioneers had then sealed this room away—like a tomb.

The chamber's only occupant—a great stone ring suspended from the ceiling by four chains—was absolutely still, the energy of any kinetic motion having been used up a thousand years ago. Dust accumulated from such a long span of time had formed into a hard shell around the ring and chains, like a gray candy coating—yet suddenly, it began to shift—breaking up in desiccated chucks that fell away to the ground.

This would have seemed inexplicable to the casual observer, for the stone ring did not move, nor did the chains rattle. But someone with more sensitive hearing—like a Madgēcot or Nephraeh—would have heard the micro-vibration as the ring powered up; it was being called upon to activate, the signal coming from a place beyond that of this reality. Soon, a tone could be perceived, steadily increasing in volume as a shimmering appeared at the ring's center—like a heat haze rising from a hot desert—which then burst outward like an eruption, only to settle back within the confines of the ring.

Where once there was empty space, there was now a shimmering silver surface—like a pond made of mercury. It was a portal, an

interdimensional gateway that bridged the unsubstantial gulf between this dimension to another.

A red pincer emerged through this aperture; it probed in the air as a large woman garbed in a skintight outfit of black bands followed behind, her eyes squeezed shut as she entered this new realm. Opening her eyes, she turned a head topped by a shock of white hair, a look of awe transforming into disappointment as she took in the room lit by the activated portal.

"Am I in some kind of closet?" Scorpia asked aloud.

When no one answered, Scorpia rummaged through the satchel Mermista had given her, removing a vial containing flecks of red particles suspended in a clear fluid. She shook it vigorously before holding it aloft between the tips of two pincers; watching closely, Scorpia made out movement within. The red specks began to coalesce in a single mass which formed into a shape—a single arrow pointing in one direction. Examining the indicated bearing, she spotted a door comprised of thick wooden planks bundled together by heavy metal bands. Tentatively testing the handle, Scorpia found that it would not budge, even with her formidable strength behind the attempt. She backed away, nodding to herself.

"Hard way it is, eh?" Scorpia said, aiming the Void Gem at the obstruction. As silent as a whisper, a beam of pure obsidian poured out of the red gem, striking against the door like black ink, bathing it in the power of the Void. Once fully covered, the enchantment imploded, leaving a fissure where once an indomitable door stood.

Exiting the room, Scorpia found herself in a long hallway that disappeared around curved bends in either direction. Looking at the vial and the orientation of the indicator, Scorpia went left, following the corridor which hopefully led to her quarry.

Wun-Dar.

* * *

“How bad is it?”

Shen glanced down at Veth before resuming his inspection of the bars blocking their escape; he was again perched on their shoulders, yanking at the bar he had almost pried loose as the Nephraeh compensated for his abrupt movements. Shen growled and cursed at the stubborn metal, but no matter how hard he tried, it would not budge.

“I can’t move it. Wun-Dar did a good job of reinforcing it with the bars next to it. Without the power of He-Man, I cannot move it,” Shen responded.

Veth pursed their lips, not liking the answer. “Can you find another one that is loose? I mean, this is the only option we have to us. We have to keep trying,”

“Yeah, okay,” Shen said, sounding unsure. “How are you doing down there? I can’t imagine your shoulders are feeling very good with me standing on them,”

Veth would have shrugged but instead tossed their head, trying to get strands of black hair out of their face.

“I am fine,” they lied—their shoulders were hurting immensely. “Although I appreciate your concern—I think we need to keep at it,”

Veth heard Shen sigh audibly. “You’re not a very good liar, *Nephraeh*,”

This made them look down, mainly so Shen would not see the smile on their face.

“Well, this isn’t something I’m proud of, but I tricked all the Madgēcots into believing I meant them no harm, so I must not be that bad at it. I guess it just doesn’t work on humans.” They said sheepishly.

“No,” Shen responded before giving one of the bars a tug. “It just doesn't work on those who are actually paying attention to you. Not that I’m paying too much attention—”

Veth knew Shen was blushing when the human abruptly cut off midsentence; they tried to peer up to see his face, but the angle was not right, and the expression was out of view. Instead, Veth took in Shen’s quintessence, seeing the embarrassment plain there; there was a certain beauty to it, the bruising of the ethereal emotion against a backdrop of his affectionate feelings for them. Veth knew that when it came to this second sight, there was no single point of perspective—if they wanted to—they could survey their own ethereal essence simultaneously as his. But they resisted doing this, not sure they wanted to compare their pattern to Shen’s; they did not want to see—

“Wait!” Shen called, abruptly drawing Veth out of themselves. “I think I got a loose one… grrrr…”

As Veth concentrated on balancing Shen, a curious sensation caught a whisper of their awareness. It was an impending advance tickling their belly; immediately, Veth knew someone was coming—not by physical means—but magical.

“Shen! Listen to me this time! Someone is com—"

A sound like popping eardrums cut off their words as a floating figure appeared abruptly before Veth.

“Greetings!” Orko cried.

“Agh!” Veth screamed, momentarily loosening their hold on Shen.

“Veth!” he yelled, toppling backward.

As quick as a thought, Veth positioned themselves to catch the falling Shen; but as it turned out, they didn’t have to.

“Magic wand, by my control; halt this plunging soul!” Orko exclaimed, directing a wand at the falling human and stopping

him in midair. Shen waved his arms helplessly as strands of dark hair drifted around his head, appearing to Veth as if he were underwater.

"Ugh, thanks. Mind getting me down now?" Shen asked, waving his arms.

"*Magic wand, cease this tether; make him land as light as a feather!"* Orko commanded.

Slowly, Shen began to descend, coming to a rest in Veth's outstretched arms.

"Oh, you needn't do that! I would have brought him all the way to the ground," Orko commented.

Veth found Shen looking at them with confusion as they realized what they had just done—quickly—they set him down, waving away the gesture behind a wall of indifference.

"Oh, well, from what I've seen of Trollan magic, you can't blame me for not wanting to take risks," Veth said, putting as much spite into their response as possible.

Orko jerked back as if stung, their long blue ears drooping at the vehemence in Veth's words, yet they were not finished with their diatribe.

"Why are you here anyway? I have not seen hide nor hair of any of you idiot Trollans since you lock us in here! And now you show up? Why?" Veth snapped. From the corner of their eye, they could see Shen staring at them. Turning slightly, Veth noticed he was grinning, instantly making them want to slap him.

"I was sent to check on you two! That's all!" Orko responded.

"Veth is right, Orko. We have been locked up in here for at least a couple of days now; besides water and dried bread magically appearing, no one has bothered to come and explain what you are going to do with us." Shen added.

"I am so sorry about what happened in the Council Chamber, truly I am!" Orko squeaked. "But the others decided to keep you in here for you to cool down—mainly, you—" Orko said, pointing at Veth. "After that, you will have your chance to submit a formal apology,"

Veth gaped open-mouthed at this, speechless at the hubris of the Crimson Council.

"A what?!" They bit out.

"Okay, okay," Shen interrupted. "Let's hold on there, Orko. Before we talk about any apology—"

"Which isn't going to happen!" Veth hissed.

"—*Before* we talk about that," Shen said, giving Veth a meaningful look. "How about you give us a little something, huh? So far, we have been very cooperative, right Veth?"

Veth responded by crossing their arms and staring silver daggers at the bobbing Trollan. He held up his hands in placation.

"What do you want to know, my friends? Just ask!" He said cheerily.

"Okay, for starters, what is that thing that attacked us in the Crimson Council chamber? Was that a Champion named Wun-Dar? We also saw it recently, when—uhhh—when we were—ummm—hanging out in here." Shen said, stammering his last words.

Veth remembered the sight of the creature gaping down at them through the cell's exit—a gore-streaked face encased in a skin of crystal. The horror of its exterior was exceeded only by what Veth had seen with their other sight; a bound quintessence screaming in ectoplasmic agony as ethereal lashes drove it to do another's bidding. It was of the foulest magic and utterly abhorrent to Veth; the fact that the Trollans were responsible spoke volumes to the magnitude of danger they and Shen were in.

“Do you think I’m a total numbskull and didn’t hear the nervousness in your voice?” Orko said before mimicking Shen’s voice. “*When—uhhh—when we were—ummm*. I know what you two were doing in here!”

Orko winked at Shen, their meaning obvious and totally catching Veth off-guard; this Trollan had a scandalous imagination. Veth shook their head in disbelief.

“How about you keep your perverse fantasies to yourself and answer the question!” Veth snapped, holding a clawed hand out threateningly to Orko.

“Okay! Geez, I was only kidding…” Orko said, sullen. “Yes, you are right; that was Wun-Dar. They are in service to the Crimson Council and have been for almost a thousand years now,”

Veth scoffed at this answer. “In service? You’ve got to be kidding me. You Trollans used dark sorcery to create a golem out of the last bearer of Wun-Dar—I saw it with my own eyes!”

Orko appeared perplexed by this—as much as a being whose face was hidden could express the emotion—scratching at one of his pointy ears while squinting at the Nephraeh.

“I don’t understand; you keep saying we use bad magic. It’s the same kind of magic we have used since I was born.” He said.

Veth’s ire subsided as a sense of understanding overcame them; they already knew this story.

“Yes, Orko, I know. I had used a power I thought was righteous all my life as well—only recently finding out it was evil. Your people fled to this dimension to escape Horde Prime, but that wasn’t enough, and you let your fear control you. Knowing that Horde Prime’s weakness was magic, the Trollans must have turned to the most powerful magic they could harness—Dark Magic. I’m sure Wun-Dar had come to this dimension seeking sanctuary, only to find the Trollans a different race than they last remembered.

Wun-Dar was probably killed in your Corporeal Sieve, and your Crimson Council resurrected them as a golem."

Orko's eyes widened at this description, it seemed the Trollan had never imagined such a thing, and he slowly backed away in consternation.

"No…" He whispered, shaking his head.

"I cannot show you what I have seen with my other sight, but it's the most logical conclusion, Orko!" Veth beseeched.

The Trollan lowered his head as he processed the recent events in his mind; after a moment, he groaned.

"I believe you," he said finally.

Veth and Shen shared a look, surprised that Orko was convinced so easily.

"Not that I'm not thankful, but I didn't think I was that persuasive," Veth said. "You must already have had an inkling of the truth already."

Orko nodded sadly. "I may be part of the Crimson Council, but they keep many things from me. I was told they are keeping you here to cool off, but they have sequestered themselves in the Malum Maleficarum for some time now. I think they are preparing for a powerful ritual,"

"Excuse me? The what?" Shen asked, eyebrows raised.

"Malum Maleficarum, he said." Veth interjected. "Sounds like a place to do evil things—like turning two captured Champions into golem slaves!"

"NO!!!" Shen shouted, surprising Veth. "Not again! I would rather die—here and now!"

Veth didn’t need to see the human’s quintessence to know he was highly agitated and afraid; they knew the cause—his experience with this Other and being turned into an assassin against his will. Veth believed Shen’s words and, without thinking, placed a hand on his shoulder, giving it a gentle squeeze.

“I won’t let that happen, Shen—trust me. We are getting out of here,” Veth said with a smile.

Their sentiments had an immediate effect on Shen; the wild panic in his eye subsided as he forced a smile.

“Okay,” he said, breathing slowly and turning to the Trollan. “Orko, you must help us escape. Please,”

Orko started wringing his blue hands as he cast furtively between the Human and Nephraeh, seeming at a loss as to what he would do.

“I want to—really! But I just can’t betray my people outright. Ohhhh…!” Orko whined.

Veth gritted their teeth as they stopped themselves from reaching out and grabbing the obtuse Trollan—instead, they waited, using patience instead of force. Hopefully, Orko came to the right decision on his own.

“Okay,” he said finally, holding up his hands. “I will not help you directly, but I will leave you both with this clue; in it lies the key to your escape. You ready?”

Veth and Shen shared a look before speaking simultaneously.

“*Just tell us, Orko!*”

The Trollan cleared his throat as he closed his eyes, placing his hands behind his back.

“Remember…there is no time in the Timeless Dimension; linear concepts have no meaning here. Sometimes you must go

backward to move forward!”

Shen and Veth stared expectantly at the Trollan, who gazed back innocently.

“Okay!” That’s it! I wish you luck!” Orko said, and with a snap of his blue fingers, vanished into thin air.

Shen turned to Veth, his expression blank.

“We are so screwed,” he said.

* * *

Scorpia was alert as she tiptoed up the winding staircase, listening for any signs her presence was detected. Not hearing a whisper of movement, Scorpia was filled with a strange unease as a thought came unbidden—that the entire building she occupied was a tomb, and the only things there were the memories of the dead. Pushing this grim notion from her mind, Scorpia glanced down at the vial held delicately between two pincers; the red arrow was still there, pointing upward in the direction she was heading.

At the top of the stairs was a hallway shorter than the one she left below; based on the ornamentation and stature of the corridor, Scorpia assumed it to be a vestibule for an important room. There were only two doors along this passageway, each facing the other; picking the one favored by the vial guiding her, Scorpia pushed the double doors open to find that her earlier assertion was correct.

A sepulchral chamber greeted Scorpia, the center of which nine pedestals sat in a row, each one circular and the color of bone. Looking closer at these platforms, Scorpia noted that they were composed of many interlocking skeletal hands, each gripping the other in a macabre chain. On a plinth at the rear of the chamber sat a hideous beating heart—with each visceral pulse, the disembodied organ belched ghostly black smoke from each of arteries, covering the floor in a stygian carpet of mist.

“What the heck…” Scorpia whispered to herself, then gasped as she spotted what she had come for.

Tucked away in a dark corner was a large figure; it stirred within the deep shadows, moving towards Scorpia with sharp footsteps.

“Who dares intrude into the chamber of the Crimson Counsel?” It asked in a hard, metallic-sounding voice.

What appeared out of the gloom was a nightmare; standing a head taller than her, Scorpia found herself face-to-face with Wun-Dar.

She screamed.

* * *

“So maybe it’s literal—like we have actually to walk backward?” Shen offered.

Veth rolled their eyes at him but decided not to voice the nasty rebuke that popped into their mind.

“How would we walk backward through a hole in the ceiling?” They responded.

“Well, Trollans float, right? It wouldn’t be a problem for them,” Shen added.

Veth pursed their lips as they considered this; the human’s logic made sense, but for some reason, they doubted Orko would give them a hint they could not use.

“I don’t think so; he said linear concepts, so maybe it’s arcane in nature,” Veth said before rejecting that as well. “No, that’s not it; neither of us is a sorcerer, and we have no access to our Champion Avatars,”

Shen tilted his head suddenly as he considered what Veth had just said.

“What is it?” They asked expectantly.

“Back in the Crimson Council chamber, right before Wun-Dar attacked us, it said something that sounded like gibberish,” he said slowly.

“Lluksyarg fo modsiw eht yb?” Veth said perfectly.

“Yes! That’s right!” Shen said, beaming. “I’m impressed that you not only remembered that but were able to pronounce it!”

Veth shrugged—they had been doing it a lot lately.

“Chalk it up to being a perfect Nephraeh,” they said with such insouciance that Shen laughed.

“Do you think that is what Wun-Dar says to transform into a Champion? Only spoken backward?” Shen asked.

As soon as he said it, Veth knew he was right, and they leaped forward to seize Shen by the shoulders.

“You genius Human!” They cried. “You figure it out! I could ki—”

Veth’s words died in their throat as they realized what they were about to say. Shen watched them expectantly.

“Kill me?” he offered innocently.

Veth squinted at him as they fought the urge to smile.

“Maybe—if you are not careful,” they said without an ounce of malice in their words. “Anyway, you’re right! Wun-Dar was saying, *By the wisdom of Grayskull*—only backward!”

Right away, Shen tried the activation words for He-Man as Veth winced; he wasn’t even close.

“Try again,” they coaxed.

"*Lucks-yarg foe re-wop eh yub!*" He shouted as Veth bent over, hugging themselves with laughter.

"I'm so sorry!" They said in between giggles. "That was just too funny!"

"You try then!" Shen huffed, crossing his arms.

With two elegant strides, Veth backed away from Shen to rhhhh for the ceiling, hand partly opened.

"LLUKSYARG FO THGIL EHT YB!!!" They shouted, instantly feeling their connection to Zhe-La established. Veth was unsurprised when instead of a blazing indigo star blazing from their chest, pure Light appeared, bathing the cramped cell in incandescent luminosity. Shen cringed at the intensity of the Light, but when he returned his attention to them, he gaped—more than just awe on his face.

Zhe-La/Veth took in their vastly different Champion form; where once black Aegis Lace and body armor covered them, now it was almost pure white—gleaming with the radiance of the most magnificent diamonds. Their black sword was also transformed; no longer did the power of Oblivion radiate out from its blade, but fierce Light, like a beacon of hope.

"Wow," Shen breathed. "You look so amazing…"

Zhe-La/Veth turned to Shen, favoring him with a beaming smile.

"You ready to get out of here?" They asked.


Iria Abella 2023

“Yes! Absolutely!” He exclaimed before trying to summon He-Man again.

“*Lucky-rg fo ree-op ey ub! Luc-gah for roopp eh yeeb!”*

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head in impatience.

“No time to wait for you to get your mouth around the words—we go now!” They said, reaching for him with clawed gauntlets.

“No wai—aahhh!” Shen cried as he was picked up and thrown over one armored shoulder.

“Veth! Put me down!” Shen protested as they gripped him tightly.

“Hush now, you’re just going for a little ride,” Zhe-La/Veth said gleefully.

With one smooth motion, they flung their sword up through the barred entrance, utterly smashing their barrier to freedom with one blow. Zhe-La/Veth then leaped, following their weapon through the breach as their charge wailed in protest.

“VEEEETTTTTHHHHH!!!”

Landing fluidly, Zhe-La/Veth examined the dank passage, seeing more grated openings in the floor leading to other cells. After a quick survey and finding the other prisons empty, they turned towards the only exit available; a spiraling staircase leading upwards.

“So now that we are out of there, do you mind putting me down?” Shen asked from over their shoulder.

“No time, Human. I need to move fast,” Zhe-La/Veth responded as they sprinted to the stairs, bounding up them in five quick strides.

“Ughh… I’m going to puke Veth…” Shen moaned.

“You better not vomit on me, *Human*,” Zhe-La/Veth warned, scanning the new passage they found themselves in. Unlike the fitted stonework of the dungeon, the walls here were smooth, curving into the floor and ceiling with no sharp corners. All the doors were slightly ovoid, making the interior of the Trollan building appear organic.

A loud crash drew Zhe-La/Veths’ attention upward—it had come from several floors up, the noise followed by yelling.

“Sounds like fighting!” Shen exclaimed.

Using the hand currently holding Shen, Zhe-La/Veth gave him a condescending pat—then realized with a start that it was his hindquarters they were touching.

“Yes, Human. Very astute,” they said, trying to cover up their embarrassment with sarcasm.

A series of rapid slams seemed to be getting closer—abruptly—a large crack appeared in the ceiling above. Zhe-La/Veth watched dust and debris fall from the widening split right before the roof caved in, depositing a figure on the floor. Zhe-La/Veth and Shen gasped as they recognized the coughing and sputtering woman before them.

“Scorpia?!” Zhe-La/Veth exclaimed.

The white-haired woman turned to them, sudden relief on her face.

“Veth?” She said, confused. “Love the new look! Did Lethe send you to help me?”

Before they could answer, a figure dropped down from the level above; Zhe-La/Veth needed no introduction to this newcomer.

“**The prisoners are loose!**” Wun-Dar roared. “**The masters will not be happy!”**

Being in its physical vicinity and seeing it clearly did nothing to assuage Zhe-La/Veth's dread of their fellow Champion. Wun-Dar's grotesque appearance, combined with the jerky way it moved, gave Wun-Dar an unnatural aspect—like it was set in a place outside this existence and was struggling to interact with this one.

"Such foul magic," Zhe-La/Veth said as they placed Shen on the ground. "Get back; I don't want you to get hurt,"

"What!?" He yelled—but Zhe-La/Veth shoved him away as they faced the other Champion.

"I know you are suffering," Zhe-La/Veth said, summoning the power within them. "Now, I will release you!"

Light poured out from Zhe-La/Veth's chest, bathing Wun-Dar in beautiful radiance. The golem Champion stumbled in the illumination, looking down at its body in bewilderment but seemingly having no effect.

"Your light trick isn't working, Veth!" Shen called.

"*I know, Human,*" Zhe-La/Veth replied in singsong. "It appears that Wun-Dar is not evil, only the methods used to make it the way—ahhh!"

Over its confusion, Wun-Dar lashed out with the Power Sword welded to its right hand—Zhe-La/Veth deflected this attack, avoiding a brutal decapitation by inches. Wun-Dar didn't even break stride as it followed this strike with a unique move; it lashed out with its free arm, sending its hook hand spearing out, slamming into the wall as Zhe-La/Veth ducked. Looking up, the Nephraeh Champion noted that the projectile was linked to Wun-Dar by a gory chain—it pulled its wayward appanage back with a tug—landing back into the waiting socket with a meaty thunk.

"You are certainly a wretched creature," Zhe-La/Veth commented. "This is going to be a messy fight,"

With a war cry, Zhe-La/Veth lunged at Wun-Dar, feinting at the last second to bring their sword up under the other Champion's guard and into its side. There was a scraping sound as they broke through the crystal layer, the golem Champion howling in fury as the sword bit into the gristle below—it lashed out with its hook hand—the movement reactionary and driven by anger. Zhe-La/Veth dodged, yanking their sword out of Wun-Dar to slice at the chain—to their shock—the shackle wrapped around the blade, holding it in place to be yanked out of their grasp. Zhe-La/Veth gazed down at their empty gauntlets as Wun-Dar made a rasping sound—its approximation of laughter—before the Nephraeh regarded them scornfully.

"My dear Wun-Dar," they said, holding out their hand. "You're about to see one of the many benefits of not having a Power Sword!"

The sword of Zhe-La vanished from Wun-Dar's clutches, reappearing in Zhe-La/Veth's clawed gauntlet. The golem Champion appeared saddened by this turn of events right before it exploded into a rage, bursting forward in an explosion of violence. It barreled past Veth, seeking to hurt them by going straight for their weak point.

"Yikes!" Shen cried.

Rolling out of the way of a two hand-chop, Shen scrambled between Zhe-La/Veth's legs as Wun-Dar pursued him. The golem Champion lashed out with its hook—but before it could hit its target—Zhe-La/Veth seized the chain, holding it fast. Wun-Dar would not be deterred from its prey; frothing like a rabid dog, it rushed after Shen, seeking to slice him to ribbons with its Power Sword. Zhe-La/Veth recognized that their companion was caught in a dead end; Shen was casting about frantically as he attempted to open a locked door. Wun-Dar would soon have him.

"NO!!!" Zhe-La/Veth screamed. It was not a plea—but a command—and using the chain, they yanked the other Champion back, wrapping its neck in the metal links while driving their knee into

its back. Wun-Dar struggled in their grip but was not strangled, the nature of its crystalline exoskeleton protecting the soft tissue below. Zhe-La/Veth was barely holding on to the golem; it fought with a strength beyond that of a Champion, drawing on years of anguish and misery—it was about to break free.

In a desperate move, Zhe-La/Veth impaled Wun-Dar from behind with their sword, the tip bursting from its chest in a spray of crystal fragments. But still, the golem Champion would not stop—the end of its Power Sword was inches from piercing Shen, the Human pressing himself tightly in the frame of a closed door.

Abruptly, Scorpia was next to Wun-Dar, swinging a black hammer in the direction of its Power Sword—it exploded into a shower of dancing sparks as metal fragments clattered to the floor. The golem Champion looked at the stump where its Power Sword once had been, pure bliss on its face as splits appeared in its faceted skin.

"Oh man, this is going to be gross," quipped Shen.

Expecting the same result, Zhe-La/Veth was surprised as a grayness began to spread outward from the arm to the rest of its body—as if it were turning to stone. As the graying crept up its neck, Wun-Dar turned to Scopria, a smile on its skinless lips.

"Thank you," it said. The voice was no longer hard and metallic but that of a man—the person that Wun-Dar had once been.

With its undoing complete, Wun-Dar stood still as a statue momentarily before collapsing into a pile, little more than dust and ashes now. Zhe-La/Veth ran to Shen's side, helping him to his feet as their silver eyes inspected his body for injury.

"Are you okay?" They asked.

Shen nodded to them, gratitude in his eyes before they narrowed.

"Scorpia! What are you doing?" He called.

Turning, Zhe-La/Veth spotted the woman running down the hall as she withdrew a vial from a satchel at her hip—she knew immediately what she was about to do.

“Scorpia—NO! Don’t do it!” Zhe-La/Veth cried as they began to sprint toward her.

Glancing furtively at the Nephraeh Champion bounding her way, Scorpia threw the glass vial to the ground, spraying black fluid over the hard surface. Zhe-La/Veth halted their advance and bared their fangs as the congealing liquid formed into three shapes, rising from the floor into familiar onyx bodies.

The newly formed Vetala turned their shiny bald heads toward Zhe-La/Veth, sensing a source of empathy to feed on.

“No!” Scorpia commanded. “You must bring me back to Lethe—I command you!”

Reluctantly, the Vetala turned from the Nephraeh Champion to perform their duty, wrapping their lithe bodies around Scorpia and melting to form the Skosis Portal. Zhe-La/Veth watched the Fallen Etherian Princess sink into the sable pool, still confused as to why she was there—but feeling like she was successful in whatever task she was sent to perform. It did not give them a good feeling.

“Veth! Hurry!” Shen shouted, about to run past them. Zhe-La/Veth immediately halted him with an outstretched hand—he looked up at them with incredulity.

“That’s our only way out of here!” he yelled.

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head slowly as they watched the Skosis Portal shrink before sealing up completely.

“That way would only bring us somewhere worse,” they said. “I will not use any method that involves a Vetala. Besides, it isn’t the only way out of here—these Trollan must have a gate somewhere they used to get to this dimension. We will find it,”

Shen nodded to them, convinced by the resolve on Zhe-La/Veth's face.

"Okay," he said. "I bet Scorpia had to use it to get here, and it appears she came from upstairs; we should—"

"There they are! The escaped prisoners!" A high-pitched voice interrupted.

Whirling, Zhe-La/Veth spotted a group of Trollans gathered at the other end of the hallway—each was garbed in a red robe, indicating that they were members of the Crimson Council.

"By the Eight-Fold Configuration! They killed Wun-Dar!" A bearded Trollan exclaimed.

"They are too dangerous; *destroy them!*" Screeched another.

Zhe-La/Veth brought their sword up just in time to block a flurry of zipping bolts—the projectiles deflecting into the ceiling or simply bursting against the long radiant blade. Upon seeing this resistance, the Crimson Council intensified their assault, lashing their wands in the air to send a flurry of screaming missiles at the Nephraeh Champion. Zhe-La/Veth was fast, but this was too much, and several sorcerous attacks made it past their guard to impact on their stomach, shoulder, and hip. A coldness suffused Zhe-La/Veth's body—an absence of heat so intense it was the immediate promise of the grave. They found their connection to Zhe-La severed, immediately reverting to their normal form to collapse backward. Two arms wrapped Veth's torso, dragging them back to safety.

"I got you, Veth," Shen said next to one of their long ears.

Veth was shivering violently as Shen brought them into the safety of an alcove. They took a moment to bask in his body heat, allowing themselves a small amount of rejuvenation in his embrace.

“Shen, they are too strong; we must flee!” Veth said through chattering teeth.

“Well, lucky for us, I managed to find a way out of here,” he responded, a smile in his voice.

Looking around, Veth recognized they were not in an alcove but a stairwell—one that led upwards.

“I take back all the horrible things I said about you,” they said.

Shen laughed. “It’s okay; I know you didn’t mean any of it,”

Veth grinned to themselves, knowing the human was right. Lifting themselves reluctantly from his arms, Veth stumbled momentarily before trying to ascend the stairs, brushing away Shen’s attempts to guide them.

“I’m fine, Human. I don’t need your coddling,” they said, not unkindly.

“Can you move a little faster then? Please?” Shen asked. Veth could hear more arcane missiles snapping and cracking against the threshold of the staircase as the Crimson Council advanced on their position.

“Right,” Veth said.

Digging deep, they summoned the energy needed to climb the stairs, acceding to Shen’s attempts to help them when needed. They were amazed at how taxed their body was—mostly—their magical aspect reacting to the contact with evil sorcery. Finally reaching the top, Veth growled when they found a red-robed Trollan waiting for them. Frustration turned to relief when they noticed this Trollan was not pointing at them with a wand but beckoning to follow.

“Hurry! This way!” Orko exclaimed.

Veth and Shen followed the floating being down the hallway a short distance before he led them to another staircase leading upwards.

“I hope you are bringing us to a way out of this wrenched dimension, Orko!” Veth panted.

“Yes! Yes! The gate! It's this way!” He said, floating upwards.

“What I wouldn’t give to be able to levitate right now,” Veth gasped, their long legs feeling like jelly as they climbed.

“I could return the favor and carry *you*,” Shen offered from behind.

“Don’t you dare!” they said, trying not to laugh.

Making it to the next floor, Veth observed Orko balk as he stared open-mouthed down the hall; there, they perceived a gaping rent in the wall, the remains of a door evident all over the floor.

“Well, that makes things easier,” Orko commented before zipping in the direction of the opening. Once inside, Veth spotted a large stone ring suspended from the ceiling by four heavy chains.

“If that’s not a gateway to another dimension, then I don’t know what is,” Shen said next to Veth. Turning towards him, they were suddenly overcome by an urge to lean against him—they were utterly spent.

Orko floated before the great ring, waving his wand in an obscure pattern as he spoke his arcane right.

“*Mystic hatch, unfasten your latch, take these poor travelers to the realm they do match!”*

The portal abruptly opened with a burst of undulating aether, which then subsided into a calm shimmering surface. Veth suddenly felt confident that this would take them exactly where they and Shen needed to be.

“After you,” Shen said, proffering his hands toward the open gate.

Veth let him see the grin on their face as they shoved him into the mercury surface; he yelped in surprise as he disappeared into the portal. Veth heard a commotion behind them; angry Trollans yelling obscenities and accusations as Orko pleaded for forgiveness. Without thinking, Veth seized their rescuer by the nape of his neck, hauling the squealing Orko with them into the unknown and escaping the Timeless Dimension.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Iria Abella, a.k.a. ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Instagram.

Anguish of Gallia

Chapter Summary

> Frosta and Hordak embark on a mission to the Frightzone- their task: secure new recruits for the burgeoning Resistance.

"Next on the list is Enos. As you suggested, we have installed temporary energy generator stations in all the major cities—now it's just the outlying towns and villages without power. With the added support of the Star Hunters recalled from Empyrea, I think running the new distribution lines to those places will only take a month. I've gone through the numbers, and the projection that Enos will be completely self-sufficient in two months is sound."

Glimmer looked up from her datapad to the person currently giving the report; Maira was standing erect in the center of The Pratham's chambers, reading from her notes projected from a cantrip on her wrist. She looked tired out from her job of running back and forth between Empyrea and Elysia—visiting all the planets touched by the wars between Madgēcots and Nephraeh. Everyone involved in that unfortunate struggle was worn out and in need of rest—looking at Bow next to her—Glimmer thought of the vacation they planned on taking once everything had been sorted out. But that was not for a while, Glimmer having promised the Madgēcots her help in rebuilding after the war—after all, she had the experience of rebuilding Etheria after the long war with the Horde.

"What about reports of unrest?" A Madgēcot Council Member said—Mirza was her name. Glimmer had become acquainted with the senior leadership of the Madgēcots over the past month, knowing not only their names but their personalities as well. Mirza was good with details, hunting them down like prey in the forest.

"What unrest? On Enos?" Aadhya asked, brow furrowing in concern.

Maira's long black ears lowered as she briefly looked back at her notes; it appeared she had been hoping to skip this part.

"Yeah, about that. The ones calling themselves 'The People for a Free Enos' are keeping their protest peaceful—so far— and continuing to demand the Madgēcots return the Mass Motive Array for re-installation to the Relativity Forge." Maira said.

"What?! That's ridiculous! We don't have the Mass Motive Array!" Aadhya exclaimed. "We are the ones helping them recover after losing their main power source!"

"Yes… well… The People for a Free Enos are claiming that after the defeat of the Nephraeh, the Madgēcots now have the Mass Motive Array and are withholding it so they can control the people of Enos—to make them a fiefdom of Elysia." Maira continued.

Aadhya shook her head as another Council Member spoke up—Navya was their name.

"It's just another reason we should wrap up our work on Enos and get out of there as soon as possible. We don't want to get wrapped up in an insurgency." They said.

Glimmer noted the other Madgēcots nod in agreement, already knowing that something like this won't just go away when the Elysians leave the planet. But that was a problem for another time, and right now, Glimmer just couldn't handle dealing with another issue.

"So, anyway… yeah, on to Taios." Maira continued. "We have made progress with herding the Skaggos back into the Continental Corral, but they made a real mess of eastern and western vegetation zones. I don't think the planet's ecosystem will recover for another ten years, so they are going to need some help in regards—"

Glimmer tuned out Maira's words as a curious sensation crept throughout her body—as if she were sinking into a cool bath. At first, Glimmer thought she was passing out—she had been

overworking herself a lot lately—until she recognized the sensation: a slow cessation of her outer consciousness, turning her awareness inward before an ascension into the metaphysical. Glimmer only experienced this during those times she wanted to view the cosmic landscape—but this was not a voluntary immersion. She could feel the will of the Star Stone behind this, it wanted her to see something vital.

Streaking up from her body like a shooting star, Glimmer once again viewed the galaxy with her spiritual sight; all the planets interlocked and joined in the balance of life. It was all so beautiful and harmonious, making Glimmer confused as to why she was brought here against her will; try as she might, she could not detect any darkness—the true darkness of absolute evil.

Is the Star Stone on the fritz or something? Wait—can the Star Stone go on the fritz? Glimmer thought as she continued to search.

But then she spotted it; not thinking to look at her home planet on the other side of the galaxy, Glimmer's heart leaped into her throat to notice it was now an onyx ball—turning about an equally darkened Eternia in a mutual orbit of wickedness.

How can this be? Is it Archon Lethe? She thought before noticing something else taking place throughout the swirling form of her home galaxy. There was a background fading behind a great many of the planets—like a negative sunrise or a foulness bleeding into reality through the veil of the cosmos.

Something was approaching from the beyond to cast the galaxy back into darkness; Glimmer noticed that it was all the inhabited planets—including Elysia. Glimmer immediately made the connection between what had happened to Etheria and what was about to happen, having a feeling it was tied to a specific place.

Castle Grayskull.

Gasping for air, Glimmer found herself on the ground, looking up as dozens of feline eyes gazed down at her with concern.

"Is she dead?" Someone asked.

"No! She's awake! Glimmer!" Bow exclaimed nearby. He was holding her hand, and Glimmer was grateful to feel the warmth of her husband's body, comforting her after such a dreadful ordeal.

"Ugh… sorry, guys. Didn't mean to alarm anyone," Glimmer said with a small smile.

Bow and Maira helped her to her feet, and after a moment's dizziness, Glimmer turned to the assembled Madgēcots to address them.

"Glimmer! Take it easy! Maybe you should just rest for a while?" Maira said.

"No, this is important. I just had a vision; I'm not sure, but—"

Glimmer was interrupted as the door to Aadhya's chambers opened, and Entrapta rushed in on her ponytails. The technical Princess looked crazed more than usual as she held a datapad in her outstretched hand.

"Glimmmerrrrr!!!" Entrapta cried, pushing aside Madgēcots to drop down before the Queen of Etheria. Glimmer looked at the proffered device, thinking she already knew who it was from.

"Let me guess. It's a message from Etheria." She stated.

Entrapta shook her head as her ponytails frazzled.

"No! It's a transmission from Thenlor! It's your father, Glimmer!"

* * *

A pleasant rustling greeted the visitors to the Old Fright Zone, the collective sound of thousands of plants shifting in the gentle

breeze as they hung from the desiccated remains of the Horde Structures. Where once the wind would have howled through this place, it was now buffeted and cushioned by the soft greenery created after the defeat of Horde Prime. Frosta knew that Perfuma had helped Scorpia cultivate much of the new growth into pleasing shapes—bunnies were Scorpia's favorite—but now, with both Princesses off world, it had become overgrown and wild. This was perfect for them; with the added cover, sneaking in to commandeer the Horde Bots should be a cinch.

Well, that was what Frost was hoping for—based on the successes they had since Netossa and Spinnerella had joined them, it was looking good for the new Rebellion. They were now able to fight off most attacks by the monsters or their lackeys, making Erelandia a safe haven for anyone who had not been darkened.

Spinnerella, Netossa, Kyle, and Rogelio had stayed behind with Hordak's bots to defend the town while Frosta, Hordak, Lonnie, and Emily undertook this secret mission. With the success of this operation and the surge in the Rebellion ranks, the plan was to re-take Dryl, thus gaining the means to create more robots. Entrapta had built a whole factory in the bowels of her castle, and with the raw materials Hordak had claimed were in storage, they could quadruple the number of robots they currently had. Things were looking up for them, but Frosta couldn't help wondering when the other shoe would drop and their luck to run out. Hopefully, it wasn't here and now.

"We are close; I am picking up a great number of power signatures in a dormant state—not far from our location," Hordak stated as he read from a glowing green screen on his armored gauntlet.

"You sure that's robots you're picking up and not something else?" Lonnie commented.

The look Hordak gave the ex-Horde soldier was cold enough to freeze fire, and Lonnie straightened, standing at attention.

“I’m sorry I questioned you, sir! It won’t happen again, sir!” She said stiffly.

Frosta rolled her eyes at Lonnie’s absolute submission to Hordak but decided not to comment on it, knowing she had no idea what it was like to grow up in the Horde. Who knows, perhaps she would be marching and saluting if the Horde had captured her when she was only a baby? Look at Scorpia.

Hordak let out a sigh. “I apologize for my reaction; it was an honest question, Lonnie. I don’t want to surround myself with sycophants as I did in the Horde—so I will answer your question,”

Lonnie gaped at this response, not expecting any form of magnanimity from the ex-Horde ruler. She turned to Frosta with the expression of a person who was in the middle of questioning their entire reality.

“I lived in the Fight Zone for decades now; I know the ins and outs of every nook and cranny—not because I visited these sites—but because I designed them. The location I’m picking up these power readings was once a waste processing center—it would have been a simple matter to remove all the equipment and tanks to turn it into a storage facility. Plus, it’s underground.” Hordak explained.

Lonnie snapped her fingers as a memory came to the fore.

“That’s right! I remember that place! Catra and I once had extra duty there, cleaning out the effluent strainers. Worst E.D. I’ve ever had, and Catra’s fur stank for a week,” she said with a scowl.

Hordak nodded sagely. “Yes, it was the prime choice for corrective discipline as well as waste disposal. Just be glad I didn’t let Shadow Weaver have her way; she had a much worse punishment for delinquent cadets,”

Frosta frowned at Lonnie when Hordak didn’t expound on his last statement, instead letting her imagination fill in the blanks.

“Come, we are wasting time. It's this way,” Hordak said, advancing down a byway between two large towers. Frosta peered upwards, gazing at the sky peaking down between the tall buildings and wild growth. It was so silent here that it was hard for her to imagine it was once active with buzzing machinery and the clatter of marching troops. It almost seemed too quiet—and once again—Frosta began to feel uneasy about their mission to the Fright Zone. After all, didn’t the first mission here go horribly wrong? Frosta wasn’t there, but Entrapta was presumed dead, only to turn up working with the Horde.

“Hordak,” Frosta said, trying not to be overheard by Lonnie. “You sure you’re not picking up anything else? I have a bad feeling about all this,”

Hordak stopped to pin Frosta with his glowing red eyes, his expression unreadable. After a moment, he nodded.

“Are you feeling something with your magical abilities, Princess Frosta?” He asked.

Frosta cringed slightly, now feeling embarrassed.

“No, it's something not so direct but no less reliable—more of an intuition,” she said.

Hordak grunted. “Good enough for me.”

He waved to the fourth party member: a round, light-colored robot who walked over to Hordak on four spindly legs.

“Emily, your onboard sensors are more advanced than mine. Are you picking up anything?” He asked.

Emily stood slightly higher as a low pinging sound emanated from her chassis; after a moment of this, she lowered with a negative bleat.

“Emily detects no movement within the Fright Zone,” Hordak explained.

“That’s strange in itself, though,” Frosta said, head tilted. “There has to be living things besides plants here—animals, bugs—something!”

Hordak conceded to this point and directed his attention back to Emily.

“Use the null-wave spectrum amplifier Entrapta installed—search in a helix pattern, beginning with our location and traveling outward,” he instructed.

“Excuse me—a what?” Lonnie said, her face the very definition of confusion.

“I have a theory that the monsters we have encountered are not only magical but are in direct opposition to the laws of nature. If they are present, they will clash with the environment in such a way as to create null-waves. If they are nearby and masking their movement, this will pick them up,” Hordak explained.

Instead of raising herself up, Emily squatted slightly as she began to oscillate, a low hum like a moan coming from her vocalizers—Frosta felt the hairs on the back of her neck stand up as the bizarre technology interreacted with her elemental powers. When she finished her scan, Emily beeped in low tones, like she was whispering.

“It appears you are correct, Princess Frosta. Emily is picking up a large signature—due South and moving towards this location.” Hordak said.

“We abandon the mission, right?” Lonnie exclaimed.

As Frosta’s eyes met Hordak’s, she realized he was thinking the same thing; they were set on this course, and there was no turning back.

“No,” Frosta said. “We either do this, or we might as well give up. There is no Rebellion without those bots.”

Hordak nodded. “You are right; you would have made a fine Force Captain, Princess Frosta.”

Frosta frowned as she tried to decide to take that as a compliment or an affront; in the end, she only shrugged.

“Let’s do this then. We are wasting time,” she said.

Moving quickly now, Hordak led the group down an adjacent alley, the end of which transitioned into a gantry staircase leading down into a vertical tube. Frosta was amazed that anyone could memorize the different ways through the Fright Zone; the entire place was like a heap of pipes, metal girders, and sharp metal pieces. They were moving in a tight passage now, Emily’s trapezoid eye providing the only illumination as Hordak steered them deeper into the bowels of the Fright Zone.

“This is it,” he said as if sensing her and Lonnie’s rising trepidation.

Stopping at a water-tight door, Hordak attempted to rotate the wheel mechanism to open the door—when it did not budge—he growled with irritation.

“Emily? If you please?” He prompted.

With a cheerful beep, the robot scurried forward with blowtorch deployed; sparks flew as she began cutting through the dogs holding the hatch in place. Frosta bit her lip as she watched this take place, willing the robot to work faster.

With a jarring clang, the door fell away, and they ventured into the expansive chamber where the entirety of the Horde Robot army was stored. Even in the low light, Frosta could make out hundreds of dormant bots sitting in charging creches and lined up in neat rows. Her heart soared to catch sight of them; with this many robots and the Princess working together, they were sure to re-take Dryl.

“Hurry, Emily! Load the operating systems and link them to your central processor!” Hordak bellowed. Frosta was amazed to hear the fear in his voice; even the mighty Hordak was feeling the vulnerability of their current situation.

Emily scrambled down a ramp and onto the chamber floor, heading toward a bank of computers. Extending a data jack, she connected to the local network via a connection port and uploaded the software needed to control the robot horde. With a whistle from Emily, every robot lifted themselves from their charging creche, turning their attention to the one who commanded them; the gloomy chamber was now lit with the glow of hundreds of purple electronic eyes as Hordak basked in the light of his reclaimed army.

“Great! But how are we going to get them out of here? For that matter, how are WE going to get out of here? Whoever is after us has us trapped!” Lonnie commented. Frosta couldn’t fault her alarm; their new robots could only leave the chamber single file, making easy pickings for someone to take them out one at a time.

Hordak looked back smugly; some of his old demeanor had returned now that he was in command of a powerful force.

“Don’t worry; we will make out own exit.” He said, glancing around the room.

“There!” Hordak said, pointing at a far wall. “Emily! Concentrated fire at a thirty-degree angle—sloping upwards!”

The storage hall was abruptly filled with clattering metal legs as the robots turned toward the indicated surface; a high-pitched whine succeeded this, followed by a searing light as hundreds of laser beams gouged a hole not only through the wall but the ground outside as well. When they were finished, a large shaft was left—big enough for five bots to walk abreast.

“Shall we go and greet those who dare stand against us?” Hordak offered.

As Frosta followed him out of the slowly emptying storage chamber on the heels of the new robot army, she could not help noticing a slight swagger in Hordak's step—the old tyrant regaining a small measure of his confidence with this victory. Frosta tried to share in his enthusiasm, but she could not shake the feeling that Hordak was overly confident.

Once out in the clean air, Frosta peered about for their pursuers—it was not long before she spotted them; creeping towards them down a wide boulevard was a mass of the black creatures. They completely filled the wide street, slinking and oozing like an oily tide, black teeth exposed to absorb the surrounding light. Frosta could hear the mass clicking of their toe claws on the cement of the ground; it was eerie, like the sound of a clock at high speed—time running out.

"Well, I guess we are going to see how well our new recruits do," Frosta commented dryly.

Before she was even finished speaking, the monsters halted, forming a sable wall a hundred paces away. Frosta could not believe what she was seeing; every other time she had encountered these abhorrent monsters, they had shown little restraint in their hunger for those undarkened like her. But then she discovered the reason why.

Striding out from behind the creatures was a man encased in jagged black armor; his open helmet revealed a handsome blue-tinged face. Two long pointed ears protruded from either side of his head, and Frosta momentarily wondered if he was somehow one of the black monsters—but then she banished this thought; the black creatures were too different from this man, too outside the spectrum of anything resembling gender. He was haughty and elegant in his poise but still portrayed elements that were masculine—the way his hips stayed motionless while his shoulders swayed. He stopped midway between the two opposite sides, regarding his enemies with cold eyes; his gaze passed over Frosta and Lonnie as if they didn't exist, fixing on the form of Hordak.

“You must be the Tinker,” he stated. His voice was an almost hoarse whisper—like a corpse speaking with withered vocal cords.

“Who are you?” Hordak challenged.

“I am Suzerain Shen’Shalidar of Morrigor. I have been tasked to come to this place and crush your rebellion,” he said simply. Frosta noticed him raise something which at first appeared as a large bone, but when she noticed it ended in a tip, realized it was a sword. A faint green outline shimmered on the blade, indicating that not only was this an unusual weapon but a magical one as well.

“You see,” Shen’Shalidar continued. “I have lots of experience crushing rebellions—some would say it’s my calling. I’m rather surprised to see you leading one, Hordak.”

The ex-ruler of the Horde was taken aback hearing his name spoken by this stranger, instantly wrong-footing him.

“You know who I am?” He asked.

Shen’Shalidar gave a slight nod—not one of assent, but of mutual respect.

“Yes, I have studied Etheria since Shen’Dar-oom entered this dimension. The time of the Horde is the only thing noteworthy in your history. I was hoping to meet you one day—to see the great man of a singular vision. Now that I have, to say that I am disappointed would be an understatement.” He said.

“I care not for your admiration nor your disappointment,” Hordak hissed. “How did you find us?”

Shen’Shalidar shrugged. “It was easy. I heard reports of the Tinker using old Horde robots and assumed this was the next place you would go—to boost your ranks. I assume your next move is to take your fortress in Dryl?”

Frosta glanced nervously at Hordak, who growled in response to the taunt; she could tell he was losing his cool.

"Really, Hordak? Disappointment heaped upon disappointment," Shen'Shalidar said with a tsk.

Frosta knew this was the last straw.

Pointing his hand cannon at Shen'Shalidar, Hordak released a lance of energy; it seared toward the newcomer with enough power to annihilate the entire street. Almost casually, Shen'Shalidar raised his white blade; Frosta watched in amazement as the beam shrunk down to a singular point, seeming to gather within itself. Once the deadly force of Hordak's assault was collected, a sphere hovered before Shen'Shalidar, looking to everyone like a red-hot coal. With a sudden thrust with his free hand, he sent the object hurtling into a group of Horde bots—they exploded into a fiery plume, metal fragments spinning in all directions. Shen'Shalidar raised his bone-white sword, inspecting it appreciatively.

"A gift from my new benefactor," he explained. "It is one of the Great Powers—what you call *Abominable*. It is called the Anguish of Gallia, and you will find it has no equal here on your paltry planet."

Shen'Shalidar sneered as he turned to Frosta, his disdain for the Etherian Princess evident.

"Even if you had all the other elemental powers working in concert, you still could not match the power I have brought with me. At my back are the Vetala—they are new to me—but I have much to thank them for—absolute freedom being one of them. They are my new benefactor's minions; besides them, I have brought something created from the beautiful magic of Death. You may have met them before—when my old master attempted to unite this weak galaxy,"

A scuffling sound brought Frosta's attention to the side streets on either side of Shen'Shalidar; shambling figures were approaching from both sides—where the black monsters were of uniform shape and size, these newcomers were more various but no less familiar to Frosta.

Ashen skin and slack features—lifeless eyes the color of curdled milk; there was no uniform outfit of this new army—unless ragged and torn clothes could be counted as any measure of dress code.

"Szi'th!" Frosta exclaimed in surprise. "How—how is this possible? Your God of Death is destroyed; Death Magic shouldn't exist!"

Shen'Shalidar laughed at this, rich and melodious—the sound entirely at odds with his ghostly voice.

"You silly girl! The Set'Heth-un'dar's light may be gone from this existence, but you cannot destroy the power of Seth-un! Not when I and other believers are keeping the spirit alive!" Shen'Shalidar exclaimed.

Frosta couldn't believe the amount of varied evil arrayed against them; Death, Apathy, and whatever the Anguish of Gallia represented—it was just too much. On top of that, there seemed no end to the amount of Szi'th appearing from around each corner—there was only one course of action—they had to retreat.

"Hordak…" She said, backing away. "I think we need to get out of here!"

"NO!" He shouted. "Not now when I have just reclaimed my army! Emily! Command the robots to attack!"

Hordak appeared entirely possessed, driven by a manic will that was beyond reasoning. Frosta could not help thinking of the battle in Elberon; he had said something that left Frosta feeling unsettled—as if leading the Rebellion was not about freedom for Etheria.

I can win this. Perhaps if I do, I can finally be worthy… of you…

Was Hordak still trying to prove himself to his 'brother'—Horde Prime? Someone who had created Hordak from a genetic template not out of any form of compassion but to make a tool to be used and ultimately thrown away. Were they following a man whose end goal was utterly unobtainable?

"Emily! Hordak! Wait!" Frosta cried. But it was too late; Emily had already transmitted the command, and the Horde bots raced forward, eager to translate the simple logic gate functions into visceral violence. The next few moments were a blur for Frosta as the two sides met in a battle the likes of which Etheria had never seen before.

Two Horde Bots directed concentrated volleys of laser strikes into a group of the black creatures—Vetala—she now knew they were called. They exploded into an ephemeral haze as more Vetala took their place, raking their razor claws upon the metal surface of the robots in revenge. Sparks flying from the rents into their carapace, the newest members of the Rebellion exploded into an expanding fireball, taking their attackers with them.

Another group of Horde Bots stomped through the Szi'th—their metal legs smiting the undead into paste. But there were too many of the wretched Szi'th; the ones not crushed clung and bit the legs of the robots, causing them to flounder and eventually succumb to the weight of the many assailants. The round shapes of the Horde Bots disappeared under an undead tide—more unneeded casualties to this ambush.

Shen'Shalidar swung about himself with his bizarre weapon; Frosta witnessed him cleave a Horde Bot in two with a casual swing—as if it were not made of metal but wet paper. He kicked the two halves away dismissively before aiming the point of his sword at another opponent—a bright flash of jagged lightning arced out of the victim and into the blade. The Horde Bot crashed to the ground, completely powerless as its energy appeared to invigorate the Suzerain of Morrigor; Shen'Shalidar's eyes flashed momentarily before the light receded, a satisfied smile on his handsome yet cruel features.

Hordak was not too far from his new nemesis—vaporizing any of the Vetala or Szi'th that came within range. Frosta feared that he was trying to make his way to Shen'Shalidar—to face this foe in a contest of strength and will. With what Frosta had witnessed of this new enemy, Hordak didn't stand a chance.

"Heeelllp meeee!" Someone screamed nearby.

Frosta whipped her head around to spot Lonnie being dragged down a nearby ally, two Vetala holding her legs as she thrashed to escape. The monsters were dragging her friend to a nearby culvert; it was big enough to fit all three, giving the Vetala a hidden place to enervate Lonnie.

"NO!" Frosta shrieked, turning from the fighting Hordak to rush to her friend's aid.

She was suddenly blocked by a group of Szi'th, veering from their original course by some unknown incentive—like a flock of birds whose movement appears to have no meaning. They reached for the young Princes with skeletal hands, seeking to bring her close to their snapping teeth. Much like the Vetala, the Szi'th wanted to bite their victims—but unlike their Empyrean cousins—the bite from the undead had much fouler consequence.

Frosta wanted neither fate—with a shoving motion—encased the wretched creatures in a block of ice. The parts of the Szi'th not within the frozen prison continued to reach for Frosta as she brushed past them, racing against time to save Lonnie.

"Lonnie!" Frosta shouted. But there was no sign of her, only an empty ally ending in a gaping drain.

"NOOO!!!" Frosta screamed, racing forward to extract her friend from the stygian domain. Just as she was about to reach the opening, Lonnie stepped forth, looking around the alley warily.

"Lonnie!" Frosta shouted, ecstatic that the other woman had escaped. "I'm so happy to see—"

Frosta's words died in her mouth as the two Vetala slid from the shadows of the culvert, their black eyes fixed not on Lonnie—but on Frosta.

"I'm glad to see you too," Lonnie said with a sneer. "Why don't you come here and join us? You will like it with my new friends,"

Whirling, Frosta ran from the darkened version of Lonnie, desperately seeking anyone still on her side.

"HORDAK!!! EMILY!!!" She screamed into the wild melee of Horde Robots versus demonic monsters. It wasn't going well for her side; most of the newly acquired Horde robots had been destroyed by the overwhelming force of Shen'Shalidar might. There was no sign of Hordak or Emily, and judging by her slowly dwindling army, Frosta was soon to join Lonnie—or worse—depending on whether the undead or empathy vampires got to her first. There was only one thing on Frosta's frantic mind and one thing only.

Escape.

Summoning her elemental powers, Frosta created a smooth sheet of ice beneath her feet—she shot forward on this new path—creating additional sections to propel her away from danger. Vetala leaped to catch their escaping prize, but Frosta only steered her ice track upwards and away from their clutches. Looking down at the battle, Frosta continued to search for the leader of the Rebellion, hoping beyond hope that he had not been taken. Having Hordak on the enemy side would have dire consequences for the Etherian resistance.

Hot wind brushed past Frosta, almost making her lose her concentration and fall from her frozen slide; searching frantically below, she spotted Shen'Shalidar pointing his blade in her direction. With a jolt of fear, Frosta realized that the dread malice of an Abominable Power was directed at her—but before she could double her efforts—Frosta felt the ice beneath her feet

vaporize. She soared through the air momentarily before beginning a freefall toward a group of Szi'th.

"NOO!!!" She cried, expanding her arms to summon a frigid gust of air. Her magic was successful in freezing the enemy below her but not entirely cushioning her fall. The petrified Szi'th shattered as Frosta crashed through them, crying out at a sudden stab of pain in her torso. Wincing as she felt at her side, Frosta felt no cuts there, only intense agony.

"Ugh, I think I broke a couple ribs," she moaned as she looked around—then instantly screamed.

Szi'th surrounded Frosta; they pinned her in place with dead eyes, mouths drooling with hunger more substantive than the Vetala's—they were not going to eat her emotions—but her very flesh.

Frosta tried to summon her elemental power but couldn't—not with the distraction of the stabbing pain in her side. She shut her eyes against the vision of gnashing teeth coming for her, hoping that the end would be quick.

A high-pitched whine brought Frosta out of her hopeless resignation—she opened her eyes just in time to distinguish several Szi'th lifted off their feet, propelled backward by a familiar red beam of light. This blast was followed by more pinpoint strikes, annihilating the remaining monsters trying to get their hands on the Princess. A sudden swell of relief filled Frosta's chest to spot her rescuer come stomping out of the swirling smoke—Hordak. He surveyed the scene briefly before coming to kneel by her side.

"Are you injured, Princess Frosta?" Hordak asked.

Frosta grunted as she allowed him to raise her to her feet, her injuries paining but not stopping her from standing.

"I think I broke every single rib on my right side—but other than that— I can walk," she answered.

Hordak grunted in acknowledgment before surveying their position.

"Good. I know of a way nearby that can take us to the many escape tunnels I installed in the Fright Zone. There is no way this Shen'Shalidar could know of their exit points—and even if he does — there are too many for him to monitor at once." He said.

"Where is Emily? Please don't tell me she was destroyed?" Frosta asked.

Hordak shook his head; at that instant, the ex-Horde ruler looked more tired than Frosta had ever seen him before.

"I commanded her to take any surviving Horde Bots and retreat. Hopefully, the enemy is too distracted chasing them to look for us." He said.

Frosta was angered by his response but bit her lip; it seemed like another one of Hordak's old traits had resurfaced—sacrificing your underlings for your own benefit.

"Come, let us make our escape," Hordak said, proffering his hand to support the injured Princess.

Frosta declined the offer of help but followed the man who once ruled half of Etheria into the bowls of his once-great empire. They had utterly failed in their mission but had succeeded in the most important thing.

They had kept themselves alive and undarkened.

‘Hey, Adora,’

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Adora discover that there was more to Scorpia and Mermista's visit to Trolla than meets the eye.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Easing the bedroom door open gently, Adora peeked through the open crack, spotting the sleeping figure of Mermista on the bed. She was face down with arms and legs splayed—reminding Adora of doing a jumping jack—her long dark hair spread out in a fan adding to the appearance. It was the position of a person who did not have a restful night, making Adora loathe disturbing her friend’s slumber.

After yesterday’s fight and subsequent return of her empathy, the Princess of Salineas had been entirely inconsolable in her grief, having wept openly and profusely. Adora remembered feeling immense pity when she watched this breakdown, instantly knowing the cause—the crushing realization of the many awful deeds you performed, wondering if you could ever forgive yourself. Adora would know; she had felt the same after Catra had saved her and was still feeling the ramifications of her time as Despara.

Catra had tried to question Mermista about Archon Lethe’s goals on Trolla but was unable to get past the endless sobbing. In the end, she transitioned back into Sher-Va and carried Mermista to their quarters in New Trolla; the two Champions of Grayskull had then taken turns by the bed until Mermista had cried herself to sleep.

“Is she awake yet?” Catra asked behind Adora.

Adora turned around to give her wife a look of incredulity as she shooed her away.

"Come on, Catra, give her time!" She whispered. *"You have no idea what we went through—having our empathy taken and then given back—then living with the knowledge of what we did,"*

Catra was about to roll her eyes but stopped when she noted the stern look on Adora's face.

"Okay, okay—sheesh!" Catra complained. "I just feel like we are running out of time—who knows what Scorpia is up to on the other side of that portal?!"

Adora nodded. "Yes, I'm worried too, Catra. But this is a person, and we can't force her to do what we want. Aren't you the embodiment of empathy now? Being Sher-Va and everything?"

"Nooo…" Catra said. "I am the embodiment of *truth* as Sher-Va,"

Adora scrunched up her face at this. "How did that happen? You were the biggest fibber when we were little kids. Didn't Lonnie call you *Catra Liar-Face*?"

Now Catra did roll her eyes as she made a mocking face.

"*Oh, har-har, Lonnie, good one!*" She said, sticking her upper fangs out over her bottom lip. "I hated that nickname, and it was totally unfair!"

Adora had to laugh at this, mainly because it was entirely fair—Catra had been the worst at telling the truth as a kid, but it wasn't her fault; it had been a defense mechanism against the abuse Shadow Weaver doled out. Catra had learned at a young age it was better to lie if the truth only got you in trouble.

"Just a little bit longer, okay, Catra? Just let her sleep," Adora pleaded.

Catra's heterochromatic eyes softened as she smiled, reaching out to take Adora's hand in hers.

"Okay." She said. "You know, you've developed quite a sensitive side. I think I'm liking it,"

Adora had a sheepish smile on her face as her wife came closer; she could feel a furry tail wrapping around her leg as Catra whispered in her ear.

"I think it makes me want to touch you," she said, breath hot in Adora's ear.

"Catra," Adora said, putting up a weak defense against clawed hands on her body. "Not two seconds ago, you wanted to question Mermista; now this?"

Catra chuckled as she nuzzled her face into Adora's neck, nipping her gently with her fangs.

"That's right, if I can't interrogate Mermista, I will settle for you. Besides, I'm still in honeymoon mode."

"Settle?" Adora complained. But it was hard for her to pretend to be incensed; Catra's attention was becoming quite vigorous, her lips meeting Adora's own in a sensual union. Feeling heady, Adora suddenly found her back against the wall as Catra pressed up against her, the need evident in her wife's body language.

"You know. *kiss* Now we are going to. *kiss* Have to go on. *kiss* A honeymoon re-do-over." Catra whispered.

"Why. *uh* Do you think. *sigh* I wanted her to sleep?" Adora responded around her wife's mouth.

Catra suddenly backed away from Adora, running a finger down her Jaadoo suit from her neckline down to her belly button.

"*Hataana,*" She said with a coy smile, the individual pieces of her outfit falling to the floor in a pile, fully revealing Catra in all her

glory.

“I love Jaadoo suits,” Adora exclaimed.


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Catra grinned fiercely as she approached Adora, the desire like fire in her feline eyes.

“Hey, guys?” A voice asked nearby.

Both women turned mid-embrace to make out Mermista peering through the cracked door to their bedroom. Her eyes widened in shock once she realized what she was witnessing.

“Oh! I’m so sorry!” Mermista exclaimed, closing the door quickly.

Catra groaned as she backed away from Adora, speaking the words to dress herself. With regret, Adora watched as the strips of magical material glide up from the floor, taking their designated places on Catra’s body once more.

“Why are we stopping?” Adora asked.

Catra looked at her incredulously. “Really, Adora? Now, who is insensitive?”

Adora sighed heavily, knowing that her wife was right. Now was not the time for romance, but since returning from her time as Despara, Adora needed that tender connection more than ever. It filled up the cracks in her soul, making her feel whole once more. Catra had noticed this, commenting the other night that if they kept up like this, they would be having a kid sooner than they had planned.

Catra knocked at the door tentatively, holding up one of her long ears to listen within.

“Hey, Mermista? Can we come in?” She asked.

“Uh, sure… you not still naked, are you?” Was the meek response.

Catra turned to give Adora a look before responding.

“Yes, Mermista. I have clothes on now.” She said deadpan. Adora could tell that her wife wanted to say something more but wisely

held her tongue.

"Well, sure… If you guys are okay with it. I don't want to be a bother…" Mermista replied miserably.

Hearing the sadness in her friend's voice, Catra's ears drooped as she turned to Adora, giving her wife a frown.

"It's okay, Mermista. You could never be that to us. We are coming in," Adora replied through the door.

Opening the door, Adora spotted Mermista lying flat on the bed, her head buried under a pillow; she was still wearing the black Aegis Lace body suit, having nothing else to change into. Adora sat on one side of the bed as her wife sat on the other—Catra started rubbing Mermista's back as she purred in reassurance. Adora had noticed that Catra had been doing that a lot now—purring not just for her comfort but for others as well.

"Mermista? Look at me, please," Adora coaxed.

Two forlorn brown eyes appeared under the pillow, red-rimmed and still wet from tears. Adora smiled kindly down at them, knowing full well the pain taking place in the soul behind.

"I know you are not in a good place right now, but can we talk? About why you and Scorpia were sent here?" Adora asked.

Mermista eyes widened in shock as she bolted upright, surprising Catra and Adora. She moaned suddenly, holding her head with both hands as Catra both helped and coaxed her to sit against the bedrest.

"Ohhhhh… I'm so worthless; how could I forget!" Mermista complained. "That should have been the first thing I told you instead of falling apart like I did—so stupid!"

Adora held up her hands, trying to stop the Princess of Salineas from beating herself up.

“Easy now! It's okay, Mermista!” She tried to say, but the other just waved her off.

“No! It isn’t!” Mermista said, appearing as if she would cry again. “Adora, you have no idea what’s going on! It’s terrible!”

Adora and Catra looked at each other, trepidation on both their faces.

“Start from the beginning, then,” Catra said.

Mermista sniffled as she got a hold of her emotions, trying to reclaim even an ounce of the cool façade she once exuded. She ran her hands back over her head, straightening her hair as she let out a slow breath.

“Okay. After the Madgēcots took Empyrea, Scorpia and I were on the run. We had taken a small ship and were just past the Omiros Bridge when one of those black monsters appeared on board—a Vetala. I have no idea where it came from; it must have been a stowaway. Anyway, it melted into one of those portals—a Skosis Portal—it’s called. At first, we thought we were supposed to go into it, but then someone came out. It was Lethe.”

“Archon Lethe,” Adora breathed.

Mermista shook her head. “Just Lethe now, but no less powerful. They had us take the ship to Eternia, and we landed just outside Eternos. We went into the city, heading straight from the seat of government. There, Lethe unleashed horror; hundreds of Vetala appeared from out of their body and from every nearby shadow, attacking anyone nearby and enervating them—taking their empathy and making them Lethe’s slaves.”

Mermista stopped as a deep shiver wracked her body; Catra immediately wrapped her arms around the Princess, trying to keep Mermista warm with her furry body. Finally, the episode subsided, and Mermista continued her tale.

"In less than an hour, Lethe had taken Eternos. In half a day, they had taken Eternia. There was a Star Force furloughed on Eternia at that time, allowing the Vetala a way off the planet and onto Etheria. It's all lost now—but that is not the worst part. Lethe has taken Grayskull,"

Adora was confused by this, and judging by the curious tilt of Catra's head, she was too.

"You mean that weird old castle out in the middle of nowhere?" Catra asked. "I've never been there, but I know it's where Shen found that Abominable Power. If you are worried about Lethe getting their hands on more of them, don't be. Shen was able to destroy the Eye of Hate, and I'm sure Adora and I can take care of the rest,"

Adora smiled at the brashness in her wife's voice but, with the way she had been feeling lately, did not share in the sentiment. Adora couldn't stand up against Mermista and Scorpia without Catra stepping in to save her; she couldn't imagine facing one of the ultimate evils.

"No, I'm not talking about that!" Mermista exclaimed with a hint of irritation. "There is something far more dangerous under the Castle—and I'm not talking about the dungeon! Beneath even that is a secret passage to this room, *The Concurrence* Lethe had called it. There is a kind of portal or gateway to another place, a nexus of all things called Subternia—that's what Lethe seeks!"

Adora pondered this momentarily, letting Mermista's words sink in *—more dangerous than one of the Abominable Powers.*

"What do you mean*, nexus of all things?"* Catra asked.

Mermista scowled at this question; it seemed to make her head hurt.

"I'm not sure… all I know is that Lethe had been waiting a thousand years to reach it. They kept saying they were running

out of time and that everything they ever desired was now within reach."

"Well, whatever Lethe wants that badly can't be good," Adora commented. "So, where do you and Scorpia fit in?"

Mermista nodded quickly. "Yes, I was getting to that. I mentioned that there is a door to Subternia in The Concurrence. Well, the only way to open it is if all seven Champions of Grayskull are present to activate their own pylons."

Catra let out a high-pitched laugh at this before favoring Mermista with her most winning smile.

"All seven Champions working together? Is that all?" She said. "Well, good luck finding them all. I think Lethe is going to run out of time!"

Catra's grin died on her face upon seeing Mermista's expression—dead seriousness set against a backdrop of dread.

"Inside The Concurrence is a giant crystal called the Well of Champion Spirits. It is like a collection point for the Spirts to go to when they are no longer bound. Lethe already has Thon-Ra and He-Ro in there. Scorpia and I were sent here to access the dimensions the Trollans are hiding in. We were supposed to find Wun-Dar—to either turn them to our side or release the Champion Spirit. Either would suit Lethe's plans."

"Okay," Catra conceded. "That leaves He-Man and Zhe-La—both Shen and Veth were killed, and we have no idea what happened to their Avatars. On top of that, Adora and I have no plans to help Lethe,"

Mermista rubbed at her eyes, appearing very tired.

"I don't think that will stop them, Catra. Lethe will find them. Trust me; they are very powerful."

Although she had felt lost since regaining her empathy, Adora suddenly knew what they had to do. It was the only logical course of action.

"Can you take us to this gate and get Catra and me through to this hidden dimension? We will stop Scorpia and reclaim this Wun-Dar for the good guys," she said, dead-set.

Mermista reached down to her hip, feeling between the folds of the Aegis Lace as if they were pockets. With a look of sudden satisfaction, she pulled out a glass vial containing a glowing indigo substance. Adora suddenly gasped, falling over backward and crashing to the ground in her haste to get away from it.

"Adora!" Catra screamed, leaping over the bed in one bound to get to Adora's side.

"Keep that away from me!" She gasped.

Right away, Mermista folded her hands over the glass vial, pressing it against her chest.

"Oh! I'm sorry!" She exclaimed. "I totally understand why it frightens you—but it's fine! It's safe inside the receptacle. It's what we use to activate the portal."

Adora seemed to come back into herself at her friend's reassuring words; she looked up into Catra's concerned face, realizing how unhinged she must seem at that moment.

"I'm sorry… I overacted…" Adora said as Catra helped her up.

"Don't be silly, Adora. You weren't over—"

"Just forget it!" Adora snapped, making her wife wince. Guilt instantly washed over Adora as the look of hurt passed over Catra's face, but even worse than that was seeing it replaced by love and understanding. Adora felt unworthy of her wife's love and even more of any forgiveness—it made her angry.

“Sorry, I didn’t mean to snap—again,” Adora said, reassuringly placing her hands on Catra’s shoulder. “You know how stress sometimes makes me a little irritable,”

Catra nodded in agreement, but looking into her wife’s heterochromia eyes, Adora could tell she was unconvinced. Catra was never easily fooled.

“We should hurry!” Mermista exclaimed as she rose unsteadily from the bed, still clutching the glass vial. “Who knows how much time was wasted on my silly breakdown!”

“Don’t be so hard on yourself, Mermista,” Adora admonished. “There is nothing silly about what you just went through.”

Adora had to stop herself as the hypocrisy of her words caught up with her, but she dismissed this thought, deciding that they had no time for the luxury of self-care.

“But you are right,” she continued. “We should go now—we are running out of time.”

* * *

Catra found herself lagging a couple of paces from her wife and friend as all three traveled the relatively short distance to the Athenaeum. It was clear that what they were attempting was important—but try as she might—Catra just could not dismiss her worry for Adora. Any reminder of her time as Despara—either explicit or vague—caused Adora to react in a manner that was dangerous in any tense situation.

Now they were planning on going to some unknown dimension to face a fallen Princess—plus who knows what else. Catra doubted her wife was up to it and knew she would never forgive herself if anything happened to Adora.

Maybe you should talk to her? Jihan recommended helpfully.

Catra shook her head dismissively, keeping her eyes on her wife. Adora had her arm around Mermista's shoulders and was consoling her friend; Catra's heart went out to Adora, knowing that she needed care just as much as—if not more than—Mermista.

We don't have time, Jihan—you heard what Mermista said. We have to move fast. Anyway, it's not the kind of conversation we can have in front of Mermista, Catra thought back.

Who said you had to speak to Adora out loud? Jihan responded.

This confused Catra, and Jihan straight away picked up on it.

Does anyone remember anything? Jihan said with a sigh. **All Champions of Grayskull can communicate with each other telepathically.**

This revelation floored Catra, and she abruptly stopped in place, mouth opened wide.

When were you going to tell me this? You mean, I can now say 'hey, Adora' inside her head anytime I want to?

Jihan let out another long sigh before responding, making Catra grin, both of her upper fangs protruding over her lower lip.

So young… so dumb… Yes, Cat-Tra. You can use the sacred telepathic link for your silly frivolities. More importantly, you can speak to Adora over long distances without the need for technology—especially during important missions.

Catra resumed walking behind Mermista and Adora, now focusing on the back of her wife's head.

Hey, Adora, she directed.

Nothing happened; Adora continued talking to Mermista without indicating she had heard Catra's thought projection.

It doesn't work that way, Cat-Tra. You must access a small amount of your Sher-Va power when speaking to Adora. Don't go too far, though! We don't need you bursting into green flames. Jihan said.

Catra nodded, focusing on the core aspect of what it was to be Sher-Va; truth. She felt the power surge inside her, eager to be released. But Catra clamped down on it, only allowing a small portion of that magic to transport her thoughts into Adora's head.

Hey, Adora, she projected.

Right away, Adora let out a small shriek as she jumped, turning around to stare at her wife.

"Are you okay, Adora? Like, did something bite you?" Mermista asked, looking around her friend for a buzzing insect.

"Uh, no, Mermista. It's just my jumpy nerves," Adora said, looking at Catra uncertainly. "It's nothing to worry about."

Seeming satisfied with that response, Mermista looked away as Catra gave her wife a mischievous grin.

Catra? Adora thought to herself.

Yep. Your worst nightmare has come true—I'm inside your head! Catra projected.

Catra was surprised to notice Adora nod—as if it all made sense.

Veth could do this, too—talk inside my head telepathically. They did it when they captured you to lure me into the forest. I forgot all about it. She thought.

Catra allowed the terrible memory of those moments pass briefly through her mind—being tricked and captured by Veth before

watching in horror as her wife was defeated and kidnapped, taken away from Catra only to be turned into Despara. Veth had later somewhat redeemed themselves by trading their life for Catra's, but she still had a great deal of anger towards them, even though they were now dead. They had a lot to answer for regarding what they had done to Adora.

So now that we have found this new way to talk to each other, can I get back to Mermista? She is looking at me funny, Adora thought.

Wait a sec, Adora. I wanted to talk to you, Catra added quickly.

I know what she wants to talk about—here we go. Now my own wife doesn't believe in me, Adora thought, forgetting someone was hearing her internal dialogue. Catra balked, simultaneously feeling guilty and hurt that Adora felt that way.

Adora, I can hear everything you think, remember?

Her wife looked furtively back at Catra—shame apparent on her face.

I'm sorry, Catra. You know I'm going through a lot, and I have my own self-doubt I'm battling. Can I please not get it from you?

The desire to reassure her wife was so intense that Catra had to stop herself from rushing to Adora's side and clasping her hand. She never wanted any kind of a rift between them ever again—she had lost Adora just too many times for that.

Adora, please, I have not lost faith in you—I love you! I'm just worried that this may be too much too soon! Catra explained.

Adora's head lowered as she took this in, still walking forward down the Trollan streets. They had just turned a corner, the entrance to the Athenaeum in view—a sizeable ovoid door, bright orange in the light of the Trollan day.

I understand that, and I don't blame you for worrying—but we just don't have time for this. We have to stop what's happening, or there may not be anything left after Lethe is done—and if there is, it may be nothing worth living for.

Catra wanted to weep to hear Adora speak of not living; it was something she would say during the long war back on Etheria, the first time she lost Adora.

I don't want anything to happen to you, Adora—you are what I am living for! Why don't you just let me go? One Champion should be enough to handle this! Catra pleaded.

At once, Adora stopped to turn around and pin Catra with her striking blue eyes. There was an intensity there, the same ferocity Catra saw after the incident with the portal. She had thought Adora had hated her then—but seeing that same look now—knew it wasn't the case; whatever she was about to say, Adora was unshakable in her resolve to see it done. Mermista had ceased walking forward to watch this interaction, completely confused as to what was going on between the two women.

I understand, Catra—truly, I do. I know how you feel because I feel the exact same way—there is no way you are going through that gate and into the unknown without me. How do you think I would feel if something happened to you? She thought.

Now Catra couldn't help herself—going straight for Adora, she wrapped her arms around her wife, hugging her tightly. Adora returned the embrace in equal measure, and for a small moment in time, the two were one.

"We will do this together, then," Catra said, batting the tears from her eyes.

"Always and forever," Adora returned.

A soft sound interrupted the two lovers from their embrace; turning simultaneously, they found Mermista watching them, appearing as if she would cry.

“Like, I don’t know what’s going on between you two, but you’re really making me miss Seahawk right now,” she complained, waving both hands at her eyes.

Catra and Adora laughed as they went to their friend, each picking a side to wrap an arm around Mermista’s midsection, directing her towards the Athenaeum.

“Sorry, that just happens sometimes,” Adora apologized.

“Yeah,” Catra said with a laugh. “We just call these moments *our spontaneous displays of affection*—it happens after you take the Vow,”

Catra caught Adora’s eye behind Memista’s head, catching a wink from her wife, which made her begin to purr in contentment.

“Oh… I love it when you do that, Catra,” Mermista mused. “I wish Seahawk could purr,”

“Does crooning count?” Adora said. “He is good at that.”

Mermista chuckled at that—it was the first time Catra had heard her laugh in a very long time—long before the Vetala turned her. Even before losing her empathy, Mermista was not known to display many emotions.

“I really missed having friends; I was so lonely the whole time I was lost,” Mermista said, wrapping her arms around each of her friends.

“Me too,” Adora said. “I’m sure Scorpia is feeling the same way.”

Adora halted the other two as she held out her hand.

“How about we go get her together?” She offered.

Catra promptly seized the proffered hand as Mermista contemplated the gesture.

“Does this mean I get to be part of the Best Friend’s Squad?” She asked.

Adora laughed. “Sure. Why not. I mean, we let Catra in, didn’t we? I’d say that any standards we once had have since gone out the window!”

Catra leered at Adora as Mermista joined her hand to the others, cementing their alliance to a common cause; the return of Scorpia and the defeat of Lethe’s plans. The three then returned their attention to the Athenaeum, resuming their course towards the Trollan dimensional gate. The route to the center of the strange building was much simpler than the first time Catra had come here; instead of a circuitous course through a maze of chambers, there was now a straight path, courtesy of Scorpia’s Void Gem. It was not long before they were standing before the stone ring suspended from the ceiling by four thick chains. The position of the Trollan sun was such that a beam of light pierced the gate, illuminating the translucent interior. Catra could detect intricate lines inside—like circuitry inside a computer—reminding her of the First One’s technology on Etheria, only in a different vein.

“Okay,” Mermista said, removing the vial from her body suit and unstopping the top. She looked uncertainly at the glowing fluid inside, appearing not to want anything to do with it now that they were ready for her to open the portal.

“Here,” Adora said, removing a clip from her hair. Since her time as Despara, Adora had decided to grow her hair back; it was now in that awkward phase between long and short where hairpins became critical.

Mermista took the clip gratefully, bending it into position so she could dip one end into the Antithetical Philter without having to touch it. With one end wetted with the glowing fluid, she proceeded to write incantations on the surface of the gate; to Catra’s Madgēcot eyes, the symbols appeared wrong; something about them provoked feelings of indifference. They were evil words, and Catra could tell it pained Mermista to write them. Once

completed with her work, Mermista backed away from the gate, looking at it with expectation.

"Soooo… like, that should have worked," she said. "I did it just as Lethe taught me, and I saw Scorpia open the gate the same way."

Adora stood next to Mermista, inspecting the gate intently.

"Maybe it's because you had your empathy returned? It only works for those who are enervated?" She proposed.

"Maybe? I have no idea," Mermista said sorrowfully.

"Okay, ladies, stand back—this looks like a job for a Madgēcot," Catra said, walking up to the stone ring with clawed hands held out.

"By the power of The Great Chaliendra Tree and all the Madgēcots —I—Catra, command you to open!!!!" She cried.

Mermista watched this display with wide eyes as Adora shrieked with laughter; Catra placed her hands on her hips, giving her wife a hurt look.

"That was good, Catra!" Adora said, still laughing. "Did you really think that would wor—"

Adora's words were abruptly cut off as a sudden explosion of magical energy burst forth from the center of the ring. All three women backed away from the gate as the turbulence settled into a glimmering surface—a portal to another dimension.

"Told you it would work," Catra said smugly. Adora stared incredulously at the fluid surface, eyes narrowing as she pointed.

"Something is coming through!" She cried.

Whipping her head towards the portal, Catra's eyes discerned movement within the rippling surface; a person was coming through—leg extending out with a head and torso not far behind.

It was a young man; his long dark hair hung loosely about a handsome face. Catra realized she recognized this person; he was still wearing the same strange black jacket as the last time she saw him—before he had sacrificed himself to save them all.

"Shen?" Catra asked in disbelief. The likelihood of this being some trick was too great. She just could not believe her friend was alive and back with her, here and now. But when he caught sight of Catra, the look in his eye was too genuine to be faked; this was Shen, one of her best friends.

"Hey, Catra," he said, smiling. It was a smile he always had for Catra—genuinely happy to see her, but with an underlying sense of sadness.

Catra did not hesitate as she rushed forward to wrap Shen in a tight embrace, making him yelp in surprise.

"Shen!!! I can't believe it; you're alive!" Catra cried happily, lifting her friend off the ground in her exuberance.

"Uh! Yeah, it's me; I'm alive… for now…" Shen groaned.

Catra set him down, seizing his face in her clawed hands to gaze at his face. She was torn between a strange sense of wanting to tear him to pieces or hug him again, but before she could decide, Adora and Mermista were to either side of her, overjoyed to see their friend again.


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“Adora! Mermista! Your back to normal!” Shen exclaimed. “Wait… your back to normal, right?”

Both Mermista laughed at this, taking turns embracing the newly arrived Shen and confirming that they were indeed back to their usual selves.

Catra felt so happy at that moment—it was happening; everyone she had lost was returning to her, and now all that was left was Scorpia. She started purring again and knew the dumbest smile was plastered on her face—but she didn’t care.

“I’m so glad your back, you dummy!” Catra exclaimed. “I wanted to tell you—”

Before Catra could finish, another shape came through the portal, one she also recognized as her tail bushed up. A Nephraeh wearing pants made of those strange black bands—they were also wearing the white jacket Catra had seen them in last, although it appeared torn and burned now. It was the betrayer—Veth—also alive and here to take those Catra cared for away.

“Look out!” Catra shrieked, pushing Shen out of the way and reaching for the sky.

“BY THE TRUTH OF GRAYSKULL!”

Veth’s silver eyes widened as they realized Sher-Va/Catra was coming for them, golden gauntlets extended out to rip and tear. Even though they had saved her life once, there was no way Sher-Va/Catra would take the chance and allow them to hurt the ones she loved—not again.

This time, Veth was going to pay.

Chapter End Notes

Both illustrations by Miledibuja, you can find their art on Tumblr, Instagram, and Twitter.

Back to the Hard Reality

Chapter Summary

Veth faces the music.

Perfuma experiences firsthand the meaning of godhood.

Glimmer makes a return trip to Thenlor.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A translation of body and spirit suffused Veth's consciousness as they briefly traveled through the realm between realms, their six senses assaulted by an array of stimuli that went outside the bounds of what even their advanced brain could handle. Thankfully this experience was brief, and with a surge of profound dizziness, Veth stepped into another dimension. It took them a moment to realign their awareness; their physical and spiritual sight overlapped in such a confusing manner it took them a moment to realize what they were witnessing.

Veth was in a room much like the one in which they found themselves upon arriving in the Timeless Dimension. Before them, they recognized the quintessence of Shen; his soul was being enveloped by another, in what Veth could rationalize as a hug. This other person's vital force burned bright with happiness to have this person back; Veth could observe this as an expression of a great bank of sadness immediately evaporating. There were two other souls nearby—also expressing delight to see Shen. Veth's keen hearing finally caught up with the rest of their focusing perceptions to pick up what was being said.

"I'm so glad your back, you dummy! I wanted to tell you—"

Veth's physical vision allowed them to discern that the person greeting the human was a Madgēcot woman—no, it was Catra!

And to either side of her was Despara—no, it is Adora now! Veth noted a dark cloud around her quintessence, like a misty haze, but the core glowed brightly with empathy. Mermista was also there, her inner life force displaying much of the same quality as Adora's, both showing evidence of their time under Archon Lethe's dark sway.

"Look out!" Catra abruptly screamed, shoving Shen away from herself. The human fell to the ground with an expulsion of breath as Veth was once again plunged into confusion.

Is there danger here? Did the Crimson Council follow us? They thought.

Before they could look behind them, Catra did something completely unexpected; raising one hand into the air, she shouted something Veth had only read in their history lessons.

"BY THE TRUTH OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

Why is Catra saying the words of activation for Sher-Va? The sword is—"

Veth's thoughts evaporated as Catra's body burst into jade flames; she was covered from head to toe in the magical conflagration of transformation. The form that was Catra grew in size, and when the inferno dissipated, a magnificent Madgēcot warrior stood in her place. Shining gold armor adorned a crimson Jaadoo suit, and under the crest of a sweeping headpiece, two glowing heterochromatic feline eyes pinned the Nephraeh Champion in their place. To witness this new version of Catra filled Veth with a feeling of awe—but this immediately turned to terror as she rushed them, her clawed gauntlets reaching out to rip them to shreds.

"Catra! Wait!" Veth cried.

Ducking at the last second, Veth barely missed a sideways slice that struck the Trollan gate; it exploded into rock fragments that clattered to the floor. Sher-Va/Catra let out a low yowl of anger at

being denied her prey—with tail twitching in irritation—she cast about the strewn rubble for Veth. But they rolled out of range of her claws, rising to their feet to raise their own hand to desperately summon the means to their only salvation.

"BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!"

A force slammed into Veth's side mid-transformation; it seemed Sher-Va/Catra wasn't going to wait for their elevation to Zhe-La, seeking to end the fight before they could even the odds. But magically summoned Aegis Lace and reinforced Nephraeh armor thwarted Madgēcot claws just in time to save Veth's tender lilac skin from violence, and Zhe-La/Va shoved Sher-Va/Catra away from themselves as they rose to their feet.

"I don't want to fight you, Catra!" Zhe-La/Veth shouted.

Sher-Va/Catra looked at them curiously—her head tilted with ears lowered—and it took Zhe-La/Veth a moment to realize she was thrown off by their new appearance. But then she shook her head as she bared her lengthened incisors.

"Too bad!" She responded, extending gold-tipped claws.

Zhe-La/Veth summoned their sword just in time to block the next attack—sparks flew from their blade as Sher-Va/Catra lashed out, trying to bypass their guard. But her attacks were wild, driven primarily by emotion, and she growled in fury as her opponent shoved her away. Zhe-La/Veth could not help noticing that the passion which had plagued them for days was also there—but instead of unhinging them like Sher-Va/Catra—it honed their martial talents to a fine point. It flowed through them with a vigor, enhancing their Champion abilities like never before. In the past, Zhe-La/Veth would take empathy from their enemies via the power of Oblivion—now they found that the same emotion empowered them, making them stronger than Archon Lethe ever could.

“I won’t let you hurt them!” Sher-Va/Catra shrieked as she kicked out with a taloned foot.

Zhe-La/Veth didn’t bother dodging the attack; instead, they seized her shin as they pivoted on their heel, sending the Madgēcot Champion crashing into the opposite wall. She cried out as her body gouged a hole in the magically sensitive stone, causing untold destruction to the already abused chamber.

“I’m not going to hurt anyone, Catra!” Zhe-La/Veth shouted. “I came back to fix my mistakes—not cause more pain!

Sher-Va/Catra regarded them with weary eyes as another voice broke the silence of the stalemate.

“FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL!!!”

With reluctance, Zhe-La/Veth turned to spot She-Ra/Adora striding towards them. They took a moment to acknowledge the changes to her Champion form—the silver instead of gold—and instantly knew that the transition was tied to the psychological anguish Adora had withstood. Zhe-La/Veth felt guilt at this, knowing that they were the one who was responsible for causing this suffering. Zhe-La/Veth vowed that if they survived this altercation, they would do everything in their power to make it right.

Unlike her wife, She-Ra/Adora’s posture was more controlled as she held her sword in a guard position, approaching Zhe-La/Veth cautiously. But like Sher-Va/Catra, there was anger on She-Ra/Adora’s face, mixed with something akin to torment; it was the cold rage of a person injured, looking to lash out at the one who hurt them.

“Adora! Please!” Zhe-La/Veth pleaded. She-Ra/Adora only shook her head, unwilling to hear their appeal.

“I remember, Veth,” she said, voice quavering. “I remember you holding me as your master came for me. I remember you covering my eyes—the last thing I saw was black teeth right before a piece of my soul was torn from me!”

She-Ra/Adora was close now—Zhe-La/Veth noticing her body aligning, preparing to spring into action.

"*Just calm down, Adora*—you said. *It will be over quickly*," She-Ra/Adora said, voice brimming with emotion. "Well, Veth, it wasn't over quickly—not by a long shot. But unlike what you did to me, I won't make you suffer!"

Not waiting for a response, She-Ra/Adora lunged at Zhe-La/Veth, trying to slip past their guard with speed and surprise. Zhe-La/Veth jerked their sword down at the last second to deflect her silver sword, earning a minor wound to their side instead of impalement. She-Ra/Adora continued her assault, probing Zhe-La/Veth's defenses with rapid-fire jabs of her sword—but the Nephraeh Champion's technique was supreme—and they thwarted every one of her attempts to strike them.

All of a sudden, She-Ra/Adora backed away from her opponent, her eyes like two blue chips of ice as she held her blade up, pommel face directed towards Zhe-La/Veth. A prismatic beam lanced out from the gem inset into the guard, which Zhe-La/Veth batted away with their sword. The magical energy steaked upward, blasting a gaping hole where once a section of the ceiling existed.

Zhe-La/Veth and She-Ra/Adora parted momentarily, allowing large chunks of the ancient masonry to fall between them—Zhe-La/Veth used this time to study their opponent—comparing her current fighting aptitude with the last time they had fought She-Ra/Adora. Her experience as Despara undoubtedly tempered her, and like the heating process for metal, She-Ra/Adora's strength came with an increased brittleness. She was deeply afraid—not of the person before her—but of herself, of what Adora could do with her She-Ra power. Zhe-La/Veth knew firsthand what this stemmed from; they were there when Despara had brutally killed the Enosian Mech Pilot. Despara had committed other atrocities in the name of the Empyrean Empire, and Zhe-La/Veth knew the burden of that guilt must be weighing down on the other Champion's soul; if she were not careful, the pain of it would smother her.

She-Ra/Adora was now stepping over the rubble, sword held back with the tip directed at the floor, ready to sweep up and bisect the Empyrean Champion if they were not careful. It was a brutal intention, most likely a remnant of Despara in She-Ra/Adora's psyche—left over like a sour taste. Even knowing that their opponent wanted to inflict maximum harm upon them, Zhe-La/Veth was filled with a profound desire to help the other Champion. Looking at the diaphanous cords of sorrow hanging from She-Ra/Adora's quintessence like sticky ropes, Zhe-La/Veth knew they could do it. They could use their Light to—if not break them—loosen them enough that She-Ra/Adora could break free of her prison.

She-Ra/Adora attacked, directing her blade upward towards their midsection, and as Zhe-La/Veth steered their own weapon to intercept the stroke—she halted and reversed—pivoting on her heel to drive the tip of her sword into their leg. Zhe-La/Veth cried out as they tried to dodge the stab, the razor edge glancing off the armor to slide across their upper thigh. The ordinarily sturdy Aegis Lace parted as the magical metal bit into the flesh under, and Zhe-La/Veth's earlier outcry was repeated at a more high-pitched octave. She-Ra/Adora flinched at the pain in their voice, and Zhe-La/Veth saw the bindings upon her quintessence tighten at the sound; hurting them was having a much more significant impact on her. Zhe-La/Veth saw their opening.

"Adora, listen to me," Zhe-La/Veth ventured. "Please, let's stop fighting and talk about this. I know you don't want to hurt me,"

She-Ra/Adora gritted her teeth as she tried to hang on to her anger, and Zhe-La/Veth could tell their words were affecting her; all they had to do was keep up the pressure. Suddenly, they had an idea. Focusing on their prime Champion power, Zhe-La/Veth brought forth a tiny portion of Light; it radiated outward from their core like a beacon of hope. She-Ra/Adora's eyes fixed on the Light as she recognized it for what it was; goodness and love beyond measure. She looked up at Zhe-La/Veth's face with absolute confusion, unable to process the duality of something so good within something she had perceived as evil. Zhe-La/Veth

observed her quintessence as the intent to do damage to them slowly faded, replaced by an openness to listen.

"I—" She-Ra/Adora said, dropping her sword arm to reach with the other. There was a need on her face, a look of desperation to be free of her grief. Zhe-La/Veth would give it to her—gladly—and they proceeded forward, looking to lessen the distance between them.

"GET AWAY FROM HER!!!"

A whirlwind of crimson, claws, and gold struck Zhe-La/Veth, sending them reeling to the floor under an intense onslaught. They barely get their gauntleted wrists up in time to block the fury of Sher-Va/Catra as she resumed her attempts to cut them to ribbons. Zhe-La/Veth dismissed their sword, leaving their hands free to grab their attacker's writs; Sher/Va-Catra immediately bore down on them in response, squeezing their midsection with her knees. Simultaneously, the Madgēcot warrior leaned in, opening her mouth wide to reveal longer upper and lower fangs, which immediately clamped down on one of their forearms.

"YAAAGHH!!!" Zhe-La/Veth yelled, wrenching their arm from her jaws.

Not finished with her assault, Sher-Va/Catra batted Zhe-La/Veth's helmet with such force they were left blinking away tears as she leaped back to land in a crouch.

"I had a feeling you would taste good, Veth," Sher-Va/Catra said, licking her chops.

Zhe-La/Veth seethed with anger as they rose unsteadily to their feet, clutching their wounded arm to their chest. By now, She-Ra/Adora had overcome her uncertainty, standing beside her wife in solidarity against the one who tried to drive them apart. Zhe-La/Veth re-summoned their sword as they prepared to face the wrath of the two Champions of Grayskull, unsure if there was an option to surrender or fight to the death for their crimes. Try as

they might, Zhe-La/Veth could not fault the two women for their anger; the Empyrean Champion had betrayed them in the worst way, playing on the empathy of Catra to achieve the goals of Archon Lethe. A part of them wanted to put down their sword and accept whatever Catra and Adora had in mind for them—but before they could do anything—Zhe-La/Veth was seized by an unseen force, instantly freezing them in place.

"I figured it was time I lent you a hand, ladies," a familiar and bored voice said.

Only able to move their eyes, Zhe-La/Veth spotted Mermista walking towards them, her Staff of Power held out as she held them in the grip of infinite friction. Zhe-La/Veth struggled against the power of the Kinetic Krystal, drawing on their awakened Nephraeh emotions to fuel the might of Zhe-La. They could feel the prison flex as they exerted her will against it—but it was happening too slowly; She-Ra/Adora and Sher-Va/Catra were approaching, their respective weapons held out to end them.

"NO! BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

After a brief flash of brilliance, He-Man/Shen came into view, pushing past Zhe-La/Veth's tormenter to stand before them, shielding them from further harm.

"Everyone, just stop! This is a mistake!" He said, facing his three friends with arms held out.

All three women looked at He-Man/Shen as if he had lost his mind —then looked amongst themselves uncertainly before Sher-Va/Catra spoke up.

"Shen, you know what they did to us. You sure about this?" She asked.

He-Man/Shen nodded emphatically, and Zhe-La/Veth could not help noticing the stripes of white-hot electricity in his hair. If they were not being held entirely motionless, the urge to touch it

would have seen them poking one of the dazzling streaks with a claw tip.

Sher-Va/Catra turned to Mermista and nodded—Zhe-La/Veth immediately felt the effects of the Kinetic Krystal release them, and they sagged against He-Man/Shen's back, completely spent having battled two Champions and a bearer of a Staff of Power.

"Thanks, Human," they mumbled into his ear.

He-Man/Shen chuckled.

"Anytime, Nephraeh," he said.

The sound of a clearing throat broke the silence; lifting their head from He-Man/Shen's shoulder, Zhe-La/Veth turned to spot the diminutive form of Orko huddling in the corning of the space. He was not floating but settled on the ground, appearing as if he had tried to hide under his hat during the conflict.

Veth had completely forgotten that they had dragged the Trollan with them through the portal, unable to leave him behind to face the consequences of helping them escape. In retrospect, it might not have been Zhe-La/Veth's choice to take Orko from the only life he knew—but it was a split-second decision driven purely by compassion. Now Orko was here in their dimension, and the only choice was to make the best of it. Looking at the ruined state of the gate, there was no going back.

"What the heck is that!?" Sher-Va/Catra exclaimed, her massive tail bushing up to the size of a small tree.

Happy at the prospect of someone's attention, Orko lifted into the air, beginning to glide over toward Sher-Va/Catra. He came to a screeching halt when the Madgēcot Champion bared her fangs and hissed loudly, her tail beating the air in agitation.

"Adora! What should I do?! Should I attack it?!" Sher-Va/Catra asked.

“NO!” He-Man/Shen cried, now placing himself between Orko and danger as Zhe-La/Veth stumbled forward. “Catra! Just stand down; there is no one here you need to fight! He is a Trollan, and he is with us! We would have never escaped the Timeless Dimension if it weren't for him!”

She-Ra/Adora suddenly reverted form, becoming just Adora as she strode forward, excitement dawning on her face.

“A Trollan! Wow!” She said, stopping to kneel before Orko, the action being completely unnecessary for someone who could rise and fall to meet another’s height. She extended her hand to Orko, who took it happily.

“Hello.” Adora said, speaking slowly. “My. Name. Is. Adora. What. Is. Yours?”

Despite their injured state, Zhe-La/Veth couldn’t help feeling amused at this scene. Orko peered back at the woman speaking to him; his head cocked quizzically.

“Greetings. Adora.” He said, matching her cadence. “My. Name. Is. Orko. I. Am. So. Happy. To. Meet. You. Is. There. Anyway. We. Could. Speak. Faster?”

Adora stood up quickly, looking around, slightly embarrassed, before answering.

“Sure! We can do that!” She said with a nervous laugh.

Reverting out of their Champion form, Veth took stock of their many injuries. Besides the many bruises and perhaps one broken bone, there was the puncture wounds on their arm—plus the deep laceration on their leg. With a surreal sense of dislocation, Veth inspected the blood oozing out of them; instead of the indigo glow they were used to, it was now more of a blue luminescence. It was a subtle change in the color spectrum, but to Veth, the meaning was monumental.

“Are you going to be okay?” Shen asked nearby. Veth hadn’t even noticed that he had returned to an unenhanced state, but he was standing close to them, arm held out in an offer of support. Testing the injured leg, Veth limped from the pain; they were going to have a hard time walking anywhere on their own. Surprising even themselves, they reached out, interlocking their arm with Shen’s and allowing him to bear a small fraction of their weight. After what they had been through together, it felt so natural to rely on the human.

Sher-Va/Catra was the only one who remained in her Champion form, watching Veth with suspicious glowing eyes. Veth could tell the fierce Madgēcot did not like seeing the traitorous Nephraeh so close to her friend, and it was taking every ounce of her respect for the human not to say anything.

Finally, with a soft shimmer of jade flames, Sher-Va/Catra reduced in size, becoming just Catra once more. She padded over to the side of Shen opposite Veth, laying a clawed hand on his shoulder as she smiled at him.

“I really am glad to have you back, Shen. Adora and I have Darla nearby in a spaceport; let's all go there. Maybe on the way you can tell me what’s going on?” She offered.

Shen nodded to his friend before giving Veth a gentle nudge indicating that they should move. They did so—awkwardly at first—mainly for the fact that they were holding back, not wanting to burden someone else with their inadequacies. But after seeing no future in proceeding in this fashion, Veth gave in, leaning into Shen fully. The two moved better this way, the sudden ease of their shared travel noticed by both parties.

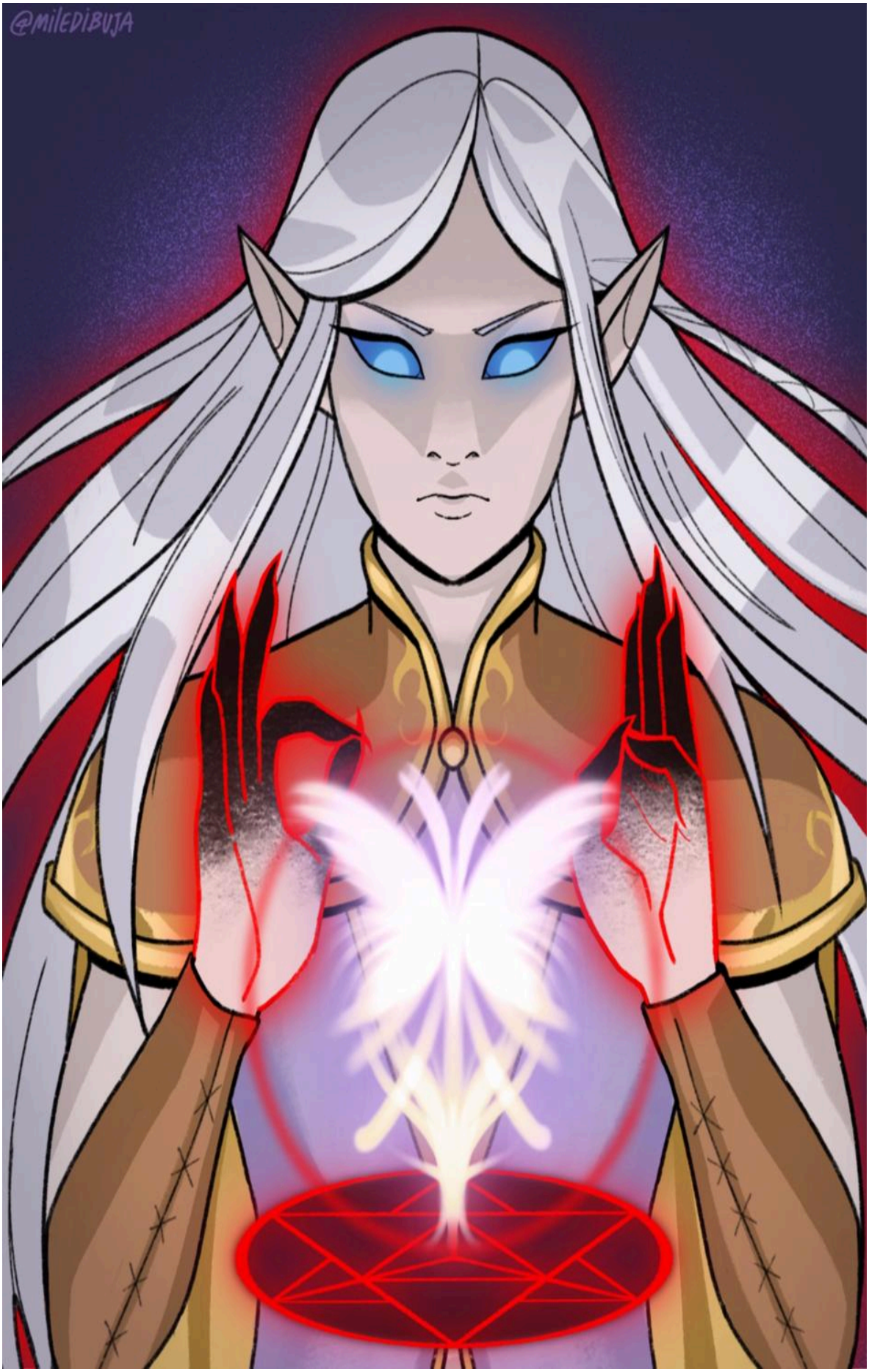
“See? Isn’t that better?” Shen commented.

Veth grunted their assent, wanting the human to think this was no big deal—but inwardly, they thanked all the stars in the galaxy that Nephraeh were not made to blush.

* * *

Perfuma could not help wringing her fingers together, over and over, as beads of sweat broke out all over her body. The last time she had been this anxious, Scorpia was about to give her testimony before the war crimes tribunal of Etheria after the defeat of Horde Prime. But where the fear of Scorpia's fate came from a more personal place, this dread concerned the future of far more than just her girlfriend—with Perfuma's knowledge of the matters at hand, the number of lives affected by what transpired before her was beyond counting.

Perfuma had watched with horror as both He-Ro and Thon-Ra were taken from the Well of Spirits by Lethe; they had reached right into the egg-shaped crystal as if were a birdcage, their hands passing directly through the hard surface as if it were only air. The spirits were extracted one at a time, the amorphous shapes fluttering like moths within the spindly fingers enclosing them like black prison bars. Perfuma had to cover her ears as each Champion Spirts emitted a piercing shriek just before crystalline containers were spun in place around them, the material used their making summoned from an unknown neither region by Lethe's foul abilities.


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Once ensconced within their containers, two Vetala were brought forth, Lethe opening their oily black chests with razer claws before thrusting the receptacles within. The creatures did not seem fazed by the procedure, their open chest cavities sealing in place over their new passengers—but Perfuma was affected by what she was witnessing—so much so that she wanted to vomit. Lethe did not care that what they were doing was an abomination, and as Perfuma was about to find out, they were not about to stop with the perversion of the bond between Champion Spirit and bearer. They were going to go much, much further.

The altered Vetala walked toward the circle of seven pylons, stopping before two in particular; somehow, the undead beings knew which crystal pillar complemented the passenger inside them. As they placed cold hands against the flawless surface, a low hum vibrated out from within the pylon as it began to glow—one a radiant blue, the other a soft orange.

As this occurred, Lethe walked amongst the unattended pylons, daubing at a self-inflicted cut on their arms to inscribe obscene sigils over the runes there. Once they were finished, Lethe brought forth Perfuma's Life Gem staff, performing an incantation before each befouled pylon as enervated minions sang behind them, the sound of which made Perfuma dizzy with its absolute depravity.

Once these preparations were complete, Lethe sat cross-legged in the exact middle of the circle and closed their eyes. An eerie chant began to emanate from deep within their throat, performed in conjunction with a series of rapid hand movements, the likes of which only a god could perform. Perfuma could not help herself now; she gazed with rapt fascination at Lethe's arcane abilities on display. The pylons desecrated by Lethe's writing began to issue their perspective light: red, yellow, green, indigo, and purple—but it was a lambent radiance, not as profuse as the pylons activated the altered Vetala.

Perfuma was starting to hope this divergence meant Lethe's attempt to open the doorway to Subternia would fail—but then a

low buzz filled the air—making her bones tickle and all the hairs on her body stand on end. A sense of potentiality filled Perfuma's being, a feeling that went beyond the cosmic and into the countless realms beyond. Perfuma perceived the geode-like cavern that was the Vestibule begin to fade, slowly being replaced by something else beyond her current capacity to describe.

Prismatic shapes, the colors of which exceeded that of the normal spectrum, coalesced into endless mandalas that corkscrewed into infinity. A confusing explosion of sound emanated from each of these configurations, reflecting off her eardrums in such a manner that it was not heard but tasted. Her body felt as if it were flying towards this madness, yet at the same time, Perfuma felt as if it were permeating into her body.

In between all this chaos, Perfuma could make out pathways, each leading to its own actuality. Focusing on each of these stable points, Perfuma was amazed that she could make out whole realities within— entire galaxies and universes were instantly known to her, making her want to either pass out from the overload or exult in the absolute totality of understanding.

There was only one word for what she was experiencing, one which had become increasingly known to her given her proximity to Lethe.

This is what it is like to be a god.

Abruptly, the view of Subternia vanished, replaced by the solidity of ordinary reality as the two altered Vetala exploded into black muck, leaving the crystalline containers within them to smash upon the crystal dais. Thon-Ra and He-Ro zipped up from the fragments of their individual prisons, seeking sanctuary within the Well of Champion spirits as Lethe's blood sigils fizzled and evaporated, leaving each of the pylons unpolluted by their taint. Perfuma felt such a surge of elation that she had to suppress the urge to shout; for now, Lethe was denied access to limitless power.

The orchestrator of this endeavor remained untouched; Lethe continued to sit cross-legged after the attempt failed, but after a few moments, opened their burning eyes.

"So, close. I am so very close…" they whispered before turning their indigo gaze upon the group of enervated minions waiting just outside the circle of pylons.

One stepped forward—Norae—her name was. Perfuma remembered that she had been a senior Acolyte from Mystacor—back before she was bitten by a Vetala. Castaspella had tasked her with categorizing the tomes and scrolls kept deep within the dungeon of Caste Grayskull, in the same area as the Abominable Powers. Much of this writing was known to contain corrupt spells, unnatural conjurations, and vile procedures for the creation of tainted artifacts. Perfuma made the connection immediately.

"I apologize, My Lord, that should have worked. I promise I will search for a much more suitable spell, one worthy of—" Norae began to say but was silenced with a wave of Lethe's hand.

"The spell was fine, my dear Child. It is the best suited for this task; we just need a little more vigor behind it. Perhaps one or two more Champion Spirits," Lethe said, turning their head to pin Perfuma in place with their indigo gaze.

"I'm sure my *dear Scorpia* will not let me down," they said, giving Perfuma a black grin.

Perfuma clenched her fists in rage at the taunt, wanting so very badly to play her wild card and speak the name of Jihan. But with a slow exhalation of breath, she calmed the tempest within and reviewed why that was not a good idea.

I still don't know if it will work—what would happen to Scorpia if I tried and nothing happened? Lethe would kill her! She thought before remembering what had just occurred before her.

But what would happen to all those realities if Lethe gains access to Subternia? They would feed on a bottomless source of

empathy, and evil would rule absolutely!

As if on cue, Lethe emitted an ululation of joy as they pointed at the Well of Champion Spirits. Perfuma's heart fell as she spotted a third nebulous shape within; it seemed that Scorpia was successful, and Wun-Dar had joined their companions. Perfuma felt panic as the impossible choice once again reared its ugly head.

"Prepare yourselves, My Children," Lethe said, clapping their hands. "We are going to give this another try,"

* * *

Once again, Glimmer found herself gazing out of the Millennial Seagull's forward viewport as the starship landed on the immense building Double Trouble called Eleutheria. The last time Glimmer visited Thenlor, she had been uncertain of what she would find—not so this time around. This time Glimmer knew precisely what she would find here.

Peering through the sheets of rain pelting the landing pad, Glimmer spotted the two large double doors opening as four cloaked figures strode out, moving fast toward the waiting ship.

"Hurry! Open the gangway!" Glimmer said to Seahawk at the pilot's controls.

Before he could respond, Glimmer was scurrying out of the cramped cockpit, making her way through the twisting corridors to the ship's hatchway in the center of the craft. She watched as the two large pistons projected toward, extending the gangway under the spacecraft to the deck below. The Millennial Falcon's new passengers scurried up the ramp, eager to escape the cold wetness; the one in the lead pulled his hood down to smile at Glimmer with fatherly love.

"Baby girl!" Micah exclaimed.

“Daddy!” Glimmer replied, wrapping her arms around her father, wet robe and all.

Castapella was beaming at the reunion as the other two visitors looked doubtfully at each other.

“*Baby girl*?” Panga whispered to Double Trouble, a single eyebrow raised.

“*I know, Kitten. And she calls him Daddy still. Can you imagine?”* They responded with a hush.

Glimmer hugged her aunt before casting a dubious look toward the Madgēcot and the Imp.

“Double Trouble, Panga; even though the circumstances seem worse than the last time I was here, it’s good to you again,” she said in greeting. “Did you come out just to say hi?”

Panga turned her yellow eyes on Double Trouble, seeming to pierce them with her feline gaze as they tried to look away.

“Atreyen…” She said with warning.

“Oh, okay!” Double Trouble huffed. “Kitten and I are going to join you on this little jaunt. It seems that with the high stakes—”

Double Trouble pause here to make the quotation sign, two clawed fingers curling at either side of their head.

“—you know, *Castle Grayskull* and all. Well, it would probably be better for you to have a Bearer of the Orb of Entropy and a sexy Star Hunter warrior at your side.”

Panga grinned at Double Trouble, giving them a playful bop with her hip.

“The Bearer of the Orb of Entropy is sexy, too,” she said with a purr.

Micah and Castaspella's eyes met; one rolled their eyes as the other made the sign for vomiting.

Glimmer beamed at all of them, feeling strengthened at having so many allies by her side. But it would not be enough—not for the enemy she knew they faced. As if sensing her thoughts, Double Trouble spoke up.

"So, *your Majesty,* you seem to be running this little shindig—what's first on the agenda? Are we going straight for Eternia, or do you have something else in mind?"

Glimmer nodded, giving everyone a look of absolute confidence—the expression of a queen.

"Unfortunately, we are going to have to ruin another honeymoon; we need She-Ra and Sher-Va now more than ever,"

Chapter End Notes

> Illustration by the fantastic Miledibuja! Check out her other art on Tumblr, Instagram, and Twitter!

The Immaru

Chapter Summary

Shen tries to patch Veth up as Catra and Adora receive a tongue-lashing.

Catra stumbles upon something that gives her a great deal of worry.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Veth! For the love of—hold still!"

Shen was trying—but mostly failing—to hold a lilac arm in place in order to suture the bite wounds closed—but the Nephraeh squirmed on the bed, seeming uncomfortable at being handled. But for once, Shen ignored someone else's desires; seeing the injury done to the other Champion filled him with an overwhelming desire to help them.

"Bah! Just—just let me do it… please!" Veth whined in response.

The two of them were in one of Darla's few cabins—alone together—but Shen could hear the others on the main bridge of the spaceship through the open door. There was an argument taking place; Catra's raised voice was unmistakable, but there was another whom Shen did not recognize. An older woman with a self-important tone, one who was used to people doing as they were told.

"No, Veth. How are you going to patch yourself using only one arm?" Shen argued.

Veth growled, plopping their head back down on the pillow as they stared miserably at the ceiling with glittering eyes.

“I could do it,” they said.

Veth spoke sullenly, but Shen noticed they did not try to fight him anymore, allowing him to lift their arm for inspection. Gently, he prodded the sleeve of the white jacket up but stopped when Veth bared their teeth in distress.

“Let me just take this off,” they said, sitting up to wiggle out of their jacket. Shen helped them take it off, holding the article of clothing up once it was off them. The white fabric of the outside was scuffed and dirty—added to that—it was dotted with holes from the fight against the Crimson Counsel and the other Champions.

“This coat of yours has seen better days, Veth,” Shen commented.

Veth waved their hand dismissively. “Just throw it away. It’s meaningless to me now,”

Shen stuck a finger in one of the gouges in the jacket, feeling the quality of its material. It was composed of three different layers: a lustrous outer surface, a middle made up of interlocking armor cords, so finely woven together as to be supple—and finally—a silky lining decorated with a pleasing pattern. A lot of care and effort had gone into a jacket that was clearly meant to be worn by someone of prominence; Shen didn’t understand why Veth would just want it thrown away. Surely it could be repaired with a little effort.

“What is the story behind this coat? “I feel like you wearing it has some special meaning,” Shen asked.

Veth turned away from him as a strained look crossed their lilac features; thinking they would ignore the question, Shen kneeled to address the wound on their forearm.

“It is called the Immaru—and wearing it is a mark of honor. It has been passed down from Champion to Champion for countless years—perhaps even before Archon Lethe. I was so proud to be gifted it when I was joined to Zhe-La; it represented everything I

thought was good with the Empyrean Empire and Archon Lethe. Now—"

Veth reached out to run a claw tip against its surface, tracing the jagged rents that marred its surface.

"I'm glad it looks like this now, for it is a false thing. It is good that it is broken—it deserves to be—much like its owner."

Shen continued to stare at the jacket a moment longer; he understood how Veth felt but could not help feeling a hint of sadness. If what Veth said was true, this jacket was old—ancient, even. Perhaps in days past, it represented honor and goodness—why can't it be that again?

"Do you think you deserve that beating you took?" Shen asked.

"Yes. Absolutely, I deserved it." Veth said, not even stopping to think about it. "There is no forgiveness for what I did to Catra and Adora. I betrayed their trust, used Catra's empathy against her, tried to drive a wedge between their love, and kidnapped Adora to be turned into a monster by Archon Lethe. I'd say I was about due for the beating,"

Shen weighed Veth's words; he had already heard about their crimes from Catra and remembered thinking that whomever this Veth was, they must be the worst kind of villain, entirely beyond redemption. But now, after spending so much time with the Nephraeh and discovering their story, he couldn't reconcile the two versions.

"I try not to go through life assuming I deserve anything—I've had too many horrible experiences to think that way. If I started to think that way, well…"

Shen's words died off as he looked down at this hand, clenching it into a fist.

"Veth, I want you to know I don't think you deserved to be hurt. I also think that, given time, Catra and Adora will see you as I do—

as someone who was mistreated in the past but did not let that crush the goodness in their heart. You should be given a second chance—not just with my friends—but with yourself. I will use the word I avoid and say that you *deserve* to forgive yourself."

For once, the Nephraeh had nothing to say as they considered Shen with glittering eyes. When the silence started to stretch into discomfiture, Shen cleared his throat loudly, putting the jacket to the side and turning his attention back to Veth's arm.

There were four holes in the forearm, perfectly spaced to the size of a large Madgēcot's mouth. He would need something to clamp the wounds closed before applying a bandage; after rummaging through the medical kit, Shen pulled out a pack of sutures.

"No," Veth said, pushing the medical supplies away. "Use the Aegis Lace—it's better."

Shen examined the only source of the unique Nephraeh material in the room—Veth's leggings—still clinging firmly to its owner. He moved to the leg opposite the injured one, holding out his hands as if about to cast a spell.

"Uh, okay," he said vaguely. "So how do I… uh… remove—"

"It's simple, Human," Veth said, clasping his hand in theirs. "Aegis Lace is a psycho-reactive material, keyed to the thoughts and emotions of the person who wears it. All you have to do is pick a section like this one—"

Veth guided Shen's hand to a strip of the glossy black material that began over their knee and ended at their hip. There he felt the material under his fingers—it was thin—like a whisper between him and the skin below.

"And pinching one end, pull it off as you imagine your intention." Veth finished, letting go of his hand.

Shen did as he was beckoned, taking a bit of the Aegis Lace between index and thumb and gently tugging it upwards. When

nothing happened, Shen turned to see an amused smile on Veth's face.

"Sorry, I just had to have a little fun," they said slyly. "Remember what I said about it being in sync with the wearer's thoughts and intentions? Hold on… now try,"

This time the section came away soundlessly, and Shen's heart started to beat faster as more and more light purple skin was revealed. He tried not to focus on the swirls and curves of the strange white markings unique to Veth's body, nor the fact that, in a fractional way, he was undressing them.

Just like the last time, once the strip of material was removed, the remaining sections inched together until the breach was sealed, fully covering the bare flesh. Shen was left staring mutely at the silky black ribbon in his hand as Veth watched him, a barely perceptible smile on their lips.

"Well? Are you going to bandage me up or let me bleed to death?" They asked.

"Oh! Okay!" Shen said, still sounding uncertain. "Did you do the thing?"

Veth's eyebrow shot up as the amusement written on their face increased by degrees.

"*Do the thing?"* They said in mimicry of his voice. "You mean, did I send a psychic command to it? No. It's no longer attached to me —you have it. You are in command of that piece of Aegis Lace."

Shen's mouth opened in a soundless "O" of comprehension as he gently took Veth's arm and started wrapping the material around their forearm. As he did so, he poured all of his intentions towards Veth into the psychically attuned Aegis Lace, pressing it firmly but gently in place, just as Veth did for him. When he was done, Veth lifted the dressed wound for inspection, clearly impressed by it.

“That is an exceptionally good dressing, Human. The throbbing has practically vanished, and the bite Catra gave me feels fully sealed,” they said, nodding with appreciation. “What exactly were you thinking when you bandaged me?”

Shen felt sweat on his forehead as panic passed over him; glancing at Veth, he saw that the Nephraeh was looking at him in that inscrutable way of theirs. He only shrugged, trying not to think about the fact that they were practically looking at his soul.

“Oh, you know, just this and that,” he said lamely. “I was just thinking ‘Heal Veth’ really hard, and I guess it worked!”

Veth tilted their head, appearing unconvinced. Shen tried to change the subject.

“Anyway, I was wondering. Why do you think you still have wounds? Shouldn’t you have healed when you were in your Zhe-La form? Or does your Champion form not do that?” He asked.

Veth pursed their lips as they nodded, their focus now off Shen.

“That is a good question,” they mused. “I do heal in my Zhe-La form; I can only guess these wounds were special. They were inflicted on me by other magical warriors, so I guess they don’t mend as well,”

Veth gave a non-committal shrug before rewarding Shen with a smile.

“I guess it’s a good thing I have you to patch me up,” they said.

Shen gritted his teeth in a rictus grin; it seemed he wasn’t off the hook yet.

“Since you’re so good at it, how about my leg?” Veth said, indicating the one that She-Ra/Adora had cut.

Shen inspected the injured leg; besides the lambent glow of Veth’s blood, the gash had since been covered by the bands of Aegis

Lace. He was confused by the need to bandage a cut that already appeared covered.

"Yes, I know what you are thinking," Veth added, seeing Shen's confusion. "But just because the Aegis Lace wraps my wound does not mean it has bound to it. I need you to help me as you did with my arm."

This did not assuage Shen's doubt, nor did it make sense.

Can't they reach their own leg? Why do they need me to do it? He thought.

But not wanting to seem churlish, Shen only shrugged, ready to be of service to the ailing Nephraeh.

"Sure." He said simply.

"Great!" Veth said, beaming. "Let me get these off first!"

With a jolt, Shen realized Veth was talking about their pants. He watched mutely as they reached for their waistband, pressing a black disc inset there—like an obsidian chip. Immediately there was a rustling sound, like dry grass in a gust of wind, and the many bands of Aegis Lace loosened.

"Come on, Human. Get my boots off, grab the bottoms of my pants, and pull," Veth instructed.

Even though he was dizzy, Shen did as he was told, trying to focus on a fixed point on the floor as he pulled first the boots and then the pants off. Once he removed the article of clothing, Shen pinched off a piece of the Aegis Lace, holding the limp material as he forced his attention to the injury and the injury only. This attempt at modesty failed as his eyes betrayed him, taking in Veth's bared lower torso in one glance.

Both legs were shapely; soft, supple muscles rippled under lilac skin. Shen was not surprised to see a sharp nail on every one of their toes—much like their fingers. Symmetrical white markings

ran from their shins to their thighs, disappearing under a pair of black briefs they wore as undergarments. Now, Shen finally did get his wandering gaze under control, flicking his eyes away before his imagination could run away with the impressions of what he had seen there.

Bending at the knee, Veth lifted their injured leg, giving Shen the space he needed to encircle it with the bandage. Shen saw a gash there, but just as he had suspected, it was partly sealed, well on the way to restoration. He frowned and glanced back at Veth's face—their expression was no longer inscrutable; there was a look of expectation mixed with a sense of something else… like…

Slowly, Shen ran the Aegis Lace around Veth's thigh, gently pressing it in place with both his hands and mind. He bit his lip when a finger deviated from its task to brush against smooth skin —with the utmost conviction—Shen tried not to let the contact give him an ounce of pleasure. Upon hearing a soft sigh, he looked up; Veth's silver eyes were heavy, their lips parted, baring their upper fangs in a look of—

"What in the name of Etheria is going on in here!?!?" A voice rang out.

Shen yelped as he stumbled away from Veth's ledge—turning— he saw Catra standing in the doorway, hands on hips as her stone-gray tail beat the air furiously. If that alone did not indicate how she felt, then the look of absolute anger on her cinnamon face was.

Uh oh, Shen thought. *This is not good.*

* * *

Catra stared out of Darla's forward viewport, trying to focus on the City of Trollos beyond the small spaceport. The buildings were tiered; their size steadily increased as they traveled inward from the city's edge, with the tallest in the center. The metropolis seemed to surge from the rocky landscape, almost as if it had

been carved from on big mountain—for a moment, Catra imagined just that—a bunch of floating Trollans waving their wands, chipping away the stone from a rocky peak to make their homes. She almost smiled at this thought—but then the incessant haranguing pierced her concentration.

"Thousands upon thousands of years' worth of history—ruined! All for what?! A brawl!?"

Catra's heterochromatic eyes narrowed as she spotted the subject of the speaker's ire; a cloudy plume rose from the middle of the city, the location of the Athenaeum—which, as of right now, was on fire.

How did that even happen? We didn't use magic during our fight that could have ignited anything, did we? Catra mused.

Three Champions of Grayskull were fighting each other, Cat-Tra. Any one of which could have destroyed the building by themselves. Jihan said in her mind.

"I *knew* we should not have allowed you two *miscreants* to stay in the city! I should have told that so-called Queen of Etheria that I don't care that one of you is She-Ra! That you wanted to come here on your honeymoon!"

Catra turned around to focus on the speaker: a middle-aged official-looking woman standing in front of the pilot's seat, hands on hips—Yariel, come to give them a tongue lashing for the damage done to her empty library. She was directing most of her wrath at Adora, who stood nearby with a forlorn expression.

"That's not totally fair, Yariel!" Adora cried. "There were these two people—actually, they are our friends. No, they *were* our friends until their empathy was taken from them. Eh—well, one is our friend again; she is right here. Tell her, Mermista! You know—about the mission?"

The Princess of Salineas was also on the bridge but appeared to be not paying attention to the goings on; she sat on one of the

long ledges before the large viewport, picking at her nails. Hearing her name spoken, Mermista looked up and yawned.

"Yep. Totally right." She said offhand. "Everything Adora is saying is correct."

Yariel crossed her arms, expelling an indignant huff at the explanation given to her.

"You people are incredible! So, the gist of what you are telling me is that you abused your invitation to stay on Trollos by inviting friends and throwing a party! That's what you did, isn't it?" Yariel screeched.

The fifth occupant of the bridge floated in a nearby corner, looking entirely out of place. Catra still wasn't sure what she made of Orko, and every time she got close to him, the fur on her tail started to itch. Catra could not help feeling sorry for the misplaced Orko; from what Shen told her, he had given up everything to save him and Veth. Now he was an outcast from his people and the dimension he was born in, never able to return.

"And on top of everything, you bring this *thing* to me and claim it is one of the mighty Trollans! Incredible!" Yariel cried, pointing an accusing finger at Orko.

Catra's tail whipped back and forth in suppressed anger as she watched Orko float down to the floor; she couldn't see his face but could see the abject misery written in his body language.

"As if!" Yariel continued, striding over to the cowering figure to continue her tirade.

"To think this miserable creature is part of the race that built the Great Arch of Zeitis! Or the upside-down castle of the Rubron Dynasty! Or even the Athenaeum, which you have destroyed!"

Orko surprised Catra then, perking up to hold a single blue finger in the air.

“Excuse me, madam, but it’s Rubreon Dynasty, not Rubron.” He said in a purely innocent manner.

Yadiel’s face instantly puckered up into a red balloon of rage as her response burst from her mouth like a volcanic eruption.

“HOW DARE YOU CORRECT ME, YOU INSOLENT CREATURE!!!”

With hand raised to strike, Yariel raced towards Orko as he resumed his cowering position, but before she could land a blow, her wrist was seized mid-strike.

“*Don’t even think about it,*” Catra said, her steely gaze pinning the older woman in place.

Yariel snarled as she pulled her arm out of Catra’s grip, whirling away in a sulk as she crossed her arms. Catra ignored this drama as she knelt before Orko, holding out a hand to the small being.

“It’s okay,” she said soothingly. “No one is going to hurt you here, I promise.”

With wide grateful eyes, Orko placed his blue hand into the offered cinnamon one; Catra laughed as the Trollan floated up from the floor, realizing that her assistance was not needed.

“I will never forget this, noble Madgēcot warrior,” Orko breathed.

“Touching,” Yariel said scornfully. “Yes, the heroic Madgēcot comes to save the day from the horrible scholar; *how brave*,”

Now it was Adora’s turn to step forward, her attempts at diplomacy utterly forgotten with the insult to her wife’s honor.

“Careful now, Yariel. Watch what you say next—I won’t hurt you permanently, but you will feel it for the next week,” she warned.

The scholar blanched as she backed away from the united front that was Catra and Adora—doubly so after Mermista stood up, arms crossed and gaze serious.

“Yeah, you should probably leave now,” the Princess of Salinas warned.

Yariel gaped at all three women, the fear turning to incredulity before returning to ire.

“Mark my words—you will regret what you have done here. There will be repercussions!” She threatened before turning towards Darla’s exit.

Catra was hot on the woman’s heels, eager to get the last word in before the scholar could escape. She followed Yariel through Darla’s exit and down the ramp, out into the bright Trollan sunlight.

“You know, Yariel, maybe one of those Champions you don’t believe exits had something to do with wrecking the Athenaeum. Did you ever think of that?” She said with a grin.

Ariel glanced back at her tormentor as she increased her stride; Catra stopped in place, placing her hands around her mouth to project her words.

“Oh, wait! There are no peer-reviewed research papers written on the subject—darn!” Catra finished, barely containing a cackle of laughter.

“Catra…”

Catra turned to see her wife standing nearby, her eyes scolding as her mouth suppressed a grin.

“Whaaat?” Catra complained. “Yariel deserved it; she’s a jerk! Did you see her try to hit Orko?!”

Adora’s mouth now pulled into a full grin as a flush appeared on her cheeks.

“Yeah, I also saw my hot wife stand up for him. You impress me more and more every day, Catra,” she said.

Now it was her turn to blush as Catra looked away, embarrassed. Adora seized her hand, pulling Catra and kissing her on the cheek.

“I don’t know why she was so upset,” Orko said behind them, surprising both women.

“I think we need to put a bell on you, Orko. I can’t have someone with no legs keep sneaking up on me,” Catra said with a chuckle.

“What do you mean by that? We destroyed something great; why shouldn’t she be upset?” Adora asked.

Orko’s head bobbed up and down in agreement. “Yes! If the Athenaeum still had the collection of great works within it, I would say it would have been a great loss. But the structure itself is a Conchifero—it's alive in a way—and when it was destroyed, it laid a seed for its renewal. Give it a year, and another building will be in its place—although the rooms will be different,”

Adora and Catra looked at each other, astonished at such a prospect as a building that could rebuild itself.

“Yariel could have learned a lot from you, Orko. If only she weren’t so blinded by her self-importance, she could have had all the answers so desperately sought,” Adora said, placing a hand on the Trollan’s slight shoulder. Catra saw that Orko did not seem encouraged by the words—quite the contrary—he seemed saddened by them.

“I’ve been informed recently that much of what I have learned in my life might be deemed ‘evil magic,’ perhaps no one should learn anything from me.” He said sadly.

“Who said your magic is evil?” Adora said, a hint of hostility in her voice.

“It was Veth; they said the magic the Trollans were using was evil,” Orko said, wringing his hands. “It’s the only kind of magic I know; I—“

“Wait,” Catra said, interrupting Orko’s words. “Veth said *your* magic is evil?”

Catra bent over, holding her sides as she started bellowing with laughter as poor Orko looked at the Madgēcot as if she had lost her mind.

“Veth is not anyone to talk, Orko—believe me!” Catra said, her expression suddenly becoming thoughtful.

“Speaking of our Nephraeh friend, I think I should go check on then,” Catra said as she began to stride back toward the extended gangway. Orko suddenly zipped in front of her, his proximity immediately making Catra itch all over.

“Oh, I will come with you!” Orko exclaimed. “Since you don’t think my magic is evil, maybe I can show you a trick or—"


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Catra interrupted the Trollan as she placed a hand on his chest as gently—yet firmly—as possible. Orko felt as light as a feather blowing in the wind as he looked expectantly up into Catra's eyes—like a puppy who only wanted to follow at its owner's heels. She recognized that look instantly.

"Hey, how about you stay here with Adora? My wife is super interested in Trollan history, and the two of you should talk. How does that sound?" Catra asked as sweetly as she could muster.

Orko looked uncertainly at Adora as Catra gave her wife eyes of pleading—seeing the desperation in Catra's eyes—Adora smiled at Orko.

"Yeah, can you stay with me, please?" Adora pleaded, holding her hands together next to her face. Catra hoped this worked; she really didn't need an infatuated Trollan following her around.

"Sure!" Orko squeaked, bobbing up and down. The ploy was a success.

Catra mouthed the words '*thank you*' to Adora as she walked up the ramp; just before she turned away, Catra caught Adora's response, '*You owe me*.'

Catra smirked as she made her way back into the starship's interior, thinking of the perfect way to pay Adora back for this favor. It would be something that she would not be particularly hard-pressed to perform.

Turning in the direction of the living quarters, Catra noticed the door to one of the cabins was open. Deciding to investigate, she proceeded in that direction quietly, using her inherent feline capabilities to soften her footsteps. Perking her sensitive ears, Catra heard voices within; it was Shen and Veth, speaking with an almost familial comfort—like two old comrades—or something even closer. There was a tone in Shen's voice that Catra just couldn't place a finger on—like he was stressed or low-key agitated. Veth's voice was what immediately put her on edge;

there was an open friendliness—even a playfulness—she had never heard from the Nephraeh before.

Catra didn't trust it.

Peeking around the corner, Catra spotted Veth on the bed, Shen nearby on his knees, inspecting the leg Adora had nearly sliced off. She listened in as Veth said something to her friend.

"Great! Let me get these off first!"

Unsure of what Veth was referring to, her rising incredulity turned to shock when Catra watched them reach down to their waistband, seeming to unfasten a clasp there.

"Come on, Human. Pull my boots off, grab the bottoms of my pants, and pull!"

Leave them be, Cat-Tra. Your friend is about to discover one of the many wonders this galaxy has to offer—to be intimate with a Nephraeh. Ah… I remember my first time —

Not now, Jihan! Catra sent to her mentor.

With heart thudding in her ears, Catra fought against the instinct to flee in embarrassment; instead, she focused on what she was actually witnessing.

There was the beautifully androgynous Nephraeh, asking for a favor in which the removal of their clothes was necessary. Then there was Shen, her best friend whom she knew so well, placed in this position where he was exposed to their partial nudity—then it hit her.

Catra knew what attracted Shen, it was evident in his past choices, and she could see it summed up in the Nephraeh before him. She also knew what Veth was capable of—she and Adora had experienced it first-hand to their own detriment. The Nephraeh had tried to lure Catra in by seduction, and when that didn't work,

played upon her compassion, finding immediate purchase there. Now here they were again, playing the part of the innocent—when, in reality—they were the honeypot, luring the unsuspecting prey into a trap.

Catra felt like she was watching Shen walk towards a cliff, but instead of physical peril, it was his sensitive heart at risk. She had to do something.

"What in the name of Etheria is going on in here!?!?" She said, stepping into the room while using her best Shadow Weaver impression.

The spell immediately broke as Shen yelped, stumbling away from Veth's bared leg to turn and face her. Catra felt a smug sense of triumph to see annoyance pass briefly over Veth's lilac features, replaced quickly by mild indifference.

"Ca—Catra!" Shen stammered. "What do you mean? I'm only helping—"

His words cut off as Catra's eyes narrowed on the object held loosely between his fingers; a section of Aegis Lace, appearing in the low light like a black velvet ribbon.

"Oh, my bad," Catra said lightly. "You were helping Veth patch themselves up after the beating Adora, and I gave them. I see that now,"

Catra feigned a smile as she glided over to the stupefied Shen, reaching for the Aegis Lace in his hand.

"May I?" She said, not waiting for a response as she plucked it from his grasp.

Veth gave Catra a cool look as she nudged her chin at their leg, indicating they should lift it back up.

"It's only right that I take a turn—right? After all, it was my wife that cut you." She said, baring her fangs in a wide smile.

“Catra, I—ah!” Veth began to say—but was silenced as Catra placed a hand on their knee, pricking them gently with her claws.

“Stay still,” Catra said firmly as she inspected the wound. “I’m surprised you want this bandaged up, Veth. It looks practically healed.”

“Well, it’s better to be safe than sorry, Catra,” Shen said behind her. Catra turned to look at her friend, seeing the compassion written on his face.

Poor buddy doesn’t know the danger he is in. Good thing Catra is here to save him, she thought.

“You’re right, Shen. Here, I will finish the job.” She said, beginning to wrap the leg with one hand as she kept it still with the points of her nails with the other.

“Catra, it’s different than Jaadoo suit cantrips. You have to imagine what you want the Aegis Lace to do while applying it,” Shen said helpfully.

Catra’s face brightened. “Oh, is that how they work? That’s really *neat,*”

She turned to gaze into the Nephraeh’s eyes while dressing their injury—all the while pouring all her anger into the psycho-reactive material. Veth tried to suppress a grimace as they felt her intentions, the Aegis Lace binding painfully to the soft flesh of their leg.

“Uh, careful, Catra. I think you’re hurting—” Shen began to say but was silenced by a raised hand from Veth.

“No,” they said, meeting Catra’s intense stare with a silvery one of their own. “I’m okay. Catra is doing it in her own way,”

Veth’s apparent acceptance of her malice annoyed Catra, which she channeled into the final touches of the dressing, increasing the agony.

“There, all better!” Catra exclaimed as she backed away.

Veth winced as they rubbed the spot she patched up but covered their discomfort with a grateful smile. Their endeavor to disregard her attempts at antagonism was starting to enrage Catra; her tail began to perform broad sweeps behind her, beating the air.

“Now that you're fixed up, how about you put your trousers back on and give me and my friend a little privacy, eh?” Catra said, the animosity beginning to seep into her voice.

Shen reached down and retrieved the article of clothing from the floor, handing it to Veth—who rewarded him with a grateful smile. With a smooth motion, Veth swept their pants up over their legs, pressing a strange black button at the waist to make the many ribbons tighten, hugging their lithe frame. Catra crossed her arms and tapped her foot impatiently, waiting for Veth to pull on their boots. Once finished, the Nephraeh stood fluidly, giving Catra a slight bow.

“Perhaps you and I might also have a moment alone, Catra? To clear the air between us,” Veth said.

“I wouldn’t look forward to that if I were you,” she responded with some bite.

Veth turned to Shen then, making Catra suddenly tense; it seemed as if the Nephraeh were about to move closer to him, which made her want to leap forward to push them away. A barely perceptible growl emanated from deep within Catra’s chest as Veth lifted their hand towards Shen—but about midway there—it veered back to tuck a strand of hair behind one of their long ears. It was the most awkward thing Catra had seen them do, and for a brief moment, she was utterly wrong-footed.

“See you around, *Human,*” Veth said, grinning at Shen before strolling out of the room.

“Yeah, you bet,” he responded, almost in a daze.

Catra didn't even know where to start as her friend faced her, a look of slight reproach on his features. She could not believe this was actually happening; back when Catra had found out Shen was in love with her, the news that someone else had caught his interest would have filled her with happiness. But now that it was happening, all she wanted to do was stop it from going any further.

"You know," she began. "I don't know what is more reckless: you jumping into an unstable portal or whatever this is with you and Veth. I'm thinking it's the latter,"

"Catra…" Shen began, looking up at the ceiling. "Look, I know what Veth did to you and Adora—I won't even try to deny that was wrong. But it's different now! They are different!"

The desire to tear him to shreds returned— but instead of doing that—Catra only shook her head, completely incredulous.

"Shen—they can't be trusted! Not with your—" She said, abruptly stopping mid-sentence. Shen only looked back at her quizzically, waiting for Catra to continue.

"Veth is dangerous, Shen. Very dangerous," she finished.

Shen snorted—not in disbelief, but in agreement.

"Yeah, I know first-hand, Catra." He said.

Catra frowned, immediately clasping Shen by the shoulders to peer into his face.

"What do you mean? Did they hurt you?" She said, threat and concern mixing in her voice.

Shen shook himself out of Catra's grip, surprising her by seeming annoyed.

"I can handle myself, Catra. Anyway, I don't know what you think is going on. I will admit to you that I think Veth is very attractive,

but they aren't interested in me. Not like that," he said.

Catra sighed softly as she stared at her friend, utterly unsure what to do. She could argue that Veth doesn't need to be attracted to him to use him, but Shen knew that. As much as she told him he was, Shen was no dummy; he grew up in a nightmare dimension beyond her comprehension.

But knowing about something and recognizing it when it was coming for you were two things; he was blinded by his desire for them. All Catra wanted to do was enjoy the fact that he wasn't dead and focus on the things she could control—namely—letting Veth know that, in no uncertain terms, Catra would allow them to hurt her friend. Ever.

"Hey, listen. I don't want to fight with you, Shen. Okay? Let's just drop it?" Catra offered.

Shen nodded, smiling. "Even if I weren't exhausted, I wouldn't want to fight either, Catra. I know you're only looking out for me; I appreciate it."

Catra's face split into a wide toothy grin as she gave Shen a friendly jab to his shoulder.

"Good, because fighting with me is a bad idea! If you don't already know it yet, I'm Sher-Va now. Even with your He-Man power, I'm back to being able to kick your butt!" She said playfully.

Shen chuckled as he rubbed his shoulder.

"Yeah, a lot has changed since I was away—all for the better, it seems. The war with the Empyrea is over, and the Nephraeh are free. You've become Sher-Va and used your power to get Adora and Mermista back—I'm really proud of you for that, by the way."

Catra's smile became embarrassed now, her face falling slightly as a thought occurred to her.

“You know, I wanted to talk to you about something,” she began uncertainly.

Catra folded her arms tightly over her chest as she paced away from her friend, her tail making quick jerking motions as she collected her thoughts. With eyebrows raised, Shen watched her back expectantly, completely unsure where this was going. Finally, Catra faced him, her cinnamon face open and expressive, her heterochromatic eyes shining with barely suppressed emotion.

“Shen, what you did back in the Relativity Forge was amazing—you showed a strength that few people have, and I envy you for it. But more than that, what you did in saving Adora—even though we now know she wouldn’t have died—I will never forget it, Shen.”

“But that is not what has… bothered me… since you sacrificed yourself to save my wife. Right before you did it, I asked you to—um, I asked you to, uh—"

Catra gritted her teeth as the pain she had felt since that day finally caught up with her; the conflicting emotions of the moment roiled inside her head and heart, making her unsure of what she wanted to say next. With a start, Catra realized that she had started crying; she wiped angrily at her eyes, annoyed that her body was betraying her moment of truth. Catra felt two hands seize hers, pulling them away from her face and holding them firmly before her.

“Catra, you don’t have to say anything—I know,” Shen said. “I would have saved Despara it even if you hadn’t asked me to do it, and I would never expect you to choose anyone over her—especially not me. My life is mine to sacrifice, and I chose to spend it then and there—nothing more,”

Catra gazed gratefully into her friend’s kind eyes as relief and gratitude washed over her in a cleansing wave, leaving her feeling unburdened by the guilt that had dogged her for months.

With a curious tilt of her head, Catra looked down at the hands holding hers; Shen had never initiated any physical contact with her before—more so after his feelings for her became more than just simple comradery. Catra knew it was more for his benefit than hers; touching her would have made things harder for Shen, straining their friendship.

But here he was, holding her hands, and Catra realized it had nothing to do with him changing his standpoint—it was a shift of disposition—from her to another.

Catra suddenly felt very scared for her friend and more unsure than ever that there was anything she could do about it. But she made a pledge to Shen to always look out for him, and if there was one thing that Catra held sacred, it was a promise.

Time to pay Veth a little visit.

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Iria Abella, who makes up 1/2 of ilikeyoucatradora on Tumblr and Instagram.

Distractions

Chapter Summary

> Veth revisits the past once more before having to deal with the future--plus a very angry Catra.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Breathe in. Let the stress flow from your extremities and into your core. Gather the pain and distractions there to form the Lequ, separating it from your Zi.

Sitting cross-legged with eyes closed, Veth reached out to caress the air, grasping it as if they were gathering sand. Pulling the closed hands towards their chest, Veth's nostrils expanded as they drew a deep breath, completing the motion with the hands flat against their breast.

Maintaining the Sed Configuration, make your body as the Harrani —the road whose course does not turn back—and place the Lequ upon it, rejecting it. Breathe out.

Veth brings their hands together as they thrust outward, claw tips waving at the opposite wall as they exhale. With the motion complete, Veth begins the process anew as they recite the Mantra of Mu—breathing in, breathing out.

They had been at this for a while now; after the tense exchange with Catra, Veth had sought solace in one of Darla's empty cabins, hoping to process their thoughts. But their contemplation had become turbulent, forcing Veth to find succor in mediation. Yet try as they might, they could not shake the memory of a brief touch —a scintillating moment of contact they had sought without foreseeing the impact.

Breath in. Breathe out. Breath in. Breathe out. Breath in. Breathe out. Breathe in. Breathe out.

Veth realized that they were no longer performing a relaxing breathing exercise—it was now more of a pant—reminding them of other activities that had nothing to do with quiet introspection. With a low growl of irritation, Veth ran their fingers through their long hair, abandoning their search for balance. They needed to face what had sent them into this state, knowing it all had to do with another one of their attempts at deception.

Why did I do it? I knew I didn't need my leg bound; it was already healed—why did I draw him into that silly performance?

Veth lightly brushed their finger over the area where Shen had touched their skin, trying yet failing to suppress an echo of the thrill they had felt. They rode that memory for a moment, sliding their claws between the folds of Aegis Lace, the sleek material treating the passion it sensed as a command to part.

Veth recalled the moment they decided to request Shen take off their pants; they had been curious—curious to know what it would like to have his hands on them in a manner a hair's breadth away from intimacy. They did not seek this knowledge with the awareness it would give them pleasure—more like it was a trial run conducted in a controlled environment. Shen would be none the wiser if he simply thought he was helping them; there would be no hurt feelings if Veth rejected the feel of his skin against theirs. But the investigation had uncovered a ripe promise of desire within Veth—one they knew well was matched in the Human.

So what? Veth thought to themselves. *I've discovered I'm sexually attracted to Sh—this Human. It doesn't mean anything—with how I've been feeling lately—I think I may be attracted to a variety of partners. This human isn't any different from them.*

YOU KNOW THAT'S NOT TRUE VETH

Veth jolted so violently they flopped back on the bed, their long black hair spreading in a fan behind them. Their silver eyes were wide as they stared at the ceiling, unsure whether they wanted to admit they had just heard the strange voice—hoping it would not speak again. They were about to be disappointed.

BUT IF YOU ARE STILL UNSURE, JUST LOOK AT HIS QUINTESSENCE AT THE SAME TIME AS YOURS—YOU WILL SEE IT THEN

"Who are you!?" Veth gasped into the air.

THAT'S COMPLICATED. ALSO, IT'S NOT NECESSARY FOR YOU TO SPEAK OUT LOUD TO ME. IT'S BETTER YOU DON'T, ACTUALLY. SOMEONE WILL THINK YOU ARE CRAZY

Veth snapped their mouth closed, realizing that they were gaping.

Maybe I am crazy, they thought abruptly. *However, I did hear Catra mention that an echo of the last Bearer of Sher-Va speaks to her occasionally.*

NO—I AM NO ECHO OF A MEMORY. I AM REAL AND SPEAKING TO YOU VIA A TENUOUS LINK I HAVE TO ZHE-LA

Veth blinked at this response, wondering how such a thing was possible before recalling that telepathic communication was achievable amongst Champions of Grayskull. The voice was familiar somehow, although it sounded nothing like any Champions they currently knew. Veth sat up slowly, realizing where they had heard the speaker's voice before.

You are the one I've been hearing during these… memories… and dreams I've been having. Aren't you?

YES. I HAVE BEEN GUIDING YOU BACK TO YOURSELF. GUIDING YOU TO A STATE OF SELF-ACTUALIZATION. I NEED YOU VETH; I NEED YOUR HELP

The horrible dream repeated in Veth's mind, the one where they imagined themselves in another's place—an ancient Nephraeh of white skin and great malice. They had also seen a dark version of themselves—Veth the Champion Vetala—dread ruler of a dark and twisted planet. The voice had been in that nightmare, speaking to them and guiding them in that landscape of evil. Veth laughed without humor, shaking their head.

Why would I trust someone who invades my mind only to show me horror? How could anything about this be beneficial for me?

I UNDERSTAND CAUTION, VETH. BUT I HAVE ALREADY BEEN BENEFICIAL TO YOU, AND YOU KNOW IT.

Veth contemplated this answer, seeing the truth in what the voice claimed. The visions evoked had helped Veth draw close to their actual being—their compassionate self—which was then instrumental in recognizing the evil in the tainted Nephraeh—the absence of empathy.

I'VE HELPED YOU; NOW YOU MUST HELP ME. I NEED YOU TO SEE THIS HORROR IN ITS ENTIRETY. PLEASE

Veth let out a long sigh, knowing they had already agreed. Whomever this person was, Veth owed them; all they were being asked to do was witness a memory, one held deep within the reservoir of experience that was the spirit of Zhe-La. A small part of Veth knew that what they were about to see would be beneficial—how, though—they did not know.

Okay. Let's do this.

Veth gritted their teeth and clenched their body, readying themselves for what was about to happen; they loathed the thought of returning to the state of absolute apathy. It was as if they were about to consume a distasteful tonic—one whose benefits outweighed its flavor.

VETH, YOU MUST RELAX YOUR BODY IN ORDER FOR ME TO ACCESS YOUR PSYCHE. ONE IS BOUND TO THE OTHER;

IF YOUR BODY IS CLOSED OFF, THEN SO IS YOUR QUINTESSENCE. PERFORM THE MANTRA OF MU ONCE AGAIN. IT HELPED ME ON MANY OCCASIONS… IN MY TIME

Veth sat back up, crossing their legs as they held an erect pose, forming the Sed Configuration. They resumed the breathing exercises, attempting to expel distractions in order to find peace. But the presence of the outside intelligence observing them did nothing to assist them in their endeavor, nor did the residue of ardor which had already been plaguing them.

Thankfully, absolute tranquility was not necessary, and Veth detected the presence of the *other* seeping in around the cracks of their consciousness. They closed their eyes, allowing the *other* to take the reins of their awareness—immediately, Veth felt like falling—but this soon subsided as they once again found themselves in the conduit of Light, moving through the essence of Zhe-La.

VERY GOOD VETH—NOW—PREPARE YOURSELF

Feeling an abrupt deviation, Veth was pushed back into recollections of the Fallen Nephraeh, starting at the beginning of that corrupted thread.

They peer around the chamber, taking in what they have wrought; bodies line the temple floor of Zhe-La. Innocents that had turned to them in a time of need—plus some of their own people; they were the sweetest lives taken that day. To extinguish the lives of Nephraeh for nothing more than their self-aggrandizement… ahhh…

They turn from their handiwork to look down at their body; the pure white skin of their arms is stained with blood. As it glistens in the torchlight of the temple, they stare at it with rapt fascination, wondering—is it a bit of blood from every single one of their victims? Or is it just one? They cannot remember—but in the end —it does not matter. None of it matters; not the people they

killed, not the Empire crumbling around them, not the Nephraeh and their silly Light, not that fool Zzar—all that matters is their ascension to Godhood.

They are liberated from all concerns for others and are now free to do whatever they want; they are going to make the most of that freedom and will make the galaxy burn for their ambition. It is not enough that they have been emancipated from compassion; they must also be unfettered from the need to feed on it. Godhood can give them that—right? What need do they have for such trivial concerns once they attain that level of existence?

They can feel the power of the Apogeon Ritual rising steadily; it is like a background hum, ready to be fully unleashed yet kept at bay. Why are they waiting? The ritual can be strengthened more, but they had used all their fuel. They are running out of time and need to act fast—but for some reason—they know they have to wait just a bit longer. For what, they just aren't entirely sure—

"Kishar! What have you done?" a voice shouts, pulling them from their reveries.

A smile spreads across their white lips as they recognize that voice—they realize this is what they have been waiting for. A giant Madgēcot stands amongst the carpet of bodies; he is magnificent in gold armor, his handsome face gazing at them with absolute dread.


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“Jihan, you’ve finally tracked me down. Where is the lovely Dinala Katan and her Void Gem? You’re going to need her if you’re going to fight me.” They say in greeting.

They can barely contain the glee spreading through them; here and now is the one who loves them more than anything—even his own life! Killing him would be glorious! It is what the Apogeon Ritual needs to be fully complete! How can they be so lucky? It is as if some outside force is orchestrating this entire sequence of events for their benefit.

“I—” Sher-Va/Jihan starts to say but then looks around at all the bodies. They know he is rethinking his decision to come and face them alone—more the pity for him. They laugh at his hesitation.

“What’s the matter, my love?” They say in mockery. “Cat got your tongue?”

The old, shared joke has its intended effect; they can see it biting at Sher-Va/Jihan’s resolve as he bares his upper incisors at them.

“I’m here to stop you, Kishar.” Sher-Va/Jihan says.

They move to him then, making sure to step gingerly over the bodies; their Zhe-La form is so immaculate, it would be a shame to mar it with the blood of the unworthy.

“And how are you going to do that, my love? With that clunky Power Sword?” They say, pointing a stained finger at his sword.

They hold their own sword aloft, fully revealing its unbound might by shedding the illusion of a Power Sword; it burns with pure magical power, wholly separated from matter's physicality. When Zzar bound the Champion Spirits to Power Swords, she secretly left Zhe-La untouched, allowing their ally full access to their Champion capabilities. They revel in the sight of Sher-Va/Jihan realizing the depths of their betrayal, knowing there is no way to defeat them. But they know their former lover well— even knowing of his impending death, he will not turn back.

“Why have you done this, Kishar? I know you no longer feel compassion, but this is just murder! What is the point?” Sher-Va/Jihan implores.

They know he is stalling for time but decide to humor him, pretending to contemplate a question that has only one answer for them.

“Their deaths serve a purpose, my dear Jihan.” They say, waving their sword at the bodies.

“You see, up until now, their lives were meaningless—here they are—hiding under a rock as great events unfold around them. Through them, I will ascend. Perhaps it is fortuitous that you came; I will add your death to the tally, strengthening the power of the Apogean Ritual.”

The revulsion on Sher-Va/Jihan's face fills them with delight—which is then promptly soured by an obscure sensation tickling at their hindbrain—a twice-removed relative of doubt.

I AM BUT A REMNANT, BUT I AM THE REAL YOU

They attempt to cover this odd emotion, bearing their upper and lower fangs at their opponent in a mockery of a smile.

“The WHAT?!” Sher-Va/Jihan exclaims. “I’ve never heard of such madness! The Shlihm-bess’a-rune has taken your sanity as well as your empathy!”

They shrug, already bored with this exchange and eager to have it concluded.

“I don’t need your belief—just your blood!!!” They cry, lunging at their former lover.

Their downward slice is halted by a timely block by Sher-Va/Jihan’s Power sword; he tries to push them away using the connected blades. They permit this to transpire—backing up a few steps and allowing Sher-Va/Jihan time to collect his wits. He

doesn't use the moment wisely, instead lunges at them with a clumsy thrust; they note that his heart is not behind the attempt and easily bat the Power Sword away.

"Poor Jihan," they say, mocking. "You see now, don't you? My power is unadulterated and unbound. You should just give up and let me kill you. I mean, can't you just do that for me? For old time's sake?"

They laugh again, pouring all their contempt for the other's love for them into the sound—but then cease their cruel giggling as rage appears on Sher-Va/Jihan's face. They are astounded by this expression; they knew such a thing was possible—everyone knew of the temper of the Madgēcots—but to see it directed at them was enough to make them remember their momentary hesitation. When they observe the ire matched by the jade fire glow in his eyes, they realize their level of peril and begin to back away.

"My power may be bound, Kishar, but I have something you do not. It is something you have lost on your path to evil. THE TRUTH!" Sher-Va/Jihan shouts as he rushes at them.

Terror courses through them as they hold up their sword two-handed in a ward against Sher-Va/Jihan's weapon—but that changes to surprise as he drops his Power Sword to seize their wrists in his claws.

"NOO!!!" They shriek, struggling in his grip.

When the green fire spreads down from Sher-Va/Jihan's eyes, coming for them across his arms, they drop a hand from their sword to push Sher-Va/Jihan away. But something weakens them, holding them fast in his grip; at first, they think it is the power of Truth emboldening the other Champion. They soon sense this is not the case; the debility is coming from them—some part of them wants this to happen.

YOU WILL SEE THE TRUTH, SOON

They fight against this hidden traitorous aspect of their being as they simultaneously struggle in Sher-Va/Jihan's grip—but it is too late; the power of Truth finds them. By small degrees, their state of mind peels away, revealing the Truth of what had always existed—but hope remains—the process is slow, allowing them time to fight.

Sher-Va/Jihan senses his efforts are not enough; letting go of one of their wrists, he places a hand on their face. They scream as his power surges into them; what was at first a gentle peeling of their lie is now a tear, and the curtain of apathy pulls back—

—they clutch it closed, barely and just enough so that they do not catch what lay behind. They are running out of time; soon, he will overcome them. They must—

Sher-Va/Jihan places his other hand on their face, sealing their fate in his binding to them. Now there is nothing they can do as the Truth is revealed to them—

—they manage to look away; they are so desperate—they are about to lose their freedom! There must be something they can do—NO! He is forcing them to see—

—There! They do see it now, not the Truth Sher-Va/Jihan wants them to comprehend, but the salvation they seek. The fool has dropped his sword and left himself defenseless! All they need to do—

NO! YOU MUST NOT! LET HIM FINISH

—is take their sword and—

I DO NOT WANT THIS

Sher-Va/Jiahn's glowing green eyes are wide with shock as his grip on their face lessens; looking down at the sword hilt held in one hand, they are confused to make out blood dripping between their already defiled fingers. Following the trail up their shimmering blade, relief and elation—

NO! NOT ELATION—ABHORRANCE

—mix inside them as they realize they are released from Sher-Va/Jihan's power—the power of Truth.

"So close, my love. So close. But in the end, you fail." They say, twisting and yanking the sword from his body.

Sher-Va/Jihan backs away, clutching his torso as crimson sheets cascade out between his arms. With an almost comic look of forlorn loss, he reaches out for them right before—

MY JIHAN! NO

—crashing back onto the ground, sword clattering next to him as a red pool spreads out around him, his life seeping away. For the last time, Sher-Va/Jihan reverts out of his Champion form; the Avatar spirit fluttering out between his lips to find sanctuary within the Power Sword. Jihan looks sad as he gazes at them; the fool still appears concerned for them even after they have just killed him.

Abruptly, anxiety courses through them as tugging yanks at their innards—

YOU HAVE TAKEN MY LOVE—MY JIHAN. I WILL SEE YOU FAIL

—incredulous, they realize it is their connection to Zhe-La—it is failing! The Champion Spirit has tried to reject them in the past, but every time they thwarted its attempt to leave; it seems that this time, with the betrayal and murder of their erstwhile lover, Zhe-La has the grounds to sever their bond. If they do not act fast, all will be lost. They cannot ascend to greatness without the power base that is a Champion of Grayskull—they must complete the ritual—now!

Sitting cross-legged, they form their hands into the precise arrangement needed to align the transcendental strands of the Apogean Ritual into the complex pattern required to attain their

final ascension. They work fast, performing the Formulae of Consummation within their intricate mind—they are so close! They can feel the very cells of their body vibrating at the frequency of infinity, losing their corporeality as they become something more —something divine. They are becoming so much more now; their senses have increased beyond the six all Nephraeh have—into experiences beyond that of a mere mortal. They can now hear the spirit of Zhe-La screaming as it drags along with them—an unwilling passenger to apotheosis. With a final screech that they can feel against the ectoplasm of their quintessence—Zhe-La shears their bond—veering away from their meteoric rise and escaping into the nether regions.

It is no matter, Zhe-La served its purpose; they no longer need it to complete the ritual. There was only the unrestricted potential and boundless possibilities before them; there was—

YOUR REIGN

—wait—

ENDS NOW

—they feel the Apogean Ritual has reached the peak as its potential recedes—minutely at first—but then rapidly. They feel the dream of absolute power fading into the background nothingness of ambiguity; the souring taste of their approaching ignominy makes them want to scream at the unfairness of the uncaring cosmos—that a magnificent being such as themselves is somehow kept from what is rightfully theirs. How is it possible—

YOU KNOW WHY

—they realize then why the ritual is failing. They may not have seen what is behind the veil of their self-deception, but they somehow know. This knowledge was keeping them from—

"VETH!!! WAKE UP!!!"

The angry voice ripped Veth out of the vision, slamming them back into the here and now of physical existence. Before they could realign their two forms of sight, all Veth could perceive was a white-hot fury directed at them with the intensity of a supernova. As their other vision came to the fore, they realized that it was not an actual star exploding before them but a very real Catra; she was standing in the cabin doorway, her feline eyes blazing as she regarded them.

"What the heck is wrong with you?" She exclaimed, hands on hips. "I've been standing here yelling at you while you just sat there like a lump!"

"Lump?" Veth asked, dazed. They were practically reeling from the perspective shift; one moment, they had been in sync with the vilest being they had ever encountered, and the next, they were being berated by an irate Madgēcot, calling them a lump.

"YES! A lump! Be glad I don't call you something worse—Etheria knows you deserve it!" She said, leaning forward to practically hiss at them.

Veth met the fiery gaze with a cool silver one of their own, projecting some of their natural insouciance for equal measure.

"What can I do for you, Catra? Besides listening to the childish new names you have for me—of course," Veth said casually.

Catra watched them for a moment longer, her tail swaying back and forth behind her in obvious irritation. Veth knew they were playing a dangerous game with the female Madgēcot, but it gave them time to gather their befuddled wits as well as listen for the strange voice which had engaged them in the vision. Veth had perceived the presence of the *other* vanish with the interruption of the vision—which they hoped wasn't permeant. With so many questions raised by what they witnessed through the Dark Nephraeh's eyes, Veth knew this *other* was the only one who had any answers.

"I wanted to have a little chat with you, Veth. Just you and me—no one else around. You know, the kind we used to have back when I trusted you—*while you manipulated me?*" Catra said.

Veth did not have to hear the acid in her voice to know how badly they had hurt Catra—they could identify it plainly in her quintessence. There was a slight curdling on the periphery of her warm and vibrant core—the place where her empathy had been flavored with distrust. This souring led to a more significant bruising at the center of her soul; it was the residue of despair from the period of a wife's absence and the knowledge of the damage done to her.

Veth had to suppress a sympathetic pang of sorrow from overwhelming them; Catra probably wouldn't be very understanding if they started weeping before her. Instead, they looked away, hoping the fierce Madgēcot wouldn't recognize her own pain reflected in Veth's eyes.

"So, what? You want to come and punish me more?" They asked, rising to their feet and holding out their arms lamely. "I'm here, Catra. Do what you will; I won't fight back—I promise,"

Catra's mouth twisted as she strode forward to stand before them; raising her hands from where they rested on her hips—Veth thought she was about to take them up on the offer and strike them. Instead, she only folded them over her chest, searching Veth's face with heterochromatic eyes.

"I'm not here for that. I'm here because I want to know your intentions—for my friend," she said plainly.

Veth balked. "My intentions? For your friend? *What!?*"

"Don't play dumb!" Catra yelled, practically baring her teeth as she leaned toward them. "I saw the little performance you were putting on!"

Catra clasped her hands next to her head, fluttering her eyes in mock vulnerability.

"*Oh, Shen! Help me get these pants off! I need your special touch in healing me!"* Catra said in a high-pitched voice.

Veth gritted their teeth as waves of embarrassment washed over them; it seemed that Catra had witnessed their little experiment and recognized it for the ruse that it was. It didn't take much imagination for them to connect the dots; with their attempts to seduce Catra in the past, they couldn't blame her for being suspicious.

"Listen, Catra, I know—um… I know how that might have looked," Veth started, amazed that they were stammering their words. "I can assure you that… eh… I think you might have taken that the wrong way. You see—"

Catra snapped her teeth inches from Veth's face; they immediately stopped speaking, backing away from the savage woman. She followed them step by step—abruptly—Veth fell backward onto the bed, looking up at Catra as she stopped between their knees, looming over them like a predator.

"I will say this once, Veth: Stay away from Shen. Whatever messed up Nephraeh seduction game you are playing with him stops now. Do you hear me? I won't let you hurt him as you hurt me—he can't take any more pain!" She said, her voice brimming with emotion.

Veth edged up onto their elbows to stare up at Catra, their eyes narrowing.

"He is stronger than you think," they said.

The reaction was immediate as Catra bristled all over—hair, fur, claws, and teeth—all raised or exposed in a threatening manner; the fearsome stance of a Madgēcot, ready to fight if she had to.

"STAY AWAY FROM HIM!" She snarled.

Veth had been ready to let Catra beat them to a pulp if she wanted—they knew they deserved it. But for some inexplicable

reason, her telling Veth to stay away from Shen made them feel panicked—and even more—grief. Veth could feel the anger building inside them—anger that anyone would tell them to stay away from the Human. With bared fangs in a mirror of Catra's expression, they rose from the bed; their dark hair and complexion giving them the aspect of a rising specter, making Catra back up a step.

"*Make me,*" Veth said, the words coming through their teeth like a rasp.

Catra's eyes were wide as her tail beat the air behind her; it was not fear Veth detected in her, only a startled surprise. After a moment, her tail stopped thrashing; the entirety of its stone-gray length was still—except for the tip—which twitched slowly.

"I've never seen you angry before, Veth," she said, head slightly tilted. "I must have hit a nerve."

Recovering a bit of their composure, Veth noticed that they were holding their claws out to slice at Catra—self-consciously—they lowered their arms, giving the Madgēcot woman a look of apology.

"I—I'm sorry about that," they said, quickly running a hand through their hair. "I must be… still recovering from our fight. I have no right to threaten you, Catra,"

Veth's mind spun, trying to find a way to change the subject as the other scrutinized them with the intensity of a laser beam.

"Anyway—why did you decide to attack me on sight, Catra? I know we did not depart on the best of terms, but I'm pretty sure I allowed myself to fall to my supposed death so Despara would not kill you. Doesn't that count as something?" Veth asked.

Catra's eyes became hooded as her ears lowered. "My life is my thing, Veth, but the lives of the ones I care about are another. You took Adora away from me, and your Archon took my friends—I

fought with everything I had to get my wife back! I was ready to trade that life you saved for her—I would do so in an instant!"

"Adora and I had just undone whatever messed up head trip Mermista was on when I discovered Shen was alive. I was feeling pretty happy at that moment—but then I saw you. I felt like what I had just gotten back was being threatened—that you would undo everything and take it all away again. Can you really blame me?"

Veth knew the truth of her words as they shook their head; they would have done the same thing if they had been in Catra's place.

"AND, on top of that, I catch you manipulating Shen just as you did with me. What am I supposed to do with that Veth? Just let you mess with him? No way." Catra finished, shaking her head.

Veth looked down at the ground; Catra was right again—but not for the reasons she suspected. There had been no malicious intent in tricking Shen, only the itch of curiosity that needed to be scratched. But they couldn't tell Catra that, not without revealing too much—for now—they would just keep their mouth shut.

"Didn't you tell me in the Relativity Forge that you would kill Shen—given a chance? He killed someone special to you, didn't he? I'm not complaining or anything—but why is he still alive? It sounded like you had plenty of opportunities to do it," Catra asked, cocking her head again.

Veth let out a long and drawn-out sigh; it seemed they would not get out of this interaction without revealing something to Catra. As painful as it was, they would tell her the truth.

"Nefeli's death wasn't Shen's fault, Catra. It was mine," they said simply. "When we were both fighting in our Champion forms, I used the power of Oblivion on him at the moment when I thought it would give me an advantage,"

Catra suddenly shivered. "Yes, I'm familiar with your fun power. It didn't work on Shen? I would think he would be very susceptible

to it,"

Veth held up a finger. "First of all, it's not my power—it was Archon Lethe's, and I lost it when… *never mind*."

Catra rolled her eyes, indicating that they should move on with a wave of her hand.

"It's not an excuse, but I had no idea that an Abominable Power had tainted Shen and that he was fighting its influence at that very moment. When I removed a bit of his compassion, Shen no longer cared about fighting the Eye of Hate—he embraced it. Everything that happened after that was a result of my actions. In the end, it was me who killed Nefeli," Veth said.

Once again, they spoke the admission aloud—their dread confession. They experience the old melancholy wrapping them like a cold, wet cloak—feeling the weight of it—Veth sat back down on the bed, glancing up at Catra as they tucked a strand of hair behind one ear. With their Nephraeh sight, they could make out the previously extinguished sections of Catra's compassion reanimate—instantly, Veth looked away, feeling utterly unworthy of the emotion. They had abused the privilege of Catra's friendship with their betrayal—seeing how greatly she cherished and valued those who had attained that status—Veth knew they had squandered a treasure.

"I'm really sorry about that, Veth, I truly am—but I still don't trust you. I feel like there is some other reason you let Shen live; I just can't figure it out yet," Catra said.

Veth shrugged—then realized they had picked up the indifferent gesture from Shen, making them smile.

"What's so funny?" Catra asked, some of the menace returning to her voice.

"Should I bother? You won't believe anything I have to say anyway," they replied.

Catra tilted her head from side to side—not agreeing nor disagreeing with the statement.

"Doesn't mean you shouldn't try." She said.

Veth looked up at Catra, seeing an impartial party in which to unburden themselves; they had spent so much time with Shen that, even though he was empathetic, there was much they felt uncomfortable talking to him about.

"I've separated myself from Archon Lethe's power—and ever since—I've been changing. I feel like everything is falling apart—with my mind, body, and life. It's like I'm burning up—like a great meteor plummeting to its destruction. But instead of eating away at me, I feel like I'm becoming… more—more vibrant! More alive! I feel… I feel… *like I want the burning*. It's like a strange ache that feels so goo—"

Veth realized they were rubbing their hands on their legs—looking up at Catra—they recognized a rosy tinge on each of her cinnamon cheeks. Veth looked down, feeling a well of embarrassment in their chest.

"Sorry!" Veth said with a lame laugh. "I don't know what that was about—I guess I was just rambling!"

With a jolt, they sensed Catra sitting next to them on the bed—looking up—saw that she was looking at them with a kind of understanding. With a small smile, Catra nodded to them.

"I'm listening," she said.

Chapter End Notes

> Illustration by Miledibuja! Check their art out on Instagram, Tumblr, and Twitter!

From Bad to Worse

Chapter Summary

Meanwhile, back on Etheria, the Resistance struggles to survive.

Help is coming... hopefully, it's in time...

The mood was somber in The Cavalier's Closet as the remains of the Resistance gathered to contemplate their options in the ever-increasing hostile environment that was Etheria. Hordak and Frosta were present, having just returned from their days-long flight from the Fright Zone. The two had just finished explaining to the rest of the group that not only did they fail to obtain the desperately needed robot army, but they also had lost one of their own to the growing tide of darkness; Lonnie had been taken and enervated. Through her, Shen'Shalidar would learn the location of the Tinker's secret hideout and would be coming for them—it was only a matter of time.

Frosta winced as she clutched at her side; the broken ribs she had suffered in the Fright Zone had been set and partially mended in the field using her magic—but they still ached from time to time. Frosta pushed this discomfort from her mind, knowing that her pain was secondary to the needs of the Resistance.

"So, what the plan, Hordak?" Netossa asked. "Since you have such a great track record for losing, how about you devise another loser plan so we can get this over with!"

Frosta glanced over at the ex-Horde ruler; he had removed his hand cannon and was currently inspecting a mannequin of equal stature as himself. He had not said a word since they had left the Fright Zone, giving Frosta pause regarding his mental state. They did not need Hordak folding under the pressure of this setback—they needed everyone if they were going to get out of this mess.

"That kind of talk isn't helping, Netossa," she scolded. "Let's try to keep the comments constructive—that's the only way we get out of this mess."

Netossa crossed her arms as she considered the younger woman.

"So, the Squirt thinks she is in charge now—eh? Okay, Squirt, I'm game—what do we do?" she asked, voice full of derision.

Not wanting to rise to the bait of Netossa's attempts to rile her, Frosta bit back her immediate response, knowing it was just the other woman's way of dealing with stress. It was best to let her vent, even if the target of Netossa's ire was Frosta; perhaps after doing so, her friend would have a clearer head and be better positioned to help the rest of the group.

"Well, I would like to hear would everyone else has to say before I propose a concrete plan," Frosta said, looking around at the others.

Next to a forlorn Peric, Rogelio held a weeping Kyle; unable to cry himself, the Lizardman was emitting a low keening sound, the sound of which was heartbreaking to hear. Frosta had never had a relationship like the ex-Horde throuple and thus had no idea what they were going through. She moved on from them, knowing that no solid council would be coming from that quarter, and turned to the next—Prince Peekablue. The beautiful, teal-skinned man was once again seated behind the counter as he pursued through a booklet containing the latest fashions from Salineas.

"Peekablue?" Frosta asked. "Any suggestions from you?"

Two dark eyebrows shot up in surprise as a bemused expression crossed purple lips.

"Uh, me? Interested in coming up with plans for… *fighting?* No. I don't think so," he said with casual disdain.

"I think we should use Peekablue as bait so we can get away," Netossa added. "Hear me out; they can't take compassion when it

doesn’t exist. Am I wrong?”

Netossa held her hands out in emphasis of her mock argument as Spinnerella tutted at her; Frosta heard Prince Peekable respond with a word that began with a ‘B’ and ended with something you did to a mild skin irritation.

“Okay, let’s move on from that helpful suggestion,” Frosta said, turning to Netossa’s wife. “What do you think, Spinnerella? Your suggestion can’t be worse than anything I’ve heard so far,”

The Princess of Aerokinesis nodded sagely, folding her delicate hands before her as she cleared her throat.

“I don’t think we should think in terms of resisting anymore—that time has passed. Am I correct in assuming that besides failing to get the army from the Fight Zone, we also have no idea where Emily and the rest of the Horde bots are?” She asked.

Hordak turned from his introspection to nod solemnly in agreement.

“Well,” Spinnerella said, continuing. “Our mission now is to survive—to leave Etheria and get as far away as possible. Perhaps we could find Glimmer and get help from Elysia?”

“Babe!” Netossa exclaimed, seizing her wife’s hands. “We can’t just leave Etheria! What about the people here? What about the people in this town? They have been counting on us!”

Spinnerella’s face fell into doubt as her wife’s words pierced the hard logic of her plan—but Frosta recognized the truth; it was their only option.

“Spinnerella’s right. We must leave, there is no way for us to fight, and if we stay, we will only end up a part of this evil. We need to find a ship—a spaceship, I mean—and get out of here while we can,”

Everyone looked at each other, feeling their own sense of loss at the thought of leaving their home planet while knowing it was the right thing to do. Kyle lifted his head from one of Rogelio's green arms and sniffed.

"Where are we going to find one of those? Etheria has just got into space exploration—and that's only because of the ships we got from Horde Prime. With the Star Force out of the question, where does that leave us?" He asked.

Frosta frowned at this question; it made sense. Just as she was about to dismiss the plan, someone else spoke up.

"Oh, that's no problem. I can get a ship," Prince Peekablue said nonchalantly.

Everyone gaped at the rakish Prince, incredulous that their salvation rested in his well-manicured hands.

"What!? Since when?" Frosta yelled.

Prince Peekablue shrugged with such casual disregard they might as well have been talking about the weather and not escaping a dire situation.

"Oh, I know someone," he said.

Netossa smirked. "Is this someone you know casually or on a more official basis?"

"Oh honey," Prince Peekablue said, limp hand up. "Not many get to be on an official basis with me—I wouldn't even say he is casual. More like a necessary… hmm… *distraction."*

Netossa gave a bark of laughter at the pompous man's licentious antics—but Frosta was hard-pressed to see the humor, too preoccupied with more serious concerns.

"So where is this 'not-boyfriend' of yours, and will he get us out of here? Better question—can we trust him? How do you know he

hasn’t been darkened yet?” She asked.

Prince Peekablue thought of that, placing a finger to his lips in contemplation.

“Hmm… good question! Well, I just saw him last night, and he didn’t act any differently—just as pushy and urgent as usual!” He said with a huff. “But as far as trust is concerned—let me put it this way; would you trust anyone involved with me?”

“That’s a very fair point,” Spinnerella said, not missing a beat.

Frosta put her face in her hands, shaking her head. She had no time for this foolishness.

“It doesn't matter!” She said to the doubt. “It’s all we have right now, and I say we go for it. If this—”

Frosta looked expectantly at Prince Peekablue, eyebrows raised.

“Bardolphus,” he said.

“—if this *Bardolphus* turns out to be false, then we will deal with him and take his ship. Unless anyone else has a better plan?” Frosta finished, looking around at the others.

No one responded, each silently admiring the Princess of Snows for her decisive leadership. Even Hordak seemed to defer to the young woman, his own tenure as leader of the Resistance having borne no fruit.

“Okay then. Peekablue? How do we find this, Bardolphus?” Frosta asked.

“I take it waiting until tonight is out of the question with the whole ‘impending doom’ thing going on,” Peekablue said, making air quotation signs. “So that leaves having to find him somewhere other than the bar, hmm…”

Everyone waited while Prince Peekablue contemplated the whereabouts of his latest lover; Frosta could practically hear the precious seconds tick away.

"Don't you know what he does during the day? Don't you ever talk" Spinnerella asked, exasperated.

"Spinny," Netossa cut in. "This is Peekablue we are talking about; just be glad he remembered this guy's name,"

"*Oh, stop*," Peekablue exclaimed, waving a hand at the taunt. "Let's see… he keeps his ship on the outskirts of town—that's where we usually end up, anyway. It's in this drearily picturesque little glade with prancing bunnies and butterflies—ugh—nature is so tacky,"

Frosta finally found herself smiling at the incorrigible Prince with no Kingdom; his antics did serve to lighten the already crushing atmosphere.

"Okay, sounds like something to go on. You all should get what you need and *only* what you need—we move out soon," Frosta instructed.

Everyone dispersed, each with their own feeling of purpose now that a common goal was in sight. Frosta was surprised that—in a group with so many strong personalities—she was the one coming to the fore.

Spotting the previous Resistance leader making his way to the rear of The Cavalier's Closet, Frosta followed Hordak through the secret door behind the counter and down into the basement. Now that both of them were no longer dodging enemy patrols and roving packs of Vetala, she wanted to have a little chat with the Ex-Horde Ruler—to clear up a few outstanding issues she had with him.

Frosta found him in his workshop, rummaging loudly through boxes and containers for what she assumed was ammunition for his hand cannon. Surprise coursed through her when the imposing

and power-suited man pulled out what appeared to be a pink plush animal from a duffel bag. Hordak held the toy up, stroking its faux fur with his free hand as a small smile appeared on his rough features.

Feeling suddenly uncomfortable, Frosta cleared her throat loudly; Hordak glanced back at her before hiding the stuffed animal behind his large frame.

"So, what's the deal, Hordak? You are the one who started this Resistance; after one setback, you just bail on leading it?" Frosta asked.

Hordak grunted before turning to face Frosta; his face was an expressionless mask, but she could see his massive shoulders hunch, indicating a great weight of sadness.

"I have failed too many times that I find myself unworthy—besides, it appears a more able successor has taken my place. I am not needed," he said without a trace of rancor.

Once again, Frosta thought back to Hordak's words in the town of Elberon—after their successful rescue of Netossa and Spinnerella. He had also mentioned being worthy then; abruptly, Frosta couldn't help feeling great pity for the old villain. Hordak was like an old beaten-down predator—claws broken and teeth worn down from years of struggle.

"I don't think being a leader has anything to do with 'worthy' or 'unworthy,' Hordak. Also, just because you were never meant to be a leader doesn't make you unworthy, either. Some people have other strengths besides leadership; I mean, what's a leader without great talent to lead?" Frosta said.

Hordak set his red glowing gaze upon the young Princess, pursing his lips as he gave another expressive grunt.

"You remind me of Entrapta. She always sought the good in others—even me." He said as a wry smile appeared on his white

lips. “She was the first person I ever met who saw any value in me,”

Frosta frowned at this statement—it gave her the boldness to ask a question that had been on her mind since Elberon.

“There has been something bothering me, Hordak.” Frosta began. “It was something you said—back when we rescued Spinnerella and Netossa. You said something about ‘winning this’ and ‘being worthy’ of someone. It’s Horde Prime, isn’t it? Even though he is gone, you are still trying to prove yourself to him.”

Hordak scowled, turning away and clenching his fists; Frosta right away recognized that the gains she had achieved with him had evaporated—but she would not relent. Placing her smaller hand on his armored gauntlet, Frosta brought Hordak’s attention back to her; the Ex-Horde ruler seemed utterly befuddled by the gesture, mouth parted slightly as he peered down at her.

“Haven’t you figured it out yet? You are no longer in that environment that Horde Prime created—*you’re with us!* We don’t need you to prove your worth—we already see it!” Frosta said.

Hordak didn’t respond, but Frosta knew her words were influencing him; in an almost absentminded fashion, he made small clutching motions at his chest, all the while mouthing words that she could not make out. Not wanting to push him any further, Frosta decided to leave Hordak to his preparations—wanting to make sure the others were not dallying. Before she exited the workshop, the Princess of Snows turned back to the Ex-Horde ruler to leave him with a final parting thought.

“It’s never too late, Hordak. It’s never too late to find a better way. I’ve seen you making great strides toward helping others, but perhaps you must be kinder to yourself. Just think about that,”

Frosta turned away, leaving the older man to his privacy; as she made the way up the old wooden staircase, Frosta could have sworn she heard weeping.

But it wasn't—only the sounds of her creaking footsteps.

* * *

Sitting in the Millennial Falcon's central lounge area, Glimmer watched as a fist-sized holographic representation of a muscular humanoid creature hopped diagonally across the black squares of the chess board, coming to rest next to a strange creature squatting on three limbs. In keeping with their divergent allegiances, both pieces eyed each other wearily, flexing bulging biceps or waving deadly appendages at one another. Bow and Panga sat in the curved booth on opposing ends of the game board, controlling the pieces via switches and buttons on the edge of the playing surface. The female Madgēcot had just made the last move, biting her lip as she second-guessed her strategy. Glimmer smiled as she observed her husband, already knowing he was one step ahead of his opponent.

"Now be careful," Entrapta warned. The inquisitive Princess was perched behind Bow on the low-rise couch, gripping either side of the seat back with her long ponytails as she rested her chin in her gloved hands.

But Glimmer's husband was not listening to the advice, already entering the commands to counter Panga's move. At once, a piece even larger than the one the Madgēcot moved intercepted her minion, lifting it into the air with two massive arms to smash to its doom on the game board below. Panga growled low in response, glowering at Bow with hooded feline eyes; it appeared as if she would leap over the table in revenge for her game piece.

"He made a fair move," Glimmer said. "Growling about it can't help you,"

Panga's head swiveled slowly towards Glimmer, her menace now directed towards the Queen of Etheria instead of Bow.

"It's not wise to upset a Madgēcot," Double Trouble interjected, languidly reclining in a nearby seat.

Glimmer crossed her arms, giving the scandalous Imp a meaningful look.

"How come no one worries about upsetting my Bow? He has feelings, too," she complained.

"That's because Bow won't slice you into bite-sized chunks when he loses—Madgēcots are known to do that," Double Trouble answered with a sharped-toothed grin.

Glimmer noticed Panga leer at her, running white claws through her hair in a causal fashion—Glimmer returned the Madgēcots cockiness with an eye-roll—but Entrapta seemed convinced.

"May I suggest a new strategy, Bow?" She said, leaning in to whisper in his ear. *"Let the Madgēcot win,"*

Glimmer smiled as she took a moment to enjoy these antics; as soon as they made contact with Adora and Catra, they would be on their way back to the dual planets of Etheria and Eternia, ready to face whatever horror Archon Lethe had brought to her home. With her cosmic understanding of the magnitude of the threat they would find there, Glimmer knew that this might be the last moment of peace she would experience. The Queen of Etheria lifted herself from her seat, making her way over to Bow to brush fingers against the back of his neck. Her husband turned from the game, his dark brown eyes meeting her sparkly ones as he smiled.

"Hey, how about we—" Glimmer started to say but was promptly interrupted by the ship's intercom.

"This is your Captain speaking," Seahawk's voice buzzed. "We have just entered the Trollan system and will soon be in communications range."

Glimmer sighed as she rolled her eyes up at the ceiling.

Never enough time these days. She thought, waving to Entrapta to follow her toward the command cockpit. Once inside the

cramped space, she found her father in the copilot's seat beside the captain himself—Seahawk.

Glimmer observed a world of twisting orange and red colors through the transparent pane of the forward viewport—not a speck of blue or anything else to indicate a liquid ocean. This orb was backlit by a brilliant sun of violet hues, its light reflecting off the ice crystals surrounding the planet, making them appear as glittering rose-colored gems.

"I am picking up Darla's signal," Entrapta said, pressing a button on her datapad. "I'm sending a signal to the ship, alerting its onboard computer that we are coming. As long as they have a portable communication device, Darla should be capable of contacting Catra and Adora wherever they may be."

Glimmer sighed. "Well, I'm sure they are off having a good time. I think we—"

She was interrupted by an audible click from Entrapta's datapad as someone on Darla opened the connection, surprising Glimmer.

"Hello, Entrapta," a sardonic voice replied.

"Catra?" Glimmer said.

"Yep. It's me, Sparkles," Catra responded. *"I had a feeling you guys would be turning up,"*

* * *

"Okay, people, the picturesque disgustingness should be right ahead," Prince Peekablue said cheerily.

Frosta was at the limit of her patience as she and the rest of the Resistance followed Prince Peekablue down the slowly dwindling trail. They had been walking for what seemed like hours as the Prince with no kingdom dithered here and there in the search for Bardolphus and his transport off-planet.

Prince Peekablue claimed his difficulty in finding the location had nothing to do with memory but an absence of a 'very highly motivating factor.' No one had the inclination to learn what this persuasion was, and thus, it remained a mystery.

It was late afternoon as the group left the slowly dwindling trail through the whispering woods, finding themselves in a meadow. True to Prince Peekablue's description, it was idyllic; small white flowers poked up from a carpet of rich green grass as grazing animals turned their heads in curiosity towards the newcomers. Vibrant butterflies fluttered lazily through a single shaft of light created by a break in the canopy high above, giving the clearing an intimate atmosphere. Squatting directly in the center of all this verdant splendor was a metallic shape the size and proportions of a small house; Bardolphus's ship was a mishmash of panels, exposed heat exchangers, and cabling—all sitting upon four landing struts like a squat toad.

"I give him cred for the local but not the ride—*ew, Peekablue!* No wonder Bardolphus doesn't have boyfriend status!" Netossa commented.

"*Gurl*… it's not his ship I was originally interested in," Prince Peekablue responded.

He glided over to the starship, placing both hands over his mouth to announce his presence.

"Oh, Bardy-Boy! Your Prince is here!"

"I really hope this next part isn't gross—I am technically still a minor," Frosta grumbled.

"It's okay, Squirt! I will cover your eyes!" Netossa said, placing an arm around the younger Princesses' shoulder.

With an audible whirring, two sections of the spaceship unfolded to reveal an open hatch from which a gangway extended. A thick-set man attired in fine clothes strolled down the plank, looking around at the arrayed newcomers with bemused confusion. A

quirky smile appeared on his jowly face upon spotting Prince Peekablue; as Bardolphus placed his hands on his hips, Frosta noticed that every finger had a massive ring on it—in fact—the man was practically overflowing with expensive finery. The only exception to this was the necklace he wore—a simple metal chain from which an Onyx eye hung. Frosta felt a sense of foreboding at the sight of it—wanting to run.

"My dear Prince Peekablue," Bardolphus said, his voice high-pitched. "I must admit, I'm quite surprised to see you here. Didn't I make myself clear the last time we saw each other? I'm pretty sure that I told you we were finished with our little… *dalliance*…"

Netossa snickered with derision as Peekablue's teal face turned a shade of violet; straight away, he whirled on his companions—hands held out in indignation.

"*It's a lie!*" Peekablue practically shriek-whispered.

"Yeah, right. We know you, Peekablue—don't forget—we were roommates," Netossa responded.

With a grimace, Prince Peekablue regained his composure, replacing the look of embarrassment with casual disregard as he returned his attention to Bardolphus.

"Oh, Honey, I'm not here for that." He said coolly. "I—*we*—need some help. You see, we are in a little trouble and need to get off-planet and out of this system. Could you do that for me, Bardy-Boy? For old time's sake?"

Bardolphus came forward to place both of his large hands on Peekablue's slight shoulder as an endearing smile appeared on his lips. Frosta noticed this warm expression did not extend to his eyes; they seemed like cold windows in an empty house—a place where no welcome would be found.

"Of course, *My Little Blue Prince,*" he said fondly. "Come into my ship—there is room for all your friends. We can leave as soon as possible."

Peekablue grasped Bardolphus's arms as he returned the affection; Frosta recognized that he was too intent on the likelihood of a renewed romance to suspect anything—but *she* did. The earlier inclination to flee returned as she looked apprehensively at the others. Peekablue was almost at the ship's entrance when she decided to speak up.

"Peekablue, wait!" Frosta yelled. "Something is not right here!"

Peekablue turned, his beautifully handsome features set in puzzlement as Bardolphus glowered at Frosta. Spinnerella stepped forward as she also sensed the unease, raising her hands in preparation to summon her magic.

"She is right, Peekablue! This seems too easy!" She said.

Peekablue's confusion turned to annoyance as he began to tap one foot.

"You know, you people are something else! You're the ones who wanted a way off-planet, and now that I am giving it to you—what? It's not good enough? Incredible! I have half a mind to get in this ship and leave youuu—ACK!"

Peekablue's words cut off in a shriek as two jet-black arms whipped out of the ship to seize him—instantly, Peekablue vanished into the darkness within as Bardolphus withdrew a sleek pistol, aiming it directly at Frosta's face. Hordak was quick on the draw with his hand cannon but did not fire—instead—he lowered his weapon with a growl, not wanting to risk hitting Forsta.

"Everyone into my ship or this girl gets it!" Bardolphus commanded.

He was promptly yanked off his feet by a spinning cone of air as a mesh of summoned energy wrapped his weapon, neutralizing any discharge from its barrel.

"Does this numbskull have any idea whom he is dealing with?" Netossa said with a laugh.

“I think I might,” a cruel whisper of a voice answered. Anxiety coursed through Frosta as she immediately recognized the speaker.

“Shen’Shalidar!” She exclaimed, seeing the man himself exit from within the ship. He walked smoothly down the ramp, raising his dread sword—The Anguish of Gallia—to point at the suspended Bardolphus.

“Put my man down—now,” he commanded.

“Or what?!” Netossa responded.

As if in answer, several of the black monsters slid out from within the ship as more crept out of the forest, completely surrounding the Etherian Resistance. Bardolphus fell to the ground as Netossa and Spinnerella released him; they backed up into the rest of the group, forming a defensive position. As the Vetala advanced on the defenders, a familiar face appeared behind the oily mass of stygian bodies—much to everyone’s horror.

“Lonnie!” Kyle exclaimed, rushing forward to meet her. Before Kyle took a step, Rogelio seized his collar, yanking him back abruptly to wrap his boyfriend in his arms.

“What are you doing? It’s Lonnie! She’s back!” Kyle yelled as he struggled.

“Kyle, you heard what Frosta said; she said she saw Lonnie taken —she has been darkened!” Peric cried.

Lonnie stopped not far from her erstwhile friends as they huddled closer to one another; she smiled at them kindly—entirely at odds with what the normal version of herself would do.

“Hello, boys,” Lonnie said in greeting. “I’m looking to get the throuple back together—you interested?”

Frosta turned her attention back to Shen’Shalidar as he drew a circle in the grass around himself—instantly, the green vegetation

turned gray as it died in real-time, leaving nothing behind but desiccated dirt. From this barren soil, new forms arose; ten shambling figures pulled themselves up like wretched plants, eager to seek the warm bodies of the living.

"I guess you weren't lying, Squirt—Szi'th still do exist!" Netossa said.

"Believe me, I wish I were wrong," Frosta shot back, eyeing the monsters.

"Imagine my shock when one of my own minions told me he had a way to defeat the pathetic Etherian Resistance!" Shen'Shalidar exclaimed, laying a black armored glove on Bardolphus's shoulder.

"This man was mine even before my new master showed up—one of my little couriers, so to speak," He continued, giving Bardolphus a firm squeeze; the man winced momentarily—just before giving Shen'Shalidar an ingratiating look.

"I suggest you all surrender now, or I will have to kill you," Shen'Shalidar said, pointing the tip of the lethal shimmering blade at Frosta and her friends.

Frosta knew what submitting would get them—a lifetime in the service of evil—and right away rejected that option. She would prefer a quick end over the prospect of having even a shred of her compassion removed—and was sure the others felt the same.

"*Let's do this*," Netossa said as if reading her thoughts.

"We will never give up!!!" Frosta screamed.

Lashing out with her elemental frost magic, Frosta encased Shen'Shalidar's cursed sword in a block of ice—he hissed in rage as the weight of the ice tipped him forward, making him kneel on the ground. Spinnerella and Netossa engaged nearby enemies as Hordak let loose with a beam of searing energy, vaporizing the first line of onrushing monsters. Kyle and Rogelio withdrew old Horde batons to fight back-to-back as Peric hid between them—

the little boy being too small and ill-equipped to face the horror amassed against them.

With Shen'Shalidar preoccupied with freeing his sword, Frosta lunged forward, intent on removing the Szi'th from the battlefield. Doing something she never dared before, Frosta directed her elemental magic *into* the foul monsters, focusing on the scraps of moisture in their decaying bodies and freezing them into serrated ice shards. The Szi'th burst apart, spraying their struggling master in gobs of rotting ichor in their violent destruction.

"*Darn, girl…* I didn't think you had it in you!" Netossa commented as she collected a writhing ball of Vetala in one of her shimmering nets.

"I really hate those things," Frosta responded, watching the other woman toss the gathered enemy up into the air as a gust of wind from Spinnerella blasted them into the sky.

"HEEELLLLPPPP MEEEE!!!"

Frosta whirled just in time to witness Peric being dragged away while Kyle and Rogelio struggled with lithe bodies, trying not to let black teeth sink into their flesh.

"NO!!!" She yelled, preparing to help them.

"Behind you!" Spinnerella warned, wide-eyed and hands raised.

What felt like a wall hit Frosta from behind—instantly sending her careening wildly through the air. She struck something—hard—and after sliding down its rough surface, Frosta realized it was a tree.

"Wha—what was that? Spinnerella?" She moaned, disorientated.

Through bleary eyes, Frosta perceived Shen'Shalidar rising to his feet, the Anguish of Gallia held in both hands as he faced off against Netossa and Spinnerella. Feeling two cold hard hands

grasp her shoulders, Frosta instantly thrashed against its hold, thinking of the dread Vetala.

"Princess Frosta, it's me—Hordak!"

Frosta sagged a moment in relief before returning her attention to her friends; from what she knew and experienced of one of the Abominable Powers, the two women were outmatched.

"We have to help them!" She said to Hordak.

As soon as she spoke, Netossa turned from her standoff with Shen'Shalidar—her eyes met Frosta's as comprehension dawned on the young Princess.

"Get her out of here, Hordak!" She yelled.

Before she could protest, Hordak hoisted Frosta under his arm, beginning to flee in the opposite direction of the disaster the Resistance had stepped into.

"HORDAK—NO! DON'T LEAVE THEM!" She shrieked, kicking and screaming against his firm grip. But the blows fell upon the metallic surface of Hordak's power armor, having no effect in stopping his retreat.

"The day is lost, Princess Frosta—the other Princess are ensuring we can escape. We must ensure their sacrifice is not in vain!" He said between pants.

Hordak was moving rapidly through the Whispering Woods; his speed and momentum enhanced by the technological marvel he wore. Between the whirring and buzzing of Hordak's straining power armor, Frosta could make out the reverberations of battle—fading quickly behind her. Just before Hordak leaped down the side of a steep ravine, Frosta swore she could make out the cries of fear and alarm.

Pressing her face against Hordak's side, the teenage girl began to weep.

The Gift

Chapter Summary

Disparate parties finally unite, turning their attention to the events on Etheria and Eternia.

The struggles and tribulations of the Etherian Resistance continue.

Shen gets a very unexpected reaction from Veth.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Holding the smooth black shaft of the Staff, Glimmer raised the Star Stone to eye level, peering into its murky depths to observe her surroundings. Through this unique lens, Glimmer beheld a representation of her galaxy; hazy dust clouds spun in an endless corkscrew around a hyper-massive center. Trillions of glittering stars twinkled—many with their own systems and planets caught in a delicate cosmic dance against the cold void.

Seven nebulae were situated amongst this interplay; four of these objects progressed by their own accord while the other three sat stationary. The four active nebulae traveled in pairs but were not harmonious in their movements; two were at odds with one another, creating a discord that—if left unchecked—would lead to disaster on a galactic scale.

There were other objects of interest—six super luminous stars of unequaled power; like their counterparts—the nebulae—these stars were also dynamic or static. From the radiance of her perspective, Glimmer realized that she was one of these stars—making their number seven, not six. The seven active stars ran along a path in support of the nebulae—but this assistance would be for naught if the discordance between the nebulae remained.

Lowering Star Stone from her gaze, Glimmer's sight reverted from that of a galaxy to a group of people standing together on a wide landing pad between two spaceships—Darla and the Millennia Seagull. She was not surprised to notice that where once nebulae had been, now Catra, Adora, Shen, and Veth stood in their place. The bright stars were her fellow bearers of Staves of Ultimate Power who were present—Double Trouble and Mermista. The green imp was standing with their Madgēcot partner Panga while the Princess of Salineas was enfolded in the arms of Seahawk. Glimmer found herself grinning at the memory of the reunion of the two lost lovers; Mermista had shrieked with glee upon laying eyes on her scoundrel, while Seahawk had melted into a weeping pile of goo. They had been in constant physical contact ever since; Glimmer doubted even the tremendous forces of the universe could ever pry them apart again.

Entrapta was nearby and entirely focused on the newest member of their intrepid party—Orko— as the Trollan attempted to hover out of reach of the scientific Princesses' sensors and instruments. But Entrapta would not be thwarted; she only extended her measuring devices at the ends of her long ponytails. Having reached the ultimate height of his levitation abilities, Orko finally gave up, lowering to the ground to allow his examination.

Not long ago, the travelers from Elysia and Thenlor had landed on Trollos, expecting to find Catra and Adora still in the midst of their honeymoon—instead, they got an unpredicted surprise in the form of Shen, Veth, Mermista, and Orko. It had been the bearer of He-Man who recounted the adventures in The Timeless Dimension—Mermista following up with her time spent in the service of Archon Lethe after Shen was complete with his tale.

It was a lot of information to convey and take in; thus, it had been agreed that they meet in this impromptu conference in the starport outside Trollos. Glimmer's father and aunt were speaking at present, filling in the blanks for those who did not come on the Millennial Falcon while Bow took notes nearby. Glimmer hoped that they could come to a form of consensus as to their next

course of action—for as of right now—she had no idea how to assault a god in one of the most powerful places in the universe.

"Cassie and I enlisted the services of an… *individual*… who took us aboard her ship and transported us to Thenlor—that's where we met up with Double Trouble and Panga," Micha was saying, waving a hand. "The rest you know about,"

Glimmer already knew her father's story but watched the others process this information. It was Shen who spoke firsts.

"Castle Grayskull? That dumpy old place? So, what if Veth's old boss has taken it over—let them have it!" He said derisively.

"*Ohhh, human*," Veth groaned next to him. "Just when I was beginning to think you had some wisdom, you go and say something like that,"

There was bite in the Nephraeh's words, making Glimmer think of the two Nebula in disharmony she had just witnessed. But there was affection in the way Veth looked at Shen, making her dismiss this thought—as did the beaming smile he returned in their direction.

It's definitely not those two who are having problems with each other, Glimmer thought to herself, examining the interplay between Human and Nephraeh. *I could be mistaken, but I believe Shen and Veth are—*

"Didn't you hear what Micah just said about Subternia?" Veth continued. "It is the nexus point at which the multitude of infinite realities converge!"

Glimmer recognized dawning horror cross Veth's beautiful lilac face as they covered their mouth briefly.

"I know what Archon Lethe plans to do," they continue, almost whispering. "Archon Lethe sustained themselves on the Nephraeh's empathy for the past thousand years. Now they want to… *feed*… on all realities at once, giving them a state of godhood

more supreme than any other being. The consequences are just too horrific to imagine!”

Glimmer could imagine what would happen if Archon Lethe got their way; she had seen a portion of that potential future in her vision.

“Evil absolute and total. Everywhere and at all times at once,” she said.

“Rather grim,” Double Trouble said, hands on hips. “So, how do we stop this nastiness from happening?”

“I think it’s rather simple, people,” Seahawk said in his typical cocky fashion. “We all go straight to Eternia and attack Castle Grayskull! We rip down the walls, dig this Archon Lethe out, and make them face justice! Etheria style!”

Withdrawing his laser rapier from his belt, the rogue highlighted his statement by performing a series of crosscuts and vertical slashes. Catra let out a bark of laughter.

“I like your style, buddy. But I think it will be a little more difficult than that. I hate to be the one who says this, but I think this situation needs a little more finesse,” she said.

“My Madgēcot sister speaks the truth,” Panga added. “To assail Castle Grayskull in a simpler time was no easy task—once we are inside, there is still the matter of defeating a god.”

“Okay,” Adora said, interjecting. “A full-frontal assault is out of the question—so is a sneak attack—neither operation addresses how to take down Archon Lethe. That leaves a reconnaissance mission. We need to get there and ascertain the threat level; once we have the enemy’s measure—that’s when we strike! I say we head to Etheria first and see what kind of allies and information we can gather there.”

Everyone looked at each other, nodding their assent at this course of action. Glimmer had to hand it to Adora; it was a good plan.

“Sounds like She-Ra is back! I take it you will be in charge of this mission?” Bow asked hopefully.

Adora appeared struck by the suggestion, right away backing down to huddle against Catra. Glimmer felt immensely saddened witnessing this display; it was confirmation that even though her friend was no longer Despara, they had not gotten the original Adora all the way. Glimmer recognized one portion of the problem which existed between the four Champions—Adora’s damage—and didn’t need further direction in finding the match—Veth.



"I don't think I have it in me, guys," Adora said as Catra wrapped her in an embrace. "I think if anyone should be leading this thing, it should be Glimmer,"

Feeling everyone's eyes upon her, Glimmer folded her hands together and pursed her lips. She had a feeling this would be the

direction this meeting would take but was careful not to be the one to steer it toward her assumption of command.

"I agree, we should have one person directing us, and it should be my Glimmer," Micah said proudly.

"Hold on," Panga said, holding up two orange hands. "I agree we should have a focal point of command, but as a representative of Elysia, there should be a Madgēcot voice in this! Also, what about Eternia?"

"I can't say I'm surprised, but you're forgetting Empyrea," Veth said coolly. "Also, with Orko here, we have a representative from Trollos as well,"

With hooded yellow eyes, Panga stared daggers at Veth, her striped tail beating the air behind her.

"I apologize for overlooking the Trollan—but forgetting you and your people was purely by design," she growled.

Glimmer stifled a groan; she was afraid this whole thing would descend into bickering, but before she could step in, Shen spoke up.

"Well, I'm pretty sure I'm a pretty good representative of Eternia—you know, being the King in waiting and all—and I say we defer to Etheria in this matter," he said, giving Veth a gentle nudge. "My Nephraeh friend also speaks for their world—what do you say, Veth? Should we all follow Glimmer?"

Glimmer watched Veth turn their head in Shen's direction, running their claws through their long black hair as they considered him. There was something very familiar in their expression, something she had once seen in the mirror on her wedding day.

"Sure. Why not," they said, giving a casual shrug. "Orko? What about you?"

With everyone's attention on him, the Trollan perked up and disentangled himself from Entrapta's current attempts to measure his dimensions with a tape measure.

"I will agree with whatever Catra decides!" he squeaked.

Glimmer saw surprise and mild embarrassment on Catra's face as her friend reacted to Orko deferring the rights of his entire species to her.

"Uh, okay, yeah," Catra said, ears lowered. "I'm going with Sparkles in charge—I mean, Glimmer,"

"So, I guess everyone except our dear representative from Elysia agrees to have Queen Glimmer of Etheria in charge!" Veth said, clapping their hands together to leer at Panga. "Does that mean you will follow our example, or will you be stubborn like all Madgēcots?"

Double Trouble placed their hands on Panga's shoulders before she could rush at the Nephraeh, the scandalous imp bringing their lips near one of the Madgēcot's long ears—whispering. Panga's disposition immediately changed from anger to mirth as a wide smile spread across her lips. Veth was not pleased.

"Got something to say, Shapeshifter? Say it out loud," They challenged.

Double Trouble favored Veth with a sharp-toothed grin before giving a brief bow.

"Oh, *honey*, it was nothing. Just a little joke between Kitten and myself," they cooed. "By the way—like your pants,"

Aegis Lace suddenly appeared on Double Trouble's lower half—the shapeshifter turned so everyone could view its fit on their lithe body as they ran green claws over their backside.

"Hey, Shen, who do you think this looks better on, me or Purple over there?" Double Trouble asked, their long thick tail waving

languidly behind them. Glimmer caught Shen shaking his head and grinning at Double Troubles' antics—but Panga and Veth were not amused—crossing their arms in unison.

Well, at least Double Trouble got the Madgēcot and Nephraeh to unify in annoyance of them, Glimmer thought, watching Double Trouble's display.

"Okay, let's not get sidetracked," Glimmer said. "Does anyone have a dispute with my heading up this venture?"

Panga waved a hand in resignation as the rest of the assembled group remained silent; Glimmer found herself once again thinking of what she had seen using the power of the Star Stone—it gave her an idea.

"So, following Adora's idea, we head to Etheria first—scout out the situation and set up a base of operations. I say we split up and go to two different locations. Since we have four Champions and three Staff Bearers, we can divide them up into two teams; Team Seagull and Team Darla." Glimmer said.

"I'm on Team Seagull," Mermista announced.

"I mean, it goes without saying that Adora and I are on a team," Catra added.

Glimmer immediately shook her head, hands on hips.

"No, I want Adora and Veth with me on Darla while Shen and Catra go on the Millennium Seagull with Mermista and Double Trouble." She stated.

"WHAT! No way, Sparkles! I retract my vote for you being in charge; you're not splitting up Adora and me—I refuse!" Catra yelled.

"Catra," Adora said, laying a hand on her wife's shoulder. "As much as I don't like it, we agreed to Glimmer being in charge."

Catra whirled on Adora. “But Adora! You’re not—”

A finger gently placed upon her lips silenced Catra; Adora smiled as she ran her finger through her wife’s long stone-gray mane.

“It will be fine, Catra—I will be fine,” she said gently. “Besides, I think I know what Glimmer is trying to do—we should trust her,”

Catra frowned as she crossed her arms but no longer argued against the decision. Glimmer was not looking forward to when Catra tried to seek her out later—hopefully, they would all be in space by then and on their separate ships.

“Okay! Now onto the next part: what are the two locations on Etheria we head for? I think Bright Moon is the obvious choice for Team Darla, but what about Team Seagull? Any suggestions?” Glimmer asked. She was surprised when Entrapta spoke up.

“I vote Team Seagull head to Dryl!” She said enthusiastically. “I’ve been getting an odd signal from there!”

* * *

“Hordak, wait up!”

Frosta scrambled to keep up with the bigger man’s stride; he was far ahead of her, stomping through the Whispering Woods with no regard for the level of noise being made.

The two of them had been on the run since that fateful ambush the day before, resting through the night to renew their flight the next day. Having been unable to sleep, Frosta was beyond tired and unsure how much longer she could keep up the brutal pace.

“Hordak! Please! I don’t have a fancy power suit to help me walk forever—wait!” She cried.

Hearing a rustling followed by what she perceived as a soft exhalation of breath behind her, Frosta bolted, fearing that a Vetala would soon have her in its clutches. Burning her dwindling

reserves in a mad sprint, Frosta screamed as a root caught her foot, sending her crashing to the ground. Rolling onto her back as fast as possible, Frosta raised her hands, ready to use her Ice Magic in a last-ditch attempt to save herself. But instead of seeing the slender and glossy form of a Vetala, Frosta only spotted the scampering shape of a small animal, scurrying amongst the underbrush in search of food. She breathed a sigh of relief only to startle with surprise when a metal-gloved hand presented itself over her head.

"Come, get up, Princess Frosta; we must move!" Hordak said.

Allowing herself to be lifted to her feet, Frosta scowled at the ex-Horde ruler's tone; she did not appreciate the fact that it was his rushing through the forest that made her fall in the first place.

"I can't keep up this pace, Hordak!" She yelled.

Just as he was about to continue his march, Hordak turned, pinning Frosta with eyes like two glowing embers. Frosta instantly felt she knew exactly what was going through his mind.

"Thinking about leaving me behind?" She spat. "Go ahead; you practically ditched everyone else in this Resistance! Once you get rid of me, nothing else will be holding you back! I bet 'Big Brother' would be so proud if he could see you now!"

Hordak did not respond to her diatribe and continued to gaze at her with an inscrutable expression; Frosta raised her hands, exasperated.

"Well? What are you waiting for?" She yelled.

"You are incorrect in your assumptions, Princess Frosta. I was not thinking of abandoning you, only doing a rough calculation in my head," he responded.

"Oh yeah, of what?" Frosta demanded.

“Your approximate weight and the required amount of my suit’s energy reserves needed to carry you. That was all,” Hordak said simply.

“Oh,” Frosta replied. “Well… in that case…”

Suddenly embarrassed, Frosta fidgeted momentarily before finding the right words.

“Carrying me is unnecessary, Hordak, but let’s at least slow down. I think if we were being chased, the enemy would have gotten us by now. Besides, where are we going? What is our plan besides just going aimlessly through the Whispering Woods?” She asked.

The ex-ruler of the Horde glanced around momentarily, Frosta’s words seeming to jar him out of his single-minded drive and back to the reality of their situation.

“I don’t have a destination; I just—” Hordak stammered. “You’re right, though. There is no point in pushing ourselves; it only serves to weaken us.”

Frosta smiled, nodding. “Yes, but we shouldn’t stand still. Let me think, hmmm…”

As she thought about where they currently were, the perfect hiding location came unbidden to Frosta’s mind. She snapped her fingers in the air.

“Our old hideout should be close by! There might be some stuff left over when we hid there during Horde Prime’s invasion!” She exclaimed.

“Let’s go,” Hordak said, indicating that Frosta should lead the way, the magnitude of the gesture not lost on the young Princess.

Frosta led them through the Whispering woods as best she could, following half-remembered lands marks toward the base they had abandoned more than two years ago. Frosta had been so young during that time, primarily taking the lead from Mermista, who

assumed command in Adora and Glimmer's absence. Besides the looming threat of death or mind control, it had been an exciting time for Frosta—being part of the Princess Rebellion against a known foe.

But now she had no clue who their enemy was or even where they were—on top of that—she was in charge now, leading a broken-down remnant of an old foe toward the hope of salvation in the old rebel base. Suffice it to say, things were not as thrilling as before—more like downright depressing.

What am I doing? What is the point of this? She thought for not the first time.

"You know, Princess Frosta," Hordak spoke suddenly, making Frosta stop in place.

"Yes?" She said, turning to regard the ex-Horde ruler. He stood there as if at an impasse, unsure whether to speak further.

"You were wrong when you said I am doing this to live up to the expectations of Horde Prime," he said.

Frosta was listening; this was the most Hordak had said in a while, and the fact that he was about to speak more of himself interested her greatly.

"I am not doing this to appease my brother's ghost or have anything to do with self-worth; I wanted to know what it felt like to be the hero for once." He said before continuing.

"After I was created, it was explained that I would be a part of something great—to spread Horde Prime's light throughout the galaxy. I was so proud to be a part of such a noble cause, and for a long time, I believed what we did was just. I rose through the ranks of clones to become one of Horde Prime's generals—one of his best."

"During the long years of non-stop war, I started to notice something; there was no pattern to Horde Prime's conquests—his

march across the galaxy had no purpose other than to fulfill his thirst for control. The people in the worlds he conquered were no better off having the banner of the Horde on their soil, and I began to see Horde Prime's peace for the lie it was."

"It was after I questioned my brother on his doctrines that I was deemed as defective and stripped of my title as general. My *Brother* demoted me to the rank of a mere ship's captain and sent me out into the nether regions of the galaxy in exile. It was during the hyperspace translation to my new fate that we veered too close to a gravitational anomaly—the immense forces of which ripped my starship out of this existence and into Despondos. There we crashed on the only planet in that dimension—Etheria."

"I landed on that planet as a fractured man; one part of me still questioned Horde Prime's ways, while the other was ashamed of my downfall. I was left with the only thing I knew how to do—domination. I attempted to do to Etheria what Horde Prime had done to the galaxy—and if not for my nagging doubt—perhaps I may have ruled Etheria long ago."

"You know the rest of the story; Horde Prime's arrival and my integration back into the clone army when he attempted to erase my personality. Then Horde Prime's defeat at the hands of She-Ra and the Tribunal that took place after. For all the pain I caused Etheria, I thought death would be my judgment—for that was what I felt I deserved. Imagine my shock when not only was I given a second chance, but I had the option to turn my skills towards helping instead of hurting. I was overwhelmed with gratitude."

Hordak took a moment to pause his monologue as the memory of the alien emotion returned to the old warlord.

"Besides Entrapta, no one had even expressed such kindness to me. The Tribunal was a manifestation of Etheria's will—thus, the entirety of the people who lived there. I was prepared to live out the remainder of my days in the Crypto Castle—working towards the betterment of the people of Etheria. But I always felt it was

never enough, and I wished for the opportunity to truly redeem myself."

"I thought I had the opportunity to lead the rebellion against these new invaders—to become a hero instead of villain—for once. What you overheard back in Elberon, I was not speaking to Horde Prime but the people of Etheria. I want to be worthy of their forgiveness—nothing more, nothing less,"

Frosta took this all in, amazed at how badly she misjudged Hordak's intentions. Instead of chasing an unobtainable dream, he was actually trying to do something of real value—misguided as it was.

"Hordak, I appreciate what you are trying to do, but forgiveness is a gift given with no strings attached. You are not required to do all this; you don't have to be the hero," she said.

Hordak gave a nod of recognition. "Yes, I appreciate that. But it's what I want to do. I want to spend the rest of my days chasing the dream of being a savior instead of a tyrant. Of being protector instead of destroyer. *It is my greatest wish.*"

Frosta shrugged, not being able to fault Hordak's aspirations.

"Well, I guess I'm glad to have you at my side. Ready to continue?" She asked, hand held out in the direction she hoped the secret hideout was located.

"Yes, I think we should—" Hordak began to say but was interrupted by a soft beep from his wrist.

"What is it?" Frosta asked.

As he glanced at it, Frosta watched as both of Hordak's red glowing eyes went wide with shock before a grin appeared on his lips.

"It's a signal—from Dryl," he said, pressing another button.

“Well?! Are you going to tell me what it is or what?!” Frosta exclaimed.

Hordak turned his attention to her, his craggy white features set in a look of hope.

“It's Emily. Somehow, she and the other Horde Bots have captured the Crypto Castle!

* * *

Mild sadness pervaded Veth’s spirit as they approached the deployed ramp to Darla’s open hatchway; they would be leaving Trollos as soon as they entered, but their mood had nothing to do with leaving this planet behind.

It’s temporary; we are only splitting up briefly and will meet again on Etheria. Once the two bases have been established, I will see him again. They reasoned to themselves. Veth suddenly stopped as another thought came unbidden.

What if something happens to him? That Human is always getting into mischief; maybe I should talk to Glimmer—get her to switch Catra and me.

With a slight shake of the head, Veth decided against that and resumed their course toward an escape from their desires.

“Hey, Veth! Wait up!” A familiar voice called to them.

Veth covered the smile that attempted to reach their lips and turned smoothly, affecting a casual air as they watched Shen run towards them.

“Yes, Human?” They said, tucking a strand of hair behind their long ear.

Shen grinned at this response as he slowed his approach—Veth abruptly noticed he was carrying something under one arm: some type of black garment.

“What do you have there?” Veth asked, pointing a clawed finger.

Shen’s smile broadened as he held the item up, revealing it to be a jacket—a black jacket of a familiar design.

“Mermista had found some new clothes and was going to throw away her Aegis Lace body suit. I took the Lace and used it to patch up your old coat—what do you think?” He said, holding the garment out.

Veth was struck dumb as they took the gift from Shen, running their fingers over its surface and recognizing the texture of the Aegis Lace.

“How did you meld the seams together?” They asked breathlessly. Unlike their pants, the Lace had bonded fully, forming one piece out of many.

“Oh, well, I took what you taught me and added a few of my own tricks,” Shen said with a wink. “You like it?”

Veth turned the jacket over in their hands, noticing openings here and there where an especially large hole had been in the original. Shen had left them open and in stylishly strategical positions—obviously—the Human had put a lot of thought into the gift.

“Try it on!” Shen prompted.

Veth did as they were bidden, not minding that Shen held the jacket open, sliding it up their arms to rest on their shoulders. He circled them once the jacket was in place, adjusting the fit and smoothing the fabric down over their chest.

“Yeah, you look much better in black,” Shen commented with a slow nod.

Veth stared back at him with mouth parted slightly, entirely struck by this unlooked-for gesture as a memory of what someone had said recently came unbidden to their mind.

JUST LOOK AT HIS QUINTESSENCE AT THE SAME TIME AS YOURS—YOU WILL SEE IT THEN

Feeling that now was the appropriate time, Veth did as the *other* had instructed; they used their Nephraeh sight to look at Shen's soul, using the unique nature of the vision to look at their own simultaneously. What they perceived was unbelievable.

Veth had beheld a variety of quintessences by now and knew that each pattern was unique—no two were the same. From the way ectoplasm coalesced into sublime anti-geometries, to the mechanisms in which emotions were displayed in etheric strands of celestial vibrations.

All soul patterns had portions of nothing voids in them, arrayed in a way that was also acutely unique to the individual quintessence. Veth had noticed that when they looked at pairs of people, sometimes their soul patterns overlapped in such a way as to fill these empty pockets within each other. Catra and Adora were a perfect example; they were matched in such a harmonious way as to be the ultimate match for one another—soul mates—bound for all eternity no matter where and in whom their quintessence reemerges after their previous shells extinguish.

That was precisely what Veth saw right now.

* * *

"So, you didn't answer my question, Veth. Do you like it?"

Shen waited for some reaction from the Nephraeh, expecting at the very least to receive a flippant comment—not silence. Veth was looking at him in their odd way; head tilted with silver eyes glittering in the rosy Trollan sunlight.

He wondered if he had gone too far with this offering; Veth had said the jacket had a name—the Immaru—explaining that the coat had been passed down over the centuries from one bearer of Zhe-La to another. Perhaps he had performed some sacrilege by altering it the way he did?

"I figured since you and the Nephraeh are starting on a new path, maybe the Immaru can as well." He continued lamely. "Sorry, did I overstep?"

Veth finally seemed to snap out of their trance, shaking their head quickly.

"No, you didn't. I like it," they said softly.

Shen felt as if the sun had risen on the cold night of existence and grinned like a fool—*they like it!*

"That's great!" He said, still smiling. "Well… okay, then. Take care of yourself, Veth. I guess we will see each other on Etheria?"

The Nephraeh only shrugged at this suggestion, still gazing at him strangely. Not wanting to draw out what was already an awkward exchange, Shen gave a weak wave goodbye before turning towards the Millennial Seagull. He spotted Catra waiting for him on the ship's gangway, hands on hips as she watched the exchange between the two Champions of Grayskull.

Maybe Veth was just being nice when they said they liked the jacket. He thought, walking towards his ride to Etheria.

"Shen, wait," Veth said behind him. Their voice had a desperate quality, something he had never heard before. Shen turned, confused.

"Yeah—"

Before he could say anything further, two hands clasped Shen's head, pulling him into a pair of soft lips—they instantly seized his, locking in a sensual union. The hands then moved urgently down his back, drawing his body into another's; Shen felt something there, a sensual declaration that translated into a promise of something more intimate.

As his attention was drawn back to the kiss, Shen realized the mouth was familiar, the unique flavor even more prevalent as a

velvet tongue slid briefly over his—two sharp points briefly tickling his bottom lip. Never in his short life had Shen experienced such an overwhelming sense of tender expression; he felt fully encapsulated by it, making him feel dizzy.



The person pulled back slightly as two glimmering eyes peered deeply into Shen's, their silvery depths brimming with affection before he was embraced more tightly this time. A smooth face

nuzzled the side of his head as a body pressed fully against his own once more, seeming to fill every part of him at once.

"Take care of yourself, Human." An androgynous voice whispered in his ear. "I very much want to be able to see you again,"

As quickly as the presence had enveloped him, it was gone, and Shen found himself watching Veth walk away.

It took him a moment to reconcile what had just happened with the Nephraeh he knew, but there was no denying that Veth had just kissed him—passionately. The evidence just didn't exist in his memory; it remained as a lingering sweetness in his mouth, a haunting scent on his body, and the manifestation of desire awakened within him.

Shen watched Veth move swiftly up into Darla—not even looking back as they vanished within. He remained standing there as if in a trace, still savoring the ultimate experience of having been kissed by Veth.

"Hey lover-boy, you staying here or what?" Catra called from behind.

Shen nodded dumbly as he turned, Catra's heterochromatic eyes watching him the entire time he walked toward her position on the Millennial Seagulls deployment ramp.

"Yeah, totally didn't see that coming," she said, sarcasm plain.

Catra's arms were crossed as Shen halted before her, a look of amusement on her face.

"All I did was give them a jacket," Shen said with a shrug.

Right away, Catra chuckled, giving her friend a playful slap on his arm.

"You're such a dummy," she said, beaming.

BONUS ILLUSTRATION!!!



Chapter End Notes

Catra and Adora sketch by Ansdrela.

Veth and Shen by Miledibuja.

BONUS ILLUSTRATION Veth and Double Trouble by AV Stravaganza a.k.a. fan_fun_off

Alleviation

Chapter Summary

Stuck with one another, Adora and Veth must come to an accord-if not-then the tasks they face in the future will be insurmountable.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

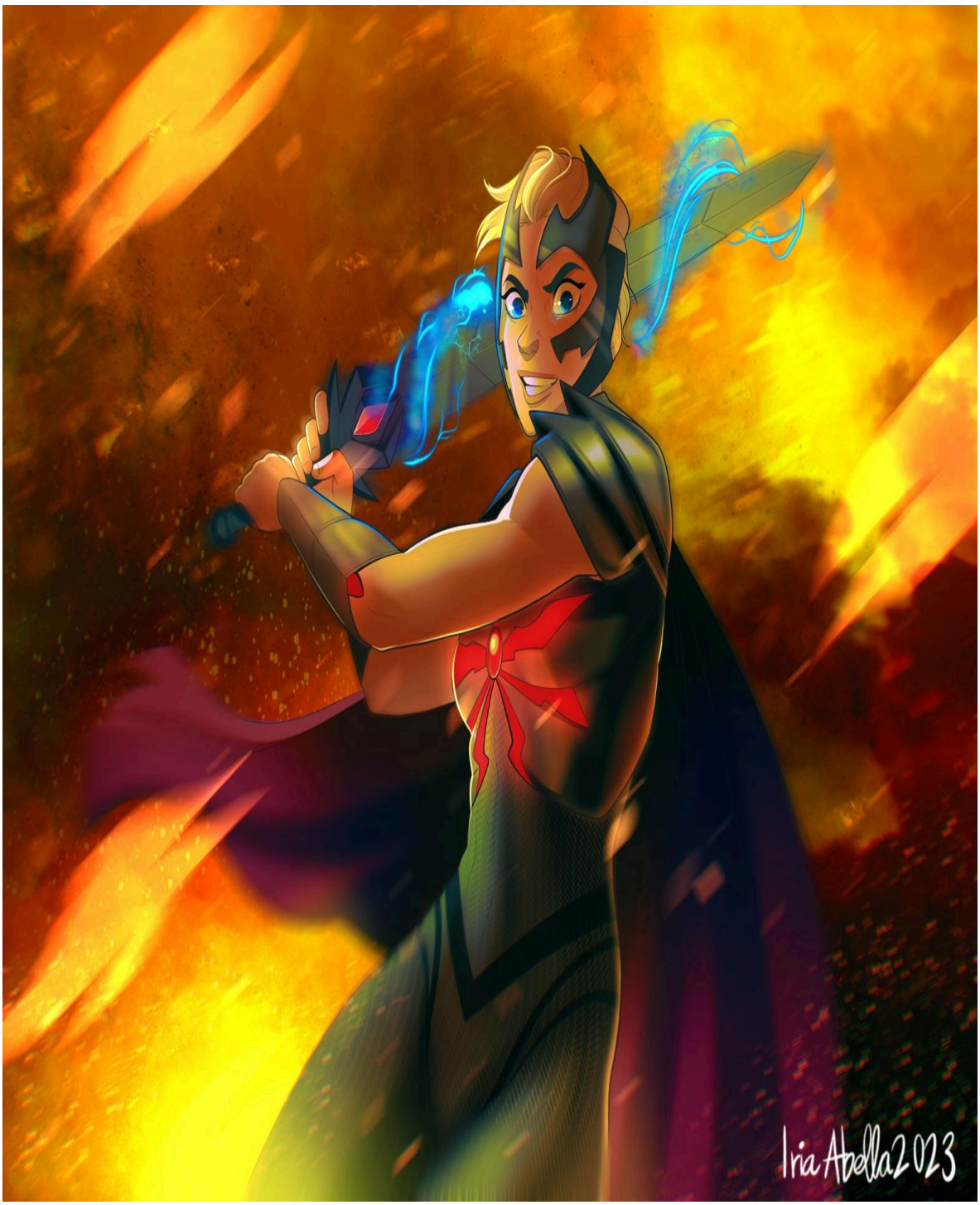
The sights and smells of battle surround her, wrapping Despara in the blanket of death and destruction—this is what she lives for, to pit her physicality against others, to utterly shatter their bodies with hands and blade. By dismantling her foes, Despara is proving them undeserving of life—and by doing so—evincing her own worth in the eyes of the cold, hard universe. This is what it is to be alive—to fight and kill—to witness those weaker than herself flee in absolute terror of their lives.

Someone is speaking to Despara, but she ignores them to run full bore down the street towards the target; an immense blocky building, small windows peering out like slits in the concrete surface. It is a fortress, an indomitable structure whose only purpose is to keep her and her forces out. It is also an object lesson; to stand against Despara is to lose.

Black shapes race to either side of her, keeping pace with Despara; it is the Vetala, panting like a pack of hungry wolves as they seek prey amongst the enemy. Out of all her allies, it is the Vetala she finds kinship with; they do not lie to themselves about what they want—like the foolish Nephraeh. The Vetala are true to their nature; they consume to satiate an unnatural desire with no care for whom they feed upon, living just for themselves.

With an almost casual sweep of her mighty blade, Despara demolishes the door baring her entrance to the fortress. She does not break stride as she accesses the cramped foyer, finding a

small platoon of enemy soldiers arrayed before her. Bright lasers lance in Despara's direction as the Enosians fire, some of which hit overeager Vetala and incinerate the creatures. She can hear the monsters scream as they are sent back to purgatory, but does not care—the Vetala's only purpose is to serve.



Despara summons an indigo disc of pure Oblivion before her, allowing her to charge the enemies behind its protection—straight away, she is amongst the soldiers—smiting them with wild sweeps of her deadly blade. The ones she has not killed panic, turning to flee towards a nearby staircase—the Vetala are immediately on these cowards—pulling them down to sink onyx fangs into flesh.

Realizing that all her enemies are vanquished, Despara runs to the nearby staircase, hoping to find a worthy foe amongst so much frailty—she bounds up many flights—taking mighty leaps over twenty stairs at once. Here and there, Despara comes across a defender racing down towards her—not bothering to use a weapon—she simply rams them with her body, shattering every bone in their body with the momentum of She-Ra. Despara leaves them smashed and bleeding, unworthy of her further attention as she reaches her destination—the Command Center—the place where the defense would be at its strongest. Perhaps here Despara can find what she seeks.

The Command Center is a circular room—banks of communication consoles in the center on a raised dais—that is where the majority of the defenders cluster. Between grim and helmeted faces, she can glimpse a heavily decorated man of seniority—obviously—the leader here.

Despara dismisses him; she does not care about decapitating the leadership and ending the fight—she wants to prolong it! If Despara could fight forever, she would, for that is what life is; the unending struggle for dominance over others, for her supremacy is supreme.

Just as Despara is about to engage the last defenders, a jarring noise grasps her attention; a large figure is stomping out of an alcove set in the room's periphery. Despara immediately recognizes it as a mecha suit, just like the ones that had defended the Relativity Forge. But instead of carrying a cannon, this one sports a shield and sword, both of which shimmer and crackle with power fields.

"Finally!" She cries.

Despara wastes no time rushing this new foe, ecstasy coursing through her as her magical sword connects with the technological one. Sparks fly as the two weapons are violently repelled by one another; Despara recovers quickly from this unforeseen reaction as the mecha suit pilot reels backward. Not wanting to end the duel so soon, Despara forgoes a killing strike; she lazily jabs at the enemy with the point of her blade, the maneuver defected by the charged surface of the shield, causing yet another potent feedback. The mecha suit pilot is prepared this time; pistons engage in the leg joints' armatures to compensate for the released energy. Despara smiles, hoping her enemy will use the respite given them wisely, giving her the desired challenge.

A popping comes from the mecha suit's arms as mechanisms engage within; abruptly, the energy shield folds away as the mecha suit takes its sword in both hands, delivering a series of overhand chops in rapid succession. Despara brings her weapon up in time to block the attack, her teeth rattling from the sheer power of the blows. She begins to laugh at the sheer exuberance of being bludgeoned, the brutality of it like balm to her warrior spirit.

But Despara's humor vanishes as pain lances her shoulder; she is getting sloppy—her attacker made it past her guard. Despara snarls with fury and jumps back away from her opponent; thinking she is retreating out of fear, the mecha suit charges, re-engaging its shield to smite its nemesis down.

Too late, the mecha suit pilot realizes their error as Despara explodes forward, smashing the shield away to cleave the arm holding it at the bicep. A static howl emits from the suit's vocalizers as the mecha suit backs away. Still, Despara will not relent, stabbing her enemy in an approximation of where the pilot's torso is before kicking the mecha suit back and off her sword. It crashes backward on the ground as a death moan emits from the vocalizer, indicating that Despara's blade has hit its mark.

Reaching down, she tears the entire front portion of the mecha suit away, wanting to witness the pilot's last moments in this life. Despara's eyes abruptly widen; she recognizes this person.

Catra lies enmeshed in the suit's harness; she is wearing her crimson Jaadoo suit, the front pierced by a mighty rent. Catra turns her heterochromatic eyes on Despara as her life essence flows in runnels down her chest, collecting in a pool around her.

"Adora… help me…" she rasps.

Confused, Despara peers down at her body and hands—no longer is she encased in black armor—but white and silver!

"Wait—what? I'm not Despara… I'm Adora!" She exclaims, the sudden realization breaking down the façade of callousness.

"Adora, please… help me! Quick! Before it's too late!" Catra pleads.

She-Ra/Adora surges forward, her intent now to mend instead of tear, and places her hands upon the broken body of her wife.

"Hold on, Catra!" She-Ra/Adora cajoles, summoning what she needs.

Right away, she perceives the flow from her core and down her arms, the warm sensation of She-Ra's restorative magic at work. She-Ra/Adora feels instant gratitude for the ability to undo her wrongs; she—

—wait… something is not right; she senses it immediately. There is a feeling of nourishment within She-Ra/Adora's being, like a drink of water after a period of extreme thirst, making her feel stronger. She-Ra/Adora instantly knows what is happening as Catra gasps, her heterochromatic eyes going wide; instead of filling the one before her with healing rejuvenation, She-Ra/Adora is leeching her wife's life away, taking it to strengthen her already formidable power.

"NO!!!" She-Ra/Adora cries, removing her hands before further harm can be done.

"Adora, you can't help me… there is too much Despara in you…" Catra whispers, her eyes closing for the last time.

But the damage is complete; being already so close to death's door, Catra's fate is now sealed. With her healing power now utterly corrupted, She-Ra/Adora can only watch helplessly as the one she loves more than anything slips away.

"CATRA!!! NOOO!!!"

With a jolt, Adora grasped at the air in a panicked attempt to forestall Catra's fate—but then, in realization—discovered that she was not in the Military facility back on Enos, but in a bed. Peering about herself, Adora perceived a dimly lit room, diamond-shaped mirrored ornaments adorning both walls to either side of the bed. *That's right*—she was in her personal cabin aboard Darla, on her way back to Etheria.

She instinctively reached down for the comforting feel of Catra's body, seeking her between the cold sheets. But there was nothing, for Catra was not with her on this trip; her wife was aboard the Millennial Seagull and off on her own mission to Dryl.

Instead, Adora turned her attention to her wrist, removing a bracelet clasped there to wrap her fingers around the small form—it felt good in Adora's hands; the warmth of the one who made it had long since dissipated, yet her essence was intrinsic to its design. Strands of stone-gray hair woven together with strips of crimson cantrips removed from a specific Jaadoo suit. Dotted amongst these materials were colorful beads embedded in the band, forming a simple design that was somehow familiar to Adora.

Wrapping the ornament back around her wrist, Adora closed the two clasps before inspecting the fit; it was perfect—not too tight,

not too loose. I was as if it were made for her—which it was, of course.

Lifting the bracelet to her nose, Adora inhaled deeply, picking up the familiar musk clinging to the jewelry—earthy impressions with sweet undertones, behind that, a strong hint of something else—like spice. She could not get enough of it—and yet—drew the arm back; the strong sense of desiderim it evoked was overwhelming, verging on a panic attack.

"I miss you so much already, Catra," she whimpered to the empty cabin.

Right before they separated, Catra had given Adora the bracelet, having made it from her own hair and clothing the night before. It was a Madgēcot Kangan, based on the design of one given to Catra by her twin brother, Viraj. The one Catra's brother had given her was called a Rahki, while the one Adora received was a Kangan; one exchanged between siblings, the other between lovers. Adora was not sure what the influence of the relationship status had in the creation of either bracelet but was thankful to have a piece of her wife so close.

She glanced about the room, already knowing it was the one Catra was sequestered in when they rescued her from Horde Prime. Ever since Adora had awakened from her nightmare existence as Despara, Catra had been a constant in her presence, helping to stem the tortured ache left in Adora's soul with the warmth of her love. Now that solace was gone, and her ability for self-comfort was unattainable, the well of sympathy Adora for herself having dried up in the blaze of Despara's crimes.

Darla was only a few days away from Etheria—but Adora didn't know if she could hold out that long. How did she go years without Catra during the war between the Princesses and the Horde? Who was that strong person that she had been, and where did she go? All that was left was this shadow, unable to forgive or heal, the path to salvation blocked behind layers of damage.

Hold it together, Adora. You got this; you are strong. You are She-Ra, she urged to herself. But the brave words had no effect; as soon as they filled her, they were gone, flowing out of the many punctures in her spirit, leaving her empty once more.

Should I go see what the others are up to? Maybe being around Glimmer and Bow would be good for me. I mean, it had been the three of us during the war. Perhaps I can reclaim a small measure of who I once was around them. She thought.

But as soon as she thought about it, Adora dismissed the idea, knowing she could run into *them* by leaving her cabin. Not for the first time did Adora wonder why Glimmer had decided to team her up with the treacherous Nephraeh—Veth. Adora knew that Glimmer wanted her to somehow bond with the Nephraeh—if only her friend knew how much of an everyday struggle it was for Adora, then perhaps she would not have made this decision. But no matter how much of a burden was on Adora's shoulders, she would not expect the Queen of Etheria to help carry it. Even in her new condition, it was not Adora's way.

But the weight of pain was very much real, more than Adora had ever had to bear in the past—for in that time—her integrity was still intact, unlike now in her debased post-Despara frame of mind. The crushing guilt combined with the dark dreams was slowly eating away at her soul—Adora was not sure how much more she could take. There seemed to be no end to the misery, no escape from the deeds and crimes committed by her own hands—it was in these moments that the paltry excuse of having no sympathy during those times evaporated. How could it be when Adora remembered doing everything as Despara? At the moment Despara committed her crimes, she remembered feeling every justification as a valid point to be delivered at the tip of her deadly blade.

Is that what she was? Just one emotion away from being a cold-blooded killer? How could Adora live with this knowledge? It would be better if she were just dead.

Instantly after thinking of such a thing, Adora's mind went to Catra, feeling immense sadness—not for herself—but for her wife. Catra would be devastated if Adora was gone—*how could she even consider such a thing?* No, there would be no relief in her demise; that left only one course for Adora—the continuation of her existence—this abject state of suffering in solitude.

Absolutely miserable, Adora curled up into a ball and began to weep.

* * *

Kaleidoscopes of dazzling luminosity reflected off silver irises as Veth gazed out of Darla's forward viewport, taking in the splendor that was hyperspace. They had never looked upon the chaos of faster-than-light travel with their Nephraeh sight—but now that they could—Veth couldn't take their eyes off it. There were so many new wonders to experience that Veth constantly found themselves caught off guard—it left them wondering: how they were ever happy without their full capacity for empathy? A more recently discovered delight had Veth reach up, gently brushing claw tips over purple lips in memory of a kiss.

Am I in love with him? They pondered. *How is that possible? I have only known him for such a short time.*

Again, Veth's thoughts ushered them to Nefeli—a love that had grown from the accumulation of a lifetime spent together. It was a genuine love Veth had felt for the other Nephraeh—no less authentic than the one they had for the Human.

But still, how could they? It felt like a sort of betrayal to Nefeli—to have these feelings for another so soon after their previous lover's death. Veth let out a heavy sigh as the feelings of guilt returned, mixing into their quintessence to sour their disposition—like a wrong ingredient added to a dish, making the meal unappetizing.

IT SADDENS ME TO SEE WHAT LETHE HAS DONE TO THE NEPHRAEH. YOU WOULD NOT BE IN THIS PLIGHT OF

UNCERTAINTY IF YOU LIVED IN MY TIME

Veth blinked to hear the strange voice speak in their mind; they had been wondering when their unknown benefactor would turn up again.

What do you mean by that? They thought back.

THERE IS NO REASON TO FEEL SHAME FOR LOVE. IT IS BEAUTIFUL TO FEEL THIS WAY, AND THERE IS NO REASON IT SHOULD BE RESTRICTED TO A SINGLE PERSON

Veth frowned as they pondered these words; the concept seemed outlandish to them—being in love with more than one person? Preposterous.

THAT IS LETHE TALKING; THEY NOT ONLY TOOK THE EMPATHY OF THE NEPREAH BUT THE OPEN-MINDED THINKING. LETHE DID THAT IN ORDER TO CONTROL YOU, FOR TO LET LOVE SPREAD WOULD HAVE STRENGTHENED IT AS A WHOLE, THEREBY THREATENING TO THEM

You seem to know quite a bit about Lethe, whoever you are, Veth directed with suspicion. *How do I know this isn't some trick by Lethe? Using some old link they had to me—from back when I used to serve them.*

The voice was silent for a few heartbeats, increasing Veth's doubt. Finally, it spoke.

I PROMISE YOU; I'M NOT LETHE. IF YOU DOUBT MY WORDS, THEN I ASK YOU: WHY WOULD LETHE HELP YOU REMEMBER WHO YOU WERE? WHY WOULD LETHE WANT THE BEARER OF ZHE-LA TO BE ONCE AGAIN THE CHAMPION OF THE LIGHT AND NOT THE DARKNESS

Veth found themselves nodding at this but was not entirely satisfied.

Yes, that is true. They conceded. *So then tell me who you are, then? Why can't you tell me your name if I should trust you?*

IT'S COMPLICATED VETH. IT'S BEST IF I SHOW YOU. WE NEED TO COMPLETE THE VISION—WE WERE INTERRUPTED BY THAT MADGĒCOT BEFORE I COULD REVEAL THE FULL TRUTH TO YOU

Veth winced at the thought of returning to that vision; they did not want to behold what further vile depravity the fallen Nephraeh would enact—but knew they must. It was somehow tied to current events, and Veth had to witness the entirety of that dark thread, no matter how distasteful the experience.

Since we have an abundance of time until we reach Etheria, how about you show me the rest now? Veth asked.

YES, I AGREE; YOU MUST SEE WHAT I HAVE TO SHOW YOU IF YOU WANT TO DEFEAT LETHE. PERHAPS YOU SHOULD FIND A PRIVATE PLACE? YOU MUST BE RELAXED WITH NO POTENTIAL FOR DISTRACTIONS

Veth wholeheartedly agreed with the advice and, without thinking, turned to identify who else was on Darla's bridge with them.

Micha was sitting on the pilot's throne, his dark eyes moving from the glowing holographic navigation sphere floating before him to the Nephraeh, sensing their movement.

"Need something?" He said, not bothering to hide the disapproval in his voice.

"No," Veth said curtly as they moved past him and towards the exit at the rear of the space. They knew that the accumulation of mistrust directed at them was well earned, but still, Veth wasn't in the mood for the older Human's dislike for them—not Micah or his hypercritical sister watching them from the corner of the bridge. Veth was eager to have this trip over; not only would they be away from these hostile people, but so they could once again be able to lay eyes upon—

Veth caught that train of thought as they glanced down the hallway leading to the cabins, knowing that to keep thinking of Shen would only cause them to veer towards greater heights of distraction.

THERE IS NO HARM IN A LITTLE FANTASY, VETH

"Not now!" Veth hissed aloud.

"Is everything okay, Veth?" A voice called behind them. Veth turned to notice the Queen of Etheria standing before her cabin, her face open and friendly. Out of everyone aboard Darla, only Glimmer and her husband had been cordial to Veth—Bow even going as far as inviting the Nephraeh to play a game involving miniaturized versions of his friends. Veth had thought such a thing slightly odd and politely declined—but was touched by the offer all the same.

"Yes, Glimmer. Things are well. I just decided I needed a break from the fun company on the bridge and was about to retire to my room," Veth said coolly.

Glimmer laughed brightly as she reached out and gently touched their forearm—something Veth noticed Glimmer did whenever she was near them.

"Oh, don't mind my father and aunt—they mean well, but they are of the older generation. They have a hard time seeing anything but someone's past," she said.

"So, does that mean you don't have that same problem? You don't think of me as the enemy any longer?" Veth asked.

Glimmer's smile became lopsided as she tilted her head back and forth.

"Well… I wouldn't say I am ready to give you the keys to Bright Moon, but I'm willing to give you a chance," she said with a chuckle.

Veth gave a shrug—that was more than they would have ever asked for.

"Fair enough," they responded.

"Don't worry; I have a lot of experience with forgiveness. During the war against the Horde, Catra had done some pretty awful things to me personally—but now—she is one of my best friends. Since you seem to be… *getting close…* to one of my other good friends, perhaps I can add you to that list one day?" Glimmer said, the hope plain in her voice.

The sentiment touched Veth; here was a person whose loved ones they had harmed, and she was now willing to call them a friend—it was overwhelming. The embarrassment Veth felt not only extended from Glimmer's offer but the apparent knowledge of their feelings for Shen.

What? Does everyone know? I only just kissed him. Their mind raced.

OH, I FORGET HOW FOOLISH THE YOUNG ARE. EVEN WITHOUT NEPHRAEH SIGHT, EVERYONE WITH EYES CAN SEE IT, VETH

"Oh! I'm sorry! Is the thing with Shen still a secret?" Glimmer said, bringing Veth out of themselves. "Don't worry; I'm not a big gossiper. I will keep it hush, hush,"

Veth gave a weak grimace as the Queen of Etheria made a zipping motion over her lips but then chuckled at their own foolishness.

"What is going on between Shen and myself has not been openly discussed, Queen Glimmer. He and I have not really had a chance to figure it out, actually." Veth explained.

"Oh, please! Stop with the Queen business! Just call me Glimmer!" Glimmer said, brushing a hand against Veth's wrist. "Anyway! I don't want to keep you from whatever you are doing—but don't forget—we are having dumplings tonight! My treat!"

Veth watched Glimmer make her way to the bridge, giving one last friendly wave goodbye before disappearing through the door.

ITS GOOD TO SEE THAT THE NEPHRAEH HAVE NOT LOST THEIR TOUCH—ALTHOUGH BACK IN MY TIME—SHE WOULD HAVE OPENLY PROPOSITIONED YOU INSTEAD OF JUST TOUCHING YOUR ARM

Oh, stop; she was just being nice. Veth thought with a shake of their head.

I ALSO FIND IT MILDLY HUMEROUS THAT THE BEARER OF ZHE-LA AND THE BEARER OF HE-MAN ARE SOUL-MATES. THE HE-MAN I REMEMBER—HERHEIF WAS HIS NAME—WAS AN OAF OF A MAN WHO PURSUED ME ENDLESSLY. THAT WAS UNTIL…

Veth frowned as the voice died off; they were interested to hear more about the person speaking to them and even more curious to know why they now sounded sad. But before they could coax the *other* to expound further, a bitter sentiment seized their attention—it was coming from outside themselves, nearby.

I FELT THAT TOO. IT'S COMING FROM THE ROOM AHEAD. USE YOUR NEPHRAEH SIGHT

Doing as the *other* prompted, Veth focused with their second sight, the transcendent nature of the vision passing through the solid walls of the cabin to the quintessence within. There Veth beheld a tormented apparition—a soul so consumed by guilt that it was slowly imploding into self-hatred. They did not need their physical sight to know it was Adora they were regarding; Veth bore witness to the consequences of their actions when they first returned to this universe. But what they now discerned was far worse—Adora was very sick, and what she needed could not be found in the realm of medicine.

VETH, FOR NOW, THIS TAKES PRECEDENCE OVER THE VISION. YOU MUST GO TO HER

Veth did not need the goad from the voice; they were already at the cabin door, pressing the button for the door chime. They watched the form within shift as the pleasant tone sounded but did not move towards the door. Not willing to give up, Veth pressed the button multiple times—eventually—Adora rose from the bed, her quintessence moving in the direction of the cabin access. The door panels slid to either side with a gentle whoosh, revealing a haggard Adora whose eyes widened with surprise as she discovered the visitor was the one responsible for her anguish.

"Hello, Adora," Veth said. They put as much friendliness in the greeting as possible but knew the gesture backfired as Adora's eyes red-rimmed squinted at the tone.

"What do you want, Veth?" She asked, crossing her arms.

Wrong-footed, Veth nervously ran fingers through their long hair, glancing behind Adora and into her living quarters. It was a mess; clothes were strewn on the floor, and the remains of several meals sat on the nearby bed stand.

"Uh, can I come in?" Veth asked.

Adora appeared incredulous, her dark eyebrows raised at the prospect of being alone with them in her room.

"Are you serious? Why would I want that, Veth?" She asked, anger plain in her voice.

Veth sighed as they deflated slightly—it was a good point. Up until now, Adora and Veth had fought each other twice in, both battles having been stopped before either could do further damage.

"Listen, Adora. I don't blame you for not trusting me—I get it. But I know what is going on with you, the pain and the guilt from your time as Despara. I can help you if you give me a chance," Veth explained.

“Yeah, I bet you know how I feel!” Adora seethed. “Of course you do! You are the one responsible for it!”

Adora made as if she were going to strike out at them—to which Veth merely shut their eyes and stood their ground, ready to accept her wrath. When no blow came, Veth opened their eyes to realize that Adora had retreated into the cabin, plopping down on the bed to hug herself in comfort. Veth took the risk of entering her domain, moving silently to sit on the bedside opposite Adora. Even though they were looking in the opposite direction, Veth could still view the trauma of her quintessence; it stung their mystical sense to bear witness to its bleak aspect.

“I’m not sure if I can fully explain how I know what you are going through, Adora. It is fairly new to me, ever since—”

“Spare me your nonsense, Veth,” Adora interrupted. “Catra already told me about your ‘special eyes’ or whatever. She also said you’ve changed—but I don’t buy it. Not for a moment,”

As damaged as it was, Adora’s spiritual being was still vibrant; it arrayed itself as a solid fortification against them, unwilling to allow the Nephraeh access. But Veth would not relent, not with the knowledge that behind her indomitable walls, Adora was in the grip of sorrow’s embrace. Veth pivoted their body, studying the other’s slouched hunch opposite them; sensing their scrutiny, Adora glanced back, the movement furtive and nervous. It was going to take a leap of faith on their part for Veth to gain an even slight measure of trust from the other—they had to be the first to show vulnerability.

“You may not believe it, but I think I’m falling in love with Shen,” Veth said softly.

It was as if they had dropped a bomb on Adora. Sitting up straight, she whipped around to gape at Veth in incredulity.

“WH—WHAT?!” She stammered.

Veth chuckled as they faced away from Adora, surprised at how much they had enjoyed saying that out loud.

"Yeah, I know, right?" They said. "I have a hard time believing it myself—after all—it wasn't long ago that I promised Catra I would kill him for what he did to Nefeli,"

"Yes, Catra mentioned that you had taken responsibility for that. That you no longer blame Shen for killing your lover," Adora added. "I still find it hard to believe you don't associate their death with him. If someone had accidentally killed Catra, I think I would have a hard time being around them,"

Veth nodded. "Yes, I will be the first to admit the situation is not perfect. I am constantly torn between feeling responsible for Nefeli's death and ashamed of my feelings for Shen. If not for my newfound 'sight' and the ability to see our mutual affinity, I may have rejected such a notation. Even though I have grown quite fond of your friend, I may have let our history mar whatever potential future we could have."

Adora snorted. "Is the point of this story to try and make me think that we could have a great future if only I forgive you? Is that what you want from me?"

Veth repositioned themselves so they were again facing the bearer of She-Ra, their silver eyes meeting her light blue ones. Adora winced slightly as eye contact was made, the painful history between the two Champions of Grayskull a residue of ice around her heart.

"All I want is for you to let me help heal you." They said.

Adora broke eye contact as she brought her hand to her breast, alighting the heart rune there—the same magical glyph Shen had on his chest.

"I want to believe you can take this pain away; I just don't know if —" she said, stifling a sob.

Veth spotted an opening within Adora's life pattern; her desperation to be free of the burden would make her susceptible to whatever they next said. But Veth chose not to speak, allowing the woman before them a moment to expel her more turbulent emotions in an outcry of grief. It was only when Adora's quintessence was once again consolidated did Veth make their overture.

"I cannot take the pain away, Adora. That is beyond anyone's capability—only you can truly achieve that. No, what I offer is my assistance in making that happen. I have never done anything like this before, but my… *Nephraeh instinct*… tells me it's possible." Veth pronounced before suddenly remembering something.

He reaches around himself—not with hands, but with heart—taking the timeless beauty found in abundance in everyday life and drawing it into himself, turning it into love.

Love for the self, which in turn, is a balm to the wounded soul, easing away the aches of trauma's bite—if only for a moment.

Veth smiled at the recollection—not just at the fact it would help them in what they needed to do—but the realization that that was when they had started falling in love.

"Why are you smiling?" Adora asked.

Veth drew back into themselves, conscious that their apparent mirth could be misconstrued.

"I'm sorry, I was just thinking about something that could help in this situation," they said, still smiling.

Adora's head tilted in curiosity. "You were thinking of Shen, weren't you?" She asked.

Veth was startled by the question, wondering if the bearer of She-Ra had her own version of Nephraeh sight—this turned to astonishment when a wry grin appeared on Adora's lips.

“It was your face,” Adora said with a chuckle. “You were smiling the same way Catra smiles when she looks at me. You said you think you are falling in love—I would say you are already there.”

Veth was abashed by the perceptive appraisal, once again thankful Nephraeh didn’t blush as they ran nervous fingers through their hair.

“I think I hit a nerve!” Adora said, watching them intently before pursing her lips and nodding. “You know what, Veth. Okay, you can try whatever it is you think will help me—especially if it’s something you learned from Shen. I’m ready.”

Veth knew the truth of her words as they witnessed Adora’s soul array itself in a receptive pattern. They could not help recognizing that, once again, it was the shared relationship with Shen that allowed Veth to find a common cause with someone they had hurt; first, Catra, now Adora. This realization further awakened their desire to see the Human again—which Veth dismissed—focusing on the task at hand.

“Okay,” they said, standing up and motioning to the bed. “Lie down—you want to be as comfortable as possible.”

Adora did as instructed and lay on her back, looking up warily at the Nephraeh standing over her.

“Uh, it’s kind of hard for me to relax with you looming over me,” she said.

“Ah—yes! Sorry!” Veth said, getting to their knees by the bedside. “Better?”

Adora made an unconvinced face and gave an ineffectual shrug.

“You need to be relaxed if this is going to work,” Veth said, standing back up and waving for her to move over. “Here, let me lay next to you,”

Adora skootched over stiffly as the Nephraeh Champion arrayed themselves next to her; Veth didn't need to glimpse either her face or soul to know this didn't put her at ease—but knew this would work in the end. Perhaps if Adora did not have to lay eyes upon them, it would allow her to center on her own inner balance; all Adora needed was the right starting point.

"Now, I don't have enough time to teach you full mastery of Nephraeh mediation techniques, so perhaps we shall just start with something you are familiar with. What form of meditation do you know?" They asked, focusing on the ceiling. When Adora did not respond, they rotated their head in her direction, discerning confusion on her face.

"I don't know any form of meditation, Veth. They never taught that in the Horde. All I know about it is from watching Catra—she just sits cross-legged with her eyes closed going `*ohmmmm*,'" she said.

"Okay, a form of relaxation that uses a constant tone that produces a specific vibration—interesting," Veth said, nodding. "Try that—but perhaps focus on your memory of Catra doing it as you perform that specific chant yourself."

Veth listened as Adora performed the mantra; she was awkward at first, but as she began to concentrate on the image of Catra, they witnessed her quintessence slowly reach another level of transcendence—if they had considered her aspect open before, now it was almost welcoming.

"Very good!" Veth said with a smile. "Now. Don't be alarmed—I am going to place my hand in yours; it will be the only contact between us,"

As Veth's clawed fingers slid into Adora's, her spirit form recoiled slightly, becoming disturbed. But as the connection was made in a physical sense, so too was it in a spiritual; Veth's quintessence brushed up against Adora's, the absolute truth of the Nephraeh's

intentions communicated to the Human on a supernatural level, calming her soul into acquiescence.

Now that Veth had a second perspective on Adora's anima, they had knowledge of processes unbeknownst to them. It was as if the vital force of the quintessence had come into focus; Veth could now discern channels interconnecting the ethereal and tangible facets of spirit and body. Many of these passageways had become clogged as strands of ectoplasmic ichor became mired in the bile of acrimony, stifling the energy flow between aspects. With their experience and understanding of the Light they could summon, Veth had an idea.

From that inexplicable place between their head and heart where they could call forth Light, Veth passed small increments into Adora's soul. There, the sublime luminescence made its way through the many empyrean pathways, absorbing minute amounts of the offending blockage during its journey. This minor change in the interplay of her spirit had massive consequences as Adora suddenly gasped, sitting up to stare down at Veth with wide eyes.

"Wow!" She exclaimed. "I—I don't know what you just did… b—but I felt that!"

Veth grinned as they lifted themselves from the bed, feeling drained from the procedure.

"Wait, that's it?" Adora asked, confused.

Veth nodded sadly. "Unfortunately, yes. I don't want to use too much Light on you at once; I am new at this, but I think the sudden release of so much suppressed energy could drive your chakra into a discord. I can only do so much; the rest is up to you."

They made their way to the exit of the quarters, turning to regard their fellow Champion before leaving.

“We have a couple of days before reaching Etheria. Would it be okay if I stopped by tomorrow morning? Perhaps if the conditions are favorable, I can perform another… *alleviation* on you. If not, maybe we can just…I don’t know—*talk?*” Veth said.

Adora stared at them as Veth found themselves at someone else’s version of a long, inscrutable gaze. Before the moment stretched into the realm of discomfiture, she gave a slight nod.

“Okay,” Adora said, giving the briefest of smiles. “I think I would like that,”

END OF BOOK IV: ZHE-LA

Chapter End Notes

Despara commissioned from Iria Abella who makes up one-half of the duo ilikeyoucatradora which can be found on Instagram and Tumblr.

Hecatomb (BOOK V: THE LOST)

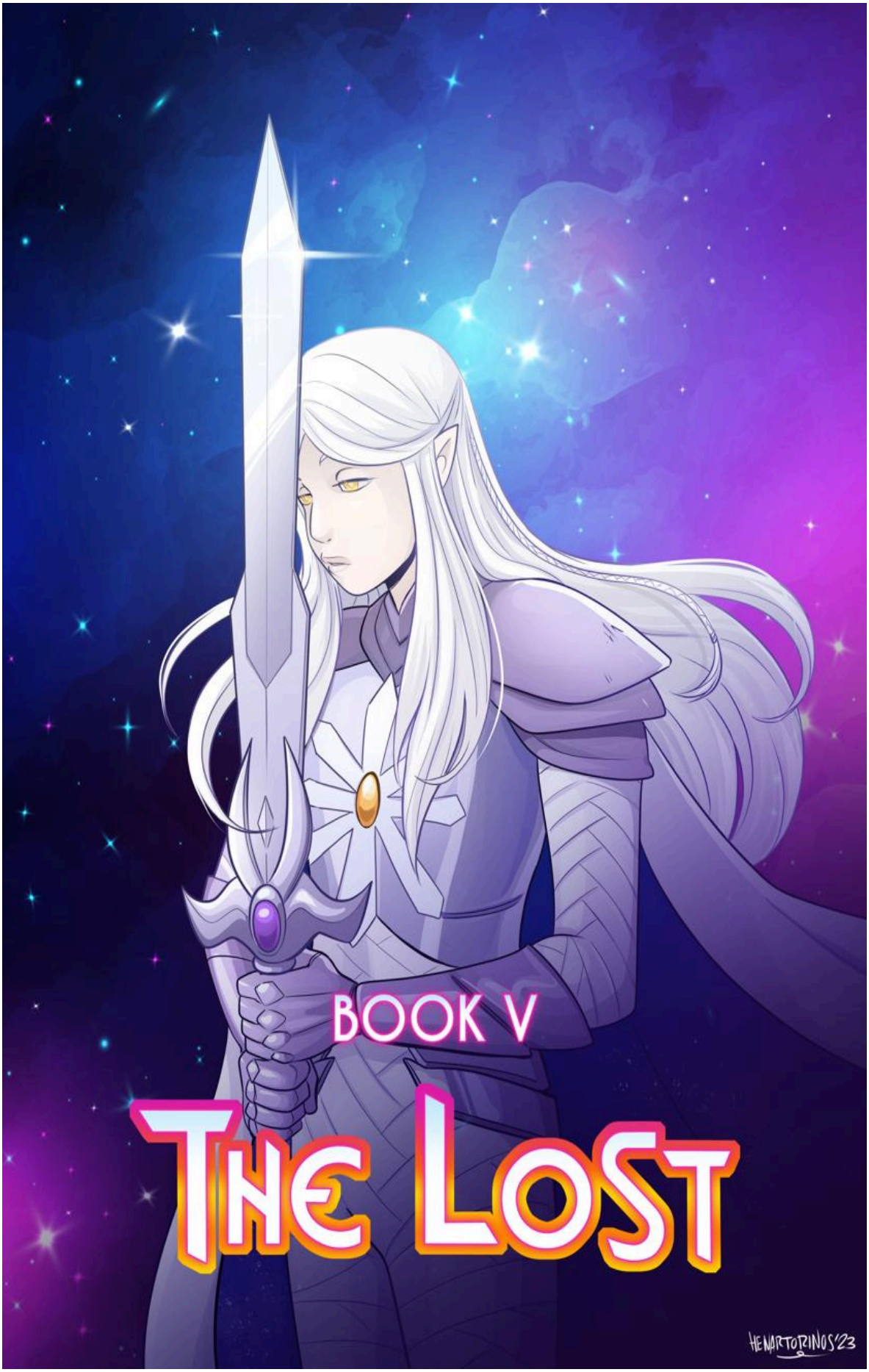
Chapter Summary

The noose is slowly closing around the necks of the Etheiran Resistance.

Hordak has a last-ditch plan.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes


BOOK V
THE LOST
HENARTORINOS'23

The sun was at its apex as Frosta and Hordak caught sight of their destination around a rock face; the Crypto Castle, sitting on a ledge and tucked away under a massive rock outcropping. The two unlikely traveling companions had spent much of the previous day making their way here, having waited until the morning before attempting the treacherous path to Entrapta's mountain fastness. Frosta took in the high wall encircling the thin spires in the middle, the entire stronghold appearing intact and ready to repel invaders. There were even the recognizable round shapes of two Horde Bots standing guard on either side of the sealed purple gate, completing the appearance of security.

"Thank Etheria, it's true! Emily actually did make it here!" Frosta exclaimed.

Hordak turned to regard the Princess, his glowing red eyes narrowing in puzzlement.

"Did you think I was lying about receiving a signal from her?" He asked.

Frosta immediately balked at the suggestion, holding up both hands in placation.

"No! Of course not! I didn't think you were lying, but I figured it was too good to be true—especially with how things have been going for us. Can you blame me?" Frosta explained.

Hordak pursed his white lips and nodded. "Yes, I understand. Come, let's see what kind of defense Emily has constructed. I'm sure it will be needed—and very soon."

Both robot sentries perked up and stood to attention as Hordak and Entrapta approached, emitting a series of staccato blurts that sounded challenging. If that wasn't warning enough, then the laser cannons appearing from within their round chassis were—a

dull glow eliminating from within the barrels, indicating a build-up of energy as they prepared to fire.

“Command epsilon, zero-one-point-two-four. Stand down.” Hordak said.

With affirmative beeps, both Horde bots retracted their weapons as the gate opened, the two fugitives moving quickly into the asylum they had sought within the Crypto Castle.

“Where is Emily?” Hordak asked one of the robot guards.

Frosta regarded the ex-Horde ruler with a quizzical expression as the question was answered, the Princess unable to decipher the binary words of the robot language.

“Come,” he said, pointing to another set of gates set within an open portcullis. “Emily awaits us within the laboratory,”

Hordak led the way, making their way quickly through the maze of Entrapta’s unique home, stopping here and there to disarm a trap or enter the correct code to a barred door. Eventually, they made it to the center of the Crypto Castle—the principal laboratory for Entrapta—connected to a smaller workshop for Hordak’s inventions. That was where they found Emily, sitting amongst a nest of computer screens as she typed commands into a keyboard with a pair of thin manipulators.

“Status, Emily?” Hordak prompted as soon as he entered the chambers.

“Really, Hordak?” Frosta exclaimed incredulously. “No, ‘Hello, Emily—how are you doing?’ or “Wow, how did you manage to take the Crypto Castle?’ or at the very least, ‘Thank you for saving our butts, Emily,’?”

Hordak glanced briefly in Frosta’s direction, frowning slightly before turning back to the round robot.

“Thank you for saving our butts, Emily,” he said in a monotone. “Now, status, please?”

Frosta crossed her arms and shook her head in exasperation as Emily gave her report, the old Horde Bot chattering away as Hordak nodded, consternation slowly dawning on his craggy features. Before the Princess of Snows could ask for a translation of the report, Emily pointed a manipulator at a nearby screen—there, a map of the surrounding area was displayed in glowing blue topographical lines. Frosta could make out a representation of the Crypto Castle in the middle—to the West of this—a mass of dots was steadily making its way in their direction; they pulsed blood red, the sight of which made Frosta’s heart beat faster.

“Um, I take it that’s not good?” She asked, pointing.

Hordak grunted. “I was hoping for a little more time to collect myself, perhaps construct a few more robots from the factory below the castle. It seems we have run out of time,”

“Can’t we just get a break?!” Frosta griped.

A chime sounded nearby as if in answer, it’s pleasant sound ominous to Frosta’s ears—it was an incoming transmission that Emily accepted with a keystroke. A light azure face popped on every screen as Shen’Shalidar’s cold gaze stared at the castle defenders from every angle—it was a perfect representation of their current predicament.

“Hordak, I thought I told you I had already foreseen your retreat to this location—and you still came here? What a pathetic world this must be that YOU were its greatest threat for so long,” Shen’Shalidar chided.

When Hordak did not respond to the taunt, Frosta leaned into the video pickup, projecting as much threat as she could muster. Shen’Shalidar raised a single eyebrow in acknowledgment, his thin lips forming a sneer of utter contempt.

"You've got it wrong, Shen'Shalidar of Morbid-Gar. No, single Etherian is a threat; that's not what you need to worry about. What you have to worry about is when we work together—together, Hordak and I will kick your creepy blue butt back to Eternia!"

Shen'Shalidar snorted at this, the sound utterly devoid of any humor.

"Two Etherians, huh? Well, I have more than you—here, why don't I show you?"

Shen'Shalidar moved away from the camera, giving Frosta a view behind him; a mixed group of Vetala, Szi'th, and enervated could be seen trudging past, the mass transit of so many marching figures kicking a cloud of dust into the air. Shen'Shalidar pointed an armored gauntlet at this horde—there—Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle, Peekablue, and Peric could be seen, marching alongside this army of evil. Frosta could not take in the entirety of this force, therefore having no confirmation that Netosssa and Spinerella were amongst them. She was unsure if this was a good sign or not—sure, they did not have to face the combined might of two Etherian Princesses if they were not on Shen'Shalidar's side. But the alternative was that they were either still free or dead—killed by the dread malice that was the Anguish of Gallia.

"Based on the expression on your face, I take it that you understand the magnitude of your predicament," Shen'Shalidar said, returning to fill the image. "Surrender now, and perhaps I will not feed you to my Szi'th,"

With a roar, Hordak lunged forward, smashing multiple computer screens with a sweep of his arm and disconnecting the transmission. Frosta winced as glass fragments peppered her, giving Hordak a long-suffering look after she had a chance to shake off the bigger pieces.

"I'm with you on not accepting surrender—but was that really necessary?" She complained.

Hordak did not immediately answer as he stood rigid, fists clenched to either side as he panted with suppressed rage. Just as Frosta was about to go into calming mode, Hordak regained his composure, letting out a long, tired sigh. He appeared so ancient now, his years of constant struggle appearing all over his body; a stoop in his spine, a sagging of his limbs, and a dimming of the burning fire in his scarlet eyes.

"Emily, do we still have the Hecatomb protocol in place?" He asked quietly.

The round form of the old Horde bot turned slowly, the single trapezoidal eye gazing up at Hordak as Emily emitted a series of sad-sounding beeps.

"Excellent," Hordak said, standing straight once more.

"Uh, you going to let me in on what's going on or what?" Frosta said.

The Ex-Horde ruler nodded, his weathered face becoming sorrowful as he faced the young Princess.

"I have a plan, but I think you will not like it," Hordak said.

* * *

"Here we go, Kitten! One, Two, Three, FOUR—

"*I am what I am; I am my own special creation…!*"

"So come take a look,"

"Give me the hook or the ovation,"

"It's my world that I want to take a little pride in,"

"My world—and it's not a place to hide in,"

Catra wasn't sure what to make of the performance before her; Double Trouble and Panga standing side-by-side in the Millennial

Seagull's common area, proceeding through a series of choreographed movements as they sang in harmony.

"I don't want praise; I don't want pity,"

"I bang my own drum,"

"Some think its noise; I think it's pretty,"

Out of her usual Jaadoo-suit, Panga wore a sheer body glove, her orange body almost entirely on display except for the portions darkened for modesty's sake. Double Trouble was also scantily clad, wearing a bikini made from something that appeared to be Nephraeh Aegis Lace.

At that moment, both Madgēcot and Shapeshifter performed a fan kick, making Shen jump in surprise. Catra glanced over at her friend sitting beside her in the circular booth, his dark eyebrows raised in shock as he gaped back at her. Catra gave him a wink before returning to the act.

"Why not try to see things from a different angle?"

"Your life is a sham 'till you can shout out loud,"

"I am what I am!"

"I am what I am!"

Double Trouble began a spin towards Panga, the Madgēcot woman reaching out quickly in time to catch the imp as they swooned backward. Catra could not help noticing how Panga gazed down at Double Trouble as she held them in a dip—the moment lasting a heartbeat before she pulled them back up, the two holding hands side-by-side as they continued their rendition.

She is in love with them, Catra thought with surprise. *How did that happen?*

The first and last time Catra had seen Panga, she had been scouring the streets of Thenlor, a one-woman army fighting against the tyranny of the Shen'Aan-war's invasion force. Now here she was, practically naked as she danced with the last person Catra thought someone like Panga would ever fall in love with.

Double Trouble suddenly pulled Panga in, wrapping her in their arms before quickly releasing her, the female Madgēcot transitioning into a pirouette as her striped tail whipped around her. Catra's eyes narrowed as she caught the tender way Double Trouble's tail caressed Panga, just briefly over her hands and hip, the affectionate touch unmistakable in its nature.

You've got to be kidding me—no way! Catra thought, realizing the scandalous troublemaker's feelings for Panga were more than simple fondness.

Double Trouble was in love with her in return.

Catra let out a bark of laughter at this discovery, earning scolding looks from both the performers as they continued their show.

"One life, so it's time to open your closet,"

"Life's not worth a darn 'till you can say,"

"Hey, world! I am what I AMMMMM!!!"

Double Trouble and Panga clasped each other's waist as they sang the last line, thrusting their free hands into the air for emphasis. With eyes wide and eyebrows raised, both performers waited expectantly for a reaction—instantly, Seahawk broke out in furious clapping nearby, accompanied by lascivious whistling. Entrapta added her own method of applause as she brought her massive ponytails together—joined by Shen, Mermista, Orko, and Catra.

"Thank you! Thank you!" The duo said together, bowing to their audience.

“Wow, Atreyen! I’ve never seen you perform that number before!” Shen exclaimed.

Double Trouble waved a limp hand and cocked their hip.

“Oh, it’s just a little number Kitten, and I came up with in our free time. You should see some of the live performances we have put on for the Grand Amphitheater. Perhaps when this is all over you can come to Thenlor and see our show—you can even bring a date. Perhaps a certain beautiful purple person would like to go with you?”

Double Trouble’s form suddenly transitioned into a black night of green dancing fireflies before returning to solid, the imp now wearing pants of full Aegis Lace and a black jacket over their bare torso. They gave Shen a sharp-toothed smile and a sly wink, earning an elbow in their side from Panga.

“Stop teasing him!” She hissed.

Catra was surprised to notice the usually unflappable Shen was actually blushing and regarded his gathered friends self-consciously.

“Wait! Did you, like, not think that everyone knew about you and Veth?” Mermista exclaimed with glee. “That’s so adorable!”

“I can attest to this!” Orko said with a raised blue finger. “Shen and Veth spent quite a bit of alone time together after the Crimson Counsels locked them up. They couldn’t keep their hands off each other!”

“What!?” Shen said, voice cracking. “Orko, you are so full of—"

Seahawk rose from his place by Mermista to flop down next to Shen, wrapping an arm around his shoulders in solidarity.

“A little birdie told me that our friend Shen here was seen kissing a certain person right before we all left!” Seahawk teased.

Shen's head whipped around to glare at Catra—she only offered a weak shrug in reply.

"Guys, it's not like that. We—" Shen started to say.

"Here he goes!" Mermista chortled, interrupting Shen. "Now he is going to tell us Veth is 'just a friend,'—yeah, right!"

"No, that's not what I was trying to say! If you give me a chance, I was going to say that Veth—"

"Wait, I'm confused. What are we talking about right now?" Entrapta butted in. "What about Shen and Veth are you referring to?"

"Oh, *honey*, it's simple." Double Trouble added helpfully. "When two people like each other, sometimes they like to get naked and—"

"Okay!" Panga cut in, placing an orange hand over Double Trouble's mouth. "I will finish! Even though I disapprove, it seems Shen and Veth are attracted to each other and have become—what's the word? *Bonded*?"

Shen bolted upright, incredulous. "What!? No! You are jumping WAY ahead, Panga!"

Catra found herself chuckling at her friend's discomfiture and doubted that her fellow Madgēcot was too far off the mark. She and Veth had spent a good deal of time discussing what had happened to them since regaining their empathy—Catra, in turn, sharing her experiences with transitioning into adolescence. The changes in her body, her emotions, and the cementation of her proclivities—even though they were approximately the same age, it seemed like Veth was undergoing a kind of awakening that she had experienced years ago. Even more amazing was their explanation of their special 'Nephraeh sight'—to be able to perceive another person's soul or quintessence.

Catra had believed them when they told her, thinking that having such ability would give a Nephraeh a level of certainty regarding relationships. Veth suddenly kissing Shen had given Catra no small amount of giddy joy to witness—if they were that sure about him to do that—then the two future lovers might as well be 'bonded.'

She was sure Shen wouldn't complain.

"Hey, Catra," Shen said, drawing her out of her thoughts. "I've been meaning to ask you now that things have calmed down a bit—where is Battle Cat?"

Catra nodded slowly. "Yeah… when we thought you died back in the Relativity Forge, they took it pretty bad. As soon as we got back to Elysia, Battle Cat wandered off into the forest with Melog—I tried to reach out to them before Adora, and I went off on our 'second honeymoon' and got the sense they wanted to be alone," she said with a shrug. "Maybe when this is over, we can go back to Elysia together and find them both?"

Before Shen could answer, Entrapta poked her head into the conversation; finger held up in preface to an explanation.

"Actually! That's not necessary!" She exclaimed.

Shen and Catra shared knowing looks when Entrapta did not continue.

"And why is that Entrapta?" Catra asked patiently.

"Oh! That is because Melog said that Battle Cat didn't believe you were dead and that the two of them were going find the closest interdimensional stitch to go in search of you," she stated.

"Uh, what?" Shen asked.

"Basically, the two of them are on a very long search for you," Catra said in explanation. "My question is: how were you able to talk with them? They can only communicate with a non-Ethyriel if they are bonded to them."

“Oh, that’s easy,” Entrapta said, waving a ponytail. “You see, all I had to do was—"

A chime sounded throughout the ship’s interior, interrupting the scientific Princess’s explanation. Everyone regarded each other with uncertainty before Catra spoke up.

“Hey, Seahawk, aren’t you supposed to be driving this thing? Are we about to crash into a black hole or collide with a star?”

“On it!” He said, jumping up to a nearby control panel and pressing a button. “Henry—status, please!”

The confusion shared amongst the others intensified as the word ‘Henry’ was mouthed questioningly back and forth.

“Oh! Henry must be Seahawk’s name for the artificial intelligence I installed into the Millennial Falcon’s computer network!” Entrapta said helpfully.

“Yes, at once, Master Seahawk,” a cultured and mechanical voice responded out of every nearby speaker. “It seems that there is another ship hailing us from a nearby hyperspace vector—Darla—is its designation,”

“Oh!” Seahawk beamed. “Put them through!”

* * *

“Millennial Seagull, this is Glimmer aboard Darla. You reading me over there?”

Adora watched from the command throne as her friend attempted to contact the Millennial Seagull—by the tone of her voice, Adora could tell Glimmer was getting annoyed.

“Hello? Anybody over there?” She repeated.

“Greetings!” An easily recognizable voice responded.

"Seahawk! What in the name of Etheria is happening on that ship? I've been trying to reach you for a while! Are you having a party?" Glimmered exclaimed.

"*Uh… not a party exactly,*" Seahawk responded nervously. "*Something more akin to a show… uh…"*

Glimmer made a chopping motion with her hand as Adora stifled a smirk.

"Nevermind!" She snapped. "We are getting close to our destination, and I wanted to make sure everything is prepared."

"Oh! Wait—we are close to Etheria?" Seahawk said. *"Henry! Why didn't you tell me?"*

There was disgust on Glimmer's face as she glanced back at Adora.

"Seahawk! I can't believe I'm saying this but put the most responsible person over there on the line! I want to talk to Catra!"

"*I'm here, Sparkles,*" came the immediate response. Adora's heart lifted to hear Catra's voice over the transmission.

"Catra, are you and Shen ready over there? I'm not sure what you will find at Dryl; you must be prepared for anything." Glimmer said.

"Don't worry, Sparkles. He-Man and Sher-Va got this. Is my wife there?" Catra said.

"I'm here, Catra!" Adora found herself yelling.

"*Hey, Babe,*" Catra said. Adora could hear the smile in her wife's voice, making her grin like a fool.

"How are you holding up over there?" Catra continued, now sounding concerned. "*Are you ready for this?"*

Adora glanced at the person standing gracefully by her side, clawed hands held behind their back—she felt a sense of reassurance at having them so close. Sensing her attention, Veth turned to Adora, favoring her with a smile and a slight nod.

The Nephraeh had been visiting Adora regularly since discovering they could use their power to help her—each time alleviating a fraction of the burden she carried upon her soul. Adora had no idea how Veth was achieving it, but the result was undeniable—they were somehow enabling her to make connections within herself, allowing Adora to appreciate Despara for what she was—a completely separate entity from her personae.

Adora still had all the terrible memories, but they were softened by the acceptance that she was not the one performing them, making the experiences divorced from her own. The nightmares had faded into only unpleasant dreams now, and Adora felt more refreshed than she had in a long time. She was now equipped to face whatever Archon Lethe had planned for them and prepared to make them pay—*for everything.*

"Yeah, Catra. I am ready," She said confidently.

* * *

Adora's tone of voice was changed to Catra's Madgēcot ears; no longer did her wife's words have that meek and uncertain edge—there was resolve there. A promise that things would be much different—not the same as before she had become Despara—but perhaps somewhere in between. Catra grinned to herself; Adora sounded dangerous.

"*You take care of yourself, Catra, and keep Shen out of trouble,"* Adora continued.

"Oh, I will. I think a certain Nephraeh would be very upset if anything happened to their *Human,*" Catra said, leering at a blushing Shen.

Adora laughed on the other end. *"They are standing right next to me, trying not to look embarrassed,"*

There was affection in Adora's voice as she referred to Veth, surprising Catra.

"Okay, everyone—let's focus." Glimmer cut in, sounding serious. *"We all know what we need to do. You are in charge over there, Catra, so as soon as you have secured the Crypto Castle, you contact us, right?"*

"You got it, Sparkles. See you on the other side." Catra said, making the sign to Seahawk to cut the connection.

* * *

"No way, Hordak! It's not happening!" Frosta screamed.

The ex-Horde ruler waved away her protests, seeming for once to take an assertive stance towards the Princess's position.

"It's the most logical course of action; once Shen'Shalidar and his forces have reached the Crypto Castle, I will instruct Emily to enact the Hecatomb protocol—causing the castle's reactor to melt down. The resulting explosion will annihilate all life within a half-mile radius, destroying the Crypto Castle and the mountain it sits upon. It's the only way to strike back at our enemy—unless, of course, you would rather capture and darkening?" He said. Frosta immediately frowned.

"No, I don't want that. But there has to be another way! We don't just blow the castle up—what about our friends who have been darkened? We would kill them and the bad guys!" She cried.

Hordak nodded. "I am aware of this. But would you rather they stay the way they are? Even when Queen Glimmer and most of the Princesses were here, we could not return those darkened back to how they once were. Now things are worse, making the likelihood of it ever happening slimmer—please—if you know of a better way, I want to hear it."

Frosta gritted her teeth, knowing Hordak was right. They were pinned in place, and even if they did manage to get away from Shen'Shalidar's army, there was nowhere else to go. At least this way, when their friends return to defeat the enemy taking over their home, they wouldn't have to deal with Shen'Shalidar and his Abominable Power.

"Okay," Frosta relented. "But not right away, okay? Only if we are definitely about to lose. Only when there is absolutely no choice—then we blow ourselves up."

Hordak nodded, extending his armored hand to the smaller Princess.

"Deal," he said as Frosta took his hand, shaking it firmly.

Their compact finished, Hordak waved to Emily, and the Horde bot projected a three-dimensional representation of the Crypto Castle upon its mountain perch. Waving both his hands away from each other, Hordak directed the image to zoom outward, the mountain fastness shrinking as the surrounding landscape came into view. There, Frosta could identify a lush forest encircling the mountain with a wide river running to one side—at the edge of this forest—the mass of Shen'Shalidar army approached from the northern plains. Hordak pointed at this, the congregation of red dots pulsing like an oncoming thunderstorm.

"They will be upon us soon, so we do not have time to reinforce our numbers with additional robots to send down to slow the enemy advance. Instead," he said, zooming the image in until only the Crypto Castle was shown. "We keep all forces within the castle and place units here, here, and here,"

Hordak indicated strategic locations behind parapets as Frosta nodded, pointing to one of the towers nearest the encircling wall.

"I say you and I position ourselves here; I will use my magic while you use that big cannon you've been lugging around. That combined with the firepower of the Horde Bots—I would say there

is a chance we could blast Shen'Shalidar off the mountain." She said.

Hordak favored Frosta with one of his rare smiles, nodding his assent.

"A sound plan," he said.

* * *

"Perhaps we should turn off your autopilot and actually start driving this thing?" Catra stated, indicating the direction of the ship's cockpit with a clawed fingertip.

"Right-O!" Seahawk exclaimed, scurrying from the ship's intercom and toward the narrow passageway leading to the pilothouse—Catra and Shen not far behind. Once ensconced within the cramped chamber, Seahawk settled into the pilot's seat, pulling back on the silver lever to bring the Millennial Seagull out of the kaleidoscopic chaos of hyperspace. Abruptly, the dual planets of Etheria and Eternia came into focus, seeming peaceful and serene in their mutual orbit of each other. Not too far off the starboard bow, Darla appeared out of hyperspace, decelerating to match the Millennial Seagull speed.

"Well, we are here," Catra commented to no one in particular.

"Here's to hoping this Lethe hasn't wreaked everything," Shen commented dryly.

Catra gave him an earnest nod, inwardly hoping that none of her friends had been harmed. With their current high stakes, the probability of that already happening was high.

* * *

"I think, perhaps, that the readings indicating the size of the enemy forces were a little off. What do you think, Hordak?"

Gazing out from the tower's vantage point, Frosta could see the enemy forces approaching the Crypto Castle; they filled the wide path, extending all the way to disappear around the bend. As the front lines got closer to the castle gates, she could make out individual faces amongst the throng; either the onyx black of the Vetala as they bared midnight fangs or the corpse-white of the Szi'th, slack-jawed and listless. Frosta saw no sign of the enervated and assumed they had sense enough to stay at the back of the queue, allowing the monsters to take the brunt of the defender's wrath. At the forefront of this evil tide was none other than Shen'Shalidar—his eyes fixed on Hordak and Frosta's position as he drew the dread sword from a scabbard at his back.

"Our plan still works to our advantage," Hordak replied. "They can only reach us from the mountain path and cannot attack us en masse—they are exposed to concentrated fire."

Frosta frowned as she watched Shen'Shalidar point the Anguish of Gallia at the Crypto Castle gates, feeling doubtful there was anything vulnerable about their foe. Both Hordak and Frosta jumped as the front gates below them began to rattle as the unnatural magic of the Abominable Power attempted to unmake their very existence.

"Entrapta made that gate out of hardened Tartarite from Geolon! It can withstand the blast from a star cruiser's main guns!" Hordak exclaimed.

"Well, I guess she didn't take Abominable Powers into consideration when she made it!" Frosta quipped. "Perhaps now is a good time to open fire?"

Hordak pressed a button in the gauntlet of his hand cannon, sending the command to all Horde bots to attack. With their laser cannons already deployed from within their chassis, the robots fired down from their wall positions into the crowd of invaders—whole swathes of Vetala and Szi'th were vaporized as withering death beams plowed through them. Shen'Shalidar withdrew his assault upon the front gate to lift his sword in a defensive

position, absorbing any of the laser strikes that came within range.

"We have them on a back foot; press the attack!" Hordak exclaimed. Aiming his massive arm cannon directly at Shen'Shalidar, Hordak fired at his nemesis, sending a blast of searing power down at him. The Suzerain of Morrigar appeared visibly strained as he attempted to absorb Hordak's offensive on top of the others—Frosta whooped with glee as she added her magic to the onslaught, spewing forth ice shards from her fingertips and into the bodies of Vetala and Szit'th. As the enemy was destroyed one by one, more took their place from around the corner—but at the moment—the defenders were holding them off.

"It's working, Hordak! We might have a shot at winning!" Frosta cried, summoning a giant ball of ice and hurling it into the mob. The chunk of frozen water smashed the varied creatures into a conglomerated paste as it bounced and skidded through their numbers, finally careening off a nearby ledge, taking many more with it.

"Yes, Princess Frosta!" Hordak replied—an actual laugh in his voice. "You and I will win the day; we must keep up—"

His words were cut off as a recognizable scrabbling came from a side wall—the sound of sharp claws sliding on stone. Horror coursed through Frosta as she saw Vetala pouring over the fortification there, the undefended side of the fortress exposed to the cliff edge. They landed well within the boundary of the defenses, instantly streaking in all directions to wreak havoc.

"Where did they come from!?" Frosta cried, turning to blast this new enemy with her elemental magic.

Hordak gaped. "They must have climbed the mountain as the main force distracted us with their numbers!"

By now, the Vetala interlopers had scaled the inner defense work and were assaulting the defenders; the Horde bots turned their

attention to this new threat—but it was already too late. Frosta watched as the monsters raked their claws over the round metal bodies, slicing them wide open. With a strangled electronic screech, the Horde bots fell from the walls, crashing lifelessly to the ground below.

"No!" Frosta cried, but the bad news was not over.

With the defenders neutralized, the nimble Vetala streamed over the fortifications—and with a massive wrench—the heavy gates fell, taken down by the Anguish of Gallia. The Szi'th lumbered into the courtyard of the castle, Shen'Shalidar in their wake—he gazed up at Frosta and Hordak still in their tower, a cruel smile on his thin lips.

"GO, FROSTA!" Hordak cried, pushing the Princess to the nearby stairs. "I will hold them off—you must escape!"

Frosta shoved his hand away, defiant. "No! I am not leaving you behind! We are a team!"

Hordak was about to respond when a massive jolt rocked the tower—peering down—both Princess and ex-Horde spotted the vile Shen'Shalidar; he was once again using his Abominable Power against them—this time—to topple the structure they stood upon.

'We gotta get out of here—!" Frosta wailed—just as the tower gave a sharp crack, beginning to topple over.

Frosta and Hordak clutched at one another as they both fell on their backs, sliding towards the opposite wall as a sense of vertigo overcame them. With a jarring BOOM, the tower crumbled around them, and Frosta found herself tumbling amongst bouncing rumble before she slammed face-first into the ground. Wiping away at a bloody nose, Frosta peered around herself, spotting Hordak as he extracted himself from beneath a slab of masonry. He shook debris off his massive frame as he searched the ruin of their shelter, Hordak's glowing red eyes appearing relieved when he spotted her.

“Are you okay, Princess Frosta?” He wheezed.

Before she could answer, the enemy was upon them, closing in on their position with clutching black hands and snapping jaws. Shen’Shalidar was there amongst them, sauntering over to the fallen defender as he made a cutting motion over his blue throat. The meaning was evident, and without further comment, Hordak lifted his gauntlet, finger poised to press the button to execute the self-destruct command.

“Arm function: Hecatomb,” he said, deactivating the safety.

“No, wait!” Frosta cried, pointing above them and into the sky.

Hordak pressed the button.

Chapter End Notes

Book V cover by Henar Torinos, 1/2 of the duo who makes up ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram.

Ambush

Chapter Summary

The fate of Hordak and Frosta is revealed.

Both pairs of Champions face their own unique challenges as the stakes are raised.

While all this happens, Lethe continues to pry their way into Subternia.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Let’s begin again, My Children,”

Upon their command, Lethe’s enervated acolytes took their places outside the ring of pylons as the three altered Vetala moved into positions for He-Ro, Thon-Ra, and Wun-Dar. It had been two days since their last attempt, for the groundwork for these rites were intricate and complex. With great care, Lethe bound the three Champion Spirits to Vetala as sigils written in their blood had been reapplied to four of the pylons by willing acolytes. These preparations seemed long and arduous, but it had taken Lethe and their minions half the time the second time around than the first. Perfuma was sure that if it came to a third time, the forces of evil would enact this ritual in a day’s time—or less.

Scorpia walked from outside the circle of crystal pillars to Lethe in the center, kneeling to present the Life Gem staff reverently to her master. Lethe graciously took the Staff of Power as Scorpia backed away, head lowered, spinning on her heel to stand by Perfuma once outside the ring.

Peering up at the cold features of her enervated girlfriend, Perfuma once again contemplated her dire choice: allow this incantation to take place, knowing it may or may not spell the

downfall for an infinity of innocent souls, or take a chance and speak a word which may or may not stop Lethe. If saying Jihan's name did not save them, Perfuma was sure Lethe would make good on their promise; she would have to watch Scorpia die, knowing she was next. There were too many dire consequences mixed with a great deal of uncertainty for Perfuma to make a rational decision. Instead, she stood stiff as a board, her fingers entwined into worried knots.

"Just stop fidgeting," Scorpia said, placing a clawed hand over her fussing hands.

The contact made Perfuma hopeful, and she pulled her hands apart to grasp the proffered claw, feeling the warm chitin that was capable of the most intimate of touches.

But Scorpia wrenched the claw away, a look of absolute scorn on her face as Perfuma's fell in disappointment. Returning her attention to the proceedings, Perfuma noted that Lethe was now in a kneeling position, ready to commence the ceremony. As they began the obscure hand movements and unearthly chanting, Perfuma turned to regard Scorpia; she would never get her back if Lethe completed this obscene rite. Scorpia would remain an enervated minion for the rest of her life—or even worse—a mere source of sustenance for a god whose hunger would know no bounds. If she did not act now, Perfuma would be committing countless souls to the same fate.

Immediately knowing what to do, she steeled herself, gathering a lungful of air to shout.

"JIHAN!!!"

At once, the chanting and singing ceased as the Vestibule fell into absolute silence. Realizing she was squeezing her eyes closed, Perfuma opened them to find Lethe's indigo eyes upon her, head tilted.

“Have something to add, my dear?” They said, rising to their feet in one elegant motion to stride over to her. Knowing she had failed and was about to meet her fate, Perfuma stared up into their white visage as Lethe towered over her.

But they did not strike her or Scorpia down as they continued to regard her curiously—like a great bird inspecting an unknown insect, deciding whether it would like to eat it or not.

“I didn’t make out what you had said; please repeat it,” Lethe said, their tone indicating that this was a command.

Relief washed over Perfuma as she realized that Lethe had not heard her—thinking quickly—she came up with a lie.

“I wanted you to cease this madness, so I spoke a countermeasure I had read from one of those scrolls you let me read. *Seylon*—I said.”

“No, she didn’t!” Scorpia blurted. “That’s not the word she said; it was… wait, I’m trying to remember…”

Perfuma stared at the larger woman with imploring eyes, willing Scorpia not to remember or speak the word that would spell doom for them both.

“Oh! I got it!” Scorpia said brightly, clicking one of her claws in the air like snapping fingers. “It was Jihan!”

Perfuma winced again, closing her eyes against the oncoming wrath—when none came, she reopened her eyes. Lethe’s face puckered up into a look of utter incomprehension, their upper lip raised in such an odd fashion it would be comical if not for the exposed black serrated teeth.

“What did you say, My Child? That sounded like utter gibberish!” They said.

“Uh… I said Jihan, My Lord. I’m not sure what it is—maybe a name?” Scorpia said helpfully.

Lethe shook their head vigorously, reminding Perfuma of an animal trying to shed water.

"Again! Gibberish!" They exclaimed.

Perfuma suddenly felt bold; perhaps she had been onto something before; Lethe was only resisting the word by some unknown means.

"Jihan!" She exclaimed, looking right up into their burning eyes. "Jihan, Jihan, Jihan, Jihan, Jihan, Jihan, Jihan, Jihan!"

Lethe was gaping now, looking between Scorpia and Perfuma as if both were completely mad. Perfuma realized then that whatever self-induced psychosis Lethe had achieved also blocked any outside stimuli from unlocking their barred memories. Her earlier fears and misgivings were completely unfounded; there was no unlocking buried Lethe's buried psyche with a mere word. It was going to take something more significant and much more direct.

"I don't understand. Are you two playing some jape upon me?" Lethe said, mild annoyance in their voice.

"NO! Never, My Lord! I—I…" Scorpia stammered, looking nervously at Perfuma.

With a subtle shake of the head, Perfuma indicated that to speak further would be unwise—taking the hint—Scorpia only looked down, shamefaced.

"I am going to recommence the ritual; I suggest the two of you remain silent," Lethe said, whirling away.

Perfuma observed the massive being re-enter the circle of pylons, resuming their cross-legged pose and deep-throated chanting. Knowing she no longer had a choice in the outcome, Perfuma watched helplessly as the reality of the Vestibule faded, slowly being replaced by the incomprehensible wonder of Subternia. The chaotic miasma of lights of shapes became even more

overwhelming than Lethe's last attempt—making Perfuma believe they would be successful.

Just as she was about to lose hope, Subternia abruptly vanished—the feedback of the unsuccessful ritual burning the foul script from the four unattended pylons. Instead of exploding, the three altered Vetala leaped back from their pylons, saving themselves another grisly fate.

Lethe was unsuccessful—again—but Perfuma did not think that would stop them from more attempts. Observing the lithe and white form of Lethe rising to their feet with a smile, she knew this fear was justified.

"We almost had it that time," Lethe said with a smile. "I think we need just a little more… *Power.* I know just the Champion we need to add to our collection,"

Perfuma frowned at this statement, not liking the certainty she heard in Lethe's voice.

"My Lord!" A nearby acolyte called. "Two ships have just arrived out of hyperspace and are heading to Etheria! One has the make and markings of She-Ra's personal spacecraft!"

Perfuma suppressed a squeal of glee at this news, but this elation died as she beheld the look of excitement on Lethe's pale white features.

"That's good news!" They said, closing their blazing indigo eyes as they reached out with their arcane senses. Their eyes opened wide as their mouth opened in a look of supreme euphoria.

"They are all here," Lethe breathed. "Fate has gifted me with the means to achieve my ascension,"

The careless words enraged the Princess of Plumeria, making her forget any notions of self-preservation.

“Fate is not looking out for you, Lethe! You are sick and misguided!” Perfuma screamed.

Scorpia started in Perfuma’s direction, but a black-stained hand halted her advance. With three strides of Lethe’s long legs, they stood before the Princess of Plumeria, their face a mask of kindness as they cupped her chin.

“You are right, my dear little Princess. Thank you for being the voice of reason—pulling me from my delusion. No one will make this happen except for me—if I go on thinking like that, I may fail.” Lethe said.

Perfuma tried to cringe out of Lethe’s grasp, but they held her tight, only letting go when Scorpia approached.

“What would you like me to do, Lord? I can take a large force and crush them!” She offered.

Lethe shook their head, finally taking their blazing eyes off Perfuma to regard their minion.

“No, these are Champions of Grayskull we are talking about, and with the loss of Mermista, I need you here. I need at least one holder of an Ultimate Powers loyal to me if I am to succeed.”

Scorpia looked dismayed at this proclamation. “But Lord, we mustn’t allow them to gain a foothold so close to us! We must—”

Lethe placed a clawed finger over Scorpia’s lips—silencing her.

“Hush now—I have everything under control. From what I have discerned, the Champions will split up, two for two—I will send an appropriate force to crush one pair while I give the other a more personal touch,” Lethe said, giving a black smile.

The massive being beckoned to the three altered Vetala, the creatures immediately responding to their master’s call, presenting themselves to Lethe. Perfuma could tell there was something special to these Vetala; they were more than just holding

Champion Spirits within them—two were bonded together by Lethe's unnatural magic.

"I think it's best to fight *like* with *like*," Lethe said, caressing their fingers over the bare scalp of the nearest Vetala. The creature shivered at the attention.

"But when fighting with like forces, it's always better to have more on your side," they added, smiling wickedly.

* * *

"No, wait!"

Frosta watched with horror as Hordak's armored finger sought the instrument of their self-immolation—it seemed to move in slow motion as it moved toward the flashing red button, pressing it down with an affirmative beep. Frosta squeezed her eyes shut, waiting for the explosive shockwave to wash over her, ending her young life.

Nothing happened.

Opening her eyes slowly, Frosta spotted Shen'Shalidar holding the Anguish of Gallia in a vertical guard position, the bone-white blade glowing with ghostly light. His blue face was rigid in concentration as he slowly lowered the sword, stopping when the tip was pointed at Hordak—the Ex-Horde ruler's gauntlet and cannon abruptly exploded in a spray of sparks, falling away from his arm in pieces.

"You think you could defeat me with your foolish technology?" Shen'Shalidar scolded. "I have the Anguish of Gallia! I am beyond you!"

Frosta rushed forward to place her body in front of Hordak, stopping him from attacking the Suzerain of Morrigor. By some inexplicable means, the Princess of Snows felt she had to delay the inevitable—if only for a few moments more.

“So, what now, Shen’Shalidar? You want our surrender?” She asked.

The handsome and cruel man smirked at this, shaking his head slowly in mock sadness.

“Sorry, Princess. That ship has already sailed. You had your chance for my mercy—*now you must die!*”

Frosta backed into Hordak as the Szi’th lurched forward, skeletal hands outstretched to grasp living flesh. Behind the white orbs of their eyes, a fell light smoldered—it was the vile power of Death, empowering their withered flesh to perform evil deeds. Frosta raised her hands to fight the monsters off, but as she tried to summon her elemental magic, Frosta felt it slip away—like a silk ribbon pulled out from between her fingers. For the first time since being granted the power of the Fractal Flake, Frosta was powerless—bereft of her elemental magic.

“How—?” She started to say—but stopped herself—the wicked gleam in Shen’Shalidar’s eyes telling her all she needed to know.

Gritting her teeth, Frosta reached back to clutch Hordak’s hand; now that it was freed of the gauntlet, she could feel his bare flesh—warm and alive. She focused on this as the tide of doom came for them both.

Suddenly, crackling white lighting seared down from above, alighting upon the approaching Szi’th in dancing arcs of power. The marching creatures froze as their atrophied muscles seized, the electrical current beginning to cook them from the inside out.

The Vetala standing in reserve jolted forward—on alert for this new attacker. But before they could take two steps, a gold and crimson blur was amongst them, slashing and tearing into their oily black flesh. Frosta tried to catch a glimpse of this newcomer, only catching sight of a long dark gray shape streaking behind it, appearing like a tail.

By now, the Szi'th caught in the flickering blaze had reached a state of complete cremation, falling to the ground as mere piles of ash. Frosta whipped her head around to the source of her deliverance, spotting him standing on a nearby parapet, his long cape flowing majestically behind him.

Right away, she grinned.

"About time you showed up!" Frosta shouted, pumping a fist in the air.

He-Man/Shen returned the gesture with a salute of his sword, his glowing blue eyes narrowing as he caught sight of Shen'Shalidar. Frosta discerned recognition there, an immediate enmity that could only be achieved after a long history of hostility.

"*Shen'Shalidar,*" He-Man/Shen cursed. "Only one so debased such as you could have wormed your way out of having to face justice! You will regret crawling out from under that foul rock you call Morrigar!"


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A loud cackle of laughter drew Frosta's attention back to the melee amongst the Vetala—she balked—noticing a seven-foot-tall warrior woman standing amongst the enemy's ruins. This newcomer was arrayed in an outlandish outfit—but the heterochromatic eyes, long black ears, and stone-gray tail were a dead giveaway.

"Why are you talking that way, Shen?" She asked, hands on hips. "*Only one so debased as you…*"

Frosta watched He-Man/Shen grin at the other's mocking, giving a lame shrug in return.

"Hey, whatever, I'm trying something new, Catra. Give me a break," he complained.

"*Catra*?!" Frosta exclaimed, taking in her friend's incredible new form.

Two glowing feline eyes pinned Frosta in place as the warrior woman gave her a nod.

"That's right, Squirt, I'm Sher-Va now," Sher-Va/Catra said.

Frosta gaped as she took a moment to take in Catra's appearance, nodding slowly.

"*Yeah… you can call me Squirt…*" she replied breathlessly.

"ENOUGH OF THIS FOOLISHNESS!!!" Shen'Shalidar screamed, making a chopping motion with his sword. "All I see is two more fools to die by my hand!"

Sher-Va/Catra crouched as the Vetala and Szi'th moved in on her position—He-Man/Shen leaped down from the castle walls; sword held up to attack. Frosta moved closer to Hordak, the two allies going back-to-back in a defensive position.

"Okay, creep. Let's do this!!!" Sher-Va/Catra said.

* * *

Bright Moon had always been a peaceful and tranquil place, but the version of She-Ra/Adora's home she found herself in was dead silent. There was no sign of a single living soul as she, Zhe-La/Veth, Glimmer, and the rest of Team Darla crept through the castle grounds.

Having landed in the small starport by the bay, the group had begun their explorations with the outlaying towers before moving into the castle proper. Now as they moved down the long and spacious corridor towards the throne room, She-Ra/Adora could not help feeling a sense of trepidation—as if they were being watched.

"If we can't find anyone in the main audience chamber, I think it's safe to say Bright Moon is secure," Micha said.

"Agreed," Glimmer said. "Everyone must have run off or are hiding in The Whispering Woods. It's strange, though; you would think someone had seen us coming and tried to stop us by now."

"Oh, I'm sure Ar—*I mean*—Lethe has seen us," Zhe-La/Veth commented. "We are not safe until they are defeated, and I think we are walking into a trap,"

She-Ra/Adora glanced at her fellow Champion, noticing their silver eyes dance about the hallway as they searched for danger.

"Yes, you would be an expert on traps, wouldn't you, Veth?" Castaspella said, not bothering to hide her scorn.

"Cassie, please, I appreciate you sticking up for me and Catra, but let's not fight amongst ourselves right now." She-Ra/Adora said.

Castaspella shrugged as Bow walked past her, holding up the scanner he had been using since they had arrived in Bright Moon. According to him, the device detected movement by tracking the micro changes in air density—if anything were moving nearby—it would tell them.

“Bow, babe, I think your newest invention might be broken,” Glimmer said with a weak grin. “I mean, there had got to be something moving—”

Glimmer stopped speaking as Bow held up a hand, both of his dark eyebrows raised in alarm.

I got something, he mouthed, indicating the direction of movement with his chin.

How many? She-Ra/Adora mouthed back. Bow held up a single finger.

Moving towards the spot Bow indicated, She-Ra/Adora recognized that it was a hidden closet; the only indication that it was a door and not another section of wall was the recessed knob. Team Darla crowded around the hidden closet as Glimmer went for the latch—after a whispered count of three—she heaved the door open as the entire group pointed swords and raised staves in its direction.

“SURRENDER!!!” Yelled She-Ra/Adora.

“SUBMIT!!!” Shouted Zhe-La/Veth.

“OH MY!!!” Gasped Castaspella.

“AGGGHHH!!!” Came the scream within.

It took a moment to recognize the person crouching on the ground—her hair was a mess, and she was out of her typical armor—but when She-Ra/Adora watched the woman raise her brown-skinned face, she was unmistakable.

“JULIET!!!” Castaspella cried. She rushed forward to embrace her girlfriend, who seemed perplexed by what was happening—as if she were questioning the basis of her entire reality.

“Cassie?” Juliet gasped, “Is it really you?”

“Yes! Yes! It's me!” Castaspella said, hauling the other woman off the ground to wrap her in a bear hug. “I’ve been waiting for this moment for so long!”

“You are all real, aren’t you?” The General of Bright Moon’s forces said, peering at the rest of the people crowding around her.

“You bet,” Glimmer said, placing a comforting hand on the other woman’s shoulder. “We are here to free not only Bright Moon—but all of Etheria and Eternia as well.”

Juliet’s eyes widened as fear blazed across her features—she shook her head vehemently.

“NO! You must leave—now!” She gasped, looking up and down the corridor furtively. “They are too strong—GO!—before they come!”

“Who, my love?” Castaspella pleaded, brushing Juliet’s disheveled hair from her face.

“THEM!” She hissed, appearing manic. “Three of those black monsters showed up not long ago; they came with a group called ‘the enervated’ and captured everyone who was not turned yet. They brought them down into the undercroft! I just barely escaped!”

“Undercroft?” Bow said uncertainly. “You mean the place we went during Glimmer’s coronation?”

“No, not that deep, silly,” Glimmer said, not unkindly. “It's right below the main structure, in the rock the castle sits upon. It’s like a big storage hall. Why would our people be taken there?”

“I have no idea, my Queen!” Juliet said. “I could only watch helplessly as they were taken there.”

“Well, we should go get them—now!” She-Ra/Adora exclaimed.

Juliet rushed forward to grasp She-Ra/Adora's wrist, halting the other woman.

"Yes! I agree! But not all of you should go!" She exclaimed, eyes full of fear. "These monsters that showed up—they're different from the others. They seem to have some… *power*… to call upon —like She-Ra—only different. I think you and…"

Juliet searched the group, her eyes alighting upon the form of Zhe-La/Veth.

"Them! The two of you should go—it would be better that way. It's cramped down there, and bringing too many people would be a disaster!" She finished.

"Well, I don't see it as a problem if I come with them," Glimmer said, raising the Star Stone staff.

"NO!" Juliet said. "They will sense the power of your staff and will see you coming!"

She-Ra/Adora glanced at Zhe-La/Veth, watching her fellow Champion frowning at the General of Bright Moon's armed forces.

"You seem to have a suspicious amount of stipulations for us, Juliet. How do you know they can sense a Staff of Ultimate Power?" They asked.

"Are you calling my girlfriend a liar?!" Castaspella raged. "You're not one to talk, Veth! If Juliet says that the enemy can sense Glimmer's Star Stone, that is because they can! What, you don't think you can handle it? I think you're afraid—"

Zhe-La/Veth held their hands up in placation, forestalling Castaspella from continuing her tirade.

"Sorry, I misspoke. I apologize, Juliet. I did not mean to impugn your honor," Zhe-La/Veth said, giving a slight bow to the General.

She-Ra/Adora watched this drama take place, feeling as if her fellow Champion's misgivings were justified. She decided to try something.

Do you think this is a trap, Veth? She-Ra/Adora projected, using a small amount of her power.

She noticed the other Champion give a small start of surprise as their silver eyes darted in her direction—they smiled.

The thought did occur to me. They sent back. **And when I peered into Juliet's quintessence, I saw indications there that she had been enervated—so it's definitely a trap. Although if it is a Vetala—or many—the two of us can handle them.**

She-Ra/Adora nodded, returning the smile.

Spring the trap? She sent.

Absolutely. Veth replied.

"Okay, General, sounds like a plan," She-Ra/Adora said. "I am unfamiliar with the undercroft—can you lead us there?"

Juliet nodded emphatically. "Yes! Absolutely, of course!"

Totally a trap. Zhe-La/Veth sent, almost making She-Ra/Adora burst out in laughter.

"I'm not a fan of this plan, but if you two think you can handle it, then…" Glimmer said, finishing her sentence with a wave of her hand.

"Just be careful," she added.

The two Champions followed Juliet down the hall in the opposite direction of the main audience chamber, finding a staircase leading down. As they traveled towards the undercroft, She-Ra/Adora could feel her Champion Spirit reacting to something—a

simultaneous repulsion and attraction—like two magnets driven towards each other's polar mid-points.

Do you feel that? Veth sent.

Yes. She-Ra/Adora responded. **Didn't Juliet say these Vetala are different?**

I don't know how they could be, but anything is possible with Lethe. Zhe-La/Veth sent.

The staircase leveled out as the trio found themselves in a short corridor, the end leading to a large wooden door that was latched closed.

"Quietly now, they should be just inside!" Juliet said, opening the door slowly and beckoning the two Champions within. Before She-Ra/Adora passed the General, she laid a large hand on the smaller woman's shoulder.

"General, I just want you to know I forgive you for this, and when this is all over and you are back to yourself, I hope you can forgive yourself," she said.

Juliet gaped up at the Champion before a scowl bloomed across her face; She-Ra/Adora only brushed past her and into the undercroft. It was a large and cavernous chamber—sturdy pillars dotted the space—the tops of which vaulted into the ceiling, adding a gothic aspect to Bright Moon's basement. This appearance was made more prominent by torches held in place by iron scones bolted to each pillar—the light of which barely kept the gloom at bay. There was something back there, in the darkness; She-Ra/Adora noticed her fellow Champion's strange silver eyes narrow as they spotted something.

"They already know it's a trap!" Juliet called from the doorway.

She-Ra/Adora turned just in time to watch the General close the door; the woman's earlier anger turned into smug triumph.

“Have fun in there!” She taunted, slamming the door closed.

She-Ra/Adora glanced at Zhe-La/Veth, giving them a shrug.

“We can always break the door down,” she said.

The sound of bare feet slapping against stone brought She-Ra/Adora’s attention back to the undercroft—there—she witnessed three black figures pad out from the stygian depths. There was no questioning that these were Vetala—from their lithe naked bodies to the black eyes set in an equally black face. Each stopped ten paces from the two Champions, spaced out in a fan.

“I am Veth, bearer of Zhe-La and Champion of the Empyrean Empire—I order you to stand down!” Zhe-La/Veth commanded.

“*Tcckkk…you do not—tcckkk…speak for Lethe anymore…nor—tcckkk… do you have the authority over us…”* One of the Vetala said suddenly. It was an eerie sound, raspy and out of sync with the mouth speaking, made all the more ominous by the fact the one speaking had no tongue.

“What?! Since when do you creatures speak?” Zhe-La/Veth said incredulously. “What purpose does it serve for those who are damned?”

“Tcckkk… so we can do—tcckkk…this!” Another Vetala said, reaching up, clawed fingers outstretched in a very familiar gesture.

“TO THE GLORY OF GRAYSKULL!!!” It said—instantly, an indigo blaze burst forth from the center of its chest as the Vetala’s onyx body began to increase in size.

She-Ra/Adora watched in horror as the other two Vetala followed in the other’s footsteps, reaching for the ceiling as they spoke their own words of activation.

“BY THE WISDOM OF GRAYSKULL!!!”

“BY THE TRANSCENDENCE OF GRAYSKULL!!!”

All three Vetala were now bright with fell luminosity as armor adorned their sleek bodies, grim helmets appeared over their bald heads, and swords appeared in outstretched hands. When the transformation was complete, three dark reflections of what it meant to be a Champion of Grayskull stood in their places. On each of their chests were twisted representations of their Champion symbols—much like the She-Ra symbol that Despara bore.

She-Ra/Adora found herself meeting Zhe-La/Veth’s gaze as both Champions turned to each other simultaneously.

“I think coming here by ourselves might have been a mistake,” Zhe-La/Veth said.

* * *

With armored claws clattering, Sher-Va/Catra charged straight toward the nearest group of Vetala. Just as she was about to barrel into the mass, she leaped to perform a somersault, simultaneously hurling a cantrip down into their upturned, fanged faces. Black oily bodies were torn asunder as the magic of the Madgēcots exploded into a green fireball—but Sher-Va/Catra was not paying attention; her eyes were already looking for her next victim.

I can’t believe what I am witnessing—these foul creatures were once Nephraeh! Lethe has twisted them into the exact opposite of what their people represent! Jihan complained.

Not now, Jihan! Sher-Va/Catra sent as a hissing wretch leaped at her—she easily sidestepped this attack, punishing the foolish Vetala with a backward slash, sending them to the ground in ruins.

Another tried to bite her leg—Sher-Va/Catra stomped down on its head—twisting her clawed foot into the ground for good measure.

Grabbing two Vetala that tried to assault her simultaneously, Sher-Va/Catra dashed them together, throwing what was left at the others with a disgusted hiss.

Taking a moment to take stock of her ally, Sher-Va/Catra spotted him crossing swords with Shen'Shalidar; He-Man/Shen had the height and bulk advantage on his opponent, but somehow the smaller man was holding his own. Shen'Shalidar heaved the Champion away from himself with a broad swing of his glowing sword—the passing of which left strange afterimages in Sher-Va/Catra's eyesight.

She closed her eyes and looked away—just as hands gripped her tail—yanking on it.

"RAAAAAGGGHHH!!!" Sher-Va/Catra screamed, twisting her body and shaking her rear with such vigor her assailant was sent rocketing into the sky. She quickly ran her claws over the length of the abused appendage, smoothing down the agitated fur there.

"Never touch my tail," Sher-Va/Catra grumbled, eyes weary.

Turning her attention back to the duel, she beheld He-Man/Shen slamming his silver sword repeatedly down on Shen'Shalidar—but astonishingly—the smaller opponent defected these attacks. Once again Sher-Va/Catra was unsettled by the weapon in the strange man's hands—right away, her tail bushed up—recognizing the evil it represented.

Maybe I should help Shen out; that thing looks way dangerous, Sher-Va/Catra considered.

"Catra! HELLLPPP!!!"

Whipping around, Sher-Va/Catra spotted Frosta and Hordak; the foul Szi'th had surrounded them—the undead grasping them with steely fingers as they tried to bite them with corrupted teeth. Hordak was shielding the young Princess with his armor-encased body as she spat out ice missiles from under him, but monsters were overwhelming him in their hunger—it would not be long

before they overcame the ex-Horde ruler and bore him to the ground.

“Coming!!!” She called, bounding over on all fours.

Batting crusty corpses to either side, Sher-Va/Catra cleared the Szi’th from the embattled Hordak—she seized one by the nape of its neck before it could clamp its jaws on her old boss. The foul creature was in such a state of decomposition that it literally fell apart once handled by the Champion, covering her claws in a gooey mess.

“Yuck, Hordak! You totally owe me for this!” The Madgēcot Champion complained, flicking the muck off her hands.

“Thank you, Catra,” he said, rising unsteadily to his feet.

Sher-Va/Catra was surprised when the old warlord offered his hand to Frosta, the young Princess taking it gratefully as she was lifted to her feet. Doing a quick survey of the battle, Sher-Va/Catra noted that there were Horde Bots amongst the fray; they fought the monsters pouring over the battlements and into the castle courtyard. But the robots were slowly dwindling against the onslaught as they attempted to defend Hordak and Frosta—soon, none would be left, leaving the two vulnerable. There was no way she could leave their side in the middle of this chaos—nor did she perceive a sign of anyone else from Team Seagull. She and He-Man/Shen had leaped from an open hatch as The Millennial Seagull passed over the Crypto Castle—but by now—her friends should have caught up to them. She shook her head—it didn’t matter right now, returning her focus to Hordak and Frosta.

“How in the name of Etheria did you two end up fighting side by side?” Sher-Va/Catra asked.

Just as she spoke, a Vetala came flying at her—mouth opened to clamp on her arm with razor teeth. Sher-Va/Catra punched the creature right through the torso, leaving the rest of its body to disintegrate into vapor.

“How about I tell you later, Catra? It’s kind of a long story,” Frosta said, hurling ice crystals into a group of Szi’th, shredding them into wriggling pieces. The young Princess returned her gaze to the Madgēcot Champion, raising a single eyebrow as she gave Sher-Va/Catra a second appraisal.

“Like the new look, Catra. Was there something in the water you were drinking on Elysia?” She asked.

“Long story,” Sher-Va/Catra said, grinning as she repeated Frosta’s words. The three allies fell into step with one another—the larger Champion taking on the brunt of the enemies while Frosta and Hordak picked off the stragglers.

“I hope Shen is doing okay against Shen’Shalidar,” Frosta commented.

“He’ll send whoever that is packing.” Sher-Va/Catra responded without hesitation. She noticed that Frosta grimaced at this comment.

“Catra, that isn’t some fancy sword Shen’Shalidar has—*it’s an abominable Power,”* Frosta added.

Sher-Va/Catra’s ears lowered at this news, and with gritted teeth, she attempted to seek out her friend once more. A jolt of anxiety coursed through her once he was spotted; He-Man/Shen was no longer holding his sword but gripping his enemy’s blade with his bare hands—the faces of both adversaries rigid in the contest of wills. Slowly, dancing electricity started to creep up the blade, emanating from He-Man/Shen’s hands as the sword began to glow—not with the earlier dread light—but with power.

A blow to the side of Sher-Va/Catra’s made her stumble—shaking her head with a vicious hiss—she spotted a Vetala in a crouch nearby. The creature must have kicked her, using its inherited Nephraeh agility to reach the height needed to deliver the blow. She growled.

“You little—!” Sher-Va/Catra said, lashing out at the creature with claws extended. The Vetala somersaulted away from her strike and out of range, finding refuge in a crowd of Szi’th.

“Oh no, you don’t!” She murmured, reaching for her lower back to select the right cantrip.

“I want to introduce you to my little friend,” Sher-Va/Catra said, balling up the piece of her Jaadoo suit. “It’s called Jvaala—The Fireball!”

She whipped the cantrip in the direction of the retreating Vetala, the magical missile howling as it sought the target for complete incineration. A concussive shockwave rocked Sher-Va/Catra, pitching her on her back as waves of energy blasted past her.

“Wow… that was way stronger than the last time…” she said, blinking stars out of her vision.

Still confused, Sher-Va/Catra tilted her head, noticing that the explosion had practically cleared the battlefield. All the Szi’th were on the ground—lifeless—the magic animating them seeming to vanish, leaving the undead just dead. The Vetala were also affected; the onyx-skinned monsters had collected into a huddle as they all looked fearfully in one direction. When Sher-Va/Catra followed the line of their gaze, she realized that it was not her cantrip that had caused so much destruction.

Shen’Shalidar was on his knees; his hand held out before him—they were smoking ruins, looking like two pieces of overcooked meat. All around him were crackling shards of bone-white material—the remains of his Abominable Power. Standing above him with his own sword held aloft was He-Man/Shen—his face a blank mask of anger as he prepared to finish the job by decapitating Shen’Shalidar.

“No! Wait!” Sher-Va/Catra cried, bounding over to her friend on all fours. She rose before her friend to grasp his wrists, stopping the blade from performing the killing blow.

"You don't want this," she said softly. "And he must answer for his crimes. *Easy…*"

Her friend's eyes focused on her heterochromatic ones as he nodded, slowly lowering the sword before he dismissed it out of existence.

"Right," He-Man/Shen said. "You're right, Catra. Thank you."

She glanced down at his enemy; Shen'Shalidar was now weeping, seeming unable to reconcile the state of his hands after bearing the brunt of an exploding Abominable Power. Sher-Va/Catra was surprised to see him still standing, remembering the last time she had been near such an occurrence; this was the second of those evil objects that met its end by He-Man/Shen's, and Sher-Va/Catra was impressed.

"Here, let me help you," Frosta said as she kneeled by Shen'Shalidar. Using her ice magic, she applied a small layer of frost to his hands—Shen'Shalidar let out a small sigh of relief as a fraction of his pain was alleviated. For some reason, this act of beneficence pleased Sher-Va/Catra—but before she could comment on it, the sound of pattering feet caught her attention.

"Where the heck have you all been?!" Sher-Va/Catra shouted at the newcomers arriving through the wall's open gate.

Panga came bounding up on all fours, grasping one of the Madgēcot Champion's golden gauntlets with her orange hands.

"I'm so sorry, Mahat! I should have been here, but we were delayed!" She cried, the anguish in her voice taking Sher-Va/Catra off guard.

"Uh… oh—its okay, Panga, everything turned out fine…" she said, giving the other female Madgēcot an awkward pat.

"We would have just followed you and used my power to halt our fall, but *someone* insisted we use theirs," Mermista said, looking pointedly at Double Trouble.

The shapeshifter only shrugged, giving everyone a sharp-toothed smile.

"What can I say, darlings? It's Chaos magic," they said.

Seahawk and Orko came strolling up behind the others—the rogue with his signature laser sword in hand while the Trollan waved a wand about, looking for threats. Bringing up the rear was Entrapta, the technical Princess walking while engrossed in her datapad and utterly unaware of what was happening around her.

"Entrapta?" Hordak called.

With two purple ponytails perking like ears, Entrapta looked up from her device as absolute joy blossomed across her face.

"HOOORRRRDAAAAKKK!!!" She cried, running at a full sprint to embrace her lost love.

Sher-Va/Catra found herself grinning at this display as He-Man/Shen came to stand next to her.

"That's going to be how Veth reacts when they see you— *'Oh, Shennnn,*" she said with a wicked grin.

With a laugh, he shook his head. "Yeah, I kind of doubt it, Catra. It's a nice thought, though."

Suddenly Seawak raised his laser sword to point over Sher-Va/Catra's shoulder, catching her attention.

"What are those creatures doing?" He asked.

With a tired sigh, Sher-Va/Catra turned in the indicated direction, seeing the mass of Vetala slowly melting into a sizeable oily pool—she instantly knew what that meant.

"Get ready, guys; I don't think our work is done here!" Sher-Va/Catra said, crouching in an offensive position.

“Do you think they are sending another army?” Frosta asked.

Sher-Va/Catra frowned; instead of a mass of more enemies coming out of the portal, it appeared as if one being was slowly rising from its inky surface. A very tall and lithe person was slowly taking shape—the level of their head rising past the heights of both Champions of Grayskull.

“This can’t be good,” He-Man/Shen stated.

When the newcomer finally fully materialized, the black substance of the portal fell away, unveiling a beautifully androgynous being garbed in an archaic and revealing outfit. Two indigo eyes blazed out of a pure white face framed by flowing white hair; they smiled, exposing rows of sharp black teeth. Sher-Va/Catra felt a jolt deep within her core as her mentor recognized his being.

Nooooo!* ... *my Kishar…

“Hello there,” Lethe greeted cordially. “It’s been a while since I set foot on Etheria—it’s so nice to have you all here to greet me!”

Chapter End Notes

New He-Man design and illustration by the always fantastic Miledibuja! Check out their art on Instagram, Tumblr, and Twitter!

Balance

Chapter Summary

In a dire situation, Veth and Adora fight against three fallen Champions as Shen and Catra face the full might of Lethe.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The three Vetala Champions fanned out in an offensive approach, their void-black eyes set upon the Champions of Grayskull with vile intent. She-Ra/Adora inspected one of the night-black figures, her eyes focusing on the corrupted symbol on its chest.

That's Thon-Ra, Zhe-La/Veth communicated telepathically. **Their Champion corresponds to the Orb of Entropy—so beware of tricks and illusions!**

She-Ra/Adora frowned, considering her companion's words.

Corresponds? Do you mean each Champion is matched up with an Ultimate Power? She sent back.

Zhe-La/Veth sighed heavily through the mind link, something She-Ra/Adora had come to know quite well during their time together.

Yes, Adora. He-Ro is in tune with the Star Stone and Wun-Dar with the Kinetic Krystal. They said, indicating each with the point of their sword. **I'm sure you can guess who She-Ra is paired with.**

The Life Gem! She thought immediately.

Yes—now—I would love to give you a full lesson, but I think we should concentrate on this fight—eh?

Just as She-Ra/Adora received the message, Thon-Ra suddenly lunged in an attempt to overwhelm her with a single thrust to the torso. The Etherian Champion expertly parried this attack, following up with a sideway bisection that Thon-Ra barely leaped away from. Before She-Ra/Adora could follow through with another move, Thon-Ra waved a hand, its entire form shimmering like a desert mirage. When the Vetala Champion came back into focus, its shape was no longer lithe but feminine; the face leering back at She-Ra/Adora framed by a jagged black facemask, the very mirror of her own.

"Hey, Adora," Despara said.

"Uhh… Veth…" She-Ra/Adora called.

She glanced back at her ally just in time to witness Wun-Dar direct its hand at Zhe-La/Veth—instantly surrounding them in a hazy teal field. The Empyrean Champion could still move in the kinetic dampening magic—but minutely slower—making them vulnerable. Seizing on this opportunity, He-Ro, teleported behind the Nephraeh Champion, its deadly sword prepared to strike.

Adora, it's just an illusion! Zhe-La/Veth sent.

Just as she received the message, He-Ro went in for the kill, the tip of its sword piercing armor and flesh as Zhe-La/ Veth attempted to twist away. They cried out in pain—hand immediately going to their side to stem the flow of lambent azure blood.

I'm going to need help, Adora! Zhe-La/Veth pleaded.

Gritting her teeth, She-Ra/Adora turned her attention back to the illusion of Despara, focusing on what that woman meant to her. Through the cleansing sessions with Veth, She-Ra/Adora no longer associated this dark version as one degree of association away from her personae—but as a totally reversed aspect of who she was. She-Ra/Adora was by no means perfect, but she was nowhere near the level of evil Despara was.

"Your tricks won't work on me!" She growled, rushing the Despara imposter with thrusts and jabs while allowing some of what she remembered as Despara to come to the surface. This tactic worked, giving She-Ra/Adora's attacks the brutal edge needed to break her enemy's defenses. The Despara imposter hissed in pain as it received a cut to the upper shoulder, retreating backward as it dropped the illusion, becoming Thon-Ra once more.

She-Ra/Adora used this opening to reach Zhe-La/Veth's side, narrowly deflecting Wun-Dar's decapitating strike from ending her fellow Champion. Turning just in time, She-Ra/Adora spotted He-Ro pointing their sword in her direction; a burst of white-hot power spewed forth, appearing much like the Star Fire Glimmer could summon. She-Ra/Adora replied with her own arcane attack, intercepting this blast with a pulse of energy from her core to disperse it. Reaching down, she pulled the Empyrean Champion to their feet, simultaneously using the connection point to bathe them in She-Ra's healing magic. Zhe-La/Veth sighed in gratitude, removing their hand from the grievous wound to reveal unblemished flesh—soon covered by adaptive Aegis Lace.

Thank you, Adora. Zhe-La/Veth sent.

You're welcome. Any idea how we are going to get out of this mess? She replied.

Just as she asked the question, She-Ra/Adora noticed the same teal outline that surrounded Zhe-La/Veth now encompassed her form, slowing her reflexes minutely. She-Ra/Adora struggled against this magical shackle while fighting the anxiety its effect had on her—it was smothering—producing a sense of claustrophobia.

I have no experience with this, but the strength of the Champions of old did not come from them individually—only when they worked together. I know these creatures; they are devoid of empathy and do not fight as one—that is our advantage. Zhe-La/Veth said in her mind.

As they spoke, a sublime blaze radiated out from Zhe-La/Veth, making all three Vetala Champions stagger away—She-Ra/Adora instantly felt free of the effects of limiting friction and could now move unencumbered. The two Champions of Grayskull closed ranks—fighting back-to-back with blades facing outwards. Having a moment to recover, the Vetala Champions rallied, approaching their foes with a wariness borne of uncertainly.

“Let’s do this, Veth,” She-Ra/Adora said with relish.


HENAR TORINOS'23

* * *

Sher-Va/Catra struggled to take in the scope of the being walking towards her—they were massive—much bigger than she was in her Champion form. This, combined with their casual regard in facing two Champions of Grayskull and two bearers of Ultimate Power made her uneasy—they seemed unaffected, playfully tossing their long white hair over one shoulder.

Sher-Va/Catra and He-Man/Shen backed away slowly as Lethe approached—their Champion Avatars sensing the threat before them on an instinctual level. The massive being stopped ten paces away from the assembled group, their burning indigo eyes scanning each figure before finding what they sought.

"Is that you, He-Man? My, I did not recognize you in this form, and I must say—I like it. Shen is your name, isn't it?" Lethe practically said with a silky purr. "You know, the bearer of He-Man once tried to court me—but he was an oaf. You, on the other hand… hmmm…"

Sher-Va/Catra's hackles rose as she stood closer to her friend in protection; Lethe's eyes found her next, instantly widening in shock as an obscure emotion passed over their porcelain features. This moment of awkwardness passed quickly, replaced by a façade of friendly congeniality.

"Sher-Va, I'm not sure how long it's been… more than a thousand years—I'm sure!" They said with a laugh. "It is good to see you in your new form as well—although—I'm not sure I can recall your last one…"

Sher-Va/Catra was incredulous as the massive being held one stained claw tip to their lips in contemplation, the expression seeming quite genuine.

Cat-Tra—something is wrong… I know it's been over a thousand years, but how could they not remember me? Jihan said.

Sher-Va/Catra heard the sadness in her mentor's voice yet tried her best not to focus on it.

I don't know, Jihan—I really need help if we are going to beat Lethe! What can you tell me about them? What are their weaknesses?

Cat-Tra, I died right before Kishar finished their Apogeon Ritual—I have no idea! From what I understand of the magic used in their ascension, they have power beyond anyone here! My suggestion is simple: RUN!

Sher-Va/Catra glanced at the others—her friends; perhaps some could escape, but those without magic would be hard-pressed to do so. There was no way she was going to leave anyone behind.

Not an option, Jihan. No way.

I know, Cat-Tra. Jihan said, sounding proud**. Just remember what I said—if not this lifetime, then the next. Perhaps we will finally meet in person?**

"Is there something funny, bearer of Sher-Va?" Lethe said, pulling the Madgēcot Champion from her internal dialogue to realize she had been smiling.

"No, not at all." She answered simply. "What do you want, Lethe?"

The alabaster-skinned giant grinned broadly, exposing rows of onyx daggers set in black gums, the sight of which made Sher-Va/Catra's tail bush up.

"What do I want? Oh, that's simple; I want you and He-Man here to come with me. Since I know the likelihood of that happening is very low, I will settle for just *him*." They said, indicating He-Man/Shen with a jut of their chin.

"I'm not going anywhere with you, fiend!" He-Man/Shen said, raising his sword.

“That’s right, honey.” Double Trouble said from nearby. “You’re gonna have to fight us for him,”

Sher-Va/Catra was surprised to see the shapeshifter’s demeanor shift rapidly from playful imp to ferocious protector as they bared pointed teeth and exposed sharp claws. Their yellow and green eyes transitioned into black orbs containing dancing green motes, indicating the magic of entropy they now bore. Mermista likewise raised her Staff of Power as Panga, Seahawk, Frosta, Entrapta, and Hordak took up offensive positions. Sher-Va/Catra noticed that even Orko seemed ready to fight, the diminutive Trollan extracting a wand from within his robes to hold it aloft. Lethe gave a tsk of disappointment.

“This is not a good idea,” they said. “There is a good chance someone will die—and I should tell you—death is no longer a possibility for me,”

Sher-Va/ recognized the doubt crossing He-Man/Shen’s face as he lowered his sword—she immediately grasped his wrist, making him meet her feline gaze.

“Don’t even think about it,” she growled.

The rueful smirk on He-Man/Shen’s face indicated he knew exactly what would happen if he defied Sher-Va/Catra—perhaps even remembering the first time he tried to sacrifice himself; knocked unconscious and locked up in Bright Moon. He nodded.

“Let’s do this, Catra,”

* * *

The black sword clattered against its opposing silver as She-Ra/Adora blocked yet another attempt by Wun-Dar to bypass her defenses; the Vetala Champion was getting frustrated now, baring its hideous teeth in impotent rage. She-Ra/Adora shoved her opponent away just in time to fend off a lunge from He-Ro—the Dark Champion going for a low blow to her legs, seeking to cripple her. She parried the blow harmlessly away, following it with

a kick, striking He-Ro directly in the face; the creature squealed in pain as several onyx teeth clattered to the floor. She-Ra/Adora allowed herself a small amount of satisfaction as He-Ro spun away, holding its wounded mouth as a stygian muck flowed between black fingers.

"That will teach you not to fight dirty," she said with bite.

Glad you're enjoying yourself, Zhe-La/Veth sent**. Be careful you don't get too cocky; this is a tenuous position we are in.**

She-Ra/Adora didn't respond—not out of spite—but because she knew the other Champion was correct. The two of them had been fighting at each other's backs for a while now, each in harmony with the other. All it would take to disrupt this balance would be if one of them made a minor mistake: an overextension of a thrust, an ill-timed block, or even a misstep. The enemy was too deadly to play around—after all—they were three Champions where she and Zhe-La/Veth were only a pair.

But She-Ra/Adora could not help recognizing a piece of herself that was instrumental in this conflict; the part that was all hard lines and sharp edges. The part which was always there, only kept in check by the boundary of compassion; it had been allowed to run free and unfettered once—but now kept bottled up and contained—only to be let out in small increments when needed. Veth had taught her how to do this—not intentionally—but as a by-product of clearing the channels within her, achieving a state of equipoise.

The Vetala Champions were attacking in a rotating pattern; two pairing up to assault one Champion of Grayskull as the other fought on an even footing. When the two couldn't get past the one's guard, they would switch up, doubling up on the opposite Champion of Grayskull. She-Ra/Adora watched as Wun-Dar moved to engage Zhe-La/Veth alongside Thon-Ra, leaving only Wun-Dar to face her.

Recognizing an opportunity, She-Ra/Adora allowed a more substantial amount of that dark personae to the surface. Excited to be released, it surged up, seeking to inhabit her soul fully—She-Ra/Adora immediately clamped down on its exuberance, lest it consume her once more.

Not all the way, Despara, not all the way… She-Ra/Adora thought, feeling the other personality creep around the edges of her identity. She allowed it into the arms and hands holding her sword, into the legs positioning for the strike, and finally, into her warrior's intent, channeling it into a fine point. This finely-honed tip was composed of only one element, the fuel necessary to defeat insurmountable odds.

Rage.

With its bleeding stemmed, He-Ro came in once more, seeking a non-direct route of attack by once more testing She-Ra/Adora's defenses—sideways feints and probing jabs. She-Ra/Adora stepped into the Vetala's Champions guard, batting away these feeble moves with two solid blows. She was an indomitable force; eyes narrowed into cold blue chips of ice as she thrust her sword toward He-Ro's abdomen. The creature tried to leap away yet screeched in pain as the tip of the silver sword penetrated black armor and even blacker flesh beneath—it yanked itself off the end of She-Ra/Adora's blade, stumbling away in an attempt to allow its Champion power to mend the wound.

"Not a chance," She-Ra/Adora growled, moving in to finish her opponent.

But at that moment, He-Ro blinked out of existence, appearing behind the Etherian Champion and in striking range of Zhe-La/Veth's back. The Vetala Champion had seen the opening and took it, perhaps sensing an opportunity to wound the Nephraeh Champion in exchange for its own life.

"NO!" She-Ra/Adora cried, lunging for He-Ro.

Sensing the assault, Zhe-La/Veth turned from their exchange with Wun-Dar and Thon-Ra, expertly diverting the surprise attack with a parry. But this interruption in Zhe-La/Veth's focus would have consequences; with their back turned, Wun-Dar scored another cut upon the Nephraeh Champions' body, slicing their upper arm and leaving it useless in holding a sword.

Fury coursed through She-Ra/Adora at seeing her ally maimed—spotting her coming—He-Ro once again blinked out of existence. She-Ra/Adora spun on one heel, sweeping her sword out in a wide arc, just in time to catch the Vetala Champion as it attempted to materialize behind her, completely bisecting it. He-Ro coughed black gore before falling to the ground in two pieces, its remains immediately dissipating into a shadowy vapor that floated up into the ceiling and disappeared.

A strange crystalline shape was left in He-Ro's wake; it immediately cracked open like an egg as an amorphous form fluttered out—this also vanished as the smoke did—into the ceiling and towards an unknown destination.

She-Ra/Adora ignored this phenomenon, whipping around to come to Zhe-La/Veth's aid—she was just in time to deflect a strike from Thon-Ra, pushing the Dark Champion back to seize her ally's arm. A golden radiance passed through this connection point as She-Ra's healing magic made Zhe-La/Veth's arm whole once more; she could practically feel the relief pour off them in waves.

Sorry, Veth! I got careless! She-Ra/Adora communicated.

It's okay, Adora! You defeated He-Ro and healed me just in time—we will get through this! Veth sent back.

She-Ra/Adora nodded back gratefully as the remaining Vetala Champions resumed their offensive positions; both sides were evenly matched now—one Champion of Grayskull for one Dark Champion.

What do you say, Veth? I'm sick of being on the defensive.

As soon as She-Ra/Adora sent the message, she heard a laugh from the Nephraeh Champion.

I think you just read my mind, Adora, Zhe-La/Veth sent back.

* * *

Galloping on all fours, Sher-Va/Catra charged Lethe, seeking to end the conflict as quickly as possible, thereby limiting the risk to her friends.

You obstinate Madgēcot—NO! They will kill you! Jihan screamed in her head.

Sher-Va/Catra ignored her mentor as she leaped, clawed gauntlets extended for a white throat—instantly—there were stars in her vision as pain wracked her entire body. After a period of weightlessness, she hit the ground—hard—coming to a rest on her back.

"Wow… that didn't go as planned," she groaned.

"Catra!" He-Man/Shen cried, pointing his sword at the one who had struck down his friend.

Lightning spat forth from the blade tip, aligning upon Lethe to form crackling arcs of snapping electricity coursing up and down their massive frame—but they were unbowed—pointing a single blackened claw in return.

"Stop it! That kind of stings!" Lethe said, sending a thin beam of indigo energy straight through He-Man/Shen's heart.

The power of He-Man instantly ceased assailing Lethe as the one casting it seized up—with eyes rolling into the back of his head—He-Man/Shen reverted out of his Champion form, collapsing to the ground.

"NOOO!!!" Double Trouble cried.

The bearer of the Orb of Entropy clapped their hands together—when they brought them back apart—a chaotic orb appeared. They hurled this ball straight at the enemy—who, for once, seemed worried. Lethe snarled in fury as they reached for the sphere, using their power to divert its trajectory. The deadly force was sent into the nearby wall, instantly turning the entire length into a black void of dancing fireflies. The castle fortification bent and twisted as the entropic magic took hold—when the enchantment receded—a mass of writhing snakes was revealed; they spilled out over the courtyard, slithering in every direction.

"My wall!!!" Entrapta shrieked. "You killed my beautiful castle wall!"

Sher-Va/Catra lifted herself as her allies instantly took action; Frosta hurled icy bolts as Panga tossed cantrips—but the assorted magical attacks only bounced harmlessly from Lethe's body.

Mermista raised her Staff of Power, using the power of the Kinetic Krystal to yank boulders off the nearby mountain face, sending them crashing down on Lethe. The mighty being simply slashed at these missiles with deadly claws, each one exploding into harmless dust.

Finally, Orko glided forward, waving his wand in an obscure pattern.

"From Yaotzin's mighty wrist, I do enlist, calling forth his bloody fist!"

Sher-Va/Catra's eyes went wide with shock as a giant skinless clenched hand appeared before the diminutive Trollan—right away—it hurtled toward Lethe, smashing them through a nearby wall and out of sight.

"Orko! You're going to pay for that!" Entrapta yelled.

Sher-Va/Catra used the moment of respite to scramble over to Shen, lifting her friend to shake him gently.

“Wake up; we need you!” She implored.

Shen’s eyes opened as he gasped, seizing Sher-Va/Catra’s wrists.

“S—so c—cold!” He stuttered.

Sher-Va/Catra gave him a grim smile—she had felt the effects of Oblivion before.

“Shake it off and get up!” She said, not unkindly.

Shen lifted himself up, immediately raising his hand and speaking the words of activation.

“BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!”

As soon as his transformation was complete, Lethe appeared from within the gouge in the wall, their burning eyes once again fixed on He-Man/Shen.

“I would rather have you alive, but if I settle for dead if I have to,” they threatened.

“Works for me,” He-Man/Shen said, charging at them.

* * *

Fighting side-by-side, She-Ra/Adora and Zhe-La/Veth hammered away at their Vetala counterparts, their united front an overwhelming advantage in the face of their enemy’s more disconnected approach.

When Wun-Dar attempted to use their magic to slow Zhe-La/Veth while simultaneously speeding around them, She-Ra/Adora stepped in; now that she knew her power was tied to the Life Gem, She-Ra/Adora bolstered Zhe-La/Veth’s life force, offsetting the dampening effects of Wun-Dar. The Empyrean Champion spun around at high velocity, catching the Vetala attacker off guard and stumbling them with a horizontal sword stroke.

Utilizing their affiliation with entropy, Thon-Ra became a copy of Catra, employing this advantage to emotionally offset She-Ra/Adora—but Zhe-La/Veth intervened—using the power of Light to dispel this dark illusion. With a magical bust from her sword, She-Ra/Adora blasted Thon-Ra away, the Vetala Champion skidding to a halt as it hissed at her in frustration. She-Ra/Adora did not relent, charging this enemy who had the audacity to use her wife's likeness against her.

"RAAHGHHHH!!!" She roared, battering at Thon-Ra with alternating slashes that were more hammer blows than sword strikes. The Vetala Champion was overwhelmed by this assault, totally inept in the face of She-Ra/Adora's wrath—it backed away by fractions—but every escape attempt was met by failure. On some instinctual level, Thon-Ra realized it had misjudged the decision to use love against its foe—but it was too late now—the Dark Champion's fate was sealed.

Bashing away Thon-Ra's guard, She-Ra/Adora performed an overhand chop in three successions, completely bisecting her enemy from shoulder to hip. The remains splattered to the floor, immediately vaporizing into a foul mist; amongst this dark vapor, She-Ra/Adora made out another of the bizarre shapes—this one gliding up like an eel as it passed through the ceiling.

She-Ra/Adora shook her head, dismissing the sight before turning to the remaining enemy. Wun-Dar had disengaged from Zhe-La/Veth to consider its position, onyx eyes watching the two Champions of Grayskull.

Adora, we have an opportunity here. If we kill Thon-Ra, then their Spirit will just return to Castle Grayskull. We should do our best to subdue Thon-Ra and thereby deprive Lethe of one of their Champions. Zhe-La/Veth sent.

As soon as She-Ra/Adora recognized the logic of these words, Thon-Ra bolted, perhaps sensing what the two Champions of Grayskull intended. Using their principal arcane abilities to imbue them with extreme impetus, the Vetala Champion crashed through

the doors sealing the undercroft, making their way into Bright Moon castle above.

"Don't let them escape!" Zhe-La/Veth cried, bounding after Thon-Ra.

She-Ra/Adora followed the other Champion out of the undercroft, racing up the stairs and into the central corridor running the length of the castle. There she saw the Thon-Ra, moving with the same pace and momentum as before, appearing as a blur shooting away. Feeling a jolt of desperation, She-Ra/Adora attempted to use her own power to enhance her stride—but soon discovered this was unnecessary.

A familiar screen of white energy appeared in the passage before the Vetala Champion—and before it even had a chance to slow its trajectory—Thon-Ra collided with the net, passing through it to tumble to the floor in pieces. Spinnerella and Netossa appeared from a nearby alcove, both Princesses appearing very pleased with the results.

"*Got you*—you creepy vampire creep!" Netossa shouted, pumping her fist in the air.

"Wow, babe—creepy creep? Isn't that overkill?" Spinnerella said with a grin.

Netossa kneeled to inspect the remains, her nose scrunching in distaste as they dissipated.

"No! Didn't you see that thing? It was huge! Way bigger than the other creeps we ran into! I figure, double the size, double the creep factor!" Netossa said.

Both Princesses turned to notice She-Ra/Adora and Zhe-La/Veth racing toward them, their faces abruptly switching to open shock.

"Oh no! You killed it!" She-Ra/Adora moaned, watching once again as another ethereal shape floated away. By now, she had realized

what she was viewing; the disembodied Champion Spirits returning to their resting place—presumably Castle Grayskull.

"Adora? Is that you? You're all silver now," Netossa exclaimed.

She-Ra/Adora nodded in greeting to her friends, waving a hand at her fellow Champion.

"Guys, this is Veth. Veth, this is Spinnerella and Netossa," she said in introduction.

The Etheirans Princesses gaped at the Nephraeh Champion, unsure what to make of someone else like She-Ra and He-Man.

"I guess it's for the best, Adora," Zhe-La/Veth said. "If your friends had not stopped them, Thon-Ra would have surely escaped,"

She-Ra/Adora sighed, knowing that they were right.

"Do you want to tell us what's going on?" Spinnerella asked.

She-Ra/Adora nodded, indicating with her hand that they should all proceed down the hall.

"Gladly—but first, we must find Glimmer and the others. I can't explain how I know this, but I have a feeling things are about to get much worse."

* * *

Sher-Va/Catra raced at her friend's heels, surprised that his two legs propelled him much faster than her four limbs combined. When he was ten paces away from Lethe, He-Man/Shen leaped into the air, seeking to smite the being with one mighty chop of his sword. Foreseeing his frontal assault, Lethe performed a lavish sweep of their long white arms, batting He-Man/Shen away as if he were a mere bug.

Lethe went to kick at the other Champion coming for them, but Sher-Va/Catra was quick, rolling under the foot to appear behind

them—she leaped upon their broad back—rending and tearing with all four sets of claws. Lambent indigo blood flowed as cream-colored flesh parted; Sher-Va/Catra was soon covered in it, bathing her in the power of Oblivion. She howled in agony as she fell to the ground, desperately shaking her body to free herself from its effects.

Look out, Cat-Tra!

Before she could respond to her mentor, Sher-Va/Catra felt fingers wrap around her throat as she was lifted limply into the air. The strength of the one who held was immense, entirely beyond anything Sher-a/Catra could summon on her own—but she struggled all the same—growling and scratching to escape.

"Perhaps I will just take you, eh?" Lethe said. "Or better yet, how about I turn you? That way, the power of Sher-Va can no longer undo my beautiful works!"

Sher-Va/Catra caught sight of the white lips parting, revealing rows of black teeth; this is what Adora had described after waking from another nightmare of her turning.

"NOOO!!!!" She wailed, unable to stop the dread fate before her.

Wind tickled Sher-Va/Catra's face as she caught the dull sound of slicing flesh—after a moment of falling—found herself gazing up at He-Man/Shen holding his word in a two-hand grip, the long blade covered in glowing blood. Lethe looked incredulously at the remains of the arm which had previously held their victim; it ended just before the elbow, the other half laying near Sher-Va/Catra. She jumped to her feet when the black hand opened and closed as if to seize her once more, kicking it away with a snarl before coming to stand by He-Man/Shen's side.

"Thanks for that," Sher-Va/Catra said.

"Don't mention it," he responded, glowing blue eyes fixed on Lethe.

The mighty being did not seem too concerned about the fact they had just lost an arm; walking over to where Sher-Va/Catra had punted it, Lethe picked up their wayward limb. Purple strands of luminous ichor extended out from the stump, connecting to the proffered end of the arm, drawing it back in. With the process complete, Lethe was whole once more; they grinned as they held their arms out, opening and closing their black-stained hands almost comically. Abruptly both shot out, streaking at He-Man/Shen to seize him by the arms—as soon as they had a hold—Lethe reeled him in; a struggling Champion at the end of two long arms with the appearance of two large white rubber bands. Before Sher-Va/Catra knew it, Lethe had her friend in their embrace—He-Man/Shen struggled against their hold as Lethe smiled broadly.

"NO!" Sher-Va/Catra shrieked, thinking she knew what came next.

But instead of opening their mouth to bite, Lethe only squeezed He-Man/Shen tighter—and to Sher-Va/Catra's horror—he began to sink into their body. By rapid increments, He-Man/Shen disappeared under the porcelain surface of Lethe's skin—until only his head remained, teeth gritted in an expression of utmost outrage. Lethe simply reached up to push his head in as their body solidified, leaving no sign that her friend had ever existed.

With a snarl, Sher-Va/Catra watched as Lethe hugged themselves, eyes closed in a look of exquisite pleasure.

"Mmmmm… I can see why Veth likes this one so much…" They said, words like silk.

Lethe opened their eyes to regard the confusion on Sher-Va/Catra's face, a knowing expression on their beautiful face.

"Yes, I know my wayward child is still alive," Lethe said, their tone reprimanding. "I also know of their illicit feelings for his one,"

Lethe ran a claw tip down their chest in a manner most unseemly, making Sher-Va/Catra want to leap forward and tear her friend

out of their body. She was not the only one—everyone else present made to rush forward in defense of He-Man/Shen—holding staves, weapons, and hands out.

"*Uh, uh, uhhhh!"* They said, waving a finger. "Blast me with magic; you risk hitting your friend! Stab me with a sword, and you might kill He-Man!"

Sher-Va/Catra held up her hands to forestall the others but did not take her eyes off her enemy.

"We will get him back," she said, voice low.

Lethe laughed at this as they turned away, moving in the direction of the stygian portal from which they came.

"Sounds good, Sher-Va. Give my regards to Veth, and tell them I will take good care of their human. If you want to come and find me, I'm sure you know where to look," they said.

The massive being stepped into the inky darkness of the portal, their feet stepping almost gingerly—like they were slipping into a hot bath. As Lethe slowly disappeared under the rippling surface, Sher-Va/Catra was aware of the sense of Deja-Vu passing over her; this was the second time someone was abducted by these means—but unlike the last time—she knew exactly where He-Man/Shen was being taken.

As soon as Lethe was gone, the portal began to close—Sher-Va/Catra resisted the desire to race forward to try and slip through after them. Even if such a thing were possible, the Madgēcot Champion knew she would still need backup if she were to defeat them.

Sensing someone approaching, Sher-Va/Catra turned slightly, finding Frosta gazing forlornly up at her.

"What are we going to do, Catra?" She asked.

Sher-Va/Catra lifted her gaze toward the heavens—there—she spotted a massive globe dominating the entirety of the sky. Her feline eyes roved over its surface, taking in a geography and aspect similar to the planet she stood on.

Eternia.

“The answer is simple, Frosta.” Sher-Va/Catra said. “We go to Castle Grayskull,”

Chapter End Notes

Illustration by Henar Torinos! Check out her art by visiting ilikeyoucatradora on Instagram and Tumblr!

Lethe

Chapter Summary

> Veth, Catra, and Adora scramble to make it in time to save Shen from Castle Grayskull.
>
> The intricate layers of Lethe's psyche are peeled back, finally revealing their Achilles heel.

Blue sky streaked past the forward viewport as Darla blasted off from Bright Moon to rocket up into the ionosphere—but the silver eyes which bored through the glass did not heed such a display. These eyes were focused on a lone point, a single flickering soul flame that only they could perceive; it was far above and on the other side of the cold gulf of space, nestled within a nexus of unimaginable power.

Hang on, Shen. I'm coming. Hang on, Shen. I'm coming. Hang on, Shen. I'm coming!

The words repeated inside Veth's head ever since Catra had given them the news; Lethe had abducted Shen from Etheria—most likely for the purpose of opening the way to Subternia. They were also certain that Lethe somehow knew of Shen's special meaning to them—that taking him was done with a measure of spite. Lethe would exact their pound of flesh from the Humans in recompense for Veth's transgressions against them, and time was running out. Beginning to feel desperate and unconscious of what they were doing, Veth started gripping the edge of the sill, creating long gouges in the metal with their claws.

Hang on, Shen—please hang on!

A warm hand clasped on theirs, making Veth start; peering down at the one that touched them, Veth found Catra gazing up at them, concern evident in her feline eyes.

"It's going to be okay, Veth. There is no way Adora or I will let Lethe hurt Shen—that's a promise!" She said.

Veth sighed, giving Catra a weak smile.

"Is it that obvious that I'm more worried about him than Lethe getting their claws on Subternia?" They asked.

Catra chuckled. "Uh, yeah. You're scratching up Adora's ship worse than I usually do while repeating, '*Hang on, Shen,*'" she said.

Veth felt a mild shock at that moment—not because their feelings for the Human were so abundantly evident—but because they *did not care who knew*. Not even a little bit. All Veth wanted at that moment was to get Shen back; if they had to shout their feelings for him across the universe, then so be it.

"I never knew I could feel this way, Catra," they said, directing their gaze back through the forward viewport. "When I lost Nefeli, I was still partly under the sway of Lethe's power—it still hurt, *but nothing like this…*"

"I know, Veth. I know," Catra said, giving their hand a squeeze.

By now, faint blue had become deep black as Darla had exited Etheria's atmosphere, distant stars twinkling in the backdrop of the stage that was Eternia. It loomed before them as a prominent dark outline, the side of the planet they faced currently in its night cycle. But Veth didn't look at this, only their objective appearing as a pinpoint of light.

Not much time had been spent on making plans when Catra and the rest of Team Millennial Seagull showed up at Bright Moon with the news of what Lethe had done. Glimmer had quickly devised a proposition; the Champions board Darla to take the fight directly to Lethe while everyone else provided a distraction. The Millennial Falcon had been the first to depart Bright Moon and would soon be landing outside Castle Grayskull, drawing most of the enemy away to allow quick access for the Champions to do their work.

What they planned to do once they faced Lethe, Veth was not sure—hopefully—some weakness or flaw made itself known, allowing victory for the forces of good.

VETH, YOU MUST FINISH THE VISION

Veth shook their head—not out of surprise—but out of annoyance.

There is no time for your foolishness—whoever you are. Lethe is close to enacting their master plan—I can't just dither here and let them get away with it!

FOOLISHNESS, YOU SAY? FOOLISHNESS IS FACING LETHE WITHOUT A PLAN TO DEFEAT THEM. THAT IS WHAT I'M TRYING TO SHOW YOU. BESIDES, TIME IS SUBJECTIVE IN THE COGNIZANCE OF ZHE-LA. WE HAVE PLENTY OF IT

The long and weary sigh which left Veth's lips gained Catra's attention, making her long ears perk up.

"What is it? Your weird Nephraeh senses picking up some new problem?" She asked.

Veth shook their head. "No, Catra. It's that voice I told you about—the *Other*. It wants me to see that horrible vision. The one where you believe Kishar kills Jihan."

Catra suddenly had a strange faraway look in her heterochromatic eyes, as if she were listening to something only she could hear. When her focus returned, there was excitement plastered on her cinnamon face.

"You should listen to it!" She exclaimed, gripping Veth's hands tightly.

LISTEN TO THE MADGECOT, VETH. BETTER YET, YOU SHOULD JOIN WITH HER AND THE HUMAN WOMAN, ADORA, FORMING THE COMMUNION. BY DOING SO, YOU

CAN ALL BEAR WITNESS TO THE MEMORY OF ZHE-LA SIMULTANEOUSLY

"What's it saying, Veth? The *other voice* or whatever," Catra asked.

"That you, me, and Adora should join and form something called the Communion. That way, we can all see this vision." Veth said uncertainly.

Catra cocked her head, the same distant look in her eyes.

"Well, the voice in *my* head says we should listen to the voice in *your* head—I can't believe I just said that!" She said.

Veth couldn't help chuckling at Catra's droll behavior, instantly knowing it was Jihan she was referring to. They nodded.

"Something tells me we should get my *Other* together with your Jihan—perhaps they have something to say to one another?" They said.

Catra turned to Adora, currently sitting on Darla's command throne and steering the ship by using the holographic navigational orb floating before her.

"Hey, Adora. Come over here so Veth can do some weird Nephraeh thing to us; they need us to join with them so we can watch some dusty old memory. It's about ancient history—you'll love it!" She said.

"Darla. Continue course on autopilot," Adora said as she rose from the command throne to make her way over to Veth and Catra.

"What's this about?" She asked, confusion plain in her voice.

"Remember the voice I told you about? The one that has been helping me remember forgotten parts of myself? Well—" Veth started to say.

"Never mind," Adora interrupted, holding up a hand. "It sounds like a long explanation, and we don't have the time. Anyway, I trust you—let's just do it."

Veth experienced joy at the admission of Adora's faith in them and the realization that the reversal of her mistrust was all due to their new abilities—summoning and manipulating Light. Among its many uses, this wondrous manifestation of pure love communicated one being's intentions to another in the most direct way possible—through the joining of quintessences. Veth discerned this was also the key to forming the Communion the *Other* spoke of—they just hoped the two women were open to it.

"So, Adora is a little familiar with what I am about to do… um…" Veth said uncertainly.

Catra and Adora shared a look before nodding to one another; grasping the other's hand, each woman held out an open palm to the Nephraeh, surprising them. Without saying another word, Veth took their fellow Champion's hands in theirs, forming a circle.

"Now, close your eyes. Relax. Focus on your breathing…yes… that's it…" Veth said.

Since their souls were already acquainted, Veth reached out for Adora first; they brushed up against her essence as in a kind of greeting. During the alleviation sessions, Veth would do this before going any further—but when they did finally meld their quintessence to hers, it was usually just partially, like dipping a toe under the surface of a pool.

This time, Veth pushed in farther—slowly, yet steadily—all the while aware that their consciousness was being subsumed into Adora's. Entire swathes of memory and physical experiences were becoming known to Veth, and they could feel the same thing happening to Adora as she was combined with them. They remembered growing up in the Horde, training hard in order to be considered suitable material to be a cadet, then working even harder to attain the rank of Force Captain. They also recalled

growing up Nephraeh—being indoctrinated into the Eduba to rise through the level of Tetrad and Decad—then being personally selected by Archon Lethe to become part of the Shub-Lugal. Soon, the distinctions between the two individuals became so hard to differentiate that—

Veth/Adora reached out to Catra next, unsure why they didn't start with her first—*didn't they know her so well?* After all, they grew up together, fought on separate sides of a war, fell in love, and got married. But then, didn't they betray her and use her against… *themselves*?

As Veth/Adora melded with Catra, they became faintly aware that she was not alone—someone else was within her, hidden and tucked away within her aspect. The more and more this passenger became a part of them, Veth/Adora realized there had been someone within *them* as well—this entity was reacting to the presence of the other, drawn together like two opposite halves to create—

The amalgamation of five different entities was complete as the Communion turned their attention to the task at hand—witnessing the moment Kishar became Lethe. The Communion already knew the story, for they had lived it—but it was essential to replay it in their psyche so the other parts of themselves could experience it. The Communion understood that they once thought this memory resided within the essence of Zhe-La—but that was not true—this was *their* memory.

The scene replayed as before—their murder of innocents to fuel the Apogeon Ritual and the confrontation with Jihan soon after. The Communion felt an odd dissociation at this part, simultaneously experiencing being the murderer and victim in one moment of pure horror. After that, the beginning of their ascension and—

—crashing back onto the ground, sword clattering next to him as a red pool spreads out around him, his life seeping away. For the last time, Sher-Va/Jihan reverts out of his Champion form; the

Avatar spirit fluttering out between his lips to find sanctuary within the Power Sword. Jihan looks sad as he gazes at them; the fool still appears concerned for them even after they have just killed him.

Abruptly, anxiety courses through them as tugging yanks at their innards—

YOU HAVE TAKEN MY LOVE—MY JIHAN. I WILL SEE YOU FAIL

—incredulous, they realize it is their connection to Zhe-La—it is failing! The Champion Spirit has tried to reject them in the past, but every time they thwarted its attempt to leave; it seems that this time, with the betrayal and murder of their erstwhile lover, Zhe-La has the grounds to sever their bond. If they do not act fast, all will be lost. They cannot ascend to greatness without the power base that is a Champion of Grayskull—they must complete the ritual—now!

Sitting cross-legged, they form their hands into the precise arrangement needed to align the transcendental strands of the Apogean Ritual into the complex pattern required to attain their final ascension. They work fast, performing the Formulae of Consummation within their intricate mind—they are so close! They can feel the very cells of their body vibrating at the frequency of infinity, losing their corporeality as they become something more —something divine. They are becoming so much more now; their senses have increased beyond the six all Nephraeh have—into experiences beyond that of a mere mortal. They can now hear the spirit of Zhe-La screaming as it drags along with them—an unwilling passenger to apotheosis. With a final screech that they can feel against the ectoplasm of their quintessence—Zhe-La shears their bond—veering away from their meteoric rise and escaping into the nether regions.

It is no matter. Zhe-La served its purpose; they no longer need it to complete the ritual. There is only the unrestricted potential and boundless possibilities before them; there was—

YOUR REIGN

—wait—

ENDS NOW

—they feel the Apogean Ritual has peaked as its vigor recedes—minutely at first—but then rapidly. They feel the dream of absolute power fading into the background nothingness of ambiguity; the souring taste of their approaching ignominy makes them want to scream at the unfairness of the uncaring cosmos—that a magnificent being such as themselves is somehow kept from what is rightfully theirs. How is it possible—

YOU KNOW WHY

They realize then why the ritual is failing. They may not have beheld what is behind the veil of their self-deception, but they somehow know. This knowledge is keeping them from attaining godhood, and it is quite insidious in its simplicity, hitting them with a hammer-blow force of crushing realization…

…the Shlihm-bess'a-rune had not removed their compassion…

…it has always been there, only forgotten…

…they still love Jiahn…

…and had just murdered him…

Complete and total anguish fills their entire being, accelerating their plummet toward insignificance. Quickly, they seize the aspect of what the Shlihm-bess'a-rune had done to them, using their slowly dwindling might to fashion it into the exemplification of the god they wish to be.

They will not be the god of apathy nor narcissism; there is only one way to banish the pain which threatens to overwhelm them completely…

…they must forget…

…they must reach a state of…

*…**Oblivion**…*

With their new course set, they frantically use their newfound ability to remove the parts of their memory which inhibit their transformation. Piece by piece, they forget their compassion once more, their pity, their forgiveness—every virtuous part of who they are. They forget the honor they felt as a Champion and what it means to be a Nephraeh and to serve the Light. They forget friendship and love—

They completely erase Jihan from their memory.

As they shed these parts of themselves, they begin to rise once more—like a balloon shedding weight—floating back into the grand expanse of unbound capabilities. They are so close to the peak—yet—they cannot gain the equivalent of sanctity. It is too late, the ritual has burned itself out, and they are left at the crest and unable to repeat the process, for they had excised the exact method required to repeat the ritual.

It is no great matter, for they still exist and are more powerful than they had ever been. They take themselves in, discovering that they are completely nude, having burned away their garments during the transformation. They are at a much greater perspective—taller, bigger—they are now a giant, much more substantial than they were in their Zhe-La form. The blood is gone from their hands, but a black staining has taken its place—this appeals to them—a reminder of what they were willing to do in order to become more.

Taking in the chamber dedicated to Zhe-La, they make out that where once Nephraeh corpses had been, strange bulbous forms have taken their place—all the rest of the bodies had been burned away. They crouch near one of these odd forms, running a claw

tip over its glistening surface—something shudders within—responding to their touch.

"Kishar?" A voice calls, drawing them out of their inspection of the fleshy sac.

Drawing themselves back to their full height, they turn to regard the newcomer, noting that they are entirely covered in a dark robe. A harsh looking, scaly face peers out at them from under the cowl; it is a female Ophidian whom they immediately recognize—not by the arrangement of her features, but by the fact she bares the Void Gem staff in her right hand.

"Ah! Dinala Katan! How interesting that I run into you here!" They say in greeting.

The Bearer of the Void gem's reptilian eyes goes wide as she takes their new body in, raising her staff in a threatening manner towards them.

"What in the name of Grayskull have you done? Where is—"

Dinala's eyes fix on the floor; looking in that direction, they spot a charred skeleton—a long chain of bones projects from the rear pelvis, indicating that whoever this was had a tail. Next to these grisly remains lies an ornate power sword; the green gemstone and style suggest that it had belonged to the bearer of Sher-Va. They search their memory for the name of this Champion but are unable to summon a face.

"I can't believe you killed him! I mean, you saved me the trouble of doing it myself—but he was your soulmate!" She says incredulously.

They are immediately filled with confusion. "Who are you talking about? Soulmate?"

*"Have you lost your mind?" Dinala asks, pointing at the skeleton. "That was *****!"*

The name Dinala associates with the body comes out as garbled nonsense; they are getting annoyed now.

"I have no idea what you are talking about, Dinala Katan, and I don't care. I suggest you leave me before something bad happens to you. I will allow it even though you attempted to destroy me on Omiros,"

They say this in a gracious manner, but their magnanimity stems from uncertainty; they have no idea how powerful they are—even more importantly—if they could beat the bearer of the Void Gem in a fight. They soon discover they have no choice in the matter as Dinala Katan leers at them, exposing double rows of serrated teeth.

"I don't think so—Kishar," she spits, raising her staff. A dull red glow emanates from deep within the Void Gem, appearing like a glowing ember. Before she can summon the destructive power, they instinctively reach out—simultaneously feeling an immense surge of magic within them. They had never felt it's like before, easily surpassing any magical power they could summon as Zhe-La. Great gouts of a violet conflagration spew forth from their fingertips, enveloping the Bearer of the Void gem in a twisting funnel of devouring fire. They perceive this new ability coming not from any outside source but from the indifference within them; an everlasting black hole of immense apathy without limit. By the expression of absolute terror on Dinala's face as she tries vainly to fight against their might, they can tell she feels it too.

They laugh at their earlier hesitation—they were so far beyond her paltry capabilities—they have outstripped any limitations they might have once had. They might not have reached the level of godhood, but they are so close that they might as well have.

"You are lucky, my dear." They say, watching as Dinala's body begins to disintegrate. "You are present at the birth of a new being!"

The bearer of the Void Gem collapses to her hands and knees, no more than a skeleton now but somehow still alive, her jaws open in a soundless scream.

"As a new being, I have shed my past existence—including my name!" They say, searching their memory for inspiration. Their mind takes them to a recollection of ancient myth, to a being who had been the personification of shedding all memory—of Oblivion.

"I am no longer Kishar… from now on, I shall be known as ***Lethe!*** *For that is who I am!" They shout. But Dinala Katan does not hear them; her remains have already collapsed to the floor, her spirit fleeing to the nether regions beyond all realities.*

They look at the Void Gem staff lying next to her corpse, taking a moment to ponder whether or not they will take the Ultimate Power for themselves. They dismiss this notion immediately—what need do they have for it? They are beyond any Ultimate Power.

YOU ARE SO ARROGANT AND BLIND. AS LONG AS I REMEMBER, YOU WILL NEVER FORGET. YOU CAN NOT ESCAPE ME

They recognize the niggling doubt tickling at their hindbrain—it is an aspect of Kishar that had somehow escaped the purge.

YES, IT IS ME—KISHAR! I AM NOT SOME MEMORY THAT YOU CAN FORGET—I AM YOU! I WILL ALWAYS BE A PART OF YOU

They summon all of their newfound power and channel it inward, burning through their body to locate this hidden aspect of themselves. It is a painful process, but the last scrap of Kishar is easily expunged, for it is Lethe's domain now—but still, they feel it.

FOOLISH LETHE, YOU ARE THINKING SO ONE-DIMENSIONALLY

They focus on their spirit now, pursuing the essence of Kishar through the spectral corridors of their soul like a hound following a scent. They chase Kishar to a dead end—the epicenter of their quintessence—the central chakra in which all other parts of their being spring forth. They push and drive into this unwanted kernel, trying to smother it with the ardor of Lethe's disregard.

YOU… CANNOT… DESTROY… ME… WITHOUT… DESTROYING… YOURSELF

They abandon their attempts at eradication, instead focusing on containment. Digging deep, they construct walls of cold dispassion, sealing away this last shred of Kishar in a prison of detachment. They feel a great sense of relief as the echo dwindles, but this solace is forever soured by the knowledge that their undoing lies within the core of their soul.

YOU WILL NEVER GET RID OF ME! I AM ALWAYS GOING TO BE A PAR—

Veth jolted back into themselves and out of the Communion, feeling mildly stunned at what they had just experienced. Catra and Adora are likewise disoriented, both women gaping at one another, their expressions haunted.

I'M SORRY, VETH. THAT IS THE LIMIT OF MY MEMORY

Veth blinked as the voice spoke in their head, rapidly replaying the scene of Lethe's birth as they assembled the pieces of the other's identity.

You are the last piece of Kishar, aren't you ? They think.

YES. I AM.

So, you are a part of Lethe that has been secretly helping me so I can defeat them? That is quite the paradox, Veth continued.

I TOLD YOU IT WAS COMPLICATED. BUT EXPERIENCING MY MEMORIES UP UNTIL THE POINT LETHE IMPRISONED

ME WAS THE ONLY WAY YOU WOULD TRULY UNDERSTAND. NOW, ALL OF YOU HAVE THE MEANS TO DEFEAT LETHE AND BRING ME BACK

Veth brought their attention back to their companions; besides being dazed, both women had a rosy tinge to their cheeks, gazing at each other with hunger in their eyes.

"Are you two okay?" Veth asked. "That was an intense experience—I'm sure being bombarded with the emotions of two different Nephraeh is something not many could prepare for,"

Catra turned to regard Veth, appearing as if she just noticed them.

" Wow… Veth… is that how you feel all the time?" She said in a husky whisper.

They favor Catra with a small smile, briefly running their claws through their hair.

"Since getting my empathy back, yes," they said with a chuckle.

Adora exhaled loudly and closed her eyes—Veth recognized the Nephraeh mediation techniques they had shown her and was sure she was repeating the Mantra of Mu in her head.

"Right," she exclaimed, finishing the quick calming technique and taking her place on the pilot's throne once more. "On to business. Darla—autopilot off,"

Catra looked incredulously at her wife. "That's it? Aren't we going to discuss what we just witnessed? Make a plan or something?" She said, hands raised.

Adora waved her hand over the navigation sphere as Darla began to respond to her commands; through the forward viewport, Veth could observe that they were approaching Eternia's atmosphere. From around the edge of the planet's Karman line, Veth could

make out the metallic glint of hostile spacecraft coming to intercept their course.

"We don't have time for that, Catra," Adora said. "I think we will just have to play it by ear—hopefully, the solution will come to us!"

Veth noticed that Catra was about to respond but stopped, cocking her head as if listening. Having experienced the female Madgēcot's existence through the Communion, Veth had an inkling of what this curious behavior indicated.

* * *

Cat-Tra, I think our course of action is rather obvious, Jihan stated in a self-evident manner. Catra wanted to roll her eyes.

And what is that, oh wise and beneficent Master? Please educate the young and dumb with your sage knowledge, Catra shot back.

"What is Jihan saying?" Veth asked, startling her. Catra peered at the Nephraeh, her confusion at their shrewdness vanishing with the recollection of the Communion.

"I was about to find out—please don't interrupt me while speaking with the voice in my head!" Catra said, waving Veth away to focus on Jihan.

As you were saying?

In the vision of Kishar's transformation into Lethe—we saw how they did not attain godhood! This is good news! Jiahn said.

Yes, it's soooo great, Jihan. They aren't a god, but they are still strong enough to fry the bearer of the Void Gem with a wave of their hand. Hooray!

Sarcasm is not a good trait for a Madgēcot, young one. Yes, they are still powerful, but we know their weakness; my Kishar still exist within them! All we need to do is use the power of Truth and make them see!

Darla suddenly rocked as the ship's shields deflected fire from the enemy craft; Adora gritted her teeth as she maneuvered out of harm's way while maintaining their course. She was refraining from using Darla's formidable weaponry to fight back; most likely, the fighters were piloted by members of the Etherian Star Force, enervated against their will.

Catra's thoughts steered back to Jihan's words—using Sher-Va's power of truth on Lethe—the idea was not an appealing one. Sure, it could work, that's how she defeated Despara—but there were consequences for that victory, namely Catra's near-death. She did not think it would be any less likely on a Nephraeh Demi-God.

But if it were the only course of action, Catra would do it; she would be saving countless lives from a fate worse than death and making right a wrong that had been set in motion a thousand years before she was ever born. Finally, Catra would be fulfilling her promise to Jihan; by bringing back Kishar, the two of them could be reunited once more; their souls being allowed to transition to the subsequent phases of their existence.

All she had to do was risk dying again.

"Catra? What is the matter? I see a great amount of resolve mixed with sadness in your quintessence. What are you going to do?" Veth said, concern plain in their voice.

Just as she was about to dismiss the Nephraeh's concern, Catra spotted a glint in their silver eyes—there was no point in denying what she knew they had identified with their Nephraeh sight.

"What I always do, Veth. I do whatever is necessary to get the job done," she answered, voice flat and without emotion.

Veth shook their head, the expression full of Nephraeh exasperation.

"I see the same need to bear the entire burden on your shoulders in your soul as a certain bone-headed human has—tell me this plan you and Jihan cooked up." They said.

An abrupt impact against Darla's hull sent Catra reeling—before she could smack her head against the floor—Veth was there, lifting Catra to her feet with a firm grip.

"You're not in this alone," they said.

Catra saw the deep black of space slowly vanish as it was replaced by sky; instead of the blue of Etheria, this expanse had an orange tinge—like copper. A vast, rugged plain spread out below them, reminding Catra of the Crimson Waste. Darla careened downward before flattening out, Adora directing the ship to follow a chasm that zigzagged along the terrain—appearing like a mighty rent in the rocky ground.

"Jihan said that Sher-Va's truth should work on Lethe—to make them remember who they once were. I agree with him—it might work. I've done it in the past," she said, unconsciously resting her hand above her belly—the place where Despara had cut her. The meaning was not lost on Veth as they placed their hand gently over hers.

"Yes, I know the story, and I'm sorry you had to do that. It was all my fault," they said sorrowfully. "But I will be by your side this time—and so will Adora!"

A fierce look crossed Veth's lilac features, the like of which Catra had never witnessed before.

"Catra. I swear by every fiber of my being that Shen will be there too—four Champions of Grayskull, standing together! Surely that is enough to overcome Lethe and bring back Kishar without the need to sacrifice yourself?" they said.

The Nephraeh is right, Cat-Tra. You have become dear to me, young one. If the choice comes between sacrificing yourself or banishing Lethe to the nether regions—choose the latter. I will not hold you to your oath.

Immense gratitude filled Catra's heart as she turned from Veth to stare out through the forward viewport. A greenish speck was slowly coming into view, situated at the end of the meandering crack they were following. Squinting with her enhanced feline sight, Catra could barely make out an open-mouthed skull—the timeless visage of Castle Grayskull. Just forward of their destination, a great battle was taking place; the bright flashes of magic being expended was unmistakable. It was her friends from the Millennial Falcon, drawing out the defenders to clear the way for the Champions. There were many people whom she cared about placing their lives on the line to hold back—she would see this to the end no matter what.

"I appreciate all your support, guys—I really do," she said meaningfully to Veth and Jihan.

"But a promise is a promise,"

The Battle of Grayskull

Chapter Summary

Shen awakes to find himself in Lethe's clutches.

Adora, Catra, and Veth race to Grayskull, hoping to stop the approaching doom of entire realities.

Glimmer and company face the wrath of Lethe's assembled army, unaware that evil has a surprise.

The end is near.

Shen regained consciousness, becoming aware of something soft and wet gently brushing against his cheek.

"Battle Cat?" He mumbled. "*I told you not to wake me up with licks,"*

When he finally opened his eyes, Shen perceived not a large Ethyriel before him but the kind countenance of Perfuma peering into his face.

"Hey there." She said, dipping a cloth in a nearby bucket. "I was wondering if you were going to come back to us or not,"

Completely aware now, Shen sensed that he was held vertically against an uncomfortable hard surface—trying to adjust himself—he quickly discovered that his arms and legs were held in place. Looking down at this body, Shen noted that his forearms, shins, and torso were encased in fine translucent substance—testing the strength of these restrictions—found he could not make them budge.

"Please just stay calm, Shen; I will try and help you—" Perfuma started to say.

"BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!!!"

An unbearable spasm lanced through Shen's body as the magic of He-Man reached into him—just as he thought the agony would become fatal—the Champion spirit withdrew, sparing his life. Shen sagged against his restraints but was unbowed; it would take much more than pain to make him give up.

"Shen, please don't do that again!" Perfuma said, placing a calming hand on his face. "Lethe has placed wards over you to keep you from summoning He-Man!"

Squinting through strands of dark hair, Shen took in his surroundings; it was an immense cavern, the walls lined with glittering crystals of various sizes, reminding Shen of the inside of a geode. Six milky white pillars fanned around him in a circle, making Shen realize he must be attached to a seventh. Bizarre script was scrawled over three of these pylons, the sight of which made Shen feel uneasy. By the pylons not marred by the corrupted writing stood the Vetala—the wretched creatures watching the bearer of He-Man with eyes black as the void.

"Where am I?" He asked Perfuma.

"In the Vestibule—Lethe brought you here not too long ago. Listen, I am going to do my best to help—"

"Is our guest awake?" A powerful and genderless voice interrupted, immediately making Perfuma close her mouth and back away.

Shen was not surprised when the form of Lethe strode into view from behind him, the immense Nephraeh boring into him with bright indigo eyes. They stopped a short distance away to grin at Shen, revealing hideous rows of onyx teeth.

"How are you feeling, my dear Shen? I hope not too bad after I had to… *detain* you," they stated.

Within his bindings, Shen gave a lame attempt at a shrug.

"It's been a while since someone absorbed me into their body—but overall, it was okay," he said.

The black smile widened at this, showing genuine mirth.

"Hmm… I can see why Veth likes you so much—*such a funny Human,*" they stated, reaching out to brush razor-sharp claws against Shen's face. They felt like icicles, making him try to twist away from their freezing bite.

"What is the matter? You don't like me?" Lethe purred. "I can assure you; I may be more than I once was, but I'm still Nephraeh where it counts,"

The mighty being leered lasciviously at Shen, their meaning quite obvious.

"I'm not going to help you get into Subternia, Lethe," Shen hissed. "I would rather die,"

Lethe made a pouty face at this but did not seem too concerned or surprised by his defiance.

"Oh… there is no need for that! I will not have you hurt; after all, there is no benefit for me—soon, I will be a god and a very hungry one at that! I'm going to need you added to my countless worshippers! No, dear Shen, you will do what I need without that," they said.

Considering the rows of jagged obsidian shards between Lethe's two white lips, Shen grimaced, thinking he understood their meaning.

"So, you are going to bite me? You are going to take away my empathy and make me one of your slaves?" He asked.

A strange expression crosses over Lethe's beautiful porcelain features, an impression that bordered on mournfulness. They again reached for Shen, but instead of touching him with their

claws, they cupped his face fully with one hand. Lethe brushed his lips gently with a thumb, their own parted in expectation.

"I… don't want to do that," they said in a dreamy whisper. "I think… I think *they* might love you—don't you see? You do as well. How… how can I ruin that? It—"

Lethe withdrew their hand to place it upon their chest, appearing as if they would weep.

"Sometimes I feel like I can almost… *imagine* what love is… *like*… a dream you think you may have had but cannot fully remember. I am not sure…" they continued, squinting their lambent eyes.

Lifting one of their black hands, Lethe held it open next to their head as if to scratch an itch.

"It hurts when I can almost taste it—*oh, it hurts*. I feel like a dam is inside me, holding back a great sea of infinite sorrow—it's all I can do to forget it!" Lethe said, seething.

Shen glanced at Perfuma; she was staring at Lethe with a mixture of horror and sadness on her face—when she caught his eye—the Princess of Plumeria gave him a minute shake of the head, its meaning clear.

Don't push this.

"If you want to experience love again, Lethe, why are you doing this? If I understand what you are trying to do—you want to get into Subternia, giving you access to infinite realities. You are going to… *feed*… on all the people in these realities and take away their empathy. Without that, there will be no more compassion. No more kindness. No more love. Is that what you really want?" Shen implored.

Lethe studied the bearer of He-Man intently, their expression unreadable—much like Veth's. But after a moment, they began to nod their head—very slowly.

"Yes, Shen, I want this. You see, it's the only way to be truly free. By fully embracing my nature, I will delve so fully into absolute apathy that not even the faintest echo of the memory of love will ever touch me. Don't you see? It's the only way," they said, words of absolute sincerity.

"I don't understand," Shen said, shaking his head. "You talk about not wanting to ruin my love and then turn around and—"

"SHUT UP!!!!" Lethe suddenly screamed. They lunged forward to seize Shen's jaw in one hand, their face screwed up in a look of total wrath. "I don't have to explain myself to you, insolent worm!"

The strength of the giant Nephraeh's grip was unreal; feeling his jaw begin to dislocate, Shen screamed. Just as he thought Lethe was about to pull his head off, Perfuma stepped in, placing calming hands on their wrist.

"Please stop; if you kill him, you will have to bond He-Man's avatar to another Vetala. You don't have the time for that—right?" She said.

The anger subsided on Lethe's face as Perfuma's words seemed to calm them—they yanked their hand away from Shen's face, leaving small cuts from their long claws.

"It would be better if I were dead than help this monster!" Shen yelled at his friend.

Lethe regarded the restrained figure before them, seeming to perceive him in a new light.

"You were goading me? Trying to get me to kill you?" They asked.

"Well, I was trying to talk some sense into you—barring that—yes, that was my backup plan," Shen said.

Lethe stood straight and tossed their mane of long white hair, then turned to regard Perfuma.

“Thank you for stopping me, my dear.” They said before turning and clapping their hands. “Everyone to their places! We begin the ritual at once!”

A flurry of activity proceeded Lethe’s pronouncement as enervated minions scurried to enact the orders, taking positions outside the ring of pylons to begin the sonorous chant. The three altered Vetala placed black hands upon their respective pylons, each pillar alighting with activation as they sensed their matching Champion Avatar.

“Shen, I am the bearer of the Life Gem and your friend; I was not going to just stand by and let you die,” Perfuma said, placing a hand on his face. “On top of that, I sense our allies approaching. They will be here soon—we still have time!”

Letting out a long weary breath, Shen sagged against his restraints and nodded.

“I hope you’re right,” he said, watching Lethe take their place in the circle's center.

“Because if you’re not, we just missed our chance to stop an apocalypse on an inter-dimensional scale.”

* * *

Glimmer surveyed the expanse of rocky waste before her; from the light of three of the twelve moons Etheria shared with Eternia, she could make out the multitude of foes rushing out to meet them. Based on the fact that many of them absorbed the weak light, Glimmer knew that they were about to face Vetala—but since this was Castle Grayskull they were facing, she also knew that there could be other unknown horrors dug up from the dungeons, sent forth to assail them.

“Do you think we should have parked my baby a little farther away?” Seahawk whined nearby.

Glimmer cast a backward glance at the Millennial Seagull sitting upon a nearby stone outcrop; they had barely enough time to disembark from the craft before a great horn sounded, alerting the enemy of their presence.

"It's okay, *sweetie*," Mermista crooned. "If something happens to it, I will just buy you a new one,"

Glimmer was having difficulty reconciling this new version of her friend with the pre-enervated Mermista; it seemed like she was overcompensating for how she had treated Seahawk. But then Glimmer shrugged; what did she know? Perhaps she would be dotting on Bow if her and Mermista's situations had been reversed.

"Okay, people, it's showtime. Get your game faces on," she said, raising the Star Stone.

To her left, Bow notched an arrow as Seahawk withdrew his laser sword—next to him, Mermista raised her own Ultimate Power—The Kinetic Krystal. Double Trouble summoned a great orb of Chaos magic as Panga crouched nearby, claws at the ready. Glimmer's father and aunt were not far from the Madgēcot and Imp, preparing their own incantations while Orko removed his wand, aiming it in the direction of the enemy.

To Glimmer's right, Hordak readied his recently repaired hand cannon as Frosta summoned ice armor to cover her body, two large icicles forming over her hands like swords. As this was happening, Entrapta opened a panel on Emily's side, pressing a great red button there—instantly, the Horde Bot disassembled and began to rearrange herself—her round body becoming larger, the trapezoidal eye wider. Her spindly legs merged to form two more robust ones as a pair of arms unfolded at either side of the body. When the transformation was complete, a mech suit stood in the place of the Horde Bot, the forward portions opening up to allow Entrapta to climb inside.

“I figured that it was easier to modify Emily than rebuild Linda II! Pretty neat, right?” Entrapta said as the hatch closed over her.

Glimmer grinned as she caught sight of the Princess of Dryl waving from behind the purple viewport, overjoyed to be once again ensconced within one of her creations.

Rounding off the team was Spinnerella and Netossa, both of the Etherian Princesses readying their unique powers in preparation for the battle ahead.

Glimmer felt a swell of confidence within her chest; she had so many old friends by her side mixed with new ones from across space and time. United with the enhanced might of three Ultimate Powers, she was sure they would not only provide the distraction Catra, Adora, and Veth needed but also utterly smash whatever Lethe threw their way.

Now that the throng was closer, Glimmer could discern that her earlier assertions were correct—countless Vetala bounded towards them. But amongst these foul creatures, Glimmer spied odd flapping shapes gliding over the ground like great black bats. Upon closer inspection, she noted that it was not the fluttering wings she had seen but voluminous robes billowing in the wind. No face could be discerned beneath the raised hood, but Glimmer had a strange feeling she had faced these foes in the past.

“Are those Death Binders?” Bow asked in a hushed whisper.

Glimmer grimaced. “That’s not possible… right? We destroyed the Set’Heth-un’dar; all the Death Binders are gone,”

Her frown deepened when Glimmer spotted two of the robed figures holding a great red chest between them, bearing this mysterious bundle towards the trespassers with great alacrity.

“Okay, everyone, hold… hold… HOLLLDDD…” Glimmer called, waiting for the opportune moment when the enemy was in the perfect killing range. Under the sound of hundreds of feet pounding on the rocky ground, Glimmer could hear a dread

clicking—it was the sound of teeth gnashing in excitement, readying to sink into living flesh.

"NOW!!!" She screamed, directing a blazing intense beam of Star Fire into the first line of attackers. A score of Vetala were vaporized into a howling black cloud as more took their place, streaking forward with claws extended. They were soon met by an assortment of magical and technological attacks as the others added their own abilities to Glimmer's.

A laser blast from Hordak's weapon sent the black monsters soaring as twin tornados summoned by Spinnerella dispersed any cohesion the creatures may have had. Double Trouble languidly hurled their chaos magic into the oncoming masses, transmuting whole swaths of Vetala into flowers, bouncing balls, butterflies, or any other seemingly random harmless objects. Rounding out the line of long-distance capabilities was Frosta, summoning jagged ice shards to shred the forward line of enemies.

But Lethe's minions were not without their own skill in range tactics. Glimmer watched as Vetala pulled gobs of an oily substance from their bodies, forming them into long javelins to hurl back at her friends. Most of these were blocked by Netossa using her nets in a defensive capacity, while the rest were shot down by the Emily Mech Suit. It was a careful balance right up until the real threats appeared; landing softly on booted feet, the robed figures entered the fray. Glimmer's heart leaped into her throat as she finally glimpsed pale faces under dark hoods, eyes sealed closed and sightless.

"No…" She gasped. "It can't be… *how?"*

The Death Binders raised skeletal hands to illuminate the battlefield with unnatural ghost light—right away—the Vetala flocked to this radiance like moths to the flame. They writhed and screeched as they basked in the mortiferous power of the Death Binders, their undead bodies becoming enhanced; they began to grow, gaining longer and more powerful limbs. Sharp claws

became great talons; their previously void black eyes now glowed with the power of Death.

"Well, that's not good," quipped Netossa.

The low thrum of a starship's engines buzzed overhead—looking up—Glimmer spotted Darla soaring straight towards Castle Grayskull. Turning back to the new threat she and the others now faced, Glimmer suddenly felt no longer confident about their chances. She sincerely hoped the distraction they created was worth it, for if Adora and the others did not stop Lethe, it seemed unlikely that those who came to Eternia aboard the Millennia Seagull would survive for much longer.

* * *

Darla's embarkation ramp deployed with a hiss of escaping air, and before She-Ra/Adora could stop them, Zhe-La/Veth was rushing down it headlong into unknown danger.

"Wait up, Veth! Slow down!" She called, hurrying after the anxious Nephraeh Champion.

Sher-Va/Catra bounded past She-Ra/Adora on all fours, rising to her feet to place a hand on Zhe-La/Veth's shoulder.

"Easy, now! Easy, Veth! We need to do this together!" She said, voice understanding yet firm.

Zhe-La/Veth brushed away the restraining hand yet slowed their pace, eyeing the closed drawbridge barring their way with angry silver eyes.

"Fine, Catra." They said, voice strained. "I think I'm going to need your help to get this door open, anyway,"

She-Ra/Adora looked askance at the battle taking place behind them; the eerie glow mixed with unearthly howls made her skin crawl—instantly making her want to turn around and help her friends.

No, Glimmer and the rest have got this. We need to stop Lethe, she thought.

"Adora! Come give us a hand with this!" Sher-Va/Catra called.

Joining the other two Champions, She-Ra/Adora gazed up at the massive door that formed the 'mouth' of the gaping skull that adorned the front of the castle. It appeared to be composed of think wooden planks held together by heavy metal battens, but she doubted this was actually the case. A thought occurred to her as She-Ra/Adora regarded this obstruction, one that she quickly voiced.

"Guys, we are the Champions of Grayskull, right? I mean, it's in all our activation phrases and everything—*By the honor of Grayskull!* —and so forth. So! Since this is *thee* Castle Grayskull, isn't it like our place? Why don't we just ask it to open?"

Sher-Va/Catra cocked her head at Zhe-La/Veth, who just shrugged in return.

"Give it a shot," they said.

She-Ra/Adora stood erect as she cleared her throat; after taking a moment to think of what to say, she looked directly into the empty sockets of the skull and spoke.

"I, Adora, daughter of Etheria, wife to Catra, bearer of She-Ra, do humbly request that the domain of Castle Grayskull do henceforth open itself to us—the purpose being—so that we may enter and exorcise the evil that has taken root within you. If we cannot achieve this noble task, then the entirety of all simultaneously existing existences will plummet into everlasting darkness from which there is no return for all time, forever and ever. Please open!" she said, finishing with a loud exhalation of breath.

An awkward beat proceeded She-Ra/Adora's entreaty as her companions regarded her with skepticism—but then a rumbling began to emanate from deep within the castle—shaking the very ground upon which they all stood. With a creak of shifting weight,

the massive door began to tilt forward from the top as it was lowered on rattling chains, slowly revealing the gaping stygian gullet that was the entrance to Castle Grayskull. With a booming crunch, the drawbridge was fully extended, opening the way to the Champions of Grayskull.

Sher-Va/Catra turned to Zhe-La/Veth, a smug grin on her cinnamon face.

"Aren't you always giving us grief about not knowing history? How come you didn't know about that? You being the smarty pants Nephraeh, and all," she said.

Zhe-La/Veth scowled back at the Madgēcot Champion; they were not in the mood for frivolity.

"I'm not exactly thinking straight, Catra—give me a break," they said, striding towards the castle.

She-Ra/Adora blew her wife a kiss before placing her hand in Sher-Va/Catra's golden gauntlet.

"You ready for this, Catra?" She asked.

"As I said before—of course, I'm going with you, dummy," Sher-Va/Catra said with a grin.

And with that, She-Ra/Adora and Sher-Va/Catra strode towards Castle Grayskull, hand in hand, quickly passing within.

* * *

Perfuma watched as Shen wrenched his face away from the brush as it came for his face—but the enervated acolyte would not be deterred; nodding to two of his fellows, they stepped in to seize either side of their victim's face, holding it still. Shen growled in fury as a lambent indigo substance was daubed on his bare skin—right before screaming in pain.

"Stop it!!!" Perfuma screamed, not able to help herself.

At a nod from Lethe, two strong arms wrapped themselves around Perfuma, holding the Princess fast before she could rush to her friend's aid.

"Don't be so emotional," Scorpia growled as Perfuma struggled.

Sagging in her girlfriend's arms, Perfuma noticed Shen had passed out from the effects of the Antithetical Philter, its compassionless properties overwhelming someone with so much empathy. His lack of resistance enabled the enervated acolytes to finish their work quickly, tracing the intricate swirls and lines of the obscene right upon all the exposed portions of his body.

Upon completing the deed, the script flashed violet—with a gasp—Shen opened his eyes and mouth to reveal the blazing light of Oblivion. The pylon to which he was affixed responded to Shen's now amenable aspect; it glowed a radiant violet as it corresponded to the spirit of He-Man.

"No, no, no…" Perfuma whispered. She could feel the shift in equilibrium as the power of He-Man was added to the ceremony—it felt as if she were standing upon a platform, one whose precarious balance was offset, tipping her and everyone else into darkness.

"Scorpia!" She shrieked, beginning to struggle even more fiercely than the last time. "Let me go! We have to stop this!"

A sound like a low moan throbbed throughout the chamber, vibrating Perfuma's flesh, bones, and soul as the rest of the pylons activated. She spotted a slight smile on the white visage of Lethe, knowing they sensed the coming of their apotheosis.

This time, the way to Subternia would be opened.

* * *

Glimmer blasted yet another Vetala off Mecha Emily's hull, the wretched creature almost gaining a handhold to rip a section of protective armor from the robot.

“Thanks, Glimmer!” Entrapta said cheerily, waving one of Mecha Emily’s arms. The technical Princess seemed completely carefree and unaware of the level of danger they were all in—but Glimmer wasn’t. The flavor of the battle had shifted with the addition of the Death Binders—not only did they boost the abilities of the undead Nephraeh, but they were adding their own magical attacks to the battle.

Glimmer had seen a Death Binder toss small bones to the ground—where they landed—a twisting white mass of ethereal shapes appeared. Looking closely at this strange appearance, Glimmer could make out deformed, screaming faces amongst the milky strands of incorporeal matter. The apparition then steaked towards Spinnerella and Netossa, tormenting the two Princesses and disrupting their use of magic.

Another cowled figure summoned a ball of corposant in mid-air, sending the crackling ball to explode near Panga and sending the Star Hunter flipping through the air. Only by Double Trouble’s intervention did the Madgēcot avoid any serious damage—using the power of Entropy—the shapeshifter transformed a nearby rock into a featherbed, breaking Panga’s fall.

Finally, there were the Szi’th; the Death Binders were capable of summoning these undead from the desiccated rock with absolute ease, leaving Glimmer to guess where they came from. Were they already in the ground, or did they come from someplace else? There seemed no end to them.

A Death Binder came soaring out of the melee and straight for Glimmer, its black robes once again reminding the Queen of Etheria of a great bat. Raising the Star Stone too late to blast it out of the sky, Glimmer found herself face to face with a hideous leering face as the Death Binder gripped her staff.

“Hello, Queen Glimmer, we meet again,” the Death Binder said, the speech in a sibilant and masculine voice. A sense of familiarity passed through Glimmer—she recognized the speaker.

"Who are you?" She asked, struggling to free the Star Stone from his skeletal clutches.

"You don't remember me?" He rasped. "Back on Omiros, I offered to show you the power of Seth-un, but you foolish rejected me! Oh, how you must be regretting that now…"

After a moment of confusion, the memory came to her—the last time Glimmer had been on that planet was during the war with the She'Aan-war's forces; she and her friends had fought through a great tower, upon the pinnacle of which they had encountered—

"*The Coven Master*," Glimmer breathed. "But how? You were destroyed when—"

Glimmer's words were cut short as the Death Binder shrieked with glee, spittle flying out of a gap-toothed mouth.

"We commend death, you fool! How do you not realize this yet?" The Coven Master said, turning to look in a new direction. "It's time to teach you the error of your ways!"

Glancing in the direction the Death Binder indicated, Glimmer perceived his meaning amidst the crowd of leaping black bodies. There she spotted the two Death Binders hauling the large chest; they placed it on the ground—right away, working at the lock mechanisms on the ornate lid. Once it was opened, one of the robed figures reached inside, removing something akin to a gnarly branch as the other Death Binder dug a hole. With the small pit complete, the strange object was thrown inside as the loose sandy dirt was quickly pushed back over it.

The Coven Master cackled with glee as he suddenly pulled away from Glimmer, pinwheeling back into enfolds of Vetala before she could strike out at him. But the Queen of Etheria paid him no heed; her eyes were glued on the small mound, dread filling her as she contemplated what new horror they must face.

Like animals sensing approaching danger via heightened senses, the Vetala scattered from the burial site, leaving behind a wide-

open space. There, Glimmer watched a mound of shifting sand rise up from the earth, a great maw at the apex as it veered towards the heavens. A buzzing hiss accompanied pale glistening shapes spilling out from within the sand; once fully clear, a white squirming worm was revealed. It was big—and by the way it pulsed—Glimmer could recognize that it was still expanding, becoming broader and longer.

When the creature had reached the culmination of its growth, a row of eyes appeared, running laterally down its length, from snout to end, each one blazing with crimson light. The worm slammed down, still giving off a sinister rasping noise as it slid towards Glimmer and her companions.

"Oh, no!" Panga gasped nearby. "That's a Xiggoth!"

"What's a Xiggoth?" Bow asked.

Panga grimaced, her cream-colored ears lowered in fright.

"I've only read about them from Elysian history. They were used by the forces of evil against the Madgēcots during the Dark Times. I thought they were extinct…"

The Star Hunter covered her mouth briefly before continuing, her tail now twice its standard size as it beat the air.

"We are in big trouble," she said.

* * *

With Sher-Va/Catra in the lead and Zhe-La/Veth providing illumination, the three Champions navigated the labyrinthine tunnels of Castle Grayskull's dungeon. They had found no enemy to bare their way as they descended into the inky depths—that, combined with the unique knowledge of Sher-Va/Catra's special passenger—gave the Champions the advantage needed to make their way quickly through the dank tunnels.

At the end of this corridor, you should see a door etched with demons—continue past that until you find a staircase going down. Take it. Jihan said.

With her enhanced Madgēcot eyesight, Sher-Va/Catra quickly spotted the door indicated by her mentor; it was solid gold with an image of prancing demons standing in a circle embossed in the metal. Each horn-headed demon was in the act of consuming their fellow before them, the esoteric symbology completely unknown to Sher-Va/Catra.

What do you suppose is behind that door? She thought to her mentor as she padded down the stairwell.

It's not important, Cat-Tra! Focus! Jihan admonished.

She could practically feel Jihan's anxiousness pouring up through her core—the approaching confrontation with Lethe was making her mentor more snappish than usual. Knowing this must be taxing—even for a supposed ghost—Sher-Va/Catra bit back her initial angry response and focused on the next long hall ahead. She could distinguish that they were entering a rougher section of the dungeons; supports lined the walls, holding aloft heavy beams which stabilized the ceiling. Sensing the immense burden of stone held aloft by mere wooden posts, Sher-Va/Catra became extremely uncomfortable.

"Man, I hate being underground," she complained.

No Madgēcot likes to be under the earth, Cat-Tra. Jihan commented, a little calmer now. **The last time I was here, this hallway was pristine. We are getting close now—be prepared!**

The shaft became narrower and more enclosed the farther they went, as did the feeling of substance that permeated their bodies —like a great weight. Soon they came to the end of their journey —an even narrow section of passage that ended in a smooth wall.

Sher-Va/Catra ran her golden gauntlet over the runes chiseled in the stone there.

"Defenders of Grayskull, speak virtue and enter," she said.

Just say love, or patience, or kindness. Any one of those—hurry! Jihan goaded.

"*Love*?" Sher-Va/Catra said.

Outwardly nothing appeared to happen, but when she poked one claw toward the wall, it abruptly passed through—as if it were a hologram.

"You guys ready for this?" Sher-Va/Catra said to Zhe-La/Veth and She-Ra/Adora.

Her companions nodded, and together, the Champions of Grayskull entered the Vestibule.

* * *

The Xiggoth had proven to be catastrophic for Glimmer and her friends—but not for the reason the Queen of Etheria had initially feared. When she had watched the corpse-pale behemoth come sliding towards her and her friends, Glimmer thought the creature would try and crush them. But before the Xiggoth was upon them, it veered suddenly, circling them with its great white body as its eerie red eyes fixated on Glimmer's party—once that happened—that's when they started to lose. Without warning, the veracious Vetala suddenly pulled down Spinnerella and Netossa, leaving Glimmer horrified.

How did that happen? Netossa and Spinnerella have been magic users for years and experienced fighters. How could they just go down like that? Glimmer's mind raced.

A sneaking suspicion drew her attention to the newest addition to the enemy ranks— after sending a wave of burning Star Fire

into a group of Vetala—Glimmer took a moment to observe the Xiggoth.

It was still moving at the edge of the battle, its array of eyes roving before focusing on a single point—turning her head in that direction—Glimmer spotted her father. On both of Micah's outstretched hands were the arcane discs of activated magic, the senior sorcerer using these conduits to summon bolts of pure magic. Glimmer watched as both of these glowing conduits abruptly vanished, leaving her father defenseless. Before she or anyone else could do anything, the enemy was upon him, pulling Micah down for enervation—he was gone.

"NOO!!!" Glimmer screamed.

But the Xiggoth was not done—fighting in complete harmony with each other, Panga and Double Trouble were next. With its red gaze upon Madgēcot and Imp, Glimmer witnessed Double Trouble suddenly lose their ability to control Entropy—they suddenly changed shape—reverting to a female version of themselves that the Queen of Etheria had never seen before. Double Trouble appeared stricken, and as Panga rushed to their aid, the Star Hunter suddenly seized up, her yellow eyes rolling into her head as she collapsed.

One by one, the rest of Glimmer's friends were taken, each undermined by the insidious methods of the Xiggoth. The Emily Mech-Suit suddenly expelled Entrapta out onto the dirt like a cat coughing up a hairball, leaving the Princess defenseless. The technology of Hordak's arm cannon and Seahawk's light sword suddenly malfunctioned as Orko, Mermista, and Frosta's magical powers evaporated—even Bow's signature weapon failed as the string broke, leaving him unable to notch an arrow. At the completion of these tragedies, Glimmer felt an anomalous phenomenon take hold of her body—returning her attention to Xiggoth—she saw that every one of its wicked eyes was upon her. It was then the creature spoke in her mind.

ssssss**Fortune**ssssss**Is**ssssss**Fickle**ssssss**Prosperity**ssssss**Leaves**sssss**You**ssssss

As soon as she heard the horrible voice, Glimmer felt her connection to the Star Stone sever. She attempted to reestablish her link to the ultimate power, but every time, it stalled. Only during rare moments in the past did Glimmer ever slip up when using her magic—perhaps one time in a thousand. But at that moment, every casting was a fluke; every attempt was a miss—it was as if luck itself was against her. In desperation, Glimmer reached out to Etheria in the sky overhead, trying to harness her Princess Power—but that, too, was unattainable.

Forlorn, the Queen of Etheria dropped the Star Stone staff as she fell to her knees. Not wanting the sight of black fangs seeking her flesh, Glimmer kept her gaze fixed on the ground, the whole time hoping this sacrifice was worth it.

* * *

As soon as Zhe-La/Veth entered the cavernous Vestibule, their silver eyes alighted upon only one thing: not the group of enervated acolytes currently chanting, nor their previous Archon, sitting cross-legged as they performed a series of unnatural hand motions. The Empyrean Champion cared not for Scorpia turning her head in the direction of the interlopers or the fact that the entire space was fading into an incomprehensible miasma of intense images—no—Zhe-La/Veth had eyes for only one thing.

"Shen!!!" They screamed.

"Curse it, Veth—WAIT!" She-Ra/Adora said from behind.

But Zhe-La/Veth was already set on their course; they burst forward at a full sprint towards the unconscious form held suspended to one of the strange pillars. This focus was momentarily interrupted as Scorpia stepped in their path—using the Ultimate Power set in her diadem—the fallen Princess launched a bolt of pure void energy the Empyrean Champion.

Not even conscious of what they were doing, Zhe-La/Veth summoned their sword while simultaneously infusing it with Light —they batted the attack away from themselves, sending the destructive magic souring out into the chaos of Subternia. Before Scorpia could react, the Empyrean Champion barreled into her, using their momentum to send the ordinarily indomitable woman crashing to the ground.

Finally reaching their objective, Zhe-La/Veth gently cupped Shen's face in their clawed gauntlets, peering into his slack face.

"I'm here, Shen! Wake up!" They pleaded.

But the human did not respond, remaining still and unmoving in their grip—fearing him dead— Zhe-La/Veth placed one of their long ears next to his mouth, sighing with relief when they felt his breath against their skin.

"They put some kind of substance on him—to force the He-Man avatar to activate the pylon," A female voice said.

Zhe-La/Veth turned to regard the speaker, seeing a beautiful blonde woman with kind eyes. After a brief survey of her quintessence, they quickly discerned she was no threat and was held there against her will.

"It must have been Antithetical Philter they used on him—it's basically Lethe's lifeblood." Zhe-La/Veth said, right away spotting the faded indigo script applied to Shen's face and hands.

Backing away, the Nephraeh Champion lifted their sword to bring it down in one careful swipe, neatly slicing away the bits of rock that affixed Shen to the pylon. Zhe-La/Veth caught him before he fell, bringing the limp form of Shen tightly against their chest and holding him there. Closing their silver eyes, Zhe-La/Veth called upon the prime power of their Champion spirit, bathing the human with pure Light directly from their body. As the foul substance forming arcane script was seared away in the sublime luminosity, Shen's eyes opened, and he gasped. Zhe-La/Veth

rewarded him with a toothy grin as he gaped at them in complete confusion.

"Hey, stupid Human. Somehow, I knew I would end up having to rescue you," they said.

Shen gave a weak snort before glancing around—following his gaze—Zhe-La/Veth witnessed Sher-Va/Catra wrestle the fallen Princess Scorpia to the ground, the fire of Truth blazing on the Madgēcot Champion's hands and in her eyes. She-Ra/Adora was dispersing the crowd of chanting minions with threatening waves of her magical sword; there was terror on the enervated acolytes' faces as they backed away from She-Ra/Adora, but Zhe-La/Veth suspected it was not directed towards their fellow Champion.

Placing Shen gently on the ground, Zhe-La/Veth turned to face the architect of this foul ritual—Lethe was still seated on the floor, their face impassive as they continued to conduct the ceremony through obscure motions. By now, the only part of the Vestibule not subsumed into Subternia was the floor—but that, too, was being swallowed into the dizzying array of madness surrounding them all.

"ENOUGH, LETHE!!! THIS STOPS NOW!!!" Zhe-La/Veth commanded.

A smirk split white lips as black teeth were slowly revealed—as Lethe opened burning indigo eyes—Zhe-La/Veth found themselves facing their once-Lord. There was no rage or hatred on Lethe's porcelain features as they regarded their wayward vassal—only a sense of muted sadness as they nodded in acknowledgment.

"My Child, I'm so glad you have come back to me at this moment. To have you here at the cusp of my crowning achievement… *thank you*…" they breathed.

Zhe-La/Veth shook their head as they lifted a sword brimming with pure Light—Lethe squinted as the radiance stung their Oblivion eyes.

“I’m not coming back to you, Lethe—I’m here to stop you,” they said.

Zhe-La/Veth sensed others nearby—looking askance—found She-Ra/Adora and Sher-Va/Catra at both sides.

“Give it up—we have stopped your ritual!” She-Ra/Adora called.

Lethe let out a bark of laughter as they came to their feet, raising black-stained to point at Zhe-La/Veth’s feet.

“The ritual is finished, my friends. Welcome to your future!” They cried.

With a sense of insurmountable dread, Zhe-La/Veth looked down—where once there was a stable crystal rock floor—now only madness existed.

They were all in Subternia—including Lethe.

It was too late.

Strangers in Even Stranger Lands

Chapter Summary

> Having been cast to the interdimensional winds, Adora, Catra, Shen, and Veth try to make sense of their new surroundings.
>
> Lethe now sits at the center of EVERYTHING and contemplates their ultimate desire.

They float at the center, the ultimate nucleus that ties untold scores of divergent realities together. They can feel the infinite potentiality surrounding them; it calls out to the depthless hunger inside them, the bottomless pit that has comprised the totality of their being for millennia now.

NOT HUNGER—BUT SADNESS. LOSS

They are here, they finally made it to their ultimate desire, and all they have to do is take it! Not only can they attain the godhood they had initially sought, but a level of divinity supreme over all others.

They reach out to grasp the strings of independent realities with ethereal hands, seizing the threads to entwine them into their soul—but it is slow going—the movements of their intangible limbs sluggish against the backdrop of infinity.

Why are they moving so slowly? Why is it taking so long? They had imagined this moment for ages, and in those fantasies, the acquisition of power was instantaneous—not this drudgery mired in tedium. Something was acting against them.

NOT SOMETHING—ME

Is it one of the others they had always sensed? One of the true gods that exist at an alignment higher than their own? Perhaps their elevation had been sensed at the last moment, and the

disparate celestial beings have united to thwart them out of jealousy. That has to be it.

NO, IT ISN'T

At the back of their consciousness, a niggling ambiguity touches their awareness; the associated emotion is wholly alien to their persona. It is a bitter heaviness weighing down everything they attempt to do, hanging about them like a smothering blanket. They feel it as a finger, pulling at the center of their throat to the pit of their core—it is unpleasant.

GRIEF IS UNKNOWN TO LETHE. BUT YOU ARE NOT REALLY LETHE, ARE YOU? YOU ARE ME

With this feeling comes a memory—it hangs on like an unwanted passenger, urgent for their attention. They try to dismiss this nagging echo—they are so preoccupied with their great work! But it latches on, dragging them down into the impression.

He smiles at them, exposing his bottom and top fangs.

"You must be Kishar," he says, extending a clawed hand. "The League of Kalosyni sent me to be your mentor,"

They take his hand in a gentle grip, immediately liking the way his soft fur feels against their white skin.

"That's marvelous! I did not imagine that the League would send the Madgēcot Champion to guide me! Do you have a name, Ser?" They say, immediately feeling embarrassed at their exuberance.

He sighs heavily, making them suddenly self-conscience.

"Please, don't use that silly 'Ser' with me—I hate those ostentatious titles! When you are with me, just call me by my name. It's—"

They are freed from the vision; the experience of coming out of it is like rising from a cold pool. But they are not freed from the

unfamiliar sensation which accompanied it—it's worse now—feeling like a ghostly ache in a part of their body, one they did not recall having.

They shake these distractions off their incorporeal form; there is no time for melancholy—not when greatness awaited! It is time for them to seize all realities for themselves, and with the Champions of Grayskull scattered to the transdimensional wind, there was nothing left to stop them.

* * *

Intense brightness followed by a feeling of translation suffuses body and soul as she leaves one place and ends up—

Adora opened her eyes and immediately squinted; the sun was so incredibly bright wherever she was, at complete odds with the softer lights of her last location.

"Wha—" She stammered. "Catra?"

"I'm here!" Catra said, clasping her hand and immediately dispelling any anxiety she may have felt. "Where are we, Adora?"

Surveying their location, Adora was utterly at odds with any rational answer. They were on a paved street of some kind as sleek metallic vehicles of varying colors passed back and forth in opposing directions. Tall trees dotted this avenue, the tops of which sported large fronds which seemed to burst from the curious plants like a small explosion. Various small buildings lined the road, most appearing to be shops where stylishly dressed people bustled in and out of.

Looming over it all was a low hill in the background, its arid surface lined with large white letters that were indecipherable to the two Etherians. Drawing on the magic of She-Ra, Adora channeled it into her awareness, heightening her sense of perception. Gradually, she was able to read the alien script.

"Holl—"

“Hey! Wow!” Someone interrupted.

Turning to the speaker, Adora found a middle-aged human woman attired in a matching outfit of some mauve billowy material standing nearby. Funny shoes with spikes on the heels were on her feet, bringing the woman to a height taller than the Etherians. With her long blond hair held in a tight ponytail, the woman’s severe-looking face watched Catra and Adora with condescending bemusement.

“You two are cosplayers, right? Well, you definitely are,” she said, pointing at Adora’s wife.

“What did you call me?” Catra said, menace in her voice.

The woman laughed richly, but the sound was devoid of any authenticity.

“Oh, that’s so funny! I’m sorry, I’m not familiar with your characters, so I don’t get whatever ‘inside jokes’ or ‘fandom references’ you may make,” she said while making air quotes.

“I’m sorry, we are new here,” Adora said, laying a hand on Catra’s shoulder. “We are also a bit lost, perhaps—”

The woman halted Adora’s words with a dismissive wave, earning a low growl from Catra.

“Oh, I know where you two belong. All the other cosplayers are out in front of the Chinese Theatre—you can’t miss ‘em,” she said.

Adora shared a glance with her wife, who shrugged back at her.

“Where is this—uh—*Chinese Theatre*?” Adora asked.

The woman laughed again, this time with a hint of sincerity.

“You two must be from a long way off if you came *here* without knowing where the Chinese Theatre is!” She said.

"*Hee, hee, hee, hee!*" Catra said, mocking the woman's laugh. "Can you just tell us where it is without the condensation?"

With two raised eyebrows, the woman bestowed a withering gaze upon Catra, who matched her expression with smug indifference.

"Your character must be one of those silly antisocial tropes that kids seem to go for these days." She said with a curled lip. "Personally, I like my characters to have more *character*—so to speak. But what do I know? I am only the producer for *North American Owl Fighter*,"

The frown was so deep on Catra's cinnamon face that Adora thought she would hurt herself; laughing nervously, she took her wife by the arm before anything untoward happened to the odd woman.

"So! About those directions?" Adora asked as sweetly as possible.

"Oh, I like you!" The woman said, patting Adora on the arm. "Yes, so, we are on Western Ave., so keep going that way," she said, pointing in the direction of the large white sign, "and turn left before you reach the Petco. Follow the avenue for about two miles; you should see it on the left. If you get to Farrah Fawcett's star, you've gone too far,"

Adora and Catra shared another look, both shrugging.

"Okay, thanks! *Byeee!*" Adora said, tugging Catra away from the woman.

"You're welcome!" The woman responded. "Oh, and hey! If you ever need temp work, come see me! Go to the *Streamline Studios* building in Production Center! Ask for Claudia Green!"

Adora walked away from the unusual encounter as quickly as possible, holding onto Catra tightly. She could not explain it, but the interaction unsettled her; it was something about the woman's demeanor—seeming friendly on the outside while all the while feeling cold. Adora hated it.

“Hey, where are we going, Adora? Let’s stop and think about this,” Catra said, pulling her to a stop.

“What is there to think about, Catra? Lethe had opened the way to Subternia and somehow sent us to…” Adora said, looking around once more. But all she saw were more streets, more stores, and even more people walking around as if no one else existed. A low rumble brought her attention upwards—there, she saw the glint of a birdlike shape soaring overhead.

“This place stinks wherever it is,” Catra said, scrunching her nose. “And I mean *literally* stinks, like, horrible—worse than Thenlor,”

“Yeah…” Adora said, feeling lost. “Well, we have no idea what happened to the others, whether they are here or in some other… *place*. Based on our interaction with that person, I can’t really say whether Lethe had achieved absolute rule over all realities or not.”

“Adora, if Lethe had won, then that would mean everyone, everywhere, would have no empathy—including us! I still have my compassion—how about you?” Catra said.

Adora didn’t even need to think about it; she knew precisely what absolute apathy felt like.

“I’m still here, Catra,” she said, giving her wife’s hand a squeeze.

Catra nodded curtly. “That means Lethe hasn’t won yet, and we can still stop them!”

“So that leaves us where we started—what next?” Adora asked.

Catra looked up and down the long street again as a dry gust of wind caressed her stone-gray mane of hair. Finally, she shrugged.

“Well, that weirdo seemed to think we belonged at some place called the *Chinese Theatre*—perhaps that’s a sign or something?”

Adora chuckled as she shook her head. “Since when does Catra believe in signs and portents?”

“Since when Catra and her furry butt got shot off into another dimension—that’s when! Come on, that weirdo said we turn right at a Pet-go—up there somewhere,” she said, pointing a black-clawed finger.

“It’s *Petco*, and it was a left, Catra,” Adora said in correction.

Catra grinned. “My wife is so smart,”

* * *

There is a bright light—but not the one that heralds the ultimate end with which he is familiar. He is going somewhere without moving, and soon, there is—

Shen opened his eyes and immediately squinted; the sun was so incredibly bright wherever she was, at complete odds with the softer lights of his last location. Feeling the subtle touch of anxiety, he reacted unconsciously.

“Veth!”

“I’m here!” They said, immediately placing a hand on his wrist. “I’m right next to you!”

Relief washed over Shen as he felt the Nephraeh’s deadly claws gently brush against his skin—now that he was calmer—Shen took in his surroundings.

“Where are we?” Veth asked.

Immediately Shen could tell they were in a city of some kind, a bustling cobblestone street filled with street vendors crying out their wares. Overhead, a brilliant copper-tinged sky peered down through crisscrossing awning, much of which was torn and weathered. The buildings surrounding them were of a familiar style and of a uniform color—light pink with subtle hints of orange; they appeared old and worn, having withstood for centuries. The creeping suspicion slowly filling Shen evaporated

into absolute certainty as Shen breathed in the air, immediately recognizing the scents of a place he had spent a lifetime in.

"I know this place," Shen said. "It's Eternos. We are on Eternia,"

"Impossible!" Veth scoffed, peering about. "Eternia is in Lethe's hands; none of these people around us are enervated!"

"I'm telling you, Veth," Shen said, looking straight into Veth's silver eyes. "This is Eternia—or, at the very least, a version of it. The last thing I remember was…"

He had just regained consciousness in the Nephraeh's arms when suddenly they were both surrounded by a maddening display of incomprehensible images. Then they were both here.

"Lethe opened the way to Subternia," Veth said, nodding. "Then this is Eternos—just not *your* Eternos,"

"So, did Lethe win? If they opened the way to the nexus of all realities, then…" Shen asked, casting about as he took in the people around them.

Veth gripped him by the upper arms this time, holding Shen still.

"I said no one here is enervated—that includes us. That means Lethe has not won yet; you believe me, right?" They asked.

It took only the briefest of looks for Shen to glimpse the truth in the subtle expression and set of their eyes and mouth. Focusing on those violet lips, Shen found himself grinning.

"You know, this is the first time we had a chance to talk since you ambushed me with that kiss," he said slyly.

Right away, the Nephraeh gaped at him, the look of absolute stupefaction quite endearing on their lilac face.

"*Are you serious right now, Human?*" They hissed. "We are in the middle of a calamitous situation on a transdimensional scale, *and*

you want to talk about kissing?"

Shen shrugged on purpose, knowing and not caring that he was taking a risk in aggravating Veth further.

"It's always good to be reminded of what I'm fighting for," he commented.

The Nephraeh looked away quickly, but not before Shen caught them attempting to stifle a smile.

"You really are something else… *Shen,"* they said, running a hand through their hair.

Their eyes were much softer as Veth cast their gaze back to him, reaching out to gently clasp his wrist.

"I promise we will talk about it, but first, can we please concentrate on finding a way back to Lethe?"

Shen beamed. "Oh! There it is! The motivation I needed!"

Before Veth had the chance to respond, he grasped them by the hand.

"Come, let me show you the alternate reality version of the city I grew up in!" he said, pulling them toward an alley he suspected would bring them to a more significant avenue.

His assertions were partially correct; it was indeed a wide road, but instead of being filled with fancier versions of the stores they left behind, a grand boulevard lined with massive columns topped with colossal statues presented itself. At the end of this thoroughfare, a mighty castle stood—Shen noted that its location matched the exact position of the Shen'Aan-war's citadel in his version of Eternos.

"I take it this is not what you expected?" Veth asked.

"Uh, nope," Shen responded, taking in the scene.

Each statue was of a different heavily muscled man in various heroic poses—holding a sword high, charging into battle, lifting an enemy overhead, or just standing with arms crossed. Shen could tell by the symbol adorning every one of their bulging chests that these were various bearers of He-Man—well, that and that they all wore a variation of furred loincloth his father had worn.

"Your kindred, I assume?" Veth said from behind him. "I never was a big fan of the furry underwear."

Shen chuckled. "From what I heard, that's what Catra had said when she first met my father—she also called it 'furry underwear,"

"Great minds think alike," they responded. "Do you recognize any of these *He-Men*?"

Shen shook his head as he began to follow the route toward the castle, gazing up into the faces of these strange forebearers as he went. Each one was unknown to him, although one or two seemed to match the records of the past He-Man Shen was allowed to study growing up.

It was only when they had reached the end of the processional that Shen found himself stopping to stare at the final representation of He-Man. This one seemed more straightforward than the others; just a crisscrossing harness adorned his chest, his handsome face framed by hair cut in a simple bob style. This He-Man was holding a sword aloft one-handed as he gazed toward some unseen horizon—his face noble and kind.

"What interests you about this one, Human? I hope it's not the hairstyle…" Veth commented.

"No…" Shen said, holding his chin in contemplation. "I don't know; I feel like I've seen him before. I—"

"The Royal Palace is closed to visitors today! State your business!" A voice commanded.

Shen turned to see two guards descending the stairs from a pair of golden doors comprising the castle's entrance—both were garbed in green bodysuits covered with yellow armor; on their heads were blue helmets with only the eyes visible. In their hands were dangerous-looking poleaxes—which, at the moment—were held in a rest position.

"Oh! I ummmm…" Shen stammered, thinking of what to say. He never had to explain himself in Eternos before, usually being recognized as the hated Outcast or beloved Prince.

"My and my friend are on an undertaking of the utmost importance," Veth said, laying a hand on Shen's shoulder. "We formally request an audience with whoever is in charge here—if you don't—it could mean disaster for you and your entire planet,"

As the guards looked questioningly at each other, Shen cast a hurt expression at his Nephraeh companion.

Friend? He mouthed.

Veth pursed their lips as they cast him a long-suffering look in return.

Focus! They mouthed back.

"Okay. We will bring you before King Randor—but I warn you, if this is some obfuscation, you two will be sharing a cell in the palace dungeon before nightfall!" One guard said.

Shen shrugged. "Wouldn't be the first time," he mumbled.

"What was that?!" The other guard asked.

"Oh, don't mind him; he has an affliction in which he spouts random nonsense at the most inappropriate times—it's completely harmless!" Veth said with a smile.

The guards both shrugged as they turned away, and Shen winced as the Nephraeh gave his arm a backhanded slap.

"Just let me do the talking," Veth hiss-whispered.

Shen rubbed his shoulder as he and Veth followed the guards up the stairs and into the Royal Palace of Eternos.

* * *

"You know what I find kind of odd, Adora?"

Adora glanced at her wife as they continued down a different street than the one they had previously arrived on, having just turned at the mysteriously named 'Petco.'

"Yeah, Catra?"

"Well, I'm usually not that particular about these things, but I've noticed that there are just humans in this place. Nothing else. No sea elves, no lizard or beast people—just plain old humans," she said.

Adora glanced around, immediately catching her wife's meaning.

"Yeah, it's kind of weird—huh? I wonder if it's just a coincidence that no other races are here. If this was a planet of just humans, wouldn't they have been alarmed to see a Madgēcot walking around?" Adora said.

Now that she was paying attention, Adora did see the occasional glance in Catra's direction—a brief look of surprise before the observer gave a slight shrug in dismissal.

"Maybe it has someone to do with us being—what was it called? Cuss-players?" Adora said.

Catra shook her head. "No, that doesn't make sense, Adora. It was *Cost-player*—you know—like gambling or something,"

Adora rolled her eyes. "What do you know about gambling? Just because you heard Seahawk talking about it doesn't make you an expert,"

Her wife's look of incredulity was rich. "Uh, just because you were a goodie-two-shoes in the Horde doesn't mean I was. I will have you know that—"

Adora held up a hand to stifle Catra's rebuttal as she focused on a nearby shop with multiple flat viewscreens in the window. On them were scenes of what appeared to be rioting—but what was most disturbing were the close-ups of the people involved in the chaos; every single one of them had a cold look in their eyes that Adora was most familiar with.

"Excuse me?" She said, stopping a nearby passerby. "Do you know what's going on there?"

The young man peered in the direction of the screens Adora indicated.

"Have you been living under a rock? Don't you know about the mass hysteria in Europe and India?" He said rudely.

Adora shook her head, raising both hands in a look of helplessness.

"Why don't you tell us, smart guy?" Catra said with a growl.

The young man was instantly alarmed by Catra's appearance before a look of acceptance calmed his demeanor.

"That is one crazy costume you have on—*hella rad*," he said. "Well, I guess it makes sense you don't know too much about it; I think the government suppresses as much information as possible. If you ask me, it's an alien takeover, and it's spread much further than Europe and India. I'm part of a Subreddit where one person claimed it's in New York and parts of Florida. I wouldn't be surprised if it's already in California—but I doubt anyone could tell if a bunch of us started going crazy,"

He laughed at his own joke as Catra and Adora shared confused looks.

"Anyway, judging by her outfit, I would say you on the way to the Chinese Theatre," He said, directing a thumb over his shoulder.

"Anyway—later,"

Adora watched her wife frown as the young man walked off, her tail making those quick jerking motions of annoyance.

"Anyway—later," she mocked. "What a dummy."

"Catra, I think I know what's happening on this planet. That mass hysteria he was talking about is actually people becoming enervated! It's happening, but very slowly for some reason!" Adora said in alarm.

A thoughtful expression crossed Catra's features, her long ears lowering before perking back up with a solution.

"Well, perhaps we will get the answers we need from the Chinese Theater. Oh, and after hearing that dummy say I was wearing a costume, it made me realize—it's not Cuss-Player or Cost-Play, its *Cosplayer;* like *cos* for a costume!" Catra said brightly.

Trying to refrain from grabbing and kissing her wife in the middle of this bizarre place, Adora settled for a wide grin instead.

"I'm so glad you are with me in this mess, Catra! Okay, let's go!" She said.

Hand in hand, the two women continued their journey down the hectic road, each taking in the sights as they went. Wherever this place was, it made Adora miss Etheria badly; it was so ugly and impersonal in this world, obviously so utterly devoid of any magic. She found herself regretting her earlier judgment of the woman Claudia Green—would Adora act any differently if she had grown up in a place like this?

Catra and Adora soon spotted a building that stuck out from the rest of the bland specimens they had passed so far; in the middle of a rectangular structure, two large red columns held aloft a

sloped metallic roof. Between the columns was what appeared to be a dragon's head carved from stone, and below that, three golden doors acted as the entrance. It was the only building in the entire city that seemed to exude any type of character, fitting nicely into an Etherian setting. If Adora and Catra were going to find any answers on this cold world, it would be here.

"That's gotta be the Chinese Theater!" Catra exclaimed.

If Adora had any doubts this was the right place, then the group of people gathered in the courtyard before it was a dead giveaway. These people were *definitely* the cosplayers—not because they were dressed differently from the city's other denizens—but because they looked so familiar to the two Etherians.

"Uh, Adora, this is weird! Why are those people dressed like our friends?!" Catra practically shouted.

An Entrapta lookalike sporting a purple wig and matching suspenders was chatting amicably with a boy wearing corpse-white make-up and badly dyed blue hair.

"Is that supposed to be Hordak?" Adora whispered.

Near them was a Bow and Glimmer lookalike who seemed to be goofing off with yet another Entrapta imposter. There were three Seahawks, another pair of Glimmer and Bows, plus some Netossas, Spinnerellas, Frostas, Scorpias, and Perfumas scattered about. Adora even spotted a very nearly naked, green-painted Double Trouble impersonator. But that was not the most startling thing either of them witnessed.

"Adora! Is that supposed to be us?!" Catra cried.

Even more prolific than the other cosplayers were the ones dressed in various degrees of similarity to Catra and Adora themselves. Numerous red-jacketed versions of a blond female walked with someone sporting furry cat ears and a matching tail. What was most unusual was that every one of these imposters

was dressed as Catra and Adora did during the war against the Horde.

"Really? Was my hair poof that poofy?" Adora said, eyeing one of her doppelgangers.

A very accurate Scorpia walked up to a nearby podium with a recognizable microphone clutched in one faux claw. With a broad smile the real Scorpia would be proud of, she waved for silence before bringing the microphone up to speak.

"Welcome to Etheria, Everyone!" She said to applause. "I'm pleased to announce the commencement of the fifth annual She-Ra and the Princesses of Power Cosplay at the Chinese Theater!"

* * *

"You stand before King Randor and Queen Marlena! The good and noble rulers of all Eternia! Stand forth and present yourselves!"

Shen and Veth strode across the circular hall that acted as the throne room in the Royal Palace, both peering about at the opulence on display. Surrounding them were walls adorned with extravagant gilding and lined with gold foil—over this—hung sweeping red banners, all displaying what Shen assumed was the royal family crest. Four large pillars held aloft a dome ceiling intricately painted with scenic frescos; below all this sat a tiered dais where the king and queen sat.

Knowing royal etiquette by heart, Shen stopped at the foot of the dais, kneeling humbly before the rulers of this version of Eternia. Glancing to make sure Veth followed suit, he was not the slightest bit surprised to see that not only did the Nephraeh not bow, but they placed one booted foot on the first step of the raised platform—a gross breach in protocol when addressing royalty.

"Why do you kneel, Human?" They hissed down at him.

"Because that is what you normally do when you stand before me," King Randor spoke up. "Although I will forgive you this one

time since this custom seems unknown to you."

"You may rise," Queen Marlena said to Shen.

Glancing nervously at the Nephraeh as he rose, Shen cleared his throat in preparation to speak—but Veth beat him to it.

"Greetings, I am Veth of Empyrea, and this is my… *partner*… Shen of—" Veth started before stopping themselves. "Actually, it's not important where he is from. What is important is that we are on an important mission, and what we would like from you is…"

Shen watched incredulously as the usually sharp-tongued and quick-witted Veth seemed utterly bereft of words. Appearing as if they were going to drown, Shen decided to step in.

"This will be hard for you to believe, but we are from another dimension. I am actually from another version of Eternia that is not so dissimilar from yours," Shen began with a chuckle. He noticed both king and queen shared a look as he continued.

"Well, there is a very powerful person in our dimension who has gained entry into a place called Subternia—"

"The underworld? That's a myth, silly boy," King Randor cut in.

As Queen Marlena beckoned to a nearby aid, Shen caught the words *Teela* and *Man-At-Arms* whispered into the young woman's ear. Knowing he was probably running out of time, Shen pressed on.

"Well, I can tell you it's no myth, and it's more than just a place where devils live. It's a central point in which all the various realities merge—and there—this person we are fighting plans on gaining ultimate power and dominance of everything. That is unless we can stop them."

"*I see…*" King Randor said, glancing nervously at the Queen.

“Your Highness,” Shen continued. “Are any of your subjects a Sorcerer or Master Magic user that could help us get back to where we need to go?”

King Randor suddenly looked very uncertain. “Well, there is someone, but I’m not sure—”

Hearing the doors to the audience chamber abruptly open, Shen and Veth turned to see an older man walk in, followed by a young woman. The man was dressed in a variation of the guard uniform —an open-faced helmet revealed a handsome face sporting a well-groom mustache. His companion was dressed in a white leotard accented with brass armor; her hair held in a tight bun behind a pretty face.

“Duncan! Teela! How good of you to join us!” King Randor called. “Our new visitors have quite the tale—you should hear this!”

Shen heard Veth sigh wearily as the two newcomers flanked the pair of them—most likely with weapons in hand.

“I told you to let me do the talking, Human,” they said.

“Step away from the king and queen and come with us, *please*,” the man Duncan said.

“We have no time for this foolishness!” Veth cried as they whirled, hand in the air.

“BY THE LIGHT OF GRAYSKULL!!!”

Figuring there was no point in forestalling now that Veth was undergoing their transformation, Shen followed suit, raising his hand to the air in preparation for his ascension into He-Man.

“BY THE POWER OF GRAYSKULL!!!”

After the displays of Light and electric power were done, two Champions of Grayskull stood in the throne room, towering over everyone present.

“They’re assassins from Snake Mountain!” Duncan shouted, pulling a large mace from a back sheath as Teela withdrew a sword. He-Man/Shen and Zhe-La/Veth held their own magical swords aloft as the two guardians came in to engage them.

“Someone, alert He-Man! We are going to need his help!” Teela shouted.

“*This is going to get interesting*,” He-Man/Shen said under his breath.

Teela came at him first, jabbing with the point of her sword while delivering acrobatic kicks with her long legs. She was a skilled fighter—probably more capable than he was in his normal form—but no match for a Champion. He-Man/Shen batted away her sword as he planted the bottom of his boot in her stomach, sending Teela skidding away harmlessly on the floor. Zhe-La/Veth was likewise disarming the man, Duncan, snatching the heavy mace out of his hands as he went to strike them to toss it away casually.

“Your fast!” He commented.

“Oh, you know, as a Nephraeh, I’m naturally fast, but in my Champion form, I’m even fas—ACK!” Zhe-La/Veth started to say before a bright beam of energy struck them in the cheek.

“Fast and talk too much,” Duncan said, taking aim with his laser pistol once more. “Not a good combination!”

He-Man/Shen directed the point of his sword towards the weapon, disintegrating it with a jagged arc of lighting before it could fire. The man Duncan looked down at his empty hand, dumbfounded as mere ashes spilled from his palm to float down to the floor.

Zhe-La/Veth seethed before him but did not make a move to strike Duncan down, wiping a gauntleted hand at their quickly healing face.

“I suggest you stand down before you get hurt, *old man*.” Zhe-La/Veth hissed.

“Father!” Teela cried, running to Duncan’s side with her sword in a defensive position. “I will not let you hurt him!”

Zhe-La/Veth scoffed at this, dismissing their sword to hold up their clawed hands.

“I didn’t come here to harm your father or anyone else!” They said. “We just wanted your help, and *you* attacked us!”

“That’s right! Everyone, please calm down. Let’s just be calm and talk about this!” He-Man/Shen added.

Teela and Duncan looked at each other uncertainly as the need for hostility dissipated from their bodies. But before the situation could be defused, someone else joined the standoff in the throne room.

“I see that I’m just in time,” a robust masculine voice rang out.

He-Man/Shen whirled, his eyes widening with shock as an odd sense of recognition coursed through upon spotting this newcomer. A heavily muscled man wearing only boots, loincloth, and cross-chest harness stood at the entrance, bearing a smaller version of He-Man/Shen’s sword. This was the final He-Man represented in stone along the processional way they followed to the Royal Palace—but that was not the first place He-Man/Shen had felt he had seen this person.

He was younger and healthier looking, but this man standing before them had an uncanny likeness to the version of He-Man the Shen’Aan-war had become after losing his connection to the power of Death. He was so similar, in fact, that He-Man/Shen found himself speaking unintentionally.

“*Father?!*” He said.

Desiderium

Chapter Summary

> Catra, Adora, Shen, and Veth struggle to come to terms with their displacement, desperate to find a way back to Subternia.
>
> Time is running out.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They are making progress, but it is meager compared to the amount waiting to be realized. Casting out with the power of Oblivion into countless realities, they latch onto the living beings there like a great transdimensional leech, nourishing themselves with vast amounts of empathy. This infusion heightens their ability to reach deeper into the Omniverse, gaining access to even more resources. To them, the cyclic nature of their rise to divinity seems so clear and simple—and yet—it continues to be stymied.

WHY DO YOU KEEP IGNORING ME? I KNOW YOU CAN HEAR MY WORDS

Another doubt casts aspersions upon their ambitions—what if they gain the godhood they seek, yet it is not enough? What if they take everything that it is possible to take, fed on every last morsel of compassion, and the… *hunger*… still lingers? What then?

YOU SUPPLANT YOUR ACTUAL AILMENT WITH A NEED FOR SUSTENANCE. BUT YOU ARE CORRECT; EVEN IF YOU BECOME WHAT YOU DESIRE, YOUR AFFLICTION WILL REMAIN

Like a nagging itch, another unfamiliar memory rises to the surface of their consciousness. It is more overwhelming than the last one, encapsulating them in its irresistible reminiscence.

“Can you hand me the ultraphonic hypospanner?” He says, leaning into the compartment containing the Xeloite Capacitor.

They select the correct instrument from the satchel, and as they go hand it to him, a furry tail once again slides up their inner thigh. They bite their lip as they hastily place it in his outstretched hand, backing away and out of range of his wayward appendage. They watch him fuss inside the compartment as his tail continues to move back and forth—as if seeking them out.

The space they are in is so cramped and confining; it is getting hard not to let their already existing desire manifest into something physical. Eyeing his backside, they inch minutely closer to him—perhaps they will be needed soon to fetch something else for him. Yes, that is a good reason to get—

Sensation blazes up and down their body as the tail finds them once more—no longer satisfied with mere caresses—it wraps entirely around their thigh, almost touching their—

A gasp of arousal escapes their lips which they immediately attempt to silence—but it is too late—they watch his long ears strain backward as he picks up their cry. As he turns, they expect yet another lecture concerning the proper relationship between mentor and apprentice—but when he recognizes what his own tail is doing, he only sighs in resignation.

They are on him in an instant.

They shed the image from their mind—where do they keep coming from? Are they being sent by the other superluminous beings attempting to stop another from surpassing them? That must be it; there is no way these are their recollections—right?

YOU ARE SUCH A FOOL

They quickly discover a correlation between the alien emotion and the memories which are not their own. One is causing the other, and it is getting worse—is it because of what they are doing?

No. They must not give in to uncertainty, not when they are so close. Not when there is no going back. This is the only choice, for the alternative is too appalling to contemplate; now that they have surpassed what they once were, they need the sustenance the boundless omniverse can provide. If they withdraw from it now, they will be resigned to an eternity as a mere husk of a shell, utterly helpless against the void within them, endlessly tormented and damned.

THAT IS NOT TRUE. THERE IS AN ALTERNATIVE. THERE IS RELEASE AND RENEWAL

No, they will drive away hesitation and push forward with all that they have. This is no looking back, only the wide-open future before them. They must do so. They must… they must… they must… they must…

* * *

"Wow, your costumes are so realistic! Are you some kind of AU of Catra and Adora?"

Adora turned to the speaker—a young woman about her age dressed as the version of She-Ra before the power sword was broken.

"Excuse me, a what?" Adora asked, both of her eyebrows raised.

The girl giggled at this; obviously, Adora said something amusing.

"You know, an *alternate universe* version—because you're not dressed like they did in seasons one through five,"

Adora was shocked. "Wait—you know we are from an alternate reality?"

The girl dressed as She-Ra turned to the Catra cosplayer next to her, giving her a dubious glance. This lookalike was dressed as Catra when Adora first left the Horde—she got up close to Catra, peering at her Jaadoo suit.

"Wow! That is a really weird outfit! It's like you stitched different pieces together like a quilt!" She said, reaching out to run fingers down the section of Jaadoo on Catra's arm.

"Hey! Respect my personal space!" Catra protested.

Her doppelganger backed away in mock appeasement, hands raised and still smiling.

"Sorry! I forgot! 'We' don't like it when Scorpia puts her hands on us without permission!" She said. "That's an amazing AJ Michalka impression, by the way! You sound just like her!"

Catra frowned. "I'm not doing an impression; this is my own voice. Maybe this AJ Michalka is impersonating me!"

The cosplayers giggled at this, getting a little closer to Catra and Adora. Feeling suddenly uncomfortable, Adora peered around at the others surrounding them; there was a friendly camaraderie amongst these cosplayers, a sense of a shared love for the world that Catra and Adora lived in. She had no idea how these people knew about a very specific period in their lives—centered around the time Adora discovered the power sword to the point they defeated Horde Prime.

On the one hand, Adora was very flattered that people would take the time and effort to mimic the appearance of her and those she cared about. But on the other hand, Adora got the sense that these people did not believe that what they cosplayed actually existed—it was a fantasy—something out of a book.

What would happen if they found out the two people they seemingly idolized DID exist and were standing amongst them?

"You're really cute!" The She-Ra cosplayer said, siding up with Catra. "I promise I won't touch, but I just have to get a better glimpse at your costume! What kind of animatronic did you use for your tail? It's so life-like!"

The girl glided around Catra to lean down towards her rear end, looking closely at where the stone-gray tail connected to the base of her spine. Catra was annoyed by this behavior, but Adora could tell her wife was getting a sense of the situation they were in.

"Uh, yeah. It's an animal-what-sit—a really fancy one." She said, turning her body so the She-Ra cosplayer couldn't inspect her hindquarters too closely.

"Did you cover your body with fuzz or something?" The Catra cosplayer asked, scrutinizing the arm not covered by the Jaadoo. "That must have taken hours to do! I can't imagine how long it will take to get off! *Wait…*"

Contrary to her promise not to touch, the girl's curiosity overcame propriety, and she abruptly ran her hand down Catra's bare arm. Instantly, the Catra cosplayer's eyes went wide—Adora felt a rising anxiety as she watched comprehension dawn on the girl's face.

Quickly searching for an avenue of escape, Adora's eyes were drawn to the front of the Chinese Theatre—there—at the base of both orange pillars, a pair of statues sat, both depicting a feline animal in repose. Adora was unsure if it was a trick of the light, but she could have sworn one shimmered a purple/blue while the other glowed green/yellow. She shook this thought away, turning just in time to watch the Catra cosplayer seize her namesake by the upper arms as manic glee blazed on her face.

"Your *REAL!!??"* She breathed in awe.


OMG
YOU'RE
REAL!
BACON
HEWARTORIUS'23

“Uh… NO!” Catra said, squirming. “I’m…I’m a cosplayer, just like you!”

Adora was about to go and help her wife when two arms wrapped her in an embrace.

“That means you’re real too! Adora, I love you!” The She-Ra cosplayer practically screamed.

Noticing the commotion, the other participants came to investigate what the fuss was about—but as soon as they were near Catra and Adora—it was like a spell had been broken. No longer were the two Etherians able to hide behind the façade of being mere cosplayers—they had become more. The previously unobtainable was now palpable, whipping the enthusiastic crowd into a frenzied state of euphoria.

“How!? How is this possible? I’ve dreamed of something like this for so long!” An Entrapta impersonator cried.

“Your fur softer than I imagined!” The Catra cosplayer said as she completely embraced Adora’s wife.

“Ugh!!! Get off me, weirdo!” Catra cried, wiggling out of the girl’s grasp.

“Let me have a turn! I want to touch her!” A girl screamed.

“Catra! I want to have your baby!” Someone else yelled.

“No thanks!” Catra said, finally freeing herself from the desperate grip and reaching for a cantrip. Pulling the section of material deftly from her hip, Catra threw it directly to the ground where exploded into a dense gray cloud. Adora felt a clawed hand seek her out through the smoke, tugging her out of the admirer’s clutches and dragging her away. Once she had regained the ability to see, Adora discovered that they were now cornered against the front of the Chinese Theatre. She searched for some other way out of the trap—but it was too late—the concealing cantrip had

run its course, and the disorientated cosplayers stumbled out of the dissipating smoke, eyes once again locked on their prize.

“I’ve never been so terrified in my life!” Catra cried.

“Should we summon She-Ra and Sher-Va?” Adora asked, her voice high-pitched.

Just as the throng began to close in on the Etherians, two deep roars reverberated from behind Catra and Adora, stopping the cosplayers in their tracks. They gaped with wonder over Adora’s shoulder, their excitement reaching new heights.

“Wow! Is that who I think it is?!” Someone asked.

Whirling together, Catra and Adora beheld a sight that straight away dispelled any panic they felt; where once two stone statues once sat, Melog and Battle Cat now stood.

“It’s Melog!” Someone commented.

“Who is that with them? Does She-Ra have her own Melog now?” Another said.

Catra’s Ethyriel friend mewled as they leaped to her side; Battle Cat likewise came to Adora, their bright yellow eyes urgent.

“Get on, Adora!” Catra said, climbing up onto Melog’s back.

Doing as she was bid, Adora mounted Battle Cat, grasping the Ethyriel’s luminescent fur between her fingers in a firm grip. Once Catra and Adora were secure on their backs, both Melog and Battle Cat bounded through the encroaching multitude. Cosplayers yelped as they were shoved to the side or leaped of their volition —soon, the two Etherians were free of their adoring fans. Taking one last peek over her shoulder, Adora spotted the She-Ra and Catra cosplayer’s embrace, their faces the supreme aspect of joy.

“That was the best She-Ra event I’ve ever been to! I can’t wait for next year!” The girl dressed as Catra exclaimed, tears of joy in her

eyes.

Battle Cat jolted forward as they raced down the busy street, leaping over the metallic honking vehicles or swerving around them. Catra clung to Melog's back not far away, her cinnamon face an expression of joy to be on her friend's back once more.

"Entrapta gave me your message!" She shouted to the Ethyriel. "You two showed up just in the nick of time!"

As Melog mewled back at Catra, Adora summoned a fraction of her She-Ra power to understand them.

"I am overjoyed to have found you, Catra. Battle Cat and I have been searching numerous astral plains in an attempt to find your and Shen's metaphysical scents." Melog said.

"I guess it makes sense you found Catra first—didn't Maira say you smelled bad?" Adora teased her wife.

Catra stuck her tongue out at Adora as Melog jumped a particularly large and boxy wheeled machine—after being momentary airborne as the Ethyriel veered towards the ground—Catra slammed down on their back with a loud exhalation.

"Eh… I bit ma oungue…" She complained.

"So now that you found us, what's the next move?" Adora asked.

"Now that Catra's location has been established, I will use my connection to Shen to find him. He is a dimension with a faint connection to this one—all we have to do is locate the nearest interdimensional stitch," Battle Cat responded.

Adora grinned broadly at this; even though the situation was dire, she never imagined that she would ever find herself traveling between realities on the backs of two magical beings.

"Sounds fun! I'm down for a little dimension hopping!" She cried.

Battle Cat and Melog veered left down an adjoining street, now heading toward the massive white sign dotting the hillside.

"So, is that where this interdimensional stitch is? The words on the hill?" Catra asked nearby.

"*No, Catra. True magic will not be found near technology. It will be tied to nature—you will see,"* Melog responded.

The two Ethyriels were moving at such a high speed that they soon left the city sprawl, continuing to follow the road which now wound up the hillside. Glimpsing back from where they came, Adora surveyed rolling green hills that quickly transitioned back into the flat expanse of countless buildings, as far as the eye could see. Tall buildings sat at the center of this conurbation, rising out of the multitude in a cluster, appearing like a collection of dirty fingers.

Adora turned from the spectacle just in time to watch the large white sign streak past them as Melog and Battle Cat crested the hill; veering to the left, the two Ethyriels continued down the other side and up another hillside. At the top, they located a beaten path—following this dusty trail—came to yet another pinnacle, at the top of which a single lonely tree sat. It was short and scraggly, the top crowned by a mass of fine needles at the enda of spindly branches.

"Here it is—the interdimensional stitch," Melog proclaimed.

"Whoa! Are you guys shooting a movie or something?" A voice called.

Adora noticed that the speaker was a young woman, hair tied up into a scarf with an old worn knapsack on her back. She held a thin white object between her fingers, the end lit with an ember that glowed brightly as it was brought to her lips. Adora knew the girl was smoking something, although she was unfamiliar with this strange method of performing the habit, having only witnessed it done with pipes or hookahs.

“Uh, no. We don’t have any guns or anything,” Adora said with a reassuring smile. “We are just looking for the nearest interdimensional stitch.”

“Oh, right on,” the girl said, taking another long pull. “Let me know if you find one; I would like to leave this reality altogether,”

As Battle Cat and Melog approached the tree, a shimmering vortex appeared at its base; it corkscrewed gently against the barren soil, lifting a fine cloud of dust into the air.

“The stitch automatically reacts to our presence,” Melog explained.

“That’s amazing, Melog! Why does it do that, though?” Catra asked.

“*Because my people were the ones who seeded these access points throughout the realities. Come, we must hurry!”* Melog said.

One at a time, first Battle Cat, then Melog approached the aperture, slipping through the small tear in existence and disappearing from that reality altogether. Only a single soul witnessed this event; taking another drag from her joint, she nodded sagely to herself.

“That was so rad,” she proclaimed.

* * *

“Father!? I’m not your father!”

He-Man/Shen stared at this newcomer, confident his assertion was correct; this was indeed a version of his vile father—uncorrupted and untainted by Zzar and her power of Death. But the man standing in the doorway couldn’t actually be He-Man/Shen’s father—that man was dead—ended at He-Man/Shen’s own hands.

“You are Adam, correct?” He-Man/Shen asked.

The man balked, glancing around nervously before puffing himself up to respond.

“Adam the Prince? Me? No! That is ridiculous! I’m He-Man!” He said.

A meaningful look was shared between Duncan and He-Man just before a feline creature entered the throne room. It was enormous—green fur crisscrossed by orange striping covered its entire body, its back, and face adored by an armored red saddle and fearsome headpiece. There was something very familiar about the beast—and then He-Man/Shen saw it—the similarities too numerous to be a coincidence.

“That must be your Battle Cat,” He-Man/Shen said, pointing his sword.

“That’s right!” The Battle Cat said in a growling voice. “And before you ask, I’m definitely not Cringer!”

“Okay! Now that we all got that settled!” Zhe-La/Veth said, clapping their hands together. “What happens next?”

He-Man pointed his sword in their direction, his face set in a mask of determination.

“By the power invested in me by the Sorceress of Grayskull, I hereby place the both of you under arrest! Come with me quietly, or there will be trouble!” He commanded.

He-Man/Shen rewarded his Nephraeh companion with a look of utmost suffering.

“You just had to ask, didn’t you?” He scolded.

“Is this guy serious?” Zhe-La/Veth scoffed. “Perhaps his furry underwear is too tight; the flow of blood is restricted to his thick head,”

He-Man/Shen stifled a laugh as he watched the other He-Man mount Battle Cat, the beast rearing on its hind legs before letting out a mighty roar.

“The sword it is, then!” He-Man said, bounding forward.

He-Man/Shen was shocked at how fast the strike came—one moment, his foe was on one side of the grand chamber—and the other, he was upon him, swinging his sword downwards in a chop. This version of He-Man did not have the stature of his counterpart, but his strike was no less mighty—He-Man/Shen was pushed back a step as he took the blow upon his own blade.

“Wow! Your pretty strong!” He commented.

“I’m the most powerful man in the universe!” He-Man declared proudly.

He-Man/Shen shot a dubious glance at Zhe-La/Veth—right before a massive green paw batted him off his feet and into one of the massive columns holding the roof aloft. A zigzagging crack steaked up from the point of impact towards the ceiling as sections of the fresco rained down on everyone’s heads.

“Uh, careful, He-Man!” Duncan warned. “Let’s not accidentally destroy the castle and everyone in it!”

“Yeah, most powerful man in the universe!” Zhe-La/Veth mocked. “Try not to end up killing the very people you claim to be protecting!”

He-Man/Shen watched the effect the Nephraeh’s taunts had on this universe’s version of his father—expecting to see a wild rage—he was surprised to watch a good-natured grin spread across He-Man’s face.

“That is especially good sense coming from one of Skeletor’s lackeys! I might take it into consideration!” He said as Battle Cat leaped at the Nephraeh Champion.

“Wait! There is someone named ‘Skeletor’ on this world?” Zhe-La/Veth said, dodging out of the way. “So, is he like a skeleton?”

“No, he’s not all skeleton,” Teela spoke up. “He has a normal body, just a skull head under a cowl—don’t ask me how that happened.”

Everyone paused in the struggle to stare at Teela—who only shrugged sheepishly.

“I’m sure they know what their master looks like, young one,” Duncan said. “You don’t have to describe the vile Skeletor to them!”

“So, wait,” Zhe-La/Veth said, knocking He-Man off the back of Battle Cat with a backhanded slap. “If this Skeletor has a skull head—how does he eat? Wouldn’t the food just fall out the bottom of his jaw?”

He-Man leaped up from the ground to seize the Nephraeh Champion’s wrists, causing them to drop their sword. The two grappled as one attempted to gain the advantage over the other in a contest of strength.

“You know, I never really thought about that one,” He-Man said in a strained voice. “Perhaps you can ask him after you are all cast into the void together!”

Just as He-Man/Shen was attempting to go to his fellow Champion’s aid, the massive form of Battle Cat blocked his path.

“Now, now. Fight fare!” The feline beast growled, exposing canines the size of short swords.

He-Man/Shen ducked and backed away from more swipes as He-Man’s faithful mount attempted to cut him to ribbons. Frustration coursed through him as an urgent need to be at Zhe-La/Veth’s side bade him to use a more rigorous fighting method. Pointing his blade at Battle Cat, He-Man/Shen allowed a small portion of his power to lance out, striking the beast in the form of jagged

lightning. Battle Cat yowled in pain as the bolt struck him in the flanks, instantly rolling on the ground to smother his singing fur.

"Battle Cat!" He-Man roared.

Spurred on by hearing his friend's cries, He-Man lifted Zhe-La/Veth bodily from the ground to hurl them into the same column He-Man/Shen had struck. It crumbled as the Nephraeh Champion connected with it, the upper portion of the stone support separating from the ceiling to tip towards the king and queen.

"Watch out!" He-Man/Shen shouted.

Leaping under the falling support, He-Man/Shen halted its descent before it could pulverize the Eternian royals—who crouched as the crushing weight sat inches above their heads. Shifting the weight away from the king and queen, He-Man/Shen placed it upon the ground with a massive exhalation of breath—turning—he found He-Man, Teela, and Duncan regarding him with curious expressions.

"Agents of Snake Mountain would have taken every opportunity to kill our royalty—not save them. Who are you, really?" Duncan asked.

He-Man/Shen glanced at his companion; Zhe-La/Veth was picking themselves out of the rubble and shaking caked dust from their slender form. Sensing the human's eyes upon them, they shrugged, tossing their topknot ponytail in a way He-Man/Shen recognized as saying *Whatever, Human. Go ahead and tell them the truth.*

He grinned to himself, recognizing what it meant that the two of them had become so familiar with one another in such a short time.

"That's a long story," He-Man/Shen said, beginning his explanation.

* * *

In comparison to being cast adrift in the omniverse by a demi-god, the sensation of dimensional translation had a much more stable feeling from the back of an Ethyreal—but the end result was the same; Adora found herself once squinting against the glare of an alien sun as she exited the interdimensional stitch. The feeling of disorientation was still present but more subdued now that she was aware of what was happening; Adora cast about, taking in the landscape of their new location.

Before her was a wide-open plain, the vast tract running far into the distance only to be halted by a wall of jagged peaks. Crisscrossing the verdant green fields was a pair of rivers, both of which ran on opposite sides of a mighty butte sitting in the center of the sweeping expanse. At the top of this flat rock was another city—but unlike the last one Adora had visited—this city was very familiar to her.

"That's Eternos, right? You guys brought us back to Eternia? Did Shen and Veth not get shot off into space and time like me and Adora did?" Catra asked.

"No, this isn't our Eternia," Adora answered, catching a glimpse of something in the distance. Creeping over the mountain range was a storm—dark clouds bloated by malicious intent seemed to reach for the city of Eternia as purple lightning bolts arced down to smite the mountains.

"*We must hurry,"* Battle Cat said. *"Lethe's power has reached this reality—soon, it will all be lost!"*

* * *

"So let me get this right, your He-Man?" Duncan said, not hiding his doubt.

He-Man/Shen sighed. *Perhaps I should have left that part of the story out.* He thought to himself.

"After everything Shen told you—that we had been cast out from another dimension as we tried to stop a demi-god from taking over all realities—*that is the part you are having a hard time with?"* Zhe-La/Veth asked.

He-Man/Shen did not regard Duncan's reaction to the Nephraeh's words—instead, his eyes were set on He-Man. With two heavily muscled arms crossed over a broad chest, he observed the interplay, having not said a single word during He-Man/Shen's explanation. Taking what he knew of Adam from his universe, He-Man/Shen assumed this version must be sizing him up, recognizing a potential rival who could challenge his power. But his assertions were soon proved incorrect as He-Man finally spoke.

"Well, it's a pretty fantastical story, I will admit. But I know other dimensions exist, for I traveled to one—the Timeless Dimension, it was called. That's where the Trollan home world resides," he said.

"You've been to the Timeless Dimension too?" He-Man/Shen said excitedly.

"It's most likely not the same one we visited, *Human,*" Zhe-La/Veth said, annoyed.

He-Man/Shen ignored the Nephraeh's words, taking to this relatable element between himself and this universe's He-Man.

"Wait—were you able to summon He-Man there?" He asked.

The other He-Man nodded. "Yes, I had to say my words of activation backward,"

He-Man/Shen shot a smug expression of triumph at Zhe-La/Veth, who only rolled their silver eyes.

"That's good you were able to achieve it—my version of He-Man couldn't manage to say them backward and was practically useless to me in the Timeless Dimension. I had to carry him out over my shoulder," Zhe-La/Veth said, giving He-Man/Shen a wicked smile.

“So, what now?” Teela spoke up. “Do you believe them, He-Man?”

Striding over to where He-Man/Shen stood, the other He-Man took a moment to regard him before nodding his assent.

“Yes, Teela. If I wasn’t just going by his actions alone, I can see great heroism in this man. I believe he is also He-Man,” he said, holding out his hand.

A strange sense of pride struck He-Man/Shen at hearing the other man’s words—he reached out to seize the proffered wrist as He-Man gripped his in a warrior’s greeting.

“What about this one?” Duncan asked, pointing at Zhe-La/Veth. “I’ve been around a long time, and I’ve never heard of their species nor of a Champion called Zhe-La,”

“Do you vouch for them?” He-Man asked his counterpart.

He-Man/Shen made a show of considering the prospect as the Nephraeh Champion shot daggers in his direction—with a laugh—he finally nodded.

“Yeah, I guess,” He-Man/Shen said with a shrug. “We are *partners,* after all,”

At the suggestion of their pairing, Zhe-La/Veth’s look of hostility was quickly replaced by causal air—He-Man/Shen noticed that they were being more aloof than usual. He attempted to dismiss the doubt creeping into his mind, wanting to concentrate on more important matters—namely—finding a way into Subternia and defeating Lethe. But such solid control over the darker aspects of the psyche had always eluded He-Man/Shen, leaving him at the mercy of his emotions.

Feeling someone watching him, He-Man/Shen glanced back to find Zhe-La/Veth’s silver eyes on him, their face now lined with mild concern.

Focus Human, they said in his mind suddenly. **I told you we would talk later, and I mean it.**

It was the first time he had experienced the psychic communication between Champions of Grayskull, and the intrusion of it caught him off guard. It also acted like a dose of cold water, shocking him out of a morose downward spiral. He-Man/Shen nodded at the Zhe-La/Veth before returning to the king and queen—both appearing as if they were still recovering from their near-death experience.

"I beg your pardon, your majesties. I apologize for the destruction brought into your presence, and I hope you can forgive Veth and myself," he said, kneeling.

Glancing over at his companion standing with their arms crossed, He-Man/Shen summoned a small portion of his power, using it to speak to the other Champion telepathically.

This would be an excellent time to give that Nephraeh pride a rest and kneel, Veth. We need their help, he sent.

With a faint hint of amusement, Zhe-La/Veth did as they were bid, coming to kneel next to He-Man/Shen before the rulers of Eternia. The queen was the first to respond, coming before the two Champions to place a gentle hand on both their armored shoulders.

"We should be the ones to apologize—you had come to us for help, and not only did we forsake you, but attacked you as well. Please rise," she said generously.

"Hear, hear!" The king said. "We will help the best we can! Perhaps Orko will know of some magic that can help you get back to your own dimension."

He-Man/Shen noticed that Duncan, Teela, and He-Man all shared wry amusement at this suggestion—the doubt plain on all their faces. Perhaps this universe's version of Orko used dark magic as

his did—He-Man/Shen hoped their fate did not rest on what he knew of Trollan magic.

"I think I might know someone a little more reliable, your highness," He-Man spoke up. "The Sorcer—"

One of the royal guards interrupted He-Man as she burst into the chamber; her panicked eyes darting about the chamber.

"There is something terrible coming!" She cried.

"Calm yourself, Andra!" Duncan said, seizing the guard by the shoulders. "What is coming?"

Andra shook her head, appearing completely inconsolable in her fear.

"I've never witnessed it's like before! You must see for yourself!" She said, beckoning to be followed.

Everyone followed Andra out of the throne room and through the corridors of the Royal Palace; as they ran, He-Man/Shen could make out a tumultuous uproar, steadily increasing in volume the closer they came to the entrance. He soon discovered the source of the noise as they exited the golden double doors; it was the combined voices of Eternos' citizens, all raised in panic and focused on a single source. Following the direction of hundreds of pointing fingers, He-Man/Shen identified the cause for such pandemonium.

What appeared like a wall of black clouds was creeping over the distant mountain range towards Eternos. Unlike the usual billowy and vaporous objects which floated in the sky, these clouds oozed down over the peaks, seeming to flow like a river toward the city. Violet lighting streaked out before the oncoming storm, either arcing toward the sky or dancing upon the ground, appearing like the feelers of some massive horrible insect.

"By Keldor's Black Bones—what is that?" Duncan exclaimed.

“This is Skeletor’s doing; it must be!” King Randor.

He-Man/Shen didn’t know who Skeletor was but doubted it was his handiwork. Glancing at his Nephraeh companion, He-Man/Shen saw recognition in their silver eyes—they knew this power.

“No, this is not Skeletor’s handiwork,” Zhe-La/Veth breathed. “It’s Lethe; they are taking over *everything*,”

Just as He-Man/Shen was about to reply, the sight of two large creatures bounding toward them along the grand processional caught his attention. As they neared, astonishment bloomed on He-Man/Shen's face—he recognized the purple and blue feline creature as well as the green and yellow one running next to them. Even more familiar were the two women riding on their backs: one a human with short blonde hair, the other a Madgēcot—her long stone-gray hair streaking behind her.

“That’s Catra and Adora,” Zhe-La/Veth breathed.

“Oh, wow, and here I was with my plain old human vision. I couldn’t see that for myself. Thank goodness there is a Nephraeh here to help me,” He-Man/Shen said.

Duncan interrupted the long-suffering stare the Nephraeh Champion gave He-Man/Shen, drawing his mace with one smooth motion to hold it out towards the newcomers.

“You know these two? Are they friend or foe?” He asked.

“Easy, my good man,” Zhe-La/Veth said, gently pushing down the weapon. “They are on our side—Champions of Grayskull, just like us,”

Duncan nodded up to the Nephraeh Champion as Melog and Battle Cat came to a screeching halt—both Catra and Adora leaped down to run up to their lost friends, relief mixed with urgency on both faces.

“Thank Etheria, we found you!” Adora said, grasping Zhe-La/Veth’s hand.

“And it looks like not a moment too soon!” Catra added.

Right away, Battle Cat pounced on He-Man/Shen, knocking him onto his back as they licked his face.

“Okay! Okay! I missed you too, pal!” He said, laughing.

“*I knew you were not dead, Shen! I knew it!*” They exclaimed between licks.

Catra approached as He-Man/Shen climbed back to his feet, giving a playful punch to one of his broad arms.

“You were right, Veth; we got this dummy back,” she said, grinning wide.

“So, what now? Will you all help us turn back the tide of this darkness? Will you fight by my side?” Asked He-Man.

Catra and Adora simultaneously balked as they laid eyes upon this reality’s version of He-Man, both women looking uncertainly between He-Man/Shen and his more scantily clad counterpart.

“Is that who I think it is?” Catra said, frowning.

He-Man/Shen stepped forward to lay a hand on the other He-Man’s shoulder. From what little he had seen of this version of Adam, he knew he was nothing like his father—this Adam exemplified everything He-Man/Shen strove to embody.

“It’s not him,” he said. “Guys, this is He-Man—he is a Champion of Grayskull, just like us,”

Catra and Adora took a second to absorb this; He-Man/Shen was certain they were reliving the moments when they had to face the Shen’Aan-war. He had come close to enacting his plan of bringing the God of Death into their universe and using that limitless power

to erase both of their personalities—it wasn't something someone could easily forgive and forget.

"If that's what you say, Shen, then it's good enough for us," Adora said as Catra nodded in agreement. He-Man/Shen turned back to his counterpart, regret written on his face.

"I'm sorry, He-Man, but to fight this evil, we must leave this place and find a way back into Subternia." He said.

He-Man nodded graciously, appearing to have already expected this answer.

"I understand; if there is anything you need, I will do everything in my power to help you," he said.

He-Man/Shen was surprised by the overwhelming amount of gratitude toward this man who appeared so much like his father. Fighting to control the emotions threatening to overcome him, he turned his attention back to Catra and Adora.

"Can we use whatever means you used to get here to enter Subternia?" He asked.

Melog responded, speaking in a language of yowls as Catra listened with perked ears. Before he could use his He-Man power to understand them, Melog had finished, and He-Man/Shen was left to stare expectantly at Catra.

"They said it is not possible for them to enter Subternia; we can only get there by going to Castle Grayskull and entering through the Concurrence—or the Vestibule, as I heard Micah call it," she said.

Meaningful glances were exchanged between the four misplaced Champions before She-Ra/Adora spoke up.

"So, we go back to Eternia and fight our way back into Castle Grayskull—we did it before, and we do it again," she said.

As soon as she finished speaking, a low rumble came from the oncoming storm; it was not far, now looming close to the city like a great wave of wickedness. Within its tenebrous mass, He-Man/Shen could make out a lithe form reaching out hungrily for them all.

“I can get you to Castle Grayskull,” He-Man said, breaking the spell of dread suffusing everyone’s spirit.

“That’s right,” He-Man/Shen exclaimed. “There should be a Castle Grayskull here too! There must be an access to Subternia there as well!”

He-Man nodded. “Yes. But it is best if I go with you; the Sorceress may not like a bunch of strangers showing up on her doorstep.”

Chapter End Notes

FYI, chapter 73 and the Epilogue will be post this Friday, 7/28!

Illustration of Catra and her overly enthusiastic cosplayer by Henar, a.k.a ilikeyoucatradora.

Champions of Grayskull

Chapter Summary

The final chapter and conclusion to She-Ra: The Lost.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The strange memories continue to assail them as they attempt to accumulate power; at first, the recollections are like annoying insects—easily swatted away and dismissed. But now, they beat upon their consciousness like a hailstorm, battering away at their resolve with visions like hunks of ice. They can no longer push forward with the visage of a handsome Madgēcot haunting them at every turn.

"We should tell the League of Kalosyni about our relationship—immediately!" He says, his long black ears lowered.

They reach over to brush their long white fingers down the fur of his face; both of them are entwined together in a bunk around his starship, Star Claw, having just consummated a desire for each other that had built over the past few months.

"Is that a good idea? They could rescind our bonds to our Champion Spirits if they find out. Do you want that?" They ask.

Already knowing the answer, they notice that he does not hesitate to answer—one of the many things they love about him.

"I will not hide my love for you—not from anyone! If that means I lose my connection to Sher-Va, then so be it!" He says vehemently, exposing sharp incisors.

They kiss him, then—passionately—before nodding their assent.

"Yes, you are right. We will go straight away and tell them!" They say.

He smiles at them, his marbled-furred face practically beaming with happiness.

"How about you and I head to Elysia after we tell them? I want to be bonded to you in front of the Great Chaliendra Tree…"

THAT WAS A TULMUTUOUS TIME FOR ME. SO AFRAID OF LOSING MY CONNECTION TO ZHE-LA YET FEELING SO MUCH JOY. I WISH I HAD KNOWN THEN IT WAS ONE OF THE HAPPIEST MOMENTS OF MY LIFE

They force this image from their mind but cannot escape the feeling of longing which accompanies it. Before they have a chance to return their attention to their great task, another reminiscence seizes their concentration.

"I'm so sorry to have to give you this news, but you have a disease called the Kamajor. I wouldn't have believed it if I hadn't read the results myself—we have not seen a case of the Kamajor since the Dark Times,"

They regard the love of their life as he takes in the news, his long black ears drooping as the Madgēcot physician issues the proclamation of his doom.

"I'm sure the Madgēcots have made great strides in medicine since the Dark Times; surely there is a cure by now!" They say.

The Madgēcot physician shakes her head. "No. There is no cure for the Kamajor. At his current rate of deterioration, he has perhaps a year of life left—if you're lucky,"

I REMEMBER THIS DAY AS IF IT WERE YESTERDAY. HOW COULD I NOT? IT WAS ONE OF THE WORST DAYS OF MY LIFE

The longing turns to disquiet as they turn from this vision, only to be confronted by another.

Zzar lifts the box from the pedestal; it is the most beautiful and intricate thing they have ever seen—they could identify numerous separate metals in its making, all fitted together in an almost labyrinthine union. It appeared that the different sections could be separated from one another, giving the box an almost mechanical aspect. There was a presence to this object, a great weight of significance which also conveyed great age.

Holding it out reverently, Zzar offers this wondrous artifact to them.

"This the Shlihm-bess'a-rune. Using forgotten technology, it was made before the Dark Times to enhance the magic within the user to heights beyond reckoning. Not only are you half magical by nature, but you are also Zhe-La—the Shlihm-bess'a-rune can use that to heal the one you love!" She exclaims.

They take the metallic box into their hands, tracing a finger over the fine lines of its hard surface.

"It sounds almost too good to be true. What is the catch?" They ask.

There is a faint upturn of Zzar's lips before she speaks—a ghost of a smile.

"Yes, there is a price to be paid—but it is small. The Shlihm-bess'a-rune is a magical machine and works in mysterious ways. It is fueled by the user's most positive attribute—it harnesses this trait to enact its miracles."

They frown at this—it doesn't sound so bad. What harm could there be in using something good to do good?

"Show me how it works," they say.

OH, ZZAR. HOW MANIPULATIVE YOU WERE. I LOOK BACK ON THIS AND WONDER: WAS SHE TAKING ADVANTAGE OF AN OPPORTUNITY? OR HAD SHE ORCHESTRATED THE WHOLE THING? MAKING SOMEONE SICK IS NOT BEYOND THE MEANS OF THE GASTROLITH OF DECAY

They feel like they are falling now, a great plummeting descent into a yawning abyss of despair. Why do they feel like they are witnessing the beginning of their downfall? What is this?

Running their white fingers over the grooves of the Shlihm-bess'a-rune's surface, they move the different sections of the artifact into the correct configuration—just as Zzar had shown them. The metallic box whirrs and clicks as unknown mechanisms align within, activating the arcane elements of the device.

A low, deep feeling pervades the bed chamber as the Shlihm-bess'a-rune activates—all they must do is allow the magic to connect with them, and the love of their entire existence would be made whole once more.

"Are you sure this is safe?" He says in a hoarse whisper from the bed. He is so hard to look at now; his body is so thin and weak, the majority of his flesh exposed with the departure of so much fur. They would do anything to save him—ANYTHING.

"Yes, my love. Everything will be fine; you'll see," they say, pressing down on the activation panels and initiating the process.

Abruptly they feel the Shlihm-bess'a-rune seize hold of something within them—not their physical body—but the other aspect of themselves. It is a strange sensation, but they can feel it taking from them—not in small increments like Zzar had made it out to be—but in great heaps, like a starving being allowed access to a great feast. They begin to feel doubt then, but as quickly as it starts, it is over, and a great gasp draws their attention back to the bed.

Where a thin, emaciated shell once existed—now—a vibrant and alive Madgēcot now lay; he peers down with wide green eyes as he examines strong arms once more covered by fur.

"You did it! It's a miracle!" He says, overjoyed.

They smile back at him, feeling strange that expression does not come so willingly.

"Everything will be just as it was, my love. You'll see," they say.

BUT IT WASN'T THE SAME, WAS IT? I HAD ONLY DAMNED MYSELF IN ORDER TO FORSTALL HIS FATE. IF I COULD DO IT ALL OVER AGAIN, I WOULD HAVE STILL USED THAT CURSED DEVICE TO SAVE HIM— BUT ASSURED MY OWN DEATH IN THE PROCESS. MY LIFE FOR HIS

They shake the echo from their head, gritting their teeth against the invasion of more unwanted memories.

"NO!!!" They try to shout into the chaos of Subternia. "I don't care; stop showing me these visions!"

Their words travel no farther than their lips, for there is no sound in this realm—but the rising dread remains, threatening to overwhelm them. At the outskirts of their awareness, they sense a presence amongst the dizzying array of realities lying before them.

A spark of hope blossoms in their chest as they somehow recognize this individual—it awakens a long-forgotten passion within them, sapping the will to continue with their great task.

YOU HAVE COME SO FAR—STRUGGLED SO LONG. BUT MORE POWER IS NOT WHAT YOU WANT

They feel this presence is drawn to them; it—no, HE—is coming for them, drawn toward them across space and time to be with them once more. The desire within transforms into an immense

yearning that threatens to overwhelm them with a single word, one they are unable to pronounce but somehow know.

JIHAN

A crack appears in the once shiny grand facade of their self-deception, and a word forms in their mind. One that they had worked so hard to forget.

Jihan.

They turn back to the task at hand—frantic now—desperate to be free of the icy tendrils worming into their incorporeal form. What they need so badly is close now; they can sense it, its approach heralded by such an intense desiderium that they would rather perish than withstand another moment of existence.

YOU ARE RIGHT; IT IS CLOSE. THE END IS NEAR

Their ascension is close at hand; all they have to do is…

* * *

Sher-Va/Catra clung tightly to the back of Melog's scruff as the Ethyeal bounded across the wasteland—glancing back over her shoulder, she could make out the tempest of evil—creeping just over the horizon after them.

"Looking back at it won't make us go any faster, Catra," She-Ra/Adora said from behind her, giving her midsection a gentle squeeze.

"Yeah, well, I'd like to know where that creepy storm is," she replied, turning to gaze forward one more.

Running just abreast of Melog was Battle Cat—He-Man/Shen, and Zhe-La/Veth mounted on their back. Next to them, He-Man was mounted heroically upon his version of Battle Cat; he pointed toward the distance—there—Sher-Va/Catra watched as a distinctive green shape began to appear.

“There it is,” He-Man said proudly. “Castle Grayskull”

As it came fully into view, Sher-Va/Catra was not surprised to discover that it was the exact same copy of the foreboding castle she had last seen—for all she knew, they could have been right back on the Eternia of her dimension.

All three mounts came to a halt before the skull-like visage of Castle Grayskull as all five Champions dismounted, walking together towards the imposing gate. With the sound of creaking metal gears emanating from deep with the green stonework, the heavy door began to yawn open, the top end crashing to the opposite side of a wide chasm to form a bridge.

“If I had any doubts about you before, they now have been banished,” He-Man said. “Castle Grayskull does not open for those with evil intent in their hearts. Come, the Sorceress is waiting inside.”

Passing quickly through a long foyer, Sher-Va/Catra found herself in a wide-open hall; pouring down from an unseeable source above, weak light rested upon a circle of seven statues, much like the version from her universe. But the figures represented in stone were different from the ones she had glimpsed on the way to stop Lethe—but that made sense—this universe would have different Bearers of the Staves of Ultimate Powers.

“Very insightful, Catra,” a rich female voice said.

An outlandish woman appeared from around one of the statues—dressed in a white and blue leotard made of feathers, she sported a cape of even larger orange feathers attached to both her arms, giving the appearance of wings. Completing the appearance of a mighty avian, a bird headdress sat atop her head—she peered shrewdly at the trespassers before nodding in greeting to He-Man.

“They were my friends and fellow Bearers,” she said. The woman held up a gold staff, at the top which sat a bird, its wings outstretched.

“Is the weird bird lady the Sorceress?” Sher-Va/Catra asked.

Cat-Tra! Be respectful! Jihan scolded.

The Sorceress laughed at this and nodded. “Yes, Catra. I am the Sorceress and Keeper of Secrets for Castle Grayskull.”

“How do you know her name?” She-Ra/Adora asked.

The Sorceress turned to pin She-Ra/Adroa with her eyes as an unknown emotion passed briefly over her features. Sher-Va/Catra thought she saw sadness there—but as quickly as it appeared—it was gone, replaced by a wall of stoicism.

“This universe had lost much in regard to what it once had; where once there were seven Champions and seven Staff Bearers, now there is only He-Man and myself. I have used my power to delve deep into the mysteries of Grayskull in search of ways to reclaim our glory—during these explorations—I discovered the nature of Subternia. I know all about you, Adora, where you truly came from and what your life was supposed to be.” She said.

Sher-Va/Catra caught the yearning on her wife’s face—she knew how much She-Ra/Adora wanted to know where she originated from before Hordak found her—both of them had. Finding out where she had come from had given Sher-Va/Catra a great deal of closure—she never knew how much she had needed it.

She-Ra/Adora quickly waved a hand, shaking her head. “That’s not important right now. We must get back into Subternia and stop Lethe before they sink all realities into evil!”

The Sorceress smiled at this. “Yes, you are right, Champion. I feel the growing power of Lethe—not just in Subternia—but here on Eternia as well! You are right to urge expediency!”

Turning with a whirl of her feathered cape, the Sorceress strode out from within the circle of statues to the nearby wall. Waving her Staff of Power, an opening appeared; she indicated the others follow before she disappeared within. Expecting to find a vast

crystalline chamber inside, Sher-Va/Catra was surprised to see only a small room—the only furnishing a large octagonal mirror sitting upon a simple stand.

"Every reality has a copy of Castle Grayskull, but the methodology of entering the realm of Subternia is different. In your reality, there is a chamber deep under the castle where all seven Champions must be present to open the way. But here—" she said, indicating the mirror. "There is the Mystic Mirror."

"That seems VERY dangerous to have such power so easily accessed," Zhe-La/Veth noted.

The Sorceress nodded. "Yes, it would be if that was all you needed. In order to open the gate through the mirror, you must be given leave by the Keeper of Secrets—me,"

"Still seems kind of reckless," Zhe-La/Veth whispered to He-Man/Shen.

"Come! We don't have much time—the Storm of Apathy will soon be upon us!" The Sorceress exclaimed. Directing the Staff of Power towards the Mystic Mirror, she began to chant, speaking in a language undecipherable by the power of Sher-Va. Shimmering waves appeared on the mirror's surface, radiating outward from the center like a bullseye before the room's reflection disappeared, replaced by an indescribable morass of chaos. Sher-Va/Catra had a hard time gazing upon the raw incorporeality of Subternia—it made her want to be sick.

Easy, young one. *Breathe.* Calm yourself, don't focus on it. Once we are in there, just look for Lethe. Jihan soothed inside her head.

Sher-Va/Catra let out a long breath as fingers clasped her gauntlet—peering down—she found She-Ra/Adora's hand in hers.

"You ready to end this?" Her wife asked.

“You know it,” Sher-Va/Catra responded, cocky grin in place. She noticed Zhe-La/Veth was peering directly into the portal to Subternia, their strange Nephraeh vision seemingly not affected as her Madgēcot sight was.

“Can you make sense of what you see in there, Veth?” She asked.

The Nephraeh Champion nodded. “Yes, I can. But I’m sure it’s hard for the rest of you. Perhaps we should join hands and let me go first—once I locate Lethe, I can guide us to them,”

“Sound like a plan—let’s do it,” He-Man/Shen said, immediately grasping their hand.

Sher-Va/Catra clasped his hand in turn while taking her wife’s in the other—a surprising both women—He-Man took She-Ra/Adora’s free hand, forming the end of the long chain of Champions.

“There is no point in me staying here,” he said. “The best use of my power will be with you—by your side.”

“Glad to have you aboard!” She-Ra/Adora said.

There was an awkward pause as He-Man and She-Ra/Adora regarded each other with curiosity—the energy bouncing back and forth between them making Sher-Va/Catra’s tail itch.

“I cannot explain it, but you seem familiar to me,” He-Man said.

“Yeah! Me too! It’s kinda weird,” She-Ra/Adora responded.

“Concentrate!” Zhe-La/Veth interrupted. “We don’t have time for this—are you all ready?”

Everyone nodded their assent, and the moment was forgotten; turning back towards the open portal, the Nephraeh Champion lifted their leg over the bottom of the mirror as they stepped fully into the realm of Subternia. Sher-Va/Catra felt pulled forward as

He-Man/Shen went next, and before she knew it, the realm of Subternia had subsumed her.

Instantly a feeling of wrongness pervaded the Madgēcot Champion's body as she screwed her eyes shut, holding for dear life to She-Ra/Adora and He-Man/Shen's hands. She felt like she was simultaneously floating and walking, swimming and crawling —everything at once. Nothing made sense to the sensations of her body—and when Sher-Va/Catra opened her eyes—it was even worse.

Complete and total madness greeted her visual senses; it was a skewed viewpoint of absolute totality as Sher-Va/Catra found herself being able to peer into an infinity of realities at once. All of them were laid out before her like an endless kaleidoscope of individual universes—the extent of which hurt her brain to comprehend.

As overwhelming as the visual stimulation was, it was counterbalanced by the complete and absolute absence of sound —which in itself—was wildly unnerving. Sher-Va/Catra knew her long ears must be turning about, almost desperate in the desire to receive even the faintest hint of noise.

Subternia does not exist in three-dimensional reality, Cat-Tra—there is more than just length, width, and height here. Scientists theorized that the dimension beyond the third is time—but that is not the case! It is simply another depth of perspective, and it will take some time to get used to. Jihan soothed.

Sher-Va/Catra tuned in on her mentor's words, letting them calm her as Zhe-La/Veth began to lead their fellow Champions away from the point of ingress. Squinting with hyper-dilated eyes, Sher-Va/Catra spotted their destination—Lethe; they were at an indeterminate distance away, upright with eyes closed and arms spread wide. An aura surrounded their lithe body—the accumulated might they had acquired during their time in this realm of ultimate access. White lids parted to reveal burning

indigo as the five Champions approached the demi-god—Lethe smiled—bringing their full attention to those who dared confront them.

Welcome, Champions of Grayskull, Lethe sent. **Don't bother trying to speak here; it is better if we converse in this manner.**

Sher-Va/Catra was discomforted with having the voice of her enemy speak so easily in her mind; it was an unwanted invasion, and she felt the presence of Jihan surge to defend her.

How dare you pervert the sacred Champion telepathic bond! You have no right to use it anymore! He said.

Lethe blinked suddenly as their eyes alit upon Sher-Va/Catra—there was surprise there, mixed with curiosity.

Ah! What surprises you have, Sher-Va! You have a little ghost friend tucked away in your mind! How quaint! They sent.

He is not just some random ghost, Lethe; it is Jihan! Sher-Va/Catra sent back.

With her focus now wholly on Lethe, the earlier discomfort at being in this realm had disappeared, and Sher-Va/Catra prepared for a fight. Seeing the way Lethe reacted to the name of their murdered lover, she knew one was coming—they shook their head vigorously—as if the act could dispel the unwanted word from within their head. It seemed that in the interim since she had last seen them, Lethe had somehow become reacquainted with his name—a chink in their armor.

Yes! I do know that name—so what? I do not care! They seethed with righteous indignation. **The Shlihm-bess'a-rune liberated me from the need for foolish love—now, I will emancipate myself from all restrictions! All needs! I will be totally free!**

THEY ARE COMPLETELY DELUSIONAL. THEY DO NOT WANT THIS—PLEASE—YOU MUST SAVE THEM FROM THEMSELVES

Sher-Va/Catra felt a strange tingling all over her body as this new voice spoke—just like every time she saw Adora during the war against the Horde. It was a giddy elation mixed with hopefulness—all tingled with a fear that this might be the last chance to make things right. It was coming from within her—from Jihan.

Kishar? Is that you, my love? Jihan said.

YES! I'M HERE! PLEASE, RELEASE ME

Sher-Va/Catra spotted confusion on the faces of her fellow Champions, indicating to her that they heard the voices of Kishar and Jihan. Somehow, being in this place beyond all space and time had elevated the Champion telepathic bond to the point it was not limited to the living. Beyond all logic, two lovers separated by death were now speaking—the wonder of it sent chills down Sher-Va/Catra's spine

Enough! Lethe interjected. **This little reunion is touching, but there will be no release for anyone but me! There is one thing standing in your way—ME!**

Lethe, please. I know you have been feeling doubt about your course of action—if not—then why have you not taken everything for yourself yet? You know why. Jihan sent.

The uncertainty that crossed Lethe's porcelain features was plain to see as they lifted a hand to their chest, absentmindedly laying their black claws there.

YOU ARE RIGHT, JIHAN. THEY ARE WRACKED WITH DOUBT. IT'S BEEN EATING AWAY AT THEM LIKE—

Silence!!! Lethe practically screamed into the mind link. **I will show you doubt—HERE!!!**

Since she was the one who bore Jihan, Sher-Va/Catra was not surprised when Lethe went for her first, sending the torrent of violet fire that destroyed Dinala Katan in her direction. The conflagration was too broad and fast for even a Champion to escape, but before it could sear the flesh from her bones, a wall of Light appeared, stopping the flame inches from Sher-Va/Catra's nose.

She turned slowly to spot Zhe-La/Veth with hands outstretched as they guided the Light projecting from their chest, forming it into a protective barrier. As the power of Lethe blasted against their shield, Sher-Va/Catra could see that it was affecting the Nephraeh Champion—their lilac flesh became waxy and dull, creating a kind of translucence in the exposed portions of their body. Zhe-La/Veth gritted their teeth as they felt their body deteriorate—they were dying.

No! She-Ra/Adora cried.

Coming up behind the Nephraeh Champion, she seized them about the midsection to rest her head against the back of theirs—instantly—an aurora of healing magic permeated Zhe-La/Veth's form, reinvigorating their previously degrading body.

Thanks, Adora. I think together we can hold them off, Zhe-La/Veth said.

Recognizing the united front against them, Lethe ceased their magical assault as absolute fury blossomed on their beautiful white face. Sher-Va/Catra could imagine there were not too many times during their long life when anyone could stand up to them.

I will just have to take a more physical approach and rip your limb from limb! Lethe screeched, immediately flying towards Sher-a/Catra.

Arcing lighting abruptly seized the wrathful demi-god in a wreath of coruscating power, slowing them to a standstill. They cast

about for the source of the attack, spotting He-Man/Shen with sword held out, directing the might of He-Man at them.

I thought I taught you a lesson the last time you tried that, He-Man, they sent, lifting a hand to point a finger. Sher-Va/Catra winced, expecting the thin lance of Oblivion to once again strike down her friend.

This time there is more than one He-Man to contend with, fiend! He-Man said, placing his hand on the hilt of He-Man/Shen's sword.

Right away, the intensity of the destructive power of He-Man was magnified—Sher-Va/Catra had to look away as the jagged bolts blasted into Lethe's body. They howled into the mind link, making everyone present wince as the incorporeal scream stabbed at the very essence of their souls. Lethe was left sagging as the power dissipated, their giant body floating amongst the epicenter of all realities like a falling leaf.

Now Cat-Tra! Here is your chance! Use the Truth on them! Jihan urged.

Surging forward, Sher-Va/Catra summoned the power of her Champion Avatar—jade fire instantly blazed on both of her clawed gauntlets—both of which reached out for Lethe. Her eyes briefly passed over the deadly razor claws, imagining them plunging into her body as she went to grasp the sides of their head.

No! Lethe cried, their blazing eyes opening as they seized Sher-Va/Catra's wrists. **You will pay for this miscalculation, Madgēcot! Pay with your life!**

Sher-Va/Catra emitted a soundless scream as the strength of a demi-god pulled at her arms, threatening to tear them from their very sockets. She tried to push the power of truth into them via the point of contact—but the connection was faint—the green flames only coursed up to end at Lethe's elbows.

Weak. Lethe taunted as they leered down at their victim. **Perhaps I will turn you into a Vetala? How would you like that? I think you will be the first Madgēcot to join their ranks!**

Sher-Va/Catra howled with rage as she kicked out at Lethe with her foot claws—but the talons on the ends of her toes had no effect, sliding down Lethe's lower thighs. They grinned at her as they pulled Sher-Va/Catra closer, their white lips pulling back to reveal onyx teeth.

Catra! NO! She-Ra/Adora cried. Sher-Va/Catra knew her wife would be coming to her aide—all her friends would be. But it was too late; Lethe had her, and even if they were beaten, she was doomed.

Cat-Tra! I have an idea, but you need to give me control! Jihan urged suddenly.

Control? Over my body? She thought back to him.

Yes! Do it now! Please, before it's too late! He sent back.

Not realizing it was ever even a choice, Sher-Va/Catra felt it then—the gentle letting go which would give the ghost of her mentor command of her very flesh. Remembering her vow and seeing no other choice, Sher-Va/Catra did as he asked, pulling back from the forefront of her consciousness to allow him predominance. She felt his ghost rise up to gently brush past her, seizing the reins that would give him authority over her body.

Immediately Jihan summoned the power of Sher-Va, gathering the magic into the core of Sher-Va/Catra's being—but instead of sending it outward, Jihan pressed it inward—wrapping the long-dead Madgēcot's soul in the conflagration of Truth.

Suddenly back in control of her body, Sher-Va/Catra watched as a fountain of green flames burst forth from her chest, pushing Lethe away and separating them from her. Recognizing the hated magic of Truth before them, Lethe attempted to back away—but it was

too late—the jade torrent followed them as it slowly took the shape of a person Sher-Va/Catra had only seen in visions.

Jihan!!! Sher-Va/Catra pulsed.

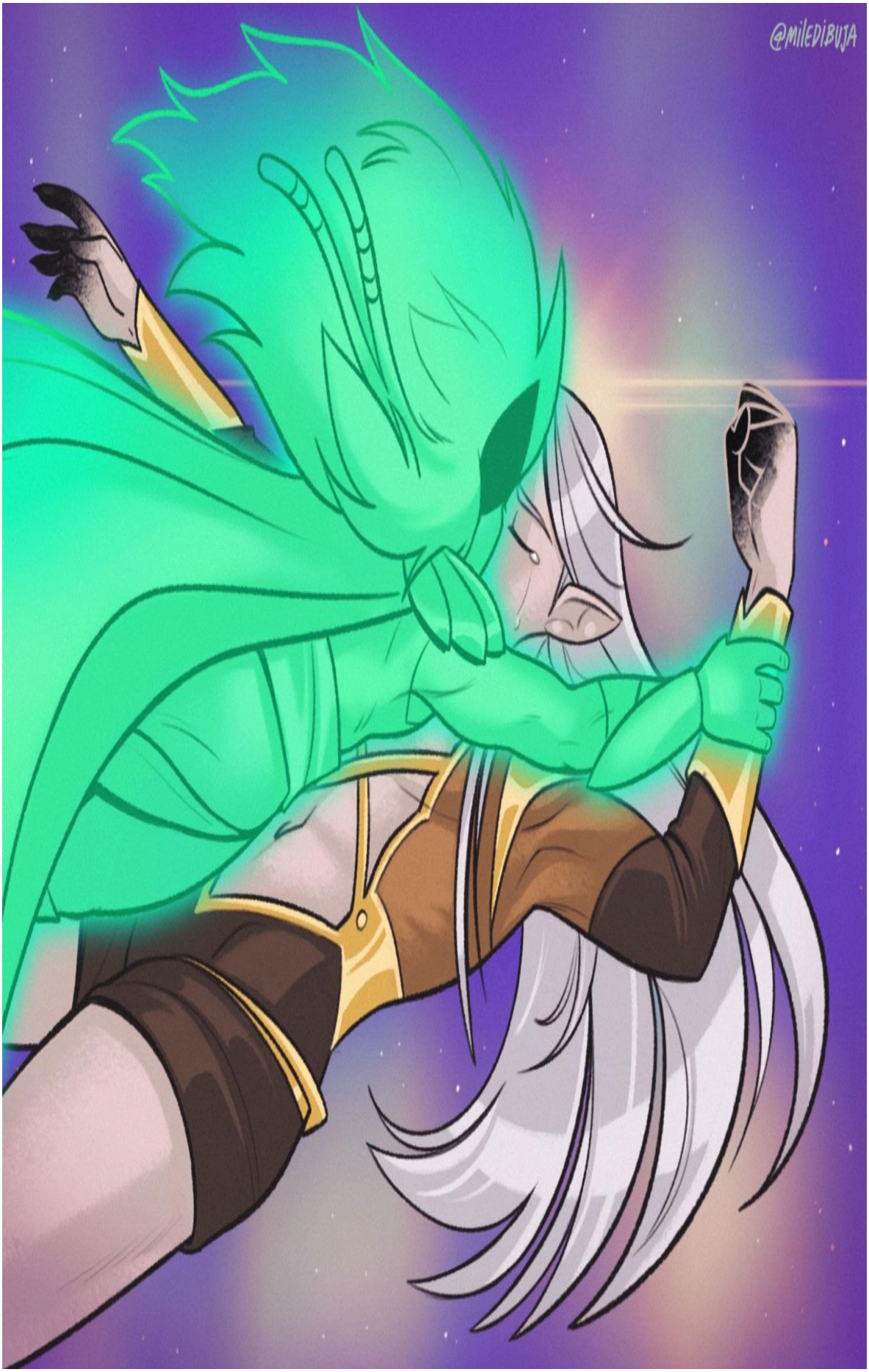
He was in his Sher-Va form, his long cape and tail steaking behind him as he pursued the one who had killed him in a millennium past. Pure unadulterated terror was on Lethe's face as they attempted to bat away this smaller person—but it was no use—their black-stained claws merely passed through the fiery specter of Jihan before them, the long gouges left in his insubstantial body merely congealing back into proper form.

But Jihan was not without substance; he reached out to seize Lethe's wrists, holding them firmly in place as the demi-god struggled—helpless in his grasp. Sher-Va/Catra knew this would not be enough to deliver the power of Truth—he had to connect with the correct chakra to ensure Lethe's eyes were opened.

A strange thing happened then, something for which Sher-Va/Catra was not expecting nor could justify at that moment. Lethe's white face—which up until then had been the aspect of hatred—suddenly softened, becoming more akin to pain as their lips parted. The flaming green specter of Jihan let go of one of their wrists to cup the back of their head, and as the uncertainty of what Sher-Va/Catra's mentor was about to do turned into absolute incredulity, he leaned in.

And kissed them.

Lethe's face became passionate as they returned the kiss as a thousand years' worth of yearning and desire was expressed in a single tear, running down their porcelain face—glittering like a diamond.


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Sher-Va/Catra watched open mouth as the power of Truth entered Lethe, burning out the apathy which had taken hold of their heart so long ago, scoring it away like so much grime on the luster of compassion. A beautiful radiance emanated between the reunited lovers, a magical illumination Sher-Va/Catra now knew as Light. It pulsed three times before erupting outwards like an explosion, a supernova of reignited love that blasted into Subternia. The maddening chaos of infinity abruptly seized in a frozen moment before shattering like a pane of glass, and Sher-Va/Catra felt herself falling as a new place came into existence around her; a vast gem-studded cavern, seven mighty pylons in a circle upon a crystalline plinth—the Vestibule.

All five Champions floated down gently, finally coming to rest on the chamber floor as the frozen fragments of Subternia tinkled around them, sounding like tiny bells. All five sets of eyes lay upon the sight before them: the spectator of Jihan on his knees, cradling a now much smaller form in his lambent green arms. Gone was the black staining as they reached up with pristine fingers, running them tenderly down the cheek of Jihan. Gone, too, was the indigo of apathy as they gazed up at their savior with golden, tear-streaked eyes brimming with love.

It was Kishar.

"You came for me across the gulf of death, space, and time, Jihan. *You saved me!*" They said in a whisper.

Sher-Va/Catra did not need medical expertise to notice that the ancient Nephraeh was on death's door; it was apparent in the tiredness of their expression and in the weak state of their withered body. They did not have long, already having extended their life beyond all mortal boundaries.

"Yes, Kishar. I never gave up on you. Never!" Jihan said, bringing the emaciated form up in an embrace. The tenuous thread of life finally failed Kishar then; they dissolved in a misty haze of Light, passing through Jihan's glowing fingers like so much smoke. The previous bearer of Sher-Va focused on his protégé then; Sher-

Va/Catra noticed the spectral tears in his eyes were matched by the physical ones of her own.

“Thank you, Cat-Tra.” He said.

Before she could respond, Jihan’s incorporeal form dissipated, dispersing into fumes that followed the course in which Kishar took.

“You’re welcome, Jihan,” she whispered to his departing spirit. In her heart Sher-Va/Catra knew that she had succeeded; Jihan and Kishar would move on into the next phase of existence to be reunited once more. A hand clasped hers as a wracking sob overcame her body, looking up, Sher-Va/Catra found her wife gazing into her eyes.

“When it comes to saving everything and everyone, we sure do keep upping the ante. Don’t we?” She-Ra/Adora said.

Sher-Va/Catra laughed as she took her wife by the hands, pulling her in for a long, passionate kiss.

“I will say things are very interesting with you guys. For one, I’ve never seen anyone defeated by a kiss,” He-Man said, pulling himself to his feet.

“Perhaps you can try it on that Skeletor guy the next time you see him,” Zhe-La/Veth said with a scandalous wink.

“What—why would I do that?” He-Man stammered, his face turning crimson.

Four Champions shared a laugh at this; the past dire moments of uncertainty were expelled in a single release of shared mirth. Sher-Va/Catra spotted Perfuma and Scorpia nearby; the two Princesses caught up in their own reunion as they held each other in a loving embrace.

“We should do this more often,” He-Man/Shen said, giving the other He-Man a friendly pat on the shoulder. “Now that we know

these interdimensional team-ups are possible."

He-Man nodded. "I like the sound of being part of something—Champions of Grayskull, you call it?"

"Yep. That's it." She-Ra/Adora said, holding out her hand. "Who is with me?"

Four Champions grasped the outstretched hand in unity as Sher-Va/Catra eyed the display wearily, her tail making quick twitching motions behind her.

"I don't know, guys; I'm part of two clubs already, the Best Friends Squad and the Super Pal Trio. I don't think it's fair to them if I join another," she said.

Three Champions rolled their eyes as He-Man nodded, unfamiliar with Sher-Va/Catra's antics.

"*Okay, fine,*" the female Madgēcot said in mock exasperation. "I'll be part of your club,"

Walking up to join the others, Sher-Va/Catra enveloped the top hand in her golden gauntlet, sealing the pact made by the noble warriors.

"Champions of Grayskull—*always.*" She said.


Iria Abella 2023

Chapter End Notes

Illustration of Jihan and Lethe by Miledibuja.

Illustration of the Champions of Grayskull by Iria, a.k.a ilikeyoucatradora.

Epilogue

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The worlds of Eternia and Etheria revolved around each other amongst the vast coldness of space, their movements utterly silent in the soundless void. Each planet was the near reflection of the other, fraternal twins with a deep magical connection, their sagas stretching back countless eons into histories unremembered. Both had seen the rise and fall of countless empires and civilizations, untold disasters of galactic consequence, and, last but not least, near absolute submission under the rule of evil.

The latest near miss with Lethe was no different; for outwardly, each planet looked the same as the day before—but on the surfaces of Eternia and Etheira—*that* was a different matter entirely.

Planet-wide festivities were underway; the recently freed citizens were celebrating their returned empathy—and together—were united in the experience of an existence without it. The horror of the near-total sway of apathy was known to every one of them—as were the names of the ones responsible for delivering them back into the light. As the jubilations raged throughout the days and into the nights, glasses and hands were raised in tribute to these protectors, all directed toward the gathering point of these honored heroes.

Bright Moon.

There, inside and outside the castle by the bay and under the faint glow of the Moon Stone, the largest and most extravagant party was currently underway. The recently reinstated Queen of Etheria had opened her own palace to the citizens of Etheria, wanting them to join their saviors in celebration. Queen Glimmer

had even opened the royal reserves, making vast quantities of food and drink available for the occasion.

This gathering was not limited to those of Etheria or Eternia either, for new friends had come to pay tribute to the heroes; dotted amongst these celebrants, Nephraeh and Madgēcots could be spotted, bringing their own flair for merrymaking to Bright Moon.

It was inside the main audience chamber of the palace that Catra and Adora took a moment for themselves, standing back away from the exuberance to take it all in. Leaning against a pillar as Catra snuggled against her side, Adora spotted Seahawk and Mermista sharing drinks with Entrapta and Hordak; the boisterous rogue was recounting an over-dramatized version of his exploits as Mermista listened with doe eyes. As this questionable and mostly untrue tale was being told, Entrapta appeared as if she was about to fall asleep as Hordak glowered incredulously next to her.

Catra spotted her brother Viraj standing with an orange-furred male Madgēcot, both of them chatting amicably with Scorpia and Perfuma. Nearby, Double Trouble was sulking as Panga pressed up against them—it seemed the effects of short-term enervation had an unforeseen ill-effect on the imp, turning their previously buoyant disposition into something more morose.

Glimmer had filled everyone in on what had happened during their ill-fated attack on Grayskull—the sudden appearance of Death Binders and the ambush of the terrifying Xiggoth. Every single one of them had fallen to the Vetala's fangs, only to be restored once the power of Oblivion had been eradicated with the defeat of Lethe. Inexplicably, the Xiggoth had reverted back into its dormant state and was now locked back up in Grayskull's dungeon—but no one knew what happened to the Death Binders.

Catra knew that if anyone was going to track down those corpse wizards, it would be Panga, the fiery female Madgēcot taking her vendetta against them from the streets of Thenlor and into the

stars. But noticing the state of her lover Double Trouble, Catra doubted her Madgēcot sister would be undertaking such a venture—perhaps when she had a chance—Catra would talk to the imp; maybe what they needed was to join her in a session with Perfuma.

Catra chuckled to herself then, thinking of the number of people needing therapy after what everyone had been through.

"What's so funny?" Adora asked.

"Oh… nothing. Just wondering how long my brother's latest boyfriend is gonna last," Catra answered.

Adora smirked at this as her eyes found more Madgēcots who just happened to be mingling with a group of Nephraeh. Adora spotted Maira amongst the throng; the onyx-furred Madgēcot was getting quite a bit of attention from a certain lilac-skinned Nephraeh whom Adora thought she remembered.

"Hey, Catra. Who is that hitting on Maira over there?" She asked.

After a quick squint, her wife grinned.

"That would be Amah—they were the leader of the Krypteia before it was disbanded. From what I know of them, they are tough—they're gonna have to be to deal with Maira," Catra said.

Something occurred to Adora as she watched the Madgēcots, something that had wiggled its way into her mind before Veth had shown up on Elysia, and everything turned upside down.

"Hey, Catra?"

"Hmm?"

"Do you want to move to Elysia?"

Her wife's head turned suddenly to peer into Adora's eyes—the look quizzical and full of mirth.

“What?!” She laughed. “Why do you want to leave Etheria?”

Adora shrugged. “Oh, I don’t know. You were just so natural there. I just want you to be where you will be the happiest—”

Adora stopped talking as Catra’s hand gripped her chin, the earlier expression having left her heterochromatic eyes to be replaced by absolute sincerity.

“I am happiest wherever you are, dummy,” Catra said before kissing her wife on the lips. Adora’s eyes closed as she enjoyed the feeling of Catra kissing her, knowing there would be time for more now that everything had calmed down. Catra gave her cheek a playful slap as she pulled away, making Adora feel a jolt of giddy excitement.

“Anyway,” Catra continued. “We won’t have to settle for one over the other. Hordak and Entrapta are close to perfecting their portal technology, and soon we can have all the planets connected! Won’t that be crazy?”

Adora thought about the outlandish idea: being able to travel any distance instantaneously—that, combined with Melog and Battle Cat’s abilities to find interdimensional stitches and travel between realities, opened a lot of possibilities.

“Yeah, exciting times ahead of us,” she said, spotting Glimmer and Bow. “I heard Glimmer talking about how there were enough Staff Bearers to create a new League of Kalosyni. What’s that about?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Oh, it’s some stupid thing she read about. It’s some lame group that makes up lame rules and keeps track of the Champions. Just another excuse for Sparkles to try and boss us around,”

Adora shrugged again as her wife crossed her arms, annoyed now.

“I like them to try and tell me what to do,” she grumbled.

“Well, I wouldn’t worry about it too much, Catra,” Adora said, patting her wife’s head. “We need a full roster of Staff Bearers and Champions before Glimmer can fully restore the glory of a thousand years past. We still need to find the two missing staves plus worthy candidates for He-Ro, Wun-Dar, and Thon-Ra.”

Right away, Catra groaned. “Adora, can we just not think about that right now? Let Sparkles worry about that! I just wanna relax!”

Adora turned her attention from Catra and back to the party—spotting Kyle, Rogelio, Lonnie, and Frosta joking around with a little boy—Peric was his name. She wasn’t sure what the story was behind their friendship but was sure it had to do with the rough times they all had—before rescue came in the form of four Champions and three bearers of Staves of Power. She had even heard that the Princess of Snows and her old boss Hordak had become close friends—but stranger things had been known to happen.

Just then, a commotion caught Adora and Catra’s attention as three quadrupeds sprinted through the Main Audience Chamber; Cringer was running in the lead as Melog and Battle Cat gave chase. Based on the joy on the green and yellow tiger’s face, it appeared to be all in good fun—that was until Cringer bumped into Castaspella, knocking over her drink.

“Ugh! Who let these animals in Bright Moon Palace?! She cried in offense.

“Cassie, they’re sentients, not animals. Two are Ethyriel’s, and one is a talking tiger from another dimension.” Micha scolded.

“Besides,” Juliet said, giving Castaspella a new drink. “Queen Glimmer waved all royal decorum for the time being—just relax and enjoy the party!”

Adora gave a small wave when the General of Bright Moon caught her eye—Juliet only responded to the hail with a weak smile. It appeared the General still hadn’t gotten over the fact that she had

tried to lead Adora to her certain death, even though she had been enervated at the time.

Looking around the room at the Nephraeh present, Adora hoped one of them could help the woman learn to forgive herself—Etheria knew there were many people who were going to need absolution in the coming days.

"Hey, Adora," Catra started, pulling Adora out of her reveries. By the tone of her wife's voice, it sounded like something had been on her mind as well.

"Yeah?"

"Back in Subternia, right at the end when Jihan was using the truth on Lethe, they seemed like they were fighting him but then just gave up. What do you think happened? Was it because Jihan was more experienced with using the power of Truth than I am and overpowered them?" Catra asked.

Adora pursed her lips as she thought about the question, taking a moment to take Catra's hand in hers, gently running her fingers over the tips of the black claws.

"I don't think so, Catra. Remember: Jihan had tried to use the magic of Sher-Va on Kishar but ended up dying for it. I think Lethe found the truth on their own at the end, perhaps knowingly or by accident. They could have taken everything, and I mean EVERYTHING—but in the end—all they wanted was forgiveness. To be held by the person they had loved and told everything was going to be okay." Adora said, pulling Catra close to kiss the top of her head. "They kind of remind me of someone else I know…"

Adora felt her wife nuzzle into her neck, all the while emitting a subtle *humph* that she didn't mean.

"Oh no, Adora. Check it out," Catra said, pointing. "Looks like someone found his latest victims,"

Not too far away were Netossa and Spinnerella—both women watching with skeptical expressions as Orko floated before them, wand raised to perform magic.

"That Trollan is such a ham," Catra said as Adora waved her to be silent.

"Now, ladies! Let me introduce you to a minor demon called the Xorgollin!" Orko began. "*From the beyond and through our bond; with a wave of this wand, you must respond!"*

A flash of oily flames followed Orko's incantation; when the smoke cleared, a bulbous fleshy sab appeared—it was hideous—looking to Catra and Adora like a large, inside-out chicken. The Xorgollin emitted an ear-piercing screech as Netossa and Spinnerella turned away, acting as if they would vomit.

The summoned demon scrambled away on two skinny scaley legs —straight into a nearby crowd of Etherians. Immediately there was chaos as people screamed and ran from the creature in their midst, Orko following behind his minion with raised placating hands.

"Don't worry! The Xorgollin is harmless! Just don't stare too long at it, or you will turn to stone!" He cried.

Adora shook her head as she watched this scene take place.

"I heard Glimmer made Orko a member of her Royal Court." She said. Catra let loose a bark of laughter.

"Did she?" Catra said, chuckling. "That's so great!"

Catra's eyes were drawn to a trio in the far corner of the room; Veth, Shen, and the latest newcomer—Adam. The visitor from another dimension had taken a lot of convincing to get him to transition out of his Champion form. From what Catra understood, his identity as He-Man was something of a secret where he came from.

Catra wondered if everyone was super dense from that reality; to all outside appearances, He-Man looked just like Adam—just minus the ugly pink shirt and tight purple pants.

But Adam was not what drew Catra's attention to this group—it was Shen; her friend was the most content she had ever seen him. Catra knew why, of course; Shen was standing with a redeemed version of his father and someone who, as far as she could tell, was his soulmate. A warm feeling suffused Catra's chest, a great welling of contentment that she knew would soon turn into a purr.

Catra noticed Veth whisper something into Shen's ear then, indicating they would like a private moment with him on a nearby balcony. Catra smiled as she watched Veth and Shen excuse themselves from Adam's company, slowly meandering through the crowd to the nearest exit.

"So, Catra," Adora said, bringing her wife's attention back to her.

"Hmm?" Catra said, still purring.

"Remember on Elysia when we were watching those children playing? I asked you what you thought about us having a child." Adora said, slightly nervous.

As if by a spell, Catra was brought back to that moment in time; it was months in the past, but after everything she had been through, it felt like years. Catra had been hesitant about the idea of becoming a mother when Adora had first proposed it—there were still so many parts of herself she had felt were unknown.

There was too much doubt—what if she ended up being just like Shadow Weaver? The words of the bitter old witch had echoed in her mind: "You remind me of myself—you've always have," The idea of bringing a child into the world only to subject it to the same toxicity Catra's adoptive mother had shown her was abhorrent.

But Catra knew better now; she had been put to the test, time and time again. When Catra had lost Adora to Veth's duplicity, instead of spiraling down into an aspect of rage and anger, she had risen to the occasion, learning how to fight as a Madgēcot and learn her people's ways. When Catra was faced with the twisted version of her wife in the form of Despara—instead of giving up—she fought to bring Adora back. When Catra had thought she had lost Shen, instead of giving in to grief, she had become Sher-Ra—the embodiment of Truth. As Sher-Va, Catra had led her people into a war against the Nephraeh—but instead of annihilating the Empyreans—Catra had preached mercy and understanding.

As if in a sudden revelation, Catra realized that was one of the greatest gifts—forgiveness. Not just for others, but for yourself. Catra had forgiven Adora for leaving her and Hordak for his cruelty. She had even forgiveness for Shadow Weaver—but those reprieves had already been granted so long ago.

No, the last person she had yet to forgive was the most important, the most vital if she was going to be a mother to another living being. At that moment, Catra realized that she did forgive herself—not only for what she did during her time in the Horde—but for any mistakes she could make in the future, for in the end, Catra was a person. Someone with frailties. Catra forgave herself not because of what she had accomplished—for forgiveness was not a commodity to be purchased—but simply because she deserved it. Because she loved herself.

The purr intensified in Catra's chest as her smile widened—suddenly overcome with emotion—she wrapped her arms around her wife, nuzzling her face against Adora's soft cheek. At this moment, everything felt right to Catra—all of the past loneliness and despair was dwindling down to an insignificant nub in the face of the torrent of love blossoming inside of her. She wanted to be a mother—and even more than that—she wanted to be a parent with only one person in all existence at her side.

"Yes," she whispered in Adora's ear. "*I want to have a baby with you,"*

* * *

Shen followed Veth down the short corridor leading to one of the palace's many balconies, the Nephraeh's unique and alluring scent mixing with the smell of sea air from the bay.

A glorious view greeted them both as they strode out upon the curved balcony—three moons alit an expanse of rolling forests dotted by rocky pinnacles, the stone towers reaching up towards the sky while casting long soft shadows amongst the treetops.

But this scene of wonder was not what caught Shen's attention: Veth was facing away as they leaned against the balcony railing, glittering eyes cast up towards the heavens, appearing to Shen as one of the billions of stars in the night sky. Veth was perched elegantly as they took in the view—spine arched slightly, their arms crossed as they rested them on the balustrade.

Shen allowed his eyes to fall on the places he had left open in their black jacket—lilac skin exposed as Veth had forgone wearing an undershirt. The white markings which adorned their skin were silver in the moonlight, giving off their own kind of soft radiance.

To say Veth was beautiful was an understatement, but the more Shen watched them, the more he realized something was off—there was a slight tenseness to their lithe form, their aspect pensive. Shen let out a sigh as he took the spot next to them, feeling trepidation as he broke the silence.

"You want to talk?" He asked.

Veth turned to regard Shen then, their previously brooding mien softening as their sliver eyes caught sight of him.

"Yes, I promised after things calmed down that we would talk about *us*," they said.

Their neutral tone made Shen slightly agitated; he hated feeling like he was hanging over a precipice, wanting to get any bad news out in the open as quickly as possible.

"I'm hoping that when you kissed me on Trolla, it wasn't just the stress of the situation that made you do that. It was something more," Shen said.

Veth glanced away then, their eyes glinting in the moonlight as they ran fingers through raven black hair. Shen felt a jolt of fear at the hesitation he saw in them—Veth had never seemed so unsure before.

"No, Human—I mean, Shen. It was not some flight of fancy on my part." They said, sharing a meaningful expression.

Hope returned as Shen permitted himself self a small amount of relief, a small smile appearing on his lips.

"So, what's next for us?" He asked.

Veth pursed their lips as a slightly pained emotion crossed their face.

"Shen, it's not as simple as that—I hope you understand. There is so much baggage regarding Nefeli—so much guilt." They said, making clutching motions at their chest. "So much has happened since they died, I—I have not even had a chance to properly mourn them…"

Shen could almost feel the intense pain he heard in the Nephraeh's voice—it instantly made him feel the shame they had just spoken of. So much was going on inside of this person he had come to care for; so much had been taken and given to them in such a short time—and here he was—wanting more from them. It was selfish.

"I understand, Veth." He began. "You need space, and I will give it to you. I hope you will learn to—"

Shen's words failed him as Veth turned suddenly, gripping his hand urgently.

"No! That's not what I want, Shen. I won't want *space* from you," they said.

Shen felt completely lost then, so unable to keep trying to guess what this person who he had come to love wanted.

"Then what do you want, Veth?" He asked softly.

They turned away again, towards the sky, searching for answers there.

"I am going back to Empyrea after this—to help my people rebuild. There is so much work to be done there, and I want to be there for the renewal of the Nephraeh. Great things will happen there now that our empathy has returned—it will be so beautiful to behold!"

Shen could feel Veth's fingers intertwine with his as they spoke, tenderly intermingled in a union.

"I want you to be there with me to see it," they finished, eyes twinkling.

Veth was smiling at him then, a coy and shy smile that was completely at odds with their typical nature. Shen could see it now, as plainly as if he had the ability to perceive reality as Nephraeh do—this was no fickle indulgence Veth was proposing. They did not just want a brief pleasurable experience before moving on—Veth was in love with him just as much as he was with them. Shen knew that a wonderous adventure lay before him, an undertaking of such a magnitude never believed possible up until now—all he needed was patience. Shen found himself matching Veth's smile with a grin of his own.

"I wouldn't have it any other way," he said.

* * *

“Hey Deras, where do you want this stuff?”

Looking up from his organization of esoteric and most likely cursed amulets, the now Senior Mysticor Acolyte spotted Julius at the open door of the chamber he occupied. The Junior Acolyte was directing a hand cart into the space, struggling as he tried to wedge it through the narrow door.

“Careful, now!” Deras said, rising to assist the other. “I don’t need you getting that stuck and trapping me in here!”

Working in tandem, the two apprentice Sorcerers managed to wiggle the obstruction through the door—Julius stumbling forward as the bulky cart jolted forward with an audible screech. The two shared a grimace as they both noticed the unpleasant and creepy noise, mostly because it fit their current location a little too well—deep below Castle Grayskull, in the extensive dungeon.

“I bet you’re eager to get this inventory done and join one of the many parties taking place,” Julius said, pointing meaningfully in the direction of the surface.

Dera shrugged in response. “Oh, that’s not it. I’m okay down here doing this important work—Micah wants all this categorized before the end of the week. After what we all went through, I think my time is better suited trying to get a handle on all this… *stuff,*”

He waved his hands about the stone-lined room, currently full of arcane and mysterious objects. Besides the lockbox full of amulets, there was a sealed tomb resting in the corner, its top cover adorned with a variation of the She-Ra symbol. Next to that was a cabinet made of bones—lining its shelves were sealed glass jars with nebulous shapes floating amongst the murky liquid within. On the opposite wall was a weapons rack—but instead of swords mounted along its frame—long glass rods sat in their place; glowing stones embedded in their cores.

Those were the items Deras could party identify, for there were even stranger artifacts in the room with him—not to mention the

numerous other chambers down in this dark dungeon. As far as he knew, any one of these objects could spell doom for Eternia, the galaxy, the universe, or even the recently discovered omniverse.

As of late, Dera's nights have been spent tossing in turning as the images of lithe bodies and hideous black teeth tormented his dreams—to say nothing of the dark memories of existence without empathy. He would sell his life in order to protect everyone from such a fate—if that meant staying down here in the dank dungeon while everyone parties—so be it.

"So, Deras," Julius began, wringing his hands. "We've been at this for hours—do you mind if I take a break and partake in the fun?"

The Senior Acolyte cast a brief glance at his subordinate before sighing wearily.

"Yeah. Fine. Go ahead—just make sure you are back here and sober come this morning. We have to crack open that disgusting slimy chamber that holds the Gastrolith of Decay, and I will need your help with placing the wards. Etheria knows we don't want to get sick with whatever is in there."

The junior Acolyte nodded enthusiastically as Deras went back to his tedious work, not catching Julius deftly pocketing something from the cart.

"See you tomorrow, and don't work too hard!" Julius said cheerfully as he exited the room.

"Yeah, yeah. Have fun." Deras grumbled, sitting down to inspect more amulets.

Julius moved quickly away from the chamber as he fingered the boxy metallic shape in his pocket. Once he was at a safe distance, the Junior Acolyte removed his prize to inspect it in the weak light cast by magical torches lining the tunnel wall.

Whatever it was, it was constructed of dissimilar metals, all formed and fitted together in a painfully intricate union. To Julius, it looked like a puzzle box—a simple toy meant to be enjoyed by someone with time on their hands. Even better, it appeared expensive—a bauble for the elite, now his to do with as he pleased. Julius had made friends with certain unsavory characters in Eternos, people who dealt in black market items. They would certainly be interested in something from Castle Grayskull.

Uncertainty made Julius hesitate for a moment—perhaps this thing was dangerous? Maybe it wasn't a puzzle box but something more sinister? Could he live with himself if he put others in danger for a mere profit?

Turning the box, Julius spotted a slip of paper tucker within one of its many creases—prising it out—he squinted as he read the hand-written script scrawled in red ink.

"Schlem... bess... a… rune…" He read slowly. "Huh, weird name."

Matching the name with the box had an odd effect on Julius—suddenly, he felt okay with stealing the relic for a profit. All he could think of now were the riches to be had. Who knows? Maybe there was more stuff down here he could sell—there was definitely a market for it.

"I don't think anything with a name like that could be dangerous," he said, pocketing the box.

"You seem rather harmless to me,"

THE END

Chapter End Notes

> Shlihm-bess'a-rune is based on the unique German word 'Verschlimmbesserung', which means "an attempted improvement that only makes things worse."

Author's Note plus BONUS ILLUSTRATIONS

Well, here we are, folks, the end of this LONG story I started writing late in 2021. It is very gratifying to finish this work which has reached a word count of over 400K + words—but also very sad. These characters have existed with me and kept me company for so long—there will be an empty place in my heart without them.

But this particular story always had an ending in mind, and if I had kept it going, it would have gotten stale and boring for me—besides, there are things in my life I have been putting off that I must focus on. I will keep writing (I don't think I can stop!), but this summer, I will take a break.

Most likely, I will fuss around with my existing works, maybe add a music track to Double Trouble and the Orb of Entropy as I did with She-Ra: Masters of the Universe. I will definitely have a few pieces done for my Double Trouble fic—most likely—by one of the artists who had created art for The Lost.

Speaking of which, I would like to thank those artists who spent so much of their time working on my crazy art. A few of them have even become friends of mine.

AVstravaganza, a.k.a **fan_fun_off**, who is now known as **aveecomics,** creates charming and funny comics that they post on Instagram and Tumblr. They have made a TON of content in the form of responses to Tumblr asks—if you scroll through their posts, you will find these hidden gems. There is a particular one about Double Trouble's upbringing that I really like…

Henar and Iria are friends who had formed **ilikeyoucatradora** – they have created a very rich and expansive AU of She-Ra that you should check out! Their Half-Moon series is my favorite, and my idea for Despara came directly from them. They are both professional and seasoned artists, which is apparent in everything they do!

Miledibuja has been creating Catradora fanart for a while and even has their own Catradora childhood friends AU which I found very touching. Their "Last Dance" comic is something you should look out for! Whenever I gave them full artistic license with my commissions, they blew me away with the results. You can find their stuff on Instagram, Twitter and Tumblr.

Ansdrela is probably the artist I worked with the longest, having her illustrations in my first fanfic, She-Ra: Masters of the Universe. You can find her work all over the place—Twitter, Instagram, Tumbler, and also DeviantArt (I think).

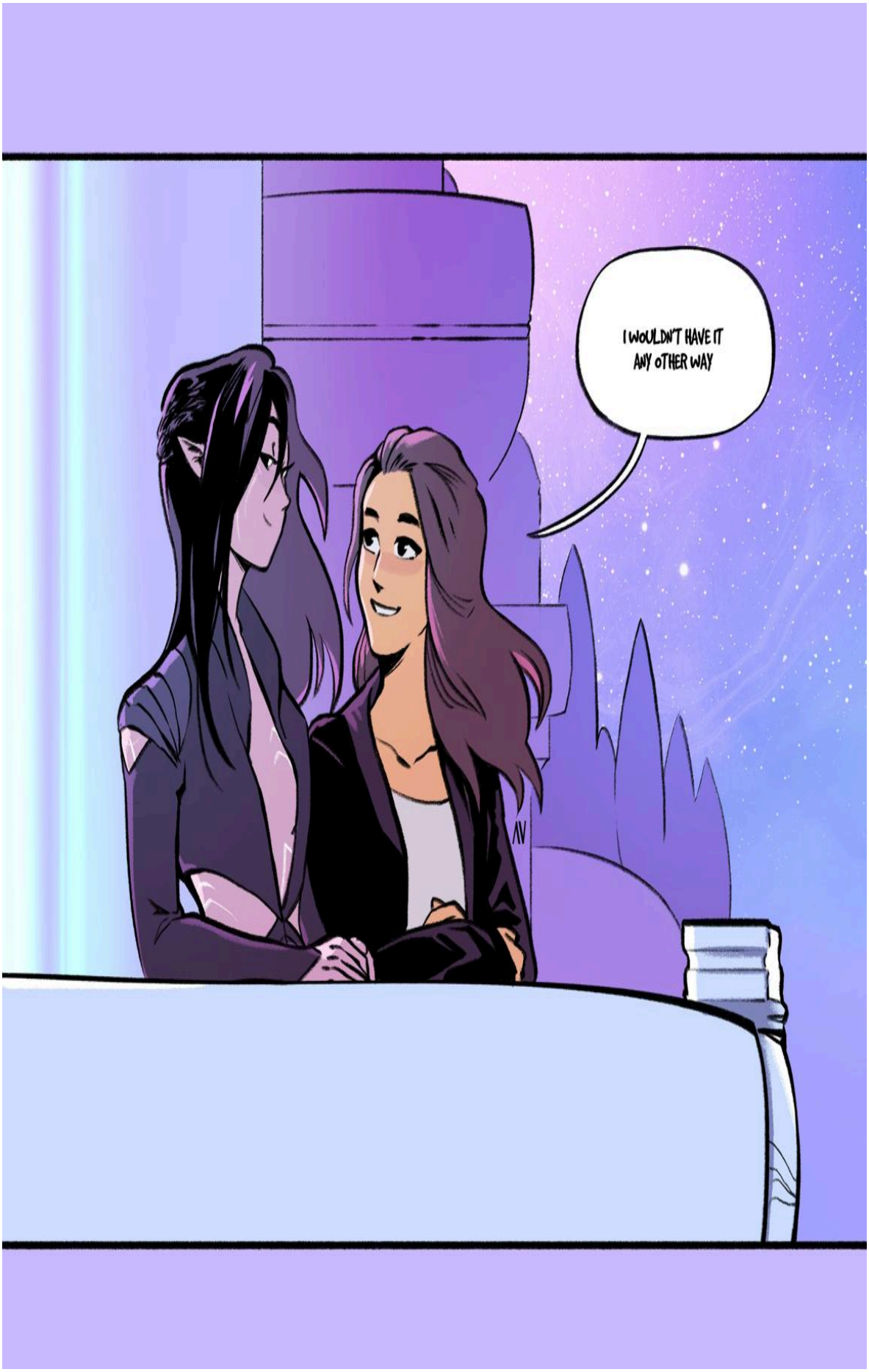
Last but not least, I want to thank YOU for reading this story! It would have come to fruition even if no one was reading it, but there is a great deal of gratification and even some validation from seeing the kudos and comments you gave me. Thank you so much!

I am not super active on social media; mostly, I just re-post art. But if I do plan on writing more, it will be announced there. I'm **largemovingtorb** on both Instagram and Tumblr.

Perhaps we will meet again?

A comic of the last scene between Veth and Shen, done for me by fan_fun_off a.k.a. aveecomics.


I AM GOING BACK TO EMPYREA AFTER THIS—TO HELP MY PEOPLE REBUILD.
THERE IS MUCH WORK TO BE DONE THERE AND I WANT TO BE THERE FOR THE RENEWAL OF THE NEPHRAEH.
NOW WITH OUR EMPATHY RETURNED IT WILL BE BEAUTIFUL...
I WANT YOU TO COME WITH ME.
I WANT YOU TO BE THERE WITH ME TO SEE IT.
AV


I WOULDN'T HAVE IT
ANY OTHER WAY

A gift from fan_fun_off a.k.a. aveecomics.



Different color variations of Zhe-La/Veth, done for me by Iria, a.k.a ilikeyoucatradora.







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